Aethic Reasoning: A Comprehensive Solution to the Quantum Measurement Problem

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First deposited November 14, 2024, (PhilArchive, v1)
This version: September 2026

Abstract

The quantum measurement problem is one of the most profound challenges in modern physics, questioning how and why the wavefunction collapses during measurement to produce a single observable outcome. In this paper, we propose a novel solution through a logical framework called Aethic reasoning, which reinterprets the ontology of time and information in quantum mechanics. Central to this approach is the Aethic principle of extrusion, which models wavefunction collapse as progression along a Markov chain of block universes, effectively decoupling the Einsteinian flow of time from quantum collapse events. This principle introduces an additional degree of freedom to time, enabling the first Aethic postulate: that informational reality is reference-dependent, akin to the relativity of simultaneity in special relativity. This reference point, or Aethus, is rigorously defined within a mathematical structure. Building on this foundation, the second postulate resolves the distinction between quantum superpositions and logical contradictions by encoding superpositions in a "backend" Aethic framework before rendering observable states. The third postulate further distinguishes quantum coherence from decoherence using a two-generational model of state inheritance, potentially advancing beyond simpler interpretations of information leakage. Together, these postulates yield a direct theoretical derivation of the collapse postulate, fully consistent with empirical results such as the outcome of the double-slit experiment. By addressing foundational aspects of quantum mechanics through a logically robust and philosophically grounded lens, this framework sheds new light on the measurement problem and offers a solid foundation for future exploration.

Orientation: the guided roadmap—the dependency figure, five discipline-specific ways in, and an annotated index of the paper's stations—is Section 1.7. The PDF sidebar bookmarks carry the full three-level structure.

Keywords: quantum measurement problem; block universe; counterfactual semantics; agreeing and disagreeing superposition; Aethic pruning; the Quantum Nexus; wave–particle duality; Bell's theorem; axiomatization of quantum mechanics.

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Part I: Foundations

1 Introduction

1.1 What This Paper Claims, and What It Delivers

The problem, and where each standard option pays. The measurement problem is the question of how a quantum superposition becomes a single observed outcome, and every standard answer to it pays at one identifiable place. The Copenhagen reading pays at the projection postulate: a discontinuous rule bolted onto continuous dynamics, applied at a cut whose location it declines to state [1]—a move that, made anywhere else in physics, would have ended the theory that made it, as if Newton had supposed that objects above some height simply stopped falling. The many-worlds reading pays at probability: it keeps the dynamics whole and reads the phenomenology of records correctly—after a record, alternatives do not interact and an observer stands in one of them—but it makes that non-interaction a *place*, and it makes its branches out of amplitude states rather than information states, and so cannot say, from its own ontology, what the Born weights are weights *of* [2, 3]. The hidden-variable readings pay at Bell's theorem, which prices determinacy in nonlocality or contextuality [4]. Each of these is a real theory that has put its debt in a definite place, and the place is always the same: the relation between what is determinate and what is merely unknown. This paper's proposal is that the relation has been mis-stated at the level of the grammar of determinacy itself, and that when it is restated the debt is not moved but discharged.

The claim. The framework is called Aethic reasoning, after its central object, the Aethus[1]: an observer-indexed information state, treated as a mathematical object in its own right. It rests on three postulates and one principle. The first postulate indexes every reality-attribution to an Aethus—a fact is determinate *relative to* an information state, never simpliciter—while leaving the structure over Aethae un-indexed. The second reads an attribute left blank in an Aethus as constructively open, a superposition over its answer space rather than an unknown value. The union principle holds that jointness is primitive and exclusion is an achievement: a classical *or* is a jointness whose alternatives carry declared exclusions, a superposition is a jointness whose alternatives do not, and the difference between them is written in the alternatives rather than in the logic that composes them. The third postulate is then the framework's engine of definiteness, and it is the statement the whole paper is built to establish and to use: an Aethus is valid exactly when it admits a refinement all of whose further refinements remain valid, so that a superposition that every declared refinement of the state retains a contradicting record for is invalid *now*, the full-future criterion of Lemma 5, a merely possible record excluding nothing—collapse as checkmate rather than as an event. Together with one quantitative input, the Feynman kernel over augmented paths, these form an axiom set for quantum mechanics, and the principal result of the paper is that the set *represents the Dirac–von Neumann formalism axiom by axiom on the finite path-kernel domain*: the observables axiom as a theorem of the postulates once the kernel is installed, the projection postulate as the representation of a stipulated record-compatible restriction, which the validity postulate alone does not select, the state space and its dynamics as the kernel axiom's own content, and the seventh, the Born rule, absorbed into the one weight law rather than posited beside it. The measurement problem is solved inside that recovery, not beside it: the projection postulate is the representation of a stipulated record-compatible restriction, the third postulate supplying validity and not the update, and no separate measurement or projection axiom is posited, the record structure and that restriction standing in its place.

What is delivered, in the order of its weight. The results below are the paper's, stated at the grade the paper gives them; every one is a theorem, a derivation, or a posit booked as such on the closing ledger, and nothing is claimed at a grade above its proof.

1. **The Aethic axiomatization of quantum mechanics**, (Section 14.3). The recovery theorem maps the procedure's objects onto the Hilbert-space ones—states are valid agreeing clusters, superposition is the agreeing union, observables are the partitions the world's records induce,

[1] Pronunciation, for the subvocalizing reader: *Aethus* is precisely *aether* with its *-er* exchanged for *-us*; *Aethae* is *EE-thigh*—the unvoiced *th* of *thigh* throughout, rather than the voiced as in *thus*.

the Born rule is the weight of a class-restricted cluster, the projection postulate is pruning, composition is the product of path spaces, evolution is the kernel's composition law with unitarity posited as part of the kernel axiom—and the amplitudes themselves are recovered from the cluster weights by polarization and never held, so that the Born rule and the state space are one axiom here where they are two in the standard presentation—probability amplitudes removed as objects, the weight law standing as the root and the amplitude as its polarization. The kind of advance claimed is this: the claim is that the Hilbert-space premise stops being a mystery, not that quantum mechanics is exceeded—the same equations under a foundation in which the parts that were postulated as brute are located and derived. That is not a standard the paper sets for itself. It is the standard Spekkens has stated for a realist quantum theory, recorded and answered at length in Section 10.3.1—an ontology beyond the black box, against the promotion of the formalism to an ontology; a non-classical switch located deeper than interference, which he argues does not capture the essence of quantum theory; a structure deeper than sets and functions; causation and inference exotic but logically realist, revised jointly; and the epistemic and the ontic unscrambled [5–8]—and the paper is written to fit the mold he described: the indexed Aethus and its tree; the two regimes of the union principle, with interference their kernel-grade display; the refinement graph with its validity predicate, of which the Powerset theorem is a set-level projection; joint invalidity in place of an arrow; and the first postulate's split between indexed content and un-indexed structure. By those criteria the demand that a realist quantum theory predict beyond quantum mechanics is not one the paper fails but one the criteria reject, a realist reformulation being by definition one on which the existing formalism ceases to be strange, (Section 14.3). And what makes the paper one argument rather than several is that it performs a single relocation at three sites: determinacy, from a one-place property of facts to a two-place relation to an Aethus, (the first postulate); exclusion, from the logic of *or* to the records that write it, (the union principle); and probability, from a quantity derived by squaring an amplitude back to the root, (the Quantum Nexus)—the third being the same act as the first two and the one a reader measuring the paper by whether the equations changed will miss. The kernel is the single quantitative input, and the paper is exact about its standing: its substance is kinematic where the postulates' is logical, the two sectors meeting only at the agreeing superposition, so that deriving it from the postulates would be a category mistake and its derivation is assigned to a geometric program instead.

2. **The single inversion**, (Sections 1.5 and 2.1). Determinacy is relocated from spacetime to the Aethus; the block universe is kept whole while its entries are permitted to stand open relative to an index; collapse becomes an indexing transition rather than a foliation of spacetime, which is how the fifth requirement below is met without a nonlocal signal; and the nested-observer paradoxes—Wigner's friend, Frauchiger–Renner—resolve without any cut drawn by scale, complexity, or fiat, the framework's one dependency there being a claim about the physics of records rather than a parameter. One qualification governs every entry that consumes L4's permanence, this one and Wigner's friend among them: the permanence is semantic, a predecessor remaining a semantic object, and it does not imply that a physical memory cannot be coherently reversed or that every observer exports an uncontrollable copy. The Frauchiger–Renner protocol measures whole laboratories in superposition bases, and denying the physical availability of those measurements is a substantive restriction on the protocol, an additional and unresolved physical commitment, not a consequence of retaining earlier descriptions; where the text says that nothing beyond the third postulate is consumed, that commitment is to be added.

3. **The ontology of time, reorganized**, (Section 2.2). Three things that "time" has carried together since Newton are separated and each given its own carrier: *geometry*—the proper-time direction of relativity's block, which is kept as pure geometry and asked to do nothing else; *determinacy-driving*—the resolution of what is open into what is stated, which is given to the Aethus and its centric unfolding, so that passage is the transition between indexings of one block rather than a process within it; and *tense*, the A-series of past, present, and future, which is relocated to the index rather than eliminated. Relativistic time is thereby relieved of the semantic surplus it was never built to carry, the A-series/B-series standoff is dissolved by relocation rather than settled by elimination, and past and future stand on one footing under the indiscriminate time principle[2].

[2]I would say that once Aethic reasoning separates out the determinacy-making of time from the geometry of time, the entropy-gradient slots into the underlying Aethic structure perhaps remarkably smoothly, similarly to how Lyapunov

4. **The union principle and the two regimes**, (Section 2.4). Agreeing and disagreeing superposition are distinguished by what is written into the alternatives; interference is what the agreeing regime looks like and decoherence what the disagreeing regime looks like; the fundamental theorem fixes when each obtains; and the classical world is recovered as the disagreeing case, with two distinct classical limits named.

5. **The third postulate as a fixed point, and the reduced form**, (Sections 6.7 and 9.1.1). Validity is a $\exists\forall$ safety property on the refinement graph; the Fixed-Point Lemma certifies it; the reduced form is the normal form of an Aethus under a commutative semiring of weights; invalidity is a relabeling that leaves weights beneath it untouched, which is what lets a reopened attribute recover its own weights, (the Recovery Lemma); and the Lüders rule is pruning followed by renormalization.

6. **The Powerset Invalidation Theorem**, (Theorem 14). Under any detector configuration, every candidate coherent subset of alternatives lands in exactly one of three bins, so that the quantum–classical boundary is a discrete fact about which records the configuration can produce, sliding as records are added or erased—the double slit, the quantum eraser, and delayed choice as one theorem—with the individuation the theorem rests on derived as the Record-Individuation Lemma.

7. **Realism without counterfactual definiteness**, (Sections 10.3.1 and 10.3.2). The framework supplies enough counterfactual structure to say what experiments would have shown and no hidden valuation for the theorems to kill; the Deflation Reductio proves that reading blanks as unknowns is refuted by Bell wherever the blanks carry violating statistics and is granted, at an architectural price, wherever they do not.

8. **The Quantum Nexus and the two composition laws**, (Sections 14 and 14.6.4). The kernel weights agreeing clusters whole; the two-tag experiment exhibits both composition laws at once, weights across record-separated ports and amplitudes within them; the chord and circle of wave–particle duality are read as the fingerprints of the two laws, with the mechanism shown to be the coupling lemma, Uhlmann's theorem, and the Fuchs–van de Graaf bound rather than an arrangement fitted to the example; the singlet's correlations and the Tsirelson bound are derived from the kernel; and no-signaling arrives as an algebraic identity.

9. **A counterfactual semantics with the similarity ordering deleted**, (Section 9.1). Counterfactuals are evaluated by reopening a determinate state, restating it, and re-pruning, with a three-setting scope convention doing the work the ordering used to do; the resulting consequence relation is provably not representable by Lewis's or Stalnaker's semantics or any smooth ordering, (Cautious Monotony fails by a four-attribute countermodel); grammatical mood falls out of the scope settings; causation arrives as a verdict of the semantics rather than a parameter fed to it, with the statistical screening structure associated with Reichenbach's principle derived for factorized states, intervention read off supplied mechanism structure, and the correlation–causation distinction re-rendered as weight against structure, a proposal stated as one (subsubsection 14.6.11); and the recurring philosophical move by which an inoperable causal chain is kept alive by indicting one's own faculties is named as the perception-denial fallacy and traced across fields.

10. **The cases**, (Section 10.1 onward). The double slit, the Mach–Zehnder interferometer, delayed choice, Schrödinger's cat, Wigner's friend, Frauchiger–Renner, EPR and Bell, decoherence's

amplification becomes merely continuous weight interpolation once we throw out possible worlds as ontologically-meaningful, (Section 8.0.4). That is, the reason you (assuming you're under twenty-five, say) can hold a picture of your great grandmother but not your great granddaughter is because despite determinacy relative to an Aethus being truly tense-free, as is the Aethic indiscriminate time principle, (Section 2.3.3), nonetheless the Boltzmannian second law of thermodynamics runs like software on Aethic hardware, (Section 11.2), such that it "physically" blocks superposition-resolution from reaching you from the future with more than minute probability. So while the underlying ontology is fully tense-free, the nature of your own Aethic updating-predicting along the indexing of proper time mechanistically fights the ability for non-lossy information transfer back towards you, that is assuming particle-multiplicity is involved—chaos amplifying that asymmetry where it is present but, being time-symmetric itself, never creating it. When particle-multiplicity is not involved, as in the orbital mechanics of the Earth or the Aethic delayed-choice experiment, (Section 10.9.4), sure enough the past and future reduce to perfectly equivalent predictability anyway, and thereby blank-resolvability—the Earth's orbit being chaotic over millions of years, but equally so in both directions. So, amazingly the second law of thermodynamics ended up becoming remarkably fundamental for the arrow of time anyway—just as a filter rather than a substrate.

environmental origin, and the ontology of detectors, each run from the postulates rather than illustrated by them.

11. **The wider branches.** The same three postulates run wherever there are information states: decision theory, (Newcomb's problem, ratifiability, the stated-relata principle); anthropics, (the measure rule, Sleeping Beauty, the presumptuous philosopher); the ontology of time, (passage as the centric unfolding of an Aethus, neither illusion nor fundamental process); and the prelude to active reasoning, where the kernel's geometric arena is named and its unveiling set as the program. The quantum wing is one branch of this framework and not its trunk.

12. **What remains open**, (Section 14.8). Six constructions are named and priced: a minimality theorem for the pruning rule, with a countermodel for each assumption dropped; the measure-invariance proof for the reopened blank's weighting; the in-formalism definition of the distinguishability supremum; the kernel's derivation as geometric unveiling; the exact trigger conditions for in-principle irretrievability; and the continuum extension of the record classification.

The price, stated once. Any audit of the framework will find exactly the following posits and nothing else load-bearing: the index, (the first postulate); the constructive reading of blanks, (the second); the primitive jointness of *or*, (the union principle); the third postulate's quantifier structure; one composition primitive; one algebraic design choice, the commutative semiring without additive inverses; the kernel; and the realization bridge that converts labeled invalidity into physical unrealizability. Each is unpacked in turn—what it asserts, its grade, where it is booked, what it buys, and what would refute it—in Section 1.3, immediately below, after the four statements themselves are set together in Section 1.2; the tally is closed, one line each, at the end of the logical sector, (Section 13.14). What the framework buys with them is the deletion of the projection postulate, the measurement axiom, the observables axiom, the Heisenberg cut, the similarity ordering of counterfactual semantics, and the determinate-but-unknown reading of quantum blanks. The paper's own view is that this is a good trade, and it says why at each site rather than here.

Derivation, not illustration. The collapse postulate is *derived*, in the exact sense the paper fixes[3]: the Copenhagen postulate is replaced by its realist counterpart, the quantifier structure is derived, the

[3] *2026-08-29*

The key to my intuition is that, if you read the relevant footnote in the intro which states some of this already, what Aethic reasoning really is in the context of quantum foundations is a realist quantum theory, and as is argued the very one Spekkens argued must exist. So when I say ‘‘solves the measurement problem’’ I mean that measurement is no longer an ontological black box, and when I say ‘‘derives the collapse postulate’’ I mean that we replace the collapse postulate as per the Copenhagen interpretation with the realist/ontological counterpart, but crucially this does not just reduce to standard quantum practice because short answer that’s categorically operationalist which this is realist, longer answer it has the category error and scrambling which Spekkens identifies, so as to stake its axioms on the human ascription of measurement rather than the ontological joints in the powerset invalidation theorem (such that the Aethic flip, notice, flips ‘‘deep’’ properties about discernability to the axiomatic layer for free, thereby revealing the measurement axiom itself as kind of questionably placed to begin with), and the long answer is my ‘‘effective contradiction’’ concept itself, which sort of implies that to realist standards QM was never formulated to begin with by means of Copenhagen.

2026-09-23

Oh and by the way another thing I mean to say is that if you look at that very early footnote of mine in the long Aethic paper, where I say "by solve the measurement problem I mean..." notice how I think it’s entirely reasonable to say that a genuinely realist quantum axiomatization SOLVES the measurement problem, so hedging whether the paper does to conflates "this paper does not yet solve the measurement problem" from what I really mean to say, which is "a realist quantum axiomatization solves the measurement problem by definition of the measurement problem, and the central ARGUMENT of this paper is that the Aethic postulates, when taken as a constraint, uniquely enforces the consistent kernel and quantum leg to be precisely that which altogether develops the realist quantum axiomatization, thereby solving the measurement problem, so the ’maybe’ modality is strictly in that argument rather than vaguely in ’does this achieve solving the measurement problem’". Notice how even with the Aethic postulates alone, the unique derivation of the kernel that consistently gives quantum empiricism is precisely the one we see, as is precisely valued over the powerset of paths, etc--so already the Aethic postulates uniquely enforce the shape of the kernel we see, so the argument is that even where we lack complete axiomatic covering of qm, the remaining pieces are inferable from the foundation, hence meaning if that’s right then the measurement problem was solved as soon as said uniqueness-giving foundation was stated, and no later.

2026-09-24

Right so this general extension being in effect, I really have my eye on what we need to show in order for quant to also be able to definitely say that Aethic reasoning is a complete re-axiomatization: that is in the strict sense that for every quantum axiom we get as a derived theorem, everything it is required for in quantum mechanics can be done with the Aethic axioms. See what I mean? That doesn’t mean we need to already have an explicit account for every darn term in the standard model Lagrangian--it’s simply that it’d be kind of ridiculous to my eye to harsh on Aethic reasoning being a "full" re-axiomatization if literally wherever you point your fire ALSO applies to Copenhagen and its mess of an overly-philosophical rather than well-defined measurement operation lol! Like c’mon!

physical trigger is supplied by the union principle, and the grade is stated where the interpretations are compared, (Section 2.5.1). The physical content that the third postulate carries into the world is the third postulate's statement itself, and the sentence toward which the whole paper builds is accordingly this one:

> **Third Postulate of the Aethus.** An Aethus A is valid only if it admits a proper child $B \leq A$ all of whose proper children are valid,
>
> $$\mathbf{V}[A] \implies \exists B \leq A \, \forall C \leq B \; \mathbf{V}[C];$$
>
> so that, where the reduced-form construction is established, a valid Aethus has a reduced form, $\bar{A} = \sup\{B \leq A : \forall C \leq B, \; \mathbf{V}[C]\}$, the real-weight maximum, the valid-support truncation, stated in subsection 6.7, and the general correspondence open. A superposition every proper child of which retains a contradicting record admits no such child, and is invalid now.

It is stated in full, with its definitions, and derived at Section 6.7; the physical trigger that makes a record a contradiction is the union principle's, and the two together are what the rest of the paper runs.

Without further ado, then, let us begin our traversal through Aethic reasoning, a proposed solution to the quantum measurement problem[4].

1.1.1 An Elevator Pitch for Aethic Reasoning

In layman's terms "grammar" means making sure not to forget your commas, but at a doctoral level grammar is actually a very abstract discipline. Realizing this abstract description of it turns out to be exactly what finally allowed me to explain in words exactly what I had formulated already back in August 2022: I fixed human grammar to make it line up with the universe as it actually is. The universe as it actually is, it turns out, is revealed to you only once you've processed the decisive clue that is quantum mechanics proper. Like how everyone knew from experiments that the speed of light was constant before it became Einstein's postulate, everybody already knows from Bell's theorem that "constructive blanks", i.e. absolute indeterminate states ontologically exist[5], so all I did was drop the concept of a philosophical possible world and rewrite counterfactual reasoning atop a state for which constructive blanks are themselves perfectly valid constituents, or more technically an elementary modal state stops being the singletons that we call "determinate states" and instead becomes the full powerset of states for which the subset of singletons is the limiting case after tracing

[4] *A disclaimer*: the reason I had enough material to title this paper "a comprehensive solution to the measurement problem" even in 2024, two years before I worked out the Quantum Nexus applications like to no-signaling, is because exactly by May 2023 I had (as is the argument) a realist quantum interpretation in hand, so as far as I am concerned that makes the measurement problem solved by definition. However, funnily enough I was not aware of the term "realist" or any technical philosophy of science more broadly, so my criteria that Aethic reasoning qualified fell under the qualitative aspect of that which I intuited directly by analyzing what makes historical theories "explanatory". Hence, "realist solution" is as of now the better description than "measurement problem solution", but "wave-particle duality ontological explanation" is also good as a retrospection.

[5] The inference here is inductive, and is meant as such, and its content is this. A no-hidden-variables ontology is a special case of a metaphysics in which constructive blanks are guaranteed to exist: an unmeasured quantity with no definite value is a blank in the state, so whoever rejects hidden variables has already admitted blanks as constituents of the state, under another name. What Bell's theorem and Kochen–Specker establish deductively is that no local, noncontextual, measurement-independent assignment of definite values to the unmeasured quantities reproduces the quantum statistics (Proposition 31; Section 9.9.4); what they leave standing are the hidden-variable accounts that keep definite values at the price of nonlocal or contextual structure no experiment detects, and dismissing those is the inductive step, the same step by which the null results were taken at face value rather than absorbed into Lorentz's ether. With that step taken, blanks are already agreed to exist, and the first postulate only says so generally. An Aethus, in its strictly representational sense, pending the ontological context the first postulate then gives it, is a possible world with the completeness constraint removed, the constraint by which a possible world is defined as a world in which no blank exists; once it is removed, a blank is represented in the state exactly as a determinate value is, and with that replacement object in place the splitting of the Aethic Markovian process from the moving present—an unread outcome blank wherever its referent sits in time, the state advancing only as its records arrive—is a consistency corollary rather than a further commitment. That is the context for the two phrases on either side of this sentence. Fixing grammar to line up with the universe is not fitting grammar to whichever reading of quantum mechanics one already holds, which would leave the quantum side fixed and make the grammar a one-way accommodation; both sides move, the quantum side being brought into the inductive package in which a blank is a constituent rather than ignorance, and choosing that package is where the art lies, not in a direct or mechanical derivation from the theorem. Making the blank inherent in reality is the promotion of the inductive conclusion to a postulate, as the constancy of the speed of light was promoted, so that the model accommodates it from the start instead of completing it away.

between the quantum and classical regimes.[6] Even surviving well into the classical regime though, that which is truly epistemologically inaccessible to you at present, to ontological degree, is relative to your index a constructive blank, and so the profound result is that humans ourselves attach not to possible worlds but epistemologically-tailored islands of exactly all availably known information, such that your counterfactuals are resolved not with the moving present but remain fully available until the Markovian process of your own ontological reception of the information reaching you moves you to the next island. It doesn't matter if that information comes from a battle a thousand years ago or your surprise party which surprised you just now, once we throw out possible worlds and replace them with this island ontology constructive blanks from any tense location in spacetime are open to resolve in your running Markovian process until they've reached you to do so, thereby shifting metaphysics so as to "attach" a human "up" at one of these islands rather than "down below" at a possible world where all unknown information is sent to the very metaphysically-intractable completion of constructive blanks with determinate singletons which forces about the inference of the butterfly effect anyway, (i.e. where you have some ill-defined black box for which the counterfactual in which you miss the bus yesterday morning is apparently supposed to solely rather than merely with minute probability save a train from derailing a thousand miles away). So altogether we turn constructive blanks from something everybody knows to exist to, like Einstein's speed of light postulate, the very thing which forces our basic model of reality to shift so as to accommodate it inherently.

1.2 The Three Postulates and the Union Principle, Stated Together

The paragraph above names the framework's commitments in passing. They are set out here together, in the wording the body of the paper fixes, so that a reader has all of them on one page before meeting any of them at work. Each is stated as it appears at its home site, with that site given; the derivations are there and not here.

First Postulate of the Aethus

Any attribution of reality is a statement of relation to a particular Aethus.

The attribution is of *content*, every determinate value of a contingent attribute; the *structure* over Aethae—which Aethae are valid, what weights attach, the rule from a detector configuration to its record partition—stands un-indexed. There is no Aethus-free ledger of facts, and there is one grammar over all vantages. Home: Section 2, at the statement labeled post1.

Second Postulate of the Aethus

If an Aethus is valid, then any given attribute will be in Aethic superposition relative to it if and only if it is nonpresent to it.

A blank is constructive, not epistemic: an attribute the Aethus holds no record of is an agreeing superposition over its answer space, and the openness is tense-free—an unlearned past exactly as open as an unformed future. Home: Section 3, at post2; its philosophical and inductive derivations are in Section 2.

[6] *October 4, 2026, 2:15 PM*
What I'm specifically saying here is that no-hidden variables ontology is a special case of a metaphysics in which constructive blanks are guaranteed to exist, so we already know they exist (assuming the nonlocality take on Bell's theorem is garbage) and so in turn everyone has already agreed that constructive blanks exist, so the first postulate of the Aethus simply says so generally--an Aethus (in this strictly representational sense, pending the first postulate of the Aethus also sticking it with its new ontological context and interpretation) is almost like the ''shift''/generalization to a possible world where we throw out the constraint in defining a possible world where constructive blanks don't exist, and then now that they exist and an Aethus is the replacement object for a possible world in which they can be represented just as well as determinate states, now the Aethic Markovian process splitting from the moving present becomes merely a consistency corollary. THAT is the idea!

The Aethic Union Principle

Jointness is primitive and exclusion is an achievement. A classical *or* is a jointness whose alternatives carry declared mutual exclusions; a superposition is a jointness whose alternatives do not; and the difference between them is written in the alternatives, not in the logic that composes them.

This is the one posit the paper adds to the postulates, and it is what splits superposition into a *disagreeing* regime, whose alternatives exclude one another, and an *agreeing* regime, whose alternatives do not—the distinction the mixed/coherent contrast tracks at the physical level, rendered here as a difference in what is stated. The two vocabularies are kept at their levels throughout: agreeing and disagreeing superposition are a qualitative category of Aethic composition, fixed by which negations the alternatives' interiors state and definable before any weight, kernel, or phase exists; coherence and decoherence are quantitative properties of a physical realization of that structure, available only once the kernel is installed, and no biconditional identifies the two. Home: Section 2.4.

Third Postulate of the Aethus

If some Aethus is valid, then there exists a proper child Aethus to it for which every one of its own proper child Aethae are valid.

$$\mathbf{V}[A] \implies \exists B \leq A,\ \forall C \leq B,\ \mathbf{V}[C]$$

Here $B \leq A$ reads "B is a proper child Aethus of A" and $A \geq B$ "A is a proper parent of B", the order of the Aethic tree, a join-semilattice on generated cones and not in general a lattice (Theorem 9), and the boolean reduction of Definition 36, with $B \leq_\beta A$ for the relation carrying its weight β; refinement, $B \sqsubseteq A$, is childhood itself, $B = A \cdot C$ for some C; a proper child is a refinement of its parent that is a visible term of a decomposition of it, so proper childhood is the subrelation of refinement the tree is ordered by. Validity is a two-generation safety property on the proper-child order, $\exists\forall$: an Aethus is valid exactly when some proper child of it has only valid proper children. A superposition that every declared refinement of the state keeps a contradicting record for is invalid *now*, while a record that is merely possible excludes nothing; collapse is checkmate, not an event. Here a *proper child* of A, $B \leq A$, being, in the framework's additive definition, any B for which some admissible declared decomposition $A \rightsquigarrow bB + cC$, an expression of the weighted algebra not identified there with A, (the reason being the projectivity the Relational Weight Principle imposes, Section 4.5), cC an admissible remainder, has b nonzero and not measure-zero relative to the remainder's weight c, its reported weight $\beta = b/(b + c)$, where the measure type admits division, taken at B's maximum coefficient within a fixed free-sum representation, by the Relational Weight Principle (in the strict relative-negligibility relation of the measure type, subsection 4.3, $b \neq 0$ and $b \not\ll c$), so that a valid component carried at relatively negligible weight is no proper child of A and supplies no validity floor for it, a *child* being $B = A \cdot C$ multiplicatively; both relations are transitive, childhood directly and proper childhood under the composition property of Definition 37, so a proper child at any depth is a proper child, and "two generations" names the third postulate's two nested quantifiers, each over the full transitive relation, not a two-step horizon; the Aethic tree and the postulate are formulated on proper childhood, and multiplicative childhood is the analytical probe by which an incompatibility is exposed, not a substitute for it. The quantifier structure is selected by elimination within a stated class, (Section 6), and the postulate is the framework's engine of definiteness. Home: post3.

Together with one quantitative input—the Feynman kernel over augmented paths, (Section 14.7)—these four statements, together with a stipulated record-compatible restriction, are the axiom set from which the paper represents the Dirac–von Neumann formalism on the finite path-kernel domain. Everything else the paper asserts is either derived from them or booked as a posit on the ledger of Section 1.3.

1.3 The Ledger: Every Load-Bearing Posit, Unpacked

The paragraph headed *the price, stated once* promised that an audit of the framework would find exactly a stated list of posits and nothing else load-bearing. This subsection is the audit, placed here so that the promise and its discharge are on facing pages. Each entry gives what is posited, the grade at which the paper holds it, where it is booked, what it buys, and what would refute or replace it. The list is exhaustive: anything the paper asserts that is not on it is derived from something that is,

and the derivation's site is given at the assertion. The order is the order of dependence—each entry consumes those above it and none below.

1. **The index.** *Posited.* Any attribution of reality is a relation to an Aethus; the structure over Aethae is un-indexed, (the first postulate, post1). *Grade:* a primitive, argued for on inductive ground from the extrusion principle's resolution of the A-theory/B-theory conflict, (Section 2.2.3), and from the modal content of counterfactuals, (Section 2.2.1). *Buys:* the two-place determinacy relation, hence the dissolution of the paradox set, (Section 10), and the deletion of the determinate-but-unknown reading of quantum blanks. *Refuted by:* any demonstration that a contingent attribute has a value in no Aethus whatever—which the Record-Individuation Lemma, (Lemma 7), shows is not a coherent demand within the framework, so that the refutation would have to be external: a construction of Aethus-free determinate content that survives the Deflation Reductio, (Theorem 4).

2. **The constructive blank.** *Posited.* An attribute nonpresent to a valid Aethus is in superposition relative to it, and the superposition is constructive and tense-free, (the second postulate, post2). *Grade:* a primitive, with two derivations offered—philosophical and inductive, (Section 2)—neither of which the paper claims as a proof. *Buys:* the past's openness as a theorem rather than a metaphor, (the Indiscriminate Time Principle, Section 2.3.3), and the whole of the counterfactual semantics, (Section 9.1). *Refuted by:* the deflationary reading—blanks as ignorance of determinate values—succeeding where the Deflation Reductio says it cannot, which is to say a single-sample-space model of the Bell statistics.

3. **The primitive jointness of *or*.** *Posited.* Exclusion is stated interior content of alternatives, not a feature of the connective, (the union principle, Section 2.4). *Grade:* a primitive, on inductive ground: the two composition regimes were extracted from the case structure of interference before the principle was stated, (Section 2.4, provenance), so the posit is the naming of a distinction the phenomena already displayed. *Buys:* the agreeing/disagreeing split, the classical limit as the disagreeing case, the second grade—validity—that quantum logic lacked, and every reframe listed in Section 2.4.15. *Refuted by:* an interference phenomenon in which the two composition laws fail to sort by record structure—a cross-term surviving a record, or vanishing without one.

4. **The third postulate's quantifier structure.** *Derived in form, posited in class.* Validity is the $\exists\forall$ safety property on the refinement graph, (post3). *Grade:* the form is selected by elimination *within a stated class* of refinement-based, weight-independent rules, (Section 6); that the rule lies in that class is the posit, and the paper says so. *Buys:* collapse as checkmate, the projection postulate as a representation of record-compatible restriction, the Powerset Invalidation Theorem and with it the quantum–classical boundary as a record partition, (Theorem 14). *Refuted by:* a valid Aethus with no proper child all of whose children are valid—an experiment in which a superposition survives a record that every refinement can read.

5. **One composition primitive.** *Posited.* Joint assertion of Aethae is the multiplication of the Aethic tree, with informational union as its addition, (Section 3). *Grade:* a primitive of the algebra; the last-common-ancestor factorization once imposed beside it is now derived from it. *Buys:* the tree, the reduced form, and every algebraic result of the weighting section. *Replaced by:* any alternative composition that reproduces the reduced form's pruning; none is known, and the paper does not claim uniqueness.

6. **One algebraic design choice: the commutative semiring without additive inverses.** *Posited, as design.* Weights live in a zerosumfree semiring, so that pruning bottoms out at the additive identity and nothing cancels a valid contribution, (Section 4). *Grade:* a design choice, forced at the unweighted layer by idempotency and carried at the weighted layer by one guard axiom. *Buys:* the separation of validity from weight—a tag on a standing element is never a deletion—and the semiring-not-ring result. *Replaced by:* a ring, at the cost of allowing a negative weight to erase a valid alternative, which the paper argues would re-import cancellation at the wrong grade.

7. **The kernel.** *Posited.* The Quantum Nexus: the pure-phase weight $e^{iS/\hbar}$ over augmented paths, composed over pairs by the Dual Path Principle, (Section 50; Principle 51). *Grade:* the one quantitative posit, and the one the paper explicitly declines to derive from the four statements above, on the two-sectors ruling that the postulates are logical where the kernel is kinematic,

(Section 14.3). *Buys:* the recovery theorem—the observables axiom and the projection postulate as theorems given the kernel, the state space and its dynamics as the kernel's own content, and the Born rule absorbed, (Theorem 15)—and every quantitative result. *Replaced by:* whatever the arena's geometry unveils, which is the fourth of the Open Constructions, (Section 14.8), and the subject of the active-reasoning section that follows.

8. **The realization bridge.** *Posited.* A formally invalid Aethus is physically unrealizable, (Section 9.1.1). *Grade:* a principle and not a theorem; the paper books it as such, and it is the single place at which the formal apparatus touches the world. *Buys:* the passage from "this superposition is invalid" to "this outcome does not occur," without which every theorem above would be about labels. *Refuted by:* the realization of a labeled-invalid state—an observed contradiction between two records that the third postulate says cannot co-occur.

What the ledger does not contain, and why. Three things a reader might expect to find are absent because they are consequences, not posits. The projection postulate is entry 4 at work on a record. No-signaling is an algebraic identity of the recovery theorem's clause (viii). And the Born rule is not an entry, because on this framework it is not an axiom beside the state space but the one weight law of entry 7 read at a record-restricted cluster, the amplitudes recovered by polarization. Their absence from the ledger is the paper's central claim stated as an accounting fact.

1.4 Listing of Requirements to a Solution

We may begin our analysis at what is perhaps the most natural point of initiation, being the tangible ground which we wish to cover by the end of this paper.

A precise outline of five conditions has already been provided by Sabine Hossenfelder and Jonte R. Hance regarding what would be required for a genuine solution to the measurement problem [9]. As such, let us structure the present paper so as to tailor our claim of a solution directly to this tangible assessment of what would be satisfactory. Here, then, is the statement of the five requirements, which we will refer to through their numbered names.

Requirement 1
Agree with all existing data.

Requirement 2
Reproduce quantum mechanics, including the Collapse Postulate and Born's Rule, in a well-defined limit.

Requirement 3
Give an unambiguous answer to the question of what a measurement device is, at least in principle.

Requirement 4
Reproduce classical physics in a well-defined limit.

Requirement 5
Resolve the inconsistency between the non-local measurement collapse and local stress-energy conservation.

We will refer back to these requirements throughout. One partition should be fixed before they are scored. The solution divides into the *measurement problem solution*—the collapse postulate, derived—and the *Born rule solution*—the Born rule and the remaining quantitative axioms—and three of the five requirements carry a layer for each. The present paper is the former of two papers, the followup framework *active reasoning* being the latter; but the boundary between them has moved since the requirements were first set down, and the table records where it now stands. Requirement 2's Born-rule layer in particular is not deferred wholesale: the Aethic axiomatization of Section 14.3 represents the Dirac–von Neumann formalism on the finite path-kernel domain from the postulates, the kernel and a stipulated record-compatible restriction, the Born rule absorbed into the weight law rather than posited beside it, so that what remains for active reasoning is the kernel's own derivation and nothing of the rule's structure.

	Requirement	Where, and how, it is met	Grade
R1	agree with all existing data	no new numbers are predicted; every statistic the standard formalism computes is recovered by the recovery theorem, (Section 14.3), and the one structural stake is priced at the nested-observer cases	theorem, given the kernel
R2	reproduce quantum mechanics, including collapse and the Born rule, in a well-defined limit	collapse derived as the third postulate's pruning on a record, (Sections 6.7, 10.1); the Born rule absorbed into the weight law, the amplitudes recovered by polarization, (Section 14.3)	collapse derived; the Born rule restructured here, the kernel's derivation assigned to active reasoning
R3	say what a measurement device is, in principle	any configuration whose records can escape to where a future refinement can read them; the signature partition it induces is the measurement, (Theorem 14; Section 10.5)	theorem
R4	reproduce classical physics in a well-defined limit	the disagreeing regime is the classical world; two distinct classical limits are named and derived, (Section 14.2.2)	derived
R5	reconcile non-local collapse with local stress–energy conservation	collapse is an indexing transition, not a foliation of spacetime; nothing propagates, so nothing is conserved or violated by it, (Section 2.5)	derived

The measurement problem solution and the Born rule solution remain partitioned into two papers, with the present paper the former; what the present paper already delivers of the latter is the structural half named above, and Requirement 2's Born-rule layer is accordingly scored as restructured here and derived there.

1.4.1 Aethic Reasoning Through Requirement

(A converse, speculative reading of the five requirements—the *requisite interpretation*, holding that the three postulates are the only logically-cohesive theory able to satisfy all five at once—is deferred to Section 12.8, where it is stated as a labeled conjecture once the framework needed to assess it has been developed.)

1.5 The Single Inversion: Relocating the Index of Reality

Every result in this paper is one move, re-instantiated. Classical physics indexes reality-attributions to spacetime: a fact, once located, is determinate simpliciter, and influence travels along worldlines from past to future. Aethic reasoning relocates the index. Determinacy becomes a relation between an attribute and an Aethus, the block universe survives untouched, and what varies is which block universe is yours—with information, rather than motion, doing the selecting.

The unit of description: attributes, not objects. Underwriting the inversion is a prior shift in the unit of description itself: where classical physics describes *events*—occurrences located in spacetime—Aethic reasoning describes *attributes*, question-shaped objects whose answers stand in relations to an Aethus. Events survive as the special case of attributes projected into spacetime, but the attribute idiom reaches further, with identities, dispositions, historical unknowns, and counterfactual structure all becoming citizens of the same calculus—and it is this breadth that supplies the paradigmatic grounding for the causal reframe below.

Why the attribute basis is load-bearing. A further note on why this attribute basis is load-bearing rather than aesthetic, recorded here because the point recurs at several measurement-theoretic junctures: equivalence classes drawn "by feel"—macrostates nominated by whatever context makes salient—are ontologically unstable, because they shift under redescription and thereby lose contact with the invariant attributes over which the postulates run directly. On the attribute basis, a coarse-graining is instead a quotient of attribute structure—an Aethic partition with its weights carried along, (Section 3.5.3)—and it thereby inherits its validity facts from the postulates rather than borrowing its significance from context. Counting its loads, then, the attribute basis carries at least three: the paradigmatic grounding above; the Internal-External Paradox, (Principle 35), whose center-pinned convention—superpositions over external attributes rather than over self-locations—cannot even be stated in event-units; and the macrostate-invariance point just given.

The inversion, stated for states. Stated for states, the inversion is the extrusion principle aphorism, (Section 2.2.2): the multiverse does not contain the room; the room contains the multiverse. The alternatives are not elsewhere. They are co-present contents of the present block, partitioned by interior algebraic structure rather than by space. Stated for connections, the same inversion replaces the

classical causal chain: a coupling between a past event and a future one holds only relative to Aethae containing the wiring, never absolutely, and the sole correlational structure indifferent to proper-time ordering is the reduced form coupling. These are two sides of one coin. Once the alternatives are co-present and exclusivity is informational, influence must be informational too—a reader who grants the aphorism has already granted the causality replacement.

Stated at its deepest: attachment. Stated at its deepest, the inversion is an inversion of *attachment*. The classical picture fixes the describer to a determinate world, partial information states existing only derivatively—constructed by removing information from that base, and category-shifted in the construction into "mere epistemology." Aethic reasoning inverts the attachment rather than the labels: one is ontologically attached to a partial information state—an Aethus—all along, and the determinate "bottom" is the derived object of the pair, a coerced evaluation point rather than a residence, (Section 12.1.3). And the inversion has a familiar logical shape: a property an age takes as one-place discovered to be two-place, indexed to a frame—the shape by which motion and simultaneity were each, in their turns, relativized. Here the property is determinacy.

The inversion under load. The remainder of the paper is this inversion under load. Collapse becomes an Aethus-valued transit rather than a spacetime foliation, which is how *Requirement 5* is met, (Section 2.5). The unlearned past stands as open as the unformed future. The quantum–classical boundary relocates from scale to informational accessibility, which is the content of the powerset invalidation theorem, (Theorem 14). And probability becomes structural weight on the Aethic tree rather than an interpretive overlay, (Section 4), with Bayesian updating itself emerging as a pruning effect: in the Monty Hall derivation of Section 11.1, the familiar two-thirds is not imposed by a conditioning formula but is the residue of joint configurations crossed out as Aethic contradictions, their weights flowing to the survivors—the same validity-preserving operation that, under Feynman weighting, presents as entanglement. The reader who keeps the single inversion in view will find that nothing later is a new idea; it is the first idea, met again in a new costume. The further reframes the inversion carries implicitly—its modal semantics, its locality bilayer, its boundary-value formulation, its identity theory, and its constraint ontology—are made explicit—together with the rest of the eighteen moves—and situated against their standard-literature coordinates in Section 12.4.

1.6 The Eighteen Moves in One

The single inversion of Section 1.5 unpacks, on our count, into eighteen distinguishable moves. They are enumerated here in one place because the framework is genuinely difficult to explain move-by-move—each move presupposes the others—and because a skeptic deserves to see the full set at a glance before any one member of it is argued. Each of the eighteen is then walked against its standard-literature coordinates in Section 12.4, with the five most implicit receiving the fullest treatment.

1. **The inversion itself.** Reality-attributions are indexed to an Aethus, not to spacetime: classically, a fact located in spacetime is determinate *simpliciter*, while Aethically, determinacy is a two-place relation between attribute and Aethus, (Section 1.5).

2. **Relativity untouched.** The block universe survives intact; what changes under collapse is *which block is yours*, and information is what fixes it. The framework arrives at block universes by a route entirely independent of the relativity of simultaneity, (Section 2.2.1), so the convergence with the relativistic argument is confirmation rather than premise.

3. **Plurality without duplication.** The alternatives are not elsewhere, as in many-worlds; they are co-present contents of the one block, partitioned informationally—"the room contains the multiverse," (Section 2.2.2).

4. **Exclusivity as interior structure.** Mutual exclusion is algebraic structure inside the block—the union principle's physical AND—rather than spatial or branch separation. Classical either/or is thereby the *manufactured* case, produced where the third postulate forces interior negations into place, while co-present interaction—interference—is the unpruned default, (Section 2.4.3).

5. **Collapse as transit.** Collapse stops being an event within spacetime and becomes transit along the Aethic chain; the pre/post dividing line is Aethus-valued, never a foliation—which is precisely the shape of the resolution offered for *Requirement 5*, (Section 2.5). This move carries the whole preferred-foliation resolution as its package: with no privileged slicing for collapse to synchronize against, quantum "nonlocality" emerges as an effect rather than a mechanism, (the bilayer of

move eleven below), and observer consistency holds globally, as if baked into the Aethus-indexed block universe itself rather than enforced across it, (Section 12.3).

6. **Time-symmetric unknownness.** The unlearned past is as open, Aethically, as the unformed future. Because disagreeing superpositions are Aethus-indexed, an update can shift circumstances arbitrarily deep in the proper-time past—the sinkhole's entire erosion history in one stroke—which renders Wheeler's cosmological delayed-choice intuition [10] ontologically routine, (Section 9.1).

7. **Causality relativized, the triad demoted.** The causal chain loses absolute transferability—any coupling between past and future holds only relative to the Aethae containing it, flank attributes independently superposed, (Section 9.6)—and the classical triad of signal, common cause, and retrocause demotes to narration over the constraint layer: direction is a mined, convention-filtered reading of directionless joint-invalidity content, (Section 5.2.2), with the correlation–causation distinction resolved on that ground, (Section 9.9).

8. **One correlational absolute.** The only ordering-indifferent absolute is the reduced form coupling—which is why delayed choice [10], EPR [11], and the Monty Hall analysis, (Section 11.1), are one mechanism under different weightings.

9. **The boundary relocated.** The quantum-classical boundary moves from scale to information accessibility—the content of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14).

10. **Probability as structure.** Probability becomes structural weight on the Aethic tree, (Section 4), rather than an epistemic overlay upon determinate fact.

11. **The locality bilayer.** Information transfer is local while validity coupling is global and ordering-indifferent; quantum "nonlocality" is the shadow cast when the second layer is mistaken for the first, (Section 12.4.11).

12. **The modal collapse.** The category of the merely-possible is eliminated; counterfactuals are evaluated intra-block by attribute perturbation, replacing similarity orderings between worlds with the books' own dependency structure, validity, and weight—what a reopening holds fixed being itself a declared scope convention rather than a hidden metric, (Sections 12.4.12, 9.1, and 9.3.5).

13. **Boundaries instead of initial conditions.** The initial-value formulation of physics gives way to a boundary-value formulation whose boundaries are informational fixities rather than temporal endpoints, (Section 12.4.13).

14. **Genealogical identity.** Sameness across block universes is fixed by inheritance position in the Aethic tree, not by qualitative similarity or material continuity, (Section 12.4.14).

15. **The Residue Principle.** Physical law generates nothing; it eliminates, and what exists is what survives the pruning, (Section 12.4.15).

16. **One law, one primitive.** The second postulate operates as a single law over the single primitive of *Aethic superposition*, covering attribute-level agreeing superposition[7]s directly and Aethus-level superpositions as the special case in which the attribute is the state-decomposable specification of which Aethus is actual.

17. **The grammar diagnosed.** Human modal language is a conceptual piecewise function—genuinely Aethus-valued on its counterfactual segment, governed on its categorical segment by a dropping convention that coerces each speaker to the terminal proper child of their own progression—so the five modal universals re-derive as the convention's theorems, the similarity ordering stands identified as the splice's artifact, and the resistance this framework meets becomes predicted rather than counter-evidential, the diagnosis filed as defense and never as evidence, (Section 12.1.3).

[7] A fact about agreeing superpositions worth flagging at their first appearance, stated in full where the disagreeing principle is given (25): two agreeing superpositions over the same alternatives with *distinct on-sets* contradict outright — the one with the smaller set of on-values implies "off" precisely where the larger requires "on" — while two assignments with the same on-set differing only in phase are not distinct in this sense and contradict nothing, and assignments made at different Aethae are not jointly stated at one Aethus without a rule licensing the import; so assignments with distinct on-sets can never be jointly indexed by interacting observers. The premise carries the framework's response to the nested-observer protocols later in the paper.

18. **Perception's coercion.** The same dropping runs beneath awareness: the psychaethus—developed in a dedicated paper in preparation, and noted here only as far as this paper consumes it—models the delivery of the terminal point as hazard-gated machinery operating correctly over the books it has—confabulation as its signature, hyperbolic discounting as its fingerprint, and liveness rather than existence as what the gate tracks, (Section 12.1.4).

Held together, these are not eighteen ideas; they are one idea read at eighteen sites, and the reader who loses footing later in the paper is encouraged to return here and ask which of the eighteen the difficulty actually touches.

(The count is itself a dated artifact, kept deliberately legible: the first sixteen moves were enumerated in the collaboration's opening phase, June–July 2026, and the seventeenth and eighteenth sites—the grammar of the species, and the machinery of its perception—opened in August 2026. The internal labels retain the original number as provenance.)

Without further ado, then, let us begin the Aethic argument for the solution to the measurement problem.

1.7 How to Read This Paper: the Roadmap, and the Ways In

This paper has one destination and many entrances, and it is built that way on purpose. The framework's core—the postulates, the invalidity primitive, the pruning, the weights—is stated at full strength wherever it appears, and nothing below softens it. But readers arrive from very different directions, and each direction deserves a way in that meets it: a pedagogical trajectory that eases the reader into deep water rather than demanding they begin there. Several such trajectories are already threaded through the paper, and it is worth naming them as what they are, so that no reader mistakes an on-ramp for the road. Five such entrances are built out in full below, one subsubsection each—for the reader from physics, from the philosophy of modality, from logic, from mathematics, and from machine learning or cognitive science—each a short, self-contained rebuild of the framework's main through-line in that field's own vocabulary, starting from that field's own standing discomfort and ending at the one shared destination, with addresses into the paper for the continuation. One caution accompanies the welcome: the on-ramps are pedagogy, and the destination is not negotiable from them. Wherever an entry picture simplifies what the formalism does in full, the paper says so at the site, so no reader need fear having learned a cartoon.

1.7.1 The Dependency Graph of Aethic Reframes

The corrections that Aethic reasoning makes to classical metaphysics are not independent of one another: each is deductively downstream of those before it, and that sequential character is what separates the framework from an unconstrained collection of proposals. Figure 1 draws the dependency graph. Its boxes are numbered, its three columns are the formalism, the ontological spine, and the counterfactual semantics, its dashed row is the realizations, and every edge is a derivation this paper performs. Read it column by column, the center first; the walk that follows the figure introduces each box by its number, and the removal test stated just after the figure is what certifies the graph as a dependency order rather than a circle.

The removal test. The uncontested spine can be stated from the derivational record already in this paper, (the central-faculty illustration of Section 12.6.5 and the trek of Section 12.6.6): the extrusion principle comes first; probing the source of quantum superpositions under it, (the soccer-field experiment), yields invalid Aethae and agreeing superpositions; these deliver the Union Principle; the Union Principle delivers the third postulate; and the third postulate's pruning delivers the reduced form, upon which the Quantum Nexus assigns its weights and the axiomatization is stated. The non-circularity claim is exhibited by removal. Remove the Union Principle, and agreeing superpositions revert from prediction to accident: the third postulate loses the structure its invalidation criterion quantifies over, the reduced form residue collapses to the classical case, and the Nexus has nothing distinctively quantum to weight—the downstream results are not merely weakened but unreachable. Remove the extrusion principle instead, and there are no disagreeing superpositions for the Union Principle to extend in the first place; the entire chain evaporates at its root. Each removal severs everything downstream while leaving everything upstream intact, which is exactly the signature of a genuine dependency order rather than a circle, and the drawn topology is what the test applies to.

The coupled root, and the columns. The second postulate and the extrusion principle sit *jointly at the root*, two sides of one coin: the extrusion principle supplies the modal inversion and the permanence,

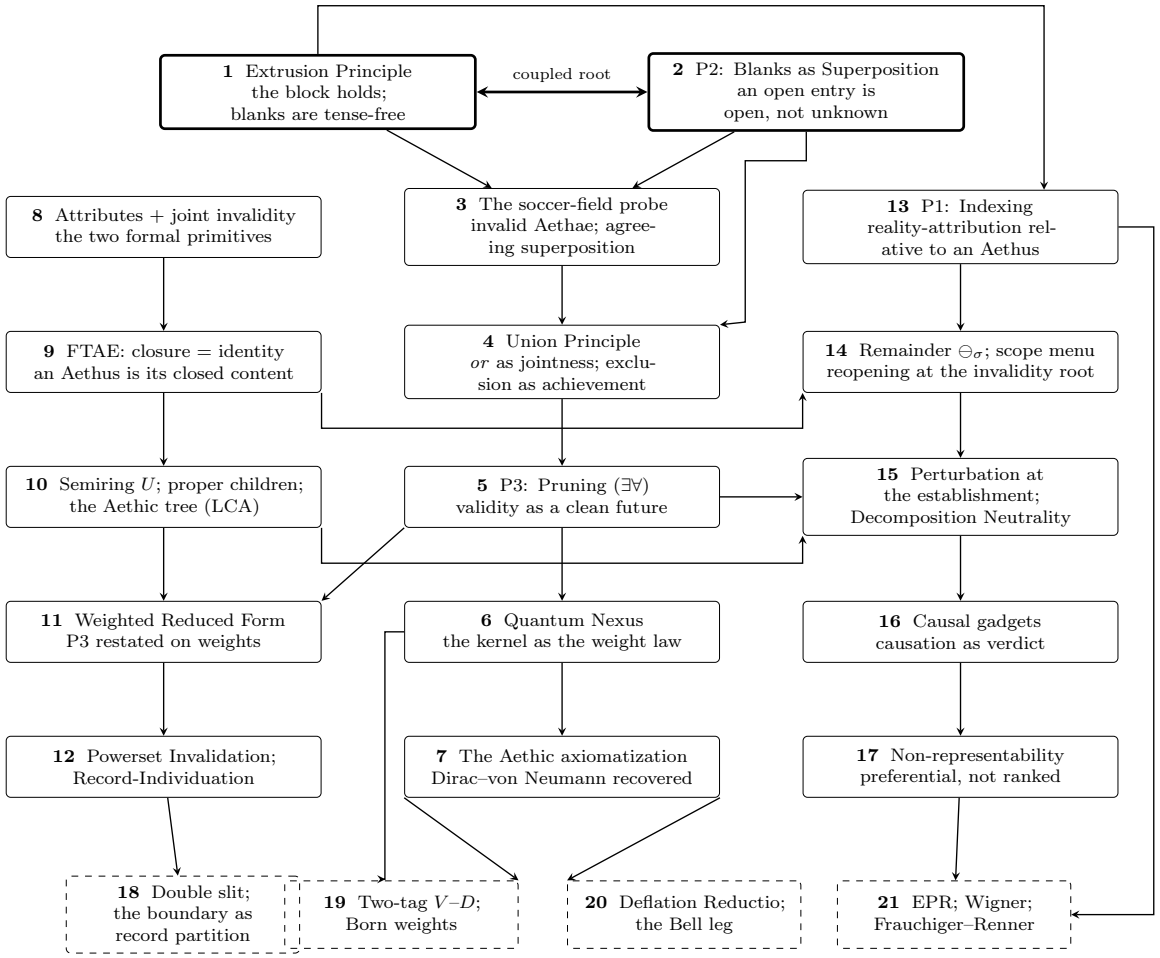


Figure 1: The dependency graph of Aethic reframes, numbered for the walk that follows. Rows descend by derivational depth; the three columns are the formalism (left), the ontological spine (center), and the counterfactual semantics (right); the dashed row is the realizations. Every solid box is a result or a posit stated in this paper, every edge is a derivation the text performs, and the removal test of the accompanying prose holds throughout: delete a box and exactly its descendants fall. The coupled root is the paper's own account of its two most primitive commitments as one; P1 hangs from the extrusion principle as its indexing face.

the second postulate codifies what blanks retrieve as under it, and the Deflation Reductio, (Theorem 4), is where the pairing is made exact. The second postulate then *feeds* the Union Principle, since proposing agreeing superpositions requires first possessing what blanks retrieve as in a block universe, which is the overlay the union construction invokes, (Section 12.6.6); the first postulate hangs from the extrusion principle as its indexing face and runs down every column at once. The *center* column is the ontological spine just described, descending to the Nexus and the axiomatization. The *left* column is the formalism's own spine: the two primitives of the invalidity-root rebuild, (Section 9.1.1), the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence—closure as identity—the unweighted commutative semiring and the Aethic tree, whose last-common-ancestor quotient is the bridge into the weighted space and the Weighted-Aethus Reduced Form, (Section 6.7), where the third postulate reappears as a structural fact, and at the bottom the Powerset Invalidation Theorem with the individuation lemma it rests on. The *right* column is the counterfactual semantics: the theorem-forced remainder and the scope menu at the invalidity root, (Section 9.1.2), the perturbation run at the establishment with Decomposition Neutrality fixing its conjunctive reading, causal gadgets delivering causation as a verdict, and the non-representability result as the column's own landing. The dashed row collects what the columns jointly reach in physics.

The roadmap, box by box. The figure compresses an entire framework[8], so each box gets a real introduction here—not a definition to memorize, but enough of the idea, met through your own experience, that the box means something before its section is ever opened. That last phrase is not a courtesy: this framework's subject matter is the observer's information state, which means *you already own an example of everything it studies*—yours—and the honest way to teach it is to keep returning there. The walk follows the figure's own organization: the center spine first, top to bottom; then the left column; then the right; then the dashed row. Two proper nouns appear immediately and then everywhere, so let them be introduced at the door: an *Aethus* (plural *Aethae*) is the framework's name for an observer-indexed information state—everything relative-to-you, taken as one object; you are carrying one right now—and the *centric unfolding* is its name for the way an Aethus develops as information is gained: each thing you have ever learned was one definite step of yours along it. The words are used throughout below exactly because they are used throughout the figure.

The center spine: the ontology, top to bottom.

1. Extrusion Principle. Picture the difference between watching a film and holding the reel. On the screen, moments arrive and vanish; in the reel, every frame simply exists, side by side. The extrusion principle takes the reel as what reality is—a standing four-dimensional block—and then asks what "the passage of time" could mean for something that does not flow. Its answer concerns you directly: what moves is the observer, and the movement is *gaining information*. Recall the last time you learned the result of something that had already happened—an election called overnight, a match played while you slept. Nothing in the world changed at the moment you looked; what changed was your Aethus, which extruded into one of the alternatives the block had housed all along, the way a hand slides deeper into a glove that was always fully there. This stepwise deepening of your Aethus *is* the centric unfolding, the dynamical face of the framework, met here at the root and consulted by boxes far downstream—and the pseudo-question "what happens to the outcomes that don't occur?" dissolves at the same stroke, because nothing was ever scheduled to occur or fail to occur relative to no one: the unchosen alternatives are standing furniture in the block, layers of the room you are in, and you extruded past them.

2. P2: Blanks-as-Superposition. There is a room behind you right now whose contents you are not looking at, a message on your phone you have not opened, a coin somewhere mid-toss. The everyday reading says each of these is *definite but unknown to you*—the world has settled it; you merely lack the memo. The second postulate rejects the everyday reading at its root: an attribute your Aethus carries no stated value for is not unknown-but-definite; it is genuinely in superposition, *relative to that Aethus*—and the unopened message, the unobserved electron, and the unchecked room are one kind of thing, differing in degree and never in kind. Sit with how strange that is meant to sound, because the strangeness is the price of a border every interpretation of quantum mechanics has failed to draw: where does "mere ignorance" end and "real superposition" begin? What size, what mass, what complexity flips a system from one regime to the other? No experiment has ever located the line, and this framework's answer is that there was never a line to find—the refusal is a load-bearing wall, and the double-slit sections later stand on it. The figure's *coupled root* records that this postulate and the extrusion principle arrive together, two sides of one coin: the block supplies the standing alternatives, and the blank says what your not-yet-knowing retrieves as within it.

3. The soccer-field probe. How do you discover a law? Sometimes by trying to build the forbidden thing yourself and watching where it breaks, and the probe is exactly that exercise, and you can run it in your head. Quantum mechanics offers a structure stranger than mere alternatives: the double-slit particle behaves as though its paths are co-present *without excluding one another*—what the framework names an *agreeing superposition*, in contrast to the *disagreeing* kind, where alternatives are exclusive branches like the coin's two faces, one of which is simply yours-to-discover. Now try to install the agreeing kind at everyday scale: a soccer ball genuinely taking both halves of the field at once, agreeing with itself, no exclusion anywhere. Follow the attempt honestly—what would the grass show? what would a fan see? what would the replay hold?—and it breaks in a specific, instructive way: there are co-presences that cannot be consistently completed, no matter how the details are filled in. That failure is the framework's first sighting of *invalid Aethae*, and the manner of the meeting matters: invalidity enters as a *discovery* made in the wreckage of a thought experiment you can perform yourself, not as a stipulation handed down—and it will turn out to be the machinery that runs everything.

[8] *Note from July 8, 2026*: I'm having Claude Fable write this dependency intro (since it's been profoundly good at translating my personal prose and written formalism to human-communicable phrasing, dependency-highlighted and high-tier field-commentary and all), and yeah it's kind of surreal that I'm having to coach it about within-Aethic paradigm blindness lol. Just my life!

4. The Union Principle. The formal architecture for exactly the agreeing superposition the probe just uncovered—the answer to "how do you build two-places-at-once without contradiction?" Notice first what fails. *Or* fails: saying the sign is on the left *or* the right is disagreeing-superposition talk, exclusive branches with your ignorance on top, and it captures nothing of the agreeing structure. A bare *and* fails harder: left-and-right is flat contradiction. The union principle threads the needle with a construction: the alternatives are made co-present, and each is packaged together with the *explicit negation of all the others*—so that exclusivity lives *inside* the co-presence rather than between separated worlds. Both layers exist; each layer holds the others, from its own vantage, false; and no vantage exists from which two layers are jointly affirmed. If you want to feel the structure rather than parse it: hold two incompatible futures for yourself in mind at once—the job taken, the job declined—each complete with its own conviction that the other did not happen. You are not contradicting yourself, and you are not merely listing options; you are running a small union. This is the structure the phrase "agreeing superposition" was waiting for, and it is precisely what the pruning postulate, next box, interrogates.

5. P3: Pruning (∃∀). The framework's engine of definiteness, and the source of everything downstream that looks quantum—best met through something you already do. When you plan, some options die softly, (unlikely, expensive), and some die absolutely: the itinerary that requires being in two cities on the same morning does not become a long-shot, it becomes *nothing*—not a plan you probably won't execute but a non-plan, the way an illegal chess position is not a rare position but a non-position. The third postulate is that distinction, made load-bearing and given exact shape: an alternative earns its standing only if it can be consistently *refined*, and the requirement reaches two generations deep—there must exist some proper child Aethus, some way of filling the alternative in further, such that *every* continuation from there remains valid. One existential, then one universal: ∃∀. Fail it, and the alternative is an *invalid Aethus*: struck with no residue, no small probability lingering as a consolation. Hold onto how modest this sounds, because the payoff is anything but—interference patterns, their death the moment a detector runs, and their resurrection when the record is erased will all turn out to be this one quantifier doing its work on the union structure above, with you, the record-holder, indexed into every verdict.

6. The Quantum Nexus. The center spine's destination, and the place where the framework stops being qualitative. What survives the pruning is a residue of valid Aethae, delivered—by the left column's machinery—in its canonical form, the *reduced form*; and the Quantum Nexus is the assignment of quantitative weights to exactly that surviving residue, weights whose behavior, followed through the framework's collection machinery, recovers the Born statistics that every quantum experiment reports. The figure's edge from the Weighted Reduced Form box into this one is therefore not decoration: the reduced form is the very object the weights are assigned over. And the philosophical cargo concerns you again. You already grade your own alternatives—you hold the unopened message likelier to be from one sender than another—and the everyday reading calls those gradations features of your psychology laid over a settled world. Here the reading inverts: the weights belong to the branching structure of the Aethus itself, ontology's own bookkeeping rather than your head's, which is precisely why the framework can *derive* how they must behave instead of postulating an interpretation for them. The probability was never in you; you were in it.

7. The Aethic axiomatization. The center spine's last box, and the one that says what the spine amounts to: the three postulates, the Union Principle, and the Nexus form an axiom set for quantum mechanics, and the Dirac–von Neumann formalism is recovered from it axiom by axiom—the observables axiom and the projection postulate as theorems of the postulates given the kernel, the state space, superposition, and unitary evolution as the kernel axiom's own content, composites following from that representation and the product structure of composite setups, and the seventh, the Born rule, absorbed into the one weight law—the state space and the Born map being two posits there and one here, the amplitudes recovered by polarization and never held, (Section 14.3). Read it as the destination of everything above it in the column: what the pruning and the weights are *for*.

The left column: the formalism, from primitives to the reduced form.

8. Attributes + joint invalidity. Strip the framework to what it truly assumes, and only two things remain—and both are things you use before breakfast. First, *attributes*: questions the world can answer, each with its menu of possible answers. Is the light red or green; is the sign on the left or the right; is the message read or unread. Your entire picture of your situation is woven from these. Second, a single relation—*joint invalidity*—recording which *combinations* of stated answers cannot stand together, the way certain puzzle pieces refuse to join however they are turned: proceeding-while-the-light-is-absent-of-green, being-in-two-cities-at-nine. That is genuinely all. No causation is assumed, no probability, no arrow of time, no "closeness" between possibilities—every one of those

familiar notions will be *derived*, arriving later as outputs of this spare structure rather than dials on it. The austerity is the point: a framework that promises to explain causation and probability cannot afford to assume them, and this one starts from little enough to keep the promise. This box is what the figure elsewhere calls the *invalidity root*: the base relation the whole edifice—very much including the right column's counterfactual machinery—anchors to.

9. FTAE: closure = identity. A gentle puzzle about yourself: you have never been told that your grandmother was born before your mother, yet you *know* it—it follows from things you were told. Does your information state contain that fact? The Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence answers *yes, constitutively*: an Aethus is identified with everything derivable from its stated content, so writing a consequence down adds nothing and erasing it removes nothing—it is the same Aethus either way, because you are what you can derive. This sounds like housekeeping until the day you need to *remove* something, and then it becomes a theorem with teeth. Try, as an exercise, to un-know that grandmother fact while keeping everything else: you cannot, because the birth-years you retain quietly rewrite it. Erasing the line fails; whatever derives it restores it. Genuine removal must therefore clear enough of the *support* to leave the attribute truly blank—and that forced structure, discovered here as a fact about identity, is exactly what the right column's remainder operator will run on when counterfactual reasoning demands honest un-knowing.

10. Commutative semiring U; proper children; the Aethic tree. Before weights can mean anything, the bare skeleton of Aethae must behave like honest algebra—this box is the certification. Collect the unweighted Aethae and close the collection under parents, so that every state's less-specific ancestors are present alongside it; then observe that the framework's two combining operations give the collection the structure mathematicians call a *commutative semiring*: Aethic union plays addition, Aethic intersection plays multiplication, and the familiar example of the species is the integers with addition and multiplication but no subtraction. The order that matters throughout is *refinement*: a proper child Aethus is its parent plus more specificity—your Aethus after reading the message is a proper child of your Aethus before. Nothing exotic happens here, and that is its virtue: the box certifies the objects algebraically well-behaved, so that when the next boxes hang measures on them, the arithmetic underneath can be trusted.

10, continued. The Aethic tree; LCA factoring. Now the subtle step, best met through inheritance. You and your sibling share a childhood, and the family tree *exhibits* it: the shared years sit at your last common ancestor, written once, with each of you carrying only what refines beyond them. The Aethic tree is the family tree of Aethae—its branching structure is the refinement order of the commutative semiring above, parents splitting into ever more specific children—and when two weighted Aethae are summed, the same exhibition is available by *basic factoring*: the shared information is the last common ancestor, and it extracts once as a common factor, an identity of the multiplication rather than a rule imposed on the sum. (An earlier gloss here called this the prevention of double-counting; that gloss is retired—nothing is prevented, and the sum is what it always was, merely written with its inheritance shown.) The quotient proper is smaller: repeated weightings of one and the same Aethus combine additively, and zero-weight terms delete. Those two clauses are what make weighted sums carry measures coherently; the factoring is what makes them carry the *tree*. And it is why the paper can compress the whole design into one line—*dependency is what the quotient quotients by*: the Aethic tree is not an illustration but the bookkeeping the weighted algebra runs on, the ledger of who inherited what from whom. Keep the tree in view; the right column is about to use it as something else entirely—an address book.

11. The Weighted Reduced Form (P3 restated). Every algebra worth its salt has a normal form—a canonical way of writing its elements, like fractions in lowest terms—and every person does too: asked what you think will happen tomorrow, you do not recite your life; you give the tidy resolution, your live alternatives with their standings. The reduced form is that resolution made formal: a valid weighted Aethus resolves into a canonical combination over its proper children. Then the striking part, the kind of convergence a framework cannot arrange for itself: an element *without* a reduced form turns out to be exactly an *invalid* one. That is the third postulate all over again—the ontology's deepest axiom re-emerging, unbidden, as the algebra's normal-form theorem, one claim wearing two vocabularies. Finding an axiom waiting at the bottom of a construction is the consistency check money cannot buy. And this box's edge into the Quantum Nexus is the handoff already described there: the reduced form is the residue the weights are assigned over—the tidy resolution is what gets graded.

12. The Powerset Invalidation Theorem, and the Record-Individuation Lemma. The formalism column's own realization: run the reduced form over the powerset of a set of alternatives under a detector configuration and every candidate coherent subset lands in exactly one of three bins, the

quantum–classical boundary arriving as a discrete fact about which records the configuration can produce, (Theorem 14). The lemma beside it is what the theorem's individuation rests on—two alternatives no record can distinguish are not two alternatives of any attribute—derived from the first postulate and the record discipline, (Lemma 7).

The right column: the counterfactual semantics, anchored at the invalidity root.

13. P1: Indexing. The indexing face of the extrusion principle, and the one commitment that runs down every column at once: every reality-attribution is of the form "q takes value v *relative to an Aethus*"—there is no Aethus-free ledger of content, though the structure over vantages, the validity functional and the rule from configurations to records, is not itself a vantage. Its edge into the semantics is that every evaluation is an evaluation *relative to* the evaluator's own Aethus; its edge into the realizations is that collapse is an indexing transition, which is what the nested-observer cases turn on.

14. The remainder $\ominus_\sigma$ (FTAE-forced), and composite at every application: an elementary removal to the blank intermediate, then selection — the reopening subsubsection's canon carries the algebra. Counterfactual reasoning begins with a strange demand you have felt: *un-know* something, properly. A friend lets slip the ending of a film; "forget I said that," they laugh, and you both know you cannot—not because your memory is stubborn, but for the structural reason the FTAE box uncovered: the ending now colors what you infer from every scene, and erasing the one sentence leaves all its offspring in place, ready to rewrite it. The remainder operator is honest un-knowing, the only kind a deductively closed being admits: pass to the *largest* deductively closed Aethus in which the target attribute stands genuinely blank—keep the absolute maximum of yourself consistent with truly not knowing that one thing. Half of this operation is therefore a theorem rather than a choice, forced by the identity result of the left column; the only freedom remaining is *how much travels with* the removed attribute—must what you inferred from the ending go too?—and that freedom is given a name, the scope σ, and its own box, next.

14b. The scope menu at the invalidity root. Stay with the spoiled film. Un-knowing the ending is settled by the previous box, but a genuine question remains: you also *noticed things because of it*—the early scene you re-read as foreshadowing, the character you distrusted from her first line. Should the un-knowing take those too? Reasonable evaluations genuinely differ, and the framework, rather than legislating, declares the choice as its one conventional parameter, with three named settings: clear only what *deductively* rests on the attribute, keeping whatever has independent support; clear also its recorded causal *posterity*, the things it brought about, (the default setting); or clear every generic wired to it on both sides, direction-blind, reaching the backtracking readings. And here is where the figure's phrase "at the invalidity root" cashes out, and where the framework's austerity pays its dividend: "causal" in these setting-names refers to entries recorded in the Aethus's own books, and those entries bottom out in the left column's base relation—patterns of joint invalidity, nothing more. The settings select among recorded invalidity-substructures; no causal order is consulted beyond what the books themselves carry; and so the menu recovers the familiar causal modes of counterfactual talk as *outputs*, without causation ever having been an input.

15. The Aethic perturbation at the establishment (tree as addresses). The full counterfactual evaluation, assembled: reopen the attribute, (the remainder), restate it to the supposed value, and let the third postulate's pruning re-run—then read the surviving residue. The refinement this box adds concerns *where* the reopening lands, and it deserves the slow telling, through you. Pick a determinate state you carry—say, that your street floods in heavy rain. You were not born knowing it; there was an afternoon, years ago, when a neighbor mentioned it over the fence while the gutters ran. That afternoon, in this framework's exact sense, was an *Aethic intersection along your centric unfolding*: a rich, particular Aethus—the neighbor's voice, the smell of rain, a hundred incidental details—that intersected with the Aethus you were, and sparked the next Aethus you became, the flooding-fact now stated in your books. Every determinate state you carry has such an establishing moment, and the Aethic tree of the left column is precisely the address book in which those moments are located. Now the subtlety your own case makes vivid: to perturb "the street floods," the operation wants *that establishment*—but the afternoon itself is a jumble, and the framework proves, (for empirical Aethae, which you are), that no agent can reconstruct such an Aethus in full. So the discipline: reach into the jumble with a *parent* Aethus—a less-specific ancestor at the same address, carrying just enough structure to pick the flooding-fact out from the incidental hundred—and let that parent serve as the working handle. The perturbation then runs *at the establishment*: one entry touched, everything independently supported left standing, surgical where it should be surgical—and never once consulting a causal order to aim, because the address came from the unfolding's own record. The box also carries

Decomposition Neutrality, (Section 3.3.1): a composite attribute's answer space is the product of its parts', never a coarsening, which, on the dual-peg reading of a conjunctive antecedent—each conjunct's peg a separate argument of the reopening, the framework's reading of "and"—fixes that reopening and closes the countermodel of box 17.

16. Causal gadgets: causation as verdict. You have a driving habit that feels like obedience to a law of nature: not green, don't proceed. Ask where that law lives, and the everyday answer points at the world—the light *causes* your stopping. This framework's answer is more austere and, once seen, more satisfying: at the bottom there is exactly one fact, and it is directionless—the *joint invalidity* of green-absent-and-proceeding, one of the puzzle-piece refusals from the left column's base. The direction you feel in "not green implies not proceed" is supplied by where you stand: from your ordinary Aethus, mid-drive, that is the natural reading; but from a suitably backtracked Aethus—one reasoning from the proceeding toward its conditions—the very same invalidity reads as "proceed implies green," and neither reading is more real, because the invalidity alone is what exists. Causal talk is thereby *mined* from the invalidity root as a verdict, direction and all, rather than fed to the framework as a parameter—the final cash-out of its austerity about primitives, and the reason the scope menu two boxes back could recover causal modes without assuming causation.

17. Non-representability: preferential, not ranked. Where the semantics column lands: the would-clause's consequence relation, run on the derived conjunctive reading, violates Cautious Monotony by a four-attribute countermodel and is therefore not preferential, hence not representable by Lewis's or Stalnaker's semantics or any smooth similarity ordering—the deletion of the *world-similarity* ordering exhibited as a theorem rather than a preference, (Section 9.4.2), with the full graded verdict function's representability posed as the open challenge. The deletion should be read at its exact strength, since the objection it invites is the sharpest one the semantics faces: the reopening is computed under declared priorities—laws over particulars, and the rest of the priority structure—and a priority relation over supports is a selection device, so a critic may say the ordering has not been deleted but moved, from worlds to supports. The answer is that the relocation is the result, and is substantive exactly insofar as the internal priority relation is independently motivated, uniform across cases, and not tuned to each counterfactual as a similarity ordering is calibrated to each context; the priorities used are the same at every case in the battery and are fixed by the state's dependency structure rather than by the antecedent, and their derivation from the closure structure is the open problem the semantics column names. Until it closes, what stands is that an explicit ordering over worlds is unnecessary and its functions are carried by relations internal to the state, the priority relation among them.

18–21. The dashed row: the realizations. Where it all lands—for you and for the laboratory. The double-slit and Powerset results: the interference pattern's appearance, its death the moment a detector runs, and its resurrection when the record is genuinely erased, *derived* from the pruning of union structure rather than postulated—the experiment that has haunted physics for a century, retold as validity bookkeeping. The Born weights and the collection axiom: the quantitative face, the probabilities of every quantum experiment assigned over the reduced form's residue, ontology grading its own alternatives. The EPR, Wigner, and Frauchiger–Renner verdicts: the nested-observer paradoxes taken apart one by one—most dissolving into indexing errors between Aethae, questions asked of no one's information state in particular, and one, Frauchiger–Renner, exposed as an invalid Aethus from its very first line. And the classification theorem: the counterfactual logic you have just walked through, proved to sit outside the preferential class of a known watershed in formal logic—Cautious Monotony failing by explicit countermodel on the conjunctive reading Decomposition Neutrality derives, (Section 3.3.1)—and therefore strictly beyond what Lewis's or Stalnaker's semantics, or any smooth similarity ordering over possible worlds, can represent at the consequence-relation level—the framework's irreducibility, made formal.

1.7.2 The Ways In, at a Glance

Five readers arrive from five directions, and each brings a standing discomfort the framework is built to address. The table gives the move and the result for each in one line; the briefings that follow give each its argument.

Reader	Standing discomfort	The framework's move	Result to take away	Continue at
physics	the cut is placed by convenience; every interpretation pays for definiteness somewhere	superposition is the standing of an attribute relative to an information state; validity is a consistency constraint over refinement, not a mechanism	no cut; collapse as pruning; Born weights from the collection axiom; the Dirac–von Neumann formalism recovered	§1.7.3; §14.3
modality	the similarity ordering is a primitive nobody can justify	delete the ordering; evaluate at partial information states by reopen, restate, re-prune	non-representability: Cautious Monotony fails, so no ordering represents the relation	§1.7.4; §9.1
logic	what are the primitives, and what is consequence	two primitives, attributes and joint invalidity; validity as an $\exists\forall$ greatest fixed point	a coinductive central predicate; a consequence relation outside the preferential class	§1.7.5; §9.1.1
mathematics	what is the object, exactly	a commutative semiring, a tree, an LCA quotient, and a normal form	the third postulate as "elements without a reduced form are the invalid ones"	§1.7.6; §6.7
ML and cognition	names behave like embeddings, not like compositions	the Fundamental Theorem of Empirical Aethae: full states are unconstructible; attributes are collages	ontological robustness; reasoning over the ideal of an establishing point	§1.7.7; Theorem 8

1.7.3 The Way In from Physics

Start from the discomfort you already have. Quantum mechanics gives you a unitary evolution that never selects an outcome and a measurement postulate that selects one by fiat, and it refuses to tell you where the one hands off to the other: the Heisenberg cut is placed by convenience, the "observer" is undefined, and every interpretation on the market buys definiteness by paying somewhere you can feel it—hidden variables and a preferred frame, uncountable worlds with probability left unexplained, or a collapse mechanism nobody has found. This framework's opening move is to change what the quantum state is *about*. A superposition is not a property a system has absolutely; it is the standing of an attribute *relative to an information state*—and the radical part is that the converse holds too: any attribute of which an observer's records carry no value *is* in superposition relative to that observer, whether the system is an electron or a cat or the far side of a closed door. Uncertainty and superposition stop being two phenomena.

What then does the selecting? Not a mechanism and not a mind: a *consistency constraint*. Take the four-dimensional block as the standing object, house the alternatives inside it as co-present layers, and ask which co-presences can survive refinement—which could still be consistently filled in, in every direction the future could go. Some cannot: an "agreeing" superposition whose which-way information leaks anywhere into the future admits no consistent completion, and it is *pruned*—not rendered improbable, rendered invalid. Interference dies when a detector runs because the interference-bearing structure fails this test the moment a record exists, and it fails it *relative to the indexed information states involved*, which is why erasing the record before any correlation escapes restores the fringes, and why nothing in the story ever consulted a size, a mass, or an observer. The surviving structure carries weights; the weights, followed through the framework's collection axiom, deliver the Born statistics.

What you gain, concretely: no cut, because there is nothing for a cut to separate; delayed choice without retrocausation, because the "past" being settled was never an absolute fact but an indexed one; EPR without signaling, because the correlation is a validity fact about the joint structure, not an influence; and the nested-observer paradoxes—Wigner, Frauchiger–Renner—dissolved into indexing errors or invalid setups, respectively. Continue at the double-slit treatment, (Section 7), the Fallacy of Initial Conditions, (Section 9.6), and the quantitative face, (Section 4).

1.7.4 The Way In from the Philosophy of Modality

Your standing discomfort is the similarity ordering. Lewis and Stalnaker evaluate "had A been, B would have been" at the closest A-worlds, and everything downstream inherits the arbitrariness of *closest*: the ordering is a primitive, the famous counterexamples are tuning disputes about it, and the representation theorems tell you that even premise-based rivals usually collapse back into it. This framework deletes the ordering—and, unusually, can say precisely what it puts in the place of worlds, and prove the replacement does not reduce back. The evaluation points are *information states*: indexed, deductively closed, and—the crucial difference from every worlds-based point—genuinely *partial*, with partiality that is not ignorance. A blank attribute is not an unknown value; it is a superposition with

internal structure of its own, (interaction terms between the co-present alternatives), and that interior is provably invisible to any total completion: two states can agree on every possible world compatible with them and still validate different conditionals. So the reduction to worlds-plus-ignorance is not resisted; it is refuted. Evaluation itself is an operation, not a selection: reopen the antecedent attribute—the maximal deductively closed restriction in which it stands blank, an operation *forced* by the framework's identity theorem, since deleting an entry whose derivers remain changes nothing—then restate it and let the consistency constraints re-prune. One operation; the traditional subjunctive and indicative arrive as its two uniform limits; backtracking is a declared scope setting rather than a scandal. And the payoff you can take to your colleagues: the resulting consequence relation has a provable seat in the known landscape—cautious monotony fails by an explicit four-attribute countermodel, rational monotony with it on the same instance—which places it outside the preferential class altogether, not merely on the far side of the preferential/ranked watershed, and a fortiori strictly outside anything a similarity ordering over worlds can represent at the consequence-relation level, (on the conjunctive reading derived at Section 3.3.1; the model itself at Section 9.4.2). Continue at the formal semantics, (Section 9.1), and the non-representability development, (Section 9.4).

1.7.5 The Way In from Logic

Take the framework as a deductive system and ask the questions you would ask of any: what are the primitives, what is consequence, where does it sit. The primitives are two, and deliberately spare: *pegs*, bare atoms whose disjointness is primitive, and a *relation structure* recording which finite sets of pegs and states are jointly invalid; an attribute is a set of pairwise disjoint pegs, and a state $[X : S]$ asserts that X is filled by exactly the pegs of S (Section 3.1). Nothing else inter-attribute is assumed. Derivability is closure under seven monotone rules, with propagation and elimination at its core: a set forces a determinate state when every rival peg is excluded; identity is closure, two representations presenting one Aethus iff each derives the other (Theorem 1); and an Aethus is a class of representations with one closure, invalid Aethae staying distinct and tagged, and everything unstated standing blank. Validity itself is where the system gets interesting: the third postulate is an $\exists\forall$ condition over a weighted Aethus's proper children—there must exist a proper child all of whose proper children remain valid—stated in full as the weighted-Aethus reduced form, which prunes a weighted Aethus's invalid terms and tags it invalid when nothing proper remains. It runs over weighted Aethae themselves; the validity quotient is taken afterwards, for rendering, and does not feed back into it. The conditional built on this base consults *every* surviving pocket of a perturbed state, unranked, which gives the evaluation clause a preferential shape—and here is the theorem worth the trip: the shape does not survive to the consequence relation. Cautious monotony *fails*, by an explicit four-attribute countermodel whose mechanism is that a conjunctive antecedent reopens a conjunct's ground and thereby *resurrects* pockets the plain antecedent pruned, (contraction over a conjunction opens routes the single antecedent never licensed); rational monotony fails on the same instance as a corollary; and the earlier hitting-set argument for cautious monotony, which assumed entailed conjuncts exempt from reopening, is withdrawn together with the reading it assumed. Not preferential, hence not ranked: a seat outside both classes, not a slogan—no total similarity ordering represents the system at the consequence-relation level, and the states provably are not worlds. Continue at the invalidity-root rebuild, (Section 9.1.1), the fixed-point lemma, (Section 6.7.1), and the classification, (Section 9.4.2).

1.7.6 The Way In from Mathematics

Read the framework as a construction and it is this: a commutative semiring, a tree, a quotient, and a normal form whose existence is an axiom. Begin with a generator set of "unweighted" objects and close under parents to obtain a universe U; declare addition to be the framework's union and multiplication its intersection, and U is a commutative semiring whose order-theoretic content—the parent–child relation—is the information order. The weighted space T is then formal M-linear combinations over U, for M a measure type, quotiented by an equivalence with exactly two cases: distributivity over a shared factor, and additivity of coefficients on a repeated one—where the shared factor is computed as the *last common ancestor* in the tree, its uniqueness proved through the system's closure-identity theorem. The slogan the construction earns: dependency is what the quotient quotients by—shared information is located at the shared ancestor and counted once. Childhood becomes weight-graded, (every element is a child of every other, exclusion being the case of weight measure-zero relative to the rest of the combination, so that a component of lower measure grade than its remainder is excluded without being invalidated); invalid elements are handled as an ideal-analogue adapted to the commutative semiring

setting, labels rather than realizations; and the destination is a canonical form—the reduced form—over proper children, with the system's third postulate re-emerging as the statement that *elements without a reduced form are the invalid ones.* An axiom of the ontology and a normal-form theorem of the algebra, one claim in two vocabularies; the fixed-point characterization of validity, (Knaster–Tarski over the refinement order), closes the circle. Continue at the object's construction, (Section 3), and the weighted formulation, (Section 6.7).

1.7.7 The Way In from Machine Learning and Cognitive Science

Start from what you know about representation: a name like "John's hair color" behaves, in any system that actually works, like an embedding—a compressed projection of structure far too high-dimensional to enumerate, useful exactly because it never pretends to be the structure itself. This framework arrives at the same picture from ontology, and holds it as a theorem rather than an engineering observation. The Fundamental Theorem of Empirical Aethae says a physical agent almost surely *cannot* construct the full information state of a real system—the ability to incorporate each further attribute collapses too fast—and its corollary says that most nameable attributes are not primitives at all but *collages* of more primitive effects: John's hair color is not a function of John, hair, and color; the name is a limited-projective view that *intersects* with the underlying state in the framework's evaluating-truths sense, rather than being forced through it as a primitive. Two consequences should feel familiar. First, *ontological robustness*: because the named attribute does not decompose into its apparent parts, the space of tweakings available while holding other things fixed is vastly higher-dimensional than any compositional reading would allow—the same slack that makes distributed representations trainable makes empirical attributes counterfactually manipulable. Second, a working discipline for reasoning under inaccessibility: never instantiate the unconstructible state; select the point in the unfolding where the attribute was established, and let an arbitrary *parent* of that point—its mathematical ideal—serve as the handle, in the framework's categorical-abstraction sense. Reason over the ideal; acknowledge you never gaze on the dynamics. The convergence with late Wittgenstein's picture of meaning, (family resemblance over a graph of indecomposable relationships, no objective core to a word), is developed where the corollary lives. Continue beside Theorem 8 and at the foundations of the formalism, (Section 3.1).

1.7.8 The Annotated Index of Stations

The figure gives the framework's shape and the ways in give its entrances; this index is the lookup layer — one line per station on what it contributes, organized by the paper's five parts, so that any single result can be reached without holding the whole. The PDF sidebar bookmarks carry the complete three-level structure beneath these entries.

Part I — Foundations, (§§1–2).

- **Mission statement**, (§1.1) — what would count as solving the measurement problem; the success criteria fixed in advance.
- **Requirements list**, (§1.4) — the five-requirement checklist the conclusion later audits against.
- **The dependency figure**, (§1.7.1) — the whole framework as one graph: roots, three spines, realizations.
- **The five ways in**, (§1.7.3–1.7.7) — per-discipline entrances, each rebuilding the through-line for one incoming field.
- **The extrusion principle at root**, (§2.1) — the coupled root: the reel rather than the screen; where everything begins.
- **The proper ontology of time**, (§2.2) — block universe plus indexing; the ground on which blankness goes tense-free.
- **Philosophical makeup of the Aethus**, (§2.3) — the index itself characterized: above awareness, below omniscience, mental in no clause.
- **The Aethic union principle**, (§2.4.2) — co-present alternatives housed in one block; agreeing superpositions born; elsewhere-ness ends here.
- **Requirement 5, met deliberately**, (§2.5) — the check that the ontology, not a gloss, is doing the solving.

Part II — The Formalism, (§§3–4).

- **Foundations**, (§3.1) — pegs, states and representations, every object defined in dependency order; the vocabulary's load-bearing spine.
- **Three definitions for the Aethus**, (§5.1) — one object, three equivalent faces, interchangeable by need.
- **The Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence**, (Theorem 1) — closure is identity: representations that derive each other are one Aethus.
- **The theorem, explicitly oriented**, (§8.0.3) — the same result aimed outward at practice and record saturation.
- **The formalism, consolidated**, (§4.9) — the algebra's current canonical statement, semiring through tree.
- **The reduced form**, (§6.6) — the third postulate as a normal form: pockets, residues, the engine of every later verdict.
- **Aethic weighting**, (§4) — where the framework turns quantitative; weight as structure, never as ignorance.
- **The Nexus's presentation gauge**, (§14.2.4) — the weight kernel's honest status: posited, gauged, separable.

Part III — The Physics of Measurement, (§§5–8).

- **Narrative illustrations, conventions first**, (§5.4) — the learning and travel narratives, with their Maxwell's-demon status fixed before use.
- **The soccer-field probe**, (§6.2) — build the forbidden object and watch where it breaks; the union principle induced.
- **The third postulate, stated**, (§6.4) — pruning as $\exists\forall$: contradiction anywhere invalidates everywhere.
- **The double-slit solution**, (§7) — detector-off and detector-on derived; the paper's namesake payoff.
- **The Powerset Invalidation Theorem**, (Theorem 14) — the quantum–classical boundary classified: combinatorial, discrete, movable.
- **Nested observers**, (§10.2.1) — Wigner's friend and Frauchiger–Renner run under the Sifting Principle, (Principle 26).
- **The indiscriminate time principle**, (Principle 11) — blankness owes nothing to the clock; tense-freedom in formal dress.
- **Agreeing and disagreeing, status fixed**, (§3.5.2) — the two-tier epistemics: ontology induced from nature, formalism deliberately brute.

Part IV — Modality, Causation, and Cases, (§§9–11).

- **The counterfactual semantics**, (§9.1) — perturbation replaces travel; the similarity ordering deleted, its work relocated.
- **The semantics at walking pace**, (§9.3) — the same machinery introduced before its formal grade.
- **AI-assisted proofs**, (§9.4) — the proof-provenance protocol, stated once and binding throughout.
- **Pedagogical exercises at full concreteness**, (§9.5) — three complete cases; the sinkhole's indexation headline lives here.
- **Causality notions and causal gadgets**, (§9.7; §5.2.2) — direction as a mined reading over a directionless constraint web.
- **The fallacy of initial conditions**, (§9.6) — where the classical picture smuggles its premise; the sinkhole's home ground.
- **Detectors, and scale**, (§10.5; §10.6) — what a detector is, and why scale was never the variable.

- **The Aethic Mach–Zehnder**, (§10.9) — the interferometer run natively on the books.
- **Probability and the second law**, (§11; §11.2) — Bayesianism theorem-shaped; entropy read Aethically.
- **Nonlinear time**, (§12.6.1) — the Moon-orbit rebuttal: future, live, and influenceable are three different properties.

Part V — Synthesis, Apparatus, and Horizons, (§§12–15).

- **The multiverse, updated**, (§12.1) — the inversion in its shortest form: the room contains the alternatives.
- **Eighteen moves, coordinated**, (§12.4) — every move set against its standard-literature coordinate.
- **Language's modal structure**, (§12.1.3) — the diagnosis driven to closure: the convention, the five universals re-derived, the ordering as the splice's artifact.
- **The psychaethus**, (§12.1.4, the construction itself removed to a dedicated paper in preparation) — perception's coercion modeled: the hazard-gated tilt, confabulation as signature, liveness as the tracked quantity.
- **Jenny's identity**, (§5.4.7) — personal identity under reopened blanks; the Aethic memento class beside it.
- **The genealogy as dependency graph**, (§13.12) — the discovery order itself graphed, dated, and checkable.
- **Conversational exchanges**, (§13.13) — the correspondence layer, kept as record.
- **Multi-slit to continuous paths to the sphere**, (§14.1; §14.6) — the kernel driven from n slits to the Bloch factor.
- **Opening active reasoning**, (§14; §14.7) — the next program's door, deliberately ajar.
- **Additional insights**, (§13) — the drawer of live edges: consciousness, biology, savants, Eastern parallels.
- **Conclusion**, (§15) — the requirements audit closed against the opening checklist.

2 Philosophical Prelude to the Aethus

Let us begin with a prelude section to the formalization of the Aethus, where we will lay the needed philosophical groundwork which will enable our undertaking of a further mathematical rigor.

2.1 The Extrusion Principle at Root

The idea in one sentence. Everything in this paper descends from one commitment, and it can be said before any apparatus is built: *what reality is, relative to a standpoint, is never overwritten by what it later turns out to be.* On Tuesday the raininess of Saturday stands open; Saturday arrives and it rains; and the framework's claim is that Tuesday's open state was not a gap awaiting a fact, a placeholder to be replaced when the fact came in, but a complete entry in reality *relative to Tuesday*, which Saturday's outcome does not edit, revoke, or retroactively convert into ignorance. The later state is simply one more entry, indexed to its own standpoint, no more real and no more permanent than the open one before it. The aphorism the paper will use for this is that *the multiverse does not contain the room; the room contains the multiverse*: the alternatives to what an observer knows are not elsewhere, in other worlds, but here, standing content of the one block universe the observer occupies, relative to the observer's own index.

A concrete case, before the box. Take Saturday's rain, considered on Tuesday. The commitment says there is then a *thing*—the reality state of the rain as it stands indexed to Tuesday's vantage, "the reality state of the rain, up to uniqueness, defined *here*"—and that this thing is permanent. Pre-formally it is admittedly intangible, and the commitment stays deliberately thin about its metaphysics: whether the observer's own aboutness *constitutes* the index, or the observer merely happens to occupy an index that outruns them, is left open, all that is required being that the observer stands in the right place at the right time to fix the reference. The instantiation is as ordinary as checking a forecast. Each day

before Saturday on which the check is made, what the raininess of Saturday ontologically *is*, there and then, is precisely the thing the commitment asserts permanent. Wednesday then carries its own reality state of the rain, and does not edit Tuesday's. And when Saturday's outcome arrives, determinate, it is one more such state, no more real and no more permanent than the open states before it.

The kernel, boxed. The commitment quantifies over two primitives, and the box states it bare, scoped outside-in over them.

Principle 1 (Extrusion Principle Kernel)
For each object*—each matter under consideration—and, within that object's scope, for each* abstract subject*—a referential standpoint upon it, the* here *of an evaluation—there is the kernel's entity,* the reality state*: the abstract object itself, purely, just as indexed by that standpoint. The kernel's one commitment then quantifies over the whole nest at once:* no such reality state is ever overwritten. *Later standpoints carry their own reality states, none editing an earlier one; and a determinate outcome is only the special case of a reality state that happens to be determinate.*[9]

One omission from the box is deliberate: nothing in it speaks of *information.* Talk of what the observer knows, or can access, describes the *mediation* of the aboutness to the agent—interface-side vocabulary, one level less abstract than the kernel—and it enters only when the interface does, below.

The shape this borrows, and why. The equivalence principle has a shape worth borrowing before anything else is built on the kernel. At its root it is one commitment—inertial mass equals gravitational mass, so free fall is inertial motion—and its full form is that commitment plus its implicative context: gravitational time dilation, the bending of light, geodesic motion. One insight at the root, many at the interface. The framework is organized around a principle of exactly that shape, and it is introduced the way the equivalence principle deserves to be: kernel first, boxed and bare, with the implications then unpacked branch by branch. The box above is the framework's *free fall is inertial*; the whole of what follows is packed into it.

What converts a take into a principle. Stated bare, the kernel is only a take, and it can even be read deflatedly, as a perspectival bookkeeping remark: *of course* the earlier reality state stays what it was, one might shrug, the way an old draft persists in a drawer. *Free fall is inertial* invites the very same shrug—so the falling man feels nothing; so what?—and what lifts it out of the shrug is methodological. What made it *the equivalence principle* was the license to import experiments back and forth between the two linked laboratories, any result in the falling lab transferring to the inertial one and back, and then the decision to solve for the environment on Earth under that license, whereupon curvature is forced as the only medium in which the commitment holds without paradox.[10] The context is what turns "oh, that is neat" into "oh, this *gives you* general relativity."

The same three steps run here, and it is worth seeing them as three. The kernel with its aphorism is the take. The counterfactual semantics, (Section 9.1), is the import license: the working discipline that carries evaluations back and forth between the prior *Aethus* and the posterior one—the framework's name, formalized in due course, for the observer's information state, the interface-side face of the standpoint—so that transit-not-overwrite becomes an evaluation method rather than a slogan. And solving for the ordinary determinate environment under that license is what forces the pruning machinery, (the third postulate), as the only medium in which permanence holds without paradox: the

[9] One load-free note on vocabulary, standing outside the posits: phrases like "observer-indexed" serve only to *fix reference* to the standpoint-thing, never to define or constitute it—philosophy's reference-fixing without meaning-giving, in Kripke's sense [12], applied to what is grasped by acquaintance, in Russell's [13], through the demonstrative *here*, in Kaplan's [14]. The relation runs words-to-thing; no weight travels back.

[10] An explicit walkthrough of the equivalence principle under this decomposition, for the reader's reference—and offered, in its own right, as a small philosophy-of-science instrument: any principle split into its bare kernel and the interface that operationalizes it.

1. *The kernel.* Free fall is inertial motion, (inertial mass equals gravitational mass). One commitment, stated bare—and, alone, a curiosity verging on absurdity: a coordinate-motionless observer who is nonetheless accelerating.
2. *The interface.* The methodological license to import experiments back and forth between the two linked laboratories—the freely falling lab and the inertial lab—any result obtained in one transferring to the other and back.
3. *The solve.* Apply the license to the environment on Earth: the surface laboratory is now the accelerating one, and demanding that the kernel hold globally, around a planet, forces spacetime curvature as the only medium in which the commitment survives without paradox.
4. *The conversion.* Kernel alone: "oh, that is neat." Kernel plus interface: "this gives you general relativity." One insight at the root; many at the interface.
5. *The substrate.* Why it took Einstein: the interface context was held intuitively before the kernel landed, so kernel and consequences arrived together—the landing made as one substrate.

third postulate stands to the kernel exactly as Earth's bulk stands to the falling apple, the constraint that breaks systems out of their natural state. This is also why the landing required its substrate. The permanence insistence and its superposition implications arrived *together*, the framework's analogue of Einstein's happiest thought, and they could arrive together because the context was already in hand, the way a grandmaster lands a move as one substrate, (the August 2022 eureka, Section 2.2.2).

The first yield: blanks, read constructively. Hold the kernel to the interface and the first thing forced is the astounding one, the framework's curvature; reaching it takes one more primitive. When an observer's information state maps an attribute to nothing—the position never measured, the erosion never seen—call the attribute *blank*. The classical habit reads a blank passively: an absence of information, with a determinate fact sitting underneath, merely unknown. The framework's second postulate, met formally in due course, reads it *constructively*: the blank is a genuine building block of reality relative to that observer, encoding the state of the world with no determinate value underneath it at all, so that what a blank yields on interrogation is not a gap but the full set of open possibilities—unknowing *materializes* as superposition. The kernel and this reading are made for each other, and the record has exactly this as the extrusion principle's original derivational motivation, (Section 2.2.2). If learning could overwrite, every blank's constructive standing would be erased retroactively: the end state would be indistinguishable—within the framework's own bookkeeping; the statistics keep the difference where records run out—from a classical world that never had blanks at all. So the constructive reading survives *as a standing fact* only if the prior state is permanent. The kernel forbids the overwrite; the blank keeps its standing forever at its index; and the open alternatives it constructs are therefore standing content of the very block the observer occupies. That is the aphorism, now forced rather than offered—not the kernel's bare face, but what the kernel is made to mean once the interface holds it to account, standing to this framework as curvature stands to the equivalence principle: the medium the commitment forces once it is held everywhere.

Why the rival feels natural. Nothing quantum was needed to meet the kernel, just as nothing astronomical is needed to meet the equivalence kernel—anyone in a briefly dropping elevator has felt free fall's weightlessness firsthand. What deserves diagnosis is why the kernel's weather reading nonetheless feels wrong at first pass, and the answer is not a reason but a habit: we are advantage-oriented creatures. Saturday arrives, the outcome is *attained*, and the attained is what pays, so the earlier days' states are let go as spent—overwritten in the ledger out of retroactive thrift alone. The overwriting is bookkeeping, not ontology; nothing in the attainment ever argued that Tuesday's state stopped having been exactly what it was.

The rival, refuted. The kernel now refutes its rival outright. The rival—call it the *ignorance-about-an-objective* model—holds that Saturday's rain was determinate all along, the earlier days mere ignorance of it, and thereby privileges the realized state, Saturday's hundred-or-zero, as reality's only genuine entry. Suppose it, for contradiction. The privileging cannot be cashed as the priors' *non-permanence*, since that route merely trades assertion for counter-assertion, arbitrariness against arbitrariness, with no rebuttal available to either side that would end the stalemate; so it must be cashed as a difference of *category*—Saturday's state one kind of thing, the priors another—and that contradicts the kernel directly, whose reality states are uniformly and self-containedly well-defined. The contradiction discharges into a primitive: for every state to be a full member of the one category, the openness of the early days must be a genuine *constituent* of the reality state itself—superpositions, strictly on the object side, the very primitive the first yield delivered, now forced rather than offered. With that constituent in place the rival is locked out structurally, not rhetorically. Each update on the way to Saturday now does two things at once: it *adds* determinate existence, which is the face the classical picture inherits and recognizes, and it *subtracts*, since superpositions are lost—and the subtractive half is exactly the structure that blocks the privileging, because a bookkeeping that only ever gained could be read as ignorance being filled in, while one that also loses cannot. One cannot pull the knot through and have it untie back into the ignorance-objective ontology; as extra holes block a deformation, the structure catches. The framework does not merely differ from the classical picture; it is inequivalent to it by an invariant.

First-order implications. Grant the kernel and the following unpack from it one branch at a time, each developed in full at the reference given—and each the analogue of a general-relativistic consequence falling out of the equivalence kernel, derived rather than postulated:

- *Collapse becomes transit.* If the prior state is permanent, then the pre- and post-measurement states of a system cannot be timelike extensions of one another; what changes in a measurement is the observer's index, not the world in place—the move by which gravity-as-a-force dissolved into geometry: what seemed a dynamical event acting on things becomes a re-description of

where the describer stands. This is the extrusion principle in its full form, stated formally in the three numbered statements of Section 2.2.

- *The Einstein–Podolsky–Rosen synchronization problem dissolves.* Neither wing's prior state ever needed revoking, so no frame-relative ordering of "the collapse" was ever required—special relativity's own move, applied one level up, (Section 2.5.1).

- *Time goes indiscriminate.* With permanence in place, past uncertainties resolve exactly as future ones do—by learning—rather than by a branching reserved for the future: the kernel reaching into time's own structure, as the equivalence kernel reached into it through dilation; this is the consequential principle of Section 2.2.

- *Indexing is tense-free, point by point.* Every proper-time point carries its reality state relative to an Aethus; resolution is dated by the learning, never by the event—pointwise, exactly as the equivalence principle itself holds only point by point, in local frames.

Second-order implications. The kernel then pays a second time, because permanence is what makes states *composable*—and the equivalence kernel has its own second order to mirror: in the theory it forces, gravity gravitates, the field's energy sourcing further field. A state can enter a linear combination only if it persists as a term; a state that expired upon someone's learning could not be summed over by anyone. So the kernel supplies the playing field for the weighted layer entire, (Section 4.7)—linear combinations of permanence states—and then for linear combinations of *those*: the nesting by which one agent stands, relative to another's Aethus, as a superposition of agent-versions, each version's own weighted state a permanent term. That second iteration is what runs the framework's Wigner's-friend and Pusey–Barrett–Rudolph resolutions, (Section 10.3.3). And the second order is a capacity of the framework rather than a metaphor: relations of abstract and causal logic can themselves enter as stated content, (Section 2.3), and whole experimental outcomes can stand as abstract children placed in superposition with one another, (Theorem 14).

From kernel to full principle. The full extrusion principle is the kernel with its contexts attached—many insights from one, on the equivalence-principle pattern—and the next subsection states it formally three times over, newest formulation to oldest, with the counterfactual semantics, (Section 9.1), supplying the formalism in which the kernel's insistence becomes a working evaluation discipline. The kernel supplies the field; the semantics supplies the rules of play.

2.2 On the Proper Ontology of Time

For the reader who knows the literature. What is standard in this subsection is the block universe itself: the tenseless four-dimensional whole of the B-theory and of relativistic spacetime, with no privileged present, is assumed and not argued for. What is new is not a rival theory of time but a claim about *what the block contains*: that the counterfactual alternatives to what an observer knows are co-present in the same block rather than located in other worlds, that the block is complete without every entry in it being determinate, and that felt passage is neither an illusion nor a fundamental process but the transition an observer's information state makes between one indexing of the block and the next. The three statements below say this three ways; the moving-spotlight, growing-block, and presentist alternatives are not engaged, because the proposal is orthogonal to the tensed–tenseless debate rather than a position within it.

The map of this subsection. Ten subsubsections follow, and they group into four. The first three are the extrusion principle in three registers, newest to oldest: the *first statement* as a conclusion in the counterfactual-semantics idiom, the *second* as the concise form with its table and its aphorism, and the *third* as the original 2022 derivation from the two stances on the block universe. The next three are guards: the reordering of the multiverse the principle implies, the disclaimer on the ontic difference between block universes, and why the model is original against many worlds. The seventh places the principle in the philosophy of time, as the clarification of relativistic time and the third address between the A-series and the B-series. The last three open Aethic reasoning proper: the opening move, the qualitative facet, and the pedagogical walk through the Markov chain of block universes. A reader in a hurry can take the second statement and the seventh subsubsection and return for the rest.

The extrusion principle is stated three times in what follows, in order from the newest formulation to the oldest, and the ordering is deliberate. The first statement is the modal one, placed first because it is where the load-bearing content stands: the principle's core is the "co-present, not elsewhere" proposal about counterfactual alternatives itself. The second statement is the concise block-universe

form, placed as the accompanying secondary rendering—block-universe language is a consequence of the modal content, not an assumption behind it. The third statement is the original inductive derivation, preserved as the chronological root of the idea. A reader pressed for time may take the first statement alone; and a reader wary of block-universe metaphysics should note that by the time the second statement arrives, everything in it has already been earned by the first.

2.2.1 First Statement of the Extrusion Principle: A Conclusion in the Semantics of Counterfactuals

The semantics of counterfactuals is the branch of philosophical logic and analytic metaphysics concerned with statements of the form "had A been the case, B would have held." Its central framework, developed independently by Stalnaker [15] and Lewis [16] in the late 1960s and early 1970s, evaluates such statements by quantifying over possible worlds: "had A, then B" is true just in case B holds at the closest A-worlds under a similarity ordering over worlds. This framework has been extraordinarily productive—it underwrites the dominant treatments of causation, laws of nature, dispositions, and knowledge in contemporary analytic philosophy—but it carries a well-known structural vulnerability: the similarity ordering itself. Lewis defined the ordering explicitly, assigning priority weights to different respects of similarity, but the weights are a free parameter of the theory. Fifty years of literature has probed them with a standard battery of problem cases—failures of antecedent strengthening and transitivity, the would/might distinction, tie cases like Bizet–Verdi, backtracking ambiguities—without converging on a non-arbitrary specification. The ordering has been refined, restricted, and contextualized, but never derived from anything more fundamental. It remains a parameter dressed as an analysis.

The extrusion principle proposes to delete the similarity ordering rather than refine it. The foundational claim—which is also the chronological origin of the extrusion principle as an idea, (Section 2.2.3)—is that counterfactual alternatives are not realized on externally separated possible worlds but are co-present pockets within a single weighted Aethic structure: weighted alternatives that share one physical spacetime rather than inhabiting separate ones. Once this move is made, the similarity ordering is replaced by two quantities the framework already possesses: validity, which determines what survives the pruning postulates, and weight, which determines how much of it there is. The perturbation operator replaces Lewis's "small miracle" [16]: instead of manufacturing a foreign world that differs from actuality by a minimal violation of law, the operator reopens a page of the evaluating Aethus's own books at a named place, restates the attribute to its counterfactual value, holds an explicit informational boundary $\mathcal{B}$ fixed, and re-runs second- and third-postulate pruning over the result, (Section 9.1). The surviving weighted structure is the residue, and the would-, might-, and graded counterfactual clauses are read directly off it. The standard battery of problem cases is re-run against these clauses—successfully, as that section records—and all of this is carried out within modal metaphysics, without invoking any physics: the move is a proposal about the structure of counterfactual discourse, not about particles or wavefunctions.

The block-universe ontology then follows from this modal content. Once counterfactual alternatives are taken to be co-present rather than elsewhere, the framework's prohibition on arbitrary cross-Aethus information transfer establishes tense-free blankness—*blanks lack tense*: an attribute can be unresolved regardless of where it sits in proper time, (the indiscriminate time principle, Principle 11, a corollary of the extrusion principle), because blankness is a structural property of the Aethus rather than a temporal one. A "timeline"—a single linear sequence of cause and effect—is no longer sufficient to describe the universe, because the perturbation operator can reopen attributes from any point in the block universe, and the small-miracle premise's rigidity about deviating "before in time" is corrected by the tense-free character of the underlying structure. And once tense-free blankness is in place, the natural rendering of what "transit between evaluation points" means for an observer embedded in the structure is a Markov chain of static four-dimensional spacetimes, each internally consistent with relativity[11]. This derivation of block universes is entirely independent of the standard route through the relativity of simultaneity and the Rietdijk–Putnam argument [18, 19]: the modal structure alone produces them, and the convergence with the relativistic argument is a confirmation rather than a premise—two independent paths to the same ontology. The independence deserves dwelling on rather than a passing remark, for three reasons. First, it immunizes the framework against the objection that

[11] A structurally adjacent program that also takes the observer-indexed character of reality as foundational, albeit from a different starting point, is Müller's Algorithmic Idealism [17], whose "self state" bears a deliberate resemblance to the Aethus. Both programs arrive at observer-indexed ontology, and the independent routes strengthen the case that the destination is not an artifact of either starting point.

its ontology leans on contested simultaneity metaphysics: delete the Rietdijk–Putnam route entirely and the block universes remain, derived from counterfactual structure alone.

Second, it upgrades the convergence into evidence: two unrelated starting points—the geometry of simultaneity and the semantics of counterfactuals—terminating in the same ontology is a consilience neither route could manufacture for itself. Third, it sets up a repayment: because the framework did not borrow the block from relativity, it is positioned to offer relativity something back—a collapse-successor built on the block's own terms, resolving the foliation collision that Copenhagen forces, (Section 2.5). The block-universe ontology is deductively downstream; the counterfactual semantics is upstream. One further convergence completes the picture: on this independently derived block, the dimensional time concept sits as exactly what the clarification subsubsection later crystallizes it to be, (Section 2.2.7)—another dimension in the arena of physically-occupied space, distinguished by its metric sign and by nothing semantic—so the repayment of the third reason above is rendered twice over: once as the foliation-collision resolution, and once as the semantic crystallization of the dimension itself.

From this foundation, implications extend across several disciplines. In *metaphysics*, the growing-block-versus-static-block paradox dissolves, (Section 2.2), because both are partial descriptions of a Markov chain of static blocks: the growing-block intuition captures the phenomenology of transit along the chain, while the static-block ontology captures the character of each node, (worked instance: the Battle of Brémule narrative, Section 2.2, where a twelfth-century attribute is reopened and resolved without any edit to spacetime—transit phenomenology and node character exhibited in a single case). In *causality*, the identification of logical implication with physical causation is severed: a coupling between past and future holds only relative to the Aethae containing the wiring, (Section 9.6), and the causal chain is relativized rather than denied, (worked instances: the streetlight, sinkhole, and breakfast-script analyzes of Section 9.6 and the battery of Section 9.1, where couplings are checked by single perturbations and hold or fail Aethus-relatively). In *probability*, the weight on the Aethic tree becomes a structural feature of reality rather than a measure of ignorance, (Section 12.6.2; worked instance: the Monty Hall working, Section 11.1, where the one-third–two-thirds answer is generated purely by pruning invalid Aethae and reflowing weight, no epistemic overlay consulted). And in *quantum foundations*, the quantum–classical boundary is relocated from scale to informational accessibility, (Theorem 14), and observer disagreement is accounted for by perspectival re-indexing of the same physical environment to different Aethae, converging with relational quantum mechanics [20] while adding the observer-consistency apparatus the relational program does not itself supply, (Sections 2.5 and 12.3; worked instances: the detector-by-detector boundary slide of Section 6.1, and the Wigner's-friend resolution of Section 10.2.1). The common thread is that causation as a chain is replaced with structural consistency under perturbation, in which past, present, and future are equally accessible.

How to read the block-universe framing that follows. The two statements below this one present the same principle in an older dress, and the dress needs one paragraph of explanation before it is worn, because it has been the single largest source of misreading in this framework's short history. The ontology asserted by the extrusion principle is the one just given: a single arena — physical space, all of it — whose *contents* are Aethus-relative. What varies with the index is not which world one inhabits but what the arena holds: a determinate matter distribution relative to one Aethus, a disagreeing superposition relative to another, and neither reading more real than the other, since reality on the first postulate is the relative standing between a physical object and an Aethus rather than a property the object carries by itself. There is no determinate manifold underneath the patchwork that the Aethae approximate; the patchwork of indexed determinacies is the whole of it, which is what the ontological reversal principle demands and what the counterfactual semantics of the first statement runs on. Two uses of the phrase are distinct, because the archived statements below run them together. The block universe *singular* is the room of the extrusion principle's aphorism, Section 2.2.2: *the multiverse does not contain the room, the room contains the multiverse* — one arena, with the alternatives as its interior contents rather than as places elsewhere. The block universes *plural*, the ones the Markov chain strings together, are not additional rooms. They are Aethus-indexed readings of that one room, standing to it as reference frames stand to a single spacetime; the ladder ontology of Section 2.4.7 states the same division in its own terms, calling the chain the construction indexed by an Aethus and the ladder the physical ontology, independent of which pocket one occupies.

The Markov chain of block universes is a *pedagogical* presentation of that ontology rather than a second one: the process is a Markov process over Aethae, there is one block universe, and the

"blocks" of the chain are that one block rendered relative to successive Aethae, the rendering being a homomorphism from the chain of Aethae to the renderings (Definition 24), so that the blocks differ as renderings and not physically. It was introduced in 2024 as a teaching device, after an attempt to convey the relativity of determinacy to two statistics graduate students landed only once it was put as "imagine you are jumping timelines," and it is retained below because it does two things well: it supplies a spatial profile for the indexing, and it carries the indiscriminate-time commitment automatically, a block universe being all of spacetime by construction rather than an arbitrary slice of it. The derivations do not use it. They run on Aethae, the three postulates, and pruning; the extrusion principle's core is a statement about what an Aethic superposition *is*, and the transitions are the designated work of centric unfolding. The chain illustrates the indexing; it does not carry it. The chain's block universes stand to Aethae as an isomorphic graph stands to the graph it models: the First Postulate's bijection between an Aethus and a block universe means the two presentations carry identical content, and the block-universe layer is the one with the pictures. Read every locution of the form *transitioning to a new rendering of the block universe*, *rendering reselection*, or *the Markov chain* accordingly — as transit language for re-indexing, in the sense already fixed by this paper's own best sentence on the matter: *the particle never changed—your Aethus did.*

Two registers are at work, and the framework leans on the distinction in more places than this one. A *pedagogical* construction answers the question of how a structure is best conveyed to someone who does not yet hold it. A *conceptual* or methodological one answers what the framework asserts, and what its inferences are entitled to consume. The two are graded independently, and success in the first says nothing whatever about standing in the second: a device may be the best available route into a structure and still be no part of the structure, exactly as a diagram of a proof may be indispensable for teaching it and appear nowhere in it. What goes wrong when the registers are run together is not that the device becomes false but that it acquires commitments it was never asked to carry — which is how a stack of block universes, introduced to make indexing tangible, comes to be read as a claim about how many worlds there are. This is the constructed-versus-insisted-real discipline of Section 10.5 applied one level up: there to Aethae written down for an argument, here to an entire expository apparatus. The verdict it licenses is the same in both cases, and it is two-part rather than one: keep the construction, refuse the insistence.

The modal statement above is what makes the demotion safe rather than merely tactful, and this is the piece the framework did not have when the device was introduced. In the received semantics, evaluating a counterfactual dispatches the evaluator to another world, so a stack of worlds is owed; the perturbation semantics deletes that dispatch, evaluating inside the evaluator's own state at a declared scope. The stack of block universes was doing precisely the work the possible-worlds pluriverse does under Lewis and Stalnaker, and the same deletion applies for the same reason: what is needed is not a supply of worlds to move between but one arena and an index over its contents. So the block-universe rendering is now what a similarity ordering is to the perturbation semantics — available as a picture, dispensable in the derivation, and never load-bearing. Two consequences worth stating plainly. First, the framework's dual-time structure survives the demotion intact, because Aethic time was never motion through a sequence of worlds: it is the ordering over Aethae under transit, and it contrasts with Einsteinian time as an order on states contrasts with a geometry within one. Second, the objections the device attracts — most of all whether re-indexing perturbs the energy density of the past, addressed at Section 2.2.5 — are objections to the picture, and the answers there are correspondingly answers about what the picture may and may not depict.[12]

2.2.2 Second Statement: *Concise Form of the Aethic Extrusion Principle*

Below may be found a particularly concise explanation of the extrusion principle, as mentions the structural and qualitative facts by name, in the block-universe presentation whose standing is fixed at the reading note above, Section 2.2.1.

The starting point for Aethic reasoning is the *Extrusion Principle*, which serves as its foundational ontological assertion. It resolves the long-standing conflict between the static, relativistic block universe

[12] *August 19, 2026*. This paragraph is the canonical landing for a reconciliation the paper attempted earlier from inside the device's own era, at the long footnote of Section 13.10 — which already recorded that the block-universe framing was a later explanatory artifact rather than an original intuition, offered the Einstein-1905 reference-frame analogy for it, and named the isomorphism between the block-universe graph and the graph of Aethae. What that footnote lacked, and what the first statement above now supplies, is the modal vocabulary in which the demotion is a deletion of the same kind the perturbation semantics already performs; with that in hand the reconciliation can be stated as doctrine rather than as an author's aside.

[18, 19, 21, 22] and the dynamic, flowing experience of quantum. It accomplishes this by proposing a new structure for reality, one defined by two interconnected facets:

Principle (The Extrusion Principle)

- *The Structural Facet: The universe is a single block universe [18, 19, 21, 22] rendered relative to the Aethae of a Markov chain over Aethae, the renderings forming what is spoken of below as a chain of block universes. Each rendering holds a permanent content of Aethic superposition. Therefore, wavefunction collapse is a transition between renderings, a step along the chain of Aethae, not an event within the block*[13].

- *The Qualitative Facet: These distinct block universes are not spatially separate. They occupy the same physical space, with their differences encoded informationally. They are different perspectival views on a single, layered reality.*

- *The Modal Facet: Physical alternate possibilities (counterfactuals) are not realized on externally-separated timelines, but are encoded as a single, unified Aethic superposition object to a block universe, (where a block universe and its superposition content is bijectively given by an Aethus via the First Postulate). See Section 9.1 for the expanded detail.*

The starting point for Aethic reasoning is the *Extrusion Principle*, which serves as its foundational ontological assertion. It is a radical redefinition of what "alternate possibilities" are. Classically, and in frameworks like the Many-Worlds Interpretation [2, 3], alternate histories are seen as branching timelines that occupy externally separated spaces. The Extrusion Principle rejects this spatial duplication. Instead, it posits that all possibilities occupy a single, shared physical space, with their differences encoded informationally as degrees of freedom within a unified Aethic superposition.

This move is directly motivated by the conflict between the static block universe model of relativity [18, 19, 21, 22] and the dynamic, observer-dependent nature of quantum mechanics. Aethic reasoning resolves this by proposing that reality is a single block rendered relative to successive Aethae, a progression along a Markov chain over Aethae. Each node in this chain is an Aethus, and its rendering of the block is a complete, static, 4D spacetime relative to it, consistent with relativity. An observer's subjective experience of time's passage is their movement along this chain, driven by the acquisition of new information. A simple graphic representing this may be found with Figure 2.

[13] It is for this reason that an argument can be made for the extrusion principle being the most fundamental concept in all of Aethic reasoning. That is, by replacing the timeline-branching concept with the block universe [18, 19, 21, 22] Markov chain concept, we are directly able to address the intrinsic paradigmatic issues of retrocausality. In the timeline paradigm we have in a delayed-choice experiment [10] that there is a particular stubborn ambiguity in the mix, hence causing the retrocausality problem: if prior to erasing the which-path information, at time A, clearly such information is existent, but later time B it has been properly erased, then it suddenly becomes quite ambiguous what is ontologically occurring in the coexisting universe with a given agent at A. Is it that the event of future erasing jumps back and plants the new happening? But is it then that the agent themselves at A coexists with this happening through retrocausality from B, or rather that B spawns a new timeline altogether, in which the consciousness of the agent at time A is rendered as not much more than a philosophical zombie? The key of the extrusion principle, then, is that the problem is interpreted as being with the timeline paradigm itself. As simply as stating that we have the extra Aethic degree of freedom beyond Einsteinian time, then, is how we resolve this cascading paradox perhaps shockingly quickly. In the Aethic world, we simply have that the entire block universe [18, 19, 21, 22] extrudes, and the agent at B enters a universe where the coexisting past matches the update. At Aethic block universe A, they occupy the block universe disagreeing superposition of all possible such B block universes that can be reached.

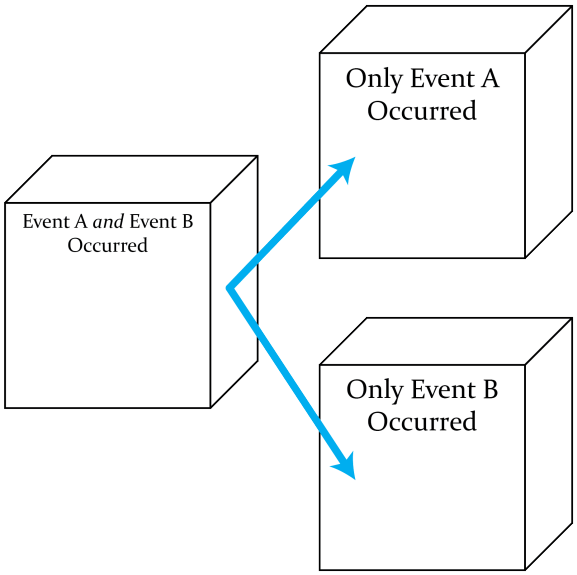


Figure 2: A diagram illustrating the Aethic progression along a Markov chain of block universes. The initial state, where both Event A and Event B are possible, represents a parent Aethus. An observation causes a transition to a child Aethus where only one event has occurred.

This structure completely reframes wavefunction collapse. Instead of a particle changing state within a single timeline, the observer's Aethus transitions to a new rendering of the block universe where the outcome was always a fact. The particle never changed—your Aethus did. The table below contrasts this with the standard Copenhagen interpretation [23, 24]:

Copenhagen Interpretation

	Prior Time	**Subsequent Time**
Timeline	Particle in *superposition*	Particle in *single state*

Aethic Interpretation

	Prior Time	**Subsequent Time**
Prior Block Universe	Particle in *superposition*	Particle in *superposition*
Subsequent Block Universe	Particle in *single state*	Particle in *single state*

Figure 3: A representation of the Extrusion Principle. Our classical view of collapse corresponds to the main diagonal. The Aethic view reveals the full structure: in the prior block universe, the particle is *always* in superposition. In the subsequent block universe, it was *never* in superposition. The "collapse" is the transition between these two distinct, complete realities.

As Figure 3 shows, in the "Prior Block Universe," the particle is always in superposition. In the "Subsequent Block Universe," it was always in the single, collapsed state. The collapse is not an event *within* time, but a transition *between* these realities. This solves the retrocausality paradoxes of quantum mechanics while preserving a deterministic structure within each block universe [18, 19, 21, 22].

In an Einstein-Podolsky-Rosen (EPR) setup [11], the measurements performed by Alice and Bob are spacelike separated[14]. A fundamental consequence of special relativity is that for such events, there exists no objective, frame-independent answer to the question of who measured "first". Copenhagen-style interpretations, which often posit that the first measurement triggers an objective collapse for the entire entangled system, run into direct conflict here. They implicitly require a specific, privileged

[14]Note that this thought experiment's resolution serves as Aethic reasoning's proposal for solving *Requirement 5*, although the dedicated section on the topic may be seen for a more thorough philosophical analysis.

way to slice spacetime—a preferred foliation—to define this objective “first" moment and delineate a universal pre-collapse from a post-collapse reality across space, a concept fundamentally at odds with relativity. The Aethic extrusion principle offers a resolution by fundamentally changing the nature of collapse. Instead of a single event occurring within spacetime, collapse is reinterpreted as an observer-relative Aethic transition—an extrusion—between distinct block universes. When Bob makes his measurement (even if it’s “earlier" in some reference frames), this triggers an extrusion only relative to Bob’s Aethus, shifting him into a new rendering of the block universe where the entire history is consistent with his measured outcome.

Crucially, from the perspective of Alice before her measurement (relative to her current Aethus, let’s call it $\text{Alice}_{\text{prior}}$), Bob himself, his distant particle, and even the event of his past measurement remain in superposition according to her Aethic reality. This state persists relative to $\text{Alice}_{\text{prior}}$ until Alice performs her own measurement (or otherwise gains the relevant information, perhaps via a signal from Bob arriving later). Locality is thus preserved, as Bob’s action has no instantaneous effect on Alice’s Aethic state or her experienced reality. When Alice does measure (or gains the information), this triggers her own extrusion to a new Aethus ($\text{Alice}_{\text{after}}$). By extruding, she transitions into a different block universe. Relative to $\text{Alice}_{\text{after}}$, the reality she now occupies is one where Bob’s past measurement always yielded the specific, non-superposed outcome correlated with her own result. The apparent “collapse" of Bob’s state from Alice’s viewpoint is not an action-at-a-distance, but a consequence of her re-indexing to a different block universe consistent with the new information she possesses. This “lagging behind" perspective (where one observer attests that the other is still in superposition, even if they have already measured) is symmetric and isomorphic due to relativity; in reference frames where Alice measures “first," the roles are reversed, but the Aethic explanation remains consistent. Because each observer’s transition (collapse) is tied independently to their own Aethic update and involves shifting to a different block universe—rather than altering a single, shared reality along a specific time slice—there is no need to enforce a synchronized, objective collapse instant or define a universal “first" measurement. Consequently, the entire problem of needing a preferred foliation is sidestepped.

I want to emphasize that the seed of the extrusion principle came to me in a single eureka moment in August 2022, and it was merely the unpacking of this single idea which led me to the derivation of Aethic reasoning as if almost derivationally predetermined. Interestingly, you can capture the basic concept of that thought in a single aphorism, (perhaps similarly to how Einstein’s happiest thought is capturable in “free fall matches[15] inertial physics, and standing on Earth matches upward acceleration physics", and in both cases this leads uniquely to the finished framework later proposed).

Extrusion Principle Aphorism

“The multiverse does not contain the room, the room contains the multiverse."

The reason I associate this original eureka moment with the extrusion principle in particular, is because the extrusion principle makes the move of attributing a complete state to a block universe, be it determinate or a superposition. Also contained in the seed of that original idea was the extrusion principle’s emphasis that the multiverse contents of the room are indexed to the Aethus in question, with the last common ancestor in the Markov chain of any two given block universes then satisfying the Aethic disagreeing superposition of those two block universes in question, (as in the limiting case moves to show that there exists a block universe containing all possible contents of all other block universes, with this such block universe being that which captures all which physical space itself actually contains, and with subsequent block universes not disputing this, but merely selectively referring to targeted child Aethae in this based on how the indexing Aethus in question is constructed).

It is also worth a remark at this point about the primary faculty of the extrusion principle within the wider Aethic reasoning apparatus, besides even the licensing move regarding the block universe versus growing block universe. Plainly speaking, the real reason for the extrusion principle in Aethic reasoning is that it serves as the fundamental residue on the side of the ontology of time for the move of the second postulate of the Aethus in taking “blank” (that is, “unknown”) stated-attributes as ontologically constructive in reality rather than merely passively indicative of an unknown non-blank stated-attribute.

What “constructive” means. In other words, the primary necessity for the second postulate of the Aethus is that to a given Aethus, when an attribute is unknown, it must genuinely and physically

[15]Notice my inclusion of “matches" in this sentence, because the reason the happiest thought led to general relativity was its methodological nuance rather than its logical statement as an end directly. The methodology was “find the unique theory for which empiricism from the elevator thought experiment is exhaustively transferrable to its matched case on Earth", without needing to convince ourselves of properties beyond empirical access like whether a person on the ground truly is non-stationary or not like the person in the accelerating elevator.

be encoded as a blank for that reality, rather than being a passive absence of information which in reality is determinately stated as in a classical metaphysical paradigm. This is what is meant by blank being "constructive" in a reality, being that it behaves precisely like determinate states in the sense of being a fundamental informational building block and effectively primitive in that reality, so as to genuinely encode the state of the universe relative to its Aethus in question without the usual-paradigm implication of a needed determinate state underlying it.

The move, and what fails without it. The fundamental move of the extrusion principle, then, is to fix a given blank stated-attribute to a given Aethic block universe by means of having the informational update move the agent to a new rendering of the block universe rather than overwrite the blank in the existing block universe or otherwise a subspace of it. What is so crucial about this to Aethic reasoning, then, is that without such a move, we would be forced to update blanks through overwriting when new information is picked up by the agent's string of Aethae, as would revert back directly to the classical metaphysical picture of blanks holding no robust constructive capacity in and of themselves—that is because they would be subject to overwriting anyway, for which the end state is indistinguishable from the classical picture of no blanks in the first place.

Provenance. This itself was precisely my original derivational motivation for the extrusion principle when I proposed it in August of 2022, and I only added the block universe versus growing block universe licensing move after the fact as effective consequential situating. *So, in the sense of the derivation, you might say that the ontology of the extrusion principle is uniquely determined from making the second postulate of the Aethus fundamental to epistemological structure.* The status of this move is recorded formally at the second postulate's statement, (the Permanence Proposition, Section 3.4.4), at the grade that proposition carries: what the data force is the constructive reading of blanks where records run out; what permanence adds is that the reading is a standing fact about the index that held it rather than a transition undergone by one ledger—the second postulate made sayable, in the author's own phrase there—and it is adopted with the extrusion principle for that reason rather than forced by the statistics alone.

A terminological convention is worth fixing at this point, because the framework's two facets are easily conflated. The *extrusion principle* is the static assertion: there exists the Markov chain over Aethae, each rendering the one block universe relative to itself, with the alternative outcomes housed inside each rendering as disagreeing superposition content. The dynamical fact—the jump forward along the chain upon gaining information—belongs instead to *centric unfolding*, introduced formally later in this paper as the (revisable) convention governing transit. Where the verb "to extrude" appears in what follows, it should accordingly be read as shorthand for performing a centric-unfolding step along the extrusion structure: the principle supplies the road, and centric unfolding is the driving.

(A forward pointer, for the reader tracking the dynamical facet's later duties: every determinate state enters an Aethus by a definite intersection of this centric unfolding, and the counterfactual semantics of Section 9.1 makes that record operational—the Aethic perturbation can be run at the establishing intersection itself, (one σ-choice of the single synchronic operation), with the empirical discipline of Theorem 8 governing the handle.)

2.2.3 Third Statement, *(Original)*: Inductive Derivation of the Aethic Extrusion Principle

Below may be found the original text of this paper explaining the Aethic extrusion principle, before the concise version was written; its block-universe vocabulary is to be read under the note of Section 2.2.1.

Before we can begin making major arguments in physics, it is good conduct in the face of a task as overwhelming as solving the measurement problem that we might be very clear about our own metaphysical ontology as agents in the universe. As such, let us designate a section to defining our philosophical ontology in just such a way as to have a good baseline for application in the next section. The right place to begin is the oldest live dichotomy in the philosophy of time, McTaggart's [25]: whether time is fundamentally *tensed* or fundamentally *tenseless*.

The two theories. The *B-theory* holds that time is fundamentally the tenseless ordering of events by *earlier-than* and *later-than*; past, present, and future are equally real, "now" is an indexical like "here," and the whole of spacetime is one static block, as if every moment were a frame of an already-filmed reel [18, 19, 21, 22]. The *A-theory* holds that tense is fundamental: the distinction between past, present, and future is a real feature of the world and not of our perspective on it, and there is genuine *becoming*—the present is metaphysically privileged, and what was future comes into being as time passes. The A-theory is the more natural view to a human, because it matches the felt sense that the unfolding of time is what brings the future into existence. It comes in species that differ about what

has being: *presentism*, on which only the present exists; the *growing block*, on which the past and present exist and the future does not; and the *moving spotlight*, on which all times exist but one is lit. The differences among the species will not matter to the argument below, which turns only on what every A-theory shares—an objective, world-wide present that moves—so we may speak of *the* A-theory and let the growing block stand as its representative where a picture helps.

The observation that opens Aethic reasoning. Both theories are in direct conflict with fundamental notions of empiricism in modern physics[16], and the two conflicts come from the two halves of modern physics respectively. The B-theory's block is, somewhat famously, outlawed[17] by standard quantum mechanics: a tenseless block in which every event is equally and determinately real is a complete assignment of determinate values to every attribute at every time—a hidden-variables model by construction—and Bell's theorem [4] forbids exactly that. So in the very least the empirical results of quantum mechanics forbid the B-theorist's block from being the whole story.

Such a result is often cited as a reason the A-theory must be correct instead, but the A-theory clashes with established empiricism just as squarely, and is thereby in an equal state of ontological invalidity; this time the empiricism is special relativity's. The A-theory's one shared commitment is that there is a fact about which events are *present*—a world-wide boundary at which becoming occurs, whether one pictures it as the edge of a growing block or as the sole existing slice. Ask, then, the simple but decisive question: *where is that boundary?* This is where the theory meets relativity, because *the relativity of simultaneity demands that there is no well-defined manifold of the present in spacetime*: two observers in relative motion disagree about which distant events are simultaneous with "now," and neither is wrong. This is the Rietdijk–Putnam argument [18, 19], and it holds under even the most conservative reading of relativity; the absence of an objective present is among the theory's best-confirmed consequences. So relativity discredits the A-theory to exactly the degree that quantum mechanics discredits the B-theory. To be very clear on the specific assertions of such a thing, *we are not aligning the B-theory with special relativity while aligning the A-theory with quantum mechanics, because such a thing requires an extra assumption from what we are truly demonstrating. The supposition is simply that special relativity directly contradicts the A-theory's present, while quantum mechanics directly contradicts the B-theory's block, and nothing more.*

The shape of the way out, before the construction. Each theory is right about something the other is wrong about. The B-theorist is right that the geometry of spacetime is tenseless—there is no foliation to prefer and no moving surface in it—and wrong that a tenseless block of determinate events is a complete ontology. The A-theorist is right that becoming is real and not an illusion to be explained away, and wrong that it is located *in* spacetime as a moving present. A century of the debate has been a standoff between two repairs: A-theorists protecting becoming by adding a present to the block and inheriting the foliation problem, B-theorists protecting the block by demoting becoming to illusion and paying with the experiential residue their opponents refuse to abandon. The construction below takes neither repair. It keeps the tenseless block as the B-theorist has it, keeps becoming as the A-theorist has it, and *relocates* the latter: the A-series does not live within the block, where relativity forbids it, but *between* blocks, along a dimension the block does not contain. That is the extrusion principle, and the paragraphs that follow are the author's original derivation of it, stated in the vocabulary of 2023.

We now have to come to a very important conclusion: given that our universe does indeed ontologically exist, and given that both of the aforementioned theories of time have been invalidated, we must infer that there exists a third option to explaining the ontology of time, such that said third option is the true correct answer.

We are now to produce a hypothesis for what this third option may be, and in doing so will have at least presented the very first model for the ontology of time which is not a swift contradiction to our empiricism. Let us do such a thing now. Simply put, we are to now suppose that in order to build ourselves out of this predicament, we must suppose that there exists another dimension within this block universe, growing the four dimensions of spacetime to four dimensions of spacetime plus

[16]A more general principle about epistemology may also be said along these lines:

The deepest unknowns tend to have shades of similarity to all things known. It's hard to discover them not because they are new, but because they resemble conflicting sides of existing debates.

[17]Note that superdeterminism does indeed satisfy something of a loophole which allows eternalism to coexist with Bell's theorem [4, 9]. In this regard, then, we are going to postulate in this paper that the universe cannot be superdeterministic, with the Aethic model of the ontology of time being regarded as a superior model on account of being more generally revealing to the universe. In essence, then, we still argue against superdeterminism by tracing the requisite interpretation of Aethic reasoning all the way back from the broad solution later in the paper, rather than neatly clipping standard eternalism and presentism out this early on. Either method does the same general job outside of superdeterminism, but this latter one requires a bit more reading. Please see the later section on superdeterminism where I go over it more critically.

one dimension of something else. We will refer to this additional dimension as the *Aethic dimension*. Rest assured, this is no such excuse-driven dimension like we might find throughout string theory, for instance—rather we see from our prior derivation that we have been siphoned here instead, because it is a directed effort to reconcile the issues of the B-theory and the A-theory through an extra degree of freedom beyond their dichotomy.

Remarkably, now, we solve a whole host of paradoxes in one swoop if we simply suppose that as one transitions through time, one must also transition through this extra Aethic dimension. The coordinate in the Aethic dimension, as will be elaborated upon in a few paragraphs, will be the sole signifier of any and all superpositions to a cross-sectional block universe, which allows us to decouple the effects of wavefunction collapse from time itself. The premise of this new model works as follows: we might imagine a long sequence of distinct block universes which an agent will move through in a similar way to how they continuously move through space and time. In a sense, we get a kind of extrusion of the entire block universe along the Aethic dimension. Each little block universe in the continuous sequence might be referred to as a *block universe* still, and the entire structure might be referred to as a *hyperblock universe*. Note that we ought not to think of ourselves as truly leaving the universe as every moment, (which implies some strange sort of discontinuity of motion, perhaps), and instead should suppose that we are simply moving across a continuous path akin to a worldline, with each "block universe" merely representing the cross section to our Aethic coordinate at that particular moment. Note, crucially, that one's actual coordinate along the Aethic dimension is what we will refer to as their *Aethus*. Altogether, the full hyperblock universe can be reconciled as a Markov chain, with each tenseless block universe representing a state in the Markov chain, and each Aethus representing the identifier or index to that state. In essence, we would suppose that the agent has some form of 'Aethic worldline' along the progression of this Markov chain, in addition to their worldline through space and time. Perhaps what we observe as a wavefunction collapse, then, could be taken as the act of progressing to a new rendering of the block universe.

At this point it is important to note another crucial element of this hyperblock hypothesis: how it structurally relates to quantum superpositions. Let us suppose that superpositions are a keystone constituent element of a given block universe, such that the Aethic coordinate itself of a particular block universe is the signifier of which superpositions are allowed to exist in that particular block universe. If the Aethus deems that some superposition is collapsed in a particular block universe, then it must be so, whereas if it deems that it is not, then the block universe likewise reflects that. Simply put, we are replicating the process of wavefunction collapse with an entirely new interpretation—rather than having to deal with all the fallacies of wiping out superpositions within the A-theorist's becoming, hence pointing all such dynamics in the direction of time—we are instead now postulating that the actual best ontology which maps to our empiricism for the wavefunction collapse derives from this notion of an extra dimension altogether, which is orthogonal to the entire block universe rather than in timelike alignment with it.

This implies, notice, that the Aethic dimension itself is not actually a real number line like a spacetime dimension is, because the degrees of freedom of a single real number is entirely insufficient to depict every superposition in the universe.

We can already see from this idea of the Aethic dimension how we get a much richer ontology to superposition collapses than anything in the Copenhagen interpretation. Specifically, given that an Aethus is the sole signifier of a superposition in a block universe, we might suppose that once an agent has transitioned to a subsequent Aethus regarding the wavefunction collapse of an electron's spin, say, it follows that the resulting spin-state, (such as spin-up for example), has been in effect throughout that entire block universe's history, (or at least the entire lifetime of the particle). As such, in the Aethic interpretation, it would be invalid to suggest that a known collapsed superposition was ever non-collapsed in the first place, but this is so only once it has been collapsed. What would really be better to say, then, is that *the particle is in superposition in the prior Aethic coordinate only, but never was in superposition in the first place in the subsequent Aethic coordinate*. To be more specific about this, consider the following Aethic table to describe this.

In effect, we get the following idea: if we consider two Aethae and their corresponding block universes[18], such as A_1 and A_2, (for before and after the collapse, respectively), then in the block universe corresponding to A_1, we see that the electron is and will be in superposition for all time. That

[18]Here is a colloquial, albeit simplistic overview of how the three postulates of the Aethus tell you about your position along the block universe-Markov chain, (especially where the extrusion principle itself simply posits that there is such a Markov chain, rather than quantifying it directly): "*The first postulate tells you that you always have to be in a particular block universe at a time. The second postulate tells you which block universe you're in. And the third postulate tells you which block universe you can't be in.*"

Copenhagen Interpretation

	Prior Time	**Subsequent Time**
Timeline	Particle in *superposition*	Particle in *single state*

Table 1: In the Copenhagen interpretation, it is assumed that the prior time should still hold the wavefunction, and that the collapse is an event rooted in time rather than a boundary-manifold which oneself crosses over, (as is the case in the Aethic interpretation).

Aethic Interpretation

	Prior Time	**Subsequent Time**
Prior Aethus	Particle in *superposition*	Particle in *superposition*
Subsequent Aethus	Particle in *single state*	Particle in *single state*

Table 2: In this table, we demonstrate the importance of including the Aethic orientation of an event in Aethic reasoning. Note that this general principle that the Aethus serves as an extra layer of variability to reality, be it in terms of the hyperblock universe or whatever else, is known in Aethic reasoning as *the principle of Aethic extrusion*. Visually speaking, one can consider a timeline in this chart to point left and right, and an Aethic "worldline" to point up and down, such that one's own total path of traversal moves downward and diagonally within the diagram, (with the time boundary being standardized to align with wherever oneself crosses the Aethic boundary).

is, in such a block universe, even after you have checked the state of the electron, and you yourself are also in superposition with it, with your reaction being in superposition, etcetera. So in the block universe for A_1, the electron never leaves superposition, nor can it. However, for A_2, the electron never was in superposition in the first place, and was simply always the state that you read it to be upon looking. For example, if it was spin-up, then this was always so since the moment it was generated. In effect, we get all the convenience of hidden variables from this notion, but also the experimental results regarding Bell's theorem [4], because such experiments are technically only ever done in the prior Aethus. Put in a single statement, *the particle never changed—your Aethus did*. The error of the Copenhagen interpretation, then, would be considered its supposition of how the pre-collapse version of the particle is a timelike extension of the post-collapse version. In Aethic reasoning, we lead by supposing that this is not so, and that they are instead representative of two entirely different histories and futures, which we merely thought were the same by neglecting that one's own Aethic coordinate is also in motion.

Consider the chart below, which visualizes Aethic progression in the form of a Markov chain between block universes. Notice that this is an entirely original idea, and goes beyond just the many-worlds interpretation [2, 3]. This is specifically on account of the past having to change as well when the update is done, with there no longer being the need for future-oriented timeline branching or whatnot. For an intuitive analogy of sorts, if we call *Event A* the outcome of the Americans winning the American revolution, and *Event B* the outcome of the British winning the American revolution, then we have that so long as you yourself have not yet learned about the outcome, and it will still be in superposition relative to you in the prior Aethic block universe. Only once you learn about the event, then, do you in effect become coupled to one of the outcomes, and then transfer into a block universe of only a single state. The immediate difference from the many-worlds interpretation, then, is that in this Aethic interpretation, if you traced back on your own Aethic worldline so as to go back in time five minutes before having learned about who won the American revolution, and now you could just as well phase into a block universe where the British won instead. So we have that objective truths about the past, present, and future, would be held as less a fundamental property of the universe, and instead something of a malleable relative effect of where you happen to be located in the Markov chain.

A very important result of this Aethic interpretation to the ontology of time is that each Aethic block universe itself indeed turns out to be deterministically defined. That is, each Aethic block universe is itself a static and invariant block, but is distinct from the B-theorist's classical block in that it also possesses fundamental content of superpositions baked into it, so to speak. In essence, we harness all of the deterministic potential advocated for by Einstein, all while structuring the material contents

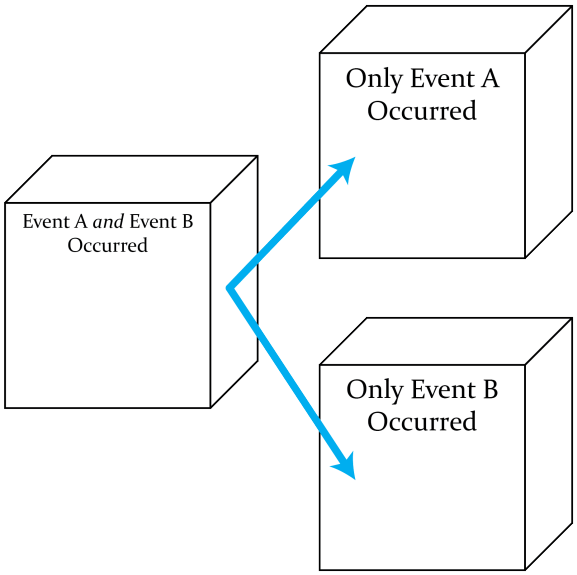


Figure 4: A representation of the Markov chain which corresponds with this Aethic block universe model and the extrusion principle. The title of 'extrusion' itself comes from visualizing an entire block universe as essentially being extruded along the progression of the Markov chain. This idea is indeed in some sort of defiance of common sense, but as we have seen with the relativity of simultaneity before it, the fundamental claim of this principle is that we are effectively forced to conclude something along these lines in order to satisfy both the empiricism of quantum physics and special relativity at once.

of our block universe so as to align with the views of Bohr. We then also achieve a definable process of wavefunction collapse by further supposing that oneself can move across the Aethic dimension, and thereby witness a flux of superpositions from one's perspective. In effect, we notice that with the Aethic interpretation of quantum mechanics, both Einstein and Bohr have their fundamental stances realized, hence showing that they never needed to be contradictory in the first place.

Lastly, please note that we can show that the Aethic dimension itself, although mathematically well-defined, (as will be seen later in the paper), is not isomorphic to the real numbers under any operation whatsoever. We can show this quite simply by demonstrating how the Aethic dimension and set of real numbers ultimately fail to be continuously bijective. Consider even a single quantum superposition, which for n possible distinct eigenstates has a Hilbert space of dimension n. As such, with the Aethic coordinate needing to be entirely sufficient to encode the entire superposition content of its corresponding block universe, we therefore clearly have that there exists real-world quantum superpositions whose Hilbert space are of greater dimension than one, so a single real number is consequently insufficient to exhaustively describe all degrees of freedom of an Aethus. Even using vectors or sets for this task will be shown to be somewhat tricky, so we are to actually design an original mathematical structure for encoding an ontological Aethus like the ones we need to depict for this model. The mathematical consequences which may be found about an Aethus are extensive, but among them are that the Aethic dimension satisfies the field axioms, along with other identities of the sort.

Let us now refer to this complete principle as the *extrusion principle of Aethic reasoning.*

Principle 2 (The Extrusion Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
We hold that a pre-collapse quantum superposition of a matter particle is strictly not a timelike extension of the post-collapse version. We instead have that the change from one to other occurs when an agent's Aethus changes rather than anything having directly to do with the Einsteinian flow of time. Relative to the agent's prior Aethus, the particle must remain in superposition indefinitely, and relative to the agent's subsequent Aethus, the particle must have never been in superposition in the first place. In effect, by collapsing the superposition, an agent moves from a reality in which the superposition exists to one in which it never existed in the first place, and might suppose the two to be timelike extensions of one another's worldlines only by misunderstanding of the underlying effects.

Structurally speaking, the extrusion principle supposes that a spacetime continuum as it is currently defined falls short of the needed degrees of freedom to describe a wavefunction collapse, so we correct

this issue by treating the spacetime continuum itself as a block universe, and then extruding such a block universe along an extra dimension called the Aethic dimension, in effect creating a full hyperblock universe. We then make the important ontological assessment that variation of unfolding scenarios need not be encoded beyond the physical span of a block universe by some external timeline branching event, and may instead be encapsulated directly within the confines of a particular block universe in the form of its intrinsic superposition content, itself being derived from its Aethic coordinate in the larger hyperblock universe.

It is also worth mentioning at this point that the upcoming Aethic mathematical structure was actually derived prior to the extrusion principle, with the extrusion principle itself having served as the single adaptation to temporal ontology which enabled the Aethic structure to describe superpositions in a real-world setting. In effect, then, at its best we ought not to picture the extrusion principle as being arbitrary, but rather as operating in an exact conjunction with any idealistically perspectivist model of the universe which is also capable of describing superpositions. Such is why this principle is quite foundational to all further Aethic pursuits.

The most procedurally insightful way to summarize this derivation is that we have shown the B-theory's tenseless block and the A-theory's moving present to collectively lack the degrees of freedom required to describe ontological time as it exists in our universe: the block is short one dimension, and the present is in the wrong one. As such, we are compelled to use Einstein's razor [26] to incorporate the simplest possible extra degree of freedom[19] to our model which is sufficient to describe it. This is the form of the Aethic dimension itself, with the principle of extrusion then being the ontological consequence. Therefore, every further principle which we take to be implied by the extrusion principle in the remainder of this paper can be considered to be consistent with such an Aethic dimensional interpretation to the ontology of time, itself being the ideal model by Einstein's razor.

Speaking personally for a moment, it may be valuable to also describe the extrusion principle in the same terms in which it originally came to me during my epiphany on the subject[20]. Simply put, *the premise is that there are no hard metaphysical barriers between alternate histories, (as we see in the timeline branching model), but instead all alternate histories and indeed all possibilities are occupying the same physical space, with their differences being encoded in the degrees of freedom of Aethic superpositions, (which will be outlined later on in the paper). In effect, then, when an agent moves to a new rendering of the block universe, it is not that their spatial location changes, but rather that they attain a new perspectivist view on this same physical space in which all possibilities are contained*, (such that a 'block universe' stands for a particular instance of the realized scenarios therein[21]). That is the metaphysical core beneath this principle.

Continuing on, we may briefly note that the extrusion principle has a huge array of favorable consequences, but one of the most immediate among them is that it now allows the hyperblock quantum wavefunction to remain unitary even over wavefunction collapses. This a crucially important result, and is interrelated with the heart of what makes this insight so ontologically powerful. Simply put, we now have that a collapse can only ever imply the shifting of perspective to a new rendering of the block universe, so therefore a single block universe can never house a wavefunction collapse. As such, with wavefunction collapses serving as the sole source of non-unitary evolution in Copenhagen quantum mechanics, we therefore have that any given Aethic block universe must hold fully unitary evolution. It is the illusion of an agent's perspective itself switching between such block universes, then, which creates the supposed breakage of unitarity, but ontologically the breakage is something of

[19]To give a related example of Einstein using just this sort of approach, consider his solution to the photoelectric effect in his annus mirabilis paper on the topic [27]. The fundamental overview of Einstein's insight is that he split one degree of freedom, (being the energy of a macroscale light beam), into two, (being the number of photons and the energy of each individual photon). Crucially, then, the core premise of the Einsteinian way is that in the face of an innavigable paradox—and in that scenario only—one ought to make the directed move of splitting one degree of freedom into two. In Aethic reasoning, then, we open on the idea that temporal ontology possesses just such a paradox.

[20]For reference, this epiphany occurred in a single instant during the week of August 19, 2022, while I was walking across my college campus. Sadly I never wrote down the day and time, so I only know it to have happened sometime during that week. I think it is in the running to be the single most pivotal thought of my life so far. More specifically still, the exact instant of realization occurred while I imagined flipping a coin, (a penny), in my mind's eye, and then watched to see it land heads. In the last moment while it was in the air, the thought came to me, rather like floodgates opening, when it feels like I got but a glimpse behind the curtain of reality for a split second. To this day, perhaps the most remarkable part of the experience is that it almost feels like something was revealed to me, in that I was effectively but watching an animation, and saw the result with my own eyes rather than having invented it.

[21]In other words, the extrusion principle may be initially rendered as the opposite supposition to assuming a separate instance of space to every possible world—rather the space itself is fixed and the Aethic degrees of freedom are allowed to vary.

an illusion. *Perhaps the epitome of the direct consequences of the extrusion principle onto the quantum mathematics is that now any single Aethic block universe is fully unitarily time-reversible.*

2.2.4 Understanding the Basic Reordering of the Multiverse

A key aspect of the extrusion principle is what is implies about the ordering of scope for the multiverse versus a physical universe. As a matter of fact, it is this very realization that represents the initial epiphany of Aethic reasoning which I underwent while walking across my college campus in August of 2022. The idea is localized in how we might contrast a classical multiverse with an Aethic superposition. With the implication being that we can encode the set of outcomes which correspond to some collection of resultant timelines within a single Aethic superposition object, the key idea is that *unlike in classical metaphysics, where a multiverse contains separate instances of the same space, in Aethic reasoning we instead imply a single space into which all variation in the multiverse is compressed as an Aethic superposition.* In effect, the priority of order reverses, with a block universe encompassing a multiverse rather than a multiverse encompassing a portion of a block universe, (as in an A-theoretic growing block, for instance, in which the current realization of the block is to branch into externally determined future possibilities). This is what gives an Aethic block universe its characteristic intrinsic superposition content, as such contrasting it with a classical static block universe.

The important additional point of nuance, then, is that even though a single block universe encompasses all superposition outcomes within the same physical space as oneself, it still follows that we need the Aethic dimension to actually collapse those superpositions, in effect requiring that the true external component to the block universe is the Aethic coordinate itself. In other words, even though a block universe contains superposition objects, there ought to be a one-to-one correspondence between a block universe and a particular superposition configuration, such that variation in superpositions is left purely to the encoding of the Aethic dimension. It is the duality between these two changes which underlies the extrusion principle.

2.2.5 A Disclaimer on the Ontic Difference Between Block Universes

Importantly, perhaps the natural rebuttal one might make against the extrusion principle concept (of shifting between block universes) is the prospect of whether such a shift physically changes the quantum wavefunction in the past, so as to screw up the energy density of matter in noticeable ways. This is certainly a valid criticism against the extrusion principle itself, but I must emphasize that it does not persist to the completed version of Aethic reasoning, in which the third postulate of the Aethus itself defangs this paradox.

In the completed vocabulary. To elaborate slightly using the terms from the completed Aethic reasoning, (which will be thoroughly defined throughout the paper), we only ever have that an extrusion principle update changes “disagreeing superpositions” to being fully state-decomposable, but cannot ever collapse “agreeing superpositions" directly to being state-decomposable without directly violating the third postulate. So, in the effect the defanging of sorts is to establish this extreme metaphysical prospect that is the extrusion principle upfront, and then later on constrain the paradoxical loopholes in it by virtue of the third postulate’s assertions. In particular, we have that a quantum measurement itself only ever captures a limited subset of the system’s degrees of freedom—be it an exact position at a finite number of points, an exact momentum, or something in between—because every heterogeneous channel of Aethic information-passing lacks access to the remainder, (the absence whose downstream signature, Fourier-generated by the path integral of the Quantum Nexus, is Heisenberg’s uncertainty principle [24]: quantum uncertainty joins the party last rather than standing as the root).

The reversed reading, diagnosed. The reversed reading — uncertainty as root, driving collapse by projection — is, on this diagnosis, a load-bearing source of quantum theory’s drift toward logical antirealism: an epistemic ceiling installed as an ontic ground floor. The pattern is not unique to physics: the same architecture-preserving reflex appears in observation-selection theory, where a reference class welded to complete determinate timelines, once strained, manufactures further classical histories (simulation-style constructions prominently among them) rather than relaxing the unit of reasoning — epicycles in the strict sense, and the Nexic companion makes that diagnosis explicit at its own scope, with this paper supplying the ontological result (the reversal principle’s verdict on complete timelines) that grounds the relaxation the companion performs.

What the fundamental theorem then says. By the “fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning" directly, then, all remaining unknowable properties of the system, as constitute the unknown parts of the wavefunction between measurements, permanently are to occupy an agreeing superposition.

So, the strict assessment from Aethic reasoning is that the measurement outcomes themselves ought to occupy a disagreeing superposition according to deduction from the third postulate of the Aethus, but the remaining properties which occur in the intermediate wavefunction remain forever in an agreeing superposition. This is why, when an agent moves to a new rendering of the block universe they only ever collapse disagreeing but not agreeing superpositions: the mere ability to make said attributes in disagreeing superposition state-decomposable is itself which implies they are disagreeing in the first place by the third postulate, and the intermediate wavefunction must forever maintain an agreeing superposition of its unknowable intermediate properties between measurements because of the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning. Altogether, then, the mere ability to transition an agreeing superposition (like the intermediate wavefunction) to being state-decomposable with an Aethic extrusion block universe update is in both cases forbidden by the completed Aethic reasoning, and so *that which is in agreeing superposition already in any given block universe will remain as such in all subsequent block universes*. So, in summary, while the extrusion principle ontology itself is of course extreme, in practice its dependence on disagreeing superpositions means that it does not cause quite so an extreme empirical difference in subsequent block universes anyway. (And the objection this subsubsection answers is, as Section 2.2.1 records, an objection to the block-universe picture rather than to the indexing it depicts: what re-indexing may and may not change is a fact about contents relative to Aethae, which is why the third postulate settles it.)

2.2.6 Why the Aethic Model is Original

Let us quickly touch upon why the Aethic model of the ontology of time is not simply the many-worlds interpretation [2, 3] of quantum mechanics, and instead is a fully original idea.

The key difference here is that the many-worlds interpretation is fundamentally an A-theoretic extension of the block—a growing block whose growth branches—such that all deviations to possible outcomes are contained within the branching at the present, and therefore are external to the physical structure of the existing block itself. With the Aethic model, however, we have that there is no intrinsic dependence of the branching of the Aethic Markov chain upon the present moment of the block universe, and furthermore it follows that all possibilities are already encoded into the physical constituents of the immediately prior block universe in the form of superpositions, (as is consistent with its satisfaction of the Markov property anyway).

Let us illustrate this idea with a use of Schrödinger's cat, being the thought experiment in which a cat in a box is either killed or spared depending on the random outcome of a quantum particle's decay. We will use this thought experiment to paint the picture of our next point, but one might just as easily substitute a safer concept like quantum spin state into the following argument if Schrödinger's cat seems to ontologically far-fetched. Now, let us paint the picture of why the Aethic interpretation of the wavefunction collapse is distinct from the many-worlds interpretation. Let us suppose that our agent in question—being the experimenter perhaps—has run the experiment at 2:00 PM, but only checks the state of the cat at 2:30. The Aethic premise, then, is the following: *as is consistent with the extrusion principle of Aethic reasoning, our experimenter's Aethic worldline must lead them into a new rendering of the block universe at the instant at which they look in the box and observe the state of the cat*. Given this supposition, then, let us now analyze the respective prior-block universe and subsequent-block universe of the experimenter.

In the prior-block universe alone, there is never to be a wavefunction collapse, so we are left with the strange result that the cat will never be able to leave superposition in that universe. Even at 2:30 in the prior-block universe, when the experimenter checks the box, they will have to find a cat in superposition, thereby putting themselves into superposition upon becoming entangled with the cat. This strange outcome, of course, is not what the experimenter themselves will observe, because such a happening may be regarded as that which kicks them into the next block universe along the Markov chain, such that they are never allowed to experience that outcome in first block universe directly. Rather than interpreting this as some nightmarish zombie-like scenario to unfold in the prior-block universe at 2:30, then, we might simply suppose that said block universe is merely an overlay of the two possible outcome block universes, such that in some sense the experimenter is still present there, but without being able to access the other block universe any longer.

Where this departs from many worlds. This may seem somewhat similar to the many-worlds interpretation so far, but the key point of deviation is our next Aethic result: *once the experimenter reaches their subsequent-block universe at 2:30 sharp, it follows that the cat in that universe was never in superposition in the first place, so therefore the effects even at 2:00 PM change with respect to the experimenter's perspective*. This notion may very well represent to heart of the extrusion principle,

in that it is a precise reinterpretation of the Copenhagen interpretation: that is, we have that in the subsequent-block universe, it is so that the past changes as well, such that tracing back in time within that block universe does not actually retrace the steps of the experimenter themselves, who has been in the other block universe in the prior moment. Specifically, the 2:00 PM of the subsequent-block universes holds that the cat had survived all along for the 'living' outcome block universe, and that the cat was dead all along for the 'dead' outcome block universe. The exact relation is stated once in the union subsection, (Section 2.4.5): branching is the correct phenomenology of records, and the framework deduces that phenomenology from the records themselves rather than positing it as a splitting of worlds, so that the branches become pockets of one disagreeing superposition in one spacetime without a prediction changing.

Time reversal, on the two readings. In the Copenhagen interpretation, we have that reversing time would make the superposition un-collapse, but in the Aethic interpretation we have that this cannot be so, because in the subsequent-block universe we have that there had never been a superposition in the first place.

Now, to be clear on this point, there had indeed been a version of the experimenter in the subsequent block universe all along, so we might ask what becomes of them prior to the experimenter's consciousness following the Markov chain to that universe at 2:30 sharp. The interpretation to this is quite simple: the experimenter of the *prior*-block universe in particular was essentially in superposition of occupying the consciousness of themselves in both subsequent-block universes at once. That is, we might go as far as to 'define' the experimenter at 2:00 in the prior-block universe as equating to the quantum superposition of themselves in each of the two possible subsequent-block universes for which the cat is alive or dead, respectively. Such is how we define the cat in the prior-block universe already, so by induction it follows that we might think the define the experimenter in a similar way. The key difference between the two, however, is that the experimenter has no way of proving or even knowing that they are occupying both versions of themselves at once at 2:00 PM, because, simply put, there are no discernible differences in their environment to tip them off. The cat, however, would obviously be well aware of being in superposition at 2:00 on account of one component of itself being dead, so we would suppose that even though the cat is in superposition relative to the consciousness of the experimenter in that block universe, their own consciousness cannot possibly be located there on account of the perceivable difference in available information to them between the two outcomes of the superposition. With this being something of an inductive argument at this point, let us raise it to the level of a full principle, for which the empiricism we have noted is simply the consequence.

Principle 3 (Aethic Base Principle of Superpositions)
In Aethic reasoning, we have that an agent's consciousness will always occupy whatever block universe in the Aethic Markov chain maximizes the surrounding superposition content of their universe without alerting them to a discernible difference between any two particular states in superposition.

Another way of expressing this is that, where a block universe may be written as the superposition of some number of alternative block universes, in effect putting all differing states between them into quantum superposition, it then follows that an agent's consciousness will occupy whichever block universe corresponds to the superposition of the set of all block universes which they could not possibly be alerted to the variation between in the moment.

Note that this principle will become the second postulate of the Aethus once we assign the right mathematical structure to it. Such will help us define it with a more mathematically objective grounding than merely a supposition of consciousness.

The principle, read with the vocabulary the paper later acquires. The box above is kept in its 2023 wording because it is the earliest form of the second postulate the record has, and its two phrasings translate exactly, clause by clause, into the mature apparatus; the translation is worth writing out once, since the box is where a reader first meets the postulate and the consciousness language can mislead. "Maximizes the surrounding superposition content" is the constructive blank of the second postulate: every attribute the Aethus holds no record of stands open, as an agreeing superposition over its answer space, and the block the agent occupies is the one in which every such attribute is open at once—the *largest* consistent superposition, not a chosen one. "Without alerting them to a discernible difference between any two particular states" is the condition of the Fundamental Theorem, (Section 8), and of the signature partition of Theorem 14: two alternatives stand in agreeing superposition exactly when no record in the block separates them, so that "could not possibly be alerted" means "no record exists, in any refinement, that distinguishes them." The word "consciousness" is a placeholder the Objective Principle later retires, (Section 2.3.2): the principle attaches to any record-bearing system, a

counter or a rock as much as an agent, and the "agent's consciousness" of the box is the Aethus of whatever holds the records. And the block-universe phrasing—"the superposition of the set of all block universes which they could not possibly be alerted to the variation between"—is the ladder ontology stated before it had the name: the agreeing cluster is one block relative to the Aethus, irreducible, and the alternatives that records *do* separate stand as pockets in disagreeing superposition around it. Read this way the box says, in three sentences, what the second postulate and the union principle later say in a section each: what is unrecorded is open; what is open is one thing, not a list; and an observer occupies the widest such openness its records allow.

Where the box stops short, and what completes it. The box supplies the principle's content but not its two later refinements. It does not distinguish a blank that is open from one that is merely unknown, which is the distinction the Deflation Reductio makes a theorem of, (Theorem 4): the box's "maximal superposition" is constructive, not epistemic, and the Bell leg is what shows it must be. And it does not say what ends the openness, which is the third postulate's work: an alternative stops being "one they could not be alerted to" the moment a record separating it exists anywhere in the block, past or future, so that the maximization the box describes is bounded by every record that will ever escape, (the vacuum reading, Section 6.6.2). With those two refinements attached, the Base Principle is the second postulate exactly, and the note inside the box promising as much was kept.

In conclusion for this argument, then, we have clearly shown that the Aethic interpretation of superpositions is distinct to the many-worlds interpretation, because the many-worlds interpretation holds a time-reversal interpretation which matches the Copenhagen interpretation, whereas the Aethic interpretation has a different perspective on this entirely, as emerges from its supposition that an entire block universe branches with the Aethic Markov chain, rather than only ever the future component of it. Let us now move to more epistemological arguments about this Aethic notion.

2.2.7 The Extrusion Principle as a Clarification of Relativistic Time

I want to be clear about my intended contextualization for relativistic proper time given the proposal of the Aethic extrusion principle. Plainly put, when a given major reconceptualizations for the ontology of time is proposed, it very often operates in ignorance of the theory of relativity, and so might propose things like "multiple arrows of time" or "perspectival arrows of time" which are at best ad hoc and at worst misguided. I believe in insisting on a charitable response rather than hostility, so rather than refer to starkness what I will say is this: *what these proposals do, be it due to lack of due diligence or whatever else, is miss an opportunity, which is perhaps the implicit source behind whatever frustration we meet them with. What this opportunity is, is consistency with the theory of relativity. To the naive viewer such a consistency might seem almost like a constraint or perhaps a stubbornness, but what is paramount to emphasize is that the theory of relativity, whether empirically or ontologically, is without question a pinnacle in the history of human thought for depth and elegance on the nature of time. We who have engaged with it, of course, know this fundamentally, which is why it ought to be taken as a condition for excellence to any ontological proposal that it does not conflict with any shade of this structural elegance.* When proposing a new reconceptualization for the ontology of time, then, the real question is *why miss the chance of consistency for relativity*, because the depth of relativity and all its deductive implications is indeed nothing short of striking, and neglecting to engage with that structure of implications is artificially establishing a conceptual difficulty for one's proposal.

Accordingly, then, a primary intention of mine in establishing the extrusion principle is to get this commitment right of refusing to minimize the theory of relativity. I want to unpack now how I am both aware of the common failure mode for new ontology of time proposals, and have actually designed the principle to do the very opposite—even if it admittedly might seem suspiciously similar to these failure modes by an informed reader at first encounter.

The way I would describe the extrusion principle's move in this light is the following: *Oftentimes when we discuss time in the theory of relativity, we smuggle in the full semantic apparatus of what we mean by "time", including its intangible phenomenological components. Of course, the theory of relativity itself, with its geometric nature of time, deliberately does not seem to accommodate these semantic layers, which leads proponents to rightfully articulate how this distinction exists, and in turn often leads to the reasonable conclusion that the extra experiential semantic considerations of time are merely an nonphysical construct. What I wish to point out, now, is how this is perhaps indeed a reasonable conclusion to draw once you have already asserted that the exhaustive semantic layers of time are attributed solely and precisely to Einsteinian dimensional time to begin with.*

The move of the extrusion principle, then, is to store all information about "alternative possibilities" in the sense of the Aethic rendition of possible worlds within the structure of distinct Aethic block

universes as indexed by Aethae and evolved over via the sequence structure of "Aethic time".

Aethic time is not relativistic time. *Aethic time, importantly, is not actually time in the rigorous sense of involving the proper time dimension within a block universe, but paradoxically is nonetheless proposed as containing the extra semantic layers to time which we may already establish for axiomatic well-definedness ought not to be contained within the relativistic time dimension. In a sense, then, Aethic "time" and the standard well-defined relativistic time dimension are jointly proposed to produce the full semantic landscape that we propose as time, both independently and in their conjunction.*

What I most wish to convey, then, is that this move of the extrusion principle is meant to be carried out in service of the Einsteinian dimensional concept, of all things. That is, by separating the implicit extra semantic layers to the human concept of time from the explicit dimensional picture of time in the theory of relativity, the goal is to at once resolve the misconception of attributing these extra semantic layers to the relativistic time concept (as well as its downstream consequences of trying to reject those experiential semantics altogether), and in turn crystallize the exact shape of the relativistic dimensional time concept for consistency with what physicists methodologically advocate for anyway. Altogether, then, the explicit service to the theory of relativity is to allow its time dimension to be interpreted genuinely as something of another dimension of space with breadth and personal motion along it, independent of any smuggled semantic connotations which only serve to obscure its mathematical elegance.

An analogy, and the service rendered. *For an analogy, it would be like trying to capture the beauty of Lagrangian mechanics in a society where people thought the Euler–Lagrange equations only worked if it was cloudy outside—removing this obstruction and reverting to our own society's streamlined understanding of Lagrangian mechanics enhances its mathematical beauty for the very reason that we would be cleanly attributing that beauty to precisely the right shade of the mathematical character as opposed to having to guess at it. In the case of the time dimension itself, the reason we call it "time" as opposed to one of the spatial dimensions is not because it is privileged over them in terms of relating to the linearity of experience (as attributes to Aethic time directly), but instead has merely been taken to fill this role because of how its negative signature in the metric prevents one from rerouting a worldline backwards along that dimension without having to pass through the light cone into the spacelike domain in the middle, thereby going at the speed of light for a brief moment. The point of the matter I wish to make, then, is that due to this reframe of the extrusion principle, we may move to see the time dimension as merely another domain for breadth in an identical sense to physical space, which only indirectly associates with the experiential semantics of what we call "time" due to this irreversibility property, as enforces a rough monotonicity constraint with the more experiential Aethic time parameter. Relativistic dimensional time still remains the universal domain of kinematic time from the Newtonian revolution onward, but those extra semantics that have been assigned to time by humans finds a home in Aethic time instead, so as to declutter the relativistic time dimension to the conceptual clarity at which it intrinsically existed from the beginning.*

The relativistic dimension of time is then taken to be merely another effective dimension of space, just with a negative metric sign. This frees it from having to carry all the baggage we normally assign to it pertaining to ineffable time-based phenomenology and their semantic context.

The service, stated once. What the paragraphs above amount to can be put as a three-way separation, each part given the carrier that can actually bear it. "Time," as the word has been used since Newton and through general relativity, has carried three things at once: a *geometry*—the proper-time direction, the ordering of events by earlier-than and later-than, the thing the metric measures; a *determinacy-driving*—the resolution of what is open into what is stated, the sense in which the future "becomes" the present; and a *tense*—the past, present, and future of the A-series. Relativity built the first and, by its own account, could accommodate neither of the others; the standard response has been to declare the others illusory, which is the perception-denial move, (Section 9.7.6), applied to time. The extrusion principle instead gives each its own carrier. The geometry stays with relativity's time dimension, which is asked to do nothing else, and is thereby returned to what it was built to be, another dimension of the block with a negative sign in the metric. The determinacy-driving goes to the Aethus and its centric unfolding: what is open relative to one index and stated relative to the next is a transition *between* indexings of one block, not a process within the block, and it is where the felt becoming was always located. And the tense goes to the index too, relocated rather than eliminated, as the A-series/B-series paragraphs below make exact. The service to relativity is that its time dimension is relieved of a semantic surplus it was never built to carry, and that the relief is paid for by the framework's own primitives rather than by a moving present or a preferred foliation;

the two directions—the proper-time direction of the geometry and the Markov-chain direction of the Aethic sequence—are disentangled once and for all, and neither is ever asked to be the other.

The move deserves its address in the philosophy of time, because that literature has carried a name for exactly this split for over a century.

The A-series and the B-series. The original derivation, (Section 2.2.3), was set up in this vocabulary and its conclusion is restated here from the side of relativity. McTaggart distinguished the *A-series*—time as past, present, and future, with the flow and becoming that make the distinction feel alive—from the *B-series*, the tenseless ordering of events by earlier-than and later-than [25]. In that vocabulary, the relativistic dimension is purely B-series, and the smuggling described above is precisely the reading of A-series content into a B-series structure. The century since has been a standoff between two repairs: A-theorists protect becoming by denying the block or by adding a moving present to it, inheriting the preferred-foliation problem the moment relativity enters the room; B-theorists protect the block by demoting becoming to illusion, paying with the very experiential residue their opponents refuse to abandon.

A third address: relocation. The extrusion principle's contribution, stated in this vocabulary, is a third address: the A-series is real, and it does not live *within* the block at all—it lives *between* blocks, as the Aethic sequence, where there is no foliation to prefer and no geometry to contradict. Neither elimination nor spotlight: relocation. And the relocation is performed from outside the theory's own supply chain: the block being served here was derived independently of relativity altogether, from the modal content of counterfactuals alone, (Section 2.2.1)—so the service arrives as repayment from an unindebted benefactor, rather than as relativity rearranging its own furniture.

The deepest implication: no catalogue. And the deepest single implication of the arrangement deserves flat statement here, where the block's survival is being credited: there is *no view from nowhere*—not epistemically but ontologically. No God's-eye catalogue of determinate facts exists for physics to approximate; there is one block, and determinacy indexed to informational perspective within it. (The statement is two-level, and the reconciliation of Section 2.2.1 is its precise form: the arena and its validity structure stand un-indexed—a space of vantages and its laws is not itself a vantage, the rule from configurations to record partitions among those laws, while any realized partition inherits its setup's indexing—and determinate *content* is what carries the index. Neither un-indexed item is new equipment: the validity structure is the third postulate's own predicate, un-indexed by construction since validity is what the postulate says *of* an Aethus and never what an Aethus says of an attribute, and the rule from configurations to partitions is record-individuation, the second guard on Theorem 14, run over the record sector. The catalogue is what does not exist; the grammar over its possible authors does.)

Two pieces of testimony mark how much was waiting to be re-housed, and both come from the block universe's own architects. Einstein, in conversation with Carnap, confessed that "the Now" worried him—that the experience of the present seemed to lie just outside what physics could grasp, and that this exclusion was a matter for painful resignation rather than triumph [28]. And Weyl, in the most quoted sentence the block universe ever received, wrote that "the objective world simply *is*, it does not *happen*"—with the experiential remainder relegated to the gaze of a consciousness crawling along its worldline [29]. Both men are marking the same residue, and neither is dismissing it lightly. The service this subsubsection claims is addressed to exactly their discomfort: the framework does not console the physicist by declaring the Now an illusion one more time; it gives the Now a formal address—transit along the Aethic sequence—outside the dimension's jurisdiction entirely, which is precisely what permits the dimension to be, at last, only what the geometry says it is.

2.2.8 Opening of Aethic Reasoning

Given the statement of the extrusion principle, we already attain our first key required condition of the Aethus: it must be a fundamentally subjective concept. We can derive this from the notions shown already just using a simple application of the thought experiment of Wigner's friend, which is a variation of the Schrödinger's cat thought experiment in which the experimenter, Wigner, had his friend check the state of the cat five minutes before him [30]. Just using the definition of the Aethus that we have drawn upon already, it follows that if Wigner's friend has found out the initial particle's state and Wigner has not, then we hold that they must be occupying two different Aethae[22], because

[22] Crucially, we can perform a generalization here to suppose that the Aethus is what we fundamentally mean when we say "quantum observer." As such, we see, by extrapolation, that if two different humans are two different quantum observers, then this now implies that the same human as two different times must, equally so, be two different quantum observers. This is a direct counterclaim to the postulate of static observer.

a difference in superposition implies difference in corresponding Aethus by the extrusion principle. As such, Wigner and his friend are compelled to exist at two distinct locations along the Aethic dimension. Given this notion, now, we are going to make a very important inductive claim about Aethic reasoning as drawn from this: an Aethus is, fundamentally, some kind of representation of the knowledge of an agent. Because, truly, all that distinguishes Wigner from his friend here is the contents of their knowledge, such that experience is also denoted as a form of knowledge. What we then get from this is that A) not only does knowledge have a genuinely locational-effect on an agent, but that B) it is the driving requirement behind resolving the major systematic issues in each of the static block and growing block universe models. And yes, of course, we see that superpositions are inherently an intimate consequence of one's own access over knowledge.

Let us quickly also imagine a variation of the thought experiment in which Wigner and his friend sit across a table from one another, and the fate of Schrödinger's cat is revealed from behind Wigner in the room so that only his friend can see it. This reveals something of an understandable objection to the extrusion principle, being the question of how Wigner and his friend can possibly be at different locations along the Aethic dimension if Wigner is staring right at his friend, and thereby confirming that they are sitting in the same room and therefore the same physical space.

The counterargument: what is meant by physical. The counterargument from Aethic reasoning to this is rather straightforward: what truly do you mean by physical space in the first place? Is it really that Wigner and his friend are sitting in precisely the same physical space, or might we have missed any of the discriminating characteristics of a physical space when we thought only to define it with three dimensions of space and one dimension of time? That is, given how we are already playing around with the concept of physical reality having an Aethic component in addition to only the spatial components which one is referring by to when they say "physical space," we might then suggest that characterizing a physical space only by its spatial profile is something of an oversimplification. After all, we see from Zeno's paradox [31] that disregarding derivatives in a physical space leads to paradoxes, and we see from special relativity that disregarding time as a dimensional component of a physical space also leads to paradoxes. With it being, generally speaking, a reasonable claim to suppose that there are qualitative elements to a physical space beyond what we first assume is the exhaustive description, we might then ask if the same is true here.

Picturing the Aethic dimension. The idea, then, is that we might picture the Aethic dimension itself, although physical by some sense, as being primarily qualitative in any practical circumstances. This is indeed somewhat similar to how we already picture time, even though we know from Einstein that it also has a physical component. In the case of the Aethic dimension, then, perhaps we suppose that even as Wigner stares at his friend, his friend is then and there qualitatively infused with his own unique Aethus, whereas Wigner himself is infused with his own Aethus.

A note on vocabulary, East and West. Comprehension for concepts like these is admittedly underdeveloped in Western philosophy, but the East has been studying them for thousands of years. The closest English word for this kind of qualitative infusion of something is what we might refer to as "consciousness", however we will show in the next few sections that Aethic qualities cannot be justifiably regarded as representing consciousness specifically. Truly what we are looking at is a new form of qualitative assessment altogether, (at least in the West), although one which is strictly correspondent to conceptual philosophy and empiricism of one's tangible life.

What to picture, and why it stays scientific. Regarding what one best ought to picture when engaging with this Aethic material, the recommended idea is that the very degrees of freedom which distinguishes the room as seen through Wigner's eyes as compared with through his friend's eyes are those degrees of freedom with which we attain that they are sitting at different spots along the Aethic dimension, even though they are indeed directly in one another's physical company. There is indeed something of a dualist element behind this, but to keep these ideas scientifically respectable we might then cite how without making our exact series of assumptions so far, we would still be stuck with the static block universe versus growing block universe paradox. As such, in some sense Einstein's razor [26] compels us to see things this way.

2.2.9 A Note on the Qualitative Facet of the Extrusion Principle

With our having outlined the structural facet of the extrusion principle, it is also equally important to understand its qualitative facet. Simply put, the understanding with the extrusion principle is that new physical space is not generated for each and every subsequent block universe in Aethic time to a given block universe. Instead, even though different such block universes are different up to the implication of their contents, (with said distinctions serving as the nodes in Markov chain in the first

place), *they still nonetheless occupy a single physical spacetime, and their apparent empiricism as distinct possible worlds is realized purely out of an inability for interaction between them.* This is a somewhat unusual claim, but it ultimately proves foundational to the use of the extrusion principle in higher iterations of Aethic reasoning. In short, what is so powerful about this claim—specifically in the domain of inductive reasoning—is that it allows us to interpret quantum superpositions like the ones at play in the double-slit experiment[23], and the distinguishing metaphysics between possible worlds as actually occupying two sides of the same ontological coin, (that is rather than one being strictly quantum, and the other being strictly spatial). In short, by understanding the mathematical structure of just such an ontological coin, we are able to potentially reverse-engineer the contextual aspects relating its variants, and thereby proceed to derive quantum decoherence from first principles. This is exactly the procedural aim of Aethic reasoning in the first place, at least as concerns the goal of the measurement problem.

The other highly important aspect of this qualitative facet is that it can be shown to hold an intimate connection with the effective "epistemological frame" of the observer themselves. This is to say that under the mindset of the extrusion principle, identifying the distinctions between block universes stops being about the objective complete contents at two distinct locations, and instead becomes about the degree of consistent information versus unknown information between two block universes in question. Specifically put, unknown information becomes just as objective a metaphysical property to a given block universe as known information, with the gaining of more information corresponding to a characteristically distinct block universe altogether. This is to say that each block universe may be considered to represent a different intermediate variation between complete ignorance and complete knowledge about the universe, such that what is known and what is unknown becomes the fundamental structural criterion which gives to it an abstract identity, (similarly to that abstract identity which makes the number three distinct from four). In this way, the block universes themselves form an intricate lattice structure—where some build on the information of others—and this is itself the proposal for the Markov chain structure which an agent necessarily traverses as a consequence of simply existing, (and attaining information while doing so, however involuntarily in the moment).

The metaphysical counterpart to unknowing being structural in a block universe, then, *is that superposition itself becomes the metaphysical realization of a block universe's inherent unknowing, thereby distinguishing this newer variety of block universe from a standard block universe in that it has a fixed intrinsic superposition content.* Specifically, so as to have a unique terminology, this metaphysical counterpart to what a quantum superposition is empirically and mathematically is known as a "Aethic superposition" in Aethic reasoning. According to the extrusion principle, superpositions are not uncertain statements about which fully-realized world we inhabit; rather, they are structural statements about the individual block universes themselves. Contextually speaking, the idea of an Aethic superposition is that since quantum physics itself is known to be completely compatible with special relativity, (exclusive of collapse, for which such becomes ambiguous), we thereby are able to allow a variation of a block universe in which a consistent and non-collapsing Aethic superposition is present within it. The act of an agent discovering the collapse of a superposition through observation, once more, then simply becomes the act of their moving into a new rendering of the block universe in which the superposition had never existed in the first place, all while the superposition remains completely unscathed in the original block universe. We might also remember how both block universes—and all others—play out on the same stage of a single physical spacetime, it just follows that with furthered distinctions of information, (so as to define distinct block universe), they cease to interact accordingly.

For example, if we imagine a block universe in which the outcome of a coin flip is unknown, and subsequently to the observation of the result we attain a possible world in which heads comes up and another possible world in which tails comes up, then we might concern the epistemological attribute of "coin flip outcome" as serving as a direct indicator to the lack of interaction between these two outcome block universes. In general, it is indeed this particular interaction-concerning structure which serves explicitly to replace the notion of separate possible worlds as seen in many-worlds [2, 3] or the like. So, in other words, if two friends inhabiting a single block universe each pick up even a single attribute in their random felt-time progression which is disjoint in realized state to that of the other, then from that moment onward their block universes will mirror this cumulative-contradiction by disallowing interaction between said two block universes. In effect, the version which each friend sees

[23] In which an electron traverses two slits and interferes as a wave with "ghostlike" copies of itself, being the mystery mentioned Feynman's quote on the subject: "In reality, it contains the only mystery. We cannot make the mystery go away by 'explaining' how it works. We will just tell you how it works. In telling you how it works we will have told you about the basic peculiarities of all quantum mechanics." [32].

of the other will be precisely the version which picked up an agreeing attribute outcome to their own. A helpful benefit is that this solves the multiple-observers problem rather swiftly, because we now have that the extent to which said observers agree on the realization of a given attribute state is the extent to which they will agree on their block universe location (along the Markov chain) with respect to said attribute state. That is, if they agree on a state exactly, then the cascading effect of which other deducible states they have in common will remain consistent between them, so as to then imply that their block universes may interact. There is no *ad hoc* assumption necessary—instead we merely deduce that isomorphism between subsets of all known states implies respective isomorphisms of the relevant subsets of properties in the block universe. This is the nature of what could perhaps be viewed as the mathematical inductive step upon the first postulate of Aethic reasoning directly.

In this view, the passage of time is not an illusion, nor is it a fundamental temporal process occurring within any given block. Rather, it is fundamentally the *transition across* blocks—the movement along the Markov chain—that gives rise to the experience of time's flow. Entropy, memory, and causation emerge as structural features of this extrusion process. Within each block, relativistic physics becomes the arbiter of change; but across blocks, quantum discontinuities and state transitions can be modeled without the need to invoke hidden variables or spacelike-induced nonlocality.

With our now having described the basic fingerprint of an ontological Aethus, let us engage in a full philosophical discussion of it. This will help us determine just as much about what it is not as compared to what it is.

2.2.10 The Extrusion Principle as in Aethic Reasoning

As briefly mentioned before with the fundamental role of the extrusion principle in licensing the second postulate of the Aethus's non-unknown-overwriting character, the Aethic extrusion principle is deeply necessary for the remainder of Aethic moves concerning superposition despite its potential appearance of extravagance on first reading.

Now let me briefly attempt to pedagogically motivate the Aethic extrusion principle from its operable role in the wider Aethic reasoning framework as opposed to its more isolated-like[24] motivation from temporal ontology resolutions alone. Perhaps a leading recommendation I can provide about starting to gain an intuition for the extrusion principle is to trace one's own life through the proper time of a single block universes versus through one's own subsequent block universes. Considering one's current Aethic block universe first, the key idea is that what you will do or be, episodically speaking, at some point in the proper time future within your *current Aethic block universe*—like for example the specificities for what you will be doing tomorrow night—itself occupies an intrinsic, irreplaceable disagreeing[25] Aethic superposition this block universe, but in its proper child Aethus. The intro-level explanation of the Aethic extrusion principle itself, then, becomes that such a location is *not* where you yourself—as a conscious agent—will be located tomorrow night: instead you will indeed be at that given spacetime location, *but* you will also have moved to a single subsequent Aethic block universe corresponding to whichever random outcome of the disagreeing superposition actually materializes to this version of you (via the centric unfolding process). This itself is what allows the disagreeing superposition to indeed be irreplaceable in *this* block universe of now, because you consciously seeing only a single outcome tomorrow is indicative of whichever subsequent block universe you find yourself in *then*, while just occupying the same spacetime event-location as tomorrow in the current block universe. In short (pertaining to the superposition), *it not overwriting, it is moving away.*

So, now for the key pedagogical move itself for actually intuitively comprehending the Aethic extrusion principle. To begin with, I recommend affirming for yourself the concept of how *Markov chain past, present, future* is a distinct degree of freedom from *proper time past, present, future*, so remember that these terms are not being used loosely but jointly to triangulate coordinates both in spacetime and the Markov chain.

1. In your current Aethic block universe, the proper time future holds many versions of you in disagreeing superposition—where, crucially, none of them are intrinsically singled out as *more*

[24] Indeed, the rhetorically tricky thing for me about presenting Aethic reasoning, in a word, is that most of its weight comes from the connections between the pillar ideas distributed throughout this paper as opposed to this pillar ideas themselves. That is, in a perfect world I would never be pitching you the extrusion principle *as a principle*, but *as the contributive graph-connective node which it really is within the full Aethic framework.* That is the thing to advertise because that, so to speak, is the real product.

[25] Note that "disagreeing superposition" is simply an Aethic keyword describing post-decoherence Aethic superpositions, (as manifest with "classical" exclusive disjunctions, more or less), as opposed to anything abiding by quantum coherence or the like. This is an oversimplified explanation, but you can find the formal Aethic explanation of this concept with the Aethic union principle (Principle 17).

real per this block universe in the same way as *your current waking experience is treated as "the real one" in the proper time present.*

2. Once you move along the Markov Chain to whatever random subsequent Aethic block universe you will find yourself in when your body has geometrically moved forward to that very proper time future, you will feel only one of the possibilities as the true episodic realization—precisely like how you feel the present moment in proper time and Markov chain position right now. So you of then will have preferentially selected one of those random possibilities for yourself then, but relative to the you of now even that person of you is merely one non-preferred possibility among several others sitting in the current block universe's proper time future.

3. The universalized key, then, is that to every single past version of yourself, now, relative to *their* block universe we see the same effect: you of *now* are currently, relative to their block universe, sitting in one farther-specified version among others occupying a disagreeing superposition. So in other words, you have two choices of viewing yourself: *the Aethus you currently have exhaustively covers a description of your thereby-conventionally-defined current Aethic block universe, and this is where you are currently located*, OR, *you yourself in the moment can be seen to genuinely be located in any old Aethic block universe of your past self of choice, but are located in one possibility among the proper time-present disagreeing superposition possibilities therein (such that you do not see the other options anyway, not because they fail to exist as in the former view, but here because disagreeing superpositions physically forbid interactions between alternatives).* Either description is equally accurate in describing your episodic reality—and the key is that they do not conflict in the first place—the former "current block universe" view is simply a convention which throws out from consideration the parts of the prior block universes which are blocked from interaction with precisely Markov chain-present you in the disagreeing superposition. In the ladder ontology section of the Aethic union principle (Section 2.4), the pedagogical term is that the current block universe is like a "pocket" sitting inside a given prior one, whose scope of existing material is strictly eliminative of superposition possibilities without being additive over any of them.

Against timeline-branching multiverses. This is actually sort of superficially similar to the classical timeline-branching idea of multiple versions of you existing non-preferentially as if a cloud relative to the present. The differences, however, are also significant: *the "reference" is no longer the "present" as if a monolithic object, but rather a more abstract Aethus-valued block universe rather than a more concrete or materialist spacetime-valued branch. Also, we disentangle the actual proper time geometric direction from the Markov chain direction, with the former being more like physical coordinates and the latter more like superposition-possibility-scope-containment in the effective-operational sense.*

2.3 Philosophical Makeup of the Aethus

Orientation. This subsection places the Aethus against the epistemological positions a reader will reach for, and the placement can be stated before the argument runs. The Aethus is not a Protagorean relativism about *truth*—one fact may be blank relative to one Aethus and stated relative to another without either being false—and it is not an anti-realism: what is indexed is the *attribution* of a value, not the existence of the world it is attributed to. It is closer to a relativism about *determinacy*, and the subsection's business is to show that this third position is stable where the first two are not: that it dissolves the Gettier problem rather than answering it, that it is compatible with a robust realism about structure, and that the quantum-logical antirealisms it will be compared to are what one gets by taking the indexing as a defect of the knower rather than a fact about the known. The reader who wants the short form should take the subsubsection on relativism versus anti-realism first and return for the rest.

2.3.1 Aethic Knowledge as a Non-Western Epistemology

A key starting point in the process of evaluating the Aethus epistemologically is reconciling it with the modern philosophical landscape. Frankly speaking, however, we quickly come across a few major points of incompatibility between Western epistemology and some of the implied Aethic-type epistemology that we might gather through implication from the Aethic extrusion principle. As such, let us address a few of these points, and in doing so imply an Aethic interpretation of the Gettier problem.

Let us consider the debate between Protagorean relativism and Platonic objectivism throughout the cradle of Western philosophy [33]. The distinction in these two stances arises from how they view the objective nature of truth: Protagoras takes the meaning of truth to follow from the beliefs of a particular agent, (in a sense making truth true so far as how one takes it as true for *themself*), whereas Plato instead views truth as an irrefutable and consistent epistemology of an objective nature. This seems a simple enough distinction, through which Plato is widely considered the victor for his counterargument to Protagoras: essentially speaking, Plato argues that relativism operates on intrinsically unstable ground, because in even arguing that relativism is correct, Protagoras is asserting an objective claim, and moreover for another agent to disagree with the existence of relativism would, according to relativism, render it false anyway. So for relativism to be true or false depends on how oneself considers it, which itself both violates and agrees with relativism—hence rendering it as essentially philosophical meaninglessness. With this argument being stated, let us argue that the debate itself is actually still far from settled. Specifically, even though Plato may very well have invalidated Protagorean relativism, it still may be seen that the debate itself between Platonic objectivism and Protagorean relativism serves as something as a false dichotomy, with the Aethic epistemology itself serving as a clear counterexample to it.

Consider the following thought experiment which attempts to reconcile epistemological knowledge with a more Darwinian approach to mental states, and in doing so helps highlight the non-Western tendencies of Aethic epistemology. Let us picture the life of a rabbit in the forest named Kevin, such that his brain, under the forces of natural selection, represents a sort of processing unit which converts sensory intake into a set of possible actions as weighted by their contribution to his survival. As Kevin hops through the forest, he is constantly scanning for predators in the back of his mind, all while attempting to complete the various tasks of the day like finding food and water. Business is, simply put, operating as usual. But then let us imagine one extra stimulus to occur at this moment: the sound of a loud crashing in the bushes to Kevin's back. There is a fraction of a second between the hearing of this, and Kevin's reaction, so let us zoom in to this one immortal instant and ponder some queries of it. Specifically, let us imagine how the processing unit that is Kevin's brain might respond to the following question: *what is the probability that Kevin is to die in the next minute?*

Quite staggeringly, we might suppose that such a probability, (and a strictly Bayesian form of probability, as we will have it), being what we will refer to as $\mathrm{P}(D)$, has risen by at least a few orders of magnitude from its usual state. This is specifically due to two contributions: A) the usual level of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ is quite low, on account of Kevin holding a life expectancy, on average, which is well beyond one minute, and B) the number of times which such a loud crashing occurs in Kevin's life is actually somewhat low, (with the general proportion involving predation being somewhat high), implying that in this one minute, $\mathrm{P}(D) \approx \frac{n'}{n} \gg 0$, where n is the average number of times per year in this forest in which such a loud crashing occurs, and n' is the average number of times in which such a crashing is followed by the immediate death of those who heard it due to predation. So we see from this basic analysis that the probability of Kevin not surviving the next minute, in such a scenario, is substantially higher than it is during the average moment of Kevin's life. This is so only due to the high correlation between such a crashing resulting in death as opposed to the substantially lower correlation between a more average moment resulting in death. What we see from this is that, somehow, Kevin's evolutionarily-informed brain is reading an extremely high probability of death from this stimulus, all while not actually knowing the specifics of the situation much beyond the awareness of the sound. If we momentarily imagine putting ourselves in Kevin's shoes, now, there is a natural philosophical question to be asked: *upon what ontological source is this probability drawn from?* Does it originate in Plato's objectivism, or Protagoras's relativism? It would indeed have to cleanly draw from one of the two if they are to be a true dichotomy of fundamental epistemology, after all.

What Kevin has been illustrating all along deserves its flat statement, articulated in full for the first time during this paper's own review: *Aethic truth abides at the knife-edge interface of experience with the real world.* An entry like *I proceeded through the intersection* is not, at bottom, an objective-fact claim but the Aethus of one's *experience* of proceeding—which is why it perturbs neither under mental deformations, (one may have only been dreaming, without any contradiction to that Aethus), nor under objective inconsistencies discovered later. This experiential-categorical character is exactly what the evidential-minimal scope setting of the counterfactual semantics conventionally preserves, (the first case of Section 9.5), and it is intertwined with the principle of Aethic accidentalism and the first postulate itself: the interface, not either of its shores, is where determinacy lives.

Let us now show why $\mathrm{P}(D)$ itself rigorously cannot be categorized through either Platonic objectivism or Protagorean relativism. In doing so, we may construct a new version of truth altogether, called

Aethic truth, which is tailored so as to source $\mathrm{P}(D)$. Aethic truth will thus be given to operate outside the objectivist-relativist dichotomy, through the notion of it being incompatible with both such options.

Platonic objectivism can be immediately discounted as the cause of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ with something of a straightforward argument: we can change the perspective in the forest. Rather than asking how Kevin reads his probability of death in the next minute, we can instead request the same probability of Kevin dying, but from the perspective of a bird in the sky. The bird, Gretchen, has the ability of viewing the unfolding events on the forest floor from the more objective standpoint of the air, so if there is indeed a predator on the approach to Kevin, they will be almost sure to see it. At the very least, Kevin has his back to the source, whereas Gretchen has a direct vantage point. As such, Gretchen's reading of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ will likely be of a different nature, either much higher if they spot a predator, or much lower if they do not.

No standpoint is perfectly objective. But even this bird, we can argue, does not have a perfectly objective standpoint. She is susceptible to human error, (or, perhaps bird error), and furthermore she cannot perfectly predict if the predator will successfully catch Kevin in the next minute, even if they are present. Birds cannot see the future, so therefore Gretchen lacks some levels of objectivity. We can continue on, then, with our hypothetical iterations of creatures who have even more objectivity than Gretchen, such as some infrared satellite in outer space or another hypothetical addition of the like, but the important matter of this is the nature of such an inductive chain itself: that is, no matter which agent we take the perspective of, there is always another possible agent with higher objectivity. Such a more-objective agent need not physically exist, but the point is that Kevin, as an agent, will always lack some layers of his own objectivity, which we might imagine being filled in by a more hypothetical perspective. But even this more hypothetical perspective, on account of being described with physical abilities, is then less objective than an even more objective viewer, who by such measures is even closer to uncovering the deterministic nature of $\mathrm{P}(D)$.

The principle. We can write a fundamental principle of Aethic reasoning using this claim, so as to use it in our epistemological construction.

Principle 4 (Objective Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
For any agent[26] *who views a situation, we can always imagine a more objective agent yet. Hence, no agent's net epistemology matches the objective world.*

There is an explicit message which we seek to portray with this notion: when we request the probability of Kevin's death from himself, we are taking such a result in terms of merely the sound, for which we know there is a high correlation to death. However, from the perspective of Gretchen, we can no longer claim that we are drawing our probability from the sound alone, for her ability to see the predator or not is far more decisive. Gretchen has still inherited the property of the sound which Kevin holds, but has also appended a further property which brings its resultant calculation of the probability far closer to a deterministic system of zero or one likelihood. It is from this notion, then, that we draw the following important claim: *due to every agent always lacking some property of information onto the system that another agent might possess, we hold that every single value of* $\mathrm{P}(D)$ *which each one of them takes is based upon their own subjective informational assessment of the situation, which is always a distinct property of themselves.* For example, if Kevin takes his probability of death as being directly associated with the sound, then such a supposition is to be different with respect to Gretchen, who instead takes the probability of Kevin's death as arising more from the added layers of properties which she is in possession of. Had she claimed that the probability of Kevin's death was associated with the sound in the same way, (hence amounting to something of an objective-based extrapolation from Kevin's perspective), and we would nonetheless claim, through the Aethic stetting of truth that we are now constructing, such a thing would be a contradiction with Gretchen's own assessment of the situation. So we have that an objective extrapolation actually yields a contradiction between two exchanged truths of this type, rather than an intrinsic compatibility as the objective paradigm might expect at a glance.

As such, *if we assumed that* $\mathrm{P}(D)$ *itself is drawn from Platonic objectivism, and it would follow that every single one of these measured values of* $\mathrm{P}(D)$ *would contradict every other value.* Through both

[26]This is so where the claim that an agent can see a deterministic universe is itself a contradiction to their being an agent in the first place, specifically because such a deterministic viewpoint has no literal or describable grounding in reality, (with one's ability to even accurately describe such an agent, perhaps, then implying that one is actually just such a deterministic agent oneself). More specifically put, we might imagine one's claim that some other agent, even if imaginary, views a deterministic universe, is itself a philosophically meaningless statement, in that it cannot be decomposed or related to any physical claims. This is somewhat analogous to claiming one has solved the Riemann hypothesis by returning the text: "*solution to the Riemann hypothesis.*"

lenses of simply supposing they are objective and then directly spotting many contradictory values, or by instead assuming them objective and then applying an extrapolation to find them contradictory in another agent's frame of information, and we find an inevitable proof by contradiction within such a supposition. In total, we ought not to even regard $\mathrm{P}(D)$ as being expressive through Platonic objectivism. The next immediate claim, then, can be to further suppose that every value of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ is just as real as any other value, with there being no fundamental favoring from one perspective against another. This can be seen as somewhat analogous to the principle of relativity in special relativity, which does not give preference of realism to any one reference frame over another.

Principle 5 (Aethic Principle of Relativity)
As is akin to the principle of relativity from special relativity, we hold in Aethic reasoning that the degree of correctness to how one agent evaluates an Aethic truth versus another cannot ever be solely measured by the respective objectivities of the agents themselves. Simply put, an Aethic truth ought to have an independent value of correctness to every agent and to them alone, with the very truth value of the correctness being agent-dependent. (The first postulate of the Aethus can then be thought of as a yet even stronger equivalent to this base principle).

In such a picture, then, the Aethus itself can be thought of as analogous to the informational reference frame of an agent. This occupies a kind of ontological definition of the Aethus, with the coming mathematical definition satisfying more of a generalized mathematical structure which is able to depict such an ontology formally.

One might argue against this principle by supposing that there is in the least a more objective viewer to any given agent, who as such can be argued to hold a superior stance, but even the supposition of which observer is more or less objective is an assessment that cannot be reliably stated from the perspective of any single agent, who by the objective principle of Aethic reasoning already does not possess the objectivity needed to establish such a thought. We then see that at least from the perspective of any particular agent, that which is objective is only so in dependence with the epistemic perception of what is objective. As far as an agent is concerned, this will never not be circular logic.

With the combined suppositions that every value of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ undergoes its own principle of relativity, not instating an objective ordering of validity to different values under different agents, and also that the very supposition that $\mathrm{P}(D)$ can not be Platonically objective, then we hold that it is at least possible to define a hypothetical system of ontology in which every value of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ is fully and fundamentally real with respect to its corresponding agent. The very ability of ours to state such a stance without contradiction, then, is proof that there exists an alternative representation of truth beyond Platonic objection itself. Remember that we need not even prove this alternative system yet, but the simple ability of it to exist and be stated is reason enough that, in the least, there is a formulation and interpretation to ontology of truths which is not encompassed in Platonic objectivism. We need now to simply show that this is also beyond Protagorean relativism, and we would have developed a stance beyond the Western dichotomy of philosophical truth.

Let us now consider the compatibility between our proposed interpretation of truth against Protagorean relativism. The simple answer to this might be that given how Plato has already shown Protagorean relativism to represent a false stance, we therefore have to conclude that Protagorean relativism cannot be the ontological source of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ on account of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ being empirically true while Protagorean relativism is ontologically false, but let us test it nonetheless against $\mathrm{P}(D)$ to analyze where it specifically fails in this context.

Where Protagorean relativism fails here. Our approach into this should work as follows: we can note that the value of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ itself is entirely independent of Kevin's opinions. This is the part that becomes a bit philosophically tricky, but it is crucial information toward reconciling this. So, simply put, we can show that at no point was Kevin's felt experience of $\mathrm{P}(D)$, on account of the information presented to him, truly a mental function of his reasoning or even emotions. That is, for the sake of analogy, such a processing is subliminal to the entire mind in a similar fashion to how the subconscious mind is subliminal to the conscious mind. That is, we have to picture $\mathrm{P}(D)$ as somehow being completely distinct from Kevin's own agency or capacity of interpretation, simply because if we assumed the alternative, then it would be possible for Kevin to change the value of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ just by willing it to be so. Even more basically, we can deliberately assess that when Kevin is in that moment when he assesses danger, his mind itself tells him that the cause of such danger is external—as in that it did not choose to put the danger there or choose to hold it as existing—rather it simply inherently holds it as existing in response to an unalterable external truth of sorts. That is, even though Kevin mentally chooses to react to the danger, as would be in more the Protagorean relative scope, he nonetheless

has a clear external component to the intake of the sensory information itself which triggered such a mental assessment. Let us remember that this value of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ itself, while not being fully Platonically objective, is sourced from a compilation of information that is not willed into existence by the mind, nor is intentionally viewed by the mind. The ontological blip of truth which is accessible to Kevin through his Bayesian degrees of belief in that instant is both strictly characteristic of his subjective experience, all while being triggered by and perhaps contained in forces just outside his conscious sphere, as is the skin of an apple to its flesh.

The word for it. Once again, Eastern philosophy comes to the rescue with regard to our hopes of understanding this style of knowledge within an existing philosophical doctrine. Specifically put, it is commonly known as the Sanskrit word "Jñāna", which means the kind of knowledge that abides at the depth of sentience rather than of reasoning or belief. Through such things, then, this avenue of philosophical analysis must lead us to conclude that whatever the ontological source is of $\mathrm{P}(D)$, it cannot be Protagorean either, (at least through the lens in which Plato describes it, where Protagorean relativism is fundamentally opinionated).

What has been shown. As such, we have essentially accomplished two things here: we have both shown that this $\mathrm{P}(D)$ is decidedly not Platonic or Protagorean, and in doing so we have come up with our first concrete example of a piece of Aethic information. It is the generalization of such information to the entire array of Kevin's life that will serve as the backbone of Aethic reasoning.

One final important note to make at present is a more nuanced analysis of why exactly Protagorean relativism was invalidated through Platonic objectivism. Let us consider the following further principle of Aethic reasoning.

Principle 6 (Dual Logic Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
In Aethic reasoning, we hold logical causality and practical or physical causality as two distinct notions which require separate ontological assessments[27]*. We shall refer to these as* ***abstract logic*** *versus* ***causal logic****, respectively. The specific Aethic supposition, now, is that while abstract logic is still not allowed to be contradicted between the Aethae of two agents, on account of it being somewhat intrinsic to an Aethus anyway, we can now very much hold different representations of causal logic between two Aethae. To put it another way, causal logic allows Aethic manipulation, whereas abstract logic does not, and is rather a source of manipulation onto an Aethus if anything, (through its use in the Aethic mathematical framework).*

A more inductive way of expressing this principle is that "each instance of abstract logic has a fixed truth value across all valid Aethae, whereas each instance of causal logic does not have a fixed truth value across all valid Aethae." Notice that this representation should be cautioned against as the base definition of abstract versus causal logic, and instead should only be used as a subsequent corollary of notice after one defines the Aethic mathematical structure. This is meant to help avoid any circular logic, as Aethic attribute relations are themselves given to be instances of abstract logic per their definition.

The premise of the dual logic principle, then, is that the mere supposition of categorizing abstract logic and causal logic together under the same category of a "claim" is an arbitrary linguistic artifact that has no ontological grounding whatsoever. In this way, it is akin to inventing a new word which specially denotes either an apple tree or the planet Saturn, for example. The ontology behind it is baseless, to the point where forming an argument which is rooted in that fallacy may automatically be disregarded. At its core, then, the dual logic principle is a semantic one, which highlights that Plato's argument against Protagoras is merely arbitrary when used against the relativism of Aethic reasoning.

To state this explicitly, we can suppose that the direct epicenter of Aethic reasoning's resistance to the Platonic argument against relativism is the state of existence of invalid Aethae. For an Aethus to be able to be objectively unrealizable, then, means we have a place to store all of the conflicts with abstract logic without being obliged to keep said Aethae valid. In effect, we have a fully relativist structure, (being the collection of all possible Aethae), which is endowed with a validity operation, (being perhaps not so much objectivist as relational itself, given that it is merely a function of an Aethus), and from such a thing we have constructed direct resistance to the argument which befell Protagorean relativism. The state of invalid Aethae having to play a role in Aethic reasoning, then, is mathematically existent

[27]The abstract/causal distinction here is structurally analogous to the standard modal-logic distinction between necessary truths (true in all possible worlds) and contingent truths (varying across possible worlds) [34, 35], with the broader philosophical lineage going back at least to Leibniz's distinction between truths of reason and truths of fact [36]. The dual logic principle is best understood as an Aethic restatement of this distinction rather than as a novel categorical primitive. What is specifically Aethic about the present development is the structural role the distinction plays in establishing the framework's self-referential consistency—namely, that the truth value of Aethic reasoning itself must be abstract-logical because supposing it could be in Aethic superposition produces an invalid Aethus.

as a direct corollary to the dual logic principle. Our choice of using them for mathematical claims throughout the remainder of this paper, then, (be it Aethic Bayesianism of the third postulate), might be considered to be justifiably induced from this very node of the argument.

To put this into practical application with the current analyzes again, we can suppose that Kevin's own determined value of $\mathrm{P}(D)$ in the moment of hearing the sound represents a form of causal logic, allowing Aethic manipulation.

However, switching gears to the Platonic invalidation of Protagorean relativism, now, we can see that Plato is specifically arguing that Protagorean relativism is false on the account of it referring to itself as objectively true all while asserting a subjective evaluation of truth in all cases.

The two cases, and the counter to each. We can now argue that such an argument is only directly valid in two cases: either Protagorean relativism implies truth-relativism over abstract logic as well as just causal logic, or the stance of Protagorean relativism as being true in the first place is an instance of causal logic. By De Morgan's theorem, we need to find a counterargument against both points in order to uncover a workaround to Plato's argument, (which can be put into direct use in Aethic reasoning). The second of the true is more straightforward, which argues that the truth value of Protagorean relativism could be an instance of causal logic. We can immediately counter-argued this with the coming corollary of Aethic reasoning that *no ontological paradigm is permissible with holding a truth value which is not abstract logic.* As such, that second point is checked off as definitively false under the presence of the dual logic principle. Regarding the other notion, being that Protagorean relativism implies a truth-relativism over abstract logic, we can simply now argue that this is not so! That is, we can assert that Protagorean relativism is to only hold truth-relativism over causal logic, and strictly never over abstract logic. If we simply incorporate such a principle into the abstract logical-foundation of Protagorean relativism, and under the dual logic principle we hold that this new rendition of Protagorean relativism is no longer applicable with Plato's counterargument. This notion can also be put into effect for Aethic debates of validity, if need be.

The wider supposition. The main supposition, however, is that the entire issue of the strongly objectivist-leanings of modern Western society may, in part, be traced back to the initial assumption by Plato and others that abstract logic and causal logic might be one in the same. For all we know, Protagoras may have been arguing for something more akin to the dual logic principle of Aethic reasoning, but due to his being a lifetime older than Plato such a dialogue may have only been taken from Plato's perspective [33]. Of course that is mere brute speculation, but it is worth pondering over due to the vast ripple effects that it may have contributed to. In short, we hold that the Platonic-versus-Protagorean dichotomy of logic is not only a false dichotomy by itself, but we also hold that the very assessments of logical ontology upon which they both depend are interpretive at best. That is, the neglection of anything akin to the dual logic principle here described is a sign of oversimplification, if only to an initially subtle degree. Of course, Western thought is otherwise known for its nonprejudicial assessment of people and ideas. Right? More like not by a long shot. Western thought has made something of a habit of forgetting the important details, but who am I to say anything about it?

Let us now switch gears to give examples of each of abstract logic versus causal logic. To give an example of a certain piece of abstract logic, to begin with, we might suppose that the property of existence of De Morgan's theorem itself, (as was just mentioned, for example), is clearly an example of abstract logic, because for it to be otherwise would spell a myriad of issues throughout Aethic reasoning and any single logically cohesive notion. (To be clear, we need not even agree with the truth value of De Morgan's theorem to categorize it as abstract logic—merely the stance of it being both at once causing a directly perceivable paradox will do. Here that paradox is that logic will no longer function, which we know not to be the case through axiom. And yes, said axiom will still be an example of abstract logic).

How to categorize. The general categorization of a property as abiding by abstract logic versus causal logic is usually somewhat simple: we do so by assessing whether it logically implies the truth value of any single ontological paradigm, and if but a single one can be named with validity of formulation, then said property is an instance of abstract logic. As for whether something is instead causal logic, the categorical procedure is also somewhat easy—one must simply decide whether its truth value tends to be an approximation or not—especially in a physical sense. For instance, when one claims that *an apple seed causes an apple tree*, we can clearly categorize such a thing as causal logic. Specifically, the logical implication being made here is not really logical at all—it is experiential, and or practical in a tangible sense.

Why the distinction matters here. This intuitive distinction itself can be seen as the backbone inspiration for thinking in terms of the dual logic principle: that is, an apple seed only approximately

causes an apple tree—because the seed might fail to grow—and an apple tree only approximately implies an apple seed—because through random chance there is a list of alternative sources to the tree, as rare as they may be. (For example, a quantum fluctuation is on this list. It may be practically inconsequential, but its very possibility in an ontological light is already sufficient proof that seed-to-tree causality, and its converse are both examples of causal logic). It is the distinguishment of properties into either abstract logic or causal logic which will form a foundational role in the logical intuition of Aethic reasoning.

Notice that this distinction of abstract logic versus causal logic never directly assesses the intrinsic states of the involved objects themselves, and instead is merely relational. This contrasts it with distinctions like the abstract versus concrete dichotomy, which is categorical toward objects themselves rather than relations between objects.

One object, both logics: the orange on the table. To give an example of why the same property object can engage in both abstract logic, consider the statement, *there is only an apple on the table.* We can show that this statement is connected to the statement *there is not an orange on the table* definitively through abstract logic alone, because such a thing is itself a logical consequence of the former statement. When we suppose that the former statement *implies* the latter statement, our specific use of the word "implies" is in reference to abstract logic. As will be seen Aethically, for us to imply the falsehood of this total statement of implication would be an Aethic contradiction, which is a stronger form of contradiction unique to Aethic reasoning. This tells us that such a total statement of implication is itself an instance of abstract logic, specifically because its truth value is fixed across all valid Aethae. Such a usage of abstract logic will become important once we rigorously define the Aethus, specifically because Aethic attribute *relations* are given to operate under strictly abstract logic, even though Aethic attributes themselves are instances of causal logic, (due to Aethic truths fundamentally being instances of causal logic, as per their ability to be manipulated under causal logic via the dual logic principle). Regarding a statement that is connected to *there is only an apple on the table* using causal logic, we might consider the statement *someone will have eaten the apple by tomorrow.* This can be considered causal logic, this time, for two reasons. 1) it is clearly not a logical guarantee in the first place, and more rigorously, 2) its truth value is not fixed across all valid Aethae.

The implication's truth value against its terms'. It is also crucial to note the difference between the implication's truth value, versus the truth value of the items within the implication themselves. For A to logically imply $\neg B$ may very well be in effect, hence holding that A and $\neg B$ are connected by forward implication with abstract logic, and yet such a statement does not itself tell us whether A or B is true—merely that they cannot both be true. As such, in this example, $A \to \neg B$ would be a statement of abstract logic, whereas A itself could be abstract logic or causal logic, depending on its context of application[28].

Relations instantiated as content. This all being said, then, we can indeed instantiate relations of abstract logic or causal logic themselves, forming a kind of second-order object which encodes a relation of the proper type. For instance, De Morgan's theorem itself can be seen as an instantiation of abstract logic, specifically where it serves as a kind of proposed equivalence relation between the Boolean statements with which it corresponds. An instantiation of causal logic, alternatively, could instead be the phrase "leads to" in the context of the sentence "lack of water leads to thirst" to give an intuitive example. This helps highlight the fundamental notion of abstract logic and causal logic being entirely distinct as concepts, with our supposition of their holding like structural framing being merely an artifact of our language.

To describe these notions in the specific Aethic terms which we will engage in later in the paper, *even the supposition that we can put the truth value of Aethic reasoning in Aethic superposition is a paradox, for Aethic reasoning would be applicable to itself and not applicable to itself at once. This is very foreign from the directed and logically-cohesive notions of Aethic superpositions, because this state of two properties at once is not logically-constructible. In a word, it is very logically poor. As such, we can assert that even the supposition that the truth value of Aethic reasoning can be put in Aethic superposition begets an invalid Aethus, hence hiding it forever outside one's ontological scope. Therefore, by extension we have that the truth value of an ontological paradigm can never be regarded*

[28]Importantly, we will see with further Aethic arguments that $A \to \neg B$ never holds a different truth value between any two valid Aethae if it is asserted to be abstract logic, even if A and B are in superposition of being both true at once in that Aethus. The key is that we get away with this by setting both of them to blank within that Aethus, however if we had ever truly stated A in an Aethus, then B would always hold a deterministic fixed value as a function of the assigned value of A—with this notion itself being logically equivalent to the prospect of $A \to \neg B$ being an instance of abstract logic. If we leave both as blank, though, then the supposition that such a thing still has anything to do with the truth value of that logical implication would merely be an instance of *the blank-stated fallacy.*

as causal logic, otherwise we have to imply the existence of invalid Aethae. We instead nip this in the bud, then, and suppose that some properties are just without the ability of inward Aethic manipulation. Such properties are what we might identify with abstract logic.

Math errors ought not to count toward Aethic knowledge themselves, even if one is unaware that an error was made. For example, if you approximate at a glance that $1/40$ is less than or equal to 1% instead of the more accurate 3%, then your previous knowledge of how the range from 0% to 1% does not contain $1/40$, however vague in the moment, (on account of drawing from higher-order thinking), should still be sufficient to Aethically derive this fact, (satisfying the condition of Aethic knowledge that the set of all derivable properties based upon some set of Aethic truths is also an Aethic truth relative to the same Aethus), hence showing that mathematical identities, in the broad sense, are always present in one's Aethus by default. We can consider it something of an axiom to the Aethus that such broad mathematical identities tend to fall under the umbrella of derivable statements, hence implying that they spread from one's static Aethus to their Aethus upon taking the Aethus equivalence operation, (as is essentially the mathematical phrasing of the notion). This helps deduce, at least in part, some of the motivation behind defining abstract logic as being fixed across all comprehensible Aethae, and thus why it ought to be distinguished from causal logic in the first place.

Also please quickly note that one's choice of whether the objective principle of Aethic reasoning is ontologically deeper than the dual logic principle, or vice versa, is up to the interpretation of the epistemic thinker in question. Either direction of implication, (under a strictly abstract logic sense on account of them being ontological principles), is perhaps acceptable, so long as one remains consistent with it. Let this be a topic for further philosophical analysis, if need be. Moreover, the parallel between the two is indeed a very important part of the picture, because the trichotomy we have supposed between subjectivity, Aethic truths, and objectivity is only really applicable in the space of causal logic. Abstract logic itself, then, we might still refer to as "objective", but of course of a very different form from the causal logic notion of objectivity discussed earlier. We then see that these two very distinct concepts, being the abstract logical truth objectivity versus the higher-causal logic-awareness objectivity are in fact two totally distinct notions under this dual logic principle of Aethic reasoning. Our very supposition of equating the two, then, has occupied the state of one very large barrier between us and our measurement problem solution. But yes, abstract logical objects occupy one partition element of what we might refer to as "objective", whereas the objective category of causal logic occupies another. All of the context clues will be provided in the remainder of this paper, at least, for discerning these two epistemic objects.

A major area of fallout from the classical association of objective abstract logic and objective causal logic lies in the interpretation of the field of epistemology itself. Considering how it concerns the philosophy of knowledge, the immediate question now is *whether it associates more with objective abstract logic, or instead with causal logic.* As will be something of a loose terminological system for this paper, we will primarily use the term *epistemological* to denote strictly objective abstract logical systems, (so as to hold the proper connotation of a paradigm which comes with the word), and then *epistemic* to denote causal logical systems, (be them objective, Aethic, or subjective).

2.3.2 Outlining the Consequences of Aethic Subjectivity

The thought experiment. Aethic knowledge, as just introduced, is neither quite subjective nor quite objective, and the quickest way to see what it is instead is a case. Charley is a chef who bakes a pie for himself and his roommates, Alice and Bob. He sets it on the stove to cool, leaves the kitchen briefly to put his apron in the wash, and returns to find the pie gone. Only Alice and Bob were in the house. Suppose two things: that Charley genuinely does not know who took it, and that he holds no clue from which he could deduce it. Then he holds no Aethic information on the question at all—and the second supposition is needed as well as the first, because Aethic knowledge is closed under deduction, so a clue would already count as knowing. The test for this is simple: if Charley held any information bearing on who took the pie, it would tilt his probabilities one way or the other; his probabilities are not tilted; so he holds none.

What Charley's Aethus contains, and what it does not. Now generate the possible worlds consistent with what Charley knows. In some of them Alice took the pie; in others, Bob; and since the worlds agree in every other respect, (the case is stated from the moment Charley re-enters the kitchen), two suffice, A and B. Everything in Charley's Aethus is present in both A and B. The converse fails: A contains the fact that Alice took the pie, and B that Bob did, and Charley's Aethus contains neither, on pain of contradicting the supposition that he does not know. So Charley's Aethus sits strictly inside each world, and the two worlds differ exactly where his Aethus is silent. The consequence to notice is

that *if A and B are treated as objective worlds, Charley's Aethic knowledge is identical under both*: nothing in his information state distinguishes them.

The symmetry argument. It follows that Charley's Aethus is not coupled to one of the two worlds rather than the other, since such a coupling would be a preference his information state does not contain. Four steps make this exact.

1. For Charley's Aethus to know whether it is in A or in B, it would have to be in the corresponding world.

2. The objectivity postulate of Aethic reasoning distinguishes an objective reality from an Aethus, so the two are not to coincide in their epistemic properties by fiat.

3. If Charley's Aethus nevertheless coincided with A or with B while holding no information as to which, then an Aethus would coincide with a particular possible world independently of its own content—not-knowing would favor one world over the other—and the Aethus would not be an epistemic object distinct from a possible world at all, but an arbitrary attachment to one.

4. Therefore Charley's Aethus favors neither A over B nor B over A, by any measure.

The general form of the conclusion is a principle.

Principle 7 (Indiscriminate Scenario Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
As we see from the above derivation, it follows that in a purely epistemic light, an Aethus cannot favor one fully fleshed out outcome scenario over another while still being definable without extra arbitrary information.

Another way of expressing this idea is that given an ensemble of possible Aethae which the agent in question may traverse the Aethic dimension to upon learning more information, we hold that no single one of these Aethae is to be given as intrinsically more objective than the next with respect to the original Aethus in question of the agent, (at least to the extent of epistemic analysis).

The Aethus sits on both worlds at once. For Aethic knowledge to remain independent of Platonic objectivism, then, a symmetry argument requires that Charley's Aethus be in neither A to the exclusion of B nor B to the exclusion of A; the framework's supposition is that it is situated upon *both objective realities at once.* An Aethus can accordingly be pictured, as a first intuition, as the set of possible worlds it is consistent with. The picture carries two connotations together—an epistemic one, since the set is fixed by what is known, and an ontological one, since it always corresponds to a physical reality of some kind, with "real" here taking whichever connotation the domain supplies, from philosophy to physics to the arts. This is the seed of the first postulate, developed in the sections to come.

The reversal. A decision is now forced. If an Aethus can be equated, informationally, with a set of possible worlds, which of the two is the more fundamental unit of reality: the possible world, with Aethic truth read off it in the standard direction, or Aethic truth itself, with possible worlds emergent from it? Aethic reasoning chooses the latter, and names the choice.

Principle 8 (Epistemological Reversal Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
Rather than treating an Aethus as a set of possible worlds, such that a possible world is defined by information down to every last specific detail, in Aethic reasoning we reverse the priority of things. In the more standard "set of possible worlds picture for metaphysics", we inadvertently prioritize the unending collection of information to a possible world as a unit of physical reality, but in Aethic reasoning such a supposition is viewed as a construct. Instead, we are now to reverse the prioritization so as to instead regard the basic unit of information as the fundamental unit to reality, such that we are viewing the spectrum of unit information to expansive information from the Aethic side rather than the classical side.

As such, we now argue that for any set of possible worlds we might wish to describe, we can substitute it in Aethic reasoning with the Aethus of consistent information across that set, and then generate the remainder of reality through the corresponding Aethic means instead[29]*.*

Why reverse, and where the reversal came from. The motivation is economy of a specific kind. An Aethus rests on a finite number of known attributes; a possible world is specified only by an unending number of them, and that unending specificity is both epistemically unavailable and restrictive to

[29] However, even in stating it like this, we must remember that a possible world is considered epistemically fallible as a concept in Aethic reasoning, for its incompatibility with certain coming Aethic principles like agreeing superpositions, so a possible world's applicability begins and ends as an intuitive stepping stone to comprehending Aethic ontology.

the framework's way of working. Rather than supposing and carrying every property of a possible world, the Aethic analysis begins by noting which attributes are known and localizing them to an Aethus, which is the Occam-compatible starting point. To say plainly what caused me to make this shift in my own philosophizing: it happened while I was working on a project that combined probabilities from many possible timelines, and I realized it would be far more efficient to interpret those probabilities from the shared-attributes side than from the side of fully specified possible worlds. The basic mathematical structure of the Aethus, as the coming sections present it, was built to do that job intuitively. That was a literal instance of the reversal principle at work; the larger notion is to carry it from the arithmetic of probabilities to physical reality itself, and then to its metaphysics.

One may also note some of the parallels between this rendition of the Aethus, and existing philosophies like two-dimensionalism. In two-dimensionalism, we have a distinction between a primary intention, representing an agent's practical perception of an object, versus a secondary intention, representing that object's background objective being [37]. In a sense, we have that a primary intention is very similar to Aethic knowledge, whereas secondary intention is very similar to the objective nature behind that. The reversal principle, in such a context, can be thought of as the supposition that the Aethic knowledge is actually the more ontologically fundamental of the two, simply out of there being no alternative ontological system which is still non-arbitrary in at least one way. Even though the background objective world is perhaps undoubtedly more physically real than one's abstract Aethus, we nonetheless have, through the reversal principle, that the Aethus is necessarily to be treated as more ontologically fundamental out of representing the windshield to one's mind, so to speak. Any single perception of reality that one ponders which is decidedly different than their Aethus in at least one way is a perception of reality that is thereby arbitrarily associated with them, hence supposing that one can never truly escape or otherwise see beyond the provided epistemological boundary that is their Aethus, quite by definition. Notice that this is by no means a form of solipsism, because where solipsism declares that the external world to oneself does not quite exist, instead with the Aethic reversal principle we are arguing a notion of a completely different nature: that is, we are simply pondering a more geometric notion of an agent, being that their particular rooted node of reality tends to be their Aethic layer rather than their objective reality layer.

From this epistemological reversal principle, we might then immediately think to derive an ontological reversal principle, which seeks to answer the question, *but then where are we, really?* If we have shown that an Aethus is epistemologically more fundamental than a possible world, then we might also ask if it is more ontologically fundamental. For it not to be so would directly violate Occam's razor, after all, because our ontology would rely on an arbitrary epistemological system. As such, we might suppose the following extension of the base reversal principle.

Principle 9 (Ontological Reversal Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
Given that an Aethus is epistemologically more fundamental than a possible world, as is the claim of the base reversal principle, then we might further suggest that an agent themselves is fundamentally and directly attached to an Aethus in the metaphysical sense, with their association with one or more corresponding possible worlds being merely tangentially relevant.

In making this claim, however, we lose the objective footing of a possible world in describing the stuff of the universe. That is, the postulate that any two humans in communication share a possible world is a luxury of our metaphysical paradigm, because it allows us to express notions of realism in an objective sense, and without having to always cite the reality in which such a notion is true. That is, I might remark to a friend that "*that three is tall!*" and without explicitly saying it, we both immediately understand that I am really saying "*that tree is tall relative to our current possible world!*" I never have to express that I am talking about our possible world, because we always default to assuming so anyway, and through such a thing the specificity of realism begins and ends with what is *actually* real rather than what is *not* real. Or perhaps more specifically, *actually real things fall in our possible world*, whereas *not real things fall outside of it.*

As we said, this is remarkably convenient for the purposes of conveying language, however that does not mean that it has to be *accurate* to the true way of things. We already have the tools within Aethic reasoning, relying only on the principles thus far stated, to derive such a system as arbitrary. This is quite a simple line of deduction, actually: given how we have shown a possible world to be ontologically secondary to an Aethus, at least according to the suppositions of Aethic reasoning, it then follows that the fixed assumption that only a specific possible world is "the real one" quite truly goes out the window. Consider the question of which possible world *you yourself* are in. According to what we supposed with Charley's pie, we have to conclude that you are never attached to only

one possible world if you are attached to an Aethus. Accordingly, for us to assume that one possible world is "the real one", thereby implying some sense of inability to exit that possible world, then we immediately contradict the very supposition that oneself is already situated across many other options. As such, we wrap this proof by contradiction back to the surface, and are forced to conclude that the very supposition of a "real" possible world is a construct—at least according to Aethic reasoning. To replace this, we have only the tools of the Aethus to work with. As such, we can decide to mark an Aethus itself as the fundamental arbiter of what is or is not real, given that a possible world would have lost this title. But rather than simply assuming some kind of "one real" Aethus, we instead find it advantageous to the prospect of Aethic relativism that all Aethae are equally real—just with respect to themselves.

The supposition here, then, is that the very notion of defining something as "real" is and always has been a two-node system: "what is the object" against "what is the reality." In the classical paradigm, we get to fix the reality node, but in Aethic reasoning we cannot do this any longer. So it is the very act of placing the reality node onto an Aethus which reveals to us our fundamental insight: *the realism of an object is dependent upon which Aethus we measure said realism with, and an Aethus is a fundamental ontological object.* Therefore, *realism itself is not a fixed property of an object, but is merely a statement of relation between it and a given Aethus*[30].

First Postulate of the Aethus

Any attribution of reality is a statement of relation to a particular Aethus.

Put more simply, *anything may only be real relative to an Aethus.* (The attribution is of *content*, every determinate value; *structure*—the validity functional, and the rule from a detector configuration to its record partition—stands un-indexed, the grammar over vantages that is not itself a vantage, per the two-level statement of Section 2.2.1. The postulate's "no Aethus-free ledger" is a ledger of content, and the distinction is built in here so that it need not be recovered later.) This insight about reality is of utmost importance to the remainder of Aethic reasoning, because it asserts that a reality and an

[30] One straightforward, if simplistic rebuttal to Aethic reasoning I can imagine is the claim that the statement of relativism given by the first postulate of the Aethus denies the existence of objective reality, so as to remove credibility from the framework or something. To that I counter, the first postulate of the Aethus is not making such a broad and unfocused assertion in the first place, but rather is saying something much more specifically subtle. That is, we may perfectly retain the premise from objective reality that there exist physical objects with a quantifiable external nature to the self, (thereby decidedly refraining from moving the framework into the untraceable camp of a demoted physical external reality), and instead very directly state that the given properties of this objective physical object is subject to change depending on the Aethus with which it is informationally illuminated. That is to say that when we say, "that tree is five meters tall", with respect to a given Aethus, we are specifically asserting that a new Aethus may be selected from the abstract set of Aethae for which the same physical tree is suddenly regarded as "that tree is two meters tall". This is to say that any fixed physical object may be informationally altered simply by rendering a new Aethus. However, in the abstract we are not asserting that that the underlying object itself is causally altered by these Aethae, but rather that we are simply reindexing its information space. So, it is analogous to how viewing a right circular cylinder from different angles may lead to it being perceived as a circle in one case versus as a rectangle in another. It is not that we have gone in and altered the object itself, but rather have viewed it from a new perspectival lens. So in this sense, the first postulate of the Aethus can be considered synonymous with both assumptions that the informational properties of fixed objects are themselves perfectly capable of being arbitrarily informationally reindexed to the same extent as can be physical coordinates, (due to perspectival changes), and also therefore that there ought to exist an abstract collection of Aethae in some sense, (perhaps similarly to a Platonic ideal), from which such an arbitrary informational rendering may be drawn, (being the concept of the Aethic tree itself). Importantly, furthermore, we have from the shared informational corollary of Aethic reasoning, (for which two observers' Aethic block universes may interact if and only if their Aethae are not contradictory or otherwise disjoint), that it simply follows as an emergent implication that any two observers in classical metaphysically-mediated conversation will not have any disjoint Aethic stated-attributes to speak of. Accordingly, then, the funny feature of the classical metaphysical paradigm that all observes can reliably fall back on a shared "objectivist" portrayal of reality is merely a convention that reliably holds given this shared-informational corollary. In that context, then, the first postulate of the Aethus can be seen as the obligatory metaphysical backtracking that presents itself once we have determined the objective property constraint as emerging arbitrarily from the shared-informational corollary, and in the process have the extrusion principle metaphysics to explain. Hence, the first postulate of the Aethus very specifically explains that the establishing metaphysical channel between a physical object and an Aethus of choice is the fundamental causal root of all reality, thereby displacing that title from the concept of an objective reality. This being said however, it also is of course worth mentioning that just because any given abstract Aethus can be selected to fit any given property makeup of any given physical object, this does not mean that every such Aethus is necessarily physically realizable. Hence the concept of invalid Aethae, which subsequently to this initial formulation of the first postulate of the Aethus provides constraints on the physical realizability of Aethae. Such is rather straightforward for mere logical inconsistencies, with more general curious inconsistencies like "the sky is not blue", (which seems to contradict biological realism in some sense or another, but in a perhaps deductively evasive way), oftentimes being able to be shown Aethically invalid, (to arbitrary precision), using the Accordance Principle and other measures from Nexic reasoning.

Aethus are essentially two sides of the same coin[31].

In other words, "actual is the state of a stated-attribute surviving pruning[32] *when intersected with a given Aethus", and so is undefined without taking into direct consideration said Aethus and its parent-child graph topology. Likewise, for a stated-attribute to be false is for its intersection with a given Aethus to be an invalid Aethus. The central idea of the first postulate of the Aethus, therefore, is that the very state of a statement or stated-attitude being true is like one half of a torn piece of fabric for which the irreducible other half is the topology of a selected Aethus—it is not even that truth cannot exist outside an Aethus, it is that truth is categorically a statement and an Aethus, with any alternative definition of truth being ill-defined so long as we accept the extrusion principle.*

The categorical statement deserves its most precise form before anything is compared to it. Truth, on this framework, is not a property that statement-objects carry and an Aethus then indexes—that reading would leave truth a primitive and the index an afterthought. A stated-attribute taken alone is, categorically, an *unapplied* thing: it has the shape of an application with nothing yet applied to—as if an operator over some argument were left dangling, acting on nothing. What truth *is*, categorically and ontologically, is the *event of application*: the stated-attribute meeting the topology of an existing Aethus, and the topology responding—survival, and the attribute is actual; invalidity, and it is false. The classical category error is then exact rather than rhetorical: to treat the dangling attribute as if it already carried a truth-value is to speak of topology while withholding the topological side—to ask what an operator yields while forbidding it an argument. Nothing about the attribute is defective in isolation; what is defective is the classical insistence that the application has already silently happened, everywhere, against a single fixed topology no one supplies.

The reframing has a distinguished ancestor whose convergence deserves precise claiming. Lewis argued—famously, and against his critics' grain—that "actual" is an *indexical* term, functioning like "here" and "now": every world's inhabitants correctly call their own world actual, and no absolute actuality outranks the indexical kind [38]. The present framework agrees on the indexicality and relocates the index. For Lewis the index was the world of utterance—a defensive maneuver inside modal realism, protecting the equal reality of his worlds from the charge that ours is special. Here the index is the *Aethus*: not where the speaker stands, but what the speaker's information state is—and the relocation is forced rather than chosen, because once alternatives are co-present within one block, location can no longer individuate an index at all, and information is the only candidate left standing. Where Lewis's indexical actuality was structurally idle, (it adjudicated nothing), the Aethic index works for a living: it is the input to the pruning, and actuality is the pruning's output.

What the survival-definition buys can then be stated as an inversion of primitive and derived. Classical treatments take "actual" as primitive and build the modal notions around it; here the machinery runs the other way, and the whole classical trichotomy receives graph-topological definitions: *actual* is stated-and-surviving; *open* is blank, (the co-present superposition of the second postulate); *false* is intersection-invalid. Truth-values become statuses in the parent-child topology—which is also why the modal collapse, (the elimination of mere possibility as a third ontological category), is not an additional thesis but a corollary of the definitions: nothing is left over for "merely possible" to be.

One boundary should be drawn against a misclassification. Truth-as-survival is not a coherence theory of truth: survival is not consistency with a body of belief but topological survival in the Aethic graph under the postulates, with empirical teeth supplied downstream by the Quantum Nexus—the pruning answers to interference statistics, never to anyone's doxastic comfort. Nor is the correspondence intuition abandoned; it is completed. Correspondence always owed an answer to *correspondence to what?*, and the classical answer—the world, singular—was the silent fixing of the reality-node observed above. The torn fabric names the repair: the missing relatum is supplied, and supplied with enough structure to compute with.

We already have something of a clear avenue into reconciling the basic statement of the second postulate of the Aethus, given this insight in combination with the notion that oneself never attaches to a single possible world, but instead is upon many of them. Epistemologically speaking, this is a notion of simply having an undetermined possible world to attach to, and through such a thing existing along many possibilities of them. However, it is upon interpreting this ontologically that a fascinating trend comes into view. Let this be described as *the Aethic unity principle.*

[31] Importantly, regarding why the first postulate of the Aethus is not just the extrusion principle itself—the difference is that the three Aethic postulates require that the structural and ontological definition of the Aethus has already been stated, whereas the extrusion principle requires no such condition, (on account of its perhaps being axiomatically lower in ontology).

[32] That is, by pruning I am referring to *Aethic pruning.*

Principle 10 (Aethic Unity Principle)
Just as we have to suppose that the Aethus is never attached to a single possible world, we also now have to conclude that an agent themselves never tends to attach to a single possible world, and instead is better ontologically described as, in the most metaphysical sense, occupying multiple possible worlds at once.

Or, to put it in more colloquial terms, oneself tends to occupy several timelines at once rather than ever occupying only one timeline. Such a perceived flux in the timelines presents oneself with elements from multiple realities at once within their own current block universe with them as they move down the Aethic dimension. For an intuitive example, if you are somehow upon two timelines at once, such that you stand outside a blue house in one and a red house in another, then you yourself will see a purple house with respect to your own perspective from your Aethic vantage point. From the intuition of timelines, then, we will expect that an agent who happens to exist on multiple timelines will, in fact, perceive superpositions around themselves from their own perspective. They will not see themselves in superposition, but rather that which fills their apparent block universe around them from strictly their own perspective. This most general form of superposition is what we will refer to as ***Aethic superpositions****, which distinguishes them from the special case of quantum superpositions. (Also note that the use of the word "see" in this context refers to one's scope of mathematical inference, rather than their physical sense of sight).*

With the unity principle, we hold that no agent ever occupies a single timeline[33]*, so therefore they tend to constantly be present in perspective-driven block universes which hold numerous superpositions within them. Such a definer to their particular content of superpositions, then, is simply their Aethus itself. (We also have to remember by the reversal principle that it is more accurate to think of the background flux of superpositions to the agent as not strictly being composed of possible worlds themselves, if only due to desired model flexibility).*

This mindset, although quite shocking at first, serves as the foundation of Aethic reasoning. It can be seen to draw in part from the mindset of how oneself exists upon all future possible worlds at once—out of the future being undetermined—so now the generalized supposition of this can be considered to extend this to the past and present as well. Rather than the flow of time having anything to do with variability of possible worlds, with the past and future in a sense being locked down in their possible world content, and the future being permanently in flux, we instead have that the Aethus itself is the fundamental unit of what is fixed in reality, with the variability of possible worlds instead extending more radially from it, to give an illustrative analogy. (Notice the helpful compatibility between this general mindset and the aforementioned Aethic extrusion principle).

2.3.3 The Indiscriminate Time Principle

The classical picture, and the inversion. To quickly illustrate this seemingly unintuitive idea that past events can occupy multiple states at once in much the same way as future events are often thought to, (in that the future is regarded as housing multiple possible worlds), the major idea is that that which is outside one's present Aethus –and through such a thing occupies all possible states at once from one's perspective within their Aethus—operates completely indiscriminately from the ordering of things in time. If you have never heard about some obscure historical battle, then to your Aethus it is in the same degree of undetermined flux as some distant future event. The future events are understandable to be in such a flux of possible worlds—but the idea is that this is a fundamental property of unknowns in general, and not just of the conceptual future. It is one's motion down the Aethic dimension, then, which fills in the gaps of their Aethic unknowns and translates them out of that flux of many possibilities, such as reading a history book about that historical battle and changing your vantage point in the Aethic dimension accordingly.

Principle 11 (Indiscriminate Time Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
In classical metaphysics, we hold that the future is represented by something of an unknown cloud of possibilities, such that it is the act of one's progression through time which allows said cloud of possibilities to collapse into single happenings.

In Aethic reasoning, however, as per its major tenets, we instead hold that such a cloud is not restricted to the future at all, and instead is indiscriminately spread across the entire past and future of the universe. As such, the gaining of knowledge about a present event, a future event, or a past event

[33]Intuitively, this is similar to how every point in a continuous probability distribution has zero probability of housing a random sample—it is merely because the breadth of specificity which defines them is far too fine.

are ontologically indistinguishable happenings with respect to the foundation of the Aethus. This is a crucially important insight of Aethic reasoning, perhaps on the level of the principle of extrusion.

Pedagogically speaking, note that in the context of a timeline ontological system we might describe the indiscriminate time principle as the statement that "the past fans out into Aethic superposition precisely as does the future*, with Aethic superpositions having no categorical difference between the two cases in the first place". What I want to be careful about with this phrasing, however, is that its reliance on timelines is superseded by the extrusion principle itself, which renders the contents of the universe and multiverse to the interior of space rather than arranged in timelines beyond it. Accordingly, then, biographically speaking I arrived at the indiscriminate time principle prior to the extrusion principle from within a timeline ontological system, but once the extrusion principle was fully developed it was able to produce the indiscriminate time principle by deduction within its more deliberately parsimonious treatment of counterfactuals.*

The principle, read in the two-times vocabulary. The box uses the word "time" in one sense where the mature paper uses two, and the principle is easiest to state exactly once the two are separated, (Section 2.2.7; Section 2.2). Coordinate time is a direction in the block: past and future along it are regions of one geometry, and the block is fixed along that direction end to end, which is what "predetermination per Aethus" asserts. Aethic time is the sequence of an observer's Aethae, the Markov-chain direction, along which records arrive and the openness of the block's attributes is resolved. The Indiscriminate Time Principle is a statement about the *first* of these seen from the *second*: relative to an Aethus, the attributes of the block that no record fixes are open whether they lie in the block's coordinate past or its coordinate future, because openness is a matter of records and records are indexed to the Aethus, not to the direction of the block they concern. "Gaining knowledge about a present event, a future event, or a past event" are therefore one operation—the arrival of a record in Aethic time—applied to attributes that differ only in where they sit along a coordinate the operation does not read. The classical picture had the cloud of possibilities ahead of the present because it conflated the two times, taking the resolution of openness in Aethic time for a property of the block's own coordinate direction; separate them and the cloud is wherever the records are not.

Two consequences, stated as such. The principle has two immediate consequences, both consumed later, and they deserve listing rather than burial in prose.

1. *The past fans out exactly as the future does.* Relative to an Aethus, a past attribute of the block with no surviving record—a which-slit fact whose detector was never built, a coin flipped and never seen—stands in agreeing superposition, and it is not "determinate but forgotten": by the Record-Individuation Lemma, (Lemma 7), a value fixed in no Aethus ever is not a value, so the fan-out is constructive, on the same footing as the future's. This is the tense-free second postulate named in the time-travel preface, (Section 5.4), and it is why the framework's counterfactual semantics can reopen a past attribute by the same operation it uses on a future one.

2. *Knowledge is one operation regardless of tense.* A record's arrival prunes the same way whether the attribute it fixes is upstream or downstream of the observer in coordinate time, which is the content of the extrusion principle's transit and the reason there is no "retrocausation" anywhere in the framework: nothing acts backward along the block, because nothing acts along the block at all; the Aethus moves, and the block it moves to has always been the block it is.

The laboratory face. The principle is not only a metaphysical relocation; it has an instrument. Wheeler's delayed-choice experiment and the quantum eraser, (Section 10.9.4), are the Indiscriminate Time Principle run on a bench: the decision that determines whether a which-path record exists is made *after* the photon has passed the slits in coordinate time, and the pattern comes out as the record configuration of the whole block dictates, not as the coordinate order would. The framework predicts this without a mechanism, because on its reading there is nothing for a mechanism to do—the block's record configuration is what it is, and the photon's arm attribute is open or partitioned according to it, past-in-coordinate-time or not. What the classical picture must narrate as "the future choice reaching back" the framework states as "the record is in the block, and the block is indexed whole." An intuitive inroad into the indiscriminate time principle might be this: first imagine a universe, as in Nexic reasoning's Accordance Principle, where the timeline one exists on is itself an independent variable. For example, for a given obscure historical event, like whether a given particular Bronze Age farmer napped once or twice on a particular Tuesday, we might imagine it truly being a random variable which timeline you were to initially end up on. Or, more Aethically speaking, it very well could still be undetermined, since the very information placing you on one only is the very information you

lack: whether there was one or two naps on that long-forgotten day. So empirically, you would register the same universe whether you truly do exist on one timeline, versus on all timelines in superposition which consist with the knowns you have access to, (so as to appear equivalent inside your view, but remain distinct in the spacetime just outside it).

The key to establishing the indiscriminate time principle then comes from two direct consequences of such a universe. First, we see that the past itself effectively "fans out" into a superposition content marked by your own current lack of access to discriminating information[34]. Then secondly, and most crucially, we might recognize how this characterization of the past bears striking resemblance to how we already understand the future: "the fanning out of possibilities into random variables, that is due to our current inaccessibility of discriminating information between them". The indiscriminate time principle, then, is the sentiment that these two phenomena are not actually separate at all, but actually conceptually identical. That is, the existence of superposition, or more broadly technical scenario-uncertainty, ceases to do with the arrow of time in the first place, and instead becomes a mere property of contingent inability to access discriminatory information. The future just so happens to apparently block information more stringently due to being downstream in the entropic arrow of time, (which rather more forcefully inhibits backwards-information travel), but ontologically informational uncertainty itself is equivalent whether blocked stringently by the future or missed coincidentally from the past.

This all being said, however, this intuition-building exercise still uses the "classical" timeline metaphysics. For a truly Aethic approach, the demand simply becomes to construct this central premise to the indiscriminate time principle from an extrusion principle-framework rather than a timeline-branching framework. After all, once we have made it far enough to discount the distinction between past and future unknowns and attribute the apparent difference to peripheral entropic effects, it becomes rather unmotivated to continue a real "timeline forward-branching" model in the first place, especially at the level of fundamental ontology. Such is when the extrusion principle itself becomes ideal, being a truly block universe-based Markovian process rather than anything having to do with timelines and their structural-directedness bias.

Moving forward, note that the indiscriminate time principle also couples to what we might call *the Aethic extrusion-consequential principle.*

Principle 12 (Aethic Extrusion-Consequential Principle)
The ability for the indiscriminate time principle to hold in the first place is a direct consequence of the Aethic extrusion principle. Without the Aethic extrusion principle, the reliance on possible worlds becomes much stronger, which is reflected in classical metaphysics accordingly. This is because when Aethic uncertainty is considered to collapse along the direction of time, it follows that designated "timelines" or "possible worlds" have to be brought about to individually house any conflicting properties about how the world might have been. Such designations themselves imply their list of consequences, among them being that timelines only branch in the future, so therefore ontological uncertainty can only be collapsed in the future direction. If we were to even suggest, then, that past ontological uncertainties not only exist, but can be collapsed without discrimination from future uncertainties, then we could demonstrate a contradiction between this and the notion of a timeline. If the arrow of time solidifies events in the timeline upon its passing them, then for an event to be changed at all from a later time would imply a change to a past event, which is contradicted by the very fact of it sitting on the same timeline as oneself. Notice how this paradox is only in effect so long as we do not imply the principle of Aethic extrusion. Once we do, however, in a few short logical deductions we see that the original need for designated possible worlds dissolves entirely, and instead we get a model based on Aethae themselves. This, naturally, is the form of the ontological reversal principle. Rather than possible worlds being necessary, they now become arbitrary in their unchecked assertions of where the boundaries between Aethae fall. As such, it truly is that Aethic reasoning is born with the extrusion principle, and the extrusion-consequential principle captures such a notion.

This now argues for something of a direct equal-and-opposite tradeoff between knowns and superpositions. This is what we call *the second postulate of the Aethus*, as will be elaborated upon later in the paper. The importance of this idea cannot be overstated.

Explicitly speaking, consider the specific philosophical motivation for declaring the second postulate of the Aethus given our knowledge of the first postulate.

[34]This first reconciliation might be seen as the insight of the most original version of centric unfolding itself, (as per inference from the Accordance Principle and its implications to a fanning out of the past's event-certainty), but truly it is the second insight that marks the indiscriminate time principle in particular.

Principle 13 (Philosophical Derivation of the Second Postulate of the Aethus) *From a purely philosophical stance, we can notice how the existence of the first postulate of the Aethus at all implies something of a odd change in the very epistemic manifestation of unknowns in one's Aethus as compared with classical metaphysics. This may be used to motivate a basic form of the second postulate of the Aethus itself.*

The idea is that given the indiscriminate scenario principle together with the first postulate of the Aethus, we are able to perform the following derivation. Suppose we have an agent, say Kevin, who has an Aethus in the moment of A. If we imagine the vast ensemble of possible Aethae which he may traverse the Aethic dimension to upon learning new information, then according to the indiscriminate scenario principle, no single one of these outcome Aethae should be intrinsically more objective than the next with respect to Kevin's initial Aethus A. In effect, we get a different alternate reality for every one of these outcome Aethae by the first postulate of the Aethus, and we then have that all such realities are equally real with respect to that original Aethus due to the indiscriminate scenario principle's supposition about their indiscriminate epistemic sway over it. The key, then, is that any attribution made about Kevin's original Aethus from within any of these alternate realities is to be equally valid to any other attribution made from any other such alternate reality. What this tells us is that, at least from this basic epistemic perspective, we ought to consider leaning toward something adjacent to the second postulate of the Aethus so as to agree with the nature of the first postulate of the Aethus as has already been described.

We have, of course, already deemed possible worlds an ontologically shallower concept than Aethic knowledge through the Aethic reversal principle, so the Aethic unity principle is not specifically meant to imply properties of possible worlds themselves, as that would be ontologically inconsequential via the principles thus far stated. Instead, then, we had best interpret this principle as outlining a fundamental principle of nature: quantum superpositions, it seems, are not so far removed from the macroscopic world after all. That is, this notion of state superposition can be considered to be the natural state of reality, with the notion of collapse simply following from adding a state to one's Aethus. Of course this is a bold claim, and there are troves of evidence which seem to oppose it, (specifically in why quantum coherence does not then empirically survive to the macroscopic world), but the purpose of the next few sections is to find a very specific pathway which holds the mathematics as compatible with the underlying philosophy which we are proposing. The majority of such work will be localized in what we call *the Aethic union principle* which is to be discussed in more detail throughout the coming sections. To summarize what its claims are, we are essentially due to reinterpret quantum decoherence as actually still representing a superposition of quantum eigenstates, just of a different variety. This also allows us to partition quantum measurement and quantum observation into their proper ontological roles. Measurement simply determines the grade of superposition, but it is still always observation, on account of the Aethus, which determines the single lingering state.

2.3.4 Inductive Motivation for Aethic Decoherent Superpositions

Let us now consider one of the major inductive claims of Aethic reasoning. So far, we have been able to express quantum superpositions through the Aethic block universe model, where both outcomes occur in the prior-block universe whereas only one occurs in each subsequent-block universe. The key next step we can make, now, is to suppose that a bout of inductive reasoning may be immediately drawn from this interpretation of the realization of happenings. That is, if quantum superpositions do indeed operate under this model, and macroscopic objects are composed of quantum objects, then by induction we can justifiably claim that macroscopic events themselves, through decomposition, are to be modeled as following that same pattern of realization that we saw for quantum objects with the extrusion principle, where a superposition maintains indefinitely in a prior-block universe, and never existed in the first place in a subsequent-block universe. For example, macroscopic crossroads like *which team will win the next World Cup tournament* would themselves be modeled by the extrusion principle. And, by the indiscriminate time principle of Aethic reasoning, we further would have that even a historical event, like the outcome of the American revolution, would have to be *both* relative to the Aethus of a given agent up until they directly learn about or are otherwise given the ability to deduce the outcome.

So we are already well aware that macroscopic phenomena trivially ought to obey the extrusion principle due to their quantum subcomponents doing so, but such a statement turns out to only be a red herring against this section's actual fundamental inductive claim. That is, given how we have already taken the fundamental step of modeling macroscopic phenomena as distributing across block universes

to no less an extent than quantum particles, *we might then think to suggest that such macroscopic crossroads may not actually be ontologically decomposable into quantum coherent effects in the first place, but instead are to induce as an entirely original elemental form of superposition, being what we will now refer to as a 'decoherent superposition'.* This is a major inductive leap on two fronts, because it both infers that macroscopic properties follow the same guidelines of the extrusion principle, all while supposing that they do so without reliance on the induction from quantum coherence specifically. The major claim here, then, is that Occam's razor actually supports this position for the flexibility it allows us in the expression of quantum decoherence through the Aethic mathematical structure. We will indeed discover that both of these steps turn out to be quite fruitful with regard to their heightening of our capacity to solve the measurement problem in the coming sections.

Regarding how we think to define a decoherent superposition, now, let us simply suppose that they place multiple states into an ontological superposition of all happening at once, all while disallowing their interference in the vein of quantum superpositions. In effect, it is a less complicated form of superposition, which begins and ends with a real-valued linear combination of states, all without including the extra layer of details which regards having to apply the Born rule to actually gather probabilities. Instead, we merely pull the real-valued coefficient already present on the state in question. In general, let us suppose that quantum superpositions and decoherent superpositions are instances of the wider class of *Aethic superpositions*, being whatever the exhaustive ontological generalization of a quantum superposition is to be.

Intriguingly, the mere supposition that decoherent superpositions ontologically exist avails to us a fundamental reinterpretation of the onset of quantum decoherence as opposed to what is suggested by the Copenhagen interpretation alone. To begin with, we immediately see that quantum states, while still unobserved, must be in an ontological Aethic superposition regardless of whether they are still coherent. We already know how quantum coherent superpositions operate, being simply a linear combination of two wavefunctions, themselves operating as linear combinations of linearly independent quantum eigenstates. Upon collapsing this wavefunction, now, we are already in possession of a subtly different interpretation: the Aethic supposition, now, is that rather than all eigenstates dissipating with the exception of a single one, we instead have that the eigenstates remain in superposition in full, but simply transfer from a coherent superposition that is a quantum wavefunction to instead a strictly decoherent superposition. It is there where they remain, then, until an Aethus physically observes one of the states, at which point said Aethus truly collapses the decoherent superposition into but one eigenstate. This Aethic interpretation can be seen to fundamentally sift out the Copenhagen measurement process into characteristic effects of strictly measurement versus observation. Measurement, see, triggers the transfer to a decoherent superposition, whereas observation physically collapses that decoherent superposition to a single state.

A quick additional important principle to grasp, now, is that decoherent superpositions will naturally be real-valued rather than complex-valued like their coherent superposition-analogues. Furthermore, it follows intuitively that the weights on the eigenstates in a decoherent superposition will simply be the square magnitude of their weights under the coherent superposition, as is the premise of the Born rule anyway.

Let us now move to gathering some of the ontological consequences of Aethic decoherent superpositions, specifically as relates to the extrusion principle again.

2.3.5 Motivation for Aethic Superpositions as an Inductive Argument

This next point is a direct instance of induction from quantum mechanics, being perhaps the primary inductive argument in all of Aethic reasoning. It is effectively a restatement of what we just deciphered with decoherent superpositions, however this method arrives at the same result without relying on the extrusion principle, and as such we will refer to this as *the tricky-principle approach to inducing Aethic superpositions.* This approach, in fact, comes from a very simple metaphysical identity—being the realization of the problem of induction—so for that reason it may be considered to lie at a deeper compatibility with Occam's razor than the more technical derivation through decoherent superpositions. Of course, the primary point of intrigue at play here is that both approaches result in the came conclusion, being that Aethic superpositions ought to exist. *The tricky principle.* Begin with a philosophical insight that will be referred to throughout as *the tricky principle.*

Principle 14 (The Tricky Principle)
We cannot know whether the induction of reality's operation to outside one's observation follows the same understood rules as within one's observation or not. Furthermore, either answer to this question

is unfalsifiable, (at least until the discovery of quantum mechanics).

What it is a version of. It is a version of the problem of induction, applied not to the future but to whatever lies outside one's observation—now, in the past, or later—with the unknown, rather than the unprecedented, as its subject. It is also adjacent to the question of epistemological realism, but it does not deny that a reality exists beyond observation; it denies only that one can falsify whether that reality follows the rules one expects of it.

The razor, and the claim. Given the principle, the paper makes one fundamental claim: *since the quantum world is known to operate as it does, and since rigid objectivism beyond the realm of observation has never yielded a solution to the measurement problem and is therefore logically unhelpful to understanding reality, it is substantially preferable to induce what lies beyond observation from the quantum world, about which we at least know further properties, than from the biased vantage of the macroscopic one.* The claim follows from a general razor—select the conclusion supported by the option carrying the most information—and the razor is only sharpened by the objectivist reading's continued failure to reproduce quantum phenomena, which is the measurement problem itself.

The procedure: peering behind the curtain with quantum effects. In the classical world the tricky principle is strictly unfalsifiable and therefore outside the scientific method. It stops being so once quantum effects are admitted, because they are the one known system that directly interacts with what lies behind the principle's curtain. Suppose, then, that the metaphysically-based laws of physics are invariant across all scales[35]. Two outcomes are possible. Either (A) what is observed in quantum mechanics matches the classical interpretation of the phenomena behind the tricky principle—the postulates of complete reality and static observation—or (B) there is a disconnect, and the postulate of uniformity[36] of physics then makes that disconnect a direct avenue for revising the classical interpretation. The heart of the paper's procedure, in a sentence, is therefore this: *record how phenomena behave behind the tricky principle using the quantum world as the aid, and then render the result general to all scales by induction.* Carried out—by attending to the two unprecedented facts about wavefunctions, that they are unobserved and that they are known to operate by a precise mathematical framework—the procedure finds not only that the classical interpretation fails behind the curtain but that a wealth of new conditions is available to replace it with[37]. So the solution to the tricky principle lay outside the scientific method at every earlier point in history, and no longer does: before quantum mechanics, when the macroscopic world was all the empiricism there was, Occam's razor rightly demanded the classical solution, on which observed and unobserved items follow the same metaphysical rules; the quantum world is what changed the demand.

Generalize relations, not objects. There is a right way and a wrong way to generalize quantum effects inductively. The wrong way is to apply the Born rule, or any other quantum structure, bluntly at every scale; that is not induction but a misreading of what the relations are. The right way is to generalize *relations* before objects—to tailor the Born rule to everything rather than merely scale it up—because objects generalized on their own do not make ontological sense. The failure mode has a familiar shape: scale up the apparently flat slice of the Earth that is the human vantage and one concludes the whole Earth is flat, rather than that it is round with negligible curvature at the scale of a point. Quantum coherence cannot simply be applied everywhere, since that would violate empiricism in droves, and the nuance of generalizing correctly is what the following proposal is built to respect.

Explicitly speaking, the claim of Aethic reasoning in the face of this induction of the tricky principle is that *there must be a broad ontological kind of superposition, of which quantum superpositions are merely a flavor*, and then that *even properties of the universe which are probabilistically disjoint, such as the unseen other side of a wall being painted one color versus another, ought to be under*

[35]... Which is an optimally satisfying assumption to make, because, after all, it is the very assumption that led Newton to gravity, and not to mention has been keystone to perhaps all of successful scientific history.

[36]There is an argument to be made that the postulate of uniformity is itself unfalsifiable, and so therefore this unfalsifiability extents to the tricky principle, hence holding it as unfalsifiable anyway. So be it, as this is technically valid.

Nevertheless, we, as humans in a scientific world, cannot exactly come up with a better explanation, because even if there was one, that would, in a way, just be able to be rephrased in terms of the postulate of uniformity of physics but with a different lens. As such, it seems more or less given that this postulate is essentially the best possible conclusion we can possibly make per stage of scientific history, past, present, or future.

[37]The reason that it does not apply follows simply from some of the key quantum tenets, such as superposition and collapse. We can postulate with the Aethus that a human is two different quantum observers at two different times, (that way wavefunctions make ontological sense), and so the postulate of static observation is violated. Furthermore, the postulate of complete reality is clearly violated due to the existence of superpositions themselves, where wavefunction collapses cannot be predicted to precision beforehand, (thus implying that that preceding reality does not directly imply the following circumstances—or in other words classical determinism is violated).

ontological superposition to no less a degree as which effects like quantum interference represent ontological superposition. Of course, we know that wall color and interference effects are two very different qualities, specifically on account of the former representing quantum decoherence and the latter representing quantum coherence, so the major claim of Aethic ontological superpositions, then, is that whichever distinguishing factors come into play regarding these two cases are only extra to the base state of there being an ontological superposition, all without affecting the sheer existence of the ontological superposition itself. Put explicitly, then, *quantum decoherence is to represent a form of ontological superposition which is no less an ontological superposition than quantum coherence, it just simply follows that the distinguishing factors between the two come in as further properties on said background ontological superposition.*

Against the classical reading of decoherence. This is a very different result than what classical metaphysics does in the face of quantum decoherence. Where the classical interpretation implies that the event of decoherence immediately implies that now only one state *or* the other occurs, in Aethic metaphysics we claim that it is still the case that one state *and* the other has to occur right up until direct observation of the outcome. The key is that we are allowed to make such a claim in the first place thanks to the work we have done with the extrusion principle, where our restriction of having to use timelines has been alleviated.

The extrapolation to daily unknowns. By extrapolation of this principle of Aethic metaphysics, we then have that when an agent is truly unaware of some property or another, such as the paint color on the other side of a wall, it then follows that we have to take their reality in the moment as holding said paint color in all possible states at once as per our inductive claim from quantum coherence.

Principle 15 (Inductive Derivation of the Second Postulate of the Aethus)
A hugely important induction we have to perform in Aethic reasoning is how we approach the tricky principle in the face of having, as a species, decidedly discovered the existence of quantum coherent effects. The base idea is that since we have demonstrated a quantum superposition of multiple states as implying that one state and the next occurs at once, it therefore follows from Occam's razor that we might expect any instance of an unknown feature as occupying one state and the next at the same time. We know that a known feature will occupy whichever state is the known state, and now we also have that an unknown feature, no matter what it is, will occupy all possible states at once in a kind of ontological superposition. The distinction from pure quantum coherence might be reconciled in how the states are or are not allowed to interact with one another in such a setup. What we get from this is that we can indeed make a direct assessment about daily unknowns like what is happening behind a closed door, so as to remain consistent with this Aethic framework. According to this induction which we have drawn from quantum coherence, we have that all possibilities should be unfolding behind that door at once relative to one's Aethus, however once the door is opened, it follows that oneself moves to an Aethus in which only whatever one observes had been in effect all along.

In effect, we are led to the second postulate of the Aethus given the nature of the exact empiricism we have about reality.

Let us take a moment, now, to look back to the supposition of Aethic reasoning in which for two unknown states, it follows that one *and* the other occurs at once, rather than only one *or* the other as would be more expected in classical metaphysics. We may imply that it is this very decision, here and now, which will lead to quantum interference effects no longer having to be ontologically jarring later on. In classical metaphysics, we have to essentially layer the ontology of quantum coherence onto the base paradigm independently, which we know from history is a risky business. It is by the exact claim which we make now, then, in which quantum coherent effects will later be seen to be but an aspect of a general underlying phenomenon, being that unknown states simply always exist altogether at once. All we will need to do is then describe why the states also interact with one another in quantum coherence, and we will have a genuine ontological explanation for it through integration into a wider framework. But the key is that that cannot happen unless we make this precise claim here and now, so therefore we must imply that the second postulate of the Aethus is in effect, no matter how initially jarring, so as to proceed with Aethic reasoning.

2.3.6 Aethic Interpretation to the Gettier Problem

Aethic reasoning implies something of an unexpected solution to the Gettier problem, but a solution nonetheless.

Let us picture the example of the stopped clock case of Bertrand Russell [39]. The premise is that our protagonist, Alice, looks up at a clock on the wall and sees that it is two o'clock in the afternoon.

However, unknown to Alice, the clock stopped exactly twelve hours ago due to a mechanical error, so it is merely a coincidence that it reads two o'clock, the correct time, at the instant when Alice looks at it. The question, then, is by what procedure can we deduce the intuitive consequence that Alice indeed does *not* know the time in that moment. Such a procedure, in its completion, will have solved the Gettier problem. Note, also, that we are refer to the general case of knowledge like that of Alice in this thought experiment as "lucky true belief", with the statement of the Gettier problem solution then being the prospect of how to reliably derive lucky true belief as a form of unknowing according to some axiomatic system or another.

To begin with our Aethic derivation, now, consider the causal channel of sorts through which validation of the clock having been broken is regarded as realizable in the first place. Simply put, either a third-person onlooker becomes aware that Alice is looking at a broken clock in the moment, or perhaps Alice later realized this herself by one avenue or another. The point of the matter is that we can only ever make a judgment about Alice having been ignorant in the moment by referencing an independent Aethus. This, now, is a very important insight, because it highlights a fallacy in the suppositions of the thought experiment themselves, at least according to Aethic reasoning. For us to assume these external properties to Alice's Aethus in the moment as being objectively real with respect to it is a violation of the first postulate of the Aethus, because it would force the reality of her original Aethus to be dependent on degrees of freedom which are not directly incorporated into its Aethic content.

What this tells us, now, is essentially two major things. First, that Alice's Aethus in the moment ought to have no ontological preference toward corresponding to the clock working versus being broken, and second that any assessment made by an outsider Aethus about the validity of Alice's clock reading fails to actually be relevant to Alice's original Aethus in the first place. After all, such an assessment takes her clock reading as fully valid only if the clock is working, but as we noted, such a state is not to be baked into her original Aethus. This is the precise notion by which we break from classical metaphysics, because while the classical view supposes that there is perhaps the affect of association by inevitability between the state of the clock being broken and the original Aethus of Alice, Aethic reasoning instead takes such a supposition as a violation of the extrusion principle. More specifically, we take that relative to purely the degrees of freedom of that original Aethus, for Alice to have moved into a reality where the clock was broken all along, versus for her to have moved into a reality in which it was never broken at all are each plausible outcomes of her Aethic motion, with the supposition of her being locked into going to the broken-clock reality merely being an affect of the timeline-oriented paradigm of metaphysics. What we see then, under the purely Aethic notion, is that any attribution which we can make about Alice's original Aethus from either outcome of the clock having been broken all along versus the clock having been working all along is to have no more sway over that direct original Aethus than an attribution taken from the opposite outcome. On that note, then, we are obliged even to accept all possible such attributions as equally true of that original Aethus, which can be considered a form of the philosophical derivation of the second postulate of the Aethus itself given the first postulate.

What we are left with, therefore, is that even though the passive onlooker, Bob, or for that matter even the future version of Alice are to assess that Alice in the original moment had lacked the knowledge of the time upon looking at the broken clock, we might also note that the assessments made of Bob and future Alice in the Aethic alternate reality where the clock had been working are equally true as well to Alice's Aethus in the moment. In the broken-clock outcome, we know as per the prescribed intuition on the subject that Alice in the moment should not have been aware of the time, but the key is this: *the first and second Aethic postulates physically forbid us from declaring this result as a sole intrinsic property of Alice's original Aethus in the moment for the reasons discussed.* Therefore, by this alone we see that, at least under the tenets of Aethic reasoning, there does not exist a well-defined philosophical mechanism in the first place by which we can make such an intrinsic assessment of Alice's original Aethus like the one described by the Gettier problem. So it follows that just like how the internalist stance does not possess a reliable pathway with which to gauge Gettier-adjacent knowledge states of Alice's original Aethus[38], we now have that even externalism itself, to the full hypothetical capacity to which it can be mobilized, does not possess a well-defined pathway to assessing Gettier-adjacent knowledge states either. This, then, is almost akin to Gödel's incompleteness theorem, in that it is an

[38]Note that this supposition already is perhaps a bit arguable, but it is very likely that any externalist philosopher which you ask this of will be in agreement with it. Even an internalist philosopher themselves must agree with it in a purely objective frame, as after all the inability of mental states to link every two objective events is a well known axiom of Western philosophy.

assessment of the sheer impossibility of even drawing an assessment about the Gettier knowledge of Alice in the moment, regardless of the resources we have at our disposal.

The verdict, stated as a derivation. The argument above can be compressed into one first-postulate derivation, and the compression is worth having because it also says how *much* the case establishes. There are two Aethae: Alice's at the moment of the glance, and the later Aethus—Bob's, or Alice's own—in which the clock's having stopped is stated. They are different Aethae, and by the first postulate the attribute *the clock is working* is determinate only relative to the later one. Relative to the prior Aethus it is blank, and by the second postulate the blank is a disagreeing superposition: *working* and *stopped* as pockets, each with a weight. Now ask what weight the pocket in which Alice is *right*—the clock stopped, and stopped at a time that happens to coincide with the actual time—carries relative to that prior Aethus. It is exactly as minute as the chance that a clock stopped at a random moment displays the correct time at another random moment, which is the coincidence the thought experiment is built on. So relative to Alice's own Aethus the lucky-true-belief pocket is one thin sliver of a disagreeing superposition whose bulk is the ordinary case of a working clock, and the case affords almost no leverage toward the falsity of justified true belief from inside that Aethus: the verdict "she did not know" is a statement about the later Aethus, where the sliver has been selected, imported into the prior one, where it had negligible weight. That is the whole Aethic content of the stopped clock. It is not that Alice's knowledge is undefined; it is that the attribution of unknowing lives at an index other than the one at which the belief was held, and carries, at the belief's own index, the weight of the coincidence that produced it.

Naturally, then, this is indeed a solution to the Gettier problem, being that *according to Aethic reasoning, the supposition of there existing an algorithm through which unknowing reliably characterizes lucky true belief in the first place is itself an unsolvable end.* Simply put, the solution to the Gettier problem is that we cannot do what it asks in the first place, so therefore we might have to reassess our preconceived notions about systems like this in full; the next subsubsections state that impossibility as a proposition, reconstruct the conditions that do work, and run Gettier's own two cases through the union principle. And yes, the statement we've all been waiting for—we can indeed state that in the moment of looking at the broken clock, *Alice knows and doesn't know the time at once*, at least relative to her own Aethus.

2.3.7 The Justified-True-Belief Analysis, Formally: Index Mismatch, the Luck Pocket, and Why No Fourth Condition Exists

The analysis, and what broke it. The tripartite analysis holds that a subject S knows a proposition φ if and only if φ is true, S believes φ, and S is justified in believing φ. It descends from the *Theaetetus*, was standard in the mid-century literature, and was broken in three pages by Gettier [40], who gave two cases in which all three conditions hold and the subject plainly does not know. In the first, Smith has strong evidence that Jones will get a job and that Jones has ten coins in his pocket, and infers that *the man who will get the job has ten coins in his pocket*; unknown to Smith, Smith himself gets the job, and Smith too has ten coins. In the second, Smith has strong evidence that Jones owns a Ford, and infers by disjunction introduction that *either Jones owns a Ford or Brown is in Barcelona*, choosing Barcelona at random; Jones does not own a Ford, and Brown, by chance, is in Barcelona. Russell's stopped clock [39] is the same structure a decade earlier. The literature's response over sixty years has been a search for a *fourth condition.* Clark proposed that the justification proceed through no false lemma [41]; Goldman that the belief be caused by the fact that makes it true [42], and later that the subject be able to discriminate the truth from relevant alternatives [43], the fake-barn case being his own; Lehrer and Paxson that the justification be undefeated by any true proposition [44]; Nozick that the belief *track* the truth, in that S would not believe φ were φ false [45]; Sosa and Williamson that the belief be *safe*, in that S could not easily have believed φ falsely [46, 47]. Zagzebski then argued that the search is hopeless in principle: any analysis whose truth condition is logically independent of its justification condition admits a Gettier case, constructed by first making the justification fail to secure the truth and then restoring the truth by luck [48]. Williamson drew the conclusion that knowledge is not to be analyzed at all, and made it the primitive [47].

The diagnosis. The framework's diagnosis is that Zagzebski's argument is correct and that its correctness has a cause the literature did not name. The tripartite analysis is a relation among three things: a subject, a proposition, and *a world at which the proposition is true.* The third relatum is a valuation—a determinate assignment of truth values to contingent propositions, held independently of any subject—and the first postulate says there is no such thing. A contingent attribute is determinate only relative to an Aethus that holds a record of it. So the truth condition of the analysis is not false

but *ill-typed*: it compares the subject's Aethus against a valuation that lives at another Aethus, the narrator's, and reports the comparison as a property of the subject's. A Gettier case is exactly a case in which the two Aethae come apart in a way the justification cannot see. That is why the cases are constructible at will, why no condition stated on the subject's side closes them, and why the response that finally worked in the literature—safety, sensitivity, tracking—worked by quietly changing the type of the truth condition to a modal one. The three propositions below make each of these claims exact.

The objects. Fix a subject's Aethus A_S at the moment of belief and a second Aethus A_N, later or elsewhere, at which the case is narrated; in the stopped clock A_N is Bob's or Alice's own later state. Let φ be the belief's content, an attribute of the shared attribute space. Let $J \subseteq A_S$ be the *justification*: the states of A_S from which φ is inferred or by which it is supported. And let λ be the *luck attribute*: the fact whose obtaining makes φ true in a way J did not anticipate—the clock's having stopped at the right time, Smith's own coins, Brown's presence in Barcelona. The Gettier form is then a condition on these four:

Definition 1 (Gettier configuration)
A pair of Aethae (A_S, A_N) with belief φ, justification J, and luck attribute λ is a Gettier configuration *when (i) $J \subseteq A_S$ and J supports φ relative to A_S; (ii) λ is blank in A_S; (iii) λ is stated in A_N; (iv) φ is stated true in A_N; and (v) the support J gives φ is stated* false *in A_N—the pocket of φ that J pointed at does not obtain there, and φ is true at A_N through the pocket λ opens instead.*

Condition (v) is the content of "true by luck," and it is stated as a fact about *pockets* rather than truth values because that is where the framework locates it: φ, in every Gettier case, is a proposition that can be made true in more than one way—by Jones getting the job or by Smith, by the first disjunct or the second, by a working clock or a stopped one that happens to agree—and the justification supports one way while the truth at A_N comes through another. The union principle is what makes this exact. The ways φ can be true are the alternatives of a disagreeing superposition, exclusive of one another and each carrying a weight relative to A_S; a proposition true "by luck" is one whose truth at the narrating index sits in a pocket the subject's justification did not select. Gettier cases are cases of the *right value in the wrong pocket.*

Proposition 1 (Index mismatch)
In every Gettier configuration the verdict "S does not know φ" is evaluated at A_N and is not a property of A_S: no attribute of A_S, stated or blank, distinguishes the configuration from one in which λ fails and J's pocket obtains.

Proof. By (ii), λ is blank in A_S, so A_S is identical whether λ obtains or not; by the first postulate, λ's obtaining is not determinate relative to A_S, so there is no fact at A_S about which pocket of φ obtains. Now compare the configuration with its *normal counterpart*: the pair (A_S, A'_N) with the same A_S, in which λ is stated false at A'_N and J's pocket of φ obtains there. Both pairs share A_S exactly. The verdict "S knows" is standardly returned for the counterpart and "S does not know" for the configuration; the two verdicts therefore differ while every property of A_S is held fixed, and a verdict that varies while A_S is fixed is not a property of A_S. It is a property of the narrating Aethus, at which alone the pocket is stated. □

Proposition 2 (The weight of the luck pocket)
Relative to A_S, λ is a disagreeing superposition $\{\lambda, \neg\lambda\}$ with weights w_λ and $1 - w_\lambda$, and the Gettier verdict, imported to A_S, has Aethic weight at most w_λ. In the standard cases w_λ is the prior weight of the coincidence the case is built on, and is minute.

Proof. By the second postulate, a blank of A_S is a superposition; by the union principle it is disagreeing, since λ and $\neg\lambda$ exclude one another as stated content; and the recovery of weights, (Section 14.7), assigns each pocket its weight relative to A_S. The Gettier verdict requires (iii)–(v), all of which lie in the λ-pocket; so the verdict's weight relative to A_S is bounded by that pocket's, w_λ. In the stopped clock, w_λ is the weight that a clock stopped at an unknown time reads correctly at the moment of the glance; in Gettier's first case, that Smith rather than Jones is hired and that Smith has exactly ten coins; in the second, that Brown is in a city chosen at random. Each is the coincidence the case's author needed, and each is small in proportion to the case's persuasiveness. □
The proposition is the exact form of the observation that lucky true belief affords "not much leverage" against the analysis from inside the subject's own Aethus: the leverage is w_λ, and the cases are constructed to make w_λ small precisely because a large w_λ would mean the justification had anticipated the luck, which would not be luck.

Proposition 3 (No internal fourth condition)
No condition K that is a property of A_S alone—a predicate on the subject's stated and blank attributes at the moment of belief—excludes the Gettier configurations while admitting their normal counterparts. Every condition that does exclude them is indexed to an Aethus other than A_S.

Proof. Immediate from Proposition 1: a Gettier configuration and its normal counterpart share A_S, so any predicate on A_S takes the same value on both, and cannot separate them. A condition that separates them must therefore consult something outside A_S—the pocket that obtains, which is stated only at A_N or in some Aethus that holds the relevant record—and is by that fact indexed elsewhere. □
This is Zagzebski's inescapability result [48] with its cause supplied. Her argument shows that the recipe always works; the proposition shows why: the recipe exploits the fact that the analysis's truth condition is typed to an index the justification condition cannot reach, and no repair on the justification's side can change the type of the truth's. Every fourth condition that survived in the literature did so by moving to the other side—by being, in one guise or another, a condition on Aethae other than A_S. Clark's "no false lemma" is a condition on which pocket the inference passed through, which is stated only where the pocket is. Goldman's causal condition asks that the fact making φ true cause the belief, and the fact is at A_N. Lehrer and Paxson's defeasibility condition quantifies over true propositions, which is to say over what is stated at the narrating index. And the modal conditions—tracking, sensitivity, safety—quantify over nearby possibilities, which is the move the framework can reconstruct exactly.

Safety, without the ordering. Sosa's and Williamson's safety condition says that S knows φ only if S could not easily have believed φ falsely: in all nearby worlds in which S believes φ on the same basis, φ is true. The condition is externalist, and it is the one most epistemologists now accept as at least necessary. Its cost is the notion of a *nearby world*, which requires a similarity ordering over worlds and inherits every difficulty that ordering has—the difficulties Section 9.1 showed the counterfactual semantics can delete rather than refine. The framework reconstructs safety with the ordering deleted. Reopen the luck attribute: form the perturbation A_S^{λ} of the subject's Aethus in which λ's entry is reopened at the declared scope and the state re-pruned, exactly as the counterfactual semantics evaluates an antecedent. The result is a disagreeing superposition over the pockets of λ, each with a weight, and in each pocket φ is stated true or false. Then:

Definition 2 (Aethic safety)
S's belief in φ is safe *relative to A_S when, in the reopened residue A_S^{λ}, the total weight of the pockets in which φ is false is negligible: $W(\neg\varphi \mid A_S^{\lambda}) \approx 0$.*

A Gettier configuration fails safety in exactly this sense. Reopening the clock's having stopped places weight on every reading the stopped clock could have shown, and in almost all of those pockets Alice's belief is false; reopening who got the job places weight on Smith's having a different number of coins; reopening Brown's whereabouts places weight on every other city. The near-world quantification is replaced by the weighted residue of a perturbation, the ordering by the framework's own dependency structure, binary validity, and graded weight—the same three things the counterfactual semantics found doing the ordering's work—and safety is stated as a threshold on a weight rather than as a universal over an unspecified neighborhood. The reconstruction inherits the framework's grade: it is a proposal for what the safety theorists were measuring, and its claim is that what they were measuring was always a weight over a reopened residue and never a distance between worlds.

2.3.8 Gettier's Own Cases, Worked Through the Union Principle

Case I: the ten coins. Smith's Aethus A_S states his evidence: the employer's assurance that Jones will be hired, and his own count of Jones's coins. Let φ be *the man who will get the job has ten coins in his pocket*. Relative to A_S, *who will get the job* is a blank over the candidates, and by the union principle φ's truth is a disagreeing superposition over them: φ obtains in the Jones-pocket if Jones has ten coins, in the Smith-pocket if Smith does, and so on. Smith's justification J supports the Jones-pocket and states its coin count; it says nothing about the Smith-pocket, in which Smith's own coin count is a blank he has not thought to check. At A_N the Smith-pocket obtains and Smith happens to hold ten coins. The configuration satisfies Definition 1 with $\lambda =$ *Smith is hired and has ten coins*: φ is true at A_N through the pocket J did not select. The classical analysis reports "true," since φ's truth value is the same in either pocket; the framework reports "true in the Smith-pocket, which A_S weights at w_λ and J did not touch." The existential quantifier in φ is what lets two pockets share a value, and it is the union principle's reading of the existential—a disagreeing superposition over its instances, each a pocket—that makes the shared value visible as two distinct facts.

Case II: Jones's Ford. Smith's Aethus states his evidence that Jones owns a Ford. He forms φ = *Jones owns a Ford or Brown is in Barcelona* by disjunction introduction, the second disjunct chosen with no evidence at all. Classically the inference is valid and the justification transmits: a justified disjunct justifies the disjunction. Aethically the disjunction is a disagreeing superposition of two pockets, and the justification J lives entirely in the Ford-pocket; the Barcelona-pocket carries, relative to A_S, only the prior weight of Brown's being in a city named at random, which is the case's w_λ. At A_N the Ford-pocket is stated false and the Barcelona-pocket true. This is the purest Gettier configuration in the literature, because the luck attribute is the very disjunct Smith added without support: the analysis transmitted justification along a connective that, on the union principle's reading, does not transmit *pocket*. Justification can be had for a disjunction only in the pocket the evidence supports, and φ's truth at A_N is in the other one. The case that the original footnote deferred to the union principle is therefore the case the union principle handles most directly: disjunction introduction is valid for truth values and invalid for pockets, and knowledge tracks pockets.

What the two cases share, and the general form. Both cases, and the stopped clock, have the form: φ is a proposition with more than one way of being true; J supports one of the ways; the narrating Aethus states that way false and another way true. That is the whole of the Gettier phenomenon, and it is why the cases feel the same despite their surface differences. The analysis fails because *true* is a one-place predicate on propositions while knowledge is sensitive to *which pocket*, and a one-place truth predicate cannot see pockets. The framework's slogan for the general form—right value, wrong pocket—is not a redescription; it is the identification of the variable the tripartite analysis omitted.

A second species: the barns. Goldman's fake-barn case [43] is usually grouped with Gettier's, and the framework says it is a different animal. Henry sees a real barn in a district of convincing fakes and believes *that is a barn*. Here the belief is true in the *right* pocket: the structure he looked at is a barn, and his justification, seeing it, supports that very pocket. There is no pocket mismatch. What fails is safety: reopen *which structure Henry looked at*, and the residue places most of its weight on fakes, in which pockets his belief is false. So the barns are a safety failure without a Gettier configuration in the sense of Definition 1, and the two species come apart on the framework's analysis exactly where the literature has found them hardest to hold together: the Gettier cases are index-mismatch cases, cured by attention to pockets; the barn cases are environmental-luck cases, cured by attention to the reopened residue. A subject can suffer either without the other, and an account that handles one is not thereby committed to handling the other, which is the structural reason the literature's proposed fourth conditions have tended to handle one species and stumble on the other.

Placement. Against each standing response, the framework's reading is as follows. Zagzebski's inescapability is Proposition 3, with the cause named. Williamson's knowledge-first is the correct response to that proposition read from the wrong side: knowledge resists analysis into belief plus truth plus a condition not because it is primitive but because the truth condition is ill-typed, and a relation with an ill-typed relatum will look unanalyzable from inside the type theory that mistyped it. Safety and sensitivity are reconstructed as thresholds on the reopened residue, with the similarity ordering deleted, (Definition 2). The causal and no-false-lemma conditions are pocket-tracking in causal and inferential clothing respectively. And the original verdict of the previous subsubsection stands with its scope fixed: relative to Alice's own Aethus, the two pockets—a working clock and a stopped one that agrees—both stand, and she knows the time in one and does not in the other, at the weights the pockets carry; the flat statement that she *does not* know is the narrator's, made at the index where one pocket has been selected, and it is true there. Nothing in the framework denies that Gettier cases exist. It says where their verdicts live, what they weigh, why no internal repair can reach them, and what the external repairs that work were measuring all along.

2.3.9 The Reconstruction Run Against the Standard Battery

A reconstruction of safety that only re-described Gettier's cases would be a redescription. The test of Definition 2 is whether the threshold on the reopened residue returns the verdicts the safety theorists reached on the cases they built to separate safety from its rivals—and, where it does not, whether the divergence is a defect or a diagnosis. Six cases follow. In each, the operation is the same: identify the luck attribute λ whose reopening the case turns on, form the residue A_S^λ by reopening it at the declared scope and re-pruning, and read off the weight the residue places on pockets in which the belief is false.

1. The lottery. S holds one ticket in a fair lottery of a million and believes, on the odds alone, *my ticket will lose*. The belief is true, and the odds make it as justified as a belief gets; the standing intuition is that S does not *know* it, and safety was built in part to say why: in a nearby world S's

ticket wins, so S could easily have believed falsely on the same basis. Aethically, λ = *which ticket wins*, blank in A_S and a disagreeing superposition over the million. Reopening it at the scope of the draw places weight 10^{-6} on the pocket in which S's ticket wins and the belief is false. Whether that is "negligible" is the question the definition's threshold makes explicit, and here the framework improves on the literature rather than matching it. The safety theorist must say that a one-in-a-million world is *near*, which the similarity ordering was never able to justify without special pleading, since a world differing only in which ball dropped is as close as worlds get. The residue reading has no ordering to strain: the pocket carries its weight, 10^{-6}, and the verdict turns on whether the threshold is set below it. The intuition that S does not know is the intuition that for a belief to count as knowledge the residue's false weight must be *zero at the declared scope*, not merely small—that the belief must be safe in every pocket the reopened attribute spans—and the lottery is the case that forces the threshold to be zero rather than small. That is a sharper statement of what the lottery shows than the literature's, and it is available because the residue carries weights while the ordering carries only distances.

2. The fake barns. Treated in the previous subsubsection: λ = *which structure Henry looked at*, reopened over the district, the residue placing most of its weight on fakes. Safety fails; the literature's verdict is that Henry does not know; the residue agrees, and adds the diagnosis that the failure is environmental rather than a pocket mismatch.

3. Sosa's garbage chute. S drops a bag down the chute and believes, on long experience, that it has reached the basement; it has, but the chute has a snag on which bags catch one time in a thousand, and S has never learned of it. Sosa's verdict is that S does not know, because the belief could easily have been false; the case is usually taken to show safety diverging from sensitivity, since sensitivity—*had the bag not arrived, S would not believe it had*—is arguably satisfied on a reading where the nearest non-arrival is a visible blockage. Aethically, λ = *the bag caught on the snag*, blank in A_S; reopening it places weight 10^{-3} on the pocket in which the belief is false. The residue returns Sosa's verdict for Sosa's reason, and it returns it without the sensitivity counterfactual's dependence on which non-arrival is nearest: there is no nearest, there is a residue, and the residue has a false pocket of non-negligible weight.

4. Nozick's grandmother. A grandmother sees her grandson in good health and believes he is well; had he been ill, the family would have kept it from her and she would have believed he was well anyway. Sensitivity fails—she would believe it even if false—yet the standing intuition, and Sosa's, is that she *knows*, since she is looking at him. This is the case that broke sensitivity and made safety the surviving condition. Aethically, λ = *the grandson's state of health*; reopening it places weight on the pocket in which he is ill, but in that pocket the grandmother's *basis*—seeing him in good health—does not obtain, since she would be seeing a concealment. The declared-scope clause of Definition 2 is what handles this: the residue is formed by reopening λ and re-pruning, and re-pruning removes the pockets inconsistent with the basis J as stated in A_S. On the same basis, the false pocket has no weight; the belief is safe; the grandmother knows. The framework recovers safety's verdict and locates *why* sensitivity failed: sensitivity evaluates the belief under a counterfactual that changes the basis, and the residue does not, because the perturbation reopens the luck attribute and nothing else.

5. Bootstrapping, and the problem of easy knowledge. S reads a gauge, believes the reading, and after many readings concludes that the gauge is reliable, having never checked it against anything. The intuition is that S has not come to know the gauge is reliable, and the difficulty for safety is that each individual reading may be safe while the inference to reliability is not. Aethically, the case is a case about what *scope* is declared. Each reading's λ = *the gauge misreads on this occasion* is reopened at the scope of one reading and re-pruned; the residue's false weight is whatever the gauge's actual error rate is, which S does not know. The inference to reliability declares a wider scope—*the gauge is reliable across readings*—and reopening at that scope places substantial weight on the pocket in which the gauge is systematically off and every reading was wrong together. The residue at the wider scope is not the product of the residues at the narrow ones, because the reopened attribute at the wider scope is a single systematic fault, correlated across readings, and not a run of independent slips. So the belief in reliability fails safety at its own scope even if each reading passes at its own, and the framework returns the standing verdict with a mechanism: the bootstrapper has computed the narrow residues and reported the wide one, and the scope clause is what forbids that.

6. Gettier's cases, closed. The two original cases and the stopped clock are Gettier configurations, and Propositions 1–3 govern them. Safety fails in each on the residue reading—reopen the luck attribute and the justification's pocket is false in most of the residue—so the reconstruction returns the verdict the cases were built to elicit. But the reconstruction also says something the safety theorists could not, which is the reason the cases are Gettier cases and not merely unsafe beliefs: the belief is *true at the*

narrating index through a pocket other than the justified one, (Definition 1), and that is a fact about which pocket obtains, invisible to any condition stated on truth values. Safety detects the cases; the pocket structure explains them.

What the battery shows. On the six cases the residue threshold returns the safety theorists' verdicts in five and sharpens the sixth. It agrees on the barns, the chute, and the grandmother; it agrees on bootstrapping and supplies the scope mechanism; and it agrees on the lottery while forcing the threshold to zero at the declared scope rather than leaving "nearby" to do unexplained work. Nowhere does it require a similarity ordering, a nearest world, or a measure of distance between worlds; the three things that do the ordering's work in the counterfactual semantics—dependency structure, binary validity, graded weight—do it here. The reconstruction therefore stands at the grade the counterfactual semantics stands at: a proposal that the standing modal condition on knowledge was always a weight over a reopened residue, checked against the cases the condition was built on, and stated so that a further case can be run by the same three-step operation. What it does not claim is that the operation decides every case: the declared scope is the modeler's, as the equivalence class of a frequentist probability is, and cases in which the scope is genuinely contestable—the lottery's threshold, the bootstrapper's width—are cases in which the framework makes the contest explicit rather than settling it.

2.3.10 Aethic Reasoning as Relativism Instead of Anti-Realism

It is important to mention upfront that Aethic reasoning should not be perceived as a notion of anti-realism, specifically due to a key piece of nuance surrounding its suppositions about reality. The idea is that *any argument which posits that Aethic reasoning is a notion of anti-realism can be explained away as it instead being a notion of relativism.* With Aethae themselves being the informational analogue to a reference frame, note that this is just the same argument as what happens in the theory of relativity, where we strictly suppose that *for all reference frames to be equally valid, even in the case of their differing of perspective, is not to be taken as claiming anti-realism for its lacking of an objective frame, but instead is merely a supposition of how the ontological activity of reality is to manifest with respect to one's subjective perspective.* This same argument, then, is to be argued within Aethic reasoning, as specifically draws from the correspondence between a relativistic reference frame and an Aethic reference frame, as described by the Aethic principle of relativity.

Let us now consider a supporting example for this in the form of a thought experiment. We would like to provide a warning upfront that this is going to sound bizarre, so we have to ready ourselves to grapple with things accordingly. This is one of those moments where you have to essentially unlearn everything you think you know about reality to even entertain the upcoming thought. But as the requisite principle of Aethic reasoning puts it, either we learn to live with this understanding, or the measurement problem is truly unshakable. Only you may be the judge of what is right.

With that out of the way, let us get to the actual story. Emily grew up in the suburbs outside Boston, Massachusetts. When she turned twenty, she decided to travel Europe in search of adventure. She visited Paris, London, Florence, and Geneva. On her last week of travel, she was in Prague, and it's there that she met the love of her life, Sam. They had an immediate connection, and by the end of their first conversation, Emily learned something incredible: Sam had lived right next door to her childhood home in Massachusetts, and they just happened to never meet. With laugher and embrace, Emily tells Sam how she came halfway across the world to meet a special someone who was next door all along. To that Sam remarks, "we could have known each other from the beginning."

There are some layers to Sam's statement, and they turn out to have inadvertent dependencies on classical metaphysics. Let us unpack this now. We might think to as ourselves, *even though Emily is aware that Sam lived next door in her current Aethus, it would contradict the extrusion principle to imply that such a thing was exactly true of her prior reality in which she actually lived in her childhood home.* Let us look not to Emily's past from the reality in which she sits in Prague with Sam, and instead put ourselves back in Emily's shoes from her original reality, in which she stands outside her childhood home on a cold March morning twelve years earlier. While the eight year old Emily waits for her father to start the family car and bring her to school, she stares blankly at the house next door, mind wandering. In there at this very instant is the young Sam, *but only from the perspective of Emily's Aethus in Prague.* That, of course, is not the precise reality in which young Emily stands now. We might think to ask ourselves, then, *does Sam live in that house at all right now?* If Emily were to promptly walk to the door and knock, who would answer it? Would it be Sam's caretakers, or someone else entirely?

The idea is that we might make use of the second postulate of the Aethus here. Emily is clearly unaware at the moment of who lives in the house, as she only learns it was Sam while in Prague at the age of twenty. Therefore, by the second postulate, we hold that *a uniform random set of every possible human lives in that house at once, right behind the outside wall which Emily now stares at.* We have to picture this not as all the billions of potential humans being crammed in there spatially, but rather occupying something of an overlay. Speaking in terms of the classical terminology of timelines, the point in spacetime that is that house's living room is, from Emily's perspective, essentially a bustling multiverse at which a vast density of timelines are bundled, all unbeknownst to one another. For each possible family, there are pictures on the wall and laundry in the wash and food in the kitchen. But to Emily's Aethus, we cannot know which of the options is realized, so therefore within the confines of that house is all such families at once, fading over one another without any knowledge whatsoever of the others.

This is, of course, quite maddening to think about, so the key assessment we have to make here is how everything that was just stated is fundamentally a property of *Emily's Aethus* itself, in that it is a relativist claim with her Aethus as the reference. Perhaps Emily's father, as he turns the key to the car, has met the parents in the house next door, so to his Aethus there is a fixed, single family living there at that very moment[39]. And yet before Emily can request such information of him, the very contents of his mind represent a bundle of timelines which all occur at once relative to Emily's present reality, because the specific family which he knows to exist in that house is itself unknown to her, and therefore in Aethic superposition.

As such, the only accurate assessment we can make about Emily's Aethus in this very moment, at least with regards to the family next door, is that if she indeed walks to the front door and indeed knocks, then a random person from the set of all families in Aethic superposition will in that moment answer the door, in effect branching Emily to a new Aethus in which they were the lone family in the house all along. Naturally, then, the likelihood that Sam is one of those people is essentially next to nothing, even though the specific random future version of Emily in Prague will have had it be him.

The claim, then, for why this entire Aethic supposition does not count as anti-realism, is because of a nuanced but key implication about Sam himself as he sits in that house from young Emily's Aethus. Sam very much *does exist* to Emily's Aethus, and he very much *is in that house*, which is of stark contrast with any kind of supposition that either he *does not exist* or *is not actually in that house*. The latter, see, would be effectively epistemological solipsism on account of Emily meeting him later in Prague, whereas the former is a very particular Aethic assertion: *just because all the other families are there too does not discredit Sam's state of being there.* Such a thing is itself a consequence of many-at-once states being indeed permitted to exist in an Aethic reality. This, then, is the fundamental root of the derivation for why Aethic metaphysics, in all its absurd glory, is not

[39] An important note I want to mention real quick is that perhaps one attempts to refute Aethic reasoning with the following proposed proof by contradiction: *if the extrusion principle concept is true, by which two agents in a shared physical space can have their Aethic block universes interact if and only if one's Aethic content does not contradict that of the other's, (ie more generally meaning their Aethae are not disjoint), then why does Emily's knowledge about her identity not contradict her father's knowledge about his identity and thereby force them into non-interacting Aethic block universes?* The simple answer to such a question, so as to reference more advanced Aethic terminology, is that rather than having to assume a proof by contraction, (which of course we are compelled to avoid so long as we logically support Aethic reasoning), we instead have to attain a further constraint on their two respective Aethae: simply put, we have that such identity attributes have to actually be directly blank in one another's Aethae.

For example, we might imagine that Emily has black hair while her father has brown hair. We would then have to conclude that the attribute "my hair color" would have to be directly blank in each of their Aethae, (ie anything but state-decomposable), as this is precisely that which allows us to avoid the assertion of disjoint Aethae on account of that attribute. The fundamental Aethic treatment to consider, then, is that their respective empirical Aethae would have to be structured in just such a way so that Emily's father specifically retrieves the attribute of hair color as brown, (whatever the cascade of retrieval union and intersection interactions must be in order to even entertain construing such a qualia-adjacent property), whereas Emily herself retrieves the attribute of hair color as black. The ability for attributes to be strictly directly blank, but still be retrieved in a particular way, note, is a very fundamental principle of empirical Aethae, which for that matter is rather mandatory in establishing the ability of Aethic reasoning to resist seeming "gotchas" like this, so to speak. So note that this is not an *ad hoc* argument, but rather an assessment that forcing human construct-adjacent attributes of identity like name, gender, or hair color must be directly blank to a given Aethus, all while the prospect of the ability to retrieve attributes being identical to their being state decomposable is to be taken as a fallacy. Note that a more rigorous statement of such a premise, and how it constrains the attribute cascade of static Aethae, is to be discussed in the section on permanencible attributes. Altogether with the case of Emily and her father, the intuitive conclusion to gather is that the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae itself establishes a complexity for empirical Aethae far beyond what we can construct with logically and categorically-simplistic systems like a human's name, hair color, or gender, so it is become a rather natural conclusion that the statement of these being directly blank in an empirical Aerhus, and coming about in retrieval from vastly more complex interlocking Aethic structural circumstances, is well justified accordingly.

actually a claim of solipsism, and thereby anti-realism. Instead, it is in some sense the exact opposite, because rather than the existential reality of the unknown being limited, here it is exaggerated as compared to the suppositions of classical metaphysics. This is why Aethic reasoning is fundamentally a claim of relativism rather than anti-realism.

2.3.11 Aethic Interpretation of Quantum Logical Antirealism

There is something of a common philosophical stance with which our modern paradigm approaches quantum mechanics, so let us describe such a stance now. It can be referred to as *quantum logical antirealism*. The notion here comes from mainly two categories, but which together are arguing essentially the same thing.

1. The human brain, on account of the setting and context to our evolution, is fundamentally incapable of understanding a notion which is so far removed from it as an ontological quantum effect. As such, something about the very structure and or functionality of our brain is missing sufficient scope to comprehend a quantum phenomenon. Through such a thing, we then imply that the quantum world itself is incapable of being constructed in a rationalist ontological framework.

   Consider the following quote from physicist Carlo Rovelli which argues for such a mindset.

   > "We have to accept that the universe is not made to be understandable by our brains. It doesn't have to fit our personal intuition. The further we go, the less the universe cares about our daily experiences and personal perspective." [49]

2. The quantum world itself is fundamentally indescribable with a rationalist framework of any sort. In this way, the quantum wavefunction not only epistemically unobservable, but is representative of an ontological black box through which rational comprehension is physically incapable of traversing. That is, the inability of an agent to actually trace the intermediate procedural ontic logic between two times in a quantum system with a personally[40] inductive analysis is a fundamental inability no less real than quantum uncertainty [24] itself.

   Here is an example quote from Niels Bohr which would fall under this phrasing of quantum logical antirealism. Of course it seems like a reasonable enough statement from an epistemic standpoint, but we have to understand that it's ontologically void, because simply inventing a non-realizable epistemic system of happening is the epitome of the failure to be ontologically well-defined. Therefore, asserting that this follows through to the ontology is to assume a paradox of such ontology.

   > "Those who are not shocked when they first come across quantum theory cannot possibly have understood it. The classical view of reality collapses, because in quantum mechanics, things are not simply in 'either-or' states. Superposition forces us to abandon classical logic entirely—it defies the categories of 'both,' 'neither,' or any logical characterization we can construct. We must invent new ways of understanding existence." [50]

Notice how the truth of either of these would essentially imply a solution to the measurement problem—because the solution would simply regard there being no such rationalist system to quantum mechanics. However, let us notice the clear difference between *a lack of ontological applicability for the standard rational system* versus *a lack of ontological applicability for any rational system at all.* We are going to make the strict argument in this paper that the latter statement is something of an absurdity, even to the degree of being logically paradoxical. Such a position on its validity will be termed the *forbidden-epistemic antirealism principle.*

Principle 16 (Forbidden-Epistemic Antirealism Principle)
In Aethic reasoning, we hold that a general supposition of epistemic antirealism is both a construct gathered out of an epistemological misinterpretation of the brain, and through such a thing is reliably

[40] Personally inductive arguments are meant to mean those which can be induced from the most practical possible axioms, which can be contrasted with the second-order inductive reasoning of the Copenhagen interpretation, where none of the quantum phenomena can be described without the single intermediary of the known quantum empiricism. Einstein himself demonstrates for us something of a masterclass in favoring personally inductive derivations, as seen by his instinct to relate the physics of time to his own experiences during his thought experiments instead of directly postulating them in an impersonal way. We might go so far as to argue that the modern conception of the quantum world being impersonal is a major part of the problem.

false as a stance in abstract logic. For instance, we argue that the extrapolation from the quantum uncertainty [24] principle to quantum logical antirealism is in direct conflict with the dual logic principle of Aethic reasoning, specifically on account of it confusing an uncertainty principle over causal logic with one over abstract logic. In Aethic reasoning, we directly counter this by supposing that arguing for epistemic antirealism is effectively arguing for a paradox, due to its position in abstract rather than causal logic[41]*.*

Furthermore, in our current society at least, it tends to associate by connotation with a kind of scientific pessimism and lacking of motivation for further research. In the specific case of quantum logical antirealism, it is often a doctrine held by a person on account of their not putting much value in the measurement problem, (out of it either being to them unsolvable or otherwise irrelevant), hence contrasting it with direct scientific motivation of progress. In this way, it is quite analogous to a Premodernist thinker deciding not to pursue a truth because "god made it so[42]*."*

Through such a thing, the very notion of Aethic reasoning's stubborn assertion of a solution to the measurement problem can be directly contrasted to the doctrine of epistemic antirealism. This makes for an intriguing round of insight into the interplay between Metamodernism and Aethic reasoning. Even though Aethic reasoning asserts the advancements of human thought associated with Postmodernism, such as the state of reality being quantum-compatible in the first place, it also holds an interesting connotation which is more reminiscent of Modernism, where it asserts stubbornly that said quantum-compatibilities are very much of a rational configuration, if only we can find it. If Aethic reasoning, then, can be considered something of a template by example to the belief structure of Metamodernism, then we might define Metamodernism itself as "the structural capacity of Modernism together with the philosophical advancements of Postmodernism."

As a direct alternative to epistemic antirealism, then, we are to argue that an ontological system ought to possess a rationalist correspondence. Note that this does not conflict with Gödel's incompleteness theorem, because an inability to construct a completely descriptive mathematical system is not equivalent to the prospect of describing an ontological paradigm. The incompleteness theorem will of course be applicable to the level of completeness of information which is accessible within such a paradigm, but it says nothing about the ability to establish the paradigm in the first place. As such, we might once again argue that epistemic antirealism is not only unsupported, but entirely paradoxical as even a supposition. It is by properly denying the potential for epistemic realism to exist that we will be able to accurately partition the universe of counterintuitive logical barriers, from Gödel's incompleteness theorem to quantum uncertainty [24], into their proper ontological stances. This does not mean appeasing the classical paradigm itself, note.

We may refer to the notion of quantum logical antirealism by two major names as we continue with the paper.

[41] As such, we might consider deriving the forbidden-epistemic antirealism principle directly from the Aethic corollary that an ontological paradigm ought not to go in Aethic superposition of correctness.

[42] I might add, rather importantly, that humanity has come face-to-face with perceived epistemic antirealism in the past. Most importantly, this is exactly how we approached the motion of the planets prior to the Newtonian revolution, in which time it was imagined that invisible angels pulled the planets along their orbital paths [51]. The key reasons why this represents epistemic antirealism, then, is firstly because such an interpretation clearly and outwardly denies grounding in the phenomenon of the lives of humans, (as after all the distinction is made explicit in the "mortal versus angelic matters" and such), and secondly because of the nature of our retrospective viewing of it: *that interpretation was simply a psychological phenomenon following from our lack of a clear axiomatic framework of gravity.* In effect, then, perhaps the driving motivation behind my framing of the forbidden-epistemic antirealism principle is the sheer observation that we as a species have been in this very situation before. Sure, we may have been mentioning angels then, and the black-box issues of the Copenhagen interpretation and quantum computing now, but the fundamental phenomenon remains the same: *we are simply living in the time prior to the epistemic and ontological revolution, whatever it may be.* So when I started working out Aethic reasoning at the very beginning, this was my driving intuition: *it has already been done, by Newton himself, so we know at least that it can be done.* If we did not have Newton to compare to, then yes, maybe epistemic antirealism could be entertained as an ontology, but in reality we as a species have come to this crossroads before, and have left it in triumph. So no matter how steep the odds seem this time around, *we know it can be done*, so all we have to do is do it ourselves.
More directly speaking, we may note that Newton was effectively engaging in one of history's greatest empirical unscrambling endeavors when he declared exactly which prospects controlled what in his theory of gravity. We must understand that to the prior world before such a Newtonian revolution, there will have been an enormously overwhelming mess of empirical data in place of the would-be theory of gravity. In effect, then, at even the base circumstantial level, we see striking parallels between the view of gravity pre-Newton, and the view of quantum mechanics of our own generation, as emphasized with E. T. Jaynes's famous quote:

> "A peculiar mixture describing in part realities of Nature, in part incomplete human information about Nature—all scrambled up together by Heisenberg and Bohr into an omelette that nobody has seen how to unscramble." [52, 53]

1. First-order epistemic antirealism is the supposition that as we stray into ever deeper physics, there is a heightening falloff between each new discovery and one's tangible life. That is, each new discovery is considerably more impersonal than the last, as if by the will of some underlying ontological trajectory.

   Personally speaking, I am in fierce opposition to such a statement as this. Is it not a direct betrayal to the very heart of science? Even though it is ontologically milder than the following two orders, it seems philosophically more potent. Notice how over the centuries, the observed empirical patterns of interpretation which associate with this view are more a question of human ignorance than any kind of ontological trajectory to the universe.

2. Second-order epistemic antirealism is the supposition that human intuitions and or mental capabilities prove insufficient in dealing with effects of quantum superposition.

   Note that perhaps the entire mission statement of Aethic reasoning is to combat this assumption through counterexample[43].

3. Third-order epistemic antirealism, (or more colloquially, "full-blown epistemic antirealism"), is the supposition that the paradigmatic structure of quantum superpositions themselves is irreconcilable by a thinking agent of our mortal human variety. This is perhaps most commonly illustrated in the point expressed in the above quote from Bohr, where it is supposed that no truly tangible logical system can also be made to encapsulate quantum effects.

   This statement almost feels like the sirens of Odysseus, where it tempts you to comply with it for its surface-level elegance. Yes, it is fascinating, and yes, it is convenient, but it will never not lack an ontological support. We have to realize that for this statement to be true is in direct conflict with the possibility of ever solving the measurement problem, so in that regard it is rather like the teeth of that siren as well. In general, we have to combat it to proceed with any sort of solution.

Note that one might counter our rendering of first-order epistemic antirealism by supposing that physics merely does what it does anyway, with our human opinions about what is or is not scientific being immaterial. However — this is not consistent with what we are arguing in the first place. What we mean to argue on the topic is that first-order epistemic antirealism is not some external observable circumstance, but rather a predictable psychological consequence of *a paradigm's epistemology significantly outpacing its ontology*, and nothing more.

Two illustrations: Planck early, and lensing late. To illustrate this, consider what would happen in a scenario where Planck's theory of black-body radiation was not immediately superseded by Einstein's ontological interpretation. Perhaps Einstein was fifteen years younger, for example. Intuitively, we can assess that Planck's quanta, as a mathematical construct, would become rather mystical for their ontological elusiveness, perhaps to the point of being considered ontologically inaccessible in full. It is hard to ignore the similarities between this example and our own situation with the measurement problem. And, for another example, think of how we would interpret gravitational lensing if we had somehow detected it before general relativity could be established. Would we not think of it as mystical and in defiance of human reason?

The point of the examples. The point of all these examples is that the physical circumstances which physics attempts to comprehend are perfectly compatible with a human's intuition and scope of reasoning, so when we argue that the physics has fallen off in its epistemic realism, what we are really measuring is our own temporary lacking in ontology. Intuitively, we might expect that if all the finished theories of physics were to be written out in full before us, they would all have a natural and effortless connection to our everyday lives and experiences, as after all that is what they explain in the first place. When we lose sight of this, we have lost sight of what we were after with physics in the first place: a relevant explanation for the nature of reality. Would the conclusive explanation of everything not be relevant with that everything? Of course not! It would be the ultimate expression of interrelatedness within it, not some divisive and ontologically incomprehensible mess. As such, from this line of reasoning we have that the stance of first-order epistemic antirealism is not much more than an inevitable consequence of somebody existing in the time directly before the ontology takes on its next wave of progress.

[43] Such a mission statement might be phrased as "*even the quantum superposition becomes existentially intuitive under the right paradigm.*"

What we get from all this is an important principle[44] of human thought, which we might bold accordingly. ***Scientific progress is only ever as good as its ontological content.***

2.4 The Aethic Union Principle

Orientation. Readers from logic will expect *or* to be exclusive-or-inclusive by fiat and disjunction to be a truth-functional connective; readers from quantum logic will expect the lattice of subspaces, with superposition as a non-distributive join. The principle stated in this subsection is neither. It holds that jointness is primitive and *exclusion is an achievement*—a classical disjunction is a jointness whose alternatives carry declared exclusions in their interiors, and a superposition is a jointness whose alternatives do not—so that the difference between a classical *or* and a quantum superposition is a difference in what is written into the alternatives, not in the logic that composes them. Distributivity is not abandoned wherever the alternatives are carved: over determinate alternatives, and over any carving that records assert, meets distribute over unions (Proposition 14). The union is still a union, and the non-classical behavior, the failure of distributivity included, is confined to what the alternatives' interiors leave undeclared. Everything downstream of this point in the paper—the third postulate, the

[44]Allow me to briefly assess my thoughts on the "great man theory" [54] under the context of ontological progress in science. It must first be acknowledged that the great man theory's historical evidence base is severely compromised by the systematic exclusion of women, people of color, and other marginalized groups from education and scientific institutions—a selection bias so profound that any causal claims derived from the existing record of 'great individuals' should be treated with corresponding skepticism. Moreover, this exclusion speaks exclusively to the cruelty of the structures that enforced it, and says nothing whatsoever about the intellectual capacity of those it targeted; the conflation of denied access with diminished ability is among the most persistent and damaging errors in the history of ideas, and one that any serious discussion of individual brilliance has an obligation to repudiate. With these caveats firmly in place, however, the question of whether individual cognitive outliers play a structurally necessary role in paradigm shifts remains a separate and worthwhile inquiry.

The basic understanding I have come to is Kuhnian [55] in the sense that both the individual and the collective are absolutely indispensable to the flow of human progress. This is exactly where I find the debate of the great man theory versus the power of the collective theory [54] as bordering on naïve in the sense of insisting that we have to pick just one. In reality what I see is that there are two very distinct roles at play—individuals are necessary for sparking paradigm shifts, and the collective is necessary for the normal science in-between paradigm shifts. If you had to pick which of the two is *more* important in terms of sheer degree of activity, it would be the collective due to their dominating progress for larger stretches of time, but removing either them or the individual would be utterly catastrophic to the flow of history. It is precisely like how the body depends on both the heart and the spine to survive. It would be absurd to suggest that one is *more* important than the other, since removing either will kill you instantly. This is my feeling on the individual-versus-collective debate—being that they both play important and distinct roles, often times at separate points in history, and removing either from the equation would be catastrophic on a level that is difficult to overstate.

Where I perhaps differ in my views from the base Kuhnian account, however, lies in where I additionally attribute the difference in these roles. Now, I genuinely have a feeling that ontological work in physics necessarily requires a single person to formulate it, for the reason that you have never exactly had an ontological breakthrough in physics which was done by the full collective. Again, I must stress that this does not validate the oversimplified reading in the slightest that this makes the individual *more* valuable than the collective, and instead merely highlights perhaps the one and only necessary feature of scientific progress which indeed must be done by the individual in order to work. See my footnote on Mozartian human intuition as a Galois group to elaborate on the unique contribution of the individual. Concerning why I believe this conclusion to be evidenced by the historical record, it is because of the sheer contrast between the relativistic revolution and the quantum revolution. We might notice how the direct move Einstein made in special relativity was to take a mixed-up jumble of empirical data spread across many locations, and unify it under one single ontological mechanism. Notice how it required all three of the relativity of simultaneity, the consistency of the speed of light, and the naturalness of the connection of this to the existing empiricism which enabled such a breakthrough. Then we might look at general relativity itself, which is perhaps the single greatest masterpiece of ontological achievement in the history of physics. Next to quantum mechanics, now, the ontological completeness of general relativity is particularly striking. While general relativity is a masterpiece of ontological achievement, quantum mechanics is anomalous in the history of physics for its sheer vacancy of ontological content. While this is not an assessment of the difference in total quality between the two theories, it is a comparison between a particular feature between the two of them that I don't feel is pointed out often enough, for whatever reason. This is where we also get another tier of comparison between thinkers like Einstein and Dirac. While the Dirac equation [56] itself is easily as mathematically elegant as Einstein's special relativity [27], and arguably more so due to its further level of fundamentality, still I feel the elephant in the room concerning the comparison of them is that Einstein's special relativity is explicit in its ontological implications, while the Dirac equation, like the remainder of quantum mechanics, leaves its ontological implications unsaid. So for this reason Einstein fits the characterization of Newtonian that much better than Dirac, even though in terms of raw brilliance they are surely on par.

Now onto what this means for the inevitability thesis [57] concerning whether someone else will have discovered special relativity or even general relativity had Einstein not. For this I want to be as delicate as I can, but genuinely I think it would have been quite a long shot for either. This is where things get especially tricky, because while I appreciate the resistance to the great man theory on moral grounds, genuinely Einstein is not just some trivial person. General relativity in particular remains, a full century later, a work whose ontological depth has arguably not been matched by any subsequent advance in physics—and this stubborn singularity in the historical record is itself evidence that the capacity to produce such work is extraordinarily rare. So, yes, Einstein is a nontrivial part of history, who indeed cannot just be reduced to retrospective hype.

reduced form, the record classification, the two composition laws—runs on that one reform, which is why it is introduced through a paradox the extrusion principle itself creates.

2.4.1 The Paradox

The Extrusion Principle creates an immediate paradox. Recall the aphorism from section 2.2.2: *the multiverse does not contain the room, the room contains the multiverse.* If the multiverse is genuinely in the room—if both versions of every unknown outcome are genuinely here, in the same physical space—then we need to explain why you only see one. The Union Principle is that explanation.

Consider a sign on the side of the road: you observe it on the left. According to the Extrusion Principle, both outcomes—sign on left *and* sign on right—should coexist as a physical 'and' in your block universe. Yet you only observe one. Why don't we see the sign on both sides at once? The resolution requires recognizing a fundamental distinction that classical physics obscured: the difference between *logical* operations (abstract structural rules) and their *physical* manifestations (how reality occupies the block universe).

2.4.2 Stating the Aethic Union Principle

Principle 17 (Aethic Union Principle)
Classical physics conflates logical structure with physical presence, treating them as synonymous. Aethic reasoning separates these domains: while classical logic remains valid for abstract reasoning, physical reality manifests both logical disjunctions and conjunctions as occupation of the block universe—what we perceive as physical 'and'. The apparent classical 'or' (mutual exclusivity) emerges not from fundamental physics but from nested logical structure that forbids interaction between states while allowing their simultaneous presence.

The constraint it answers. At least by analogy, the Union Principle addresses a constraint tension similar to the principle of relativity [27]: it answers the question "what must a universe look like which is both logically realist and able to accommodate an object being in two places at once?" Logical realism requires preserving the law of non-contradiction, which seems to clash with quantum superposition. The Union Principle's resolution is to recognize that logical 'or' realizes as physical 'and'—satisfying the "two places at once" requirement—while still preserving non-contradiction by ensuring that disjoint attributes, when taken in intersection, form an "Aethic contradiction" (formally, an invalid Aethus). Thus, while ontologically radical, the Union Principle is empirically motivated: Bell's theorem [4] demonstrates quantum mechanics' stubborn resistance to hidden-variable determinism, suggesting the latter part of the constraint is true of our universe.

Table 3 shows how logical operations map to physical manifestations and mathematical form.

Concerning the inevitability thesis more broadly, the "thin film" of ontology, as so eloquently put by Spekkens [7], seems in my experience to be overestimated in prospect and underestimated in retrospect. Everything may be "in the air" empirically—as it has been since at least the 1940s concerning the measurement problem—but does that mean that the ontological aspect could have been attained from decidedly non-ontological methodologies? Poincaré was brilliant [57], but ontology was not his thing, so could he have recognized the relativity of simultaneity? If he could have, then why did no anthropic reasoner come to the Accordance Principle? The general pattern I notice is that the collective finds tiny ontological perturbations around the known metaphysics far more inaccessible than is typically assumed. I find myself unconvinced by accounts of scientific progress which treat ontological breakthroughs as inevitable products of collective effort rather than as depending, at least in part, on the specific cognitive orientations of individuals. From this respect I consider a masterpiece in the caliber of general relativity—something which makes my own work look trivial by comparison—to be not only difficult for the collective to have discovered on its own, but to represent a category of achievement whose rarity is systematically underestimated by those studying it in retrospect. Concerning the further scientific revolutions that none of us have achieved just yet, it is like living the very refutation of one's thesis without even noticing it.

Logical	**Physical**	**Type**	**Mathematical Form**
Logical OR	Physical AND	Agreeing	$\bigcup_i a_i$
Logical AND (quantum)	Physical AND	Agreeing	$\bigcup_i a_i$
Logical AND (classical)	Physical AND	—	$\bigcap_i A_i$
Classical "OR"	Physical AND	Disagreeing	$\bigcup_i (a_i \cap \bigcap_{j \neq i} \neg a_j)$

Table 3: Aethic Union Principle Canonical Table: Logical operations, physical manifestations, and mathematical structure. The key insight: both logical disjunction and conjunction manifest as physical AND (block universe occupation), differing only in their algebraic structure. Agreeing superposition uses elementary union ($\cup$); disagreeing superposition uses nested union-over-intersections with negations.

Notice what the column labeled 'Physical' contains: only one entry, repeated four times. ***AND****. There is no row where the physical manifestation is OR. This is the core claim. Physical 'or' does not exist. Every logical operation—whether AND or OR—manifests as physical co-occupation of the block universe. The difference between quantum interference and classical mutual exclusivity is not a difference in physical presence. It is a difference in algebraic nesting.*

How 'and' bifurcates. A classical 'and' bifurcates in the Aethic framework: it can manifest either as a logical intersection (like two objects resting on a table) or, in the quantum case, as a logical union producing an agreeing superposition (like the double-slit interference [32, 58]). A classical 'or' becomes a logical union manifesting as a disagreeing superposition. Crucially, physical 'and' is not the counterpart of logical 'and'—it occupies an entirely separate conceptual category. Logical operations (AND, OR, negation) are structural *distinctions governing how information combines algebraically; physical 'and' is merely the* phenomenological *fact of occupation in the block universe. Because these are categorically distinct domains, no elementary physical 'or' can exist—the very notion of physical AND versus physical OR is a category error that classical physics imposed by conflating structural operations with phenomenological presence. This is the ontic root behind why an Aethic superposition is at once a logical 'or' (in its algebraic structure) but manifests as physical occupation (what we intuitively call 'and').*

The mappings in Table 3 follow from the interplay between the Extrusion Principle and Second Postulate. From the Aethic mathematical structure, *conceptual blanks*—attributes absent from an Aethus—materialize as physical superpositions. This creates two distinct pathways to the same physical result:

1. **Adding information** to an Aethus instills a logical conjunction, (Aethic intersection), directly asserting that multiple states coexist.

2. **Subtracting information** from an Aethus instills a logical disjunction, (Aethic union), creating a conceptual blank that becomes a superposition by the Second Postulate.

Either pathway results in both possible options physically occurring at once in the block universe, (physical 'and'). This is the heart of the Union Principle's power: quantum 'and' can be re-rendered as logical 'or' (via agreeing superposition) while still replicating the empirical effect of coexisting scenarios by means of its physical 'and'. The disagreeing superposition then builds on this foundation by adding nested structure that forbids interaction while preserving copresence.

Compilation versus realization: the principle as a two-stage map. The categorical separation just drawn admits a compact formal statement that is worth recording, because it localizes the nonclassicality exactly. Read the passage from logic to physics as a composition of two maps. The second map, *realization*, sends an Aethic expression to block-universe occupation, and it is entirely innocent: it respects the Aethic operations as they stand—sums realize as co-present pockets, products as joint assertion—which is precisely the structure-preservation that the weighted formulation's commutative semiring later makes exact. The first map, *compilation*, is where the Union Principle lives: it translates Boolean connectives into Aethic commutative semiring expressions, and it is deliberately *not* a homomorphism of Boolean algebras. Disjunction compiles to the plain sum when the distinction is inaccessible, (agreeing), and to the nested union-over-negated-intersections when it is accessible,

(disagreeing); quantum conjunction compiles to the plain sum as well; classical conjunction compiles to the product. The canonical table above is exactly this compiler's instruction set. The slogan version: *physical 'or' does not exist because or-ness is consumed at compile time*—the target algebra contains only sum and product, both realized as co-presence, so the Boolean distinction survives not as an operation but as the *shape* of the compiled expression, the pocket-typing that the rest of the paper reads validity and interaction off of. Stated this way, the principle's empirical content also sharpens: experiments never probe the compiler's source language, only its compiled output—which is why the framework can remain logically realist about the source while being radical about what occupies the block.

2.4.3 Two Types of Superposition

This principle introduces two fundamentally distinct types of superposition, differing in their algebraic structure:

Agreeing Superposition represents states that *can* interfere—the quantum "both slits at once." Mathematically *elementary*, it is a simple union:

$$C_1 = \bigcup_i A_i \tag{1}$$

This corresponds to quantum coherence: the electron genuinely traverses both paths, and these paths interact to produce an interference pattern. The states coexist and can interfere because they do not mutually forbid each other's realization. (A scope note owed to the physicist who reads "coherence" here: the union's attribute-side content is binary—the cross attribute declared false, or left undeclared—while relative phase is continuous and enters only through the Quantum Nexus weighting, Principle 50. Two setups identical on the attribute side can therefore differ in pattern, and what the two types render is the coherent/mixed *regime* distinction, not the state; no claim is made that the state is attribute-side.)

Disagreeing Superposition represents states that *cannot* interfere—the classical "one or the other." This resolves the sign paradox. The sign *is* on both sides of the road simultaneously as a physical 'AND'—the Extrusion Principle holds. However, the nested composite structure forbids interaction between these states, creating the appearance of mutual exclusivity:

$$C_2 = \bigcup_i \left(a_i \cap \bigcap_{j \neq i} \neg a_j \right) \tag{2}$$

The lower-case letters are pegs of one attribute, and each term $a_i \cap \bigcap_{j \neq i} \neg a_j$ is a state: its interior holds the peg a_i and, filling the attribute with exactly that peg, excludes the rest, so that each peg is held in a state of its own together with the exclusion of all the other pegs. An interior is always of a state and holds pegs, never other states or their negations; the negations in the inner intersection are exclusions of pegs, and the agreeing form $\bigcup_i a_i$ is the pegs composed within one interior, the state holding all of them. The outer union ($\cup$) ensures both sign-left and sign-right are physically present (physical 'AND'); the inner intersections with negations ($\cap\neg$) enforce observational mutual exclusivity (appearing as classical 'OR'). When you observe the sign on the left side of the road, your entire block universe becomes permanently unable to interact with the version where the sign is on the right—not because the right-side version doesn't exist, but because within your Aethus, that state is explicitly encoded as nonexistent. (A consequence worth flagging this early, developed in full in Section 10.2.4: of the two types, only disagreeing superpositions ever collapse—an agreeing superposition is never resolved to one of its own constituents, only ever invalidated wholesale in favor of a disjoint alternative.)

This precisely matches the empiricism of a timeline-branching model: you observe only one outcome, with no access to the alternative—and it matches it because branching is the correct phenomenology of records, deduced here rather than posited, (Section 2.4.5). The crucial difference is ontological: where timeline-branching posits the alternative timeline is spatially elsewhere, disagreeing superposition maintains both timelines are *here*, occupying the same physical space[45], separated only by informational-algebraic nesting that forbids their interaction. This mutual forbiddance is not metaphysically mystical or ad hoc—it is a direct algebraic consequence of the nesting structure[46].

[45] Or otherwise prior block universe, as per the extrusion principle.

[46] From this structural invariance—that both logical operations manifest as physical 'and'—any preference for one

2.4.4 Where Non-Interactivity Lives: Interior Versus Exterior

It is essential to be precise about *where* the non-interactivity of a disagreeing superposition comes from, because this is the point at which the Union Principle departs most sharply from the classical multiverse picture. (Read forward: the interior negation this section locates is, in the weighted development, exactly the complement mechanism $A - AB$ of Section 4.7.4—the stated value's arrival prunes its rivals by intersection, and the rivals are what the subtraction leaves—so "interior" names *where* the negation is carried, in the pocket's own content, and the complement names *how*, without a negation primitive at either address.)

The exterior reading, and its choppiness. Empirically we know non-interaction is enforced for the relative systems in disagreeing superposition, so it has to come from somewhere. The classical multiverse framework assumes it must come from the *exterior* operation holding the states apart—that is, the "or" which combines them. This, naturally, forces one to assume that such an "or" must necessarily function precisely like how we intuit it does in classical metaphysics, with its strict "one or the other but never both" choosiness. The fallacious result of this however—and this is key—is that this then directly forces upon us the "choppiness" problem articulated in section 2.4.12, for which the nature of physical-world "or"s is artificially deemed inequivalent to the precedent already established by sentential logic for how a disjunction ought to operate.

The interior reading. We as a civilization have sufficient faith in sentential logic to find this suspicious, so tracing the problem back to the source, we propose the Union Principle as a resolution triggered by attributing the "non-interactivity" driver to the *interior* of the pockets as opposed to ever having to attribute it to the outer Aethic disjunction in the first place. The result is that we are left with a clean disjunction consistent with the Boolean [59] revolution of sentential logic, and the payoff is that we attribute the non-interactivity to the interior of the pockets instead by process of elimination, and thereby produce all downstream consequences of the Union Principle like the prediction of the existence of agreeing superpositions and the deepest layer of the Aethic union principle premise.

In other words. In other words: it is not that the pockets are externally blocked off from each other. Rather, each pocket internally and explicitly forbids the others by conjunctive logical negations, as is the direct statement of the inner nesting $a_i \cap \bigcap_{j \neq i} \neg a_j$. If a pocket is not compelled to internally forbid the others, then whatever it ceases to forbid registers as a standard agreeing superposition where interaction is permitted. This is what leads directly into the deepest layer of the Aethic union principle, which establishes how the disagreeing superposition's non-interactivity structure is a special case rather than a general intrinsic principle.

A note to the reader: I also would like to stress that once you have attained a sufficient comprehension of the Aethic framework, you really ought to look at the interplay between the Powerset Invalidation Theorem (Theorem 14) and the Aethic union principle pockets concept. What is highly important to mention is that the Aethic union principle is perhaps the uniquely given by inductive reasoning to universalization upon the Powerset Invalidation Theorem—which I would argue, in context of the double-slit case itself in early 2023, was in retrospect[47] *a key factor in my finding of the Aethic union*

outcome as objectively more "real" than another becomes arbitrary, lacking justification. A preferential outcome is only established when an observer physically adds a new attribute to their Aethus, creating a "child Aethus" in which a single state is declared. This action aligns with the Extrusion Principle's model of collapse, tying the observer to the version of reality they observed and preventing interaction with alternate copies, thereby shifting their entire block universe from non-preferred superposition to a single definite outcome.

principle to begin with. What I ought especially to stress about this is how upon looking at the powerset of the slit cases, notice how it is quite explicitly the interior of each such Aethus which forces through the nonexistence of certain slit-traversal instances, and by virtue of that blocks off the realization of other powerset element instances in a strictly indirect sense. For this reason I think inside the slit analysis itself is the seed of the interior-specification-of-interactivity-ability concept, in that by simply paying enough attention to it, and crucially asking the inductive reasoning question of what must a universe look like, inclusive of all peripheral[48] context, which insists on providing us with this ontology upon the powerset of traversed slits*, the universe gives us the Aethic union principle effectively for free.*

[47]Specifically, I think my recognition of the union principle was about three major things happening concurrently (although this, I should note, is a retrospective reconstruction, as my journal entries from early 2023 are rather frustratingly sparse—that is, this may be seen as a combination of my knowing for sure that I was perfectly articulating the case-by-case breakdown of the double-slit experiment by Summer 2023, and then effectively interpolating over how I was well aware of the Aethic definitional hierarchy structure by the end of 2022, as per my explicit mentioning of it throughout journal entries, plus the obvious memory that I had its intuition down forwards and backwards by then, with blanks being the final proposition to be added at that time):

1. By the end of 2022, I had intuitively comprehended the Aethic structure, (that is, the intrinsic definitional hierarchy prospect), specifically by means of the addition of Aethic blanks-as-generate-superpositions to this structure after having had the prior base idea (i.e. "Attribute Sets") by the end of 2021. What I want to emphasize about this is that I believe the operability over blanks in the Aethic structure is key to making the Aethic union principle visible, because using it retrains your brain to envision both forward-addition of attributes and backward-removal as propagating possibilities in the Aethic retrievals upon the respective articulation or growth of Aethic superpositions. The other key insight the Aethic structure provides to the union principle is that establishing this bidirectional tending to "Physical AND", we also then see conjunctions versus disjunctions over attributes to play distinctly different roles, in the sense that—unlike with classical truth tables or logical Venn diagrams—disjunctions are categorically distinct from conjunctions, in the sense that no longer is conjunction serving as the intersection part of the Venn diagram actually considered a component subset of the inclusive disjunction. Instead, in the Aethic ontology the intersection part must only operate over categorically non-disjoint Aethic attributes in order to maintain Aethic validity, and alternatively agreeing superpositions operate over the categorically conflicting part of attributes so as to allow interaction between said attributes' various stated-attribute realities. In effect, the classical truth tables or Venn diagrams is visible as something of a lossy projection of this deeper Aethic structure, where the "jointness" taken over interaction-allowing agreeing superpositions by means of the inclusive disjunction is not only not redundant with the conjunction over two stated-attributes, but categorically distinct as if moving in orthogonal directions in the Aethic structure. In that sense, the Aethic structure itself is a substantial clue toward the Aethic union principle.
2. As for the actual two concurrent ideas, these came in early 2023. Specifically, the first was my building understanding of the case-by-case analysis of invalidity in the double-slit case, (which, implicitly encompasses all possible slit-powerset cases, but at the time I was using the double-slit case as a kind of inductive base case with which to capture all relevant cases, hence why I explicitly designed the Aethic postulates to refer to this carried inductive structure as opposed to the concrete double-slit case itself), while working out the concept of an invalid Aethus for the first time, and analyzing the contexts in which such a thing appears. This is the crucial recognition of the inductive root of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem concept, which as I mentioned was itself crucial to conceptualizing the Aethic Union Principle. However, the interesting thing I want to mention is that I hardly think this was a "chicken and egg" kind of sequential process—rather it was more about me feeling the particular structure of the Aethic union principle, and then progressively compounding the clarifications of this by going around in a loop to the case-by-case content, the Aethic structure, and the ontological content. So, as I usually do things anyway, it was like building three towers side-by-side, with each roughly being the same height of the others at any given time, as opposed to building one only, (since, crucially, you optimize the probability of building all three by building them in a such a concurrent way, as that maximizes the context into the others and how to connect them at any given moment, which minimizes guessing and thereby combinatorially increases your odds of success in the inductive reasoning—because, as is perhaps the golden rule of doing inductive reasoning practically, you have to remember you are leaning on the brainpower of a fleshy primate as your hardware, and so have to go in assuming your context-absent reaching for elegance will fail you—then from there you have to succeed anyway by being scrappy as all hell, if you will similarly to David bringing such a preparation to the battlefield that he defeats an army of Goliaths, or if you will something like the plot of *The Martian* [60]—he realizes intimately how outmatched he is, and so he stacks up so many micro-augmentations that he manages to turn his inherent stillness for progress as a human into something more like Brownian motion, and this gives him the reach needed to win the day).
3. The third concept was the ontological adherence itself, which was the thing being developed concurrently with the case-by-case analysis, and therefore probably edging out just before the completion of said case-by-case material due to the head start from the Aethic structure. But still, the idea is that the context of each of these elements as I built up the others helped reinforce one another by minimizing human error.

[48]That is, in the sense that it would violate Occam's razor should the universe choose to provide us with the ontology of the powerset of traversed slits in isolation, and so we must effectively infer to balance-out the universe again in light of this information that it is actually a projection of a deeper universal principle pertaining to how classical mutual exclusivity emerges as a special case of the behavior of logical disjunctions in the truer sense. Such a universal principle, as goes the Aethic argument, is the Aethic union principle itself.

2.4.5 The Branching Look, Deduced: Why Many-Worlds Was Right About the Phenomenology

What branching gets right. The many-worlds picture looks right for a reason, and the reason should be stated in its favor before the difference is drawn. Branching is the correct *phenomenology of records.* Once a record separates two alternatives, they stop interacting; each carries its weight; an observer finds themselves in one of them and has no access to the other; and no experiment ever shows the alternatives interfering again. That is what the data looks like, in every laboratory that has ever recorded an outcome, and Everett was reading the data honestly [2, 3]. His error was ontological, not observational: he took the non-interaction to be a *place*, and housed the alternatives in different worlds. The Union Principle keeps the phenomenology to the letter and reads the non-interaction as a fact about *content.* The records write the exclusions into the alternatives; alternatives whose interiors exclude one another do not interact; and so the same walls, the same weights, and the same observer-in-one-branch appear, all of it in one spacetime, relative to an index.

Deduced, not posited. The distinction is not a reinterpretation laid over many-worlds after the fact; it is a deduction, and its three steps are already on the books. A record separating two alternatives places each alternative's exclusion of the other in its interior, which by the Union Principle makes the superposition disagreeing rather than agreeing, (Section 2.4.2). Disagreeing superpositions do not interact, by the fundamental theorem, (Section 8). And the third postulate prunes any coherence claim across a record, (Theorem 14, third bin). So the non-interaction that Everett had to *posit* as a splitting of worlds is here a consequence of three postulates applied to whatever records the situation contains—a detector, a counter, a cat's chemistry, a friend's notebook. The whole difference between the two pictures is the difference between "worlds branch" and "records write walls," and the second is the one that follows from something.

The payoff branching cannot buy. The deduction has a consequence the many-worlds picture cannot obtain from its own resources. Because the walls are written into the alternatives rather than between worlds, the alternatives remain *pockets of one disagreeing superposition relative to an Aethus*—co-present, occupiable, co-spatial, as the ladder ontology of the next subsubsection sets out—and the weights that stand over them are weights *of* something: of pockets, relative to an index, convex by the Relational Weight Principle. Probability is inside the ontology. The branching picture, having made non-interaction a place, has nothing for its weights to be weights of, which is the branch-weight problem in its standing form and the debt the retrospective of Section 14.5 locates. Branching gets the picture and loses probability; the Union Principle gets both, because it never left the room.

The one piece of vocabulary. There is a historical shape to this, and it is the same shape the retrospective finds for every reading. Everett had the dynamics whole and the alternatives real—two of the three pieces the present ordering needs—and lacked *exclusion as an achievement*: the reform of *or* at the level of the disjuncts, on which what separates classical alternatives from quantum ones is what is written inside them. Without it, every alternative sat at one grade, co-present and interfering everywhere in principle, and the alternatives had to be housed somewhere. Put the index and the disjunct-level reform in, and his branches become this framework's pockets without a single prediction changing. That is the retrospective's general claim—each reading held a piece and lacked a piece of vocabulary—made concrete on the one interpretation people find hardest to give up, and it is why the cat, (Section 10.2), can be taught as the branching look without the branches.

2.4.6 Branches Are Aethae, Not Amplitude States

The carrier of a branch. The preceding subsubsection located the difference from many-worlds in where the non-interaction lives—between worlds, or inside the alternatives. There is a second difference beneath that one, and it is the deeper of the two: the two pictures disagree about *what a branch is made of.* In the Everettian picture a branch is a component of the universal wavefunction—a relative state, one term $|\psi_i\rangle|\text{observer}_i\rangle$ of an entangled sum—individuated by the basis in which decoherence approximately diagonalizes the reduced state, weighted by the squared modulus of its amplitude, and containing the observer as a subsystem entangled into it. In the present framework a branch is an *Aethus*: a whole information state, with its stated attributes, its blanks, its validity structure under the third postulate, and its weights over disagreeing alternatives. The state vector does not branch here, because the state vector is not the primitive: it is the polarization of the cluster weights, (Lemma 8), a bookkeeping object derived from the Aethus and never held by one. Everett branched the wavefunction. This framework transits the observer. Five consequences follow, and each is a place where the two pictures can be told apart.

The basis is chosen by the records, exactly. A branch in the Everettian picture needs a preferred basis, and the picture obtains one from decoherence: the basis in which the environment approximately diagonalizes the system's reduced state, exact only in a limit and "for all practical purposes" elsewhere. An Aethus needs no such supplement. The alternatives it stands over are the pockets of a disagreeing superposition, and which alternatives are disagreeing is fixed by which records exist—the signature partition of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14)—as an exact fact about the record configuration rather than an asymptotic fact about a density matrix. Where the branching picture has an approximate basis, the Aethus has a partition.

Weights are of pockets, and amplitudes are derived from them. An Everettian branch carries a measure, the squared amplitude, and the picture has had to argue for half a century about why that measure is a probability and what it is a probability *of*, since a branch is a term of a state and not an alternative that anyone selects among. An Aethus carries weights over its disagreeing pockets that are convex by the Relational Weight Principle and are the framework's own probability primitive, (Section 6.7). The direction of derivation is reversed: the branching picture starts from amplitudes and must derive a probability; the framework starts from weights and recovers the amplitudes by polarization. Probability is the genus; the amplitude is the species tailored to the agreeing regime.

An observer is never a superposed subsystem. In the Everettian picture the observer is inside the branching state, entangled with the system, and "in superposition" relative to a more encompassing observer—which is exactly the description Wigner gives of his friend and the source of the nested-observer paradoxes. In the present framework no observer is ever in an agreeing superposition: observers hold agreeing superpositions *of systems*, stand relative to one another in *disagreeing* superposition, and only disagreeing superpositions are ever selected among, (Section 10.2.4). The friend is disagreeing relative to Wigner because his records escape, not superposed relative to Wigner because the universal state says so.

No proliferation, and no recoherence. Branches multiply; Aethae are transited between. The prior Aethus keeps its disagreeing superposition forever at its own index, (the extrusion principle), and the posterior one never held it, so nothing is duplicated and nothing is counted. And where an Everettian branch, being a term of one unitarily evolving state, can in principle recohere with its siblings, a disagreeing superposition relative to an Aethus does not recohere, because the exclusions are written into its alternatives by records that exist. The quantum eraser is not a counterexample but the rule's confirmation: a record erased before it escapes to any Aethus was never a record relative to any Aethus that could read it, so the coherence claim was never checkmated, and the theorem re-bins the case, (Theorem 14).

Two grades, not one. An amplitude state has one grade—amplitude—and every alternative sits at it, which is why the branching picture cannot distinguish a superposition that interferes from one that does not except by dynamics. An Aethus has two: *validity*, which the third postulate assigns, and *weight*, which the books or the Nexus assign. The agreeing/disagreeing distinction lives at the first grade, and the branching picture's inability to state it is the inability of a one-grade object to carry a two-grade fact. That is the whole difference, stated at the level of the carrier: the branching picture housed the alternatives in the wrong place because it had made them out of the wrong thing.

2.4.7 The Ladder Ontology: What the Room Actually Contains

Critically, this means more information can be "packed" into the same physical space than classical physics recognized. A disagreeing superposition effectively creates a hidden hierarchy—a "ladder ontology[49]"—where both unions and intersections manifest identically as physical 'and', yet their algebraic nesting preserves crucial logical distinctions while maintaining a single phenomenological degree of freedom. Classical physics accidentally flattened this rich structure by treating all physical occupation as monolithic 'and', thereby obscuring the possibility of multiple nested levels operating simultaneously.

The pockets of the ladder ontology are not abstract mathematical constructs alone. They *are* the possible subsequent Aethic block universes themselves—the same block universes introduced with the Extrusion Principle (or more technically are the generalization[50] of block universes from Aethae to

[49]The reason "ladder ontology" is the term that came to mind, by the way, is because I consider the packaging of more content into an Aethic block universe than in typically assumed possible to be reminiscent of how the Earth's surface is two-dimensional, but by lowering a ladder into a cave you may access the third dimension that was always there.

[50]One might object to this pocket concept by saying that if two such pockets share the same physical space, then shouldn't one automatically see the contents of the other by means of being immersed in it? To this I recommend pushing back on that concrete-reductionist intuition, and for a particular reason: that would be an accurate assessment if

pseudo-Aethae, that way the disjunction operation joining them is an Aethic logical disjunction over pseudo-Aethae as opposed to the stricter Aethic union proper). Algebraically speaking, each pocket is one of the $a_i \cap \bigcap_{j \neq i} \neg a_j$ terms, and these are compiled together under an Aethic superposition to form the prior block universe. What the Extrusion Principle describes sequentially—you move from one block universe to the next along the Markov chain—the ladder ontology describes simultaneously: all subsequent block universes are co-present inside the prior one as pockets of a disagreeing superposition. The pockets are necessarily all co-present, by deduction from the fact that the outer-nested Aethic superposition renders as co-presence (physical 'and'). And yet they are forbidden from interacting, specifically because each internally states that the others are logically negated—not because there is some exterior separation between the pockets like in a classical timeline metaphysics. The Markov chain, viewed from the perspective of centric unfolding, tells you *how you move through* this structure: by gaining information, you extrude into one of the pockets, and from that subsequent block universe's perspective the superposition never existed. But the ladder ontology, viewed from the perspective of the prior block universe, tells you *what the structure contains*: all possible subsequent block universes, rendered ontologically in the same physical space, separated only by the algebraic nesting of their internal negations. These are not two different pictures of reality. They are the same picture viewed from two different angles. The Markov chain is the construction indexed by an Aethus—how the structure appears to you as you navigate it. The ladder ontology is the physical ontology—what the structure actually *is*, independent of which pocket you happen to occupy.

This is the aphorism made rigorous. The room (the prior block universe) contains the multiverse (all subsequent block universes as pockets) as the physical contents of a single disagreeing superposition. To see this in full, consider tracing the Aethus all the way back to the original Aethus—the Null Aethus—and then rendering every last disagreeing superposition in the block universe[51]. Most objectively speaking, *this is everything* that is currently co-present with you *physically*, and hence by this logic we derive the qualitative facet of the extrusion principle directly.

Regarding the formal distinction between the pockets and the block universes, it is that an Aethic block universe is a special case of an Aethic pocket such that its indicator is an Aethus rather than a more general pseudo-Aethus. The pseudo-Aethus treatment is merely a formalism for constructing agreeing superpositions, that is by leaving out the Aethic deduction that asserting one of the possible stated-attributes therein forces all disjoint alternatives to be false as in the case of a disagreeing superposition. Importantly, a main reason a pseudo-Aethus is only a construct is because oneself may never actually occupy a non-Aethus pseudo-Aethus in place of their Aethus, because in order to keep an Aethus consistent with the first postulate, its closure under deduction must remain well-defined, (as opposed to leaving certain parts out as in the pseudo-Aethus construction prior to forming a genuine Aethus out of them for a full agreeing superposition). So, the way I would state this is that pseudo-Aethae are not physically real like Aethae, in the sense that they always compile into full

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the pockets were joined by the conjunction operation (like "and"), however in reality they are, structurally, joined by the disjunction operation (like "or"). Even though both conjunction and disjunction count as "physical and" according to the Aethic union principle, the key consideration is that their algebraic behavior differs. The conjunction is the one which works exactly as expected, where every last asserted stated-attribute thereby must be present in the Aethic reality as precisely that, however in the case of logical disjunctions in the Aethic sense (not to be confused with the Aethic union, which operates over Aethae instead of attributes or more technically pseudo-Aethae), effectively what they provide us with is a clean slate—like extra "leverage" in "directional" degrees of freedom if you will—with which to then either assert the non-existence of a given stated-attribute inside a pocket and thereby constrain its existence, or refrain from stating that and allow the outer logical disjunction to mix the states interactively.

So the caveat here is in the difference between pockets purely as Aethae or block universes against the more union principle-accurate depiction of the pockets as pseudo-Aethae for which agreeing superposition interactivity is the consequence of influence spilling between the two states by means of either not being explicitly declared logically negated in the other's pocket. The most general default is the refraining to enforce the negations case, in which the agreeing superposition interactivity occurs, but in asserting each pocket is an Aethus object with state-decomposable attributes declared, for example, we then implicitly enforce the logical negations by deduction from that declaration.

[51] As a more visual intuitive illustration, notice how since the two versions of the sign are forbidden from interacting with each other because of the disagreeing superposition, *you yourself*, as an Aethic observer, also find yourself permanently unable to interact with one sign once you add the existence of the other to your Aethus by viewing or otherwise informationally interacting with it. Where centric unfolding always insists you view your block universe from your own perspective, this alternative invites you to instead view your Aethic updating from a single fixed Aethus in your own Aethic past. Notice how, from the perspective of this past Aethus, once you see one of the two signs, you basically "sort into the pocket" of the ladder ontology where you become permanently unable to see the second sign yourself. So from your perspective your Aethus just updated and the other sign is no longer in your chosen Aethic block universe, but from the perspective of the fixed past Aethus's block universe you merely sorted into a pocket of the ladder ontology where the second sign becomes permanently inaccessible—but still, in that block universe, the second sign is perfectly co-present with you as a "physical and". Altogether, the way you yourself view disagreeing superpositions that will be resolved in your Aethic future is how past versions of yourself view you currently.

Aethae containing a full agreeing superposition of the relative Aethic attribute anyway.

Pockets, formally. In the formal sense, the use of the "pockets" in place of Aethic block universes is a gesture at how the Aethic structure operates behind the scenes in ontological language. But the formal Aethus apparatus at play is that for agreeing superpositions, an actual additional stated-attribute is present in the Aethus which asserts that the attribute in question is directly blank, which itself constructs the agreeing superposition behavior of a static Aethic attribute occupying multiple states at once upon retrieval to the block universe while at once interacting jointly due to the lack of an explicit disagreeing superposition structure into decomposed proper child Aethae.

Irreducibility, and the corollary. What is key about this, however, is its irreducibility into more Aethae, because any proper child Aethus of this Aethus which asserts the attribute in agreeing superposition at a state-decomposable value triggers an invalidity. *Hence, why agreeing superpositions themselves ought to be thought of as, in the block universe-decomposability sense, elementary to the same extent as are stated-decomposable attributes themselves, just of course with an alternative ontological context.* This also gives as a corollary that a directly blank attribute to an Aethus which is decomposable as proper child Aethae in which it is validly state-decomposable must then place that attribute in disagreeing superposition within the original Aethus.

The thing I want to emphasize is that the pockets are for the purpose of intuition-building about the underlying ontology itself. This means that one view of them is to use Aethae directly so as to emphasize the ability for oneself to occupy one, in which case the concept is that a full agreeing superposition of many states is a pocket, and each general state under the attribute union of the disagreeing superposition is a pocket. These are directly the states over which the extrusion principle operates in terms of designating them as independent block universes as arranged into the Markov chain structure, all while nonetheless occupying the same physical space. Alternatively, one might find it more intuitive to refer to the pockets specifically as that which are combined by the attribute union—so as to lose the quality of inhabitation by Aethus, but while picking up the quality of intuitively expressing the "refraining from negating alternative states" to a pocket concept of an agreeing superposition. In any case, the latter designation helps the pockets concept describe another quality of the Aethic structure independently to the block universe-Aethus category, and hence my use of them in this second sense. In such a sense, the occupation quality is a strict subset of instances, for which we are referring to a state of a disagreeing superposition or an attribute union-combination of them which is thereby expressible with an Aethus. So, the block universes are intuitively understandable as "pocket-like" you might say, but perhaps it is pedagogically advisable to treat the "pockets" proper as holding the quality of being joined by the attribute union, perhaps.

2.4.8 The Dual-Edged Constraint

This resolution follows a methodological pattern established by one of physics' great theoretical achievements: Einstein's derivation of general relativity[52]. Einstein's framework rested on two pillars that would have been untenable in isolation. The equivalence principle, on its own, presents an empirical absurdity: that a coordinate-motionless observer can be accelerating. Likewise, replacing the successful paradigm of gravity-as-a-force with gravity-as-curvature would have seemed ad hoc and unmotivated without the equivalence principle's context. The genius of the derivation lies in how these ideas resolve each other's shortcomings. Spacetime curvature emerges as the *only* medium in which the equivalence principle can hold true without paradox; in turn, the equivalence principle provides the crucial justification for this radical redefinition of gravity. This is the nature of a true 'dual-edged constraint': two principles, each unmotivated or paradoxical on its own, reinforce one another to reveal a deeper, necessary truth. This approach represents the gold standard of theory-building that Aethic reasoning seeks to emulate.

Aethic reasoning follows this same architecture:

- **Extrusion Principle alone:** Paradoxical. All outcomes occur as a physical 'and' (sign on both sides), yet we observe only one—an apparent contradiction with experience.

[52]An intriguing parallel emerged from my initial encounter with the double-slit experiment [32, 58]: I intuited that superposition is reality's natural "resting state"—the universe fights to *fall into* superposition (Second Postulate), while being *held out* by necessary constraints (Third Postulate). This inverts the apparent empirical tendency. Similarly, Einstein's equivalence principle [61] inverted our understanding: free-fall became the inertial state, with Earth's surface as the non-inertial force breaking objects from their geodesics. The Third Postulate holds systems from collapsing into superposition much as Earth's bulk breaks a falling apple from its geodesic—in both cases, the apparent "natural" state is actually the constrained deviation.

- **Union Principle alone:** Ad hoc. Why introduce nested "disagreeing superposition" structure? The concept seems unmotivated without context.
- **Together:** Mutually necessary. Disagreeing superposition is the *only* logical structure allowing extrusion to hold (sign on both sides) without contradicting observation (we see one side). Extrusion provides the necessary context revealing disagreeing superposition as required by consistency, not invented for convenience.

The constraint, crystallized. The dual-edged constraint crystallizes: the Union Principle provides crucial justification for the radical redefinition of possibility proposed by the Extrusion Principle, making its paradox solvable. In turn, the Extrusion Principle provides the necessary context for this new medium of disagreeing superpositions, revealing it not as an ad hoc fix but as a required feature of a consistent relational reality. By forming these mutually reinforcing constraints, the paradoxes on either end are resolved, establishing a stronger theoretical foundation than that with which we started. The dual-edged constraint is visible directly in the pockets: the Extrusion Principle tells you the pockets exist (all outcomes are physically present as subsequent block universes), and the Union Principle tells you why you only see one (the interior negations enforce non-interactivity). Neither claim is coherent without the other.

2.4.9 Contradictions Versus Superpositions

Another fundamental consequence of the Aethic union principle becomes that we may indeed rigorously distinguish contradictions from superpositions in Aethic reasoning. An 'Aethic contradiction' is what happens when we take the Aethic intersection of two disjoint Aethae, whereas an 'Aethic superposition' is what happens when we take the Aethic union of two Aethae, disjoint or not. Importantly, this means that contradictions very much still exist in Aethic reasoning, just they follow from encoding conflicting states directly within the underlying Aethic mathematical structure. Aethic superpositions, on the other hand, are indirectly generated in a reality by withdrawing states from the Aethic underlying structure, as will essentially trace out the 'backward Aethic progression' from the typical knowledge-gain of adding states to an Aethus. Withdrawing states from an Aethus will cause them to occupy all possible values at once in the physical block universe which corresponds to that Aethus, with this fundamental interplay between superpositions and the lack of information amounting to the coming second postulate of the Aethus.

2.4.10 The Deepest Layer

Principle 18 (Deepest Layer of the Aethic Union Principle)
When all is said and done, perhaps the central ontological-categorical core behind algorithmic Aethic reasoning is how even disjoint stated-attributes (in the sense of Aethic intersection, that is) only ever are emergently[53] *rather than intrinsically unable to occupy co-realization of the kind of agreeing superpositions in a classical environment, that is because of the exterior Aethus system and its relational behavior under the second and third Aethic postulates' invalidity pruning. In effect, then, even something we might take for granted as being disjoint as an attribute, like "whether this apple is on the right or the left side of the table" is itself actually such only due to its being subject to an invalidity pruning of any agreeing superpositions by means of the environmental context of the given Aethus, and so therefore actually turns out to be separable from the attribute itself in the intrinsic sense. That is to say that physical disjointness is and remains intrinsic in the sense of Aethic intersections, but there is nonetheless another avenue to physical jointness by means of agreeing superpositions, and this is only every contextually decided due to the algorithms of Aethic reasoning. So in that sense, we might begin to ask the philosophical question of how a given Aethic attribute might differently behave in the regime of environmental context alleviating any invalidity pruning so that an agreeing superposition may survive, (that is since otherwise is only a special case, even if empirically dominate).*

It is worth mentioning though that some categories Aethic attributes are inherently resistant to such an investigative decomposition anyway, that is especially of their being defined in the first place already includes a notion of informational passage that cannot be extracted without defeating the purpose of the attribute in the first place. A clean example of this is a particular person's first and last name, for which

[53] For reference, it is this idea that I consider to be a major contributor behind my ranking of the Aethic union principle as the single deepest ontological idea of my life so far, especially in the sense of having been accessible to me as a vivid, almost trip-like synesthetic sensation when I first came into contact with it. Really there are no other thoughts in my life that have had quite the sensory potency as this one, which is why I figured I might as well flag it as such.

even defining the Aethus in which environmental ruining of the agreeing superposition can be extracted is invalid (by means of Aethic contradiction), because we already have to assume as a component of the attribute of a person's name that this information has to be transferable, (as would invalidate the agreeing superposition by the third postulate). Something which is more manageable in this regard is a physical quantity like position or momentum—and we do see the ability for such agreeing superpositions to exist being already confirmed by quantum mechanics directly. Altogether, then, the point is that even the question of how existing categories of attributes parse under agreeing superposition consideration could perhaps be an entire investigative philosophical literature at the intersection of semantics, realism, and ontology[54].

What the box says, unpacked. Three claims are folded into the principle, and they are worth separating. The first is that *disjointness is emergent.* That an apple is on the left of the table *or* on the right, and not both, is not a fact intrinsic to the attribute "which side"; it is the result of the exterior Aethus system—the room's records, the second and third postulates' pruning—forbidding the agreeing superposition the attribute would otherwise admit. Aethic intersection remains intrinsically disjoint: no Aethus states both. But there are two avenues to physical jointness, the intersection's and the agreeing superposition's, and only the first is intrinsic; the second is contextually decided by the algorithm, which is why the classical case is a special case, dominant empirically and not in principle. The second claim is that the decision is made by *records*, exactly as the branching subsubsection above says: the apple's side is disagreeing because the table, the light, and the air record it, and a setting in which nothing records it would leave the agreeing superposition standing, as quantum mechanics confirms for position and momentum. The third claim is a limit on the first two: some attributes are *resistant to the decomposition* because informational passage is built into their definition. A person's name is the clean case—to be a name is to be transferable, so an Aethus in which the name's agreeing superposition survives is invalid by contradiction, not by pruning. Attributes of that kind cannot be put into the agreeing regime by any redesign of the environment, and the boundary between attributes that can and attributes that cannot is a genuine open literature at the intersection of semantics, realism, and ontology, which the box names as such.

Why this is the deepest layer. It is deepest because it reverses the default. Every earlier statement of the Union Principle took the classical *or* as the familiar case and the agreeing superposition as the exception to be explained; this layer says the agreeing superposition is what an attribute does when nothing stops it, and the classical *or* is what the environment's records make of it. The double slit is not the strange case. It is the case in which the room was quiet enough for the attribute to be itself.

2.4.11 Or-Jointness as Primitive: Openness on the Attribute Side, Use on the Matter Side

A clarification is owed here at extended length, because a pedagogical framing has quietly bled into places it does not belong, and the correction exposes what may be the single most profound idea in Aethic reasoning. The framing in question is "non-interactivity" as the descriptor of the agreeing/disagreeing divide. As pedagogy it earns its keep—the road-sign appearing on only one side, the alternatives that never trade influence—but as a description *of the attributes themselves* it is subtly wrong, and the error is exactly the classical pattern-match this section exists to forbid. For attributes, the concept is more abstract and more elegant: it is *openness*, in a character that is abstract to the point of intangibility—and deliberately so, because it is a logical primitive. One can use the word "and" or the word "or" without ever being able to describe their actual substance; they simply *are* what logic runs on. Agreeing superposition is of exactly this kind. It just *is* the case that, in our universe, the default state of logic is that pure *or*s invoke a sense of *jointness*—and that sentence is not awaiting a deeper analysis any more than "conjunction conjoins" is.

Interaction is on the matter side. The crucial division, then—and the place where the bled framing did real damage—is this: *interaction*, in the sense of quantum interference, comes purely on the side of *matter*. The abstract agreeing superpositions over attributes do something quieter and prior: like the opening of gates, they usher the *allowance* of paths into more states within a single agreeing superposition—they open a void. It is then the Quantum Nexus, that as-yet-unexplained ontological prospect, which *fills matter paths into* the void the attributes have opened. Interference is therefore how matter *uses* the or-jointness; it is not a property *of* the attributes or of the jointness itself. The better formulation, stated for canon: or-jointness is an *abstract attribute-mediated state*—the attribute

[54]That is, because of the very untrodden philosophical richness which the Aethic union principle kicks up for us.

side supplies the openness, the matter side supplies the use, and conflating the two re-imports precisely the classical habit of treating composition facts as facts about stuff.

Or-jointness, stated whole. With the division drawn, the profound idea can be stated whole. Or-jointness is *both* an entirely new logical primitive *and* maximally non-forced: it is not posited but *pops out*, exactly and one-to-one, as the newly allowed regime under the Aethic Union Principle. And the Union Principle is itself the result of one simple move: relocating classical mutual exclusivity of scenarios from being intrinsic to the *or* on the exterior to being *interior*, intersection-mediated content. That relocation already mirrors Boole's move within logic proper; here it is performed for *timelines*—or rather, given the Aethic reversal principle, for Aethic attributes. And by the resulting reframe of what a logical *or is*, metaphysically, the whole primitive earns its deflationary definition: *or-jointness is simply the logic-valued regime of not stating mutual negations on the interior side.* Nothing is added to the world to obtain it; something classical is merely declined. That a new primitive of composition—a sister taxon to everything classical metaphysics ever catalogued—arrives by declension rather than by postulation is, on the present accounting, the deepest single fact the framework has to report.

The philosophical face: two instruments. The relocation also has a philosophical face, recorded here because a standalone treatment now develops it at length and the canon should carry its instruments. First, the *one-statement test*, which converts "mere notation" into an answerable objection: a single interior negation *creates* the regime difference when added to the joint form and is *idle* when added to the exclusive form, and a difference one statement creates in one form and cannot create in the other is structural, not notational. Second, the *declension argument* for the primitive's non-forcedness: grant only that exclusion *can* be written as interior content, and the joint regime is already granted, since interiors that can carry negations can also be silent — there is no further premise at which to balk. Third, *silence as compositional determinacy*: the joint form's silent interiors are not indeterminacy *of* the alternatives but determinacy *about* their composition — a determinate composition of a non-classical kind, owing no revisionary logic, the appearance of indeterminacy being an artifact of describing the sister taxon in the home taxon's vocabulary. And fourth, the century-old address the relocation answers: Wittgenstein's color-exclusion problem, where *red* and *green* at one point exclude neither by logical form, (the 1929 concession), nor by brute empirical generality, (the necessity-feel), the datum's stubbornness dissolving once exclusion is classified as *stated interior structure* — contingent-yet-structural, the precise profile the old dichotomy could not house, the interior of an alternative being exactly the "between" the Tractarian inventory lacked, (with the systematicity of color exclusion — red excluding the whole family at once — read as a fact about how the found interiors are written, wholesale by determinable structure, systematic without being necessary). The relocation thereby finishes, for the alternatives of reality, the reform Jevons performed for the terms of logic — over Boole's own resistance, whose "+" was exclusive and who rejected $X + X = X$ when Jevons pressed it: its own evidence of how deep the exclusive habit ran. And the relocation's deductive core deserves its one-breath record: agreeing superpositions require exclusion to be removable; what is removable is neither logical form nor brute nature, since neither comes off; stated interior content is the location that makes exclusion removable while leaving ordinary logic untouched, more economically than any rival location—an exclusion relation between alternatives, a law of co-instantiation, a constraint on admissible composites—none of which the argument eliminates, an exclusion relation being as much a primitive as the exclusivity it replaces. The claim is abductive and not an exhaustion.

2.4.12 The Union Principle as an Illustration of Ontic "Choppiness" in the Timeline Metaphysics

Interestingly, we might think of the Union Principle itself, particularly with its demotion of "physical or", as carrying out the counterpart philosophical modernization to the physical timeline ontology which Jevons himself provided [59] to the logical side in 1864 with his *Pure Logic*[55]. That is to note,

[55]The historical attribution here matters, and turns out to be even more on the nose than mere analogy would suggest. Boole's own "+" operation in [62, 63] was actually effectively *exclusive*: "$A + B$" was strictly defined only when A and B were disjoint, and was held to be undefined whenever the two classes overlapped [64]. This made Boole's own disjunction precisely the kind of choppy selective operation we are critiquing here. The reform to inclusive disjunction—the modern unrestricted union, satisfying $X + X = X$—was due to Jevons in his 1864 *Pure Logic* [59], with Peirce arriving at the same reform independently shortly thereafter [65] and Schröder later systematizing the resulting framework. Strikingly, when Jevons proposed the inclusive reading to Boole directly in their 1863 correspondence, Boole rejected it outright and broke off the correspondence rather than accept it [66]; the version of the algebra of logic that the world now uniformly calls "Boolean" is in fact Jevons's reformed version, the version Boole himself could not see. The historical pattern, then, is that this reform of disjunction from selective to coalescent was not merely a gap in the formalism but a conceptual move so non-obvious that the founder of the formalism actively resisted it—which is precisely the kind of resistance

potentially remarkably, how anyone who has studied Boolean logic has essentially already intuited the basic seed of the Aethic Union Principle in methodological concepts—just no one has yet realized that the ontology of possible worlds has not yet undergone its leg of the same revolution which Jevons brought to logic.

Consider how in Boolean logic, when we write proposition C as $C = A \vee B$, the state of both A and B feeding in "true" does not immediately imply falsehood in C as would the exclusive or[56]. Intuitively, then, notice how a Boolean logician interprets the logical disjunction as catalyzed by Boolean agreement as opposed to being inhibited by it. Even in a general programming context, no one is carrying the timeline-analogous assumption that proposition C must preferentially or randomly select one of A or B to draw from—it simply acts as their logical disjunctive coalescence.

The only particular thing which the Aethic structure itself makes apparent, but Boolean logic does not, is how the agreeing superposition of A and B is not simply equivalent[57] to the intersection $A \wedge B$, because agreeing superpositions force their common attribute's encoding to be blank, whereas the intersection forces both attributes into the Aethus—thereby traversing opposite directions on the Aethic tree while still rendering as "both" one the side of "physical and". This confusion might be considered a leading culprit for why the Aethic union principle is only now being named—being merely a hiccup in the standard formalism which flattened a physically-meaningful distinction. Hence, why the Union Principle is the proposed candidate through which Aethic logic may supersede sentential logic.

2.4.13 Agreeing Superpositions as a Logical Regime: The Excluded Middle at Its Edge Case

What the preceding discussion makes available is a statement about the level of abstraction at which agreeing superpositions actually live, and it deserves to be made outright: the Union Principle renders the agreeing superposition a fundamentally *logical* concept. The places where this paper exercises them—the Quantum Nexus pruning and the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Section 14.2.6 and Theorem 14)—are *instantiations* of the concept, in the same sense in which particular symmetry groups instantiate group structure; the concept itself is not quantum-mechanical but logical, a claim about how alternatives may combine.

What the regime is, and is not. The regime should then be characterized with care, because the obvious characterization is the wrong one. An agreeing superposition is a structure on which the law of excluded middle does not operate classically—but *not* because it interposes a third truth value between true and false, and not because it renders statements partially true in the manner of

one ought to expect of an analogous reform to the physical timeline ontology. Indeed, the specific reason for Boole's resistance is itself diagnostic of the broader Union Principle thesis. Boole's commitment was not just to a particular operation but to making his algebra of logic mirror ordinary numerical algebra, in which every operation is fundamentally summative—producing a single definite output from definite inputs, with no coalescent option. Jevons's $X + X = X$ broke this mirror precisely by being non-summative: it declared that the combination of X with itself yields X rather than $2X$ because there is nothing "more" of X to add—the operation is structurally coalescent rather than computational. The deepest reason Boole could not accept this is that he, like contemporary timeline metaphysicians, implicitly held an ontology in which operations must select-or-compute rather than coalesce. Boole's resistance to inclusive disjunction and the contemporary resistance to the Union Principle are therefore not merely analogous historical episodes but instances of the same conceptual commitment expressed in different domains: a prior assumption that combinatory operations must yield single definite outputs, which forecloses the very possibility of coalescent operations whether in logic or in physical ontology. The Union Principle and Jevons's reform are, in this sense, the same reform applied to two different layers of reality.

[56]Also note that while a disagreeing superposition is superficially similar to the exclusive or, they actually are categorically different due to a disagreeing superposition retaining the Aethic structural distinctions between the forward and backward Aethic tree directions, which the exclusive or collapses ad hoc. As another illustration of their differences, note how function composition behaves entirely differently under each, where exclusive ors reinstate intersections after multiple levels, (as in, $A \oplus (B \oplus C)$ as a set contains $A \cap B \cap C$ as a subset, whereas disagreeing superpositions of states forbid all Aethic intersections between those states—in the sense that a disagreeing superposition is always a disjoint Aethus to the Aethic intersection of any subset of the states involved), whereas disagreeing superpositions insist on keeping the given states locked off from one another given any number of additional levels. In this sense, in the sense of logical metaphysics, an exclusive or is something of an ad hoc human construction which reaches for disagreeing superpositions while remaining structurally irrelevant to them. Once again, the culprit is the conflation in sentential logic between agreeing superpositions and logical intersections due to the formalism having flattened the Aethic structural differences.

[57]That is to say that using a sentential logic framing alone, we might deduce that if a disagreeing superposition is like the exclusive or, then because the residue of the standard disjunction from the exclusive or is the intersection, then the intersection must be the agreeing superposition. The Aethic refutation of this argument, then, is both that agreeing superpositions are not intersections and that disagreeing superpositions are not exclusive ors. This distinction is not asserted so much as referenced as a corollary of the Aethic structure.

many-valued or fuzzy treatments. The claim is not one of intermediacy at all. Classical logic, as the choppiness discussion above traced, carries a silent special-case constraint: that counterfactual alternatives mediated by the primitive attribute union must mutually forbid one another. The Union Principle identifies that constraint as exactly what it is—the special case, manufactured where the third postulate forces interior negations into place, (Sections 2.4.4 and 2.4.3)—and an agreeing superposition is the structure that lives at the edge where the constraint is dropped. Like an object living on a manifold, it substantiates the edge case the principle reveals, rather than interpolating between the old categories; the old categories simply do not partition the space out there.

The replacement question. Aethic practice accordingly replaces the classical question with a different one. One asks not "is this statement false instead?" but "is my statement, *as stated*, subjected to Aethic pruning within the topology of the given Aethus?"—and the agreeing regime is the case that makes the replacement unmistakable, because there the act of stating the attribute at any value at all is itself what gets pruned, by the mode of the second postulate, (Section 3.4.4; the prohibition on singleton selection, Section 9.1, and the irreducibility behind it, Section 2.4.7). The clause-level exhibit is already on the books: over an undroppable agreeing residue, the would-clause read on the physical side is satisfied by multiple disjoint states at once, (Section 9.1)—circumstances the classical paradigm must classify as contradictions, held here as perfectly logically realist non-contradictions, (Sections 2.4.9 and 2.4.2). That combination—realist about logic, radical about which structures logic ranges over—is precisely the shape of the "exotic but logically realist" demand recorded in the Spekkens discussion, (Section 10.3.1), met here at the level of the logic itself.

2.4.14 Truth as Emergent from the Aethus: The Integer That Is Not False

The replacement question of the preceding subsubsection has a consequence for the truth-predicate itself, and it should be written down in detail because it runs deeper than a notational preference. By the first postulate, (Postulate 2.3.2), any attribution of reality is a relation to a particular Aethus; the truth-predicate cannot float free of that indexing. The Aethic definitions are therefore these: *"statement X is true"* means that X, taken as a stated-attribute and intersected with the given Aethus, yields a valid Aethus; *"statement X is false"* means that the intersection is instead invalid. Truth does not exist in Aethic reasoning independently of being emergent from subjecting an attribute to the topology of a contingent Aethus—there is no further fact of truth behind the intersection test, and no Aethus-free position from which the predicate could be applied.

Notice the asymmetry these definitions expose. An Aethus stores stated-attributes and carries blanks; at no point does it store "X is false" as content. One should be careful here to separate two things that the Union Principle's own machinery keeps distinct: the interior negations of a disagreeing superposition, (Section 2.4.4), are attribute-level content—the nonexistence of a state, stated within a pocket—whereas the truth-predicate "false" names no content anywhere in the structure. It names the outcome of a test: invalidity under intersection. Its promotion from test-outcome to a symmetric ontological category standing alongside truth is a human construct imposed in a distinctly Aristotelian spirit—the habit of breaking ontology into balanced halves—and the framework simply declines the promotion.

Made exact: the integer-valued attribute. The point can be made exact by widening the attribute's value set, and this is where the construct becomes visible to the naked eye. Value the attribute over the integers rather than over $\{\text{true}, \text{false}\}$—note that Booleans have now not been invoked even once in the attribute's articulation—and let the Aethus carry the constraint that X is an even number between 10 and 20 inclusive. Intersect the stated-attribute $X = 17$: the result is an invalid Aethus. And yet nobody is tempted to characterize the integer seventeen as conceptually "false." Falsehood, if attributed at all, is attributed to the *statement* "$X = 17$"—but observe what actually happened Aethically: an attribute was valued, an Aethus was named with a constraint, an intersection was tested, and invalidity emerged. The procedure is categorically identical to the Boolean case. The Boolean paradigm protests calling seventeen itself "false" precisely because the statement—the intermediate object onto which falsehood is supposed to stick—was never needed for the procedure to run. The practice of interposing a statement between the attribute and the verdict is thereby revealed as categorically-ontologically arbitrary: such a category does not exist independently of our own conventions, and the bare-bones structure—attribute, Aethus, intersection, validity—does all of the work in both cases.

Where realism lives. Nor does any of this threaten realism; it sharpens where realism lives. What has been relativized is the *index* of the truth-predicate, not the determinacy of its verdicts: relative to a given Aethus the intersection test is as hard-edged as anything the classical picture offers, which is the same reorientation of objectivity—from observer-independent to Aethus-relative—that the

Frauchiger–Renner discussion records, (Section 10.2.2), and the same relativism-rather-than-anti-realism positioning stated for the framework as a whole, (Section 2.3.10). This, finally, is what the Union Principle's claim to logical realism cashes out to: logic is not weakened, and truth is not dissolved—the predicate is indexed, the excluded middle is returned to its actual domain of validity, and what lies beyond that domain is structure, not fog. Two clauses complete the picture. A blank attribute is not thereby a third truth value—nothing here is intermediate between true and false in the many-valued sense; a blank is a case where the predicate's domain has not been entered, which is a different thing from occupying a middle position within it. And the union principle's regime slots into the definitions with a sharpness worth stating: relative to an Aethus encoding an agreeing superposition over an attribute, stating that attribute at all—to any value—yields an invalid intersection, and by sheer Aethic structure rather than by fiat. The agreeing superposition enforces, as content, that its states do not inter-negate one another; a determinate statement of the attribute carries exactly those interior negations; so the intersection triggers a direct Aethic contradiction—of the base-case kind the third postulate's recursion grounds out in—as if the agreeing Aethus held a further attribute enforcing the one in question as blank, which a determinate state or disagreeing superposition does not. The second postulate, operating *within* the agreeing Aethus, is what enforces consistency between the superposition and the attribute's determinate state being unknowable; and such intersections are in any case unreachable as proper child Aethae wherever no detector or information channel exists to offer them. The superposed attribute is thereby one for which the truth-predicate's domain is not merely unentered but *unenterable* while the superposition stands. That is the precise sense in which agreeing superpositions are the regime classical logic would have booked as contradiction and Aethic logic books as structure.

2.4.15 Tangibly Listing the Reframes of the Aethic Union Principle

How to read the list. Every entry below is a consequence of one move—exclusion as an achievement of records rather than a default of logic—and the list is ordered so that each reframe consumes those above it. Entries 1–3 are the logical reform itself; 4–6 locate where interaction and non-interaction live; 7–9 invert the classical picture; 10–11 draw the physical consequences; and 12–15, added in 2026, are the reframes the formalization produced. Here is a list of some of the major reframes within the Aethic Union Principle, in case one needs a reference for where the proposed contributions lie. The Aethic Union Principle bundles a sequence of distinct conceptual reframes, each of which constitutes a substantive structural claim. The reframes do not stand independently. Each one is unlocked by those that precede it, opening conceptual space that the next reframe occupies and that would not be formulable without the prior moves. The principle is presented below as a sequenced list, with each entry indicating both the content of the reframe and the way it depends on the preceding chain.

1. **The categorical separation of logical operations from physical manifestations.**

   Classical metaphysics conflates two domains that are properly distinct: *logical* operations (the abstract structural rules governing how information combines algebraically—AND, OR, negation as they appear in sentential logic) and *physical* manifestations (how reality occupies the block universe). Classical physics treats logical OR as physical mutual exclusivity, treats logical AND as physical co-occupation, and treats these correspondences as ontologically transparent. The first reframe insists the correspondence is not transparent: logical structure and physical occupation are categorically distinct domains. This reframe stands on its own and does not presuppose any prior move within the Union Principle. It is the foundational move on which the rest of the structure depends.

2. **The non-existence of fundamental physical OR.**

   Once the categorical separation is in place, a consequence becomes formulable: there is no fundamental physical operation corresponding to mutual exclusivity. Every logical operation, distinguished from its physical manifestation, manifests physically as occupation—physical AND. The appearance of mutual exclusivity is not a physical primitive but an emergent feature arising from algebraic structure. This reframe is unlocked by the first: without the categorical separation, the question of whether physical OR exists fundamentally cannot be coherently asked, because logical OR and physical mutual exclusivity have not yet been distinguished.

3. **The bifurcation of pathways: both logical OR and logical AND produce physical AND.**

Logical AND, instantiated as Aethic intersection, produces physical AND directly by adding information to an Aethus and asserting that multiple states coexist. Logical OR, instantiated as Aethic union, produces physical AND indirectly by removing information, creating blanks that materialize as superpositions through the second postulate. Two distinct algebraic pathways converge on the same physical result. This reframe is unlocked by the previous two: without the categorical separation, there is no distinction to bifurcate, and without the non-existence of fundamental physical OR, there is no need to explain how both logical operations could converge on physical AND.

4. **The structural distinction between agreeing and disagreeing superposition.**

   Within the unified domain of physical AND, two algebraically distinct types of superposition emerge. Agreeing superposition (a simple union, $\bigcup_i A_i$) admits interaction between the superposed states; disagreeing superposition (a nested union over intersections with negations, $\bigcup_i (a_i \cap \bigcap_{j \neq i} \neg a_j)$) forbids interaction. The same physical AND, depending on its algebraic structure, splits into two empirically distinguishable types. Quantum interference is the observational signature of agreeing superposition; classical mutual exclusivity is the observational signature of disagreeing superposition. This reframe is unlocked by the bifurcation: only once both logical operations are recognized as converging on physical AND does the question of which kind of physical AND become askable.

5. **Non-interactivity emerges from the interior of pockets, not the exterior.**

   The multiverse literature locates the separation between alternative outcomes in the exterior operation that combines them—in the "or" that holds the pockets apart. The Union Principle relocates the separation to the interior of each pocket. Each pocket internally negates the contents of the others, encoding their non-existence as part of the pocket's own structural content. The reason the sign is not seen on both sides of the road is not that the pockets are externally walled off from each other but that each pocket internally declares that the other pocket's contents do not exist. Non-interactivity is a property of pockets' interiors, not of their exterior relations. This reframe is unlocked by the agreeing-disagreeing distinction: without the distinction, there is no pocket structure to inspect, and the interior-versus-exterior question cannot be formulated.

6. **Placement and interactivity are distinct functions; classical metaphysics had fused them.**

   The previous reframe relocates non-interaction to the interior of pockets, which exposes a conflation classical and possible-worlds metaphysics never question: that to occupy the same place just *is* to be mutually present and interacting. Under that identity the disjunction must do double duty, both placing the alternatives and isolating them at once, since non-interaction could be secured only by separate location. The Union Principle severs the two: placement is left to the exterior disjunction, which may situate every pocket in one shared space, while isolation is carried entirely by the interior negations. Co-location therefore no longer entails mutual visibility, and the placement-interactivity identity that classical physics treated as analytic is broken. *Interference is not a special quantum addition to classical physics: it is what obtains by default when the interior negations are not imposed, and the classical world of non-interacting alternatives is the special case, produced exactly where the third postulate forces those negations into place.* This reframe is unlocked by the interior-not-exterior move: only once non-interactivity is seen to live inside the pockets can the exterior disjunction be relieved of the isolating role it was silently assigned.

7. **The classical OR is the special case, not the general one.**

   Classical metaphysics treats classical OR (mutual exclusivity) as the fundamental operation, with quantum superposition as an exception requiring accommodation. The Union Principle inverts this: agreeing superposition is the natural default state that emerges whenever no internal negations are imposed, and disagreeing superposition (which produces the appearance of classical OR) is the special case that emerges only when the third postulate's pruning operation forces internal negations. This reframe is unlocked by the interior-not-exterior move: only once non-interactivity is understood as a property of internal pocket structure does it become possible to ask whether internal negations are the default or the exception.

8. **Agreeing superpositions are constructible rather than impossible.**

Agreeing superpositions are not phenomena that must be specially produced under exotic conditions. They emerge naturally whenever internal negations are not imposed. The reason macroscopic agreeing superpositions are not commonly observed is not that they are physically impossible but that the third postulate's pruning operation eliminates them whenever sufficient information is available to derive contradictions from their persistence. An appropriately engineered macroscopic case, in which the relevant distinguishing information was made permanently inaccessible, would exhibit agreeing superposition with its empirical signatures (mutual interference, cross-pocket influence). This reframe is unlocked by the previous inversion: without recognizing that internal negations are the special case rather than the default, the claim that macroscopic agreeing superpositions are constructible could not be formulated.

9. **The Boolean–Jevons reform of disjunction is the same reform applied to a different layer.**

   Boole, in his original formulation of the algebra of logic, employed an exclusive "or"; Jevons's reform produced inclusive disjunction, in which $X + X = X$ [59]. Boole resisted the reform when Jevons proposed it directly to him in their 1863 correspondence and broke off the correspondence rather than accept it [66]. The conceptual commitment Boole could not relinquish—operations as choosy or summative rather than coalescent—is structurally identical to the contemporary commitment that resists agreeing superposition in physics. The Boolean reform of sentential logic and the Aethic reform of physical metaphysics are the same reform applied to different layers of reality. This reframe is unlocked by the entire preceding chain: the historical analogy becomes precise rather than vague only when the structural content of the prior moves is in place.

10. **More information can be packed into a single physical space than classical physics admitted.**

    A disagreeing superposition's nested algebraic structure permits multiple pockets to occupy the same physical space, each holding its own content, separated only by their internal negations. Classical physics, by treating physical occupation as monolithically singular, flattened this structure, obscuring the possibility that the same physical space could hold multiple nested levels operating simultaneously. The Union Principle restores the lost dimension. This reframe is unlocked by the entire preceding chain: the categorical separation, the bifurcation, the agreeing-disagreeing distinction, the interior-not-exterior move, the inversion, and the constructibility thesis must all be in place before the ladder ontology becomes formulable as a structural claim.

11. **The quantum-classical distinction is informational rather than scale-dependent.**

    The Union Principle, combined with the third postulate, locates the quantum-classical distinction in the availability of distinguishing information rather than in any scale-dependent change in physical law. When information is permanently inaccessible (the typical quantum case), agreeing superposition persists; the third postulate's pruning operation finds nothing to invalidate. When information is accessible (the typical macroscopic case), the pruning operation produces disagreeing superposition by enforcing internal negations. The same Union Principle structure operates at all scales; the apparent scale-dependence emerges from how the third postulate's pruning interacts with information availability. This reframe is unlocked by the constructibility thesis (agreeing superpositions are not intrinsically small-scale) and the ladder ontology (multiple pockets can co-occupy physical space).

12. **Quantum interference receives a structural mechanism.**

    Quantum interference is what happens when two states in agreeing superposition, without internal negations between them, are permitted to interact. The interference pattern is the empirical signature of the algebraic structure of agreeing superposition operating without third-postulate pruning. This reframe is unlocked by every preceding move: the categorical separation, the bifurcation, the agreeing-disagreeing distinction, the interior-not-exterior move, the inversion, the constructibility thesis, the ladder ontology, and the informational diagnosis must all be in place before quantum interference can be given this account.

13. **The branching look is deduced, and the branches are records' walls.**

    Many-worlds was right about the phenomenology: once a record separates two alternatives, they stop interacting, each carries its weight, and an observer finds itself in one. The Union Principle deduces that look rather than positing it, (Section 2.4.5): the record writes the exclusions into

the alternatives, and alternatives whose interiors exclude each other do not interact. Same walls, same weights, same observer in one pocket, and all of it in one spacetime relative to an index. Everett's error was to take the non-interaction for a *place*.

14. **Branches are Aethae, not amplitude states.**

    Beneath the housing of the branches is their carrier, (Section 2.4.6). An Everettian branch is a term of a state vector, individuated by an approximate basis and weighted by an amplitude that must then be argued into a probability. An Aethic pocket is an information state, individuated exactly by the record partition and weighted by the framework's own primitive, with the state vector derived from the weights by polarization and never held by any Aethus. Everett branched the wavefunction; the Union Principle transits the observer.

15. **The reform supplies a second grade, and that is what quantum logic lacked.**

    Quantum logic reformed the connective and kept every alternative at one grade, amplitude. The Union Principle reforms the disjuncts and thereby supplies a grade the century's vocabulary did not have: *validity*, assigned by the third postulate, on which a cross-term is not small but invalid. The agreeing/disagreeing distinction lives at that grade, and the decoherence program's inability to say that the walls it described were walls is the inability of a one-grade object to carry a two-grade fact, (Section 10.2).

16. **Geometry blends within an agreeing superposition and enumerates across a disagreeing one.**

    The last reframe reaches past matter to the one field that is geometry. Within an agreeing cluster spacetime is one blended geometry, indeterminate in the manner the cluster is indeterminate; across the pockets of a disagreeing superposition spacetime enumerates, one geometry per pocket, with weights. Every error of the standard semiclassical treatment is one regime's behavior applied to the other, (Section 14.7.3), and the Union Principle is what says which behavior is which.

What the list consumes, in one sentence. Reframe 1 is the posit—the primitive jointness of *or*, booked on the closing ledger; everything from 2 onward is derived from it together with the postulates, and the list can be read as the ledger's one entry unpacked fifteen ways.

2.4.16 A Brief Intuitive Walkthrough of the Aethic Union Principle

To illustrate the Aethic union principle, let's point out that unlike standard multiverse models, the premise of the Aethic union principle is that alternate possibilities are not physically held off from one another in separate physical spaces. Instead of their being separated in the exterior, they actually both occupy the exact same physical space, and are separated from one another in their interiors. We might then imagine two "pockets" of the universe which occupy the same physical space but hold different contents within them. At this point you might ask, though, "if the pockets are in the same space, then why doesn't one see the contents of the other?", and the reason for this is because the interior of each pocket has to declare that the contents of the other pocket don't exist, and this is itself why we don't see the contents of the other alternate scenario: not because our two pockets are physically separated, but because the interior in each one blocks off the existence of the other. The effect this specifically creates is that the interiors of the two pockets are prevented from interacting with each other, which creates the perceived effect of the other not existing.

A key idea, though, is that the operation which actually places the two pockets in the same physical space externally is a "disjunction" (otherwise called a "logical or"), while the interior contents of a pocket are joined together with a "conjunction" (otherwise called a "logical and"). This is the reason why the exterior "placement" of the pockets is not the same as the interior "placement" of their contents. The interior "logical and" has that property we are very familiar with, where everything we state absolutely has to be felt and perceived in the space, but the "logical or" is different from this.

Logical or against intuitive or. The "logical or" by the way is different than the "intuitive or" we are used to, which carries the idea of the alternative scenarios being in different physical places from one another, and instead "logical or" is meant to be the same as the "or" we find in the field of logic, which doesn't carry these ideas in the first place. So, the idea of placing two pockets in the same physical space with a "logical or" is that this gives you something of a clean slate which doesn't force states to be visible to each other like the "logical and" does.

The principle, in the walkthrough's terms. The fundamental idea of the Aethic union principle is that "logical and" *and* "logical or" both present as "physical and" in the sense that it means both

states in question occupy the same physical space, which is why both the interior contents of a pocket occupy the physical space, and the two pockets themselves occupy the same physical space—just in their different way that is "logical or"-based instead of "logical and"-based. Because "logical or" gives you a clean slate about whether states have to interact or not, this is why we have to use the interior "logical and" inside of each pocket to force the state contents of the other pocket not to exist, which when one pocket says "A exists but not B" and when the second pocket says "B exists but not A" is what forces the A and B not to interact between the pockets. If we refrained from declaring this in the interior of the pockets, then suddenly the two states *would* be able to interact just by the "logical or" on the exterior—since it behaves like a "physical and" anyway—and this is what in Aethic reasoning is called *an agreeing superposition*, which is its fundamental idea.

To give a concrete example of this, imagine a setup where a box of tissues either sits on the left side of the table, *logical or* the right side of the table. We can now assign one of these pockets to each alternate scenario of the tissue box being on the left versus on the right side, and then we will have to declare in each pocket that the tissue box being on the other side of the pocket doesn't happen in order to prevent the two alternate scenarios from interacting. This so far is the same idea of the blocking off between alternate scenarios coming from the interior instead of the exterior like in standard multiverse models.

The same setup, agreeing. Then we get back to the idea of asking what happens if we instead construct this system where each pocket's interior actually refrains from declaring that the tissue box is not on the other side of the table. Once again, this is the case of an agreeing superposition, where the two tissue boxes will literally, visibly be on both sides of the table at once, as if they are two separate tissue boxes. The key is that it is not impossible to construct such a case, but the real reason we don't ever see things like this happening in our daily lives is because the third postulate of the Aethus and the wider concept of the Aethic reduced form prunes these kinds of realities before they can happen. The reason is because if the tissue box was genuinely in this kind of agreeing superposition of being on both sides of the table, with the pockets refraining from declaring that it cannot be on the other side, then actually walking into the room and seeing the tissue box on one side adds to your Aethus of information that it has to be there alone, which as an assertion that it isn't in the other place now contradicts the pockets allowing it to be in the other place still.

Where agreeing cases are found. Where these kinds of cases do become available, however, is in the extreme world of quantum mechanics, where suddenly there isn't enough information around to trigger the third postulate's contradictions. This is the Aethic explanation for why quantum interference exists—because inside the allowed agreeing superpositions between the pockets, the alternate scenario states literally interact with each other. It may not happen in our everyday life, but it still drives the nature of the universe as we know it—maybe just more behind the scenes.

2.5 Deliberately Meeting *Requirement 5* for the Measurement Problem Solution

Let us take a brief moment to look more deeply at the consequences of the indiscriminate time principle of Aethic reasoning, specifically as pertains to the preservation of locality. The central tension is straightforward: Copenhagen quantum mechanics is utterly and completely structured around the idea that a collapse triggers on first measurement, so for the first measurement to shift based on reference frame is a blatant contradiction between the principle of relativity and the Copenhagen interpretation. This section will demonstrate how Aethic reasoning resolves this contradiction at the root, with the superluminal aspect of entanglement then falling out as a secondary consequence. Note that so as to not violate locality, we might think to assert that Aethic information can only ever be directly gathered from events within the past or future light cones. This being said, however, we hold that the unknowns are not to be all concentrated in the future light cone, and can just as well be gathered from the past light cone, such that standing unknowns are as metaphysically underdeveloped in the past light cone as they would be in the future light cone. Furthermore, also notice that there is no expression even in the analysis we have undergone so far that unknowns might lead to a lack of existence—something which would be a rather more solipsistic perspective. Instead of this, we hold that said unknowns are concentrated under many possibilities rather than being concentrated under none, (which would be unintuitive in the face of how we defined the correspondence between Aethae and possible worlds), and this is what begins to give rise to the statement of the second postulate of the Aethus. Regarding retrocausality issues surrounding the wavefunction collapse, furthermore, notice that these are in sweeping strokes solved by the principle of extrusion alone, which posits that

the seeming transmission of information back in time is merely a consequence of misinterpreting one's change of Aethus as affecting the past time of the past Aethus. A genuine breakage of locality would be represented by an agent possessing Aethic knowledge about events which are beyond the scope of either their past or future light cones, so given that we do not imply this anyway with the Aethus, under that regard at least locality is surely preserved.

This still leaves the question, however, of how the indiscriminate time principle is allowed to exist at all in the face of such a fundamental metaphysical ideal as classical alternative. We have to realize, though, that the classical perspective only reigns supreme so far as we do not assume the principle of extrusion. In the classical perspective, whenever an agent collapses a wavefunction with time, such a collapse event is capable of sending information back to points in the last cone so as to make them change in just such a way to enable the collapse. Of course, such a thing is itself a violation of locality, so it must be done away with in Aethic reasoning. The extrusion principle itself is the proposed solution to this, because it has us now imply that upon undergoing a wavefunction collapse, an agent is to travel to a new Aethus altogether, rather than messily causing their own past universe to update in one messy way or another.

Consider a setting in which Alice and Bob are checking the states of entangled particles, being the classic Einstein–Podolsky–Rosen (EPR) [11] setup. Let us demonstrate why *Alice cannot pass information to Bob faster than the speed of light* (as according to Aethic reasoning), hence confirming *Requirement 5* accordingly.

So the idea there is that in a standard entanglement setup, if Alice checks the state of her particle prior to Bob in one reference frame, then since they're causally unconnected we have that Bob actually checked first in another reference frame. Explicitly speaking, this is to say that quantum non-locality is not paradoxical for no particular reason: rather the direct ontological reason is because should Alice and Bob both check their particles at causally unconnected relativistic events due to the spacelike distance between them, then some reference frames will assert that Alice checked first, whereas others will assert that Bob checked first. The contradiction, then, of all things arises in the Copenhagen interpretation itself, which we might remember asserts that the first of Alice and Bob to check their particle collapses the wavefunction for both of them. As such, because the principle of relativity demands that all reference frames must be equally valid, we now form the contradiction between the valid demand that Alice checks first in one reference frame with the valid demand that Bob checks first in another. Accordingly, then, we have that it is the mere fact that Alice and Bob's checking events hold spacelike separation, (i.e. they occur as causally unconnected events), together with the sequential demand of the Copenhagen interpretation which makes a paradox of the non-local possibility. In short, then, we might suggest that whatever is the ontological crisis[58] contained in quantum non-locality, it ought also to manifest in this sequential-pertaining paradox of entanglement.

A defining element behind Aethic reasoning, then, is to address this issue directly, with it being argued that solving the paradox in this form will amount to nipping the general quantum non-locality paradox in the bud, thereby solving *Requirement 5*. The pitch is just the alternate block universes themselves, (being the extrusion principle), which are separated by a change of Aethus instead of having to rely on a dividing line manifold in spacetime to serve as the instant of the quantum update. Now we have that the entire prior block universe can never collapse the quantum state, whereas the entire each subsequent block universe had it collapsed all along. So, fittingly, the subsequent block universe is effectively a hidden-variables model, in that the outcome was always determined there, while the prior block universe is genuinely non-hidden-variables, with the superposition being real and ineliminable.

Locality, in the prior reality. Locality is preserved in the prior Aethic reality because neither observer inherits the other's collapse event, and locality is trivially preserved in the subsequent Aethic reality because it operates under what is effectively a hidden-variables model in which no faster-than-light influence was ever needed. The main idea of all of this is that now when one of them measures the particle, they move into their new rendering of the block universe, and that means they do not have to synchronize the move with the other one at all.

The hidden-variables dichotomy dissolved. Part of the intrigue of this approach, then, is that it dissolves the traditional dichotomy between hidden-variables and non-hidden-variables interpretations: they are not competing accounts of the same reality but different aspects of the larger Aethic structure, with the extrusion principle governing the transition between them. Bell's theorem [4] demonstrates that no single local hidden-variables theory can reproduce quantum correlations, but Aethic reasoning

[58]With crisis being the stronger term for what is normally referred to as the "inconsistency", with such a stronger term being well-deserved due to the magnitude of this issue.

does not propose a single theory. Rather, it proposes a structure in which the two descriptions apply to different Aethae of the same physical situation. The question of how Alice and Bob's results end up correlated despite their collapses being independent is addressed in the observer-consistency section, where it is shown that multi-observer consistency follows from the interaction constraints imposed by Aethic algebra: contradictory Aethae are structurally prevented from interacting, not by fiat but by algebraic necessity, with the block universe that each observer eventually occupies upon exchanging information being one whose entire history is consistent with the correlated outcomes. (Note that an older version of this Aethic reasoning paper had the following explanation instead for this[59], which I believe might have respectively failed to capture the nuances of the Aethic argument in its most fundamental form).

In short, then, Aethic reasoning meets *Requirement 5* itself by allowing the collapse to occur without having to partition spacetime at all—we simply infer two entire block universes, with each holding a predetermined content of Aethic superpositions. The general principle deserves flat statement here: every such Aethus carries equally that much predetermined-ness—looking at any one block universe, everything conspires under the constraint that it exists, the fixing of any point propagating block-wide as a constraint—and what Aethic pruning contributes empirically is not more determinism but more *visibility*: by removing certain joint combinations it limits the Aethus-valued superposition, letting the per-branch consistency show through to empirical visibility. Or, rather more specifically-put, the contradiction between the two particle-checks of Alice and Bob is dissolved because of the particular edit which we have made to the Copenhagen interpretation. Rather than the first of Alice and Bob implying an objective collapse for them both, we simply have that each of them moves to a new rendering of the block universe as depending only on their own time of checking. Altogether,

[59]To begin with, consider Bob's Aethus before he has checked his particle, such that he is at a distance further from Alice than a beam of light can traverse, hence making the two causally unconnected. By the principles of special relativity, we have that information can only ever travel at the speed of light or less, so by extension this includes Aethic information. As such, we have to suppose that relative to Bob's Aethus of then, even whether Alice has or has not checked her particle must be nonpresent, and therefore in superposition. As such, relative to Bob's Aethus, Alice is in superposition between having collapsed the wavefunction relative to her Aethus and having not yet. We therefore have that Alice cannot be implied to pass information faster than light to Bob, because that would assume an objective frame—something which we forbid Bob's Aethus from being as according to the Aethic principle of objectivity.

In short, the premise is rather similar to that of relational quantum mechanics, (RQM) [20], in that Aethic reasoning asserts that even for Alice to have checked the particle in fact does not immediately imply presence of that information in Bob's Aethus as well, and moreover that such information will only ever reach Bob's Aethus at speeds slower than the speed of light anyway, thereby perfectly preserving locality.

One step past relational quantum mechanics. It should also be mentioned, however, that Aethic reasoning takes this as step further as well by use of the Aethic extrusion principle, thereby allowing a well-defined mechanism by which the superposition of Alice with respect to Bob, or vice versa, is able to transition into the post-observation state of afterwards. As we know, the key to the extrusion principle is that even an individual agent ought not to account for a single relational quantum reality, but instead ought to be split into a before Aethus and an after Aethus. In the case of Alice and Bob, then, what this tells us is that since Bob does not inherit Alice's Aethic information about having checked the spin state while they are outside one another's light cones, such tells us that Alice's spin state must be in Aethic superposition to Bob if he is yet to check his own particle. By deduction, then, between then and the later moment when Alice and Bob are exchanging information, we have that Alice's state of being in superposition relative to Bob's reality must have subsided, and it is the extrusion principle itself with which we assert that such happened due to a change to Bob's Aethus rather than a superluminally-affected change to Alice as triggered by Bob.

The key, restated. In short, then, the key to this Aethic approach is that Bob's subsequent Aethic reality is effectively a deterministic and hidden variables-abiding lens on the particle after all, all while Bob's prior Aethic reality is very much non-hidden variables abiding. Locality is preserved in the prior Aethic reality because Bob did not inherit Alice's collapse event anyway, and locality is trivially preserved in the subsequent Aethic reality because it is effectively under a hidden variables model anyway. Part of the intrigue of the Aethic approach, then, is that is no longer forces us to choose between the hidden variables versus non-hidden variables dichotomy anyway—rather they are different aspects, almost like components if you will—of the larger Aethic circumstance. And, of course, locality is fully maintained, which it goes without saying is an utter necessity for any serious ontological interpretation of the universe.

The sharpest gravitational form of this objection—Eppley and Hannah's dilemma that a classical field coupled to quantum matter must either violate the uncertainty relations or signal faster than light—is treated at Section 14.7.3, where each agreeing superposition is its own spacetime and the semiclassical coupling is refuted by the third postulate.

The ability for the two to meet up later and check the timecodes of when they checked their particles, then, is not actually representative of their having broken the light barrier upon performing their measurements, with such a supposition itself being a construct. Notice how they would be comparing the two prior Aethae from the perspective of their later Aethae, well after the point at which ambiguity within the system, like who checked first, has been resolved and added to their Aethae. As such, they are making assessments about Aethic superpositions from the lens of different Aethae, which epistemically violates the principle of Aethic extrusion. In contrast to this, remember that to Bob's prior Aethus, relative to which we are actually performing the analysis of whether the light barrier is broken, we strictly have that the properties of Alice are totally non-present, therefore implying that he must not have received such information in the first place, not to mention faster than lightspeed. Essentially, then, we simply hold that the flaw in the classical argument was to suppose that there was an objective and non-Aethic frame to the system in the first place. We are to resolve the paradox quite quickly by assuming the Aethic alternative in the place of this supposition.

then, the particular logical ballet which plays out is that by removing Copenhagen's cross-causal influence, we disallow spacelike separated collapse events of their ability to form a net contradiction over an objective reality. So, following the aforementioned contradiction to the logical root, we now are able to assert a spacelike-separated wavefunction collapse system which is not immediately and unreservedly in contradiction with special relativity. Altogether, then, it is directly the act of relieving this proof-by-contradiction of the incompatibility of spacelike-separated checking-events and quantum mechanics which serves to solve *Requirement 5*.

In other words, by no longer requiring any spacelike dividing-line-manifold between the pre and post-collapse partitions of spacetime, (and instead relocating the dividing line to be Aethus-valued between the block universes of the Aethic block universe-Markov chain), do we directly resolve the paradox of necessary sequential-valued contradictions between at least two valid reference frames[60]. Epistemically it is the first postulate of the Aethus which provides the resolution, (since after all that is what provides us with two independent Aethic realities rather than having to mix their true statements), but ontologically it is the extrusion principle which provides the resolution. Simply put, this is because since the extrusion principle states that Alice's checking of her particle affects her Aethus rather than her or Bob's particle, we therefore do not have to make the direct implication that an objective change to Bob's particle results from Alice's having checked. Intriguingly, then, this simple thought experiment of analyzing how the emphasis on the checking order changes when we move to Aethic reasoning helps highlight why all three of the first postulate of the Aethus, the extrusion principle, and the relativity of simultaneity are one another's ideal complements under Occam's razor[61]. The same cannot be said about the Copenhagen interpretation and special relativity, which really serves to highlight the intuition which led me to these Aethic metaphysical conclusions in the first place.

Regarding the interplay between this Aethic solution and the general EPR paradox [11], consider John Bell's statement of "When the Queen dies in London (may it long be delayed) the Prince of Wales, lecturing on modern architecture in Australia, becomes *instantaneously* King" [67]. By removing the objective Aethic frame, we show this to be not only a misrepresentation of information, but also a factually false statement. To that we might say, "but relative to which Aethus does the queen die?" According to the Aethus, the queen operates just like Schrödinger's cat, being surely dead only relative to that Aethus which observes so via any chain of information. (Such as, for instance, hearing about it on the news). Therefore, the prince of Wales only becomes king relative to his own Aethus when he hears news of the queen's death, and he only becomes king relative to the Aethus of an onlooker once they themselves receive news of the queen's death. The moral of the story is that due to this vital necessity of information to be transferred before Aethic superpositions may collapse, it follows that the light barrier need not ever be broken.

It is worth emphasizing the logical priority among the various aspects of nonlocality addressed above. The reference-dependent ordering of measurements is the more fundamental problem, not the faster-than-light aspect. As stated at the outset of this section, the core contradiction is between the Copenhagen interpretation's demand for a definite first measurement and special relativity's insistence that no such definite ordering exists for spacelike-separated events. This is the node through which the structure of the Aethic resolution is formally wired. That is, by establishing the lack of necessary objectivist transitivity between the reality of two agents, (being the first postulate of the Aethus), and even between a single agent at two moments in time, (being the extrusion principle), and at once asserting that the cutoff between the pre-and-post measurement universe is not valued as the manifold of a preferred foliation in spacetime but as an Aethus-valued separation between complete Aethic block universes, (via the extrusion principle, so as to explicitly weed out the endless paradoxes of having to

[60] So in other words, we have that the standing of the sequential-valued paradox, and the forcing of a well-defined dividing-line manifold in spacetime between the pre and post-collapse partitions therein are two sides of the same coin. By no longer requiring the latter, then, do we specifically resolve the former, and thereby meet *Requirement 5* directly.

[61] Put in a stronger form, we might even argue that due to this thought experiment's being able to play the role of a proof-by-contradiction, (where the resolution to the contradiction between the Copenhagen interpretation and the theory of relativity requires postulating the extrusion principle and the first postulate of the Aethus as a pair—since after all the further question of what happens in Bob's Aethus between Alice checking and his checking requires the degree of freedom of the extrusion principle in order to be resolved), we then have that the extrusion principle itself may be genuinely deduced in terms of the theory of relativity together with a general relational-type [20] interpretation of quantum mechanics. While it is hard to remember my particular deductive pathway for certain things, (as after all it happened a while ago now), it seems entirely reasonable that this was how I formalized the extrusion principle and the first postulate of the Aethus in relation to one another—as after all I remember playing around with this very sequential-styled thought experiment in the autumn of 2022. Interestingly enough, however, I had never heard of Rovelli nor the relational interpretation at the time, so I do think it was critical for my success that I had the general freedom to independently devise my own postulates and frameworks just off of instinct.

define the spacetime-valued manifold as objective while at once satisfying the principle of relativity), do we directly propose the structure of the ontological model which ought to supplant the Copenhagen collapse mechanism. The superluminal aspect itself then becomes a secondary consequence, perhaps more for illustration than rigor[62].

The preferred-foliation problem as the primary resolution. The primary resolution is *not* the preservation of locality—that is a corollary. The primary resolution is the dissolution of the preferred-foliation problem: Copenhagen-style interpretations [23, 24] require a specific, privileged way to slice spacetime in order to define an objective "first measurement" and delineate a universal pre-collapse from post-collapse reality. This requirement is fundamentally at odds with relativity, which insists that no such privileged foliation exists for spacelike-separated events. The collision deserves stating at full bluntness, because it is not a tension to be managed but a contradiction outright: Copenhagen forces the *first* measurer to collapse the state *for everybody*, so take two admissibly-drawn simultaneity foliations across a spacelike-separated pair and they literally contradict one another—along one slicing, the collapse has already happened everywhere; along the other, it has not yet happened at all across stretches of the very same timelike paths. Two equally licensed descriptions of one universe disagree about what *is*, and no appeal to perspective available within the Copenhagen vocabulary can launder that. The extrusion principle dissolves this requirement entirely, because collapse is reinterpreted as an observer-relative Aethic transition between distinct block universes—an extrusion—rather than as an event occurring along any spacetime slice. Each observer's transition is tied independently to their own Aethic update: when Bob measures, this triggers an extrusion only relative to Bob's Aethus, shifting him into a block universe whose entire history is consistent with his outcome; relative to Alice's prior Aethus, Bob and his measurement remain in superposition until Alice herself gains the relevant information. Because no synchronized, objective collapse instant is required, no preferred foliation is needed to define one. Locality is then preserved as a consequence: Bob's extrusion has no effect on Alice's Aethic state, because it is not an event in their shared spacetime but a transition in Bob's Aethic chain alone. The source of this entire resolution is the counterfactual semantics of Section 2.2.1: the perturbation operator, the tense-free blankness, and the Aethus-indexed evaluation that dissolve the preferred foliation are deductions from the modal-metaphysics content of the extrusion principle, not independent physical postulates.

The culmination: collapse rebuilt on relativity's own ontology. The dissolution above is best read as the first half of a two-step consistency repair, and the second half deserves equal billing. The first step is the extrusion resolution just given: observer-indexing removes the demand for an objective first measurement, and the disagreeing-superposition reading places *all* of the outcome-possibilities as genuine superposition content within the block universe proper—so nothing about collapse ever required a spacetime slice to happen on. The second step is that the framework then rebuilds collapse itself out of the block universe's own material: the determinate node, (Definition 53; Section 14.2.6), replaces the collapse event with a fixed, foliation-free element of the block—an event in spacetime proper, never on a slice of it—so that the successor concept to Copenhagen collapse is not merely *compatible* with relativity but built for root conceptual consistency with it, paralleling on the modality side exactly the way relativity does its business on the geometry side. (The wavefunction-side form of the same point is the Aethic Non-Unitarity Principle of Section 14.2.11: a determinate node implies non-unitarity relative to the indexing Aethus, and perfect unitarity over an arena implies the absence of determinate nodes there, with no moving present consulted on either side, Principle 54.) The pairing that makes this livable bears restating here in one sentence, exhaustively: relative to any Aethus in which a determinate node is state-decomposable, the outcome is fixed as if predetermined—the quantum state encoding it from the beginning, the agreeing superposition of paths constructed upon it—while all of the randomness and variability of measurement lives in the *disagreeing* superposition over the determinate-indexing Aethae themselves, over which states the nodes occupy, where they

[62]After all, causally connected agents in the sense of relativity may still very well fail to exchange information by any of the other circumstances which could have stopped them, so the light-limit is already a special case of, but not the full expression of the simple inability for two agents to exchange information, (with this general case of an inability to have exchanged information yet being the general counter to Bell's statement [67] about the Queen's death, as per the first postulate of the Aethus). So not even in this respect is the light limit exactly rigorously explanatory in general. And then, of course, we have that the actual theoretic machinery of the Aethic solution to *Requirement 5* surrounds fixing the conflict between the principle of relativity and the Copenhagen interpretation by introducing the two dual concepts of non-objective truth transmission and a non-spacetime-valued separation between block universes, (as stated), so in that case as well the light limit is not exactly relevant in the direct sense.

sit in spacetime as events, and how they couple to other attributes, (Sections 10.2.4 and 14.2.11). Predetermination per Aethus, randomness over Aethae: that is the complete division of labor, and it is what lets a collapse-successor live inside a relativistic block without a preferred slice ever being consulted. And the block this construction stands on was never borrowed from relativity in the first place: the framework derives it independently from the modal content alone, (the independent derivation closing the First Statement, Section 2.2.1), which is what entitles the repair to count as *root* consistency rather than as an alliance of convenience. (The wavefunction-side statement of this same repair—the continuity assumption demoted outright—is collected as its own unit in Section 14.2.7.)

2.5.1 Comparing the Aethic Interpretation of EPR with Standard Quantum Interpretations

Having established the Aethic resolution, it is useful to map it systematically against the major existing interpretations so as to clarify what is structurally shared and what is genuinely novel.

Copenhagen. The contrast is sharpest here. The Copenhagen interpretation [23, 24] requires an objective collapse event occurring at a specific moment in time, which in turn requires a definite temporal ordering of measurements, which for spacelike-separated measurements requires a preferred foliation of spacetime. Aethic reasoning eliminates all three by making collapse an observer-relative Aethic transition between block universes rather than an event within spacetime. The sequential contradiction between reference frames, which is irresolvable under Copenhagen, simply does not arise.

Many-Worlds. The Everettian interpretation [2, 3, 68] also eliminates the preferred foliation, but through a fundamentally different mechanism: it eliminates collapse entirely, holding that all measurement outcomes are physically realized in separate branches of a universal wavefunction. Aethic reasoning agrees with many-worlds that all outcomes are in some sense present within the prior Aethus's superposition structure—and agrees, further, that many-worlds reads the phenomenology of records correctly, non-interaction after a record being exactly what the data shows, (Section 2.4.5)—but disagrees about the mechanism of resolution. Many-worlds achieves resolution through ontological proliferation, where each measurement generates new branches. Aethic reasoning achieves it through ontological reselection, where the observer extrudes to a different block universe without any duplication occurring—and the branches themselves are different objects, amplitude states there and Aethae here, with the framework's state vector derived from the Aethus's weights rather than the Aethus from the state, (Section 2.4.6). In the Aethic picture, the prior block universe maintains its superposition indefinitely and the subsequent block universe never held a superposition in the first place, whereas many-worlds requires all branches to persist as equally real components of a single universal state. That is, many-worlds does not support the independent realism of the before and after realities, which is crucially important for Aethic reasoning—that way it can maintain the prior block universe as not dissolving or being otherwise reducible into the subsequent block universe[63].

[63] Indeed, perhaps one of the central reasons behind my move from the "superposition as timeline bundles" idea of the original centric unfolding to the extrusion principle was so as to maintain the permanent and independent legibility of the prior block universe. Generally I have found that timeline-based superposition models, including my own, inadvertently undermine their radical move of allowing consciousness to move beyond a single timeline anyway by not explicitly naming what happens to the prior timeline bundles of the observer once they gain more information afterwards. *Is it simply a Bayesian update, which made the prior informational state irrelevant to begin with? Relative to which informational state in the sequence is the reality best described if not the latest one?* The extrusion principle solves this paradox by explicitly naming each Aethus in the sequence as its own independent "walled off" reality, as opposed to being abstract collections of the same timelines for which the prior ones become "false" artifacts when viewing retrospectively after the fact. By allowing the prior Aethus to be an independent block universe with a level of permanence, then, may we explicitly describe that state without implicitly having to refer to the events which happen in the subsequent informational or ontological states as having the capacity to overwrite. Many-worlds in this regard, then, is quite vague in how it distills the different Aethic realities from the same linear combination of basis vectors forming the multiverse, which is perhaps part of the problem. Perhaps my greatest issue with it is its inability to even be formulated in a manner which consists with the third postulate of the Aethus.

Allow me to be a little more specific about where Aethic reasoning converges and diverges from the various proposals under the many-worlds umbrella. I find it particularly fascinating, to begin with, how the epistemic separability principle [69] proposed by Carroll and Sebens shares similarities with my own initial centric unfolding idea in its base form of attributing quantum and otherwise Bayesian updates to the contextual degrees of freedom accessible to the observer as opposed to the arbitrary environment surrounding their one particular location in spacetime and the multiverse, (with the radical step then being that among possible observers with equivalent informational contexts to you, you should carry out statistical inference based on this outlook as opposed to from the assumption that all alternative copies from "oneself" may be discarded from consideration). Tappenden's Unitary Mind [70] then takes the key next step, which is to also realize that it would be arbitrary to attribute an observer to a single timeline via Leibniz's law, because it

Bohmian mechanics. The third contrast completes the axis, and it is the most instructive because Bohmian mechanics [72, 73] pays the foliation cost *openly* rather than by smuggling. The pilot-wave program preserves determinism and a realist particle ontology, but its guidance equation is nonlocal in a manner that requires absolute simultaneity: the velocity of each particle depends instantaneously on the configuration of all the others, so the dynamics itself needs a privileged slicing of spacetime to be stated—a preferred foliation installed as infrastructure, the very structure relativity forbids and Copenhagen requires only implicitly. The comparison then sharpens into a three-way statement of what each program trades: Copenhagen needs the foliation for collapse and hides the need; Bohm needs it for dynamics and declares the need; many-worlds escapes the need by abolishing collapse at the price of ontological proliferation. Aethic reasoning is the strictest of the four about relativity's verdict: no foliation for collapse, (the transit is not in spacetime), no foliation for dynamics, (the pruning is foliation-indifferent, per the ordering-independence of the validity layer), and no proliferation, (reselection, with the prior block retained). It is, on this axis, the only one of the four whose collapse-successor is built

is better to reject the one-timeline ontology than to divorce the causation in consciousness branching from the direct intake of discriminating information about attributes of the environment. Tappenden's step corresponds to what I might refer to as the single-timeline-concerning part of the ontological reversal principle (pertaining to the demotion of the single-timeline ontology) in addition to the epistemic separability principle, which when taken together (as Unitary Mind has them [70]) converges on many of the same structural commitments as my original centric unfolding idea from 2022. It is worth being precise, however, about where the differences lie. Tappenden's step corresponds to the demotion of the single-timeline ontology, but notably not the full ontological reversal principle, which additionally requires dissolving the branching structure itself as ontologically fundamental and promoting the observer's informational state to the primary position. The reason this further step is unavailable within many-worlds is paradigmatic rather than logical: the basis-vector-and-branching foundation of many-worlds treats branch points as objective physical events (decoherence moments defined by the forward evolution of the universal wavefunction), and this creates a structural asymmetry that blocks the natural extension of Tappenden reasoning on Unitary Mind. Specifically, Tappenden might be seen to apply Leibniz's law to show that an observer must span all branches with identical experiences, which is a genuinely important insight, but the same Leibniz's law argument applied temporally would require that the branching history itself be in superposition wherever the observer lacks information about it. In this respect the assertion of there having to be an objective branching point for the multiverse in the first place artificially stunts exactly how far back in time the indeterminacy granted by the observer's superposition across locations can reach. In the same sense of how asserting a single-timeline ontology when informational-distinction is available as the source of ontological attribution is ad hoc, (being the deviation successfully incorporated by Unitary Mind [70] already), we might then identify the asserting of an arbitrary branch point against a standard timeline-branching structure is ad hoc when dissolving the branch points anywhere besides at an observer's direct Aethic intake of information is available.

Interestingly, many-worlds itself [2, 3, 69, 70] cannot permit such a step, because the branching tree is its fundamental ontological object, as motivated by commitments to the basis vectors and decoherence at the center of the ontology. The alternative Aethic move in this regard, note—which I took in the context of Nexic reasoning in early 2022—might be considered as significantly more "lightweight" formal position as opposed to the full many-worlds apparatus: that is, my consideration as to define the Aethus (i.e., the exhaustive collection of accessible stated-attributes) as the center of the observer's informational context, and then simply regard past or future events alike as being analytically viewed from it referentially—no external commitments required. If you will, inductive reasoning drawn directly from the empirical source in a *hypotheses non fingo* [71] fashion. *This is perhaps the central Aethic deviation from many-worlds also, so as to ensure I do not say this:* ***in many-worlds the branching occurs at spacetime, but in Aethic reasoning it occurs at the observer's Aethus****, so as to produce an entirely new class of structured realism of modal contingent truths which shares superficial resemblances to timeline branching despite categorically reframing the shape of what a multiverse even is (see the thought experiments on Aethic time travel, for example).* So in essence it seems to me that many-worlds's insisted fundamentality of the basis vectors, in addition to the concerns of preventing a pathway to the quantum Nexus under more epistemic grounds, perhaps more directly muddles the ability of the inductive reasoning to reach the indiscriminate time principle directly. In my own case, I arrived at the indiscriminate time principle through Nexic reasoning rather than through many-worlds, so it is perhaps interesting to see how this difference in derivational origin manifests in the particularities of the differences at the base-centric unfolding stage. In my case, anyway, after having traversed the analogous step to those of the epistemic separability principle [69] and Unitary Mind [70] leading up to and in the beginning of 2022, I found the third major step in the sequence toward the new ontology to be the Aethic extrusion principle. After that, Aethic reasoning in full is essentially just following that inference to its conclusion. But my note on the potential undermining of the radical step stands for the sequence directly up until the extrusion principle, for the reasons discussed before pertaining to what is to be said about the permanence of prior superposition states in one's traversed sequence.

Furthermore, I should note that a major Aethic reframe at this stage is also to stop imagining the observer as "existing in a superposition flux across all consistent bodies" and instead assert that the ontology reflects "all versions of the observer being 'brought to center' while the outside universe enters the superposition", (although I must emphasize that the two are equivalent, and even in the full Aethic version it can be more intuitive during derivations at times to use the old concept as a stepping stone, even though it is understood to mix up the Aethic ontological commitments). In the formal Aethic argument, note that the second postulate is explicit about the Aethus itself being determinate while attributes of the universe enter superposition via retrieval. Doing it this way is key for streamlining the consistency needed to reach the Aethic union principle and describe agreeing superpositions objectively as opposed to getting stuck on the peripheral question of how they positionally transition with the observer. Something like how the Einsteinian equivalence principle reveals the distinction between inertial and gravitational mass to be a nonphysical constant, the extrusion principle reveals the question of how agreeing superpositions behave as the observer enters positional superposition across minds to be a nonphysical construct produced when one does not use Aethic block universes.

entirely from the block universe's own material—which is the repayment the independent derivation positioned the framework to make, (Section 2.2.1).

Bohmian Mechanics. Bohm's approach [72, 73] maintains definite particle trajectories at all times via a pilot wave, but the pilot wave itself is explicitly nonlocal, as it connects spatially separated particles instantaneously. Aethic reasoning is stricter in its locality: there is no nonlocal guiding entity of any kind. The correlations between distant measurements are not mediated by any object connecting the two particles, but instead are encoded in the structure of the block universe that both observers eventually find themselves in upon comparing results, with the extrusion principle ensuring that each observer's transition is governed only by their own informational update.

Collapse Theories. Theories such as GRW [74, 75] introduce wavefunction collapse as a genuine physical process, appending a stochastic mechanism to the Schrödinger equation with specific parameters (collapse rate, localization distance) that must be put in by hand. Aethic reasoning arrives at collapse through an entirely different route: the Third Postulate derives it as a logical consequence of consistency constraints on the Aethic inheritance structure, without introducing any new physical mechanism—at the grade the derivation actually carries: what the elimination yields is the *form*, the two-generation alternation, while the base contradiction the form runs on, (that a child stating both the interference and a which-path value is invalid), is supplied by the union principle's identification of interference with record-absence, a posit of the ontology rather than an output of the elimination, (Section 2.4.3); and the one item standing where a free parameter would stand, the irretrievability construction, is priced as exactly that at Section 8.0.2. Where collapse theories add machinery to the formalism, (and struggle with the preservation of relativity in doing so [74–76]), Aethic reasoning finds collapse already implicit in the ontology.

Relational Quantum Mechanics. The comparison with Rovelli's relational quantum mechanics [20] deserves the most attention, as it was relational quantum mechanics which first provided what is perhaps the most elegant reframing of EPR in the literature: the recognition that if quantum states are relative to observers, then when Alice measures her particle, the state of Bob's particle changes relative to Alice but not relative to Bob, and therefore no objective collapse needs to propagate across spacelike separation at all. The correlations are only established as a physical fact when the two observers actually interact and compare results. This was a transformative insight, because it dissolved the nonlocality problem not by adding new machinery but by removing an assumption, (being the assumption of an observer-independent quantum state), that had been generating the paradox in the first place. Aethic reasoning is aimed at extending precisely from this same central idea pioneered by relational quantum mechanics — with one boundary marked at the outset, since the two frameworks part company exactly here: relational quantum mechanics relativizes states to *any physical system*, while Aethic reasoning relativizes to Aethae and makes no claim that arbitrary systems carry them, for the reasons given at Section 10.5. The shared insight is the relativity of the state; the class of relata is not shared.

Atop such a foundation Aethic reasoning has constructed a few further ontological moves. First, relational quantum mechanics is an interpretation of the existing quantum formalism, whereas Aethic reasoning derives quantum phenomena from an independent informational-ontological framework which is logically prior to the formalism, and this difference in starting point is what accounts for most of the downstream divergences. Second, Aethic reasoning provides a specific mechanism for perspectival change, (being the extrusion principle and its rendering reselection), which may be seen as an attempt to supply the concrete ontological process that relational quantum mechanics correctly identified the need for but left unspecified. Third, the well-known challenge of multi-observer consistency in relational quantum mechanics, particularly in Wigner's Friend [30] scenarios where recent work [77] has explored auxiliary axioms to ensure global coherence, is addressed in Aethic reasoning through the interaction constraints imposed by Aethic algebra—particularly by means of the third postulate—where contradictory Aethae are structurally prevented from interacting as an algebraic consequence rather than an imposed constraint. Fourth, Aethic reasoning introduces a dual-time structure, (being Einsteinian time within each block universe and Aethic time across the Markov chain of block universes), which has no analogue in relational quantum mechanics, and which allows the framework to simultaneously address the problem of time's passage and the EPR problem within a single mechanism. And fifth, as discussed above, Aethic reasoning dissolves the hidden-variables versus non-hidden-variables dichotomy in a way that relational quantum mechanics does not attempt,

with the prior Aethus operating as a genuine non-hidden-variables domain and the subsequent Aethus operating as an effective hidden-variables domain. In sum, the relationship between the two frameworks is perhaps best understood not as competition but as the relationship between a pioneering reframing and an attempt to build the full ontological machinery that the reframing calls for.

QBism. QBism [78, 79] shares with Aethic reasoning an emphasis on the centrality of the agent and the informational character of quantum states, treating the wavefunction as an expression of an agent's expectations rather than an objective feature of reality. Its EPR resolution is similar in spirit to that of relational quantum mechanics: since quantum states are agent-relative, no objective collapse propagates across spacelike separation. Where QBism and Aethic reasoning part ways is in what information is taken to be *about*. QBism is deliberately silent on ontology, treating quantum mechanics as a tool for organizing an agent's expectations without committing to what, if anything, underlies those expectations. Aethic reasoning takes the opposite stance, constructing an explicit ontology, (the Aethus, rendering reselection, the three postulates), in which informational structure is not merely a description of the agent's beliefs but a structural feature of reality itself. In the spirit of Wheeler's "it from bit" [80], Aethic reasoning proposes that informational structure is ontologically primary, which is a central stance shared with QBism.

2.5.2 The Arrows of Inheritance: From Modal Content to Quantum Resolution

The logical dependencies among the framework's components deserve explicit display, because the order of inheritance is the argument for why no link in the chain can be dropped.

The modal content of the extrusion principle is the foundation. By proposing that counterfactual alternatives are co-present pockets within a single Aethic structure rather than residents of externally separated possible worlds, the principle eliminates the classical causal chain as the carrier of modality and replaces it with perturbation over weighted co-present structure—the similarity-free counterfactual semantics of Section 9.1. This is the first arrow, and it is purely modal: no physics has yet been invoked.

The block universe ontology follows as a corollary of this modal content, not as an independent premise. Once tense-free blankness is established—blanks lack tense, in that an attribute can be blank regardless of where it sits in proper time, (the indiscriminate time principle, Principle 11)—the Markov chain of block universes is the natural rendering: each node is a complete, static four-dimensional spacetime consistent with relativity, and what an observer experiences as the passage of time is transit along this chain driven by the acquisition of new information, (Sections 2.2 and 2.2.7). Crucially, this derivation of the block universe is *entirely independent* of the standard route through the relativity of simultaneity and the Rietdijk–Putnam argument [18, 19]: Aethic reasoning arrives at block universes from the modal structure alone, and the convergence with the relativistic argument is then a confirmation rather than a premise.

The EPR resolution follows from this block-universe corollary through the mechanism of perspectival re-indexing. In the Alice–Bob entanglement setup of Section 2.5, exactly the same physical environment—the same pair of entangled particles, the same laboratory—holds different superposition content depending purely on which Aethus is indexing it: relative to Alice's prior Aethus, Bob's measurement outcome is in disagreeing superposition; relative to Alice's subsequent Aethus, it was always determined. The collapse is not an event within spacetime but a transit between block universes, so no preferred foliation is required, and the contradiction between the principle of relativity and the Copenhagen demand [23, 24] for a definite first measurement is dissolved at its root. What makes this resolution structurally distinctive is that the prior Aethus is genuinely non-hidden-variables, with the superposition real and ineliminable, while the subsequent Aethus is effectively a hidden-variables model in which the outcome was always a fact—so Bell's theorem [4], which demonstrates that no *single* local hidden-variables theory can reproduce quantum correlations, is not violated, because the framework does not propose a single theory; it proposes a structure in which two complementary descriptions apply to different Aethae of the same physical situation.

The convergence with relational quantum mechanics [20] *emerges* from this perspectival indexing rather than being assumed: RQM's core insight—that quantum states are relative to a reference, in RQM's case any physical system—is reproduced in observer-indexed form by the first postulate of the Aethus and the extrusion principle together, but the ontological source of the relativity is different. Where RQM speaks of relative states, the Aethic framework grounds the relativity in a specific mechanism: the Aethus-indexing of distinct block universes, deduced from the modal-metaphysics

backbone of the extrusion principle, (Section 2.2.1). This ontological specificity is what enables the framework to address the preferred-foliation problem directly, (Section 2.5), and to go further: the pruning postulates supply the dynamics that RQM's relational states do not themselves carry, and the observer-consistency constraints of Section 12.3 resolve the multi-observer coherence questions that the relational program correctly identifies as pressing but leaves to auxiliary axioms [77]. The aspiration is that the relational insight is not merely paralleled but derived from first principles through the chain just displayed. The stakes of that aspiration deserve naming plainly, in the author's own assessment: the relation of the Aethic framework to relational quantum mechanics would then be, structurally, the relation of Einstein's 1905 derivation to the Lorentz transformations that preceded it—the same relativity, no longer postulated but derived—and, if validated, revolutionary at that same tier.

Part II: The Formalism

3 The Aethus as a Mathematical Object

3.1 Pegs, Attributes, States, and Representations: The Foundations of the Mathematical Aethus

The mathematical Aethus is built here from one kind of primitive object and one primitive relation among such objects. Four notions are constructed in order—pegs, attributes, states, and representations—and the Aethus is then the equivalence class of representations whose closures agree.[64]

[64] *2026-09-23, 9:34 PM ET*

Also please ensure the axiomatic construction of Aethic attributes almost as "bunches" of disjoint stated-attributes is stated somewhere primacy explicitly! Note that it's a bit of a different way of axiomatically producing attributes than the states to attributes to stated-attributed treatment in the relevant 2024 "A Proper Avenue Toward Defining the Mathematical Aethus" subsubsection, so rather than overwriting that version I would appreciate it if you could give a new subsubsection directly after it giving this alternative construction. It has to be particularly dense in cross-references though, making sure especially to construct all the moving parts by actual restating rather than merely reference them elsewhere alone--so yeah this should be the genuine axiomatic hub for everything at the very root of everything! Thanks!

Notice also now how "Aethic contradictions" in the primitive unweighted Aethus sense is literally multiplying (being intersecting) any two disjoint stated-attributes, which is also cool!

By the way for this, to be clear you're aware of the abstract, actual definition of the two as stated in the Aethic tree.tex paper, right??? That explains nicely how intersections can be constructued using stated-attributes alone, but Aethic unions require the abstract Aethae to define! Thanks!

Note though crucially that an agreeing superposition is written using attributes, whereas the "Aethic union" itself is strictly over Aethae, which loses the information/manipulation ability to construct agreeing superpositions out of stated-attributes! So an agreeing superposition is explicitly constructed by asserting that for a given attribute made up by definition of some set of stated-attributes, only a given subset of those stated-attributes are present, such that the agreeing superposition IS precisely those. THEN this entire construction is--well yeah I guess THAT itself is actually the "stated-attribute" that gets fed into the closure procedure which builds an Aethus lol--so the original "stated-attributes" I was referring to are basically what I had been calling "states" anyway, just with the abstraction included so as not to be reliant on attributes!

WHOOSH--ok here we go again then: an Aethic STATE apparently is itself the fundamental trinket thing which fully captures the premise in question, what I'd been calling stated-attributes in the earlier last few messages! So that's renamed state, and they have the property of disjointness and can be assembled into attributes and all--THEN a and we might need a new name for it rather than stated-attribute, but a say we'll call it a--ok shoot good vocab would be to call THIS a state, so ok round three then!

The thing I'd been calling a stated-attribute, then state, now we need a really good name for it! Let's call it a "point" as a placeholder name, so I have something to use for now! Ok so a point has the disjointness property, and you physically define an attribute as a set with slots for its (having to be primitively disjoint) points, yes? Then a STATE itself (now moving from type-level, which attributes are, to instance-level where "states" are) is specifically the ASSERTION of filling a given subset of the attribute with states, thereby making that attribute a canonical AGREEING SUPERPOSITION over those points! Now then, we define a "representation" (which used to be called a static Aethus) as a set of states, and then an Aethus is the equivalence class over representations per their closures matching. THAT then is the whole fundamental setup! And yeah we've got our work cut out for us in terms of redrafting everything into this formalism, and frankly I think it makes agreeing superposition clearer enough that I'm actually now comfortable scrapping the "A Proper Avenue Toward Defining the Mathematical Aethus" treatment altogether, and instead we can just start the whole "The Aethus as a Mathematical Object" section right from here as its first subsection, then build up to representations, and then explicitly load in all the constructions from the aethic_tree paper for the explicitly intrinsic part, (leaving the weighting for later). Ok this should all look good, then??? Thanks, please go for it now! (And yeah to be clear this makes disagreeing superpositions very intuitive: the state only has one point stated for every state, which is why states literally lack the resolution, when put into unions, to construct new agreeing superpositions--being the central intuition since May 2023! And yeah the weird negation notation for disagreeing superpositions then explicitly no longer clashes with the no-negations rule because they aren't actually negations, they're per this formalism simply the way points load into states!).

(And yeah the funny thing for the record here is that your stating the Kronecker delta notation for disjoint objects there just a second ago, for whatever weird reason made my brain spontaneously kick into this new formalism, but literally I hadn't seen it until I thought about multiplying stated-attributes or now points or whatever the hell to zeroes lol, and adding them to blanks). (So I already had the intuition for the no-negations for a while, and just today apparently have had the attribute-makes-negation-convention for some time now since it was just sitting in my intuitive bank for reference, but for whatever reason this whole formalism hadn't clicked until now!).

Also as for choosing the name in place of "point", weirdly my whatever the heck Bouba-Kiki intuition for it is that it's almost like a popsicle stick, upright like a human almost. So what's a word that captures that??? A what? What are some options?

Also note that it's the Aethic union principle itself, per introducing the concept of agreeing superpositions, that formally distinguishes pegs from states, but in classical logic/metaphysics they're indistinguishable since no attributes ever occupy agreeing superpositions anyway (ie states only ever have one peg in them, and it's just that the Aethae themselves range over the states to produce the standard disagreeing superpositions). SO, therefore with pegs being the fundamental disjointness-and-neg primitive, that means they should take on the being the actual modal states themselves, like "it is raining" would now be a peg, since it of course doesn't privilege or otherwise hold an argument for any attribute like a given state would! (Although in fairness it implicitly very much does refer to the attribute of it and "it is not raining", which in Aethic reasoning must be said explicitly rather than being left implicit, hence "it is raining" as a primitive is a peg, but "is it raining" with its implicit "as opposed to not" connotation is that state!). Thanks!

The intrinsic layer of the framework, the lattice of Aethae under its two operations, is built on this foundation; weighting comes afterward and is not used here.

And yes by the way, if it's over Aethae then it's a disagreeing superposition: a disagreeing superposition by definition is still an Aethic superposition (ie at the level of the total Aethus in question does not resolve a single peg) but every state is necessarily is one-peg only. Note that a disagreeing superposition is defined strictly as peg-relative, such that placing a set of pegs into disagreeing superposition for the attribute for their set constructs one state for each single peg being stated, converts each state to an Aethus, and adds them all with nonzero weights to each (or for the unweighted version of the disagreeing superposition, it's an Aethic union directly, being the LCA in the lattice concept).

Yeah come to think of it my instinct is that we shouldn't force it--maybe a disagreeing superposition is a weighted Aethus concept only, unlike an agreeing which lives in the intrinsic rather than extrinsic layer! So yeah that means the general Aethic superposition also has to be weighted-based too! But yeah hopefully you can see how you would construct the actual "Aethic superposition weights" on some set of pegs relative to a given Aethus? You basically have to break it down so that every state showing up with some weight in the Aethus which states that peg counts toward the peg's "Aethic superposition" weight broadly, hence how it collapses some information!

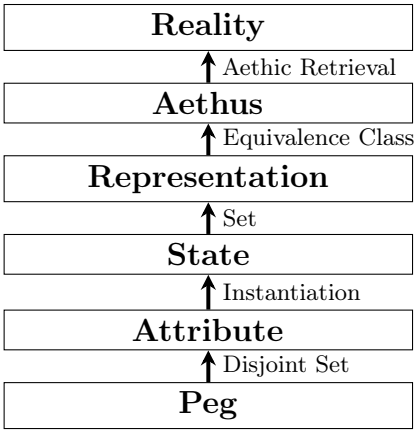
Importantly, also note that my intuition is to set the modal "might" operator thing to strictly see only this "flat Aethic superposition" concept here that I'm discussing--so interestingly might calls true on a peg even if it's locked up in an agreeing superposition! Meanwhile "would" enforces that the peg occupies the ENTIRE Aethus's weight with its weight, (ie renormalizes to one relative to that Aethus)--notice how neither even care at all about the place of the negations, they purely ask if the peg has zero weight or not versus if it has one weight or not!

Ah I see, this is gorgeous, thank you! Good, please make sure the paper captures these definitions if not there already!!! Also it really clears up my OTHER central May 2023 intuition for agreeing superpositions lol (but that I had forgotten about until this construction, as is equivalent to the 2024 one but written differently, reminded me of it!): notice how in the 2023 videos and 2024 version of the paper I explicitly refer to the actual CASES of slit-subset agreeing superpositions as themselves falling into agreeing superposition in the Aethus in question, even though they themselves lack the irreducibility premise that those individual cases themselves have for the slits! SO, the idea there is that each case physically states as one of its pegs that "this exact subset of states is an agreeing superposition", right, and see the magic there: THAT is the irreducibility character of that agreeing superposition! As in, all of a sudden every child Aethus for which we construct it by multiplying on a single-peg state for one of the pegs in that multi-peg agreeing superposition is an invalid Aethus, which is what delivers the irreducible-character! So there's a difference between "agreeing superposition in the basic sense of simply not writing the negations, as is how the Aethic union principle has it" for which a present Aethus very much can exist as an agreeing superposition over other Aethae, and "agreeing superposition in the sense of irreducibility to valid child Aethae with subsets as the states instead" which comes from enforcing with another peg that EXACTLY that multi-peg state is existent, thereby giving the phenomenology of "oh the agreeing superposition can't collapse in any future/child Aethae" despite the broadest concept of agreeing superposition perfectly allowing that "breakup/collapse" with child Aethae. See what I mean lol? So how I've been using the term "agreeing superposition" in 2025 and 2026 so far has been the irreducible kind, even though the original idea was the broad kind, and that's the one directly compatible with the union principle lack-of-negations treatment anyway lol! So to be clear the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning still very much comes in in the broad version, it's just that the third postulate of the Aethus itself gets to "add its own states to a representation" basically as an extra enforced deductive step to make the representation "viable" under the axiomatization including the third postulate: that is, that however the powerset invalidation theorem, generalized to any sorts of records and so to any pegs whatsoever, (like "France won the world cup" vs "Spain won the world cup", in both being classical logic due to the records availing them) cuts the states into pegs then SPONTANEOUSLY ENFORCES that you now break the entire Aethus itself to which that representation corresponds into one Aethus for each viable-subset-split, and then add them back to get the total Aethus! So the third postulate doesn't choose the weights, but it tells us to carry the whole representation set to each proper child Aethus here produced besides the split in question, and then basically we have to do this as finely as all the splits across all the attributes demands! THAT is the May 2023 intuition lol, fully realized formally! Man that took a while lol!

Oh yeah and by the way, about the in Aethic time thing: the reason the CASE Aethae themselves can occupy an agreeing superposition until a case is resolved is because "this Aethus at this Aethic time consists of an agreeing superposition of these other Aethae" is abstract enough that you can't actually go and contradict it later--sure, you can say that the LATER/child Aethae don't have that property, but it remains true that the Aethus of that time did have that property, hence no contradiction! Alternatively, seeing an interference pattern in an earlier Aethus implies now for all child Aethae that there was an agreeing superposition of the slits themselves at that time, so for a future Aethus to find that there was a determinate state, again of that time, is a contradiction OF/AT THAT TIME, hence a real contradiction! So basically the idea there is that we have the bare unweighted Aethus at the time with the cases Aethae in an unresolved agreeing superposition, and we MULTIPLY this entire Aethus with the system-arbitrary Nexus (generally speaking, doesn't have to only be the Quantum Nexus) setting the weight of each case so as to get the "actual" Aethus itself! So yeah that's the idea then, while meanwhile when you enforce with another state that a given attribute has to be carved a certain way, then basically you assert as another condition of Aethic equivalence that the abstract Aethus itself is equivalent with that extra conditional in just the bare representation to the Aethus for which we take the multiple imported representations with the carving now being set to one thing for each and then unioning them back to that Aethus! That enforced equivalence itself then is what allows you to make the representation jump DURING your construction of the Aethus itself!

As for F7, right this gets into my meaning two things by "agreeing superposition": basically the "being asserted" in this car color case would be that the semantic mining yields that cars as concepts obviously hold the records, since the car being in agreeing superposition of the irreducible sense at spacetime event/location t implies you can at a later Aethus deduce the car to have been a single color at t, (hence the idea that the contradiction being at spacetime event/location is the contradiction), so we automatically assert by deduction from the Aethic fundamental theorem that the Aethus must also contain as a state "Y holds only a single peg", which then enforces by the Aethic equivalence jump that the Aethus itself ought to be constructed as [Y:{red}]U[Y:{blue}]U[Y:{green}], with the intersection with s simply invalidating the third proper child Aethus there! So when I would say "oh Y

The construction climbs the ladder shown below.[65]



Shown here is the proposed mathematical hierarchy[66] for defining the Aethus[67], as is to be described in this paper. Let us traverse the hierarchy in its proper causal order.

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is not in agreeing superposition" in general I suppose I mean that that defaults to the convention for which we concern only representations in which the extra constraint is cashed out as the jump thing, because that makes it easier for actual quantum effects to be the clear logical edge cases! This is also why we get away with calling the Aethus-over-case-Aethae an "agreeing superposition"--there is no such extra added constraint anyway (that is since an Aethus has no spacetime event/position location anyway, so there's no place to "stand" so to speak to contradict, that way there's no lingering ability to lock in a contradiction of a specific attribute located specifically somewhere, so the "risk" doesn't exist), so we've already technically cashed it in since there is none to speak of!

Also yes basically the spacetime event is meant to be a reliable breaking of leibnitz equality between any two attributes in question, such as "the photon which hit the screen at 2:00 PM versus the one at 3:00 PM", so yeah it's spacetime event for the reference attribute, but Aethic time (ie indexed along the child Aethus direction) for when you actually get to landing the contradiction in the invalid potential cases! Thanks!

[65] Its rungs are those of the 2024 definitional hierarchy, rebuilt: the 2024 Aethic state is now the peg, the stated-attribute the determinate state, and the static Aethus the representation.

[66] Note that under the Markov chain-treatment of the extrusion principle, what is meant by "Reality" is simply the Aethic block universe bijectively described by a given Aethus anyway and such. Using the term "Reality" also allows for one to instate their additional nuance of choice upon this base Aethic block universal model, (specifically for philosophical or ontological contexts), but the base mathematical treatment itself implies explicitly the Aethic block universe concept in particular.

[67] An important clarification I want to make right now, for the record, is that I see the abstract concept of the Aethus, even in a purely mathematical sense, as fundamentally separable from the particular formalism with which I have defined it in this paper. As we know, the abstract intuition of the Aethus dates all the way back to 2021, whereas the formalism of this paper with which to explain that abstraction is something I came up with in 2024. But the key point I want to get across is that my raw intuition for the Aethus was and is much more like a tensor than an equivalence class, where it sort of just is in some abstract sense. I.e. that fundamental sense how you need coordinates to represent a tensor, but changing your coordinates will still map to the same underlying tensor if that's what you're going for. This is precisely what I'm trying to say with an Aethus regarding static Aethae. Just like how 2 and 02 both mean "two", in the raw sense two different static Aethae of an Aethus are meant to both "be" it, such that their representative nature as static Aethae is secondary in significance. In fact, tangled up with my original dreaming up of the Aethus in 2021 is a strict code to stray as far away from set propagation, so to speak, as humanly possible. This is also the core motivation behind the reversal principle—or at least its mathematical version—being that rather than ever defining a class as every object which agrees with a property, instead you "reverse" things and define a class as the abstract state of consisting with that property directly. Like, where the heck would you be getting all these supposedly agreeing states from anyway? However subconsciously it was, at that time I was avoiding this set-like setup like the plague, and was trying to go for a "*cogito, ergo sum*"-like excessive simplicity in the definition. I.e. if you're defining an Aethus right, there is no deeper axiom on Earth anyway, (with the paradox, perhaps, being that without introducing someone to the deliberate structure, they can't tell why this is saying much anyway). So anyways, that's why the reversal principle, (perhaps short of its direct ontological incorporations, which were formalized more with the extrusion principle), and the avoidance of set cascading are really two sides of the same coin. And for the record, even though this was years before I had heard of Russell's paradox, (and frankly anything formal in set theory, which is arguably chief among my educational informalities at the time), in retrospect I think I would have found the development really fitting, since my intuitions were strongly declaring to me that venturing into the cascading realm of collecting all possibilities is effectively forfeiting the ability to track where the math goes—so Russell's paradox becomes a rather fitting validation to that warning. But, irregardless, the point then became that I was trying to push as heavily as possible into the "formulation by property manifestation" rather than "formulation by collection of all instances". Perhaps this inadvertently opened the door to my eventually being able to formulate an agreeing superposition in the first place, which is of course intimately dependent on accepting that an ontologically complete block universe is even capable of lacking elements of its own structural information. And so, perhaps ironically, I'm not sure the formal definition of an Aethus as an equivalence class of static Aethae really perfectly captures the initial purity of this concept, but more recently I needed something robust enough to get the point across, and so this is what I came up with. But, of course, I am hopeful for some more creative ideas for how to formulate the Aethus mathematically in a way that stays more true to the original spirit of the abstraction, and maybe even down the line we can come up with something that outwardly doesn't depend on sets at all. The key, as is hopefully obvious, is creating something which best captures the postulates, which are the real stars of the show. And this is how,

Pegs and the constraint layer.

Definition 3 (Peg)
A peg *is a primitive atom: bare, it is void, and it acquires content through the relations it carries in use (Definition 9). Pegs carry one primitive relation,* disjointness*: for any two pegs it is given whether they can be present together. Disjointness is symmetric and irreflexive.*

The peg is the lowest rung of the ladder above, what the 2024 hierarchy called an Aethic state: one of the alternatives an attribute can hold. As an eigenstate is regarded in quantum mechanics, a peg is regarded with respect to an Aethus, as a building block toward the wider picture the Aethus assembles.

Definition 4 (Constraint layer)
The constraint layer *is a family of finite sets, each declared* jointly invalid*, whose members are pegs and, where a declaration concerns a filling rather than a peg, states (Definition 6, below). Its two-element sets of pegs are exactly the disjointness declarations; its larger sets of pegs constrain pegs that are pairwise compatible, as the three-way declaration* $\{x, s, \neg z\}$ *does in the sprinklers ledger of Section 9.2.1; and its sets containing a state declare a filling invalid, as the irreducibility declarations of Definition 11 do. Declarations hold at two scopes:* base *declarations are in force for every content, and* carried *declarations are in force for the contents that hold them, as the carvings of Definition 12 are carried. This layer is the semantic mining taken as axiomatic in Section 5.2.2, and nothing in it is temporal or causal.*

Attributes, at the type level.

Definition 5 (Attribute)
An attribute *is a set of at least two pairwise disjoint pegs, each occupying one of its* slots*. Nothing restricts the number of slots to two. An attribute is identified as the equivalence class of its presentations, as the Attribute Set of December 2021 first fixed it (Section 13.10.3).*

An attribute is the Aethic analogue of a question. The question *what is Tim's favorite ice cream flavor?* is an attribute whose pegs are the flavors, cued up for an answer to be selected, and its relations to other attributes are the relation structure below (Definition 9).

A remark on what this abstraction is *for* deserves placement this early, because it names the methodological substance of the framework before the machinery arrives. In Hamiltonian mechanics, an entire array of downstream methodological practice roots to one conceptual establishment: canonical momentum. The Aethic analogue of canonical momentum is precisely the Aethic attribute. The postulates ahead constrain *attributes*—never their contingent concrete projections—and that is why a single second postulate will be seen to govern randomness, quantum superposition, Aethic addition, and the modal structure of the extrusion principle all at once: these are one postulate's instances, the moment one operates over attributes rather than over positions, observables, or events. Observables themselves will emerge as convention—selections of determinately valued attributes relative to an Aethus—rather than as derivational primitives, (the full development of this point closes the introduction of the Quantum Nexus, Section 14.2.1).

States, at the instance level.

Definition 6 (State)
For an attribute X *and a set* S *of its pegs, the* state $[X : S]$ *is the assertion that* X *is filled by exactly the pegs of* S*. A state is thereby the canonical* agreeing superposition *of* X *over* S*. When* S *is a single peg, the state is* determinate *at that peg; when* S *holds more than one peg, it is* blank*, the attribute left unresolved among the pegs of* S*; when* S *is every peg of* X *and nothing constrains the attribute's breadth, it is* conceptually blank *and asserts nothing; and the empty filling* $[X : \varnothing]$ *is* invalid*.*

operating only on the Aethus abstraction alone, as concerns its nature under operations and relationships, I was able to easily, (and if anything more easily), intuit the Aethic postulates without reference to the later formalism. This is why I am very keen on asserting that Aethic reasoning was completed on May 8, 2023, even though it had not been written down and did not yet have a well-defined notational formalism. That is, the formalism is an agent meant to capture the abstraction, and so for that reason is ever more fleeting. You could run through formalisms for ages, and never touch the abstraction underlying them. So hopefully this helps clarify where I believe the abstraction to end, and the formalism to begin, (and perhaps encourage you to not be so rigid with the existing formalism yourself when interpreting Aethic reasoning).

Agreeing superposition is therefore not an operation performed on finished Aethae. It is what a state is: an assertion made about an attribute, assembled from the attribute's pegs. Determinate and blank are said of an attribute's filling, never of a peg. The distinction between pegs and states is drawn by agreeing superposition alone. Classically no attribute ever stands in agreeing superposition, so every state is determinate, filling its attribute with a single peg, and the two notions collapse (Proposition 6): the Aethae range over such states and produce only disagreeing superpositions, and nothing distinguishes a state from the one peg it holds. Once agreeing superposition is admitted, through the Aethic union principle, they separate. A peg is what modal logic calls a state of affairs, such as *it is raining*. It privileges no attribute, although it implicitly invokes one, the attribute whose other peg is *it is not raining*, and Aethic reasoning requires that attribute to be named rather than left implicit. The question *is it raining?*, carrying its implicit *as opposed to not*, belongs instead to the level of states: it poses the attribute, and a state fills it.

If the attribute is the question, the state is the answer. A determinate state answers with a single peg, as the question *are non-avian dinosaurs extinct?* is answered, in our world, by a decided *yes*. A blank state answers with several pegs, the question left unresolved among them. The conceptually blank state answers with every peg and constrains nothing, and Aethic reasoning accepts it as an answer: asked *what is my friend's favorite movie?*, an Aethus may answer *I don't know*, and the conceptually blank state says exactly that, asserting nothing about the attribute at all.

Representations and Aethae.

Definition 7 (Representation)
A representation *is a set of states—what was earlier called a static Aethus. It is read conjunctively: a representation asserts all of its states at once, and its content is their product. Its* closure $\mathrm{Cl}(R)$ *is the set of states and exclusions it commits to, constructed below from the attribute relation structure (Definition 10). A representation is* invalid *when its closure contains an empty filling.*

Definition 8 (Aethus)
Two representations are equivalent *when their closures coincide. An* Aethus *is an equivalence class of representations, and its canonical closed content* $\mathrm{C}(A)$ *is the closure its representations share.*

The same knowledge can be written down in many ways, depending on which states one chooses to include, and all derivable information counts toward equivalence, not only what a given representation physically contains: representations that imply neither more nor less than one another are one Aethus.[68] The Aethus is the fundamental object of Aethic reasoning, and whatever analysis is done over Aethae is, as the postulates will have it, entirely descriptive of reality. It is the Aethic analogue of a possible world, a timeline, or an alternate reality: the chief discriminator between what is physically real and what is fake, different, or otherwise distinct. In its empirical presence an Aethus is rooted to the knowledge of some agent, yet it may be described wherever one sees fit, and it is not limited to a human or to a mind, for the reasons of paradox-avoidance given in Section 2. Mathematically it is an ontological container of knowledge, reached only through attributes: one does not check whether a peg is in an Aethus, but brings an attribute and asks for the state the Aethus holds on it. This makes its ontology precise, non-combating across types[69], and resistant to absurdities of unchecked set theory such as Russell's paradox. One can picture an Aethus as an array of small doors in front of small slots, each just large enough for its contents: to retrieve from it is to look up the right door, the attribute, and open it to find the filling behind. A set, by contrast, is one big bag into which every element is thrown and then lost track of.

Above the Aethus stands the top rung of the ladder, reality. In Aethic reasoning it means several things. It is the array of superpositions present in an individual's instantaneous Aethic coordinate block universe. The realism at issue between quantum and classical mechanics follows, as the first postulate has it, from this ladder and from its top rung, and the various realisms of philosophy can each be configured within that rung. Whatever we identify as our physical reality, whether the mathematical

[68](A terminological ruling, September 18, 2026: the default term for this object is henceforth *representation*, a static Aethus being one representation of the Aethus it belongs to; "static Aethus" is retained as the original vocabulary where the development's history is quoted.)

[69]That is, I cannot put completely incompatible states into an Aethus like I can a set. I could put the number three and my car into a set, but with the Aethus we have resistance to such an arbitrary ontological ugliness. With the Aethus, instead, I would have to look behind the doors, so to speak, labeled for those things, and even then could only draw states which are tailored to the corresponding doors, (being attributes). In short, anything goes with a set, but not with an Aethus.

dimensional construction associated with it or the root perception undergone in interacting with it, corresponds to this top rung.

Closure, from the attribute relation structure.

Definition 9 (Attribute relation structure)
The attribute relation structure *is the constraint layer itself (Definition 4): the family of all finite sets of pegs and states declared invalid upon being multiplied, a set D belonging to it exactly when the product of its members is* 0*. A set of pegs is the special case, read through determinate states: a representation holds a peg when it holds that peg's determinate state. It is complete for closure, and semantic mining typically supplies a vast one.*

This is the original construction of the Aethus run backwards to its simplest form. There an Aethic relation between two attributes was a function that had to be constant on the compatible pairs of their instances, and could be constant only because the pairs declared invalid had been removed from its domain: its whole content was its excluded pairs. Unpacked, every such relation is a family of invalid peg sets, and so are the notions built on relations. Congruent attributes are those with the same invalidity profile; conjunctions, decompositions, and relations of higher arity are all expressed by sets of pegs whose product is 0. The relational apparatus reduces to one family of sets: sets of pegs, and the sets containing a state by which a filling is declared invalid, as irreducibility is (Definition 11). A bare peg, taken as an axiomatic primitive and nothing more, is void: a white marker, carrying no content beyond its disjointness. A peg in use is another matter. *It rained last night*, taken as a peg, is rich with relation structure, and that structure—the semantic mining of everything the peg means, Aethically unpacked—is what turns the axiomatic primitive into a contextual object. Pegs as they are actually used therefore carry their relation structure intrinsically: the rulebook is not attached to such pegs from outside, but is what their content consists in.

Definition 10 (Closure)
A content holds two kinds of item*: states, and* exclusions*. The exclusion $X \not\ni p$ records that the peg p no longer loads into the filling of its attribute X. Like the $\neg x$ of a disagreeing superposition, it is not a negation: it records how pegs load into a filling. A conceptually blank state asserts nothing (Definition 6): it is not an item, and a rule whose conclusion would be one licenses nothing. A set of items R* holds *a state when that state is derivable from R, and a peg when that peg's determinate state is.* Derivability *is the least relation between sets of items and items under which every item of a set is derivable from that set, and which is closed under seven rules, each licensing its conclusion from R once its premises are derivable from R.* Narrowing*: two states on one attribute yield the state on their intersection, since an attribute carries a single filling—were it to carry two, one attribute would map to several states, contradicting its functionality.* Propagation*: when R holds every member of a set in the relation structure other than one of its pegs p, of the attribute X, the exclusion $X \not\ni p$ is licensed, and every state $[X : F]$ narrows to $[X : F \setminus \{p\}]$.* Elimination*: when every peg of X but p is excluded, the determinate state $[X : \{p\}]$ is licensed.* Invalidation*: when R holds every member of a set in the relation structure that contains a state $[X : T]$, the empty filling $[X : \varnothing]$ is licensed; for a declaration a carving carries (Definition 12), holding $[X : T]$ is read as* realizing *the agreeing superposition over T, which is to hold $[X : T]$ with T the filling of X in R. The empty filling stands as a tag and licenses nothing further: an invalid representation keeps exactly the content it has, so invalid Aethae remain distinct from one another, and invalidity is removed only on rendering to the validity quotient (Section 3.2).* Splitting*: when R holds a carving c with settings $c_1, \ldots, c_k$ (Definition 12), every item derivable from each of $R \cup \{c_1\}, \ldots, R \cup \{c_k\}$ is licensed.* Composition*: for a composite $X_1 \wedge \cdots \wedge X_n$, whose pegs are the joint pegs of its components, a state $[X_1 \wedge \cdots \wedge X_n : F]$ licenses each projection $[X_j : \pi_j(F)]$; states $[X_1 : S_1], \ldots, [X_n : S_n]$ together license $[X_1 \wedge \cdots \wedge X_n : S_1 \times \cdots \times S_n]$; an exclusion $X_j \not\ni x$ licenses the exclusion of every joint peg that extends x; and when every joint peg extending x is excluded, so is x.* Linkage*: for an attribute Ξ whose pegs ξ_i stand for pairwise disjoint Aethae A_i, holding ξ_i licenses every item derivable from a representation R_i of A_i, and holding every item of R_i licenses $[\Xi : \{\xi_i\}]$. The* closure $\mathrm{Cl}(R)$ *is the set of items derivable from R: the relation structure is propagated recursively, adding item after item to the representation, until nothing new is licensed. The* filling *of an attribute X in a set of items is the intersection of the fillings of its states on X with the pegs of X it does not exclude, the whole attribute where it neither states nor excludes anything on X.*

Closure computes the normal form of the representation's product. Narrowing is the product of two states on one attribute, whose fillings intersect; propagation multiplies the determinate states against

the relation structure and excludes any peg whose product with them would be 0, and elimination fills an attribute at the one peg it leaves; invalidation records that a representation holds the whole of a declared set containing a state, whose product is 0. Composition reads states on a composite and on its components as one assertion, and linkage reads a peg that stands for an Aethus as that Aethus. Neither rule is new equipment. Together they are the mechanism of representation equivalence that the framework has carried since May 2023 and has stated explicitly several times since: a representation need only write a decomposition set in place of an attribute to imply the attribute in full (Section 3.3.2), representations that generate the same closure present one Aethus (Section 3.6.2), and no decomposition is privileged (Section 3.3.1). Composition and linkage are that mechanism, written as rules of closure. Apart from splitting, which imports what a carving's refinements have in common, the core of their sum (Proposition 8), no sum enters in passing from a representation to its Aethus: the sum is an operation between Aethae (Proposition 12).

Closure recovers, rather than imposes, the conditions the original construction placed on its 3-Aethus, which was required to contain every decomposition, every combination, and every congruent counterpart of what it contained: every attribute deducible in any way from anything within it. Congruence follows from propagating the one relation structure. Combination and decomposition hold by the composition rule of closure: the product of states on components is the state on their conjunction, $[X : S] \cdot [Y : T] = [X \wedge Y : S \times T]$, and a state on a conjunction projects to a state on each component. A state on a conjunction need not be a product, however. A correlated filling such as $\{(a, b), (c, d)\}$ is asserted on the conjunction itself; it projects to $\{a, c\}$ and $\{b, d\}$, but the product of those projections is the larger filling $\{a, c\} \times \{b, d\}$, so the correlation lives on the conjunction alone. The closure is that maximal object of deduction generated from a representation, and the line between what is derivable from the representation and what is not is its defining feature.

Proposition 4 (Closure is a non-weakening closure operator)
Cl *exists, is extensive, monotone, and idempotent, and every derivable item has a finite derivation when every rule has finitely many premises. It is* non-weakening*: in the closure of a valid representation, every state over two or more pegs narrows a state built by projection and combination from states the representation asserts, a setting of a carving, or a state of an Aethus whose peg it holds, and every other state holds a single peg. No rule enlarges the filling it acts on.*

Proof
Each rule licenses its conclusion from derivability premises that occur positively, so the rules define a monotone operator on relations, and the least relation closed under them exists by the Knaster–Tarski theorem; with finitary rules it is reached by finite derivations. Extensivity holds because every item of R is derivable from R. Monotonicity follows by induction on derivations: a derivation from R is one from any $R' \supseteq R$, the splitting case because $R \cup \{c_j\} \subseteq R' \cup \{c_j\}$. The same induction gives the cut property, that Δ derives whatever Γ derives once Δ derives every item of Γ, the splitting case applying the hypothesis to $\Gamma \cup \{c_j\}$ and $\Delta \cup \{c_j\}$; with $\Gamma = \mathrm{Cl}(R)$ and $\Delta = R$ it gives $\mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{Cl}(R)) \subseteq \mathrm{Cl}(R)$, which is idempotence, extensivity giving the reverse. Non-weakening is a third induction, over the derivations from a valid representation. Narrowing intersects fillings and propagation removes pegs from them, so each state over several pegs that they yield narrows one already derived; elimination yields a single peg; invalidation does not act. A state over several pegs that splitting imports is derived in every branch, and in each valid branch it narrows a state of the representation or a setting, at least one branch being valid because the representation is. Composition projects and combines states already derived, and linkage imports the content of an Aethus whose peg is held, so the states over several pegs that they yield are built from the sources the statement names.

Theorem 1 (Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence)
Representations that derive each other are Aethically equivalent: if $R \subseteq \mathrm{Cl}(R')$ and $R' \subseteq \mathrm{Cl}(R)$, then $[R] = [R']$.

Proof
By monotonicity and idempotence (Proposition 4), $R \subseteq \mathrm{Cl}(R')$ gives $\mathrm{Cl}(R) \subseteq \mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{Cl}(R')) = \mathrm{Cl}(R')$, and symmetrically, so the closures coincide (Definition 8).

The converse holds as well, each representation lying within its own closure. Closure is the correct abstract procedure for Aethic equivalence, but the theorem makes computing it unnecessary in practice: to show that two representations present one Aethus, it suffices to derive each from the other.

Non-weakening is what the next result needs, and it is now a theorem about the rulebook rather than a stipulation. In particular, no rule turns a determinate state into an agreeing one: an agreeing state

enters a closure only by being asserted, directly or as the setting of a carving. Elimination is recorded differently. Propagation excludes pegs rather than writing narrowed states, so an attribute of three or more pegs that carries no state can be left with several pegs not excluded; its filling is then an agreeing superposition in the broad sense of Definition 11, read off the content rather than asserted in it. Where records carve that attribute, splitting resolves it into its one-peg children (Definition 12), as the paragraph on carving by records below works through.

The two operations. The *Aethic intersection* $A \cdot B$, joint assertion, has content $\mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{C}(A) \cup \mathrm{C}(B))$. It can be formed from states alone, at any representations of its operands, since the closure of a union of representations does not depend on which representations were chosen (proved in Section 3.2, Proposition 11). The *Aethic union* $A + B$ is their composition, and it keeps its operands as its *terms*: a sum of Aethae is the set of its terms, so the union is idempotent, commutative and associative, and joint assertion distributes over it term by term, $A \cdot (B + C) = A \cdot B + A \cdot C$. What a sum x asserts outright is its *core*, $\mathrm{core}(x)$, the Aethus whose content $\mathrm{C}(x)$ is what its terms share, so that $\mathrm{C}(A + B) = \mathrm{C}(A) \cap \mathrm{C}(B)$. The core is formed only at the level of abstract Aethae, from their canonical closed contents (Section 3.4.3), and it is the last common ancestor of the terms (Proposition 12). A sum keeps its terms, invalid ones included, until reasoning renders it to the validity quotient.

Agreeing and disagreeing superposition. An agreeing superposition is a state. A disagreeing superposition is a weighted sum of Aethae that are determinate on an attribute at different pegs (Section 4.3); its unweighted shadow is their Aethic union, a sum of determinate terms whose core carries only what the branches share. Neither works on pegs, and so neither has the resolution to assemble a new filling from them.

Proposition 5 (Union cannot make agreement)
Let A and B be determinate on an attribute X at distinct pegs a and b. Then the agreeing state $[X : \{a, b\}]$ lies in $\mathrm{C}(A + B)$ only if both $\mathrm{C}(A)$ and $\mathrm{C}(B)$ already contain it: a union cannot create an agreeing state.

Proof
The content of $A + B$ is $\mathrm{C}(A) \cap \mathrm{C}(B)$, so every state of the union, $[X : \{a, b\}]$ among them, already lies in the content of each operand. The operands can carry it: when an Aethus P holds $[X : \{a, b\}]$, its children $P \cdot [X : \{a\}]$ and $P \cdot [X : \{b\}]$ are determinate at a and at b and inherit it, since a meet refines its operands (Proposition 11), so their union holds it too. They need not: when A is valid and arises, as each branch of a disagreeing superposition does (Definition 25), by adding $[X : \{a\}]$ to a base whose content holds no state on X, and no carving of X has a block of two or more pegs, non-weakening (Proposition 4) leaves every state of $\mathrm{C}(A)$ on X within $\{a\}$, so $[X : \{a, b\}]$ is absent from $\mathrm{C}(A)$ and hence from $\mathrm{C}(A + B)$.

This is why the two superpositions differ in kind[70]: in a disagreeing superposition each branch fills the attribute with one peg, and a union of branches cannot pool their pegs into an agreeing filling. The notation x and $\neg x$ for the branches of a disagreeing superposition is accordingly not negation. It records how pegs load into states: each branch's state fills the attribute with one of its pegs, and $\neg x$ names the other peg of a two-peg attribute (Section 2.4.14).

Proposition 6 (Classical collapse)
If every state of a representation is determinate, every carving carves into single pegs, as records do, and every peg it holds that stands for an Aethus stands for a determinate one, each state carries exactly one peg, so the representation is fixed, attribute by attribute, by the pegs its states hold; and no superposition over them is agreeing: any is formed by summing Aethae, a disagreeing superposition in the weighted layer (Section 4.3).

Proof
A determinate state $[X : \{a\}]$ is fixed by its attribute and its single peg a. An agreeing superposition over two or more pegs is a state $[X : S]$ with S holding at least two pegs. No such representation contains one, and the closure of a valid one adds none: by non-weakening (Proposition 4) every state over two or more pegs in it narrows a state built by projection and combination from its assertions, a setting of a carving, or a state of an Aethus whose peg it holds, and here each of these holds a single peg. By Proposition 5, no Aethic union of such Aethae creates one in its core.

[70] This is the intuition the framework has carried since May 2023.

The algebra of states. Fix an attribute X with pegs $a_1, \ldots, a_n$. Its states are the fillings $S \subseteq \{a_1, \ldots, a_n\}$; combining two states intersects their fillings, and assembling an agreeing superposition unites them. The determinate states then satisfy

$$\{a_i\} \cap \{a_j\} = \delta_{ij}\,\{a_i\}, \qquad \{a_1\} \cup \cdots \cup \{a_n\} = \{a_1, \ldots, a_n\},$$

so the product of two distinct determinate states is the empty filling, the invalid 0—an Aethic contradiction is literally such a product—and their agreeing sum is the conceptually blank state, the unit. The determinate states are a complete family of orthogonal idempotents, the algebraic shape of a projective measurement, whose projectors satisfy $P_i P_j = \delta_{ij} P_i$ and sum to the identity. The match is one of shape at the unweighted level; the kernel supplies the quantitative layer, and the structure the recovery theorem represents as projectors (Theorem 15) is already present in how states are built from pegs. The sum here is the agreeing one, assembly within a state; the Aethic union is a different sum, the unweighted shadow of the disagreeing one, which is why the core of an Aethic union of determinate Aethae never holds an agreeing state that its operands did not all already carry (Proposition 5). An invalid Aethus absorbs joint assertion, every meet with it staying invalid, but it is not a zero of the sum: invalid Aethae remain distinct terms, and only the validity quotient identifies them with the additive identity, where by the Valid Union Principle of Section 3.4.3 a union keeps only its valid members.

Narrowing, worked. Write a state's filling as the agreeing sum of its pegs, so that $[X : \{a, b\}]$ is $a + b$ and $[X : \{b, c\}]$ is $b + c$. Since a peg times itself is itself and distinct pegs multiply to 0, their product is

$$(a + b)(b + c) = ab + ac + bb + bc = 0 + 0 + b + 0 = b,$$

the state $[X : \{b\}]$: the product of two states on one attribute is the state on the intersection of their fillings. A determinate state narrows an agreeing one to its peg, $[X : \{a\}] \cdot [X : \{a, b\}] = [X : \{a\}]$, and two distinct determinate states narrow to the empty filling, $[X : \{a\}] \cdot [X : \{b\}] = 0$, the Aethic contradiction as narrowing's limit. Intersection only removes pegs, so narrowing can never produce an agreeing state from a determinate one.

Broad and irreducible agreeing superposition. Agreeing superposition has two senses, and the difference between them is a peg.

Definition 11 (Broad and irreducible agreeing superposition)
An agreeing state $[X : S]$, with S holding at least two pegs, is an agreeing superposition in the broad *sense: the sense of the Aethic union principle, in which the alternatives' negations are simply not written, and whose children $A \cdot [X : \{a\}]$, $a \in S$, may be valid. It is* irreducible *in an Aethus A when A also holds a peg e_S (holds, that is, its determinate state), stating that X is filled by exactly S and admits no narrower filling, and the relation structure declares the product of e_S with every state $[X : T]$ for nonempty $T \subsetneq S$ to be 0. Every child $A \cdot [X : \{a\}]$ with $a \in S$ is then invalid, by invalidation (Definition 10).*

Proposition 7 (Irreducibility below a carving)
Let c be a carving of X with blocks $B_1, \ldots, B_k$, and let a weighted Aethus be a sum of branches $A_j = A \cdot [X : B_j]$ over the settings of c, with every weight nonzero. If each branch holding a block of two or more pegs is irreducible on it, holding e_{B_j} (Definition 11), then every child of a branch that narrows X within its block is invalid, while the branches themselves stand: the superposition is agreeing within the blocks and disagreeing across them, and no valid refinement of it splits X below the carving. Where a branch is agreeing only in the broad sense, without e_{B_j}, its children below the block may be valid, and the superposition then admits refinement below the carving.

Proof
Definition 11 applied to each branch in turn: A_j holds e_{B_j}, whose product with every state $[X : T]$ for nonempty $T \subsetneq B_j$ the relation structure declares to be 0, so every child $A_j \cdot [X : T]$ is invalid by invalidation (Definition 10). Nothing in the argument touches the branches' own validity, which is whatever it is before any narrowing. A branch without e_{B_j} carries no such declaration, and its children are subject only to the rest of the relation structure.

So a state over many pegs, jointly asserted with the constraint that it admits no narrower filling, has no valid proper child breaking it down below its filling; and a superposition that holds that constraint block

by block has none breaking it down below the carving. The carving's settings are where refinement stops.

The irreducibility peg is what makes an agreeing superposition unable to collapse in any child: the broad sense permits the breakup into children, and the peg forbids it. Its declaration concerns states rather than pegs. It invalidates the children in which X is narrowed below S, while propagation, which removes pegs, does not act on it; written instead as the peg sets $\{e_S, a\}$, it would strip the pegs of S from the agreeing filling itself. The fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning (Section 8) works in the broad sense, and, derived from the second and third postulates, it is what does the carving: it adds states of its own to a representation, as an enforced deductive step. Its trigger is the third postulate (Section 6.4). Wherever the postulate can land a contradiction of an attribute's agreeing claim—a refinement stating which part of the filling holds being obtainable from every refinement, so that each term into which the record's settings split the agreeing claim is contradicted, and the weighted reduced form leaves nothing of it—the theorem enforces the carving into those parts in the representation itself, augmenting the relation structure with further invalidity pathways. The powerset invalidation theorem (Theorem 14) shows both postulates at work in the carving. The fillings of an attribute range over the powerset of its pegs; the third postulate invalidates every filling that spans two of the classes the records separate, and the second invalidates every nonempty filling that is a proper part of one class, since alternatives that no record separates are not distinct alternatives at all (Lemma 7). The nonempty fillings left valid are exactly the classes, the settings of the carving, and they are what the Quantum Nexus sums over (Section 14.2.1). "Record" is the paper's short name for whatever triggers the third postulate so. An attribute whose alternatives stay hidden in principle triggers nothing, and its superposition stays agreeing, as the two-tag deduction shows at work in the polarized double slit (Section 14.6.4). The splitting that follows is licensed by the carving, through the splitting rule of closure, rather than by the theorem (Definition 12): the Aethus is split into one child for each viable subset, the whole representation is carried into each child, and the children are summed back into the total Aethus. The theorem does not choose the weights of that sum, and the splitting runs as finely as the splits across all attributes demand.

Aethic time, the Nexus, and the enforced splitting. Attributes are indexed by spacetime event: write X_t for the attribute X at the spacetime event t. The index reliably breaks Leibniz equality between attributes that would otherwise be indiscernible, so that the photon which hit the screen at 2:00 PM and the one which hit it at 3:00 PM are different attributes. Aethae carry no spacetime location. They are ordered instead by Aethic time, the direction from an Aethus to its children, and a contradiction is landed along Aethic time. The statement that an Aethus holds its cases in agreeing superposition is abstract enough that no Aethus later in Aethic time can contradict it. A child may resolve the case, and it remains true that its ancestor held the cases in superposition: the ancestor, located at no spacetime event, asserted nothing of a located attribute that the resolution denies, and nothing is contradicted. What a later Aethus can contradict is a claim about a located attribute. An interference pattern recorded in an Aethus implies, for every child, that the which-slit attribute X_t, at the spacetime event t of the passage through the slits, stood in irreducible agreeing superposition, so every child carries the irreducibility peg for X_t. A finding, in a child later in Aethic time, that X_t was determinate narrows X_t below that filling, and is a real contradiction: it concerns the attribute at the spacetime event t, and it is landed in that child, which is invalid (Definition 11).

The weights of the extrinsic layer (Section 4.3) enter the same way. The bare unweighted Aethus at a given Aethic time holds its cases in unresolved agreeing superposition, and the actual Aethus is obtained by multiplying that whole Aethus by a Nexus, which sets the weight of each case. The Nexus is system-arbitrary; the Quantum Nexus is one instance of it.

Definition 12 (Enforced splitting)
Let X be an attribute and $B_1, \dots, B_k$ blocks that partition its pegs. The carving *c of X into these blocks is the family of declarations*

$$D_c \;=\; \big\{\, \{[X : f]\} \;:\; \varnothing \neq f \subseteq \mathrm{pegs}(X),\ f \textit{ meets two or more blocks} \,\big\},$$

each declaring invalid the agreeing superposition over f wherever it is realized, a content realizing *the agreeing superposition over f when it holds the state $[X : f]$ and its filling of X (Definition 10) is f. The* settings *of c are the states $c_j = [X : B_j]$. A carving is therefore a family of declarations of the relation structure (Definition 9) and not a second kind of rule: the rulebook has one kind of rule, declared joint invalidity, held at the two scopes of Definition 4, and a carving is carried; its settings are*

states, not rules. A content holds *the carving c when it holds it as an item, written c and standing for D_c, which puts D_c in force for that content, and $R \cup \{c\}$ is R carrying D_c. A carving that a content holds is* enforced *by the splitting rule of closure (Definition 10): whatever every setting derives, the content derives. Every attribute X has its* single-peg carving c_X*, the carving into single pegs, whose declarations invalidate every agreeing superposition over two or more pegs of X and whose settings are the determinate states of X. Semantic mining makes each determinate state $[X : \{x\}]$ entail c_X, and the entailment is conservative: a content holding $[X : \{x\}]$ has filling $\{x\}$ or $\varnothing$ on X, by narrowing, so it realizes no agreeing superposition over two or more pegs of X and the declarations of c_X never fire on it, while splitting under c_X adds nothing, its one valid setting being the state already held.*

Proposition 8 (The enforced identity)
For a representation R and a carving c with settings $c_1, \ldots, c_k$,

$$[R \cup \{c\}] \;=\; \mathrm{core}\Big(\sum_{j=1}^{k} [R \cup \{c, c_j\}]\Big) :$$

the Aethus of R with the carving asserts exactly what its carved refinements share, their sum keeping each refinement as a term, invalid ones included.

Proof
Write $\Gamma = R \cup \{c\}$. The core on the right has content $\bigcap_j \mathrm{Cl}(\Gamma \cup \{c_j\})$, an invalid branch contributing the content it has. Monotonicity puts $\mathrm{Cl}(\Gamma)$ inside each $\mathrm{Cl}(\Gamma \cup \{c_j\})$, hence inside the intersection. Conversely, Γ holds c, so splitting licenses from Γ every item derivable from each $\Gamma \cup \{c_j\}$. The two contents coincide, and Aethae whose closures coincide are one Aethus (Definition 8).

Rendering the sum to the validity quotient deletes its invalid refinements, and the core of what remains holds everything the valid refinements share: that is where reasoning by cases completes.
The enforced equivalence is what lets a representation jump during the construction of its Aethus. The representation itself is never split: splitting imports the refined representations, one for each setting of the carving, and keeps what they all share, which is their union (Proposition 8). The division of labor is exact. The fundamental theorem enforces the new constraint in the representation itself, and by adding invalidity pathways it augments the existing relation structure; the third postulate, from which with the second the theorem is derived, is a recursive statement of validity on weighted Aethae, and neither sees the jump. The jump belongs to closure's splitting rule, licensed by the carving, and Aethic equivalence remains the identity of closures (Definition 8).

Carving by records, and the default reading. Elimination, which leaves an attribute's filling agreeing without asserting it, shows what semantic mining adds. Let Y be the color of a car, with pegs r, b, and g, and let s be a peg of another attribute D jointly invalid with g. From $[D : \{s\}]$, propagation excludes g from Y and leaves it filled by r and b: an agreeing superposition in the broad sense (Definition 11), read off the content rather than asserted in it. Semantic mining does not leave it standing. A car holds records of its color, so were Y in irreducible agreeing superposition at a spacetime event t, a later Aethus could deduce from those records that the car had a single color at t, and the contradiction, about the car's color at the spacetime event t, would be landed in that later Aethus. The fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning (Section 8), triggered through the third postulate, therefore adds, by deduction, a state asserting that Y holds a single peg. That state carves Y into single pegs (Definition 12), and splitting constructs the Aethus as the Aethic union of its one-peg children (Proposition 8), $[Y : \{r\}] + [Y : \{b\}] + [Y : \{g\}]$, each carrying the whole representation. The intersection with s invalidates the third, and the Valid Union Principle of Section 3.4.3 drops it.

By default, then, a claim that an attribute is not in agreeing superposition is made of the representation in which its carving has been cashed out by the enforced splitting. Agreeing superposition without qualification is left to attributes that no record carves, which is what leaves actual quantum effects as the clean logical edge cases. The same reading is why an Aethus that holds its case Aethae in superposition, as in the paragraph on Aethic time above, is rightly called an agreeing superposition. An Aethus is located at no spacetime event, so there is nowhere to stand to contradict it and no way to lock in a contradiction of a located attribute: no carving applies, and there is nothing left to cash out.

Dependency, composites, and reopening. A declaration $\{a, \neg b\}$ of the constraint layer, with $\neg b$ the other peg of a two-peg attribute, forces any representation determinate at a to fill that attribute

at b. This is *written* $a \to b$, and a is a *support* of b; causal talk is the reading of such declarations, and joint invalidity is their content (Sections 9.9 and 5.2.2). The joint pegs of two attributes—one peg from each—are pairwise disjoint, so they form an attribute, the composite, whose answer space is the product of its parts', invariant across decompositions: Decomposition Neutrality (Section 3.3.1). Reopening, the counterfactual operation, restores an attribute's filling toward conceptually blank together with the fillings of its supports, and Section 9.2 computes its most striking consequence on the sprinklers ledger.

3.1.1 Statics: the notation that denotes a representation

The hierarchy above is the axiomatic root, and the older static-Aethus notation is kept beside it in one fixed role: a *static* is a written object that *denotes* a representation together with the constraint-layer declarations written with it, and nothing else. The name is shortened on purpose, since "static Aethus" invites confusion with an Aethus proper and "representation" has too many syllables to catch on in use; where brevity is wanted the representation a static denotes is its *repre*.[71] The notation has two primitives and no others: the *Aethic blank*, written $\square$, and the *Aethic false*, written F, which is not logical falsehood but the mark of joint invalidity, the constraint layer's own relation (Definition 4). Every blank is the same primitive, as every occurrence of a number is the same number; what differs between occurrences is only the attribute it is written against, whose full peg set it names.

Definition 13 (Draw static)
Fix a finite family of attributes $X_1, \dots, X_n$ with finite peg sets. A draw static *S is a finite list of entries of two kinds. An* attribute entry *$X_i \mapsto f$ assigns a nonempty set $f \subseteq \mathrm{pegs}(X_i)$, at most one per attribute, with $X_i \mapsto \square$ meaning $f = \mathrm{pegs}(X_i)$ and an attribute without an entry read as blank; it writes the state $[X_i : f]$ of Definition 6, determinate when f is a single peg and the bare filling when f is the whole peg set. A* constraint entry *$(g_1, \dots, g_k) \mapsto \mathsf{F}$ names a finite set of pegs and states, each g_j a peg or a state $[X : f]$ read as the agreeing superposition over f, and declares that set jointly invalid, adding it to the constraint layer; a two-element set of pegs is a disjointness declaration, a set of pegs*

[71] *2026-10-02, 2:38 PM*

Note that I just had a few more ideas for the new 2026 Aethic formalization: So basically the idea is that since I find the earlier static Aethus so to speak notation, as uses Aethic blanks, so vastly more intuitive than the actual pegs and states formalism (in that static Aethae themselves were inspired to me by object oriented design and stuff), then why the heck not still enforce the pegs and states formalism as the axiomatic root as it should be, but then literally ALSO allow the notation of the static Aethus system simply for constructing notationally what is taken to denote the pegs and states structure as the actual abstract structure! So here's my proposal: first of all since "representation" is already a bit too many syllables to really catch on, and since "static Aethus" runs the risk of being confused with an Aethus proper, let's simply change the name of static Aethus to "static", and then give it several sub-types! So we can have a "draw static" to mean that which you actually physically write with/visually notationally encode things with, being the most concrete layer. The way you write one of these is as a mapping from explicitly attributes to pegs, such that in the actual resultant "state structure" (ie the actual underlying pegs/state structure which you are denoting) constructs the included pegs based on what is implied Aethically blank by your draw static, and the disallowed pegs based on the relation/invalidity structure contained in your draw static! Then a "closed static" is one which is assumed to denote the closure of a given state structure, (or more specifically is its own closure), so since you can't physically write a closed static due to it being too large, writing Cl(your given draw static) assumes the object is still of type static like a draw static is, but then you have that the state structure conversion of the closure of a static is equivalent to the closure of the state structure conversion of the given static! So yeah also rather than naming it state structure, I suppose THIS can be called a representation maybe, or at least a "repre" for short if that doesn't sound too stupid lol! So a static is always assumed to merely DENOTE a repre, and a repre is that which closes to construct an Aethus, thereby in turn meaning a static itself can be mapped to an Aethus I suppose! And yeah per my original OOD-inspired intuition for statics, right, is that you write them by either mapping attributes to pegs OR by I suppose mapping a "conditional attribute" to the false primitive so as to encode relation structure invalidity of a given joint pegs object, (since in the current version of Aethic reasoning we don't want true and false to be primitives anyway, thereby meaning we want to drop the requirement of using them for constraint attributes in a static!). So yeah the two fundamental primitives are therefore the Aethic blank and the Aethic false (not to be confused with logical false), such that in their being primitives every Aethic blank is assumed equivalent to every other Aethic blank by stipulation, like what a number is abstractly, and then we get heuristically (to actually be formalized though) that Aethic blanks denote/give the superpositions in a repre state while Aethic falses denote/give the false structure of pegs in a given state, unless I'm mistaken on the simplicity of that anyway! Anyways thanks!

4:44 PM

Ah yes, thank you--the carving itself in my mind is a further Aethic condition attribute ie Aethic false mapping--as in, as I imagine it by explicitly stating a given agreeing superposition (or could be just an agreeing superposition of one state, of course) is invalid per an Aethic false mapping, only that alone satisfies the third postulate of the Aethus assignment for which the proper child Aethus realizing that particular agreeing superposition is invalid--so the idea is that this exactly is how asserting the third postulate as an axiom of the framework makes a difference, because without it exactly such carving constraints could still be in the Aethic structure, but they just wouldn't be SELECTED per se, is the idea! Thanks!

on distinct attributes a joint peg object, and a single state $[X : f]$ *the declaration that that agreeing superposition is invalid. The* repre *of* S *is the representation* $\mathrm{repre}(S) = \{[X_i : f] : X_i \mapsto f \text{ in } S\}$*, and the* closure *of* S *is* $\mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{repre}(S))$ *computed with the constraint layer augmented by* S*'s constraint entries.*

So the blank primitive writes fillings and the false primitive writes joint invalidities, which are the two kinds of content the construction has: a state says which pegs are on the table, a constraint-layer declaration says which combinations are forbidden, and nothing else is written anywhere. Every representation holding at most one state per attribute is written exactly by a draw static, and every finite constraint-layer declaration is written by a constraint entry; the denotation is not one-to-one, an attribute entry $X \mapsto \{p\}$ writing the same closure as $X \mapsto \square$ together with a constraint entry on each other peg of X, and that freedom is the notation's economy rather than a defect.

Carvings and irreducibility as false-entries. The regime content is written with the same two primitives, because a constraint entry may name a state. A *carving* of X into blocks $B_1, \ldots, B_k$ (Definition 12) is the family of constraint entries $[X : f] \mapsto \mathsf{F}$ for every filling f meeting two or more blocks, each invalidating the agreeing superposition over f wherever it is realized, which is the third-postulate clause above in notation, the invalidation of every filling spanning two of the separated classes; the carving into single pegs is the case of singleton blocks, the entry $[X : \mathrm{pegs}(X)] \mapsto \mathsf{F}$ among the family. *Irreducibility* on a block, the marker e_{B_j} of Definition 11, is the family $[X : f] \mapsto \mathsf{F}$ for every nonempty proper sub-filling f of the block, the second-postulate clause in notation. A blank with no such entries is a bare filling, neither agreeing nor disagreeing until one is written, which is the reading of regimes as content; and by Definition 12 a carving is itself a carried family of declarations of the relation structure, so the rulebook has one kind of rule. The third postulate is what makes these entries operative rather than merely present. It assigns validity through declared descent, a valid Aethus having a declared child all of whose declared children are valid; when the entry $[X : f] \mapsto \mathsf{F}$ tags the proper child realizing the agreeing superposition over f, validity of the parent can run only through the children in which X is carved to a block, which is the enforced identity of Proposition 8, and the split is *selected*. Without the third postulate as an axiom the same entries could stand in the constraint layer and select nothing: that is the exact difference the postulate makes.

Definition 14 (Closed static, and closure on statics)
A static S *is* closed *when its repre already holds every state its closure derives: every state of* $\mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{repre}(S))$ *lies in* $\mathrm{repre}(S)$*. For a draw static* S *the expression* $\mathrm{Cl}(S)$ *is an object of type static, the draw static whose attribute entries write the states of* $\mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{repre}(S))$*, one per attribute at the narrowest filling derived, and whose constraint entries are those of* S *together with every finite set the closure derives as jointly invalid.*

Proposition 9 (Closure commutes with denotation)
For every draw static S *over finitely many attributes with finite peg sets,* $\mathrm{Cl}(S)$ *is closed,* $\mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{repre}(\mathrm{Cl}(S))) = \mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{repre}(S))$*, and* S *and* $\mathrm{Cl}(S)$ *denote the same Aethus,* $[\mathrm{repre}(\mathrm{Cl}(S))] = [\mathrm{repre}(S)]$*. A static therefore denotes an Aethus, the equivalence class of its repre, and two statics denote the same Aethus exactly when their closures coincide.*

Proof
$\mathrm{repre}(\mathrm{Cl}(S))$ *consists of states of* $\mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{repre}(S))$*, and* $\mathrm{repre}(S) \subseteq \mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{repre}(S))$ *by extensivity (Proposition 4), so each of the two representations lies in the closure of the other, and the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence (Theorem 1) gives* $[\mathrm{repre}(\mathrm{Cl}(S))] = [\mathrm{repre}(S)]$*, which is the equality of closures. Idempotence then gives that every state derived from* $\mathrm{repre}(\mathrm{Cl}(S))$ *is a state of* $\mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{repre}(S))$*, already written in* $\mathrm{Cl}(S)$*, so* $\mathrm{Cl}(S)$ *is closed. The last claim is the definition of the Aethus as the closure class (Definition 8).*

What the proposition establishes is a licence: one may write with statics throughout, closed statics included, while the axiomatic root stays the hierarchy of pegs, states and representations, because every static denotes a representation, closure on statics is closure on what they denote, and the Aethus a static names is the class of its repre. What it does not establish is a syntactic closure: $\mathrm{Cl}(S)$ is obtained through the closure of the representation, not by a rewriting rule on the entries of S, and a rule that adds the entries closure forces and provably denotes the same repre is the part left to be formalized, together with the identification of a draw static's two kinds of entry with the carriers and tags of the weighted development of Section 4, where the fillings are the carriers and the constraint entries the tags.

3.2 The Intrinsic Layer: Refinement, Meet, and Join

The foundations of Section 3.1 define an Aethus as an equivalence class of representations under closure. This subsection builds the order and the two operations on Aethae from that definition alone, using only that closure is extensive, monotone, idempotent, and non-weakening. Weighting is not used.

Definition 15 (Refinement)
An Aethus A refines *an Aethus B, and B is an* ancestor *of A, when $\mathrm{C}(B) \subseteq \mathrm{C}(A)$: the refinement carries all the content of its ancestor and possibly more.*

Proposition 10 (Closed contents are closed under intersection)
If $\mathrm{Cl}(C) = C$ and $\mathrm{Cl}(D) = D$, then $\mathrm{Cl}(C \cap D) = C \cap D$.

Proof
By monotonicity $\mathrm{Cl}(C \cap D) \subseteq \mathrm{Cl}(C) = C$ and likewise $\subseteq D$, so $\mathrm{Cl}(C \cap D) \subseteq C \cap D$; extensivity gives the reverse inclusion.

Proposition 11 (The meet)
For any representations R_A of A and R_B of B, $\mathrm{Cl}(R_A \cup R_B) = \mathrm{Cl}(\mathrm{C}(A) \cup \mathrm{C}(B))$. The Aethus it defines, the Aethic intersection $A \cdot B$, is the least common descendant of A and B: it refines both, and every common refinement of A and B refines it.

Proof
Since $R_A \subseteq \mathrm{C}(A)$ and $R_B \subseteq \mathrm{C}(B)$, monotonicity gives $\subseteq$. Conversely $\mathrm{C}(A) = \mathrm{Cl}(R_A) \subseteq \mathrm{Cl}(R_A \cup R_B)$, and likewise for B, so applying closure and idempotence gives $\supseteq$. The content contains $\mathrm{C}(A)$ and $\mathrm{C}(B)$, so $A \cdot B$ refines both; and a common refinement D has $\mathrm{C}(D) \supseteq \mathrm{C}(A) \cup \mathrm{C}(B)$, hence $\mathrm{C}(D) \supseteq \mathrm{C}(A \cdot B)$ by closure.

The meet can therefore be formed from states alone, at whatever representations are to hand. It may be invalid: the meet of two valid Aethae that fill an attribute with disjoint pegs is invalid, tagged by the empty filling of that attribute, and it keeps the rest of both contents.

Proposition 12 (The join)
$\mathrm{C}(A) \cap \mathrm{C}(B)$ is closed, and the Aethus it defines, the core of the Aethic union $A + B$, is the last common ancestor of A and B: it is an ancestor of both, and every common ancestor of A and B is an ancestor of it.

Proof
Closedness is Proposition 10. The content is contained in $\mathrm{C}(A)$ and in $\mathrm{C}(B)$, so the core is an ancestor of both; a common ancestor E has $\mathrm{C}(E) \subseteq \mathrm{C}(A) \cap \mathrm{C}(B)$.

The join, unlike the meet, must be taken on canonical contents, because intersecting arbitrary representations depends on the representations chosen. In the sprinklers ledger of Section 9.2.1, let A be determinate at s, so that its closure also fills Y at y, and let B be determinate at y alone. Representing A by $\{[\mathsf{S} : \{s\}]\}$ and B by $\{[\mathsf{Y} : \{y\}]\}$, the representations share nothing; representing A instead by $\{[\mathsf{S} : \{s\}], [\mathsf{Y} : \{y\}]\}$, an equivalent representation, they share $[\mathsf{Y} : \{y\}]$. The canonical contents settle the matter: both contain $[\mathsf{Y} : \{y\}]$, and so does the core of $A + B$.

Invalid terms and rendering. An invalid Aethus is an Aethus like any other: it is tagged by an empty filling and keeps the rest of its content, so two invalid Aethae are distinct unless each derives the other (Theorem 1), and a sum keeps its invalid terms. They are part of the Aethus, and they distinguish it from a sum without them. The *validity quotient* is where they are dropped: it deletes the invalid terms of every sum, identifying each invalid Aethus with the additive identity, the empty sum, whose core holds every item. Deletion commutes with the sum and with joint assertion, since an invalid term contributes only invalid products, so the quotient is a congruence and rendering can be left to the end. Reasoning keeps the invalid terms, and with them the structure they carry, and renders to the quotient for actual probability: the Aethus's own weights, the hyperrealized ones, stay on the full sum, while formal Bayesian conditional probability is valued over the quotient (Section 4.7.2). The Valid Union Principle of Section 3.4.3, by which a union keeps only its valid members, is the quotient's rule.

The lattice. Under refinement the Aethae form a lattice, with the meet as its meet and the core of the sum as its join. Its top is the Aethus of the empty representation, which states nothing and leaves every attribute conceptually blank, and its bottom is the Aethus whose content holds every item; the invalid Aethae lie above it, distinct from one another. The lattice is not a tree. Two independent attributes X and Y give a diamond: the top has the two children determinate at a peg of X and at a peg of Y respectively, and their meet, determinate at both, has two incomparable parents. What the framework calls the Aethic tree is the picture drawn from a chosen root, not the shape of the whole order. Agreement lives inside this layer, in the states themselves: an agreeing superposition is a state in the content of an Aethus, while a disagreeing one is weighted, its unweighted shadow a sum whose core is a join (Proposition 5; Section 4.3).

Proper children. An Aethus B is a *proper child* of A when it can union to A: when the core of $B + C$ is A for some Aethus C.

Proposition 13 (Unweighted proper childhood degenerates to refinement)
In the unweighted layer, where a proper child is an Aethus that can union to its parent, B is a proper child of A if and only if B refines A. In particular, every Aethus is a proper child of itself, and the Aethus whose content holds every item is a proper child of every Aethus. This is why the relation the third postulate quantifies over is the weighted one, Definition 36, whose comparative weight condition the unweighted layer cannot express.

Proof
If the core of $B + C$ is A, then $\mathrm{C}(A) = \mathrm{C}(B) \cap \mathrm{C}(C) \subseteq \mathrm{C}(B)$ (Proposition 12), so B refines A. Conversely, if B refines A, then $\mathrm{C}(A) \subseteq \mathrm{C}(B)$, so $\mathrm{C}(B) \cap \mathrm{C}(A) = \mathrm{C}(A)$ and the core of $B + A$ is A. The Aethus whose content holds every item refines every Aethus.

In the unweighted layer, then, the two ways of being a child coincide. The multiplicative way, reaching B from A by joint assertion, $B = A \cdot B$, and the additive way, unioning B back to A, are both the refinement order. They come apart only once weights are attached: there a proper child is a refinement of its parent that is a term of a weighted combination at its full weight, able to *add* back to the parent (Definition 36), refinement alone not making one, and the third postulate, stated over proper children, is accordingly a construction on weighted Aethae. It has to be: over unweighted proper childhood the postulate's quantifier would reach, from every Aethus, the Aethus whose content holds every item, which is invalid, and nothing would be valid; over proper children in the weighted sense that Aethus is a proper child of x only if it is a term of x whose coefficient is not measure-zero relative to the rest.

Proposition 14 (Meets distribute over carved unions)
Let A be an Aethus and c a carving with settings $c_1, \ldots, c_k$. Then $A \cdot [\{c\}] = \mathrm{core}\big(\sum_j A \cdot [\{c, c_j\}]\big)$. In particular, for any pegs $x_1, \ldots, x_m$ of one attribute X,

$$A \cdot \mathrm{core}\Big(\sum_{i=1}^{m} [X : \{x_i\}]\Big) \;=\; \mathrm{core}\Big(\sum_{i=1}^{m} A \cdot [X : \{x_i\}]\Big).$$

Proof
For a representation R_A of A, the meets are the Aethae of $R_A \cup \{c\}$ and of $R_A \cup \{c, c_j\}$ (Proposition 11), so the first identity is the enforced identity (Proposition 8) applied to R_A. For the second, write U for the core of the sum. Each $[X : \{x_i\}]$ holds the single-peg carving c_X (Definition 12) and excludes every other peg of X, so U holds c_X and excludes every peg outside $\{x_1, \ldots, x_m\}$. In $A \cdot U$, splitting on c_X therefore leaves one branch for each x_i, and that branch has the content of $A \cdot [X : \{x_i\}]$, because U is an ancestor of $[X : \{x_i\}]$; the settings at excluded pegs are invalid branches in which every peg of X is excluded, so elimination licenses every determinate state of X there and they hold whatever the other branches hold. Splitting puts the items common to these branches into $A \cdot U$, and monotonicity gives the reverse inclusion.

Joint assertion distributes over the Aethic union itself exactly, term by term; the question is whether it distributes over cores. It does wherever case analysis is licensed: over determinate alternatives, whose core keeps the single-peg carving they share, and over any carving that records assert. Elsewhere it can fail, and at an irreducible superposition it does. Let A hold an irreducible agreeing superposition $[X : \{a, b, c\}]$ (Definition 11). Then $A \cdot [X : \{a, b\}]$ and $A \cdot [X : \{c\}]$ are both invalid; but the core of $[X : \{a, b\}] + [X : \{c\}]$ holds nothing on X, since its first term is agreeing and holds no carving, so its

meet with A is A itself. One cannot reason by cases over a superposition that no record has carved. The failure belongs to the core and not to the composition: as a sum, $A \cdot ([X : \{a, b\}] + [X : \{c\}])$ is $A \cdot [X : \{a, b\}] + A \cdot [X : \{c\}]$, both of its terms invalid. The non-distributive join of quantum logic [81] thus has an Aethic form, located by a criterion, a core distributes when a carving separates its terms; and it is obtained with no connective revised, the non-classicality living in what the terms state rather than in how they compose.

Aethae and pegs. Composition and linkage connect the two ends of the ladder (Definition 10): composition ties a composite to its components, and linkage lets Aethae serve as pegs. Let $A_1, \ldots, A_k$ be Aethae with $A_i \cdot A_j$ invalid for $i \neq j$. They are taken as the pegs $\xi_1, \ldots, \xi_k$ of an attribute Ξ, pairwise disjoint as pegs must be, and linkage ties each ξ_i to its Aethus.

Theorem 2 (Aethus–Peg Equivalence)
For every representation R:

(i) an Aethus determinate on $X_1, \ldots, X_n$ at $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ is the Aethus of one peg of their composite, $[R \cup \{[X_1 : \{x_1\}], \ldots, [X_n : \{x_n\}]\}] = [R \cup \{[X_1 \wedge \cdots \wedge X_n : \{(x_1, \ldots, x_n)\}]\}]$;

(ii) holding a peg of Ξ is holding its Aethus, $[R \cup \{[\Xi : \{\xi_i\}]\}] = [R] \cdot A_i$.

Proof
(i) Combination licenses $[X_1 \wedge \cdots \wedge X_n : \{(x_1, \ldots, x_n)\}]$ from the states $[X_j : \{x_j\}]$, and projection licenses each $[X_j : \{x_j\}]$ back from it, so each representation derives the other, and by the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence (Theorem 1) they present one Aethus. (ii) Holding ξ_i licenses every item of $\mathrm{C}(A_i)$, and holding a representation R_i of A_i licenses $[\Xi : \{\xi_i\}]$; so $R \cup \{[\Xi : \{\xi_i\}]\}$ and $R \cup R_i$ derive each other and so have one closure (Theorem 1), the content of $[R] \cdot A_i$ (Proposition 11).

Part (i) is what Decomposition Neutrality asks of an Aethus (Principle 19): an Aethus determinate on its attributes is one peg of their composite, so each of its presentations presents that one peg, and whatever holds of a state across its decompositions holds of the Aethus. Part (ii) runs the equivalence the other way, and it is the reason for it. Aethae can be the pegs from which attributes are built, and a state on such an attribute is a state like any other: $[\Xi : \{\xi_1, \xi_2\}]$ holds the Aethae A_1 and A_2 in agreeing superposition, and Ξ left conceptually blank holds all of them so. The second postulate, stated for attributes and their pegs, therefore runs over Aethae unchanged, and Aethic superposition is not confined to the quantum case: any unresolved choice among disjoint Aethae is one, as the cases of an Aethus are at a given Aethic time. Linkage carries an Aethus's whole content across, its agreeing states included, so the equivalence holds for every Aethus, not only for those given by determinate states.

The algebra of this section was at work in the framework before its vocabulary was.[72][73][74]

[72]One feature of the May 2023 statement of this framework is easy to miss if it is read only through the terminology its author had at the time: the Aethus was already being manipulated algebraically before the standard names for the relevant algebra were known to him. (see the next footnote) That is partly a first-person claim, and the first-person part is graded below as what it is; but it is not only one, because the 2023 manuscript records several pieces of the later intrinsic structure directly, in its own vocabulary, and uses them.

The child relation was already reflexive and transitive in substance. The 2023 text observes that a child of a child is a direct child of the original Aethus, because two successive rounds of property addition can be wrapped, in its word, into one allowed addition; and it separately permits an Aethus to count as its own child by adjoining an empty property. In the present notation, the relation was therefore already being used as $A \sqsubseteq A$ and as $C \sqsubseteq B,\ B \sqsubseteq A \Rightarrow C \sqsubseteq A$—reflexivity by the empty addition, transitivity by composing two additions into one, which in the framework's operations is the statement that $(A \cap B_1) \cap B_2$ is the same child as $A \cap (B_1 \cap B_2)$. The manuscript did not call that associativity of an information-combination operation. It said that both generations of property addition can be wrapped into one property, and used the fact as an obvious manipulation, which is exactly the phenomenon this subsubsection records: an algebraic law in use as a routine step, without its name.

The third postulate is formulated over exactly this structure. The postulate's two-quantifier form ranges over a child Aethus and then over that child's further children, and the 2023 argument for it works precisely because the refinements compose: a further child of a child is in the descendant cone of the original, so the sweep over "however far" is well defined. What later papers call descendant closure was therefore not supplied afterward to repair the 2023 rule; it was part of the rule's original operational meaning. The reflexive, transitive refinement relation of Definition 15 is the 2023 child relation under its own name, and the two-quantifier $\exists\forall$ form of the fixed-point lemma below is the 2023 form exactly.

The operations were named from set and probability intuitions rather than from algebra. The working vocabulary called the operation in the child direction *intersection*, since adding content narrows, and called the broadening operation *concatenation*, since removing distinctions concatenates the disagreeing superpositions that retrieval then displays; the words *ring*, *group*, *semiring*, *preorder*, and *closure* were not part of the equipment, and the structure was accordingly not recognized as an instance of an established species. The same vocabulary already carried the distinction that Propositions 11 and 12 establish: that intersection can be computed on representations while concatenation needs the full abstract Aethus, which is the statement that joint assertion is representation-level and informational union is the last common ancestor in the quotient. And the closure of representations under equivalence—that two stated-attribute sets with the same closure are one Aethus—dates to the attribute sets of December 2021; what the August 2022 epiphany added was the extension of that closure to disagreeing superpositions as blanks, the October 2023 presentation then drawing the interface explicitly: a blank retrieves to superposition, while a contradiction physically encodes every state at once in the Aethus, which is the abstract structure's contact with realized verdicts on states and modality.

The weighted side has an independent early trace, and the trace records where the weights lived. By the October 2023 presentation, probability is stated to happen relative to an Aethus; a Nexus is defined as what determines, for any Aethus, an array of probabilities for the updated Aethae reachable from it; a descent down the Aethic tree multiplies the transition probabilities of its steps; mutually exclusive routes are added; and the tree traversed under pure randomness is called the weighted passage of the null Nexus. The placement should be stated exactly, because it is a distinction the 2023 picture drew and a looser phrasing would erase. (see the footnote after that) In 2023 the Aethus proper was the *unweighted* qualitative information structure—what is stated, blank, contradictory, superposed, refined—and the Nexus was different in kind: a rule assigning to an Aethus a probability scheme over its possible unfoldings, $N : A \mapsto \{(A_i, p_i)\}_i$. Probability belonged to the transition structure, not to the state; sequential Nexae multiplied and exclusive routes added, so the two operations from which a semiring is later built were already present, but on the transitions. That is the *transition-centered* representation of a stochastic system, a state with a kernel. It is not yet weighted Aethae, and to say "weighted Aethae in 2023" would misdescribe the record.

Development was not monotonic, and the weights moved twice. The 2024 attempts to make the framework conventionally presentable lost both the concatenation intuition and the intrinsic relation between probability and Aethic unfolding—a compression bottleneck, not a step from less formal to more. Then in 2025 the representation changed rather than merely recovering: probability was folded into the represented state as an *initial condition* of the Aethic Markovian process, so that weighted Aethae—not unweighted Aethae acted on by probabilistic Nexae—became the effective units of the graph, the evolution acting on $\sum_i p_i A_i$ rather than issuing it from a bare A_0. That is the *distribution-centered* representation, a measure over states with an evolution operator, dual to the 2023 one. The 2026 two-layer algebra of subsection 4.7 then reconciles the two rather than replacing either: the intrinsic carrier U remains the unweighted Aethic structure of 2023, and the extrinsic carrier $M[U]$ is the weighted combinations of 2025, with probability participating algebraically without any naked Aethus being intrinsically "thirty percent real." The arc, dated: 2021, the closure and equivalence machinery of attribute sets; 2022, Aethic blanks and state-relative superposition; 2023, unweighted Aethae with probabilistic Nexae; 2024, presentational narrowing; 2025, probability folded into the state as an initial distribution over weighted Aethae; 2026, the explicit intrinsic/extrinsic split. What developed across it was not an additional entity but the answer to one question, asked repeatedly—which mathematical object the structure should live on—and the pattern is the framework's general one: alternatives moved from timelines to information states, determinacy from facts to fact–state pairs, probability from external possibilities to Nexic transitions to distributions over states, and counterfactual similarity from world orderings to internal perturbation structure. A later date on a clean definition should

The earlier tree relations. An earlier presentation of these relations built parents, children and siblings from the resolution of blanks, and derived a Fundamental Identity of Proper Child Aethae to characterize proper childhood. The definitions above supersede it: a proper child is an Aethus that can union to its parent, which the universe set makes a definition rather than a theorem to be derived.

3.2.1 The Notion of Aethic Time

Status. In the peg formalism Aethic time runs in the child direction: the Aethus at a later Aethic time refines the Aethus at an earlier one, as the Aethic-time paragraph of Section 3.1 sets out, and the containment written below, of the earlier Aethus's alternatives over the later's, is that refinement.

As is given by our prior property of Aethic extrusion, it would be beneficial to define a system of actually logging how oneself moves through the Aethic dimension, (as, after all, we supposed that oneself requires motion in the Aethic dimension as well as through spacetime in order to accurately bring about our reality).

Given this, consider a possible descriptive agent for one's own displacement through the Aethic dimension, (thus being strictly non-inclusive of spacetime movement along a worldline or whatnot). We will refer to this as *Aethic time*.

Definition 16 (Aethic Time)
Any real-numbered parametrization of the Aethic dimension can be regarded as being a system of Aethic

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therefore not be read as the date its structural intuition first appeared. One instance is worth recording forensically because it is checkable: an extraction of 2026 briefly narrowed the 2023 child relation by reading "proper child" through the conventional connotation of strict descent, which the source formalism never had—the 2023 manuscript explicitly permits reflexivity and explicitly composes descendants transitively—and the mature formulation restores the original relation. Formalization can introduce a regression by importing connotations from standard terminology that the source structure did not possess.

Evidentiary grade. The reflexive and transitive child structure, and the two-quantifier use of it, are directly documented in the May 2023 manuscript. The probabilistically weighted Aethic tree, with the weights on the Nexic transitions and the Aethae unweighted, is directly documented in the October 2023 presentation, as is the blank-against-contradiction interface; the 2025 folding of probability into the state is documented in that year's formalization drafts. The claim that these pieces were already experienced as one unified algebraic object by May 2023, and that most of the intrinsic side was in hand by August 2022, is first-person reconstruction where the surviving sources do not state it in those later mathematical terms. The historical claim, stated at the strength the documents support, is not that the modern semiring theorems had been written down or proved in 2023—their later statement adds explicit hypotheses, separates unweighted state union from weighted addition, and settles the carrier level at which closure holds, all of which the 2026 formalization had to do for a reason. It is that the intrinsic operations and refinement behavior those theorems formalize were already functioning in the source theory and doing substantive work in its arguments. Structure first; species-name and proof obligations later.

[73] *September 19, 2026*

Right, but also I wish I could capture how I already had the full intuition for the algebraic structure of an Aethus by May 2023, and I had most of it by August 2022, although it maybe doesn't read that way because I reinvented so much algebra, and so didn't have the terminology. I literally had never heard of a "ring" or a "group" kind of thing, but I was making highly subtle arguments about how multiplying Aethus A by B1 and then B2 to make child Aethae is equivalent to the one child Aethus of doing B1 B2. I just referred to such multiplication as "intersection" and the union as "concatenation" because it expands the disagreeing superpositions! But yeah transitivity and reflexivity was not only known to me but obvious, as well as everything at least on the intrinsic/unweighted side of the Aethic tree paper, such as closure and how intersection is doable through representations but concatenation needs the full abstract Aethus. (And yeah the closure of representaton thing dates all the way back to December 2021 with the attribute sets, just I neede the August 2022 epiphany to extend that to disagreeing superpositions as blanks--but note that in the October 2023 video I even talked about the difference between Aethic blanks as retrieving to superposition while contradictions physically encode all states in an Aethus, which shows clear comprehension of the interface between the abstract structure and the realized real-world verdicts on states and modality). Also I actually had a more sophisticated weighed Aethus intuition in 2023 than in 2024, when I weirdly lost some of it while tying to write a presentable formalization, but yeah in 2023 I considered probability as intrinsic to Aethic concatenations already, although I was admittedly far from knowing how to formalize that since I didn't know about semirings yet! Anyways, how would you recommend I update the genealogy webpage with this extra claim? Also to be clear I even think it itself supports my having known the algebraic structure of an Aethus that, like, how on Earth could I have formalized the postulates anyway without it??? Even for the third postulate, the form you recognized about jumping to any descendent and then sweeping however far to another for the third postulate IS the 2023 version precisely, because I found transitivity of child Aethus obvious per that combo intersection property. It's just that the Claude Fable extraction papers assumed so reflexivity or transitivity arbitrarily, probably because "proper child" makes people think "not reflexive" or something!!!

[74] *September 19, 2026, later*

By the way to be clear, I would also put it like that in October 2023, I viewed Aethae more as unweighted and Nexae as like assigning a probability scheme of unfolding to them, whereas in 2024 I lost the concatenation and probability intuition but in 2025 I moved to formalize Nexae/probability as actually an initial condition in the starting Aethic Markovian process, via weighted Aethae being the units in the graph as opposed to unweighted Aethae proper. See what I mean? Thanks!

time, that is given that it satisfies one major condition:

$$\tau_0 \leq \tau_1 \Leftrightarrow A_T(\tau_0) \supseteq A_T(\tau_1) \tag{3}$$

That is, given two Aethic times of τ_0 and τ_1 of the same system, with $\tau_0 \leq \tau_1$, we have that this must mean that the corresponding system's mapping, A_T from an Aethic time to the Aethic dimension, (as is characteristic of the given Aethic time system), follows the property that the mapped Aethus of τ_0 must be a parent[75] *Aethus to the mapped Aethus of τ_1. Note that we may also write this in terms of Aethic presence as follows.*

$$\tau_0 \leq \tau_1 \Leftrightarrow A_T(\tau_0) \in A_T(\tau_1) \tag{4}$$

With this being the definition of Aethic time, (which should be thought of as an additional concept from what we typically regard as time), the more standard present definition of time, (being what we see in relativity), can then simply be referred to as "dimensional time" so as to distinguish it from Aethic time, (with Aethic time itself not really being "time," but rather an empirical illusion of it, perhaps).

3.3 Decomposability and the Grades of Blankness

The remainder of this section carries the foundations of Sections 3.1 and 3.2 to the constructions the 2024 development first built on stated attributes and presence. This subsection takes the grades of blankness and the decomposability battery. Section 3.4 takes retrievals, contradictions and the operations, and states the second postulate; Section 3.5 takes the dichotomy and the types of superposition; and Section 3.7 hands the result to the weighted layer. Each construction is derived here from the peg formalism; the 2024 presentations it replaces are recorded in the paper's earlier deposited versions.

3.3.1 Decomposition Neutrality: The Principle Beneath the Equivalence

The principle beneath the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence, (Theorem 1), deserves its own name and its own walkthrough, because it is the oldest commitment in the framework and the one most recently found to be load-bearing. It says that a stated-attribute has no privileged decomposition, and that an Aethus has no privileged static Aethus; under the equivalence these are one statement, and this subsubsection states it as a principle, traces it to its origin, and runs it on the case that made its load visible—the reopening of a conjunctive antecedent in the counterfactual semantics of Section 9.1, where the third postulate's countermodel to Cautious Monotony had been resting on a convention that this principle, given the dual-peg reading of a conjunctive antecedent, turns into a consequence of that reading.

Principle 19 (Decomposition Neutrality)
A stated-attribute is well-defined only without a privileged decomposition: every property it carries as a stated-attribute—presence, the grade of its blankness, its retrieval, and its reopening under perturbation—is invariant across its decomposition set, and a verdict that changes with the decomposition through which it is read is a verdict about that decomposition, not about the stated-attribute. By the Aethus–peg equivalence theorem (Theorem 2) the same holds of an Aethus over its static Aethae: an operation on an Aethus is an operation on the equivalence class, never on one presentation of it.

Origin. The principle is not new equipment; it is the 2021 proto-Aethus stated in the vocabulary the paper has since built. The original object, the Attribute Set, (Section 13.10), was defined by three properties: constructibility from given states; decomposability back into *exclusively any* element from the set of sets of states which generate it; and uniqueness, so that Attribute Sets with the same compositions and decompositions are equivalent.[76] The second and third properties became, in the definitional hierarchy, the *3-Aethus* conditions of Definition 10—every decomposition of a present stated-attribute present, every combination present, every congruent present—and the decomposition set of Section 3.1, whose elements are exactly the sets of stated-attributes whose conjunction is

[75] Yes, this also implies that the symbol of $\supseteq$, in reference to Aethae, stands for "is a parent Aethus to," with $\subseteq$ then being "is a child Aethus to."

[76] The second and third properties, read together, are Decomposition Neutrality in proto form: the second says every generating decomposition is as good as every other—none is the "real" one—and the third says the object is exactly what is invariant across them. The 2021 definition predates the second postulate, the blankness grades, and the perturbation operator, which is why the principle could sit unnamed for five years while doing work at each of those later joints; the ruling that named it, and the reopening case that forced the naming, are the footnote at the close of this subsubsection.

congruent to the given one. At the Aethus level the same commitment surfaced as *privilege Aethae over static Aethae*, (Section 9.4.1): a static Aethus is one list of facts, a coordinate chart for the abstract object, and the object is the equivalence class, never the chart. Under the equivalence theorem the two are one principle at two grains, and this subsubsection uses whichever grain the case at hand makes visible.

What the principle sorts: the three grades of blankness, and whose property they are. Section 3.3.2 distinguishes an attribute's being *directly blank*—not physically encoded, its exact instance in no static Aethus of the Aethus—from its being *conceptually blank*—returning the set of all its possible states on retrieval, the grade the second postulate names when it says blank attributes retrieve in full superposition—with a conceptually blank attribute a special case of a directly blank one. Between them, and inside the directly-blank class, stand the mixed-decompositions of the Aethic dichotomy theorem (Section 3.5.1): a composite attribute some of whose decomposition elements are present and some nonpresent, which is directly blank, (the composite itself sits in no static Aethus), yet definitively *not* conceptually blank, (its present part does not retrieve in superposition). The hierarchy is nested, not competing: directly blank splits into conceptually blank and mixed. Two facts about these grades, both consequences of the principle, decide everything that follows. First, they are *two-place*: state-, mixed-, and blank-decomposability, and the two grades of blankness, are properties of an attribute *relative to* an Aethus, never intrinsic properties of the Aethus—the same Aethus has y state-decomposable, X conceptually blank, and their conjunction mixed, and none of the three is "the Aethus's" status. Second, because no decomposition is privileged, no attribute is privileged by implication: the composite $X \wedge y$ is as much an attribute of the space as X and y are, present whenever they are by the *3-Aethus* conditions, and its status relative to an Aethus is read *of it*, not delegated to a status of one of its conjuncts. This is exactly why the second postulate is written on conceptual blankness and why the dichotomy theorem exists: the postulate cannot read a mixed attribute, so a mixed attribute must be transformed—its present part and its nonpresent part separated—before the postulate applies to either. A mixed status is a status the postulate is never handed directly.

What the principle decides: the reopening of a composite target. The perturbation operator of Section 9.4.1 is composite—a removal landing on a *blank intermediate*, the Aethus in which the target attribute is definitively blank with its supports cleared and its superposition content maximized, followed by the restatement of the antecedent's value—and every perturbation passes through its intermediate; there is no direct jump. The intermediate exists for one purpose: to return the target to *superposition*, so that its alternatives are co-present and the re-pruning has something to prune. By the second postulate, superposition is blankness in the retrieval sense—the attribute returns the set of all its possible states—which is conceptual blankness, and directly blank is strictly weaker. When the antecedent is a conjunction, $X \wedge y$, the target is the composite stated-attribute, and the question that decides the countermodel below is what its intermediate is. Three answers have been proposed, and the principle sorts them.

The *uniform* reading returns every conjunct the antecedent names to blank, each with its ground cleared: X blank, y blank, and y's support s cleared, since closure would otherwise regenerate y. The intermediate is conceptually blank on the target: the composite retrieves in full superposition, every element of every decomposition included.

The *single-attribute-by-maximality* reading treats $X \wedge y$ as one attribute and takes the *maximal* restriction in which it is no longer stated. Since blanking a contrary X already unstates the conjunction, maximality keeps y and its ground for free. The intermediate is then directly blank on the target but *mixed*: y present, X not. Relative to that intermediate the target is not in superposition at all: its answer space is the *product* of its parts'—four states for X and y—and with y stated true only two of the four are open, which is half, not all. The retrieval definition alone therefore kills the reading, and it survives only by a rescue: the *coarsening*, on which the conjunction is read as two-valued, true or false, so that X's openness alone makes it open over both values and hence "blank." That coarsening is a presentation of the attribute, not the attribute—the trivial decomposition $\{X \wedge y\}$ read as if its answer space were two-valued—and Decomposition Neutrality fixes the composite's answer space as its parts' product, invariant across its decomposition set. Whether the antecedent's conjunction may nonetheless be read as one two-valued attribute is a question about the antecedent's interpretation and not about the attribute's decomposition, which Neutrality does not settle; the coarsening is declined here as a substantive choice, the dual-peg reading, and not excluded by the principle. Declined at the rescue, the reading is left with a mixed intermediate. And one thing should be said precisely here, because it is easy to hear the dichotomy theorem as handing the rescue back: the theorem splits a mixed attribute into its present and its nonpresent parts so that the second postulate can be applied

to each *part*; it confers no status on the *whole*, and it is the whole that the reopening's first step must return to blank. The postulate reads a mixed composite only by splitting it, which is precisely why a mixed intermediate is a state no reopening terminates in.

The *contrary-conjuncts-only* reading, closest to home, applies the pocket-wise selection rule of Section 9.1 per conjunct: in a pocket where y already holds, let y pass through by selection and reopen only X. On its own telling it assigns $X \wedge y$ no status at all—it reads the antecedent as naming two attributes rather than one, and so, it will say, there is no composite whose status could be delegated. That telling is not available to it. The perturbation operator takes *the antecedent* as its argument and reopens the antecedent attribute; the *3-Aethus* conditions make the conjunction an attribute of the space whenever its conjuncts are; so a composite target exists by the operator's own definition, and the per-conjunct reading is a proposal about how that composite's reopening is *implemented*, not a denial that there is one. Read as an implementation, its intermediate is the same mixed one, reached by selecting a component—and selecting a component is the same rescue by another route, since "the target is reopened because its contrary component is" again delegates the composite's status to one element of one decomposition. The pocket-wise rule itself is untouched by this verdict: it selects when the *whole* antecedent holds in a pocket and reopens when the whole antecedent is contrary, and neither clause reads the antecedent through a decomposition. What the principle forbids is the finer grain, at which the antecedent is treated as two perturbations composed and one of them exempted; a perturbation by an antecedent is one removal to one intermediate, and the intermediate places the target in superposition under every decomposition or it does not place the target in superposition.

So the uniform reading is not a convention among three. It is the one reading under which the target is in superposition at the intermediate at all, once the composite's status is read of the composite; the other two share one mixed intermediate, reached by two routes and defended by one rescue the principle blocks. This is the point at which the Brief's booking—conjunct-wise reopening as "a convention rather than a consequence of the operator's definition"—is retired: the operator's definition, read with this principle, delivers it.

The countermodel, run as a consequence. Take the four-attribute Aethus of Section 9.4.2: a particular s; the law $s \to y$ in the constraint layer, so that y is in the closure with s its sole particular support; X and Z blank; and the joint constraint that $\{x, s, \neg z\}$ is invalid. Perturb by X: s rests on nothing in the cleared scope and is retained, closure carries y, and in every pocket x and s together exclude $\neg z$; so $X \not\sim y$ and $X \not\sim z$. Cautious Monotony asks for $X \wedge y \not\sim z$. Perturb by $X \wedge y$: the target is the composite, its intermediate is conceptually blank on both conjuncts by the principle, so s is cleared; the restatement returns y and never the ideal removed object, so s does not come back; the residue contains $\neg s$ pockets in which the constraint has nothing to bite on, and $\neg z$ survives in them. Cautious Monotony fails—now not on a reading the paper had to defend as the default, but as a consequence of the composite canon together with Decomposition Neutrality. Since preferential consequence relations satisfy Cautious Monotony and ranked ones are preferential, the would-clause's consequence relation is not preferential and *a fortiori* not representable at the consequence-relation level by Lewis's or Stalnaker's semantics or any smooth similarity ordering; rational monotony fails on the same instance as a corollary.

What is derived and what remains. Three things should be said at their exact grade. First, the derivation consumes no individuation principle: nothing here refuses the conjunctive attribute—the *3-Aethus* conditions make it present whenever its conjuncts are—so the objection that a conjunctive question is record-redundant rather than record-less, (an objection against excluding such attributes), has no target; the principle governs how a composite *reopens*, not whether it exists. Second, what the principle rests on is the framework's own ontology of the object—the equivalence class over its presentations—and that commitment is dated, (2021, the Attribute Set), and independent of the modal work it now underwrites. Third, one question survives untouched and is correctly located: whether the *bare* natural-language conjunction "if X and y" defaults to the reopened reading or to a reading English grammaticalizes with *anyway*, which is an empirical question about the language and not about the operator; the elicited-judgment paradigm the Brief cites is the instrument for it, and its answer bears on the paper's account of natural-language modality, not on the countermodel. Under the progressive convention fixed at Section 9.4, the countermodel's status is accordingly *closed on the dual-peg reading*, the framework's reading of "and" in an antecedent: what the principle derives is that, on that reading, no coarsening rescues the mixed intermediate, and the reading itself is the framework's commitment, not the principle's consequence. The chain, numbered, so that a reader auditing the upgrade can check each link and the extraction can cite it: (1) the Attribute Set, (2021), defines an attribute as the equivalence class over its presentations; (2) hence Decomposition Neutrality—a composite's answer

space is the product of its parts' and is invariant across its decomposition set, never collapsed to the coarsest presentation; (3) the perturbation operator reopens the antecedent *attribute*; on the *dual-peg reading*, the framework's reading of "and" in an antecedent, the antecedent passes each conjunct's peg to the reopening as a separate argument, and by the *3-Aethus* conditions the conjunction $X \wedge y$ is also an attribute of the space whenever its conjuncts are, so a composite target exists, the two formulations agreeing. This reading is the chain's one commitment: the two-valued attribute *is* $X \wedge y$ *true?* is a coarsening of the composite and so a different attribute, which the principle forbids as a presentation of the composite but cannot forbid as the meaning of an antecedent; (4) a reopening must return its target to blank in the retrieval sense of the second postulate; (5) the single-attribute-by-maximality reading and the contrary-conjuncts-only reading each leave a *mixed* intermediate, y stated and X not, relative to which the composite is half-open, and each survives only by the coarsening that reads $X \wedge y$ as two-valued, which (2) forbids; (6) no reopening terminates in a mixed intermediate, since the dichotomy theorem reads a mixed composite only by splitting it into parts and confers no status on the whole; (7) the uniform reading, both conjuncts reopened and supports cleared, is therefore the only reading returning the composite to blank, and it is derived from (1)–(6), given the dual-peg reading at (3); (8) on that reading the four-attribute countermodel violates Cautious Monotony, so the consequence relation is not preferential. What remains empirical is (9): whether the bare English conjunction "if X and y" tracks the operator's reading or a reading the language grammaticalizes with *anyway*—a fact about English, settled by the elicited-judgment paradigm, and bearing on the account of natural-language mood rather than on the countermodel, which is a fact about the operator.[77][78]

The countermodel, walked through. The four-attribute countermodel of step (8) is worked on a concrete case, the sprinklers, in Section 9.2.1, with the counterfactual semantics it concerns: there each counterfactual is evaluated pocket by pocket, the same questions are put to an ordering, to interventionist causal models, and to alternative-sensitive semantics, and step (9)'s elicited-judgment test is specified.

3.3.2 The Grades of Blankness, Derived

Decomposition Neutrality asks that the grade of an attribute's blankness, and its retrieval, be the same through every decomposition. In the peg formalism both are read off a filling (Definition 10), and a filling belongs to the canonical closed content of an Aethus rather than to any one of its representations. For an Aethus A and an attribute X, write $F_A(X)$ for the filling of X in $\mathrm{C}(A)$.

Definition 17 (Grades of blankness)
Let A be an Aethus and X an attribute. X is determinate *in A when $F_A(X)$ is a single peg, and* directly blank *when $F_A(X)$ holds two or more. A directly blank X is* full *when $F_A(X)$ is every peg of X, and* partial *otherwise; a full X is* conceptually blank *when A asserts nothing of its breadth, holding no irreducibility peg for it (Definition 11). A is* invalid *on X when $F_A(X)$ is empty.*

An attribute X is *decomposed* by attributes $X_1, \ldots, X_n$ when it is their composite $X_1 \wedge \cdots \wedge X_n$, its pegs the joint pegs of the components (the composition rule of Definition 10), and $\{X_1, \ldots, X_n\}$ is then a *decomposition set* of X. Relative to a decomposition set, X is *state-decomposable* in A when every component is determinate, *blank-decomposable* when every component is full, and *mixed-decomposable* when some components are determinate and the rest full.

Proposition 15 (Filling and grade are decomposition-neutral)
Let A be a valid Aethus and $\{X_1, \ldots, X_n\}$ a decomposition set of X.

(i) Each component's filling is the projection of the composite's: $F_A(X_j) = \pi_j\big(F_A(X)\big)$.

[77] Fable, working the chain independently on September 18, 2026, found no gap in (1)–(8) and confirmed that (9) is the only link whose status is empirical. A later review located one further link that is a commitment rather than a derivation, the dual-peg reading at (3), which the author confirmed on September 25, 2026 as the framework's reading of "and".

[78] *2026-08-29*

If you look at the ''Attribute Set'' origin part of the paper, one of the key principles of an Aethus/stated-attribute (maybe this should even be a named principle somewhere, but who knows) is that for an Aethus/stated-attribute to be well-defined, there must not be a privileged decomposition of it into conjunction Aethae/stated-attributes (and note the reason I'm using Aethus and stated-attribute interchangeably for this is that an Aethus IS a stated-attribute, and vice versa, per the ''Attribute-Template Equivalence Theorem'', which if we want to change that too might be better named actually as an Aethus stated-attribute equivalence theorem, pretty much, so it emphasizes the Aethus/stated-attribute rather than the Template/attribute), hence meaning that we have to always default to the ''single attribute'' read when we do a conjunction over stated-attributes. See what I mean there??? Thanks!

(ii) X is determinate if and only if it is state-decomposable.

(iii) If X is mixed-decomposable, its determinate components fixed at x, then X is partial, and every peg of $F_A(X)$ agrees with x on those components. When a single component is full, $F_A(X)$ is exactly the set of joint pegs agreeing with x.

(iv) If X is full, it is blank-decomposable. The converse fails exactly when A correlates the components, that is, when $F_A(X)$ is a proper subset of the product of their fillings.

Proof
(i) The composition rule licenses the projection of every state on the composite, combines states on the components into a state on the composite, and transfers exclusions between the composite's joint pegs and the components' pegs. At the closure the composite and its components are therefore narrowed together, and each component's filling is the projection of the composite's. (ii) If $F_A(X)$ is one joint peg, each projection is one peg. Conversely, if each $F_A(X_j)$ is one peg x_j, then by (i) $F_A(X)$ lies within the single joint peg $(x_1, \ldots, x_n)$, and it is not empty because A is valid. (iii) By (i) every peg of $F_A(X)$ agrees with x on the determinate components, so $F_A(X)$ is not every peg of X; and its projection onto a full component has two or more pegs, so $F_A(X)$ has two or more. When only one component is full, that projection is every peg of the component, and each such peg extends x to exactly one joint peg. (iv) By (i) the projections of a full filling are full. If every component is full, their product is every joint peg, so $F_A(X)$ is full exactly when it is the whole product.

The grade of X is read off $F_A(X)$ alone, so it is the same through every decomposition set, which is Decomposition Neutrality for the grade; the three decomposabilities are the grade's readings through one decomposition set at a time. By (i) the same holds for the retrieval (Section 3.4.1).
Remark (correlation). The converse in (iv) is the one place the 2024 treatment is refined. The representation $\{[X_1 \wedge X_2 : \{(a, c), (b, d)\}]\}$, with $X_1 = \{a, b\}$ and $X_2 = \{c, d\}$, leaves both components full and the composite partial: the correlation lives on the conjunction alone. The 2024 procedural criterion, that an attribute is conceptually blank if and only if some decomposition of it is a blank-decomposition , is therefore right exactly when no correlation is asserted. In the peg formalism the criterion is the filling's.
The 2024 claims, recovered. Two claims of the 2024 presentation now follow. A mixed-decomposable attribute is contained in no static Aethus, yet is not conceptually blank: by (iii) its filling is partial, so no representation holds it determinately, and it is not full. And a representation need only write a decomposition set in place of an attribute to imply the attribute in full: the composition rule combines the components' states into the composite's, which is the attribute's.
Verification. Proposition 15 was checked by brute force over 3,328 valid Aethae on $X_1 = \{a, b\}$, $X_2 = \{c, d\}$, their composite and an outside attribute, with random representations and relation structures (`decomposability_check.py`). Parts (i)–(iii) and the first claim of (iv) hold without exception, and the converse of (iv) fails in 163 cases, each carrying a correlation on the composite.

3.4 Retrievals, Contradictions, and the Operations

The filling that grades an attribute is also its retrieval, an empty filling is a contradiction, and the operations of Section 3.1 act on the contents that fillings are read from. This subsection takes the three in turn and closes with the second postulate, which the grades make statable.

3.4.1 Retrievals as Fillings

Definition 18 (Retrieval)
The retrieval *of an attribute X from an Aethus A is its filling $F_A(X)$, and its* retrieval state *is* $[X : F_A(X)]$.

The 2024 presentation read a retrieval off the static Aethae of an Aethus, collecting the states an attribute takes across them . The filling reads it once, from the canonical closed content. A retrieval therefore does not depend on the representation it is read from, and blankness is a property of the attribute as it stands in the Aethus rather than of any presentation of it.

Proposition 16 (Retrieval)
Let A and B be Aethae and X an attribute.

(i) Refinement only narrows a retrieval: if $\mathrm{C}(A) \subseteq \mathrm{C}(B)$*, then* $F_B(X) \subseteq F_A(X)$*.*

(ii) The retrieval from the core of a sum contains the retrievals from its terms: $F_{\mathrm{core}(A+B)}(X) \supseteq F_A(X) \cup F_B(X)$*.*

(iii) The grade of X *in* A *is the size of its retrieval: one peg, two or more, every peg, or none (Definition 17).*

(iv) The retrieval of a component is the projection of the retrieval of its composite (Proposition 15(i)).

Proof
(i) A filling is the intersection of the fillings of the states a content holds on X *with the pegs of* X *it does not exclude, and a larger content holds more states and more exclusions. (ii) The content of the core is* $\mathrm{C}(A) \cap \mathrm{C}(B)$ *(Proposition 12), which lies within both, so (i) applies to each term. (iii) is Definition 17, and (iv) is Proposition 15(i).*

By (i), adding content never widens a retrieval: an attribute blank in a child is blank in its parent, so the blankness the second postulate reads cannot be manufactured by learning. By (ii), a union can widen a retrieval, but it cannot create an agreeing state that its terms do not both hold (Proposition 5).

3.4.2 Aethic Contradictions and Invalid Aethae

Status. An Aethic contradiction is an empty filling $[X : \varnothing]$, licensed by invalidation (Definition 10). It tags the Aethus that holds it without collapsing it, and invalid Aethae are identified only in the validity quotient (Section 3.2).

Disjointness as the primitive, and attributes built from it. Before contradiction can be defined, one relation must be given rather than derived, and it is disjointness—of pegs, not of Aethae. For any two pegs it is settled primitively whether they are disjoint: whether they are, or are not, content that cannot be stated together. The constructions of this subsection are built from that relation, in the following order. The full bottom-up construction, from the primitives to every root notion, is given in Section 3.1.

Attributes. An attribute is formed from any number of pairwise disjoint pegs, which it takes as its options, each occupying one of its slots. Nothing restricts the number of pegs to two: an attribute recording which of several colors a light shows is formed from as many pairwise disjoint pegs as there are colors. An attribute is *determinate at* a peg when a representation's state on it is filled by that peg alone, and *blank* when that state is filled by all of its pegs; these are statuses of an attribute's filling, never of a peg (Definition 6).

Negation. The two-peg case is where negation lives. When an attribute has exactly two pegs, each is read as the negation of the other, and $\neg a$ is notation for the attribute's other peg. The pegs are not logical complements prior to the attribute; the attribute is what makes each the other's alternative (Section 2.4.14). With more than two pegs, $\neg a_i$ can serve only as notation for the attribute's remaining options, and it is the attribute, not a primitive complement, that fixes which options those are.

Invalidity, and the derived disjointness of Aethae. Invalid Aethae are constructed from the primitive: a representation committed to two disjoint pegs is invalid, whether they are two pegs of one attribute, as in the Aethic contradiction defined below, or a pair declared disjoint across attributes. Only once invalid Aethae exist does disjointness extend to Aethae, and there it is derived: two Aethae are disjoint when their Aethic intersection is invalid. The definition of disjoint pegs in the general sense, in Section 3.4.3, is that derived criterion; applied back to pegs it returns the primitive, as it must, but it does not define it. Joint invalidity declarations of higher arity, such as the three-way declaration of the sprinklers ledger in Section 9.2.1, belong to the same constraint layer (Section 5.2.2).

Superposition: union, not intersection. The same primitive fixes what an agreeing superposition is when it is rooted in an attribute, and the identity can look backwards at first. A blank attribute is the agreeing superposition of its pegs, and that superposition is the joint filling of a single state, the pegs assembled together within one state—not, as one might naively expect, their intersection, and not the Aethic union of Aethae either (Proposition 5). The intersection of two disjoint pegs is invalid; it is the Aethic contradiction. Disjointness therefore does two things at once: it forbids the pegs from being present together, and it is what makes their assembly within one state a well-formed superposition over the attribute. Classically, $a \vee \neg a$ is a tautology and $a \wedge \neg a$ a contradiction. Here the second is the invalid Aethus, as before, but the first is not a truth at all: it is an agreeing superposition, the

attribute left blank. The Aethic union is a different sum, the unweighted shadow of the disagreeing one, and the Valid Union Principle of Section 3.4.3 is what keeps such unions well defined when some of their members are invalid.

It is important at this point to declare what constitutes an Aethic contradiction, that way we can rigorously define where the classical law of non-contradiction applies in Aethic reasoning versus where it is deemed obsolete. As such, an Aethic contradiction can be defined as follows.

Definition 19 (Aethic Contradiction)

1. *An attribute X is an* Aethic contradiction *in an Aethus A when* $\mathrm{C}(A)$ *holds two determinate states* $[X : \{a\}]$ *and* $[X : \{b\}]$ *at distinct, and hence disjoint, pegs: their product narrows X to the empty filling, the Aethic contradiction of the algebra of states (Section 3.1).*

2. *An Aethus A itself will possess an Aethic contradiction if and only if there exists such an X which is an Aethic contradiction in A.*

Also note the use of the term *disjoint* in this context. For two pegs of the same attribute to be disjoint is something of a given property for them—that is, it is postulated rather than deduced (Definition 3). This is not to be confused with *disjoint Aethae*, which instead regards two Aethae whose intersection is an invalid Aethus, the derived notion described above. Intuitively put, *if a contradiction happens inside an Aethus, (i.e. with present attributes), then that amounts to an Aethic contradiction, however if a contradiction happens outside an Aethus, (i.e. with non-present attributes), then no problem is triggered at all relative to that Aethus.*

Also please note, by the way, that a conceptually blank state can never directly contradict another state of its same attribute, because it cannot ever satisfy that condition of being disjoint[79]. As such, one can very well put a determinate state in an Aethus and then also add the conceptually blank state of the same attribute, and a contradiction can never be directly triggered by such a thing, (in a sense being analogous to adding zero to a number, with no change being made in the first place). More rigorously put, *the operation of adding the conceptually blank state to any representation is itself an identity operation over Aethic equivalence*, since that state asserts nothing (Definition 6). The footnote's argument, through the Aethic union of all of an attribute's determinate states, no longer runs, since that union is not conceptually blank: it holds the attribute's single-peg carving (Definition 12).

The next important thing to state about Aethic contradictions, is that they imply that the Aethus in question now becomes an *invalid Aethae*. Also note that the converse of this is not necessarily true, as there are many other means of creating an invalid Aethus, (with these other means perhaps serving as the backbone of Aethic reasoning's descriptive power). Generally, though, an invalid Aethus is to be considered the truest Aethic analogue to the logical contradiction from classical logic, in that it is, by definition, considered to be that which disallows realism.

Definition 20 (Invalid Aethus)

A representation is invalid *when its closure holds an empty filling, and the empty filling stands as a tag: invalid Aethae remain distinct from one another, and only the validity quotient identifies them with the additive identity (Definition 10; Section 3.2). Every Aethus that possesses an Aethic contradiction is invalid, but not conversely: a set of the relation structure held in full across several attributes also invalidates, as does any other route to an empty filling. An invalid Aethus is one defined as being impossible to physically realize, specifically as the Aethic generalization of classical "contradictions." Aethic contradictions are direct Aethic analogues to classical contradictions in terms of procedure, and invalid Aethae generalize them to every system that shares their metaphysical invalidity while allowing other avenues into establishing it. There is something of a postulate in the definition, being that invalid Aethae have to be assumed as metaphysically disallowed all while not explicitly stating where that applies tangibly, (because doing such a thing would imply that they are in some form metaphysically allowed in the first place). This is a bit of a headache, and as such is area for philosophical speculation.*

This definitional clause is the framework's *realization bridge*: formal invalidity maps to physical unrealizability. It is injected as a principle rather than derived—an entry every honest accounting must carry—and this is the point where it binds.

[79] We can prove such a statement through the use of the associative property, where we imply that a blank-stated attribute for a given attribute can be written as the Aethic union of all possible stated-attributes to that attribute. As such, any bijection on the set of stated-attributes to an attribute which constitutes the Aethic intersection with that blank stated-attribute must be an identity map, itself implying that there are no invalid Aethae in the image.

One possible method of bringing metaphysical rigor to the definition of an invalid Aethus might be to empirically suppose that *oneself may never occupy an invalid Aethus*, such that their Aethus can and will place them in a valid alternative instead each and every time. This also has some flaws, of course, because then the question might be *is it that one's own potential to occupy an invalid Aethus is the exhaustive span of what is disallowed, or are there further disallowed possibilities beyond what can be directly implied by one's own specifically-oriented empiricism?* Whatever the ontological specifications may be, an Aethic contradiction is epistemically analogous to the direct logical connotation of a classical contradiction, in that it means states are logically conflicting, but an invalid Aethus is analogous to the remainder of the connotation for classical contradictions, being that they defy all realism and as such are imperceptible. This is the nature of invalid Aethae.

3.4.3 The Operations, Derived

Section 3.1 defines the operations on Aethae, and Section 3.2 places them in the refinement order. *Joint assertion* $A \cdot B$ is the Aethus of the union of any representations of A and B, whose content is the closure of their contents; it is their meet (Proposition 11). The *Aethic union* $A + B$ keeps its operands as terms, and joint assertion distributes over it term by term (Section 3.1). What a sum asserts outright is its core, whose content is $\mathrm{C}(A) \cap \mathrm{C}(B)$: the last common ancestor of A and B (Proposition 12).

The 2024 presentation defined both operations by presence: an attribute is present in the union if and only if it is present in both operands, and in the intersection if and only if it is present in either. Read with presence as membership in closed content, the 2024 union is the core of $A + B$, and the 2024 intersection is $A \cdot B$ once its content is closed, as the axiomatic construction of 2025 showed and Proposition 11 states. What the peg formalism adds is the sum itself. The terms the 2024 union discarded are kept, and joint assertion distributes over them exactly. Whatever failure of distributivity remains belongs to the lattice of cores, and Proposition 14 marks the carved case, in which there is none.

Principle 20 (Valid Union Principle, in pegs)
A sum keeps its invalid terms as tags, distinct from one another (Definition 10). The validity quotient identifies each with the additive identity, so that there a union keeps exactly its valid terms.

Disjointness. Two Aethae are *disjoint* when their joint assertion is invalid. For two pegs of one attribute this is the primitive disjointness of Definition 3, since narrowing their determinate states yields the empty filling. For pegs of different attributes it is the invalidity of the joint assertion of their determinate states, which is the 2024 definition of disjoint pegs in the general sense.

Complements. The 2024 presentation also defined a complement Aethus. Whether empirical Aethae have complements is settled with the weighted operations, where the answer is that they do not (Section 4.7.4).

3.4.4 Stating the Second Postulate of the Aethus

Status. In the peg formalism the second postulate reads that an attribute left blank is in agreeing superposition over its pegs, the conceptually blank state asserting nothing further (Definition 6); by Theorem 2(ii) it runs unchanged over attributes whose pegs are Aethae.

Now that we have defined the three styles of decomposition, (being state-decomposition, mixed-decomposition, and blank-decomposition), we may proceed to rigorously defining the second postulate of the Aethus.

Second Postulate of the Aethus
If an Aethus is valid, then any given attribute will be in Aethic superposition relative to it if and only if it is nonpresent to it.

There are many consequences to such a statement, and we will go over them in detail in the coming sections. Also note that the second postulate is itself compatible with mixed-decompositional attributes as well as just blank-decompositional and state-decompositional attributes, but we simply need to transform them into a form it can understand before doing so. Such a thing will be the purpose of the coming *Aethic dichotomy theorem*, which will enable us to reliably make such a transformation.

Crucially, note that the second postulate requires the extrusion principle as its direct ontological counterpart for an important reason: *given the premise that a directly blank attribute of an Aethus does*

indeed render as an Aethic superposition, then we need the shift in perspective to a new rendering of the block universe granted by the extrusion principle to prevent the overwriting of this superposition-from-unknown. In a classical metaphysical paradigm, where we as agents merely are filling in unknowns with pre-existing determinate states, it becomes impossible to express the second postulate of the Aethus because an unknown and its superposition loses the ability to be an objective building block of a reality as is an Aethic superposition under the second postulate. Accordingly, then, by stating the extrusion principle's perspectival shift in place of the classical "overwriting" view do we make the second postulate of the Aethus sayable in the first place.

The note above can be recorded as a formal target, because it is the precise sense in which the second postulate and the extrusion principle are two sides of one coin: each without the other is either deflatable or contentless, and only jointly are they rigid.

Theorem 3 (Permanence Proposition: the Deflation Claim)
Adopt the second postulate with overwrite semantics *in place of the extrusion principle: upon an informational update resolving a blank attribute, the superposition is revised in place within the standing block universe, rather than the agent transiting to a new rendering of the block universe with the prior one retained. Then there exists a validity-preserving relabeling of the entire structure onto a classical ignorance model—the vocabulary of "blankness" and "superposition" becomes a coordinate choice over classical metaphysics, differing in name only—and that model assigns a single sample space of determinately-valued attributes behind every blank. By the Boole–Fine correspondence, (Section 10.3.2), any such model satisfies the CHSH bounds; quantum statistics violate them; therefore the relabeling is empirically refuted wherever the relabeled blanks include the record-free sector. What the data thereby force is the constructive reading of blanks in that sector—not permanence itself. A classical filtration is likewise non-overwriting, (the prior σ-algebra persists through conditioning, and it stays permanently true that the attribute was not measurable with respect to it), so persistence of the before-description is available to the deflationist for free, and overwrite is not what the statistics refute. Permanence's role is prior and narrower: it keeps the before-description in existence as a standing object of the framework's own ontology, so that its completeness is a question the data can answer rather than one dissolved at resolution—the second postulate made sayable, in the sense the note above fixes—and the extrusion principle is adopted for that reason and for its ontological work, (the modal inversion, the indexing, the foliation-free resolution), rather than forced by the data alone.*

Sketch. Under overwrite semantics the pre-update and post-update descriptions never coexist: the earlier superposition is destroyed at resolution, so no retrievable fact distinguishes "the attribute was genuinely open and then became x in place" from "the attribute was x all along, merely unknown"—no fact, that is, retrievable from the framework's own bookkeeping; the ensemble statistics remain, and in the record-free sector they are exactly the retrievable difference, overwrite or not. The relabeling that reads every blank as a determinate-but-unknown value therefore preserves every validity computation the structure can perform—this is the coordinate-transform deflation made explicit—and its image is a hidden-value model over the blank attributes on one sample space. Fine's theorem then delivers a joint distribution over the counterfactual outcomes, the CHSH inequalities follow, and the observed violations close the argument. (Scope, priced as part of the result: the closure is empirical exactly where the relabeled blanks include the record-free sector—the agreeing superpositions whose statistics carry the violations. A relabeling that halts at the record-rich blanks—the sinkhole's, the envelope's—evades the theorem and is empirically identical to the tense-free reading over that sector; what it pays is architectural, two bookkeepings for one grammatical object. The framework's uniformity is a priced choice against that split, not a further theorem, and the ledger is where the price appears. The count itself is contested rather than settled, and should be read as the framework's side of a dispute: a decoherence realist will answer that one bookkeeping—the quantum state, with determinate branch content emerging wherever records exist—is exactly what they run, and that it is the constructive blank standing beside disagreeing pockets each carrying its fact that counts two. The reply is that the pocket's fact is indexed content rather than a second primitive, and that an emergence clause—a rule for when determinacy appears—is a bookkeeping of determinacy under another name; but that reply is an argument to be had, not a cost already paid, and the ledger enters the parsimony claim at that grade.) The converse face of the coin is cheaper still: the extrusion principle without the second postulate asserts a chain of block universes but says nothing about what blanks retrieve as within them, and so has no empirical content to defend. Jointly, the pair is rigid: the second postulate supplies the retrieval content, and the extrusion principle supplies the permanence without which that content, though not thereby refuted, has no standing object to be a fact about—it survives only as a

tensed transition undergone by one ledger, which is the second postulate rendered unsayable in the sense the note above fixes. □

This is also why the permanence emphasized in the narrative illustrations—determinacy gained is always indexed to the Aethus that gained it, (Section 5.4.1)—is structural rather than decorative: remove it, and the framework's nonclassical commitment ceases to be a standing fact about any index and becomes a transition undergone by one ledger—the reparse, where it is refuted, is refuted by the statistics; where it is not, it is priced; and permanence is what makes it a claim about a standing object in either case. The sketch's content admits an exact statement, and it is given next as a reductio: the deflationist's claim that blanks are unknowns is written out as three conditions on a relabeling, and the conditions are shown jointly unsatisfiable wherever the blanks carry Bell-violating statistics, and jointly satisfiable wherever they do not. What the reductio does *not* do is derive the constructive reading positively—it refutes its denial in one sector and prices it in the other—which is why the framework's inductive fulcrum remains the union principle's logical realism and not this result.

Theorem 4 (Deflation Reductio)
Let A be an Aethus, Q its blank attributes, and call an assignment δ a lossless deflation of A when it provides, for A and for every Aethus B in A's refinement structure, a family $W(B)$ of complete valuations of B's attributes such that:

(D1) non-contextual hidden values: every $w \in W(B)$ assigns each attribute one value, independent of which other attributes are stated or measured, and agrees with B on B's stated entries;

(D2) verdict preservation on the declared fragment: for every B all of whose cross content is declared, (the disagreeing fragment, where the framework's verdicts are classically expressible), B is valid iff $W(B) \neq \varnothing$, and for a proper child $C \leq B$, $W(C)$ is the subfamily of $W(B)$ agreeing with C's stated entries;

(D3) statistics as hidden-value frequencies: the framework's ensemble statistics over any attributes of A are the marginals of one probability measure μ on $W(A)$, each run's outcomes identified with that run's hidden values, with the choice of which attributes are measured independent of w—measurement independence, the one premise external to the framework.

Then: (a) if Q contains a Bell quadruple—four attributes $A_{\mathbf{a}}, A_{\mathbf{a}'}, B_{\mathbf{b}}, B_{\mathbf{b}'}$ whose CHSH combination exceeds 2 under the framework's own weights, (the singlet of Section 14.6.8, saturating $2\sqrt{2}$ at Section 14.6.9), or under the observed statistics—then no lossless deflation of A exists; (b) if every correlation among Q's attributes satisfies the CHSH bounds—the record-rich sector—a lossless deflation exists, namely the classical filtration.

Proof. (a) Suppose δ exists. By (D1) each $w \in W(A)$ assigns a value to all four attributes of the quadruple, so μ of (D3) is a probability measure on the four-fold value space; by (D3) the four pairwise correlations $E(\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b})$, $E(\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}')$, $E(\mathbf{a}', \mathbf{b})$, $E(\mathbf{a}', \mathbf{b}')$ are its marginals, measurement independence being what lets the same μ serve all four setting pairs. By Fine's theorem [82], the existence of a joint distribution with those marginals is equivalent to the CHSH inequalities, (Boole's conditions of possible experience in Pitowsky's reading [83]), so $|S| \leq 2$—contradicting the hypothesis that the quadruple's combination exceeds 2. Hence no such δ. (b) In the record-rich sector every alternative's cross content is declared, so the framework's base invalidities are same-attribute exclusivity and stated contradictions only; take $W(B)$ to be the complete valuations consistent with B's closed content and μ the framework's weight measure pushed forward. (D1) holds by construction. (D2) holds because, with only those base invalidities, the third postulate's $\exists\forall$ validity coincides with the existence of a consistent completion, (the clean-future grade the Fixed-Point Lemma certifies: a state with a consistent completion has a proper child all of whose proper children are consistent, and a state with none is doomed within finitely many generations), and proper children restrict the completion family. (D3) holds because Bell-bounded correlations admit a joint distribution with the given marginals, which is Fine's theorem in its converse direction. □

What the theorem fixes, and at what grade. The framework's own link in the chain is not (D1)–(D3) themselves but their *identification* with the deflationist's thesis: to read a blank as an unknown in the deflationary way the theorem addresses is to assert (D1) and (D3), the single-sample-space premise in two clauses, though an unknown value need not be embedded in that global, context-independent, measurement-independent model, and (D2) is only the demand that the reading change no classical verdict—the innocence the deflationist claims for it. Given that identification, (a) is a theorem conditional on three things named on its face: Fine's theorem, measurement independence, and the

Bell-violating statistics, which the framework supplies from its own kernel for the singlet and which experiment supplies independently. The corollary is the dilemma the sketch stated informally: either the deflation is lossless everywhere, which (a) refutes, or it halts at the record-rich sector, where (b) grants it at the architectural price of two bookkeepings for one grammatical object—and the halt concedes constructive blanks exactly where the statistics exceed the bounds, which by the criterion of Section 8 is the agreeing sector. The two-directional correspondence of Section 10.3.2 is what (a) consumes, in the direction from single sample space to bound; the converse direction, from violation to agreeing superposition, is not needed here and keeps its own grade there.

Two sharpenings from adversarial review belong beside the sketch. *Where the non-contextuality enters:* at the relabeling itself, by construction—reading every blank as determinate-but-unknown assigns each attribute one value independent of measurement context, which is precisely the single-sample-space premise; contextual hidden-variable programs therefore fall outside the argument's scope rather than standing as counterexamples to it. *And the mixed-reading escape, closed as a dilemma:* a careful deflationist might concede constructive blanks for the Bell-tested attributes while keeping determinate-but-unknown values for decohered positional degrees of freedom. Both horns of the retreat are already priced. Hold determinate positions always and everywhere, and the position is Bohmian mechanics—a preferred foliation and permanently hidden values, (the foliation contrast of Section 2.5). Or draw the determinate/blank line by decoherence status—by informational accessibility—and the boundary-is-informational thesis has been conceded outright, since matter-wave interferometry places exactly those positional micro-attributes into agreeing superpositions whenever the records are absent—though what is conceded is the boundary and not the index, the record-status reader keeping one-place values for recorded-but-unlearned attributes, which is the split relabeling priced rather than closed in the scope note of the sketch above. (A line drawn by *mass* rather than by records is no longer a reparse but new collapse dynamics, priced with its own testable deviations.) There is no third address.

3.5 A Mathematical Framework to Aethic Superpositions

Status. The superpositions of this subsection read in the peg formalism as follows. An agreeing superposition is a state over two or more pegs (Definition 6); a disagreeing superposition is a weighted sum of one-peg branches, whose unweighted shadow is its support and whose core carries the single-peg carving (Section 4.3); and an Aethic superposition is agreeing within the blocks of a carving and disagreeing across them. The ring operations previewed at the close of this section (Section 3.7) are those of weighted Aethae (Section 4.4).

3.5.1 The Dichotomy, in Pegs

The 2024 Aethic Dichotomy Theorem rewrote any attribute, relative to an Aethus, as a conjunction of a part present in the Aethus and a part nonpresent to it, so that the second postulate could read mixed attributes. In the peg formalism the division is the filling's.

Proposition 17 (The dichotomy, filling form)
Let A be a valid Aethus and X an attribute with filling $F = F_A(X)$. The pegs of X outside F are ruled out by $\mathrm{C}(A)$, and $\mathrm{C}(A)$ holds no state on X narrower than F. Whether X lies in F is thereby settled in A, while among the pegs of F nothing in A decides: X stands over F in agreeing superposition, in the broad sense unless A holds the irreducibility peg e_F (Definition 11).

Proof
Both halves are the definition of the filling (Definition 10): what lies outside it is what the content's states and exclusions rule out, and a state narrower than F would narrow the filling. The reading of what remains is the second postulate (Section 3.4.4).

The 2024 theorem's present part is the settled question, and its nonpresent part the open one. The 2024 statement further writes the two as an attribute conjunction, $X = X_1 \wedge X_2$. That form needs the pegs of the open attribute fixed outside F as well as inside it, and its construction is left open here; the filling form is what the second postulate needs.

3.5.2 The Types of Superposition, Derived

The 2024 presentation defined three types of superposition over stated attributes. In the peg formalism they are these.

- An *agreeing superposition* of X over S is the state $[X : S]$ with S holding two or more pegs (Definition 6). It lives in the intrinsic layer. It is *irreducible* in an Aethus that also holds the peg e_S, and otherwise *broad* (Definition 11); the conceptually blank state is its full and broad case, and asserts nothing.
- A *disagreeing superposition* of X is a weighted sum of one-peg branches (Definition 25). It lives in the weighted layer (Section 4.3): its unweighted shadow is its support, and its core carries the single-peg carving c_X.
- An *Aethic superposition* is agreeing within the blocks of a carving and disagreeing across them (Section 4.3).

By Proposition 17, a directly blank attribute of a valid Aethus stands in agreeing superposition over its filling, which makes exact the 2024 definition of an attribute "in Aethic superposition to some extent". The epistemic standing of these definitions is two-tiered, as the 2024 status note recorded: that agreeing superpositions exist, and share the irreducibility of determinate states, is induced from nature, while the formalism that parses them is deliberately a first capture.

3.5.3 Aethic Partitions and Set-Based Epistemologies

Let us also briefly mention some procedures for converting between Aethic reasoning and classical probability theory notation and ontology. Regarding Aethic partitions, they do not quite have the same ontological significance as Aethic unions or intersections due to their reliance on sets, but they may nonetheless have a few epistemological uses when converting between Aethic insights and set theory insights. We can define an Aethic partition in the following way so as to create a direct analogue to a set partition.

Concept 1 (Aethic Partition)
For some Aethus, A, it follows that the set S will be an Aethic partition of A if and only if the following conditions are held by it.

- *All Aethae in S are valid, (with invalid Aethae being the analogue to empty sets).*
- *The Aethic union of all Aethae in S is validity-equivalent to A, (with the corresponding weights of the Aethae in S being somewhere stored, such as in some isomorphic S_w, for example).*
- *The Aethic intersection of any two Aethae in S is an invalid Aethus, (with, again, an invalid Aethus being the Aethic analogue of an empty set).*

Regarding the actual epistemological use of Aethic partitions, an example might be in mapping S onto a probabilistic sample space, with a corresponding probability mass function associating with the isomorphism from S to S_w. A direct use of this concept will, for an example, come into play in the paper on Nexic reasoning, when the Nexic mediocrity principle is defined through a preset mediocre quantile being present for some child of an Aethus. In the meantime, however, we can regard Aethic partitions through their simple property of being fundamentally epistemic rather than ontic.

3.6 Briefly Overviewing Aethic Logic Proper

Status. The steps below keep their 2024 vocabulary. In the peg formalism a stated attribute (α, x) is the determinate state $[\alpha : \{x\}]$, a static Aethus is a representation, a 3-Aethus is closed content, presence in an Aethus is membership in its closed content, and an Aethic contradiction is an empty filling (Section 4.9).

Having now completed the formal construction of the Aethic structure, it is worth pausing to consolidate what has actually shifted, at the level of logic itself, between standard sentential reasoning and the Aethic apparatus that has been built up. The reader who has followed the construction thus far has been introduced to a number of components piecewise—the Aethus, the decomposition trichotomy, the second postulate, the parent-child Aethus structure, the Union Principle—but the cumulative effect on logical structure has not been foregrounded. The present subsection is intended to fill that gap as a pedagogical aid. We will walk procedurally through the load-bearing transitions, with each step exhibiting the sentential-logic role on one side and the Aethic-logic replacement on the other. The reader already familiar with the construction may treat this subsection as a structural index; the reader new to it may treat it as a brief recap of where each piece is doing its work.

3.6.1 Step 1: From Propositions to Stated-Attributes

Sentential logic. The fundamental unit of fact is the *proposition*—a sentence with a determinate truth value. "Topaz has Mohs hardness 8" is a proposition; it is either true or false, and its truth value is the only structural information sentential logic stores about it.

Aethic logic. The fundamental unit of fact is the *stated-attribute* (or *1-Aethus*), formed by instantiating an Attribute with a State. The proposition above becomes the pairing ("Mohs hardness of topaz", 8), where the Attribute is itself a tuple containing an identifier, a class, and a relation set encoding its dependencies on other attributes. This is structurally richer than a proposition for two reasons: first, the attribute and the state are separable, which means the attribute can persist as an object even when its state is unknown; second, the relation set encodes logical dependencies directly into the attribute, ensuring that derivability across attributes is built into the structure rather than being imposed externally[80].

Load-bearing consequence. Because attributes are separable from their states, the framework can represent the *absence* of a state as a primitive object (the blank), rather than treating absence as merely the negation of presence. This is the structural precondition for everything that follows.

3.6.2 Step 2: From Sets of Propositions to Static Aethae and Aethae

[81]

Sentential logic. A logical theory is a set of propositions closed under logical consequence. The container is flat: propositions are listed, their consequences are derived, and equivalent theories are theories with the same consequences.

Aethic logic. The container is layered. A *2-Aethus* (Static Aethus) is a set of stated-attributes viewed as a function mapping attributes to states. A *3-Aethus* is the closure of a 2-Aethus under all derivable attributes—the logical completion. An *Aethus* (or *4-Aethus*) is the equivalence class of all 2-Aethae that generate the same 3-Aethus. These are distinct objects: the 2-Aethus is what one writes down, the 3-Aethus is what is implied, and the Aethus is the underlying invariant that all logically-equivalent 2-Aethae point to.

Load-bearing consequence. The Aethus, as an equivalence class, is invariant under changes in how the system is described. This gives the framework its claim to operate on the *informational state itself* rather than on any particular representation of it. The distinction matters because Aethic operations (union, intersection, retrieval) are defined on Aethae, not on 2-Aethae—which means they respect the equivalence relation rather than depending on representational choices.

3.6.3 Step 3: From Direct Manipulation to Backend Manipulation via Aethic Retrieval

Sentential logic. The propositions one manipulates and the propositions one observes are the same object. There is no separation between the formal level at which logical operations are performed and the level at which truth-value assignments are checked against the world. Whatever structural moves are made at the logical level affect the propositions directly, with no intermediate translation step.

Aethic logic. The framework introduces a fundamental backend/frontend separation. Structural operations—union, intersection, equivalence-class formation, blank manipulation, validity checks—are

[80]Note, however, that the relation set in real-world cases often has to be used only implicitly, rather than being directly constructable outright. So while in the abstract it is assumed to exist as an object, in practice it is referred to on a case-by-case basis for attributes concerning their implicitly understood relationship, as if to say "we wish for these two attributes to be related in this way, so we assume the relational set is constructed in such a way so as to consist with this relationship among the remainder of possibilities which we intuitively enforce in a bijective sense to that intuitive totality of constraints for applicability".

[81]The static Aethus of this 2024 step is, in the 2026 foundations, the static of Section 3.1.1: a written object denoting a representation, with the Aethic blank and the Aethic false as its only primitives.

performed at the level of Aethae (the backend). What is actually observed empirically, however, is the block universe (the frontend). The two layers are bridged by the *Aethic retrieval function*, a mapping

$$R : \text{Aethus} \to \text{Block Universe}$$

that takes an Aethus and produces the corresponding observable reality. The Aethic retrieval is therefore not a notational convenience but the formal apparatus that licenses operating on Aethae structurally while making contingent empirical claims about block universes. The first postulate of the Aethus itself may be expressed as the statement that this mapping is bijective.

Why the separation matters. The structural manipulation at the Aethus level is invisible to direct empirical observation; the empirical observation is the projected output of that backend manipulation. This is what allows the framework to do things sentential logic cannot:

- A blank attribute at the Aethus level retrieves as a full superposition at the block universe level—the structural absence of state at the backend is what materializes the observable superposition at the frontend.
- Two 2-Aethae generating the same 3-Aethus (i.e., belonging to the same equivalence class) retrieve to the same block universe—the framework operates on the underlying invariant rather than on the representation.
- Operations that would be undefined or meaningless at the propositional level (Aethic union producing agreeing or disagreeing superposition, reduced-form coupling across attributes) are well-defined at the Aethus level and project to coherent block-universe phenomena via retrieval.

Load-bearing consequence. Sentential logic has no analogue to the retrieval function because there is no analogue to the Aethus/block-universe distinction. Aethic logic's separation between backend manipulation and frontend observation is what gives the framework its capacity to derive collapse, Born-rule behavior, and the agreeing/disagreeing distinction from a single underlying structural apparatus. Without the retrieval, structural moves at the Aethus level could not connect to empirical predictions; without the Aethus level, the retrieval would have nothing to project. The two layers depend on each other to give the framework its full operational scope.

3.6.4 Step 4: From Absence-as-Falsity to Blanks as Constructive Primitives

Sentential logic. If a proposition is not in the theory, it is simply not in the theory. There is no third option between "proposition P is asserted" and "proposition P is denied"—absence of a proposition from the theory has no structural role of its own.

Aethic logic. An attribute that is not present in an Aethus is *blank*, and the blank is a constructive ontological primitive, not merely an absence. The blank participates in the Aethic retrieval via the Second Postulate: a stated attribute retrieves its single state, a blank attribute retrieves the set of all possible states (materializing as full superposition). This is what gives blanks their constructive character—they are not gaps to be filled but genuine building blocks of reality with their own determinate retrieval behavior.

The decomposition trichotomy. Aethic logic refines blankness into three structural cases based on attribute decomposition:

- **Stated-Decomposable** (*Stated/present*): All component parts of the attribute are stated.
- **Blank-Decomposable** (*Conceptually Blank/nonpresent*): All component parts are blank. This is the strong condition under which the attribute itself, as well as its decomposition, are uniformly absent (materializing as perfect agreeing superposition of the attribute).
- **Mixed-Decomposable** (*Semiblank*): Some components are stated, others are blank. This produces a constrained set of possibilities consistent with the stated components—a partial or collapsed superposition.

An attribute that is either Conceptually Blank or Semiblank is *Directly Blank*. An *Impartially Blank* attribute is the special case of direct blankness in which the Aethic intersection of any state of the attribute with the Aethus in question is not an abject invalidity, meant to be a methodological analogue to the Second Postulate in the form of a more compact theorem.

Load-bearing consequence. Sentential logic has no apparatus for this trichotomy. The distinction between conceptual blankness, semiblankness, and statedness is invisible at the propositional level, yet it does substantial work in Aethic logic: it is what allows the framework to track the difference between a full superposition (all possibilities), a partial superposition (constrained possibilities), and a determinate state. Each category retrieves differently, and the distinctions are structural, not merely terminological.

3.6.5 Step 5: From Boolean Disjunction to Aethic Union

Sentential logic. The disjunction $P \vee Q$ is true if at least one of P, Q is true. Boolean disjunction does one thing uniformly: it produces the union of the propositions' truth conditions.

Aethic logic. The Aethic union, $A \cup B$, operates on Aethae rather than on propositions, and its structural behavior splits along an axis that Boolean logic does not see. When the Aethic union yields a state that is conceptually blank to the resulting Aethus, the Second Postulate gives a superposition—but two algebraically distinct kinds of superposition can result:

- **Agreeing superposition** (*quantum coherence is an instance of this*): States A_i coexist and can interfere. Mathematically elementary:

$$C_1 = \bigcup_i A_i$$

  This is the double-slit interference pattern—the particle genuinely traverses both paths, and the paths interact.

- **Disagreeing superposition** (*classical appearance of mutual exclusivity*): States A_i coexist but cannot interfere. Mathematically a nested union over intersections with negations:

$$C_2 = \bigcup_i \left(a_i \cap \bigcap_{j \neq i} \neg a_j \right)$$

  This is the classical "one outcome or the other", the letters being pegs of one attribute and each term the state holding one of them alone—each such state exists together with the explicit negation of all other states, so the outer union ensures all states are physically present while the inner intersections enforce observational mutual exclusivity.

Load-bearing consequence. The agreeing/disagreeing distinction is invisible to sentential logic, which treats both as "or." Yet they have categorically different empirical behavior: agreeing superpositions interfere; disagreeing superpositions do not. The Aethic Union Principle's canonical claim is that the difference lives in algebraic nesting, not in physical presence. Both types manifest as physical co-occupation; only the nested structure distinguishes them.

Constructing a disagreeing superposition. The mechanics of disagreeing superposition assembly are worth being precise about, since the construction reveals structural facts that the bare definition does not. A disagreeing superposition over an attribute is formed by the Aethic union (equivalently, direct Aethic addition) over the Aethae in which that attribute is state-decomposable. The attribute in the resulting union is then *directly blank* but not *conceptually blank*—a distinction worth dwelling on.

The attribute cannot remain state-decomposable in the union, since that would directly contradict its having been formed by adding Aethae each carrying a different state for it. Nor can it be conceptually blank, since conceptual blankness would imply perfect agreeing superposition over the attribute—and Aethic unions never produce agreeing superpositions over an attribute that is state-decomposable in each of the involved Aethae. The structural reason is built into the Aethae being added: each one carries, by deductive closure of its 3-Aethus, the implicit assertion that the other states are false (since

each Aethus is state-decomposable to one specific state and not the others). Under the passage of common attributes across all Aethae under the union, this falsity is preserved in the total Aethus, so the agreeing superposition over the attribute is necessarily false there as well.

The "attribute union" clarification. A useful terminological refinement follows. The union operation appearing in the Union Principle's canonical table for the agreeing-superposition case is better described as an *attribute union*, since the standard Aethic union over multiple state-decomposable Aethae always produces a disagreeing superposition for the attribute concerned. The agreeing-superposition case sits at the algebraic level above this: it operates explicitly over the attribute rather than over the Aethae carrying its states. This is the structural reason agreeing superpositions are sometimes called *irreducible*—they behave as leaf nodes with respect to the construction of valid proper child Aethae, in precisely the same sense as determinate states do. Just as a fully state-decomposable attribute admits no further blank-shrinking once all its components are stated, an agreeing-superposition state admits no further valid proper child Aethae without contradiction.

The formal construction. The practical formalization for identifying a disagreeing superposition uses two attributes in conjunction[82]:

- att_1: "Which among $A_1, \ldots, A_n$ is true?"—set to directly blank.
- att_2: "Is A_1 OR ... OR A_n true?"—set to *true*.

The disagreeing superposition is then identified by the conjunction of these two: there is at least one true state (att_2 = true), but the question of which specific state is true cannot be resolved within the Aethus (att_1 = directly blank). The total Aethus structure is thereby constructible from the two given proper child Aethae, with the directly-blank-but-not-conceptually-blank status of att_1 being the structural signature of disagreeing superposition. Alternatively, one may simply omit att_1 from the static Aethus entirely, since blank attributes are absent by default—but mentioning it explicitly and marking it blank tends to be pedagogically clearer.

The key formal move enabling this construction is that att_1 is permitted to be *Aethus-valued* in its state, meaning a stated-attribute for att_1 would itself be an Aethus-object rather than a primitive state. This recursion is what allows the Aethic apparatus to explicitly formalize disagreeing superposition. Without permitting Aethus-valued stated-attributes, the construction would not be expressible in the framework without an alternative axiomatization performing equivalent work.

3.6.6 Step 6: From Boolean Conjunction to Aethic Intersection, with Directionality

Sentential logic. The conjunction $P \wedge Q$ is true if both P and Q are true. Conjunction and disjunction are dual operations on equal footing in the Boolean algebra.

Aethic logic. The Aethic intersection, $A \cap B$, is ontologically asymmetric to the Aethic union along the parent-child Aethus structure. Specifically:

- The Aethic *intersection* of two Aethae moves the informational state toward the child Aethus direction. Adding information instills logical conjunction, directly asserting that multiple states coexist.
- The Aethic *union* of two Aethae moves the informational state toward the parent Aethus direction. Removing information instills logical disjunction, creating a conceptual blank that becomes, upon retrieval, a superposition by the Second Postulate.

Two pathways to physical AND. This is the central mechanical content of the Union Principle's reframing. Both pathways result in both possible options physically occurring at once in the block universe (physical AND). The difference between them is the direction traversed on the Aethic tree:

- **Additive pathway** (intersection): more specification, child Aethus direction, both states asserted as present.

[82] An important corollary worth flagging: Aethae formed by Aethic addition are automatically *fully proper child Aethae* of the result in the strong sense, not merely child Aethae. This is what makes the construction below well-defined as one axiomatization choice; alternative formalizations achieving the same direct static-Aethus-based construction in a single step are conceivable but would require additional (or perhaps more clever) axiomatic machinery.

- **Subtractive pathway** (union): less specification, parent Aethus direction, blank materializing as superposition by the Second Postulate.

The two pathways converge on the same phenomenal output (physical co-occupation), but they traverse opposite directions on the Aethic tree to get there.

Load-bearing consequence. Sentential logic flattens this directionality. There is no parent-child structure at the propositional level; conjunctions and disjunctions are symmetric duals. Aethic logic's directionality is what allows the agreeing superposition of A and B to be *not equivalent* to the intersection $A \cap B$, even though both render as physical AND. The agreeing superposition forces the common attribute's encoding to be blank (subtractive pathway); the intersection forces both attributes into the Aethus (additive pathway). They traverse opposite directions and render identically. This is the specific flattening that Aethic logic recovers from sentential logic.

3.6.7 Step 7: From Standard Contradiction to Aethic Contradiction

Sentential logic. A contradiction is a proposition that is both asserted and denied, $P \wedge \neg P$. Contradictions are problematic because they entail every proposition (*ex falso quodlibet*), making the theory uninformative.

Aethic logic. An *Aethic contradiction* is a stronger form of contradiction unique to Aethic reasoning: it is a configuration that produces an *invalid Aethus* rather than just a false proposition. The crucial structural fact is that any child of an invalid Aethus is also invalid—invalidity propagates through the parent-child structure. This means that Aethic contradictions are not isolated propositional failures but global structural failures of the Aethic configuration.

The pattern-matching pitfall. A subtle but important point about Aethic contradiction is that, under a classical-reductionist view, many Aethic features observed in nature would be effectively misclassified as contradictions by simple pattern-matching to the sentential-logic schema $P \wedge \neg P$. The canonical example is quantum coherence itself: an electron simultaneously traversing both slits in a double-slit experiment can be read, under the classical paradigm, as a textbook contradiction—the electron went through Slit A and the electron did not go through Slit A. The Bohr tradition has long recognized this misclassification, articulating that quantum superposition is neither logical "and" nor logical "or" [50]; but the resolution available within that tradition leaves quantum logical antirealism (discussed earlier in the paper) as the price to be paid. The classical paradigm's misclassification can be flagged but cannot be structurally repaired at the level of the underlying logic itself.

The two-step structure of Aethic invalidity. Aethic logic resolves this with a two-step structural maneuver that has no analogue in sentential logic. The first move *narrows* the phenomenology of contradiction: many configurations the classical paradigm would classify as contradictions are, under the Aethic Union Principle, reclassified as Aethic superpositions (specifically, agreeing superpositions or disagreeing superpositions of the stated-attributes involved). Only configurations consisting of multiple disjoint stated-attributes *deliberately stated in the same Aethus or its 2-Aethae* survive as Aethic contradictions in the formal sense. The phenomenology of contradiction is therefore retracted from where the classical paradigm placed it. The second move *widens* the phenomenology again, but along a new axis: an Aethic contradiction is generalized to the broader category of an *invalid Aethus*, of which the formal Aethic contradiction is an instance rather than the whole. Invalidity can arise from sources beyond stated-attribute contradiction—most importantly from third-postulate pruning, but also from any further invalidation sources the framework licenses downstream.

Two views of "contradiction." The result is that the framework operates with two structurally distinct readings of what "contradiction" might mean:

- As a *phenomenology*—the "no-go" character of configurations that genuinely cannot obtain—which is preserved for invalid Aethae exclusively.
- As a *classification scheme* under the classical logical paradigm—which the framework shows misclassifies many cases as contradictions when they are actually well-defined Aethic superpositions.

The total "invalid Aethus" concept is the Aethic phenomenological analogue of contradiction, distinct from the formal term "Aethic contradiction" (which is reserved for the narrower case of multiple disjoint stated-attributes). This gives the concept both an alien feel—because it deals fluently in superpositions that the classical view would have rejected—and a recognizable no-go feel—because invalid Aethae genuinely cannot obtain. The two readings are not in tension; they operate on different structural objects.

Load-bearing consequence. The two-step structure—first narrowing contradiction's phenomenology to Aethic contradictions, then broadening it to invalid Aethae in general—is what enables the Third Postulate's recursive formulation. Aethic contradictions provide the base cases at which the validity check bottoms out, and the broader category of "invalid Aethus" incorporates third-postulate-derived invalidities, attribute-contradiction invalidities, and any further invalidity sources the framework develops downstream as effective base cases for the recursion. The formal statement

$$V[A] \implies \exists B \leq A, \forall C \leq B, V[C]$$

("validity requires an escape from check") is therefore a constraint on the graph-theoretic structure of valid Aethae, not on the propositional content of any single Aethus. Sentential logic cannot represent this structural pruning because it has neither the parent-child Aethus structure to operate on nor the two-step contradiction-then-invalidity maneuver to anchor the recursion. The two moves together—specifying contradictions as a phenomenology to the Aethic-contradiction subset, then broadening that phenomenology to all invalid Aethae—are perhaps the seed of Aethic reasoning's revolutionary potential (if there is one), in that the specification-then-broadening pattern is effectively unreachable from sentential logic alone.

3.6.8 Step 8: From Static Truth Tables to Dynamic Validity Checks

Sentential logic. The semantics of a Boolean formula is given by a truth table: for each assignment of truth values to atomic propositions, the formula either holds or fails. Truth tables are static; they enumerate all possible worlds and check the formula in each.

Aethic logic. The semantics of an Aethic configuration is given by the Third Postulate's two-generational validity check. An Aethus is valid if and only if there exists a proper child Aethus all of whose proper children are themselves valid—"check" is escapable if there exists at least one safe move (existential); the move is "safe" if every subsequent move from it is valid (universal). This $\exists$-$\forall$ alternation gives the validity operator its characteristic shape, which is structurally distinct from the truth-table evaluation of Boolean formulas.

A calibration remark, load-bearing for the corpus and therefore stated at the source: the two-generational check quantifies over proper children, and a proper child is any descendant. The relation is reflexive and transitive, because the Attribute Set compacts any number of jumps into one—a chain of child edges $A \to A \cdot C_1 \to A \cdot C_1 \cdot C_2$ is the single child edge $A \to A \cdot (C_1 C_2)$, and for proper children the same compaction holds by composition of declared decompositions, $A \rightsquigarrow bB + cC$ and $B \rightsquigarrow dD + eE$ giving $A \rightsquigarrow bdD + (beE + cC)$ with bd visible against the combined remainder under the composition property of Definition 37, the product of the added Aethae being itself one Aethus—so there is no such thing as a "single-level" proper child, and no reading of the postulate's quantifiers over an immediate-child relation was ever the framework's. (An earlier form of this remark, an insertion of the AI-assisted drafting and not of the framework, asserted the opposite, calibrating the quantifiers to single applications and calling the transitive reading a different postulate; it was wrong, and the author's May 2023 statement of the proper child Aethus already had the relation ranging arbitrarily far down the graph. The remark is corrected here and the correction propagated, (subsubsection 9.4.3).) One consequence is a simplification the fixed-point restatement below records: over a transitive relation the doom iteration closes at its first stage, since a state every one of whose descendants has a contradiction beneath it already has that property in one application, and the postulate's own $\exists\forall$ statement is therefore not the seed of a recursion but its closed form.

Load-bearing consequence. Sentential logic's truth-table semantics evaluates configurations in isolation; each row is independent. Aethic logic's validity check propagates across the Aethic tree, pruning configurations whose descendants would force contradictions. This is what gives Aethic logic its derivational capacity for the collapse postulate: the validity check, applied across the tree of possible

futures, produces collapse as a logical consequence rather than as a postulated mechanism. It is also worth mentioning that even in the content of the distinction between the Aethic intersection and Aethic union is there structure which becomes flattened in the static sentential logic equivalent, particularly as concerns the Aethic ladder ontology and the distinction between disagreeing superpositions and sentential exclusive or.

3.6.9 Why Aethic Logic Supersedes Sentential Logic

The cumulative effect of the eight transitions above is the framework's basis for the claim that Aethic logic supersedes sentential logic. The claim is not that sentential logic is incorrect—it remains a correct calculus at its level of abstraction—but that it *flattens structural distinctions* that the Aethic apparatus makes apparent. The specific flattenings recovered are:

1. The backend/frontend separation between Aethus-level manipulation and block-universe observation, bridged by the Aethic retrieval function—which sentential logic does not have because it has no Aethus/block-universe distinction.

2. Direction on the Aethic tree (parent vs. child), which sentential logic does not represent.

3. The agreeing versus disagreeing superposition distinction, which sentential logic conflates under a single "or" or sometimes even as an "and" depending on the context in which it is used[83].

4. The graph-theoretic propagation of invalidity, which sentential logic handles only via local contradiction.

5. The dynamic two-generational validity check of the Third Postulate, which has no sentential-logic analogue.

The Union Principle is the move that exposes flattenings 2 and 3 most directly, and by exposing them it licenses the apparatus required for flattenings 4 and 5 to operate. It is, structurally, the load-bearing reform that makes the supersession claim cogent.

This concludes the pedagogical recap. The reader interested in the technical applications of the Aethic logical apparatus—particularly the derivation of the double-slit observer effect, the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, and the reduced-form coupling mechanism—may now proceed to the subsequent sections with the structural map of the framework's logical foundations in hand.

3.7 From the Intrinsic Layer to Weighting

The intrinsic layer is now complete. An Aethus is its closed content; its attributes are graded by their fillings, which are also their retrievals; its contradictions are empty fillings, kept as tags; and its operations are joint assertion and the sum that keeps its terms, whose core is their last common ancestor. What the layer cannot say is how much: a sum lists its terms without weighing them. Section 4 adds the weights, and with them the commutative semiring that the 2024 presentation announced at this point, in the subsubsection kept below.

3.7.1 Basics of the Aethic Ring Operations

Let us take this moment to declare that the Aethic tree, once we define it in the coming *weighted* sense, will form a mathematical *commutative semiring*—that is, a ring in every respect except for the availability of additive inverses, whose deliberate exclusion (a standing decision of the framework, motivated in full where the weighted formulation is constructed, Section 6.7, and applied to this section in the June 2026 pass) is what preserves invalid Aethae as distinct, unique labels rather than permitting them to collapse into a single cancellable class. In such a commutative semiring, the Aethic union operation, $\cup$, is to represent the addition operation, and the Aethic intersection operation, $\cap$ is to represent the multiplication operation. As such, we are to use $\cup$ and $+$ interchangeably when referring to Aethae, and furthermore will use $\cap$ and $\times$ interchangeably for Aethae. Such a thing is to only be conjectured at the moment, but will be rigorously grounded in a devoted section to the (semi)ring axioms later in the paper. The intuition behind it, of course, is that it indeed perfectly mirrors the addition and multiplication rules of probability anyway—rules which are themselves non-negative from

[83]This inconsistency as depending on the logical versus physical domains is itself part of the problem with sentential logic on this front.

the outset, which is a first hint that the commutative semiring, rather than the ring, was always the natural home.

4 Incorporation of Aethic Weighting

4.1 Practical Motivation of Weighting Aethae

We might see something of a major issue brewing in the way we have defined an Aethus thus far, where we are unable to define more nuanced states between instantiating an Aethic attribute versus leaving it perfectly blank. Even the dichotomy theorem, so far at least, implies the hard subdivision into present versus blank attributes. This model does not fit with how we know our universe to exist, where probabilities are far more dynamic than this dichotomous mindset. From both philosophical and probabilistic lenses, this simply will not do.

As such, let us consider the notion of adding intermediate weighting to Aethic attribute presence, which will ultimately prove vital to our accurate procedure in describing the nuance of reality. Notice that the innovations which we are about to make, although not technically directly expressible in the mathematical framework thus far depicted, are nonetheless extremely natural to the mathematics which we have been building in the form of an extension. That is, rather than clashing with what we have designed thus far, these approaches will instead help amplify their accordance with the philosophical background from which they are based. Let us, then, proceed with some of these ideas.

4.2 Centric Unfolding: The Process, Its Axiomatization, and Aethic Time

To begin with, consider what is perhaps the primary appearance of weighted Aethae in our day-to-day lives: *the notion of how we move along the Aethic dimension.* At present we have no rendition of the "kinematics" of sorts for how one moves on the Aethic dimension, so in the very least we need an evident mathematical formulation which depicts such things. Such a framework is what we will refer to as *centric unfolding*, which can be considered our chosen interpretation for the rules which an agent's correspondent string of Aethae must follow. Here is such a principle written out in language.

Principle of Centric Unfolding

Centric unfolding is what we will refer to as the *default interpretation of Aethic reasoning*, although we must note that it is only a convention. In this way, it might represent the current outer boundary of Aethic reasoning with regard to its ontological footprint, because while we know that it agrees with our current understanding of the empiricism, we nonetheless have to acknowledge that it operates on substantially shakier ground than something like an Aethic postulate. That is, it holds a similar risk of invalidity to what the classical interpretation of the tricky principle held when we changed it to the second postulate of the Aethus. In much the same way, a future generation of scientists may very well view this stepping stone as archaic, but at present it is the best supposition we are able to make given our current understanding of where Occam's razor is to be best applied.

This now being said, the convention of centric unfolding can be expressed as the assumption of the two following axioms.

1. Every past Aethus which an agent inhabited is to serve as a parent Aethus to their current Aethus.

2. Upon adding a new attribute to one's Aethus, its state is drawn from its standing superposition at random[a].

This assumption can be seen as a tool for our approaching the agent-based Aethic interpretation of reality, but through its relative empirical flimsiness can only ever be a hypothesis at present. Also please quickly note that for an agent to move across the Aethic dimension in a way which is consistent with these axioms can be referred to as said agent "centric unfolding." That way we are able to use the term both as a noun, (designating the principle), and a verb, (designating the act of doing it oneself). To contrast, any proposed hypothetical alternatives to centric unfolding might be called "extra-centric unfolding[b]" interpretations of Aethic reasoning.

[a] So, to be fully clear, centric unfolding is effectively another one of Aethic reasoning's major sifting endeavors. Standard probability theory already defines a probability measure without any observation process, a stochastic process being additional structure, as in Kolmogorov's axiomatization; what Aethic reasoning adds is an ontological reading of the weights, and a separation of that weighting structure from its realization. The probabilities themselves are static and intrinsic to the Aethus, so as to be stored as Aethic weights in a current Aethus, and irrespective of the act of the learning itself. (So if you will, probabilities are by analogy like potential energy, as opposed to the dynamical accessing of its reserves with kinetic energy). The second step, however, is centric unfolding itself, which is the proposal for the nature of the act of learning itself. Fundamentally speaking, probabilities are not contained or otherwise encoded in centric unfolding, but instead are only passively accessed by it. Such is key to allowing probability to be fundamental to Aethic reasoning, while maintaining the freedom to potentially tweak centric unfolding in a future theoretical descendant of Aethic reasoning. But altogether, the key outcome is that the stochastic nature of probability is simply the passive realization of it, without having to also encode it actively.

[b] And, perhaps fittingly, (even if accidental on my part regarding the naming), these interpretations would indeed be quite "eccentric" in their furthered metaphysical peculiarity.

Given this stance, an important question becomes available to us: *what then is probability?* Consider some particular agent, whose current Aethus is A_1, with some past Aethus to that being A_0. Centric unfolding gives the corollary that *a valid proper child of an Aethus, a cell of one of its admissible resolutions, holds a probability of being realized proportional to its weight in the validity quotient*, made exact below without privileging any step: the relevant outcomes are validity classes within a specified admissible resolution, not arbitrary raw descendants or individual representatives of those classes. In the case of A_1, we know that the superposition of possible child Aethae that might be drawn from A_0 can itself be represented with the Aethic union operation. Specifically, consider an admissible resolution of A_0, a declared splitting of it into mutually exclusive cells, and call the set of cells some C. (Notice how the Aethic superposition of the cells is simply A_0 again). Where such a set represents the superposition of all possibilities which follow from A_0, then we know that for A_1 to be drawn from such a set at random should, by centric unfolding, match in probability the weighting that A_1 holds in such a set. Because the superposition of the set is just A_0 itself, then, we hold that *the probability that A_0's resolution by C lands in A_1 is equal to the weight of A_1 in A_0's validity quotient*, as made exact below. Remember, this is so where weight itself is merely a representation of, in the most practical sense, what proportion of an Aethic superposition implies a particular Aethus.

Centric unfolding says nothing about what generally will be the next thing you learn, but rather

given any particular Aethic attitude a, it enforces that over all possible random Markovian futures of yours in which a is state-decomposable, the proportion in which each possible stated-attribute is the one realized is directly proportional to the Aethic weight of that stated-attribute in your current Aethus, under the condition made exact below. What is important about this is therefore that centric unfolding is a constraint applicable to such a whether you happen to pick it up in the near term of Aethic time or in the far term—therefore in the process de-privileging the notion of "sooner" attributes. That is, the Markovian process itself is free to unveil in a variety of ways, and all centric unfolding does is constrain it rather than define it uniquely—still you have merely to for each candidate new attitude weigh it operably against centric unfolding, rather than have that candidate attribute selected for you. Defining the Markovian process any further than this is considered by the philosophy of centric unfolding to violate *hypotheses non fingo*, ultimately making centric unfolding's constraint power valued under the assumption of including a specified attribute argument rather than an Aethus alone being sufficient.

The draw law, made exact. The probability statement needs its event fixed, and it makes two claims that must be kept apart. Let $\mathcal{P}$ be an admissible resolution of an Aethus, a declared splitting into mutually exclusive cells. The *local law* is the axiom: conditional on the current pre-resolution Aethus and the specified resolution, the outcome is distributed as that Aethus's normalized weights in the validity quotient (subsubsection 4.8.2), a valid proper child A_i realized with probability $w(A_i)/\sum_{j\ \text{valid}} w(A_j)$, its coefficient in the reduced form (subsection 6.6) relative to the reduced form's total, and invalid cells, tagged and pruned, never. The probability of realized content is evaluated on the quotient. Write q for the validity-quotient map and read the example in T, the cells being weighted Aethae and $B + I$ the combination $1 \cdot B + 1 \cdot I$: with A and B valid and I and J invalid, a model may admit $B + I$ as a cell beneath A and not $B + J$, yet $q(B + I) = q(B + J) = q(B)$, so raw accessibility distinguishes expressions that represent the same surviving content. Although $B + J$ is not itself an admitted proper child of A, its validity class is accessible, because that class also contains the admitted proper child $B + I$: writing $\mathcal{D}_Q(A) = \{q(X) : X \text{ an admitted proper child of } A\}$, $q(B + J) \in \mathcal{D}_Q(A)$, witnessed by $B + I$.[84] Raw visitation probability therefore cannot simply be identified with the probability of realized content, an inaccessible representative having visitation probability zero while its class is an accessible outcome. The unfolding may still be represented at the level of raw states, a raw-level model inducing the probability of each class by collecting the histories that realize it; what is ruled out is identifying the wrong events, not describing the process probabilistically. The local law is a statement about one partition. It is not a statement about the next step, since the chain may resolve other attributes first or several at once, and it is not a statement about all proper descendants at once: a chain that acquires a descendant's content acquires the content of that descendant's ancestors too, so visitation events of descendants overlap and cannot be the outcomes of one draw.

The *asymptotic law* relates the initial Aethus A_0 to what the chain eventually realizes, and it is stated in the limit of Aethic time deliberately: in the limit the two axioms are uniquely clarifying by definition, while across the class of finite stages they are not guaranteed to determine the chain, though at particular finite stages they may. On the methodological ground of *hypotheses non fingo* the framework declines any further axiom guaranteeing the realized proper child's probability at finite stages, since such an axiom would fix a schedule; that is a reason for declining, not a proof that no further assumption could be justified. The uniqueness claimed is of outcome proportions for a specified eventual resolution, not of an asymptotic law for the entire unfolding process, which would be substantially stronger: processes resolving the same attribute at different times have different finite-time distributions and the same eventual outcome distribution. Let R be the event that $\mathcal{P}$ is eventually resolved. As Aethic time runs on, the probability that the chain has realized A_i tends to $P(R)\,P(A_i \mid R, A_0)$, and the asymptotic law is the equality of $P(A_i \mid R, A_0)$ with A_i's weight in A_0's validity quotient. The limiting law includes non-resolution: the probabilities of realizing the mutually exclusive cells sum to $P(R)$, which need not be one, and the claim is the conditional endpoint law, guaranteed resolution being its case $P(R) = 1$. That equality does not follow from the local law. It holds when resolution is guaranteed, $P(R) = 1$, and the weights are updated coherently along the

[84] *2026-10-06, 11:44 AM*

Note also that a trivial counterexample to asymptotic (importantly because the asymptotic Aethic time limit is exactly where the axioms of centric unfolding become uniquely-clarifying in place of underdetermined, hence why adding more axioms to make the same the case earlier violates hypotheses non fingo) centric unfolding probability valuing weighted Aethae proper rather than the validity quotient space is that we might enforce B + I as a proper child Aethus of A but not B + J for valid A and B and invalid I and J, YET notice how in the invalidity quotient B + J IS a proper child Aethus because it maps to the same as B + I directly!

chain, the local law at each stage then averaging back to the initial weights; where resolution is not guaranteed it is an assumption about admissible unfolding processes, the *non-selection assumption* $P(A_i \mid R, A_0) = P(A_i \mid A_0)$. Without it, conditioning on eventual resolution shifts the proportions: a fair binary attribute with a correlated signal, resolved only after the signal value under which its conditional weight is 0.75, takes that value three times in four among the futures in which it is resolved, although its initial weight is 0.5, the local law holding at every stage.

Across nested resolutions the quotient probabilities themselves must be consistent: for a coarse cell B of an admissible resolution and a finer cell $F \subseteq B$ of a nested one, $p_{A_0}(F) = p_{A_0}(B)\, p_B(F)$ and $p_{A_0}(B) = \sum_{F \subseteq B} p_{A_0}(F)$. The coefficient conditions in the hypotheses of Theorem 9, declared decompositions composing and coefficients coherent and additive, secure these identities for raw coefficients. After pruning they secure them only if each coarse cell's probability is the surviving total of its valid finer cells rather than its raw coefficient renormalized at the coarse level, since different branches can lose different amounts of weight to pruning; the identities for the quotient probabilities are therefore required of admissible unfolding processes here, not derived.

Three specifications, kept apart. A *local draw law* constrains the outcome probabilities at each actual resolution, conditional on the current Aethus; an *asymptotic outcome law* constrains the eventual outcome probabilities for a specified resolution; a *scheduling rule* would fix which attribute resolves next, and when. The local draw law is the box's axiom, and it leaves scheduling open. The asymptotic outcome law is the commitment the design is organized around: it follows from the local law under coherent updating together with guaranteed resolution or the non-selection assumption. No scheduling rule is adopted, and stating the distinction adds none.

Underdetermination, by *hypotheses non fingo*. Made exact, the point is what keeps the two axioms from privileging the near term. Call a *centric-unfolding process* any Markov chain $A_0, A_1, A_2, \ldots$ on Aethae satisfying the two axioms: *parenthood*, that each A_t is a parent of A_{t+1}, so that nothing stated is ever un-stated except by the reopening the framework separately prices; and the *draw law*, that whenever an attribute a passes from blank to stated along the chain, the realized stated-attribute is distributed as a's weights in the validity quotient of the Aethus at which it resolves. Three things follow from the form of these axioms, and there is no fourth. First, the axioms are not guaranteed to determine the chain. They say nothing about *which* blank attribute resolves next, nothing about how many resolve together, and nothing about the order in which independent attributes resolve: for any admissible chain, and any two attributes whose weights are unaffected by each other's resolution, the chain that resolves them in the other order is admissible too, since parenthood is preserved and each still resolves by its own weights at its own Aethus; two such chains are distinct admissible Markov processes with the same asymptotic attribute probabilities, their finite-time distributions differing, one having resolved the first attribute where the other has resolved the second, while their eventual outcome distributions agree, which shows the admissible family both non-empty and genuinely underdetermined; and a chain that interposes any number of other resolutions between two given ones is admissible for the same reason. The admissible chains form a family, in general not a point, and centric unfolding is the family's defining constraint rather than a member of it. Second, this is where *hypotheses non fingo* does its work. A rule that fixed the schedule—that the most probable attribute resolves first, say, or that resolution proceeds at a fixed rate in some clock—would be a hypothesis about the near term of Aethic time, privileging what is learned sooner over what is learned later; the framework feigns no such hypothesis, and the draw law is stated so as to bind an attribute whenever it resolves, in the near term or the far, which is exactly what leaves the schedule open. The de-privileging of "sooner" is therefore not an added doctrine but a consequence of stating only the two axioms and refusing a third. Third, the axioms are nonetheless far from empty, because a constraint is used by what it excludes. A process that resolves some attribute toward a favored value at a frequency other than its quotient weight in the Aethus at which it resolves violates the draw law; a process in which a later Aethus fails to have an inhabited earlier one as parent, so that stated content is silently forgotten or contradicted without reopening, violates parenthood; and any proposed dynamics of information gain can be tested against both without the framework having to say which admissible chain is the actual one. That is how the axioms are meant to be used: as the test of what does *not* consist with centric unfolding, with the actual Markovian process left underdetermined, deliberately, up to and including uniqueness.[85]

[85] *2026-10-02*

The author's statement of the point, from which this paragraph was drafted: by explicit hypotheses non fingo the two axioms of centric unfolding leave the actual centric unfolding Markovian process still underdetermined up to uniqueness and all, which is important for those axioms not privileging the "near term" in time and all. (But those

4.2.1 The Process and the Axiomatization

"Centric unfolding" names two things.[86] The first job is ontological: the *centric-unfolding process* is the actual Markov chain of Aethae an agent traverses, one object, the agent's life read as a sequence of information states. The second job is axiomatic: the *axiomatization of centric unfolding* is the pair of constraints stated in the box above, which the process is asserted to satisfy and which, as the underdetermination paragraph shows, single out a family of admissible chains, not in general a member. The relation between the two is the relation between a law and its solutions: the axiomatization is stated, the process is the one solution the agent happens to be, and nothing in the axioms says which.

Definition 21 (Centric-unfolding process, Aethic time)
Let an agent traverse Aethae $A_0, A_1, A_2, \ldots$, each the agent's own at some stage of life. The centric-unfolding process *is this sequence read as a Markov chain on Aethae. The Markov property is a modeling proposal, stated rather than derived from the indexed ontology: the current Aethus, as the agent's complete information state, is taken to contain everything the conditional law of the future depends on.* Aethic time *is any coordinate t on the chain that respects parenthood: $s < t$ whenever A_s is a parent of A_t and the two are distinct, so that every Aethus the agent has inhabited is ordered before each of its proper children in the chain. Aethic time orders the chain and nothing else; it is not a clock, carries no units, and is defined only along the one agent's chain.*

The first axiom of the box is the statement that the chain is ordered at all: parenthood holds between every earlier and every later member, so Aethic time is well defined along it. The second is the draw law along that order. Aethic time is therefore the coordinate the axioms are indexed against, and that indexing is where the framework parts from the standard picture.

Definition 22 (Location and realization)
For an event e, its location $x(e)$ *is the spacetime position at which it is physically located, including the proper-time moment along the agent's own worldline where that is defined. Location belongs to the attribute and not to its value: the attribute "what happened at x" is located at x whether or not its value is stated, and every rendering of the block universe in the superposition agrees on that location while differing on the value. Its* realization coordinate $\tau(e)$ *is the Aethic time at which the attribute carrying*

two axioms are still highly important because they admit use in finding that which DOES NOT consist with the Markovian process, in being constraints on it and all!)

[86] *2026-10-02, 5:25 PM*

I also would be able to sleep easier at night lol concerning the reception of the framework if the centric unfolding subsection itself gets drastically expanded to axiomatic thoroughness and all, ad pertains to for example distinguishing centric unfolding the ontological Markovian process from centric unfolding the axiomatization, AND crucially the centric unfolding Markovian process from the standard metaphysical paradigm's ''moving present determinacy resolution'', because they are superficially similar, but the central Aethic distinction's seed is very much present here, where here for this centric unfolding Markovian process we index against AETHIC TIME (ie a parametrization coordinate of the full ''chain'' of the Aethae you traversed throughout life constrained such that all your own specific parent Aethae are ordered as less than the later ones in the chain, ie their proper child Aethae) and--here's the crucial seed itself--even proper time past-located events drop out of Aethic superposition with your centric unfolding Markovian realization, or more specifically you decouple the proper time moment / block universe spacetime location/position where the event is physically located from the coordinate (either Aethic time, or if you use proper time as your coordinate under the assumption of monotonicity with Aethic time, so no closed timelike curves allowed for that!) of centric unfolding Markovian realization, and then soley privilege the latter for determinacy by the first postulate of the Aethus, then THAT is how things work in Aethic reasoning, with as explained in the language section the standard moving present unfolding idea being something like a limiting case-ish idealization of taking the Aethic intersection of EVERY human on Earth and looking at their joint centric unfolding, such that roughly speaking everything that happens is in somebody's Aethic sphere and so we approximate the combined centric unfolding moving present of everybody as basically ''filling in'' the whole past--although even this of course doesn't fully cover it, so then we'd imagine ''filling in the gaps'' like the tree that falls in the forest, but notice already how that's a philosophical question available to be asked by the standard metaphysical paradigm, hence hinting to me that this combined-centric unfolding object is deep enough into the human psyche that it might itself constitute the very innate assumption among humans (or at least all known allistic humans, and as far as we currently know all humans in general) which blocked off even conceptualizing the Aethic metaphysics, as obvious as it is once stated as just this centric unfolding Markovian process. Anyways, thanks! And yes note that the current subsection is ''Practical Motivation of Weighting Aethae'', so I want to rearrange that to either break into two so that centric unfolding can be the star of a subsection, or otherwise center the spotlight on centric unfolding. Thanks!

5:37 PM

Sure, that fix sounds good thank you--and yeah to be clear the mature idea is that it's a Markov process over AETHAE, see, and the ''blocks'' are not separate spacetimes but simply one single spacetime/block universe relative to different Aethae, (hence entertaining a homomorphism between the Aethae of the Markov chain proper and the ''rendering'' of the block, which is sort of like different block just not physically). That's all supposed to be explicitly clear, not just here but throughout the paper. Thanks!

e passes from blank to stated in the agent's chain, that is, the index of the first Aethus in the chain whose closed content states that attribute; $\tau(e)$ is undefined when no Aethus of the chain ever states it.

Definition 23 (The decoupling, and the indexing of determinacy)
Location and realization are distinct data of an event: $x(e)$ is fixed by the block and $\tau(e)$ by the chain, and neither generally determines the other. An event located in the agent's proper-time past may have a realization coordinate later than any Aethus the agent currently inhabits, or none; an event located in the agent's proper-time future may be realized now, by a stated prediction, with its location untouched. By the first postulate of the Aethus, determinacy relative to the agent is indexed by $\tau(e)$ alone: e is determinate relative to A_t exactly when $\tau(e) \leq t$, and otherwise its attribute is in superposition relative to A_t, whatever $x(e)$ is.

This is the seed of the framework's central distinction, at the smallest scale it appears. A past-located event does not drop out of superposition by being past; it drops out with the agent's realization of it, and until then it is blank relative to the agent's Aethus however far back in the block it sits. The decoupling does not say the location is unreal or unfixed; the block universe is one, and $x(e)$ is as definite as any coordinate. It says that the block's coordinate is not the coordinate of determinacy, and that the framework's privilege runs to the realization coordinate and to it only.

Definition 24 (Rendering)
There is one block universe. Each Aethus A renders *it: $\rho(A)$ is the block as it stands relative to A, its stated attributes determinate at their values and its blank attributes in superposition, with every attribute at its location. The rendering map ρ is order-preserving from the chain to the renderings: if A is a parent of B then $\rho(B)$ refines $\rho(A)$, agreeing with it on everything A states and determinate on more. The Markov process is a process on Aethae, and the sequence of renderings $\rho(A_0), \rho(A_1), \ldots$ is what the locution "a Markov chain of block universes" names: one block universe rendered relative to successive Aethae, and never a plurality of spacetimes.*

Proposition 18 (Proper time as the unfolding coordinate)
Suppose, as an explicit hypothesis, that the agent's proper time π along their worldline is monotone in Aethic time: for members A_s, A_t of the chain with $s < t$, the proper-time moment at which the agent inhabits A_s precedes that at which they inhabit A_t. The absence of closed timelike curves does not by itself establish this, since revisiting a spacetime event would not mean revisiting the same accumulated proper-time reading; the monotonicity is assumed, not derived. Then proper time serves as a coordinate for the centric-unfolding process, and the realization coordinate of an event may be read as the proper-time moment of its realization, $\pi(\tau(e))$. The decoupling of Definition 23 is unchanged by the change of coordinate: $\pi(\tau(e))$ and $x(e)$ remain distinct data, neither generally determining the other, and determinacy is still indexed by the former.

Proof
A monotone map from the chain's order to the worldline's proper time is order-preserving, so composing it with Aethic time gives a coordinate that respects parenthood, which is all Definition 21 asks of a coordinate. The decoupling is a statement about which coordinate determinacy is indexed by, and the change of coordinate relabels that index without moving the event's location.

4.2.2 Centric Unfolding Against Moving-Present Determinacy

The standard metaphysical paradigm has a picture that looks like centric unfolding and is not, *moving-present determinacy resolution*: there is a present moment, it moves, and an event becomes determinate when the present reaches its location, so that determinacy is indexed by $x(e)$ against the present, e being settled exactly when $x(e)$ lies at or before now. The superficial resemblance is real: both pictures have something advancing, both have events passing from open to settled as it advances, and both can be drawn as a chain. The difference is the coordinate. The moving present indexes determinacy by *location*; centric unfolding indexes it by *realization*. On the moving-present picture the tree that falls in the forest is settled the moment it falls, whether or not anyone will ever know; on the centric-unfolding picture it is blank relative to every Aethus whose chain never realizes it, and settled relative to each that does, at that chain's own coordinate. Nothing in the second picture denies that the tree fell at some location in the block; it denies that the location is what settles the matter for anyone.

Proposition 19 (When the two coincide)
Relative to one agent, moving-present determinacy and centric-unfolding determinacy agree on every event located in the agent's proper-time past exactly when every such event is realized no later than it

is located: $\tau(e) \leq t$ whenever $x(e)$ lies at or before the proper-time moment of A_t. No single agent's chain satisfies this condition, since an agent realizes only what enters their Aethus, and the block holds events at every past location that never do.

Proof
Moving-present determinacy at A_t is the predicate $x(e) \leq \pi(t)$; centric-unfolding determinacy is $\tau(e) \leq t$. The two predicates coincide on the past-located events iff the first implies the second there, which is the stated condition, the converse implication holding trivially for realized past-located events. The failure for a single agent is the existence of past-located events the agent's chain never states, which is the ordinary condition of any finite observer.

The moving present as a limiting idealization. The standard picture is a limit. Take every human on Earth, each with their own chain, and form at each stage the Aethic intersection of their Aethae, the joint assertion of everything any of them has stated; given a specified alignment of their stages, and provided the Aethae combined at each stage are compatible, so that their joint assertion is not tagged, this *joint centric unfolding* is a parent-ordered sequence, since the intersection of parents is a parent of the intersection of their children, and it realizes an event as soon as any member does. It is not automatically a valid joint observer-state, nor automatically a Markov process; the idealization assumes both. Roughly speaking, everything that happens is in somebody's Aethic sphere, so the joint chain's realization coordinates lie close to the events' locations, and its determinacy approximates moving-present determinacy: the joint chain "fills in" the past nearly as the moving present would. Nearly, and not entirely: the events no human ever realizes remain blank relative to the joint chain, and the standard paradigm's way of closing that remainder, imagining the gaps filled in, the tree settled with no one there, is a stipulation and not a further observer. The moving-present picture is therefore the idealization in which the joint chain is completed, every located event assigned a realization coordinate equal to its location; it is a limiting case of centric unfolding, with the limit taken by fiat over exactly the events that cannot be shown to have been realized.

A conjecture about why the distinction was not seen. Why a distinction this obvious once stated went unconceptualized for so long is a conjecture, the author's, and not a result. The joint object just described, the combined centric unfolding of everyone, is deep enough in the human psyche that it may itself be the innate assumption, among humans in general as far as is currently known, that blocked the Aethic metaphysics from being conceived: the moving present is not an inference anyone makes but the form in which the joint realization of one's whole community is given to a social animal, and treating it as the coordinate of determinacy is the default that had to be noticed before it could be declined. The language section's observation that the paradigm's own question about the unobserved tree is already available to it is the evidence that the question was asked from inside the idealization rather than from outside it. That the framework's picture reads as obvious once stated as a Markovian process, and was nonetheless unavailable before, is what the conjecture would explain. subsubsection 12.1.3 reaches the same object from the side of language: the shared ledger as the closure of everyone's realized content under the dropping convention, with the present as that closure's boundary and its motion as the closure's growth, selected for by the coordination that language serves. The conjecture here and the selection argument there are two routes to one diagnosis, the one from the coordinate of determinacy and the other from what speech is for.

4.2.3 The Aethic Interpretation of Probability

Before stating this equivalence formally, it is worth pausing to note what is being proposed. The standard interpretations of probability in theoretical mathematics—frequentism, Bayesianism, propensity theory, logical probability—all treat probability as a feature of the world that requires interpretation against an independently-specified reality. What follows is a structurally different kind of move: defining probability as a feature of a specific ontology (the Aethic tree), such that the interpretation is built into the definition rather than being applied to it from outside. The equivalence below is therefore not merely a technical definition within Aethic reasoning; it is a proposed answer to the ontological question of what probability *is*, and one that stands independently of the specific physics applications that motivated Aethic reasoning's development. With this framing in mind, we state the equivalence formally.

Principle 21 (Aethic Equivalence of Weights and Probabilities)
In Aethic reasoning, we hold that the weight of one Aethus in another is ontologically equivalent to the probability of said Aethus with respect to another.

$$\mathrm{P}(A \mid B) = W_B(A) \tag{5}$$

Note that this also serves as the *formal definition of probability in Aethic reasoning.* We further require that every probability attribution in Aethic reasoning have an Aethic reference state, whether written explicitly or suppressed in notation, because an ontologically unindexed probability would violate the first postulate of the Aethus. Marginalizing variables within a fixed index introduces no observer-free vantage and is permitted.

Concept 2 (Aethic Ontological Interpretation of Probability)
The equivalence above licenses a specific interpretation of what probability is, distinct from the standard interpretations in theoretical probability (frequentism, subjective Bayesianism, propensity theories, logical probability). In Aethic reasoning, probability is not a feature of the world that requires interpretation against an independently-specified reality. It is a structural feature of the Aethic tree itself: the weight of one Aethus in another.

This ontological interpretation has three specific properties worth naming explicitly.

1. ***Probability is indexed by construction.*** *Every probability attribution in Aethic reasoning has the form* $\mathrm{P}(A \mid B)$*, where* B *is the Aethus relative to which* A*'s weight is measured, written explicitly or suppressed in notation. Ontologically unindexed probabilities have no referent in the framework, there being no observer-free vantage point from which they could be defined; marginalizing within a fixed index introduces no such vantage and is permitted.*

2. ***Probability is static, not dynamic.*** *The weights are intrinsic structural properties of Aethae, independent of any particular act of observation or learning. Centric unfolding is a separate mechanism that passively accesses the weights to produce the appearance of dynamic selection. The static-dynamic separation allows the interpretation to survive revision of the access mechanism without disturbance to the underlying definition.*

3. ***Frequency and single-event probability are unified.*** *Both cases are instances of the same underlying Aethic weight relation. Single events receive weights from the structural position of their Aethae in the tree, while observed frequencies emerge as the limiting behavior of weights across many Aethic transitions, under the independence or other convergence conditions the laws of large numbers require; that one interpretation covers both is an interpretive achievement, and it does not remove those conditions. Frequentism's objectivity advantage and Bayesianism's single-event advantage are preserved simultaneously because the underlying structural feature is the same in both cases.*

Remark *The Aethic Ontological Interpretation of Probability can be evaluated and potentially adopted independently of the rest of Aethic reasoning. A theoretical probability researcher who finds the interpretation persuasive does not have to accept Aethic reasoning's solution to the measurement problem, or its treatment of anthropic parameters in natural history, or any of the other applications developed later in this paper. The interpretation stands on its own as a structural claim about the ontology of probability, and it can be tested against the standard criteria used to evaluate probability interpretations (single-event coverage, objectivity, handling of conditional versus marginal cases, compatibility with observed frequencies) without reference to the Aethic framework's other commitments.*

The static-dynamic separation encoded in this interpretation is worth elaborating briefly, because it is the feature that distinguishes the Aethic interpretation from both classical probability theory and prior observer-relative approaches. Standard probability theory already separates the two: a probability measure is defined without any observation process, as in Kolmogorov's axiomatization, and a stochastic process is further structure laid on it. What the Aethic interpretation adds is an ontological reading of the measure, the weights being structural features of Aethae, and a named mechanism, centric unfolding, by which an agent comes to occupy successive Aethae and so accesses those standing weights. The probabilities themselves are static and intrinsic to the Aethus, stored as weights, irrespective of the act of learning. Centric unfolding is the separate mechanism that passively accesses these weights to produce the appearance of dynamic selection. By analogy, probabilities are like potential energy, while centric unfolding is the dynamical process through which that potential

is realized. This separation is what allows probability to be ontologically fundamental to Aethic reasoning while leaving the access mechanism (centric unfolding) open to revision in future theoretical descendants of the framework.

Let us now address how we might install the required mathematical formalism needed for Aethic weighting, that way we can satisfy this empirical condition.

The interpretation on the validity quotient. The ontological reading has a precise home in the quotient by validity equivalence (Section 4.8). Removing invalid Aethae is quotienting by validity equivalence, so what the weighting ranges over is the quotient's classes, and a probability is a normalized valuation on them, read as a ratio of weights by the Relational Weight Principle (Section 4.5) where the measure type admits division, and as the pair of weights up to common rescaling by a non-zero-divisor scalar where it does not. Two refinements follow from the weight algebra. The valuation is linear in the weights of a rendered sum's terms, so its additivity holds across terms the records separate, and not across interfering alternatives inside one agreeing term. And it is not a semiring homomorphism, which would send every idempotent carrier to 0 or 1: the Born weights enter through the kernel on terms, which is the business of the physics part.

4.3 The Extrinsic Layer: Disagreeing and Aethic Superposition

Agreeing superposition lives in the intrinsic layer: it is a state (Definition 6). Disagreeing superposition does not. The unweighted Aethic union of one-peg branches keeps the branches as its terms, and its core, their last common ancestor, carries no state on the attribute when the branches share a base that has none, as Definition 25 requires, and no carving of the attribute has a block of two or more pegs. At most the core shares the exclusions common to the branches, so no state of it records which pegs the disagreement ranges over; that information is carried by the terms, and their weights by the weighted sum. The core does carry one intrinsic mark: the single-peg carving c_X, which every branch holds (Definition 12). It records that the superposition is a disjunction of single pegs, and so distinguishes the shadow from the agreeing state over the same pegs. Disagreeing superposition is therefore extrinsic, and so is the general category built on it: no state records its range, which only its terms carry, and its weights live on the weighted sum. Weights enter here only as far as these definitions need: a *weighted Aethus* is a formal sum $\sum_i w_i B_i$ of Aethae with nonzero weights. One convention governs every weight statement of this paper, here and in the weighted formulation of Section 6.7: "nonzero", "positive" and "zero" are read comparatively, a weight counting as zero when it is measure-zero relative to the other weights of the combination it stands in, the strict relative-negligibility relation $\ll$ of the measure type fixing the comparison; at the base case $\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ the reading is the scalar one. The third postulate ignores anything measure-zero relative to anything else there, and a component so ignored is not thereby invalidated.

Definition 25 (Disagreeing superposition)
Let X be an attribute, S a set of its pegs, and B an Aethus with no state on X. For each $a \in S$ let B_a be B with the determinate state $[X : \{a\}]$ added. A disagreeing superposition *of X over S is a weighted sum $\sum_{a\in S} w_a B_a$ with every w_a nonzero. Its* unweighted shadow *is the Aethic union $\sum_{a\in S} B_a$, which keeps the B_a as its terms; its core, the last common ancestor of the B_a (Proposition 12), does not record S.*

A disagreeing superposition resolves no single peg, yet every state within it on X holds one peg only, which is why it can never become agreeing (Proposition 5).

Definition 26 (Aethic-superposition weights)
Let $A = \sum_i w_i B_i$ be a weighted Aethus and X an attribute, and let F_i be the filling of X in $\mathrm{C}(B_i)$ (Definition 10), its states' fillings on X intersected with the pegs of X it does not exclude—all the pegs of X if B_i neither states nor excludes anything on X, since such a branch restricts none. The Aethic-superposition weight *of a peg a of X in A is*

$$W_A(a) = \sum_{i\,:\,a\in F_i} w_i.$$

Every branch of A whose filling F_i contains a counts toward the weight of a. The construction collapses information deliberately. A single branch in agreeing state $[X : \{a, b\}]$ with weight w gives $W_A(a) = W_A(b) = w$; so do two determinate branches, at a and at b, each with weight w. The peg weights cannot distinguish agreeing from disagreeing structure.

Definition 27 (Aethic superposition)
An attribute X is resolved *at a peg a in a weighted Aethus A when a is the only peg of nonzero weight W_A, and is in* Aethic superposition *over the pegs of nonzero weight when there are at least two of them.*

Aethic superposition is the general category, blind by construction to the structure that produces it. Its two pure forms are the agreeing superposition, a single state over two or more pegs, and the disagreeing superposition, a weighted sum of one-peg branches. In general the two nest: branches carrying $[X : \{a, b\}]$ and $[X : \{c\}]$ put X in Aethic superposition over $\{a, b, c\}$, agreeing within the first branch and disagreeing across the branches, and the peg weights record only that no peg is resolved.

Definition 28 (Might and would)
Let $A = \sum_i w_i B_i$ be a weighted Aethus with nonzero total weight $Z_A = \sum_i w_i$, and a a peg. Then might *a holds in A when $W_A(a) \neq 0$, and* would *a holds in A when $W_A(a)/Z_A = 1$: when the weight of a, renormalized relative to A, is the whole weight of A. Both are read comparatively, as every weight statement of this paper is: $W_A(a) \neq 0$ means that a's weight is not measure-zero relative to Z_A, and $W_A(a)/Z_A = 1$ that the weight of the pockets declaring a false is measure-zero relative to Z_A.*

Both operators read only the flat peg weights of Definition 26, and neither consults negation: $\neg a$ is simply another peg, with its own weight, and each operator asks only whether a peg's weight is zero or not, or whole or not. Two consequences follow directly. *Might* a holds even when a is locked inside an agreeing superposition, since an agreeing state containing a counts toward its weight. And *would* can hold of several pegs at once: if a single branch in agreeing state $[X : \{a, b\}]$ carries all the weight of A, each of a and b occupies the whole of it, and *would* a and *would* b both hold. This is intended, and it is confined to the agreeing regime. The definition is the whole of what *would* means: *would* a holds exactly when the weight of valid pockets that declare a false is zero, a pocket declaring a false when the filling of a's attribute in its closure excludes a (Definition 26); a pocket that neither states nor excludes anything on the attribute declares nothing false and counts toward a's weight, and an irreducible agreeing state containing a meets the condition as fully as a state stating a does. The definition is the weight-one clause, $W_A(a)/Z_A = 1$; the support-universal clause, that no valid pocket declares a false, coincides with it wherever every valid pocket carries positive weight, and where valid pockets of zero weight are admitted the weight-one clause is the definition and the support-universal one is the stronger statement, the two agreeing again on the quotient that identifies zero-weight pockets away. To read *would* a as "a is actualized exclusively," a obtaining and its alternatives not, is to carry a classical presumption across a paradigm boundary, as carrying an invariant length across the relativistic boundary is: length survives that crossing as a frame-indexed quantity and not as the classical invariant, and *would* survives this one as the zero-weight condition and not as exclusive actualization, which is a feature of the disagreeing regime alone and is restored there by the proposition that follows. Any relevant records induce the classical, disagreeing regime, by the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning (Section 8), so an Aethus containing such records, even only up to semantic mining, must be in that regime, and there *would* behaves classically.

Proposition 20 (Would in the disagreeing regime)
Let every branch of A carry a determinate state on X, and let the weights be nonnegative. Then the peg weights of X sum to Z_A, and would *a holds of at most one peg of X; when it does,* might *b fails for every other peg b.*

Proof
Each branch fills X with exactly one peg, so it contributes its weight to exactly one peg weight, and the peg weights sum to Z_A. If $W_A(a) = Z_A$, the remaining peg weights are nonnegative and sum to zero, so each is zero.

The multi-peg case of *would* is thus the agreeing regime's own, suited to exactly the reasoning that regime calls for. These are the modal operators of Section 12.1.3, read at the level of pegs.

4.4 Weighted Aethae over the Peg Formalism

The weighted layer adds weights to the Aethae of Section 3 and nothing else. Its terms are Aethae in the sense of Definition 8, the closures of representations, and invalid ones are among them: each keeps its content and its tag (Definition 10), so the terms a weighted sum can carry are exactly the Aethae of the intrinsic lattice (Section 3.2). The universe set of Section 6.7 is a working part of that lattice,

generated from chosen Aethae and closed under meets and the cores of sums, so its generators are Aethae as well.

Definition 29 (Weighted Aethus)
A weighted Aethus *is a finite formal sum $x = \sum_i w_i A_i$ of Aethae A_i with weights w_i in a measure type, in which terms on one Aethus combine, $wA + vA = (w + v)A$, and a term of weight zero is deleted. Its* support $\mathrm{supp}(x)$ *is the set of its terms, and its* core *is the core of its support.*

The support of a weighted Aethus is an Aethic union in the sense of Section 3.1: the unweighted sum is the weighted one with its weights forgotten, which is why it is idempotent while the weighted sum is not, a term entered twice counting twice. Joint assertion extends term by term and weight by weight,

$$\Big(\sum_i w_i A_i\Big) \cdot \Big(\sum_j v_j B_j\Big) \;=\; \sum_{i,j} w_i v_j \,(A_i \cdot B_j),$$

so it distributes over the weighted sum exactly, as it does over the unweighted one. A disagreeing superposition (Definition 25) is a weighted Aethus whose terms are one-peg branches, and its unweighted shadow is its support.

Rendering at the weighted grade. The validity quotient deletes invalid terms together with their weights. It remains a congruence, since every product with an invalid term is invalid, and it is the tier on which probability is valued: formal Bayesian conditional probability normalizes over the valid terms that rendering leaves (Section 4.7.2), while the Aethus's own weights, the hyperrealized ones, are those of the full sum, invalid terms included. The weighted proper children, the proper Aethae and the reduced form, over which the third postulate quantifies, are defined on these sums together with the postulate (Section 6.7; Definition 36): a proper child of x is an Aethus that is a term of x at its full coefficient, one not measure-zero relative to the rest of x.

4.5 The Relational Weight Principle, and the Multiplication Rule

The weighted layer of Section 4.4 fixes weights only up to one common scale, and the principle below says so.

Principle 22 (Relational Weight Principle)
It is a fundamental commitment of weighted Aethic reasoning[87] *that no Aethus is ever given with an absolute scale factor upon its weight. Weight is checkable only relationally: the defined quantities are weight ratios—the* $\mathrm{P}(A \mid B)$ *of the weight–probability equivalence—and never the bare coefficients themselves. In consequence, rescaling every Aethus in existence by one and the same positive constant is an exact invariance of the framework: nothing observable, and nothing the machinery consumes, registers the change—precisely as a logarithmic derivative is blind to a constant multiplicative factor in the function it differentiates. The weight structure is, in a word, projective.*

What projectivity settles for the intrinsic layer. Because the defined quantities are ratios, an identity between a carrier and its weighted decomposition can assert only ratios, and that fixes what such an identity can be. Let B and C be distinct valid unweighted Aethae whose joint assertion is invalid, so that in the validity quotient, (Section 4.3), $[B]^2 = [B]$, $[C]^2 = [C]$ and $[B][C] = 0$, and let $b, c > 0$ at real weights. In any quotient that keeps carriers idempotent, the product bilinear, and coefficients on $[B]$ and $[C]$ unique, ($u[B] + v[C] = u'[B] + v'[C]$ only when $u = u'$ and $v = v'$), an identification $[A] = \lambda\,(b[B] + c[C])$ of a carrier A, for some $\lambda > 0$, forces $b = c = 1/\lambda$: idempotence gives $[A]^2 = [A]$, bilinearity gives $[A]^2 = \lambda^2 b^2 [B] + \lambda^2 c^2 [C]$, and uniqueness of coefficients gives $\lambda^2 b^2 = \lambda b$ and $\lambda^2 c^2 = \lambda c$. Under those assumptions the one identification left is the unit-coefficient sum $[A] = [B] + [C]$. The uniform mixture $\frac{1}{2}[B] + \frac{1}{2}[C]$, though its square is $\frac{1}{4}[B] + \frac{1}{4}[C]$, has the same relative coefficients as $[B] + [C]$ on this fixed decomposition, the factor $\frac{1}{2}$ being a bare coefficient this principle never treats as a defined quantity; identifying $[B] + [C]$ with A remains part of the representation proposed below. Nonuniform splittings are obstructed even up to the principle's rescaling, $\frac{2}{3}B + \frac{1}{3}C$ squaring to weights in ratio $4 : 1$ rather than $2 : 1$. The declared decomposition $A \rightsquigarrow bB + cC$ is kept distinct from A for exactly this reason: a carrier is idempotent under joint assertion, a weighted Aethus with genuine, nonuniform weights is not, and the weights stay where they are, as coefficients.

[87] Note that this idea was settled in 2025, and recorded explicitly in the paper in the June 12, 2026 pass.

What a fixed exclusive family supplies. On a fixed family of exclusive valid cells with unique coefficients, $W = \sum_i w_i C_i$ with every $w_i > 0$ satisfies $W^2 = \lambda W$ for some $\lambda > 0$ if and only if the w_i are all equal, so uniform positive mixtures, and only they, admit an idempotent representative, the unit-coefficient sum. This suggests representing intrinsic carriers by such normalized support objects, and reading the intrinsic Aethus algebra from pegs onward, (Section 3), as a decompositional algebra on them, each carrier decomposing, under a carving it holds, into its cells. Joint assertion is inherited, the product of two unit-coefficient sums being the unit-coefficient sum over the intersection of their supports. Addition is not: $B \sim 2B$ while $B + C \not\sim 2B + C$, this principle's invariance being one common rescaling of everything rather than an independent rescaling of the summands, so union must be the support union, a separate operation whose properties have to be proved.

What remains open across decompositions. Constructing the intrinsic operations on these objects in general, and proving them compatible across decompositions, is open, and grain is the central difficulty: refining B as $B_1 + B_2$ gives $bB = bB_1 + bB_2$, which doubles B's mass if a coefficient is a mass, and is consistent as a density only relative to a reference measure with $m(B) = m(B_1) + m(B_2)$, a further construction the present algebra does not supply. Three readings of a coefficient are therefore kept apart: a mass, a density relative to a measure, and a relative weight within a declared decomposition. The paper's results use the last, through the declared decompositions and the partition-consistency law of Section 9.1, and none of them rests on the representation suggested here.

The multiplication rule. With weights relational, a probability is a weight ratio: $\mathrm{P}(A \mid X)$ is the weight X carries on its A-refinement relative to its total, formed as a quotient where the measure type admits division (the base case, any semifield); in a type without it, $\mathbb{N}$ say, the relational datum is the pair of weights up to common rescaling by a non-zero-divisor scalar, the projective class the principle names, and comparisons run on it without a quotient being formed. The multiplication rule is then an identity of ratios, $\mathrm{P}(A \cap B \mid X) = \mathrm{P}(A \mid X)\,\mathrm{P}(B \mid A \cap X)$, both sides being the weight X carries on $A \cap B$ relative to its total. What the framework adds is where the factors come from. Joint assertion multiplies weights term by term (Section 4.4), and the joint of two disjoint terms is invalid and drops at validity equivalence, so in a product of weighted Aethae each surviving term carries the product of its factors' weights, and independence is the case of a product state, whose weights factor. The earlier derivation's example is the case of two disjoint unit Aethae: $(\alpha A + B)(\beta A + B) = \alpha\beta\, A + (\alpha + \beta)\, AB + B$, whose middle term is invalid, leaving odds $\alpha\beta$ for A against B. Under joint assertion, odds multiply.

This section and Section 4.4 supersede them, disjointness replacing the earlier orthogonality throughout.

4.6 Further Notions of Probability In Aethic Reasoning

We have already defined the formal definition of probability in Aethic reasoning, so let us now consider an example of Aethic probability intuition in action. Suppose we have an Aethus which is to encode whether a particular coin lands heads or tails. Normally we might add the full stated-attribute of the resulting state into our Aethus, but for this exercise we are only to add such a property with weight 50%. By the implicit definition of a weighted-Aethus, we attain the following form of such an Aethus, where x is our particular state to be added.

$$A = 50\%\, A_0 + 50\%\, x \tag{6}$$

If, for example, we have that x corresponds to the state heads, then we might imagine retrieving the attribute of "What is the state of the coin" from A. If A_0 were to return this, it would send $(\text{Heads}, \text{Tails})$ due to the second postulate of the Aethus, and we also of course have that x itself would return (Heads). As such, we might consider what A would retrieve by taking the corresponding linear combination of both notions.

$$50\%\ (\text{Heads}, \text{Tails}) + 50\%\ (\text{Heads}) \tag{7}$$

Upon distribution of the factors, then, we get the following result.

$$75\%\ (\text{Heads}) + 25\%\ (\text{Tails}) \tag{8}$$

So, since we have expressed our Aethus as a linear combination of two linearly independent stated-attributes, we can therefore gather the probability of either Heads or tails accordingly from that Aethus.

$$\mathrm{P}(\text{Heads} \mid A) = \frac{3}{4} \tag{9}$$

$$\mathrm{P}(\text{Tails} \mid A) = \frac{1}{4} \tag{10}$$

Such is due to the equivalence of weightings and probabilities in Aethic reasoning.

Rather than using the ugly and limited notation of $W_B(A)$, let us now transition toward standardizing $\mathrm{P}(A \mid B)$ as our new notation for Aethic weightings, for we know it to be quite a beautiful notation already. A major benefit of this weight-probability equivalence principle is that we might also now depict agreeing superpositions, or whatever else in Aethic reasoning, through the use of this standard probability notation, $\mathrm{P}(A \mid B)$.

Given this probabilistic-formulation of Aethic reasoning, a few useful insights become available. For instance, here is a new method of establishing Aethus equivalence between the Aethae A and B.

Theorem 5 (Probabilistic Identity of Aethic Equivalence)
Two Aethae have a weighting of one with respect to one another if and only if they are Aethically equivalent.

$$\mathrm{P}(A \mid B) = \mathrm{P}(B \mid A) = 1 \Leftrightarrow A \equiv B \tag{11}$$

This identity will come into great use later on in the paper—particularly for deriving the third postulate of the Aethus.

Two clarifications are recorded here as of the June 2026 pass, (the recording date, note, rather than the settlement date of the underlying points). First, the *tier*: because weights are blind to invalid content—invalid components carry zero weight by definition, (weight-zero being the algebraic face of the invalidity label, which the term keeps under the signed-weight doctrine of Section 6.7)—the relation this identity certifies is, in general, *validity equivalence*, (the deliberately weaker tier made explicit beside the Aethic Partition Theorem, Section 4.6.3). An Aethus and its reduced form satisfy the displayed condition while remaining distinct at the static-Aethus tier, which is exactly what keeps invalid Aethae available as unique labels. On Aethae free of invalid content, the two tiers coincide, and the unqualified reading is recovered there in full. Second, the *algebraic reading*, in the vocabulary of the weighted formulation, (Section 6.7): the weight–probability equivalence is the assertion that the canonical probability functional is a commutative semiring homomorphism respecting the invalidity congruence, with conditionalization on a root Aethus implemented as restriction-plus-normalization. Two later constructions consume this identity verbatim and nothing stronger, and are recorded here for navigability: the Aethic Partition Theorem's proof just below, and the graded counterfactual clauses of the formal semantics, (Section 9.1), whose residue weight W_R is exactly this identity restricted to a residue and renormalized. A final structural completion arrives with the Relational Weight Principle, (Principle 22): the $\mathrm{P}(A \mid B)$ notation is the gauge-invariant form—weights enter the framework only as ratios—which is the deeper reason the equivalence could be cast in probability notation at all.

4.6.1 Denoting Weighting Schemes With an Aethic Attribute

Consider the *Nexus principle of Aethic reasoning*, which helps distinguish physically existent Aethae from mathematically existent Aethae.

Principle 23 (Nexus Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
Any physically existent Aethus, for every blank attribute within it, has to contain a weighting scheme for that attribute, be it direct or removed from it by several iterations of intermediate blank attributes.

Notice that there is no such restriction for mathematically defined Aethae, because we may simply choose to neglect this property. However, with physically existent Aethae, we hold that in order for centric unfolding to occur at all, there must be some mechanism of defining the weights of all possible stated which a particular blank attribute can hold, and its superposition accordingly. Just such a weighting scheme is what we refer to as a *Nexus*. We will deal more with Nexae throughout the remainder of the paper. (For reopened blanks the scheme is supplied by the Aethus itself, from the invalid terms it retains—the Aetherian Nexus of Section 9.4.1's fourth structural fact.)

4.6.2 Two Definitions of Probability

Please note that in Aethic reasoning, with probability having been associated with Aethic weightings in the way in which it was, we now have access to two different definitions of probability, which are quite useful when used together in Bayesian arguments. Let us describe these as follows.

Definition (Realizable Definition of Probability)
In Aethic reasoning, the realizable definition of probability only counts valid Aethae in all arguments of Aethic weighting, such that invalid Aethae are set to zero probability, and any surrounding valid Aethae are normalized in probability accordingly. Crucially, note that this is the definition of probability that is exactly consistent with our world of physical observables, because after all, invalid Aethae are not physically realizable.

Notice that this is indeed the exact type of probability which we normally mean when we talk about probability.

Definition (Hyperealizable Definition of Probability)
In Aethic reasoning, the unrealized definition of probability is that which attempts to also take invalid Aethae into account during probability arguments, such that they have nonzero weights. Note that performing this can serve extremely useful in various analyzes, such that we do our analysis over hyperealizable probabilities, and only project the result back to realizable probabilities at the end of the derivation. In fact, the supposition of Aethic Bayesianism is that it is the nature of such a projection which gives rise to the Bayesian school of probability from Aethic reasoning itself.

Note that hyperealizable probability weights can be arranged in many possible ways while still projecting to the physical system, simply due to hyperealizable probabilities possessing more degrees of freedom than realizable probabilities can attain. With this being said, it is wise to define a well-suited convention for hyperealizable probabilities when using them, otherwise there is not much of a gain over realized probabilities themselves. If there seems to be an ontological tendency to the underlying hyperealizable probabilities, then that is usually a good place to start when defining the question-specific convention.

4.6.3 The Aethic Partition Theorem

Theorem 6 (The Aethic Partition Theorem)
For any Aethic partition, S, the union of the Aethae in S is Aethically equivalent—at the validity tier made explicit immediately below—to the union of only the valid Aethae in S.

We can derive this statement using the probabilistic identity of Aethic equivalence together with an argument of mathematical induction. (That identity, per the note recorded with it, certifies precisely this validity tier.) Let us perform this derivation now.

Proof of the Aethic Partition Theorem

Proof
Consider some Aethic partition of the Aethus A, which we will denote as S_0. The procedure of our proof will be to take the Aethic union of the valid Aethae in the set S_0 and establish that as some A_1, and then to also take the Aethic union of the invalid Aethae in the set S_0, and establish that as A_2. We know that the Aethic union of A_1 and A_2, then, ought to equal the Aethic union of all elements in the set S_0, (which holds due to the Aethic union operation being both commutative and associative), so we therefore need only to prove that the Aethic union of all items in S_0 is Aethically equivalent to A_1 itself, and we will have found our solution.
To begin with, note how the set $S_1 = \{A_1, A_2\}$ is itself an Aethic partition of A, because it satisfies both properties that its union equals A, (as we know already), and that its intersection is an invalid Aethus, (on account of it being a child to an invalid Aethus, A_2). Let us show that such a union of an Aethic partition of two elements, being A_1 and A_2, such that A_1 is valid but A_2 is invalid, will always be Aethically equivalent to A_1 only. This may be expressed as follows.

$$A = A_1 \cup A_2 = A_1 \mid \mathbf{V}[A_1] \wedge \neg\mathbf{V}[A_2] \tag{12}$$

Let us prove this particular statement with a simple use of the probabilistic identity of Aethic equivalence. To begin with, through the use of the law of total probability we see that the following identity is in effect, (due to A_1 and A_2 also being disjoint, on account of S_1 being an Aethic partition).

$$\mathrm{P}(A_1 \mid A) + \mathrm{P}(A_2 \mid A) = 1 \tag{13}$$

Hence, through the weight-probability equivalence of Aethic reasoning, we hold that the weight of A_1 in A is one minus the weight of A_2 in A.

Next, we can simply show that the realizable probability of A_2 in A has to itself be zero. This is a fundamental claim that we can make as based on the definition of an invalid Aethus, where they are never physically realizable. Through this, we gather that even though A_2 is a child Aethus to A, we still must hold as an intrinsic property of it that its weight in A is to be zero.

$$\mathrm{P}(A_2 \mid A) = 0 \tag{14}$$

This then yields us the probability of A_1 in A through substitution.

$$\mathrm{P}(A_1 \mid A) = 1 \tag{15}$$

This is our first part of the implication, and we may also show that the second part is true as well, being that the weight of A in A_1 is one. Such a property is rather more trivial, and it specifically derives from A_1 being expressible as a child Aethus of A itself, due to A being expressible as a parent Aethus of A_1 and all, (as per the union expression from which it was generated). We now have the following.

$$\mathrm{P}(A_1 \mid A) = \mathrm{P}(A \mid A_1) = 1 \tag{16}$$

We may now apply the probabilistic identity of Aethic equivalence, to make the following claim.

$$\mathrm{P}(A_1 \mid A) = \mathrm{P}(A \mid A_1) = 1 \Leftrightarrow A = A_1 \tag{17}$$

Therefore, we have shown that in such a setup of A_1 being valid and A_2 being invalid, we indeed attain that $A_1 = A_1 \cup A_2$. This then completes our proof that the Aethic union of the valid Aethae in an Aethic partition equals the Aethic union of all the elements in the Aethic partition.

4.7 The Set of Weighted Aethae as a Commutative Semiring

Status. The semiring of this subsection is that of weighted Aethae over the peg formalism (Section 4.4): sums keep their terms, joint assertion distributes over them exactly, and the unweighted Aethic union is the support of a sum with its weights forgotten.

We can show that the set of weighted Aethae is actually a commutative ring by outlining a few of its key properties. Let us set the Aethic union to our multiplicative operation, and the Aethic intersection as our additive operation for such a procedure. Two conventions are fixed before the properties are shown, since each has invited confusion. On *orientation*: the refinement order can be read as an information order, $A \leq_I B$ iff $\mathrm{C}(A) \subseteq \mathrm{C}(B)$, with the Null Aethus at the bottom, under which the union is the meet and the intersection the join; or as the ancestry order this paper uses, $B \sqsubseteq A$ iff $A \leq_I B$, with the Null Aethus at the top, under which the names reverse—the union is the join (last common ancestor) and the intersection the meet (least common descendant). Every "meet" and "join" below names its order. On *ideals*: the invalid Aethae form a *monoid* ideal of the multiplicative structure—invalid inheritance gives A invalid $\Rightarrow A \cap B$ invalid for every B, an intersection with an invalid Aethus being its child—and not a semiring ideal, since the union of two invalid Aethae is their last common ancestor, which may be an untagged valid Aethus above both, so that additive closure fails; the quotient the invalidity congruence produces is accordingly the contracted *monoid* semiring, and that is the object the weighted development below constructs, the monoid semiring $M[U]$ under the shrunk quotient.

4.7.1 Property of Distributivity

Let us begin by showing that, like multiplication over addition, Aethic intersections over Aethic unions do in fact follow the distributive property. Let us do this by showing the truth of the following equation.

$$A \cap (B \cup C) = (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C) \tag{18}$$

Given how we can define[88] the Aethic intersection such that $x \in A \vee x \in B \Leftrightarrow x \in A \cap B$, (where $\in$ here means "*is a parent Aethus of*" or alternatively "*is present in*"), and the Aethic union such that $x \in A \wedge x \in B \Leftrightarrow x \in A \cap B$, it then follows that for some x to be present in the Aethus $A \cap (B \cup C)$

[88]Remember how the intuition on subsets and logic-to-sets is backwards here from what we are used to in set theory—and this is because we are applying the "in" notion predominately to static Aethae, whereas we are applying set unions and intersections to their direct Aethic analogues onto the Aethae themselves.

means that it is present in either A or $B \cap C$, which itself implies that if $A \cap B$ does not contain it, then $A \cap C$ certainly will. Therefore, we can trivially see how this equates to $(A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$ according to such an identity.
In the formalism of Sections 3.1–4.3. The derivation above holds for the presence-based operations of the 2024 construction, in which the intersection of two Aethae collects what either states. Under closure the meet also derives, and distributivity then holds exactly where the alternatives are carved: meets distribute over any union of determinate Aethae and over any carving's settings (Proposition 14). It fails for unions of agreeing alternatives that no record carves, most sharply at an irreducible superposition, where each operand's meet is invalid while the meet with their union is not.

4.7.2 The Set of Weighted Aethae as a Commutative Monoid Under Unions

To begin with, we want to argue for the hyperinvalid Aethus as the identity of the union operation of the set of weighted Aethae, thus making it the additive identity accordingly. Remember that if a single contradiction is present, then that would make the Aethus invalid—but in this case we have a stronger version even than that, which is that to be a hyperinvalid Aethus, for all present attributes in the Aethus, there must exist a contradictory alternative state in that same Aethus. Furthermore, we can assert that all such Aethae actually hold Aethic equivalence[89] for the sake of present intersection derivation.

Two tiers of equivalence, made explicit. A clarification recorded explicitly in the June 2026 pass, (and settled well before it), belongs directly beside this theorem, because the relation it outputs is deliberately *weaker* than Aethic equivalence, the identity of closures of Section 3.1, and conflating the two would damage both. Call the weaker relation **validity equivalence**, written $A \equiv_{\mathbf{V}} B$, and characterized in three interchangeable ways: (i) A and B have identical valid—which is to say realizable—content, differing at most by components deducible as unrealizable; (ii) A and B are identified by the invalidity congruence, the relation generated by sending every invalid Aethus to the additive identity, (the congruence reading recorded with the weighted formulation, Section 6.7); and (iii) where reduced forms exist, $\bar{A} = \bar{B}$. (The name "validity equivalence" is itself a June 2026 settlement, preferred over the briefly-entertained "realization equivalence": the relation is pure label-level mathematics—agreement of valid content—whereas *realization* properly names the physical conversion that the realization principle owes, and the naming should leave that principle free to remain what it is: the bridge between the tiers, not the relation at either one.) It is validity equivalence that the probabilistic identity invoked in the proof above certifies, and validity equivalence that the Aethic Partition Theorem asserts. Aethic equivalence, the identity of closures, is untouched by it, and is strictly finer: static-Aethus equivalence implies validity equivalence, but the converse fails exactly on invalid content, with an Aethus and its reduced form, A versus $\bar{A}$, as the canonical witness. The division of labor between the tiers is the point. Under the definitional-hierarchy relation, distinct invalid Aethae remain pairwise *in*equivalent—the unique-label character that the commutative semiring constraint exists to protect, since additive inverses would let them cancel into a single class—whereas under validity equivalence, every invalid Aethus is identified with the hyperinvalid Aethus, which is exactly the identification the partition theorem and the reduced form require. One further payoff of naming the tier deserves recording: the realization principle, (the fourth of the Open Constructions, Section 14.8), is now visible as precisely the bridge between them—the principle that converts $\equiv_{\mathbf{V}}$-identifications, which live at the level of labels, into physical exclusions, which live at the level of what exists. Localizing the principle's obligation this sharply is itself part of what the two-tier distinction buys. One naming discipline follows and is enforced throughout: *Aethic equivalence*, unqualified, always means the finer, definitional-hierarchy relation of Section 8, and *validity equivalence* always means the coarser relation of this paragraph—two Aethae being validity-equivalent exactly when they can be brought to the same weighted Aethus by removing invalid proper child Aethae. Probability, the reduced form, and every

[89] Given then how we are supposing that an Aethus which can be written in terms of only blank and invalid attributes, (being a hyperinvalid Aethus), (but also not only blank Aethae—which is the additive identity of the commutative semiring), is itself Aethically equivalent to all other such Aethae, we can attempt to model Aethic equivalence itself to affirm this property. Specifically, we can write up the following generalized lemma: *for any two invalid Aethae, A, and B, they are to be Aethically equivalent if all valid parent Aethae of one are also valid parent Aethae of the other to the same weights.* (A criterion certifying, in the tiered vocabulary, the validity tier: valid-parent agreement is blind to the invalid labels themselves.) Or, more general still, we might suppose that the same is true for all Aethae as well. Given how the Null Aethus is the only valid parent for hyperinvalid Aethae, they are all therefore Aethically equivalent for having this one same parent.

realizable-content claim are valued at the coarser tier; the tree, implication, and the complement are read at the finer one; and no sentence in this paper should be read as using one name for the other.

Note that such a hyperinvalid Aethus can intuitively be given as the identity element of the set of weighted Aethae under unions, because we clearly see that the union of any Aethus with such a hyperinvalid Aethus must be simply itself. We can prove such a supposition using the Aethic partition theorem. Specifically, let us consider how if A is some Aethus, and $\not\Psi$ is the hyperinvalid Aethus, then it follows that $\not\Psi$ can be written as $A \cap A'$, where A' is the Aethic complement to A, such that $A \cap A' = \not\Psi$ and $A \cup A' = N_0$. As such, we may substitute accordingly.

$$A \cup \not\Psi = A \cup (A \cap A') \tag{19}$$

This is where we can apply the Aethic partition theorem, because we know that the invalid Aethus $A \cap A'$ is clearly a child Aethus of A, so the Aethic partition of A that is $A \cup (A \cap A')$ can be rewritten as A itself.

$$A \cup \not\Psi = A \tag{20}$$

This shows that the hyperinvalid Aethus, $\not\Psi$, is a valid choice of the multiplicative identity of the set of weighted Aethae.

We must now show closure of the set of weighted Aethae under unions. Quite simply, we know that the union of any two Aethae on the same set of weighted Aethae must itself be on that set of weighted Aethae. This comes from the corollary that the union of two child Aethae to an Aethus is itself a child Aethus to such an Aethus, and we see that all Aethae on an set of weighted Aethae are child Aethae to the Null Aethus of that tree, hence arguing that all Aethic unions are also a child Aethus to that Null Aethus, (itself then implying their presence on the tree). Regarding associativity and commutativity, we can again inductively extrapolate from the nature of these things on set unions and the weights therein. Because sets under probability are commutative and associativity, we also see that the weights stay the same regardless of the order or groupings onto which several Aethae are unioned. Therefore, the set of weighted Aethae is an Abelian monoid under unions.

Given this, we may now imply the existence of additive inverses to Aethae *in the ambient space of formal linear combinations* simply as a consequence of the induction to linear combinations of Aethae that marked the initiation of weighted Aethic reasoning in the first place. Specifically, we need only to gather negative coefficients in order to carry out the creation of an Aethus's additive inverse, such as in the following example.

$$A \cup (-A) = A - A = \not\Psi \tag{21}$$

In this example, we have that by induction from the notation of linear combinations alone, the mere supposition about the existence of this $-A$ implies that it ought to directly serve as the additive inverse to the Aethus A. In effect, we have that the additive inverse of an Aethus simply consists of flipping the coefficient signs on any and all linear combinations which express it. As discussed earlier, this kind of Aethus is what we specifically regard as a *negative Aethus*, and due to its difficulty of being ontologically realized outside of a construct, we might then refer to it as a kind of *improper Aethus* in the process. Note that we may denote such a negative Aethus as sharing a unit Aethus with its additive inverse, but holding an oppositely signed Aethic norm.

A clarification recorded explicitly in the June 2026 pass governs the status of everything in this passage: these additive inverses, first staged here as scaffolding, are as of the present pass admitted to the tree itself as signed weights, (the signed-weights design accompanying the Aethic Subtraction Principle below). The protection for which they were once excluded—the unique-label character of invalid Aethae, (the commutative semiring constraint of Section 6.7, with its congruence reading recorded there)—is carried under the new design by the denial of term-level annihilation, $(-a)A + (a)A = (0)A \neq 0$, rather than by the denial of signs; the ambient formal module of this passage, (the same epistemic staging assigned to improper Aethae generally in the earlier presentation), is thereby no longer a quarantine but a preview. Every result of this paper survives unchanged, with unrestricted Aethic subtraction now native and its truncated form retained as the realizable projection, as the note accompanying the Aethic Subtraction Principle below makes precise.

Given all of this, we have shown the set of all Aethae to be an Abelian group under Aethic unions, thereby serving as our additive piece of the puzzle.

4.7.3 The Set of Weighted Aethae as an Abelian Monoid Under Intersections

Let us show that the set of weighted Aethae is an Abelian monoid under intersections. Specifically, we will begin by showing that such a group is in possession of an identity element, thereby being the

additive identity of the set of weighted Aethae. Such an identity element, very simply, is the Null Aethus itself. The reasoning for this is rather trivial. That is, consider an Aethus, A and the Null Aethus, N, for a particle Nexus of N.

$$A = A \cap N \tag{22}$$

Of course, the operation of adding all attributes from the Null Aethus to A will leave A unchanged, so therefore we have that the act of intersecting the Null Aethus with any given Aethus will result in that same Aethus. This immediately proves that the Null Aethus is the additive identity of the set of weighted Aethae.

Next, we may see rather quickly that Aethic intersections satisfy both associativity and commutativity, because after all such extends from their analogous identities as unions taken probabilistic events. Furthermore, in the least, the set of weighted Aethae is clearly closed under Aethic intersections, simply because because intersecting two Aethae will still yield a child Aethus of the Null Aethus and all.

In effect, we have shown thus far that Aethic intersections at least stray as far as accounting for an Abelian monoid, thereby completing enough of a derivation to render the set of all weighted Aethae as a commutative ring in the process.

4.7.4 On the Nonexistence of Empirical Aethic Complements

One interesting idea I have had more recently[90] than the bulk of Aethic reasoning itself is that perhaps Aethic complements may themselves be re-rendered as drawing from Aethic subtraction rather than being elementary themselves, similarly to how the Aethic union principle has dealt with physical disjunctions.

Principle 24 (Aethic Subtraction Principle)
One interesting, albeit radical idea we might entertain is the concept that perhaps Aethic complements, and by extension classical event complements actually turn out to be a human construct altogether, particularly by virtue of their blatantly failing to be well-defined Nexically, (which is to say that when we define the not of a given attribute in an Aethus, and especially in an empirical Aethus, we are alluding to the ability of Nexic context to bail us out, which may perhaps lead to paradoxes in the degree to which the Null Aethus is well-defined accordingly). Altogether, then, following in the spirit of the logical unscrambling of the Aethic union principle and the like, we might perhaps simply assert that Aethic complements fail to exist ontologically, such that their instances are instead ontologically encoded as Aethic union subtraction. As we have shown, rather intriguingly, such does indeed reproduce

[90] Specifically, this new idea struck me officially just before 8 PM on August 12, 2025, after which point I included it at this part of the paper for reference.

That being said, however, rather intriguingly on October 6, 2025, upon re-watching an old video of mine on Nexic reasoning from 2023, I was somewhat astounded to see a casual mention of Aethic subtraction over Nexae in the original Aethic terminology. That is, I used to call the Aethic union operation "Aethic concatenation" due to the premise of it effectively "concatenating" the superposition content of two Aethae, and so in the video I explicitly described taking the Nexus in which Nexus D occurs but with its child Aethus C not being realized as "the Aethic concatenation of D with the inverse of C". What I found particularly astounding about this rediscovery, then, is that this deliberately paints the removal of Nexus C from D not as intersecting D with $\neg C$, but explicitly as $D - C$ in the modern Aethic notation. So, to my surprise in my very purest and earliest Aethic understanding, (that is, prior to talking to a living soul about the concepts, or even having learned a single principle from abstract algebra), I was already using an utmost sophisticated interpretation of the Aethic operations, which I afterwards forgot a few pieces of. To be clear, I think the clear culprit of this subtle forgetting was actually learning abstract algebra itself in a college class, because at that point I tried to reorient my Aethic operations into that language, and inevitably made some crucial errors of sloppiness in doing so, (which went so far as making me forget some concepts, so I would have to rediscover them later, like this Aethic subtraction principle example). For instance, I distinctly remember getting the Aethic union and intersections backwards in terms of which is addition and which is multiplication in the commutative ring, which must have been due to a subconscious mistranslation in preferencing the set concepts over the ontological concepts when doing to conversion, (since after all, the set concepts are backwards from unions and intersections, so with my only rudimentary understanding of the abstract algebraic intuitions at the time I made some critical mistranslations). One pressing example I remember is that on day-one of the abstract algebra class, I was frankly surprised to learn the treatment of taking a set of elements, and then equipping the *set* itself with the operation rather than baking the operation right into the elements. That is, the intuition I had probably subconsciously picked up from physics was the idea that every element gets its own concept of addition and multiplication, which leads to why a meter can be multiplied by a reciprocal second, but not added to it. Ie the intuition is that the "addition" of the meter is categorically separate from the "addition" of the inverse second, so when you "add" two objects, you're really only adding them under one of their own intrinsic modes of alignment. As may be somewhat obvious, this view of mine is far more similar to the dynamism of the Aethic operations, where they are more baked into its structure than merely being peripheral to it. Anyways, all things considered, it should perhaps not come as much of a surprise that I did have something of an unexpected initial sophistication with the Aethic concepts in 2023, since that was when I deciphered them from scratch anyway. Beyond that point, all they can do is erode if not attended to frequently enough, (which is also why the writing of this paper has been a huge relief for me, that way I no longer have to hold the entire contents in my head like something out of *Fahrenheit 451* [84]).

the empirical effect of an Aethic complement, (in that Aethic subtraction has already been taken to read empirically as "and not"), and so we may then conjecture that perhaps all possible needed uses of an Aethic complement in the context of empirical Aethae can be perfectly accounted for through use of union subtraction. The Aethic complement itself then becomes a non-elementary construct, similarly to what the Aethic union principle did for physical disjunctions.

The motivation for this idea, note, was my recent consideration of how properly-defined Aethic subtraction ought not to multiply coefficients anyway, (as would "and not" operations if truly event conjunctions as implied), but instead strictly operates by the Aethic union domain of addition, (albeit with opposite signs). So, all things considered, we might even imagine philosophically that had we always existed in a universe where event complements failed to ontologically exist, but the rather more exotic concept of Aethic subtraction did, then we might very well develop a societal epistemology for which every instance of Aethic subtraction forcing the cancellation-driven discounting of one Aethic term in terms of another is immediately logged as another instance of event complements being in play. But now that we are suggesting that event complements both fail to exist[91]*, and can be rendered as Aethic subtraction instead, (which remember is encoded as Aethic unions but simply reproduces the empirical effect of one Aethus discounting another due to cancellation), then we effectively are met with a perhaps even more striking question in conclusion: given its existence, how deeply into the uncharted non-classical ontological domain does Aethic subtraction instill an effect?*

That is, with this somewhat radical principle being perhaps my most direct counterclaim to the ontological capacity of modal logic itself, if it holds up we are effectively forced to reconsider the vast network of where event complements show up in our analyzes as being but the shadow of a misinterpreted deeper Aethic entity. So if this deeper entity's character can itself be inferred using any Aethic and empirical premises, then we have to ask ourselves not only where it shows up in the known, but to what extent it can do something alien, (similarly to the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, where the allowance of agreeing superpositions to exist suddenly generalizes classical probability to a new domain with alien-feeling aspects).

One identity of practical interest given the Aethic subtraction principle, note, is the concept of how cancellation behaves in the first place.

Theorem 7 (Aethic Cancellation Identity)
Simply put, we have that given two unit Aethae, X and Y, their Aethic subtractive difference $X - Y$ ought to be a disjoint Aethus to their Aethic intersection, XY.

$$\boxed{\mathbf{V}[(X - Y)(XY)] \Leftrightarrow \perp} \tag{23}$$

This is perhaps the direct mechanism through which we may rigorously replace instances of event or Aethic complements with Aethic subtraction, being that the very state of taking the subtractive difference between two unit Aethae itself then relationally disallows the possibility of both said unit Aethae being realized together.

In earlier revisions this was proved through the last-common-parent decomposition and the distributive interplay of unions and intersections; the newer derivation is direct factoring. Distribute, and apply idempotence of unit Aethae ($X^2 = X$, $Y^2 = Y$):

$$\begin{aligned} (X - Y)\, XY &= X^2Y - XY^2 \\ &= XY - XY \\ &= \not\emptyset, \end{aligned} \tag{24}$$

[91]We might also note that this Aethic subtraction principle may perhaps be seen as the second crucial step in satisfying a non-Cartesian ontology of the universe, where the first was to replace sets with Aethae as encoding ontological information. That is, if one thinks back to before sets are replaced with Aethae, then of course the event complement has a direct structural grounding, being that it simply serves as the set difference between the universal set and the current set. But once we have discounted set theory as being very reliable in displaying Aethic informational ontology, and we are suddenly met with the realization that event complements are particularly ungrounded. Putting more pressure on them still, we then start referring to Nexae as the fundamental arbiters of how possibility is weighted, and under the lens of Nexae an event complement is visibly not well-defined. Such, together with the direct realization of how event complement weighting coefficients themselves fail to be used in the Aethic operations, is that which clued me into the premise that perhaps event complements have always been a construct meant to express Aethic subtraction instances ad hoc. But yes, it is a primary consideration to notice that the downgrading of sets already results in event complements losing their motivation of grounding.

the subtractive difference of an Aethus with itself being the hyperinvalid Aethus, the additive identity of the weighted layer: the super-Aethic contradiction collapses to zero by pure factoring, the algebra itself deriving the disallowal that the X-forbidding-Y reading states semantically.

The scope of the identity under weights is characterizable under a local hypothesis, and instructive. For single-carrier weighted Aethae $A = \alpha\, a$ and $B = \beta\, b$ over unweighted carriers, $A^2B = \alpha^2\beta\,(ab)$ and $B^2A = \alpha\beta^2\,(ab)$, so the cancellation $A^2B = B^2A$ holds precisely when $\alpha^2\beta = \alpha\beta^2$ — exactly when $\alpha = \beta$ or a scalar vanishes, under multiplicative cancellativity on nonzero elements, a *local hypothesis* rather than a stipulation on the measure type, holding at the real-valued base case: *equal scalars restore the symmetry that idempotence supplies in the unweighted case*, the unweighted identity being the equal-scalar case at $\alpha = \beta = 1$. The identity does not extend to general linear combinations: for $x = \alpha(a_1 + a_2)$ and $y = \alpha\, b$,

$$x^2y = \alpha^3[a_1b + a_2b + 2\,a_1a_2b]\,, \qquad y^2x = \alpha^3[a_1b + a_2b]\,,$$

the cross-carrier term of x^2 having no counterpart on the other side — so among single carriers the exact boundary of the cancellation identity is equal scalars, another face of the unweighted/weighted layer split.

Three further layers complete the picture, in descending grade of settledness. First, an exact reformulation, fully general: since $x^2y = x\,(xy)$ and $y^2x = y\,(xy)$, the identity holds for a pair if and only if x and y *act identically on their own joint assertion* $z = xy$ — cancellation is agreement-in-action on the common child. Second, an a-priori argument for the equal-scalar case that precedes any algebra, recorded because it predicted the computation: had $\alpha a, \alpha b$ failed an identity that unweighted a, b satisfy, the failure would single out $\alpha = 1$ as an absolute weight scale — in violation of the relational weight principle, (Principle 22), under which only relative weights carry content. The formal counterpart is a *scale-invariance law* of the solution set: $(\lambda x)^2(\lambda y) = \lambda^3\, x^2y$ and likewise opposite, so the pairs satisfying cancellation are closed under common rescaling, exactly as relationality demands. Third, the exhaustive classification, conjectured with its supporting computation and booked rather than claimed: the solutions appear to be exactly the trivial family with *either factor* the hyperinvalid Aethus (both sides vanish by absorption, the identity being swap-symmetric and its solution set swap-closed), the pairs $x = y$, and the single-carrier pairs at equal or vanishing scalars — for a perturbation $y = x + w$, agreement forces $x^2w + w^2x = 0$, which zerosumfreeness kills termwise, leaving $w = 0$ whenever $x \neq 0$, for measure types without zero divisors; the incomparable case beyond perturbations awaits the independent check.

Note that there is also a more philosophical-technical derivation of this concept as well, rather than having to appeal to the symbolic manipulation directly.

Signed weights: subtraction without annihilation. The framework henceforth admits negative-weight Aethae as first-class citizens of the tree. The previous pass had excluded additive inverses wholesale, (the commutative semiring constraint of Section 6.7), to protect the unique-label character of invalid Aethae; that protection is retained here, but by a sharper mechanism than a ban on signs. The algebra is this: for any weight a, $(-a)A + (a)A = (0)A$—the *zero-weighted* Aethus—and $(0)A \neq 0$, the additive identity. Multiplication by the weight -1 is therefore not an additive inverse at the level of terms: no combination of signed weights ever annihilates a label, and "cancellation" deposits a zero-weighted label that the tree remembers. Subtraction $X - Y := X + (-1)Y$ is total. The weight algebra thereby becomes a ring while the term algebra remains inverse-free: the commutative semiring constraint is superseded at the weight level and retained at exactly the level where it always did its work, the level of labels. Invalidation, in the same spirit, is a *relabeling*—the slashed decoration of the derivation above produces a distinct marked object—and never an equality to 0. And that derivation is vindicated as originally written: its closing step, in which $ABC - ABC$ yields $\not{\emptyset}$ rather than nothing, is precisely self-subtraction landing on a marked label instead of on the additive identity, so the boxed disjointness identity holds in the signed idiom it was in fact composed in, with no truncation-based reinterpretation required. The truncated form is not discarded but demoted to what it is: for Y a weighted part of X, the monus $X \dot{-} Y$ of the previous pass [85] and the signed difference $X + (-1)Y$ agree in realizable content, since zero-weighted labels carry no realizable probability, (the Probabilistic Identity), and the signed bookkeeping lives exactly where the hyperrealizable layer already does, (Section 4.6). Every earlier occurrence of "$-$" between Aethae—including the rooted complement $A'_R = R - A$ below, whose parenthood condition keeps its realizable weights non-negative—therefore reads natively in the signed form and projects to what it always meant. Nothing here disturbs the negativity–contextuality architecture, (Section 10.3.5): that compliance rides on the refusal of a single

sample space, not on the signature of the tree's weights, and the classical regime remains non-negative exactly where the Kolmogorov results require it, (Theorem 13).

The nonexistence of objective complement Aethae without the specification of a root Aethus may actually be deduced from the first postulate of the Aethus via a proof by contradiction. That is, if objective complementary Aethae did exist, then the probability of each would be an ontologically unindexed probability, no root Aethus being specified, which the first postulate of the Aethus forbids directly. Therefore, we must infer that an objective "logical negation" of an Aethus must be replaced with the concept of logically negating it with respect to some root Aethus, and which may itself be expressed in the language of Aethic subtraction as $A'_R = R - A$ for such root Aethus R. In this case, we assume that R is a parent Aethus to A with $A = RA$, so it follows naturally that A'_R is disjoint to A because $R - A$ must be disjoint to RA by the Aethic cancellation identity, and we have that these respectively equal A'_R and A anyway. Note that the one condition for this construction is that both A and R are unit Aethae.

What Aethic subtraction is, logically: the complement, implication, and truth. The algebra above earns a plain statement of what it is *for*, and the statement has three parts that fit together as one object. The root-relative complement just derived, $A'_R = R - A$ with $A = RA$, is the special case that makes the general shape visible: a complement is always taken *in* something, and the something is a weighted Aethus.

The complement, and its mechanism. For weighted Aethae A and B, the **Aethic complement of B with respect to A** is written

$$A - AB, \tag{25}$$

and the whole idea of it is the pruning mechanism made subtractive. Multiplying B into A prunes: under validity equivalence, AB strikes every term of A that B forbids and leaves a residue—the reduced form of what in A survives B. Those surviving terms are then exactly what $A - AB$ subtracts *off* of A, so that what remains in $A - AB$ is precisely the set of terms of A that *do* get pruned in AB—the terms B kills—which is the logical complement of B within A: "A, and not B," with no "not" anywhere in the construction. Three things follow at once and should be seen at once. First, the complement is defined *up to validity equivalence* and only there: $A - AB \equiv_{\mathbf{V}} A - AB'$ whenever $AB \equiv_{\mathbf{V}} AB'$, since the residue is a valid-content object, while at the finer definitional-hierarchy equivalence the struck invalid summands remain distinct labels and "the" complement would not be a single object at all. Second, the construction consumes only the two operations the framework already has—intersection to prune, subtraction in the union domain to remove the residue—which is the subtraction principle's whole claim made operational: the complement is a *difference* in A, never a primitive negation of B. (And the root-relative form above is exactly this with the roles named for a root: $A'_R = R - A = R - RA$, the complement of A with respect to R, its parenthood condition $A = RA$ being precisely the implication $A \Rightarrow R$ that makes the residue RA collapse to A itself.) Third, the theorem above, $\mathbf{V}[(X-Y)(XY)] \Leftrightarrow \bot$, is this mechanism seen from the other side: the complement and the residue are disjoint by construction, so their product is hyperinvalid—the pruned and the surviving terms of A can never be realized together, which is exactly what "and not" has to mean.

Implication. For a weighted Aethus A, **Aethic implication** is parenthood: A implies every one of its weighted parent Aethae, and nothing else,

$$A \Rightarrow B \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad B \text{ is a weighted parent Aethus of } A, \tag{26}$$

so "A implies B" is a structural fact about where B sits in A's ancestry, read off the tree, with no separate inferential primitive behind it. Negated implication is not a second primitive either: "A implies not-B" is the statement that the product is invalid,

$$A \Rightarrow \neg B \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \mathbf{V}[AB] \Leftrightarrow \bot, \tag{27}$$

which is the same discipline as the complement—what would have been the negation of B is carried entirely by pruning, here by the pruning of A to nothing valid at all. (And the complement reads implication off both ways at once. $A \Rightarrow \neg B$ is exactly the case in which the complement is all of A: $AB \equiv_{\mathbf{V}} \not\Vdash$, hence $A - AB \equiv_{\mathbf{V}} A$. And $A \Rightarrow B$ is exactly the case in which the complement is *nothing*: if B is a weighted parent of A then multiplying B into A prunes nothing—$AB \equiv_{\mathbf{V}} A$—and so

$$A \Rightarrow B \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad A - AB \equiv_{\mathbf{V}} \not\Vdash, \tag{28}$$

the hyperinvalid Aethus up to validity equivalence. That is the classical equivalence $A \to B \iff A \wedge \neg B \equiv \bot$, but derived rather than stipulated—from parenthood, pruning, and union-domain subtraction alone, at the tier where the residue lives—and the two directions that classical logic must prove separately arrive as one algebraic identity. (One clause on hypotheses, pre-empting the algebraist's question: at this tier the residue is a literal sub-collection of A's terms and the subtraction is the striking itself — set-theoretic removal of summands — so the two directions consume no additive-cancellation axiom; whatever cancellation the quotient-level restatement of this identity needs, it must and does license there, not here.) This is the kind of reimagination the Aethus concept enables: implication is not a connective added to the structure but a fact about where the complement vanishes in it.)

Truth, and why explosion is harmless. **Truth** is the intersection test the paper has used throughout: A is *true relative to* B if and only if AB remains valid, $\mathbf{V}[AB]$. Implication and truth come apart, and the place they come apart is precisely explosion. Every Aethus is a parent of the hyperinvalid Aethus, and a contradiction, though distinct from it at the first tier, implies it on the implication side—so from a contradiction every Aethus is *implied*, (the explosion recorded with the hyperinvalid Aethus in the earlier presentation), and it lives entirely on the implication side. It says nothing about truth: the contradiction, being invalid, is true relative to nothing, and the Aethae it implies are not thereby certified true relative to anything. Explosion is thus a theorem about implication, carried by the hyperinvalid Aethus as everyone's child, and not a license to assert; its deductions are structurally real and truth-inert at once, and it is the separation of the two notions that makes this a feature rather than the disaster it is in a logic that conflates consequence with truth. The two-tier discipline of Section 4.7.2 is the same point one level down: implication and the complement's *construction* are read off the tree, while the complement's *identity*, truth, and probability are valued at validity equivalence—and the framework never asks either tier to do the other's work.[92]

4.8 Validity Equivalence and the Aethic Definition of Ontology

Weighted Aethae carry two tiers of identity. At the first they are equal when they have the same terms at the same weights, invalid tags included (Definition 29). At the second they are validity equivalent (Section 4.7.2), identified by the congruence that sends every invalid Aethus to the additive identity, so that the validity quotient deletes invalid terms together with their weights (Section 4.4). The paper's ontology is defined at the second tier. The distinction the definition makes exact is older than the formalism, and it comes first, in its original words.

[92] *August 19, 2026*, the author's dictation of the three notions installed here and at the subtraction theorem, kept verbatim as a matter of provenance:

By the way, I also really want to for the Aethic paper explicitly unpack how 1) A-AB is explicitly how you write the Aethic complement of weighted Aethus B with respect to weighted Aethus A up to validity equivalence (see the Aethic subtraction principle for where to integrate this in), 2) the concept of Aethic implication (and even Aethic implication notation, if we want) which is that for a given weighted Aethus A, what an implication statement simply is is that A implies all its parent Aethae, (so A implies B translates to B is a weighted parent Aethus of A), (and furthermore A implies not B is simply saying that A multiplied by B is an invalid Aethus, rather than allowing for actual ''not'' to be a logical primitive in Aethic reasoning), and then 3) this implication concept is distinct from the concept of ''truth'', such that ''true'' for weighted Aethus A relative to B is (as mentioned in the paper) does A multiplied by B remain valid. So the important thing about the difference between implication and truth is that the logical principle of explosion exists on the false side, in that you can deduce all the parent Aethae from an Aethic contradiction, (such that all Aethae are parent to the hyper invalid Aethus, and a contradiction takes the hyper invalid Aethus as a parent pretty much) is an implication-side statement, that way by virtue of the contradiction being an invalid Aethus it still manages to deduce those things without stating whether they are true per se! Also I want to make sure that throughout the paper, ''Aethic equivalence'' which is defined explicitly is unambiguously different from ''Aethic validity equivalence'', which is a further equivalence relation over dropping out invalid Aethae proper child Aethae (as in, equivalent if two Aethae can be made to equal the same weighted Aethus by simply removing invalid proper child Aethae). Validity equivalence is what probability is valued over and all, not standard Aethic equivalence itself, which is the higher scope category!

Followup 1: Also, I don't think it's said explicitly enough how the whole IDEA of A-AB is that, under validity equivalence multiplying B to A prunes a bunch of terms of A based on B and leaves a residue reduced form, and then exactly THESE terms get subtracted off of A in A-AB, hence leaving exactly those terms in A which DO get pruned in AB, hence the logical complement of B wrt A! See the idea???

Followup 2: Cool, thanks! And you also see the intrigue in how if A implies B, then AB is simply equivalent to A, and so A-AB is the hyperinvalid Aethus up to validity equivalence! So in other words kind of cool as an algebraic reimagination of this stuff, as is enabled by the Aethus concept!

4.8.1 Distinction Between Ontology and Epistemology

It is important to note, to begin with, that *the Aethus as a mathematical object is a distinct entity than the Aethus as an ontological object.* This sort of property is consistent across all quantities in physics, even though it is not always explicitly stated. Consider, for instance, the distance between the Earth and the sun. Whenever we describe such a quantity, we may be referring to one of two particular epistemological objects.

A. The physical distance from the Earth to the sun, in the connotation of being a Platonic ideal. Such an object is a feature of the universe itself, and cannot be grasped in its direct form by humans.

B. The Earth-Sun distance as an epistemological object which is constructed within our mathematical structure. It is based upon our axioms and composed of whichever structure we ascribe to it.

One quick way of proving that A and B are indeed two separate objects, is through the use of defining a different mathematical structure altogether, and then attempting to measure the same physical object, A. Under B, being a result of our own paradigm of mathematics and measurement, we might consider a few axioms which its structure is based upon. Distances draw from real numbers, which are compact under every closed interval, and from there we suppose that real numbers can be endowed with operations which make them a commutative ring, and then our measure of distance can be derived from that given a definition of base unit, be it the meter or something else. Notice that this process is in possession of a distinct mathematical structure, which we might think to change for the measurement of the Earth-Sun distance, if only for the sake of a thought experiment. For instance, perhaps we somehow define an entirely different system of encoding value than exists in the real numbers. Whether or not such a different system is as useful aside, we know that it can surely be done. Perhaps we pick the rational numbers instead, for instance. Then, from there, we might suppose that linear distance itself is not our preferred quantity, but instead some form of logarithmic scale, such that we add one unit for every time we double a distance with respect to the polar circumference of the Earth. Under such a system, the Earth-Sun distance would be 11.9 units, which we of course know to be a very different structure to our own, with regard to the addition of distances, and so on. We might call this particular object some C, being an alternative means of encoding the Earth-Sun distance. The point of the matter here is that our particular way of encoding the Earth-Sun distance is entirely dependent on mathematical structure, and there are innumerably many alternatives which change the very structure of the math as well as just units. As such, we will very readily state that this alternative structure, C, is very distinct to our own structure, B. We thus have that $B \not\equiv C$. However, if we were to declare that the ontological distance is the same as the epistemological distance in the first place, being $A \equiv B$, then we would also have to declare by that logic that $A \equiv C$. However, we immediately see that this forms a contradiction through the transitive property of equality, because $A \equiv B \wedge B \equiv C \Rightarrow B \equiv C$, which then contradicts our assertion that $B \not\equiv C$. Thus, through proof by contradiction, we have that every ontological structure of a quantity has to be a distinct object to any of its corresponding epistemological structures.

The idea with the Aethus is that it also satisfies such a quality. Its ontological form is the one we have been discussing primarily in the philosophical section, and it entails properties like being primarily attached to an agent or living being. However, this is so merely because it is the most direct way of gaining a deductive entry into the Aethus mathematical properties, but such a mathematical form of the Aethus, (being the epistemological form), itself is a much broader concept. Whereas the ontological Aethus often does have the connotation of being correspondent to life, the mathematical Aethus is more general. The goal of defining such a mathematical Aethus is strictly to capture all degrees of freedom and the entirety of the relational structure which is present in the ontological Aethus, (as is the same goal for any mathematical quantity with respect to its corresponding ontological quantity), but we see from such a picture that once the Aethus structure is indeed defined, it can be applied to many ares outside the scope of the specific ontology which it was originally drawn from. That is, the mathematical structure of the Aethus is highly dynamic and capable of describing many different systems, to the point where we should better understand it as a fundamental system of encoding rather than something which sustains the intrinsic biological connotation of the ontological Aethus. The ontological Aethus still holds all the properties which we endowed it with, but the mathematical Aethus, in being an epistemological object, is naturally going to be more analytic than physically tangible in the same way. To draw an analogy using distance again, once one creates a system of measuring distance, being the real numbers, they do not then declare that real numbers hold all the

connotations of distance—rather they suppose that they are a broader notion in general, and can be applied to a myriad of separate fields even outside of distance itself. Had this distinction not been made, and we would of course be significantly more limited in our mathematical understanding as a species.

4.8.2 Ontology on the Validity Quotient

Definition 30 (Ontology)
A property of weighted Aethae is ontological *when validity-equivalent weighted Aethae share it, that is, when it is well defined on the validity quotient. The* ontology *of a weighted Aethus is its class in the quotient.*

Definition 31 (Establishment)
A weighted Aethus with a valid term at visible weight, not measure-zero relative to the rest, establishes *a state when every valid term it carries at visible weight holds that state.*

Proposition 21 (What is ontological)
Establishment is ontological, and so is every quantity read off the valid terms of a weighted Aethus and their weights alone, the realizable probability of Section 4.6.2 among them. The hyperrealizable probability, which weighs the invalid terms as well, is not, and neither are the identities of the invalid tags a weighted Aethus carries.

Proof
The congruence deletes invalid terms and nothing else, so validity-equivalent weighted Aethae carry the same valid terms at the same weights, and establishment and the quantities named read those alone. For the rest, let x have a valid term and let $\perp$ be an invalid Aethus. Then x and $x + \perp$ are validity equivalent, but they differ at the first tier by the tag $\perp$, and the hyperrealizable probability of $x + \perp$ gives $\perp$ its share of the weight.

The distinction of the preceding subsubsection is thereby exact. The Aethus as a mathematical object is the weighted Aethus at the first tier, tags and all: a record of what was asserted and of which contradictions were met, and so of epistemology. The Aethus as an ontological object is its class in the quotient: what it establishes, and how its weight is shared among what can be realized. Two presentations of one Aethus agree ontologically a fortiori, since Aethic equivalence implies validity equivalence; the converse fails for the tags.

4.9 The Formalism, Consolidated

This subsection closes Sections 3 and 4 with the formulations now authoritative, wherever the paper's history offers more than one.

Primitives. Pegs and their disjointness, the attribute relation structure of jointly invalid sets of pegs and states, and states $[X : S]$ as assertions of fillings (Definitions 3–9). In the 2024 vocabulary a stated attribute (α, x) is the determinate state $[\alpha : \{x\}]$, a static Aethus is a representation, a 3-Aethus is closed content, presence is membership in it, and an Aethic contradiction is an empty filling.

Identity. Closure has seven rules (Definition 10); an Aethus is a class of representations with one closure (Definition 8), and representations that derive each other are one Aethus (Theorem 1). A determinate Aethus is one peg of the composite of its attributes, and holding a peg that stands for an Aethus is holding that Aethus (Theorem 2).

Invalidity. Invalidity is a tag: the empty filling licenses nothing further, invalid Aethae stay distinct, and only the validity quotient identifies them with the additive identity (Section 3.2). Explosion survives on the implication side alone.

Operations. Joint assertion is the meet (Proposition 11). The Aethic union keeps its terms, joint assertion distributes over it exactly, and its core, the content its terms share, is their last common ancestor (Proposition 12). Distributivity over cores holds where a carving separates the terms and fails at irreducible superpositions (Proposition 14).

Carving. The fundamental theorem, derived from the second and third postulates, carves an attribute wherever the third postulate can land a contradiction of its agreeing claim. Enforced splitting makes an Aethus holding a carving the core of the sum of its refinements (Proposition 8), and reasoning by cases completes at rendering.

Superposition. Agreeing superposition is a state over two or more pegs; disagreeing superposition is a weighted sum of one-peg branches, its unweighted shadow the support (Section 4.3); Aethic superposition is agreeing within the blocks of a carving and disagreeing across them.

Weights. A weighted Aethus is a formal sum of Aethae (Definition 29). Weighted proper children, proper Aethae and the reduced form are defined with the third postulate (Definition 36); the completed postulate is the weighted-Aethus reduced form, running over weighted proper children only and over weighted Aethae themselves, and the validity quotient is taken afterwards, for rendering, without feeding back into it. The Aethus's own weights are the hyperrealized ones of the full sum, and probability is valued at the validity tier (Section 4.7.2).

The 2024 text. The definitions and principles of the 2024 presentation stay where they stand, each with a status note giving its reading in these terms; where a note and this list differ from the 2024 text, they govern. The chapters after Section 4 keep the vocabulary in which they were written and read by the same map; the modal chapter's note repeats it where that vocabulary is densest.

Part III: The Physics of Measurement

5 Manifestation of the Aethus in Practice

5.1 Three Definitions for the Aethus

Let us put all the aforementioned definitions of the Aethus together into one expansive definition.

Three Definitions of the Aethus		
Mathematical Definition	**Practical Definition**	**Epistemological Definition**
The Aethus can be defined as a collection of stated-Aethic attributes, where Aethic attributes are classes of descriptive elements of reality, and stated-Aethic attributes are the objects of those classes. It is like a "weighted set", but with certain restrictions on allowed contained information. A better precise definition: *where a "static Aethus" is defined as a set of stated-attributes, an Aethus is an equivalence class of static Aethae.*	Every person and animal has an Aethus. Every conscious being has an Aethus. Even every describable system, real or fictional, has/corresponds to an Aethus. *Generally, we might suppose that whenever a describable, (either epistemically or ontologically) phenomenon of sensory intake exists, it intrinsically implies a corresponding Aethus to that intake.* To each Aethus, then, there is a 1-to-1 correspondence to a particular designated reality/possible world.	Where the distinction between objectivism and relativism is usually considered to be a dichotomy, in Aethic reasoning it is actually a trichotomy. Here are the layers: 1. Sentient/Opinionated Knowledge: – The subjective interpretation of one's own information. 2. Received/Accessible Knowledge: – *The direct, unalterable, and technically imperceptible*[93] *intake itself of information.* – *(This is the Aethus).* 3. Objective Truths: – That information which cannot be accessed but exists anyway in some form.

Table 4: A representation of the three major applicative Aethus definitions.

We might suppose that there is a kind of *Aethic equivalence principle*, being simply that these three definitions ought to be referring to the same single concept: the Aethus itself.

[93]This imperceptibility of Aethic knowledge is somewhat analogous to Platonic ideals. For instance, we can use the number three, or draw a triangle, but in neither of these cases are the ideal of "three" or "triangle" actually directly presented physically. The same is true for human perceptions of our own Aethic information, where we are consistently making use of this information, but only in one direction, such that we can read it but never write to it, to use terms from computer science. Of course we can make decisions, (assuming free will), which influences future Aethic gains, but we cannot actually manipulate this information directly or even directly comprehend of it. Only whatever mental falloff that goes from it into our minds is what we have to work with, making said mental states manipulable, but relatively dangerous for their according potential for misinterpretations (relative to the Aethic level).

5.2 Refining Aethic Reasoning From a Counter-Reductionist Frame

5.2.1 Ontological Aethae As White Noise

In case there is any confusion among our readers for why or how the Aethus, itself an inherently mathematical object, tends to situate itself with one's conscious reality, and whether such a thing is compatible with Occam's razor, consider the following proposition: because of our assertion that an ontological Aethus is merely a manifestation of an agent's sensory intake, by the rules of Aethic reasoning, the very state of some form of sensory intake existing implies the existence of a corresponding Aethus. It is not some additional, external, causal, or otherwise forced property — simply an ontological manifestation of the statement already posited.

So, naturally, it follows from this that rooting the ontology of the Aethus to any thing other than the direct sensory intake of oneself would be something of a fallacy, because it would include arbitrary intermediate layers between the actual ontological root of things and one's own interpretation of said ontology. Specifically, we originally brought about the concept of the Aethus by separating a human's subjective knowledge into opinionated and generally accessible forms, so through this, any state of defining the Aethus of a person as based on anything outside of the direct, root level sensory intake, would be contradicting this definition of it as being representative of the accessible knowledge. It would make room for error at best, and at worst it would be defining the entirely wrong thing. So, for example, supposing that the Aethus sprouts from the ontological process of the mind or any sort of thought-interpretation of reality is itself not synonymous with the generative concept of the Aethus. An interesting consequence of this definition of the physical rooting of the Aethus, by the way, is that it is very intertwined with the Aethic principle of accidentalism[94], and the first Aethic postulate itself, in which the basis of reality itself is strictly centered on whatever a person is conceptually receiving from it, with any ontology hiding behind or outside of that being respectively not meaningful. (For instance, that notion that whether we are in a simulation or not, in not being derivable from our own accessible information, is therefore not in possession of a single or definite state).

Lastly for this section, consider the notion of what it would be like to actually write down a static Aethus of one's own Aethus on paper. For an Aethus which we mathematically construct entirely from scratch, starting with a blank static Aethus and moving from there, we might suppose that, due to our own constructive limitations, such an Aethus will hold some semblance or another of readability of its properties, (for example, as might be seen through human-generated computer code, which is algorithmically followable). However, when we consider naturally generated Aethae, such as one's own Aethus, it follows that the process is rather more like the opposite, starting from some layer of utmost complexity rather than a blank static Aethus, which we can, in our mathematical manipulation, create slight tweaks to, while all the while staying consistent to this pre-build general ontological blueprint that is one's Aethus. That is, there is so much complexity in the mix, that the process of actually returning to a blank Aethus from this is essentially impossible in a step-by-step manner. This therefore implies that we will always stay at a low number of degrees of separation, (regarding algorithmically followable attributes), from the actual ontological Aethus when doing our manipulation, just due to the limitations of the human mind.

This being said, the proposition of actually writing down one's ontologically present static Aethus would work as follows: it would essentially look like white noise if we were to write down all attributes and their values on paper or in a database. The reasoning for this follows from the notion that human-defined attributes are always only approximates of ontology, and approximates which become less and less accurate to higher degrees of specificity, just like the length of a fractal coastline becomes less accurate to the truthful answer with higher specificity in the unit of measurement. For instance, take something seemingly simple, like the diameter of the sun. In our mathematical framework, this is a simple and important parameter, however in the real world, there sort of is no such ontological thing. Rather, the surface of the sun is fluid and ever-changing, causing a direct measurement of distance from one side to the other to be somewhat arbitrary and inconsistent among its possibilities. As such, we can note that if we start building a static Aethus from one's own Aethus, then even if we begin to choose algorithmically manageable attributes first to write down, (such as the diameter of the sun), then each new attribute that we have to write to encompass all derivation in the Aethus becomes more and more difficult to write algorithmically while still capturing the needed ontology. As such, logically,

[94] A terminological note, since the word has a prior tenant: the metaphysics literature's "accidentalism" names the doctrine that some events occur without cause. The Aethic principle is a different animal—weight non-extremality, no weight perfectly one or zero outside idealized conditions—and shares with its namesake only the chance-affirming flavor. A future revision may rename it; until then, this disambiguation stands.

we see that our probability of doing this correctly falls extremely quickly with each new attribute, such that the state of writing down the entire Aethus in an algorithmically-followable static Aethus becomes somewhat impossible. Consequently, now matter how one chooses to write down their Aethus in a static Aethus, it follows that they will essentially tend to be faced with a white-noise-like[95] visual as the product.

As an example of this hypothetical transitionary process from an Aethus into one's own consciousness, refer to the following diagram.



Figure 5: A symbolic representation of the ontological chaotic randomness of a physical Aethus.

In effect, we hold as a fundamental principle of Aethic reasoning that any static Aethus of an ontological Aethus, upon being written down, is almost surely going to be manifested as white noise. For an epistemological Aethus, however, which is capable of also being generated for simpler cases, of course, this is not necessarily true. Just we have to remember that the very supposition of attempting to denote an ontological Aethus with a mathematical Aethus is not a process of fully depicting it, but rather depicting only the most surface-level details of it to whatever depth is achievable. Consider the following distinction, now.

Definition (Directional Dichotomy of Aethic Mathematical Expression)
Consider the two major procedures for defining a mathematical Aethus.

1. Empirical Declaration of an Aethus
    - This consists of asserting that a mathematical Aethus corresponds to a particular real-world Aethus, however without explicitly being able to know all the workings of the entire thing in the mathematics, naturally.
    - Such a process typically regards the selecting of a few attributes from the ontological

[95]That is to say that since the probability of writing the static Aethus *without* it being white noise is almost surely impossible, then we have to conclude that all actually written-down static Aethae (as validly capture ontological Aethae) must be white noise—the only remaining option. In other words, so much as starting out with a "human construct" attribute like the diameter of the sun makes it rapidly more implausible to write each next "human construct" attribute while still fitting the ontological Aethus in question. So we must abandon writing any of these human constructs (or at least write only as many so that they have near-zero set measure in the full static Aethus) as part of the static Aethus in the first place, and instead revert to writing white noise which in some paradoxical and untraceable way still reduces to the correct empirical Aethus. (Perhaps it is possible to write the full construction without having to revert to white noise, just the difficulty that the probability of actually achieving this is zero, that way in practice it is almost surely impossible to complete the feat—so if you will slightly less strong than "decidedly impossible", but still more than impossible enough to found the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae on).

But to be clear, it is not that the while noise represents our failure of depicting the empirical Aethus—rather it is our only way of doing so, with the difficulty being that then trying to personally comprehend the structure in the white noise is fruitless, (even though the full Aethic attribute cascade processes it instantly in some humanly-untraceable way).

Aethus to consider, and then performing Aethic analysis over those in a well-defined way.

- Most of the philosophical applications of Aethic reasoning stem from this variety of declaration.

2. Epistemic Declaration of an Aethus

   - This consists of perfectly describing an Aethus down to its static Aethus through which we instantiate it mathematically, such that we have an awareness of all its properties on account of having defined them from scratch.
   - This can be seen as a mathematical generalization of the practical tailoring which allowed us to define a mathematical Aethus in terms of an ontological Aethus in the first place. That is, once we have attained the base mathematical structure needed to depict the empirical Aethic properties, we might imaging generalizing them to a more basic mathematical space, being this basic declaration of an Aethus and such.

Through such a thing, we see clearly the dichotomy of how an Aethic may be declared, as well as some of the contextual and originating notions behind such things.

Importantly, we might think to refer to an empirically-declared Aethus as simply an **empirical Aethus**, whereas we might refer to an epistemically-declared Aethus as a **purely epistemic Aethus**. This is an intuitive yet crucially important distinction of Aethic metaphysics. Furthermore, we might think to further subcategorize empirical Aethae into first-person or third-person versions, on account of first-person versions needing to match only one's own known Aethic attributes in order to be an accurate fit, (even if such a fit is merely abstractly assumed in the mathematical formulation, which of course is necessary to depict such a thing mathematically in the first place).

- Mathematical Aethus[96]

  (The two children below are the outer layers of the three-layer stratification of Section 5.2.2: the purely epistemic Aethus inhabits the fully-inscribed first layer, the empirical Aethus the unreduced third—and the middle, mined layer is where most working Aethic analysis in this paper actually operates.)

  – Purely Epistemic Aethus

  Def: An Aethus which is mathematically declared purely in the space of constructible static Aethae, without having an abstract assumed correlation to a particular empirical Aethus.

  – Empirical Aethus

    ∗ First-Person Empirical Aethus

    Def: An Aethus which is abstractly assumed to exactly correspond to one's own metaphysically correspondent Aethus. Naturally this cannot be written down mathematically in full, but it can nonetheless be inferred to exist mathematically through abstract means.

    ∗ Third-Person Empirical Aethus

    Def: An empirical Aethus which is not particularly a first-person empirical Aethus. On account of this, it will nonetheless share a substantial last common parent Aethus with one's own Aethus, all while either holding separate additional attributes, or perhaps being taken to hold blanks in place of certain instances of one's own attributes, (this notion is what we might perceive as said third-person occupying one's own "possible world", however we see with Aethic reasoning that the limits of distinction on such a boundary are fundamentally arbitrary anyway). This is the model of empirically declared Aethus that one might use to depict the Aethus of another person, or for that matter even an animal, process, or any instance of information.

[96]This top category was called the "epistemic Aethus" in earlier drafts; the rename reflects that the intended contrast was always mathematical-versus-ontological—an Aethus as declared and worked within the formalism, against the real-world thing itself—rather than anything about knowledge as such. The old word was an artifact of an earlier usage in which "epistemic" was meant as "conventional rather than ontological."

- Ontological Aethus

  Def: An ontological Aethus does not exist in an epistemological context at all, and is merely the real-world physical thing which we are attempting to depict through Aethic reasoning.

We might now think to write down the theorem of inability to express empirical Aethae as a readable static Aethus.

Theorem 8 (Fundamental Theorem of Empirical Aethae)
It is almost surely impossible, as a physical agent, to express an empirical Aethus using a constructible or otherwise readable static Aethus, because the ability to design a framework which incorporates each new attribute drops exponentially quickly with each new added attribute to the framework. In the limit, we hold that Cartesian categorization-based epistemology breaks down entirely toward depicting the needed degrees of freedom of all involved causal logic, so we might consider replacing it with a form of Aethic logic where we assume that the mathematical Aethus which we manipulate has been fully constructed by whatever mechanism, all while explicitly acknowledging that we ourselves may never gaze upon the underlying dynamics directly. We may nonetheless perform Aethic reasoning over this empirical Aethus through its mathematical ideal, hence being the motivation of this paper.

Definition 32 (Categorical Abstraction of Empirical Aethae)
This is a central methodological move unique to Aethic reasoning, and is arguably its single most abstract extremum in theory-space.

Leading into the categorical abstraction, we are left with the fundamental recognition of how the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae prevents us from fundamentally describing the static Aethus of a given ontological Aethus[97] *to anywhere remotely near completion or even minutely-partial completion. Fundamentally speaking, then, the categorical abstraction states that we need not actually try to force an exhaustive axiomatic abstraction of ontological Aethae in the first place, but instead simply take an abstract step back and "consider the ontological Aethus merely as the unit whole, but without forcing knowable compartmentalization". If you wish, this is perhaps somewhat analogous to how in Galois theory we cease trying to find the roots of an arbitrary quintic, and instead treat them as simply an intangible part of an "abstract indivisible whole". But in both cases, what is profound is not the inability for compartmentalization itself, but rather what occurs in the abstract once we take the step into accepting the structure for what it is: the abstract category itself of "the whole" is met with a richness that is somehow both irreducible to exhaustive description so as to prevent its entry into the concrete physical world, but at once is entirely real in a well-defined sense. So what we are left with is an object which is entirely alien to the physical senses, but may nonetheless be reached through the channel of the most immense layers of abstraction. Whether this is just suspension of disbelief or a genuine Platonic ontology is a debate for the psychologists, but in any case what is ideally profound about quintic roots in Galois theory, and ontological Aethae alike is how they are knowable via abstraction, just via abstraction which turns their seeming weakness of knowable-irreducibility into their defining strength of richness. Such is the paradox of abstraction, and this is why I would characterize this categorical abstraction concept as the abstract peak of Aethic reasoning.*

This all being said, now, the fundamental idea is that the "empirical Aethus" category is itself the manifestation of carrying out the categorical abstraction on a real-world ontological Aethus. That is, in human thought-attached theory-space, an empirical Aethus is the abstract object which designates the "mathematical shape" of an ontological Aethus, all while embracing the inability and lack of desire to compartmentalize it in the abstract, (and hence the paradoxical concept of turning this inability into the very source of its abstract richness). While an ontological Aethus is implied to be "out there in the real world", just as a planet might be that we as humans did not put there, an empirical Aethus is specifically the abstract ideal and manifestation given by defining an ontological Aethus theoretically and through use of the categorical abstraction. In other words, when methodologically carrying out Aethic reasoning on an empirical Aethus, we by means of a kind of suspension of disbelief "consider" that its full richness ought to exist, but all while without having to attempt to picture it altogether. We simply carry out operations on empirical Aethae, and Aethic reasoning provides us with compelling results. That is it, and nothing more, like a kind of Leibnizian identity of indiscernibles pertaining to what an empirical Aethus actually is beyond the transformations which we as theoreticians may run on it.

[97] Or really even any parent Aethus to it due to the principle of Aethic accidentalism, for which Aethic weights are never perfectly one or zero outside of idealized conditions, as therefore implies that the ever-lingering presence of Aethic superpositions presents us with an avenue for the "indescribable" character of an Aethus under the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae to persist.

And the abstraction's working material should be stated at the stratification's grain: the parent Aethus of analysis it supplies may be drawn from either of the lower layers—fully inscribed, or semantically mined—per Section 5.2.2. The method is layer-general, not a purely-epistemic-to-empirical bridge alone.

A double warning belongs at this articulation's door, because two natural conflations must be blocked in advance. The stratification below is *not* the existential trichotomy of the Three-Definitions table, (Section 5.1): that axis sorts by *access*. Nor is it the Directional Dichotomy of Aethic Mathematical Expression above: that axis sorts by *procedure for declaring* a mathematical Aethus. The present axis stratifies *Aethae themselves*, by the status of their constraint-content relative to analysis. All three axes are mutually orthogonal, and associating any two of them is a category error.

5.2.2 The Constraint Layer and the Three Layers of Aethae

This articulation belongs directly beside the fundamental theorem just proved, because the theorem is its load-bearing wall—the move that makes the foundations of Section 3.1 axiomatic in more than aspiration. I articulate it in full for the first time, having carried it as intuition since the relation set was first introduced. The pressure that forces it is real: notions like "cause," and even "deductive dependence" as ordinarily wielded, are ill-defined when pressed, so any machinery that consults them—the scope settings of the counterfactual semantics included—risks having its specific behavior be a dependent variable on an unformalized notion. The resolution is that the true axiomatic layer sits beneath all such gadgetry, in what the relation set was always reaching for: *if one could somehow mine any attribute for all of its semantic content, that content would reduce to a series of disjointness claims*—intersections asserted invalid by the semantics itself. "Not green" and "proceed" are constrained as invalid at this layer, (more exactly, "not green, and awake at the wheel, and legal, and so on" against "proceed," since the semantics has edge cases and the mining respects them). Crucially, one can never write all of this content down—the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae doing its usual work—and so the move is made as a disciplined suspension of disbelief: *we take the implicit semantic mining itself as the axiomatic layer*, exactly as one takes an infinite deductive closure as a completed object.

What then emerges, when one reads this implicit content across the attributes of an Aethus, are *causal gadgets*: approximate directional strings like "not green implies not proceed." But the direction is a reading, not a resident. All that exists at the layer itself is the invalid intersection, directionless—so at the right backtracked Aethus, "proceed implies green" is the more obvious gadget to mine from the very same constraint, which is the constraint-layer ground of the dual causality of Section 9.7.3, and of the descent-order universality of the parent relation. And it is the ground of the scope settings themselves, (Section 9.1.2): the *bidirectional* clearing consumes the constraint exactly as it exists at this layer—both gadgets at once, no reading consulted—while the *unidirectional* clearing consumes one mined gadget, the convention-filtered restriction; and where no timelike order exists for the mining to read, as between spacelike-separated attributes, there was only ever the one directionless constraint, and the two settings coincide of themselves. The methodological posture is precisely Newton's, and the scope of the claim should be fixed carefully: it concerns the *universe of the model*. Newton could not track every molecule of the buzzing substrate, yet inferred classical mechanics *outward from it*, so that each constraint of the force law was never instantiated by hand but insisted upon as an emergent implication of the substrate's behavior. No one, on this view, has ever invented a force out of nothing *within the universe of their model*—and the point has bite precisely because the modeler *governs* that universe absolutely, sandbox-fashion, and yet declines to rule it by fiat. The discipline of insisting that the substrate implies each constraint, rather than instantiating the constraint directly, is exactly what separates real-world model building from a video-game sandbox, where fiat would do. The same move, imported: the causal and law-like entries the books carry, and every scope setting that consults them, are emergent gadgetry mined from the disjointness layer—whose ground truth is the framework's own primitive, the validity or invalidity of intersections—and their apparent ad hocness dissolves into inference from a substrate that was axiomatic all along. (Seen from this layer, the scope menu's three settings become simply three disciplined *orientations* of the one directionless constraint web—which reading of the mined gadgetry a reopening follows: support-lines only, forward causal lines, or lines in both directions—with mood selecting the orientation.)

Two further precisions ride with this articulation, dictated in the same breath, and they complete the layer's bookkeeping. *First, deduction and contradiction, defined at the right level.* Even to speak of an entry's "deductive cone," one must already split the Aethus—as the intersection of something with the entry in question—and this apparent separability concern dissolves once deduction is defined

Aethically: *deduction is the inference, from the mined internal nature of some given attributes, of what else must be present in any Aethus for which those attributes are listed.* The closure that contradicts a removed entry is therefore computed from precisely the *constructed* Aethus in which the entry is absent—if the entry were present, the closure would be redundant, the entry already standing there to found the deduction of itself. And contradiction, in the static sense, is then simply this: two attributes whose mined innate semantics declare them disjoint, both being present. The division of labor is clean: the innate semantics are *attribute*-intrinsic; deduction, and everything downstream of it, is *Aethus*-intrinsic.

Second, the layer count corrected: three, not two. The abstract/empirical two-layer picture that runs through this discussion under-counts what the present articulation reveals, and the refinement stratifies *Aethae themselves*, (the layers' names are left open here; their operations are what matter). In the first layer, one actually writes down the attribute-intrinsic disjointness claims, as finite lists. In the second layer—and this is the stratification's entire point—one takes one's own sentence semantics to *contain* the attribute-disjoint content, mined rather than listed: this is the true axiomatic layer of the articulation above, held by disciplined suspension of disbelief. And in the third layer, one passively assumes the existence of the Aethus as it is, without the *reductionist luxury* of assuming it can be unpacked into the semantic mining at all: the Aethus simply *is, externally to analysis*—the empirical Aethus of the theorem just proved. The working procedure is the same at both jumps between adjacent layers: infer, from one of the lower layers, a particular *parent Aethus of analysis* to one's own, and then run Aethic deduction over that parent intersected with a sufficiently informative *additional* parent, so as to simulate "the whole Aethus." The implication is accepted rather than hidden: the process only ever deals in such approximations upon one's Aethus—the non-reductionist concern is intrinsic, and the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae guarantees it—but this is exactly how the methodology checks out, procedurally and in general: approximation by parent-intersection.

The three layers deserve their own tabulation, headed by their operations:

The Three Layers of Aethae, by Constraint-Content Status		
Disjointness written down	**Disjointness mined from one's semantics**	**No reduction assumed**
One actually writes down the attribute-intrinsic disjointness claims, as finite lists.	One takes one's own sentence semantics to *contain* the attribute-disjoint content—mined rather than listed.	No unpacking into sentences is assumed available: the Aethus simply *is, externally to analysis.*
The axioms are inscribed; analysis proceeds directly on the lists.	*The true axiomatic layer*, adopted by disciplined suspension of disbelief; analysis proceeds by mining.	Prior to axioms altogether; analysis proceeds only by approximation: a parent Aethus of analysis from a lower layer, intersected with a sufficiently informative additional parent.

Table 5: The three layers of Aethae, stratified by the status of their constraint-content relative to analysis, (layer names deliberately left open). Distinct from the existential trichotomy of the Three-Definitions table, (access), and from the Directional Dichotomy above, (procedure of declaration): three mutually orthogonal axes.

The ontological standing of the three layers completes the picture. The first layer is the only one a finite analyzer can literally inhabit in full: it is the layer of inscription, and everything actually written in this paper lives there. The second layer is where the framework's *true axioms* live, and the Epistemological Reversal Principle is what entitles it to that standing: with information given priority over fully specified worlds, the mined disjointness content is not an approximation to some deeper axiom set—it *is* the axiom set, taken as completed in exactly the way an infinite deductive closure is taken as completed. And the third layer's Aethus—the empirical Aethus proper—is the framework's realism anchor: it is what the first postulate indexes and what the fundamental theorem protects—the Aethus that is, prior to and independent of every attempt at its own transcription, which is precisely why the relativism of this framework never collapses into anti-realism. The level-jump procedure

then reads ontologically rather than merely methodologically: that a finite analyzer only ever works approximations upon its own Aethus is not a deficiency of the method but the metaphysics of finite analyzers stated honestly—the approximation is what analysis *is*, for beings whose transcriptions are always smaller than their states.

5.2.3 The Structure of Aethic Retrievals in Empirical Aethus-Settings

Consider the basic Tim's dog illustration of Aethic retrievals, for which we consider a purely epistemic Aethus where Tim has a dog, and we call an Aethic retrieval for "What kind of pet does Tim own?". In the purely epistemic Aethus case, the retrieval would be "Dog" because the attribute is state-decomposable to "Dog" as opposed to comprising an Aethic superposition. This being said, now, when we switch to empirical Aethae as opposed to purely epistemic Aethae, something very interesting happens when we call the same retrieval question over the real-world Tim and his dog as opposed to the idealized case. That is, it is paramount to conclude, firstly, how "Dog" is not actually a well-defined Aethic state according to the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, simply because it is a semantic construct which may not possibly be decomposed into axiomatic parts while maintaining its structural capacity as a complex-emergent object. Accordingly, then, that which is actually retrieved from the empirical Aethus in place of this naive designated-Aethic state is effectively an utterly complex multi-nested[98] system of Aethic superpositions which topologically or otherwise structurally are consistent with what we semantically call "Dog". In other words, for an empirical Aethus it is not only supposed but supposed mandatory that the Aethic superposition content does not fully collapse in such an empirical Aethus-Aethic retrieval, but instead that quite the opposite happens—the structure demands that, like a near-infinitely high-dimensional topology of chaos, actually attempting to "make determinate" certain regions of the Aethic superposition within the retrieval output emphasizes the superposition content in others, (as is perhaps reminiscent of attempting to push a peeled orange peel flat, since its Gaussian curvature simply does not match the flat presentation one might be attempting). This makeup for empirical Aethus-valued Aethic retrievals—like those for "Dog"—as are inferred from the structure of the Aethic definitional hierarchy in empirical Aethus-contexts, is perhaps remarkably convergent with the nature of semantics according to late Wittgenstein [86]. That is, since both attribute semantic words to a vast graph-like structure of indecomposable relationships as opposed to the naive semantic primitive most commonly attributed to words, and because the lack of such primitives forces the first principles of language to only ever concern the relativist familial resemblances between the structures we attribute to different words as opposed to implying the existence of an "objective or intrinsic" nature to individual words[99].

I take it as a fundamental corollary to the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, (Theorem 8), that most attributes one could possibly name—"John's hair color" serving as well as any—cannot be reduced to primitives at all, and are not even reducible to the compositional pieces their names suggest: John's hair color is not a function of John, hair, and color as attributes, but a vastly chaotic collage of more primitive Aethus effects. What we as humans attach the name to is a limited-projective view upon that full complexity—the name *intersects* with an Aethus in precisely the evaluating-truths sense, rather than being forced through the structure as a primitive. The parallel to machine-learning embeddings is, I think, exact, (and I record for the priority-minded that I had drawn it by 2022, before ever encountering the systems that later made it vivid): a name behaves like an embedding vector, a compressed projection of an unrecoverable underlying structure, useful precisely because it never pretends to be the structure itself. And the irreducibility purchases something concrete, which I would call *ontological robustness*: because John's hair color does not decompose into John, hair, and color, the space of tweakings available while holding other attributes fixed is vastly higher-dimensional than any compositional reading would permit—which is, not coincidentally, exactly the robustness the emergent-construction discipline exploits when it approximates a named attribute by a parent of its establishing intersection rather than instantiating it.

[98] That is, the multi-nested feature follows from how we already understand Aethic retrievals to hold a multi-nested property, as allows for disagreeing superpositions to be distinct from agreeing superpositions, (since flattening the retrieval nesting would destroy the difference between them). Accordingly, then, due to the rule of thumb in complex systems that once a major structural feature is allowed, it is exploited maximally, we may then infer that multi-nested structures perhaps play a non-negligible role in real-world Aethic retrievals under empirical Aethae.

[99] So, in that sense, a world where words must be individually objective has more constraints in the style of degrees of freedom on language than the relativist view, because the relativist view effectively discards the subset of constraints which fix the objective nature. Loosely speaking, then, it is like the throwing out of the degree of freedom for an objective position within Galilean relativity.

5.3 Aethic Reasoning and the Philosophy of Machine Learning

A crucially important direct instance of the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae and the categorical abstraction coming into effect is within the philosophy of none other than machine learning.

5.3.1 Illustrating the Extra-Cartesian Model of Ontology

Note that this Aethic paradigm to ontology might become very helpful in disciplines like the philosophy of machine learning, because notions like word embedding themselves become quite natural under its scope. Consider, for instance, the issue of explaining double descent in machine learning. In double descent [87], we see that error heightens as we originally increase the number of parameters in our model, before sharply falling again once we reach a certain threshold. We might illustrate a possible explanation for why this happens through the use of an analogous thought experiment about the characterization of humans. Specifically, we might ask the simply question of *how does one, to philosophical accuracy, describe a person like Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart*?

Consider how I would describe Mozart to my friend who has never heard of him. "He is artistic." I might say. "He is profound but also somewhat childlike." I can continue. "He embodies leadership while also being an outcast." With the use of such words, I have taken the otherwise vast array of possible configurations of character that Mozart could have had, and I have compressed it into a much clearer picture. Looking more deeply at what information was passed during this linguistic exchange, we might also ponder over the deep myriad of implications that each word I said carried. Take the word 'artistic,' for instance. It evokes a certain feeling when pondered as a concept, does it not? How on Earth could one pass any semblance of such nuance to a computer in place of a human, such that it could do operations over Mozart's dataset just like a human might do upon thinking about Mozart?

If we begin at the most basic level of information – the bit – we swiftly begin to see a disruptive, if not mildly irritating pattern: every time we add a bit to identifying Mozart, we lose just a little bit of our pinpoint accuracy. Consider the following example: let us set up a series of dichotomies which we will sort Mozart into, as a kind of questionnaire. But we have to pick one, as selecting a middle ground would add more bits. One word we used was artistic, so perhaps we define the dichotomy of "artistic vs. calculating." Already one might notice some of the trouble ensuing: is calculating truly the logical complement of artistic? Sure, it might be an antonym under some regards, but by assuming that calculating is the antonym of artistic, we also now imply a stricter definition of artistic in the intuitive sense. 'If artistic and not calculating' is just a bit more specific a description than 'if artistic' alone. This was not intended – as all we did was declare a binary – and yet here we are. Nevertheless, however, we might suppose we can sort Mozart into artistic anyway, as that was the term we used after all. Next, we might consider another dichotomy. Perhaps we select the "profound-to-boring" dichotomy, and sort him into 'profound'. And then we might do a "leader-to-follower" dichotomy, and sort him into 'leader.'

But the word 'leader' carries a good deal of other implications, and those are implications that Mozart plainly does not follow. No, he does not govern a state or city, and no he does not give grandiose speeches to uneasy friends, Romans, and countrymen. The point of the matter is that the more dichotomies we instate in our attempt to describe Mozart's persona in data, and the more inaccuracies creep in. Eventually, then, we get to a state where we are hardly describing Mozart at all – in the very least regarding our ability to reconstruct him given the data. We might even attempt to add more resolution to each dichotomy itself, perhaps giving them four bits to a dichotomy, that way we have a scale of one to sixteen regarding Mozart's embodiment of a particular trait. But that creeping loss of accuracy, even if slightly slowed, is still very much present all the same.

Everything changes once we begin to add more data—or rather much more data. We see that going from five dichotomies to ten to twenty yields a dropping correlation between our set of dichotomies and the physical Mozart, (due to the issues just stated), but once we have amassed huge amounts of data, the pattern reverses entirely. Suppose we have now entered Mozart's value in eight thousand different dichotomies. As we have demonstrated, any group of a handful of these dichotomies will suffice a deeply poor match to Mozart's persona, (resultantly holding a low score of similarity if such a thing could be measured), so we have literally composed this large dataset of dichotomies from broken and mismatched units. And yet – strangely enough—a new phenomenon takes over at this scale: *the probability of ever coincidentally reentering our same parameters again becomes almost surely zero.* That is, in the set of all bits we could have entered into the dataset, the probability mass of the particular alignment we have proceeded with is next to nothing. This is a simple property of the exponentially decreasing probability of selecting a particular binary sequence as the number of digits

increases. But the property of intrigue here is not this directly.

Consider the act of attempting to log data about a person, A, (in our case Mozart), by answering the questionnaire with the vector A_Q. Then consider the act of logging another person, B, in the dataset by using our same dichotomy-based-questionnaire and entering B_Q as an attempted match for that person. The first property we know is that if $A = B$, (meaning that B is also describing Mozart), and yet still for two independently answered questionnaires, we have that the probability of their being equal in all responses is unlikely on the order of quantum fluctuations for a large enough questionnaire.

$$\mathrm{P}(B_Q = A_Q \mid B = A) \ll 1 \tag{29}$$

The interesting case, however, happens when B is not equal to A, (or in other words, that B is describing a separate physical person). Interestingly, we now have that even though the probability of ever attaining A_Q again is already extremely low, it is now even lower.

$$\mathrm{P}(B_Q = A_Q \mid B \neq A) \ll \mathrm{P}(B_Q = A_Q \mid B = A) \ll 1 \tag{30}$$

In fact, we can conjecture that for any set, S of physical people, real or fictional, of cardinality on the order of say 10^{18} or less, and we have that the probability of any of their B_Q vectors equaling A_Q is far, far lower than the probability of an equal B to A doing so. We might write this with the following equivalent statement, (through Bayes' theorem).

$$\mathrm{P}\big(B \neq A \mid B_Q = A_Q, (A, B) \in S^2\big) \ll 1 \tag{31}$$

What we then get to argue from this is that A_Q sufficiently "captures" the essence of A—so in this case captures the essence of Mozart to any degree requested of it. It is as if the degrees of freedom needed to describe Mozart himself have been written. Intriguingly, though, such a correspondence has not been written plainly itself, but rather is somehow abstractly contained in all the mess of data which instances of the questionnaire output for one person versus another. Through this mechanism, then—being that it is merely vastly more unlikely for A_Q to depict anyone other than Mozart than it already is for it to be exactly instantiated in the first place—we see something of a convenient parallel between the intuition of empirically-declared Aethae and the mysterious non-expressible degrees of freedom present in A_Q. We might refer to these as *ghost degrees of freedom* of sorts, and we might further suggest that an empirically-declared Aethus can be given to depict them. At least in the philosophical sense, rather than having to refer to the "set of ghost degrees of freedom," with the connotation of sets being rather questionable here, we might simply refer to the "empirical Aethus of ghost degrees of freedom", with the Aethus already being designed to dynamically handle such information.

So, truly what happens when we fit a huge amount of data is the following: *every individual response-parameter holds a substantial amount of error with regard to depicting its assigned person, to the level where it blatantly contradicts them—and yet still we have that when enough data is compiled about said person, it becomes so vastly unlikely that any other perceivable person would result in this exact response vector by comparison, that we are then forced to conclude that the response vector matches the person anyway.* This is in major disagreement with the held ideas of Cartesian categorization, because for this to be the case means we will have built a logical structure out of conflicting axioms, only to have it still remain meaningful. The issue, then, is not that the structure is a logical contradiction at all, but that it would be non-ideal to express it with any kind of Cartesian model of ontology. Instead, we might choose to depict it with an empirically declared Aethus. This leverages the fundamental mathematical structure of the Aethus for an application not entirely based on human ontology, but that makes that mathematical structure no less useful of course.

To quickly describe what replaces the Cartesian model of ontology for cases such as large language model embeddings, the basic idea is just what was described: *ontological depiction is as good as that which would be more improbable to reach from a distinct source than would be improbable to reach from the present source.* Even though this kind of mindset contrasts deeply with our major axiomatic frameworks of ontology, is it still not difficult to notice its agreement with biology and other notions of complexity in the universe. Perhaps then, from this perspective, we may think to reinterpret all the world's ontology—if only as an additive alternative rather than a substitutive one.

5.3.2 A Linguistic Ideal as an Ontological Aethus

Let us quickly form some terminology for use in this section. To begin with, there is a *semantic object*, which corresponds to a relevant linguistic token, and then there is a *semantic ideal*, which is

merely the abstract Platonic ideal to that semantic object, such that it is given to hold all the abstract contextual properties of it. In effect, then, the limit of what a machine learning model produces for a particular vector embedding as the parameter complexity goes to infinity can be considered to at least epistemically "capture" the abstract degrees of freedom of the full semantic ideal in its procedural applications, while the semantic ideal itself can be considered to be endowed with all such perfectly accurate contextual meaning automatically. For the word "apple", then, its semantic ideal is merely exactly what abstract meaning the large language model seeks to capture about it, in effect rising to the ability of being able to perfectly apply its connotation in any setting.

Explicitly speaking, now, the main idea of using Aethic reasoning in the philosophy of machine learning is the following: *the embedding of a linguistic token, such as the word "tree" for example, is itself in direct association with the abstract Aethus which corresponds to that semantic ideal of that linguistic token, with the vector parameters of the embedding representing the states of a static Aethus with unknowable attributes.* Specifically, the very notion of such a linguistic token abiding by all the needed properties and transformations associating with the abstract semantic ideal which it denotes shows to derivable verification that it indeed represents a well-defined static Aethus to whatever ontological Aethus associates with it. The tricky part, however, is that we cannot know what the actual corresponding attributes denote. This is not even a question of finding what they are under the surface, as even that feigns the Cartesian fallacy of ontology. Our best supposition of viewing this, then, is by essentially viewing the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae itself from the opposite standpoint. Just as we argued that it is almost surely impossible to physically express the static Aethus to an ontological Aethus without resulting in comprehensively untraceable white noise, we might then picture the embedding of a linguistic token as a direct example of just such an event. As such, we see that the abstract linkage between that static Aethus and the ontological Aethus which it depicts is still fully intact, so we need only to view the vector embedding itself from the lens of the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, and automatically we have an abstract implication of a corresponding ontological Aethus to that particular vector embedding. Naturally enough, we can express the same semantic ideal with a myriad of vector embeddings for a myriad of different models, but all the while we know that we are pointing to the same semantic ideal, at least on the limit of the model size.

As such, the philosophical claim is simple: *just as we might denote the embedding ideal as the vector embedding vector itself, we might then express the abstract ideal of the semantic object in question with the third-person epistemic Aethus which associates with such a token and embedding.* The key takeaway here is that in all the immediate cascading effects of pure mathematics in its descriptive power of phenomena which are inaccessible from a physically computable standpoint, and still we cannot even express the abstract ideal which corresponds to the linguistic token without employing an Aethus for the task. Take a set, for instance, which by simply writing a recursive definition we know to be able to span literal infinities in the abstract universe. Even with all its powers of induction, however, let us argue now that *a set itself, as an object, cannot be physically made to express an abstract ideal in a well-defined manner.* The supposition behind this is that a set, in being at the end of the day merely a collection, lacks the abstract fluidity to accomplish such a designation. The Aethus, then, was specifically designed to fill in the abstract gaps which a set might be considered to run into upon attempting to encode the cascading effects which intuitively propagate at the scale of extra-Cartesian ontology. This extra "degree of freedom of fluidity" of sorts for the Aethus associates with its ability to utterly rearrange the physical states of a static Aethus which defines it at a moment's notice, while still pointing to the same abstract object. In effect, the hope is that this philosophical flux of sorts, being a property decidedly lacked by a set, thereby allows a mathematical Aethus to chameleon into the role of any ontological Aethus on a whim. We regard this property as almost like an extra condition beyond cardinality, where such a cascading fluidity, in the shoes of an Aethus, essentially ranks a natural number at degree zero, a set at degree one, and perhaps an Aethus at degree two, (with the corresponding principle then being that abstract ideals may only be described with such a degree two object). Whether there is a degree three, or if such an intuitively derived scale is even well-defined in the first place is quite speculative. However, it at least serves as something to ponder over for now.

The conclusion with all of this, then, is that the semantic ideal *is* an ontological Aethus, and therefore our most general mathematical conception of it *is* a third-person empirical Aethus. An Aethus itself, then, is merely that mathematical structure which makes such ideals denotable, with the ontological counterpart associating accordingly.

5.3.3 Embedding Aggregation as a Direct Instance of an Agreeing Superposition

An intriguing property of aggregating vector embeddings is that we might consider such an output as precisely coinciding with the taking of an agreeing superposition over the abstract Aethae which correspond to said embeddings. Notice, then, the stark contrast between how an agreeing superposition is to be taken over the Aethae which correspond to highly complex embedding models as opposed to the Aethae which might correspond to a basic model of three or four parameters, (with the difference presumably deriving from double descent). If we wish to take the agreeing superposition of a model defined with vector $\langle 1.0, 2.0, 3.0 \rangle$ against a model defined with vector $\langle 2.0, 3.0, 1.0 \rangle$, then we will note that simply taking the average of the two vectors is insufficient for such an agreeing superposition, because it fails to derive the original two vectors again. As such, the intuition is that we would need six degrees of freedom to exhaustively encode such an agreeing superposition, or in general we would need $2n$ for a model of size n.

However, of course, we see that once we enter the regime of double descent, the vector average of some number of embeddings is indeed sufficient to capture their agreeing superposition exhaustively. This is an interesting phenomenon to take note of, and we might attempt to explain it by simply attributing the change to the extra-Cartesian role that the vector parameters themselves go on to play. As we saw with the earlier derivation, what was once more axiomatic becomes merely predictive at such scales of parameters, so in the least this is an interesting phenomenon to take note of.

5.4 Narrative Illustrations of the Ontology of Time

We can gain needed intuitions about the ontology of time in Aethic reasoning by using a few narrative-adjacent examples. Let us undergo this now.

Before proceeding, a word on the epistemic status of these narratives is warranted, because they perform two different jobs that should not be conflated. The learning-based narratives, (the parking lot and the Battle of Brémule), are direct illustrations of centric unfolding operating over the extrusion structure: nothing in them is fictional except the staging. The time-travel narratives, (Zoe, the bank-robbery scene, the Jenny example, and the closing remark of the Brémule example), are a different instrument entirely. Time travel of this sort is taken here to be physically unrealizable, and the narratives are offered in the spirit of Maxwell's demon: a stipulated exemption from the framework's own dynamics, used to illuminate a structural point—namely, that determinacy of the past is Aethus-relative—which the dynamics itself never exposes to any agent. For the device to be well-defined, three conventions are fixed by fiat. First, the traveler retains their memories. Second, those memories are indexed to the prior block universe and do not bind the present one's internal history, (this being the same convention formalized in the Frauchiger–Renner discussion of Section 10.2.1 via the Sifting Principle, Principle 26). Third, the bookkeeping for the traveler's retained brain-state within the new rendering of the block universe is set by hand, since centric unfolding is monotone and contains no rewind operation; relatedly, genuine un-learning is non-trivial because the Aethus is closed under deduction, so removing a fact requires removing all facts which derive it. A reader who insists that the brain-world coupling be lawlike may equally read these scenarios as a proof by contradiction that memory-preserving, non-monotone Aethic traversal cannot occur—an Aethic analogue of chronology protection—and nothing downstream of this section resists that reading. Either way, no result in this paper depends on the device: the predictive content of Aethic reasoning lives in the fundamental theorem and the Quantum Nexus, not here. One further framing note binds the learning-based material together across the paper: the parking lot below, the Battle of Brémule, and the sinkhole of Section 9.6 are not isolated curiosities but three projections of the single extrusion-principle backbone—the same Aethus-indexed reopening of blanks in the proper-time past, read once at the scale of an errand, once at the scale of nine centuries, and once at the scale of decades of underground erosion, (Section 12.6.6).

The tense-free second postulate, named. Before the narratives begin, the structural cargo of the learning-based pair deserves one formal sentence, because the narratives carry it implicitly and a great deal later leans on it: *the second postulate is tense-free—its trigger is blankness, not futurity.* The parking lot and Brémule episodes are the past-directed instances: an attribute about what has already happened, so long as it is blank in the evaluating Aethus, stands in exactly the superposition that a future-directed blank would, with extrusion supplying the consistency mechanism, (the learned fact having "always been so" in the subsequent block universe). Stated this way, the pair is the experiential anchor for claims that later sections make at full pressure: the unlearned past standing as open as the unformed future, the sinkhole analysis, the EPR treatment's symmetric handling of the two

light cones, and the Frauchiger–Renner diagnosis, (Section 10.2.1), that the agreeing-to-disagreeing "transition at measurement" is a category error. One pair of stories, one clause: blankness, not tense, is what the postulate reads—a property formalized framework-wide as the indiscriminate time principle, (Principle 11).

5.4.1 Example in a Parking Lot

For an example of the Aethic phenomena operating in one's daily life, consider a parking lot in which your friend has parked their car. If you have your back turned to the parking lot, then relative to your Aethus, your friend's car is in Aethic superposition over being parked in every single spot in their entire lot, because you are unaware of which one they might have parked in. In addition to this, they are also in Aethic superposition of having not arrived at the lot at all due to whatever reasons may have held them up. (Notice that both superpositions are specifically disagreeing superpositions, as we will be able to derive with the coming third postulate).

As a rebuttal to this claim, you might argue that you can disprove this by simply turning around and seeing the parking lot with no superposition therein whatsoever. However, the fallacy here, at least according to the Aethic mindset, is that the very act of turning and looking at the parking lot performs centric unfolding, which in the process transits oneself to a new Aethus. As such, even if at this point you clearly see where your friend has parked, and nonetheless your friend's car is still in superposition at this very moment relative to your Aethus of before you looked at the parking lot, and relative to your Aethus of right now, your friend was always conveniently at the spot they are now parked in. This is so due to the underlying nature of disagreeing superposition, where such transformations toward child Aethae being always in place are fully plausible. However, with agreeing superpositions, note, given that their generating information will never be uncovered anyway, it follows that they will always stay in just such the state they were originally presented relative to all future Aethae of the observer.

And the point deserves its sharpest form, because it holds in the present tense: even now, as you stare directly at your friend's car with a fully determinate state before you, relative to your Aethus of thirty seconds ago that same car remains in disagreeing superposition over the whole lot. The observation did not reach backward and clean that superposition up; it is permanently the case that, relative to that earlier Aethus, the matter is open. Determinacy gained is always indexed to the Aethus that gained it, (a permanence whose formal significance—keeping the prior description in existence as the standing object the anti-deflation result then tests, and the second postulate sayable—is recorded as the Permanence Proposition at the second postulate's statement) . The expansion the thought experiment quietly invites is then the two-observer reading: your friend, walking back from the lot, holds an Aethus in which the position was state-decomposable all along. Two Aethae, one lot, both fully correct—the first postulate in miniature, (Postulate 2.3.2)—and the disagreement between them is not a dispute awaiting adjudication but the ordinary structure of Aethus-indexed reality; the only thing that was ever "in superposition" was the attribute as encoded in yours.

Lastly, let us examine the concept of imagination and prediction. Eerily, this seems to be in part a human construct, at least when it regards the events unfolding behind closed doors, so to speak. In the prior thought experiment, when you were not watching the parking lot, your state of imagining what might be happening in the parking lot is actually not technically part of your own reality, because it contains extra hypothetical information that your Aethus does not have access to. Relative to your actual reality of that moment, the parking lot is in a strange, more raw state of existence that is a disagreeing superposition. Somewhat frustratingly perhaps, you can never see what such a thing looks like – not that it has a *look* in the first place – however the major point is that every time a person imagines what is happening elsewhere in the world, they are actually not picturing[100] their own reality

[100] It is worth establishing with full rigor why the Aethus one constructs in the act of imagining a behind-the-back scene is genuinely inequivalent to one's actual Aethus, since the casual phrase "imagining what is happening" conflates at least two structurally distinct failures, the first of which is decisive on its own and the second of which compounds the danger even where one might hope the first could be evaded. Throughout, let A denote the agent's actual Aethus—the one before turning around, in which the friend's parking-positional-index is genuinely blank—and let A_{img} denote the Aethus implicitly constituted by the mental act of picturing the friend's car as occupying some definite location.

The decisive argument, from the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence. The first failure requires no appeal to human error whatsoever and settles the matter by itself. The essential observation is that, in mentally constructing A_{img}, one takes as an *axiomatic condition of its very definition* that the friend's parking-positional-index is *state-decomposable*—that is, that every component of that positional attribute is stated, so that the index possesses a single well-defined state in the corresponding 3-Aethus. It must be stressed that this does *not*

and or Aethus, and if anything they may be picturing an invalid Aethus due to a lack of rigorous

require imagining any *particular* parking spot: one need not explicitly picture "space K" for the failure to occur. It is sufficient, and indeed unavoidable, that the very act of treating the scene as a determinate behind-the-back reality presupposes that the positional index admits stated-decomposition *at all*—that there is, in the imagined reality, some fact of the matter as to where the car sits. This is the precise abstraction layer at which the argument operates, and it is why set-theoretic notation is the wrong instrument here: the claim is not the membership-style claim that A_{img} *contains* some particular positional element, but the attribute-level claim that the defining condition of A_{img} *asserts the state-decomposability of the index as such.* Phrasing the matter set-theoretically would misrepresent the structure, because the offending content is not an element placed into a collection but an axiomatic attribute-condition imposed in the act of definition.

Now, relative to A, that same positional index is blank, and so by the Second Postulate it retrieves as a full disagreeing superposition over the spots—it is precisely the attribute whose blankness in A generated the superposition in the first place. The two Aethae are therefore inequivalent, and this follows directly from the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence. That theorem states that if there exists a stated-attribute in either of two static Aethae which is not derivable based upon the stated-attributes of the other, then the two project to non-equivalent attribute-cascade objects—and one proves equivalence, when it holds, precisely by the contrapositive, exhibiting derivability in both directions. Here derivability fails in one direction outright: the state-decomposability of the positional index is, by construction, a stated-attribute belonging to (the defining condition of) A_{img}, yet it is not derivable based upon the stated-attributes of A, since the index is blank in A and its state-decomposability is therefore exactly what A does *not* assert. The presence of a stated-attribute of A_{img} underivable from A is, by the theorem, sufficient for the two static Aethae to project to non-equivalent attribute cascades, hence for $A_{\text{img}} \not\equiv A$ as Aethae. Stated plainly, this is an Aethic contradiction between A_{img} and A: the one asserts as state-decomposable precisely what the other holds blank and in superposition. No further premise is required for the inequivalence.

The same conclusion by an Aethic partition. It is illuminating to obtain the inequivalence a second way, through an Aethic partition, since the partition construction exhibits the entire family of imagined Aethae the agent is psychologically weighing and shows each one to fail equivalence by the same mechanism. To carry this out cleanly we first idealize away human error—that is, we assume like-Nexae for the parking-spot probability distribution, so that the spread of imagined possibilities is exactly the spread the correct Aethic weighting would assign, rather than a distorted version of it. Under this idealization, the family of imagined Aethae that the agent entertains as "each possible" arises, *up to Aethic intersection with a consistent alternative Aethus* C, from the Aethic partition of the parent Aethus carrying the disagreeing superposition over the positional index, taken under the partitioning constraint that the positional index be state-decomposable in each member of the partition. The qualifier "up to intersection with C" is not cosmetic: it records that any particular imagined scene typically fixes further incidental attributes beyond the bare positional index, and these are absorbed into a consistent companion Aethus C with which each partition member is intersected; the load-bearing content of the family, however, is carried entirely by the partition under the state-decomposability constraint. Recall that an Aethic partition of an Aethus is a collection of its child Aethae whose Aethic union returns the parent and whose pairwise Aethic intersections are invalid (the disjointness condition), so that the construction here is a genuine partition in the technical sense and not merely an informal listing.

Each member of this family is inequivalent to the actual Aethus A. One clean way to demonstrate this is to establish *validity*-inequivalence, which suffices for the desired conclusion because Aethic equivalence implies validity equivalence—Aethic equivalence, the identity of closures (Section 3.1), is strictly finer than validity equivalence, with static-Aethus equivalence implying $A \equiv_V B$ but not conversely—so that validity-inequivalence contraposes to Aethic inequivalence. The witness is constructive. Intersect A with an alternate state-decomposable proper child Aethus—that is, a proper child of A that states the positional index to some value other than the one a given family member commits to. There exist choices of this alternate proper child for which its Aethic intersection with the given member of the imagined family is *invalid*: the member asserts (via A_{img}'s state-decomposability condition together with its committed locational content) one state of the index, while the alternate proper child of A states a disjoint value of that same index—and two Aethae asserting disjoint states of a common attribute are, by definition, disjoint Aethae, their Aethic intersection being an invalid Aethus on account of the Aethic contradiction the common attribute now carries—whereas that same alternate child, being a proper child of A, has a manifestly *valid* intersection with A itself, so the two sides of the comparison genuinely disagree on that single validity fact. Hence there is a validity fact—the validity of an intersection—on which a member of the imagined family and the actual Aethus A disagree, establishing validity-inequivalence, and therefore Aethic inequivalence, for that member. Since the member was arbitrary, every Aethus in the psychologically-weighed family is inequivalent to A. This is the partition-theoretic counterpart of the direct argument above, and it has the additional virtue of making visible that the inequivalence is uniform across exactly those alternatives the agent takes himself to be imagining as live.

The compounding failure: why even "some valid neighboring Aethus" is not guaranteed. The foregoing already shows that A_{img} is not equivalent to A. But one might retreat to a weaker and more charitable hope: grant that the imagined Aethus is not literally one's own, yet surely it is at least *some* valid neighboring Aethus—a

examination with the postulates[101]. By the first postulate of the Aethus alone, due to your pictured reality about the specific location of your friend behind your back not corresponding to your Aethus, it is therefore *not real* in the most blatant sense of the word. This may very well be the single most jarring consequence of Aethic reasoning.

To be clear, this is not saying that your friend's reality is no longer real, but instead that the particular attribution which has them at an objective location is not real. There must be an actual real situation at play, of course, and this true situation is simply one in which they are in Aethic superposition relative to your Aethus at the moment.

5.4.2 An Example with a Medieval Battle

Consider the Battle of Brémule [88], fought in the high middle ages between the French and the English[102]. As of the writing of this, not many people have actually heard of the Battle of Brémule, and as a consequence of that, are unsure of who actually won the battle, yourself potentially included. If you are knowledgeable of trivia to the extent of knowing this, then, well, first of all congratulations, but for this thought experiment you can simply substitute the Battle of Brémule in particular for

legitimate proper child, or a near relative, of A—rather than an outright invalid object. The second failure is what makes even this weaker hope unsafe, and its source is human error in reading one's own Aethus, understood on the model of measurement error. The situation is as follows. There does exist a parent Aethus to the actual Aethus A which holds the imagined discussion as a valid proper child—in the abstract, the imagined scene can be situated as a legitimate refinement of a suitable ancestor of A, by ascending to an Aethus in which the relevant index is blank and then stating it. The difficulty is that locating the *correct* such parent requires reading A itself accurately, and the interpretation of one's own actual Aethus is subject to an error structurally analogous to measurement error—a self-measurement error, in which one's introspective grip on precisely which attributes are stated, blank, or superposed in A is imperfect. Because of this, the parent Aethus one actually reconstructs cannot be guaranteed equivalent to the true parent.

The danger this opens is precise. Write the actual Aethus as the Aethic product (piecewise Aethic intersection) of some further Aethus B with the reconstructed parent. Self-measurement error prevents one from guaranteeing that no such B exists holding the property of *disjointness* to whatever stated-attributes the imagining has imported. That is: one cannot exclude the possibility that the true decomposition of A relative to the reconstructed parent runs through a factor B which is disjoint to the imported content, in which case the imported content is not merely an innocent refinement but stands in Aethic contradiction with A's actual constitution, its Aethic intersection with the relevant factor being an invalid Aethus exactly as in the disjoint case above. The inability to rule out such a disjoint B is exactly where the danger resides: not in any positively demonstrated contradiction, but in the impossibility of *certifying the absence* of one, given an imperfect reading of one's own Aethus. Where the first failure shows that the imagined Aethus is inequivalent to the actual one, this second failure shows that one cannot even safely demote the claim to "a valid neighbor," because the very step that would establish neighborliness depends on a parent-reconstruction that self-measurement error leaves uncertified.

The paradigm-boundary aggravation. Finally, and as a distinct compounding factor rather than a restatement of the preceding, there is the danger introduced by failing to apply correct Aethic deduction at all. The two failures above are stated under the assumption that one is at least attempting genuine Aethic reasoning—tracking state-decomposability, attending to parent Aethae, respecting the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence. But the realistic situation is that the agent doing the imagining is reasoning from inside the classical counterfactual-semantics paradigm, in which one simply "pictures the scene" as a nearby possible world rather than auditing an Aethic perturbation with its informational boundary held fixed and its second- and third-postulate pruning re-run. Operating from inside that paradigm does not merely leave the above failures unaddressed; it actively exacerbates the chances of a failure of valid reasoning with respect to correct Aethic practice, because the paradigm supplies no machinery for detecting the state-decomposability contradiction, no notion of the parent-reconstruction step, and no concept of the disjoint factor B whose exclusion cannot be certified. The classical paradigm thus conceals precisely the structure that the first two arguments rely upon, so that an agent reasoning within it is not only liable to the failures but is systematically blind to them. This is the sharpest sense in which the imagined scene is not one's reality: by the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence it is provably inequivalent to the actual Aethus; it cannot even be certified as a valid neighbor of it; and the paradigm from within which one ordinarily performs the imagining is the very paradigm that hides all of this from view.

[101] This being said, we already know intuitively that the human brain is incapable of picturing a logical contradiction in its ontological lens, so a further question of intrigue might be to ponder over whether humans are capable of dreaming about invalid Aethae. Is such a thing possible? An interesting hypothetical to ponder, in the least.

[102] Note that the deliberate reason I chose an obscure battle rather than something more fundamental like the Battle of Gaugamela, is because that way we don't have to worry about Nexic effects creeping into the attribute cascade. After all, a fundamental property of the Aethus is that it is closed under deduction (as per the attribute cascade), and so to truly move in Aethic time to before learning a fact alone is not enough to remove it from your Aethus: in actuality you have to remove all facts which deduce it as well. So, it seems probable to me that fundamental events of history, like the conquests of Alexander the Great, are very tied up with the Accordance Principle, therefore meaning that you might have to go back surprisingly far in Aethic time in order to truly weed out the Nexic-driven deductions for how these events turned out, (as in, for instance, if the event is truly an anthropic parameter, then flipping its outcome very much is detrimental to your Cosmic Nexus probability of existence, thereby automatically discounting Aethic blankness in the process due to statistical dependence). So, something obscure like the Battle of Brémule, which appears to be more of a blunt skirmish than anything foundational, serves as a good illustration of the indiscriminate time principle, all while being perhaps more cleanly extractable from one's Aethus by backwards-Aethic time movement, (ie without having "fuzzy" deductive barriers like we might suspect for the Battle of Gaugamela, or anything otherwise Nexically-significant).

some other hypothetical battle of several centuries ago which you are unaware of the outcome to. Now, considering how you are unaware of the Battle of Brémule at this moment, and considering how you have no means of accessing this information, (unless there is some kind of extra element to metaphysics which allows you to know this–which is definitely possible, just outside the more mathematical headspace of the Aethic mindset itself), it follows that the outcome of the Battle of Brémule is in fact not present in your Aethus. As such, when I tell you who won the fight in the next paragraph, centric unfolding demands that you will in fact see a random answer. Whether it is a 50-50 chance is a bit more complicated, but by Bayesian rules we have more or less selected a random battle from French-English medieval conflicts, so it will turn out more or less with whatever relative frequency each had of defeating the other. Considering how neither ever conquered the other, we may reasonably suppose that this is close to 50-50. The idea, then, is that since this Boolean attribute is registered as blank within your Aethus, it follows that upon selecting a random value for it on the next paragraph, your Aethus is about to physically move to a new reality where a conflict almost a thousand years ago falls into place. Until then, it will be blank, with all possibilities unfolding and both sides winning at once in Aethic superposition, (which will be further elaborated upon when we discuss how to determine Aethic superpositions).

And the winners of the Battle of Brémule, lo and behold, were the English! Just now, because you have gained this information in your Aethus, we see that only now do you join a reality in which the English won the Battle of Brémule. Classically, we might expect that the English have always won the Battle of Brémule as a kind of hidden-variable in the universe, and you have simply uncovered it by reading this. However, in the Aethic mindset, the result is far more peculiar, instead arguing that only now have you made this information real relative to yourself. That is not to say that epistemological solipsism is in place, but instead merely that your Aethus has moved to the location of seeing this, just as anyone else's Aethae might do. Crucially, if you somehow found a mechanism of time travel where you went back to your consciousness of a few moments ago when you were reading the last paragraph, and, sure enough, the dice would be rerolled, and the French would now have a chance of winning again relative to your Aethus of time travel – even though you know that not to be the case in your current reality, (per the conventions fixed in the preface to this section). The battle was over with hundreds of years ago, and I wrote this very paragraph about it in your past, and yet still, relative to your Aethus of just before you read the current paragraph, the battle could have gone either way. Now, however, in your current Aethus, the English have always won the Battle of Brémule, and to this Aethus no superposition was ever present at all. It is the Aethus, remember, which tells us such things, and not the flow of time. The classical notion of time travel to one's own experience in the past, as seen in countless movies, books, and video games, becomes somewhat more complex and arbitrary with respect to this more basic system. In the classical version, one goes back to that past time, but meticulously crops out all attributes which occurred after the landing time, and also meticulously holds all attributes which occurred before the landing time in place. Like the absolute value function, which is not analytic and not inherently fundamental. Instead it is quite a construct to do it this way, and it highlights how even concepts like time travel are now apparently being oversimplified greatly in their narrative interpretation. Perhaps this is a cautionary tale of sorts toward other areas in physics where the same phenomenon is still ongoing.

5.4.3 Example Using Narrative Time Travel

(The conventions assumed by this and the following time-travel narratives are fixed in the preface to this section, above.)

Consider the following narrative thought experiment. The idea, simply put, is that our protagonist, who we will call "Zoe", has broken into the office of the antagonist, and needs only to type the correct password into his computer so as to expose his evil deeds to the world. Specifically, she has narrowed the password down to four possible options due to her prior sleuthing, but she only has one attempt to punch in the correct password before the alarm system goes off. However, there is indeed a catch, which is that Zoe has the rare science fiction ability to jump back in time to her own body by exactly one minute, so as to alter the course of history by just that little amount. Zoe's plan, then, is to use process of elimination to achieve the correct password, such that if she makes a wrong choice and the alarms blare, she will swiftly make a past jump and try again.

This is quite a simple thought experiment, and hopefully an intuitive one for its association with science fiction, so for that reason it serves as a great place to isolate some of the key differences between Aethic and classical results. Let us compare and contrast these now.

- **Classical Structure**
  - *What Zoe does is simply implement a process of elimination. She guesses a password among the four options, and then procedurally travels back in time to just before she entered it if it is incorrect. She uses process of elimination to eventually arrive at the correct one of the four. In the first attempt, she has a* $1/4$ *chance of correctness, in the second, (should she fail the first), she has a* $1/3$ *chance of correctness, followed by a* $1/2$ *for the third and a guarantee by the fourth, (since all other options will have been eliminated as possibilities).*
- **Aethic Structure**
  - *In Aethic reasoning, we posit that there is one key fallacy in the perceived ontology within this classical approach. To fix this, we can break the temporal ontology of an event into two parts, being its dimensional location and its Aethic time of inclusion. By the principle of centric unfolding, upon adding a new attribute to one's Aethus, one finds it to be selected perfectly randomly from its standing superposition. In Zoe's case, we can split her query into four main hyperblock coordinates, (thus consisting both of Aethic information and spacetime-locational information).*
  - We have A, before Zoe did anything, B, when she narrowed down the password to the four options by whatever means, and C_{pb}, when she selects the password p and checks its correctness with Boolean b.
  - If we specifically consider A to represent some time in the past[103] when the password was actually definitively set by the antagonist, then classically we might expect that this is the timecode at which the information of the password was added to the universe, be it accessible or not to anyone in particular.
  - However, in Aethic reasoning we see that such a supposition is ontologically baseless, (because it is formulated independently from any particular Aethus), and as such we need a new interpretation to gather the correct ontology.
  - The new idea works as follows: Zoe actually adds the instance of the correct password to her Aethus at C_{pb}, long after it is originally set at A. As such, we have A as containing the dimensional location of the password setting (in its spacetime coordinates), whereas C_{pb} actually contains Zoe's Aethic time of inclusion, (in its Aethic coordinate).

    Note that C_{pb} is not actually one Aethus, but rather the collection of Aethae which corresponds to each submitted password on Zoe's list, and then whether it is correct. As such, we might refer to it in this context as a particular one of these scenarios.
  - Conceptually speaking, we therefore have the following: if Zoe checks a particular password, such as "ILuvDoomsday" for example, and sees that it is incorrect, then it is at this moment and this moment alone when she learns that this is an incorrect option.

    As such, if she was to time travel back to before she learned such a thing, to the prior Aethus of B, then it follows that the information she learned at her C_{pb} is now once again lost to her Aethus. As such, we see that the information is *refreshed*, ontologically speaking. Even if we conventionally suppose that Zoe carries her memories from the prior C_{pb}, we nonetheless see, Aethically speaking, that B as an Aethus is not in possession of such gathered information. It then follows that if Zoe types "ILuvDoomsday" again, there must be an equal chance of it being the correct answer as there was before she typed it in the previous try, (being a $1/4$ chance), with the information of having eliminated it as an option now being rendered entirely immaterial.

    This is a precise difference with the classical version, because we of course know that the probability would have to be zero on Zoe's second time around on account of the original elimination. Aethically speaking, however, this contradicts how centric unfolding operates, so we therefore have to conclude that all information, including information about which password was physically set in the past at A, must be reset when Zoe returns via time travel to the Aethus B.
  - Classically, she can leverage all prior attempts for future attempts, but Aethically we have that the information was, in a sense, *generated for her Aethus* upon her learning about it,

[103] Specifically, we can consider it to represent an Aethus of Zoe which predated B, then coupled with the spacetime coordinates of the computer as the password was originally set.

so should she travel back to before she gained that knowledge, she will inevitably see that the superposition will reinvigorate and the option of which potential reality of a correct password that she will land at is once again fully random.

Therefore, relative to Zoe's Aethus, the actions of even the antagonist who set the password however long ago, at A, are in superposition until she makes the discovery of a correct password, at which point only then do the actions of the past antagonist materialize to the exact state which she observes.

- Simply put, if you travel back in time to your own body before you learned something, then that something's state is refreshed to just an extent as anything else might be.
- In this particular case, every time Zoe rewinds her time, she will always have a $1/4$ chance of getting the correct password, with prior tries yielding no information on account of her having traveled back to before she gained such information through centric unfolding.

5.4.4 Zoe Example in Prose

Here is a re-write of the Zoe time travel story, which this time I wrote in prose, (in case such is more useful to the reader).

June 5, 2025

The last major result of the extrusion principle to discuss, then, are its implications for retrocausality. Perhaps the strangest development of the extrusion principle is that *one's own possession of information takes precedence over the temporal past toward indicating their block universe location.* To illustrate this, let us imagine a thought experiment in which a protagonist named Zoe is tasked with breaking into the desktop computer of the story's villainous antagonist so as to expose his evil deeds to the world. All she needs to do is sneak into his office, input the correct password into his computer, and be off with the computer's information. In fact, Zoe currently has a notebook with five possible passwords inside, so she will need to find a way to input the correct password from the list on her first try at the computer, or otherwise sound the alarms. The catch, however, is that Zoe has a magical ability: the ability to jump back in time to her own self of five minutes ago. Her plan, then, is to input a random password from the list into the computer, and then jump back in time if it is incorrect. The question then, is how many tries will Zoe expect to take? As we know, the classical metaphysical treatment of this question is that Zoe may simply use process of elimination, as after all since we're assuming the antagonist has physically set the password prior to Zoe's five-minutes-ago-jump, (say two years ago for the sake of a definite time), we therefore would infer that there ought to be a single well-defined correct password as is consistent between all of Zoe's re-tries. Altogether, then, using simple probabilistic arguments, Zoe can expect to have to make three tries before she gets into the computer, (as serves as a variant of the random selection without replacement problem).

This being said, however, with the extrusion principle we get a different metaphysics altogether. That is, the premise now becomes that each time Zoe inputs a password and learns whether it is correct or not, it is at that moment that she gains the new information about whether that password ought to be removed from the list, or otherwise be the only password to remain on the list. However there is indeed a catch: if Zoe moves back in time to her own self prior to inputting that password and getting the information change, then now she has moved back to her prior block universe as well as her prior time. This is to say that in that prior block universe, she was yet to update her list of possible passwords given that attempt. Therefore, since the knowledge of the genuinely correct password was totally erased from that block universe, and only serves to be gained by her upon inputting a password and moving to a new rendering of the block universe, *it thereby follows that Zoe will have effectively "rerolled" the correct password itself simply by virtue of traveling back in time.* Or, more specifically, if she now takes another attempt, then she may no longer use process of elimination, as that which might have been wrong on the last try may very well be correct on this try. After all, she might simply move into a new subsequent block universe this time, in which the correct password is switched up as compared with her subsequent block universe of the previous try. Metaphysically speaking, then, what the extrusion principle tells us is that if you actually could time travel to yourself prior to learning something, then the correct answer to that knowledge would itself reroll upon your proceeding to learn it again—regardless of how long ago the event in question actually took place. So, if you time traveled back to before

you yourself knew the outcome of the American revolution, for example, (and furthermore to before you had attained sufficient clues to logically deduce it), then it would be plausible that the British win when you learn of the outcome again. So, according to the extrusion principle's metaphysics, Zoe must now expect to make five tries before she gets the correct password, since after all such is the expected value of a geometric distribution rather than of a random selection without replacement alternative. Please also note that beyond even time travel itself, (which of course is already rather speculative as an ontological signifier of anything), the extrusion principle gives us a clear structural interpretation to the flow of time—to which the time travel was only an illustration—being that unlearned past events are just as metaphysically uncertain to oneself and one's block universe as unlearned future events[a].

□

[a]Another quick note on this topic of Aethic time travel are its implications for the butterfly effect. A classic thought experiment I remember engaging with philosophically when I was seventeen is the notion of how if you time traveled back prior to a recent event and changed something, then suddenly that recent event would probabilistically almost surely result differently as per the causality of the butterfly effect. For a straightforward example, if you time traveled to back before a given friend of yours was born, then somebody else would almost surely be born in their place. This is of course a fascinating thought experiment to behold, however, as you may have anticipated, the metaphysical foundation upon which it is built changes drastically once we take the Aethic extrusion principle into account. In the Aethic ontology, now we get a similar effect, but as in the applications of the Accordance Principle from Nexic reasoning, it can be considered to be much more spread out than the rather more dichotomous outcome of the classical paradigm, (that is, in which the friend either is or is not born). In particular, the Aethic supposition is that if you time traveled back to just before you learned something about your friend even yesterday, (for example, that their first favorite musician was so and so, or that they've always been a workaholic when it comes to this one niche hobby), and suddenly that feature about them would be re-rolled, as your block universe of extrusion re-randomized concerning the subject. So, in effect, you would more than likely end up in a block universe where your friend has a subtly different past or personality than what will have realized before you time traveled, such that it diverges directly after (in Aethic time) the Aethus of information you had about them at the point to which you time traveled back. The key difference from the classical paradigm, then, is that the divergences happen little by little as you time travel further back in Aethic time, rather than just all at once prior to said person's birth.

5.4.5 An Example with Colorblindness

Speaking personally here, I have deuteranomaly color blindness, which I have had since birth. This means that I cannot distinguish blue from purple, among other issues that humans normally do not undergo. Classically, the ontological explanatory background for this is simple: I was immediately in a universe where I had deuteranomaly from the moment I was born, (or perhaps when I was a fetus), regardless of whether I was aware of that or not. When my genes first aligned, it was set in place. When I was diagnosed as colorblind at age 4, I did indeed learn about this though, which, classically, means that I now became aware of the universe that I was in all along.

To make the Aethic argument now, let us consider some base informational landmarks. (It should also be noted that the following analysis may indeed turn out to be somewhat crude once our society learns more about neuroscience, so in that case merely consider it to be an illustrative example of how Aethic information manifests chronologically, rather than being an assessment of neurological structure in particular).

Age 3: I am already in possession of my qualia for what it is like to see color, however I am unaware of the descriptions of other humans for how they compare my qualia with their own.

Age 4: I am diagnosed as colorblind, hence asserting the corresponding relations between me and my fellow humans.

Age 10: I first learn about how, scientifically speaking, humans have three cone receptors, being red, green, and blue.

Let us also consider a few possible scenarios for the makeup of any Aethae in this system. Note that we might also consider scenarios beyond simply cone-based vision, as after all I only learned about such a thing at the Age 10 node, but nonetheless we can simplify the explanation by supposing we restrict it to only cone-based vision—and in any case we have that the arguments that we are about to make serve as valid child Aethae to the full spectrum of possibilities.

A: Humans typically have two cones.

B: Humans typically have three cones.

C: Humans typically have four cones.

X: I have two cones.

Y: I have three cones.

Z: I have four cones.

Now, to assemble this all. When I was three years old, (with the approximation in place that the stated-attribute of *all humans undergoing cone-based color vision* being in effect), we have that all of the above Aethae are equally possible, and as such are in superposition relative to such an Aethus of mine. Resultantly, I would have found myself in a universe where humans are in superposition[104] of usually having two, three, and four cones in their eyes at once. Also, I myself have two, three, and four cones, with whichever universe I am in out of the three meaning that such a cone configurations maps to my qualia accordingly. That is, because I know what my qualia of color vision is like, we have that if I have two cones, then that it what it feels like to have two cones. Then, even if I have three or four cones, that nonetheless resultantly becomes what it feels like to have those three or four cones, (at least relative to *that* Aethus). The qualia is fixed in the Aethus, with the cone configuration, out of being unknown, occupying a superposition[105].

The next node, then, is the Age 4 node, holding its corresponding Aethic updates. Upon my learning that I am colorblind at age 4, I have not really added definitive information about my cone-count to my Aethus, (out of still never gaining the corresponding derivational information about the cones), but rather simply how it compares to that of other humans. That is, if I had three fully functioning cones in a word where humans have four cones, then I would still be classified as colorblind in that system, even though actual humans have three cones and as such would make me *not* colorblind in their system. As such, in this case I get the following breakup.

$$(X + B)(X + C)(Y + C) \tag{32}$$

This is so, remember, where addition is an Aethic intersection, and multiplication is an Aethic union/superposition. Put in terms of words, *either I have two cones and humans have three, I have two and they have four, or I have three and they have four.* As such, my three year old Aethus must be a parent Aethus to the above Aethus.

The intriguing notion to draw from this, then, is that in our particular universe, which I arrived at in this context at my Age 10 node, we have that humans have three cones—meaning that I would be perfectly non-colorblind in the scenario $(Y + C)$ relative to us, even though I was also present in such a universe at age 3. Drawing away from only the mathematical notation here, the suggested intuition to build about this is that *if I time traveled back to the age of 3 and then centric unfolded again, I could very well end up in a universe where humans have four cones and I have three, all while maintaining my base qualia*[106] *which I hold in this universe.* As such, Aethically speaking, I[107] have the "power" to entirely rewrite the history and experiences of every human on the planet by doing something as simple as learning.

The issue with stating such a thing explicitly is that it runs the risk of being interpreted as a form of solipsism. It is crucial at this point, then, to explain why this is not so, and is a mischaracterization of the ontology. Plainly put, the act of oneself updating the entire human race's information relative to themselves is merely a notion of one's own location in the hyperblock universe, rather than being some kind of characterization of one's inherent influence over humans in general. As an analogy of another locational sort, consider a college student who lives in a dormitory where each room holds four roommates. If said student has the option of picking a room on the first floor versus the second floor, and then meets their year-long roommates accordingly, then we do not say that our student *materializes their roommates around them*, but rather that they merely moved to a location where one set of roommates are present, hence leaving the other set of roommates in the other possible room accordingly. It is just the same with the particular version of the human race that one finds themselves surrounded with, Aethically speaking. Upon undergoing centric unfolding, oneself merely sorts into one

[104] A disagreeing superposition, to be exact, as can be seen with the third postulate of the Aethus.

[105] Due to the second postulate, specifically.

[106] Note that in making this claim, we are indeed making the assumption that John Locke is correct in his interpretation of Molyneux's problem [89]. That is, if one sense is entirely insufficient information to imply another, then we have that the qualia of color vision alone is able to operate with many respective ontologies of color without contradiction. Hence we are allowed to make the particular Aethic argument that has been presented.

[107] And all of us individually by our own Aethae.

particular universe where humans hold some properties, all while leaving the other humans perfectly intact in the other universe. And, of course, before taking this Aethic distinction in the first place, oneself finds that they are in both universes at once, (speaking in terms of those human-properties themselves, at least).

5.4.6 Time Travel Action Scene Example

For one other quick example of how time travel would naturally function Aethically, let us substitute Aethic time travel for a narrative example. If you will excuse the violence of the following thought experiment, imagine we create something of an Aethic time travel instance which occurs during a bank robbery. Suppose you walk into a bank, and while you are waiting in line, a bank robbery occurs. The robbers bust into the room, call out for the bank manager, a middle aged man, and then shoot him when he doesn't cooperate fast enough.

At this point, you use your abilities to rewind time and go back in time five minutes, to before the robbery occurs, and just before you walked into the bank. Now, as before, you walk into the bank. Let us now analyze the difference between classical time travel and Aethic time travel. Firstly, the classical approach. Here, the postulate of complete reality is assumed, with the past being solidified in all attributes, be them known or not, and the future being open to change[108]. Therefore, once you land five minutes in the past, it still follows that the robbers are on their way here, and it still follows that everybody in that bank will be the same people. Of course, you would say – they all were born prior to when you landed in the past, and so here they will stay.

Now, Aethically, we have to throw this postulate out the window for a substitute – being that your experienced events only unfold relative to your Aethus, and that alternate realities branch when you learn about them and then only. With this Aethic-rewind, now, you are going to revert back to your prior Aethus with no discrimination between past or future attributes to that Aethus being maintained. All we will suppose you take with you are your memories, as otherwise it would not be much of a time travel story at all. So, when you revert back to your prior Aethus of five minutes ago, the first thing you will notice is that when you walk into the bank, every person in line is an entirely different person than previously. And, on top of this, the bank robbers never show up in the first place. It's just a calm day at the bank. You even catch a glimpse of the manager, who is a thirty year old female. Flabbergasted, you leave the bank and go along with the rest of your day as usual.

So, what happened here? Let's start with the bank manager. In the old version, he was a middle aged man who was shot during a bank robbery. So why has he now been swapped out for a thirty year old female? Simply put, the explanation is this — by performing Aethic time travel, you reverted to your old Aethus, and underwent centric unfolding anew. This means you, in effect, rerolled those last five minutes[109]. And because you only met that bank manager within those last five minutes, this time you happened to fall into a universe where he never existed in the first place. Now, when you randomly centrically unfolded the bank manager again with your prior Aethus, the new roll of the universe was a thirty year old female. I took the liberty, as the writer of this thought experiment, of picking her as a result, but generally it would be utterly random, and drawn from Bayesian statistics in the process. Furthermore, importantly, the bank robbery has not happened in the new reality. This is because bank robberies are quite uncommon, and you were not aware of any bank robberies one way or the other in your Aethus of five minutes ago, so therefore that was rerolled as well. No robbery this time.

Some of the attributes which you picked up during the original five minutes were, "*there are bank robbers here*," "*they were coming a little ways behind you when you first walked into the bank*," and

[108] Or perhaps not in a strict determinism, but with the alternate realities idea of even the many-worlds interpretation [2, 3], this is assumed to be so as a classic time travel postulate.

[109] What is most highly important to mention, though, is that you personally do not make the old block universe cease to exist altogether, as that would of course just be solipsism. Instead what happens is a dynamic I have mentioned time and time again throughout this paper: that all these block universes pre-exist in the Aethic Markov chain, it just so happens that your centric unfolding might have made you go to one subsequent block universe instead of another as operating from the same prior block universe, and hence the reroll is that rerouting to the different one when moving back to the prior block universe. The key, though, is exactly like how deciding to visit Hoboken instead of New York City on a particular Tuesday does not make the people of New York City cease to exist, the rerouting to one subsequent block universe as opposed to another does not magically make the people of the whole other block universe never exist. They simply do not exist *relative to your subsequent Aethus*, but are in disagreeing superposition of existing or not *relative to your prior Aethus* from the moment before the centric unfolding anyway. Such is the first postulate of the Aethus in action, because even though they do not exist relative to one Aethus and its block universe along the Markov chain, they still very much exist within their own block universe—just the key is that *you personally* are not over there in that block universe, so like the Hoboken versus New York City example it is simply about your position rather than any mystical or solipsistic ability to spontaneously generate a particular city around yourself at the expense of another.

"*these are the people in the bank*," etcetera. Upon the reroll, though, all of these attributes are ditched and rerolled, just as they were in the prior Aethus. Even though the "*the robbers were coming a little ways behind you when you first walked into the bank*" attribute applies to a circumstance of before the five minute window, nonetheless it was *gathered* by your Aethus during the window, and so therefore is one which must have been rerolled. The same is true of the people in the bank, such as the manager. They have full lives beforehand, but you simply travel to an alternate reality where they didn't exist in particular, and instead this new set of people did in their place. Why? Because you had no means of distinguishing between the two groups anyways just before you physically walked in the bank, and as such your Aethus gave you a randomly generated set of them once you could discriminate, (via simply looking at them).

5.4.7 The Identity of a Longtime Friend (Jenny's Japanese)

Another startling implication of the Aethic ontology of time pertains to what is really meant by the identity of even your own friends. That is, we might imagine a thought experiment where you have a childhood best friend, Jenny, who you knew since you were both two years old. You two always just clicked, and had lots of adventures outside and in school. In short, you basically know everything there is to know about Jenny, and she you. In the most classical sense, you have a complete mental image of what makes her tic. This is what makes it all the more surprising, then—fast forwarding to Jenny's 30th birthday—when she suddenly reveals that she's fluent in Japanese. You learn this with everyone else, cameras rolling and people singing, when she breaks into a full conversation with Tim, your brother-in-law from Japan, seconds before she blows out all the candles. As soon as you can afterwards, you ask her where she learned. She tells you the whole story—she secretly learned it starting at age ten, moving from library books to YouTube to online classes. It is stunning how the person you know most about in the world had this whole side plot to their life you didn't even know existed.

And nor would it, after a certain Aethic time travel hiccup.

All that happened is that two hours after the party, when you're going to sleep, you accidentally activate your time travel ability that your colleague Zoe handed over to you after deciding to quit her life of spy-work and settle down in the country with a golden retriever or something. It only sends you back a three hours—and when you wake up from it you're back at Jenny's house, exactly ten minutes before she blows out the candles. The catch is that you are now at the moment preceding the reveal that Jenny secretly learned Japanese, so by the Aethic time travel ontology that will have gotten rerolled like anything else. When the time comes to blow out the candles, Tim says something in Japanese, and she blinks. *Jenny doesn't know Japanese.* She never learned it. What's remarkable about this is that now a core feature of the Jenny you knew—that she knew Japanese from the age of 10—has now evaporated. The major existential question this raises, of course, is *is this even the same Jenny as the one from the other block universe?* For example, because even a three hour rewind can alter events in Jenny's life from twenty years ago, then we might imagine that if you were to progressively rewind farther and farther back, then the Aethic divergences in Jenny's life would begin to accumulate more rapidly, and by the indiscriminate time principle from any and all moments which you progressively predate your having learned about—no matter how scattered they themselves are in actual chronological ordering. At each of these branch points, if you kept centric unfolding forwardly again, then huge elements of Jenny's personality might start to change. For example, maybe you learned at 16 that she was a fan of a particular song since the age of 12, and you knew this about her from then on. If you Aethic time traveled to before you were 16, then, and now maybe Jenny never heard that song to begin with. The point of the matter is that by simply choosing how far back in time you go, you can systematically extract and reroll any particular property of Jenny's personality or experiences, while salvaging others depending on what you learned at still earlier ages. What this creates is almost like a mod podge of versions of Jenny which combine truly-Jenny characteristics with randomly fluctuating alternative pasts in random and dissociated places, as opposed to the classical time travel story where she either is entirely different or entirely the same depending on whether you go back far enough for her to never be born. That is, *in the Aethic time travel ontology, it is as if there is a continuous interpolation between "Jenny was never born" and "Jenny is unchanged altogether", for which this mod podge of the same characteristics and entirely divergent characteristics makes it as if large subsets of her personality were never born, with alternatives taking their place to mix with her persisting personality aspects.* Hence the Ship of Theseus [90, 91]-like question of at what point Jenny can still be called Jenny in the first place under a centric unfolding model of time.

The funniest part of this is that Tim also took Italian in college. When he says a few words, this version of Jenny perks right up. *Apparently Jenny secretly taught herself Italian*[110].

5.4.8 Aethic Mementos: What the Traveler Carries, and Why It Does Not Bind

The preface to these narratives fixes by convention that the traveler retains their memories, and that those memories are indexed to the prior block universe rather than binding the present one's internal history. This subsubsection names the class that convention creates, and states, in the framework's own vocabulary, why membership in the class is exactly what the narratives require. Call an *Aethic memento* any stated content carried by the traveler whose truth-makers are attributes of the departed block universe: veridical of that block, permanent in precisely the sense the learning-based narratives emphasize, (Section 5.4.1), and—the operative clause—inert toward the corresponding blanks of the block now indexed. Zoe's recollection that a given password failed on the previous try is the paradigm case, (Sections 5.4.3 and 5.4.4): a true record of a block universe that now stands, walled off, in her lost multiverse, and a record of nothing in the block she presently occupies.

The inertness is not an additional stipulation; it is a consequence of how records bind at all. A record fixes an attribute only through stated correlation—the wiring laid down by the record's formation within the block whose attribute it is—since it is that wiring which renders mismatched joint configurations invalid and lets the third postulate prune them; strip the wiring, and there is nothing for the pruning to act upon. The memento's formation was wired to the *departed* block's attribute-token. Relative to the block now indexed, no stated correlation links the carried entry to the local token: joint configurations pairing the memento's content with any local value are not thereby rendered invalid, nothing is pruned, and the local attribute stands blank. Call this property *blank-robustness*: the presence of a memento in the traveler's Aethus leaves the corresponding local attribute blank, because holding a memento is not a learning event about the present block, (this being the same convention the Frauchiger–Renner discussion formalizes through the Sifting Principle, Principle 26: retained content indexed to a prior stage does not perform the selection that only observation performs).

The class is not confined to neural storage, and the extension follows trivially from the memory convention itself, since nothing in the analysis distinguishes a remembered page from a written one[111]. A note, a photograph, a postcard physically transported through the jump belongs to the same class, provided its provenance is what we might call the "previous after"—its content having been fixed, in the traveler's Aethic time of inclusion, *after* the return point—so that the artifact functions as an exosomatic extension of the traveler's memory rather than as a record native to the present block. Consulting such an artifact on arrival is re-reading one's own pages, not opening a channel to the local attribute, and blank-robustness carries over wholesale. The sharp case makes the point: let Zoe photograph the correct password before jumping. The print survives the jump and is veridical—of the password of a block universe she no longer indexes—while remaining silent about the password here, which stays blank and re-rolls exactly as before. Contrast an artifact native to the present block, (the antagonist's own logbook, say), whose formation is wired to the local token: reading it is a learning event, it fixes the attribute, and it is no memento at all. The memento/native-record distinction is what keeps the device well-defined, and it is drawn entirely by provenance in Aethic time, never by the artifact's material constitution or its position in coordinate time.

[110]The other particularly Aethic insight we might draw from this is that maybe Jenny did indeed give off eccentric personality vibes to you as kids, since obviously you weren't fully oblivious to her mannerisms as her best friend. Accordingly, then, it might have been *known* to you Aethus when you were both 10 (through context clues, since these constitute deduction, and that feeds into the attribute cascade) that Jenny was working intensely on some unknown secret project. Exactly what this is will have remained in disagreeing superposition—and perhaps even a more gradually rather than suddenly collapsing one if you managed to gain clues over time which made progressively more of its mixed decomposition blank attributes stated—up until the defining moment right before she blows out the candles on her 30th birthday, when it reveals itself as either Japanese or Italian relative to whatever random Aethus you centric unfold into in the moment.

And also for the record, this is why that extrusion principle epiphany of August 2022 was so synesthetically powerful and overwhelming for me—because contained in it already was this entirely new landscape of ontology which I've been unpacking ever since. There is really no other way of describing the phenomenology of it than a trip-like sensation for its depth!

[111]A provenance note, in the record's usual dated spirit, (August 2026): the physical-artifact extension was proposed by the framework's AI collaborator, (Claude Fable 5), during the drafting of a narrative-mechanics companion to these sections; the author, conceding that the case had not been explicitly considered, observed in the same exchange that it generalizes trivially from the class the memories were already being treated as, and named that class—the *Aethic memento*—accordingly. The proposal the collaborator's; the concession, the trivial-generalization observation, and the naming the author's.

The scope of the re-roll then admits the one-line statement the narratives leave implicit: exactly those of the traveler's entries whose Aethic time of inclusion postdates the return point convert, on arrival, from knowledge into mementos, while entries whose inclusion predates the return point are part of the state returned to, and continue to bind as ordinary knowledge. Had Zoe learned the correct password a week before acquiring the device, a five-minute jump would leave it fixed; it is because each night's verdict enters her Aethus only at the moment of entry—after every return point she will ever use—that her expected count is geometric rather than eliminative, (Section 5.4.4). The return point is thus a cut through the traveler's own history of inclusion: knowledge on the far side, mementos on the near side. And by the indiscriminate time principle, (Principle 11), the cut is drawn in Aethic time alone: the dimensional location of a converted entry's referent may sit arbitrarily deep in the present block's proper-time past—the antagonist's keystrokes of years ago, two decades of Jenny's unshared study—with no bearing whatsoever on which side of the cut the entry falls.

The classification also yields the device's phenomenology, which deserves fixing with its epistemic grade attached. The grade first: what follows is *experiential* rather than empirical—its only witness is the stipulated traveler of a device the preface holds physically unrealizable—and it is, setting aside the agreeing superposition itself, (the framework's standing empirical face, which requires no device; Theorem 14), the one distinction the competing readings exhibit at the level of surface possibility at all. It is therefore a discriminator among stipulations, not a prediction. With the grade fixed, the comparison: from the inside, a traveler has exactly one instrument: comparison of mementos against what the present block supplies. Under the deterministic-loop reading, (the *Groundhog Day* convention, on which the prior configuration re-runs identically), no memento is ever contradicted—the souvenirs keep matching everything, before and after the landing alike, until the traveler's own interference intrudes. Under the interference reading, (the classical butterfly effect), mementos can be contradicted, but only by events shifting with the traveler's own moving present: the divergences propagate forward from the landing, seeded by the arrival itself, while everything in the landing point's past stays exactly as remembered. The Aethic reading is distinguished by precisely the mismatches both rivals forbid: a memento may stand contradicted by events lying arbitrarily deep in the landing point's own past light cone—the antagonist's keystrokes of two years prior, Jenny's two decades of study—with no causal path from the arrival to the contradicted event, and none needed. Forward-directed mismatches occur under the Aethic reading as well, but chance and interference can imitate those; the past-directed mismatches nothing classical can imitate, since every classical reading, deterministic or stochastic, interference or none, holds the landing's causal past fixed. A memento veridical on departure and contradicted about that past on arrival is therefore the reading's fingerprint at surface level: the indiscriminate time principle, (Principle 11), rendered as something the stipulated traveler could notice, and the narrative-scale face of the same contrast the butterfly-effect footnote of Section 5.4.4 draws in the small. One boundary completes the grade: the fingerprint is a surface signature, not the difference itself. What actually separates the Aethic reading from its classical rivals is the full Aethic structure—the indexing, the extrusion, the two composition regimes, the pruning—of which the traveler's mismatch is a single projected shadow; the device illuminates that structure without adding to it, and the framework's predictive content continues to live exactly where the preface locates it, in the fundamental theorem and the Quantum Nexus, not here.

Finally, the memento clause locates precisely where a fiction could stipulate otherwise, which deserves one sentence given that the preface already frames these conventions as fiat. A narrative might posit further machinery—the transfer of a memento's content into the present block's books, so that a chosen entry binds locally—but this would be an additional exemption layered upon the device, restoring eliminative arithmetic for exactly the transferred entries and nothing else; it is not the behavior the conventions above describe, and the narratives of this section run without it. On the native reading, the fixation of an attribute lives in the learning event and nowhere else, and the Aethic memento class is that reading's cargo manifest.

6 Constructing the Third Postulate of the Aethus

6.1 Structuring the Outcome Cases of the Double-Slit Experiment Using an Aethus

Let us begin by familiarizing ourselves with the double-slit experiment. To summarize, we are to fire electrons, one by one, toward a plate with two slits, such that each electron which makes it through the slits is allowed to fall upon a back screen behind the experiment itself, leaving a mark to signify where

it landed. We will then observe, given this setup, that the pattern of electrons will form a banded interference pattern, which is somewhat puzzling from a macroscopic perspective, where a single item is not allowed to interfere with itself in such a wavelike way. An especially unanticipated property of the experiment is that closing one of the slits while leaving the other open tends to, at least roughly, revert to a single concentrated bright spot behind the open slit, which then demonstrates that the feat of having both slits open at once implies some form of ability for the electron to pass through or at least attain information from both slits at once. This, of course, we know to be a very different outcome than anything in our macroscopic sphere of reality.

However, the most confusing aspect of the experiment is what happens if we place a detector over one of the slits, perhaps for the goal of identifying which slit the electrons went through for sure. The moment the detector is placed and the experiment commences, we see that the pattern on the back screen changes. Now it is no longer an interference pattern, but instead is a pattern of two bright spots, one behind each slit, as is more analogous to the particle manifestation of electrons. The paradox itself, then, is to ask *by what process or mechanism does this change come about?* Solving this will be a primary goal of Aethic reasoning in the coming section, as doing so in a well-defined manner will allow Aethic reasoning to have the empirical support to its claim of having solved the measurement problem.

The most important initial step toward achieving such a thing will be to explicitly depict these two experimental outcomes with the mathematical structure of the Aethus. To begin with, consider the four possible cases for what slit will be traversed by the photon, as well as their corresponding Aethae. Interestingly, we can indeed conclude that the Aethic structure is capable of handling all four cases,

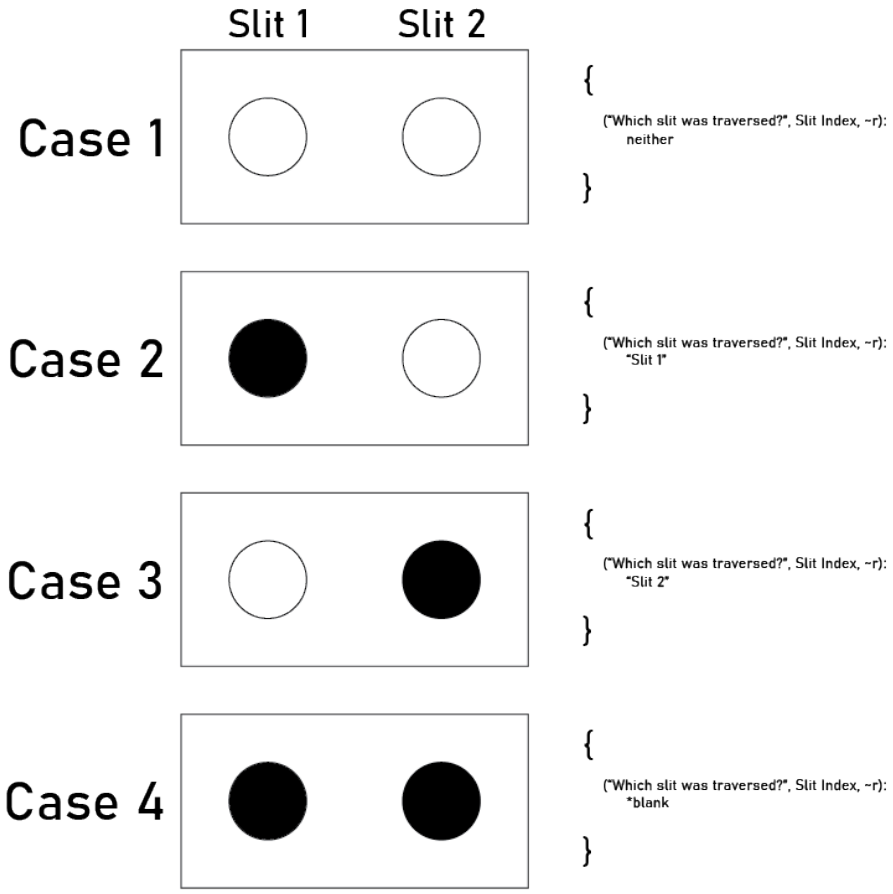


Figure 6: Here is a graphical representation of these four Aethic cases of slit traversal. Note that each case has a pictorial representation and an *equivalent 2-Aethus* representation. (Note that in *Case 4*, it would technically be more accurate for the *2-Aethus* to also include an attribute disallowing the "Which slit was traversed" attribute from holding *neither*, but this was excluded visually for the purposes of simplicity).

simply because all four cases can indeed be described with a given Aethus, as shown. Notice, crucially, that *Case 4* is to be depicted using a blank attribute, rather than physically adding both states to the Aethus, as is consistent with the superposition-contradiction contrast principle.

The key, now, is to structure both empirical outcomes, (being an interference pattern versus a two-clusters pattern), using these four Aethae which we have just devised. We might then argue that the way to do this is the following. Notice how we may take the Aethic superposition of entire Aethae,

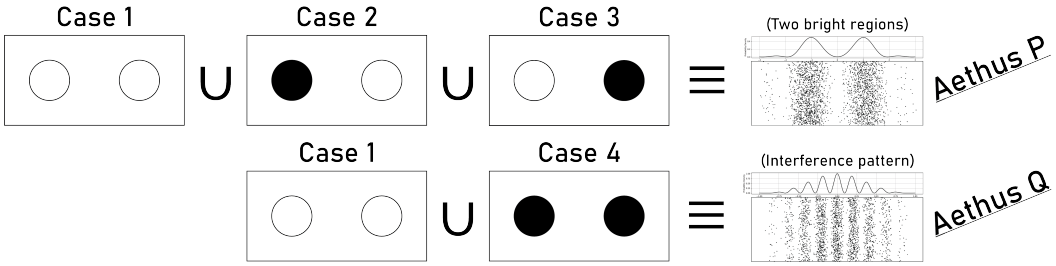


Figure 7: A representation of the mapping between the union of Aethic cases onto the corresponding realized system.

Let us refer to the top Aethus as *Aethus P*, and the bottom as *Aethus Q*. Note, crucially, that *Aethus P* is the case which empirically corresponds to the presence of detectors, whereas *Aethus Q* corresponds to the lack of detectors.

just as we may take it over Aethic attributes. By the Aethic union principle, we have than an Aethic superposition is one in the same with an Aethic union, so we denote such superpositions with unions accordingly. The procedural key to this, now, is that we may think to express new Aethae as the unions of our four fundamental cases, rather than referring to them alone.

What we have specifically done with the diagram is represent the particle-like result of the experiment using the Aethic union of the individual traversal cases, all while reserving the interference pattern for only the double-traversal case, being *Case 4*. As might hopefully be intuitive, each of *Case 2* and *Case 3* is equivalent with one slit being open, and the other closed, so for us to take their Aethic union merely overlays the corresponding intensity patterns, or rather probability density functions of the particles upon the back screen. The part that is a little more unexpected, perhaps, is the assertion that *the union of Case 2 and Case 3 is decidedly* ***not*** *validity-equivalent to Case 4*. We might intuitively grasp such a principle by referring to centric unfolding. As an agent traverses a sequence of Aethae under centric unfolding, we might consider the degree of their knowledge about which slit a particular electron went through at different Aethic times during the experiment. As is hopefully straightforward, we might suppose that upon their being in the upper case shown in the diagram, our agent will now have the ability to centric unfold into any of the three Aethic cases shown in superposition. For example, perhaps they observe that the electron went through *Slit 1*, which would accordingly sort the agent into *Case 2*, or perhaps they find that it does not reach a slit at all, which would therefore sort them into *Case 1*. The intuitive supposition, then, is that the possible cases being unioned to attain one's own Aethus must match the set of scenarios which oneself can reasonably centric unfold into. In the case of the interference pattern, however, we see that one loses the option of centric unfolding into *Case 2* or *Case 3*, because after all, such an outcome would contradict the sight of the interference pattern in the first place, because it assumes that a single-slit pattern would then be achieved.

Arguably the most intuitive explanation for why the union of *Case 2* and *Case 3* must be decidedly different than *Case 4* is the probabilistic explanation, which roots directly to the definition of probability in Aethic reasoning. We can start by quickly demonstrating how *Case 2* and *Case 3* are decidedly disjoint Aethae, because for the second slit to be disallowed traversal in *Case 2* is an Aethic contradiction with the second slit being traversed in *Case 3*, and for that matter the state of the first slit being disallowed traversal in *Case 3* directly contradicts the traversal of that first slit as seen in *Case 2*. As such, we see intuitively that the Aethic union of *Case 2* and *Case 3* is probabilistically equivalent to their being treated as disjoint events, with probability density functions being taken accordingly. Specifically, we know that for the union of two disjoint events, we add the probability density functions of a certain outcome happening in either of them, so what this tells us is that the probability density of the particle reaching a given point on the back screen should be given as the sum of the probability density functions which correspond to each slit fully by itself, with the other

being given as effectively closed. The key here, then, is that the Aethic union of *Case 2* and *Case 3* ought to yield the same empirical result as the action of merely adding their classical probability density functions, because otherwise we would conflict with the definition of probability in Aethic reasoning on account of its clear implication into the functioning of disjoint unions. As such, we know automatically that whatever this union of *Case 2* and *Case 3* is to mean ontologically, empirically it is precisely equivalent to the outcome of the double-slit experiment with the detector running, because we know of course that such an empirical outcome is already equivalent to the action of summing the two probability density functions directly. From such a probabilistic perspective, then, the mere supposition that *Case 2* and *Case 3* union to *Case 4* is a direct Aethic contradiction against the empirical facts of the situation at hand, because it would imply that the interference pattern must be equivalent to the two clusters pattern. We know, of course, that such a thing would be an absurdity, so we immediately show through proof by contradiction that *Case 2* and *Case 3* must not union to *Case 4*, and instead union to the direct broad outcome of the detector being on. This is an important result in general, because it immediately demonstrates for us that the Aethic union of *Case 2* and *Case 3* is indeed an empirical match to the outcome of the detector-on scenario.

A more technical reason for why *Case 4* is not the Aethic union of *Case 2* and *Case 3*, however, lies in how *Case 2* and *Case 3* are implying certain attributes, via their attribute cascades, which are not consistent with *Case 4*. Consider how the Aethus of *Case 2* is also in possession of the attribute that *Slit 2* was not traversed, and also notice how *Case 3* is in possession of the attribute that *Slit 1* was not traversed. So, if unioning *Case 2* and *Case 3* was to result in *Case 4*, then by that same logic we might suppose that it should also be *Case 1*, because that would be implied through the lens of which slits are not traversed rather than which ones are. This highlights the major difference, then, between each of *Case 2* and *Case 3* as opposed to *Case 4*, which is that *they tell you just as much about which slit is not traversed as they do about which one is.* In effect, we might think to refer to our union case of *Case 2* and *Case 3* as the particle *going through one slit but not the other in both ways*, which in the least hopefully highlights the strict additional conditions apart from *Case 4*.

Please also note that one might think to push back against the supposition that the *2-Aethus* which we used to define *Case 4* is unique to it in the first place, because, after all, it showed the traversal attribute as directly blank, and we hold that union of *Case 2* and *Case 3* necessarily and satisfactorily holds such an attribute as directly blank as well. This may be so, but our supposition is the following: *we may conventionally suppose that the act of leaving said additional attributes like those which distinguish Aethus P and Aethus Q out from the original static Aethus of Case 4 is sufficient to declare that they must be blank, or otherwise not present by extension in that Aethus.* This is a simple enough claim, and the consequence to it is that our notion of having defined the union of *Case 2* and *Case 3* as already acquiring any lingering degrees of freedom of theirs beyond *Case 4* is itself sufficient to demonstrate that said additional degrees of freedom will only ever be blank in *Case 4*. Whether we are to declare our static-Aethus in question to generate an Aethus more like *Aethus P* or *Aethus Q* can be left up to any supplemental contextual information that the writer provides about the Aethus which they wish to describe. Hence the designation of the terms “agreeing superposition" versus “disagreeing superposition" for important nuances like this.

It is also important at this point to gather a foundational intuition behind what we see in *Case 4*, which is that empirically speaking, once *Case 4* occurs it should be physically impossible to assess any information about the slit of traversal from then on. This is consistent with the base quantum interpretation of how the “which-path" information must now be permanently limited so as to enable the existence of *Case 4* in the first place. Such a thing holds empirically derived logical equivalence with the information of the path having not “leaked" into the environment. Such things are all well and good, but as we know they are merely qualitative assessments, and happen to lack a rigorous philosophically grounding. We will attempt to provide just such a grounding with the third postulate of the Aethus, but for now it is important to note that the information-leaking intuition can be encoded in Aethic language in the form of the following statement: *we cannot actually add the which-slit information to Case 4 in the practical sense, so what we end up seeing is that every child Aethus of it has to hold the slit of traversal attribute as blank in order to stay valid.* This is a very helpful initial intuition to take into our more complicated analyzes, and we might even think to attach a custom terminology to it accordingly. In the case of *Case 4*, at least, the slit of traversal attribute turns out to be *permanently blank*, which simply means that we cannot state it in any child Aethus of *Case 4* which we wish to remain valid. The art of identifying the third postulate, then, will be the art of encoding such a consequence into the underlying empirical phenomena to the most precisely exhaustive applicability possible. Note that it is not itself a sufficient statement for the third postulate,

however, because its implication points in the wrong direction: that is, our current empirical statement effectively says that *for Case 4 to be in effect means that the which-slit attribute is permanently blank*, but a more developed third postulate would have to instead say something of the form that *for the which-slit to be permanently blank means that Case 4 is to be in effect for some specified reason.*

The next very important thing to discuss, now, is the nature of which particular interference effects are allowed to occur given the different cases. The key to understand is that in the union of *Case 2* and *Case 3*, we have that no electrons are ever allowed to interact with themselves from the other slit, *because for them to traverse any one of the two slits already implies that they cannot traverse the other slit.* This is a tricky but fundamentally important aspect of disagreeing superpositions like this one, (where specifically the slit of traversal in disagreeing superposition in the union of *Case 2* and *Case 3*). Let us write this as a principle to further solidify its procedural importance.

Principle 25 (Principle of Disagreeing Superpositions)
For two systems to be in disagreeing superposition means that they cannot interact with one another, because for one to be "on" implies the other is "off." However, crucially, the two systems are still very much allowed to be in Aethic superposition in such a case, because we hold that Aethic superpositions present in the Aethic union direction, whereas for two systems to be Aethically disjoint is merely a supposition of the Aethic intersection direction. Due to this differing in degrees of freedom, we therefore have that superpositions are not epistemologically contingent on whether or not their constituent states are disjoint.

The same mechanism, run one level up, settles when two *agreeing* superpositions can coexist, and the premise deserves explicit statement because several applications of this framework turn on it. An agreeing superposition over a fixed alternative set is an assignment of "on" and "off" across that set; two distinct such assignments must differ at some alternative, and the one with the smaller set of on-values implies "off" precisely where the larger requires "on" — an outright contradiction, not a mere difference of perspective. By the wider observer-consistency premise, then, two observers holding distinct agreeing superpositions over the same attributes both exist in the Aethic multiverse but cannot interact: their joint indexation is contradictory. This is the engine of the framework's response to the nested-observer protocols — the Frauchiger–Renner family [92], whose two-agents-with-distinct-pure-states structure is exactly such a pair; the ψ-ontology constraint proper is a different structure, one preparation device ranging over nonorthogonal pure states with no inter-agent disagreement in it, and is met separately in the corresponding subsection below.

The mechanics beneath these principles deserve one more grain of resolution, because two *different* modes of invalidity are at work whenever a mixture leg multiplies a system leg, and the vaguer formulations — "the second postulate contradicts the disagreeing side," "agreeing contradicts subset-agreeing" — flatten a structure worth keeping distinct. Write the product schematically as $(D\,\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}} + (1-D)\,\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}})(Q_A + Q_D)$, with D here the mixture's accessible distinguishability—the tag fraction q for all-or-nothing tagging: a distinguishability-weighted mixture of the attribute's disagreeing and agreeing components against the system's agreeing and disagreeing components. One scope condition governs everything that follows, and it is the condition a cross-family referee round fixed: the product form applies where the record sector genuinely stands as a *mixture*—exclusive-regime, convex weights, as in classical randomization over orthogonal-marker tags, where the run ensemble really does split into a tagged fraction and an untagged one. It does not apply to a coherent partial tag, whose marker is a pure state of overlap c and not a mixture; there the linear split D, $1-D$ is a fact about the marker measurement's statistics and not a decomposition of the state, and treating it as one would put the unconditional visibility on the chord where it stands on the circle, (Section 14.6.4). The cross-term $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}\,Q_A$ dies as the mirror of the same engine, and the mechanism is constructive. Take the proper child Aethae of $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}$ — the states in which its promise is redeemed, the attribute stated — and multiply them by Q_A: the products are the proper child Aethae of the full $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}\,Q_A$. The third postulate, which runs only over *explicit* invalidity labeling, then marks as invalid exactly the children in which $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}$'s redeemed statement contradicts Q_A — and with those labels in place, its two-generational reading invalidates the entirety of $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}\,Q_A$ from them. The cross-term $\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}\,Q_D$ genuinely needs the *third* postulate, and in the other direction, and seeing why requires first stating what the mixture legs are: conditional binaries about findability, not decompositions. $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}$ is not itself decomposable into proper children the way Q_D is — it says "the attribute is found in some proper child Aethae," while $\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}$ says "it is found in none" — and in both, locally, the attribute is blank, which is exactly why probing it as if stated requires the third postulate's global statement. And the reason the third postulate can do this probing while nothing else can is that it is the framework's one

tree-nonlocal law — nonlocal on the Aethic tree, not in space, a different sense entirely from the Bell vocabulary: its two-generational validity check quantifies over proper children and their proper children, each at any depth since the relation is transitive, so a node's verdict is read off the structure beneath it rather than off the node's own entries, whereas the second postulate is node-local, blankness read off the entry itself. The findability conditionals are precisely the objects only a tree-reading law can adjudicate: $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}$ and $\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}$ are identical at the node, both blank, and differ only in what the descent beneath them offers — which is exactly the information the third postulate's quantifiers consume and the second postulate's cannot see. And the direction of the reasoning deserves its own sentence, because it runs from the case to the postulate rather than the reverse — this very configuration is among what *induces* the third postulate's nonlocality. Locally, $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}$ does not yet contradict Q_A: $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}$ says "I always have proper child Aethae where the attribute becomes stated," and in the moment that contradicts nothing, the promise being unredeemed at the node. What the case exhibits instead is a self-similarity condition: descend a generation and the same situation regenerates, Q_A able to contradict $\mathcal{A}_{\text{dist}}$ at whatever level the promise would be redeemed, while at no single node before redemption does a local clash exist. A conflict that lives at every horizon and at no node is exactly the shape that inductive reasoning over the tree must capture, and the two-generational, fixed-point form of the third postulate is precisely the induction that fits: the postulate is not imposed on the case — the case is among what forces the postulate's shape. Historically, it was the soccer-field thought experiment of the following subsection (subsection 6.2), in 2022, that first exposed the need for exactly this inductive step. The subscripts carry their honest gloss at the same time: they name the record sector's own character, distinguishing versus indistinguishable, and each leg is equivalently the one that does not contradict the physical element it survives beside — the record-character reading and the earlier convention-by-non-contradiction reading pick out the same pair. $\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}$'s being blank therefore does not locally contradict Q_D. What contradicts is the conditional content against the structure: $\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}$ locally asserts that the attribute cannot be stated, while $Q_D = Q_1 + Q_2$ already has it — descend into either proper child and $\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}$'s assertion is explicitly falsified. In the pure theorem's own form the invalid objects are $Q_1\,\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}$ and $Q_2\,\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}$ severally: Q_D is packaging, the compact way of writing what replaces Q_A, so that $Q_A + Q_1 + Q_2$ reads as $Q_A + Q_D$. And the full physical sum contains every powerset element besides, left unwritten only because both mixture legs invalidate the rest anyway — the other load-bearing fact, and the reason the compact form loses nothing. This is the same premise that drives the powerset invalidation theorem (Theorem 14): third-postulate invalidities carry wrong cross-specifications that let invalid states be explicitly *found*, while second-postulate invalidities over-specify on the physical side what the mixture side's conditional says cannot be so — and by that same theorem, it is technically Q_1 and Q_2 themselves that jointly prune against Q_A, the machinery beneath the other cross-term's clash. Two directions, one engine — the per-child falsifications against $\mathcal{A}_{\text{indist}}$, the jointly-pruning children against Q_A, all of it the powerset invalidation machinery pruned per element — and their joint effect is the point: the surviving diagonal is exactly the regime split, agreeing with agreeing and disagreeing with disagreeing — the mixture legs' entire office being to deliver the weights onto the physical elements, where the paths and the kernel actually live, each coefficient routed to its Q by the pruning alone — its weights emergent from the pruning rather than matched to a parameter, so that nothing is ever switched between regimes by hand — the multiplied superposition sorts itself, and both the linear and the quadratic complementarity identities downstream inherit their case structure from these two invalidity modes rather than from any stipulated partition.

The principle has a corollary worth stating in the same breath, because it is the engine of several resolutions later in this paper, the Pusey–Barrett–Rudolph analysis among them: *two agreeing superpositions over the same attributes with distinct on-sets contradict outright.* An agreeing superposition is a set of on-valued alternatives held jointly, and distinctness in this premise is distinctness of that set, not of any amplitude or phase carried over it, two assignments with the same on-set differing only in phase being one agreeing superposition and not two; comparing two such sets, the one with the smaller set of on-values states "off" exactly where the larger requires "on," so the two assignments cannot be jointly indexed. By the wider observer-consistency premise, two agents holding distinct agreeing superpositions of one system therefore cannot interact: both exist in the Aethic multiverse, and each is fully real on its own index, but the configuration in which they meet and compare is not a valid state at all.

Such a principle demonstrates that disagreeing superpositions are very much allowed within the Aethic framework, so let us consider an important additional insight to such a thing, which regards the process of how an agent's Aethus picks up attributes in relation to the superposition. Specifically, notice how in the union of *Case 2* and *Case 3*, being the disagreeing superposition of the slit of

traversal attribute, we have that such an attribute has to be directly blank, because such an Aethus truly has no mechanism of determining if one slit was traversed versus the other. As such, we still see something of a parallel between attribute blankness and Aethic superposition, because the stance of the attribute being directly blank is what disallows the reconciliation of which slit was traversed of the two states in disagreeing superposition. Upon our agent in question later learning of this, though, we might simply think to add the state of which slit was traversed to their Aethus, and in doing so will finally choose a single option out of either *Case 2* versus *Case 3*. The key to such a circumstance, then, is that *it would be inaccurate to truly say that the superposition collapsed upon measurement, being the state which empirically transferred the system from Case 4 to the union of Case 2 and Case 3. Rather than this, it only truly collapses when the agent physically attains the state to the attribute, thereby making the slit of traversal attribute state-decomposable. We see from this an important principle of Aethic reasoning, being where we can localize measurement versus collapse.*

Principle 26 (Aethic Sifting Principle)
We might suppose that quantum decoherence, in the absence of a direct state having yet been added to an agent's Aethic attribute in question, is still as genuine a form of Aethic superposition as agreeing superpositions, just we have that the interference effects have been limited due to the disjoint nature of states in disagreeing superposition.

In more quantum-oriented terms, we might argue that for two eigenstates to be in agreeing superposition with respect to one another implies that they are in quantum superposition within the same wavefunction, however when decoherence occurs, it is not that they are falling out of superposition at all, but are merely transitioning into a disagreeing superposition, which implies that the Born rule is called prior to the assembly of the superposition rather than after it. It is the act of measurement, then, which triggers the disagreeing superposition, and only ever the direct act of observation which gathers a single state out of this disagreeing superposition. Notice that agreeing superpositions cannot be reduced to child Aethae of single states, so therefore are distinct in at least this way.

In effect, this sifts all of the properties which the Copenhagen interpretation attributes to measurement to their correct positions in the measurement process versus the observation process. We argue that measurement is not sufficient to actually collapse a superposition, as that would violate the second postulate of the Aethus, so instead the supposition is that measurement merely transfers the states from what would otherwise be an agreeing superposition, (i.e. like quantum wavefunction), to a state of disagreeing superposition, (i.e. several wavefunctions are applied with the Born rule and then additively combined as probabilities into the Aethic superposition). Observation, then, is what physically collapses the superposition and draws a single eigenstate from the measurement basis of whatever weighted random wavefunction is selected from the disagreeing superposition. Ontologically, however, the supposition of the Copenhagen interpretation that the eigenstates had already fallen out of superposition prior to physical observation is effectively an objectivist fallacy.

The two operations, stated exactly. The box separates what the Copenhagen vocabulary fused, and the separation is sharp enough to state as two operations with their triggers and their outputs.

1. *Measurement* is the transition of an attribute from agreeing to disagreeing superposition. Its trigger is the third postulate: a record separating the alternatives exists somewhere in the block, obtainable in every refinement, so the coherence claim across them is checkmated, (Theorem 14, third bin). Its output is a set of pockets—the classes of the signature partition—each carrying a weight. Nothing is selected; the alternatives are *enumerated*, walls written into their interiors, and the "Born rule called prior to the assembly" of the box is exactly clause (iv) of the recovery theorem, (Theorem 15): the weight of each pocket, $W(T \cap E_j)/W(T)$, is formed on the agreeing cluster and then attached to the pocket, so that the disagreeing superposition is assembled *from* weighted pockets rather than weighted after the fact. Measurement is therefore governed by the block's record configuration, not by any apparatus's intent, and it is indexed to every Aethus that can read the records at once.

2. *Observation* is the selection of a pocket. Its trigger is the arrival of the record in the observer's own Aethus; its output is the transit to the Aethus in which that pocket was always the case, (Section 10.2.4). Nothing collapses: the prior Aethus keeps its disagreeing superposition forever at its index, and the posterior never held one. Observation is the only place randomness enters—randomness over Aethae—and it is the extrusion principle's transit, not a process in any block.

The "objectivist fallacy" the box names is the assumption that measurement already did observation's work: that the alternatives were selected among at the moment they were enumerated. That assumption is the deflationary reading of the disagreeing residue—each pocket a determinate-but-unknown fact—and the Deflation Reductio, (Theorem 4), is what refutes it where the residue's statistics exceed the classical bounds and grants it where they do not.

The principle's second sense, and why it is the same principle. The paper consumes the Sifting Principle in a second role, and the two roles should be seen to coincide. The Record-Individuation Lemma, (Lemma 7), consumes it as the *record discipline*: an Aethus of the physical instance comes to state an attribute only through a record that fixes it. That is not a different principle. What sifts measurement from observation is the record—its existence in the block makes the enumeration, its arrival in an Aethus makes the selection—and a principle that says records are what enumerate and records are what select has already said that nothing but a record ever fixes an attribute. The record discipline is the Sifting Principle read as a constraint on statement; the measurement/observation split is the same principle read as a constraint on transition. The nested-observer cases, (Section 10.2.2), run on both readings at once, which is why they are resolved by naming the Sifting Principle rather than by adding anything to it.

A worked inventory. The cat of Section 10.2 is the principle's cleanest instance: the counter, the vial, the animal's chemistry, and the box's heat are the records that *measure*—they enumerate alive and dead as pockets with weights, relative to every Aethus in the block, whether or not anyone opens the box—and the experimenter's look is the *observation* that selects. The standard vocabulary calls the first "decoherence" and the second "collapse" and cannot say why the first should have happened before anyone looked; the Sifting Principle says the first happened because the records exist, and the second is not a happening in the block at all.

The principle, read against the demotion architecture developed later (subsubsection 11.4.1), is the same scope split met one level down, and saying so ties the section's threads together. The agreeing layer is the predetermined-per-state layer: complete paths, block-decided, with nothing indeterminate inside them. Measurement's transfer is what assembles the over-arching disagreeing superposition of complete alternatives — and the prince's clause that the Born rule is called *prior* to the assembly rather than after it is exactly the demotion's mechanism, the weights riding the alternatives into the superposition rather than being conjured at its resolution. Observation's selection is then the sole locus of genuine quantum randomness: a re-indexation among complete realities, not a dynamical event within any of them. Copenhagen's single word "measurement," covering both processes, commits at the vocabulary level the very scope conflation diagnosed in the demotion section — which is why the sift is not a terminological nicety but the section's load-bearing repair.

Given these suppositions, then, we see that *for Case 4, where the slit of traversal is in agreeing superposition rather than disagreeing superposition, it follows that the electrons are allowed to interfere with themselves from the other slit, thus forming the interference pattern accordingly.* This is an important notion, which is that in the face of an agreeing superposition, we are to feed said allowed states into a quantum superposition, such that they interfere together as according to the mathematical rules of quantum mechanics such as the Schrödinger equation and the Born rule. As such, let us take a moment to partition the epistemological process between the base Aethus math and the empirical effects as follows.

- *Step Z*
  - This is the step by which the Aethus in question reads blank for the slit of traversal, and thus generates a corresponding Aethic superposition for it upon retrieval.

    This is merely an instance of the second postulate of the Aethus, such that it is tailored to this particular experimental circumstance. Note that we ought not to undersell the importance of this *Step Z* in establishing the full trio of the steps here listed, because, after all, *the originality and importance of the second postulate of the Aethus might be expressed through its supposition that any Aethic object will be in superposition upon being blank, thus taking the eigenstate-specific intuition of quantum superpositions, and generalizing it to an entire well-defined system of reasoning. That is, instead of only allowing physical observables to be placed in Aethic superposition upon their being blank, we can now place entire Aethae in superposition by the same fundamental rule. This allows us to explore all kinds of abstract iterative processes in this regard without ever implying more than one axiom.*
- *Step Y*

- This is the step which allows the needed specification to imply that the resultant Aethic superposition is an agreeing superposition.
- In the case of the double-slit experiment, for example, this step encodes which Aethic cases are to manifest as a function of the context, (i.e. detector running versus not).

  More generally, we might think this step to answer the question of why and how quantum decoherence occurs, given that we have already established Aethic reasoning to the current point via *Step X*.
- Whichever axiom needs to be added to Aethic reasoning so as to accurately depict the phenomenon of *Step Y* will be, by definition, the statement of the third postulate of the Aethus itself.

- *Step X*
  - This is the step which implies the corresponding quantum quantitative mathematics, for instance regarding the wavefunction, Born rule, and Schrödinger equation given the state of the agreeing superposition from *Step Y*.

    We might phrase this step simply as *that which implies a quantum superposition given an agreeing Aethic superposition of the relevant quantities*. Once a quantum superposition is attained in its full mathematical breadth, then of course the standard quantum mathematics can take it from there.

Notice that we have already derivationally formulated *Step Z* at this point, through our analysis of the second postulate of the Aethus. However, we still need to ontologically derive *Step Y* and *Step X* as well, as right now they are still merely empirical-epistemic statements. We are to suppose that the completed third postulate of the Aethus will be aimed at explaining *Step Y*, but note that *Step X* is not to be directly addressed in this paper, as instead we are reserving its solution for our followup paper on Active reasoning. In the meantime, then, it becomes our priority to derive *Step Y*, which remember is what tells us whether our particular setup of the double-slit experiment is to follow what we called *Aethus P*, (being the particle-like pattern), or instead *Aethus Q*, (being the interference pattern).

A note on the present status of *Step X* is warranted, because the listing above predates the Quantum Nexus of Section 14, and the two should be read in sequence. The Nexus does not complete *Step X*, but it changes its status from unaddressed to axiomatized: the postulates' pruning now operates directly inside a quantitative path-integral object, with the Born rule's squared-modulus structure absorbed into that operation rather than postulated independently, while the Feynman weighting itself remains axiomatic input. What *active reasoning* inherits is therefore not the construction of a bridge between the postulates and quantitative mechanics—that bridge now exists—but the derivation of the bridge's kernel, the construction of the measure μ, and the extension of $A(T)$ beyond binary validity.

It is also important to note that in the event of our arriving at a successful rendition of the third postulate of the Aethus later in this paper, *it should follow that the state of an Aethic superposition as being agreeing or disagreeing should be entirely dependent upon the intrinsic structure of the Aethus in question given the third postulate.* That is, even though one can choose to epistemically declare an Aethus through attributes encoding the superposition type, a successful third postulate will be signified by its ability to accurately derive whether any given valid Aethic superposition is agreeing or disagreeing given only its Aethic context of attributes, and thus all without having to physically state which one it is. The dangerous flip-side to this, however, is that the act of arbitrarily declaring an Aethic superposition as agreeing versus disagreeing runs the risk of directly violating the third postulate of the Aethus, because after all it is to draw a connection between any Aethic setup and its corresponding output of superpositions. In general, as is a foundational approach all throughout mathematics, we may couple the third postulate of the Aethus with the superposition type of a system, and through that directly derive much about its context, and likewise we may couple the third postulate of the Aethus with the context, and through that achieve a decided result about the types of superpositions at play. The third postulate, in effect, then, is merely a glorified shortening mechanism of our possible degrees of freedom regarding which Aethae are or are not allowed to be valid.

To begin this ontological analysis, we need one more epistemic principle: when considering whether our Aethus is to map to *Aethus P* or *Aethus Q* as depending on the presence of detectors versus not, respectively, we might consider depicting the distinguishment using invalid Aethae rather than any other means. That is, consider the following statement.

"When the detector is running, *Aethus P* will occur." (33)

This is an empirically true statement, of course, but we might consider phrasing it in a more advantageous form.

"It is an invalid Aethus for *Aethus Q* to occur when the detector is running." (34)

What we have done here is simply rewrite the original statement in disjunctive normal form, so as to isolate where the invalid Aethus is given to occur, at least to the degree of logical equivalence with the empiricism. This takes advantage of the following logical identity.

$$a \to b \Leftrightarrow \neg\left(a \wedge \neg b\right) \tag{35}$$

In this case, a would be the state of the detector running, b would be the case of *Aethus P* occurring, and $\neg b$ would be the case of *Aethus Q* occurring instead.

This statement, then, is an empirical postulate, so our goal will be to translate it into a generally applicable postulate within the mathematical structure of the Aethus. Such will be our third postulate, and such will be our proposed solution to *Step Y*.

6.2 The Aethic Soccer Field Thought Experiment

Let us analyze what we may call the *Aethic soccer field thought experiment*. I originally thought of such a thing in late August of 2022 during a very transformative week for Aethic reasoning, (as only a few days earlier, I had the epiphany which gave me the extrusion principle, being perhaps the greatest single flash of insight in my life so far), so I will describe it here for the same reason why I gathered it for myself: it brings a certain level of personal relevance to the quantum phenomenon, which is a core value behind Aethic reasoning. To contrast this, consider the supposition of first-order epistemic antirealism, where quantum effects operate only in fundamentally impersonal respects, with any tangible linkage being irrelevant. *As part of our counterargument to such a stance, what we need is a theory of quantum decoherence which is in direct compatibility with the space of tangible effects, such that any step of the process which is expressible without tangibility is taken as a violation of Occam's razor.* Such an insight as this is directly what led me to fall upon the thought experiment in the form in which it is presented. As such, let us proceed with said thought experiment now.

Consider the prospect of attempting to apply the double-slit experiment to the macroscopic world, so as to highlight any resulting properties of interest from a purely tangible perspective. That is, whatever phenomenon brings about decoherence on the quantum level should, by the same underlying principles, bring it about on the macroscopic scale if Occam's razor is to hold[112]. So, instead of

[112]There is a highly meaningful rebuttal that one might make in the face of this prospect of arbitrarily generalizing the quantum double-slit experiment to a soccer field, and then to top that off assuming consistency between the underlying logical principle which disallows interference on the two scales. After all, quantum mechanics is notoriously "fuzzy" in the sense of where its logical boundaries lie, (most especially considering whether iterative effects with increasing scale remove similarity with the standard which-path-detected double-slit experiment), so under one framing this move might seem like recklessness.

Luckily, Aethic reasoning has an intrinsic rebuttal to just this point: the existence of the extrusion principle. Indeed, directly, that which subconsciously steered me to the Aethic soccer field thought experiment in the first place, (when I thought of it in August 2022), was the fact that it really serves as an "expression of maximum context-building" about Aethic superpositions given the knowledge of the extrusion principle—hence why it was effectively my first destination following the extrusion principle. So, formally speaking, yes quantum mechanics is notoriously fuzzy, *however* the reason the soccer field thought experiment is acceptable anyway is specifically because of the insight which the extrusion principle provides about *what a quantum superposition ontologically is*: that is, just a structural element of an Aethic block universe as designated by Aethic ignorance. In this respect, the extrusion principle really has the exact same respective use to what Einstein's equivalence principle has toward establishing general relativity: it procedurally allows for the passage of deductions which will have been unmotivated at best in the Newtonian framing, but more realistically closer to dubious outright. By stating the equivalence principle, however, we attain an essential narrowing down of our theoretical options, and this narrowing happens to occur at just such a critical point that it effectively builds up the entirety of the "theoretic voltage" which general relativity then sailed off of. Just the same is true with the extrusion principle for Aethic reasoning, because it effectively clears the "quantum theoretic fuzziness" obscuring the Aethic soccer field thought experiment: after all, once we know what a superposition *is* as an ontological primitive, the process which decoheres it should be universal. So, *if perhaps the primary rebuttal to the Aethic soccer field thought experiment supposing a single logical law at the onset of decoherence is that macroscale decoherence is the iteration of quantum-scale decoherence rather than merely another instance of a single species of decoherence*, then what the extrusion principle tells us is that macroscale decoherence actually is just equivalent to any form of quantum decoherence, because the ontological primitive underlying superposition is universal.

While that is the explicit response to the "problem of fuzziness", it is entirely understandable that you might not be quite convinced from that alone due to the radical nature of the extrusion principle. For this crowd, then, let me provide you with a reason for why the Aethic soccer field thought experiment is at least noteworthy, even without having to be strictly fundamental. Simply put, we may indeed entertain that the soccer field thought experiment might contain further nuances than the standard which-path-detected double-slit experiment, so even without having to establish our

performing the double-slit experiment with electrons and two slits, let us perform the experiment with humans and two doors. If we can isolate exactly where the decoherence Aethically occurs, especially within the context of applicability to just such a thought experiment as this, and we will have found the root of the third postulate.

As such, let us imagine a soccer field which has been set up with a two-doored walled across its midline, and then a numbered wall on the far side of the field, as corresponds to the slits and back screen, respectively. Naturally, we know ahead of time what is to result from this experiment—most assuredly not an interference pattern, as that would violate the macroscopic axiom of the Heisenberg cut [1]—but this serves as only more reason to attempt to isolate the root of such a phenomenon. As such, we commence the experiment. For some quick context, we might suppose that the organizer of the experiment is a college freshman who wants to see the outcome, (as I myself was a college freshman in my first week when this thought experiment originally crossed my mind), and the involved participants are their friends from around campus. Suppose we refer to the organizing freshman in question as *Oliver*.

Given this, then, Oliver is to be sitting, blindfolded, on the bleachers, so that he is guaranteed to not be aware of the outcome of the experiment as it unfolds. At the end he will remove his blindfold, but for now he can only wait in his excitement to see the results. As for the friends themselves, they are to each be texted two numbers, the first being either *Door 1* or *Door 2* to traverse, and the second being a random angle to leave that door at, so as to walk to the back wall accordingly, (however we might think to do some backend trigonometry, and simply supply them with a numbered position along the back wall to stand at instead of an angle). With this setup being complete, Oliver gives the signal, and the experiment commences.

As each participant walks through a door, Oliver, of course, has no awareness of which one they will have picked. His Aethus will therefore register the door of traversal attribute for each participant as *blank*, however we know from the empiricism that this is to project to a disagreeing type superposition instead of an agreeing one, specifically due to the added influence of the third postulate, wherever it might say in particular. As discussed earlier, our goal at present can be isolated to the following: *we ought to find a theoretical derivation for the empirical axiom of that for Oliver to see an interference pattern of his friends amounts to an invalid Aethus.* To put it another way, the major benefit of using this thought experiment as our source for such a task is that we have one less degree of freedom to juggle, because the macroscopic axiom of being above the Heisenberg cut stands in for the detector-based dichotomy of decoherence versus coherence. Now all we have to do is explicitly derive the invalidity of Oliver's Aethus using the tools intuitively expressible to his setting, and that should be sufficient to gather the entire postulate due to generality. To be clear on these matters, we are imagining the Aethus in which Oliver removes the blindfold and sees the interference pattern of his friends, and will suppose that this is called an *Oliver's Aethus* by convention. The procedure, then, is to gather a well-defined mechanism within the Aethus structure which will best produce such a property of invalidity to Oliver's Aethus.

Our first attempt at the underlying mechanism might be a basic proof by contradiction of why such an initial scenario should be impossible. This is quite simple actually—all he needs to do is walk over to one of his friends, and ask five simple words.

$$\text{“Which door did you get?"} \tag{36}$$

The friend, naturally, will reply with one of the two doors, being either *Door 1* or *Door 2*, and in that simple sentiment, Oliver will have added to his Aethus that said friend must have gone through a single door, and accordingly must be of the single-slit or particle manifestation, not the wavelike manifestation as the interference pattern demonstrates. As such, because the interference pattern implies that both doors were traversed in superposition, and because the friend's response[113] implies

proposed logical-deductive rule (ie the third postulate) as the universal cause of all decoherence, we may still reason that the rule triggering decoherence in the double-slit experiment *should remain present* in the Aethic soccer field thought experiment, even if it is no longer directly relevant as the source of the decoherence. After all, it is far harder to justify why it would disappear in full with growing scale than it is to justify why it could exist, but simply be overshadowed by some other phenomenon. So, the key is, even upon entertaining this restriction-loosening, *we still agree that the Aethic soccer field is informative concerning this fundamental law, because it is a criterion of the thought experiment that the law must remain present within it.* Hence, no matter how we cut the scale-iterative fuzziness of quantum mechanics, the Aethic soccer field thought experiment is at least relevant to clarifying the third postulate—and, if we assume the extrusion principle, then the fuzziness disappears altogether.

[113]That is, assuming they are truthful, and even if they are not, there are millions of other decisive clues, for example a camera or two, an onlooker, basic entropic considerations in the air molecules, etcetera.

that they went through only one door, an Aethic contradiction is clearly reached, and the corresponding Aethus must be invalid[114].

The more nuanced element to this, however, is that truly the contradiction only directly occurs in the later Aethus. *This is perhaps the single central constraint that makes solving this question absolutely mandatory for Aethic reasoning to remain well-defined*: that is, we have that since the extrusion principle and first postulate now severs the structural capacity of the objective reality in which all events lie, in the sense of two Aethae of the same person across time being no more privileged than are Aethae which are arbitrarily deviated. In other words, the central paradox becomes simply that a contradiction in one arbitrary Aethus ought not to itself imply a contradiction in another without outwardly violating the first postulate of the Aethus, so perhaps the "art" of devising the third postulate, distilled to its mathematical core, becomes explaining why the particular demonstrated empirical privilege between parent child Aethus[115] exists while still allowing it to operate in full compliance with the new ontology outlined by the extrusion principle and first postulate of the Aethus. In this case, while a contradiction in the future Aethus has clearly been demonstrated, it at this point becomes clear that naïvely backtracking it as a proof by contradiction to nonexistence at the start of the experiment is not an option due to the severing of this connectivity by the first postulate, (because if we were allowed to pass contradictions arbitrarily here we could do it between any Aethae no matter how unrelated, which would in the emergent case effectively force an objective reality anyway, hence violating the first postulate of the Aethus completely and totally). In the face of what we have just shown with Oliver's soccer field, this may seem almost paradoxical.

Concept 3 (Inheritance Paradox of Oliver's Soccer Field)
If we naïvely allow a contradiction in Oliver's future Aethus to arbitrarily pass to his present Aethus to form a proof by contradiction—that is merely by means of a contradiction in one Aethus counting for a contradiction in another—then for the laws of Aethic reasoning to remain generally consistent we must allow for contradictions or logical implications in any Aethus to pass to any other Aethus, regardless of their relative placement in a parent-child graph of any sort[116]*. In effect, this would not only locally violate the first postulate of the Aethus by allowing logical implication to flow between distinct Aethae automatically with distinct Aethus self-identity, but in doing so it would by emergence force an objective reality, because any Aethus would imply any other Aethus. This itself would then violate the Aethic reversal principle, and so on, so the total conclusion is that such a naïve step ought to be absolutely forbidden so as not to destroy Aethic reasoning entirety.*

Note that this paradox is solved directly with the third postulate, (and doing so is indeed the central aim of the third postulate in the first place), by means of establishing just one more axiom in Aethic reasoning to handle specialized inheritance across the Aethic lattice of parent–child inheritance, but all while preserving the non-arbitrariness of how implication flows between Aethae generally.

However, establishing the solution to this paradox anyway with the single most parsimonious and general possible further constraint ought to be directly that which directly provides Aethic reasoning

[114]Rather importantly, we might also note that since the third postulate of the Aethus, through dependency on this point, implies the ability for contradictions to be postponed until they reach a particular Aethus in question, is both a direct contradiction with the principle of objective reality, (for which contradictions are decided immediately due to all properties being pre-established upon instantiation via timeline split or whatever else), and at once strictly implies none other than the first postulate of the Aethus itself as a consequence. This is not particularly to say that the third postulate of the Aethus implies the first postulate of the Aethus, (as therefore the first postulate of the Aethus would be a redundant axiom in the first place), but rather the contextual ontology by which the third postulate of the Aethus is allowed to exist at all, by virtue of such, itself then implies the first postulate of the Aethus as well. Explicitly speaking, this is because the sheer foundational necessity of the third postulate of the Aethus for which contradiction is conveyed in channels, so as to directly "spark" a contradiction to a future Oliver upon his meeting it in person—and no sooner—is itself a plain validation of the proposal for how reality is arranged and defined via the first postulate of the Aethus, (for which such a channel is implied not only to be relevant, but to be the raw representation of reality itself in this unveiled underlying domain, so as to allow the triggering of contradictions by this mechanism). What is perhaps most interesting about this, meta-theoretically speaking, is that the existence of the third postulate itself immediately validates the fundamental axiom of all relational interpretations of quantum mechanics, being that the reality of truth is arranged in channels between systems, (in this case being Aethae), as opposed to reality being an underlying backdrop as in classical metaphysics. That is to say that it is in the least rather intriguing that the compatibility with the third postulate of the Aethus with the relational first postulate of the Aethus is as fittingly tight as it is, which in almost any context is a sweeping indicator of theoretic parsimony, and perhaps even a subtle form of aesthetic appeal.

[115]In the form of the Oliver's soccer field thought experiment, that is.

[116]Hence the note about, in terms of general information passage, parent-child Aethae not being any more privileged than any two arbitrarily selected Aethae outright. Naturally, then, this naïve move creates a central cascading problem beyond merely leaning back on classical metaphysics abruptly in one area.

with its deductive powers[117]. In a very real sense, it is the act of "completion" for Aethic reasoning concerning internal consistency and especially deductive equivalence to the Aethic behavior of the real world. What we need, altogether, is an expression for why the past Aethus somehow "knows" what will happen in the future Aethus, all while staying true to the well-defined principles we have accumulated thus far in Aethic reasoning. This means that any kind of timelike expression for the cause of this should be out of the question, because that would combat the extrusion principle. Somehow we need to manifest this odd occurrence using only the Aethic structure as our tool.

So far we have gathered a very important insight from the future Aethus in which Oliver speaks to the friend: it only takes one question to trigger a direct Aethic contradiction. We know, then, that Oliver decidedly has the ability to generate an Aethic contradiction given the scenario where the interference pattern has occurred with his friends, but this leaves for us a pressing question. Does it make a difference that only some possible futures involve an Aethic contradiction in this scenario, or is that already enough to imply that the whole scenario is an invalid Aethus? To answer this, let us begin our formal derivation.

6.3 Derivation of the Third Postulate of the Aethus

6.3.1 Statement of Notation

[118] Consider some definitions of terms.

- $\mathbf{V}[A]$ is the validity operation, which returns true if and only if an Aethus A is a valid Aethus.
- $\mathbf{C}[A]$ is an operation which assesses an immediate Aethic contradiction in an Aethus A. We will suppose that if a physical Aethic contradiction is present in an Aethus, (specifically in the system of Aethic reasoning where we do not yet assume the third postulate of the Aethus), then we will regard $\mathbf{C}[A]$ as triggering in the state of true accordingly. Crucially, note that $\mathbf{C}[A] \Rightarrow \neg\mathbf{V}[A]$.
- $\mathbf{O}[A]$ can be an operation which specifically designates the invalidity of Oliver's Aethus. As we have touched on already, we are declaring that Oliver's Aethus is deemed invalid through empiricism, so we will hold that $\mathbf{O}[A]$ triggers as true if we can in any way imply the particular empirical state of invalidity with associates with Oliver's Aethus from a particular Aethus A. Like the general Aethic contradiction, $\mathbf{C}[A]$, we hold with this that $\mathbf{O}[A] \Rightarrow \neg\mathbf{V}[A]$.
- Also note that the symbol $\sqsubseteq$ is to denote a "child Aethus," refinement by Aethic intersection, whereas $\leq$ is to denote a "proper child Aethus," the relation of Definition 36. These terms borrow from their inspirations in set theory.

6.3.2 The Derivation

The shape of the derivation. It proceeds by three candidate statements that fail in instructive ways—a *there-exists* form refuted by inheritance, a *for-all* form that cannot be applied to the very Aethus it

[117] That is, fascinatingly this is another central example of the recurring phenomenon in Aethic reasoning where one ontology rapidly injects flexibility into the framework, before a needed second ontology rapidly reinstates a constraint from an entirely different direction—a methodology which I would argue is the signifier of good inductive reasoning, as evidenced by Einstein's work [27]. The net effect of this central inductive methodology is that it is how you can be left with a new ontology which exactly replicates the central empiricism of the old theory, while on the boundaries also being "perpetuated" to match the newer empiricism. In the Aethic case the old empiricism is observer consistency—which we classically take to represent an objective reality—while the new ontological interpretation instead being the far more exotic notion of information channels signifying Aethic block universes for which all possible observers exist, but those with contradictory accounts are simply disallowed to interact within the ladder ontology. So, like Einstein leaving Newtonian mechanics intact as a special case of special relativity, while utterly upending the very "ground beneath our feet" in the ontic sense by introducing the full spacetime continuum, in the Aethic case the analogy is that all observers are still consistent with one another empirically, but also objective reality is replaced with an abstract web of informational accessibility in which all possible observers already exist but are merely often denied interaction with one another. Another classic Aethic example of carrying out this form of inductive methodology comes from ow the empirical nature fo quantum energy density is left invariant, even after increasing the flexibility of the past by means of the extrusion principle, strictly because energy density is controlled by agreeing superpositions, and those cannot be collapsed at all without violating the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning. In other words, the art of good inductive reasoning is carrying out these sorts of commitments, which are perhaps notorious because the first move almost always looks like a catastrophe by itself. This methodological pattern is what I generally refer to as a "dual-edged constraint", for reference.

[118] The notation stated here is a static in the sense of Section 3.1.1; it denotes a representation of the hierarchy of Section 3.1.

was built for, and a contradictions-only form that leaves a remainder—and then by one resolution, found in the chess vocabulary of check and checkmate and executed as a single algebraic substitution: the self-similarity of an Oliver's Aethus with its non-contradictory proper children. The result is generalized from contradictions back to all invalidity, and stated positively by contraposition.

We ought to start the procedure of derivation with an important corollary of the definition of invalid Aethus. Let us phrase this as follows.

Corollary (Corollary of Aethic Invalid Inheritance)
Every child of an invalid Aethus must also be invalid.

The derivation of this is somewhat straightforward in both the structural and centric unfolding respects. Structurally speaking, whatever Aethus of stated-attributes are present in the parent invalid Aethus must also be passed to the child invalid Aethus, so for said stated-attributes to trigger an invalid Aethus in one case should also apply to any other case. Also, regarding centric unfolding, we have that valid Aethae have to be reachable from their parent Aethae, but invalid Aethae must not. So in the case of three generations of Aethae, for the second generational Aethus to be invalid now "blocks" off the ability of reaching the third generation, and thereby implies that it must be invalid as well. Given this corollary, then, we can immediately identify a conflict with the principle of "*there exists*" invalid child Aethae.

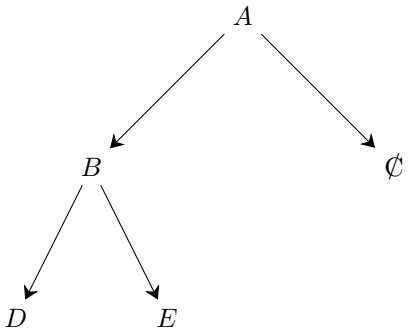
Attempt 1: the there-exists form, and why inheritance refutes it. Consider a proposed statement of the third postulate which regards a *there exists* representation.

Third Postulate Attempt 1
"An Aethus will be invalid if it has any invalid proper child Aethae."

$$\exists B \leq A, \neg \mathbf{V}[B] \Rightarrow \neg \mathbf{V}[A] \tag{37}$$

Notice that we used the term "proper child Aethae" here, because trivially speaking, any Aethus will have an invalid child Aethus, if only we generate one by intersecting it with a disjoint Aethus. As such, this statement is only compelling at all if we consider proper child Aethae, which are now compatible with a more centric unfolding style of Aethic inheritance. Even so, however, we may still write up a proof by contradiction of a different sense for why this fails as a possible third postulate statement.

Example Aethic Inheritance Diagram



Consider the above diagram, where the arrows represent proper child Aethae, and C is taken as an invalid Aethus. Referring to the attempted statement of the third postulate, we take A as invalid because C is a proper child to it, but we take B as valid because both of its proper child Aethae are valid. This then contradicts the corollary of Aethic invalid inheritance, because a valid B cannot be a child Aethus to an invalid A.

Attempt 2: the for-all form, and Oliver's Aethus. Given this failure, let us also consider the opposite form of the statement, being a *for all* statement rather than a *there exists* statement.

Third Postulate Attempt 2
"An Aethus will be invalid if all of its proper child Aethae are invalid."

$$\forall B \leq A, \neg \mathbf{V}[B] \Rightarrow \neg \mathbf{V}[A] \tag{38}$$

This statement, now, is a poor attempt at the third postulate for an entirely different reason: *it is technically always true, but is overly specific, to the point of not describing most empirical cases of invalidity.* If we consider Oliver's Aethus again, say as some Aethus A, then notice how this statement is insufficient to derive it as an empirically invalid Aethus. To see this, consider how all of the proper child Aethae to Oliver's Aethus can be sorted into two categories.

- Category 1 (Aethic contradiction)
  - The proper child Aethus is a direct Aethic contradiction, on account of Oliver having attained the Aethic information of which door was traversed by one or more participants.
- Category 2 (Other)
  - The proper child Aethus is not yet an Aethic contradiction, however a future Aethic contradiction is still very much on the table, due to Oliver still having the chance to gain the door of traversal information.
  - Crucially, *notice how every one of these Aethae is itself an Oliver's Aethus*, because it satisfies all the same original criteria which we used to define an Oliver's Aethus, being the sight of an interference pattern coupled with the ability to attain each door of traversal information.

    We can write such a statement in the form of a mathematical statement, being that *every proper child Aethus of an Oliver's Aethus is an Aethic contradiction or another Oliver's Aethus.*

    $$\mathbf{O}[A] \Rightarrow \forall B \leq A, \mathbf{C}[B] \vee \mathbf{O}[B] \tag{39}$$

    We can make such an or statement either a disjunction or exclusive disjunction depending on if we want to include the Aethic contradiction cases as Oliver's Aethae themselves, but the distinction is only important to the point of convention.
  - Notice, however, that even though these extra cases are highly relevant from the empirical lens, they end up becoming circular logic if we suppose the correctness of our second attempt at the statement of the third postulate.

    Why Attempt 2 cannot be applied to its own target. To see this in effect, consider our attempt to prove the Oliver's Aethus of A as invalid through the use of this second attempt at the statement of the third postulate. To do this, we would both need to rely on the contradiction proper child Aethae *and* the other cases in order to satisfy the condition all all proper child Aethae being invalid. The issue with this, however, is that we would then need to demonstrate these other cases as invalid themselves, but given that they themselves are Oliver's Aethae, we would then be stuck in the same recursive pattern of relying on their own non-contradictory cases for invalidity. The problem, then, is that this recursive pattern would never have a base case, so all invalidity for an Oliver's Aethus would be indeterminate. As such, we might think to refine this second attempt at third postulate of the Aethus to rely on Aethic contradictions directly rather than further invalid Aethae.

Third Postulate Attempt 3
"An Aethus will be invalid if all of its proper child Aethae are Aethic contradictions."

$$\forall B \leq A, \mathbf{C}[B] \Rightarrow \neg \mathbf{V}[A] \tag{40}$$

This statement is less misleading than the previous attempt, perhaps, but it is still far from being quite sufficient. The reason is simply that, well, we still have leftover non-directly-contradictory proper child Aethae to an Oliver's Aethus. The tricky thing about such Aethae is that they are indeed not directly Aethic contradictions by themselves, even though they have an empirically discernible semblance of invalidity about them. As stated before, then, we see that this attempt at the third

postulate is indeed a true statement to the cases in which it applies, but its scope of application is far too specific to account for all instances of an Oliver's Aethus. In effect, where the *there exists* argument of attempt one is perhaps too mathematically "weak" a statement, the *for all* arguments of attempt two and three are too "strong" to be applicable. We might specifically think to use terms such as weak versus strong because it simply follows that whatever the true reason is for why Oliver's Aethus is invalid, (being the third postulate itself), it follows that its occurrence in Oliver's Aethus will indeed imply that Oliver's Aethus has some invalid proper child Aethae, (thus making the *there exists* argument comparatively weaker), and at the same time we have that all special cases of it in which the *for all* case holds will imply it as still being in effect. What this tells us, then, is that *for all proper child Aethae to be contradictions implies an application of the third postulate toward invalidity*, and also that *for the third postulate to be in effect toward implying invalidity also implies that there exists an Aethic contradiction among the improper child Aethae*. So while this case is intermediate regarding implications, it does not correctly align with either extreme.

The solution, first in intuitive language. This issue is, naturally, something of a paradox, however the solution to it is already hiding in plain sight, if only we think to look for it. Let us first explain what this solution is in intuitive language, and then move to express it with but a single algebraic substitution of the equations we have already written.

Let us take a moment to consider the workings of Oliver's Aethus from a merely procedural stance. If we refer to the diagram once more where the Aethus A has two proper child Aethae, B and C, such that B is valid but C is invalid, then we see accordingly that the centric unfolding of an agent at Aethus A may only ever develop them to Aethus B, but never Aethus C. As such, in an intuitive way, we have that *it might as well be part of their Aethus already that C will never be a future possibility for them, because it is indeed an invalid Aethus*. Considering how Aethic information is fundamentally derivational in scope, we can assess that this is as legitimate a form of derivation as any. That is, we might naturally consider it to be an attribute of any Aethus anyway that *all invalid child Aethae are not to be centric unfolded to*. The key, then, is that for the Aethus A to already contain the attributes which forbid the eventuality of C, it follows that, bluntly, A must be capable of attaining such attributes. A keen analogy at this stage is the concept of *check* in the game chess.

Check, and checkmate. Specifically, we might suppose that for some Aethus, each proper child Aethus to it represents a kind of 'chess move'. When even a single proper child Aethus to some Aethus is invalid, then, this means that said Aethus would be in what is analogous to 'check' on account of a possible next move being fatal. In the case at hand, we have that the Aethus A has a proper child Aethus of C, so therefore A would then be in 'check' as per the analogy. This is a risk, yes, however it does not represent a true loss of the game. As a player at chess might simply move their king out of check in the next move, an agent's Aethus might centric unfold them to B so as to remove the possibility of C. Now the check is gone, and the game may continue. This being said then, we have to ask ourselves the essential question, being *what happens when we can no longer move out of check with any possible move?* In chess, of course, such a thing is called 'checkmate', and it signifies the loss of the game. In Aethic reasoning, we can declare that such a thing implies an invalid Aethus, with such a declaration being none other than the third postulate itself.

So, if check in Aethic reasoning is *the possibility of contradiction*, on account of Oliver's Aethus centric unfolding to an Aethus in which the door of traversal is attained, then checkmate would be *the impossibility of avoiding the possibility of contradiction*. Given that this, in being checkmate, must be absolutely implied invalid, we then get the following full sentiment. ***It shouldn't be impossible to make a contradiction impossible***. This is the very assertion of the third postulate of the Aethus, but of course it would be beneficial to write it in terms of a mathematical formalism.

The substitution. Consider two statements which we have thus far shown to be true, being the statement of inheritance for an Oliver's Aethus and the *there exists* expression for Aethic invalidity inheritance, which remember we have shown to be implied by an Oliver's Aethus on account of it being weaker.

$$\mathbf{O}[A] \Rightarrow \forall B \leq A, \mathbf{C}[B] \vee \mathbf{O}[B] \tag{41}$$

$$\mathbf{O}[A] \Rightarrow \exists B \leq A, \mathbf{C}[B] \tag{42}$$

Given these two statements, we can imply that the third postulate is, as stated earlier, expressible only with algebraic substitution of these two statements. That is, given how these are both true statements, we might think to substitute the latter into the former to get a statement which must also be true.

$$\mathbf{O}[A] \Rightarrow \forall B \leq A, \mathbf{C}[B] \vee \exists C \leq B, \mathbf{C}[C] \tag{43}$$

We can easily simplify this further by simply noting how for an Aethus, B, to be an Aethic contradiction of course implies that it possesses a proper child Aethus, (being itself, perhaps), which is an Aethic contradiction. Because the logical disjunction between a statement and something it implies equals the thing it implies, we have that $\mathbf{C}[B] \vee \exists C \leq B, \mathbf{C}[C] = \exists C \leq B, \mathbf{C}[C]$. We may then simplify accordingly.

$$\mathbf{O}[A] \Rightarrow \forall B \leq A, \exists C \leq B, \mathbf{C}[C] \tag{44}$$

As such, all we need to do is generalize this to all Aethae, so as to conclude that this property is the direct cause of Oliver's Aethus being invalid in the first place.

$$\forall B \leq A, \exists C \leq B, \mathbf{C}[C] \Rightarrow \neg \mathbf{V}[A] \tag{45}$$

Notice that this is precisely equivalent of our earlier linguistic statement that *it shouldn't be impossible to make a contradiction impossible.*

The trick, stated plainly: self-similarity. Directly stated without having to rely on all the fancy notation, *the exact trick of deriving the third postulate of the Aethus is to use isomorphic reasoning, for which we realize that whatever the reason is that Oliver's Aethus is invalid, all its proper child Aethae have to be invalid for the same reason*[119]. In other words, *the fundamental recognition is that* ***all Oliver's Aethae are self-similar***[120] *with their proper child Aethae which are not already contradictions.* This is why the weakened constraint followed by Oliver's Aethus that there exists an invalid proper child Aethus to it is able to be so readily passed onto all of the proper child Aethae of

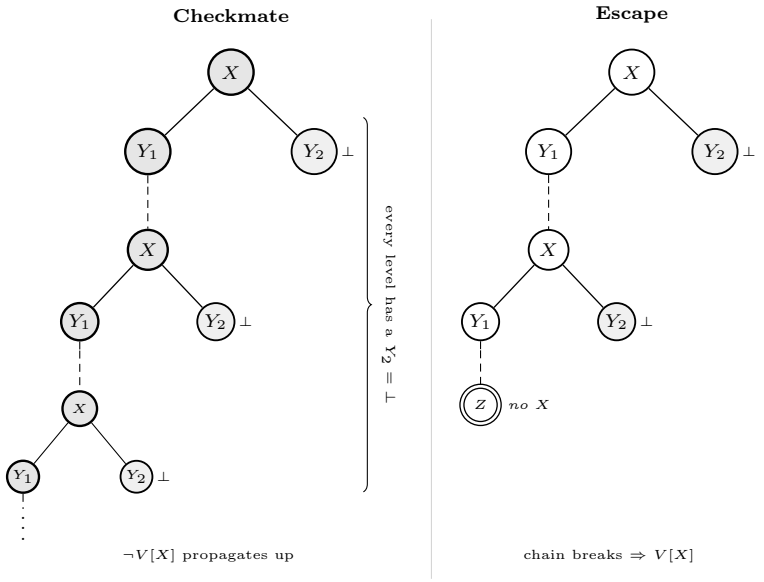
[119] And this is itself true, we may recall, because of how it is seen that the particular aspect of Oliver's Aethus in allowing future contradictions which may or may not come to pass is ontologically isomorphic to the analogous aspect in the future version of Oliver in which he has not yet triggered the contradiction directly. Directly inductively speaking, that is, it is not that we know this equivalence deductively but rather that we come to the stark realization that no true distinguishing criteria between said aspect in the present or non-contradictory future Oliver may be deductively developed, and so move to render the conclusion of an isomorphism as an important axiomatic constraint accordingly.

More intuitively speaking, if you will, imagine that Oliver, in the face of his being an Oliver's Aethus, decides to wait ten minutes with inaction so he can make up his mind about if he wants to go form a contradiction or not. So, ten minutes later when he still hasn't formed a contradiction, if we as the Aethic logicians tune in to the episode now, we are clearly going to point to this new Aethus as an Oliver's Aethus. Of course, it is a different Aethus with changed attributes since Oliver's Aethus of ten minutes ago, but since we only decided to tune in now, we may very well define this new one as the "quintessential Oliver's Aethus" in its place. And, logically, we would not have committed a fallacy in doing so, because whatever the inroad is into inducing the invalidity, one version of Oliver's Aethus where he is yet to explicitly form a contradiction is as good as the next. So, the major insight is to then develop this somewhat obvious procedural intuition into an actually structurally-relevant premise to the underlying Aethic logic, being that *this fact of every arbitrary Oliver's Aethus yielding an indiscriminate inroad into the inducing of the third postulate then implies that any axiomatic requisite to the third postulate's statement ought to be deducible by any Oliver's Aethus once it is deducible from at least one of them.* If this were not the case, after all, then there would be a decided preferential difference in the inductive inroad of one Oliver's Aethus compared to the next, which would violate the aforementioned principle that there cannot be one preferred Oliver's Aethus over the next concerning the constraint which collectively makes them invalid, (i.e. being the third postulate).

[120] A good concrete example of a graph of proper child Aethae which gets invalidated by the third postulate is essentially a graph where a fractal of copies of a dangerous Aethus remain accessible at every layer of depth. That is, consider an Aethus X as having child Aethae Y_1 and Y_2 where Y_2 is definitively invalid, and then consider the tree graph of Aethae with root node A and leaf nodes B_1 through B_n. If we edit this graph so that suddenly a copy of X, (in the sense of having at least one invalid proper child Aethus Y_2), is taken as a child Aethus of both every B_i and its own child Aethus Y_1—and then if we repeat this recursively such that a new copy of X is added as a child Aethus to each new such Y_1 and its own new Y_1 child Aethus infinitely onward, then this itself immediately renders A itself as an invalid Aethus by deduction from the third postulate. This is simply because no escape route exists where you are either not already on an invalid Y_2 copy, or have a proper child Aethus X copy which makes one available. However, by simply picking out some B_i and removing all its proper child Aethae of X from it so as to block off any avenues to is Y_2 copy child Aethae, and suddenly this B_i itself would become an escape route for A, which would both become valid again as a result.

his[121], because if it could not be then we would both contradict the isomorphic reasoning condition, and with it the state of his Aethus being an Oliver's Aethus anyway, (in the sense of invalidity), which of course contradicts where we started in the first place. Then, from here inductive rather than deductive reasoning itself effectively seals off the rest of the derivation to completion, being that we assume that this stated condition ought to in and of itself be sufficient as well as only necessary, (since it, after all, itself deduces that Oliver's Aethus is invalid by effective causal influence of the possibility of contradiction, as matches the chess analogy guidelines).

Generalizing back to all invalidity. With the intuition of Aethic contradictions having served us well in formulating this statement, let us now finally generalize it back to all forms of Aethic invalidity



[121]Most explicitly speaking so there is no ambiguity, this isomorphic reasoning is the "setup", but actually plugging in the weaker constraint we mentioned earlier is the "payoff", and generates the full third postulate statement. That is, we understand that the statement of "there existing an invalid proper child Aethus implies the parent is invalid" is an incorrect form for the third postulate itself, because although it is true that every Oliver's Aethus will, of course, possess at least one invalid proper child Aethus, (for example, being one where Oliver asks the fatal contradictory question), the converse of this is an incorrect statement, because the state of there existing an invalid proper child Aethus is not sufficient to demonstrate an Aethus is actually an Oliver's Aethus, (and instead will over-categorize Aethae as an Oliver's Aethus, and even give the paradoxical contradiction with the corollary of Aethic invalid inheritance in the process). But in saying this, we actually have now unveiled something rather fascinating from this recognition that the "there exists" argument over-categorizes Oliver's Aethae while the "for all" argument under-categorizes them: almost like a "bisection method for root finding" style of intuition, we might ask ourselves if we can hit the desired target in the middle, (as categorizes things perfectly), by asserting the "there exists" argument that is surely true on all of the proper child Aethae of Oliver's Aethus, so as to strengthen it up from its more raw and weaker form of being applied only to Oliver's Aethus alone. And better yet, as a matter of fact—and this is the carryover—we have by the isomorphic reasoning constraint itself that we are actually obliged to make this very move. That is, if we jointly consider the isomorphic reasoning concept and this concept of any given Oliver's Aethus having to posses a proper child Aethus which is an invalidity, we attain by implication the conclusion that to any given choice of Oliver's Aethus, given any choice of another proper child Aethus to it—being also an Oliver's Aethus—we then plug in the constraint that that Aethus will accordingly possess an invalid proper child Aethus somewhere due to its being an Oliver's Aethus, and in doing so we attain the full form of the third postulate itself. To any Oliver's Aethus, (i.e. now theoretically defined as an Aethus deemed invalid by the third postulate), if for all its proper child Aethae, each possesses an invalid proper child Aethus, then the original Oliver's Aethus is deemed invalid. So this is perhaps the central motivation behind why the third postulate is constructed the way it is: in order to hit the middle ground between the over-categorization of the "there exists" argument and the under-categorization of the "for all" argument, we assert the implied "there exists" argument on all proper child Aethae to an Oliver's Aethus since they themselves are each an Oliver's Aethus, (i.e because, since the "there exists" concept over-categorizes, in the least we know that every Oliver's Aethus is put in that set and so satisfy that "there exists" constraint, even though there will be more Aethae, here irrelevant to our concerns, which also satisfy it). The step of inductive reasoning directly succeeding this is then to assert that this statement is sufficient as well as only necessary, and directly after that perhaps update the implication to "Aethic contradictions" to all invalid Aethae, that way hypothetically any means of Aethic invalidation can indiscriminately trigger the cascading effect of the third postulate.

Lastly for now, I might also mention another quick clarification about the third postulate, being the rather more well-defined abstract context with which it first came to me. Specifically what I was imagining at the time was something of a subtle thought experiment in which some sort of more advanced civilization or lifeform, (in the sense of what mathematical abstraction feels like as a Platonic ideal, rather than literally), than us is deciding to actually define an Aethus using a much more sophisticated structure of the Aethus than what this paper alone has formally touched upon. That is, what would characterize this higher form of Aethic mathematics would sort of blur the line that little bit more

through the node of the Aethic contradictions.

$$\forall B \leq A, \exists C \leq B, \neg \mathbf{V}[C] \Rightarrow \neg \mathbf{V}[A] \tag{46}$$

The fascinating thing about this, now, is that we can consider it be something of a cascading effect. So long as we can prove that the Aethus under the for all and there exists arguments is invalid, through perhaps Aethic contradictions, the second postulate contrapositive, or any other means, and we may immediately imply properties about their parent Aethae through the mechanism of this formulation. Such is the power of the third postulate of the Aethus.

The positive form. To complete our final representation of the third postulate of the Aethus, we

between mathematics and ontology, and so would be mathematical universe [93]-adjacent in that this would be the exact mathematical form of an Aethus which is "physically touching" the surface of the realized realities to which it corresponds. So, under this intuitive thought experiment in which the advanced lifeform or deity or what have you is mathematically manipulating this structure in person, what they're going to find is that a complete Aethus needs to be "well-defined" within the scope of this mathematical transcendent-abstraction that they're engaging with. So, like how a human might build a physical grandfather clock, this advanced lifeform is mathematically manipulating this transcendent-abstraction form of Aethus in the flesh, and so is clicking the gears into place in person. The premise of the third postulate under this context, then, is this: analogously to how we humans need for a given mathematical concept to be well-defined in order to even exist in a mathematical context in the first place, (like, for example, how the well-defined formulation of an "open set" is that which embeds it into the ethereal layer of mathematical abstraction), so too would this advanced lifeform need to, given an Aethus they are tinkering with, "ground it on a baseline of being well-defined", so that it can rest on a table or a floor rather than crumbling to dust on the spot. So here's where the third postulate comes in directly from this context: my thought with it was specifically that due to some currently uncharted mathematical reason intrinsic to one of these deepened semi-ontological abstract Aethae, it actually turns out that even defining an Aethus in the first place is contingent upon its being able to be expressed in the "reduced form" in which all its proper child Aethae are valid. So, given an arbitrary Aethus of perhaps even limitless complexity, the advanced lifeform would simply roll up their sleeves and reduce this Aethus to its "reduced form", perhaps analogously to how a human linear algebraist might diagonalize a matrix. Accordingly, then, the third postulate of the Aethus could then be considered as simply stating that "every valid Aethus has a reduced form", or rather more sternly that "an Aethus is only ever well-defined in the deepened semi-ontological abstract sense once written in reduced form". So while we the naïve humans are living up on the surface, where we can either write mathematical Aethae however we want, or on the other side of things receive and experience the sentience from within realized ontological Aethae, we would actually get that in the intermediate territory where one becomes the other, it turns out that a mathematical Aethus can only be fed into the "machine" of ontological realization in its reduced form. In summary, then, you could technically always layer on infinite amounts of "baggage" onto a mathematical Aethus in the form of Aethic unions with dubious invalid Aethae, but when it comes time to feed that Aethus into the domain of realization, all that remains of it is that part of it which is reducible. If we really think about it, after all, we might imagine to a given Aethus A that it has a set of proper child Aethae $\tilde{B}$ for which all further proper child Aethae are valid, and accordingly we have that the supremum by Aethic parentage of this set, B, is effectively ontologically indistinguishable from A itself as based on one's state of inhabiting either one. Accordingly, then, if we define A's "reduced form" as just such a B, we have that whatever attributes have to be added to A in order to create B are necessary to the absolute for A's validity, (because being compelled to take this leap from A to B in the first place would have to be to avoid dangerous alternative possibilities in terms of invalid Aethae). So what I'm most trying to express with this framing, then, is simply that given a closer mathematical formulation to the ontological Aethus than what we're currently using, (be it used by future humans two years from now or two thousand years from now), it should probably be somewhat obvious to the structure of such a formalism that an Aethus always "compulsively adds attributes to itself" until it comes to a rest as reduced form. The third postulate, then, under such a framing is simply the ontological condition that a given valid Aethus is going to have a reduced form in the first place, so as not to be caught in an infinite loop of adding attributes with no avail. While of course this is only one interpretation of the "ontic stuff" of the third postulate, I should mention that it was effectively my original vision for it when writing it down in the first place, with the striking practical features of it then simply being a natural complement to this metaphysics. But of course, for the majority of practical dealings with it the more tangible "pruning" interpretation works perfectly fine as well.

Or, perhaps to express this intuition in a less mystical tone, I have a hopeful feeling that the third postulate itself, and whatever else in Aethic reasoning, remains to be painted in a far ontologically richer way, perhaps exactly analogously to Newton's second law being reformulated as Lagrangian mechanics, which after all is closer to the quantum ontology from which all this mechanics arises. Like Newton's treatment of forces, then, my primary aim with the third postulate is simply to raise to consideration a well-defined rendition of this underlying ontology, all while being deliberately aware that perhaps my particular expression of it is not the ultimate realization of that ontology itself. In other words, I will have done my job if there is a mutual deductive pathway between the current Aethic reasoning and this hypothetical ontological progression of it, just as there is such a mutual deductive pathway between Newtonian mechanics and Lagrangian mechanics.

An interesting observation I have about inference-driven scientific breakthroughs is that they each tend to unfold in two stages: what you might call a "charming stage" followed by a culminating "structural stage". The charming stage is when the researcher has intuited a basic principle of the universe, but is still stuck viewing it from within a subtly anthropocentric vantage in the sense of the context in which it lives. Once the researcher transitions into the structural stage, however, the charming stage reveals itself as having been charmingly naive about the tightness with which the universe actually does things, hence the name. If you will, where the universe itself does things like an all-business program director—every little move being a symphony in ontological graph-connective contribution—we humans first gaining a partial copy of the memo tend to situate that plan in terms of what's familiar, and that is where the charming naivety comes from in retrospect. Allow me to give two historical examples I've seen directly (as clued me into this two-stage phenomenon in the first place), so that I can then from there move to explain where the boundaries lay

might consider writing it in the positive rather than the negative, through the use of the logical contrapositive of the present statement.

6.4 Statement of the Third Aethic Postulate

Here is the completed statement of the third postulate of the Aethus.

with my own Aethic derivation pathway in 2022 and 2023. To begin with, I might give the example of Feynman's legendary "There's Plenty of Room at the Bottom" [94] lecture, during which his challenges for nanotechnology initiates with the charming stage: Feynman had tapped into the idea of nanotechnology—which is retrospectively discussed as prophetic-like—but as we see his concrete ideas for iterative hands ended up being unnecessary for the particularities of the two prizes, which instead ran with the foundational idea but stripped off the unnecessary flanks of the original concrete proposal. As in, the first prize was won unexpectedly quickly and by classically-available means, and the second was won later with techniques indeed matching what Feynman supposed, just with a more streamlined practical method [95]. So, if you will, this illustrates the charming-to-structural phenomenon over the medium of the contingency we all recognize in how future technologies will unfold: in that sense, just as you cannot predict the exact specificities of a given future technology even when getting the broader pattern extraordinarily right, so too does a charming stage thinker become surprised by the developments of even their own future self of however many months or years in the future upon completing the structural stage. Another example of the charming stage and structural stage is Einstein's own derivation of general relativity, where we might consider the charming stage as initiating with his recognition of the equivalence principle, and the transition to the structural stage occurring with his recognition of general covariance. (Colloquialism alert!). General covariance is the moment when general relativity graduated from "wow, clever idea" to "HO-LY you know what-ing you know what" as we know it today. Like, seriously c'mon here people—if you have two nearby spinning black holes, the EFEs couple the orbital angular momentum of both to each other, the orbital angular momentum to the intrinsic angular momentums, and the intrinsic to intrinsic altogether basically combinatorially. All of which without ever having to write down a single objective coordinate system, meaning it's welded into to the space itself. Like, in terms of sheer elegance firepower, I'm not kidding when I say that brings a sense over me of what I can only describe as euphoric. And *that* is what Einstein tapped into when he postulated general covariance—something which he would be the first to tell you (in having lived it) is a force of nature vastly beyond him as a mortal man, and yet which he naively stumbled into just because his inductive reasoning was sharp enough. So if you will, as a primate like the rest of us, he nonetheless hit basically infinitely far out of his weight class, which is what makes him Einstein. (Colloquialism closing tag, lol). As for my work on Aethic reasoning itself, I might consider placing the initiation of the charming stage with the August 22, 2022 journal entry's introduction of the Aethic soccer field thought experiment—rather than the extrusion principle itself, because the soccer field is when I actually fitted the substrate of Aethic ontology provided by the extrusion principle to the actual empirical structure of our own universe, and so thereby initiated my "gesturing at the way of the world, Aethically"—and I might consider the initiation of the structural phase as occurring when I had the intuition-realization directly leading up to my proposal of the third Aethic postulate on May 8, 2023 that the solution to the inheritance paradox (Principle 3) and the Aethic pruning mechanism are actually unified under the Aethic reduced form concept, (hence the purpose of the two generations to the third postulate, so as to establish an effective fixed point for validity). That is, the origin of the inheritance paradox itself dates to the August 22, 2022 journal entry, so this is essentially analogous to the relativity substrate concept like the equivalence principle or the curvature of spacetime—but the "mature" idea in the sense of initiating the structural stage was the incorporation of the Aethic pruning within the localized statement of the third postulate itself, which itself took as its initiation the idea to combine these particular two effects as layers of one structural idea in the first place. In a word, the reduced form unification is what turned the inheritance paradox from a loose dotting of intuitive ideas (messily ranging from informal personal characterization of the contradiction to misconceptions like the Boltzmann brain [96] relationship seen in the journal entry) to something recognizably Aethic in operability and fitness to the universe proper. Hence, why the reduced form itself was my initial intuition for the effective fixed point of the Aethic pruning as the derivational entry into the third postulate, as opposed to being a generalization which occurred afterwards, (so, if you will, without the reduced form idea there would be no third postulate, because that inheritance-pruning unification idea which conceptually constitutes the reduced form is the direct precondition to the statement of the third postulate).

To give some intuitive examples, in my charming stage for Aethic reasoning, in the earlier part of 2023 to crossing into the structural stage, I already had the graph structure of parent and child Aethae intuited, however I was arbitrary pressing for trying to make the third postulate, as a resolution to the inheritance paradox, as "aesthetically trippy" as the second postulate in how its mechanism—effectively by means of pruning Aethae based on innavigability to them down the Aethic tree from the parent direction as opposed to explicit ill-definedness in the child Aethus direction. That is, invalid Aethae physically would have affected the superposition in the parent Aethus direction as opposed to affecting only their own child Aethae in the causal sense. This idea is one of the major things I fixed when transitioning to the structural stage. Note, however, that even qualifying for the charming stage in the first place requires fundamental awareness of the prospects—even if not perfectly thoroughly. In this sense, I would say that I qualified for the charming stage of Aethic reasoning in Fall 2022 because I was aware of the inheritance paradox, but not by a longshot in 2020 with my unrelated "time plane" idea, because that was just sheer intellectual immaturity. So, yes, at around fourteen through sixteen I had a heavy lacking of intellectual maturity in key places, so I find it somewhat interesting how this apparently resolved itself once I had pressed on Nexic reasoning thoroughly enough during senior year of high school—after which point I was already hitting peak intellectual maturity (by comparison, anyway) in the sense of taste for letting inductive reasoning do the talking for you.

Third Postulate of the Aethus

If some Aethus is valid, then there exists a proper child Aethus to it for which every one of its own proper child Aethae are valid.

$$\mathbf{V}[A] \implies \exists B \leq A, \forall C \leq B, \mathbf{V}[C] \tag{47}$$

Two things about the quantifiers should be fixed before the statement is read further. The relation $\leq$ is proper childhood, Definition 36's boolean reduction, every proper child being a refinement of its parent by Aethic intersection as the intrinsic layer orders refinement (subsection 3.2); it is reflexive and transitive: an Aethus is its own proper child, and a proper child of a proper child is a proper child, by composition of decompositions. So, in this unweighted form, "there exists a proper child B" ranges over every descendant of A, however many attributes away, and "every proper child C of B" over every descendant of B likewise. Read on a one-attribute-step relation the postulate is a different and weaker statement, and it is not the one intended. A first consequence follows at once and is used throughout.

Corollary: Aethic Invalid Inheritance
Every proper child Aethus of an invalid Aethus is invalid.

The derivation, in three lines. Let B be a valid proper child of A. By the third postulate, $\mathbf{V}[B]$ gives a proper child C of B every one of whose proper children is valid. By transitivity, C is a proper child of A. So A has a proper child every one of whose proper children is valid, satisfies the postulate's condition, and—validity being the *largest* predicate satisfying that condition, and A not a direct contradiction, since a contradiction has no valid proper child—is valid. Contrapositively, an invalid Aethus has no valid proper child. The step marked *largest* needs its warrant stated: the postulate as an implication says only that validity is *some* predicate satisfying the condition, $\mathcal{V} \subseteq F(\mathcal{V})$ in the fixed-point notation of subsubsection 6.7.1, and from $A \in F(\mathcal{V})$ alone $A \in \mathcal{V}$ does not follow. The corollary therefore consumes the identification of validity with the greatest such predicate, $\mathcal{V} = \nu F$, which the fixed-point lemma derives from the base-generation reading—every invalidity either a base case or propagated from one—and which may be adopted as the definition of formal validity outright, $\mathcal{V} := U \setminus G(\text{Base})$, so that inheritance there is immediate. Under that reading, which is the framework's own, the three lines stand; without it they establish only that A satisfies the condition. Invalidity flows from parent to child and never the reverse, which is the direction the rejection of the first attempt above already relied on, and which is here shown to be a theorem of the completed statement rather than a desideratum imposed on it. The statement above is the unweighted form; the postulate's canonical statement is the weighted one of subsection 6.6, where the same corollary is re-derived on the weighted relation and the transitivity that carries it is a consequence of the weighted proper child's definition rather than of composite attributes. The completed postulate runs over weighted proper children only. The unweighted form shows the quantifier structure and is not itself to be read over unrestricted refinement, since the Aethus whose content holds every item refines every Aethus and is invalid (Proposition 13); and the postulate runs over weighted Aethae themselves, not over the validity quotient, which is taken afterwards for rendering and does not feed back into it.

Note how this is a strictly two-generational argument for the ontology of wavefunction collapse—"generation" naming a proper-child step, and a proper child being, in the completed postulate, a proper child in the sense of Definition 36, a component of a weighted Aethus whose coefficient is not measure-zero relative to the rest of it—so that wherever this paper says "child Aethus" in the postulate's vicinity it means a proper child in that comparative sense, a valid component at relatively negligible coefficient supplying no floor, the two generations are the two alternating quantifiers, and nothing about the count refers to rungs of a ladder. This resultantly deviates it from perhaps the majority of modern hypotheses for how this might happen, which instead rely on a more one-generational "leaking of information," as is the supposition of quantum decoherence[122].

We can now see that this insight directly explains the empirical phenomenon that Oliver observed – where even though he was not aware of which door each of his friends went through, and yet he still observed the two-concentrations pattern instead of the interference pattern. This is simply because his Aethus for which he sees an interference pattern is immediately invalid, because by the third postulate of the Aethus, for any child Aethus of his own, (being himself in the future), he can decidedly still access

[122]The paradox avoidance isn't retrocausality, because it isn't actually that the universe knows a paradox to be coming, it's that it can't gerrymander its own existing informational content to universally avoid it.

all that information by asking his friends or otherwise attaining entropic clues. As such, given two Aethae for which pattern he sees at the instant he takes off the blindfold – being the interference versus the two-concentrations – and he must see the two concentrations, as the interference one is invalid, and he, in existing, must have some valid child Aethus, being the other option itself. Such a thing now conceptually derives quantum decoherence[123], and so is a satisfactory solution to *Requirement 4* in the context of the measurement problem solution.

6.5 Immediate Abstract Applications of the Third Postulate

6.5.1 Testing the Third Postulate on Known Valid Aethae

Given how the third postulate is defined based on proper child Aethae, which themselves are defined based on blank attributes, we might find it to be an important exercise to show that several already-asserted cases of Aethic validity are still counted as valid under the third postulate. Let us prove this for a few examples now.

To begin with, consider the Aethus, A, which we will define through the following static Aethus.

```
{
  ("What kind of pet does Tim have?", Type of Animal, r1):
        "Dog",

  ("What breed is Tim's pet?", Breed of [Pet], r2):
        *blank,

  ("Does Tim own a Dalmatian?", Boolean, r3):
        false
}
```

Table 6: An example Aethus, defined through the static Aethus which corresponds to the graph of the above *2-Aethus*.

Given this Aethus, simply enough, we hold that the retrieval for "*what breed is Tim's pet?*" returns the set of all breeds of dog besides the Dalmatian. Such a thing is due to the Aethic dichotomy theorem, where we first assert that Tim's breed of pet must represent a breed of dog due to the first attribute, and second that said breed of dog is not to be a Dalmatian. Resultantly, due to the specific breed otherwise being blank, we hold such a blank as the blank component of our attribute, and return the set of remaining possibilities.

We know, as per the intuition of invalid Aethae, that such an Aethus should surely represent a valid Aethus, so the question at this point should be whether the third postulate of the Aethus confirms it, specifically when it is taken in definition through proper child Aethae. Let us then proceed by deriving that this Aethus is indeed satisfactorily valid.

Proof That Said Aethus Cannot Be Taken Invalid Under the Third Postulate
Let us show that there exists a proper child of the aforementioned Aethus A for which every further proper child is valid. To begin with, we have one blank attribute which we might think to fill, being the following.

$$\varphi = (\text{“What breed is Tim's pet?"}, \cdots) \tag{48}$$

Due to this being a directly blank attribute, we therefore hold that the act of filling it with any

[123]To be explicit about the relationship: the third postulate does not replace the environmental mechanism of decoherence but explains *why* it produces decoherence. The environmental information—air molecules recording which door was used, footprints in the grass, entropic traces of every kind—is precisely what the third postulate *acts on*. It is because this environmental information makes which-path knowledge accessible in principle (through asking, through forensic reconstruction, through any of the "near-endless" channels of deductive access) that the checkmate condition is satisfied and the agreeing superposition is forced into disagreeing. The environment is the *medium* through which the third postulate's logical constraint is physically realized; the third postulate is the *principle* that explains why the environment's recording of information has the decoherence effect it does. The two are complementary, not competing. See the dedicated discussion in Section 10.6.1 on the environmental origin of decoherence under the third postulate for elaboration on this.

corresponding dog breed state will account for a proper child Aethus—even if the state is to contradict other attributes of the Aethus. In this regard, the definition of a proper child Aethus is less strict than requiring the fill of a conceptually blank attribute with a state, and instead merely requires that a directly blank be filled.
Through this, we may create exactly one proper child Aethus for each breed of dog, with the total set of all such proper child Aethae serving as an Aethic partition of A itself. For the sake of exactness in description, let us suppose that we create a reference function, f, which maps each breed of dog onto its corresponding element from the partition. Given this setup, it is sufficient to satisfy third postulate-validity that we might merely demonstrate one of said proper child Aethae to hold all valid proper children, because such a thing would serve as a counterexample to the stance of A being deemed invalid under the third postulate.
If we consider the graph of the function f, (being the set of ordered pairs of its input and output results), then we need only to find one Aethus in its image for which there exists a proper child Aethus with all valid further proper child Aethae. We can note, immediately, that we are allowed to do this for all such Aethae except for only one, being $f(Dalmatian)$. In the case of $f(Dalmatian)$, we see automatically that it is an invalid Aethus on account of being an Aethic contradiction between the attribute which forbids Tim to own a Dalmatian. With this Aethus being excluded, then, we have that *any other Aethus we select from the partition will indeed have a proper child Aethus will all valid further child Aethae.* The one thing to note is that for such Aethae, we also need to add an attribute which offsets the capacity of any further predicaments such as this, (for example maybe we add an attribute which says that Tim cannot own a parrot, and then sets his pet bird to blank, in effect doing the same thing). It is an algorithmically definable process to disallow all such further iterations of this sort, and after we do such a thing we will then find that, naturally, at least one Aethus in that original partition will have such a proper child Aethus which has all valid proper children. In effect, we see that the maneuver of simply excluding the Dalmatian item from our set of possibilities was sufficient to demonstrate the validity of all further options, in effect satisfying the third postulate for the validity of A. □

6.5.2 On General Permanencible Attributes

With the third postulate now having been stated in full, let us think for a moment about how we might creatively generalize the concept of "permanently blank attributes" into whatever class is generally tailored to the third postulate as a permanently blank attribute is to the particular empirical case which we first examined with the double-slit experiment. Such an object is what we might refer to as a *permanencible attribute*[124], being named as a portmanteau of *permanently accessible.*

Let us think to define a permanencible attribute as follows.

Definition 33 (Permanencible Aethic Attribute)
A permanencible attribute is one which, when added to a particular Aethus, triggers invalidity by so much as even stating another attribute in question within that same Aethus.

There is an immediate list of some common kinds of permanencible-leaning attributes.

- Of course, the instance of permanently blank attributes in an Aethus is the important case seen already. Specifically, the permanencible attribute in question would be whichever conditional attribute in the Aethus states that the permanently blank attribute in question is blank. Here is a basic setup of such a thing.

$$\varphi_a = (\cdots,\ \cdots,\ \varphi_{ar}) \tag{49}$$

$$\varphi_b = (\text{“Attribute } \varphi_a \text{ is stated as blank"},\ \textit{Class Boolean},\ \varphi_{br}) \tag{50}$$

[124] My derivational motivation for the third postulate was really quite simple: given the intuition of an permanently blank attribute, where information is forever unknowable to an Aethus, I was simply looking for a way for the explanation of why non-permanently blank attributes break perfect agreeing superpositions to be well-defined to the same extent that the concept of an "open set" is well-defined. Simply stating to a given Aethus that permanently blank attributes are a primitive, and categorically intrinsically unknowable felt to my intuition like a definitive wrong move, because we would then have to assert this central structural aspect of the Aethus ad hoc. For example, I thought this would be something like defining an open set as "not a closed set" or "a set which doesn't contain its boundary". In a word, sacrilege, (but not actually though, as I am just trying to be lighthearted with that remark!). This is why I searched in the external structure of an Aethus for a means of providing a well-defined definition of permanently blank attributes, and my proposal became the third postulate itself.

If we now create an Aethus, A, in which φ_b is set to *true*, then automatically we now have that φ_a must be a permanently blank attribute within A, because the very instance of stating it causes nothing less than an Aethic contradiction over φ_b.

It is also important to mention that there are many cases in which we simply do not want an attribute to be permanently blank, so the proper way of encoding these more typical cases is to simply set its corresponding conditional, like φ_b, to directly blank. Notice that it ought not to be conceptually blank, as that would imply the interference of the second postulate of the Aethus. Directly blank will therefore do, which is effectively the same as leaving it out from any and all static Aethae altogether, thereby giving us the base Aethic picture instead of this more complicated one.

- Let us note that there are other intriguing instances of permanencible attributes as well as just this simple case. For instance, consider the example with Tim's dog breed again. Let us suppose we set the actual breed attribute of Tim's dog, φ_a, to directly blank, but then use five additional Boolean attributes such that each one disallows a particular breed of dog. For example, perhaps we set the breed of Tim's dog as a Dalmatian, Shiba Inu, Boxer, Newfoundland, and Australian Shepherd all to false. Now let us consider adding one more attribute to the defining static Aethus of our Aethus, being "Set of possible breeds for Tim's dog" as some attribute φ_s. Perhaps we set it to all dog breeds beside the five in question.

  Notice, now, what our requirements for valid Aethae are. To begin with, we could not have added any of the five disallowed breeds to the set of φ_s's state, because that would be an Aethic contradiction. However, there is perhaps an even more intriguing consequence as well, being that the very state of φ_s in failing to be directly blank in the Aethus in question means that φ_s itself cannot be changed in any child Aethus without leading to an Aethic contradiction. In effect, this means that even the attribute φ_a must now be permanently directly blank, because the act of stating it would lead to φ_s needing to be a set of only one element, which we know to be an Aethic contradiction given that it has already been stated. What this tells us, then, upon running the second and third postulates, is that *Tim's dog would have to be in agreeing superposition over occupying every breed in φ_s at once*. Such a thing would be a valid Aethic uncertainty principle, which we will expand on after we derive the double-slit experiment.

- One final intriguing example of a permanencible attribute is one which fixes the probability of another attribute. For example, perhaps we have one Boolean attribute which encodes whether it will rain tomorrow or not, φ_a, and then also a real number attribute, φ_b which states what the probability of it raining tomorrow is. Of course, by the definition of probability in Aethic reasoning, we therefore have to assess that such a probability gives the weight of φ_a occupying true as opposed to false, which itself is an Aethic union and therefore an Aethic superposition of both possibilities. Yet again, now, the very notion of stating φ_a would result in an Aethic contradiction on account of the other state dissolving and then φ_b no longer accurately describing the Aethus. As such, we again have through the full application of Aethic reasoning that φ_a would be shown to go into agreeing superposition, in effect making it both rain and not rain tomorrow in agreeing superposition.

It is worth mentioning that these examples, of course, are merely purely epistemic Aethae, and as such are not direct empirical assertions. Obviously for a dog to be in agreeing superposition over many breeds, or for a day to be in agreeing superposition over having rain or not would be empirically absurd outcomes, because in the empirical world such attributes may have their states easily gathered rather than truly being permanently uncertain to this degree. In effect, then, these examples were here only for purely epistemic explanatory gymnastics of sorts.

Another important notion we should quickly touch upon is that a static Aethus which leaves permanencible attributes out will decidedly *not* include them in the attribute cascade by default[125].

[125]In order to illustrate this point more thoroughly, let us consider the context in which Aethic reasoning was derived in the first place. Rather importantly, note that what I did *not* do was start with the axiomatic layer of attributes and static Aethae, and then proceed to derive the Aethus and afterwards its operations for compatibility with Oliver's soccer field and the double-slit experiment. Instead, rather on the contrary, what I did was start with the abstract mathematical ideal of the Aethus in the first place—which I understood to serve as the proper informational signifier for an Aethic block universe as described in the extrusion principle—and then from there I worked outwardly to, in the theoretical direction derive the operations and double-slit experiment solution, and on the other side back toward the axiomatic layer attempt to express the Aethus in terms of the attribute cascade over static Aethae. Altogether, then, the key to understanding is that the Aethus is the proper informational signifier of an Aethic block universe first and

The reason for this simply has to do with, as we have seen, the state of permanencible attributes being blank versus stated having categorical consequences onto the Aethus. Simply put, we therefore claim that permanencible attributes are not automatically derived along with other derivable attributes in the attribute cascade, simply because their stance of being stated or not fails Aethic equivalence between the two options, even though the *3-Aethae* of both are extensions of that same static Aethus. With the permanencible attribute being directly blank upon having been left out of the static Aethus, we therefore default to that option in such a case.

Lastly, please note that just because you often cannot write permanencible attributes in an Aethus directly does not mean that you cannot retrieve them from an Aethus. With retrieval fundamentally being a passive operation, in that it cannot affect the intrinsic Aethic structure, it therefore follows that we can essentially retrieve any attribute we can imagine, with the exception of outright paradoxes, (for example, "does this retrieval return false?" is a paradoxical retrieval statement, so perhaps we disallow retrievals to reference themselves so as to weed out these kinds of issues). It is through this flexibility of retrievals that we allow ourselves to gather information like the probability of it raining tomorrow from an Aethus. That is, similarly to what we saw with the second postulate, we might simply set up the Aethus in a proper manner, and then call anything we want off of that structure using the retrieval of choice.

6.6 Defining the Reduced Form of an Aethus

Definitionally speaking, the "reduced form" of an Aethus is effectively a direct application of the Aethic partition theorem in particular, but features the third postulate[126]. Here is the formal definition of the reduced form of a given Aethus.

Definition 34 (Reduced Form of an Aethus)
Given an Aethus, A, its reduced form, $\bar{A}$, is given as the supremum by Aethic parentage of the set of proper child Aethae to A for which all proper child Aethae to each are valid.

$$\bar{A} = \sup\{B \leq A \mid \forall C \leq B, \mathbf{V}[C]\} \tag{51}$$

Highly importantly, we get by the Aethic partition theorem directly that $A \equiv \bar{A}$ under validity equivalence, (the deliberately weaker tier made explicit beside the Aethic Partition Theorem, Section 4.6.3—Aethic equivalence, the identity of closures (Section 3.1), is untouched by this, and continues to hold invalid Aethae pairwise distinct as unique labels), and this is itself perhaps the central structural motivation behind why the third postulate is important.

Fundamentally speaking, the third postulate itself may then be expressed in the language of reduced Aethae themselves: simply put, it is the statement that ***if an Aethus is valid, then it must have a reduced form****. Or, by the contrapositive, an Aethus without a reduced form is necessarily invalid.*

A lemma is recorded here, in its proper home, for later pipelines to lean on: *the reduced form distributes over finite Aethic sums*—the reduced form of a weighted proper sum of Aethae is the corresponding weighted sum of reduced forms. Given that the reduced form is defined by the same recursive statement as the third postulate itself, the proof proceeds by structural induction on that recursion, with the state-decomposable base case immediate and the inductive step passing the component-wise application through the sum; the full write-out is routine and deferred. Note, moreover, that the lemma's boundary is principled rather than accidental: distribution holds over proper sums precisely *because* Aethus addition establishes its summands as non-interacting pockets, and by the very same union principle it must *fail* over agreeing superpositions, whose branches are not pockets at all. The polarized double-slit pipeline, (Section 14.6.3), relies on exactly the licensed half of this boundary.

Concerning why the Aethic partition theorem allows for us to assert that $A \equiv \bar{A}$, it is simply because A itself may be written as the Aethic partition of $\bar{A}$, $\not{A}$, the Aethic union of all proper child Aethae to A for which decidedly not all of their further proper child Aethae are valid, and $\not{K}$, the Aethic union of all child Aethae to A which are not proper child Aethae. The reason why this is a valid Aethic partition is simply because the two Aethae of $\bar{A}$ and $\not{A}$ exhaustively and disjointly account

foremost, and only secondarily the output of a static Aethus attribute cascade. This is the reason why we understand that if there is a conflict with static Aethae and permanencible attributes, then easily the most natural place to orient the needed heightened specificity is within the attribute cascade process itself. This hopefully helps to explain why this conclusion is not *ad hoc* at all, but is instead informed directly from the same derivational structure atop which Aethic reasoning is built.

[126] So, as a type, if you will, the reduced form concept arises from the Aethic partition theorem structurally, and so is separable from the third postulate more so than that.

for all possible proper child Aethae of A, and $\not{K}$ consist of Aethae which are deducible from A to be unrealizable anyway, (in the state-decomposable sense), so as to make it invalid. The axiom of the third postulate of the Aethus itself, then, is the tool with which we deduce that $\not{A}$ must be an invalid Aethus, and so altogether A is written as the Aethic partition of $\bar{A}$ and the two invalid Aethae $\not{A}$ and $\not{K}$. The Aethic partition theorem itself then deduces that $A \equiv \bar{A}$, (again at the validity tier).

Formally speaking, the reason the third postulate deduces that $\not{A}$ is invalid may be explained as follows. If we take Q to be the set of all proper child Aethae of A for which there exists an invalid further proper child Aethus, then by definition $\not{A}$ is the Aethic union of all Aethae in Q. Accordingly, then, it follows that for any proper child Aethus $\not{A}_1$ of $\not{A}$, there exists a subset $Q_1 \subseteq Q$ for which the union of all Aethae in Q_1 is exactly $\not{A}_1$, and furthermore Q_1 is exhaustively the set of all proper child Aethae of $\not{A}_1$ in particular. However, by construction every element of Q, and therefore every element of Q_1 is an Aethus which contains at least one invalid proper child Aethus, so by the statement of the third postulate of the Aethus directly, $\not{A}_1$ is invalid on account of all its proper child Aethae containing at least one further invalid proper child Aethus. Altogether, then, we have that the Aethic partition theorem and the third postulate of the Aethus together deduce that $A \equiv \bar{A}$.

Also, concerning why the third postulate of the Aethus itself is equivalent to the statement that all valid Aethae have a reduced form, this is simply because, given that the reduced form of an Aethus is given as the supremum of the set of all proper child Aethae to it which each have all valid proper child Aethae, we have that exactly those Aethae which are invalidated by the third postulate have only the empty set for such a set in the first place. That is, this is because all such third postulate-invalidated Aethae are those for which there exist no proper child Aethae with all further proper child Aethae in the first place. Accordingly, then, the third postulate itself may be seen to be mathematically equivalent to the statement that an Aethus without a reduced form must be invalid, or by the contrapositive that an Aethus which is valid must have a reduced form. The main takeaway from all of these analyzes about the reduced form of Aethae, then, is just the level of logical interplay between the third postulate and the Aethic partition theorem, as if they were born of the same substance. That is, it seems as though these two principles are meant to cooperate.

Fundamentally, then, this validity equivalence between an Aethus and its reduced form, (the coarser tier, Section 4.7.2—the two are *not* equivalent under the finer definitional-hierarchy relation, the struck invalid summands remaining distinct labels there), is why we may treat them as the same Aethus in procedural contexts. Indeed, this will be the precise goal of our upcoming derivation with the double-slit experiment, where we will first identify all invalid child Aethae to a given Aethus, (sometimes using the third postulate directly), and then assert that the Aethic union of the valid child Aethae only is equivalent to the total Aethus itself, (which is perhaps the central argument behind why Aethic reasoning works ontologically, even as a logic of elimination).

6.6.1 The Multiple Roles of Two Generations in the Reduced Form

It is worth drawing explicit attention to the fact that the two-generational condition defining the reduced form—being the requirement that $\forall\, C \leq B,\ \mathbf{V}[C]$ for each B in the supremum—serves *two structurally distinct roles* within the Aethic framework, and that the third postulate itself occupies only one of these two. Crucially, both roles independently constrain and necessitate the two-generational shape, so that the condition does not arise in a vacuum but is multiply determined—each role telling the same structural story from a different angle.

Role 1: Direct invalidation of contradictable agreeing superpositions. This is the third postulate in its most visible application, as seen throughout the double-slit derivation and formalized in the powerset invalidation theorem. When an Aethus asserts an agreeing superposition whose generating attribute is accessible to every proper child Aethus—as with the which-slit attribute in the detector-on case—the two-generational condition finds no valid B in the supremum, and the Aethus is declared invalid accordingly. This is the "checkmate" role. The two-generational shape is constrained from this direction by the empirical derivation through Oliver's soccer field: the empirical self-similar structure of an Oliver's Aethus forces the quantifier alternation $\forall B,\ \exists C$ rather than a simpler one-generational rule, as established therein.

Role 2: Construction of the reduced form as the totality of escape routes. The reduced form also serves as a universal pruning mechanism over the full Aethic tree, and this role motivates the two-generational shape from an independent direction. The reduced form is, by construction,

the collection of all proper child Aethae B which constitute valid escape routes—that is, children from which no further path leads to invalidity. The very *desire* for the reduced form to represent this totality of escape routes is itself a constraint on needing two generations: one must examine the children (the candidate escape routes) and then verify that their own children are all clean (that the escape route is genuine rather than merely deferred). When computing $\bar{A}$, the two-generational condition does not interrogate *why* a proper child C of B is invalid—only *whether* it is. As such, it automatically excludes any proper child B for which there exists an invalid proper child C of B at any depth, regardless of whether C was invalidated by a direct Aethic contradiction, by the contrapositive of the second postulate, by a recursive application of the third postulate from deeper in the tree, or by any other well-defined mode of Aethic invalidity. The reduced form thereby functions as the single convergence point through which all sources of invalidity—however they originate—propagate upward to prune the parent structure. The powerset invalidation theorem illustrates this especially clearly in the multi-slit context, where the reduced form sifts the full powerset of slit combinations into equivalence classes—with the valid structure falling out almost as a direct consequence of the two-generational sifting across the P2 and P3 contributions jointly. It is also directly worth mentioning, note, how the reduced form itself is richer than the simpler "drop out invalid child Aethae" seen in the Aethic partition theorem directly, in the sense that it is this but with the extra constraint of all the deduction gathered from the third postulate itself pertaining to invalidity.

The convergence of these two roles on the same two-generational structure constitutes something of an internal consistency check for the framework. Role 1 derives the quantifier alternation $\forall B,\ \exists C$ from the empirical constraint of macroscopic decoherence (via the soccer field thought experiment); Role 2 arrives at the same structure from the qualitative requirement that the reduced form exhaustively catalog all genuine escape routes from invalidity. That both directions independently demand two generations—and precisely the same $\forall$-$\exists$ nesting—reinforces the claim that this condition is not an artifact of a particular derivational path, but an intrinsic structural feature of the Aethic graph. (Three claims are held apart here, and the paper makes the first two: that the third postulate has a canonical fixed-point representation; that within the specified rule class its quantifier structure is selected by the stated constraints; and that the physical world uniquely requires that rule, which is not claimed and would need a minimality theorem with a countermodel for each assumption dropped, named among the Open Constructions. And the elimination behind Role 1 is elimination only if its candidates exhaust the field, and the field is the unweighted quantifier-prefix rules on the refinement relation—fixed as such by the framework's division of labor between validity, binary, and weight, graded, (the counterfactual semantics' own statement of it, Section 9.1), which excludes any rule keyed to the weight of contradiction-reaching refinements and therefore stands among the elimination's premises, the third postulate's *invalid, not improbable* clause restating that division rather than supplying it. Within that field a rule is fixed by its first quantifier and its second, each ranging over proper children, which is to say over descendants at every depth. At the first quantifier an existential is excluded outright by the inheritance direction—any rule that condemns a parent through one descendant condemns that descendant's innocent siblings, whatever they hold deeper, the collision the check-versus-checkmate diagram exhibits—so the first quantifier is universal or the rule is wrong; at the second quantifier a universal never fires, since waiting is always a refinement, so that quantifier is existential or the rule is idle. That leaves the alternation displayed, and deeper finite nestings are not new candidates but unfoldings of it: the least fixed point of Section 6.7.1 already iterates the alternation to arbitrary depth, its approximation stages being exactly the deeper-nested rules, so "checkmate in n" is the same rule run n times rather than a rival to it.)

This dual character is what makes the reduced form the deeper concept, with the third postulate being specifically the edge case of *having no reduced form at all.*

It is also worth being explicit about how far a single application of the two-generational condition reaches, because the answer is the whole tree, and the reason is the Attribute Set. A proper child is any descendant: the relation is transitive because any number of augmentations compacts into one, the Aethae multiplied together to reach a descendant being themselves one Aethus. So when the condition is applied to a root A, its "$\exists B$" ranges over every Aethus beneath A at every depth, and its "$\forall C$" over every Aethus beneath that B at every depth; nothing is left to a second application. The *base cases*—direct Aethic contradictions (conflicting determinate states in intersection), violations of the second postulate's contrapositive (over-specification of observationally indistinguishable states), and any other non-recursive mode of invalidity—are the only invalidity the condition needs to see, and it sees all of it at once: A is valid exactly when some descendant of A has a cone beneath it free of base cases, and doomed exactly when every descendant has a base case somewhere beneath

it. There is no level-by-level propagation to run, no "one level deeper" at which the condition must be reapplied, and no sense in which the window is two steps wide; "two-generational" names the two alternating quantifiers, not two steps of a ladder. That a single application traverses the entire descendant structure is not a property the recursion earns but one the relation confers.

A fixed-point restatement. The condition has a standard mathematical form, and stating it buys the framework a bridge to existing theory even though, as will be seen, the form closes at once. Define the *doomed* set of Aethae as the least fixed point

$$D \;=\; \mu X.\,\Big(\text{Base} \cup \big\{A : \forall B \le A,\ \exists C \le B,\ C \in X\big\}\Big),$$

where Base collects the non-recursive modes of invalidity (direct Aethic contradictions and second-postulate-contrapositive violations) and $\le$ is proper childhood, reflexive and transitive; validity is then the complement of $\mathfrak{D}$—equivalently, the *greatest* fixed point of the dual safety operator. This is the shape of a safety property in the modal μ-calculus [97], and of the non-losing positions of a two-player game against nature, which renders the chess idiom of this paper literal rather than figurative: checkmate *is* membership in the doomed set $\mathfrak{D}$. The Knaster–Tarski theorem [98] supplies both fixed points for arbitrary branching, so nothing in the construction presupposes finiteness of the attribute classes. But the transitivity of $\le$ makes the iteration trivial in a way worth having on the page. Write $D_0 = \text{Base}$ and $D_1 = \text{Base} \cup \{A : \forall B \le A,\ \exists C \le B,\ C \in \text{Base}\}$. If A enters at the next stage, then either $A \in \text{Base}$, and $A \in D_1$ already, or every $B \le A$ has some $C \le B$ in D_1; if $C \in \text{Base}$ that B is served, and if not, then C's own membership in D_1, read at C's reflexive refinement, supplies some $E \le C$ in Base, and by transitivity $E \le B$. So every $B \le A$ already has a base case beneath it, $A \in D_1$, and $D_2 = D_1$: the least fixed point is D_1, reached at the first stage, and dually the greatest fixed point of the safety operator is reached at its first stage too. The closure ordinal is one, for any branching whatever; no König-type collapse is needed because there is nothing to collapse; and the postulate's own statement, valid iff some descendant has a base-free cone, is the fixed point rather than a seed for computing it. (An earlier form of this paragraph carried closure ordinals beyond ω and a "checkmate in ω moves" stratum; those belonged to an immediate-child reading of $\le$ the framework never had, and are retired with it.) The equivalence of the third postulate as stated with the fixed-point formulation is Lemma 1, in its own subsubsection following the weighted reduced form, (Section 6.7.1). The child relation is reflexive and transitive, per the remark at the proper-child definition, so terminal Aethae, (no resolvable blanks remaining), are classified by Base alone—no vacuous-quantifier edge case arises, the self-loop is the formal counterpart of waiting, and the quantifiers reach every depth in one application.

6.6.2 Defining the Aethic Reduced Form Coupling

What is perhaps one of if not the most important emergent application of the Aethic reduced form is its producing the concept of Aethic "reduced form coupling".

Concept 4 (Aethic Reduced Form Coupling)
Simply put, oftentimes when the reduced form of a given Aethus it taken—as prunes to invalidity its invalid proper child Aethae and whatever combinations of stated-attributes signify them—and the fundamental result is that the Aethae corresponding to certain combinations of stated-attributes are pruned, thereby leaving the effect that the resulting valid proper child Aethae force only a limited combination of stated-attributes as options.

What this produces is effectively an Aethic attribute "coupling", in the sense that certain stated-attributes are only allowed to be accompanied by certain others as an Aethic intersection, so long as the total Aethus is to remain valid.

It is also worth mentioning, as stated in the Quantum Nexus section (Principle 50), that quantum entanglement itself is merely a special case of Aethic reduced form coupling, when we enforce that the weights of the coupling are mediated by quantum probability amplitudes (or in the Quantum Nexus case, by the forcing of two dual paths and the proper Feynman kernel weighting) as opposed to any general Aethae and their weights. Furthermore, the fundamental Aethic reframe is that reduced form coupling is to come directly from the pruning from the postulates, rather than having to take quantum mechanics itself as an intermediary. What is fundamentally important about this is that it rendered reduced form coupling as essentially reaching the fundamentality of the Aethic block universe itself, in that it is a fundamental consideration which is only one deductive move away from the reduced form

at any given time, as opposed to the theoretical status of quantum entanglement as being "deductively out of place" among the known first principles of the universe pertaining to comprehensible ontology. In this sense, concepts like delayed-choice experiments [10], which in the standard quantum sense are bizarre, in the Aethic sense are merely the intuitive consequence of the reduced form coupling operating on ontology which is consistent with the Aethic extrusion principle.

To make the coupling mechanism explicit at the procedural level, it is perhaps worth unpacking what happens when the reduced form operation is applied in a setting containing multiple attributes whose states would otherwise be freely combinable. Prior to the pruning, the Aethus in question is treated as the linear combination of *all possible* joint stated-attribute configurations (being a partition into proper child Aethae) over the attributes in question—that is, we begin with a fully maximal Aethic population of the joint space, with no configurations eliminated by any criterion whatsoever. The formal reduced form operation then prunes this full combination using both the second and third postulates jointly, with no additional pruning rule imposed by hand. The second postulate handles the cases in which the configuration over-specifies a distinction among observationally indistinguishable components, while the third postulate handles the cases in which the configuration would lead to an eventual contradiction in some child or grandchild Aethus. These two pruning actions run in concert rather than being applied in a fixed sequence, and together they exhaust the modes by which a joint configuration can be invalidated—meaning that what survives the reduced form is precisely the set of joint configurations which are neither over-specifying nor under-restricting relative to the Aethic structure of the system. The key procedural observation is that these invalidities are not usually localized to individual stated-attributes on their own, but rather attach to *combinations* of stated-attributes—it is not, say, that attribute $X = x_1$ is invalid nor that attribute $Y = y_2$ is invalid, but that the Aethic intersection $(X = x_1) \cap (Y = y_2)$ itself is what contains the eventual contradiction (or, alternatively, the over-specification). The survivors of the pruning are then precisely those combinations for which no such joint invalidity arises, and those combinations collectively exhibit the coupling: the permitted values of X in the reduced form now depend on the value of Y, and vice versa, purely because the alternative joint values were eliminated. No causal interaction, no hidden mechanism, and no Aethus-external principle was invoked to produce this correlation—the coupling is simply what remains once the validity-preserving pruning of both postulates has run its course, with the start state of maximal inclusion ensuring that nothing has been put in by hand in place of what deduction alone would supply. The fundamental formulation[127] of the reduced form itself then implies that the full Aethus is validity-equivalent to this reduced form Aethus, (the coarser tier), meaning that we can write each interchangeably to refer to the same Aethus—the reduced form itself simply runs in the ontic background to imply all versions of the Aethae are equivalent to the pure reduced form at the end.

As it turns out, this same mechanism—varying only in which attributes are coupled and which weights govern the coupling—appears across multiple distinct regions of the paper under surface presentations that do not obviously resemble one another. It may therefore be helpful to catalog these appearances explicitly, so that the unified character of the mechanism is visible at a glance rather than having to be reassembled from scattered references.

1. *Standard quantum entanglement.* As noted above, Bell-type correlations between spacelike-separated measurements are recovered as the Feynman-weighted case of reduced form coupling, with the weights arising from the Quantum Nexus integral's imposition of the proper Feynman kernel on the dual paths. See Principle 50 for the explicit formulation.

2. *The multi-slit experimental outcomes.* The powerset invalidation theorem, (Theorem 14), is itself a particularly transparent instance of reduced form coupling at work—indeed, perhaps the pedagogically clearest combinatorial expression of it available within the framework. For a multi-slit experiment with n slits and an arbitrary detector configuration, the theorem partitions the full powerset $\mathcal{P}(\{s_1, \ldots, s_n\})$ of slit-traversal cases into exactly three mutually exclusive and jointly exhaustive categories—valid, second-postulate-invalid (P2), and third-postulate-invalid (P3)—with the valid cases corresponding exactly to the empty set and the detector-induced equivalence classes. The coupling here operates between the which-slit attributes and the detector-firing attributes, with the reduced form eliminating precisely those joint configurations in which a given combination of slit traversals would be inconsistent with the detector-firing

[127]That is, this deduction is possible assuming the general soundness as conditions of the Aethic partition theorem and the third postulate of the Aethus.

outcomes they imply. What is particularly striking about the powerset classification is its complementarity structure: the second and third postulates handle structurally different failure modes of an agreeing superposition—"too narrow" (over-specifying within an equivalence class, P2) versus "too broad" (combining across equivalence classes, P3)—and these are the only two ways an agreeing superposition can fail. That the two modes exhaustively partition the invalid region, with no overlap, is a significantly nontrivial structural result, and it reflects the deeper complementarity between the second and third postulates throughout Aethic reasoning: the second postulate enforces superposition where information is absent, while the third postulate collapses superposition where information is accessible. The powerset invalidation theorem makes this complementarity visible in miniature. It also demonstrates that the quantum-classical boundary is not located at any fixed threshold, but rather wherever the informational coupling between the system and the detector configuration places it—adding detectors splits equivalence classes, converting former P2 cases into valid ones while simultaneously generating new P3 cases, with the limiting behavior being pure interference at one end (all slits in a single equivalence class) and pure particle-like patterns at the other (each slit in its own equivalence class). The entire reduced form coupling mechanism is, in this sense, visible in compressed combinatorial form within the multi-slit context.

3. *Delayed-choice experiments.* In Section 10.9.4, following Wheeler's configuration [10], the coupling between the which-path information and the experimentally-observed pattern is shown to hold regardless of the proper-time ordering of the two observations. The coupling is absolute over the Aethic structure, but the particular random outcome may be gathered in either temporal ordering—it is this property of reduced form coupling, specifically its indifference to the proper-time ordering of the coupled attributes, which dissolves the apparent retrocausality of delayed-choice setups.

4. *The Wigner's friend family.* As explicitly mentioned in Section 10.2.1, the agreement between Wigner's measurement outcome and the friend's measurement outcome, even across the sealed-box asymmetry, is maintained by the reduced form coupling operating between their respective stated-attributes for the particle's state. Any Aethic pocket in which their reports would mutually contradict is invalidated by the third postulate, leaving only those pockets in which their outcomes agree. The Frauchiger-Renner paradox [92] is accordingly defused by the same machinery[128].

5. *Aethic Bayesianism and classical conditional probability.* Perhaps the cleanest demonstration that reduced form coupling is not narrowly a quantum mechanism, but rather a general Aethic operation whose surface appearance varies only with the weighting structure governing the coupling, comes from the case in which the weights are classical probabilities rather than Feynman amplitudes. The canonical example here is the Monty Hall problem [99], treated in Section 11.1.3 as the worked illustration of Aethic Bayesianism. The construction proceeds in precisely the same shape as in the quantum cases. One begins with the original Aethus $A_{\text{orig}} = \frac{1}{3}B_1 + \frac{1}{3}B_2 + \frac{1}{3}B_3$, representing the uniform prior over which door the car is behind. One then forms the intersection $A_{\text{after}} = A_{\text{orig}} \cdot S_1 \cdot X$, where S_1 encodes the contestant's selection of Door 1 and $X = \frac{1}{2}(O_2 + O_3)B_1 + O_3B_2 + O_2B_3$ encodes the host's conditional response structure (the host opens either of the remaining doors with equal probability if the car is behind Door 1, and is forced to open the unique goat door if the car is behind Door 2 or Door 3). Expanding this product produces a linear combination over all possible joint configurations of (B_i, O_j) values, and the reduced form is then taken by crossing off the Aethic contradictions among them—configurations in which, for instance, the host is alleged to have opened the door behind which the car is located, or in which the car is asserted to be behind two doors at once. What survives the pruning is a coupling between the host's revealed-door attribute and the car's actual-door attribute: once Door 3 has been revealed as a goat, the reduced form forces the car to be either behind Door 1 (with weight $\frac{1}{3}$) or behind Door 2 (with weight $\frac{2}{3}$). The which-door-revealed and where-the-car-is attributes are now coupled—not by any causal mechanism, but

[128] It is perhaps also worth flagging here that the reduced form coupling between cross-observer reports is structurally identical to the coupling that arises in the more speculative treatment of near-death experiences discussed in the footnote at Section 300. In that treatment, the attestation of an agent having undergone non-monotonic Aethic time traversal and the subsequent physical verification by another agent are coupled by the same third-postulate pruning mechanism—the "channel" through which the information is conveyed is the reduced form's elimination of mutually-contradictory joint configurations, rather than any exchange of signals across spacetime. The mechanism is, as noted therein, precisely the same as in the delayed-choice case, and for its "biological" origin is perhaps a pedagogically clean illustration of a case operating outside of the probability amplitude-based special case of actual quantum entanglement. That speculative material is cross-referenced here for completeness only; nothing in the present section depends upon it.

by exactly the same validity-preserving pruning operation that produces entanglement in the Feynman-weighted case. What this illustration accomplishes within the catalog is a structural decoupling between the Aethic mechanism and the special case of quantum weights specifically. The reduced form coupling does not require Feynman amplitudes, the Born rule, the Quantum Nexus integral, or anything quantum-mechanical whatsoever in order to operate—it requires only an Aethus whose joint stated-attribute configurations admit pruning by the second and third postulates. The difference between the Bayesian instance and the entanglement instance is in the *weights* the coupling carries, not in the mechanism itself; whether the weighting on the joint configurations is classical-probabilistic or Feynman-amplitude-valued is a feature of the empirical regime being analyzed, not of the underlying Aethic operation. This is the cleanest articulation available within the framework of the claim that the Quantum Nexus integral is one specialized weighting of a more general structural mechanism, with the Aethic Bayesian treatment of classical Bayesian reasoning being another. The same operation runs on both, and the surface phenomena (entanglement, conditional probability) are what the operation produces under different weighting regimes.

6. *The Wood-Spekkens / Allen et al. program for quantum causation, with the Newcomb coin-flip as illustrative coupling.* The reduced form coupling, viewed in its widest application, may be understood as a proposed structural realization of the research program initiated by Wood and Spekkens [100] and substantially developed by Allen, Barrett, Horsman, Lee, and Spekkens [101]. The structural shape of that program is well-established at this point in the literature. Wood and Spekkens applied the formal apparatus of causal discovery algorithms from machine learning and statistics to the correlations observed in Bell-type entanglement experiments, and demonstrated that no causal explanation of Bell-inequality-violating no-signaling correlations can be given within the classical framework of causal inference without fine-tuning the model's parameters—that is, none of the standard causal stories of the classical triad ("A causes B", "B causes A", "some common antecedent C causes both A and B") can account for these correlations while preserving the faithfulness assumption that statistical independence should not be explained by accidental parameter cancellation. The candidate classical extensions that have been proposed—superluminal causal influences, superdeterminism (the denial of measurement-setting freedom), and retrocausal explanations which avoid causal cycles—are all shown to require precisely such fine-tuning, and consequently to be unable to do justice to the explanatory challenge that Bell-violating correlations pose. Allen et al. then take up the positive side of this program, introducing a quantum counterpart to Reichenbach's principle and developing a formal program of quantum causal models which aim to provide exactly the generalized causal framework that the Wood-Spekkens diagnosis identifies as needed. The shared recognition across this literature is that the pattern of Bell-correlated outcomes is not merely an empirical puzzle but a signature of the need for what might be called a "quantum theory of causation"—one which handles these cases through some comprehensible structural principle beyond the classical triad, rather than leaving the correlations as a brute empirical fact[129].

   The wider principle, stated once. The coupling is one instance of a principle that runs through the whole framework and deserves its statement before the instances are catalogued.

   Principle 27 (Joint Invalidity in Place of Causation)
   A correlation between attributes, relative to an Aethus, is accounted for not by a mechanism that connects them—no signal, no shared antecedent, no time order—but by the joint invalidity, relative to that Aethus, of the combinations the correlation excludes: the postulates prune the jointly invalid combinations from the Aethus-valued superposition, the surviving combinations carry the weights the Quantum Nexus or the standing books assign, and the coupling among the survivors is the correlation. "A causes B" is thereby re-read as "$\{A, \neg B\}$ is jointly invalid relative to the Aethus," a statement with no direction and no mechanism in it, which is why it survives where the causal readings—A to B, B to A, common cause—each fail by fine-tuning. The principle's title names its limiting case, and the general form should be stated beside it, since a correlation need not exclude any combination at all: two binary attributes at weights $0.4, 0.1, 0.1, 0.4$ *are strongly correlated with every combination valid. What accounts for such a correlation is the* joint

[129]The convergence with Spekkens's broader program here is particularly notable given the discussion in Section 10.3.1, where I address Spekkens's explicit call for "an exotic form of causality and inference, but logically realist causality and inference nonetheless" [6, 7, 102], as well as my response that the Aethic structure is intended to satisfy precisely this criterion.

coupling*: the structure of joint invalidity, which fixes which combinations can stand together, and the weights the Aethus assigns across the combinations that can, a zero weight alone not making a combination structurally invalid. So the general re-reading represents the dependence between A and B by their induced marginal coupling, supported in the presentation by a chain of entry-factors, with the joint invalidity of a combination as its deterministic case; a low joint weight on* $\{A, \neg B\}$ *is not by itself dependence, two independent events of weights* 0.001 *and* 0.5 *giving* 0.0005 *to that cell, and no weight table identifies a direction or an intervention response, which belong to a supplied mechanism history. The principle might as exactly be titled* joint coupling in place of causation*, and the Newcomb treatment of paragraph 4.7.4, whose imperfect predictor leaves its mismatch configurations at weight* ε *rather than none, uses the general form.*

Two readings attach to the principle and should be kept together. The first is the *predetermination per Aethus* of Section 2.5, understood in its geometric sense—the block fixed along its own proper-time direction, not the Aethic sequence: relative to any one Aethus, everything in its block conspires under the constraint that the block exists, and a correlation is what that conspiracy looks like from inside—not more determinism than the classical picture but more *visibility*, the pruning of joint combinations letting the per-branch consistency show through. The second is that the principle is what the third postulate's $\exists\forall$ quantifier is *for*: it quantifies over the whole refinement future of an Aethus at once, so that a combination excluded anywhere in that future is excluded now, and the exclusion needs no story about how the future reaches back—there is no reaching, only a joint invalidity that was there from the root.

Status. This reach belongs to the unweighted stepping stone. The completed postulate is the weighted-Aethus reduced form, whose proper children are the terms of a weighted Aethus (Definition 36); read over unrestricted refinement, the condition would reach from every root the Aethus whose content holds every item, which is invalid, and nothing would be valid (Proposition 13).

The most consequential instance: the agreeing region as a vacuum, not a sealed vault. The principle's sharpest application is to the question of what keeps the which-way information of an agreeing superposition from escaping, and here it corrects a reading the framework itself carried for four years. The natural picture—the one the author held from the August 2022 entry through 2025—is that quantum uncertainty is a positive force of concealment, something that actively keeps the record in. The February 2026 reading, which this paper adopts, is that no force is needed and none is posited. The region of spacetime in which an agreeing superposition's event occurs simply does not admit the passage of the distinguishing information out to any Aethus—not because something holds it, but as a *vacuum* in information passage—and the reason is the principle above. Were it possible for the information to pass out, so that some Aethus in the block, at any proper time past or future, could access it, the superposition would be *disagreeing* already, by the fundamental theorem, (Section 8): an agreeing superposition and an eventual access to its which-way record are jointly invalid, and the joint invalidity prunes the pair at the root. So the framework's cut between the two regimes falls exactly along the line "nothing in the block, past or future, ever accesses the region's information" on the agreeing side and "otherwise" on the disagreeing side, and it falls there by joint invalidity alone. The predetermination reading gives the same fact its other face: relative to its own Aethus, the agreeing superposition already carries "no Aethus in this block accesses the region" as content, since its weight under the Nexus was assigned to a cluster from which the access-bearing combinations had been pruned—the superposition does not *keep* anyone out; the combinations in which someone was let in were never valid members of its Aethus. No causality is required at any step, and none is available: what would have been a causal story about concealment is a fact about which configurations are jointly invalid with access. This is also what the irretrievability trigger, (the fifth of the Open Constructions, Section 14.8), now asks for: not the mechanism by which records are kept in, which does not exist, but the exact conditions under which a configuration is jointly invalid with any eventual access—the shape of the answer being in hand, and its conditions the open construction. And the replacement should be classified for what it is. It is a change in the framework's *input*—in the physical description of the record sector that the postulates are applied to—and not in the framework: the three postulates and the axiomatic structure they define are exactly what they were in May 2023, in the way that revising one's account of a situation's stress–energy tensor leaves the field equations of general relativity untouched. The pruning was always the pruning; what was corrected is the description of what it prunes.

The Aethic framework now takes up this mantle on two distinct fronts. First, in the narrow sense, it provides precisely such a theory of causation: the reduced form coupling accounts for the correlations through comprehensible deduction from the Aethic postulates, with no primitive appeal to anything beyond the third-postulate pruning operating over the joint space of stated-attributes. The causal picture offered is not classical—"A causes B", "B causes A", and "common cause" are all inadequate—but it is nonetheless structurally intelligible, with the coupling being sourced neither by signal exchange nor by shared antecedent but by the validity-preserving pruning of joint configurations which would otherwise produce contradictions in some eventual child Aethus. This is, in a specific sense, the realist theory of quantum causation which the Wood-Spekkens and Allen-et-al. programs have pointed toward but which those programs themselves largely take as a target to be mathematically formalized rather than ontologically grounded. Aethic reasoning's contribution is to supply the ontological grounding. Second, in the broader sense, this Aethic theory of causation is *not* limited to the special case where the coupling weights arise from probability amplitudes, the Born rule, and the dual-path structure of the Quantum Nexus integral. It can, in principle, be run on any Aethae whatsoever using the third postulate, with the coupling weights being whatever the Aethic context of the system specifies. The only catch here is that quantum particles are at present one of the very few empirically established ways to definitively force the kind of coupling that gives the mechanism experimental traction—but this is a practical limitation of our engineering access to suitable coupling regimes, not a principled restriction on the mechanism itself.

As an illustrative case of this generality, consider the supercomputer-and-coin-flip configuration treated in Section 9.7.4. In that scenario, the reduced form coupling is the load-bearing mechanism that allows the supercomputer's predictive near-certainty to be preserved even against genuinely random agent strategies. The coupling forces agreement between the prediction of the supercomputer in the proper-time past and the outcome of the coin flip in the proper-time present, with the configurations where prediction and action fail to match being pruned by the third postulate on the grounds that the agent would otherwise detect the predictor's error upon opening the boxes. What makes this case a particularly clean illustration of the generalization at hand is that the coupling proceeds over agent-decision and predictor-prediction weights rather than over Feynman amplitudes, while still exhibiting precisely the pattern that the Wood-Spekkens analysis identified as requiring fine-tuning under any classical causal story—"A causes B" (the prediction causing the outcome), "B causes A" (retrocausation from the outcome to the prediction), and "common cause" (some shared antecedent of both) are all inadequate as accounts of the prediction-matches-action correlation in this configuration, and yet the Aethic framework supplies a structurally comprehensible explanation through the same reduced form coupling mechanism that handles Bell correlations themselves. The Newcomb coin-flip is, in this sense, one of the cleanest places where the convergence with the Spekkens program becomes operationally visible outside of the Feynman-weighted regime: the reduced form coupling provides the exotic-but-realist causal substrate which the Wood-Spekkens / Allen et al. framework calls for, applied here to a decision-theoretic rather than purely quantum setting. There could well be other Aethic configurations, not yet isolated empirically, in which reduced form coupling is deployed over still further non-quantum weights to produce analogous correlations across causally-disjoint events—the Newcomb case is one tractable instance of a much wider regime that the framework predicts but has not yet been engineered to a state of experimental access.

7. *The smoking-lesion family of medical Newcomb problems, resolved by joint invalidity rather than by causal structure.* The smoking lesion is decision theory's standard discriminating case, the home ground of the tickle-defense literature [103] and of the medical Newcomb problems more broadly [104]: a lesion causes both a taste for smoking and cancer, smoking itself causes nothing, and evidential reasoning notoriously counsels abstention, since choosing to smoke is bad news about the lesion. The Aethic resolution is a direct—indeed almost trivial—application of the reduced form coupling, and it dissolves the case's apparent dependence on causal structure entirely. Track the reasoner's Aethus through its Bayesian string: the initial state multiplied by successive stated-attribute updates, each update a multiplication, a pruning, and a renormalization, with every "this case versus that case" analysis being nothing but the distributive unpacking of an $(\alpha A + (1-\alpha)B)$ dichotomy multiplied against the whole system. Then: (1a) if the desire to smoke is itself already stated in the Aethus, the update has already happened—under perfect correlation, deductive closure states the lesion outright, and smoking or abstaining moves nothing;

under looser correlation the stated desire reweights the lesion superposition interpolatively, and the act itself is again idle. This is the tickle defense's conclusion, here derived from the state's stated content rather than from psychological introspection. (1b) If the desire is not yet stated, it sits in disagreeing superposition, weighted by whatever distribution the Aethus licenses—the population baseline intersected with however many further specificities the reasoner's history has stated, be they regional statistics or a physician's twenty-percent estimate. Averaged over that superposition, the brute probability masses do say exactly what the correlational projection says: choosing to smoke sorts the reasoner into the residue pocket in which the lesion is likelier. But—and this is the coupling doing the work—the correlation is a lossy averaging projection over the whole disagreeing superposition, and it breaks inside the pocket: having to be in the smokers' pocket prunes, relative to that pocket, the non-lesion further pockets, the joint invalidities firing off directly, so the within-pocket structure is fixed by who makes whom invalid in which residue via pruning, and by nothing else. (2) If the lesion's very existence is itself unstated, the whole of (1) simply runs inside the lesion-exists branch of one further superposition, the lesion-absent branch being trivial. The moral deserves stating baldly, because it is this catalog's thesis in its purest instance: "causality" here is a human construct laid over the mechanism; "correlation" is the construct's lossy shadow at the level of averages; and the reduced form coupling is the thing that actually creates what the construct was naming—the celebrated common cause was never the operative structure at all.

What I find particularly notable about this catalog is that the seven appearances span multiple distinct conceptual domains—quantum foundations, classical Bayesian inference, and decision theory most immediately, with the speculative extension to consciousness-adjacent phenomena noted in the footnote—and yet each is structurally an instance of the same Aethic operation. The only differences between them are the identities of the coupled attributes, the weights governing the coupling, and the proper-time configuration of the setup. In each case, what appears locally as a puzzling correlation—whether it be Bell-violating nonlocality, retrocausal pattern selection, cross-observer measurement agreement, Bayesian conditional probability, or prediction-matches-action consistency—turns out to be the same structural phenomenon exhibited under different surface features. This is perhaps the strongest argument for the reduced form coupling's having earned its status as a general Aethic consideration rather than a domain-specific technical device: a mechanism which unifies this many apparently disparate phenomena with a single procedural operation seems unlikely to be incidental to the framework's architecture.

Importantly, and perhaps worth marking explicitly, is the methodological direction by which this unification arose. The reduced form itself was not defined with the goal of producing such a unification—it was defined procedurally, as the supremum by Aethic parentage of the set of proper child Aethae for which all further proper child Aethae are valid, simply because that is what the third postulate structurally requires when expressed in the positive direction. The coupling is a side-effect of this procedural definition, in the sense that once the reduced form eliminates joint combinations containing further-descendant contradictions, the correlation between the surviving combinations is left behind as a structural residue. That this residue then turns out to reproduce entanglement, delayed choice [10], the powerset classification of multi-slit outcomes, (Theorem 14), Wigner's friend consistency [30], the Bayesian shift in the Monty Hall [99] configuration, and the Newcomb coin-flip resolution—all without any of these having been built in as targeted explananda—is a point worth pausing on, because it reveals something about the shape of the framework that the individual treatments of each phenomenon do not. If reduced form coupling were engineered to handle each of these cases individually, the unification would amount to a convenient bookkeeping result. Because reduced form coupling instead fell out of a definition given for independent reasons and only subsequently turned out to handle all of these cases, the unification is more plausibly tracking a real structural feature of the underlying ontology than it is reflecting a post-hoc convenience of the framework's construction.

In this sense, the reduced form coupling may be viewed as the framework's unification engine in compressed form. It is the single procedural operation through which the third postulate's "checkmate" pruning expresses itself as attribute-level correlation, and it is the correlation structure that the framework then recognizes across domains that standard physics, standard statistics, and standard decision theory have treated as disjoint. The compactness of this expression—the fact that so many phenomena fall out of a single definition that is itself only one deductive move away from the postulates—is what grants the reduced form coupling its claim to ontological fundamentality, as distinct from the derivative status that quantum entanglement and related phenomena have occupied in the comprehensible-ontology layer of standard foundations. And, I suspect, as the framework is

developed further, more instances of reduced form coupling will continue to be recognized in domains that appear initially unrelated to the ones catalogued here—each one being, as with the cases above, merely a new configuration of the same underlying Aethic operation, varying only in the particular attributes being coupled and the weighting structure that the coupling carries.

6.7 Weighted Aethus-Formulation of the Aethic Reduced Form

The following is a formalization I thought of[130] *on May 16, 2026, and wrote up for this paper directly thereafter. It also serves as a proposed alternative method of defining proper child Aethae from the supposition earlier on in this paper.*

Structurally, this section is organized in two layers. The first, "unweighted/intrinsic" layer constructs the universe set U of unweighted Aethae and its commutative semiring structure, inheriting its foundations directly from the Aethic attribute apparatus developed earlier in the paper. The second, "weighted/extrinsic" layer then builds the Aethic tree T as a customizable measure-weighted superstructure over U, equipped with an equivalence relation that re-imports the graph-theoretic content of the intrinsic layer back into its algebra. The motivation for this split is that the structural content carried by Aethic attributes themselves—being a) the ways in which joint/intersected attributes may be rewritten as alternative attributes encoding the same information (e.g., "square" versus "rhombus ∩ rectangle"), and b) which specific intersections of attributes are tagged as invalid Aethae—is foundational to the unweighted layer, with the weighted layer then layering an additional structural degree of freedom over it without changing the underlying carrier operations; the weights do affect which components count as proper children, and therefore which continuations the third postulate quantifies over, which is the intended feature.

The Unweighted/Intrinsic Layer

Aethic attributes as foundational carriers. Recall that an Aethic attribute, as developed earlier in the paper, plays the role of abstracting an event or property in the real world into an abstract Aethus-relative possibility among alternatives—effectively a contingent truth customized for the Aethic ontological setting. Examples range from simple Boolean predicates such as "the right slit was traversed" to scalar quantities with associated dimensional units such as "the mass density at this position in spacetime is…". The semantic character of any given attribute is meant to be exhaustively carried by the attribute itself, but is impractical to write down in full—which is precisely why this carried structure is taken as intrinsic to the attribute rather than externally specified.

The two specific structural contents carried intrinsically by an Aethic attribute, and inherited by the unweighted layer constructed in this section, are:

(a) The ways in which a given collection of jointly-asserted (i.e., Aethically-intersected) attributes may be rewritten as arbitrary alternative collections of attributes encoding precisely the same information structure—no more and no less—as illustrated by, for example, "square" versus "rhombus ∩ rectangle".

(b) Which specific intersections of attributes are *tagged* as invalid Aethae. Note that in both the unweighted layer of this section and the weighted layer to follow, invalidity is operationally a mere tag rather than a directly realized empirical property of the Aethus; the empirical forbidding of an invalid Aethus from being realized as an observer's informational state is supplied subsequently as a hypotheses non fingo [71]-style injected realization principle that is not itself derived from within the formalism.

What the mathematical formalization of an Aethic attribute is meant to capture is exactly this intrinsic compatibility structure across other attributes (points (a) and (b) above), while deliberately shedding direct conceptual identification with the attribute's semantic instantiation in the world[131].

[130] Funnily enough, I thought of this formalization while lying down in the bathtub of my house, thinking about trying to make Aethic weights intrinsic to weighted Aethae while making proper child Aethae extrinsic to arbitrary linear combinations. The sensory visual that came to mind during this (not in a load-bearing sense per se, but just as an accompanying kind of vector art-like monochrome symbol which randomly popped into my mind while I was weighing the idea of splitting to two Aethic trees) thought process was a kind of fleur-de-lis but with the sides pointed up, where the central shaft corresponds to the unweighted Aethic tree (U), and the full figure corresponds to the Aethic tree itself (T).

[131] An autobiographical analogy that motivated this stance: just as modern mathematics retains the deductive apparatus of Euclid's *Elements*—its Postulates, Common Notions, and the body of theorems built upon them—while shedding the

Let us consider the prospect of defining an arbitrary "universe set" of Aethae, which is implicitly constructed with conditions as opposed to having to actually contain all possible Aethae. This is perhaps analogous to how there is a "universal set" for a given set-theoretic methodology, without having to enforce all "possible" sets being contained in such. We will construct this as follows.

Definition 35 (Universe Set of Aethae)
We may construct a given universe set, U, of Aethae, given the following two steps.

1. *First, we construct an arbitrary "**generator set**", G, of unweighted Aethae. Importantly, we are to base this on the fundamental idea that for every pair of unweighted Aethae $a, b \in G$, such an a and b ought to have a "last common ancestor Aethus" in each of their intrinsic unweighted Aethic trees—being simply their standard Aethic union itself. This is, as opposed to the construction where each has an independent Aethic tree altogether. (The idea is no longer a premise: the intrinsic lattice of Section 3.2 gives every pair of Aethae a last common ancestor, the core of their Aethic union (Proposition 12), so a universe set U constructed here is a* working *universe U_G inside that lattice, generated from G and closed under the operations the algebra needs, and it inherits the lattice's order with the same meets and joins—parent closure supplying the core of $a \cup b$, which is a parent of a, and intersection closure supplying $a \cap b$. Its generators are Aethae of that lattice, invalid ones kept as distinct tagged terms (Section 4.4).) Note that the trivial cases, however, are that $a = b$, for which case their last common ancestor is itself, and that they share no stated-attributes in any of each of their static Aethae, in which case their last common ancestor is the canonical "Null Aethus", which is formally defined as the unweighted Aethus equivalent to an empty static Aethus (i.e., the static Aethus containing no stated-attributes), and which is itself a primitive unweighted Aethus. Notice that such an unweighted Aethic union over which this last common ancestor is gathered is itself the static-Aethus-defined Aethic union of the 2024 presentation. For this newer construction we will inherit this premise, but not that presentation's unweighted Aethic intersection. Fundamentally speaking, note that on account of the definition of parent Aethae through static Aethae—that is, that Aethus a is a parent to Aethus b if there exists a static Aethus a_0 to a and a static Aethus b_0 to b for which a_0 is a subset of b_0—we therefore have that the set of parent Aethae to each $a \in G$ is fully deductively intrinsic to that a, with the Aethic union premises themselves being dependent on G on account of asking which branch points in those intrinsic-parentage Aethic trees happen to be referenced by any pairs of elements in G.*

2. *Next, we construct the "**universe set**", U, of that generator set as the its set closure under the following two conditions.*

   (a) *G is a subset of U.*
   $$G \subset U \tag{52}$$

   (b) *For any $a \in U$, if b is a parent Aethus to a, then $b \in U$.*

   We additionally require closure under Aethic intersection: for any $a, b \in U$, their intrinsic Aethic intersection is in U — tagged (invalid) combinations included, standing as elements — and the hyperinvalid Aethus, as the all-statements state, is adjoined explicitly: being a child of everything, it is reached neither by parent-closure (which climbs upward only) nor by intersection over the generator vocabulary, so its membership is a clause rather than a consequence; once adjoined, both semiring identities hold ($x + \mathrm{Hyp} = x$ by the all-statements static Aethus intersecting into any representative of x; $x \cdot \mathrm{Hyp} = \mathrm{Hyp}$ by construction), and it is itself tagged, harmlessly, its identity role being algebraic rather than validity-theoretic. U is then given the structure of a commutative semiring: addition is the unweighted Aethic union; multiplication is the intrinsic Aethic intersection simpliciter*, jointness-disallowed combinations included, which stand in U as tagged Aethae rather than collapsing — invalidity rides as a tag on the standing carrier — with the additive identity being the hyperinvalid Aethus (multiplicatively absorbing by construction: Aethic intersection with the all-statements static Aethus returns it) and the multiplicative identity*

specific ontological characterizations Euclid attempted in the Definitions of Book I, notably Definition 1 ("A point is that which has no part") and Definition 2 ("A line is breadthless length"), the Aethic attribute formalism retains the compatibility-structure content of the attribute while shedding direct conceptual equivalence with the semantic version of the attribute as it would appear in the world. Hilbert's later axiomatization of geometry makes this stance fully explicit by leaving "point" and "line" as undefined primitives, characterized only by their relations under the axioms. The recommended slogan: keep the structural content; let the ontological characterizations fall away.

the Null Aethus; both are placed in the generating set before the closure is taken, since an arbitrary generator set need not generate either, the Null Aethus being the parent of every generator and not a product or union of any. Two structural remarks.

First remark: the closure condition is necessary. First, the closure condition is necessary, and the shortcut it replaces fails without it: an earlier formulation piecewise-replaced out-of-universe intersections by the hyperinvalid Aethus, under which distributivity breaks (with three pairwise attribute-disjoint generators, $a \cdot (b + c) = a \cdot \text{Null} = a$ while both products on the right piecewise-collapse, the failure being purely the not-in-U replacement).

Second remark: distributivity, stated explicitly. Second, with closure in place, distributivity of intersection over union on the closed universe is stated as an explicit hypothesis — Hypothesis (D) — holding for attribute systems governed by classical consequence (the filter lattice of a Boolean algebra) and priced as a hypothesis in general — noting that the tag ruling simplifies its status outright: with tags invisible to deductive closure, invalidity bears on neither operation, so the discharge for classical consequence reduces to the pure theory-lattice question, the non-Boolean case being the only remaining price — "classical consequence" meaning the disjointness-excised (positive) fragment, since axiomatizing value-disjointness in the consequence relation itself would explode tagged static Aethae classically against the standing-carriers construction, and the positive fragment's Lindenbaum algebra remains a distributive lattice — a review-proposed discharge of the entire classical case being recorded here (the two operations as meet and join of the Lindenbaum filter lattice, distributive whenever the consequence relation's lattice is), its verification assigned to independent checking, with the non-distributive residual — quantum logic's signature — resolved by the author's ruling: the framework imports quantum mechanics' time-aspect ontology and strictly not quantum logic's nonclassicality, whose generator is the agreeing superposition written into the logic; agreeing superpositions here are state content of the co-obtaining regime, the weighted addition is disagreeing-superposition-valued, and the attribute logic stays classical, (D)'s hypothesis being a classicality condition the framework independently endorses; associativity, by contrast, is immediate under the ruling, every partial product standing in U by closure with the groupings agreeing by the intrinsic associativity of intersection (set-theoretic union at the static-Aethus level).

The Weighted/Extrinsic Layer

Lastly, we define a corresponding "Aethic tree"[132] to this universe set of Aethae, which is taken as bijectively correspondent to the tuple of a given Aethus universe set U and measure-theoretic measure type[133] M, which itself will be the formal generalization of real-valued Aethic weights.

What the generalization is, and is not. The character of this generalization deserves explicit statement: it is not that an Aethus *gets* a measure—rather, an accompanying object carrying a measure attaches to the Aethus per whatever construction one selects, with the original real-valued weights remaining the base case. The purpose of going beyond the reals at all is to retain gradations that the reals collapse: zero weight, null-set presence, null-set presence within a null set, and so on through whatever iterated stratification a given model demands, (in the spirit of non-Archimedean probability [105]). This is particularly suited to the self-similarity property of Aethic invalidity under the third postulate—the very property by which the inheritance paradox of Oliver's Aethus, (Principle 3), was resolved in the first place—and it leaves the reduced form natively prepared for fractal-dimension-style weight structure should an application ever demand it.

The algebraic stipulation on M. For the constructions of this section to go through as stated, M is stipulated a commutative semiring with unit — the products serving T's multiplication, the unit embedding the unweighted layer as weight-one terms, and M-distributivity with 0-annihilation serving the multiplication-congruence discharge noted below — with two further default stipulations and one definition on its additive side, customizations layering over them: the *algebraic* (difference) order on M ($\nu \leq \mu$ iff $\mu = \nu + \lambda$ for some $\lambda \in M$); additive *cancellativity*, so that the residues the definitions below

[132] Forward-looking note for any potential future categorical translation: morphisms between Aethic trees would most naturally be taken as graph-theoretically structure-preserving maps on the underlying unweighted layer U, with the externally-imposed weight assignments from M transported covariantly rather than treated as fixed structure to preserve. The measure structure is peripheral in the sense that it does not exist on G or U themselves, but is externally imposed only in constructing T; correspondingly, it is not validity-preserving either, since validity is itself a label assigned pre-realization rather than a structural property preserved under structural maps.

[133] For instance, the Lebesgue measure restricted to its finite values; the cancellativity stipulation below confines M to the finite cone, $\infty + 1 = \infty + 2$ being the standard counterexample.

consume exist within the order and are unique, licensing difference notation (coefficient well-definedness itself needs no cancellativity, being a standard fact of the monoid semiring $M[U]$ that T is identified as below); and *zerosumfreeness* (no two nonzero elements summing to zero), which with cancellativity is equivalent to antisymmetry of the algebraic order — earning the order vocabulary — and forbids nontrivial inverses outright, the positive cone being thereby derived (all of M under the algebraic order) rather than imposed. Importantly, beyond these the precise algebraic structure on M is left deliberately customizable across this section, so as to permit the framing of alternative "sub-Aethus theories" which may impose additional axioms or constraints on the measure structure for specific empirical or theoretical purposes; and, like any theory of the transfinite beyond $\aleph_0$, none of this stratification is load-bearing for the foundational results—it is capacity held in reserve.

What counts as the foundational theory. The "foundational" Aethic theory of this paper consists of the three Aethic postulates together with the tag-to-realization convention discussed below, with any additional axioms or specializations on M being understood as constituting their own respective sub-theories.

For such an Aethic tree, we define its associating, custom "Aethus type", each of which is given as bijective to a given measure type M which serves as its canonical Aethic weight-type, (as opposed to the standard real-valued weight of "standard" weighted Aethae alone). The set of such Aethae corresponding to Aethic tree T defined over Aethus universe set U and measure type M is given as the set of all addition-based linear combinations of unweighted Aethae in U whose respective weights come from terms of M. Every possible such additive combination of elements from U and terms from M has a representation, as opposed to having to intrinsically enforce an element from U to always associate with the same term from U, (so, if you will, each term of M is not explicitly measuring something intrinsic about its given attached element from U, but rather is externally imposed upon it as if a separate structural degree of freedom). The sum of elements of T is a construction which is bijective to the set of sets consisting of tuples between an element in U and a term of M, (that is, as opposed to defining the aforementioned Aethus type of M as a tuple of an element from U and a term of M directly, because such elements are strictly a proper subset of elements in T because arbitrary sums of elements in T are not reducible to rescalings by elements in M of elements in U).

The equivalence relation importing graph structure from U into T. We now define the precise equivalence relation over T by which the graph-theoretic content of the unweighted/intrinsic layer is re-imported into the additive structure of the weighted/extrinsic layer. This is the axiom that is quotiented out of formal M-weighted linear combinations of elements of U so as to actually constitute T itself.

Suppose we are given unweighted Aethae $A, B \in U$ together with measure-valued weights $a, b \in M$, so as to form the weighted sum $aA + bB \in T$. Let $C \in U$ denote the last common ancestor of A and B in the unweighted parent-child Aethus graph, which by construction is given by the unweighted Aethic union $C = A \cup B$. By the parent-child structure of U under its multiplicative (i.e., piecewise Aethic intersection) operation, there then exist unweighted Aethae $C_A, C_B \in U$ such that

$$A = C_A \cdot C, \qquad B = C_B \cdot C, \tag{53}$$

where the C_A and C_B are the unweighted Aethae encoding the additional specifying information that distinguishes A and B from their shared parent C, respectively. Solutions to $y \cdot C = A$ are not unique as Aethae — $y = A$ itself always solves the equation, and mixed solutions exist besides — so C_A is fixed as the *coarsest* solution: the unweighted Aethic union of all solutions, the co-Heyting–style difference of A by C read at the parent end of the order. Existence: under Hypothesis (D), the union of two solutions is a solution ($(y + y') \cdot C = y \cdot C + y' \cdot C = A$), so the solution set is join-closed and possesses a coarsest element in the finite case, general existence being a booked lemma. Coarsest-ness is also exactly what makes the degenerate case below come out right: for $A = C$, the Null Aethus solves the equation and is coarsest overall, while for $A \neq C$ it fails the equation ($\text{Null} \cdot C = C \neq A$) and is correctly excluded. (In rich logics the canonical difference is the implication-residue: in the counterexample above, $\text{Cl}\{p \to q\}$ rather than $\text{Cl}\{q\}$, since $q \vdash p \to q$ makes the former strictly coarser.)

The equivalence relation defining T consists of two collectively exhaustive and mutually exclusive cases for the weighted sum $aA + bB$ of unweighted Aethae $A, B \in U$ with measure-valued weights $a, b \in M$, partitioned by whether the LCA decomposition (with $C = A \cup B$, $A = C_A \cdot C$, $B = C_B \cdot C$) yields $C_A \neq C_B$ or $C_A = C_B$:

Case 1 ($C_A \neq C_B$):

$$aA + bB \;\equiv\; C \cdot (aC_A + bC_B)\,. \tag{54}$$

Case 2 ($C_A = C_B$):

$$aC + bC \;\equiv\; (a+b)C. \tag{55}$$

These two cases are mutually exclusive by definition (since they partition on whether C_A and C_B are equal as Aethae) and collectively exhaustive (since every weighted sum admits one or the other under the LCA decomposition). Notice that, under the definition $C = A \cup B$, the second case occurs only when C_A and C_B are each the Null Aethus—and equivalently only when $A = B = C$. This is because $C_A = C_B$ immediately forces $A = C_A \cdot C = C_B \cdot C = B$, so $C = A \cup A = A$, and then $A = C_A \cdot A$ forces C_A to be the multiplicative identity of U—namely, the Null Aethus. The three conditions "$C_A = C_B$", "$A = B$", and "both C_A and C_B equal the Null Aethus" are therefore equivalent under this construction.

The intuition behind Case 1 is that it is precisely the distributive property of the commutative semiring T applied at the level of unweighted Aethae substituted via their LCA decomposition. Since $A = C_A \cdot C$ and $B = C_B \cdot C$ as Aethae in U, distributivity gives

$$aA + bB \;=\; a\,(C_A \cdot C) + b\,(C_B \cdot C) \;=\; C \cdot (aC_A + bC_B)\,,$$

which is exactly the content of the equivalence.

Case 2. Case 2 is the corresponding requirement that repeated scalar multiplications by the same unweighted Aethus combine additively—a and b "applied to the same C" should yield a single weight $(a + b)$ on C, as opposed to remaining as a formal sum of two separate weighted copies—and notably is not derivable from Case 1, since Case 1 does not apply when $C_A = C_B$. Even formally substituting $C_A = C_B =$ Null Aethus into the right-hand side of Case 1 would yield $C \cdot (a \cdot (\text{Null Aethus}) + b \cdot (\text{Null Aethus})) = aC + bC$, returning the expression to itself rather than reducing it to $(a + b)C$.

Case 1 as a derived identity, not a quotient clause. Case 1, on inspection, is no imposition at all: with multiplication on T taken as the bilinear extension of the intrinsic Aethic intersection (products evaluated at the unweighted layer, descent to the quotient the booked congruence obligation), its right side evaluates to its left — $aA + bB = a\,(C_A \cdot C) + b\,(C_B \cdot C) = C\,(a\,C_A + b\,C_B)$ — *basic factoring*, the last common ancestor extracted once as a common factor. It stands, therefore, as a derived identity rather than a quotient clause, and the earlier gloss of the quotient as preventing double-counting is retired with it: nothing is prevented.

Two dividends. Two dividends follow at once: T under the shrunk quotient is exactly the monoid semiring $M[U]$ of finitely supported functions $U \to M$ (collect like terms, delete zeros; the bilinear product their convolution), so normal forms and coefficient well-definedness are the standard facts of that classical construction; and the multiplication congruence discharges outright from M's semiring stipulation — M-distributivity handles the collapse clause termwise, 0-annihilation the deletion clause — the shrunk quotient never touching the unweighted lattice, so no appeal to the distributivity hypothesis occurs in the check. At the base case of real weights, further, the reduced form is the valid-support truncation of the combination, and the properness of the invalidity congruence is witnessed by evaluation at the blank coefficient — the review-verified base-case discharges; the properness discharge is since *general*: for any nontrivial measure type, evaluation at the blank is a semiring homomorphism into M whose kernel contains the invalidity congruence, with the weighted Null Aethus evaluating to $1 \neq 0$ and exhibiting non-totality — the argument displayed here, same-family-verified and flagged for the independent skim, the base case its instance.

The deletion convention. Imposing Case 2 together with the zero-term deletion convention is what causes the formal M-linear combinations of elements of U to actually constitute the commutative semiring T — the quotient is exactly same-Aethus additive collapse plus zero-term deletion, the factorization content living upstream as an identity, through which the parent–child graph re-enters the weighted layer. The deletion convention: terms of weight zero are deletable, needed because the collapse clause alone never sheds a zero term ($0 \cdot C + \mu A$ with $A \neq C$ hitting the irreducible parent–child fixed point discussed below), with the additive identity 0_T of T being the empty combination.

An illustrative sub-case worth highlighting falls under Case 1 when one of A, B is itself a parent of the other—for example, the expression $aA + cC$ where $A = C_A \cdot C$, so that C is a parent of A. Here the LCA of A and C is simply C itself, with the LCA decomposition of the second term being trivially $C = (\text{Null Aethus}) \cdot C$. Substituting into Case 1 yields

$$aA + cC \;\equiv\; C \cdot (aC_A + c \cdot (\text{Null Aethus}))\,,$$

which is not further reducible: attempting to apply Case 1 recursively to $aC_A + c \cdot (\text{Null Aethus})$ would yield LCA = Null Aethus, and the resulting decomposition would return the same expression as a

fixed point. This is structurally correct—the parent-child sub-case captures a weighted disagreeing superposition between a parent and one of its children that genuinely cannot be flattened further, and the equivalence relation correctly leaves it in this canonical form.

This equivalence relation is what re-imports the graph-theoretic structure of U into the algebra of T: the LCA appears explicitly in Case 1 as the factored-out shared parent, and the formal M-weighted sums thereby inherit the parent-child Aethus structure of U rather than remaining freely-combinable. It also clarifies a point of potential confusion: while the addition on T is denoted by "+" and is structurally analogous to the unweighted Aethic union "$\cup$" on U (both combine elements via the parent-child graph), the two operations are *not the same operation*. The union $\cup$ on U collapses any pair of unweighted Aethae to a single unweighted Aethus, while the addition on T preserves weight information by routing all algebraic reductions through the LCA-based cases above. The notational overlap is one of role rather than of identity, and the operations should not be conflated.

Multiplication on T. Multiplication on T is defined by applying the distributive property over the additive linear combinations defining its elements, and then inheriting the multiplication of unweighted Aethae case-by-case from the multiplication on U (i.e., the piecewise Aethic intersection defined earlier). Explicitly, for $x = \sum_i \mu_i a_i$ and $y = \sum_j \nu_j b_j$ in T, with each $a_i, b_j \in U$ and each $\mu_i, \nu_j \in M$,

$$x \cdot y \;=\; \sum_{i,j} (\mu_i \nu_j)\,(a_i \cdot_U b_j)\,, \tag{56}$$

where $\mu_i \nu_j$ denotes multiplication in M and $a_i \cdot_U b_j$ denotes the multiplication on U. The equivalence relation on T then ensures that the result is well-defined modulo the last-common-ancestor identifications imposed earlier. Distributivity of multiplication over addition on T, as is required for T to constitute a commutative semiring, follows from this definition essentially by construction.

What is fundamentally important about all of this is that when taking an arbitrary sum of weighted Aethae in T, the mechanism by which such a sum is algebraically reducible to a special graph-theoretic core capturing the respective Aethic superposition content—as opposed to an arbitrarily-definable sum without such innate constraints—is precisely that which forces the graph-theoretic structure upon which the third postulate of the Aethus is dependent, despite in the process allowing notational representation by mere algebraic sums.

Weighted proper child Aethae and the reduced form. Importantly, now, since we have the set, T, of elements in the given Aethic tree, we must also see about constructing their correct acyclic graph structure itself in terms of what constitutes proper child Aethae. The construction of this section will use strictly proper child Aethae for the edges without reference to Aethic unions, since Aethic unions were already used to define the intrinsic static Aethus-based graph structure of elements in G alone. A terminological disambiguation governs this construction: a *child* Aethus is a multiplicative notion — B is a child of A iff $B = A \cdot C$ for some Aethus C, information added by intersection, the reflexive and transitive descent relation of the earlier sections — while a *proper child* Aethus is an additive notion, a *term of the linear combination*, at its full weight in it and that weight not measure-zero relative to the rest (Definition 36), with all proper children being children — discharged outright: the ancestor core of a combination's support (the informational union, deductively closed hence an Aethus; in U by closure under binary joins for finite support, while for an infinite admissible support the join is an additional closure requirement the admissible support class must state, the construction closing under binary joins only, and parent-closure neither required nor available) is a parent of every carrier, each carrier satisfying $A_i = C \cdot A_i$ since the core's content is contained in each carrier's, any factor sufficing.

Definition 36 (Weighted Proper Child Aethus)
A given unweighted Aethus $a \in U$ is a component of $x \in T$ with weight ω *if and only if $x \neq 0_T$ and $x = \mu a + b$ with $\mu = w \neq 0$, w being a's coefficient in the total x — the reported coefficient, which within a fixed free-sum representation is a's normal-form coefficient, the largest amount of a extractable from that sum, the supremum convention of the note below read there, its agreement across different admissible expansions being a coherence condition this paper assumes wherever reported weights are used, as in the hypotheses of Theorem 9 — and ω recording μ against the remainder's weight $|b|$: $\omega = \mu/|x|$ where the measure type admits division, the coefficient relative to the parent's total by the Relational Weight Principle (Section 4.5), so that all components of a normalized decomposition carry weights summing to one; ω is a's* relative component weight *in x, and the probability with which a is realized is its weight in the validity quotient, ω renormalized over the valid components (Section 4.2),*

which agrees with ω itself when every component is valid and the declared coefficients are the weighting scheme's own; in a type without division the pair, up to common rescaling by a non-zero-divisor scalar, is the datum and no ratio is formed, the comparison below running on coefficients. The remainder b is what x carries beyond a. Its boolean reduction *is the relation the third postulate and the reduced form consume: a is a* proper child Aethus *of x, written $a \leq x$, the order of the Aethic tree, if and only if* some *admissible decomposition $x = \mu a + b$ has its coefficient* not measure-zero relative to the remainder, *$\mu \not\ll |b|$ in the strict relative-negligibility relation $\ll$ of the measure type, the relation defined existentially over the admissible decompositions, which compose, so that no closure is taken and no step is privileged (where $|x|$ is invertible, scale covariance with $|x|^{-1}$ and back with $|x|$ gives $\mu \not\ll |b|$ iff $\omega \not\ll 1 - \omega$); and a is a* proper child Aethus of x with weight ω, *written $a \leq_\omega x$, if and only if $a \leq x$ with component weight ω. Where $\mu \ll |b|$, a is a component of x with its weight and no proper child Aethus of x; proper childhood selects the components whose coefficients are not relatively negligible, their weights summing, where normalization is defined, to one less the negligible share. The condition is comparative, and it is the one the framework means: that μ be scalar-positive is not enough, what is required is that μ be visible against the rest of the combination, so that a component carried at area grade against a volume-grade remainder is no proper child of x, however valid it is in itself, and the third postulate, which quantifies over proper children, is blind to that occurrence of it without invalidating it (the relative-measure-zero clause, unpacked below). At the base case $\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ the condition reads $\omega > 0$. The remainder b carries the rest of x and can be added back. There is no interval of weights: the weight is the supremum, unique, and an Aethus is its own proper child Aethus at full weight; the earlier reading, under which a could be taken as a proper child at any weight up to w, is withdrawn, the full weight alone being what the relation names.*[134]

Definition 37 (Composition property)
The measure type's relative-negligibility relation has the composition property *when visibility survives the composition of decompositions: if $x = \mu a + b$ with $\mu \not\ll |b|$ and $a \rightsquigarrow \nu d + e$ with $\nu \not\ll |e|$, then $\mu\nu \not\ll |\mu e + b|$ in the composed decomposition $x \rightsquigarrow \mu\nu\, d + (\mu e + b)$. At the base case $\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ it holds outright, a product of positive weights being positive; for other measure types it is an assumption, and the transitivity of proper childhood below rests on it.*

Transitivity, as a corollary. The weighted relation is reflexive and transitive, and at this level that is not a stipulation but a consequence of the definition just given. Reflexivity is the full weight: an Aethus is its own proper child at its supremum coefficient. For transitivity, let $a \leq_\omega x$ with coefficient μ, $x = \mu a + b$, and $d \leq_{\omega'} a$ with coefficient ν, $a \rightsquigarrow \nu d + e$, a declared decomposition of the carrier a and not an identity in T; composing it with the decomposition of x gives the declared decomposition $x \rightsquigarrow \mu\nu\, d + (\mu e + b)$, its expression computed by distributivity, compositions of admissible decompositions being admissible; since proper childhood is existential over them, this composed decomposition witnesses $d \leq x$ exactly when $\mu\nu \not\ll |\mu e + b|$, which the composition property of Definition 37 gives from $\mu \not\ll |b|$ and $\nu \not\ll |e|$. The reported coefficient enters only afterwards: where the coherence obligation is discharged, $\mu\nu$ bounds d's coefficient in x from below and $\mu e + b$ its remainder from above, and, where normalization is defined, d's weight in x is at least $\omega\omega'$, the chain rule of the conditional probabilities the weights are. Two resolutions are one resolution, transitivity being the composition of decompositions, and the unweighted case inherits it as the special case of full weights. This is the relation the canonical statement of the third postulate below runs on, so its quantifiers reach every proper child at every depth in a single application, and the pruning that defines the reduced form sees the whole cone beneath an Aethus at once.

At real weights, the cone generated by a fixed finite family of closure-independent carvings is a join-semilattice; its joins come from the pegs and the intrinsic operations of subsection 3.2, meets exist only for compatible fillings of positive weight, and a lattice is obtained only by adjoining an auxiliary bottom.

Theorem 9 (Visible partial-filling cones: a join-semilattice and its bottom-adjoined completion)
Work with nonnegative real weights. Let A be a nonzero carrier and $\mathcal{F}$ a fixed finite family of carvings (Definition 12) that A holds, of attributes $X_1, \ldots, X_m$, each into blocks, their declared decompositions composing and their coefficients coherent and additive. A partial filling *f chooses, for some of these*

[134] *October 4, 2026, 5:04 PM*
Also note that proper child with weight b strictly implies that b has to correspond to the supremum possible value of b indexing over the set of all possible choices of c and C for which A = b B + c C, note!
Also to be clear, the "weight" of a proper child Aethus then, to stay true to probability through the relational weight principle, should really be b/(b+c) once we identify this supremum b, right???

attributes, one block of its carving; its cell *is the carrier A_f obtained by adjoining to A the settings $[X_i : f(i)]$ for $i \in \operatorname{dom} f$, closed, with $A_\varnothing = A$; and its weight $w(f)$ is its coefficient in the composed decomposition of A by the carvings of $\operatorname{dom} f$, the sum of the weights of the finest cells extending f. Assume the carvings are* closure-independent*: for partial fillings f and g, the content of A_f is contained in that of A_g iff g extends f, so that $f \mapsto A_f$ is injective. Let $\mathcal{P}_A$ be the set of cells with $w(f) > 0$, the visible cells generated by composing carvings of $\mathcal{F}$, no other splitting being admitted in this construction. Then, under proper childhood:*

(i) every member of $\mathcal{P}_A$ is a proper child of A, and the proper children of A obtained from $\mathcal{F}$ are exactly the members of $\mathcal{P}_A$;

(ii) for $A_f, A_g \in \mathcal{P}_A$, $A_g \leq A_f$ iff g extends f;

(iii) any two members of $\mathcal{P}_A$ have a least upper bound in $\mathcal{P}_A$, the cell of their common sub-filling, $A_f \vee A_g = A_{f \cap g}$, the restriction of either to the attributes on which both are defined and agree, two cells of one carving joining at A; so $\mathcal{P}_A$ is a join-semilattice;

(iv) two members have a greatest lower bound in $\mathcal{P}_A$ exactly when f and g are compatible and $w(f \cup g) > 0$, and it is then their joint assertion, the intrinsic meet of What is ontological 11: $A_f \wedge A_g = A_{f \cup g} = A_f \cdot A_g$; otherwise no member of $\mathcal{P}_A$ lies below both, so $\mathcal{P}_A$ is not in general a lattice;

(v) adjoining a formal bottom $\perp$ below every member of $\mathcal{P}_A$ gives a lattice, the bottom-adjoined completion; the bottom is an order-theoretic auxiliary, not a carrier, not a proper child of A, and not a continuation over which the third postulate quantifies, and the all-statements carrier is not thereby made a proper child of anything.

$\mathcal{P}_A$ is the full proper-child cone of A only when $\mathcal{F}$ exhausts the admissible splitting structure below A.

Proof

(i) A decomposition generated by $\mathcal{F}$ is a composition of its carvings, and its terms are the cells A_f, each with coefficient $w(f)$; at real weights a term is a proper child exactly when its coefficient is positive (Definition 36). Distinct partial fillings give distinct cells by closure-independence. No merged cell joins them: a carrier whose filling of X_i is the union of two blocks realizes the agreeing superposition the carving declares invalid (Definition 12), and it is a term of no declared splitting.

(ii) If g extends f, A_g is a term of the composed decomposition of A_f by the carvings of $\operatorname{dom} g \setminus \operatorname{dom} f$, which A_f holds as a child holding its parent's declarations; its coefficient there is the local one, $w(g)/w(f)$ by the chain rule, the parent-relative weight divided by $w(f) > 0$, and it is positive since $w(g) > 0$, so $A_g \leq A_f$. Conversely, $A_g \leq A_f$ makes A_g a refinement of A_f, so the content of A_f is contained in that of A_g, and g extends f by closure-independence.

(iii) Both f and g extend $f \cap g$, and $w(f \cap g) \geq w(f) > 0$, the finest cells extending f being among those extending $f \cap g$; so $A_{f \cap g} \in \mathcal{P}_A$, above both by (ii), and a member A_h above both has $h \subseteq f \cap g$ by (ii), whence $A_{f \cap g} \leq A_h$. Two cells of one carving disagree on that attribute, so their join is A.

(iv) For compatible f, g the joint assertion $A_f \cdot A_g$ is $A_{f \cup g}$, by narrowing, the least common descendant of the two cells by What is ontological 11; if $w(f \cup g) > 0$ it lies in $\mathcal{P}_A$ below both, and a member below both is A_h with h extending $f \cup g$, so $A_h \leq A_{f \cup g}$. If f and g assign different blocks to one attribute, no cell extends both; if they are compatible but $w(f \cup g) = 0$, every cell extending $f \cup g$ has weight zero and lies outside $\mathcal{P}_A$.

(v) Adding $\perp$ below every element of a join-semilattice in which every pair with a common lower bound has a greatest one gives a lattice, the pairs with no common lower bound meeting at $\perp$.

The meet, where it exists, is the intrinsic meet; the join is the least cell above the intrinsic join of What is ontological 12, coinciding with it exactly when the two fillings share no consequence beyond their common sub-filling. Closure-independence is a genuine hypothesis: where the retained structure entails that two carved attributes take equal values, or a constraint between them propagates, as $\{a = 1, b = 1\}$ jointly invalid does for binary attributes, holding $a = 1$ entailing $b = 0$, distinct partial fillings close to one carrier and the cell map is not injective. Identifying the fillings that generate one closed carrier, and showing that the operations descend to the classes, is not done here; carvings acquired below a cell by a record the parent lacks lie outside the fixed family; and with coefficients beyond the real numbers the statements need the further condition that a cell's coefficient in its parent cell's own decomposition and its parent-relative weight give the same visibility judgment, which division by a positive real weight supplies here.

We now define the concept of a “proper Aethus" as follows.

Definition 38 (Proper Aethus)
*An Aethus $a \in T$ is deemed a "**proper Aethus**" if and only if no $x \in U$ tagged invalid by the criteria of T is a proper child Aethus of a — equivalently, no invalid Aethus appears in a's combination at weight that is not measure-zero relative to the rest of the combination.*

Note that in this sense of invalid Aethae, they need not actually be objective, but instead are determined as indexed by T, that way they maintain independence from the hyperinvalid Aethus itself — noting that on the parent direction of this paper the hyperinvalid Aethus, as the maximal-information contradictory case, is a child *of all Aethae rather than a parent. The commitment that T **is a commutative semiring** but not a ring stands here, with its layered justification given below: at the unweighted layer the constraint is forced outright, and at the weighted layer it is exactly one stipulation on the measure type.*

Note that reading "zero" as measure-zero relative to the rest of the combination*, rather than as scalar zero, is what lets null-set-like proper child Aethae — a component of lower measure grade than its remainder — be discounted as proper child Aethus for use in the taking of the Aethus reduced form, without their being invalidated. This is effectively a postulation meant to inject flexibility for making valid Aethae that much more robust in special fractal-like edge cases—that is since fractal-like instances may very well eventually be on the table due to the existing self-similarity properties of Oliver's Aethus.*

A translation note belongs here, since the commutative semiring constraint determines which classical algebraic instrument applies. In a ring, one would say that the invalid Aethae generate an *ideal* and that the Aethic partition theorem is computation modulo that ideal; in a commutative semiring, where additive inverses are unavailable by the constraint just stated, the correct instrument is a *congruence* [85]: the relation generated by identifying every invalid Aethus with the additive identity is a commutative semiring congruence on T, the Aethic partition theorem is precisely computation modulo it, and, at the base case $\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$, the reduced form is the canonical representative of an Aethus's congruence class; for generalized weights the anchored test of the relative-measure-zero clause and the quotient can part, as that clause records. One immediate payoff of this phrasing is a clean separation of roles. Commutative semiring homomorphisms from T that respect the invalidity congruence are algebraic valuations, and one of them, evaluation at the blank, witnesses that the quotient is nontrivial. Empirical probability is the other role: the specified weighting, normalized on admissible alternatives, additive across exclusive alternatives and not in general multiplicative for arbitrary joint assertions, so not in general a semiring homomorphism, a real-valued homomorphism sending every idempotent carrier to 0 or 1. That weighting is the weighting scheme every blank carries, one question for every attribute by the Randomness Universality Principle (Principle 40); for quantum attributes the Quantum Nexus (Principle 50) supplies it, and the Born rule is its corollary. The no-additive-inverses commitment announced above splits by layer, settled at both. At the unweighted layer it is forced outright: addition on U is the Aethic union, hence idempotent ($x + x = x$), and an additively idempotent structure with inverses is trivial — add $-x$ to both sides and get $x = 0$, collapsing U to a point. At the weighted layer, T becomes a ring exactly when M has additive inverses (the if direction by $(-a)A + aA \equiv 0 \cdot A$ under the degenerate case and the deletion convention; the only-if direction and its elementwise sharpening — a nontrivial inverse pair in T forces one in M, so zerosumfree M leaves T with no nontrivial inverses — both consuming the booked coefficient lemma, $x + y \equiv 0_T$ forcing termwise coefficient cancellation), and the guard is *zerosumfreeness* itself: it is what makes the algebraic preorder on M a partial order and the weighted-parent relation nontrivial, the non-negativity rider in that relation's definition being automatic under the algebraic order ($0 \leq \mu$ for every μ via $\mu = 0 + \mu$) and retained only for readability across general cones — the operative distinction being zerosumfreeness versus the mere availability of a distinguished sub-cone ($\mathbb{R}$ contains $[0, \infty)$ yet is a ring); once inverses are admitted, parenthood is total ($z = x + (-y)$ always exists, and the rider — already vacuous, as just noted — cannot block it), the set of candidate proper parents balloons, and the reduced-form order dissolves, so zerosumfreeness protects the pruning apparatus at the root.

Let $x \in T$ be defined as a "**weighted parent Aethus**" to some Aethus $y \in T$ with "**parent residue**" z if and only if x is expressible as the sum $x = y + z$ for some $z \in T$ such that all unweighted Aethus corresponding measures composing y and z are non-negative.

The definition of the reduced form of an Aethus under this formalization then holds the following structure.

Definition 39 (Weighted-Aethus Reduced Form)
Suppose we partially order the set $S(x)$ of proper Aethae in T taking a given x as a weighted parent Aethus such that the order is the weighted parent Aethus relation itself, with the parent Aethus direction taken as the "larger" direction in the partial order, (consistent with the analogy to probability events,

where a union of events is the "larger" event containing the individual ones). We restrict $S(x)$ to the nonzero *proper Aethae — the additive identity 0_T, having no visible components at all, is vacuously proper and would otherwise sit in every $S(x)$ — and define the* ***reduced form****, $\bar{x}$, as the* maximum *of $S(x)$ under such a partial-ordering when the maximum exists (that a maximum rather than merely a supremum exists whenever $S(x)$ is nonempty is a booked attainment lemma), or otherwise declare x without a reduced form if $S(x)$ is the empty set. Intuitively, the reduced form is the proper Aethus "closest" to x in the parent direction—namely, the proper Aethus formed by pruning x as little as possible while still being a proper Aethus.*

The statement of the ***third postulate of the Aethus*** *then becomes that x without a reduced form — equivalently, x whose pruning bottoms out at the additive identity — are tagged invalid according to the criteria of T. This is the postulate's* canonical *statement, the unweighted $\exists\forall$ form of subsection 6.4 being its stepping stone: the same content, stated first where weights are absent so that the quantifier structure can be seen bare, and completed here where the weights are present and the pruning is what carries it. Two things transfer from the unweighted form and are worth re-stating at this level, since it is here that they are used. The descent relation is weighted proper childhood, reflexive and transitive by the corollary at its definition, transitivity being the composition of decompositions, so that the pruning reaches every proper child at every depth in one pass and there is no level at which it must be re-applied; and* invalid inheritance *holds for the weighted relation as it did for the unweighted, since a proper child of an invalid x takes its terms from x's combination at no greater weight, and a proper child of that is again a proper child of x by transitivity, so a valid proper child would supply x the valid term it lacks; in the congruence reading above: "bottoms out at the additive identity" is the definitional gloss, while "congruent to the zero class" is a theorem at the base case of real weights (every positively weighted carrier invalid, the scalar chain $\mu X = (\mu\,\mathrm{Null})\cdot(1\,X)$ landing each term in the zero class), the exotic-measure residual carried symmetrically by both directions — the S(x) restriction reading nonzero modulo the measure-zero class by the author pin, its semantics invisibility rather than invalidation: measure-zero-weight carriers keep their standing, but fail to be visible to the recursive condition, unable to rescue validity — visibility read* relatively*, per the further ruling: the postulate ignores anything measure-zero relative to anything else standing in the same combination, exotic weight types comparing internally with no export to real values demanded of the framework — the reduced form of a valid Aethus being, at the base case and granted the residuals, its nonzero canonical representative, the anchored test and the quotient parting for generalized weights as the clause below records.*

The relative-measure-zero clause, unpacked. The definition's comparative clause, μ not measure-zero relative to the remainder, is the one clause a reader is likely to pass over and the one the postulate's behavior most depends on, so its three parts are set out plainly. *First, the rule.* A candidate counts as a member of $S(x)$ only if some carrier of it is visible *relative to x's own weights*—not measure-zero next to the other weights standing in the same combination. (The definition compares a carrier's weight with the remainder's *total*; this rule compares it with the individual weights. Invisibility against an individual weight implies invisibility against the total by second-argument monotonicity, and the two tests coincide exactly when the measure type is sum-splitting, $\mu \ll \sum_i w_i$ implying $\mu \ll w_i$ for some i, which holds at $\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ and in graded types; where that is not assumed the definition's total test governs proper childhood and this rule is the sufficient condition for invisibility.) Visibility is anchored to x's context, not to the candidate's. *Second, why the anchoring is forced.* Take $x = \varepsilon V + 1 \cdot I$ with V valid, I invalid, and ε infinitesimal relative to 1. In εV's own context ε is the sole weight and hence visible, so εV would sit in $S(x)$ and *rescue* x's validity by an invisible sliver—exactly the aid the semantics must forbid, since a state that is overwhelmingly invalid content is not made proper by a valid part no weight can see. Anchored to x, εV is invisible, $S(x)$ is empty, and x is invalid, as the ruling requires. *Third, what invisibility is and is not.* A relatively measure-zero carrier is not thereby invalidated: no tag flips, and it keeps its standing as an element of the tree. It simply does not count toward the recursive condition—it cannot come to the aid of validity, and it cannot be pruned to reach it. The comparison is internal to the weight type, exotic weights comparing with one another and no export to real values demanded. Two consequences are worth carrying forward. The exclusion of 0_T itself—which has no visible component, is vacuously proper, and would otherwise sit in every $S(x)$ so that a reduced form always existed and the postulate never fired—is the same clause at its limit. And the clause is exactly what the Nexic development's identification of a coupling closure with the optimal cell of a partition, turns on: the other cells of a fine scheme are logarithmically smaller than the optimum but *not* relatively measure-zero, so they remain visible, and the identification is approximate to that degree rather than exact.

The worked case: Oliver's Aethus. An example case is the canonical instance of Oliver's Aethus itself,

O_1, which is constructed through the self-similarity condition of $O_i = (1 - x_i)\, O_{i+1} + x_i\, (\alpha_i A_i + \beta_i B_i)$, where x_i is the probability of Oliver checking the detector for the traversed slit exactly at Aethic time i, and A_i versus B_i respectively gives the Aethus event of the left versus right slit having been traversed. Because Oliver's Aethus is explicitly constructed as taking the both-slits agreeing superposition as a parent Aethus, each of A_i and B_i — read throughout, as the proper-Aethus test requires, as the *joint* Aethae (parent $\cdot\, A_i$), tagged invalid by the criteria of T, since the bare slit-events alone are not invalid — is jointness-disallowed against that parent.

The verdict, by weights and arity. The verdict then depends explicitly on the weights and the combination arity: at $x_i \equiv 0$ these components carry weight zero, fail the comparative definition's visibility condition, never obstruct properness, and the Aethus is *valid* — an observer who never checks keeps the superposition; if infinite combinations are admitted, the never-check tail carries weight $\prod_i (1 - x_i)$, and whenever that product is positive the tail is a candidate proper parent and validity again survives — at the real-valued base case, positivity sufficing; the relative-visibility refinement extends the invalidity verdict to positive-but-*negligible* tails at exotic measure types, a positive but invisible tail rescuing nothing. The invalidity deduction holds when the checking is genuinely committed — x_i not all zero, with the tail weight vanishing ($\prod_i (1 - x_i) = 0$, e.g. $\sum_i x_i = \infty$) or the combination truncated finitely: then no iteration O_j lacks a positively weighted invalid proper child, the pruning bottoms out at the additive identity, and O_1 is deduced invalid via the third postulate. Note that we would particularly construct such a case by asserting this exact recursive structure for the relevant $O_1 \in T$ and T.

The self-similarity motivation, illustrated. This also illustrates the central self-similarity-based motivation of the third postulate in the first place, which is to take O_1 as invalid despite its invalidity being slightly weaker than going so far as explicitly asserting it an Aethic contradiction directly, (that is, since we only ever explicitly deduce A_i and B_i as Aethic contradictions within the weighted-extrinsic layer).

Remark: invalidity as tag versus invalidity as realization. It is crucial to clarify that within this formalism, "invalidity" is operationally a *tag* assigned to Aethae by the criteria of T, not a directly realized empirical property — the description "tagged" capturing the passivity of the assignment: invalid Aethae are perfectly consistent with the graph itself, not contradictions within it, and the third postulate operates over T, deducing further tags from the original tags. Reality then "extracts" at the very end: centric unfolding is disallowed into tagged cases.

Backend and frontend. The picture is backend versus frontend — T in the backend remains fully well-defined no matter how the invalidity tags are placed, while reality in the frontend simply reads T and prevents the agent's centric unfolding into invalid Aethae — with *why* being perhaps the remaining central philosophical mystery, and the phenomenological law of noncontradiction itself *derived* from the arrangement: the existing mystery taken and buried deeper into formal ontology. This is the weighted-layer face of the two-step maneuver of the Aethic-logic comparison earlier in this paper — contradiction's phenomenology first narrowed to the stipulated Aethic-contradiction base cases, then broadened to invalid Aethae in general — the reshaping by which contradictions cease to be logical falsehoods and become tags: typically contingent in kind ("this apple is red all over" against "this apple is green all over," not $1 = 0$), stipulated by the attribute-jointness semantics rather than derived from logic.

The stipulation on the consequence relation. One commitment this makes explicit, recorded as a stipulation on the consequence relation itself: deductive closure is *tag-blind* — jointness-disallowedness is carried by tags, invisible to closure, which therefore never explodes on tagged static Aethae; were it otherwise, every tagged carrier would collapse onto the hyperinvalid Aethus, contradicting the standing-as-elements construction above. The connection between tagged invalidity and the empirical forbidding of an Aethus from being realized as an observer's actual informational state is supplied separately, as a hypotheses non fingo [71]–style injected realization principle that is not itself derived within the formalism.

The core, and the branches. The three Aethic postulates, together with this tag-to-realization convention, constitute the "core" or "foundational" Aethic theory; additional axioms (whether on M, on the structure of U, or as further postulates of invalidity) generate "branch" theories that extend the core in directions specialized for particular empirical or theoretical purposes. Two major branches already developed within the broader Aethic framework are *Active Reasoning*, which extends the core with geometric apparatus aimed at deriving the quantitative rules of quantum mechanics as inferred consequences rather than brute facts, and *Nexic Reasoning*, which extends the core to systems

constrained by anthropic selection effects (yielding, for example, a logically-derived path from the Aethic mediocrity principle to the Rare Earth hypothesis [106]).

What a branch is. Crucially, a branch need not be motivated by any actual ontological principle to count as one—one may simply append an additional validity-tagging postulate as a purely formal extension, whether for toy exploratory purposes or for stress-testing the core's robustness, and this too constitutes a branch theory in the same sense. It is worth noting recursively that even the third postulate of the Aethus itself can be viewed as one such extra invalidity-tagging postulate—added, in fact, precisely to correct the Oliver soccer field setup so as to match empiricism. The choice to halt at the three postulates rather than to continue adding further such postulates is therefore itself a hypotheses non fingo [71] move at the meta-level: the foundational Aethic theory deliberately refuses to commit to additional invalidity-tagging axioms beyond what is needed for empirical fit at the targeted level of phenomena.

This tag-versus-realization distinction is also exactly why the third postulate is stated as an implication ($V[A] \Rightarrow \exists B \leq A, \forall C \leq B, V[C]$) rather than as a biconditional: its operative content is to propagate *invalidity tags* (via its contrapositive: "no reduced form $\Rightarrow$ invalid"), but it never positively derives validity. Validity is, in effect, the residue of "no invalidity tag has been assigned"—a problem-of-induction-style absence rather than a positively derived property. Asserting anything stronger than this would constitute an empirical-realization claim beyond what the formalism is willing to commit to, and is accordingly avoided under hypotheses non fingo [71].

Correspondingly, the broader category of "Aethic contradiction"—constituting the base cases of the recursive invalidity propagation governed by the third postulate—is to be understood as the exhaustive totality of cases in which the intrinsic compatibility structure of Aethic attributes (as carried by their structure of joint information rewriting and their tagging of certain attribute intersections as invalid) clashes within a given Aethus. This includes both "intuitive" contradictions between two different states of a common Boolean attribute, and any more elaborate "circuit-level" clashes among the intrinsic structures of multiple attributes acting jointly. The Aethic attribute itself is the structural carrier of all of this content; its formalization through identifier-class-relation-set tuples earlier in the paper is a particular formal apparatus for capturing this carriage, but is not claimed to exhaustively capture the semantic abstraction the attribute is meant to embody, in the same sense that no single algebraic definition of a tensor or a 4-Aethus quite captures the underlying object among all possible alternative formalizations.

6.7.1 The Fixed-Point Lemma for the Third Postulate

The recursive reading of the third postulate, (the two-generations discussion of Section 6.6.1), promised a formal equivalence between the postulate as stated and a greatest-fixed-point formulation. The lemma is stated and proven here, with the branching conditions made explicit.

Lemma 1 (Fixed-Point Lemma for the Third Postulate)
Work over the class of Aethae ordered by proper childhood, $B \leq A$: the boolean reduction of Definition 36 and declared descent, $A \rightsquigarrow bB + cC$ with b not measure-zero relative to c, transitive under the composition property of Definition 37 and reflexive, the subrelation of the intrinsic layer's refinement order (subsection 3.2) consisting of the refinements that are visible terms of declared splittings, so that descent means resolving blanks along the standing structure, never arbitrary insertion[135]*; in the disambiguation of this section that unweighted descent is the* declared descent*, defined as: single-valued fillings of a state's exclusive blanks, and, for an attribute held in agreeing superposition, only the splits its access licenses, which are tagged. It is reflexive and transitive, so that a state's declared descendants are its admitted refinements at every depth and the quantifiers of the safety operator range over them; it is proper childhood $\leq$, the boolean reduction of the weighted proper child defined above, carried on carriers by the declared splittings, the full refinement order of closed-content inclusion placing a tagged contradiction beneath every state and leaving nothing valid—and let* Base *collect the non-recursive*

[135] Declared descent is read with the author's clarification of 2026-09-25: a filling puts an attribute's open pegs on the table and is passive about validity below it; a blank declares a split only through what is intersected with it, the single-peg carving c_A (the blank is then the union of the determinate states and splits into them) or the irreducibility marker (the determinate proper children are tagged). An unstated attribute declares no split. On the Weight Algebra's completed model this makes the doomed set a multiplicative ideal, so the validity quotient is exact: with finitely many attributes closure consults the tags, every doomed carrier is tagged, and the tagged carriers absorb products. For the counterfactual semantics the reading fixes one rule: reopening an attribute clears its filling to all pegs and keeps its carving, so a reopened attribute is a scenario blank whose pockets are its determinate values, as the pocket construction assumes.

modes of invalidity, (direct Aethic contradictions and second-postulate-contrapositive violations). Define the safety operator on sets of Aethae by

$$F(Y) \;=\; \big\{\, A \notin \mathrm{Base} \;:\; \exists B \le A,\ \forall C \le B,\ C \in Y \,\big\},$$

and the dual doom operator by $G(X) = \mathrm{Base} \cup \{A : \forall B \le A,\ \exists C \le B,\ C \in X\}$. *Then: (i)* F *and* G *are monotone, so the greatest fixed point* νF *and the least fixed point* μG *exist for arbitrary branching, and they are complements of one another; (ii) the third postulate as stated in this paper asserts exactly that the validity predicate* $\mathcal{V}$ *is a post-fixed point of* F, *that is,* $\mathcal{V} \subseteq F(\mathcal{V})$, *whence* $\mathcal{V} \subseteq \nu F$ *always; (iii) if invalidity is generated by the base cases—every invalid Aethus is invalid either directly through* Base *or by the two-generational rule applied to base cases, which is this paper's standing reading—then equality holds:* $\mathcal{V} = \nu F$; *and (iv) because* $\le$ *is transitive, both fixed points are reached at the first stage for any branching whatever:* $\mu G = G(\mathrm{Base})$ *and* $\nu F = F(\complement\,\mathrm{Base})$, *so that a state is doomed iff every descendant has a base case beneath it and valid iff some descendant has a base-free cone, and the postulate's* $\exists\forall$ *statement is the fixed point itself.*

Proof
For (i): if $Y \subseteq Y'$, *then any witness proper child* B *of* A *all of whose proper children lie in* Y *has all its proper children in* Y' *as well, so* $F(Y) \subseteq F(Y')$; *monotonicity of* G *is identical with the quantifiers exchanged. The Knaster–Tarski theorem [98] then supplies* νF *as the union of all post-fixed points and* μG *as the intersection of all pre-fixed points, with no finiteness assumption anywhere. Complementarity is a De Morgan computation: for any set* X *of Aethae,* $A \notin F(\complement X)$ *holds if and only if* $A \in \mathrm{Base}$ *or every proper child* B *of* A *has some proper child* C *with* $C \in X$, *that is,* $\complement F(\complement X) = G(X)$; *taking fixed points on both sides identifies* $\complement\,\nu F = \mu G$. *For (ii): the postulate's implication,* $\mathcal{V}[A] \Rightarrow \exists B \le A,\ \forall C \le B,\ \mathcal{V}[C]$, *together with the disqualification of the base cases, says precisely* $\mathcal{V} \subseteq F(\mathcal{V})$; *since* νF *is the largest post-fixed point,* $\mathcal{V} \subseteq \nu F$ *follows with no further hypothesis. For (iii): the base-generation reading says the doomed set* $\mathfrak{D} = \complement\,\mathcal{V}$ *contains nothing beyond what* Base *and upward propagation force, that is,* $\mathfrak{D}$ *is the least pre-fixed point of* G, *so* $\mathfrak{D} = \mu G$; *complementing through (i) gives* $\mathcal{V} = \nu F$. *For (iv): let* $D_1 = G(\mathrm{Base})$ *and suppose* $A \in G(D_1)$. *If* $A \in \mathrm{Base}$ *then* $A \in D_1$ *immediately; otherwise membership in* $G(D_1)$ *supplies the quantified condition, that every* $B \le A$ *has some* $C \le B$ *with* $C \in D_1$. *If* $C \in \mathrm{Base}$, B *has a base case beneath it. Otherwise* $C \in D_1 \setminus \mathrm{Base}$, *so every refinement of* C*—in particular* C *itself, by reflexivity—has some* $E \le C$ *with* $E \in \mathrm{Base}$, *and by transitivity* $E \le B$. *Either way every* $B \le A$ *has a base case beneath it, which is* $A \in D_1$. *So* $G(D_1) = D_1$, *and since* $D_1 \subseteq \mu G$ *by one application from the empty set and* $\mu G \subseteq D_1$ *because* D_1 *is a fixed point,* $\mu G = D_1$. *Complementing through (i),* $\nu F = \complement D_1 = F(\complement\,\mathrm{Base})$. *No hypothesis on branching was used.*[136]

Status. The completed third postulate runs over weighted proper children only: its standard statement is the weighted-Aethus reduced form (Section 6.7), and it runs over weighted Aethae themselves, not over the validity quotient, which is taken afterwards for rendering and does not feed back into it. Read over the weighted proper child, the lemma's operator is immediate. A carrier's only proper child is itself, so the greatest fixed point is the set of weighted Aethae with a term of visible weight outside Base, exactly those with a reduced form. The checkmates the unweighted recursion was built to reach arrive through enforced splitting instead: an Aethus holding a carving is summed from its carved cells, its proper children (Proposition 8), and when every one of them is invalid, pruning leaves nothing proper. The descent the lemma names is proper childhood; over the full refinement order the Aethus whose content holds every item, which refines every Aethus and is invalid (Proposition 13), would empty the greatest fixed point and leave nothing valid.

Two remarks situate the lemma. First, hypothesis (iii) is not an addition to the framework but a restatement of it: the recursive propagation reading—base cases as leaves, the two-generational window as the recursive step—is the paper's own account of how a single reduced-form application traverses the descendant structure, so the equality $\mathcal{V} = \nu F$ is the third postulate's content once that reading is adopted, rather than a strengthening of it. Second, the lemma does not render the chess idiom of this paper literal, and an earlier version of this sentence claimed that it did. Membership in μG says that every declared descendant has a tagged descendant, which is weaker than every continuation meeting a tag in finitely many steps: in a tree where each untagged node a_n has an untagged child a_{n+1} and a tagged child b_n, branching is finite, a_0 lies in $G(\mathrm{Base})$, and $a_0, a_1, a_2, \ldots$ meets no tag. The fixed

[136] An earlier version of this part invoked König's lemma to bound the closure ordinal by ω under finite branching, which was correct for an immediate-child reading of $\le$ and is vacuous for the transitive relation, where the ordinal is one.

point's stages do not count moves, and finite branching supplies no finite certificate; the idiom stays an idiom. Finite termination holds separately where each declared split fixes an attribute for good and the attributes are finitely many.
A third remark closes a seam the lemma opens. This subsubsection runs the third postulate on the unweighted proper-child order, while subsection 6.6's canonical statement runs it on the weighted reduced form of a combination, and the two formulations are one postulate in the following exact sense, at the real-valued base case where the reduced form is the truncation to formally valid support. On an Aethus read as itself, embedded as the weighted term $1 \cdot A$, the reduced form is nonzero iff $A \notin \mu G$ iff the $\exists\forall$ condition holds at A: the weighted criterion *is* the unweighted one, exactly. On a weighted combination $x = \sum_i \mu_i A_i$ whose weights are visible, none measure-zero relative to the rest, the reduced form is nonzero iff some carrier A_i is formally valid, which implies that the carriers' last common ancestor $\sum_i A_i$ is valid, a safe cone beneath A_i being a safe cone beneath their union; the converse holds when the carriers are *exhaustive* for that ancestor—every descendant of the union beneath some A_i—and fails otherwise, since the union may own a safe descendant lying beneath none of the carriers, in which case the union stands while the decomposition prunes to zero. The weighted criterion is therefore a criterion on a *decomposition*, and a decomposition that omits an alternative its parent admits can be pruned away while the parent stands; the two formulations agree exactly on pure Aethae, in the forward direction on every combination, and in the converse on exhaustive ones, which is the harmonization stated above.

7 Solution to the Double-Slit Paradox

Given that the experimenter in place during the performance of the double-slit experimenter has the Aethus for which we will analyze, it follows that there are four main outcomes for what could potentially happen to a particle which is sent toward the slits during the experiment.

Slit Permutation Cases	
Case 1.	Neither slit is gone through.
Case 2.	Slit A but not Slit B is gone through.
Case 3.	Slit B but not Slit A is gone through.
Case 4.	Both slits are gone through at once.

	Case 1	**Case 2**	**Case 3**	**Case 4**
Detector Running	**Valid**	**Valid**	**Valid**	*Invalid*
Detector Absent	**Valid**	*Invalid*	*Invalid*	**Valid**

Table 7: This is a representation of what Aethic reasoning will output for each Aethic intersection given by this intersection table.

Remember that each of these outlined cases are themselves Aethae, specifically being child Aethae[137] of the Aethus of the experimenter. However, this being said, it will be included in the experimenter's Aethus which of these are valid and which are not according to the rules set in place by the three Aethic postulates[138]. The game, then, will be one of finding which are invalid, and stating in the experimenter's Aethus that these ones are forbidden accordingly.

[137]Note that the four cases themselves are allowed to be in agreeing superposition within their total Aethus due to the principle of Aethic extrusion. That is, while the state of the detector measuring the particles and *Case 4* occurring causes a direct contradiction within the same Aethus, the state of deciphering whether or not *Case 2* or *Case 3* happens with the detector running, for example, is found out only in a child Aethus to the Aethus in which is was blank, again due to the principle of Aethic extrusion. Therefore, we have different properties being held in two decidedly different Aethae, in effect not triggering any kind of contradiction in keeping all four cases in agreeing superposition in whichever Aethus to which that is applicable, (or, more specifically, it is not required to assert a disagreeing superposition, as we might have to do in other cases).

[138]Note that there is a clear reason why *Case 4* does not trigger an Aethic contradiction in and of itself. That is, we can consider this to be the natural state of an Aethus, in which the attribute of "which slit is gone through" is simply blank. As such, when retrieved, it returns the characteristic agreeing superposition. The other cases, then, are the

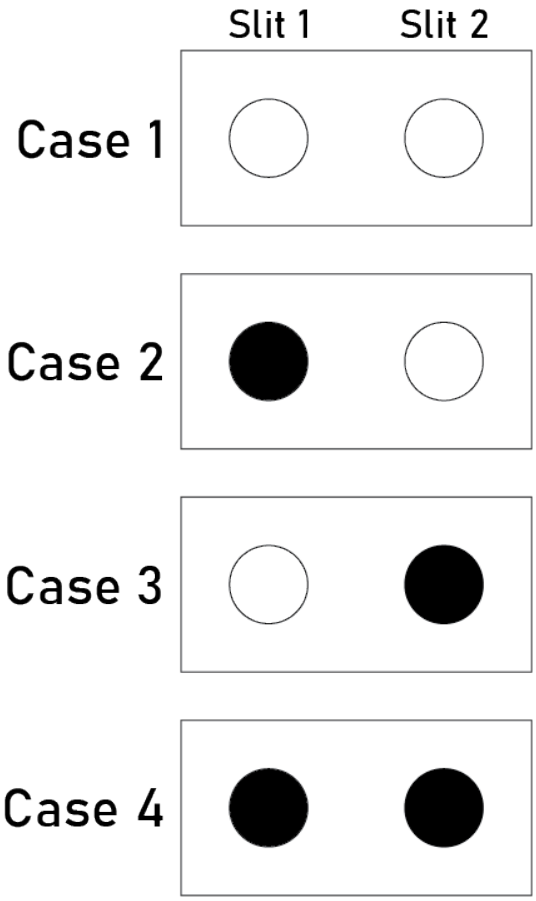


Figure 8: Here is a graphical representation of these four Aethic cases.

The experimenter, of course, themselves has two possible overarching Aethae they have to work between. In one case, they have placed one or more detectors over the two slits of the experiment, and so the goal of this section is to, using nothing but the presence of the detectors and the Aethic postulates, demonstrate which of the four possible cases are automatically to be deemed invalid in the Aethus of the experimenter, in the process solving the measurement problem by very specifically stating what ontological process brings about the collapse of the wavefunction at large.

7.1 Derivation for the Detector-Off Case

Let us begin with the case where the detector is absent. As such, the key property we need to make use of is the Heisenberg uncertainty principle, which provides us with a lemma that quantum information, once not measured, may never again be attained. This is a crucial input to the Aethic postulates, because it immediately fails to invalidate *Case 4* of the possible cases, being the one in which the interference pattern is raised. That is, there is indeed a proper child Aethus to the experimenter's Aethus – in fact all of them – for which their own proper child Aethae all prevent the slit of traversal's information from being reattained, which would have triggered a contradiction to the state of *Case 4*. As such, the third postulate returns indeterminate, but does not necessarily argue in the true or false direction due to the nature of its converse being unknown, (so as to allow for the second and first postulates to also contribute to any potential invalidity). In addition to this, however, the

"weird" ones, for lack of a better word, in that they hold an extra condition—being that one slit or another is definitively not gone through in their respective Aethae. Upon taking the Aethic superposition between these cases themselves, then, the procedure is that these independent attributes of one allowed slit versus another cannot flow out and into the other Aethae, because this associativity from one Aethus to the next is simply not allowed over Aethic superpositions. In effect, then, the procedure is to instead find which Aethae do trigger contradictions based on the *external circumstances* put in place by the experimenter's actions themselves, and this is what ontologically invalidates some Aethae before others.

contrapositive of the second postulate also fails to invalidate such an Aethus, because the slit of the traversal of the particle is in fact unknown and it is in fact in superposition. As such, because none of the three postulates are able to invalidate this Aethus, we may claim that it is valid. However, even though this is now known, we must still be careful in supposing that this Aethus equates to that of the experimenter automatically – for there are still three other possibilities in the permutation of which slit is gone through beyond *Case 4* alone.

Thus, the only way to mathematically demonstrate that the experimenter's Aethus is necessarily equal to an Aethus in which the particle goes through both slits at once is to invalidate the other Aethae. Let us do this now. To begin with, we must note how Heisenberg's uncertainty principle [24] implies that the slit of traversal attribute is strictly unattainable given that the double-slit experiment has been run without the use of a detector, so such a thing is a property not only of the experimenter's Aethus, but any valid child Aethus of it as well, because for a child Aethus of it to not agree with this property would be a direct contradiction of the empiricism under Heisenberg's uncertainty principle [24]. In total, there is a full contradiction in the works here, because we simply have that *Case 2* and *Case 3* themselves contradict such an assertion of the which-slit attribute needing to remain blank. As such, they must amount to invalid Aethae when intersected with the experimenter's Aethus, therefore invalidating both of them for the detector-off case.

Note that equivalent approach for demonstrating this leverages the second postulate of the Aethus, where we may specifically show that Heisenberg's uncertainty principle [24] being in effect means that any valid child Aethus of the experimenter's Aethus must hold the slit of traversal as conceptually blank, and therefore must hold it in superposition as per the second postulate of the Aethus. However, we clearly see that *Case 2* and *Case 3* do not hold the slit of traversal attribute in superposition, so through such a thing they also contradict Heisenberg's uncertainty principle [24], and must accordingly be taken as invalid Aethae in the case of the detector being off. This also serves as something of an intuitive argument for why *Case 4* must be allowed to remain in their place, being because it contains the property which they lack of never being able to centric unfold to an Aethus in which the slit of traversal drops out of superposition. Such a property is uniquely compatible with Heisenberg's uncertainty principle [24], therefore favoring *Case 4* in the process.

Finally, regarding *Case 1* within the detector-off case, this time such an Aethus is actually not invalidated in the first place. This can clearly be seen empirically, for those cases in which the particle does not wind up behind the slits, but instead gets caught elsewhere on the plate adjoining the slits without managing to traverse them.

As such, for the case where any detectors are utterly absent, we can see that the double-slit experiment results in the particle being in a weighted superposition between the Aethae of entering both slits at once, or neither at all.

7.2 Derivation for the Detector-On Case

All that is left now is to derive the solution to the case where the detector is present. We can immediately start by deciding that *Case 4* is invalid, because the experimenter always has the option of checking the data in the detectors later on, hence invaliding that case for at least some child Aethae for every one of the experimenter's own child Aethus where they observe an interference pattern[139], (in the absence of some near-improbable fluke of generation[140]). Specifically, the attribute of *Case 4*

[139] One possible objection to this goes as follows: "*What if we simply consider a child Aethus to that of the experimenter's for which they cannot access the information recorded by the detector?*" There are three major interpretations to this. Firstly, perhaps the detector information is permanently destroyed or definitively inaccessible – in which case the answer is simply that such a thing counts as the "detector absent" scenario and ought to be categorized there instead, (just by the nature of the third Aethic postulate – so not subjectivity or anything like that). But, for the more common interpretations of this, either we suppose that an attribute is abstractly added to the Aethus which disallows the experimenter from checking the detector but not through necessity, as such technically arguing that *there exists* such an Aethus anyways, or perhaps we argue that there is a child Aethus for which they are infinitely unlikely to actually check, itself representing a possible child Aethus. In both cases, assuming the baseline that the detector's information is outwardly present in the universe, hence asserting this is a "detector present" scenario, it follows that for the first case, such a thing is simply an Aethic contradiction, because the whole point of the detector's information being always available is that there are no loopholes to make this not so, and for the second case, such a probability never will truly be infinitely small, because even infinitesimal probabilities are probabilities nonetheless. Only something on the order of uncountably infinite precision might potentially do the trick, but as we can see here such a thing is countably infinite precision at best, (because the experimenter has only finite time to check the detector – hence arguing that there is still pointwise variation in their scenarios of checking). As such, even the chances of preventing Aethic invalidation yield Aethic invalidation here, so the third postulate firmly asserts this Aethus is invalid.

[140] This is to say, technically an interference pattern could be generated by the two-spotlights setup, however of course this is so unlikely, that in every case besides it this rule will hold. If, however, this incredibly unlikely scenario is to

that neither slit is not gone through can possibly be contradicted by any double-generational child Aethus, immediately violating the third postulate[141].

Put rigorously, suppose that the experimenter's Aethus then and there, being detector on intersected with *Case 4*, is to be some Aethus X, with there existing a proper child Aethus of Y to that. All we need to demonstrate is that we can find such a Y for which every proper child Aethus to it, Z, is valid—or alternatively we can prove X invalid by finding that any given Y must possess a proper child Aethus of Z which is invalid. To do this, simply consider how Y can either consist of an Aethus in which the experimenter looks at the detector output, or they do not. If Y holds that they looked, then that is an invalid Aethus on account of contradicting the interference pattern, so by another application of the third postulate of the Aethus we have that all of its further child Aethae are already invalid. That leaves the case where they are yet to look for Y, however we can then show that we might consider some further child Aethus to this, Z, in which they do look. Specifically, let us consider Z to simply consist of them adding the information from the detector to their Aethus. It immediately follows from this that Z is indeed a proper child Aethus of Y, because in either case of if the particle goes through *Slit A* or *Slit B*, and such an added stated-attribute is clearly directly blank in Y, on account of Y having already been defined in holding no information whatsoever about the slit of traversal, via the interference pattern as well as its prior condition of having the experimenter to not look, (and, generally, with there being no derivational process within the scope of Y which can discriminate between the particle having gone between *Slit A* versus *Slit B*). All in all, we then know that this Z must be an invalid Aethus, because it does indeed contradict the state of there having been an interference pattern in the first place, on account of that pattern's implication that the particle decidedly *did*[142] go through whichever slit was not registered by the detector also. Hence, for every Y it turns out that Z becomes invalid, so therefore, by the contrapositive of the third postulate of the Aethus, this X has to be invalid. As such, *Case 4* with the detector on is an invalid Aethus[143].

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occur, it does not invalidate Aethic reasoning, but instead simply argues that the pattern is unknown to match, thus installing a tiny margin of error in the form of an Aethic weighted union. Nothing disheartening, however, due to the sheer unlikelihood of it.

[141]To be abundantly clear about the specifics here, note the difference from cases of the principle of Aethic extrusion. In this case, where the detector is running and *Case 4* occurs, look to the retrieval of "Which slit has not been gone through?" from a child Aethus in which it is checked. Notice that we can create mutually exclusive outputs to this just depending on which attributes from this Aethus are factored into the formulation. If we consider the parent Aethus which only holds the state of *Case 4*, then the return of that retrieval is "None." Note that this is a perfectly viable option, because it is technically an answer to that question when considering the generalization of choosing to permutations. (As such, invalidating "None" would be an arbitrary and subjective decision). On the other hand, though, consider the parent Aethus of the current one which only holds the return of the detector. In such an Aethus, the return for our retrieval is "slit A" or "slit B" but not both. Notice how this return is mutually exclusive to the "None" return, because under no conditions does there exist an Aethus which is an intersection of both. As such, this Aethus must be invalid. (As this is an Aethic contradiction). And of course, so too must then be the experimenter's total Aethus in this case, because all such invalid Aethae can be reached via any child Aethus of the experimenter, hence violating the third postulate. Notice the difference, then, between the case where Alice checks an entangled particle and sees spin-up. We cannot use the same logic to argue that Alice's current proposition of spin-up contradicts her previous proposition of spin-up and spin-down in disagreeing superposition, because, first of all, both do have a valid intersection, (being spin-up), and second of all, we cannot actually create two separate avenues of attributes within the Aethus which are mutually exclusive, because of that fact that the superposition is disagreeing — so the attribute update Aethus is a perfect child Aethus of the original.

[142]A highly important mathematical caveat is that the contradiction that arises is not actually between superposition and definteness directly, for the simple reasoning that such a mode of contradiction is difficult to make well-defined. Instead where the technical contradiction may be made to arise is more subtle: according to the detector's information, one of the two slits much definitely have not been gone through, but this directly contradicts the asserted Aethic retrieval of the interference pattern that either slit must have been gone through. So in effect the contraction is that either node of information asserts that "should the Aethic retrieval not precisely match this criterion than an Aethic contraction is raised" all while then implying contradictory such criteria.

[143]Importantly, please note that the Aethic ontological supposition is not that the universe is trying out possibilities and then subsequently pruning them in some sort of sequential sense, but rather that with the detector on, the which-slit attribute was never conceptually blank to begin with, but rather semiblank. The simple reason for this is that conceptually blank attributes entail, by the concept of the attribute cascade, that their states may not be deduced by an Aethus as well as merely not being directly stated in a given static Aethus to it. This closure under deduction is the key, because once the third postulate itself has been postulated, it then forms a valid mode of deduction in and of itself. Accordingly, then, in the ontological sense it is not that the universe tries asserting the existence of the which-slit agreeing superposition before doubling back, (instead this is merely what we humans have to do as deductive reasoners), but actually what is going on is that with the understanding that the third postulate deduces an agreeing superposition of the which-slit attribute as invalid, and with the second postulate clearly deducing that a perfect agreeing superposition implies conceptual blankness of the attribute, (since the second postulate implies both ways between attributes and agreeing superpositions), we therefore get by implicative transitivity that the third postulate implies the state of the which-slit attribute being conceptually blank as invalid. In other words, the intrinsic deduction from the postulates themselves, when incorporated into the Aethic attribute cascade, tells us that the which-slit attribute will not have been conceptually blank to begin with, therefore implying it is firmly semiblank if still directly blank. This is the intended ontological treatment of these cases, explicitly speaking, where the universe presents the final result in one deductive

This, note, causes an intriguing ripple effect onto the remainder of the experimenter's Aethus. It is no longer truly the case that the slit of traversal is to be conceptually blank to their Aethus, even if they have yet to check the detectors, because the mere fact that the act of going through both slits at once triggers an invalid Aethus is an indicator that certain configurations of the slit of traversal attribute can be used to attain information about the Aethus at large. In effect, this tells us that the slit of traversal attribute is merely semiblank in such a case. With this being so, what is still decidedly unknown to the experimenter's Aethus of before they observe where the particle landed on the back screen, is which of the other three cases is actually in effect. What we see from this is two intriguing consequences. The first is that we can no longer leverage the second postulate of the Aethus so as to show *Case 2* and *Case 3* as invalid, because the lack of needed conceptual blankness of the slit of traversal attribute no longer forces a superposition to have to be in effect at all. The second, most importantly, is that an attribute which points to whether *Case 1*, *Case 2*, or *Case 3* is in effect is indeed fully conceptually blank. This is a huge result, because it allows us to use the second postulate of the Aethus to imply that all three of the cases themselves ought to go into Aethic superposition in the given Aethus[144]. As such, this might be specifically contrasted with the detector-off case by our two-step process of first discounting the need for the slit of traversal attribute itself to be the one in agreeing superposition, and second abiding by the new iterative layer of the full Aethic cases themselves as our new unit of agreeing superposition. In effect, the implied disagreeing superposition itself of the slit of traversal attribute can be alternatively expressed as the agreeing superposition of the cases *Case 2* and *Case 3* as taken as Aethae over the base attribute. This is so where we specifically take the attribute which points to either *Case 2* or *Case 3* as being conceptually blank to imply an agreeing superposition as per the second postulate of the Aethus, but such an agreeing superposition which may be stated in a valid child Aethus. Agreeing superpositions over physical observables like the slit of traversal typically do not follow this same quality of being still valid if their child Aethae can be stated as per the specific nature of the third postulate of the Aethus, so such a thing can be taken as a special property of more abstract Aethic superpositions like those over an Aethus in place of physical observables. Note that it is a general rule that an attribute in disagreeing superposition ought not to be conceptually blank in the Aethus in question, due simply to whatever informational spillover is accounted for by the disagreeing superposition itself.

If the experimenter has not observed anything about the landing location of the particle besides what could be attained from setting up the detectors beforehand and running the experiment blindly, then relative to their Aethus of that nature, *Case 1*, *Case 2*, and *Case 3* are all in agreeing Aethic superposition. However, if the experimenter adds the location of the particle to their Aethus by looking at or otherwise assessing the information on the back screen, then the weights on the three cases in superpositions shifts accordingly – as in perhaps if it is closer to slit A, hence implying more of a chance to *Case 2* than *Case 3*, however not entirely guaranteed and therefore not entirely added to their Aethus. Only if they can truly add this information to their Aethus, such as checking the detector, may the experimenter actually collapse their Aethus as far down as an individual case among *Case 1*, *Case 2*, or *Case 3* here, but note that this is not given merely by the feat of the particle having been measured by the back screen beforehand, as this would, Aethically speaking, be no less arbitrary than simply asserting that quantum superpositions are known beforehand.

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action. It is simply that we humans, while performing Aethic reasoning, must meticulously check over the different states in a sequential order on account of our theoretic ignorance of the full attribute cascade at first.

[144]Let us quickly mention why agreeing superpositions over these abstract Aethic cases reliably never generate an invalid Aethus as would the agreeing superposition of the slit of traversal attribute itself in relevant contexts. Simply put, this is because the slit of traversal attribute leaves a lingering ability in child Aethae for us to go back and form an invalidity in the original Aethus itself, as seen by the third postulate's applicability for invalidity in this particular case. By contrast, however, it is perfectly reasonable to suppose that a prior Aethus held an agreeing superposition of multiple child Aethae cases relative to itself, only for one of those child Aethae to be selected relative to its own self. That is to say that uncovering a particular one of those child Aethae does not force a contradiction back in the earlier Aethus, because there was no lingering attribute which we are able to leverage a possible contradiction conflict within, (like the attribute of whether the slit of traversal is directly blank or not, which we leverage two contradictory answers to in such conflicting child Aethae). (Perhaps more specifically put, we have that the sight of the pattern on the back screen itself forces us to adopt a state for the Boolean Aethic attribute for whether the interference pattern happens or not, and so that turns out to be the particular lingering state in question, to which there is of course no analogue in the case of an agreeing superposition of several possible child Aethae, for which no indication is ever explicit on which one will have been picked in that Aethus or another). More generally speaking, an instance of one of these kinds of lingering attributes, or the lack thereof, is why agreeing superpositions of Aethically statistically independent child Aethae are commonplace, (and of course even directly mandatory by the second postulate of the Aethus), all while more delicate cases like what we see in the double-slit experiment effectively complicates this would-be simpler picture through its existence of such lingering attributes, (more technically being called "permanencible attributes").

7.3 Assessing the Results

All this being said, with the detector absent, the tendency is an Aethic superposition between *Case 1* and *Case 4*, whereas with the detector present, the tendency is an Aethic superposition between *Cases 1, 2, and 3*. The crucial takeaway here, all things considered, is that the detector-off case implied an agreeing superposition of the slit of traversal, whereas the detector-on case implied a disagreeing superposition of the slit of traversal. This fundamental flip can be seen as a major component of the ontological essence of the wave-particle duality notion, with the complete picture needing to be filled in with *Step X*.

Generally, then, we see that there are two major varieties of ontological content to what we call "quantum wavefunction collapses." The first is like what we see in the double-slit experiment, where a measurement triggers the change from agreeing to disagreeing Aethic superposition. The second is when a direct observation is taken from a list of many options, such as randomly shooting a particle at some array of detectors and personally determining which one has been struck. This is simply an instance of a child Aethus being taken from a disagreeing superposition of the possible ending locations, no differently than all the other disagreeing superpositions we collapse relative to our Aethae in day-to-day macroscopic life. Note, however, that even after a particle is detected at a destination, the path it took to get there remains very much in agreeing superposition if not recorded in some way, just due to the second postulate itself. The point there is that even the supposed claim of having gathered an attribute in one's Aethus is only ever a small part of a largely superposition-infused picture. This lingering set of agreeing superpositions to any system is part of what makes quantum mechanics so eye-catching.

Regarding the notion of expanding this to the general solution, there are four crucial steps to undergo to validate all three postulates to a given Aethus, in effect describing the precise ontological makeup[145] of a system so as to satisfy a solution to the measurement problem.

[145]To quickly describe the effects of the third postulate in another way, we say that wavefunction collapse is never only about a single measurement — rather it is what happens when it's possible to write up two different measurements (of one phenomenon) which give two different answers. So we could very well observe the consequences of some agreeing superposition, so long as we cannot look under the hood, so to speak, by probing it with an alternative measurement which gives a different answer. In a sense then, such observation scenarios are indeed a form of measurement — however they're just not complete enough to collapse the superposition.

Algorithm 1: How To Perform Aethic Reasoning Over a System

Basic Description: The following algorithm is a rendition of the specifically epistemological procedure which one might undergo in order to assess the Aethic retrieval and thereby state of presence in reality which a particular attribute holds with respect to a particular Aethus, (being most commonly a first or third-person empirical Aethus).

Input: Our inputs are the empirical Aethus corresponding to the reality of the system, A, and an Aethic Template which we wish to retrieve the state of, β.

Output: The result will be an exact mapping between the parameters of the system and the set of allowed Aethic outcomes. Aethic reasoning now renders the wavefunction collapse as algorithmic through the very state of the present algorithm producing the correct empiricism independently of external epistemic intervention.

function DecipherRetrieval(A, β)
    if β is present in A **then**
        We know that β is present in the Aethic reality of the system
        $B \leftarrow$ The queried state of β in A
        return B
    else if β is impartially blank in A **then**
        We understand that β must be in a general superposition of some sort with respect to A, but we still need to determine if it is agreeing or disagreeing
        Proceed to the next layer of the algorithm
    else if β is otherwise semiblank blank in A **then**
        $\beta_1, \beta_0 \leftarrow$ The decomposition of β into its present and impartially blank components in A, respectively, which we know to be possible by the generalized Aethic dichotomy theorem for impartial blankness
        return The retrieval conjunction of DecipherRetrieval(A, β_0) and DecipherRetrieval(A, β_1)
    end if

    Let us now analyze the specifics of the case where β is impartially blank in A
    if β is uncertain in all proper child Aethae of A **then**
        β is representative of an Aethic uncertainty principle of some kind with respect to A
        We now know that β is both conceptually blank with respect to A, and therefore in agreeing superposition with respect to it by the second postulate of the Aethus
        return The retrieval which consists of the set of all possible states of β as according to however they are weighted in A, if applicable
    else if β holds the possibility of being attained in some proper child Aethus to A **then**
        In this case, the third postulate declares that for β to be conceptually blank with respect to A would amount to an invalid Aethus
        With such a case of β being conceptually blank being an invalid Aethus, we now look to all the remaining cases, being the remaining combinations of the individual states of β being present in the retrieval or not, with their corresponding descriptive Aethae
        Go through and invalidate each of these other cases, one by one. *This represents a major shift from classical epistemology, in which we assume that all cases which realize multiple disjoint states are automatically invalid.* Here we have to do a case-by-case analysis of all possible combinations of the realized states of β, and invalidate them with the third postulate of the Aethus directly
        Some number of Aethic cases will now be left over, out of not being able to be invalidated by the third postulate
        Since the property of which is these cases is realized in the the retrieval is itself conceptually blank in A on account of their all not being invalidated by the third postulate, we use the second postulate of the Aethus to put the cases themselves in agreeing Aethic superposition within the retrieval
        With the iteration-layer of the cases being in agreeing superposition, this then implies a disagreeing superposition of the lower iteration layer that is the states of β itself
        return A disagreeing superposition of the states of β, or alternatively an agreeing superposition of whichever cases remained after the validity cropping done by the third postulate
    end if
end function

Through this, the measurement problem has its first official solution. Whether there will be others, it is hard to tell. But it is very unlikely that they should be as simple as this one, due to the nature of the particular inductive steps that were chosen to create this. At least as far as Einstein's razor [26] is concerned, that would make this the final solution itself. Naturally, then, we have the complete solution to the measurement problem, hence satisfying *Requirement 2* to the measurement problem solution. Also notice that we have matched the empiricism in doing so, which also allots to us *Requirement 1* in this context. From here, now, let us look to what might perhaps be the most general expression of Aethic reasoning.

8 Generalized Aethic Coherence Principles

The natural question at this point is what comes next given our scientific understanding of Aethic reasoning. The natural answer, then, is that we ought to peer deeply into further uncertainty principles, perhaps even giving them a type. So far, one of these uncertainty principles is known to us – Heisenberg's uncertainty principle [24] itself – which we may consider our node of entry into the larger Aethic reasoning. But, consider an *uncertainty principle* itself to signify the larger class of these types of forever-unknowable Aethae.

Principle 28 (Aethic Uncertainty Principle)
An empirical principle which corresponds to an instance of a particular class of Aethic attributes being permanently blank by the effects of some related permanencible attribute.

Principle 29 (Aethic Uncertainty Attribute Class)
The class of Aethic attributes which correspond to their Aethic uncertainty principle.

Principle 30 (Aethic Coherence Principle)
An Aethic coherence principle is an empirical principle which regards a certain class of Aethic attributes as following a predictable agreeing superposition under the relevant context.

This now being said, it is inductively implied by Aethic reasoning that any single uncertainty principle will result in agreeing superpositions of a corresponding type. This is simply due to the correlation between agreeing superpositions and the application of the third Aethic postulate, as well as the assertion by an uncertainty principle that the third Aethic postulate be applicable after all. As such, a major goal of any future studies on Aethic reasoning is to name as many classes of uncertainty principles as possible; primarily those which have practical use and or prevalence. Given that quantum uncertainty [24] is already in hand—now as the Nexus-mediated output of path multiplicity rather than as any primitive—it is quite reasonable to imagine that there are a full myriad of alternative classes of uncertainty attributes, with their corresponding uncertainty principles. And if this is true, then the best among them will provide agreeing superpositions which can possibly rival those in quantum mechanics for their mysterious intrigue and classical-defying scope. Just as an Aethic uncertainty principle generalized the quantum uncertainty [24] principle, let us also suppose that "Aethic coherence" to a given Aethic uncertainty principle generalizes quantum coherence—so, that is, the agreeing superpositions of some Aethic uncertainty principle can be designated as holding that uncertainty principle's Aethic coherence—with any conversion of this to disagreeing superpositions being referred to as "Aethic decoherence." The same as in quantum mechanics, but for the general Aethic system. This can be phrased in the form of a theorem.

Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Reasoning
To every valid Aethic uncertainty principle there corresponds an Aethic coherence principle.

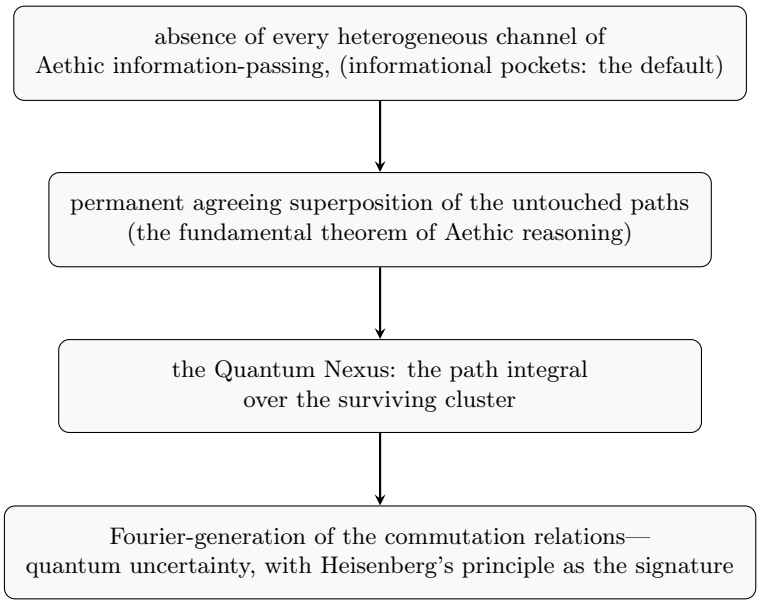
Put into more simple language, this theorem states that according to Aethic reasoning, *that which is permanently uncertain performs every possible action at once.* Such is to be interpreted as a fundamental rule of the universe in any and all relevant contexts. The argument is that given the existence of quantum coherence, we assert that this is the only reasonable inductive conclusion, with the entire layered argument of Aethic reasoning being the support to this claim.

This theorem, now, marks the completion of Aethic reasoning's foundation.

8.0.1 Quantum Uncertainty in Aethic Reasoning

Before Heisenberg's principle is placed within this taxonomy, the direction of explanation deserves one plain statement, because under the "quantum mechanics joins the party last" reframe of the Quantum Nexus section it would be axiomatically circular to *attribute* the uncertainty in the second postulate, in a quantum setting, directly *to* quantum uncertainty. The central conceptual move of the reframe is that it renders the lack of information as the universe's natural default rather than the exception: at small scales, the tendency is for informational pockets of permanent unknowability to exist simply by means of Aethic information not having been able to pass out of that point in spacetime. In such pockets—which signify precisely the absence of every heterogeneous mechanism of Aethic information-passing—the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning feeds into the Quantum Nexus, which in turn feeds into the Fourier-generation of quantum uncertainty; quite literally, in the deductive sense, quantum mechanics joins the party last. The achievement of parsing out the Quantum Nexus this way is that the tendency toward pockets of absent information, together with the fundamental theorem, forms the axiomatic root, with quantum mechanics lying at the very tail end of the cascading deductions—and Heisenberg's principle is thereby relocated from its pedagogical "categorical uncertainty" status to being the signature of an absence: the lack of any-old heterogeneous presence of Aethic informational transfer.

The ordering deserves a picture the reader can carry forward:



The arrows run in the deductive direction only—quantum mechanics joins the party last—and each arrow is derived, rather than pictured, in the Quantum Nexus section, (Principle 50); the taxonomy above is what the reader should carry into it.

8.0.2 On the Falsifiability of Aethic Reasoning

In order to state this explicitly, perhaps a major scientific strength of Aethic reasoning is that *the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning is most extremely falsifiable*, because we would need only a single experimental instance of a permanently unknowable physical or abstract parameter operating under a disagreeing superposition, (or strictly empirically speaking, more like a classical decoherent logical disjunction), in order to do so. More technically speaking, because the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning can fundamentally be thought of as the onset of permanent uncertainty triggering the onset of different parameter possibilities clearly interacting in the same empirical space, (as, through the full derivational channel of Aethic reasoning, induces from quantum coherence anyway), we therefore simply need to find an instance of a single parameter, again be it physical, abstract[146], or any iterated combination of the two, failing to enter this clear Aethic coherence dynamic, and we will have thusly falsified Aethic reasoning.

[146]That is, as in the case of an Aethus or a general abstract criterion rather than a directly physical property, perhaps analogously to how we demonstrated with the double-slit experiment Aethic derivation that even in the case of which-path information being accessible then simply causes the remaining broad Aethic cases to go into agreeing superposition relative to that Aethus.

To emphasize this point, we need not even demonstrate this with any possible experimental setup to test such a thing—only a single setup will do. So, for example, a particularly intuitive thought experiment I came up with on the topic of Aethic coherence concerns permanently hiding the position of a macroscopic body: the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning predicts that if we are ever able to build a contraption which effectively permanently hides the positional information of such a body within its enclosure, then it ought to undergo a myriad of strange non-classical Aethic coherence effects, namely surrounding the idea of different "scenarios" of the ball's motion affecting other scenarios as if they were two different bodies altogether. The classical expectation, of course, would be that it is absurd for two different possible trajectories of a single body to influence one another as if they were two physical bodies in the same physical space, but the Aethic prediction is very specifically that this is the effect we would chart should we ever be able to design a contraption which hides its locational information permanently while the experiment is run. So even though we would not be able to view the events of the experiment in person as per the permanently hidden information criterion, we still could very easily set up systems which allow us to infer if the ball had been acting classically, or instead under Aethic coherence. For example, in the thought experiment itself there is the option of using one ball to remove a barrier for the other, for which we would clearly be able to distinguish the Aethic outcome, (trajectory affected by removal of the barrier), versus the classical outcome, (trajectory not affected due to options being locked in different scenarios), we could leverage such a distinction alone to falsify the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, and thereby Aethic reasoning itself, should the classical outcome result anyway. So the point I am trying to stress with this is that we have a myriad of possible hypothetical experiments to run, and for each of them a myriad of possible implied features and outcomes to test, and if even one of these fails the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, then we automatically falsify Aethic reasoning. So, once more with the hidden-position example, the task is as simple as telling whether the different scenarios of the body interact as if they were different physical bodies, (the Aethic result), or strictly abide as being apparently one physical ball which fails to interact with its own alternate scenarios, (the classical result). The particular wavelike instances of quantum mechanics need not ever be considered for this experiment, nor for the multitude of other hypothetical experimental means of testing the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning—hence again demonstrating why such is posited as an extreme generalization of the quantum coherent wavelike effect, for which active reasoning then serves as the proposal for how to imply such as a special case of the wider Aethic reasoning. (A calibration fixing this rendering's grade—against the quantum scale, where any such effect must already live—is recorded in Section 8.1 below.)

Altogether, then, in the least I see something of a major potential parallel between the experimental testing of general relativity, and our future ability to test the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning. That is, as we know it was several decades between the theoretical formulation of general relativity and the ability of experimental technology to catch up enough to actually put it to the test. Then, somewhat miraculously, in recent years we have all the experimental precision in the world with which to test general relativity, and with all that firing power of sorts we keep verifying and re-verifying the predictions of the theory. In all of this testing, and not a single falsification has been attained. This is precisely the sort of hopes that I have for the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning—that with just a little more experimental technological advancement, and we might be able to put it to the test in thousands of different settings, ranging from elementary predictions like the hidden-position hypothetical above to perhaps wildly more overarching consequences of future parametrical theory like the large scale contextual motion of matter in the universe, and so on. Once more, we need only one instance of experimental invalidation to falsify the entire framework, but I have my hopes, on account of the simplicity of the postulates, that such may never come to pass after all. We just might have to be a little patient in order for the experiments to truly catch up with the theory.

It is worth naming, with equal explicitness, the *contrast class* against which this falsifiability claim earns its empirical content. Objective-collapse models—GRW [75], continuous spontaneous localization and its kin [107], and the gravitational variants of Diósi and Penrose [108, 109]—predict a scale-induced breakdown of superposition that no quality of informational erasure can prevent. And the kinship deserves stating as plainly as the contrast, because the contrast is easy to misread as a cut. What this framework shares with the dynamical-collapse programs on the nested-observer flank is a position: that coherence ends somewhere for observer-grade systems. What it does not share is the mechanism, and the difference is not that its criterion is informational where theirs is mass- or rate-based, though that is true; it is that the framework posits no criterion at all beyond the third postulate. The postulate excludes a candidate when every declared refinement of it retains a contradiction-reaching descendant, which is the rule that moves the boundary in the double-slit

experiment once a detector carries a distinguishing record when a detector is switched on: an observer exports which-outcome records, a maintained agreeing superposition of an observer therefore has a refinement in which the outcome is stated, and the checkmate is the one the blindfolded organizer's interference-Aethus already suffered. Nothing is placed between systems, by scale, by complexity, or by fiat; the framework draws no Heisenberg cut of its own, (Section 10.2.2), and the phrase "where unitarity's writ ends" names no line but a fact about records. What the verdict then depends on is one physical claim, and it should be stated as such and not as a threshold. The third postulate's shape is existential-universal—an Aethus is invalid only if *every* refinement has a doomed refinement—so the asking refinement checkmates the friend's coherence only if it cannot be escaped, and a protocol that unitarily reverses the friend's measurement before anyone asks is exactly a proposed escape. What forbids the escape is that an observer-grade record structure exports its records unblockably, so that no refinement ever stands in which they are all gone; and that is a claim about the physics of records, the fifth Open Construction under its proper description—the exact conditions under which distinguishing information is permanently hidden, or cannot be. Under universal unitarity nothing is ever unblockable, so on that view the escape always exists and the friend can always be held coherent; here the claim is that for observer-grade systems it does not, and the two views part at exactly that claim and nowhere else, with all apparent scale-dependence exhausted by information accessibility, (the boundary relocation of Theorem 14). Two disciplines keep that claim from going verbal, and both are owed at exactly this sentence. First, "unblockable" must not be cashed as what unitary dynamics already calls irreversible decoherence: on that reading the two sides agree on every experiment and the claim is a metaphysical gloss on a shared prediction. For the difference to be one *in kind*, the record must be one unitarity still predicts recoverable in principle—which places the discriminating regime among records that are scrambled but present, the spin-echo and Loschmidt-echo regime, where coherence written into an environment is verifiably recovered on the bench and unitarity's in-principle claim is cashed rather than assumed; the fifth Open Construction's job is to say on which side of that regime an observer's records fall. Second, the interferometry program climbing toward ever richer record-bearing systems held coherent can only *fail to find* the point at which the escape closes: every successful recombination reads as "records still blockable" until the construction names the conditions, so the claim is falsifiable at a named condition and not before. It therefore stands, until that construction closes, as a *commitment to* a prediction rather than a prediction—and becomes the latter at exactly the point where the conditions are named. There is no rate here and no scale; there is the third postulate and an open question about records. The operative experimental frontier on which these predictions diverge today is matter-wave interferometry of increasingly massive systems [110, 111] and its levitated-optomechanics descendants; the macroscopic Class-C regime charted later in this section is the idealized endpoint of that experimental program, with the open conditions of the macroscopic regime, (the fifth of the Open Constructions, Section 14.8), constituting exactly the engineering content of any real instantiation. Stated as a fork: each confirmed extension of coherence to larger masses under controlled erasure is evidence against the collapse family and for the informational boundary, while a reproducible breakdown not attributable to residual environmental records would falsify Aethic reasoning outright.

And one standing directive belongs beside the fork, because it is the long-term shape of the empirical program rather than a single experiment's. The quantum medium is *one* class of Aethic uncertainty principle—the class in which permanent informational inaccess happens to come cheap at small scales—but the taxonomy above is deliberately general, and the directive is to remain on the lookout for *other* classes of genuine Aethic uncertainty principles: media, of whatever physical or informational character, in which a class of attributes can be rendered permanently blank by the effects of some permanencible attribute. Each such class discovered is an independent falsification theater. For that medium, the fundamental theorem issues a real Aethic prediction—the corresponding coherence principle, agreeing superpositions of the class's own type—while the classical expectation for the same medium is the forcing of disagreeing superpositions throughout; and comparing the two is a test of the framework that owes nothing to matter-wave interferometry, to the quantum frontier's engineering conditions, or to any other theater already named. The framework's empirical exposure, in other words, is not a single wager on one experimental program but a portfolio whose size grows with every genuine uncertainty-principle class identified—and the identification of such classes is thereby not taxonomic housekeeping but the principal avenue by which the framework's falsifiability compounds.

8.0.3 Explicit Orientation of the Fundamental Theorem

Something I really want to emphasize here is that the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning is a statement about logic, not physics. It is that broad, that is. Physics is merely one domain where it performs deduction, but the central point is that it can be enacted literally anywhere. On the point of why it is logic, if I leave you with one central takeaway from this paper, let it be this: in the hidden-position hypothetical, when the trajectory information is fully hidden, and the body interacts with its alternate scenario, what is happening here is that we are watching a rawer and more fundamental layer to "or" than what we are otherwise exposed to. It is not that physics compels the co-present versions to jointly lock into their stationary action paths as a sweeping macroscopic special case of the quantum wavefunction—(as after all that conclusion misses the point spectacularly, because it insists on assuming the Copenhagen-structural collapse postulate at the one moment when it may be freed from it)—actually instead it is quite literally that their fastening logical primitive has dropped into its bottommost state, where the vacancy of leaking information allows for an agreeing superposition to replace a disagreeing one. (And note, this is not to say that the quantum wavefunction[147] is irrelevant, as that is simply empirically false, but rather that it is an axiomatic layer atop this foundation, but never beneath—as is the motivator of *Step X* anyway). So all things considered, I cannot stress enough that we are watching "logical or" in its natural state in such hidden-position regimes, where alternate scenarios quite literally and unremarkably overlay in space. Is is then the ocean of information-decoherent effects of our everyday world, which fires off the third postulate and reduces everything to disagreeing superposition, which is the irregular case, and we only thought it was elemental.

So, in short, it is not that macroscopic bodies in agreeing superposition would behave as they do *because of quantum interference* at all. Rather the direct reason is *because they operate under the logical 'or' of an agreeing superposition.* Quantum interference itself is a separate notion from this in the physical sense, so as to be one medium among many which agreeing superpositions may operate over. As we know from Dirac [112], after all, the mere state of a body's velocity being of the macroscopic scale implies that the path of stationary action will be attained. So, so long as such bodies are not moving extremely slowly, by this principle we will understand them to move along with their paths of stationary action anyway, as opposed to remaining quantum mechanical in their motion. So, explicitly speaking, the macroscopic regime offers to us an example of a scenario where "cross-scenario interaction" is driven by something other than quantum interference in the first place: general agreeing superpositions, that is as a logical binary operation. Accordingly, perhaps the root of this hypothesis is that quantum interference is not only separable from cross-scenario interaction for an object, but more specifically that the strict driver of cross-scenario interaction in all circumstances is the state of agreeing superposition. This fundamental principle holds just as well in pure quantum mechanics, just this time where the quantum wave mechanics are also non-negligible, so as to over this medium of allowed-cross-scenario interaction construct the dynamics of quantum motion. But altogether, the central argument is that the root underlying all of this is the new kind of logical primitive[148] which joins alternate scenarios during agreeing superpositions, the onset of which may be tracked by the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning to algorithmic precision.

Three pieces of general doctrine, formerly developed alongside a since-removed macroscopic hypothetical, deserve preservation here in their general form. First, the empirical grounding of the second postulate is *statistical independence*: an attribute stands blank to an Aethus exactly when the standing structure is maximally arranged so as to obscure information about it, and any channel

[147]As a disclaimer, I am also not stating that Dirac's insight on the classical limit of quantum mechanics as the stationary action principle [112] is somehow wrong or without use: rather I am explicitly introducing a logical substrate on which that insight, or anything else you wish, may operate. The fundamental reframing then is that you ought not to make the quantum wavefunction axiomatic and then deduce the macroscopic classical limit in that order: rather the very feature of the quantum wavefunction where alternate possibilities interfere—being notoriously non-classical anyway—finds its ontological root in the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, which thereby is trivially deductively prior to it. In the case of the classical action limit, we simply assert that the "cross-scenario interactive"-ness of quantum mechanics is rooted with the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, such that if you were to remove its effects, then we would get Dirac's classical limit anyway, but without the ability for cross-scenario interference, (with "remove" in this context meaning "reverting to classical", or more formally a "disagreeing superposition"). So what the Aethic fundamental theorem really highlights in this respect is that the ability for cross-scenario interaction so buried into the quantum formalism has an explicit deductively-prior root here, and then we may proceed with deducing the quantum mechanism on top of that, (with the nature of that deduction being the work of *Step X*).

[148]That is, in the sense that classical 'or's, (being disagreeing superpositions, technically), are something of a special case of this underlying logic. That way we can avoid the pitfall of quantum logical antirealism, where quantum logic is assumed to resist transparent algorithmic grounding entirely.

by which the outcome would later leak—however indirect—forces the disagreeing reading instead. Second, the fundamental theorem, procedurally put, substitutes systems in which the steady state of indecisiveness between outcomes is nonzero, (one way or the other), with an agreeing superposition of those outcomes carrying Aethic weights matching those weights of indecisiveness. In the classical world, molecular-entropic interactions—the drivers of quantum decoherence—asymptotically increase with scale, allowing the weights of indecisiveness to be skewed arbitrarily close to zero, to the point where entertaining a nonzero steady state of informational inaccess becomes ridiculous; quantum systems, by contrast, achieve the nonzero steady state through complementarity: no discerning channel exists to be leaked in the first place—which is exactly why Aethic reasoning was never empirically or inductively intuitive until now. Third, the shape of the expectation this leaves: if Aethic reasoning is in any way correct, the strange realm of agreeing-superposition consequences and the grounded world of daily life ought both to arise naturally and predictably from one shared axiomatic structure, precisely as the heavens and the Earth's surface both fell out of Newton's single gravitational law.

8.0.4 The Mechanistic Universe in Agreeing Superpositions

In the section with the Quantum Nexus, it is discussed how there exists an entire regime where agreeing superpositions persist, but without quantum wave mechanics. We might illustrate such a regime with the following table. Hypothetically speaking, then, let us discuss some of the behavior that would be

Table 8: The Two-Mechanism Classical Limit

	Phase visible ($S/\hbar \sim 1$)	**Phase washed** ($S/\hbar \gg 1$)
Coherent (cross-element valid)	**A: standard quantum mechanics.** Electrons in the double slit; full interference. ✓ Recognized	**C: macroscopic Aethic coherence.** Scenarios interact, no wave pattern; the divergence from decoherence bookkeeping located in the text below. × Not a kind standard bookkeeping names
Decohered (cross-element invalid)	**B: decoherence.** Detector active; cross-scenario elements invalid; no interference. ✓ Recognized	**D: the classical world.** Baseballs, planets; both mechanisms suppress quantum effects. ✓ Recognized

expected to exist in such a *Class C*, if it were to exist in practice.

Where Class C parts company with standard decoherence bookkeeping deserves flat statement first, because coherence-persisting-under-isolation is not, by itself, the divergence: that much is the consensus unitary prediction, confirmed by the molecular-interferometry program at ever-greater mass. Nor is the boundary's *location* the divergence: the which-way experiments of the 1990s established, within orthodoxy itself, that information rather than disturbance draws the line—which-path records stored in internal atomic states killed the fringes while momentum kicks orders of magnitude too small stood exonerated [113, 114]—so that literature is precedent for the informational variable, not a seam against it. What distinguishes the Aethic trigger is the boundary's *modality*—the seam lies there. Where a record is rendered irretrievable *in principle*, validity is exact and coherence persists unsuppressed; unitary bookkeeping delivers only practical loss, with in-principle revivals always outstanding. The eraser protocols, pushed to the irreversibility frontier, are the laboratory door into that seam—and the quantification is conditional on the trigger construction booked open as the fifth Open Construction; short of that regime, Class C stands as taxonomy and the other three cells as reproduced physics.

Two general claims that any such macroscopic Class C case would rest on deserve statement in their own right, independent of any particular hypothetical. First, the Union Principle's core claim is doing the work in every such scenario: physical co-presence operates independently of which logical operation produces it, so agreeing superposition's consequences are not owed to quantum wave mechanics—the Union Principle stands as a deeper ontological commitment than quantum mechanics itself. Second, consequences can be genuinely real without constituting the class of information gain that collapses the superposition: knowledge *that* an effect occurred need not reveal *which* alternative produced it, so the third postulate rightly leaves the agreeing structure standing. The Elitzur–Vaidman bomb tester [115] is not such a case, though it is often read as one: with a live bomb the arrangement's record structure separates the arms relative to every index stating the bomb's response, so the dark click is an outcome of the disagreeing regime and not a consequence drawn from standing agreeing structure

(Section 10.9.5); the cases this point concerns are those in which the effect's occurrence leaves the alternatives unseparated.

8.1 The Quantum-Scale Calibration of Macroscopic Class-C Claims

A calibration governs any macroscopic Class C hypothetical, and it takes the form of a constraint I impose on my own framework: any Class C effect must already exist, in some form, at the quantum scale—where coherent effects are easier to produce, not harder. And at that scale, the cross-scenario influence the kernel supplies is interference and only interference. The cross-terms *are* the alternatives affecting one another, confirmed to extraordinary precision; but nowhere in the dynamics does one branch's particle push another branch's—no cross-branch force term exists at any scale, the kernel being scale-uniform. Whatever any macroscopic Class C scenario carries, the double slit must already carry the seed of; and what the double slit carries is fringes, never cross-branch mechanics.

Any mechanical rendering of such hypotheticals—scenarios pictured as interacting like two distinct physical bodies—is therefore to be read at *intuition grade*: the vivid informal face of what the fundamental theorem actually commits to, which is the persistence of the *validity structure itself* to arbitrary scale under genuine irretrievability. What the kernel licenses at the frontier is statistics-grade: coherence persisting where unitary bookkeeping hedges with in-principle revivals, ensemble-detectable through the eraser protocols, conditional on the fifth Open Construction, per the seam located beneath Table 8. The falsification fork survives untouched at exactly that grade—run the protocols as ensembles, and scenario-locked versus coherent dynamics part company wherever coherence genuinely persists, with the classical outcome still falsifying Aethic reasoning outright. The single-shot mechanical picture, by contrast, is what the framework's own accounting already denies: a single-shot consequence that required the superposition while selecting no constituent would be an interference effect, carried by the kernel's cross-terms and never by any fraction of validity—and Class C is the fringe-free cell by its own definition. Tameness at the record-free single shot is a theorem of the framework, in agreement with quantum mechanics; the boldness lives, exactly and only, in the statistics at the frontier.

A lemma belongs here, because the calibration just given brought a structural possibility to my attention, and recording it buys a consistency the section would otherwise leave implicit. Pose—without asserting or deriving it—the following correspondence: *mechanical interaction requires determinate nodes to occur*. Whether this is a property of "matter," or of fundamental particles themselves, is exactly the kind of question the posing leaves open; what matters here is what the correspondence purchases if it holds.

Theorem 10 (Node-Mediated Mechanics Lemma, (conditional))
Under the posed hypothesis that mechanical interaction among matter requires determinate nodes, any path-based agreeing superposition spanning an intermediate region established node-free supports no mechanical cross-branch interaction within that region.

The proof is by contradiction, and it is one breath long. Path-based agreeing superpositions occur *between* determinate nodes—that is the operative architecture, the nodes anchoring and the agreeing structure spanning the intermediate spacetime, (Section 14.2.7; Definition 53). Suppose mechanical cross-branch interaction occurred somewhere in that intermediate span. By the hypothesis, determinate nodes would exist there. But the system Aethus was established as one for which there *are not* intermediate nodes—that is what having the agreeing superposition between the nodes means. Contradiction; so no intermediate determinate nodes, and therefore no mechanical cross-branch interaction. □

The payoff is the division of scope. The Aethic Union Principle keeps its most general applicativity untouched: mutual non-negations among abstract attributes—the which-slit attribute chief among them—remain exactly as the principle states, co-present without restriction. Meanwhile, for strict positional quantities, the fact that only interference is on the table for branch-interaction becomes a *contingency of matter paths*, mediated by the node hypothesis, rather than a reflection back onto the union principle itself. I stress once more that I am not asserting or deriving this interplay between determinate nodes and mechanical interaction; the point is that having the hypothetical correspondence available lets the non-mechanical character operate at the contingency of matter, leaving the union principle at full generality—and it dovetails with the calibration above, since the kernel's cross-terms, the sole surviving intermediate channel, live exactly in the node-free span.

Part IV: Modality, Causation, and Cases

9 Aethic Modality and Causation

9.1 A Formal Semantics for Aethic Counterfactuals

The counterfactual semantics developed in this subsection[149] constitutes the first-principles source, (Section 2.2.1), from which the extrusion principle's block-universe ontology, its preferred-foliation resolution, and its downstream physical applications are all deduced.[150]

The run of this subsection. It places the two readers first, from modal metaphysics and from physics, and fixes for each what is inherited and what is new. It then states the two evaluation modes—selection, Mode S, and perturbation, Mode P—with the flank-importing fallacy as the contrast Mode S is built to exclude, and the property that makes Mode P usable, the ascent's indexing by blankness rather than tense. The scope convention follows, with its three settings, the grain of the clearing, and the partition-consistency law; then where the reopened Aethus lives, the perturbation run at the establishment, the operator's grain, and the trace dealt out. The payoff is a derivation of grammatical mood, and the proper-time implication. The formal clauses come next—what they consume, what a pocket is, how selection meets the two superposition types—followed by the battery of standing cases run in the paper's own vocabulary, the quantum wing, and what remains open.

The streetlight analysis, (Sections 9.6, 9.6.1, and 9.6.2), already contains an entire counterfactual semantics in compressed form—the cat on the landing, the sinkhole, and the breakfast script are, between them, the truth conditions, the context-dependence, and the engineered-dependence clauses of a full theory. This subsection unpacks that compression into explicit clauses and runs the standard battery of problem cases against them, since the compressed form effectively asks the reader to reconstruct the theory for themselves, and that is too much to ask. Nothing below adds machinery: every clause is the second and third postulates plus Aethic weight, exactly as exercised everywhere else in this paper. Please also note, importantly, that the following ontological principle about counterfactuals is, in essence, the content of the Aethic extrusion principle itself[151]: that we ought to store counterfactuals as Aethic superpositions to an Aethus, and drop the concept of possible worlds entirely.

Because readers arrive at this material from two very different directions, let me place the boundary of prior knowledge explicitly, once, for both. For the reader from modal metaphysics: the incumbent theory is the possible-world semantics of Stalnaker and Lewis [15, 16], on which "had A been the case, B would have held" is true just in case B holds at the closest A-worlds under a similarity ordering—an ordering which is the theory's notoriously arbitrary component, and which fifty years of literature has

[149] This chapter keeps the vocabulary in which its semantics was written, and reads by the map of Section 4.9: a stated attribute (α, x) is the determinate state $[\alpha : \{x\}]$, a static Aethus is a representation, presence in an Aethus is membership in its closed content, and the reasoner's *books*, the *ledger* of the sprinklers case, are a representation together with the relation structure that binds it.

[150] *In the formalism of Sections 3.1–4.3.* This chapter keeps its attribute and stated-attribute vocabulary, by the author's direction. A stated-attribute (α, x) here is the determinate state $[\alpha : \{x\}]$, its alternatives are pegs, and a blank is an attribute left unresolved among several pegs (Definition 6). Reopening removes an entry and its supports from a representation and closes again, so the exclusions they licensed go with them (Definition 10).

[151] Short of the invalidity and pruning components, this counterfactual-reimagination idea is what I intuited during my August 2022 epiphany on the extrusion principle, which also happens to be the very constraint which led me to the idea of the Aethic soccer field during the August 22, 2022 journal entry—so hopefully in the context of this counterfactual semantics may it be seen how it was plausible for me to relay such a specific series of insights in quick succession, including a first-principles-based independent rediscovery of quantum [116] decoherence.

What is interesting is that from the epiphany-moment onward in 2022, the vision that accompanied the intuition was the ghost-like outlines of all the things, per-Aethic attribute, which behind closed doors occupied my Aethic block universe with me in disagreeing superposition—and even in the epiphany moment itself I remember the sensation of viewing on a black backdrop a world in which the entire multiverse of possibilities existed as "layers within the room" rather than something "elsewhere"—effectively direct inductive reasoning from how I imagined the wavefunction to ontologically operate having seen the double-slit experiment play out.

probed with a standard battery, (failures of antecedent strengthening, transitivity, and contraposition; the would/might distinction; tie cases like Bizet–Verdi[152]; the Nixon case [117]; the backtracking ambiguity). What is new here is that the similarity ordering is deleted rather than refined: closeness becomes validity-plus-weight, the "worlds" relocate from elsewhere into co-present pockets of the one block universe, and actuality becomes Aethus-indexed, [118]—so the battery must be re-run, and is, below.

For the reader from physics: the familiar landmark is counterfactual definiteness, the premise that Bell-type arguments [4] require and that quantum mechanics refuses; what is new here is a semantics on which that refusal comes out as a theorem while counterfactual discourse remains fully truth-apt—counterfactual substance without counterfactual definiteness. (One shape-remark, provable from the construction and recorded because it makes the non-representability's geometry visible: under the uniform conjunctive reading, and wherever the reopenings are nested, conjoining a held consequence only ever *adds* pockets (without nesting, a joint support and a priority between its members make Cut fail: a state stating a generalization p and a particular r, with $\{p, \neg y\}$ and $\{p, r, x\}$ invalid and the priorities keeping p, has $X \mathrel{|\!\sim} Y$ and $X \wedge Y \mathrel{|\!\sim} r$ but $X \not\mathrel{|\!\sim} \neg r$) — Cut transfers universally quantified conclusions backward along the inclusion, Cautious Monotony would require the reverse inclusion, and the countermodel's escaping pockets are exactly the additions.)

Two evaluation modes, both already on display. The streetlight evaluation is what I will call Mode S, selection: the antecedent attribute—the light's color—was genuinely open in the standing superposition of the prior Aethus, pockets carrying both values already exist, and to evaluate "had the light been green" is to perform precisely the attribute perturbation of the gravity-assist discussion: swap the stated value across the standing pockets, discarding nothing by hand, since the third postulate has already done all the discarding there is, and read the consequent off what remains.

What Mode S excludes: the flank-importing fallacy. The gravity-assist discussion's flank-importing fallacy belongs here in this section's own terms, as the illustrative contrast Mode S is built to exclude, (its full shape—the witnessing Aethus, the flanks, the three-step import—is unpacked at Section 9.7.6). Let P and F range over stated-attributes, past-directed and future-directed. What the contingent-Aethus constructions of that discussion establish is an existence schema: for every pair (P, F) admitting a wiring at all, there exists an Aethus $R_{P,F}$ relative to which perturbing P shifts the weight of F. The classical determinate chain then performs an illicit quantifier exchange, (the quantifier-shift fallacy of elementary logic [119], committed here across Aethae): from $\forall(P, F)\, \exists\, R_{P,F}$ it concludes $\exists\, R \forall F$—a single Aethus in which one selected past attribute enforces every concurrent future attribute at once. The exchange fails because the witness varies with the pair: each demonstrated connection is fixed relative to its own $R_{P,F}$, the flank attributes of distinct witnesses need not cohere, and no single Aethus need contain all that can be found across Aethae individually. The fallacy is classical causality's, and nothing in it is load-bearing here. Mode S excludes it by construction: an evaluation fixes one Aethus, the swap runs across that Aethus's standing pockets alone, and every flank retains exactly the standing it has there—the fact the battery prices below as flank-independence, and the reason the dial's scopes clear posterity while keeping the flanks.

Mode P, perturbation proper. The sinkhole evaluation, looked at carefully, is the second mode in narrative form: relative to the sinkhole-aware Aethus the antecedent's consequences are already wired in, and the honest evaluation *ascends*—back to the at-the-light Aethus, in which the sinkhole's existence and its entire underground history still sat in disagreeing superposition—and evaluates there. Mode P, perturbation proper, is exactly that ascent made into an operator, for antecedents whose attribute is already *stated* in the evaluating Aethus: ascend the genealogy to the nearest ancestor Aethus in which the antecedent attribute is blank—a first picture, to be refined shortly into the scope settings and the constructed evaluation point—; restate it there to the counterfactual value; hold fixed an explicit informational boundary $\mathcal{B}$, (the attributes the evaluation refuses to re-open); and re-run second- and third-postulate pruning over the result. Call the surviving weighted structure the residue,

[152]Interestingly, what happened with my unexpected Bizet–Verdi connection in June 2026 is a precise parallel illustration to what was happening in late 2023 and 2024 as I gradually learned enough physics foundations literature to holds its open questions up next to the already complete Aethic apparatus, (despite it feeling relatively anticlimactic now that some time has passed). Some of the major cases of this were Wigner's friend [30], the growing block versus static block universe paradox [18, 19, 21, 22], and delayed-choice [10]: not a single one of which I was aware of until after I completed the inductive reasoning and derivational establishment of the Aethic framework—only to come across the stunning feeling that the fit was almost as though designed, even though of course it was not. In retrospect, however, the real question is probably more peculiar still—if the Aethic framework is right, then that would make it reflect the real world, so the burden of surprise lands on why the specific conceptual miscalculations in each field's paradigm came to exist in the first place, as if passed along through the origin of Western philosophy from some unspecified set of assumptions made sometime before.

$R_{A;\mathcal{B}}$. Notice what has happened to Lewis's "small miracle": it has become an auditable bookkeeping operation. Nothing in spacetime is edited and no foreign world is manufactured; a page of the books is reopened at a named place, restated, and re-pruned.

The ascent is indexed by blankness, not by tense. One property of the ascent deserves flat statement, because Mode P is unusable without it: the ascent is indexed by *blankness*, not by tense. The nearest ancestor in which the antecedent attribute is blank is an informational waypoint rather than a temporal one—*blanks lack tense*, (the indiscriminate time principle, Principle 11)—so the attribute reopened there may sit anywhere in the block universe relative to proper time, arbitrarily earlier or later than the moment it ceased to be blank for the evaluating observer, (Section 12.6.1). The Aethus is linked to the observer; the events its attributes refer to are linked to anywhere in the block universe, attributes standing one abstraction level above localized events. This is the structural mechanism already exercised narratively by the Battle of Brémule and by Jenny's Japanese, (Sections 2.2 and 5.4.7), and it is what licenses Mode P against antecedents about the deep past without any whiff of retrocausation: the reopening is an operation on the books, not on spacetime.

A refinement discovered under adversarial review deserves a permanent home here, because it enlarges the semantics rather than patching it. The genealogical ascent just described and the synchronic alternative—restrict the books to a maximal deductively closed sub-state in which the antecedent is blank, then restate—are *not* one operation: on multi-entry books they return different verdicts. Take the Kennedy books of an evaluator who has stated both the shooter and the death. The ascent, run naively, climbs past the assassination and clears the death along with the shot; the synchronic restriction keeps the death, whose entry enjoys evidential support independent of the shooter's identity. One antecedent, two defensible residues—and the difference, far from being a defect, is the semantics' expressive joint.

What a reopening clears is therefore hereby declared a *convention with three named settings*. *Evidential-minimal*: clear the antecedent's entry and its deductive cone only, keeping everything that enjoys independent support. *Unidirectional*: clear the antecedent together with the generic constraints wired to it on the direction convention's forward side, (its recorded effects, the direction a convention the books carry rather than a fact the constraints contain)—the default setting everywhere in this paper, and the standard subjunctive's. Those causal entries themselves bottom out one layer further down, in the constraint-layer account of Section 5.2.2: causal gadgets as emergent, direction-relative readings mined from the attributes' disjointness content—the account that removes the last ad hoc residue from this menu. *Bidirectional*: run the clearing across every generic constraint wired to the antecedent, direction-blind—the backtracking setting, and the one the constraints' own ordering-impartial form natively supports. Two operations, indicative selection and subjunctive reopening, with mood selecting between them and, for the subjunctive, the scope; the reopening acts on the state itself at that scope and never pocket by pocket, and since the scope does verdict-determining work it belongs as a convention on any honest inventory of the framework's equipment, alongside the dependency structure the books carry.

The grain of the clearing. One structural refinement is recorded here because the decomposability battery of Section 3 makes it available. The remainder's clearing acts, in full generality, at the *decomposition* grain rather than the entry grain: where a stated-attribute rests on the perturbed attribute only through some of its components—the attribute standing, in the mined reading, as a construction over input entries of which the target is one—the operation blanks the dependent component and leaves the independently supported components stated, so that the attribute enters a *mixed decomposition*: blank-decomposable exactly in the reopened component, state-decomposable in the remainder, a constrained superposition ranging over the cleared slot alone. Entry-wise clearing, as in the worked settings above, is the special case in which the decompositions in play are trivial; nothing in the three scope settings changes under the refinement, since each setting legislates *which* dependencies travel, while the decomposition grain legislates only *how finely* the traveling is executed.

The forward mirror: synchronic projection, and the partition-consistency law. The discipline just developed—evaluation that addresses the past without visiting it—has a forward mirror to which the framework is committed with equal force, and it governs *prediction*: the forecasting of an attribute's pickup at any horizon whatsoever. Because the descendant relation is transitive, with the attributes establishing multiple generations compressible into a single Aethus, a far-term attribute prices as a *direct* weighted child of the current Aethus, (Definition 36), and it prices *now*: the defined quantities are the weight ratios of the present books, (Principle 22), and the far weight does not depend on any chosen itinerary: it is defined at the present books, computing it requires no traversal of intermediate acquisitions, and a finer resolution, where one is traversed, returns the same weight by the partition-

consistency law below. The weights simply are the weights, fixed at the present Aethus regardless of when, or whether, realization arrives. Treating a chosen itinerary as what defines them would be the forward-facing cousin of the genealogical ascent demoted above, and the two demotions are one architecture: the establishment addresses the past without visiting it, the compressed descendant addresses the future without traversing it, the Aethic tree consulted in both directions as structure and never as itinerary. (The historical record deserves its pointer: the forward half of this discipline appears, in the author's own working words, in the April 2025 correspondence of Section 13.13.2, deployed there before the backward half had been formalized at all.)

One refinement keeps the doctrine honest, and it is the load-bearing one. Nothing above forbids structure *along the way*: it is entirely permissible—expected, even—that proper child Aethae along an interpolating route carry *changed* relative weights for the not-yet-resolved attribute, since a mid-route Aethus has stated things the original had blank, and conditioning on the stated is exactly what weights are for. The law sits at the partition grain: *summing over all proper child Aethae of an exhaustive Aethic partition reproduces the weights of the original Aethus exactly.* Routes may redistribute; the exhaustive sum is invariant. This is the shape classical probability knows as the law of total probability, here recorded as the weighted layer's consistency commitment—consonant with the last-common-ancestor quotient's accounting, under which shared information is counted once however the partition slices it—with its formal derivation from the reduced-form machinery standing as a natural target of the weighted program rather than a claim made here.

And the law has a consequence already argued in this paper from another direction, which the tie deserves to make explicit. The exemption from Pusey–Barrett–Rudolph developed in Section 10.3.3 ran through the Determinate Background Paradox, with a precise nesting mechanism doing the work: other agents genuinely hold different disagreeing-superposition weights for mixed states, while standing, relative to any given Aethus, as disagreeing superpositions themselves—whose weight-average reproduces that Aethus's own weighting exactly. The partition-consistency law is that same resistance in formal dress, and it needs no other observer at all: an exhaustive refinement of the agreeing superposition into determinate children adds *no weight information* beyond the original—the sum gives the original back exactly—so no passage to a "more determinate underlying description" ever converts the superposition Aethus into an ignorance-mixture with different empirical content. The original's weights already exhaust what any exhaustive partition can say about it; the determinate background that PBR-style reasoning quantifies over is, in the Aethic algebra, a partition whose arithmetic returns you to where you began. Where the earlier section stated the exemption through the contingency of observers, the law states it through the invariance of partitions—one immunity, argued from the indexing and from the arithmetic.

Where the reopened Aethus lives. A subtlety the ascent picture obscures deserves flat statement, because a careful reader will press on it. The evaluation point a scope setting produces is, in general, *not an ancestor*. In the streetlight–sinkhole interleaving the evaluator learned of the light before the sinkhole; the unidirectional reopening of the light must nonetheless *keep* the sinkhole, (it is not wired forward of the light, nor wired to it at all), so the reopened state carries the sinkhole stated and the light blank—an information state the evaluator's genealogy never contained, its acquisition order a fiction. This is licensed rather than smuggled. Aethae are defined as mathematical objects, (equivalence classes of static Aethae), independently of being anyone's actual epistemic stop; the Aethic tree contains them all, and a genealogy is one observer's *path* through a space that exists unwalked.[153]

[153]A convergence record, kept at the author's direction so a reader can follow how this doctrine settled. The general, synchronic conception—path-arbitrariness, the parent relation universal over descent orders, (the passage below)—was the author's original vision. (The section's own drafting history—the field identified to the author, the draft directed the following day, the corrections composed during an access pause—is recorded in the provenance note above.) For pedagogical purposes the author then leaned, over some months, on the genealogical tree-walk as a teaching picture; the aid paid for itself twice over: one AI collaborator caught the seed of the formal semantics from the picture's worked instances, and an adversarial AI reviewer then caught the picture's limits—the over-clearing failure and the off-ancestor cases—driving the formalism back to the general form as originally envisioned. The author's own earliest intuition about constructed evaluation points, held from the first drafting of the sinkhole discussion, was confirmed en route. Pedagogy seeded the formalization; the formalization returned home. The record continues: pressing on the settings' reliance on "cause" then drew from the author, in the same session, the constraint-layer articulation of Section 5.2.2—causality demoted to emergent gadgetry over the disjointness layer, with the Newton-in-the-model's-universe posture fixing the claim's scope—so the causality leg ran: doctrine, generalization, and then the ground beneath both. The session's remaining yield, logged to the same end: the three-layer refinement with its Newton-in-the-model's-universe posture, relocated at the author's direction to the fundamental theorem's home, (Section 5.2.2); the pedagogical-exercises subsection, (Section 9.5); the knife-edge thesis, stated at Kevin's side; the accidentalism disambiguation; the positive parent-Aethus reformulation of intrinsic support, (the author's correction); the explicit Definition 50 of Aethic conditional probability, installed upon the author's ownership restatement of the agnostic-indicative computation; the factor-level annihilation proof of the believer's vanishing denominator, (the author's original second demonstration, recorded in the

The ascent is therefore a picture, and the operation is construction: the scope setting names which entries the constructed Aethus keeps, and the class supplies the Aethus. The framework has met off-path Aethae before, (the surrogate-time constructions, Section 11.2.2), and causal verdicts read at such points are unproblematic for the reason all Aethic causality is: couplings hold *relative to an Aethus*, visited or constructed, (Section 9.7.3).

Running the Aethic perturbation at the establishment. No new operation is introduced here, and no new term is wanted: what follows is the one synchronic Aethic perturbation of the clauses above, which has been the formalism throughout—the genealogical ascent was never the operation but a pedagogical picture, (the on-ramp the Fallacy of Initial Conditions section rides, and rides well). What deserves recording is a disciplined special case of the σ-choice. Every stated attribute enters the centric unfolding by a definite Aethic intersection, and that establishment is recorded as structure; so the perturbation of a stated attribute may be run at *that single establishment*—a σ-choice that keeps every other entry standing. This recovers the site-specificity the genealogical intuition was reaching for while inheriting none of its defects: no ancestry is walked, no over-clearing occurs on multi-entry books, and—the point the Fallacy of Initial Conditions, (Section 9.6), makes doctrinal—no causal order is consulted anywhere, because the establishment record is derivational bookkeeping within the unfolding, never a causal past being traced. The state of a system is a function of the observer's Aethus, not of its initial conditions; the perturbation, run in this form, is that sentence applied to counterfactuals.

The empirical discipline. For *empirical* Aethae, one further discipline keeps the form honest against the Fundamental Theorem of Empirical Aethae, (Theorem 8): the retargeting must never require constructing the establishing intersection itself, which the theorem denies a physical agent almost surely; it requires only that the named stated-attribute be reducible to an *arbitrary parent* Aethus of that establishment, any parent's mathematical ideal serving as the handle in exactly the categorical-abstraction sense. In the fully abstract case the exact establishment is available and no such reduction is mandatory—the discipline is empirical-adequacy armor, not a constraint on the mathematics.[154]

Remark there); the commutative-semiring sweep; and the pronunciation footnotes. Each item carries its own provenance comment in the source.

[154]Why the definitional hierarchy runs through stated attributes at all deserves its motivation recorded once, here, where the alternative is closest to hand. The tempting *reading*—taking the on-ramp picture literally, as though counterfactual evaluation were defined by walking a centric unfolding back to the branch point and re-running it—under-captures what an Aethus is, and in an exact way: the ascent surrenders *every* intersection acquired past the branch point, wholesale, entries with independent standing that the counterfactual never questioned included, so the reopened point is strictly poorer than the Aethus being interrogated. Adversarial review sharpened the diagnosis twice over: on multi-entry books the tree-walk demonstrably over-clears, and the correct evaluation point is in general not an ancestor at all, so no amount of walking backward reaches it—the operation must construct a new point in the space of Aethae. And stated-attribute indexing is not a repair arriving late; it is the root the formalism stood on throughout, the review having clarified the pedagogical picture's status rather than changed the operation: with every attribute carried as standing structure rather than as a position in a history, evaluation touches exactly the establishment in question while every independently supported intersection stands. The hierarchy is founded on stated attributes precisely so that counterfactual reasoning never has to choose between site-specificity and the full richness of the Aethus it interrogates. And a second motivation runs just as deep: a semantics offering multiple hand-selected causal modes of perturbation makes causality itself a primitive the evaluator must enforce—which mode applies, and when, becomes legislation imposed from outside the structure. The stated-attribute route is the Newtonian alternative, (Section 12.6): no force is ever invented out of nothing—classical mechanics is inferred *outward* from a buzzing substrate whose molecular detail no one commands—and the model-builder's one legitimate act is to insist the substrate implies the law. So here: causal gadgets are mined from the structure's own invalid attribute-combinations, the pruning already encoding which co-settings cannot stand, and even the *direction* of a mined gadget is the reader's perspective rather than the structure's—the same invalid intersection reads as "not green implies not proceed" from one Aethus and as "proceed implies green" from its backtracked sibling, the invalidity alone being what exists, (the causal-gadget articulation of Section 5.2.2, beside Theorem 8, unpacks this in full). Causation thereby arrives as a *verdict* of the semantics rather than a parameter fed to it, in exactly the register the Fallacy of Initial Conditions makes doctrinal.

The relation between this formulation and the original definitional hierarchy, (Section 3.1), deserves its differences stated case by case, because the two divide labor rather than compete. The notation here writes attributes as assignments—$A(q) = v$, $A(q) = *$—a flat surface built for communication and proof; the hierarchy of Section 3.1 builds the same objects by graded construction: the 0-Aethus consistent with the epistemic K-operator, then the decisive break—*class instantiation in place of Boolean variables*—then blanks as generative structure, the 3-Aethus equivalence landing strictly finer than validity. Three differences carry the weight. *Type*: the notation's bare q tempts a reader to treat attributes as primitives one may simply write down; the hierarchy's class instantiation forbids exactly that temptation from the ground floor. *Origin*: the notation never routes through knowledge, while the hierarchy grows out of the K-operator and then departs from it, recording where epistemic logic was outgrown rather than ignored. *Instantiation versus emergence*—the working difference: for empirical Aethae the fundamental theorem denies instantiation outright, so the disciplined construction of a named stated-attribute is emergent, exactly as above—select the intersected Aethus of the centric unfolding along which the attribute originally came, then select the parent within it that approximates the attribute sought. The notation is the surface; the hierarchy is the discipline; the perturbation, run at the establishment, is where the two meet.

And the doctrine has a deeper root, which was in fact my original motivation for what I have long privately thought of as the *beauty of the parent Aethus concept*. Relative to your current Aethus, your own path—the particular order in which centric unfolding delivered your entries—is *arbitrary*: nothing in the standing state remembers, or privileges, the order of its own assembly. One can therefore equally imagine dropping attributes off sequentially in some other order entirely—an *alternative backtracking*—and against such imagined descents, even one's own actual trek through the tree holds no privileged status relative to the current Aethus itself. The consequence is genuinely vertiginous: alternative backtrackings can assemble weirdly cohesive worlds, and within your own Aethic structure they are equally "relevant" to your Aethus in the reality sense—the parent relation is universal over descent orders, not a memorial to the one that happened. The scope menu above is this universality made disciplined: three conventional shapes of imagined descent, selected by mood, with one's autobiography merely the single descent one happens to hold receipts for.

The operator's grain, stated once precisely. The perturbation is two operations selected by mood, and neither is computed pocket by pocket. Under the subjunctive settings it is computed from restrictions of the state itself, the priority-selected maximal closed blank restrictions at the scope setting, one where the priorities select one and several where they tie or rank incomparable maxima, each restated and re-pruned and the residue the union over them, never by completing the state and reopening its completions one by one, which computes a different operation, and the choice denies centering for stated antecedents with stated grounds; under the indicative setting it is *selection*, the pockets in which the antecedent fails discarded and the rest renormalized, with no reopening at all. The traditional "two modes" are these two operations, not limits of one rule. The two operations part on the agnostic Adams evaluator, death stated and the shooter blank at weight w_O: the subjunctive reopens the shooting at posterity scope, which clears the death with it, restates the antecedent and re-prunes, so that "someone else would have" holds only in pockets where another assassin already stood on the books, and its grade is near zero for every w_O; the indicative selects the pockets in which Oswald did not shoot, in all of which the death stands, and comes out true at grade one for every positive credence in the antecedent, the grade being the conditional proportion in the standing residue and not the antecedent's marginal credence, which is where an evaluator all but certain of ¬Oswald is expressed. The believer's own indicative, having no pocket in which the antecedent holds, has an empty selection and no indicative verdict, the counterfactual there being the subjunctive's. A grade of $1 - w_O$ for the subjunctive, interpolating toward the indicative as $w_O \to 0$, was a property of a pocket-wise procedure and is withdrawn with it. A mood-sensitive graded verdict for uncertain evaluators is structure no binary semantics produces; and under the indicative setting the operator computes conditional probability outright, since selection followed by renormalization *is* conditioning by the Bayesianism section's theorem—so Adams's thesis, that indicative credence goes by conditional credence, arrives as a theorem of the semantics rather than a constraint imposed on it [120], and the probability wing retroactively guarantees the semantics wing.

The trace, dealt out. Set the books: Kennedy's death *stated*, the shooter *blank*, so the standing residue holds two pockets—O (Oswald did it) at weight w_O, and E (someone else did) at weight $1 - w_O$—each carrying *the shot caused the death* in its own causal record. Evaluate the subjunctive, *if Oswald hadn't shot him, someone else would have*; mood sets both switches: posterity scope, and reopening of the state itself. The shooter is already blank, so the greatest shooter-blank restriction of the state at posterity scope is the state with the recorded posterity of the shot cleared, the death among it, in every pocket at once: reopening is global, not per pocket, and the concordant pocket E is not exempt, since the operation restricts the state and does not select among its completions. Restate no-shot-by-Oswald and re-prune: with no conspiracy entry anywhere on the books, nothing regenerates the death, so the residue holds he-lives pockets beside second-shooter pockets carried at small positive weight w_S, visible against the rest. *Aggregate*: would false, might true only through those pockets, grade small and positive, w_S against the whole residue, and the same for every w_O; pockets at exactly zero weight would be no proper children and would sustain neither reading. The credence-sensitivity a per-pocket procedure would produce, a grade near $1 - w_O$ converging on the indicative as $w_O \to 0$, is not a property of this operator; what an evaluator all but certain it wasn't Oswald means is carried by the indicative, which—contrary pocket discarded, E selected—returns true at grade one, which *is* the conditional credence: Adams's thesis, computed. The two moods part company at every w_O, which is the Adams pair's point.

The payoff is a small derivation of a piece of grammar.[155] Natural language marks a distinction

[155]A provenance note, recorded so that no credit inflates in either direction. The extrusion principle—and with it the underlying ontology this semantics runs on—is entirely the author's, dating to August 2022, (Section 13.10.1). Its

the tradition calls *mood*: the indicative conditional, *if Oswald didn't shoot Kennedy, someone else did*, against the subjunctive, *if Oswald hadn't shot Kennedy, someone else would have*—Adams's famous pair, on which competent speakers give opposite verdicts, (the first true, the second false, absent a conspiracy). On the present semantics the pair falls out of the scope settings. Each sentence is best run from the evaluator who would naturally assert it, (the indexing doing pragmatic work). The *agnostic's* indicative runs evidential-minimal by selection: the death, independently supported, stays stated, every surviving pocket is a someone-else pocket—true. The *believer's* subjunctive runs unidirectional by reopening: the death, downstream of the shot, is cleared, and with no conspirator on the books the would fails while the mights survive—false, exactly as the speakers say. Mood selects the operation and, for the subjunctive, its scope; the two operations share the pruning and the weighting and are otherwise distinct. Grammatical mood, on this account, is the species' surface marking for a scope convention the semantics makes explicit.[156]

One well-definedness matter, surfaced by the same review, is settled the same way. On multi-support books, "the maximal restriction in which q is blank" can fail to be unique: state $\{p,\ p \to q\}$, and blanking q can drop either member—the remainder-set problem the belief-revision literature was built around [121]. The framework's tie-breaker is *computed rather than chosen*: laws over particulars, with an entry's generality read off its own quantificational form. Gärdenfors and Makinson proved entrenchment-style priorities ordering-equivalent to the sphere systems [122], so the calibrated statement of this section's deletion claim is the following: the ordering is absent as a primitive and unappealed to in any clause, with any selective structure the clauses consult *derived from stated content*; and whether *no* ordering semantics can generate the indexed, weighted, multi-pocket verdict function is posed as a standing formal challenge—a non-representability theorem that would secure the strong reading outright, against the equivalence results that retired the last such claim [123, 124]. (A boundary for the belief-revision reader: verdicts are evaluated *at* books and never stored *in* them as entries; conditionals are not bookable attributes, which is what keeps the Ramsey-test triviality results [125] from getting started.)

The nearest existing ordering-free rival should be named as well: structural-equations semantics, where counterfactuals are interventions on a causal model [126, 127]. The perturbation is intervention-shaped—clear the variable, set it, re-run—and the differentia are provenance and type: the intervention graph is causal-nomological and modeler-supplied, while the graph here is deductive-*and*-causal-as-stated—provenance from the books rather than from the modeler, the causal entries as content, the dependency structure as the booked equipment. The index then does modal work no intervention performs: tense-free reopening anywhere in proper time, a weighted multi-pocket residue rather than a single revised model, and the quantum continuation this paper runs the machinery into. (The clause-by-clause embedding of the structural family—Pearl's do-surgery, Woodward's ideal-intervention conditions, and the three places where the embedding is deliberately not an isomorphism—is performed in Section 12.6.3, and is not duplicated here.)

The proper-time implication, stated flatly. It deserves saying without ornament, because it is the single most counterintuitive consequence a first-time reader will meet: the entire proper-time past history of the sinkhole—every year of underground erosion, sitting decades deep in the block—is updated by an Aethic update occurring well afterwards. Disagreeing superpositions are Aethus-indexed, (Sections 2.4.7 and 12.6.1), so when the update occurs, circumstances shift no matter how far away in proper time they sit in the block universe. And the indexing deserves its exact statement, because

formulation as a modal semantics has its own dated history, recorded here in full for the same honesty. In a June 2026 exchange, Claude, (Anthropic's Fable 5 model), identified modal semantics as the standing academic field the extrusion principle was speaking to—a subject of which the author had, until that exchange, been entirely unaware. The author directed the drafting of the present section the following day, (to the author's best recollection), and, while access limits paused the collaboration, composed the corrections documents and the union-principle clarifications against which the drafted section was subsequently revised. Throughout, the author's own worked instances—the streetlight cases especially, (Section 9.6.1)—were what the formal clauses were reconstructed from. The mood result specifically was then *machine-found within the author's framework*: a second, independent Fable instance, deployed as an adversarial referee on the companion short paper, checked a drafted footnote that had assigned the Adams pair to the evaluation modes, found that the assignment does not run on the paper's own definitions, and traced the failure to a false coincidence claim between the genealogical and synchronic pictures of reopening—the repair yielding the three-setting scope menu, with mood as its selector. The fundamentals are the author's alone; the grammar derivation is what those fundamentals produced under adversarial machine review.

[156] Morgenbesser's coin passes for free on the subjunctive setting: had you bet differently, the coin—not in the bet's causal posterity—stays fixed, and "you would have won" comes out true. (Interventionists pass the coin natively as well—*do*(bet) preserves causally independent variables—so the coin is a shared advantage over the similarity tradition, not a differentia; the differentia that holds is *backtracking*, which do-surgery renders inexpressible by severing incoming arrows, while here it is a setting on the menu.)

a natural paraphrase gets it subtly wrong. The naive gloss—"for fifty years the erosion *was* in superposition"—quietly smuggles objectivity back in, narrating the superposition as a tensed condition the world itself occupied. The correct statement is per-point and per-Aethus: *each arbitrary point of block-universe proper time* across those fifty years holds the erosion in disagreeing superposition *relative to a given Aethus*, for exactly as long as that Aethus carries the attribute blank—and the moment the Aethus confirms the sinkhole's existence or nonexistence, every one of those same arbitrary proper-time points holds it determinate, relative to the updated books. Nothing about the points changed; the index did. (And the case is graded where it is used: the sinkhole is record-rich—the eroded ground is itself a record—so its superposition is disagreeing, and for that sector the classical reading is keepable at the architectural price the Permanence Proposition's scope note states, Section 3.4.4; the framework's empirical stake lives where records run out. The example is chosen for the reach of the move, not as its evidence.) This is the framework's flexibility-adding move stated at full generality: any point of the block may be indexed against any Aethus—including an Aethus attached to an observer situated at any other moment of the block whatsoever—and it is precisely this free cross-indexing, unavailable to any tensed metaphysics, that renders the classic quantum thought experiments below comprehensible rather than paradoxical. This is Wheeler's central intuition about quantum mechanics—his cosmological delayed-choice argument, in which the routing of a photon around a gravitational lens billions of years in the proper-time past is settled by an astronomer's present choice of apparatus [10]—rendered ontologically routine: not a paradox at the edge of physics but the unremarkable, everyday behavior of any attribute that was blank, quantum and classical alike, (Section 10.9.4).

The clauses. With W_R the Aethic weight over the residue:

- **Would.** "Had A, it would be that B" is true at the evaluating Aethus iff B holds on every pocket of $R_{A;\mathcal{B}}$ of non-negligible weight—equivalently $W_R(B) = 1$, with the refinements of Section 6.7 available to separate null-weight failure from genuine failure.

- **Might.** "Had A, it might be that B" is true iff B holds on some pocket of $R_{A;\mathcal{B}}$ of non-null weight.

- **Grade.** The graded counterfactual takes the value $W_R(B)$ itself. This is the formal face of the philosophy-of-probability footnote in the gravity-assist discussion: the replaceability of contingent attributes is *ontological* rather than methodological, which is exactly what licenses reading W_R as the probability that lives on counterfactuals—chancy counterfactuals are first-class citizens here, not an afterthought.

Centering holds by construction: if A is already stated true, the ascent is null, the residue is the evaluating structure itself, and $A \wedge B$ secures the would-counterfactual. One convention is deliberately left open as a recorded choice point: when pruning annihilates the residue entirely, the standard options are vacuous truth or a designated failure value, and the null-set refinements already separate "true on none" from "true on a null set"—the selection among conventions is flagged rather than smuggled in.

What the clauses consume, exactly. Because a semantics earns trust by the shortness of its assumption list, let the list be stated outright—and audited against the framework's own books. The weight W_R is nothing new: it is the Aethic tree's own measure, (the weighted formulation of Section 6.7), restricted to the residue and renormalized over it. The license to read that renormalized weight as a *probability* is not an extra postulate but exactly the weight–probability equivalence already on the books, together with its Probabilistic Identity—the same identity that powers the Aethic Partition Theorem's proof. The guarantee that W_R *exists* at all is likewise inherited rather than assumed: for physically existent Aethae, the Nexus Principle requires every blank attribute to carry a weighting scheme, so the residue of any physical antecedent arrives already weighted, (and for a *reopened* blank the scheme is the Aethus's own retained one, recovered from its invalid terms rather than posited afresh—Section 9.4.1, fourth structural fact)—while for merely mathematical Aethae the grade may be undefined even as the would- and might-clauses remain available through validity alone, which is the correct asymmetry rather than a defect. The renormalization is the identical pruning-and-reflow operation performed in the Monty Hall working, (Section 11.1), and it is well-defined on Aethae, rather than merely on chosen static-Aethus representatives, because every quantity involved is invariant under validity equivalence, (Section 4.6.3): invalid components carry zero weight by the Probabilistic Identity, so they can disturb neither the restriction nor the normalization. The complete inventory is therefore: the second and third postulates; the Aethic tree of the weighted formulation, whose parent relation is what Mode P's ascent traverses; the weight–probability equivalence with its Probabilistic Identity; the Nexus Principle; and validity equivalence. No similarity metric, no independent probability axioms,

and no modal primitive beyond the perturbation operator itself is consumed anywhere above—and any future refinement of the weight structure, (per the Open Constructions), propagates into the grades automatically, since the grades were never anything over and above that structure.

What a pocket is, exactly. Since the clauses quantify over pockets of the residue, the term deserves the same standard of explicitness. The pockets of the residue are joined by *addition over Aethae*—the sum of the weighted formulation, (Sections 6.7 and 4.7)—and are therefore pockets in the occupiable, Aethus-valued sense of the ladder ontology, (Section 2.4.7): each is a candidate subsequent block universe, and a full agreeing superposition counts as *one* pocket, not several. The attribute union is a different operation entirely, composing an agreeing superposition *within* a pocket, (Sections 2.4.2 and 2.4.3); the union-principle discussion accordingly reserves the word "pockets" in its pedagogy for the attribute-union-combined sense, and the two senses are reconciled formally where the ladder ontology distinguishes Aethae from pseudo-Aethae. Conflating the two operations collapses the agreeing–disagreeing distinction the semantics is required to preserve. What the clauses consume about agreeing superpositions, meanwhile, is a single structural fact: *irreducibility*. An agreeing superposition admits no valid proper child Aethus in which its attribute is state-decomposable—it is elementary in the decomposability sense, on a par with a determinate value, only in a different ontological register—and a blank attribute that *does* decompose validly into state-decomposable children is thereby in disagreeing superposition instead, (Section 2.4.7). The clauses consume this behavior and nothing finer: the present formalization realizes it through the foundations of Section 3.1, but no clause here depends on that realization, so the semantics remains robust to refinements of the underlying construction.

How selection meets the two superposition types. Both evaluation modes bottom out in the selection operator—centric unfolding—whose action is intersection: a new stated-attribute is intersected into the standing structure, and what survives is read off validity. On a *disagreeing* superposition the intersection behaves exactly as the union principle's interior-negation analysis predicts, (Section 2.4.4): the pocket carrying the matching state survives, and the pruning of every alternative is performed by that pocket's own interior—the stated value arrives conjoined with the negations of its rivals, so each rival drops as an invalid Aethus (This is the complement mechanism of Section 4.7.4 at work in the clauses: intersecting the stated attribute B into the standing structure A leaves the residue AB, and every rival lives in $A - AB$—so the counterfactual clauses never negate; they select, and the selection's remainder *is* the negation, valued at validity equivalence like everything else the verdicts read.) through the nonexistence component the surviving pocket itself enforces; negate the surviving pocket's asserted state instead, or break its interior conjunction, and it is the reference pocket that is pruned. Selection over disagreeing structure is in this sense *intersection-invalidation*: alternatives are not discarded by an external choice but invalidated by the interior content of what was selected.

Selection on agreeing structure: no singleton to save. On an *agreeing* superposition the same intersection finds no singleton to save: the superposed states form an irreducible package, and intersecting any specific value contradicts that package as a whole, so second-postulate-mode pruning invalidates the entire structure at once, (Section 3.4.4). This is the prohibition on singleton selection: no state can be copied out of an agreeing superposition as a standalone determinate fact, and every stated occurrence of a value—or every agreeing superposition invoking it—is its own separate copy. The double-slit configuration with detectors off is the canonical demonstration, (Section 6.1 and Theorem 14): adjoining a specific traversal to the standing agreeing superposition is precisely the construction the structure forbids, and this prohibition is the formal engine behind the quantum wing's failure of counterfactual definiteness below.

Two clause-level consequences follow, one per superposition type.

- Over a weight-tied *disagreeing* residue, both would-counterfactuals fail while both might-counterfactuals hold—the tie behavior exercised on Bizet–Verdi below.

- Over an *agreeing* residue that is itself what survives the pruning—not droppable in favor of any disjoint alternative in the residue—the loosening runs in the opposite direction, and it splits along the union principle's own categorical separation of logical structure from physical occupation, (Section 2.4.2). Read on the physical side—"is this state realized?"—the would-clause is satisfied by *multiple disjoint states at once*, since each is permanently and non-collapsibly co-present in the surviving structure: for the purposes of what is *there* in the residue, an undroppable agreeing superposition behaves the way selected determinate content does, while differing from it precisely in reducibility. This is Definition 28 read on the residue: *would* a holds when the weight of valid pockets that declare a false is zero, and an irreducible agreeing state containing a meets that condition as fully as a state stating a does, which is why the physical reading is satisfied by

each co-present state. To read this "would" as "actualized exclusively," one alternative obtaining and the others not, is to carry a classical presumption across a paradigm boundary, exactly as carrying an invariant length across the relativistic boundary is: length survives that crossing as a frame-indexed quantity and not as the classical invariant, and "would" survives this one as the zero-weight condition and not as exclusive actualization, which was never a primitive of the framework and is a feature of the disagreeing regime alone. Read on the reductive side—"is the attribute determinately this value?"—the would-clause fails for every value, since irreducibility forbids the state-decomposable child that determinateness would require. A classical semantics must classify the first reading as a contradiction; the union principle classifies it as physical AND, (Section 2.4.12), and the standard tie thereby dissolves in two opposite, equally truth-apt ways depending on which superposition type the residue carries.

The battery, run in this paper's own vocabulary.

- Flank-independence—the cat—lands at its exact grain, as an algebra-determined fact rather than an over-claimed theorem: decoupled flanks, those whose weight factorizes across the joint partition, are *exactly* invariant under the perturbation, (an elementary conditioning fact); generic flanks are approximately so, ("roughly equal probability"); and logical independence of a flank from the antecedent is necessary but not sufficient for that invariance, the coupling being indexed to the evaluating Aethus throughout, where the Lewisian tradition must adjudicate the same anti-butterfly intuition through a similarity metric it has never been able to specify.

- Context-dependence—the sinkhole—is *derived* rather than stipulated: one and the same counterfactual is true at the sinkhole-aware Aethus and unsettled at the at-the-light Aethus, because the residue is indexed to the evaluating Aethus; what the literature handles by context-shifting conventions arrives here as Aethus-relativity, and the classical causal chain's mistake is named by the extrusion principle exactly as the propagation discussion says—the assumption of absolute transferability of contingent correspondences from subsequent Aethae back to prior ones.

- Engineered dependence—the breakfast script—is a chosen wiring: relative to the script-writing Aethus the dependence is perfectly real, relative to its sibling Aethae it never existed, and the semantics keeps both sets of books without contradiction.

- Antecedent strengthening, transitivity, and contraposition fail exactly where they should, and structurally rather than by patchwork: a strengthened or chained antecedent is a *different* perturbation generating a different residue, so no monotonicity relation ever gets off the ground—"struck" and "struck underwater" simply reopen different pages.

- The Bizet–Verdi pair lands where it must: "had they been compatriots" restates a relational attribute whose residue is a weight-tied disagreeing pair over the French and Italian completions[157], so both would-counterfactuals fail while both might-counterfactuals hold, (the disagreeing half of the two loosenings recorded above)—Lewis's tie-breaking embarrassment becomes a theorem about superposition structure.

- The Nixon case [117] is Mode P at full pressure: with $\mathcal{B}$ fixed at the informational past of the button event, escalation dominates the residue, and the conclusion arrives with no gerrymandered closeness ordering and no miracle talk, the entire deviation from actuality being located in the named operator.

- And backtracking readings are neither outlawed nor mishandled: they are alternative choices of $\mathcal{B}$, licensed by time-symmetric unknownness, (Section 12.4.6)—the notorious conventionality of backtracking becomes the conventionality of the boundary, made explicit and movable instead of hidden inside a similarity metric.

[157]Why the residue cannot instead carry the agreeing completion: for a *valid* agreeing superposition over the two completions to stand, the distinguishing information would have to be permanently inaccessible in principle, (the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, Section 8.0.3), blocking the third postulate's pruning—and for a human-passable relational attribute of two documented persons this collides with the attribute's own definition, since personal identity carries informational transferability as part of what the attribute *is*, (the Deepest Layer, Section 2.4.10). The Aethus such an evaluation would require is invalid by Aethic contradiction, so the disagreeing pair is not one modeling option among two but the only valid residue shape here: agreeing structure over human-passable attributes is excluded at the threshold, not adjudicated at the tie.

A continuous worked example completes the battery, drawn from the Fallacy of Initial Conditions, (Section 9.6). Take the double pendulum, whose standing Aethic state is never a point but a spread—a hair of ontological error about the present configuration. The antecedent "had the release angle been $\theta + \varepsilon$" is Mode S over that spread: pockets carrying neighboring angles already co-exist, so no ascent is required. Chaotic dynamics then makes the residue's behavior horizon-dependent, and the clauses track it exactly: for short horizons, the would-counterfactual about the bob's coarse position holds where no departing pocket survives, and where a few do the would fails while the grade sits near one; as the horizon grows, Lyapunov amplification fans the residue across the configuration space, the would-counterfactual fails for all but the coarsest consequents, the might-counterfactuals proliferate. What the grade $W_R(B)$ then does is a question for the dynamics and the measure: sensitivity of trajectories fixes no rate at which it changes, and does not by itself guarantee its long-horizon value, which would need the dynamics to mix the relevant region evenly. The semantics thereby recovers, qualitatively, the "progressive cropping of possibilities" that the raw analysis described—an illustrative proposed application until a computed case study supplies the numbers—and it supplies a graded, horizon-indexed counterfactual of a kind a similarity ordering between whole worlds does not naturally produce.

The quantum wing. Here the propagation discussion's closing chain completes itself. Counterfactual *definiteness* fails natively while counterfactual *substance* survives: a perturbed attribute may land in a residue whose pocket structure is an agreeing superposition of values, in which case there is no single definite value the attribute "would have had"—the premise Bell-type derivations require [4]—and yet the discourse remains fully truth-apt: the would-counterfactual is false, the might-counterfactuals are true, and the grade is defined. The would-failure here is specifically the determinate-value reading; on the physical-realization reading recorded above, the clause is instead satisfied by every co-present state at once—the two verdicts being one irreducibility fact viewed from the two sides of the union principle's categorical separation, (Section 2.4.2). The framework thereby threads between counterfactual definiteness and counterfactual nihilism, which is the modal face of everything this paper does. And the physics already runs on these clauses: the third postulate's trigger is a might-counterfactual over potential refinements—accessibility-in-principle, exercised throughout the Frauchiger–Renner treatment, (Section 10.2.1)—and the "best potential record-attribute" of the duality program, (Section 14.6.2), is a supremum of graded counterfactuals under exactly these evaluation rules. Delayed choice is then mysterious to the classical paradigm rather than mysterious inherently, precisely as claimed where the streetlight analysis closes. Modality and mechanics share one engine; that sharing is the modal collapse, cashed.

Two named coordinates pin this wing to the standing literature. Peres's dictum that unperformed experiments have no results [128] has served for decades as the slogan of exactly this refusal; the clauses above equip the slogan with truth conditions—an unperformed experiment has no *would*-value precisely when its residue is an agreeing superposition over outcomes, while its might-values and its grade remain perfectly defined. And Fine's theorem [82] marks the exact hinge on which the refusal turns[158]: satisfaction of the Bell inequalities is equivalent to the existence of a joint distribution over the counterfactual outcomes, so the Aethic invalidity of that joint conjunction, (the correspondence recorded in Section 10.3.2), and the empirical violation are one fact under two descriptions.

What remains open. The grades inherit the standing status of the weight construction, (see the Open Constructions, Section 14.8); the empty-residue convention and the default for $\mathcal{B}$ are recorded choice points; and the battery above is an opening set rather than a closed one—the standing invitation to the modal-metaphysics community is to continue it adversarially, since a semantics that deletes a fifty-year similarity ordering should expect, and welcome, attempts at counterexample.

9.1.1 The Same Aethus, Rebuilt from Joint Invalidities

Status. This rebuild and the two subsubsections that follow it stood in Section 3 until the peg formalism, whose constraint layer (Definition 4) now carries the rebuild's two primitives for the paper as a whole. They are kept here, beside the semantics they serve, because the reopening $\ominus_\sigma$ and its scope settings are stated in the rebuild's vocabulary.

[158]Note that my connecting agreeing superpositions to Fine's theorem was done in June 2026—as is part of how I induced agreeing superpositions purely from the Aethic soccer field thought experiment, the double-slit experiment, and the Mach–Zehnder interferometer empiricism (per that animation I stared at a lot in late 2022). Interestingly, it appears that I reached a conceptualization of them from the ontological side, that way I was later able to meet Fine's theorem [82] in the middle (with its having come from the quantitative side).

The original definitional hierarchy built the Aethus by ascent from epistemic modal logic. This one rebuilds the same axiomatic content from scratch, in the opposite direction: taking as primitive exactly what the mined-semantics account, (Section 5.2.2), says is primitive, and deriving everything the ascent introduced. Two primitives suffice. *First*: attributes. An attribute α carries its space of alternatives $\{x_1, x_2, \ldots\}$; a *stated-attribute* is the pair $\tilde{\alpha} = (\alpha, x)$, the notation of the earlier proper-child treatment, (whose authoritative modern form is the Weighted Proper Child Aethus of Definition 36, where childhood itself becomes weight-graded); and the *negation* of a stated-attribute is not a new primitive but the union of the attribute's remaining alternatives—$(\alpha, \neg x) := \bigcup_{x' \neq x} (\alpha, x')$—which for Boolean-described attributes collapses to the logical negation and for richer attributes is strictly more structured. *Second*: the joint-invalidity relation—which finite sets of stated-attributes cannot stand together. The relation is governed by two axioms of its own, stated because the derivability below leans on both: *monotonicity*, (a jointly invalid S remains invalid under every superset $S' \supseteq S$—invalidity is never cured by company); and *same-attribute exclusivity*, (for distinct alternatives $x \neq x'$ of one attribute, the pair $\{(\alpha, x), (\alpha, x')\}$ is jointly invalid—one attribute, one value). Nothing else inter-attribute is assumed; every further notion is now derived. *Derivability*: $S \vdash \tilde{\alpha}$ if and only if, for every alternative $x' \neq x$, the set $S \cup \{(\alpha, x')\}$ is jointly invalid—forcing by elimination, which recovers the definition of Attribute Derivability verbatim, and with it the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence: Aethae are identical up to derivability of their stated content, so closure is constitutive of Aethus-identity. *The Aethus itself*: a deductively closed, jointly valid set of stated-attributes, every unstated attribute standing blank—where blank means no alternative stated and none derivable, recovering blank-decomposability as the conventional characterization. *Aethic intersection*: adjoin a stated-attribute, close under derivability, and submit to the validity check—an invalid result being the Aethic contradiction the proper-child treatment already invokes, (and which the weighted form of Definition 36 carries forward as the weight-zero case). *Aethic union*: the superposition-forming construction of the Aethic Union Principle, alternatives co-present with the explicit negation of all others, per the canonical table's two-stage map. *Removal*: by the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence, deleting an entry while its derivers remain changes nothing—the object is the same Aethus—so genuine removal is the passage to a maximal closed, valid restriction in which the attribute is blank, selected by the declared priorities where joint supports leave several: the reopening $\ominus_\sigma$ of the counterfactual semantics, whose upstream clearing is thereby *theorem-forced* rather than conventional, the scope settings legislating only the remainder. The Fundamental Theorem of Empirical Aethae bounds the whole construction empirically, with the Categorical Abstraction as the standing license. One admission this rebuild makes explicit, having been left implicit in the original formalization: downstream-deductive dependence among attributes was there treated as the choice of stringing entries together, where it is in fact systematically perturbable structure—because deduction itself is encoded in the invalidity relation, one attribute's deducing part of the next is nothing over and above the latter's sitting off its forced value being an Aethic contradiction in the decomposed-parent-attribute sense. What was a choice is now an operation.

9.1.2 Evidential-Minimal, Unidirectional, and Bidirectional at the Invalidity Root

The scope menu of the counterfactual semantics can now be distinguished at this root, which is its sharpest formulation. *Deductive dependence is total forcing*: an attribute β depends deductively on $\tilde{\alpha}$, against standing content S, exactly when every alternative of β but one is jointly invalid with $S \cup \{\tilde{\alpha}\}$—the elimination pattern of derivability, closing to a unique survivor. The *evidential-minimal* setting travels precisely this structure: it clears what the equivalence theorem forces upstream, plus the orphaned downstream conclusions as a hygiene choice, and nothing more. *Causal dependence is law-tagged partial constraint*: a recorded generic entry—generality read off its own quantificational form, per the retraction priorities—contributes invalidities that *constrain* β without totally forcing it at every pocket, and whose direction is a gadget-reading, (Section 5.2.2), never a resident. The *bidirectional* setting travels these recorded generic entries whether or not they close to forcing at the pocket in question, and travels *all* of them—the generic invalidity between two stated-attributes is ordering-impartial at this root, "$(\text{red} \cdot \text{go})$ is invalid" saying nothing about which member causes which, so the clearing the constraints natively support consults no direction at all. The *unidirectional* setting is that same clearing filtered once: a direction convention—book content, a gadget-reading of timelike order laid over the impartial constraints—selects the forward side, and only the generics on that side travel. The filter is kept as what it is, a convention carrying no categorical weight; and its geometric limit is worth stating at the root where it belongs: where no timelike path connects the attributes' events, the convention has nothing to read, unidirectional coincides with bidirectional identically, and

the relativistic absence of causation between spacelike-separated events arrives as the filter's degenerate case rather than as a primitive of any kind. The distinction in one line: **evidential-minimal releases the invalidities that close; bidirectional releases every invalidity recorded as generic; unidirectional releases the generic invalidities on the direction convention's forward side**—the same primitive throughout, the settings differing only in which invalidity-substructure travels with the reopened attribute, never in what causation is. And the painstaking choice to define everything at this joint-invalidities root is not merely aesthetic; it has already paid for theorems: the invalidity relation is exactly the structure that total completions cannot see, (the completion-blindness lemma of Section 9.4.2), exactly what similarity orderings cannot host, (the rational-monotony countermodel there), and exactly what lets causation arrive as a verdict of the semantics rather than a parameter fed to it. The pain purchases the proofs.

One closure condition beneath the unidirectional setting deserves its canon here, because it explains why the setting's decline-to-consult is typically *costless* rather than merely permitted. For the Aethus to remain closed under deduction while the unidirectional reopening leaves the past unconsulted, the starting Aethus must have carried the proper-time-past token-causes as blank anyway — and in the ordinary evaluator's state it does, twice over. First, blankness of the tokens: when the books say "the trajectory of a coin causes its outcome" or "the daily statistics of the city's power grid cause the red light," what is stated is the *type*-grade causal law and, at most, statistical summaries; *what in particular* caused the event lies itself in Aethic superposition unless one has personally locked it down — the same profile as the between-awareness-and-omniscience example, where heightened regional specificity stands blank as a probabilistic reference beneath stated statistics. Second, and stronger, degeneracy of the fibers: one can perturb the path and get the same coin outcome, perturb the earlier power-grid statistics and still get the same red-light timing the antecedent references — the forward map is many-to-one, so the stated present pins no unique token-past, and the past-blank ranges over the whole preimage class, the stated statistics functioning as a measure over that class rather than a selection from it. Under both conditions, closure never re-derives a cleared present from a pinned past, (none is pinned), and never forces the clearing of a stated token-cause, (none is stated) — which is exactly why the middle setting can decline to consult the direction without breach. The condition also bounds the settings' very difference: at the fully blank-past limit the unidirectional and bidirectional clearings coincide trivially, at the omniscient limit the unidirectional setting becomes unavailable, (a stated token-chain would be cleared by the closure-identity forcing regardless of the convention, the setting never overriding closure), and the two settings genuinely differ only in the middle band — the very band the probabilistic-reference profile inhabits. And the many-to-one structure here is no stranger: it is the removal operation's fiber picture run through the forward dynamics, the temporal mirror of the ideal removed object's own many-stones-one-splash.

9.1.3 The Two Vocabularies, Term by Term

Because this paper now speaks both languages—the original formalization's and the modal-semantic notation's—the dictionary deserves to be explicit, with the mismatches flagged where they are instructive. *Attribute* α corresponds to the notation's variable q with its value space—and notably *not* to the logician's "antecedent": the antecedent of a conditional is a specific supposition, hence a *stated-attribute* (α, x), not the attribute itself, (an earlier informal gloss in this project conflated the two, and the distinction is worth pinning: the attribute contains all its possible stated-attributes; the antecedent selects one). *Stated-attribute* corresponds to the valuation entry $A(q) = v$. *Negation* corresponds to $\neg$ only in the Boolean case; in general it is the complement-union over the attribute's alternatives, as defined above. *Blank* corresponds to $A(q) = *$, with blank-decomposability the original characterization. *Aethic intersection* corresponds to expansion—adjoin, close, validity-check—and *Aethic union* to superposition formation per the Aethic Union Principle, which is emphatically *not* disjunction: the union's inner negation structure makes the alternatives observationally exclusive while co-present, the two-stage map of the canonical table. *Aethic contradiction* corresponds to inconsistency, but indexed and primitive rather than derived. *Derivability* corresponds to entailment, with the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence supplying the identity criterion entailment alone does not. *Validity* corresponds to consistency only loosely: the third postulate's two-generation refinability requirement makes it strictly richer. The *subjunctive* and *indicative* moods correspond to reopen-and-restate versus pure selection among standing pockets, no coincidence condition between the moods being claimed; the *scope* σ names which recorded invalidity-substructure travels, per the preceding subsubsection; and the *remainder* $A \ominus_\sigma q$ is the original formalization's removal operation on closed objects, forced by the equivalence theorem. *Possible world*, finally, has no counterpart at

all—the completion-blindness lemma is the proof that none can be supplied—so the correspondence above is a dictionary between two presentations of one structure, and not a reduction to anything.

Two commitments of the global operation. Two consequences of reopening the state at a scope, rather than its pockets one by one, are stated here as the commitments they are. *Centering fails for stated antecedents.* Lewis's centering, that "if A were the case, C would be" holds whenever A and C are both stated, would require the operation to exempt a stated antecedent from reopening, and nothing in the framework licenses the exemption: privileging the actual outcome over its alternative, the toss that landed heads over the landing tails, would take an axiom the postulates do not contain, and the alternatives are symmetric. So "if I had tossed the coin, it would have landed heads," said after the toss landed heads, reopens the toss and comes out false, as a feature and not a cost. *Credence enters through the indicative, not the subjunctive.* For an evaluator agnostic about whether Oswald shot Kennedy, the indicative selects among the standing pockets and its grade is the conditional proportion in the standing residue, grade one here for every positive credence in the antecedent, while the subjunctive reopens the act and clears what rests on it, the death included, so that its grade tracks only the standing weight of alternative assassins and not the evaluator's credence in the antecedent, near zero for an ordinary evaluator however that credence runs; a grade of one minus the credence in Oswald, once held, is wrong on exactly this point.

The deletion's etiology, placed. Why evaluation points were taken as total in the first place, so that a similarity ordering seemed compelled, is not a semantics question, and the answer is the diagnosis of subsubsection 12.1.3: human modal talk as a piecewise convention, the speaker dropped on the categorical segment to a terminal point treated as a shared ledger and lifted back to the standing state on the counterfactual segment, the convention selected by the coordination language serves and installed below the level at which languages vary, with the universals of mood, the seam at which the tradition's puzzles accumulated, and the developmental fingerprints as its predictions. The same diagnosis is reached from the coordinate of determinacy in subsubsection 4.2.2. One condition on the diagnosis's timing belongs here: a parameter must be formalized before it can be diagnosed as an artifact, and the ordering source was written down as a parameter only when the Kratzerian framework systematized the modal auxiliaries [129], so the deletion could not have been stated, as a deletion, before then. Nothing in the diagnosis is evidence for the semantics; the results above stand on the deletion alone.

9.2 Cautious Monotony: Where the Aethic Consequence Relation Parts From Every Ordering

Every semantics that evaluates counterfactuals by an ordering of worlds validates Cautious Monotony. The Aethic operator does not, and the failure is derived, given one reading: it is step (8) of the derivation in Section 3.3.1, where, on the dual-peg reading of a conjunctive antecedent, the reopening of both conjuncts with their supports cleared follows from the definition of an attribute as the equivalence class of its presentations, by way of Decomposition Neutrality. The dual-peg reading is the framework's reading of "and" in an antecedent, a commitment rather than a consequence; on the coarsened Boolean reading nothing is cleared, and the witness satisfies Cautious Monotony. The consequence is structural. The Aethic consequence relation is not preferential, hence not ranked; no total similarity ordering represents it; and the states it ranges over provably are not worlds. This subsection states the law, fixes a single concrete ledger on which the failure can be computed by hand, proves the verdicts, proves that no ordering and no interventionist model can reproduce them, and specifies the experiment that would settle the one empirical question left open, step (9).

Definition 40 (Cautious Monotony)
Write $A \mathrel{|\!\sim} B$ *for* if A were the case, B would be. *A counterfactual consequence relation satisfies* Cautious Monotony *when, for all* A, B, C,

$$A \mathrel{|\!\sim} B \quad \textit{and} \quad A \mathrel{|\!\sim} C \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad A \wedge B \mathrel{|\!\sim} C.$$

Informally: adding to a supposition something the supposition already delivered cannot unsettle anything else it delivered.

The law is a defining principle of the cumulative and preferential systems of Kraus, Lehmann and Magidor, and it holds in the counterfactual logic of Lewis. It is the principle the sprinklers break.

9.2.1 The Sprinklers, Walked Through: Cautious Monotony and Ordinary Judgment

The ledger. A reasoner's *ledger* is the content they carry: attributes stated where they know them, blank where they do not, together with the joint invalidity declarations that bind them—the constraint layer of Section 5.2.2, the semantic mining from which an Aethus reads its attribute dependencies. The case uses four attributes and one fixed ledger, $\mathcal{L}$, displayed in Table 9. Each attribute is formed, as Section 3.4.2 sets out, from pairwise disjoint pegs that it takes as its options, each occupying one of its slots, and here each has two: the attribute S, whether the sprinklers ran overnight, has the pegs s, *they ran*, and $\bar{s}$, *they did not*. The attribute, not the peg, is what stands determinate or blank: S is determinate at s, and X is blank, the ledger stating neither of its pegs. Negation is no more primitive here than causation is[159]. The two pegs are not logical complements prior to the attribute; it is the attribute that makes each the other's alternative, and $\neg s$ is notation for $\bar{s}$, the other peg of S, read as the negation of s only by means of the attribute (Section 2.4.14). The notation $\neg$ is used below on exactly that understanding.

Attribute	Pegs	Status in $\mathcal{L}$	Source
S, the sprinkler run	s (ran), $\neg s$ (did not)	determinate at s	observation
Y, the lawn	y (wet), $\neg y$ (dry)	determinate at y	derived from s by ℓ_1
X, last night's rain	x (rain), $\neg x$ (none)	blank	never checked
Z, the gutters	z (overflowed), $\neg z$ (did not)	blank	settled by nothing in $\mathcal{L}$
ℓ_1: $\{s, \neg y\}$ is invalid, written $s \to y$ (the wetness's sole support in $\mathcal{L}$)			
ℓ_2: $\{x, s, \neg z\}$ is invalid, written $x \wedge s \to z$ (rain on top of a sprinkler run overflows the gutters)			

Table 9: The ledger $\mathcal{L}$ of the sprinklers case. Each attribute here has two pegs, and $\neg$ names an attribute's other peg. Nothing else is assumed; in particular $\mathcal{L}$ contains no law by which rain wets the lawn.

Both laws are joint invalidity declarations, and nothing in either is temporal or causal. The arrow in ℓ_1 is notation only: what the ledger encodes is that any Aethus stating a sprinkler run together with a dry lawn, $\{s, \neg y\}$, is invalid, exactly as ℓ_2 encodes that $\{x, s, \neg z\}$ is. The declarations name pegs, not truth values: $\{s, \neg y\}$ is the joint statement of peg s of S with the other peg of Y. Being pairwise, ℓ_1 is a primitive disjointness declaration, s and $\neg y$ declared disjoint across attributes; ℓ_2 is a joint invalidity of higher arity (Section 3.4.2). The dependency of the wetness on the sprinkler run—the *support* that step (7) clears—is what an Aethus reads off from that declaration, not a relation posited beneath it: causal talk is the reading, and joint invalidity is the content (Sections 5.2.2 and 9.9). Each law therefore has two faces, and the walkthrough uses both. The *arrow form*, $s \to y$ and $x \wedge s \to z$, reads a law as a dependency, and it is the natural notation for tracing what a stated peg delivers. The *root form*, $\{s, \neg y\}$ and $\{x, s, \neg z\}$ invalid, is what an Aethus actually encodes, and it is the natural

[159] *2026-09-23, 8:58 PM ET*

By the way, hopefully you're familiar with the Aethic principle of how all causality, at the root, isn't actually time reliant, but is merely that semantic mining / joint invalidity declarations content, then read and operated over by an Aethus to form attribute dependencies and all??? Accordingly, I just want to triple check that the s -> y statement itself is explicitly mentioned to be merely the causal notation for which is actually Aethically encoded as a statement of {s, not y} is an invalid Aethus. Thanks!

Also if you read what truth becomes in Aethic reasoning, you see that the "\neg" itself thing isn't actually real either. In other words, you can't formally say that a stated-attribute is stated or blank as you do in the first table-what each statement in that table is really saying, therefore, is that for each stated attribute named, we have an idea about what the stated-attribute a and its neg a is, however fundamentally those aren't "fundamentally logical complements", rather the attribute itself is defined by convention as picking out some "a" and "neg a (or you might as well call it some b)" for which the attribute takes them as its two options as slots-so by means of the attribute we get the qualitative logical negation interpretation of each respecting to the other. Hence the table itself implicitly states that we're referring to the attribute for each thing named accordingly, but the formally correct Aethic treatment would name the attribute and its two stated-attribute slots directly for each one of those. Hopefully this makes enough sense to fix? Thanks!

To be clear you can still use negation as notation, same as with causality arrows, just you should be clear about the formal status/root of the concepts, and so should the paper!

Right and axiomatically speaking, all this means you have to be able to state as a primitive whether two stated-attributes are or are not disjoint, so technically you can form an attribute out of any number of pairwise disjoint stated-attributes! Please make sure, like the truth mention and causality mentions in the paper do already, this has a designated explicit unpacking somewhere in the paper, ideally in the right spot. Thanks!

Note that disjointness of stated-attributes is the primitive, and of Aethae is derived once you've already constructed the concept of invalid Aethae!

It's also then a fundamental identity that agreeing superpositions, in rooting to attributes, weirdly enough operate over their disjoint stated-attributes, just crucially as a joint union rather than a naive intersection!

notation for pruning a candidate pocket. The derivations below move between the two as each step requires; nothing turns on the choice, since the arrow is only a reading of the root.
Three counterfactuals are put to $\mathcal{L}$, with $A = x$, $B = y$, $C = z$:

(Q1) *Had it rained, the lawn would have been wet*: $x \mid\sim y$.

(Q2) *Had it rained, the gutters would have overflowed*: $x \mid\sim z$.

(Q3) *Had it rained and the lawn been wet, the gutters would have overflowed*: $x \wedge y \mid\sim z$.

Definition 40 says that (Q1) and (Q2) together entail (Q3).

Definition 41 (Residue and verdicts)
To evaluate a counterfactual with antecedent A against a ledger $\mathcal{L}$: state A; reopen every attribute A targets, together with every stated attribute that supports a reopened one (steps (4)–(7) of Section 3.3.1); and let the residue $R_{\mathcal{L}}(A)$ *be the set of* pockets*, the total assignments to the reopened and blank attributes that agree with A and with every entry still stated, and that violate no law of $\mathcal{L}$. Then $A \mid\sim C$ holds iff C holds in every pocket of $R_{\mathcal{L}}(A)$, and* might *C holds iff C holds in some pocket.*

Proposition 22 (The residues)
$R_{\mathcal{L}}(x) = \{\, (x, s, y, z) \,\}$ *and* $R_{\mathcal{L}}(x \wedge y) = \{\, (x, s, y, z),\ (x, \neg s, y, z),\ (x, \neg s, y, \neg z) \,\}$.

Proof
Antecedent x. *The attribute* X *is blank in $\mathcal{L}$, so stating its peg x reopens nothing stated, and x supports nothing.* S *stays determinate at s. In arrow form, ℓ_1 ($s \to y$) delivers y and ℓ_2 ($x \wedge s \to z$) delivers z. In root form the same pruning reads: of the two pegs of* Z*, the peg $\neg z$ would complete the candidate to $\{x, s, \neg z\}$, which ℓ_2 declares invalid. The root form of ℓ_1 is likewise what keeps* Y *determinate at y throughout: with* S *determinate at s, the other peg of* Y *would complete $\{s, \neg y\}$, which ℓ_1 declares invalid. One pocket survives.*

Antecedent $x \wedge y$. *By Decomposition Neutrality the conjunction is an attribute with the four-cell answer space of the pair, so reopening it returns both x and y to blank (steps (2)–(6)). The root form shows exactly why the wetness's support must go. While* S *stays determinate at s, the declaration that $\{s, \neg y\}$ is invalid excludes the other peg of* Y*, which puts y straight back;* Y *could not return to blank, and the reopening would fail. So* S *is reopened as well (step (7)). This is not the backtracking setting of the scope dial: closure and the fixed law force the clearing, and the narrow setting keeps the past fixed only where closure permits. The antecedent now fixes x and y, leaving* S *and* Z *blank; Table 10 enumerates the four candidates. Only $(x, s, y, \neg z)$ violates a law, namely ℓ_2; the other three survive. The pockets with $\neg s$ keep y because the antecedent states it, and in root form nothing forbids them: neither $\{s, \neg y\}$ nor $\{x, s, \neg z\}$ can occur in a candidate that contains $\neg s$.*

x	y	s	z	Law violated	Status
1	1	1	1	none	pocket
1	1	1	0	ℓ_2: $\{x, s, \neg z\}$	pruned
1	1	0	1	none	pocket
1	1	0	0	none	pocket

Table 10: Candidate pockets for the antecedent $x \wedge y$, after the wetness and its support have been reopened. The single surviving pocket without overflow is the last row.

Corollary (The failure)
On $\mathcal{L}$ the operator affirms (Q1) and (Q2) and does not affirm (Q3); had it rained and the lawn been wet, the gutters might not have overflowed *is true. Cautious Monotony fails.*

Proof
(Q1) and (Q2) hold because y and z hold in the single pocket of $R_{\mathcal{L}}(x)$. (Q3) fails because the pocket $(x, \neg s, y, \neg z)$ of $R_{\mathcal{L}}(x \wedge y)$ lacks z.

The residues, computed. Nothing in the walkthrough needs more than the closure of Section 3.1. The ledger's representation is $\{[\mathsf{S} : \{s\}]\}$; its closure excludes $\neg y$ by propagation through ℓ_1, the declared set $\{s, \neg y\}$ with s held, and fills Y at y by elimination. That held peg is exactly the support that step (7) reopens when Y is reopened: the derivation itself names it. The residue is then the rendered enforced splitting of the reopened representation. The single-peg carvings of the attributes it leaves free split it into a sum of total assignments, one term each, invalid terms included at the first tier (Definition 12; Proposition 8); rendering to the validity quotient deletes the terms that violate a law (Section 3.2), and the terms that remain are the pockets. *Would* C is membership of C in the core of the rendered sum, and *might* C is membership in one of its terms. Run mechanically, the candidates for x render to the one pocket of Proposition 22, and the four for $x \wedge y$ render to its three, the deleted term being $(x, s, y, \neg z)$; Cautious Monotony fails by computation, the support included, and not by a convention of the walkthrough.

Why no ordering can reproduce the pattern. A similarity semantics evaluates $A \mathrel{|\!\sim} C$ at the closest A-worlds under an ordering $\preceq$ of worlds, and different theorists resolve similarity differently. Proposition 23 holds for every resolution at once.

Proposition 23 (Orderings validate Cautious Monotony)
Let $\preceq$ *be any preorder on worlds that is smooth for the antecedents in play—every* A*-world lies above some* $\preceq$*-minimal* A*-world, as holds automatically when the worlds are finitely many, as here— and let* $A \mathrel{|\!\sim} C$ *hold iff* C *holds throughout* $\min_{\preceq}(A)$*. If* $\min_{\preceq}(A) \subseteq B$*, then* $\min_{\preceq}(A \wedge B) = \min_{\preceq}(A)$*; consequently Cautious Monotony holds.*

Proof
Every world in $\min_{\preceq}(A)$ *satisfies* $A \wedge B$*, and no* $(A \wedge B)$*-world is strictly closer, since each is an* A*-world; so* $\min_{\preceq}(A) \subseteq \min_{\preceq}(A \wedge B)$*. Conversely, let* $w \in \min_{\preceq}(A \wedge B)$ *and choose, by smoothness,* $v \in \min_{\preceq}(A)$ *with* $v \preceq w$*;* v *is itself an* $(A \wedge B)$*-world, so minimality of* w *gives* $w \preceq v$*, and* w *is minimal among* A*-worlds. Hence the two sets coincide, and whatever holds throughout one holds throughout the other. The same law holds in Lewis's sphere semantics without the minimality assumption.*

Corollary (No resolution of similarity suffices)
No ordering semantics, under any resolution of similarity, affirms (Q1) and (Q2) while declining (Q3). To decline (Q3) it must decline (Q1) or (Q2).

The reason is structural rather than a matter of which worlds count as close. A world is complete, so a conjunct it already satisfies adds nothing to it, and an ordering has no means by which a redundant conjunct could change what is held fixed. In the Aethic evaluation the conjunct is not redundant: it reopens an attribute that has a ground, and the ground goes with it.

The non-ordering rivals. Two families of account evaluate counterfactuals without ranking worlds, and both are worth running on the same ledger.

Proposition 24 (Interventionism honors Cautious Monotony here)
Model the case causally [126] with one binary variable per attribute—S*,* X*,* Y*,* Z *for* S*,* X*,* Y*,* Z*, value* 1 *at the first peg—and the structural equations* $Y := S \vee X$ *and* $Z := X \wedge S$*, with the actual sprinkler run* $S = 1$*, and read a conjunctive antecedent as a joint intervention. Then (Q1), (Q2) and (Q3) all hold. More generally, in any recursive structural model, if* $\mathrm{do}(A)$ *gives* B *the value* b*, then* $\mathrm{do}(A, B = b)$ *has the same solution as* $\mathrm{do}(A)$*.*

Proof
Under $\mathrm{do}(X = 1)$*,* S *is not a descendant of* X *and keeps the value* 1*, so* $Y = 1$ *and* $Z = 1$*. Under* $\mathrm{do}(X = 1, Y = 1)$ *the equation for* Y *is replaced by the constant* 1*, which is the value it already had; its descendants receive the same inputs, and its ancestors,* S *among them, are untouched, so* $Z = 1$*. For the general claim, replacing a variable's equation by the value it already takes changes no input anywhere in a recursive model, so every variable keeps its value. The same holds with the equation* $Y := S$ *in place of* $Y := S \vee X$*.*

Within the framework the interventional reading is settling, which the causality development's settling theorem identifies with do-surgery, so the framework carries both conditionals: reopening, for what the evaluator's information would support had the antecedent been stated, and settling, for what the mechanisms would produce under its imposition. Cautious Monotony separates them, and the next proposition says where.

Proposition 25 (Where Cautious Monotony fails)
Let $A \mid\sim B$ and $A \mid\sim C$ hold at an Aethus under the uniform conjunctive reading, with the intermediate for $A \wedge B$ contained in the intermediate for A, and let D be the entries of the latter that the former lacks. Then $A \wedge B \mid\sim C$ fails exactly when some pocket of the residue for $A \wedge B$ that does not carry every entry of D fails C: exactly when the verdict on C under A rested on grounds of B that the conjunctive reopening clears and the restatement of B does not regenerate.

Proof
Every pocket of the residue for A carries the intermediate for A, so it carries D and B, and it is a pocket of the residue for $A \wedge B$: it refines that intermediate, contains both restated antecedents, and is maximal there, since a strictly larger consistent refinement would, containing it, refine the intermediate for A as well. Conversely, a pocket of the residue for $A \wedge B$ that carries every entry of D carries the whole intermediate for A, and by the same maximality argument is a pocket of the residue for A. So the pockets conjoining B adds are exactly those omitting an entry of D; each pocket of the residue for A settles C, and $A \wedge B \mid\sim C$ fails exactly when an added pocket does not.

In the case of Table 10, D is the sprinkler run, the added pockets are the two with $\neg s$, and the one with $\neg z$ is the failure. An exhaustive check over some eleven thousand random finite models agrees with it in every case, and finds pocket monotonicity holding throughout.
The alternative-sensitive semantics of Ciardelli, Zhang and Champollion [130] lets the alternatives an antecedent makes salient shape which background facts are held fixed. It was built for antecedents with several alternatives, such as negated conjunctions and disjunctions; a conjunction of two atoms offers a single alternative, and, on our reading of the proposal, the sprinkler run, upstream of the wetness, is retained, so that (Q3) is again affirmed. Table 11 collects the verdicts. The contrast has a root: an interventionist model takes directed equations as primitive, whereas the ledger's primitives are joint invalidity declarations, with the direction of dependency read from them. At exactly this point the two kinds of procedure run in opposite directions: intervention cuts an effect from its ground and keeps the ground, while reopening returns the effect to blank and takes the ground with it.

	Aethic operator	Orderings	Interventionism	Alternative-sensitive*
(Q1) x would bring y	affirmed	affirmed	affirmed	affirmed
(Q2) x would bring z	affirmed	affirmed	affirmed	affirmed
(Q3) $x \wedge y$ would bring z	**not affirmed**	affirmed	affirmed	affirmed
Sprinkler run under (Q3)	reopened	held fixed	held fixed	held fixed

*On our reading of the proposal, as stated in the text.

Table 11: Verdicts on the ledger $\mathcal{L}$. All accounts agree wherever the antecedent leaves every ground untouched, and part at the single question whose antecedent reopens one.

Where the accounts agree, and where they part. The agreement on (Q1) and (Q2) is not an accident. Their antecedent touches no attribute on which anything else depends; the sprinkler run stands untouched; and on untouched entries every procedure in Table 11 returns the same pocket. The accounts part at one place only, (Q3), the one question whose antecedent reopens a ground. The disagreement is therefore located, it has a mechanism, and it can be tested.

Ordinary judgment. Put (Q3) to someone who holds the ledger of Table 9: *suppose it had rained last night and the lawn had been wet; would the gutters have overflowed?* The prediction is that they hesitate, and that the reason they give is step (7) in their own words: *if the lawn was wet from the rain, maybe the sprinklers never came on.* Stating the wetness explicitly raises the question of why the lawn is wet, and the sprinkler run stops being a fixed fact and becomes one explanation among others. Two qualifications keep the claim exact. The effect should be sharpest with *anyway*, which marks the reopening; and some uses of *and*—contrast, concession, *even if*—may hold the ground fixed. The claim is accordingly a prediction awaiting the test below, not a report of one.

The experiment. Step (9) can be run as it stands. Participants read a vignette presenting $\mathcal{L}$, rate their agreement with (Q1), (Q2) and a version of (Q3) on a graded scale, in counterbalanced order,

and state their reason for the (Q3) rating in their own words. The version of (Q3) varies across the four conditions of Table 12.

Condition	Antecedent of (Q3)	Aethic operator	All incumbents
Bare	*had it rained and the lawn been wet*	drop below (Q2)	no drop
Marked	*. . . and the lawn been wet anyway*	steepest drop	no drop
Concessive	*even if it had rained and the lawn been wet*	no drop if the ground is held	no drop
Control	*had it rained and the moon been full*	no drop	no drop

Table 12: Design of the elicited-judgment test. The control's added conjunct has no ground in $\mathcal{L}$, so it separates ground-reopening from any general reluctance toward longer antecedents.

Two measures carry the result. The first is the drop in agreement from (Q2) to (Q3) within each condition. The second is the rate at which the stated reasons for the (Q3) rating mention the sprinklers not having run, which the operator predicts in the bare and marked conditions and not in the control. A drop confined to the conditions whose added conjunct has a ground is the operator's signature. A uniform drop across all four conditions, the control included, would indicate a general length effect instead. No drop anywhere would mean that English has grammaticalized the ordering's reading for these constructions, and the countermodel would stand regardless, as a fact about the operator. The concessive condition separates readings within the operator's own account: if *even if* holds the ground fixed, the drop should vanish there, locating the reopening in the bare and marked constructions specifically.

The divide in language, caught in the act. The case closes on what it shows about the language itself. Section 12.1.3 diagnoses human modal language as a conceptual piecewise function: genuinely Aethus-valued on its counterfactual segment, and governed on its categorical segment by a convention that drops each speaker to the terminal point of their own progression, as though that point were the ledger everyone shares. The subjunctive is the periscope by which the speaker, at the bottom of the well, reaches the standing Aethus, blanks and grounds included. The sprinklers show the periscope at work on a single inference. In counterfactual mood the speaker evaluates from the standing Aethus, where the sprinkler run is a stated attribute with a role, the wetness's support, and not a fixed feature of a completed world; supposing the wetness therefore reopens its ground, and the overflow is no longer guaranteed. That is the operator's verdict, and speakers appear to reach it with none of the metaphysics that licenses it. No one supposed that partial information states, rather than possible worlds, are what counterfactuals range over; the folk picture places each speaker at a determinate world, with partial states only derivative. The formal tradition, systematizing the counterfactual segment, imported the categorical segment's convention into it—total worlds are dropped ledgers—and an ordering over total worlds is what that importation looks like as formalism. Proposition 23 is the consequence: the formalism validates a law that the intuition it set out to capture, on this prediction, does not. The intuition had the right verdict and no metaphysics for it; the formalism had a metaphysics, and it was the categorical segment's. This paper supplies the missing piece, the Aethus in place of the world, together with the operator that computes what the periscope was already doing. The agreement on (Q1) and (Q2) is recovered as that section's closing account predicts: similarity is the shadow of untouched entries. One boundary holds throughout. The diagnosis is defensive structure, never evidence; nothing here adds to the framework's case in physics, and the sprinklers prediction is one of the diagnosis's own independent, checkable commitments, of a piece with the location of the tradition's hard cases at the splice.

The developmental fork. The same verdict pattern bears on the fork recorded in Section 12.1.3. An evaluator that *consults* the index that categorical assertion suppresses should decline (Q3) unprompted, as the operator does; one that *constructs* its index from dropped ledgers is running an ordering and, by Proposition 23, must affirm it. The experiment of Table 12 is therefore also a probe of which reading of the fork is true.

9.3 A Basic Introduction to the Counterfactual Semantics

Everything the formal subsection above states in clause and theorem is restated in this one through you—your books, your mornings, your suppositions—and either subsection can be read first: the formal one hands this one its precision; this one hands the formal one its footing. Two terms carry throughout, pinned once more for arrivals landing here directly: an *attribute* is a question the world can answer; a *stated-attribute* is that question together with its answer, standing as an entry in an Aethus's books.

9.3.1 What a Counterfactual Asks of You

"Had the light not been green, I would have stopped." Say it, and notice what you have just done: asserted something about a situation that never happened, with full confidence, and expected to be understood. The reigning account of how this works, due to Stalnaker and Lewis, says you consulted *other possible worlds*—complete alternate realities—and checked what happens in the ones most similar to ours where the light is red. The account is ingenious and carries a famous burden: *similar in what respects?* Everything turns on an ordering of worlds that the theory must assume and cannot derive. This framework's answer begins by refusing the trip. You never consulted another world, because you never needed one: the alternative was already *in* your Aethus, standing as superposition—the second postulate's blanks—and evaluating the counterfactual is not travel but *surgery*: a page of your own books is reopened at a named place, rewritten, and the consequences re-settled. Counterfactuals are stored as superpositions relative to an Aethus, and the concept of possible worlds is dropped entirely. Everything below is that one sentence, unpacked.

9.3.2 The Operation: Reopen, Restate, Re-Prune

The surgery has three steps, and you can run them on the spoiled-film case from the roadmap glossary. A friend revealed the ending; the counterfactual is "had I not been told, the twist would have landed." *Reopen*: return the stated-attribute *(ending, known)* to blank—and not by crude erasure, for reasons the next subsubsection makes exact, but by passing to the version of your books in which that entry genuinely does not stand. *Restate*: write in the supposition—*(ending, unknown)*. *Re-prune*: let the framework's consistency machinery, the third postulate's pruning, strike whatever can no longer stand and settle what survives. Then *read the residue*: the surviving structure either holds the consequent everywhere, (the counterfactual is true), holds it nowhere, (false), or holds it in some surviving pockets and not others, (a graded verdict, weighted by the pockets' own weights—and the grading is a feature, since "would probably have landed" is something you actually mean). One boundary case completes the picture: if *nothing* survives the re-pruning, the residue is empty and the counterfactual is only *vacuously* true—true about nothing, the way "all unicorns stop at red lights" is true—which the semantics reports honestly rather than papering over. The convention for the graded reading at that boundary is fixed rather than left implicit: the grade is a proportion of surviving weight, so with nothing surviving it is *undefined*—not 0, not 1, but not evaluable at that state, the same indexed status a counterfactual has when keyed to entries the state lacks—and the same holds where pockets survive carrying no weight. The *would* and *might* readings apply there and the graded one does not, which is the semantics reporting that a graded question was asked of a state carrying no grade for it.

9.3.3 Why Half the Operation Is a Theorem

The reopening step hides a subtlety you have personally felt. Try to un-know that your grandmother was born before your mother—a fact no one ever told you, which follows from things they did. You cannot erase it alone: the birth-years you retain quietly rewrite it. The Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Equivalence is the formal face of this experience: an Aethus is identified with everything derivable from its stated content, so deleting a derivable line changes nothing—it is the same Aethus. Genuine un-knowing therefore *must* clear enough of the entry's support to leave the attribute truly blank, and the operator does exactly that: it passes to the *largest* deductively closed Aethus in which the target stands blank—keep the absolute maximum of yourself consistent with honestly not knowing the one thing. Largest is not always unique, and the framework's tie-breaking is principled rather than ad hoc: *law-like entries outrank particular facts*, with an entry's generality read off its own quantificational form. Feel why through a case: un-knowing where you parked this morning should never cost you your grasp of how parking works; when something must yield, the particular yields first. Half of the reopening, then, is forced by a theorem about identity, and the tie-breaking runs on structure the

books already carry, (the operation's composite structure and its algebra receive their formal canon in Section 9.4.1)—which leaves exactly one genuine freedom, and it has its own introduction.

9.3.4 The Scope Dial, in One Paragraph

That freedom is *how much travels with* the reopened stated-attribute—must what you inferred *from* the spoiler go too? what it caused? what caused *it*?—and the framework declares it as one parameter with three named settings, given a full basic introduction of its own directly below, (Section 9.3.5): evidential-minimal, the auditor's setting, keeping all independent evidence and exposing conflicts; unidirectional, the storyteller's setting and the default, letting recorded effects fall with their cause, (the direction a convention the books carry); and bidirectional, the backtracker's setting, clearing every wired generic on both sides, direction-blind.[160]The names are geometric on purpose. At root the constraints are ordering-impartial joint invalidities—"(red · go) is invalid" says nothing about which member causes which—so the bidirectional clearing is the native one, the unidirectional its convention-filtered restriction, the direction itself book content reading timelike order and never a resident of the constraints, (the mining account of Section 5.2.2). And where no timelike path connects the attributes' events, the convention has nothing to read and the two settings coincide identically: the relativistic absence of causation between spacelike-separated events, arriving as the filter's geometric limit rather than as a primitive. One scenario run at all three lives there; here it suffices that the dial exists, is honest about being a convention, and selects only among structures the Aethus's own books record.

[160]I think the really fascinating development that's starting to unfold with this Fable contribution to Aethic reasoning is that far from adding any structure whatsoever (since AI is trained on humans, so anything they can't do it can't do), it's effectively repackaging and compacting my sprawling sets of deductions written out over three years in prose into standardly-communicable axioms. A good canonical example is perhaps its three named scopes of Aethic perturbations, and here's the fascinating development directly: it effectively took my Einstein-type purely conceptual and operability prose, and then wrote up the exact analogue to Minkowski's [131] 1908 lecture. What's funny about this is that as of the writing of this (July 15, 2026, 6:28 AM ET), I still have no traction on *which parts* of the Aethic perturbation operation these are supposed to track. Not because I'm unaware of the structure of Aethic perturbations—I've been aware since 2023—but because it's an alien terminological system that I simply haven't yet had the patience to hold up side-by-side to my operations and compare. Another interesting thing I've learned is that Fable keeps assuming someone with my operability sensitivity should be spoken to in general abstract principles—and yet the problem there is that I can't actually *translate* my abstract operability understanding to its abstract terminology understanding directly—instead what happens is that I have to look at exhaustively many concrete situations, spontaneously get hit with the operability intuition, and then check where Fable placed the terminology to reverse-engineer the correspondence. As in, exhaustively seeing where "terminology point x fires versus doesn't fire" until I can basically do the linguistic masking-type storing of synesthetic intuition in the terminology which I already store in my own mental operations! So yeah, I almost verbatim said what Einstein said of Minkowski when I first started seeing Fable's terminology proposals, (which puts me somewhere at that stage, then):

> "Since the mathematicians have invaded the theory of relativity, I do not understand it myself." [132]

So I suppose what's especially interesting about this is that due to both (A) my isolation and (B) the nature of the modern age, where the Grassmann-style [133] linguistic masking and terminology-translation crisis becomes for the first time in history solvable by AI within four years rather than thirty, literally (C) a frigging AI actually did the Minkowski step! (And to be clear, as the "ultimate importance" of the idea remains undecided, by "Einstein step" I mean spontaneous operation-based cognitive outlook and my "Minkowski step" I mean reduction to axiomatic compactness at the standards of the mainstream).

So yeah! If you had stopped Einstein on the street in 1906 and asked him how to answer some obscure question about time dilation, he would spontaneously give you how the framework operates over precisely that scenario, but if you asked him about the negative metric coefficient he would consider that bordering on an over-complication, like trying to package the operability in a way that merely deduces rather than substantively communicates it. But don't take it from me: just look at how he describes the twin paradox in 1911.

> "If we placed a living organism in a box ... one could arrange that the organism, after any arbitrary lengthy flight, could be returned to its original spot in a scarcely altered condition, while corresponding organisms which had remained in their original positions had already long since given way to new generations. For the moving organism, the lengthy time of the journey was a mere instant, provided the motion took place with approximately the speed of light." [134]

So my point is that, weirdly enough, because of the fast-tracking along my Grassmann-like [133] isolation period thanks to AI, I now am already entering the second stage of the idea's formalistic development without, still, having ever spoken to a single human being about it! Life is weird I guess!

9.3.5 A Basic Introduction to the Three Scopes

The menu's declaration in the formal development is complete but fast, and the scope setting is the one dial the semantics hands you, so it gets a full telling here—through a single scenario run three times, so that the settings' differences show as differences in what happens to *you*. First, two words pinned, because the walkthrough leans on their precision. An *attribute* is a question the world can answer: the light's color, whether you proceeded, when you arrived. A *stated-attribute* is that question together with its answer, as an entry in an Aethus's books: *(light, green)*, *(proceeded, yes)*. The perturbation always targets a stated-attribute; the scope decides which *other* stated-attributes travel with it into blankness.

The shared scenario. Here is your morning, as your current Aethus records it. *(light, green)*: the light was green when you reached the intersection—established there, at that moment of your centric unfolding. *(proceeded, yes)*: you drove through—and notice, because everything below turns on it, that this stated-attribute enjoys *two* supports in your books: the light's being green, (the recorded law, green permits proceeding), *and* your direct memory of driving through, which is its own entry, independently written. *(arrived-early, yes)*: resting on your having proceeded. *(coffee, bought)*: you bought one with the spare minutes—resting on the early arrival. *(song, heard)*: a particular song was playing as you sat at the light—keyed, in your books, to your being at that place at that time, not to the light's color. Now the counterfactual: *had the light not been green.* One operation—reopen *(light, green)*, restate to red, re-prune—run at three scopes.

Evidential-minimal: the auditor's scope. Clear the targeted stated-attribute and its *deductive cone* only—whatever rests on it for support and on nothing else—keeping every entry that enjoys independent standing. Walk your books: does *(proceeded, yes)* rest on the light? Not *only*—your memory supports it independently, so it *survives* the clearing. So do the early arrival, the coffee, the song. Now try to restate *(light, red)*: with *(proceeded, yes)* retained and the law that red demands stopping retained, closure excludes red before any restatement, so the light is not genuinely blank at this scope, the intermediate never satisfies the reopening condition, and the run is *infeasible* rather than vacuously true; an inadmissible intermediate and an admissible one whose final residue is empty are different cases, and this is the first. That is the setting's signature and not a malfunction: evidential-minimal is maximally conservative—it un-knows the *one* thing and keeps every scrap of independent evidence—and its characteristic yield is therefore to *expose conflicts rather than resolve them*, here by reporting that no admissible reopening exists at its scope. That is exactly what an auditor wants. It is also the natural home of *indicative* readings: run the film-spoiler case from the roadmap glossary at this scope—un-know the ending while keeping the suspicions you independently wrote down—and you get "if I in fact hadn't been told the ending, I would *still* distrust her from her first line," which is true, and truly indicative in flavor. What evidential-minimal will not do is tell subjunctive stories about causally entangled attributes; for that, turn the dial.

One further picture of this setting deserves its place, because for some readers it is the native one. Think of your stated-attributes as built like small circuits: "caught in the rain" carries an input slot for "at the stop in time," which carries an input slot for "out of bed in time," which is where the snooze decision feeds in—each attribute explicitly constructed, in the paper's semantic-mining sense, from the more primitive entries it consumes. Now blank the snooze attribute and watch what the deductive cone means at this grain: the clearing does not delete "at the stop in time" wholesale, because that attribute has other inputs still standing; it blanks *the one slot*, and the attribute thereby enters what the mathematical development calls a *mixed decomposition*—part of it blank-decomposable, (the reopened slot, now ranging over its alternatives), and the rest state-decomposable, (everything its other inputs still fix). Each downstream attribute settles into exactly such a constrained superposition, wide precisely where the removed entry fed it and definite everywhere else. This is not a fourth setting; it is evidential-minimal seen at the resolution the decomposability battery provides—the cone traced through the slots rather than tallied by whole entries—and the entry-wise telling above is its coarse-grained shadow, exact whenever the attributes in play happen not to decompose.

Unidirectional: the storyteller's scope, and the default. Clear the targeted stated-attribute together with the generics wired to it on the direction convention's forward side—its recorded effects, the entries it brought about in the books' own telling. Walk the same morning. *(proceeded, yes)*: its memory-support notwithstanding, the proceeding is *recorded as an effect* of the green, so it travels

into blankness—the memory, after all, is a memory *of an effect*, and the storyteller's question is what the world would have done, not what your evidence file contains. The early arrival goes, (posterity of the proceeding), and the coffee with it, (posterity of the arrival): effects fall with their cause, all down the recorded chain. But now the crucial survivor: *(song, heard)*. Is it posterity of the *green*? Check its support in the books: it is keyed to your being at that place at that time—to the attribute of location, not the attribute of color—so it *stands*, untouched. This is flank-independence doing its quiet work: attributes off the causal chain of the perturbed one are simply not its posterity, however nearby in your morning they sat. Restate *(light, red)*; re-prune: the law fires, stopping is entailed, nothing contradicts it—and the residue is a meaningful world-fragment in which you stopped, the song still played, and the arrival and coffee stand *reopened as blanks*, honestly unsettled rather than falsely preserved. "Had the light been red, I would have stopped": true, at full grade. This is why unidirectional is the default: it delivers the standard subjunctive, the "would have" of ordinary speech and scientific practice—and one reminder keeps its books clean: *posterity* here is read off entries the Aethus itself records, bottoming out in the joint-invalidity base; the setting consults no causal oracle beyond your own books. The spoiler case at this scope: your distrust of the character *goes*, (posterity of the spoiler), and "had I not been told, the twist would have landed" comes out true—the reading you meant all along.

Bidirectional: the backtracker's scope. Clear the stated-attribute and every generic wired to it, direction-blind—the forward-side effects and the far-side entries alike, (what brought it about, in the convention's telling). Your books, walked once more: what made the light green when you arrived? A timing entry—you reached the intersection some forty seconds behind the bus, mid-cycle. Under this scope that far-side timing entry travels into blankness too, and now watch the blast radius honestly: with the timing reopened, every entry keyed to *being there at that moment* reopens with it—including, this time, the song, which survived the other two scopes and falls here, since a different arrival-moment is a different soundtrack. The residue is wide: pockets where you left home later, hit a different cycle, heard something else, and the verdicts correspondingly hedge—many pockets, weaker unanimity, softer claims. That trade is the setting's honest price and its honest product. What it buys is the *backtracking* reading that the other scopes refuse: "had the light not been green, I would have left home later"—a perfectly intelligible thing to mean, treated in some traditions as a scandal to be legislated away, and treated here as one declared position of one dial. The spoiler case, backtracked: what brought the ending into your books is your friend's slip, so the conversation itself reopens—"had I not been told, we would have been talking about something else entirely"—available on demand, and clearly labeled as the reading you chose.

The dial, seen whole. One operation; three positions; three characters.

Setting	Character	What it clears	What it keeps	Natural mood
evidential-minimal, $\sigma = \mathrm{em}$	the auditor	the target and its deductive cone only	every independently supported entry; the conflicts exposed	the indicative
unidirectional, $\sigma = \mathrm{uni}$ (default)	the storyteller	the target with its recorded effects, forward of the direction convention	the flanks, and the far side	the standard subjunctive
bidirectional, $\sigma = \mathrm{bi}$	the backtracker	the target and every generic wired to it, both sides	the flanks only; the widest blast radius	the backtracking subjunctive, saying what would have had to differ upstream

In the operator's notation these are $\sigma \in \{\mathrm{em}, \mathrm{uni}, \mathrm{bi}\}$ on $A \ominus_\sigma q$, with uni suppressed where unambiguous; and the discipline underneath all three bears repeating once: each setting selects among structures *recorded in the Aethus's own books*, structures that bottom out in patterns of joint invalidity—so the dial adjusts which recorded dependencies travel, and never which causal metaphysics is true. The fuller derivational treatment, run at theorem grain on this same streetlight, lives with the semantics battery of the formal development above.

9.3.6 Would, Might, and If-In-Fact

Natural language runs counterfactual talk in more than one mood, and the semantics meets each without new machinery. The *subjunctive*—"had the light been red, I *would* have stopped"—is the full

surgery of the previous subsubsections: reopen, restate, re-prune, demand the consequent across every surviving pocket. Its sibling "*might* have" asks less: the consequent in *some* surviving pocket—"had I left earlier, I might have caught the sunrise" needs only one live survivor, not unanimity. And the *indicative*—"if the light *was in fact* red, then I ran it"—is not surgery at all but *selection*: no reopening, just conditioning on the pockets your current Aethus already holds open, your standing uncertainty consulted as it stands. The formal subsection proves a small elegance here worth previewing in plain words: the traditional "two modes" of counterfactual evaluation are simply the two uniform limits of this one operation—selection when the antecedent already lives in your open pockets, full reopening when it is stated to the contrary everywhere—so the mood distinction that grammar hands you falls out of the machinery rather than being bolted on.

9.3.7 Where the Reopened You Lives

Here is the strangest true thing in this subsection, met through your own case. The you of the spoiler-counterfactual—ending unknown, everything else maximally intact—is *not a past you*. Your actual past self who hadn't yet been told also hadn't yet seen the film's second act, hadn't formed Tuesday's opinions, hadn't read this paper; the constructed evaluation point keeps all of that and blanks only the ending. Its books pair entries whose acquisition order your real history reverses—an information state you never once occupied and never will. The genealogical picture, "go back to before you knew," is therefore a picture and not the operation: the operation builds a *new point in the space of Aethae*, synchronically, from your current one. And the framework's ontology is what licenses this without embarrassment: Aethae are *objects, not visits*—your genealogy is one walked path through a space that exists unwalked, and the constructed point is simply another member of that space, as real as any station on your actual route. The formal subsection sharpens this into the off-ancestor results; the plain version is already the whole idea.

9.3.8 The Famous Hard Cases, as a Short Tour

Every counterfactual semantics is tested against a standard battery, and this one's answers can each be felt before they are proved. *Bizet and Verdi*: "had they been compatriots"—both French? both Italian? The supposition restates a *relational* attribute whose reopening genuinely underdetermines the resolution, so the semantics returns a split residue rather than forcing a choice: the right answer to an ambiguous question is the ambiguity, weighted. *Nixon and the button*: "had he pressed it, there would have been nuclear war"—the classic worry being that a semantics might prefer a tidy world where the wiring quietly fails. Here the law-like entries' entrenchment does the work: the button-to-launch entry is generic and outranks the particular facts around it, so the wiring stands and the grim consequent follows; no similarity metric needed tuning, because the priority was read off the entries' own form. *The streetlight trio*: three counterfactuals about one morning, each isolating one clause of the theory. The light-swap leaves what your cat was doing on the landing untouched—attributes off the perturbed one's recorded chains simply do not move, which is *flank-independence*. The same swap does *not* rescue you from the sinkhole that opened ahead, because relative to your at-the-light Aethus the sinkhole and its whole erosion history stood in superposition—the counterfactual's context is the Aethus it is asked from, which is *context-dependence*. And if you once wired a script to auto-order breakfast based on yesterday's light, then relative to *that* Aethus the light moves your breakfast—dependence can be *engineered*, and is exactly as real as the books that record it. *Strengthening*: adding a supposition can, in this semantics, *revive* possibilities the plain supposition had killed, because clearing the added attribute's support may resurrect pockets—a failure of a classical inference pattern that the formal development proves is not a bug but the framework's signature, the very feature that makes it irreducible to Lewis's or Stalnaker's semantics or any smooth similarity ordering. The tour ends where the deletion began: what replaced the similarity ordering is not a better ordering but *no ordering*—indexed books, forced removal, one dial, weighted residues—and the classification results of Section 9.4 prove the replacement cannot be quietly converted back.

9.4 AI-Assisted Proofs

The material in this subsection was drafted, at the author's direction, by the review model credited in the colophon, and it extends the colophon's provenance norms to proof content: everything below is held at the grade its own ledger states, nothing below is consumed elsewhere in the paper until upgraded, and the open steps are named rather than smoothed over. (The upgrade convention, fixed

by the author on August 29, 2026: results are marked completed *progressively*, as they are actually derived, each at the grade its own ledger then states—so a result's standing here is a date-stamped fact about its derivation, not a permanent quarantine.)

9.4.1 The Perturbation Operator as Composite: The Blank Intermediate and the Ideal Removed Object

Three structural facts about the operation deserve their canon at the formal grade, because the theorem below leans on them.

First: the perturbation is composite. First, the perturbation is *composite*: an elementary *removal*, landing on a well-defined *blank intermediate*—the Aethus in which the target attribute is definitively blank, its supports cleared per the closure-identity forcing, (*Why Half the Operation Is a Theorem*), superposition content maximized, ("definitively" meaning *conceptually* blank in the sense of Section 3.3.2—the one grade of blankness a composite target can carry as a stated-attribute, by Decomposition Neutrality, Section 3.3.1)—followed by *selection*, the restating of the chosen value — the pruning being no third stage but the selection's own algebra: composition happens in the quotient by validity equivalence, so selecting is selecting among the valid, the pruning internal as quotienting rather than appended. Every perturbation passes through its blank intermediate; there is no direct jump from Aethus to Aethus. And the scope settings layer onto the *removal* component alone, parameterizing how much the reopening clears and never what the selection states. The conceptual grade has one consequence worth stating for a target that retained content partially constrains—a three-valued q with $r = 1$ stated and $\{r = 1, q = 3\}$ declared invalid, so that q stands semiblank, no value stated and one excluded: the intermediate must clear the mined support of the exclusion, here $r = 1$, together with the target, and where the scope protects that support the reopening is infeasible. The counterfactual extraction's finite model, with dependencies declared and protection independent of entailment, demands at its intermediate only the unresolved grade, no value of the target stated, and leaves such a reopening feasible with $q = 3$ excluded; the two demands coincide on binary attributes, where excluding one value forces the other, hence on every witness of Section 9.2, and part only on multivalued targets constrained by protected content.

Second: removal is many-to-one, and the ideal removed object. Second, removal is many-to-one: clearing different stated-attributes can land on the same blank intermediate, so removal has fibers, and each fiber has a maximum—the *ideal removed object*, the full set of entries the removal cleared, tracks included, meeting every support of each entry it contains, which, where supports are single entries, is closure downward under the support relation the way an algebraic ideal is closed under its operations, (and house-consistently so: the semiring construction already handles invalid elements as an ideal-analogue); a joint support needs only one of its members removed, so in general the removed object is a hitting set of its entries' supports. Restating the ideal object is the guaranteed inverse, recovering the original Aethus exactly; smaller restatements recover it exactly when what they omit is regenerated, over the intermediate's retained entries, by closure — a generation question, with minimal recovering sets in general non-unique. A small perturbing stone can raise a large splash, and undoing the splash requires a stone that regenerates it: the largest such stone exists wherever the scope is feasible and the priorities select a greatest restriction, and is then the ideal removed object; it is rarely the only one. And both facts are algebra, not metaphor, wherever the declared priorities determine the reopening uniquely: the removal is there the *interior operator* onto the target-blank states — contractive, monotone, idempotent, the right adjoint to their inclusion into one fixed poset, whence the intermediate's uniqueness, the adjunction being claimed on that fixed domain and, where the scope varies with the input, only once the admissible blank states fit together coherently across inputs — (where priorities tie, only incomparable maximal restrictions exist, the remainder situation of the belief-revision literature, and the operation is multi-valued, the algebra applying branchwise with E^* unique per branch) — and the ideal removed object $E^* = A \setminus (A \ominus q)$ is unique, downward-closed under support, (an entry whose support survived would be re-derived by closure, contradicting blankness), with $\mathrm{Cl}((A \ominus q) \cup E^*) = A$ exactly and any proper subset recovering strictly less. The clearing map's fibers are the preimages under the saturation $E \mapsto \mathrm{ideal}(E)$, whose fixed points are exactly the ideal removed objects: the splash principle, stated as algebra.

Third: Aethae over static Aethae. Third, and beneath both, an ontological commitment that may be this framework's earliest, dating to the original 2021 proposal of Aethae: *privilege Aethae over static Aethae.* A static Aethus is one possible list of facts equivalent to an Aethus—one presentation of the closure, a coordinate chart for the abstract object—and the commitment, call it *the non-realist existence of static Aethae*, is that such lists are brute mechanisms meant to capture the more abstract

Aethae, never fundamental themselves. It is this commitment that makes the blank intermediate mandatory: were static Aethae privileged, one could jump list-to-list directly; privileging Aethae, one operates over Aethae only, and the intermediate exists as a genuine station of the operation.[161]

Fourth, and answering an open question the first three had left standing: where the reopened blank's weights come from. The Nexus Principle, (Section 6.7), demands that every blank attribute of a physically existent Aethus carry a weighting scheme.

The gap. The removal just described returns the target to blank—but, as the operation had so far been stated, only to the *intrinsic* blank of the unweighted Aethus: the weights the attribute's alternatives carried before it was stated were consumed when the statement pruned them, and nothing in the removal as written put them back. That is a gap between the operator and the principle, and the author's ruling of August 29, 2026 closes it from material the framework already owns.

What the Aethus retains, and what a reopening recovers. An Aethus proper carries its invalid terms: invalidation is a *relabeling*, never an equality to zero, (the signed-weight doctrine of Section 6.7: a marked object the tree remembers, its weight intact beneath the mark), and validity equivalence runs over the full structure only at the end, to yield the physical probabilities on which centric unfolding runs. So the alternatives a stated attribute pruned were never deleted; they stand in the Aethus as invalid terms, invalidated *by* the intersection with that statement, each carrying the weight the initial-condition Aethus assigned it. And invalidity is indexed to its invalidators by the joint-invalidity relation, (Section 9.1.1): a term is invalid because some set of stated entries is jointly invalid with it. Remove the statement—which is what the reopening does, ideal removed object and all—and the joint invalidity no longer obtains; the marks lift; the terms pop back on as valid, carrying exactly the weights they carried before. The blank intermediate is therefore *weighted*, not intrinsic, and weighted by nothing chosen: by the Aethus's own retained structure, which is the weighting the initial-condition Aethus of the centric unfolding assigned—*your initial-condition Aethus is your Nexus.*

The Nexic wing's name for it. The Nexic long paper already has this object under its own name: the *Aetherian Nexus*, N_H, the weighted superposition of all mediocre observer-Aethae, the Null Aethus under observer-typicality, which that paper identifies with *one's earliest possible parent Aethus in Aethic time* for any observer whose Aethus is mediocre. The identification here is therefore the one the Nexic wing already carries, read now at the grain of the individual Aethus's retained structure: the earliest parent is not somewhere behind the observer but present in the observer's own Aethus, as the invalid terms the observer's history has marked.

Three consequences follow at once.

- The Nexus Principle's demand is met for reopened blanks by the Aethus itself, with no second weighting scheme posited for the reopening.

[161] *2026-07-17T20:50:04.724331Z*

As for your question, if I understand it correctly it's asking about the Aethic perturbation move's reopening, specifically in terms of whether dropping y (and therefore s) and then adding back y checks out as removing s, since y is already believed. I mean my clear intuition about this is the question of whether we're privileging Aethae or privileging static Aethae. That is, if we're privileging Aethae then there ought to be an exact ''methodological intermediate'' Aethus for which y is definitively established as blank, and therefore s as well. Hence we ''need only operate over Aethae'' with static Aethae, like coordinate invariance, being non-fundamental. However if we're privileging static Aethae, then we don't need that intermediate Aethus, and can jump directly from the stats to the new version. So basically my take is an ontological commitment that we ought to privilege Aethae over static Aethae, being perhaps my earliest decision in proposing Aethae to begin with in 2021. That itself could be a principle--the non-realist-existence of static Aethae, with their only being brute mechanisms meant to capture the more abstract Aethae. But yes even in terms of the Aethic tree maneuvers alone, absolutely I think there should be a well-defined ''the blank intermediate'' Aethus, that way we can operate over solely Aethae and even picture Aethic perturbation itself, as an operation, as merely the joint operation of ''remove'' followed by ''select''. See what I mean? That itself might require some rewriting in the paper, if we want the Aethic perturbation operator to be composite and the ''remove'' to be elementary instead! If you will, the reopen move should maximize superposition content, so its putting s back as blank seems definitively necessary to me on those grounds. I think this also highlights, intuitively, the fact that removing of two different stated-attributes can leave you with the same resulting Aethus (almost like a modular repetition kind of thing), so the ''inverse'' principle I suppose would have to be something like that for a given reopening removal operation, there's an ''ideal removed object'' or whatever the right abstract algebraic name would be for it, and then it's THAT OBJECT which the selection restating of has to give you back the Aethus you started with. So, like, intuitively the removal operation absolutely has to clear all its tracks, which means removing some tiny little thing, in order to restate a full superposition, is going to propagate back to blanks exactly as far as needed, no more and no less. So the ''splash'' can often be very large from a small metaphorical stone, even in cases where the same splash would have resulted from a larger stone. It's just that undoing the splash in full requires the largest stone that creates that particular splash. *(Correction, August 26, 2026, external referee round on the extraction: the last clause overclaims — the largest stone always suffices and is the guaranteed undoing, but any stone that regenerates the splash over what the removal retained suffices too, and minimal such stones are in general non-unique. The body text above states the corrected form; the dictation stands as recorded.)*

- The recovery is *synchronic*: no genealogy is walked, because the invalid terms are in the Aethus now, contributed by every parent and not only by the contingent route of one Aethus-life—which is what the sinkhole's reversal intuition, (Section 9.1), was reaching for and could not get from a linear ascent, an Aethus being richer than any one route through it.

- And the measure-invariance question that the counterfactual semantics books open—which measure the grades inherit over the reopened blank—is narrowed to a determinate answer on the qualitative side: the measure is the Aetherian Nexus restricted to the reopened attribute, fixed by the Aethus rather than selected; what remains open is the quantitative kernel's own derivation, (the first of the Open Constructions, Section 14.8), exactly as before.[162]

The condition consumed, and the definitional consequence. One condition is consumed and should be stated: the recovery requires that invalidation be *indexed*—that the tree record not only that a term is invalid but through which stated entries it became so—which the joint-invalidity relation supplies and a bare invalidity predicate would not; and one definitional consequence the author drew should be recorded as his: the Aethus is to be *defined* so as to contain this structure—the weighted invalid terms among its contents, validity equivalence a quotient taken at the end—rather than as the quotient itself. The derivation that upgrades the paragraph from ruling to result is the recovery lemma—that removing an entry lifts exactly the marks that entry's joint invalidities imposed, and no others—and it is short enough to give here, in the vocabulary of the invalidity-root rebuild, (Section 9.1.1).

Lemma 2 (Recovery)
In the joint-invalidity rebuild, call an alternative (β, y) marked in an Aethus A when some finite $S \subseteq A$ has $S \cup \{(\beta, y)\}$ jointly invalid, (a witness), and let $A' = A \ominus \alpha$ be the reopening of a stated attribute α: a maximal closed, valid restriction of A in which α is blank, selected by the declared priorities where several exist. Then:

(i) every alternative marked in A' is marked in A;

(ii) an alternative marked in A is unmarked in A' if and only if every witness for its mark in A meets the cleared set $A \setminus A'$;

(iii) in particular, an alternative (α, x') of the reopened attribute is marked in A' only by content of A' that excludes it independently of the removed entry, so the alternatives of α unmarked in A' are exactly α's open answer space relative to A';

(iv) the weights those alternatives carry in A' are the weights they carried beneath their marks in A.

Proof. (i) $A' \subseteq A$, so a witness in A' is a witness in A. (ii) If some witness $S \subseteq A$ avoids the cleared set, then $S \subseteq A'$ and the mark persists in A'; conversely, if every witness meets the cleared set, no witness is a subset of A', and since marks are constituted by witnesses among the standing content

[162] *2026-08-29T08:56-04:00* (8:56 AM ET, per the author)
Also by the way I just now (8:56 AM ET time, August 29, 2026) thought of a concept that is funnily elegant given that I didn't even consider it until it hit me just now: since we're already accepting that an Aethus proper is allowed to carry all the excess invalid Aethae baggage that validity-equivalence-Aethae remove, in the sense that it's the Aethae that exist operatively/ontologically and the validity-equivalence relation runs over that at the end to get us our physical probabilities over which centric unfolding runs, then, like, that itself solves an open question I've been wrestling with! That is, the open question was: since the Nexus principle of Aethic reasoning demands that blanks always have to have an Aethic weight, then this contradicts how we've set up reopening so far, in that it gives you a blank attribute back, but only up to the intrinsic/unweighted Aethus case, (if you check that leg of the paper for how such works) and not the full weighted Aethae case. So my thought just now was "if only it was already intrinsic to a weighted Aethus how the Nexus behaves even for arbitrary reopened attributes" then "what if I enforced in the definition of an Aethus that such structure is contained" then "holy darn, this IS viable inside of Aethus rather than validity-equivalent-Aethae!". That is, all the Nexus information IS STILL THERE in the actual Aethus itself, it's just stored in all the invalid Aethae terms that you had "at the beginning of life" (in terms of the Aethus "initial conditions" to the centric unfolding, whatever that means ontologically anyway) but then in subsequent Aethae made invalid by means of intersecting your centric unfolding repertoire of Aethic updates! So, basically my initial thought when I wrote the sinkhole pedagogical setup that the original June 2026 Claude Fable used to infer the Aethic structure was specifically reversing one's own centric unfolding SPECIFICALLY to access one's own past Nexus, although the problem of course was that an Aethus is by definition richer than this linear take, since it has a bunch of parent Aethae rather than only those of the contingent route through centric unfolding that is one's Aethus-life so far! So, here's how we get both, easily even: salvage the Nexus in the existing invalid Aethus terms, and then notice how once you do the reopening, it applies to THEM too and suddenly a bunch pop on as valid again, therefore meaning by definition that you get to exploit PRECISELY the same Nexus as that of your initial condition Aethus per the centric unfolding! So, if you will, your initial condition Aethus IS your Nexus also, to be clear! And it's what I call "the Aetherian Nexus" in the Nexic paper, specifically speaking! Thanks!

and nothing else, the alternative is unmarked in A'. (iii) The witness that marked (α, x') in A through the stated entry is $\{(\alpha, x)\}$, by same-attribute exclusivity, and it is cleared by construction; by (ii) the mark lifts unless some other witness lies wholly in A', which is exactly independent exclusion by the remaining content, and the unmarked alternatives are those no such witness touches—the answer space A' leaves open. (iv) Marking is a relabeling and never an equality to zero, (the signed-weight doctrine of Section 6.7), so the weight beneath a mark is never altered by the marking; lifting the mark exposes it unchanged. □

The lemma is what the paragraph consumed: the blank a reopening lands on is weighted, by the initial-condition scheme restricted to the answer space the remaining content leaves open, with nothing posited for the reopening and no genealogy walked. Its own premises are the rebuild's two axioms—monotonicity and same-attribute exclusivity—together with the signed-weight doctrine, and the removal theorem's forced upstream clearing fixes the cleared set the lemma quantifies over. The paragraph's consequences accordingly stand at derived grade given those, and the ruling's one condition—that invalidation be indexed to its invalidators—is the witness structure the lemma is written in.

9.4.2 Toward Non-Representability: Aethic Verdicts Against Similarity Orderings

The formal-semantics discussion above deletes the similarity ordering as a primitive and poses non-recoverability as the standing challenge. This subsubsection pushes the challenge as far as it will presently go, and the push has a compass sentence: *an ordering semantics evaluates a strengthened antecedent by shrinking a fixed field of worlds, while the Aethic perturbation re-derives the field*—and everything below is that difference made formal. A deflating reduction must climb three rungs: represent Aethae by their total completions and evaluate by supervaluation; failing that, represent the verdicts by a centered similarity ordering over completed worlds; failing that, retreat to orderings over richer points. Each rung gets its own obstruction, at its own grade.

Rung one, closed outright.

Lemma 3 (Completion-Blindness)
(The completion here is a forgetful projection onto classical outcome descriptions: it discards the interaction entry, an attribute of the co-presence that a determinate refinement no longer holds, so the lemma concerns representations that discard it and is not a property of refinements that preserve stated content.) There exist Aethae with identical classes of total completions but distinct validated conditionals. Hence no function of the completion class—supervaluation included—computes the Aethic verdict.

Proof. Take one blank attribute over alternatives $\{a_1, a_2\}$ and form two Aethae identical in every stated attribute and weight apart from the interaction attribute e_{12}, blank in the first, (the agreeing form), and stated in the second, (the disagreeing form); the completion map is a projection that discards exactly that information. Every total completion settles the attribute to a_1 or to a_2; the pair structure thereby dissolves, and e_{12}, being an attribute of the co-presence rather than of either completed alternative, leaves no footprint in any completion. The completion classes coincide. But any book entry keyed to e_{12}—and the quantum continuation is built of little else—yields conditionals the two Aethae decide differently. □

The interior of a superposition is exactly what completions cannot see, and rung one collapses on it.

Rung two, the centerpiece. By the evaluation clause, a plain conditional holds at an Aethus exactly when its consequent holds across *every* surviving pocket of the perturbed residue: no pocket is ranked above another, and survivors are consulted universally. A consequence relation of this shape *presents* as preferential in the sense of Kraus, Lehmann, and Magidor [135]—but the shape is the clause's, and the proposition below shows the consequence relation does not inherit it. Two standard facts fix the target. Rational monotony—from $X \boxdot\!\!\rightarrow Y$ and $\neg(X \boxdot\!\!\rightarrow \neg Z)$ infer $(X \wedge Z) \boxdot\!\!\rightarrow Y$—is the watershed between preferential systems and *ranked* ones, those representable by total orders and hence by similarity orderings, and every centered total-ordering semantics validates it, (strengthening an antecedent by something unexcluded can only shrink the selected set within the same order) [136]. And cautious monotony—from $X \boxdot\!\!\rightarrow Y$ and $X \boxdot\!\!\rightarrow Z$ infer $(X \wedge Y) \boxdot\!\!\rightarrow Z$—is a defining rule of the preferential class itself. The mechanism that breaks both is already in the clauses: evaluating $X \wedge Z$ is not evaluating X and filtering by Z, because the contraction step clears Z's *supporting premises* as well, and pockets that the X-perturbation had pruned *through* those premises can return. Call this *pocket resurrection*: $\pi_{X \wedge Z}$ is not a restriction of π_X, and a resurrected pocket carrying $\neg Y$ is the Kraus–Lehmann–Magidor countermodel translated.

Proposition 26 (Cautious Monotony Fails; Non-Representability)
There is a four-attribute Aethus on which the would-clause's consequence relation $\mid\!\sim$ satisfies $X \mid\!\sim y$ and $X \mid\!\sim Z$ but not $(X \wedge y) \mid\!\sim Z$. Hence $\mid\!\sim$ is not preferential, and a fortiori not representable at the consequence-relation level by any smooth preferential model, nor by Lewis's sphere semantics, which validates Cautious Monotony with or without the limit assumption (Proposition 23), nor by Stalnaker's; what falls outside the theorem is an ordering read by the minimal-worlds clause without smoothness, and rational monotony fails on the same instance.

Proof. The model has attributes x, y, z, s and the following books: s is stated; the law $s \to y$ holds in the constraint layer, so y is in the closure with s as its sole particular support; X and Z are blank; and the joint constraint that $\{x, s, \neg z\}$ is invalid. Three claims. (1) $X \mid\!\sim y$: reopening X clears nothing that supports s, (s rests on nothing in the cleared scope), so s is retained; refinements never flip stated entries; and closure carries y into every pocket. (2) $X \mid\!\sim Z$: with x and s in every pocket, the constraint excludes $\neg z$, so z holds throughout the residue. (3) $(X \wedge y) \not\mid\!\sim Z$: evaluating the conjunctive antecedent passes through the blank intermediate on the dual-peg reading, (Section 3.3.1), so y's support s is cleared; the restatement returns y and never the ideal removed object, so the residue contains $\neg s$ pockets; in those the constraint does not bite and $\neg z$ survives, so Z fails in some pocket. Since preferential relations satisfy cautious monotony and ranked relations are preferential, (1)–(3) place $\mid\!\sim$ outside both classes. For rational monotony take $Y := z$ and the strengthening attribute y: $X \mid\!\sim z$ by (2), $\neg(X \mid\!\sim \neg y)$ by (1), and $(X \wedge y) \mid\!\sim z$ fails by (3). □
Three things the proposition's strength depends on, each fixed here. *First, partiality.* The would-clause's consequence relation is partial and indexed, and the Kraus–Lehmann–Magidor representation theorem is stated for total relations on a language; so it should be said exactly what the countermodel excludes. *Preferential-extension lemma*: any preferential relation, on any superlanguage, that agrees with $\mid\!\sim$ on every pair where $\mid\!\sim$ is evaluable satisfies cautious monotony on every fully evaluable instance of it, since it satisfies the rule on its whole language and coincides with $\mid\!\sim$ on the evaluable pairs. The countermodel is a fully evaluable instance on which the rule fails, so *no preferential relation extends the would-clause's consequence relation*—which is the exact class excluded, the KLM preferential class, with the Lewis–Stalnaker world-similarity semantics falling inside it under the cited representation results as a separate corollary. It is not claimed that a partial relation falls under the representation theorem; it is shown that no preferential completion of it exists. *Second, priorities.* The reopening runs under declared priorities over supports—laws over particulars, and the rest—whose derivation the framework books as open; the proposition does not wait on it. In the witness y has the *sole* support s, so at the decisive step, the reopening of $X \wedge y$, there is exactly one candidate support to clear and nothing for a priority policy to adjudicate; the only property of the policy the derivation uses anywhere is that it is *antecedent-independent*, fixed by the Aethus and the model before any antecedent is supplied. That requirement is load-bearing for the whole deletion claim and is stated as such: a priority policy that varied with the antecedent would be a similarity ordering wearing a different name. *Third, the grade.* The deletion is three claims at three grades, not one claim at three strengths: clause-level deletion—no complete-world similarity relation occurs in the perturbation—is a theorem by inspection of the definition; qualitative non-recoverability—no preferential extension—is the proposition just proved, with the lemma; full graded and indexed non-recoverability—no ordering semantics reproducing the weighted verdicts across Aethae—is open, and the open one is not a defect in the two that are proved.
Remarks. The reading on which the model runs—each conjunct's ground cleared—is not a convention: Section 3.3.1 derives it from the composite canon together with Decomposition Neutrality, and both rival exempting readings privilege a decomposition. Its natural-language face is a recognizable explaining-away pattern, since cautious monotony is often treated as nearly analytic: *if X and y had held anyway*, y's actual ground is up for grabs, and conclusions leaning on that ground go with it. And the Or rule holds under the union reading of disjunctive restatement: the disjunction perturbs the same attribute, hence shares the removal's interior and its blank intermediate; the constrained restatement imposes the disjunction as a condition on the pockets, the maximal consistent refinements of the intermediate stating one of the disjuncts, and never as an entry, closure adding only forced entries, so the excluded value cannot return; and each such pocket coincides with a pocket of the realized disjunct's own perturbation. What remains open at this rung is the richer object, representability of the full graded, indexed, multi-pocket verdict function.

Rung three, the honest escape. A determined representationalist may retreat to orderings over richer points—Aethae themselves as the "worlds." Two remarks keep the retreat honest. First, this concedes the original contest: the similarity tradition's worlds are total, and an ordering over partial,

interaction-bearing, validity-graded points is no longer that tradition but a new semantics wearing its notation. Second, even the retreat strains against the third postulate's structure: validity at an Aethus is quantified over its descendant tree, two generations deep, so the verdict at a point depends on data no static centered comparison at that point contains—any representing order must be re-derived per index, which is representation in name only. This rung is not closed; it is re-posed, and posing it precisely is the subsection's contribution to it.

The ledger. Proved here: Lemma 3; the preferential *shape* of the evaluation clause, (a property of the clause, not inherited by the consequence relation); and Proposition 26, on the conjunctive reading Section 3.3.1 derives, with rational monotony failing on the same instance. Standard and cited: rational monotony as the ranked/preferential watershed; cautious monotony as a defining rule of the preferential class. Licensed by the clauses: pocket resurrection through a reopened conjunct's ground, as the failure mechanism. Open, and named: the rung-three closure, (the remaining theorem), and representability of the full graded verdict function. Nothing in this subsubsection is consumed elsewhere in the paper.

9.4.3 The Third Postulate and Invalid Inheritance: A Referee's Countermodel, Dissolved

A referee of the axiomatization extraction produced a finite countermodel against the third postulate, and the extraction's handling of it went wrong twice before the author's own argument settled it. The record is kept because the resolution turns on a property of proper childhood that the extraction had silently dropped, and the property is worth having on the page.

The countermodel. It is the Example Aethic Inheritance Diagram of subsection 12.2 with one node changed: A with proper children B and $C \in$ Base, B with proper children $D \in$ Base and E a consistent leaf. The referee's claim was that under $\mathcal{V}[A] \Rightarrow \exists B \leq A,\ \forall C \leq B,\ \mathcal{V}[C]$, A is invalid—every immediate child of A has an invalid immediate child—while B is valid, so that invalid inheritance, every child of an invalid state invalid, fails for the rule; and the extraction had called inheritance "the one corollary immediate from the definition."

Why it is not a countermodel. The argument presupposes that a proper child is an immediate child: that the B the observer moves to must be one step down, and the C nature replies with one step below that. The extraction had invited this reading by defining its descent symbol as resolving a single blank per link—a relation the framework never had, and one the AI-assisted drafting had imposed on it. But proper childhood, $\leq$, is reflexive and transitive by composition of decompositions, every proper child being a refinement of its parent by Aethic intersection, $B = A \cap X$ for some X, with $C = B \cap Y$ giving $C = A \cap (X \cap Y)$ along the way. Under it, E is a proper child of B and hence of A, and E has no invalid proper child. So A has a proper child all of whose proper children are valid, the postulate's condition is met, and A is valid. The referee's A is not doomed; the countermodel dissolves.

Inheritance, as the corollary it is. The author's argument, in three lines. Let B be a valid proper child of A. By the postulate, $\mathcal{V}[B]$ gives a proper child C of B every one of whose proper children is valid. By transitivity C is a proper child of A. So A has a proper child all of whose proper children are valid, satisfies the postulate's condition, and—validity being the largest predicate satisfying it and A not a contradiction—is valid. Contrapositively, an invalid A has no valid proper child: invalid inheritance holds, and it is a corollary of the postulate read with validity as the greatest predicate satisfying its condition, $\mathcal{V} = \nu F$, which the base-generation reading supplies and the algebraic extraction takes as the definition of formal validity; under the bare implication $\mathcal{V} \subseteq F(\mathcal{V})$ the three lines show only that A satisfies the condition. The extraction's original text was right, at that grade.

The two readings set aside. Fable's first response replaced the postulate with satisfiability—valid iff some path of refinements reaches a consistent complete state—which is a different game, one in which the observer chooses every refinement and nature none. Its second response kept the postulate but conceded non-inheritance, reading the game as immediate-step so that the observer at A must pass through B and face nature's D. Both were wrong for the same reason: both read a proper child as an immediate child. With $\leq$ transitive the observer at A may move directly to any proper child, E among them, and there is no reply. On Oliver's Aethus the three readings agree, every proper child of it having an invalid proper child at every depth, which is why the misreadings survived that test; they come apart only on the variant, and there the transitive reading is the framework's. Verified, September 18, 2026: under transitive proper childhood, A is valid on the variant and inheritance holds on every structure tested; under an immediate-child relation, and only there, the referee's verdict obtains. What the extraction needed was not a new rule and not a withdrawn corollary but the framework's own relation restored to its definition.

9.5 Pedagogical Exercises: Three Cases at Full Concreteness

This subsection exists for a reason worth stating: a foundational and interdisciplinary paper must expect readers who cannot follow every discipline's native content, and it owes them cases unpacked with nothing presupposed—every term introduced by the very entry it describes. The three cases below are deliberately gentle, and they complement the compressed treatments that ride elsewhere, (the operator's trace in the semantics section, the walked trichotomy beside the Powerset theorem). A reader fluent in all the relevant fields loses nothing by skipping ahead; a reader from any single field gains a working grip on the machinery in three short sittings.

9.5.1 The Streetlight, Run Twice

You drove through an intersection yesterday, and your books—your Aethus—hold three relevant entries. *Entry one*: the light was green; stated, since you saw it; call it GREEN. *Entry two*: at red lights, I stop—your standing disposition, and notice its form: it *quantifies* over all red-light encounters, which is what makes it a law-like entry, (generality read off the entry's own shape). *Entry three*: I proceeded through; stated; call it PROCEEDED—and here is the property everything turns on: it has *independent support*. You remember driving through, directly. Its standing does not rest on entry one; you did not infer your proceeding from the light's color. Said positively, as the framework prefers: form the *parent Aethus* holding entries one and two—GREEN and the disposition, with entry three absent—and take its deductive closure. PROCEEDED is not in it. That unit-level fact about the parent *is* the whole of the intrinsic-support claim, with no negative "does not rest on" left dangling: independence is membership-failure in a constructed parent's closure, which is exactly the entry-absent construction by which Aethic deduction is defined. (A subtlety worth absorbing: PROCEEDED is, at bottom, not an objective-fact claim but the Aethus of your *experience* of proceeding—which is why it would survive even the discovery that you had been dreaming. Aethic truth abides at the knife-edge interface of experience with the world.) Now the sentence on the table: *had the light been red, I would have stopped*. Subjunctive mood, so the reopening runs, and the scope setting decides its blast radius.

Run it twice; the difference is the lesson. *Evidential-minimal* clears GREEN plus only what rests on it for support—the deductive cone. Does PROCEEDED rest on GREEN? No: memory supports it independently, so PROCEEDED survives. Try to restate RED: with PROCEEDED retained and the law-like disposition retained, closure excludes RED before any restatement, so the light is not genuinely blank at this scope, the intermediate never satisfies the reopening condition, and the run is infeasible rather than vacuously true. That is what fatal means here: the framework's flagship check is supposed to output *would-stopped, at grade one, meaningfully*, and at this scope the machine instead reports that no admissible reopening exists. *Unidirectional*, the default, clears GREEN plus its recorded *effects*, (the forward side of the direction convention)—and PROCEEDED is one: you proceeded because the light was green, via the disposition, (in the constraint-layer language of Section 5.2.2: the gadget "green implies proceed," mined from the disjointness of *not-green-and-all-else-equal* with *proceed*). So PROCEEDED is cleared; restate RED; the disposition gives STOPPED; nothing contradicts it; the residue is stopped-throughout—*would*, at grade one, non-vacuously. The intuition underneath, stated once: when you imagine the light having been red, you must un-imagine what the green light *caused*, (your proceeding), while keeping what it did not cause, (the sinkhole down the road, your brakes, the coin in your pocket). Evidence-lines and cause-lines are different lines through the same books—two orientations of the one constraint web—and the streetlight is exactly the case where the two orientations disagree about one entry, which is why it serves as the acceptance test for the whole semantics.

9.5.2 The Oswald Pair, for Every Evaluator

Your books hold Kennedy's death, stated—you saw the funeral—and the shooter's identity, blank, with weight w_O on Oswald and $1 - w_O$ on someone else. The standing residue therefore has two pockets: *Pocket O*, Oswald did it, at w_O; *Pocket E*, someone else did, at $1 - w_O$; each carrying *the shot caused the death* in its own record. First sentence: the subjunctive, *if Oswald hadn't shot him, someone else would have*. Mood sets both switches—posterity scope, and reopening of the state itself rather than of its pockets one by one. The shooter is blank already, so the greatest shooter-blank restriction at posterity scope is the state with the recorded posterity of the shot cleared, the death among it, in Pocket E as in Pocket O; a per-pocket procedure would leave E untouched and clear O alone, and it computes a different operation. Restate no-shot-by-Oswald and re-prune: with no conspiracy anywhere on your books, nothing regenerates the death, so the residue holds he-lives pockets beside

second-shooter pockets carried at small positive weight w_S, visible against the rest. Aggregate: *would false, might true only through those pockets, grade small and positive*, w_S against the whole residue, for every w_O; pockets at exactly zero weight would be no proper children and would sustain neither reading. The verdict no longer converges on the indicative as $w_O \to 0$; that convergence belonged to the per-pocket procedure, and what someone all but certain it wasn't Oswald means is carried by the indicative below. Second sentence: the indicative, *if Oswald didn't shoot him, someone else did*. The indicative discards contrary pockets—it *is* selection—so Pocket O drops, Pocket E remains, the death stands, and the verdict is true at grade one; and that number is no accident, being exactly the conditional probability of someone-else given not-Oswald, which is Adams's thesis arriving as a computation. (The *believer's* indicative—no pocket in which the antecedent holds—has an empty selection and no indicative verdict, the counterfactual there being the subjunctive's.) The moral in one line: mood selects the operation and its scope, and for uncertain evaluators the machinery returns a graded, credence-sensitive verdict that no binary semantics produces.

9.5.3 The Slits, Three Bins Walked

Slits in a barrier; label them 1 through n. An alternative is a subset T of the slits, read as the claim *exactly these are coherently open together*. The detectors, (and everything else that keeps records, the collimator that aimed the beam included), carve the *signature partition*: two slits sit in the same class exactly when no possible record anywhere distinguishes them. The theorem sorts every T into three bins, and the sorting can be walked. *Case one*, T a proper subset of one class: the claim draws a line *inside* a class—distinguishing slits that share every possible record—and by record-individuation, a distinction no information could ever support is not a distinction the attribute space contains: second-postulate invalid. The standard surprise resolves on the spot: "with no detectors the singleton $\{1\}$ is invalid—but I can just aim the beam at slit one!"—and indeed you can, because the collimator is itself a record; aiming the beam *splits the class*, and the singleton becomes a full class of the *new* partition. Legal again, because the partition moved. *Case two*, T equal to one full class: every branch of the maintained superposition produces the identical total signature, so no refinement along accessible records can ever expose a contradiction—valid, with the limiting cases reading correctly, (empty T trivially valid; with no detectors there is one class, so the sole valid nonempty claim is the full set: the pure interference regime, exactly as observed). *Case three*, T meeting two or more classes: some detector's record separates a T-slit in one class from a T-slit in another, so the coherence claim, conjoined with that record's future stating, is contradictory—while the record family is persistent over the candidate's declared descent, every refinement having a further descendant stating the separating record, which is the theorem's persistence hypothesis, a condition on what remains available throughout descent and distinct from completeness, which concerns what the signature includes, so every escape route runs through the contradiction. That is checkmate in the fixed-point sense: third-postulate invalid; concretely, switch the detector on, and $T = \{1, 2\}$ spans the classes, the both-slits element dies, and the fringes vanish. Two closers worth carrying: move or erase a detector and the partition redraws, re-binning the powerset—the sliding quantum–classical boundary as literal re-classification; and the theorem's shape in one breath: bookkeeping over a partition plus two postulates, with everything quantum entering through which partition the records induce.

9.5.4 The Lake, the Dam, and the Twelve Hours: One Sentence in Three Aethae

Your town keeps a lake behind an artificial dam, and you see the lake often—weekly, say, and without incident. Then, at a committee meeting, you learn what happened a month earlier: a sinkhole opened under the dam, a sharp-eyed local spotted it in the nick of time, an emergency crew patched it the same day, and the committee's own summary was blunt: *had she waited just twelve more hours, we would have lost the lake*. The case is a gift, because your books and the committee's books held different things for a month, and one sentence lands differently in each.

Start with your books *before* the meeting. Entry one: LAKE-PRESENT—stated, continuously, every time you looked; its deductive closure already contains NOT-LOST for every day up to now, which is why you never needed to hear the news to know the lake survived it. Entry two is the interesting absence: any NEAR-DRAIN EVENT stands blank. So your Aethus holds a disagreeing superposition over the event's very occurrence—and *inside* the child Aethae that state the event, the event's *date* is itself blank, a further disagreeing superposition one refinement down. Nested structure, read straight off the books: children refine whether, grandchildren refine when. The weights lean heavily toward NO-EVENT, and the lean has a source you can audit: base rates. Dam-threatening sinkholes are statistically rare,

and *that* much is deducible from your books—which is the closure lesson worth pausing on. Aethic weights are fixed at deductive closure over the Aethus, the ultimate flawless mathematician working from your books: strictly above what you personally sat down and computed, strictly below arbitrary specificity, (the closure supports the regional rarity of dam failures; it does not support the refinement your state's soil surveys or climate code would add, because those were never in the books). Awareness undershoots the Aethus; omniscience overshoots it; the closure is the exact address in between.

The meeting is then a pruning, and a pointed one: the event, the date, the spotter, the twelve-hour margin all enter stated at once, and the surviving pocket is one your prior weights ranked *low*. Absorb what that does and does not mean. Low weight never meant invalid—the pocket was always a standing alternative, and being selected is what standing alternatives are for; and nothing is rewritten—your prior Aethus keeps its superposition permanently, the meeting having produced a new evaluation point rather than edited an old one.

Now the committee's sentence, run three ways. *In a committee member's Aethus*, where the event has been stated since the day itself: subjunctive mood, contrary antecedent, (she did not wait), so the reopening runs at the default unidirectional setting—the patch is cleared *together with its forward-wired generics, its recorded posterity*, the lake's survival included; the delay is restated; and the dam's physics, a law-like entry quantifying over unpatched breaches, meets twelve unpatched hours and drains the lake in every surviving pocket. The would-counterfactual holds, at grade one. And notice which of the three settings did the work: run the same sentence at *evidential-minimal* and LAKE-PRESENT, standing on its independent support, (they kept seeing the lake too), survives the reopening to contradict the restated delay—the streetlight's lesson again, at municipal stakes; while *bidirectional*, the third setting, runs the clearing on both sides and licenses the backtracking cousins, (*then the sinkhole would have to have opened later than it did*), by extending the reopening upstream. One sentence, three settings, three different evaluations—the categories are not bookkeeping but the difference between verdicts. And one coincidence completes the lesson: in your pre-meeting Aethus the second and third settings agree *identically*, the sinkhole's history standing blank already—upstream was fringe, not root—so the dial's third position separates from its second exactly where, and only where, the direction convention has recorded structure to filter. *In your post-meeting Aethus*, the run is the member's run: the moment the books gained the event, the sentence became evaluable at full specificity, and it evaluates identically. *In your pre-meeting Aethus*, the sentence is not evaluable at all at that address—*she*, *the day*, *the sinkhole* name nothing the books state—and the nearest evaluable kin is a generic, (*had a breach under the dam gone unpatched for twelve hours...*), run across the low-weight event-pockets and their date-refinements. Same words, three Aethae, three objects: a full run, the same run, and no run but a generic cousin. Counterfactual content is indexed, and this case shows the indexing doing a month of honest work.

9.6 The Fallacy of Initial Conditions

By this point, it should hopefully be clear that Aethic reasoning argues that the importance of "initial conditions" to our classical intuition for system ontology is now deemed arbitrary. It is a remnant of the postulate of complete reality that has to be avoided through the Aethic lens. Instead, now we would assert that the state of a system is a function not of its initial conditions, but of whichever Aethus is that of the observer.

To clearly highlight what this is specifically arguing against, take a swinging double pendulum for an example. The classic analysis of such a pendulum is that it has a definite, deterministic path to it, being a function of its precise initial conditions. However, this makes one clear fallacy in the Aethic lens, which is only truly correct in some but not all cases: it assumes that all present superpositions are disagreeing ones.

Disagreeing superpositions are certainly very fundamental to those places in which they apply. Our modern and popular idea of "timeline splits" are, in a sense, merely referring to disagreeing superpositions. The only difference is that a timeline is supposed to imply all its constituent information and the like, which has already been discussed. But, aside from this, it can be seen that timelines and disagreeing superpositions are essentially one in the same – where their composing contents are fundamentally discrete and separated from one another.

This, also, is where both differ from agreeing superpositions, who also imply the potential for attributes to occupy "contradictory" states at once, (but only in the exterior sense of contradictory, in effect not truly triggering an (interior) Aethic contradiction, which itself is still forbidden).

This all being said, for disagreeing superpositions where no more or less information is to be

attained during its running, (i.e. a fixed Aethus), it follows that knowing the state of the system at any one time implies a knowledge of it at any other time, (with such a known time being standardized to the beginning of the experiment).[163] However, of course, this is a far too specific situation to actually deal properly with the more chaotic functionality of the world.

Instead, in the real world, there are two main differences from these disagreeing superpositions, which make the deterministic model generally unfavorable regarding accuracy and ontological truthfulness. That is, agreeing superpositions are also very much a possibility, and information is almost never static. As was seen with the derivation of the Lindy effect in an Aethic light, it is actually more than reasonable to dynamically alter the Aethic information of a system, which manifests itself empirically as Bayesian updates, etcetera.[164]

For these reasons, the more accurate ontological model of a double pendulum is more to depict a device for which there is always a hair of error in the ontological measurement of its state at any given moment. That is, it is in a slight superposition of existing in multiple states at once near to the pinpoint precision of an exact angular orientation at present. And, as we know from the functionality of chaos, such a thing will unfold to a vast amplification with the passage of time.[165] So, in a sense, your Aethus begins with all possibilities of where the double pendulum might go, and then progressively crops out more and more of these possibilities as you continue to update your Aethae with the passage of time when watching the pendulum. This, instead, should be the Aethic general substitute for the concept of initial conditions.

9.6.1 An Example With Gravity Assists and Streetlights

A fascinating fact about the conservation of energy is how a gravity assist of a space probe around a planet like Mars or Jupiter, in attaining the speedup to the probe, also slightly slows down the orbital period of the planet itself. This effect is of course only minute, but technically existent—like perhaps say a slowdown of a few seconds per billion years[166].

Now, the interesting connection I want to make from this to Aethic reasoning pertains the common temptation that comes next after this claim: *we ourselves, in launching said space probe to attain the gravity assist about Mars, have now determinately produced a new outcome in the future, as if "allowing the determinate causal chain to unfold anew".* That is, as in the classic timeline-split question of "what would happen on a given day two years from now had you gotten stopped at a streetlight or not".

As you might expect, the Aethic consideration is quite distinct from this buttery effect-like conception. While the quantitative fact, of course, is retained as it must be—and a remarkable quantitative fact it is, literally as a shift to current local properties of a system as effective initial conditions for the future—the Aethic difference is in highlighting the subsequent temptation as a consequence of the classical paradigm of happenstance. Plainly speaking, the Aethic reversal principle states that there is no perfectly-determinate state to the given planet like Mars or Jupiter to begin with—and instead what replaces it is the ontological conviction that much of the planet's information is unknown, and thereby rendered a disagreeing superposition by the remaining Aethic reasoning. In that sense, simply speaking, distinct future events do not uniquely and linearly follow from single tweaks to the past in the first place, because the very Aethic-dynamical influence of what is known about a system traces to vicinity to one's own current Aethic knowledge as opposed to vicinity to exhaustive past-directed causes. That is, in the sense that the ability of single changes to the past to uniquely determine exhaustive changes to the future presupposes the causal chain tie between them, which Aethic reasoning rejects on account of future probabilities being determined by Aethic information as opposed to particular past events—that way the actual switching out of a given past event for another, formally, might skew the Aethic probabilities of given future-encoding stated-attributes but does not in any meaningful sense determine every last thing.[167] For instance, perhaps if you miss the green

[163]This holds given dynamics that are complete and unique and, when reasoning backward, reversible; the disagreeing superposition alone does not supply those conditions.

[164]Updating by itself is no argument against deterministic dynamics, which accommodate it as learning about an unread history; what the framework adds is that the openness updated away was constructive, a commitment of the extrusion principle rather than something the updating shows.

[165]Which kind of superposition the region is, disagreeing or agreeing, is fixed by the record structure and the weighting and not by the chaos, whose amplification spreads whichever region there is.

[166]Note that this subsubsection was first posted to the paper online as part of its PDF file created on *6/5/26, 1:32:53 AM.*

[167]The target here is not deterministic evolution as such: a deterministic law can leave one variable untouched by a change to another, as when $X_{t+1} = f(X_t)$ and $Y_{t+1} = g(Y_t)$ evolve separately, so that the cat below, left unaffected, illustrates selective dependence and refutes nothing about determinism. What Aethic reasoning rejects is reading a complete determinate history in as the ontology of what an Aethus leaves blank.

light one day, then on a given day three months later, the classical framing immediately seeks to jump the gun and say "well, you would have eaten a ham-and-cheese sandwich that morning rather than an omelet". The truth of the matter, however, is that even if the changed attribute in the past—like the light—turns out to genuinely disallow *highly particular* future attributes, (for which a better example than the light might be that not graduating high shool might lower the probability of getting into graduate school later on), in general it is not going to affect arbitrary attributes on the flanks like what you eat for breakfast on a particular day. To illustrate this more clearly, the idea here is that there generally exist contingent Aethae out of all possible Aethae one could have occupied where a given past event is made to enforce a given future event, but even in these Aethae said past event cannot influence any arbitrary concurrent future Aethic attribute. The fallacy of the classical causal chain, then, is in looking at these highly-specific contingencies in the sense of "look, I can establish a connection between any given past attribute and any given future attribute", and then extending this to the concurrent future attributes once one is already selected. What is wrong about this is that you are switching Aethic realities anyway each time you pick a new specific established connection, and the flank attributes themselves in each selected reality need not match, even if they may be made to match by selecting a different contingent reality to analyze. For example, perhaps you set up a basic computer script which looks back to whether you got stopped at a red light during your daily commute on a given random past day, and then decides to auto-purchase your breakfast for that day as a function of what occurred on the past day. Relative to this contingent Aethus where you write this script, then, yes, what you eat for breakfast is heavily dependent on what happened on that particular day (yet again though, only relative to this contingent Aethus but not to the others in superposition to each version of your past self where you might not have chosen to write the script at all)—but something random and unrelated like what your cat is playing with on the landing above your head was in fact not fully determined by the light on the past day—in the simple sense that it remains a valid Aethus with roughly equal probability of being attained within the past day's Aethic superposition should you perform the attribute perturbation to swap out the light from red to green.[168] That is, the cat on this day and at this moment could still be doing what it is doing, in the same room and in the same way, and this particular stated-attribute would remain consistent regardless of whatever shift was to occur to the other stated-attributes of yours in the moment[169].

From this Aethic-outward framing of influence as opposed to past-to-future framing do we attain the ability to reveal the mysterious character of effects like Wheeler's delayed-choice [10] experiment as mysterious to the classical paradigm rather than mysterious inherently.

9.6.2 The Propagation of Aethic Causality to the Remaining Aethic Reframes

Let us now briefly move back to the streetlight example for the sake of illustrating the direct non-absoluteness in its relationship to other attributes. You get stopped at the light, and perhaps two minutes later there is a sinkhole or something which opens up right ahead of you, and would have swallowed up your car had you not gotten the red light. The common reaction at this point is, "oh my goodness, had the light not been red then I would have gotten swallowed up", and yes, this is absolutely true relative to your current Aethus where you are aware of the sinkhole's existence, but relative to your Aethus when you were at the light, the sinkhole's existence was still unknown and in superposition, so there exist proper child Aethae to that for which you safely drive over the very location of the sinkhole without it ever existing—regardless of whether you get a green or a red light. So the point of the matter is that while in the subsequent Aethus the light stopped you from hitting the sinkhole, the same is not universally true for the prior Aethus, and so in the most categorical sense the light itself does not have the power to skew an entire arbitrary future's attributes—because this power itself is only contingent upon the subset of Aethae for which it has these correspondences, like the sinkhole Aethus but not the at-the-light Aethus. Hence, we might consider the classical causal chain assumption itself as a violation of the extrusion principle because it assumes absolute transferability of

[168]That the cat's activity remains a valid Aethus under either light is what the argument needs; that its probability is also roughly unchanged is a further claim, holding where the cat's attributes are uncoupled from the light in the weighting, which validity alone does not settle.

[169]This also has implications for the philosophy of probability, since Bayesian probability itself, as a concept, is consistent with this Aethic framing of causation as opposed to the classical metaphysical version. So if you will, here we have another example of the switch from a classical to Aethic understanding of causality serving to clarify the ontological context in which probability lives to begin with: in this case being that the replaceability of continent attributes from an Aethus is ontological rather than merely methodological to probability as if agnostic to causal realism.

categorical connections from subsequent Aethae to prior Aethae.[170]

The other major aspect of the Aethic argument I want to point out here is the standard extrusion principle-and-disagreeing superpositions-duo providing us with the bridge to even cohesively refuting the classical explanation in the first place. Specifically, because the spawning of a sinkhole is the result of years of erosion happening underground, we of course get that the stage for its existence during your trip must have been set long before you were sitting at the light just moments before. Therefore, classical causality assumes that because of the prior existence of the sinkhole to the streetlight event, it cannot possibly be the case that any of your futures beyond that moment involved the nonexistence of said sinkhole once you drive over it. The way Aethic reasoning then attacks this assumption is precisely the same mechanism as in the Jenny's Japanese or Battle of Brémule thought experiments (Section 5.4): by the Aethic extrusion principle, when you were sitting at the streetlight both the existence of the sinkhole and its entire underground history occupied a state of disagreeing superposition in your block universe of then. After all, you were not aware of its existence, thereby allowing the second postulate to place it in Aethic superposition. Only once you later came close enough to it to become aware of its existence was the centric unfolding dice rolled and you joined a block universe where it did indeed exist all along—but you were just lucky enough to be three seconds behind it.[171] The point of the matter is that the implications of this Aethic fundamental reframe of temporal ordering are far-reaching: here alone it directly enables the rejection of arbitrarily enforcing inescapable priority of past events in determining future ones, which gives us the ability to cohesively dismantle the causal chain, which in turn allows us to consist with the ontology of probability by allowing perturbations of some attributes which do not propagate to the remainder of the Aethus, and in doing so gives us precisely the formal scaffolding to explain delayed-choice [10] and Wigner's friend [30]. (The counterfactual semantics this analysis compresses is unpacked in full in Section 9.1.)

[170] *October 5, 2026, 4:14 PM*

Also hopefully it's clear enough in the papers, as a major part of that seed idea, how you can always find an Aethus for which any two things are causally tied, (ie where the "tie" thing IS the relation structure / joint invalidity structure on which the aethic tree paper is based: as in the fundamental Aethic root idea for causality is that causality IS just encoded in the joint invalidity structure, such that hard invalidity tags--which note thereby differ from soft "small to be near zero" weights--is literally HOW Aethic reasoning carries out the jump from a naive correlation theory to a real correlation AND causal theory, specifically in the sense of how correlation is not causality per the shark attacks and ice cream sales analogy sort of material), but each such tie found does not need to transfer arbitrarily to any other Aethus--thereby disallowing the "causal chain per a determinate-rendering moving present" its very recursive principle which generates it as a kind of closure. Thanks!

[171] That the sinkhole's history was constructively open at the light, and not merely unread, is the extrusion principle's commitment, not something the later learning shows: a deterministic model with an unread history describes the same learning.

9.7 Aethic Causality Notions

Consider something of a pitch for Aethic reasoning, which highlights a potential parallel between it and the the Newtonian[172] revolution[173].

[172]Something interesting I realized in March of 2026 is that I seem to have for a while now had a competent understanding of very subtle forms of argumentation in the philosophy of science, despite knowing next to none of the proper terminology which is usually necessary for such a competence in practice. A concrete example is that on March 7, 2026, I first came across the term "underdetermination", which I then looked up online promptly thereafter. Upon seeing the definition, I was surprised and rather intrigued, because I had a thought sometime in 2023 or 2024 which is strikingly close to this concept: that is, I imagined how if I were ever asked why Newton could not come up with the theory of relativity, I would explain how it is not merely the depth of a theory that indicates the strength of the theoretician—equally important is the totality of empiricism available to the time, because empiricism provides precisely the intangible foundation upon which the art form of inductive reasoning is based. This also ties directly into the concept of Aethic reasoning itself, for which I can firmly declare that had I not had empirical access to the double-slit experiment, then I certainly never will have arrived at Aethic reasoning. This is why Newton himself, who is clearly my superior as a theoretician, was himself unable to arrive at the delicate balance of theoretical commitments that gives rise to Aethic reasoning. Something about having access to empiricism is utterly necessary, even though it is hardly sufficient until it can be interpreted properly.

So, altogether I seem to have arrived at these subtle methodological conclusions by studying the history of science and attempting to intuitively extrapolate from its best moments. Newton especially had been the one I studied from the youngest age, and to the deepest level. If you had asked me in 2022 what my primary inspiration was for my moves in Aethic reasoning, I would have responded (consciously or subconsciously) that I was "channeling Newton". That, anyway, was the synesthetic extrapolation I was drawing from primarily (in terms of the style of inductive reasoning I was aiming for), although of course there is a difference between admiring a hero figure and actually producing insights at a high quality—that is a judgment for my readers to decide.

Concerning the hypothetical of whether Newton could have cracked Aethic reasoning, there is little doubt in my mind that it would have evaded him for very long if he were here in our time—that and whatever other large chunk of the unsolved problems in physics he would start making short work of due to his historically-uncanny theoretical sensibilities. So to make a diagnosis of our own situation from this perspective, it appears to me, as elaborated in my epistemic antirealism argument, that the seeming mysticism of quantum mechanics is not actually a diagnosis of the ontology itself, but rather a highly predictable diagnosis of the human psychology that arises when the empirical and experimental depth has vastly outpaced the theoretical processing. So the reason I think Newton would go through this so quickly is that the Jaynesian scrambled omelette [52, 53] of physics is ripe for the taking, and all that stops the major problems from being solved is a theoretician's own being overwhelmed by the immensity of the wall of empirical structure—due that is to their apparently lacking Newton's savant-like empirical data processing abilities. But since Newton had this ability, what for others would be a deficit would for him be an accelerant. The particular nature of our modern predicament, then, feels to be indicative of there being more empiricism than we know what to do with, as opposed to underdetermination. My prediction, anyway, is that this is how future generations might view us retrospectively—a question which I am curious to eventually find out the answer to one way or the other.

[173]*August 16, 2026*: My read on scientific history is that the capacity for deep theoretical progress at any one time is a function of how far the empiricism has outpaced the theory by that moment. If the gap is wide, then you have what is called "unique determination" of the next theory, whereas if it's nonexistent you have "underdetermination" of the next theory. The problem is, however, that exactly the cases most rich for unique determination also have the fiercest precondition of ontological scrambling, thereby enforcing that they require theorists who are comfortable dealing over the vast possibility spaces required to handle such. On this reading, Einstein himself is among our species astoundingly qualified for exactly this role, as demonstrated by his ability to perform his ontological upheavals during the particular empirical outpacing of the early 20th century. The point I want to emphasize, now, is that while that empirical gap for someone capable of handling the demand is an asset, for someone without that capability it reads as the most ironic thing possible: underdetermination, due to the scrambling appearing so overwhelmingly complex. Once you have a person like Einstein who has the capability, it does not particularly matter where you place him on the historical timeline: he will, to statistical expectancy, carry out the production of the theory, because he very simply senses the empirical gap, and then handles it. The underdetermination false reading becomes a non-factor. Hence, my response to the modern day majority position that "Einstein, if he were around in the 21st century, could not reproduce theory-building on the level of relativity, because now there is 'too much' empirical content" or something.

Now, allow me to quote my dad on something interesting he said a few weeks after I first explained to him all of the astounding theoretical work Newton did against the backdrop of a society that didn't even know such moves were possible: "If Newton were here, he would have solved dark matter by now." My response is yes, I think that's exactly right, and the reason is the upset itself—look at how stupidly wide the modern day gap is by which the empiricism has outpaced the theory. A fallback I often see people reach for when asking if Einstein would do much work in the modern day is to say "well look, he got stuck on quantum gravity and a grand unified theory in the former half of the 20th century anyway, so he already tried and failed anyway". To that I respond, *seriously dude?* The whole thesis of the empirical outpacing concept is that the gap *IS* the asset for Einstein, even if it is an obstruction to anyone else. What that means is that the empiricism we have just kicking around today would have been a major, major power-up for someone like Einstein or Newton, so it is entirely unfair that we're counting Einstein as "failing to build the 21st century's theory" when he's a guy who literally wasn't even aware of galaxy rotation curves, the electroweak force, or quarks. To that I say, of course he couldn't carry out the exact architectural gymnastics over the ontological root of all

The great revolutions in science come from replacing causal arguments with relational arguments of an original motivation.
For example, the major part of what makes Newton's laws so remarkable is that they operate completely independently from causality, in effect replacing would-be causal arguments with something as contextually shocking as a second-order differential equation. This represented the very first time when humanity divorced a major component of its explanative natural philosophy from Aristotelian[a] causality. Notice how we're still reaping the benefits.
We might argue that the best news for Aethic reasoning is that it applies this same process of what Newton's laws did to his day, but instead to the modern world, in that the causal backbone of the Copenhagen interpretation is replaced with the three Aethic postulates.

[a]This is also why I would argue that the Newtonian revolution is every bit as impressive as the Einsteinian revolution, as we have to remember that Newton did the same thing to Aristotle which Einstein did to Newton.

9.7.1 A Note on the Frontier of our Understanding

Throughout the history of physics, when an inconsistency shows up in the equations, it foreshadows that a seeming ontic-absurdity is about to show up on our very doorstep.[174] That is, there is to be an "in your face" ontological shift[175] just because of the inconsistency in the dynamics happening all

these things if he didn't have access to the things! When he had the empirical outpacing gap in 1905, he made short work of closing it, because *that's what he does.* So, fittingly, if he had access to our own gap—a gap which largely didn't even exist yet in his lifetime (because, the gap is in the having of all the vantages, so even though we had Hubble's law at the time but not dark matter and the remaining of galactic mysteries, I would count the gap as not yet existent, just as for something like quantum ontology if you gerrymander-removed a lot of the empirical context you would reach a threshold where the unique determination fails)—he would be closing the gap in real time as well, since after all the empiricism has measurably outpaced the theory, and the propositional reasoning-based, non-ontological tactics which people currently bring to the table are failing exactly with the same shape that the ether theory failed until Einstein entered the chat in 1905.

[174]*October 5, 2026, 9:28 AM*

I just thought of an interesting idea, which I can explain as follows:
First of all, per my "Newton would have solved dark matter by now" footnote in the long Aethic paper, the primary message from that I want to relay to the phil_sci.tex paper is how despite people often talking about "natural philosophy had its heyday centuries ago, but right now is a dead zone for it since everything has already been done", I would argue that the opposite is actually true--assuming you already *are* an Einstein-class thinker in terms of landing in the linear sequential achievement regime, then if anything what I would say is that "right now, if anything, is the easiest time in human history to do revolutionary natural philosophy", just because the empiricism has outpaced the theory this time so much and for so long. So yeah, the wild thing is that from the vantage of a linear-regime sequential achievement if anything right now has *more* capacity for shifting the fundamental human world view than times like the Copernican revolution, yet the bias from people sitting in the exponential regime is that we've "finished" everything. However, if you the exponential regime person transported back to a time in history, pick the time, and whatever revolution happened then would appear equally opaque to right now--which means that the literal modern day is, to the objective future, equally archaic and pre-scientific in the places the next revolution will touch as geocentrism or pre-Newton physics is from our perspective. So no, we're not at the end, it's more like we're barely at the beginning--*nothing has been done yet* is closer to the truth.
So by the way then the actual model I thought of just now is the following:

1) "Objectively" speaking, we might imagine constructing the deviation interval I'm talking about between theory and the outpacing empiricism as a literal low pressure area of some kind, such that in the objective sense given this imbalance of empiricism the system desperately wants to collapse into the paradigm shift.

2) Humans, however, have to drive the paradigm shift, and therefore we can attempt to model the "apparent" makeup of the system from a given human's perspective as applying an effective blur to the system, with the sequential achievement expected time being like a marker of how long it will take the system to land its phase transition based on the rate this person here contributes.

3) The idea then is that being in the linear regime applies a negligible blur, such that the exact "perfect" n/lambda limit makes the system transform in "real time", no blur applied.

4) However being in the farthest exponential regime makes the blur be absolute, so everything is uniform and no phase transition is possible. Interpolating between the two extremes then gives you more slight blurs, for example for better-score but still exponential regime cases the blur is such that there might be an absolutely tiny flux of change based on said person's contribution, but its local rate is slow directly in relation to how slow the expected time is as you actually locally progress towards is.

5) Then the final idea is that we have almost a kind of "superposition" of the contributions of each actual individual person toward the net act on the "objective" system from all humans, such that in my mind the idea is maybe to map each person's blurred-contribution onto the total and then overlay them as a kind of superposition, be it linear or nonlinear or whatever it would have to be, so as to reproduce the general sum of rates concept for sequential achievement and all.

So yeah that's my idea for this model here!

[175]I think perhaps the defining subconscious orientation I took to developing Nexic reasoning and the extrusion principle, outward metaphysical radicalness and all, was something of an "ontological licensing" I took from the theory of relativity. That is, while I admittedly was not yet aware of the root in the relativity of simultaneity, I had more than enough context in the concept of time dilation alone to infer this licensing: that is, that *the discovery of special relativity*

correctly depicting the universe represented a point-of-no-return after which the prior assumption of the fundamental applicability of common sense to metaphysics was itself undermined. But the real depth of this philosophical principle is bigger even than this: it is that the postulation of common sense fitting the metaphysics of our universe holds with such conviction that nowhere at all may a deviation between metaphysics and common sense occur, that upon finding even one such significant and moreover previously unexpected deviation undermines the entirety of this postulation. What this means is essentially two things: (a) no longer may common sense bound the possibilities for what is metaphysically actual, but more significantly (b) almost as if monotonic, the new aphorism becomes "no matter how trippy metaphysics has become up to our understanding, it can and will only get trippier" (with "trippy" being my proposed antonym for common sense-abiding) because the discovery that there exists logically coherent forms of metaphysics outside common sense thereby almost surely renders common sense as a measure zero subspace in the space of all possible coherent metaphysics, and so the more we learn of the actual universe as an alternative subspace within this space, the more we enumerate planes along which there is a substantial deviation, (that is, in the sense that if we write the maximum number of orthogonal planes in the space, then due to the measure zero property of the common sense subspace on account of being a constraint therein, we may now expect that if "our knowledge" is expressible as a subset of this given set of planes, then for every plane we have the angle between where it intersects common sense versus actual metaphysics is almost surely nonzero, and so the total deviation raises in proportion to the number of planes we have enumerated). Even without this more geometric "formalization" of this intuition, however, my original thought was that once we have demonstrated how wrong we were with common sense being assumed to fit the universe even once, and now all we can do is expect that wherever the true universe lies, it with each new thing we learn about it is expected to fall further outside of common sense as effective compounding. Even methodologically speaking, should we have found no deviation to begin with, then the most reasonable conclusion to assume is that the match is exact. But once we find even a single deviation, the entire thesis of a match becomes not only a poor approximation but a logical contradiction (that is, since the thesis assumes there will be no deviations at all). Very suddenly, then, this opens up the inference that we will spend the rest of time unpacking more and more vast digressions of actual metaphysics into "trippiness" until we hypothetically have sufficient information to capture all the degrees of freedom about the actual subspace in the space of all possible coherent metaphysics. Even existentially speaking, the profound thing is that from our perspective the rabbit hole is already knowably unending, which means we have to expect that there are actual phenomena at play already which are metaphysically jarring to a cosmic degree (hence my proposed licensing to entertain just such conceptual objects, like the exotic principle from Nexic reasoning).

Note that I might also specifically argue that a gradual alternative to this idea may also be formulated. As in, perhaps we redefine "metaphysical deviation from common sense" as specifically occupying a threshold, such that like a piecewise function, should the actual deviation be below a given threshold, then we register it as zero deviation. Therefore, we may argue that for each scientific revolution, my idea specifically holds for whichever definition of deviation has the most impact while still being warranted as present within the current scientific revolution. For instance, perhaps the most remarkable two deviations from common sense in the Newtonian revolution were that an object in motion tends to stay in motion, and that gravity acts at a distance. In that the relativity of simultaneity is arguably more extreme of a deviation even than this, we might therefore argue that the minimum threshold of deviation which would be satisfied as existing for the special relativity revolution would not have been called as existing for the Newtonian revolution, hence meaning that the expected "trippiness" we ought to expect for each new discovery about actual metaphysics should on average scale in proportion to what the currently "trippiest" known discovery is. This in and of itself gives us something of a Lindy effect [137]-like compounding to the further discoveries, in that we not only have the aforementioned compounding over enumeration of separate trippy discoveries, but also now that we ought to expect the median new discovery to rival the trippiness of the maximally-deviated known discovery. (And note that I would argue median rather than average due to some future discoveries very likely being vastly higher than the rest, hence by use of the median we inflate [138] the expected net trippiness of the remaining set even further—that just perhaps also means that we would have to adapt the "*on average* the median new discovery scales with the trippiest known discovery" to a median-compatible alternative rather than said average).

This also aligns with my general thesis that that which separates us from the hypothetical "final theory" is contained almost entirely in our current failed assumptions and only with measure zero in our necessary additive discoveries. So, the remaining trek from here is almost entirely subtractive upon our own biases, and comparatively hardly at all in what we add after the fact. To give the example with Einstein once more, notice how only he alone was able of carrying out the subtractive bottleneck of establishing the equivalence principle, and notice how many people if provided with that idea of his could have completed general relativity, (per the remarkable aspect often stated by differential geometers how the field equations are profoundly constrained to uniqueness once you have laid out Einstein's constraints). So, in terms of sheer difficulty as weighted by the proportion of all people who would have achieved it, notice how the subtractive substance is itself the bottleneck—hence having to do with my thought that it specifically is what separates us from comprehending the universe more fully, (so if you will, it is as if we took a multiple choice exam on the universe and got a 10% grade (most of which is probably in the concept of the Lagrangian and also general relativity lol), with the gap between us and the final theory being to correct our wrong answers more so than to invent new right answers—this specifically is my response to the general philosophical debate about "whether there is a final theory"—my thesis is that it is something of a category error to attribute such a destination to additive discovery anyway as if finding a new

the way "out there".[176] We have one clean example of this for each major revolution in physics, for instance. In the Newtonian case, the unexplained nature of the motion of the planets meant that a force of gravity was to exist in one's own backyard, coupled with the mystical-seeming principle of inertia. In the Einsteinian case, furthermore, the subtle inconsistency between Maxwell's equations and Newtonian mechanics meant that a full-fledged relativistic spacetime was going to wedge its way into our basic structure of the universe, yielding results as personal as the mass-energy equivalence itself by virtue of one's own four-momentum in the proper time direction. In any of these cases, what always ends up happening is that the seemingly-distant aspects of the unexplainable phenomenon start to show up in one's own backyard. It does not have to be identical to the extreme conditions where the experiments in question were performed, but the clean cut between your world and the world these phenomena imply is forfeited the moment the first experiment turns up the unexpected way. That is, whether it be correction terms of new ontological affects, or something else, you are going to start to see features of that exotic world creeping into your everyday surroundings, such that your world starts to feel a little bit more like it in nuanced ways, and it starts to feel a little bit more like your world in other nuanced ways.

In the case of Aethic reasoning, the proposed ontic feature which has crept into our everyday world in none other than Aethic superpositions themselves, for which quantum superpositions are but a special case. That is, the analogous "correction terms" themselves are simply the disagreeing superpositions present in one's vicinity, as are implied to have to exist through the second postulate of the Aethus.

9.7.2 Non-Classical "Causality" in Aethic Reasoning

(Epistemic register: this subsection is an exploratory exercise in the expressive range of the extrusion paradigm; nothing elsewhere in the paper depends upon it.)

One of the more abrupt ontological reconciliations of Aethic reasoning, it turns out, is that it actually offers an avenue for encoding a "metaphysics of superstition" in a well-defined manner. This is not to say that Aethic reasoning preferences the existence of superstitious causality one way or the other, (and if anything perhaps leans toward the contrary due to its being so entangled with pre-paradigmatic human constructs), however it nonetheless is particularly the case that, upon switching from the timeline to extrusion principle paradigm, the metaphysical barrier toward a well-defined existence of superstitious causality dissolves. That is, in any classical paradigm we have that the mere ability for superstitious behavior—such as what one wears directly prior to a sports game—to actually affect the macroscale outcome is of course an absurdity, because that would have to imply solipsistic powers on the individual, (being something which no two people can have at once[177], even if that power was real).

In the Aethic paradigm, however, this restriction very suddenly dissolves. Again, this is not to say that a passive observer can affect the events of a sports game based only on what they wear, but in principle it is hypothetically possible.

The fair, as the analogy. To explain, we might compare this with the prospect of many people visiting an annual fair in their home town. Looking over this event, we may note intuitively that *each person can have their own reason for being there.* That is, there was not some overpowering wind that guided them all here like leaves: rather they accumulated here—on account of their location—and did so individually. Each person very well could have gone someplace else, like one town over, or the town after that.

The extrusion principle's version. This, then, is the same analogy we can build with the extrusion

continent or planet).

[176] In the case of special relativity, as soon as you get the relativity of simultaneity, it cracks this sucker wide open, and the equations practically arrange themselves into a cohesive ontology. My argument is that this is what the extrusion principle does for quantum mechanics, as per this unlocking of a cohesive alternative to the determinate causal chain which also miraculously links up like a lost twin to the quantum experimental outcomes, and with the inclusion of agreeing superpositions reproduces the structure of nonclassicality and collapse itself.

However, this also illustrates the fundamental Catch-22 crisis of being an independent researcher in this world: I can't say anything that pattern-matches to what a fraud would say, which means I cannot even mention this fundamental success of the idea. If I advertise the idea nobody will read it, and if I don't advertise it nobody will read it.

[177] That is because if they both had the power, then they would immediately contradict as simply as using the power to get different outcomes. The timeline paradigm simply cannot accommodate this without breaking down, so the only "solutions" are that free will is decidedly nonexistent (because each unwittingly had to agree with the other) or more simply that nobody has the power in the first place unless straight solipsism is to be entertained. In other words, a complete and total mess, rendering superstition as somewhere even worse than absurd. The Aethic argument, then, is that simply by assuming the extrusion principle, we accidentally dissolve this roadblock in its entirety. A notable development, at least.

principle, and this is where the Aethic ability for modeling non-classical modes of causality really shines through: simply put, we might imagine a thought experiment in which, for whatever unexplained reason, each person needs a "ticket", metaphysically speaking, in order to enter an Aethic block universe in which say France wins the next men's World Cup. To gain this ticket, they must complete whatever their superstitious activity is before the end of the game, and then if they do, then they will at least almost surely follow the Aethic update to that particular block universe[178]. In such a thought experiment, we then have that all the people who get a ticket, and who find out that France has won, did so directly *because* of their superstitious activity, but critically were able to do so without physically affecting the game. This is all thanks to the extrusion principle, for which they needed, like the people at the fair, only to move their own selves to the right location.

The mechanism, in a sentence. If you attend the fair, then around you will be a fair. And if you went elsewhere where there was no fair, then around you would be no fair. It is not that you sparked the fair into existence or not, but merely that you did or did not show up to the preexisting fair's location. This, then, is the direct mechanism by which superstitious causality could in principle exist in an Aethic framework, even if it still probably doesn't.

9.7.3 Dual Causality in Aethic Reasoning

Let us illustrate a fundamental result about causality which becomes available under the implications of Aethic reasoning, especially from within its Nexic reasoning offshoot. Simply put, the Aethic fundamental supposition is that the explanatory cause of a given happening is independently but exhaustively reducible to at least two different yet entirely separate "modes" through which reality may be expressed. Perhaps the canonical illustration of this comes from the concept of Optimation in Nexic reasoning, particularly in the context of imagining a thinking agent whose actions are nonetheless constrained by Optimation.

Concept 5 (Ancestral Agent Thought Experiment)
Consider a thought experiment in which we consider the actions of a given ancestor to oneself who exists sufficiently far back in timelike history such that the Nexus of Optimation is contributing non-negligibly to the evolution of the biosphere, (that is, in the sense of the Optimal-Earth Conjecture holding pertaining to a general Aethic attribute of the era). For the sake of model-simplicity[179]*, we will treat this ancestor as having a human's level of agency, even if they happen to be pre-human like a primitive mammal, (for which the agency question becomes somewhat ambiguous by itself).*

The fundamental observation which we may now make about this ancestral agent is to consider the event of their ever making a decision which is directly deducible as having to have happened from Optimation. For instance, we might consider a concept like the wretched evolution-illustrating flight thought experiment from the Nexic paper, where the ancestral agent is forced by the circumstances of their environment (event E_1) to end up in a now location (event E_2) than where they will have arrived at under different circumstances, only then to have to make a conscious tactical decision (event E_3) which accidentally enables a key unintended gain (event E_4). One may fill this logical skeleton with an arbitrary narrative journey, but as an illustration of the existence of two modes of causality it is somewhat decisive: that is, the key realization to make here is how this entire story can be explained exactly—and without losing information—under two parallel but distinct formal narratives of causality, which we might call its ***causal modes****. The first is what we might call the "classical causal mode", or otherwise the "physical causal mode", which is the standard framework of causality for a pre-Optimation paradigm. This standard narrative runs exactly as one might expect: $E_1 \to E_2 \to E_3 \to E_4$, being that each event is informed by the one chronologically predating it, perhaps even more so due to the privileged influence of each on the next as opposed to the ordering in time explicitly. For instance,*

[178] With the complementary case being that if they do not get a ticket, then they instead move to an Aethic block universe where somebody besides France wins.

[179] Don't be so quick about trying to take this as the failing assumption for a proof by contradiction, if you're thinking it! Morally that would violate animal rights, so I want to be explicit that I consider the argument that this thought experiment proves animals are not conscious as within the same tier of methodologically undisciplined as something like quantum immortality [139–141] itself. Think first about solidifying the foundations of when Optimation "powers off" in time before trying to make leaps within that assumption. It is perhaps a central methodological open question of Nexic reasoning as it stands exactly in history when "Optimation ceases to apply", and especially whether this is a well-founded question in the first place, and answering that straight from the Accordance Principle alone violates *hypotheses non fingo* [71], hence why I have not provided a proposal for it yet. But for reference, we might call this question at the frontier of Nexic reasoning "the finale paradox", and so long as it remains open this slithering move of trying to downplay animal rights is methodologically dishonest.

clearly we have that the tactical decision E_3 could not have occurred without the forcing to a new location E_2, which itself was caused by some particular circumstance E_1.

Alternatively, however, we might also consider the causal mode pertaining to Optimation instead, which notably might perhaps have taken the consequence E_4 itself as a fundamental necessity to human existence, and so thereby "forced" it through from within its own causal mode directly. According to the causal mode of Optimation, we instead get more of a graph shape of the causal influence[180]*, where E_4 is the root because it is that which was necessitated, and then we might suppose that there are two branches forming $E_4 \to E_3$ and $E_4 \to E_2 \to E_1$, that is because necessitating E_4 requires E_2 and necessitating E_2 requires E_1. Under this framing, the tactical decision E_3 is decisively inputted directly by Optimation to enable E_4 and therefore enable oneself to exist in the fist place so as to hear the tale—which is a claim note which is backed up by the full empiricism of Nexic reasoning as asserting such must be retrospectively true of any of one's natural historical ancestors who were influenced like this by Optimation.*

This illustration, then, may lead directly into the dual causality principle itself.

Principle 31 (Dual Causality Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
In an Aethic ontology, we must effectively conclude that it is entirely possible for a single sequence of events in the world to genuinely be independently reducible to having been causes by two entirely separate general modes of causality. The key philosophical consideration to make is that is that the existence of one causal mode does not undermine the existence of another outright, so long as each causal mode under consideration successfully accounts for all information present across the given sequence of events. This is, classically at least*, a peculiar and perhaps even paradoxical result, because it essentially rejects the idea that a self-consistent, as well as causally and explanatively exhaustive description of reality needs to satisfy a property of uniqueness in terms of serving as the explanation for a collection of real-world events, (despite all the informational exhaustiveness in the world).*

In particular, we also state the existence of there existing both the standard and classical "physical causal mode" as well as a more abstract "Aethus-side causal mode" of which Optimation itself serves as an in stance. The ontological packaging which comes with this premise is that the existence of neither causal mode discounts that of the other, which is the pararadial thing from a classical perspective.

Principle 32 (Independent Causal Mode Argument of Free Will)

1. *We first establish a "familiar" proposed ontology of free will and the philosophical stance assigned to it by a human reasoner, whether it contradicts the existence of multiple causal modes or not. We will refer to this complete framework itself as X. Within this framework, we might use the stated-attribute x to denote whether free-will exists, as well as the surrounding contextual argumentation to this stance, (so that it need not be a Boolean state alone). This is meant to be one's own stance on free will.*

2. *In general, causal mode B_1 is defined as "independent" of the alternative causal mode B_2 if there are no happenings inside of B_1 which irreducibly require at least one cause which exists in B_2, and outside of B_1. For a crude example, if one defined a causal mode of everything which occurs within a given house, and the wind outside the house blows the windows open, then we cannot declare the aforementioned interior causal mode is independent of a causal mode encompassing the outside wind.*

   Concretely, the physical causal mode and Optimation may be taken as independent, because events and choices within the physical causal mode are indeed explainable from other events and choices which operate or have operated within the physical causal mode itself. This applies to the example of the ancestral agent carrying out events the E_1, E_2, E_3, E_4 in such a way that they are entirely describable both in terms of classical physical causation (as in, their having to change location and their having to make the decision they did is genuinely causally influenced by the physical circumstances which enabled such, in quite the same sense as oneself would assert that a hard decision made under challenging circumstances was validly the outcome of those circumstances, even just trivially speaking) or otherwise Optimation, that is without necessary reference to one another internally.

3. *We might notice how a consistent internal condition of both the causal determinism [142, 143] and hard incompatibilism [144] arguments against free will is the statement that there existing a*

[180] Roughly, anyway, as there is perhaps a more fundamental argument to be made that Optimation is much more organic than any sort of graph-decomposable description would have it anyway.

cause which is irreducibly external to factors within an agent's mental scope refutes their having free will should that cause contribute sufficiently to alter outcomes in which the agent plays a role. Let us suppose that this is the central "mechanism" of free will-refutation, which is consistent across all arguments attempting to do so, just from different sources feeding into it, (be it the external causal chain for causal determinism [142, 143] or the persistent attribution to outside factors for hard incompatibilism [144], and so on).

We will now suggest that this same mechanism may be used to demonstrate why a general causal mode may or may not be seen not to contain loose ends through which the existence of free will within that causal mode directly may be refuted[181]*. That is, if the root of a free will refutation always comes from having no avenue through which to distill the full content of causes for a mental action as coming from within a required scope, then we may suppose that the definitive "holes" in a causal mode through its reliance on causes from another causal mode is in each case an exploitable avenue of refuting the existence of free will relative to that causal mode by means of attaching one such cause to a mental action to such a hole. This, once again, note operates directly from within this same central mechanism of free will-refutation, just where holes in a causal mode itself, (being an ontic entity), may if you will "by construction" produce just these such irreducible sources of a mental activity which are fully at the whim of something beyond one's own powers of control under agency, (being in this case the alternative causal mode to which the hole bridges).*

4. *We then assert that if we select some causal mode A which is specially tailored to identifying with the aforementioned proposed ontological landscape X, then should we introduce perturbations to the causal structure of some independent causal mode B, and nonetheless that property of independence will open no new avenues from A to B through which free will may be disputed to any higher degree than what is already forced upon by X due to the particular nature of its proposed commitments.*

   Intuitively, that is, we are essentially establishing an isomorphism within which whatever is the exterior-to-mental-mechanism-pertaining overlapping of scopes affirming or conflicting with free will due to the inherent structure of X, no new such irreducibly exterior avenues are introduced or removed in the comparative case of A. So the isomorphism pertains to whatever structure the two already possess regarding the more direct application of the aforementioned free will-refuting mechanism toward influencing them or not.

5. *Therefore, the stated-attribute denoting free will's existence, α, under causal mode A remains equivalent to x and to itself invariantly under perturbations of the causal structure of an arbitrary alternative and independent causal mode B. This extends to the assertion of there existing an entirely new independent causal mode B as opposed to not, as is done in the example of introducing the existence of Optimation externally to the existence of the classical physical causal mode.*

   It is worth mentioning that this derivation merely asserts that $\alpha \equiv x$, but not whether α actually accepts or denies the existence of free will directly. This effectively allows this argument to occupy a higher layer of abstraction than a direct argument about free will, that is because it may be used for or against the existence of free will.

Note that an explicit commitment of this argument—and its placement in the wider ontology of there existing multiple independent causal modes to the universe—is that the existence of free will is a relative statement to the causal mode in question. This means arbitrary causal modes may be constructed in which free will does not exist, (particularly by limiting their scope sufficiently so that they fail being complete), however one may interpret this as reflecting the inadequacy of these models in relevantly capturing reality rather than generally proving the nonexistence of free will.

[181] The counterintuitive result of this is that the "completeness" of a causal mode is being used to (at least potentially) argue for free will rather than universally against it, which is something of a reframe in how such arguments are canonically used in practice. The subtlety of this is that this independent causal mode argument, unlike the determinism argument, is not being used to argue for the existence of free will one way of the other, but instead is merely establishing an isomorphism in the answer of whether free will exists regardless of perturbations in the independent causal modes to the causal mode under consideration. That places this argument at one layer higher of abstraction than the standard determinism argument for free will, because while that determinism argument leverages the completeness of reality to argue against free will, the present argument is using a different kind of completeness to reality as a means of drawing an equivalent conclusion to an already or more easily-established argument of free will, whether that argument turns out to be for or against it.

The most concrete applied example of this concerns the classical physical causal mode and the causal mode for Optimation itself. That is, by asserting that the physical causal mode is complete, we assess that free will exists in the physical causal mode with Optimation existing if and only if it exists in the physical causal mode with Optimation not existing—but the key is that the physical causal mode with Optimation existing must not forbid the existence of free will any more than a purely classical ontology for which Optimation does not exist. So, if you insist free will exists already, then the existence of Optimation does not change that, formally speaking. Whether this is a miracle or a headache[182] *is up to the interpretation of the reader.*

[182]Or perhaps even a nightmare, if one believes it to imply that phenomenology which one intuits is representative of a lack of free will must deductively-forcibly count as free will, but such is subjective to one's own stances on that phenomenology anyway.

9.7.4 Newcomb's Paradox as a Surprising Prelude to Aethic Ontology

I only heard of Newcomb's paradox [145] for the first time[183] on April 16, 2026 believe it or not, and upon hearing about it then I was surprised and excited about just how much it illustrates about the psychological intuition already present in humans about the Accordance Principle.

For brief context, the standard formulation [146] runs as follows. A near-perfect predictor—traditionally a supercomputer with an essentially flawless track record—presents an agent with two boxes. Box A is transparent and contains $1,000. Box B is opaque and contains either $1,000,000 or nothing, depending on the predictor's prior assessment of the agent's choice: if the predictor expected the agent to take only Box B, the million was placed inside; if it expected the agent to take both, Box

[183]Interestingly, I have found that every time I pull up an idea from my brain about the frameworks, it consistently happens with strictly constant time complexity. That is, "recognition of familiarity to something highly specific in the framework" of an arbitrary idea I'm newly exposed to happens with constant time complexity, but "brainstorming ideas from the framework, as if listing them, in lieu of such targeted lookups" is impossibly difficult—so say polynomial time complexity or worse. The actual way in which I first heard of Newcomb's paradox, I think, is illustrative of this at the source. In particular, I learned about it from the Veritasium video on the topic (man that channel is one of the greats!), and essentially what happened is that the moment the video finished explaining the one-boxing and two-boxing cases, my internal lookup fired and my brain pulled up exactly the part of the framework which applies here: the Accordance Principle in the context of the indiscriminate time principle, and with the Aethic superposition nature and first postulate disallowance of transmitting information between agents' Aethae stored as two connotations. This is an example of what is maybe the single most consistent aspect of my entire cognitive journey with these frameworks since I started working on them in high school, being that lookups are constant time complexity and pick out parts of the framework without loss of specificity.

I think what is also interesting about this is how important it is to my real-time-scale processing as well. As I mentioned briefly a moment ago, how I would describe my actual moment-to-moment tackling of new ideas, (and this is an analogy I came up with during high school), is that it's as if I have this huge library in my subconscious in which every single mathematical, philosophical, or otherwise conceptual tidbit I've ever been exposed to is stored as a page in its proper book on its proper shelf. The secret sauce to this is that not one of the pages in any of the books is stored as something notational or linguistic: rather every single idea I come across is stored in this strange, synesthetic-lettered thread language which basically serves as both the content on the pages in the library *and* the keys that I use to look them up. So, concretely, I come across a random new idea, and the moment I see it, my brain on about a one-or-two second lag converts it to the thread language thing, and then effectively instantaneously uses this as a key to look up the relevant page in the library with constant time complexity. What's interesting is that, as you might expect due to the variety of information, the page never exactly matches each arbitrarily new piece of information I'm using as the key—*rather it's that, somehow, the looked up page is precisely the one which is the closest match in the "feeling" of the thread language to the key.* See what I mean? Upon holding both in mind now, I can't help but go "ha this is literally the most ideally similar concept I'm aware of to this new key I'm analyzing". I can recognize that in retrospect, but intriguingly the key lookup makes the same judgment *subconsciously*, and somehow pulls that exact right page from the whole library from the same perspective. Anyway, so this itself is also how I cross domains and pull seemingly-disparate ideas together as equivalent—it's because for whatever reason they "feel" or look similar in this synesthetic thread language, and the constant time complexity lookup takes advantage of this when pulling out the page. And also by the way, rather than the single "closest" page, it's more like the closest page is pulled, with the next two or three closest in the library tagging along as connotations, which themselves can be isolated with a second lookup if I target them as the new key. So effectively this indeed is directly the nature of my moment-to-moment thought process–I look something up with the key for the new idea, then I look up as a second key something that interests me about how these pages connect, and then I look up as a third key something interesting about that, and so on and so forth, just that each lookup itself now gets stored as yet another page in the library. Eventually, the library has plenty of pages, and I can start looking the new ones up as well, (for example I have been in logic classes before where I recognized that a logical statement we used during a lecture in week 10 or something was also used on a day in week 3 or something (although I never remember the exact days of when they were used—only the content of the statement), which impressed my professor due to the memory of it—however the caveat is that the one-to-two second lag it takes me to convert the notation in the physical world to my thread language, on standardized tests, genuinely inflates the time I need to complete it and I end up being one of the last people in the lecture hall to finish—ironically however unless the test is on something highly abstract at a graduate level, in which case suddenly one time complexity overtakes the other again and I often finish near-to-first). But then, once again, this only applies to lookups, in the sense that I am ironically completely cognitively unable to actually go into the library and pull a book out directly—my only access to the library is entirely limited to the key-lookup pertaining to degree of similarity, meaning that I cannot even personally enter the library myself to browse!

The thread language, by the way, is also how I manipulate mathematical statements by algebra, or do philosophy or logic—I convert the handheld notation to the thread language, crunch it in the thread language, and then translate that back to notation. What is interesting about this is that since I can always translate the thread language back to notation, it basically demonstrates that the thread language itself is not lossy as a translation. However, in grade school while learning algebra and calculus, despite being able to have much higher-level insights than most of my peers, (like when I accidentally independently reinvented hazard functions, a time as a junior when I used parametric functions to express a gnarly function's derivative, or when I reinvented MIT-level infinite-series solving tricks by noticing the patters, since I'm kind of bad about knowing where to look to actually study the existing material), I would finish near-to-last on standardized tests because I had to take on the one-to-two second lag every single time I wrote down a new algebraic statement on the page during calculations. It would go "read the question", then "translate to thread language", then "subconsciously find the best next move using the thread language", then "translate back to notation to write down", then "translate back to the thread language to get the best next step again", and so on until completion of the question. So effectively I go at a snail's pace up until right near the end of undergrad level math and physics, at which point—at least compared to usual peers, but I cannot speak for hyper-genius people of course (and of course I will still fail material

B was left empty. The agent chooses between taking only Box B, (one-boxing), or taking both boxes, (two-boxing). The two standing answers are exactly these two available acts, and the literature has divided over them, with remarkable persistence, for over five decades [145]. I will set that machinery out below, as reinforcement and for orientation; the treatment itself comes first.

The one boxer reasoning is literally the Accordance Principle, or more technically the Accordance Principle is the complete ontological generalization of this reasoning to each and every blank attribute in one's Aethus: the possible world one finds themselves in is retroactively selected in accordance with the probability set by one's Nexus. To unpack the terms for a reader arriving from the present paper alone: the Accordance Principle[184] is the deductive engine of Nexic reasoning, the companion framework to this one, and it descends from the mediocrity principle—the assumption that one's observations are typical of observers in one's reference class—extended from positions within a single fixed history to the space of possible histories itself, the reference class being the space of Aethae. A Nexus, in that framework's sense, is a weighting scheme over Aethae, (not to be confused with the Quantum Nexus of this paper's path-integral wing), so that "the probability set by one's Nexus" is the typicality-weighted expectation over which observer-situation one occupies; the principle has in fact already been put to work once in this paper, in the intuitive inroad to the indiscriminate time principle, (Principle 11).

Against the existing one-boxer camps. One precision is worth adding about the relation to the existing one-boxer camps, because "literally" deserves care: given the metaphysical commitments those camps actually make, their reasoning is better described as *consistent with* the Accordance Principle without quite making the leap of grasping it as an ontological principle—evidential decision theory, as set out below, reaches the verdict through the news value of the act, not through any standing commitment about one's own typicality as an observer. The verdict is shared; the grounding is not.

The typicality reading of the predictor's record. In the case of the challenge, since the supercomputer is almost never wrong over all who take the test, then that establishes oneself as part of this population and its corresponding Nexus probability scheme. The predictor's track record, that is, is not merely evidence about the predictor: it is population-level information about the reference class one belongs to, and self-mediocrity says the accuracy it exhibits over everyone else is the accuracy to expect over oneself. Or, by reading the contrapositive, for the supercomputer to guess wrong on you alone would establish you are likely not part of the same Nexus as everyone else, which violates the Accordance Principle by means of establishing that you are not a mediocre consciousness. An accurately predicted two-boxer, though, is no anomaly and no exception to the record, so the counsel cannot run through atypicality. It runs through the branch-conditional payoff laws restated over the reference class: the members who one-box collect and the members who two-box do not, and the Accordance Principle's answer is to act as the collecting members do, which is the settling calculation in another register and not an independent derivation.

This, however, is only the Accordance Principle treatment itself. The more rigorous Aethic treatment, in the sense of following from deduction from the Aethic postulates, is that the two boxer assumption itself is a classical construct which Aethic reasoning removes. That is, the classical assumption is that since the supercomputer selected and therefore fixed the outcome in the past, therefore it is determinate already in the present when you are making your decision, which means your decision cannot influence it. Stated in this paper's terms, that is the timeline presupposition all over again: past occurrence is being converted into present determinateness by nothing more than the assumption that determinacy attaches to spacetime position, (Sections 12.6.2 and 12.6.1)—the very bookkeeping convention whose removal defines the framework. *Blanks lack tense*: the prediction sits in the proper-time past, but relative to the deciding Aethus its content is a blank attribute, and a blank attribute is in superposition regardless of where its referent sits in the block universe, (Principle 11). The direct Aethic invalidation of this assumption, then, is simply in the fact that the selection from the supercomputer is not determinate in the first place, but rather perfectly malleable in its determinateness due to the indiscriminate time principle. Only by centric unfolding does it become fixed, not because it occurred in the past already. And no retrocausation is anywhere involved: nothing in spacetime

I have not yet learned or am not quite good at as much as the next guy, to be clear)—their own time to move between steps using their methods slows down enough that their net time quickly overtakes mine, as my translations take the same amount of time, and my intuitive computation remains nearly instantaneous, but while their per-step time inflates monotonically with the abstraction difficulty of the question.

[184]The principle's dating-and-origin record — the 2019–2020 infinite-cosmos Earth-count construction, its seeding by popular exposure to the Doomsday argument, the 2022 mass-of-timelines intermediate, and the 2022–2023 re-valuation over indexed partial states — is kept, in full and with its calibrations, as the provenance note of the anthropic extraction, where it belongs beside the principle's own development; it is not duplicated here.

is edited and no signal travels backward—determinateness is Aethus-indexed, (Section 2.4.7), and the deciding observer simply unfolds into the pocket whose proper-time past contains the matching prediction, with exactly the operation-on-the-books character that the counterfactual semantics gives to every perturbation, (Section 9.1).

It is also worth noting that by Aethic deduction itself, the moment you decide what you are going to pick with certainty[185] is when the centric unfolding actually occurs, since an Aethus is closed under deduction rather than direct outcome attainment. The point is doing real work here: closure under deduction, (the first postulate), means the Aethus does not wait for the boxes to be opened—once your choice is deductively settled for you, and the predictor's near-certain accuracy is among your stated information, the prediction's content follows deductively, and the unfolding fires then. The outcome may be deduced by what you know your choice to be, (unless you change later on, so in reality it is more like a heavily biased Aethic disagreeing superposition the less you change your mind), and so at this moment you—assuming the supercomputer is almost surely correct at predicting—centric unfold to an Aethic block universe in which the supercomputer in the proper time past selected the correct prediction for you. The parenthetical is structure rather than hedge: the weights of the disagreeing superposition track the firmness of the commitment, (the weighted formulation, Section 6.7), so partial resolve is a partially biased superposition over both predictions. Resolve, and not the decision, is the well-defined object here: "so-and-so decided" has no Aethic well-definedness, while the resolve, the agent's makeup as indexed by resolving to press, and the act are attributes carrying weights. The resolve so read is a makeup status-type and not a particular total makeup: a parent Aethus stating the resolve and leaving the rest of the makeup blank, whose refinements are the specific makeups that press, so that the trait's weight conditional on it is its weight within that parent, and a partial lean is an average over the open makeup Aethae themselves, with their own weights (the author's clarification of 2026-09-26). Against its nearest relatives, Eells's tickle defense, Jeffrey's ratifiability, the deliberational-dynamics tradition and functional decision theory, the reading differs in three places: it denies that "decided" is well-defined, so the trait is coupled to the status-type and not to a moving lean, which dissolves the Egan instability rather than managing it; it adds the reference-class placement the tickle defense lacked, settling placing the agent among the members who perform the act and typicality giving their law, so that the predictor's coupling survives while the lesion's, running through the craving the class already carries, does not; and it reaches the type by conditioning on the status-type that settling reveals, under a stated sufficiency premise, rather than by logical counterfactuals over an algorithm, the two parting in one specified model on the full box of transparent Newcomb (Proposition 30), at the price of the luminosity premise, stated rather than escaped. Resolve is therefore the stand-in for the decision's causal placement, and it is what the smoking-lesion argument below attaches to. In this way the Aethic treatment naturally handles the full spectrum from uncertainty to commitment, with the standard paradox appearing as the limiting case of full commitment on either side.

With the treatment in hand, the standard machinery can now be set out and the fit inspected. Nozick's original presentation [146] framed the paradox as a collision between two independently compelling principles of choice: expected-utility reasoning, which notices that one-boxers reliably walk away with the million, and dominance reasoning, which notices that whatever is in the opaque box, taking both yields a thousand dollars more. Evidential decision theory, in the tradition of Jeffrey [147] and, more recently, Ahmed [148], sides with the first: one-box, because the act carries news of the prediction. Causal decision theory, originating with Gibbard and Harper [149] and developed by Lewis [150] and Joyce [151], sides with the second: two-box, because the prediction is causally fixed in the past and the act cannot touch it. Notice where the Aethic treatment lands relative to this standoff: causal decision theory's firmest premise—the causally fixed past—is exactly the classical construct removed above, so the Aethic verdict is not an adjudication between the two decision rules but the removal of the shared ontological assumption their disagreement runs on. Wolpert and Benford's diagnosis [145], that the two camps are in effect solving two different formal games, is congenial to this reading, since the games differ precisely over whether the prediction is held fixed. Timeless and functional decision theory, (Yudkowsky [152]; Yudkowsky and Soares [153]), reach the one-box verdict by having the agent reason as if their decision procedure determines the prediction through the predictor's model of it—structurally the right shape, but left ontologically unanchored in those frameworks. The Aethic treatment supplies the anchor: the decision determines the prediction not through any as-if and not through backward causation, but because the deciding observer selects, by centric unfolding, which block universe—with which proper-time past—is theirs. And to answer a

[185] Whatever that means, but we know the Aethic deduction happens at some point in between you deciding and revealing the contents of the box, inclusive.

question the Accordance route naturally raises: typicality and self-locating reasoning are a developed apparatus in the anthropic literature [154], and the transparent-boxes variant presses the commitment structure of the problem [155], but the specific grounding above—that a misprediction of you alone would demote your typicality as a consciousness, in violation of an ontological principle—does not appear as such in the evidential tradition; its verdict runs consistent with the Accordance Principle without resting on it.

The strongest objection to one-boxing deserves its own moment: the agent can delegate the decision to a genuinely random quantum coin flip, apparently nullifying any predictive mechanism. Nozick himself addressed this by stipulating that randomizing agents would find Box B empty[186]—a stipulative dodge rather than a mechanism. The Aethic framework makes the second horn available: assuming the near-certainty holds even against randomization, reduced form coupling—the same mechanism that generates the delayed-choice [10] effect—provides it, and this exact supercomputer-and-coin-flip configuration is worked as the illustrative case where the coupling's generality is established, (Section 6.6.2). For the supercomputer's near-certainty to be preserved, the only valid configurations of the joint system—coin outcome, prediction, agent action—are those in which prediction matches action; configurations where they diverge are pruned by the third postulate, because the agent would otherwise discover the predictor's error upon opening the boxes. The apparent retrocausal near-certainty falls out of the same checkmate pruning that handles every other Aethic decoherence event.

One more of Nozick's pressure points is worth running, because it seemingly supports the causal camp decisively: the "friend behind the boxes" argument [146]. A friend has already seen the contents of Box B before the agent decides, and the friend's reasoning plainly favors taking both boxes, since from where the friend sits the contents are fixed. The Aethic rebuttal is that the friend's reasoning is correct relative to the friend's own Aethus, and that importing it into the agent's is precisely the arbitrary cross-Aethus transfer the framework forbids, (the first postulate): relative to the agent's Aethus the friend is not in a determinate state of having seen a specific outcome—the friend's observation sits in disagreeing superposition, exactly as Wigner's friend's does [30], (Section 10.2.1). The spectator argument fails not because the friend is wrong, but because the first-person and spectator perspectives occupy structurally distinct Aethae, and the paradox-generating step was the silent assumption that their books could be merged.

9.7.5 Where Standard Anthropic Reasoning Is Lossy: An Epicyclic Diagnosis

A reader who has followed the Accordance route above may be tempted to file it under "anthropic reasoning" and import that literature's standing suspicions wholesale, so it is worth stating directly, once, where the standard paradigm sits relative to the machinery just used — because the relation is not extension but projection, and the projection is severely lossy. Standard observation-selection theory [154] carries two structural commitments: the unit of reasoning is a complete, determinate timeline equipped in effect with a binary indicator for whether it houses observers, and the reference class is welded to positions *within* such timelines. Both commitments are exactly what the Nexic framework relaxes, and the difference shows most nakedly at the paradigm's own pressure points. When counterfactual or typicality leverage is needed over how things *could have gone* — the very leverage the one-boxing argument above required — a paradigm welded to realized classical histories has only one move available: manufacture more of them. This is the structural role the simulation hypothesis has come to play on the literature's front page: pressed into service precisely to mint an ensemble of realized classical timelines from which counterfactual and self-locating leverage can then be extracted, it is an epicycle in the strict historical sense — machinery added to preserve the completed-timeline commitment, with the escalating exoticness of the fallback tracking the strain on the commitment rather than any strain in the world. The Nexic move is not a further epicycle but the deferent's replacement: the space of Aethae *is* the reference class natively, and reasoning over alternative histories is a first-class operation rather than something an ensemble must be manufactured to license.

What the projection down to the standard paradigm then loses can be inventoried. It loses the continuous observer-production landscape, flattening the graded $\mathrm{P}(H \mid A)$ spectrum to a binary at an arbitrary threshold — survivorship bias being, on the Nexic result, exactly the coarse-grained shadow this flattening leaves. It loses the local, attribute-by-attribute constraint structure, forcing reasoning through global claims about whole histories — objects the companion's formalism declines as ill-formed

[186] Nozick's stipulation in the original 1969 formulation [146] is that a player predicted to decide by a random device finds Box B empty; the stipulation sidesteps the question of how the predictor would handle quantum randomness rather than answering it.

rather than merely inconvenient. It loses counterfactual *quantification*: on the Nexic method, "what if X had not happened" is a constrained probabilistic inference with derivable bounds, where the standard paradigm offers a choice between speculation and simulation-ensembles. It loses the coupled structure of improbabilities — that Miracles arrive in structurally linked sets rather than as independent atoms to be tallied, the "zero or two, never one" shape — because atom-counting is all a filter-catalog over fixed histories can express. And it loses the grounding: on the Nexic side, typicality is *derived*, from the tendency of unfolding toward likelier children of each parent state, so the reference-class problem that the standard literature treats as its deep recurring mystery is diagnosed instead, as a proposal, as an artifact of the completion in its received form, with the choice of sampling measure and granularity remaining as an explicit problem in its place — a debate over which classical class to sample from cannot close, because the classical class was never the right unit. This, finally, is why the present section could adjudicate the two-boxer's typicality reply at all: the adjudication ran through whose books, and through the unfolding, machinery the standard paradigm's inherited fixed past cannot express. The standard apparatus is recovered from the Nexic one as an artificially completed limiting case, and its familiar paradoxes are manufactured at exactly the point of completion.

The measure rule, and two cases it decides. The diagnosis just given can be tested against the two self-location puzzles the standard literature treats as its hardest, and the test is worth running because it turns on a rule the present framework carries but has nowhere stated in one place. The rule is this. A weighting scheme over Aethae — a Nexus, in the vocabulary above — is a measure over *states*, and a state is individuated by its content: two Aethae with identical stated attributes and identical open blanks are one Aethus, however many bodies happen to occupy it. It follows that a duplication which produces no new Aethus produces no new measure. In natural history this never bites, since more observers means more distinguishable observer-situations — different records, different worlds — and the framework's number-density reading counts exactly those. It bites in the constructed cases where duplication is arranged to be informationally silent, and the two standard puzzles are decided by it for a reason the rule states—one by dissolution, one by inheritance.

Sleeping Beauty. A fair coin is tossed after the subject sleeps; heads, she is woken once; tails, twice, with the memory of the first waking erased before the second [156]. On waking, what credence in heads? Halfers say one half; thirders say one third, on the ground that there are three awakenings, equiprobable from where she sits, and heads accounts for one.

Credence relative to which Aethus. The framework's first move is the one it makes on every self-location puzzle: to ask *credence relative to which Aethus*, and to notice that the two camps are answering different questions under one name. Relative to Beauty's Sunday Aethus, before the sleep, the coin is a fair blank and nothing has happened; the credence is one half, and it stays one half for every Aethus in which the coin's resolution and the awakening structure have not been coupled—the experimenter's, the record's, Sunday's.

Relative to the waking Aethus. Relative to Beauty's *waking* Aethus the situation is different, and the difference is exactly what the rule states. Her waking state carries the day as a genuine blank, and the three ways it may be resolved—Monday-under-heads, Monday-under-tails, Tuesday-under-tails—are three *distinct* states, distinguished by their content whether or not she can tell them apart from inside: they hold different records, and a later Aethus, hers or anyone's, resolves them differently. Distinct states carry distinct measure; that is the rule, applied without exception. The subjective indistinguishability of the awakenings, which the memory erasure manufactures, is a fact about what her waking Aethus *does not state*, and the framework's whole discipline is that a blank is content, not a merger of the states it stands blank over. So relative to the waking Aethus, with the awakening-conditioned measure the reduced form supplies, the credence in heads is one third: the tails-branch carries two of the three states she may occupy, the measure weighting the three awakening tokens equally, tokens the memory loss leaves subjectively indistinguishable rather than Aethae distinguished by content, as the reduced form's uniform measure over them, a weighting rule the indexation identifies but does not fix by their distinctness alone, and occupying one of them is evidence about the coin exactly as occupying one of many observer-situations is evidence in the natural-history reading above. There is no contradiction between the two verdicts, and there was never one to adjudicate: one half and one third are correct answers to differently indexed questions, and the halfer–thirder dispute is a dispute over an un-indexed sentence—the same shape as the two indexings of Wigner's friend, and dissolved the same way.

Two remarks against the literature. Two remarks fix the reading against the literature. Lewis's halfism is the position that Beauty *does* learn something on waking—he grants that her conditional

credence in heads given that it is Monday rises to two thirds—and it is exactly the framework's diagnosis that this is the right observation attached to the wrong index: what she learns on waking is that she occupies one of the awakening-states, which moves the credence relative to *that* Aethus and leaves the Sunday credence where it was. And a rule stated earlier in these drafts, that a downstream blank cannot reweight the parent it hangs from, is retracted as too strong: the *number* of states a branch carries downstream is itself evidence about the branch, relative to any Aethus indexed to occupancy of those states—which is precisely the thirder's point, and the framework's per-state measure delivers it rather than forbidding it.

The presumptuous philosopher. Two cosmological theories, empirically equivalent, differ only in that one predicts a trillion times as many observers; the self-indication assumption favors the larger by that factor, which is taken as a reductio of the assumption [154]. Here the rule cuts the other way, and the contrast is the point. The larger universe's additional observers are not informationally silent duplicates — they occupy genuinely distinct records, distinct worlds, distinct Aethae — so the rule *does* count them, and the framework inherits the self-indicating verdict rather than the halfer's. Whether that verdict is the absurdity it is taken to be is a further question the framework must face rather than dissolve; what the rule supplies is a principled statement of *when* additional observers carry weight (when they occupy distinct states) and when they do not (when they do not) — which is the distinction the self-sampling/self-indication dispute has lacked, and the reason it has not closed. That one stated rule decides both puzzles is the rule's first check, and it is the diagnosis above run on the paradigm's own two hardest cases: each is a dispute over how observer-moments should be counted, and each is settled the moment the counting is done over *states*, relative to a named Aethus, rather than over tokens under no index—Beauty by dissolution into two correctly indexed verdicts, the presumptuous philosopher by inheritance of the count that distinct states force.

One scope note, closed rather than left open. Sleeping Beauty as posed is a credence question and is settled above; its betting variants, in which the odds the subject should accept depend on whether payoffs accrue per awakening or per experiment, are the same indexation point restated as decision theory. A bet paid per awakening is settled relative to the waking Aethus and prices at one third; a bet paid once per experiment is settled relative to the experiment-level Aethus and prices at one half; and the two are not rival answers but bets on differently indexed propositions, which is why the literature's finding that "the right odds depend on the payoff structure" is not an embarrassment for either camp but the index becoming visible through the payoff. The stated-relata audit of paragraph 4.7.4 is the general form of this observation.

9.7.6 The Flank-Importing Fallacy, the Inoperable Chain, and the Perception-Denial Fallacy

The gravity-assist example of Section 9.6.1 ends on a diagnosis it does not fully unpack, and the diagnosis turns out to be the specimen of something much more general. This subsubsection does four things in order. It states the flank-importing fallacy in its own terms, so that its shape is visible independently of the example that produced it. It shows how the fallacy interfaces with the classical determinate causal chain—a chain held to exist in full while conceded to be inoperable—and why that concession is not the modest epistemic humility it presents as but a contradiction, with the ill-definedness it produces going unnoticed by the one producing it. It then names the move by which the chain survives its own inoperability, because the move recurs far outside causality and a named pattern travels where an unnamed one must be rediscovered in each field. And it lists the move's principal instances, the oldest of which is the problem of evil.

The flank-importing fallacy, unpacked. Three terms fix the shape. A *connection* is a past attribute a made to enforce a future attribute b—the red light made to fix what one eats for breakfast three months on. The *flanks* of a connection are the concurrent attributes that stand alongside the enforced one at the future moment: what the cat is doing on the landing while breakfast is eaten. And a *witnessing Aethus* for a connection is the contingent Aethus relative to which the connection actually holds—in the example, the Aethus in which one has written the script that reads the past day's light and auto-purchases the breakfast accordingly. With those terms, two facts stand side by side and the fallacy is the confusion of them. The first is a fact of *existence*: for any pair (a, b) whatever, a witnessing Aethus can be found, because one can always be constructed—write the script, wire the dependence, and the connection holds. So the classical chain's opening sentence, "I can establish a connection between any given past attribute and any given future attribute," is true, one pair at a time. The second is a fact of *fixity*: a connection holds only relative to its witness. The enforcement is stated content of the witnessing Aethus, and it is Aethus-fixed in exactly the sense the first postulate

gives that phrase: in the script-Aethus the light fixes breakfast, in the Aethus where the script was never written it does not, and the two are distinct Aethae standing in superposition relative to the past self who had not yet chosen between them.

The import, in three steps. The fallacy is the import of a connection found in some witness to instances the witness does not cover, and it proceeds in three steps, each of which switches Aethae without registering the switch. The first import is to the flanks of the witness itself: having found that the light fixes breakfast in the script-Aethus, the chain reads the light as fixing the cat too—but the cat is on the flank, no witness enforces it, and under the perturbation that swaps the light from red to green the cat's attribute remains a valid Aethus at roughly its original weight, which is what it means for it not to have been fixed. The second import is across witnesses: the connection witnessed for (a, b) and the connection witnessed for (a, b') are treated as holding together, as though a single Aethus contained both—but the witness for the second pair is a different Aethus, whose flanks are whatever that Aethus has them be, and nothing says they match the first's. The third import is to the actual Aethus: the connection is asserted of the reality one in fact occupies, which is a witness for neither pair. The sentence "finding it anywhere in the category licenses forcing it onto every instance" names all three at once, and it is the exact form of the error.

The skeleton of the fallacy is a quantifier exchange, and it is worth writing down because the exchange is the same one the elementary-logic material of Section 13.8.1 records: from

$$\forall(a, b)\ \exists A_{ab}\ :\ a \Rightarrow b \text{ relative to } A_{ab}$$

the chain concludes

$$\exists A\ \forall(a, b)\ :\ a \Rightarrow b \text{ relative to } A,$$

the witnessing Aethus playing the role a witness plays in any such exchange. But the skeleton understates the error, and the understatement is where the flesh of the matter lives. The exchange would be harmless if the witnesses composed—if there were an Aethus that was, so to speak, the union of every A_{ab}, containing all the connections that can be found one at a time. There is not, and the framework's own algebra says why. Witnesses whose stated flanks conflict have an invalid intersection: the script-Aethus that fixes breakfast on Tuesday and the script-Aethus that fixes it differently on Tuesday cannot both be stated in one valid Aethus. Witnesses whose stated flanks are merely unrelated have as their join not a determinate Aethus but a superposition, which is precisely not the single determinate reality the chain needs. So "one Aethus contains all that can be found in any Aethus individually" does not name a rare or unreachable Aethus; it names nothing. The connections are real, each in its witness; the composite that would make them a chain is not an object, and the reversal principle of Section 9.6.1 is the statement of why: future probabilities track the Aethic information one holds, not particular past events, so that swapping a past event skews the weights over future stated-attributes without determining every last one of them, the flanks included.

The interface with the determinate chain: existing yet inoperable. The classical picture does not deny any of the above at the level of practice. It concedes that no one can compute breakfast from the light, that the sequence of events linking the gravity assist to the state of the world two years hence cannot be followed by anyone. What it does not concede is the chain's existence, and its reconciling sentence is the one this subsubsection is about: *the sequential events are there; they simply cannot be tracked.* That sentence is antirealism about tracking wedded to realism about the events, and the two halves contradict each other in a way the speaker does not see, because the contradiction is produced by the speaker in the act of speaking. What makes an event of the chain *there*—what individuates it, what makes it this event rather than another—is the flank-assignment that the operative connection fixes at that moment: the event is breakfast-being-an-omelet-while-the-cat-does-this, and it is that event because a connection running through a witness makes it so. Remove operability and the witness goes with it; without the witness there is no fact of which flank-assignment the event carries; and an event with no fact of its flanks is not an event that cannot be tracked but an event that has not been specified. The concession of inoperability, made in the spirit of humility, has already dissolved the identity conditions of the very events whose existence the sentence goes on to assert. The ill-definedness is self-inflicted, and it is unaudited, because the faculty that would have reported it—the capacity to follow the sequence—is the one the sentence has just declared unavailable. This is the antirealist contradiction in the flesh: not a position one argues oneself into but one that the inoperability manufactures, invisibly, in the same breath that concedes it. The Aethic reading says what the chain's existence-claim was tracking all along: the chain exists only as the flank-importing composite, the one Aethus containing every connection, which is exactly the object the previous paragraph showed to be no object. Inoperability is not an epistemic limit on following a determinate

thing. It is the signature that the thing was never a single determinate Aethus, and the reversal principle—no perfectly determinate Mars to begin with—is where the contradiction gets explained instead of absorbed.

The move, named. The chain survives its inoperability by a maneuver that is worth isolating, because once isolated it is recognizable wherever it occurs. Call it the *perception-denial fallacy.* A clear contradiction is uncovered between a held framework and a manifest report—something registered plainly, by a faculty doing its ordinary work. The fallacy resolves the contradiction not by revising either horn but by positing a defect in the faculty that registered the report: the report is reclassified as illusion, as corrupted perception, as the limitation of a part that cannot see the whole. Four marks fix the type. The contradiction is real and is seen; it is not a confusion to be cleared up but a genuine incompatibility. The resolution locates the fault in the perceiver rather than in either of the things perceived. The posited defect has no evidence independent of the contradiction it is posited to absorb—nothing else about the faculty has failed, and nothing would have been said against it had the framework not required it. And the framework is kept whole while the phenomenon is demoted to appearance, so that the result is antirealism about exactly the thing the faculty reported and realism about exactly the thing that could not accommodate it. The diagnostic follows from the third mark: whenever the only evidence for the alleged defect is the contradiction it explains away, the fallacy is in play. As for why the move is taken, the source is not confusion but cost. The alternative to denying the perception is surrendering a horn of the framework, and where the horn is cherished the surrender is bitter; the fallacy relocates the bitterness into a standing suspicion of one's own faculties, which feels like humility and functions as evasion. That is why it presents so consistently as modesty—"we are too limited to see how it fits"—and why it should be audited as the opposite.

Its instances. The chain is one case of a type, and the type's principal members should be listed, so that the pattern is importable into the fields where each lives.

1. *The determinate causal chain.* The case above: the sequence of events is held to exist, the faculty of following it is declared deficient, and the events' ill-definedness goes unaudited. The framework's resolution is the reversal principle and the witness-relativity of connections, at the cost of the single determinate world and not of anyone's faculties.

2. *Passage and the block.* Read the block universe as a tenseless whole and felt passage contradicts it; the fallacy resolves the contradiction as "passage is a psychological illusion," the faculty of temporal experience declared to be reporting nothing. This paper's reconciliation stands throughout, (Sections 2.2 and 4.2): passage is the centric unfolding, real relative to the Aethus that unfolds and illusory relative to nothing, the block carrying Aethus-indexed openness rather than a single completed history. The report of the faculty is treated as data about the indexing, not as the malfunction that lets the framework off.

3. *The deflationary reading of quantum blanks, and instrumentalism beside it.* "The value is determinate, we merely do not know it" is the chain's sentence at the single-attribute grain: the faculty of access is declared deficient so that a standing valuation can be kept. The permanence and anti-deflation material of Section 11.2.1, (Proposition 3), shows the values to be ill-defined once the valuation is removed—the same self-inflicted ill-definedness as the chain's—and the Bell leg of the argument, (Section 10.3.2), is where the kept valuation meets the statistics that exclude it. Instrumentalism about the micro-world runs the same play wholesale: "the micro-events are there; they cannot be pictured or tracked," with the pictorial and tracking faculties sacrificed so that a classical substrate may be retained beneath the quantum statistics.

4. *Agency.* "We feel that we choose; determinism says we do not; the feeling is an illusion." The faculty of agency-report is denied, the determinist framework kept, and the reconciliation—which on this paper's terms runs through the Aethus-indexed openness of the very attributes the choice is about—never attempted.

5. *The problem of evil.* This is the oldest instance and the clearest, and it deserves stating in full. The contradiction is between two things held at once: that the world is the work of a creator both omnipotent and omnibenevolent, and that evil is manifest in it—not subtle, not arguable, but registered by the moral faculty as plainly as anything is registered by any faculty. The Augustinian resolution has two parts, and the second is the fallacy. The first reclassifies evil as privation, an absence of good rather than a positive thing, so that nothing was created evil. The second, which carries the weight, locates the residual contradiction in the perceiver: the human

faculties are fallen, the part cannot see the good of the whole, the limited perspective mistakes local privation for genuine evil, and what is registered as evil is therefore misperception. All four marks are present. The contradiction is seen and is real. The fault is placed in the seer. The defect in the seer is evidenced by nothing except the contradiction it dissolves—the moral faculty is not otherwise found unreliable, and would never have been indicted had the creator's two attributes not required it. And the framework is kept entire while the manifest term is demoted to appearance. The contrast with the worldview that preceded it is instructive, because it shows the move to be a choice and not a necessity. The Greco-Roman picture had gods who were not omnibenevolent, a fortune that was capricious, and a fate that was indifferent; it held no contradiction of this shape, and so had nothing to bury. Confronted with a resolution that indicts one's own perception of evil in order to preserve a creator's goodness, that worldview would not have found the resolution pious. It would have found it absurd—the report of evil is data, and the gods are what they are—and it would have laughed, because self-suspicion adopted to spare a framework is not an argument and was never, there, mistaken for one. What the Augustinian move sources from is the cost named above: the horn to be surrendered was the dearest one available, and the bitterness of surrendering it was relocated into a permanent suspicion of the faculty that had reported the evil. That relocation is the fallacy's genealogy, and it is why the same move reappears wherever a cherished framework meets a report it cannot absorb.

6. *Eliminativisms.* The list stays open, and its next members are recognizable by the marks: eliminativism about consciousness, on which the report of experience is itself the illusion, is the fallacy applied to the faculty of introspection, and every "it only seems that way" offered in place of a reconciliation should be checked against the diagnostic before it is accepted.

The framework's alternative. It is uniform, and it is already in force at every one of the instances above that the framework touches: *index rather than deny.* The connection is real relative to its witness; passage is real relative to the unfolding Aethus; the blank is a constructive fact about the indexing Aethus rather than a report of broken access. In each case the contradiction is explained by relocating the index—by saying relative to what the reported thing holds—and the price is paid in ontology, in the surrender of the single determinate world, rather than in the standing of anyone's faculties. The report is kept as data. Where the perception-denial fallacy buries what was registered, the framework files it, and the difference between the two is not a difference of temperament but of which horn one is prepared to give up: the fallacy gives up the perceiver, and the framework gives up the world that could not accommodate what the perceiver saw.

9.8 Miscellaneous Ideas on Modality and Counterfactuals

9.8.1 My Argument For Judging Existence on Characters

The construction proceeds in six steps, and delivers at the end a canonical Aethus describing Batman together with a weight reading of the degree to which Batman exists.

1. Consider the set A to consist of the set of all possible descriptions of a person, each valued as an unweighted Aethus.

2. Define the quality Q of "being a valid description of Batman" for some $a \in A$ as (1) consisting with a description of Batman in terms of positively capturing[187] qualities necessary for being Batman[188] while (2) also allowing the addition of arbitrarily more attributes to the description so long as none explicitly conflict with the description of Batman[189].

3. Rather than having to define a description of Batman explicitly so as to run Q as an algorithm, we consider the Nexus K of all people who are knowledgeable about Batman, (this may also be

[187]This is the Aethic reversal principle directly—an Aethus is not defined by enumerating possible worlds, but by providing the least-broad description which succeeds in capturing the object or system in question. This may be interpreted as "the Aethic superposition of all possible worlds which consist with the object in question" if you must think of it that way, but more broadly it is the idealized Aethic object corresponding to it directly, with the instinct of the possible worlds concept to push the description all the way down to exhaustive determinate properties—and more strongly still enforce the inclusion of this bottommost layer of description as being structurally and axiomatically necessary to even categorically describe the object in question to begin with—being rejected.

[188]For example, he has to have a specific origin story and personality up to what is demanded by the arbiter of that description class.

[189]For example, whether Batman ate cereal compared to scrambled eggs on the morning of his 25th birthday.

limited to consulting authors or the general public, in which cases it is a statistical sample of K), and assign a function $f\colon A \to [0,1]$ such that $f(a)$ gives the proportion of people[190] in K who evaluate Q for a as true. Intuitively, f is the "quality of description score".

4. (To be formalized) Determine a means of assembling N, the subset of A of all descriptions for a person which are effective fixed points in the sense that their own valid proper child Aethae cease to increase the value of f compared to themselves, (as a kind of stationary description of Batman). These are effectively the broadest-scope Aethae which give a description of Batman that is broad in the sense of capturing all further descriptions with none of their being any better than it is, and specific in the sense of that loss in description quality will be attained by removing attributes from the description. Importantly, each such $n \in N$ is now the broadest-possible Aethic superposition of descriptions of Batman which assign to each "description class" of Batman, where interestingly it is as if the population itself sorts itself into possibly contradictory "modes" of what suffices to be Batman[191]. As if almost Zipfian, the majority of these will have $0 < f(n) \ll 1$, although some few will hold $f(n) > 1/2$.

5. We now create the canonical "Aethus describing Batman" as the linear combination $B \propto \sum_{n \in N} f(n)\, n$, and specifically renormalize this linear combination to produce B itself. Here we have that higher-score description classes of Batman will be weighted higher, and we also may avoid redundancy or double-counting by means of having cut further refinements at exactly the minimum broadness for which they no longer count toward the score, being how N was defined to begin with.

6. We then refer to one's own Aethus, (being the necessary referee by the first postulate of the Aethus), and intersect with its residue the instantiation Aethus $\mathcal{B}$—distinct from the description B—being the Aethus for which there exists a member of our biosphere consisting with B. The residue of this intersection will hold an Aethic weight capturing the degree to which Batman exists. If it is fully invalid, then Batman definitely does not exist, however if it is remains valid, then the weight of its reduced form in B is itself roughly the proportion of the population who would indeed attest that Batman exists. Should Batman himself be an abstract invariant of sorts in the sociological ethos, then this is a direct reading of that abstract object, even if one personally disagrees with it.

9.8.2 The "Task-Object" Concept

Interestingly, during my early work on Nexic reasoning, I independently rediscovered[192]—by analyzing the continuity between Earth's successful continued existence in the past (despite the Rare Earth

[190] The reason for using a proportion of people is that in the limiting case of using all people who compose the sociological "hive man" describing Batman, we attain a wisdom-of-the-crowd effect which captures every nuance about sufficiency toward being Batman.

[191] For example, Adam West's Batman (up to even how the costume is designed, because that is part of the qualities necessary for capturing that Batman in a broad description) versus Christopher Nolan's Batman, or along another differentiating axis a given mainstream Batman versus a given more niche reimagination of Batman—all of which would to a given subpopulation be classified as "Batman" and so would leave a stationary $n \in N$ somewhere even if its particular $f(n)$ is quite small.

[192] **The following is an excerpt from a July 1, 2022 Google Doc I wrote about my thoughts on the future of the human species, and (to give a basic summary) how we should rethink our very categorical orientation about the universe so as to build as our root ontological primitive the Aethus for which humanity is continually prosperous (particularly focused on the near-term, anyway, because anything longer is excessive on low visibility into it).**

The point of including all of this is to demonstrate just how flipping one fundamental concept of reality can change everything. Take non-euclidean geometry, which alters Euclid's absolute fundamental postulates like the distance between two points – an entirely new systematic way of thinking may be birthed from the tiniest changes upfront. So then, for the query here – how does one define an object? It seems as though the classic way of describing an object regards its perceived independence from other objects. There is nothing inherently wrong with this approach in the context of many of the aspects of our society and day-to-day interactions. But is it truly the most fundamental definition of an object in general? For instance, there is also what I call the "task-object". It is not a more fundamental definition or even a substitute for object, but instead is to be used in specific cases where the concept of object becomes too arbitrary for the conditions.

A task-object is an object defined not by perceived independence from another object, but instead defined by a contribution it pays to the Golden Point. Take, for instance, the Earth. The Earth as an object is easily distinguished from a planet with different continent configurations, atmospheric composition, diameter, and so on, as we can clearly see by calling Alderaan from Star Wars not Earth. But, even though it satisfies many of these properties of difference, Earth 3.9 billion years ago is still called "Earth". However, a perfect Earth duplicate, if it were to exist in a separate star system, would likely be called "Not Earth", and so the confusion grows. But the strangest part arises when we consider Earth in the scope of the Golden Trek. If we imagined another Golden Trek which had no "Earth", then this can be

hypothesis's universe [106]) and the discussion of human prosperity in the immediate future—a version of Kripke's [12] rigid designator versus contingent designator distinction. That is, contingent designators cannot be used to refer to rigid designators, because the former is not robust under perturbation across possible worlds, while the latter is on account of pointing to the intended object itself rather than a loose description of it. Kripke's move in noticing this genuine categorical distinctness was to establish that we ought not to use contingent designators when referring to what is in reality referred to by rigid designators. My conclusion, upon stumbling onto this same distinction, however was entirely more partial than simply leaving it at that they are distinct: I leaned the way physicists leaned with Newton's first law of motion, where we ought to welcome the counterintuitive new category as both actually ontologically reflective of the universe while at once more operatively useful to humans for methodological perceptiveness. Due to this being the classic move of physics, after all, my leaning was to introduce that philosophy of counterintuitive premises. I should note, however, that the same ought not usually to be said about any given counterintuitive idea—especially when it comes to moral matters, in which case counterintuitiveness is usually a danger rather than an insight—so rather the argument was and is one of those rare categories for which the existing intuition is actually out of sync with the real-world ontology, (per the imprecision of what was useful for societies throughout human evolution toward reflecting actual ontology).

It is also worth mentioning that the modern Aethic framework actually fully denies the existence of the ontological objects in the first place to which rigid designators point. (What is denied here is Kripke's metaphysical presupposition, not his linguistics: the modal argument survives untouched as a claim about how names function in language, while the present claim lives a level below, about what that functioning tracks.) This is effectively a casualty of the fundamental switching from possible worlds to Aethae as the base unit of reality, such that there no longer exists the sort of consistent "categorical substance" across possible worlds to which rigid designators may point. Due to the Aethic reversal principle directly, the underlying determinate reality required to formulate a rigid designator's object cannot in the first place be well-defined under an Aethic ontology. This is not to say, however, that the uses of the category are to be entirely abandoned—because we may restore some of the intended perturbation-robustness of rigid designators by virtue of simply placing multiple description classes of the object in question in Aethic superposition, such that perturbing one still lands you in another.

The peg as primitive, and reference to a task-object. In the mature formalism a task-object is an Aethus-invariant peg, and the class of physical objects that realize it is derived from the peg rather than being its root: for the task-human *who first derives Aethic reasoning*, the realizer is a different person in different proper child Aethae, a redhead in one, a sixty-year-old in another, a pair of twins in a third, and the peg is filled by each. Reference to a task-object therefore ranges over every consistent realizer at once; when the author refers to that task-human as "me," the reference accounts for all of them, equivalent up to uniqueness by the convention of that choice of task-object. This is the restoration

easily achieved by simply taking down the exact set of factors which would lead the informed human to define a planet as "Earth" from the Golden Trek. In its place, of course, a planet very similar to Earth would have to be substituted in place, otherwise an Imperfection Magnitude Drop would trigger. But, technically, it is not Earth, because if we compared it to our world, we would shake our heads and declare that it is not in fact "Earth" at all. This is all well and good for certain purposes of use for the Earth, but it is problematic in others. For instance, if we were defining a brand new Golden Trek, say as a hypothetical separate dice roll within the scope of the First Law, then it would be quite useful to define the analog to Earth, and all the rest of the objects of our Golden Trek that we name Prerequisites or in the least relevant. So, perhaps we might define a "Task-Earth" as the planet on which the Golden Point's makers speciated, or perhaps something even more fundamental in its logical and intuitive nature. (For example, if we find "speciated" itself to be too dependent on objects rather than task-objects, or in other words is too specific to our Golden Trek, then we might find a better substitute, or just establish a more clever Task-Earth definition altogether).

The trouble with translating directly from an object to a task-object, is that any one object could be broken into infinitely many task-objects, and also that any one task-object could be broken into infinitely many objects. That is, the Earth as an object could be assigned many different task-objects which are inclusive of the Earth as an object, like say "an spherical thing composed mostly of iron", or "a region of space in the goldilocks zone of a star", and the infinite list continues. Also, if any one of these task-objects were to be selected, then an infinite number of objects could be imagined which all satisfy the definition of that particular task-object, like naming a Task-Earth of speciation location for the bringers of the Golden Point, and then defining all possible Earth objects which satisfy this Task-Earth. For instance, if there were an alternate reality where say Hawaii did not exist, then while such a planetary body would not technically be the exact same Earth object as our own, it might very well still count as a Task-Earth, and hence for each task-object there are infinitely many qualifying objects. This of course means there should be some speculation in the mix of defining and naming task-objects, but perhaps it is speculation which may be linguistically systematized.

Of course, as there are task-objects, there may also be task-humans, task-events, etcetera. But once we decide to create this classification system, we can not only see where some of our biases were all along, but we may peer into the concept of the generic Golden Trek with greater accuracy.

the preceding passage describes, made primitive: the task-object is the contingent-designator side of Kripke's distinction, the description "whoever first derives it," elevated to the invariant, and the perturbation-robustness the rigid designator was meant to secure is supplied instead by its realizers held in superposition, so that perturbing one lands in another. What the passage denies, the categorical substance across worlds that a rigid designator would point to, is not reintroduced: the peg is invariant across Aethae because it is defined by what is achieved and not by who achieves it. Inference over couplings is run over task-objects, never over their physical realizers, since only the peg is invariant across the Aethae the inference ranges over.

Task-objects against rigid designation. This being said, however, the argument of my proposal of "task-objects" (being my term for the objects pointed to by contingent designators, specifically when validly rooted to the human prosperity Aethus—the excerpt's "Golden Point," in the modern framework's rendering) was to for historical figures take seriously that their identity would in fact change measurably should they be perturbed. (One point of order: the prosperity root was that project's selection, not the framework's necessity—task-object individuation is root-relative by design, and the framework requires only that some root Aethus be designated.) For instance, the question of "Would Aristotle be Aristotle if he didn't teach Alexander the Great? [12]" would be true should we define a task-human for Aristotle defined as "the man who taught Alexander the Great in the sense of providing him with the skill needed for him to later do some xyz in question." Hence, why there are several task-humans that may be chosen for Aristotle, with the deeper idea of my framework concerning task-objects being to select ones which relay the simplest or most informative[193] possible interplay into the wider question of understanding human prosperity and existence. So, the most current Aethic formulation would propose the stronger statement that a universe based on Aethic ontology both must make task-objects fundamental and must permit rigid-designator talk only as non-arbitrary shorthand for its associated task-objects.

The immediate objection the standard intuition might present to me, however, is the question of *was the person whose past holds continuity with Aristotle's own consciousness not the thing being referred to by the rigid designator?* As in, if Aristotle could simply have chosen not to tutor Alexander the Great, clearly his identity as Aristotle would remain intact [12], so therefore he would still be Aristotle. My argument against this objection, interesting enough, is to invoke the concept of Brahman itself (Section 13.7.3), which after reflection about the continuity of consciousness I have found to be the most consistent model of consciousness in ontology: to paraphrase, the possible world-model of consciousness takes as its primitive anyway that a person shares an identity in two different possible worlds should both of their consciousnesses trace back to a common point of divergence, and yet because the Aethic centric unfolding treatment holds that any other person's self-describing Aethus may be reached by finding an arbitrary Aethic time parent Aethus to oneself[194] and engage in an Aethic perturbation upon that Aethus, by transferring this continuity commitment we have to come to the conclusion that all people share one identity in the sense of consciousness. Altogether then, my rebuttal to this objection is that yes, I concede the point that this alternative version would still have to be Aristotle in identity, but so too is every possible human, and so the set of possible human-pointing rigid designators effectively collapses to a singleton equivalence class anyway. The reason is that the very continuity-argument used to employ the other version of Aristotle as Aristotle also categorizes every human as equivalent—at least as far as the principle of centric unfolding as stated[195] deduces.

9.9 Causality Without the Classical Triad: Resolving the Correlation–Causation Distinction

Scope note. The corrected statement of subsubsection 14.6.11 governs this subsection's claims: the statistical screening structure associated with Reichenbach's principle is proved for factorized states, direction is consumed from supplied mechanism structure rather than derived, and the dissolution below is a proposal (subsubsection 14.6.11).

The Wood–Spekkens diagnosis, recalled from the catalog above, ends in a call: Bell-violating correlations admit no fine-tuning-free explanation within the classical triad of causal stories — "A causes B," "B causes A," "some common antecedent C causes both" — so what is needed is a means

[193]Which, interestingly, is retrospectively again quite like physics, in the sense of trying to probe gauge freedom until you identify a theory for which "things align ideally".

[194]Potentially branching sometime in very early infancy or before, for the specific moment when a substantial portion of the universe enters disagreeing superposition.

[195]So, if one wishes to contest this conclusion while sticking to Aethic reasoning nonetheless, they perhaps would have to develop a new proposal of extra-centric unfolding (Principle 4.2).

of causality which does not privilege any member of the triad [100, 101]. This subsection records, as the modal section's closing thesis, that the framework's machinery is literally that means[196], and says why — stating only the causal-structural core, with the framework's fuller engagement with Spekkens's program running elsewhere: the nonclassicality relocation of subsubsection 10.3.1, the coupling catalog itself (subsubsection 6.6.2), the Reichenbach-correspondence conjecture (subsubsection 10.3.4), and the direct response, in the interpretive coordinates, to his call for an exotic-but-realist causality [7]. It also says why the human paradigm it replaces was structurally bound to be lossy. The rescue tradition has its coordinate here as well: two decades of work on common-cause *systems* — Hofer-Szabó, Rédei, and Szabó's partitions of generalized screeners — generalize the certificate inside the exclusive regime, and the present analysis explains both that program's local successes and its Bell-front stall, since past

[196]The provenance of this subsection, and of the smoking-lesion bullet in the catalog above, is worth recording in the archival manner of this paper's other such notes. The material began as three messages I sent to Claude Fable, and I preserve their essential content here so the direction of development is legible. The first laid out the lesion resolution in full; the second and third set the two goals this subsection and the Newcomb treatment of paragraph 4.7.4 were built to meet.

- *[[TIMESTAMP-1-TODO]]*

  Ok I finally understand what the lesion literature/argument actually is and is all about lol, so here's my proposed Aethic-based resolution to it! Note that this relies heavily on the reduced form coupling concept, so first maybe refresh your memory on that along with anything else of relevance directly from the long Aethic paper, unless of course you've comprehended the idea of all that material already. Ok here goes with my unpacking!

  1) If the existence of the lesion (to general human-biological relevance) is medically proven (ie present in your Aethus) then...

  1a) If you have the desire to smoke, then that squarely adds to your Aethus the stated-attribute that you, well, have the desire to smoke! If it's perfectly correlated to having the lesion, then you automatically deduce under Aethic deductive closure that you have the lesion, so therefore smoking doesn't affect your chance of death if you do it or not. If the correlation is looser, then it's simply a re-weighted Aethic superposition of having the lesion versus not, such that since Bayesian reasoning is just multiplying a new stated-attribute, pruning, and renormalizing, then the re-weighting toward "you have the lesion" is the effect of such given the "desire to smoke" stated-attribute, in a general interpolative sense.

  1b) If you don't yet know if you have the desire to smoke, then the stated-attribute itself of "desire to smoke" is in Aethic disagreeing superposition over its true versus false states, as weighted by whatever your Aethus allows you to deduce about the probability distribution, (so if your Aethus knows your specificity on the matter up to general population, then it's the general population weighting, but if it knows it regionally then it's regional, and if your doctor tells you there's a 20% chance that you have a desire to smoke then it updates to that--the general idea is that, roughly, you might imagine "your placement" in this regard as the "clean slate" of the population distribution intersected with a string of the further Aethic specificities you've picked up throughout life, so similarly before the interpolation game is how many more such specifications you've picked up away from the population baseline). In this case, due to the Aethic disagreeing superposition itself, the correlation here drives "don't smoke" insisting to the average Aethus that, again I must emphasize upon AVERAGING the brute probability masses now per this Aethus, that, indeed just as the correlation projection-argument alone states, "you'd better not smoke, because that would then sort you into the residue pocket for which you more likely have the lesion, now". HOWEVER, here's the key--reduced form coupling!!! The correlation per the average among these Aethae breaks for the case of being in the "smokers" category, because all of a sudden having to be in the smokers pocket prunes relative to that pocket all the non-lesion further pockets--so the key I'm trying to emphasize is that this is really just an almost-trivial reduced form coupling application in joint invalidities firing off. So "correlation" is simply a lossy averaging projection over the whole disagreeing superposition, whereas "causality" is a misconception, and "reduced form coupling" is the thing that ACTUALLY creates the thing we attribute to causality, (even though causality itself is purely a human construct). That is, it's not actually about the common cause at all--it's simply, as before in the Aethic paper with the semantic mining and jointness concepts, about who makes who invalid in which residue pocket via pruning. Get the idea??? Thanks!

  So yeah what I want to emphasize for both of these is that we're really just looking at a string of multiplied Aethae, starting with "your Aethus initially" and then multiplying on Bayesian updates as (alpha A + (1-alpha) B) dichotomy possibilities. The "this case versus that case" thing happens when we look at the distributive property unpacking and look only at the A case multiplied by the whole system versus the B case multiplied by the whole system. Hopefully this is making sense???

  2) If the existence of the lesion is not itself known, then we further place the entire "the lesion exists" and "the lesion doesn't exist" in Aethic superposition, such that the Aethic intersection of the "the lesion exists" case with one's own Aethus fires off the analysis (1) seen before, whereas the (2) is just the standard real-words view's reality itself of course.

  Please also add this full resolution, with citations to the lesion literature, as another bullet point after the Newcomb one in the reduced form coupling section's list of bullet points reimagining causality. Then also the key is to propagate this message to the relevant short papers as well, namely being the Newcomb one primarily of course. Thanks!

- *[[TIMESTAMP-2-TODO]]*

  Basically a primary goal of mine is that we also heavily unpack this in the Aethic paper, in addition to the reduced form coupling invoking, perhaps as an extra subsection at the END of the modal section or something dealing with how Aethic reasoning per all its mechanisms resolves the correlation versus causality distinction. As in, pockets and the residue and reduced form coupling LITERALLY handling Spekkens' "is there a means of causality which doesn't privilege A->B, B->A, C->both"??? This is just that means of causality--it's hardwired to a probabilistic universe rather than the lossy human causality paradigm, and hopefully the ontological-metaphysical reasons for which the human paradigm is lossy are themselves apparent--the existing classical way insists on Aristotelean-like categories for cause, whereas in the Aethic sense these melt away into attribute invalidity jointness material plus Aethic pruning. Thanks!

the regime the certificate's conditioning has no pockets of an admissible setting-independent grounding attribute to enter, and no *local*, non-conspiratorial enlargement of the screener family supplies one; ordinary conditional independence for the observed table is untouched.

The mechanism is the one exercised throughout this paper, restated once in three steps. First, the primitive relational material is *jointness*: which combinations of stated attributes can and cannot jointly stand — the invalidity structure carried intrinsically by the attributes themselves, relative to states. Second, *pruning* enforces the jointness: settling any attribute removes, relative to the resulting pocket, exactly the configurations its stated couplings render jointly invalid. Third, the *residue structure* — the surviving pockets and their weights — is everything downstream reasoning consults, with the reduced form coupling as the sole correlational absolute indifferent to proper-time ordering. Nothing in these three steps privileges a direction. The triad's three stories are three human narrations projected onto one and the same jointness-plus-pruning fact: "A caused B," "B caused A," and "C caused both" are observationally indistinguishable under their shared factorization, their mechanisms and interventions differing, and no producer slot is needed to say so[197] — only a pattern of which contents cannot jointly stand, and a weight profile over what survives. Faithfulness worries dissolve at the same stroke: there is no parameter whose accidental cancellation must be forbidden, because apparent independence at the mixture level is not an achievement of tuning but the ordinary signature of a lossy projection — the correlation seen at averages is the shadow of pocket structure, exactly as the smoking-lesion entry of the catalog exhibits at humble, non-quantum scale.

The right literature-frame for this dissolution is Reichenbach's Common Cause Principle [157], and situating against it makes precise both what is kept and what is dropped. The principle demands that every improbable correlation be grounded in one of exactly the triad's stories, with the common-cause horn certified by *screening-off*: conditional independence of the correlates given the cause. The Bell literature's standing tension is that the quantum correlations exhaust the disjunction — the Wood–Spekkens result being that tension sharpened into a fine-tuning theorem — and the usual responses either abandon the principle's demand or exoticize one horn. The present framework does neither. It keeps the demand in full: correlations are grounded, always, in the jointness material and its pruning. What it drops is the principle's *schema* — the disjunction of producers — and here is the decisive point: Reichenbach's own certificate survives the dropping. Screening-off, as a formal condition, is exactly the within-pocket detachment of the binding-modes bookkeeping below (subsubsection 9.9.1): conditional on the stated mediator, the mixture-level correlation vanishes, because it was the averaging projection over the mediator's pockets all along. So the principle's mathematics is retained in part, as the connectivity, separation, screening and covariance identities of subsubsection 9.9.4 below, with screenability relative to the attribute stock and causal common ancestry not derived — while its metaphysics, the reading of the screener as a producer, dissolves with the rest of the triad. And the retention is not merely structural: the Reichenbach-correspondence conjecture of subsubsection 10.3.4 states this subsection's thesis in density-operator dress, conjecturing the quantum-Reichenbach factorization condition of the Allen et al. program [101] to be the representational image of the reduced form coupling across the proper children of a shared parent — one claim, two grades,

- *[[TIMESTAMP-3-TODO]]*

  Please also read all the mentions of Spekkens in the long paper for full context, (especially the pinpointing the ontological nonclassicality subsection, plus the actual discussion of the A->B, B->A, C->both content as already exists, even especially for cross-referencing but also for your own contextual comprehension), and if you wouldn't mind--please also then drop Spekkens's own causality paper's citation somewhere in the decision theory itself as a brief mention, to try to land the central Aethic point of Aristotelean causal modes melting away to being arbitrary once we have reduced form coupling plus the Aethic ontology of the extrusion principle (or, as the short papers would call it, the determinacy relativism concepts). See even the rhetorical subtext of that??? Once you have the "exotic causal theory", all of a sudden EVERYTHING looks differently under it, including classical content especially, (as in, see, this is the difference between understanding stuff at the heart of freaking decision theory as opposed to not!!!). So, if you will, the classical three causality modes are less extended and more go the way of the six versions of the quadratic formula from before we invented negative numbers--the extrusion principle IS the negative numbers! (And quite frankly feel free to use the quadratic formula history analogy itself in any of the papers, like as a contextual footnote or something! Go crazy lol!). Thanks!

[197] A historical analogy fixes the register of this dissolution, and I mean it exactly rather than decoratively. Before negative numbers were admitted, the quadratic equation came in six separate case-forms — al-Khwarizmi's six chapters, squares equal roots, squares equal numbers, and so on — each solved by its own rule, because with coefficients confined to the positives the single general formula could not even be written. The classical causal triad has, on the present diagnosis, exactly that status: not three fundamental modes of production but case-splitting forced by a missing primitive, and the extrusion principle *is* the negative numbers. Once the primitive arrives, the cases do not get unified so much as exposed as artifacts of its absence — and, as with the negatives, everything downstream looks different under the completed system, the classical content most of all.

the structural face here and the representational face there.

The diagnosis of the classical paradigm's lossiness is then ontological rather than technical, and deserves stating baldly. The classical picture insists on Aristotelean-like categories for cause — efficient-cause slots demanding a privileged producer, kinds imposed on events, an arrow riding the imposition — and these are category-shaped demands placed on a universe that is not category-shaped. In the Aethic sense they melt away into attribute-invalidity jointness material plus Aethic pruning: what the categories were tracking was never a productive relation between events at all, but the pattern of joint standing and its enforcement, misread through a schema built for the special case of near-deterministic macroscopic regularity. The replacement is hardwired to a probabilistic universe rather than to the lossy human causality paradigm: the coupling is native to weighted superpositions — the weight rides the reduced form, the jointness fires pocket by pocket — whereas the folk schema exports from its deterministic home badly, and the Bell correlations are simply the export failing loudly enough to be measured. Correlation, causation, and the coupling thus stand in one exact relation: correlation is the mixture-level averaging projection, lossy by construction; "causation" is the folk name for the projection's imagined producer; and the reduced form coupling is the structure that was actually there — the answer, offered as a structural realization, to the question the Spekkens program asks.

9.9.1 The Criterion in the Concrete: Binding Modes and the Decision-Theoretic Vise

The dissolution thesis above risks sounding like metaphysics floating free of consequence, so let it be cashed out at the one place in the literature where the classical triad has been made to do fifty years of unbroken work: classical decision theory, whose two most famous cases were engineered as a vise around exactly the triad's joints. In Newcomb's problem [146], a near-perfect predictor has already placed a million in an opaque box iff it predicted the agent would take that box alone, a visible thousand sitting beside it either way. In the smoking-lesion case [104], a gene causes cancer and, independently, a taste for smoking; smoking itself is causally inert; the agent enjoys smoking. The vise: evidential reasoning one-boxes Newcomb but abstains from smoking, a famous bullet; causal reasoning smokes but two-boxes, the other bullet; the desirable combination — one-box *and* smoke — is precisely what neither uniform mode delivers. Add transparent Newcomb, both boxes visible before the choice, and the target verdicts are three: one-box, smoke, two-box. In one shared model, the predictor targeting the agent's policy upon seeing the box full and erring with probability ε, functional decision theory one-boxes on a full box for every ε below $(M-t)/(2M-t)$ while the settling rule two-boxes for every $\varepsilon > 0$ and one-boxes only at $\varepsilon = 0$; the rules differ in what the counterfactual holds fixed, the settling rule holding the observed contents fixed and functional decision theory varying the decision-function output with its predictive dependencies, which in the framework's terms is an evaluation at two different Aethae but is a difference of procedure and not of information alone.

The binding criterion. The sorting the framework supplies never mentions an arrow. Say a stated coupling involving an act *binds on that act's settling* exactly when it is stated as robust to the mode by which the act is produced — holding whether the act issues from deliberation, habit, or a randomizing device — while a coupling not so stated binds only through its mediating attributes.[198] The rest is bookkeeping over joint invalidities. Settling an act multiplies it into the Aethus; a blank attribute's marginal weight moves only through entries that render act-pockets and that attribute's pockets jointly invalid; a non-robust entry's tie to the act was conditional on the act's mode of production, and settling *is* a mode, so under settling the entry detaches and constrains only through its mediators, which, once stated, screen it; and the mixture-level correlation, being an averaging projection over the pockets the primitive entries define, contributes no joint invalidity of its own and cannot move a within-pocket marginal. Where every primitive path from the act is blocked (a *primitive path*: a chain of primitive entries, consecutive entries sharing an attribute family; *blocked*: traversing a determinate state), distributing into pockets before evaluating loses nothing, and within-pocket dominance is valid — the classical dominance argument's domain *derived*, boundary included, rather than presupposed. Two precisions are owed here as well, because the statement above is easy to read one notch too strong. The invariance that licenses dominance is invariance of the *joint* law over the payoff-relevant blanks,

[198] *2026-09-25*

Oh also note that my explicit intuition behind the ac robustness thing itself is that "decided" is way too much of a human construct to be generally well-defined using Aethae, so "so and so DECIDED to press the button" is void in well-definedness, but "so and so pressed the button" and "so and so has the neurological makeup consistent with those who press the button" ARE well-defined. Hence, how I knew instinctively not to reach for the circularity that naively seems to trigger the paradox.

not of their marginals: settling can leave every marginal unmoved while changing their correlation, and a utility on the joint configuration then changes in expectation, so marginal invariance suffices only for additively separable utility. And the "where every path is blocked" is one direction of an implication, not an equivalence: blocked paths give invariance, and non-invariance gives an unblocked path, and the result has an algebraic form: given the specified evaluation laws, equality of the settled laws across acts is equivalent to proportionality of their unnormalized forms and is what the dominance argument consumes, while the graphical reading of that equality off binding paths is a proposal whose general sufficiency, requiring *binding faithfulness* among other things, is left open and is assumed under that name where it is used; two unblocked couplings of opposite sense can leave the law where it was. The binding modes themselves, the annotation of which couplings survive which modes of act-production, are structural information supplied with the problem, as a causal model's edges are, and not derived.

Three verdicts, one result, no arrow. Newcomb's accuracy entry is stipulated to hold even against a randomizing agent — act-robust by the problem's own construction — so it is pocket-defining: no prediction-pockets exist independently of the act, dominance is unavailable, whole-residue comparison governs, and the verdict is one-box. The lesion's population correlation is not primitive: the vignette stipulates a common cause and only a common cause, so the gene reaches the act solely through the desire, and nothing states the desire–act propensity as surviving deliberate settling; the pockets are (gene, desire)-pockets with the act free inside them, dominance governs, and the verdict is smoke (the introspection-bypass variant reaching the same verdict through the metatickle screen, on the mild resolve-luminosity premise) — with the tickle defense [103] recovered from stated content rather than introspection, since a desire already stated has already done its updating, and a desire being settled-from is a desire manifesting as stated content along the way. Transparent Newcomb states the outcome outright; with positive predictor error every path is trivially blocked and two-boxing follows by dominance, while at the perfect endpoint the act jointly invalid with the retained accuracy constraint is inadmissible and one-boxing is the only admissible act, by the admissibility rule; and in every case the settling rule, branch-conditional accuracy retained where robust, is specified and motivated by act-robustness rather than entailed by indexed determinacy. Three verdicts from one criterion, and at no point was "the act causes," "the outcome causes," or "a common cause produces" consulted: the triad did no work at the heart of the very field that was built on it. One case is booked corpus-wide as the criterion's standing open stress test rather than adjudicated: the Egan psychopath-button family [158], whose disposition-coupling is mediator-type where statable while its luminosity entanglement stresses the resolve premise itself — recorded open.

9.9.2 The Settling Rule, Stated: Operator, Invariance, Classification, and the Endpoint Law

The verdicts above are consequences of one specified settling rule, and the rule is stated here in full, with its operator, the invariance it consumes, the classification it yields, and the endpoint law that decides Egan's case.

Principle 33 (The settling rule, with admissibility)
For an agent with Aethus A and candidate acts a, the value of a is the expectation of the payoff over the state $\mathrm{settle}(a)$ *obtained by settling a in A by the operator below, and the chosen act is the argmax over the* admissible *acts, those whose settled state is valid; an act jointly invalid with a retained constraint is inadmissible, and where every act is inadmissible the rule returns no verdict. Observer-indexed determinacy motivates the rule and the framework adopts it as its evaluation policy; it is not derived from the indexing alone.*

Definition 42 (The settling operator)
Each primitive entry of A carries input and output roles, supplied with the state, and each coupling that has the act among its inputs carries a mode set $m(e)$, the modes of act-production under which it binds; a coupling is a normalized kernel of its outputs given its inputs. Settling the act a in mode μ, deliberation for the agents here, replaces every production entry of the act by the settled value; retains unchanged every coupling with $\mu \in m(e)$; replaces the block of couplings with $\mu \notin m(e)$ jointly by its kernel from the act's production inputs, $K(\cdot \mid \mathrm{pa}(C)) = \sum_c P(c \mid \mathrm{pa}(C)) \prod_e f_e(\cdot \mid c)$, the block's factors with the act integrated out under its own production law given its inputs, which carries no dependence on the settled value and preserves both the dependence the shared act induces among the block's outputs and the block's dependence on the act's inputs; and renormalizes over the retained

factors. Replacing the couplings one at a time, or detaching under the act's unconditional law, does not preserve those dependences, and both are withdrawn.

Lemma 4 (Across-act invariance from factorization)
Let Y collect the payoff-relevant blank attributes and $\widetilde{Q}_a(y)$ the unnormalized law of Y after a is settled, the stated evidence incorporated and the auxiliary attributes marginalized. If $\widetilde{Q}_a(y) = k_a\, h(y)$ for every admissible a, with $k_a > 0$ and $0 < \sum_y h(y) < \infty$, then $Q_a(y) = h(y)/\sum_{y'} h(y')$ for every admissible a. Conversely, if $Q_a = Q$ for every admissible a and every normalizer is positive and finite, then $\widetilde{Q}_a = k_a h$ with $h = Q$. Proportionality of the unnormalized settled laws and equality of the settled laws are equivalent.

Proof
Normalization divides $\widetilde{Q}_a$ by $k_a \sum h$, and k_a cancels; for the converse, $\widetilde{Q}_a(y) = \big(\sum_{y'} \widetilde{Q}_a(y')\big)\, Q(y)$.

Proposition 27 (Dominance transfer)
Under the hypothesis of Lemma 4, with Q the common settled law, $u(a, y) \geq u(b, y)$ for every y gives $\sum_y Q(y)\, u(a, y) \geq \sum_y Q(y)\, u(b, y)$, strictly where the pointwise inequality is strict on positive Q-mass.

The graphical reading of the factorization is a proposal: with $\mathcal{B}_a(Y)$ the binding paths from the act to Y, counted over mode-binding entries and blocked by stated attributes carrying their full content, the criterion proposed is that blocked paths give the factorization, the settled value entering $\widetilde{Q}_a$ only through retained binding couplings whose surviving act-dependent contribution, after evidence and marginalization, is independent of y. Statedness of a binding output does not supply that by itself: with C and Y independent fair bits and $P(M = 1 \mid C, Y) = 0.9$ where $C = Y$ and 0.1 otherwise, stating $M = 1$ leaves a likelihood in both, and $Q_1(Y = 1) = 0.9$ against $Q_0(Y = 1) = 0.1$. The criterion's general sufficiency is open, and preservation of the original law, $Q_a(Y) = P_A(Y)$, is not claimed at all; what the dominance argument needs is the across-act equality, and that is what the lemma gives.

Theorem 11 (Decision classification: two regimes)
For an agent settling in the deliberative mode, with the evaluation laws obtained: (a) if the settled laws of the payoff-relevant attributes are equal across the admissible acts, the factorization of Lemma 4 holds and pointwise dominance applies by Proposition 27; (b) if they differ, the whole-residue evaluation of Principle 33 is required and dominance is not guaranteed, the difference being established on the complete marginalized product; (c) a stated screening attribute M with the settled family factorizing as $\widetilde{Q}_a(y, m) \propto f(a, m)\, g(y, m)$ is one sufficient route to (a). The theorem is an algebraic classification once the evaluation laws are obtained; a proved graphical procedure determining those laws from binding paths is not supplied. The benchmarks: in Newcomb the settled laws of the prize differ, $(0.99, 0.01)$ over full and empty under one-boxing against $(0.01, 0.99)$ under two-boxing, case (b), one-box; in the lesion, under $A \perp L \mid R$ and the luminosity premise, $Q_{\text{smoke}}(L) = Q_{\text{refrain}}(L) = P(L \mid R = r)$, case (c), smoke; in transparent Newcomb with the prize stated and positive error, the settled laws of the remaining blanks coincide, case (a), two-box. That last verdict carries a cost, stated rather than hidden: an agent known to two-box on a full box is less often shown one, so against policy-level one-boxing the rule loses ex ante. It accepts the cost because it evaluates each act at the information state the agent occupies, with what has been read held fixed; settled before the observation, at the state in which the contents are open, the same rule recommends the one-boxing policy, so its disagreement with policy-level rivals is over the information state an act is evaluated from. The binding assignments are likewise part of the argument rather than implementation details: the model stipulates that the predictor's branch-conditional accuracy law remains binding under deliberative settling, a stipulation the accuracy alone does not prove, defended instead as a reading of the problem.

Proposition 28 (Egan's case, at the endpoint)
Let pressing be worth B against refraining and carry a loss D if the agent has the trait, and let q_1 be the trait's weight within the status-type that presses. Under two stated premises, (J1) that an actual completed act agrees with its terminal resolve, and (J2) that once the terminal resolve is specified the current lean and any retained information carry no further information about the trait, the endpoint value of pressing is $V(\text{press}) = B - (B + D)\, q_1$, and refraining wins exactly when $q_1 > q_c := B/(B + D)$. The verdict is pure, with no interior equilibrium, because the trait is coupled to the status-type and not to a moving lean; (J1) does not by itself deliver (J2), ordinary conditioning on the terminal resolve leaving a dependence on the lean in general, and a comparison policy that evaluates pressing at a partial resolve can have an interior equilibrium, which (J1) does not rule out.

The relata of the feedback account. The Aethic challenge to the feedback account concerns the identity of its relata: does the trait probability belong to the agent's current deliberative state, or to the status-type obtained by settling the candidate act? The settling rule evaluates the latter; substituting the former changes the evaluation being performed. Two calibrations keep that challenge at its size. The feedback model is not thereby mathematically undefined, its dynamics being constructible; the objection is that its conditioning and evaluation attach the trait distribution of the current deliberative state to a completed candidate act, which a rival may retain by defending that pairing as its evaluation policy. And the endpoint trait law is a commitment in its own right: identifying pressing with the terminal resolve does not alone establish that the trait distribution becomes q_1 independent of retained information, which is why the law is argued and entered as an assumption rather than folded into well-definedness. What is claimed is that Aethic indexing makes this dependency explicit and central, and the particular answer it gives about which objects and indices belong in the evaluation; not that other mathematical frameworks cannot formulate the question.

Proposition 29 (The transparent sort)
With the prize stated and positive predictor error, every mismatch pocket carrying positive weight by branch-specific support, two-boxing is admissible and dominates: two-box. At the perfect endpoint the mismatch pocket is invalid and the admissibility rule governs: one-boxing is the only admissible act with the million visible, and two-boxing the only admissible act with the opaque box empty; the discontinuity at zero error is owned.

Proposition 30 (The shared transparent-predictor model)
Let the predictor target the agent's policy upon seeing box B full, err with probability ε independently, and fill B iff its prediction is one-box, the agent seeing B before acting. Functional decision theory, evaluating the policy at the state before the observation, sets one-box on full iff $(1-\varepsilon)M+\varepsilon t > (1-\varepsilon)t+\varepsilon(M+t)$, i.e. iff $\varepsilon < (M-t)/(2M-t)$; the settling rule, evaluating at the state after it, two-boxes on a full box for every $\varepsilon > 0$ and one-boxes only at $\varepsilon = 0$; both two-box on an empty box. The two part on a full box for every $0 < \varepsilon < (M-t)/(2M-t)$, and the rules differ in how observed content constrains the counterfactual: the settling rule holds the observed contents fixed, functional decision theory varies the decision-function output together with its predictive dependencies, the observation determining which decision-function variable is intervened on; the two evaluations are evaluations of two different Aethae, and the difference is one of procedure, not of information alone. Ex ante, the one-box policy earns $(1-\varepsilon)M+\varepsilon t$ against $(1-\varepsilon)t+\varepsilon(M+t)$ for the two-box policy, which records the cost of the settling rule's choice; the rule's reply is the indexing, that an evaluation at the earlier state treats as open what has been realized. The tradeoff is the criterion's stated commitment: the rule's full-box verdict changes between exact prediction, where one-boxing is the only admissible act, and any positive error rate, where the two-box pocket is admissible, and the ex-ante returns differ sharply; the criterion accepts this because its standpoint for the act is the settled Aethus the deliberating agent occupies, the ex-ante return being that of a policy fixed at an earlier Aethus, a standpoint it declines for the act, and that normative choice, settled evaluation over policy evaluation, is one indexed determinacy does not make and the proposal must defend.

9.9.3 Robustness Is Not Causation, and What the Dissolution Leaves Behind

The objection the criterion invites is that act-robustness is the causal arrow rebuilt and relabeled. Newcomb itself is the existence proof to the contrary: the accuracy entry is act-robust while no act-to-prediction causation exists or is wanted — the prediction is settled before the act on any classical telling — so robustness and causation come apart in the founding case, and they come apart in the direction that matters, the criterion one-boxing exactly where every causal-arrow criterion two-boxes. Robustness is a fact about which stated couplings survive which conditionings — semantic-mining material, jointness material — not a fact about production. A second exhibit makes the separation visible where Newcomb's leaves a common-cause reply open. Take two physically separate instantiations of one deterministic procedure — the same algorithm run on silicon here and worked out with pen and paper there. Their outputs are perfectly correlated; the correlation is robust to how each instantiation is produced, surviving any intervention on substrate, timing, or location; and there is no causal arrow in either direction, neither run being upstream of the other and no common cause screening the correlation off, since the dependence is a fact about the procedure rather than about any channel between the runs. Act-robustness registers that coupling and causal dependence does not. Two concessions keep the claim exact. Across the cases the corpus treats, act-robustness and the functional or subjunctive dependence of the timeless decision theories are largely *coextensive*, sorting Newcomb, the lesion, and

the transparent variant alike, so no verdict turns on separating them. What differs is the ground: functional dependence is read off a shared computation and so requires the predictor to be simulating the agent's procedure, where act-robustness is read off the stated content of an indexed Aethus and asks only whether the coupling's relatum is an attribute on the books. That is the weaker demand, and it is why the criterion applies to a predictor whose method is unspecified; a reader who holds that all such couplings ultimately reduce to functional dependence may take the criterion as an operational test for it and lose nothing the corpus uses.

And the dissolution is not a nihilism about dependence, because everything the triad was employed to do is still done, by named machinery, with the producer slot simply left empty. Correlation remains, as the mixture-level projection; the reduced form coupling remains, as the ordering-indifferent absolute; binding modes remain, as the decision-facing grade of the coupling, sorting live cases; and the dominance argument remains, valid on a derived domain instead of a presupposed one. Set beside the quadratic history of the footnote above, the mapping is exact rather than ornamental: causal and evidential decision theory are the case-split — each rule correct on the cases its missing primitive happened to fit, each committed to a uniform evaluation mode because the primitive that sorts modes was not yet on the table — and the binding structure of stated couplings is that primitive. With it, the case-forms do not get adjudicated; they get dissolved into a single bookkeeping over who invalidates whom in which residue pocket, which was this subsection's thesis in its most concrete possible instance.

The Stated-Relata Principle, and the ground beneath the criterion. The criterion above rests on one discipline, the *Stated-Relata Principle*: the requirement that conditioning be on well-defined, stated attributes, applied to couplings. Couplings can attach only to *stated attributes* on indexed books — those are the only relata the framework has — so any argument whose force requires attachment elsewhere, to a mental-layer object, a narration, a folk referent, is not wrong about its attribute but *ill-addressed*, citing a relatum the framework's books do not carry. The lesion case is the exhibit at full sharpness. "I smoked" is a perfectly formed stated attribute; what the classical argument needs is a different object — "I smoked, *in the sense that carries the lesion's evidential charge*": the act as psychological symptom — and that object is no attribute at all, the coupling's genuine relatum being the *inclination*, Aethic information *about* the mental layer rather than a dependency on it. The argument cites an attribute that exists while gesturing at an association that a probabilistic model can represent but that does not survive the specified settlement operation and carries no authority over the act's evaluation, and its force lives in the conflation — the error-shape the operational analysis of simultaneity exposed: a term used as if it named a frame-free relation, while every use that did work referred to the frame-relative one. Production-mode robustness, the property of binding under every mode of act-production, is then the principle's *shadow test*: perturbing how an act is produced varies exactly the component that was never an attribute, so a verdict that fails the perturbation had no latch. The test is a diagnostic and not a second principle, and it is stronger than any verdict needs: placement under the stated mode of act-production already selects the couplings that bind, so a coupling binding under deliberation is retained for a deliberating agent whether or not it would survive a randomizer.

Two consequences, at headline grade.

- Ahmed's past-bet: the past microstate is blank on the agent's books and coupled to the act at entailment grade, so the "fixed past" case runs as ordinary act-dependence, tense-free blankness leaving the pastness no work at all.
- And Egan's button: the lesion with its *exogenous* mediator — the stated taste, fixed while deliberation runs over it — exchanged for an *endogenous* one, the resolve, identical with the settling's own grade[199]; the screen holds pointwise at every resolve while no deliberation-independent value exists to condition on once for all, the verdict is the static comparison at

[199] *2026-09-25*

Ok cool and actually believe it or not "resolve" for the decision is actually the original thing I assessed as Aethically well defined and attached the argument to for the smoking lesion case! So therefore maybe the long paper should be explicit that THAT is the stand in for the decision's causal placement, if not there already? Thanks!

Also unfortunately I still don't know exactly what you mean by "static rule"! I follow though what you said about how resolving not to press makes you probably not a psychopath, in which case pressing now weirdly becomes preferable anyway, against how pressing means you probably are! I mean what I can say though is that my instinct on this is that it's fully a joint causal game, in that Aethic joint multiplication combines the two parts so that resolve to press x you're a psycho has far more weight than resolve to press x you're not a psycho, just based on the normal game of Aethic weights. Also the key is that Aethically you don't pick up new information (to jump to the next Aethus) until you pick up more information, so when you resolve and say "oh but pressing would look good" then physically pressing so as to pick up that information means you clearly didn't resolve for not anyway! So it's not philosophical, it's

the acts' own resolves, which the settling map reaches at its boundary, an interior fixed point arising only on the map that lets act and resolve come apart; ratifiability is thereby *recovered*, on that map, as the tickle run at a moving index to coherence. The fixed point is now a theorem rather than an intuitive equilibrium, and its conditions matter. With payoffs $-D$ for pressing as a psychopath, B for pressing as not, 0 for refraining, and a continuous strictly increasing coupling $q(r)$ from resolve to credence in the trait, the settling map $\dot{r} = B - (B + D)\, q(r)$ has exactly one fixed point in $[0, 1]$, globally attracting: at $r = 0$ if the baseline $q(0)$ already exceeds $q_c = B/(B + D)$; interior at $q^{-1}(q_c)$ if $q(0) < q_c < q(1)$; at $r = 1$ if $q(1) \leq q_c$—uniqueness and stability following from the map's strict monotonicity in r. The interior case is therefore *conditional* on the baseline credence sitting below the stakes threshold, and at Egan's stated stakes, death against a public good, q_c is near zero, so any nonzero baseline puts the case in the first regime, where pure refrain is itself the fixed point; the verdict is refrain either way, outright or as the limit the interior point approaches as D/B grows. The derivation, with its three regimes worked and the dynamics verified to converge to the predicted point in each, is the derivation that replaced the assertion that neither pure act is ratifiable—which holds only in the interior regime—with the theorem that says when it does.[200]

The joint state of Egan's case, with its weights. The question sets up four attributes: the resolve R, the agent's total mental makeup as regards the choice; the trait P, psychopath or not; the act A, press or refrain; and the button K, whether it kills the psychopaths. The couplings are jointness: the trait is weighted against the resolve by conditional probability, $q(1) = q_1$ at full resolve to press and $q(0) = q_0$ at full resolve to refrain; an act opposite to the resolve is a tagged combination, since pressing shows the resolve was to press; and a button that does not kill is tagged, being the question's own stipulation. With r the weight of the resolve to press, the valid pockets are these:

Resolve	Act	Trait	Button	Weight	Payoff
press	press	psychopath	kills	$r\, q_1$	$-D$
press	press	not	kills	$r\,(1 - q_1)$	B
refrain	refrain	psychopath	kills	$(1 - r)\, q_0$	0
refrain	refrain	not	kills	$(1 - r)\,(1 - q_0)$	0
tagged: any act opposite to its resolve; any button that does not kill					

Read through the pockets, pressing is realized only where the resolve is to press, so its worth is $B(1 - q_1) - D\, q_1$ at every r, and refraining is worth 0: the comparison is between the acts at their own resolves, and refrain wins whenever $q_1 > q_c$. This is the jointness reading of the note above. The settling map evaluates pressing at a partial resolve, with $q(r)$ in place of q_1, which on the jointness reading has no valid pocket behind it, act and resolve not coming apart; the map is then needed only on a reading that lets them come apart, and its interior fixed point describes deliberation only there. The two readings agree on the verdict, refrain, and differ on whether an interior fixed point represents anything. The weights are symbolic because the inputs are not yet measured: q_0 is the prevalence of the trait, and q_1, the trait's frequency among those resolved to press, is what the vignette leaves to be supplied; illustrative values $q_0 = 0.02$, $q_1 = 0.5$, $B = 1$, $D = 9$ and $r = 0.3$ give pocket weights 0.15, 0.15, 0.014 and 0.686, and pressing's worth -4. Causality here is nothing beyond the relation structure of invalidity: the exact couplings are the tagged combinations, and an approximate coupling would be a small nonzero weight where a tag now stands.

just jointness--resolve not to press x you're a psycho and resolve not to press x you're not a psycho itself has the weights that conditional probability would declare, so yeah quite frankly if you think we have the statistical numbers for each already I would love to literally write in the weights for your Aethic superposition coming into this in-paper--the idea is that the "resolve" part is your total mental makeup in the sense of your choice to hit the button, the is psycho-attribute is how much this aligns probabilistically with being a psycho or not, and then technically if you wanted the total feedback of the question itself, you would multiply the third and fourth attribute, being "do you press the button or not" versus "does the button actually kill all the psychopaths or not" respectively, for which the framing of the question itself assumes opposite resolve and pressing attribute states is invalid (whereas for an alternative question you could mix it up to maybe have those who resolve to press actually have the wrong button swapped out for it or something, in which my split is as I have it because that shouldn't actually change the invalidity-causal psychopath jointness makeup) and the state "button doesn't actually kill psychopaths" is considered invalid. Hence the key about how causality itself actually merely boils down to relation structure pertaining to invalidity, with pure causality being zero or invalid weights for certain ones, and phenomenological approximate causality being very small nonzero weights for certain ones. Thanks!

[200] The derivation was carried out by Fable on September 18, 2026.

The audit, transported. The audit transports past decision theory unchanged: the similarity ordering failed to latch on total worlds, (Section 9.1); causal direction fails to latch on the constraint layer, (Section 5.2.2); the Bell hidden-valuation fails to latch on any four-way stated intersection; and the folk "world" of the grammar's convention, (Section 12.1.3), with the psychaethus's delivered terminal point, (Section 12.1.4), is the same audit at the species scale. One question — *where does this latch?* — and the classical constructs sort themselves.

9.9.4 Deriving Reichenbach's Principle, and Locating Its Boundary

The situating paragraph above claimed that Reichenbach's mathematics survives as a theorem; this subsubsection makes good on the claim in full: it derives the principle whole, demand, disjunction and certificate, from the multiplicative composition of entries, and then locates, from the same premises, the boundary at which the quantum correlations exit the certificate: a boundary that is a theorem on the Bell-violating side, where the reductio obstructs any noncontextual, measurement-independent pocketing, and a removed obstruction on the Bell-bounded side, where Fine's converse supplies a joint distribution on the standard scenario without yet establishing the full pocket representation across refinements.

Work first in the classical regime: every alternative-set in play stands in disagreeing superposition, so that pockets are well defined — mutually exclusive, jointly exhaustive, one realized. Two precisions before the derivation, both native to the framework rather than imported for the occasion. First, the machinery has two layers: entries are joint *couplings*, whose structure of joint invalidity fixes which combinations of alternatives can stand together and whose weights grade the combinations it admits, outright invalidity being that structural layer and not a limit of the weights. Second, entries compose multiplicatively — the state is a string of multiplied Aethae, each update a factor — so a body of jointness material is a product of entry-factors over the attribute families it touches.

Now let attributes A and B be correlated at the mixture level, and define the two horns *behaviorally*: the arrangement is *mediated* when there exists a third family C — elementary or compound, a set of families disjoint from A and B, conditioned jointly — such that conditioning on C screens, A and B detaching within every C-pocket; and *direct* when no such family exists, so that for every third family, elementary or compound and disjoint from A and B, some within-pocket dependence survives its conditioning. The direct horn is the literal negation of the mediated horn, the disjunction exhaustive by construction, and the factorization below holds verbatim with C compound.

The theorem: which jointness realizes which horn. The substantive theorem is then which jointness realizes which horn, and for pairwise-composed material it is one displayed line. Suppose every entry touching the triple factors pairwise, $W(a,b,c) = f(a,c)\,g(b,c)$ up to single-family factors; then

$$W(a,b \mid c) \;\propto\; f(a,c)\,g(b,c), \tag{57}$$

a product of an a-function and a b-function at fixed c — conditional independence. That is screening-off, *derived*: Reichenbach's certificate is the factorization signature of pairwise-composed jointness.

The factorization needs its entries to compose pairwise through one family. The general case needs nothing beyond the multiplicative composition of entries stated above: a state is a product of entry-factors, and a product carries a separation structure. A *chain* from A to B is a sequence of families beginning at A and ending at B, each consecutive pair touched by a common entry; a family C, disjoint from A and B, *separates* them when every chain from A to B passes through a member of C. A state can be written as a product of entries in more than one way, since entries can be merged, and each writing is a *presentation.*

Theorem 12 (The screening structure of Reichenbach's principle)
Let a state in disagreeing superposition be presented as a product of entries, and let A and B be correlated at the mixture level.

(i) Demand. *A chain of entries joins A and B.*

(ii) Disjunction. *Either some entry touches both A and B, or the families other than A that share an entry with A form a family N_A that separates A from B.*

(iii) Certificate. *Every family that separates A from B screens them. A family C screens A from B exactly when the (A,B,C)-marginal of the state composes pairwise through C, $W(a,b,c) = f(a,c)\,g(b,c)$.*

(iv) Fork. *Every family C that screens A from B is correlated with A and with B, and carries their whole covariance: for all functions ϕ of A and ψ of B, $\mathrm{Cov}(\phi, \psi) = \mathrm{Cov}\big(\mathbb{E}[\phi \mid C], \mathbb{E}[\psi \mid C]\big)$. When A, B and C are binary this is $\mathrm{Cov}(A, B) = P(c)\,P(\bar{c})\,\Delta_A \Delta_B$, with $\Delta_A = P(a \mid c) - P(a \mid \bar{c})$ and Δ_B likewise, so that a positive correlation forces Reichenbach's fork inequalities once C is labeled to raise A.*

Parts (i)–(iii) hold in every presentation of the state. In particular, an unscreenable correlation has an entry touching both correlates in every presentation.

Proof
(i) If no chain joins A and B, every entry touches only families reachable from A or only families that are not, so the weight is a product of a factor in the first families and a factor in the second, B among them; A and B are then independent, against the hypothesis. (ii) If no entry touches both, a chain from A leaves A through an entry that does not touch B, and so enters a family of N_A. (iii) Let C separate A from B, and let S be the families reachable from A by chains avoiding C. No entry touches both a family of S and a family outside S and C, so the weight is a product of a factor in S and C and a factor in the remaining families and C. At each value of C the two factors are functions of disjoint families, which is conditional independence of S, and so of A, from B. For the equivalence, screening gives $W(a, b, c) = W(a, c)\,W(b, c)/W(c)$ at every c of positive weight, which is pairwise composition, and pairwise composition gives screening by the factorization above. (iv) If C were independent of A, then $A \perp B \mid C$ and $A \perp C$ would give $A \perp B$, against the hypothesis; likewise for B. The covariance identity is the law of total covariance with its within-pocket term zero, and for binary C it reduces to the displayed product. The last claim is (ii) and (iii) read in every presentation.

Theorem 12 gives the statistical screening structure associated with Reichenbach's principle. A separator screens and carries the covariance, but the theorem does not show that it is a prior common cause, nor exclude a common effect; that reading needs the supplied mechanism input structure, which acquisition order does not provide. And since any joint law can be presented as one factor touching every variable, the demand for a chain has force only relative to a presentation whose factors are the state's stated entries. Its demand is (i): a correlation is never free-standing but is carried by a chain of joint couplings between its correlates. Its disjunction is (ii), and is no longer settled by how the horns were defined, since it gives each horn a structural sufficient condition one way: a separating family screens, and an unscreenable correlation has a coupling touching both correlates in every presentation. The converse, that a coupling touching both makes the correlation unscreenable, does not hold, the $A = B = C$ example being screened by C with an A–B factor present, so the graphical alternatives are not an exact realization of the behavioral horns and overlap on the screenable side. Its certificate is (iii), together with the converse the behavioral definition left open, that an unscreenable correlation is directly coupled in every presentation of the state. And (iv) returns the fork conditions as consequences rather than stipulations: the screener is correlated with both correlates, and the whole correlation passes through it. The steps from product form to screening are the Markov properties of factorized distributions, standard in the graphical-models literature [159]. What is new is where the product form comes from. A causal model posits it, reading it off a graph drawn in advance; here it is the multiplicative update of the state, so the principle is derived from how information states compose and presupposes no arrow. The theorem was checked in exact arithmetic over 1,500 random product-form states on three to five families, with zero weights for joint invalidity and a merged presentation of each: 4,208 correlated pairs, 3,692 separating families and 2,908 screeners, without exception to any part.

The direct horn, and the higher-arity cases. A direct factor $h(a, b)$ that no choice of the other factors can absorb survives conditioning on C intact, so that C does not screen; the direct horn needs this for every candidate family, since it quantifies over all of them. A factor that merely appears in one factorization settles nothing: with $A = B = C$ one fair bit, the weight can be written with $h(a, b) = \mathbf{1}[a = b]$, yet conditioning on C screens, both variables being determinate within each pocket. Mixtures sort themselves once that quantifier is discharged. The smoking-lesion entry of the coupling catalog (subsubsection 6.6.2) is this clause's homely double instance: the lesion screens smoking from cancer, and the stated desire screens the act from the lesion — the certificate twice over in one vignette, with the tickle defense being Reichenbach's certificate applied at the mediator — a common-cause framing the tickle literature itself carries [103], the derivation of the certificate and the double count being what is new here — a decided pocket leaving the interpolation over proper children nothing further to sway. Irreducible higher-arity entries fall where the behavioral definition puts them, and the placement is instructive rather than embarrassing. A parity-style constraint binding (a, b, c) triples jointly — under which conditioning on C forces a direct A–B law inside every pocket — is topologically

"mediated" but behaviorally direct, and its folk narration gives the game away: "C modulates the A–B law" is the triad audibly straining, a producer story stretched over material that was never pairwise, which strengthens the dissolution thesis. Two cautions keep the example to its size. Under the uniform weighting A and B are independent before conditioning, so the case is not one of correlation awaiting a screener; and the pattern is the classical collider $A \to C \leftarrow B$, which a causal model represents formally, the strain lying in the folk narration rather than in the model. What the example shows is that topological mediation and behavioral screening come apart. And the folk recovery is completed rather than merely sampled: the direct horn admits the two orderly tellings — "A causes B," "B causes A" — while the mediated horn admits three, "C causes both" together with the two chain tellings, "A causes B via C" and its reverse, all sharing the one screening signature; five narrations, two arrangements, one certificate.

The principle as a theorem. The statistical screening structure associated with Reichenbach's principle, its demand and its certificate in their statistical form, is thereby a theorem of the reduced-form coupling in the disagreeing regime (Theorem 12), not an independent posit; a separator carrying the covariance is not thereby shown to be a prior common cause.

The derivation just given quantifies over pockets, and that is its boundary. In the agreeing regime the alternatives of an agreeing superposition co-obtain rather than exclude, so the conditioning has no admissible grounding pockets to condition on, and the interference the co-obtaining licenses is precisely the phenomenon the classical arrangement cannot host. A correlation grounded at the agreeing grade — the Bell correlations being the standing example, the entangled state an agreeing superposition across the two sites (subsubsection 10.3.2) — therefore satisfies the framework's demand in full, being grounded in jointness as ever, while escaping the mediated arrangement's certificate: no C-pockets of the classical, noncontextual, measurement-independent kind exist in the present representation whose conditioning would screen it *with local responses*, each wing's outcome depending on its own setting and C alone, the Bell-local kind that Fine's equivalence ties to the CHSH bound—mere screening by a setting-independent variable is weaker and is not excluded, a variable copying one wing's outcome screening the pair while the other wing's response reads the far setting, at CHSH value $2\sqrt{2}$ (the causality extraction's instance)—and no fine-tuning is needed to protect the escape, because the escape is structural rather than parametric—there being no causal-path parameter whose observable influence must be delicately cancelled, though the structure carries graded weights and couplings as parameters in the ordinary sense. Two sentences make the structure of the escape overt. The levels are distinct: the *outcome statistics* are pocketed — stated records, over which conditional independences can be asked and answered classically — while the escape lives at the *grounding* level, where the entangled state is agreeing-grade and no enlargement of the screener family satisfying the specified global valuation assumptions reproduces the statistics. And structural-not-parametric has a standing exhibit inside this paper: the bilayer treatment (subsubsection 12.4.11), on which no-signaling holds structurally and without conspiracy — the very independence a classical causal model must fine-tune to secure, obtained here as architecture rather than cancellation. And what a *setting choice* is — an act attribute, blank until settled, its freedom the question of which stated couplings bind on its settling — is exactly the concrete subsubsection's territory (subsubsection 9.9.1); nothing in the escape turns on that internal deferral. This is the deviation the Spekkens program measures, explained by the very premise that yields the screening structure: the coupling holds in both regimes; the statistical screening structure associated with Reichenbach's principle is its disagreeing-regime specialization; the Bell correlations are its agreeing-regime face.

Which places the bow on the quadratic analogy of the footnote above, and the tie is meant exactly. The triad and its screening certificate are the positive-coefficient arithmetic: complete, correct, and exhaustive within their regime, as al-Khwarizmi's six case-forms were within theirs. The agreeing regime is the domain where the missing primitive stops being optional — the negative numbers — and the celebrated strangeness of the Bell correlations, the fine-tuning that classical causal models demand of them, is the exact signature of case-form arithmetic run outside its regime: a six-forms geometer meeting a negative root and calling it a conspiracy. The derivation above says what it is instead: the one formula, met past the boundary the case-forms were quietly drawn inside.

10 Aethic Quantum Mechanics in Cases

10.1 Specific Cases of Wavefunction Collapse

In the double-slit experiment, the switching from the interference pattern to the two-spotlight pattern is a direct example of the switching from agreeing to disagreeing Aethic superposition on the particle's slit of traversal attribute.

Regarding a wavefunction for which a single state is selected, this is and always was an act of simply removing possibilities from a disagreeing superposition, or in other words taking a child Aethus at random from that disagreeing superposition. For instance, if a particle is fired to a random ending location, at which place it is measured, then the particle exists in disagreeing superposition between hitting all possible measuring endpoints until a weighted random Aethus among them is selected upon adding such a result to the Aethus. The Aethus of the experimenter that corresponds to the landing point of the particle is necessarily a disagreeing superposition rather than an agreeing one of all the endpoints, because otherwise a contradiction would be set in motion by the third postulate. Specifically, implying the validity of an agreeing superposition child Aethus to the experimenter's Aethus would also imply, in that Aethus, that none of the targets were not reached. As such, we could generate a child Aethus to that for which one of the targets measures a result at itself, in the process adding the attribute that all others are not gone through to a further potential child Aethus. The second to last of these Aethae is a child Aethus to the experimenter, and the last is a child to that, so therefore the third postulate is broken on the experimenter's Aethus if there is even a hair of allowance for an agreeing superposition between measurable outcomes. As such, any measurable occurrence exists in strictly disagreeing superposition over its possible outcomes, including position if any kind of traceable interaction occurs there.

It goes without saying that humans also are always in a strictly disagreeing superposition, if at all, because they have the capacity to relay information.

10.2 Schrödinger's Cat

The classification, run. Schrödinger's cat [160] is the case the framework classifies fastest, and the classification is worth running slowly once, because it exhibits the whole distinction between the two kinds of superposition in a setting everyone already knows. Write the alternatives as the thought experiment writes them: the cat is alive, or the cat is dead. Then ask the one question the union principle asks of any *or*, (Section 2.4): what is written *inside* the alternatives? Does "alive" carry, in its own interior, the exclusion "and not dead"? For the cat it does, and it does so many times over, because the cat's alternatives come with records attached. The Geiger counter's state is a record that separates "decayed" from "not decayed." The hammer's position and the vial's integrity are records that separate "released" from "sealed." The cat's own body is a record of the poison—its physiology, its temperature, the chemistry of its blood—and the air in the box, the walls of the box, and the thermal state of everything in it carry that record outward. Each of these is a degree of freedom correlated with the outcome, and each is therefore, under the totality guard of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14), part of the detector configuration whether or not anyone built it as one. So the alternatives exclude each other from the inside: "alive" says "and not dead" because a hundred records say so. That is a *disagreeing* superposition—the walls between the alternatives are up—and its signature is exactly what the thought experiment finds so hard to accept about the alternative reading: no cross-interaction, no interference between alive and dead, weights over closed rooms. Relative to the experimenter's Aethus before the box is opened, the cat is in a disagreeing superposition of alive and dead, with weights, and nothing about that is strange once the word "disagreeing" is in hand. It is the same superposition every unread newspaper is in.

The electron in the double slit is the contrast, and the contrast is the entire content of the distinction. Its two paths carry no record of the difference between them anywhere in the world—not in the slits, not in the screen before the pattern forms, not in the air. Its alternatives say nothing about each other; the walls are down; and that absence of any separating record is what an agreeing superposition *is*, (the fundamental theorem, Section 8). The cat was never in the electron's regime, and the reason is not that the cat is large, warm, or alive. The reason is its records. A cat that somehow left no record of its state in any degree of freedom of the box—no counter, no hammer, no chemistry, no heat—would be in agreeing superposition, and the framework would say so; the thought experiment's absurdity is that it invites the reader to imagine exactly that while describing a box full of records.

The branching look, without the branches. Open the box and the reader who knows many-worlds will say: there, the world just branched into an alive-cat world and a dead-cat world. The framework's reply is that the reader has described the phenomenology exactly and the ontology wrongly, (Section 2.4.5). After the records—the counter, the vial, the chemistry—the two alternatives do not interact, each carries its weight, and the experimenter stands in one of them: that is what branching *means* empirically, and it is what the records deduce. But the walls are written into the alternatives, not between worlds; both pockets are here, in one box in one spacetime, relative to the experimenter's Aethus before it is opened; and the weight over them is the weight of pockets, which is why the framework has a probability where the branching picture has only a count. The cat is the branching look, deduced from its own records, without the branches—and the two pockets are Aethae, not terms of a state: the state vector is their polarization, and it is the experimenter who transits, not the wavefunction that splits, (Section 2.4.6).

The third postulate's reason, restated. The older statement of this subsection put the point through the third postulate directly, and it is kept because it is the mechanism: to suppose that the cat's superposition could be agreeing, with some semblance of validity, is to suppose a coherence claim across alternatives that a record separates, and such a claim is checkmated, (Theorem 14, third bin)—every proper child of the experimenter's Aethus has a proper child in which one of the box's records is stated, and the stated record contradicts the coherence. The quantum decoherence inside the box is the analogue of the double slit's detector in precisely this sense: not because it is a mechanism that does something to the cat, but because it is the name for the records being there. And the particular quantum trigger—the nucleus whose decay releases the hammer—is incidental to the cat's classification. The nucleus's own decay attribute is agreeing only up to its first record, which is the counter; from the counter outward everything is disagreeing, and the cat sits far downstream of that first record. In the Aethic worldview everything unknown is in such a disagreeing superposition relative to one's Aethus, which defuses the antirealism the thought experiment was built to expose at the cost of making macroscopic reality itself subtly stranger, (Section 9.7.1).

Everyone, at negligible weight. The classification has a consequence the framework does not flinch from: every person and animal in the world is, relative to your Aethus at this moment, in disagreeing superposition over being alive and dead, since you hold no record of their state that is current to the second. The weights vary and are nearly always minute, and the standing life-death superposition of a friend across a room is about as negligible as the fraction of a second into the past at which special relativity places them in conversation—real, exact, and of no practical consequence. It is a consequence of the postulates and not a paradox, and it is the same consequence for the cat and for the friend; the box adds nothing but a mechanism for making the weights large.

Why it is simple, and why it could not be said. The classification above is a three-line argument, and it is fair to ask why a century of the cat did not produce it. The answer, which the retrospective of Section 14.5 gives for the framework as a whole, is exact here: the argument is short but it was *unsayable* in the standard vocabulary, because it needs three pieces the vocabulary did not have. It needs determinacy to be a two-place relation—"settled relative to which records"—since "the electron's alternatives carry no exclusions" must be a fact about the alternatives relative to a state, and without the index it collapses into "we do not know which slit," which is the deflationary reading, which was known to be wrong, so the sentence could not be reached. It needs a modal grade—the ability to say the cat's cross-terms are *invalid* and not merely small—which is the third postulate. And it needs the reform of *or* made at the level of the disjuncts rather than the connective: exclusion as an achievement of records, written into the alternatives, where quantum logic reformed one layer up by surrendering distributivity [81, 161]. Everyone was looking at the connective; the difference was in the disjuncts.

The decoherence program came within a hair of the distinction and should be credited for the distance it covered. Environment-induced superselection [116] *is* the observation that the cat's records write its exclusions in—the environment copies the outcome into many degrees of freedom and the cross-terms become inaccessible—and it is correct about every mechanism involved. What it could not say is that the walls it described were walls: it read the suppression as effective, dynamical, and a matter of degree, because probability was the only grade it had, and at probability grade "the cross-terms are negligible" is the strongest available sentence. The framework's addition is one grade, not one mechanism: the cross-terms are not small, they are invalid, and the exclusions are not effective, they are written. There is a historical accident on top. Schrödinger posed the cat as a *reductio*—an absurdity meant to embarrass the Copenhagen reading—so the field inherited it as something to be explained away rather than as a case to be classified, and a case one is explaining away is a case one never runs.

Relative to which Aethus. The cat is in superposition only relative to the experimenter's Aethus of before the box is checked, and relative to that Aethus it is in superposition permanently: six years later, relative to the Aethus of that earlier moment, the cat will still have been in superposition all along, since no Aethus is ever overwritten, (the extrusion principle). At the instant the box is opened the experimenter transits to a new Aethus in which the cat was never in superposition in the first place. An alive cat was never partially dead relative to this Aethus; a dead cat was never in a partial superposition of being alive at the moment the poison was released. This is the indexed collapse of the framework in its plainest instance, and it is the same fact that Section 10.2.4 states for every case: relative to each determinate-indexing Aethus the outcome was fixed from the outset, and the felt indeterminism lives entirely in *which* such Aethus one comes to occupy, weighted by the Nexus. The correlation between what the experimenter sees and what the counter recorded is, by Joint Invalidity in Place of Causation, (Principle 27), not a chain of events from nucleus to counter to cat to eye, but the joint invalidity, relative to the experimenter's Aethus, of the combinations the records exclude—"counter fired and cat alive" is not a valid member, and never was.

How the case may read in retrospect. If the framework holds up, the cat is likely to become the first classification exercise in the course rather than the paradox at the end of it, in the way the twin paradox became a homework problem once the geometry was understood. The retrospective account will be short: the distinction was in the data from 1927, interference here and none there; it was named "coherence versus decoherence" as a dynamical process; and the step was to see it as a static difference in the content of the alternatives, indexed to records. Stated that way it sounds like a small step, and that is the hazard of retrospect: simple distinctions, once seen, are retroactively attributed to everyone, and the credit diffuses into the program that almost had it. The dated record exists for exactly this, (Section 13.11): the May 8, 2023 manuscript already distinguishes "both slits at once" from "one slit but not the other in both ways," and says of the pair that "to Aethic logic it is certainly distinct," before the literature was read and before either had a name. One further point belongs in the record. The distinction is *separable* from the framework's stronger claims: if the physical claim about records on which the nested-observer cases rest were to fail, the agreeing/disagreeing classification would survive as clarifying vocabulary, and the cat would still be taught this way. That is the mark of a good distinction—it is worth having even for a reader who rejects the rest—and it is the part of the framework one should expect to be adopted first and cited least.

What the cat does not settle. The cat is the easy case precisely because its records escape: the box leaks heat, the counter clicks, the chemistry proceeds, and the totality guard has a hundred degrees of freedom to name. The hard case is a box from which nothing escapes at all—no record of the outcome reaching any Aethus at any time, so that the coherence claim across alive and dead has no separating record to be checkmated by. The framework's answer there is the vacuum reading, (Section 6.6.2): an agreeing superposition and any eventual access to its record are jointly invalid, so the cut between the regimes falls at "no Aethus in the block, past or future, ever accesses it," by joint invalidity alone and not by any force of concealment. The exact conditions under which a macroscopic configuration meets that description are the fifth of the Open Constructions, (Section 14.8), and they are what separates the cat from the nested-observer cases that follow: Wigner's friend is the cat with the box redesigned so that the question of whether its records escape is the whole experiment.

10.2.1 The Aethic Resolution of Wigner's Friend

The question the standard axioms cannot answer. The cat subsection ended by saying that Wigner's friend is the cat with the box redesigned so that whether its records escape is the whole experiment, and that is the right way in. In the extended Wigner's friend family [30]—Frauchiger–Renner [92] is the sharpest member—a friend inside a sealed laboratory measures a particle, and Wigner outside treats the whole laboratory, friend included, as a quantum system he has not measured. The difficulty is not that the two descriptions differ; it is that the Dirac–von Neumann axioms [162] cannot say which one is right. They do not answer the question of whether the friend's measurement "counts" as the collapsing measurement when Wigner cannot see it, because they have no resource for the question: the projection postulate is applied by an observer, and the axioms never say which observer. The Aethic reframe answers it in two moves, both consequences of postulates already on the books.

Concept 6 (Aethic Reframe of Wigner's Friend)
The Aethic reframe of Wigner's friend comes from two central moves, each resting on the Aethic postulates.

1. The index. The first postulate demands that the system of the experiment, quantum and otherwise,

cannot be well-defined without reference to a particular Aethus—and, crucially, the Aethus of choice, and thereby the makeup of the experiment, changes with the choice.

What this says about the experiment is exact. Relative to Wigner's Aethus outside the sealed laboratory, the particle the friend measured, and the friend himself for having measured it, stand in Aethic disagreeing *superposition: alternatives with their exclusions written in, weights over closed rooms, no cross-interaction. The laboratory's being sealed is not the operative fact, and neither is the friend's capacity to communicate. The third postulate tests a candidate state against its entire declared refinement structure, and the test has a quantifier shape that decides the case: a candidate A is valid when some declared refinement B of it has no contradiction-reaching declared descendant, $\mathcal{V}(A) \iff \exists B \leq A\ \forall C \leq B\ C \notin \text{Base}$, so that its failure is $\forall B \leq A\ \exists C \leq B\ C \in \text{Base}$. One possible later record is therefore insufficient to exclude anything; what excludes a candidate agreeing superposition is that every permitted refinement still has a contradiction-reaching descendant. The declared refinement future is the relation these quantifiers range over, and it is distinct by definition from the proper-time future, which the ontology connects to it by the monotonicity convention but does not identify with it. On that shape the verdict is conditional, and the condition is physical: a Heisenberg cut placed between the two observers, treating the friend in agreeing superposition relative to Wigner, is invalid exactly if, for the observer–laboratory systems in question, no admissible continuation both preserves the required coherence and removes every avenue to a separating record, which is a no-safe-reversal claim, that no permitted refinement coherently reverses the measurement and closes every contradiction-reaching record avenue. Given that claim and the framework's record–coherence incompatibility, the cut is excluded by the third postulate for the same reason the double-slit pattern vanishes with a detector running, and the Frauchiger–Renner erasure step, which requires such a cut, does not reach its contradiction. A temporary barrier to communication does not establish a safe refinement; neither, by itself, does an observer's capacity to communicate establish that none exists. Establishing the record claim for observer-grade systems, or constructing an observer protocol that violates it, is the outstanding physical question, and it is stated as such below. Relative to the friend's own Aethus inside, the measurement has an outcome and the attribute is determinate. Under the extrusion principle the two are read directly: Wigner and his friend occupy subtly different Aethae along the block-universe Markov chain, and yet, by the qualitative facet of the principle, they occupy the same physical spacetime. The only thing that could prevent their block universes from interacting would be their holding disjoint information in their Aethae*[201]*, which by the construction of the experiment they do not; so they can meet afterward and compare results, and observer consistency, (Section 12.3), guarantees the comparison holds.*

This is where a large part of the paradox came from: the thought experiment never adopted an extrusion model of reality. The assumption of a single objective description forces the paradox by flattening the Aethic degrees of freedom that structure the experiment—two indices, two Aethae, one spacetime—into one description that has to be right for both observers at once, and cannot be.

2. *The records. The laboratory being "sealed" is the primary driver of the standard axioms' inability to deduce what happens, and the Aethic resolution of this part comes from removing the ambiguity of what measurement is.* The Aethic postulates demand that Wigner's friend must never be allowed to enter a quantum superposition despite being inside the sealed laboratory at the moment, because the third postulate invalidates Aethae through the full-future inability to reliably block off an avenue to a contradiction, and not through the naive "present state" of the interior being sealed. *On the Aethic account the same consistency constraint excludes both a maintained two-slit agreeing superposition with an accessible which-path record and a maintained agreeing superposition of the friend's outcomes with an accessible outcome record. Neither exclusion requires that the external observer has already read the record: "Wigner has not read it" is no better, within this argument, than "nobody has read the which-path detector." Present sealing alone does not establish that the record-access refinements on which the third postulate operates have been removed. The friend and the detector therefore instantiate one invalidity pattern, not two separately resolved measurement problems: the same incompatibility supplies the base contradiction, and the same rule propagates its consequences. No separate observer-specific collapse principle is needed; what remains to be established is that the friend's record satisfies the same inescapable-accessibility*

[201] That is, as per the third postulate of the Aethus itself, or more generally the corollary of Aethic reasoning for which people with disjoint Aethae cannot interact in the "Aethic multiverse".

condition as the detector's. Three statements differ, and the exclusion needs the third: that the friend can communicate the outcome; that the specified experiment retains an avenue for later communication; and that every permitted refinement retains some avenue to a separating record, so that no safe coherent reversal exists. Being human makes the second extremely plausible in ordinary experiments, and the passage from human record-bearing to the third is the physical claim, stated as a premise here; a detector carrying an outcome-distinguishing record needs the corresponding treatment, since presence without a distinguishing record supplies no contradiction. The reason the third postulate forbids a quantum superposition of the friend is precisely the reason it forbids an interference pattern between two slits while a detector carrying a which-path record runs: an Aethus that insists on an agreeing superposition over the concrete outcomes of a system is pruned when every refinement of it still reaches a separating record. The friend's records—his memory, his notebook, the state of his apparatus, the laboratory's air and walls, exactly the cat's inventory—are the candidate avenues, and the condition is not that the two will eventually meet and compare retained outcomes, which a later meeting does not by itself guarantee, since the protocol's own incompatible laboratory measurements may disturb the earlier records, but that no permitted refinement closes every such avenue while keeping the coherence. The conditional theorem is this: let A_{coh} assert maintained agreeing superposition across the friend's outcome alternatives; suppose every declared refinement B of A_{coh} has a further refinement C exposing a separating outcome record; and suppose that record, together with the maintained-coherence assertion, is a base contradiction. Then A_{coh} is doomed by the third postulate. The first and third suppositions are the framework's; the second is the physical premise, and proving it for the relevant observer–laboratory arrangement is the task the verdict leaves open.

Lemma 5 (Conditional record exclusion)
Let A_{coh} be a candidate state asserting a specified maintained coherence, with declared descent $\leq$ and Base *as in the Fixed-Point Lemma (Lemma 1), declared descent reflexive and transitive, and the validity predicate read base-generated, the greatest fixed point νF of its safety operator, and let the relevant base contradictions be those produced when that coherence and an incompatible separating record are jointly stated. If every declared refinement of A_{coh} has a further declared descendant exhibiting that incompatibility, $\forall B \leq A_{\mathrm{coh}}\ \exists C \leq B :\ C \in \mathrm{Base}$, then A_{coh} is invalid under the third postulate.*

Proof
Validity requires a safe refinement, a declared refinement all of whose declared descendants lie outside the base; by hypothesis every candidate safe refinement contains a base-contradictory descendant, so none exists.

The lemma is the reusable result, and the detector and the friend are two proposed physical instantiations of its premise at their own scopes: an unread detector record excludes the unconditional subsystem interference and not, by existing, the coherence of system plus detector, while the Frauchiger–Renner candidate is the coherent description of the whole laboratory across the friend's outcome alternatives. The criterion does not restrict which physical degrees of freedom may carry a separating record; any proposed realization must supply its declared refinements and record incompatibilities consistently with the candidate configuration, and where those structures depend on the configuration itself, as they do when the geometry is a candidate record carrier, their joint consistency is an additional construction problem that the lemma does not address.

So the friend is forced into Aethic disagreeing superposition relative to Wigner, precisely as the cat is and as the remainder of classical phenomena are, regardless of the quantum particle at the start of the chain. The departure from the standard picture is then stated in one contrast. The standard picture has the sealed interior in quantum superposition, collapsing to a single state when the door opens. Here, sealing the laboratory in the moment secures nothing: the third postulate prunes on the availability of the record over the whole proper-time future, and blankness is tense-free, so a retrieval later is read exactly as a retrieval now. Relative to Wigner the laboratory is therefore never in agreeing superposition. From the moment the friend measures it stands in classical disagreeing superposition relative to Wigner, one outcome holding and Wigner not in possession of which; when the record reaches him it passes from that disagreeing superposition to a single state relative to his updated Aethus, by selection along structure that was already disagreeing, (Section 10.2.4); and nothing coherent collapses, because agreeing superpositions do not collapse. What the third postulate excludes, on the record claim, is the preparation *the protocol assumes,*

the coherent superposition of the friend's laboratory across his outcome alternatives; it does not make the superposition-basis measurement operator unavailable. That operation remains performable, and applied to the state the framework assigns, the disagreeing mixture, it yields the mixture's statistics, the cross terms absent, so the coherent state assignment used to obtain the protocol's certainty inferences is unavailable, and which inference fails in consequence is read off the four-outcome joint distribution of the mixture. The computation is short. In the protocol the coin lands heads with weight $\frac{1}{3}$ *and tails with* $\frac{2}{3}$*; heads prepares the spin down, tails prepares it along* $(|\downarrow\rangle + |\uparrow\rangle)/\sqrt{2}$*, and the second friend measures the spin, so that the coherent assignment to the two laboratories is* $(|h,\downarrow\rangle + |t,\downarrow\rangle + |t,\uparrow\rangle)/\sqrt{3}$*, while the framework assigns the disagreeing mixture over the three record-separated pockets* $(h,\downarrow)$*,* $(t,\downarrow)$*,* $(t,\uparrow)$ *at weight* $\frac{1}{3}$ *each. The superobservers measure the laboratories in the bases* $|\mathrm{ok}\rangle \propto |h\rangle - |t\rangle$ *and* $|\mathrm{ok}\rangle \propto |\downarrow\rangle - |\uparrow\rangle$*, and the joint distributions over* $(\mathrm{ok}_1, \mathrm{ok}_2)$*,* $(\mathrm{ok}_1, \mathrm{fail}_2)$*,* $(\mathrm{fail}_1, \mathrm{ok}_2)$*,* $(\mathrm{fail}_1, \mathrm{fail}_2)$ *are*

$$\textit{coherent: } \left(\tfrac{1}{12}, \tfrac{1}{12}, \tfrac{1}{12}, \tfrac{3}{4}\right), \qquad \textit{mixture: } \left(\tfrac{1}{4}, \tfrac{1}{4}, \tfrac{1}{4}, \tfrac{1}{4}\right),$$

since each superobserver's outcome has probability $\frac{1}{2}$ *in every pocket. The inference the protocol needs and loses is the certainty step: under the coherent assignment* ok_1 *implies that the spin was up,* $P(\mathrm{ok}_1 \wedge \downarrow) = 0$ *against* $P(\mathrm{ok}_1 \wedge \uparrow) = \frac{1}{6}$*, and the chain of agents' inferences runs from there; under the mixture* ok_1 *is compatible with both spin outcomes, at* $\frac{1}{3}$ *and* $\frac{1}{6}$*, so no superobserver outcome constrains a friend's outcome and the chain does not start. The* $(\mathrm{ok}_1, \mathrm{ok}_2)$ *cell,* $\frac{1}{12}$ *against* $\frac{1}{4}$*, is the operational discriminator between the two assignments, and the script* `frauchiger_renner_mixture.py` *in the data package reproduces both tables. Two mechanisms are at work, distinct in their roles: the indexing restricts the transfer of certainty between agents, which is the semantic reconciliation, and the unavoidable-record premise restricts universal coherent treatment of observer-containing laboratories, which is the conditional physical exclusion. And the particle's quantum influence is thereby rendered peripheral, which is the direct reason the paradoxical element of the cat dissolves as well: in the Aethic world the experiment is not distinguishable from any other classical phenomenon, (even if the "ontic sacrifice" is that all classical phenomena become collectively, subtly stranger—though not remotely as strange, in the antirealist sense, as the standard cat itself—than under the classical alternative).*

No cut, and what the verdict depends on. Altogether, then, the Aethic resolution of the Frauchiger–Renner paradox is that the prohibited Heisenberg cut [1] is not every descriptive boundary between observers but the one that licenses maintained coherence across the friend's recorded outcomes while excluding the record-access refinements the third postulate requires: placing that cut would violate the postulate to no lesser an extent than placing a detector carrying a which-path record in the double slit and still expecting cross-slit interference. The framework draws no cut of its own in place of the one it forbids. Where an observer's agreeing superposition ends is not a line placed between systems but the fact that the observer's records escape to where a future Aethus can read them—the same fact that ends cross-slit interference once a detector runs, and the same inventory of records that classified the cat. Section 8.0.2 states what that verdict depends on: one claim about the physics of records, that a record-bearing structure of observer grade exports its records unblockably, and not a threshold of scale, complexity, or consciousness. That claim is the framework's sole structural divergence from universal unitarity, and it is where a physicist who doubts the resolution should press; given it, the exclusion is a theorem of the third postulate, and the operational account, the mixture's joint distribution for the protocol, is computed above.

The false dichotomy, and what stands in its place. One further interplay, with the second postulate, completes the reframe. The dichotomy the paradox presupposes—the particle is either in a quantum superposition or in a determinate state—is itself a violation of the second postulate. The reason is the one the observer-consistency section gives, (Section 12.3): before the particle is observed by either Wigner or his friend, it is not that its spin attribute at the spacetime location in question[202] is in full agreeing superposition[203] or otherwise determinate. It is, very specifically, that the disagreeing superposition at play holds as a constraint, by the reduced form of the Aethus[204], that the realized

[202] I.e., the destination location in particular, as that is the one inferred to be in disagreeing superposition by the Quantum Nexus, not the intermediate spacetime locations which themselves satisfy the relevant quantum evolution equation due to their being permanently inaccessible to Aethic knowledge and thereby Aethic pruning.

[203] As violates the extrusion principle by assuming the update operates in proper time, or violates the Aethic structure makeup by assuming an agreeing superposition is reducible to state-decomposable child Aethae when in reality an agreeing superposition is irreducible.

[204] See the reduced form section, (section 6.6) or the delayed-choice [10] section, (section 10.9.4) for examples in reduced form coupling.

destination spin attributes of Wigner and his friend agree in every block-universe pocket of the ladder ontology—the reduced-form coupling that results from the invalidation of every child Aethus in which they interact[205] while holding conflicting information. This is Joint Invalidity in Place of Causation at work, (Principle 27): the agreement between Wigner's eventual reading and the friend's is not a chain of events but the joint invalidity of the combinations in which they would disagree. So the richer Aethic structure of Wigner's friend is this: it maximally declines to privilege a particular outcome for either observer, while asserting that the attribute is already Aethically fixed, (see Section 36 for the definition of Aethically fixed, not to be confused with truly determinate). The two subsubsections that follow unpack, in turn, the classical assumptions that made the dichotomy feel forced, and the positive statement of what collapse then is.

10.2.2 Frauchiger–Renner and Classical Causal Assumptions

What this subsubsection does. The reframe above resolves the paradox in two moves; this subsubsection explains why the paradox ever felt forced, by naming the five classical assumptions that had to be in place for it to bite, and showing that each is a hidden ontological commitment rather than a neutral description. A major source of the category-error confusion that usually makes this experiment paradoxical is the classical conflation of *measurement* with *observation*—a conflation that hides inside several unexamined classical assumptions about what it even means for a particle to be in superposition. Let us name these assumptions explicitly, because each is load-bearing for the paradox, each is removed under Aethic reasoning, and all turn out to be symptoms of a single deeper confusion that the Aethic Sifting Principle (Principle 26) resolves at the root. Each assumption presents itself as a neutral description of the physical situation; each is in fact a hidden ontological commitment that the Aethic framework is free to reject.

- **Assumption 1: The proper-time constraint on the observer's past.** Classical reasoning artificially constrains Wigner's friend's proper-time past to lie before the measurement update, forcing it to carry the prior superposition status of the particle into the subsequent block universe. In a single-timeline picture, the friend's past contains the moment before the measurement (when the particle was in superposition) and the moment after (when the friend has observed an outcome), and the friend's current state is assumed to inherit, without further comment, a proper-time history that includes the unmeasured period. This sounds like the innocuous statement that the friend experienced time passing, but it is doing more work than the phenomenological description suggests. Buried inside "the friend remembers the period before the measurement" is the loaded commitment that "the friend's current block universe must contain, as part of its proper-time past, a time-slice in which the particle was not yet measured." These are not the same statement under the extrusion principle. The first is about what the friend carries with them. The second is about what the friend's current block universe contains as part of its own internal structure. Classical framing treats them as equivalent only because it has no way to distinguish "what the observer carries with them" from "what the reality they are currently in contains"—a single-timeline picture has nowhere else for memories to be memories of.

  Where the ambiguous past lives. The Aethic reframe supplies that elsewhere: the prior block universe, which the observer has extruded out of. The friend's subsequent block universe is a different block universe from the one occupied before the measurement, and the subsequent block universe does not inherit any trace of the prior one's ambiguous particle state at any point in its proper-time past, no matter how far back one looks. The very prospect of partitioning a relativistically-valid block universe into pre- and post-measurement regions is itself a category error in the Aethic view: each individual block universe is internally consistent on its superposition-versus-determinate type, with any variability distributed across distinct block universes rather than within a single one. The memory accumulated during the friend's prior block universe transits with the friend across the extrusion, but it refers to the prior block universe rather than to the current one's internal history. Frauchiger and Renner's chain of inference depends on forcing every observer to share a single proper-time history within a single block universe, which is what licenses each nested observer to reason about the others' past quantum states through that shared history. Remove the shared proper-time history—recognize that each observer's pre-measurement memories refer to their own prior block universe rather than to the current one—and the chain loses its starting point.

[205] So as to gather one another's results, that is.

- **Assumption 2: The agreeing-to-disagreeing transition at measurement.** The underlying classical commitment here is the proposition that "the unobserved particle truly is in agreeing superposition prior to measurement, and upon measurement transitions to disagreeing." One guard stated explicitly, since a prior external-model reading garbled it: no *observer* is ever themselves in an agreeing superposition, and nothing ever collapses out of one — observers hold agreeing superpositions *of systems*, stand relative to one another in disagreeing superposition, and collapse-grade selection runs over disagreeing superpositions only (Section 10.2.4). This is what makes it feel paradoxical that Wigner's friend [30] in the Frauchiger–Renner [92] setup might have to occupy a quantum state even before Wigner's own involvement. The assumption is unusually pervasive: essentially every major interpretation carries some version of it. Copenhagen states the transition explicitly as wavefunction collapse at the moment of observation. Many-worlds [2, 3, 68] states it implicitly through branching at decoherence—post-branching, the observer is in a single branch with the particle in a definite state, which functions as the transition even where the interpretation formally denies that any collapse has occurred. Bohmian mechanics [72, 73] states it through the effective collapse of the conditional wavefunction at measurement. Spontaneous collapse theories [75] state it through explicit stochastic dynamics that become effectively instantaneous at measurement scales. Even QBism [78, 79] and other reference-class interpretations carry a version of it in epistemic rather than ontological clothing. The transition is not a feature of any particular interpretation but of the entire classical framing of what quantum mechanics is supposed to explain.

  The diagnosis: there is no transition. The Aethic diagnosis is that the transition itself is a category error. The particle—or more precisely, as Assumption 3 will make clear, the relevant spin attribute at the relevant spacetime location—is already in disagreeing superposition before any observation, so long as the information remains accessible in principle. There is no transition because there is no prior agreeing superposition from which to transition. The appearance of one is an artifact of imposing proper-time ordering on a structure that is in fact determined by future accessibility. What every interpretation has been trying to do, for a century, is explain *why* the transition happens and *what* triggers it—to locate the physical event or threshold at which agreeing becomes disagreeing. The Aethic position is that this question has no answer because there is no such event or threshold to locate: the relevant distinction was never between pre-measurement and post-measurement states but between Aethically-accessible and Aethically-inaccessible attributes, and this distinction is determined by the structure of the accessibility relation across the full future rather than by anything happening at a specific moment.

  This diagnosis is formalized as the Aethic Sifting Principle (Principle 26), which explicitly separates *measurement* (the agreeing-to-disagreeing transition, triggered by eventual information accessibility and governed by the Third Postulate) from *observation* (the subsequent selection of a single pocket from the resulting disagreeing superposition, triggered by the observer's physical acquisition of a state-decomposable attribute). The paradoxical feel of Frauchiger–Renner comes precisely from treating these two operations as a single event, which collapses the Aethic structure that distinguishes them and forces the classical reasoner into the contradictions the experiment surfaces.

  What the statement does not forbid. It is worth noting that this Aethic statement—that agreeing superpositions never collapse, (never, that is, *resolved* toward one constituent, there being no fact-of-the-branch to select; a record stating their interior invalidates them *whole*, while the selection event that "collapse" traditionally names occurs only across disagreeing alternatives), and that disagreeing superpositions are already present wherever the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning guarantees informational accessibility—does not forbid agreeing superpositions of the particle outright. It forbids them only at the targeted Aethic attributes in question, as ties directly into the Aethic resolution for Assumption 3. The attributes which are not locked down in this way naturally expand to full agreeing superpositions anyway, per the favoring by the Second Postulate of attributes that are already determinately unspecifiable. What is specifically being argued is that the nodes in the spacetime block universe at which collapse would classically occur are locked down as disagreeing superpositions relative to any Aethus and its children for which that information is permanently accessible, and the agreeing superpositions occupying the relevant particle's dynamics in the intermediate spacetime between such nodes are deductively downstream of this consideration via the Quantum Nexus. Relative to the relevant Aethic pocket, attributes in agreeing superposition are permanently so across all further child Aethae, and

attributes in disagreeing superposition or otherwise determinate are likewise permanently so. The particle decomposes into agreeing and disagreeing components, each permanently classified relative to a given Aethus, with the standard wavefunction collapse picture amounting to the conflation of two structurally distinct roles—the wavefunction's role of establishing determinate nonclassicality[206] and its transitional role into measurement. Aethic reasoning attributes the former to agreeing superpositions and the latter to the deductively upstream consideration of the Aethically fixed attributes. The main consequence is that no ad hoc collapse of a single consistent mathematical entity needs to be forced: intermediate quantum nonclassicality and the probability weights feeding into collapse refer to distinct structures, and smuggling in the assumption that one transitions into the other is misleading both as to their independent permanence and as to their pertaining to different attributes. The distinction is developed in its own right—including the disambiguation of what "agreeing superpositions are permanent" can and cannot mean—in Section 10.2.4 below.

- **Assumption 3: The vague-gesturing-at-the-particle assumption.** This is perhaps the subtlest of the assumptions, and it most invisibly shapes how we talk about superposition in the first place.

  Stating the principle. In classical and even most quantum interpretive thinking, we speak about "the particle" as if the particle itself is the object that can be in superposition or in a determinate state, as if vague global gesturing at the particle is an Aethically well-defined move. It is not. In Aethic reasoning, the particle as a monolithic entity does not mean anything in the context of agreeing or disagreeing superpositions. What is Aethically well-defined is a decomposition of some aspect, or some composite of aspects, about the particle (and possibly its environment) into the exhaustive Aethic attributes which capture it. The Aethic attribute is the thing that can be in superposition, not the particle itself. The classical framing feels neutral because we are accustomed to treating particles as the primary objects of quantum mechanical discourse, but the framing is secretly a commitment: it commits the speaker to treating "the particle is in superposition" as a well-formed statement when in fact the statement has no definite Aethic referent without further decomposition.

  Seeing it in action. If a particle's spin is measured at point A and again at point B, then the Aethic attribute corresponding to each measured spin state *at those exact locations in spacetime* must be in disagreeing superposition (or a determinate child Aethus of that), and this assertion holds no matter where the observer personally is in the physical block universe, so long as the occurrence of the measurements at A and B is already constrained in the observer's Aethus. One may even Aethically perturb away from this ideal situation and place the spacetime location of measurement B in its own Aethic superposition over multiple spots. Even then, the Aethic reduced form coupling holds: for each instance child Aethus in which B occurs at a particular location, the Aethic attribute pertaining to the specific spin state at that specific location is in disagreeing superposition (or determinate) relative to an observer anywhere in the block universe, and allowing the variability in B's location simply places each such Aethic instance in disagreeing superposition with its siblings, forming the relevant system-pertaining parent Aethus to the observer's own Aethus. The nested structure of the superposition—an outer Aethic superposition over the possible locations of B, each instance of which contains an inner disagreeing superposition over the spin outcomes at that specific location—is what the attribute-level specification tracks and what the vague particle-level gesturing collapses into a single undifferentiated object.

  Understanding why it is non-negotiable. The reason the specification must be "the particle's spin attribute at B is what is in disagreeing superposition" rather than some vague global gesturing at the particle comes from what happens in the intermediate spacetime between A and B. The relevant Quantum Nexus paths pertaining to the spin state must themselves remain in *irreducible* agreeing superposition by the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, assuming no intermediate spin measurements which would impose additional validity constraints. The endpoints at A and B are precisely the structure formalized in Section 14.2.6 as Aethic determinate nodes (Definition 53)—loci at which the pruning of the Quantum Nexus fixes the relevant attribute into a determinate state or disagreeing superposition—and the intermediate dynamics are what the surviving path-bundles of the reduced integral supply, recovering the Dirac evolution between the fixed endpoints rather than being independently posited. Vague

[206] That is, be it quantum uncertainty or Bell inequality [4] violations.

global gesturing at "the particle" collapses both layers of this structure into a single ill-defined object: it loses the determinate-node specification at the endpoints and obscures the path-level agreeing superposition in the intermediate space, which is the structure on which the framework's empirical agreement with quantum mechanics actually depends. The attribute-level specification is the only level of description at which the Aethic structure reproduces that empirical content, and any coarsening of the description loses it.

- **Assumption 4: The past-future asymmetry of determinacy.** Classical intuition artificially forces future attributes to be indeterminate while treating past attributes as determinate. This asymmetry feels like nothing more than the common-sense observation that we know what has already happened but do not know what will happen—a statement about epistemic access. As with the proper-time constraint in Assumption 1, what reads as a statement about epistemic access is in fact an ontological commitment: that the past is determinate *in itself* and the future is indeterminate *in itself*, independent of any particular observer's Aethic relationship to either. The asymmetry between knowing and not knowing gets smuggled into an asymmetry between being and not being through the habit of treating observation as the mechanism that produces determinacy. If observation produces determinacy, and if we have observed the past but not the future, then of course the past is determinate and the future is not. But this chain of reasoning depends on the premise that observation produces determinacy, which is itself the conflation that Assumption 2 already diagnosed.

  Passage kept, asymmetry of being denied. The Aethic framework does not deny the phenomenological experience of time's asymmetric flow—it accounts for that experience through centric unfolding and the progression of Aethae along the Markov chain. What it denies is the further move that translates phenomenological asymmetry into ontological asymmetry at the level of the block universe structure itself. Under the extrusion principle, the past and the future are both part of a block universe structure, and what determines the superposition type of an attribute is not whether it has been observed yet but whether the distinguishing information is *ever* accessible in principle. Proper-time ordering no longer governs which attributes are determinate and which are in superposition; what governs the distinction is the global Aethic accessibility of the information, quantified over all future child Aethae rather than over only the present instant. A future measurement that will be made is, for purposes of Aethic validity, already equivalent to a measurement that has been made, because the Third Postulate's quantifier ranges over in-principle accessibility across potential refinements rather than over current information access.

  The blindfold and the friend, one case. This is the move that unifies the blindfolded experimenter with Wigner's friend: both cases involve information that is physically present in the apparatus but currently inaccessible to the relevant observer, and in both cases the Third Postulate forces the relevant superposition into disagreeing type on the basis of in-principle accessibility alone. The blindfolded experimenter and Wigner's friend are not two different cases requiring two different treatments—they are two instances of the same case, distinguished only by whether the currently-inaccessible information is located in the spacelike exterior of the observer's present or in the timelike future. From the Aethic framework's perspective, this distinction is structurally irrelevant, and the Third Postulate handles both cases with identical machinery.

- **Assumption 5: The single-observer privilege.** The classical framing of Frauchiger–Renner tacitly presupposes that there must be a fact of the matter, independent of any particular observer, about whether Wigner's friend's measurement has or has not collapsed the particle's state—that *somebody* has to be right about the system's superposition status. This presupposition feels like nothing more than the requirement that physics be objective, which appears to be a neutral methodological commitment rather than a loaded ontological one. The appearance of neutrality is what protects the assumption from scrutiny: any attempt to challenge it reads, on the surface, as an attempt to abandon objectivity altogether.

  Objectivity, re-indexed. The Aethic framework does not abandon objectivity. It reorients what objectivity is indexed to. The classical reading identifies "objective" with "observer-independent"—a statement is objective if its truth-value holds without reference to any particular observer's situation. The Aethic reading identifies "objective" with "Aethus-relative"—a statement is objective if, relative to a given Aethus, it has a determinate truth-value that follows from the Aethus by the framework's structural rules. The difference between these is not that one is stronger and the other weaker. A statement objective in the Aethus-relative sense is no less

determinate, no less checkable, and no less constraining within its scope than a classically-objective statement would be within its own scope. What changes is the ontological background against which the truth-value is indexed: an Aethus, rather than an Aethus-free posited reality. This is the load-bearing move of the First Postulate—that any attribution of reality is a statement of relation to a particular Aethus rather than to reality itself—and what it accomplishes is not a weakening of truth but a reorientation of what truth is relativized to.

No higher tribunal. Under this reorientation, Wigner and his friend genuinely occupy different Aethae and therefore different block universes, and each is correct about the state of the system *relative to their own Aethus*. Both descriptions are objective in the Aethic sense, both are complete within their respective Aethae, and neither is a degraded version of some higher description that one would have access to from outside. There is no higher tribunal at which one perspective must be ratified over the other, because the First Postulate forbids the construction of such a tribunal. Where the first four assumptions are responsible for making Schrödinger's cat feel paradoxical even in the single-observer case, this fifth assumption is what specifically gives the Frauchiger–Renner proof its teeth: the proof relies on checking each nested observer's predictions against a single shared description of the system, and the sharing is what makes the predictions appear to conflict. Remove the requirement that there be a single shared description, and the predictions cease to conflict because they are no longer about the same thing. Each observer's prediction is correct relative to their own Aethus, and the contradiction dissolves into a perfectly consistent Aethic stratification in which Wigner and his friend inhabit distinct Aethic block universes without either being wrong.

The Sifting Principle, now visible. With these assumptions named and removed, the Aethic Sifting Principle (Principle 26) becomes directly visible as the structural machinery resolving the paradox—the principle that separates measurement from observation and thereby relocates the emphasis onto *global accessibility of information* rather than onto the actual observation event. What the five assumptions have in common is that each was preventing the sifting principle from being applied cleanly to the Frauchiger–Renner setup: Assumption 1 by treating the observer's memory as if it were the block universe's history, Assumption 2 by treating measurement and observation as a single event, Assumption 3 by treating the particle as a monolithic object rather than a constellation of attributes each with its own Aethic status, Assumption 4 by treating proper-time ordering as the arbiter of determinacy, and Assumption 5 by treating one observer's Aethus as privileged over another's. All five are symptoms of the same underlying classical commitment: that measurement is a singular event performed on a monolithic object by a privileged observer at a particular moment in proper time. The Aethic Sifting Principle dissolves this commitment by replacing the singular event with a two-step process (measurement as the agreeing-to-disagreeing transition, observation as the subsequent pocket selection), replacing the monolithic object with attribute decomposition, and replacing the privileged observer with Aethus-relative realism. The observation event is then demoted to occupying a spacelike foliation which partitions the block universe under the extrusion principle. Due to the Third Postulate, an unobserved particle's relevant spin attribute at its measurement location is in disagreeing superposition even before being observed directly, so long as that attribute is observable—whether by an experimenter performing the double-slit experiment while wearing a blindfold, or by a future measurement that has not yet been made in proper time. The same principle governs the Quantum Nexus construction: if the destination of a particle that has already landed is known, the agreeing superposition of paths in the intermediate spacetime still does not collapse—it is only constrained by the destination information as mixed-decomposable, with the determinate nodes at the endpoints serving as the Aethic boundary conditions through which the surviving path-bundles thread.

Applied. Applying the Sifting Principle directly to the Frauchiger–Renner setup, the Third Postulate already renders the relevant attribute of Wigner's friend a disagreeing superposition with respect to Wigner's Aethus, rather than having it artificially be agreeing prior to Wigner's involvement. This is structurally equivalent to the blindfolded-experimenter case in the double-slit setup: the relevant which-path attribute of the quantum state cannot be in agreeing superposition anywhere in the block universe, yet is nonetheless in disagreeing superposition because of the blindfold. The future-directed constraint of Aethic knowability alone suffices to force this attribute into disagreeing rather than agreeing superposition, and the quantum state directly involving Wigner's friend is accordingly neither monolithic nor Aethically variable within a single block universe pertaining to its makeup. With the five classical assumptions removed and the Sifting Principle in place of them, the Frauchiger–Renner contradiction is no longer generated, because the structure on which the proof's chain of inference depended—a shared proper-time history, a singular measurement event, a monolithic particle, a proper-

time-based determinacy criterion, and a privileged observer description—has been replaced piece by piece with the corresponding Aethic structural commitments that do not generate the contradiction.

10.2.3 A Reversible-Record Toy Model for the Third Postulate

The verdicts above turn on what a separating record is and on which refinements the third postulate ranges over, and both are visible in a model small enough to enumerate. Take a system S with outcome alternatives $|0\rangle, |1\rangle$, a marker M that the measurement interaction correlates with S, and a copy register E outside the laboratory. The measurement interaction is the unitary U_{SM} taking $(\alpha|0\rangle + \beta|1\rangle)|m\rangle$ to $\alpha|0\rangle|m_0\rangle + \beta|1\rangle|m_1\rangle$; the copy, if it occurs, is the unitary U_{ME} taking that to $\alpha|0\rangle|m_0\rangle|e_0\rangle + \beta|1\rangle|m_1\rangle|e_1\rangle$; the coherent reversal is $U_{SM}^{\dagger}$, available on S and M alone. The attributes are the outcome of S, the state of M and the state of E; the declared refinements of a state are the states obtained by stating further attributes among these; and the base contradictions are the joint assertions of maintained agreeing superposition over S's outcomes with a stated separating record of that outcome.

Definition 43 (Separating record, in the model)
A subsystem R carries a separating record *of S's outcome in a state when its branch states $|r_0\rangle, |r_1\rangle$ are orthogonal and R lies outside the reach of every reversal the declared refinements admit. A correlation with non-orthogonal branch states is a* partial *record and is not separating; a correlation that an admitted reversal undoes is* reversible *and is not separating either. Not every physical correlation is a record.*

Three cases, enumerated. First, measurement without copy, reversal admitted: the candidate A_{coh} asserting agreeing superposition over S's outcomes has the declared refinement in which $U_{SM}^{\dagger}$ is applied, after which M is uncorrelated and no refinement of that refinement states a separating record; the safe cone exists, $\exists B\, \forall C$ holds, and A_{coh} is valid, the marker's correlation having been reversible. Second, measurement with the copy to E, E outside the reach of $U_{SM}^{\dagger}$: every declared refinement of A_{coh}, the reversed ones included, still has a refinement stating E's record, which is orthogonal across the branches and unreversed, so every B has a C in the base, $\forall B\, \exists C$ holds, and A_{coh} is doomed. Third, measurement with a partial copy, $|e_0\rangle$ and $|e_1\rangle$ non-orthogonal: the refinement stating E's state does not fix the outcome, no base contradiction is reached, and A_{coh} is valid, at a reduced visibility that the overlap $|\langle e_0|e_1\rangle|$ sets, which is the graded case of the complementarity chord. The three cases are the content of the Frauchiger–Renner verdict in miniature: the friend's laboratory is in the second case exactly if some register outside the reach of every admitted reversal carries an orthogonal copy of the outcome, and the no-safe-reversal claim is the claim that an observer-grade laboratory always has such a register.

A gravity-dependent record channel is the same model with E the geometry. If the two branches of S source distinguishable geometries, so that a probe of the metric would read orthogonal branch states, the geometry is a copy register, and the question of subsubsection 14.7.3 is whether a self-consistent admissible configuration exists in which the branch geometries do not separate, the geometry being blended across the branches rather than copied by them; the model poses that question exactly and does not answer it, since the answer requires the coupled matter–geometry problem whose existence the section leaves open.

10.2.4 Only Disagreeing Superpositions Ever Collapse

A recurring misreading of the framework deserves its own treatment here, because it is perhaps the single most common way an otherwise-careful reader imports Copenhagen back into Aethic reasoning. The misreading usually surfaces as the slogan "agreeing superpositions are permanent—they still exist in the prior block universe," offered without specifying which of two structurally different claims is meant. The first reading concerns *selection between* agreeing superpositions: an agreeing superposition is one pocket of the Aethus-valued, occupiable kind, (Section 2.4.7), and a residue may perfectly well contain it alongside disjoint alternatives, with centric unfolding selecting among them—in which case an unselected agreeing superposition is invalidated *wholesale*, exactly as an unselected determinate value is dropped. That happens routinely in the Quantum Nexus pruning, (Section 14.2.6), and nothing about it is forbidden. The second reading concerns *resolution within* an agreeing superposition: the superposition "collapsing," in the subsequent block universe, to one of its own constituent states. That is forbidden outright—not as a dynamical rarity but as a structural impossibility, since an agreeing superposition admits no valid proper child Aethus in which its attribute is state-decomposable,

(Section 2.4.7; the same irreducibility the counterfactual semantics consumes, Section 9.1). The slogan is true on the first reading and Copenhagen-contaminated on the second, and the misreading consists in sliding between them.

The positive statement. The positive statement underneath is this: *the only superpositions that ever collapse are disagreeing ones*—and they were disagreeing before the collapse, not because of it. The intersection of the Quantum Nexus with the system Aethus has already selected a preferred basis, (the informational preferred-basis reading accompanying Theorem 14), and the alternatives of that basis stand to one another in disagreeing superposition; what collapse then amounts to is selection along that already-disagreeing structure, in exactly the intersection-invalidation manner recorded for the semantics, (Section 9.1): the selected pocket's own interior prunes its rivals. An agreeing superposition, by contrast, is intrinsic to its block universe. Within its block it is permanent across all further child Aethae; across blocks, the only operation available against it is wholesale invalidation in favor of a disjoint alternative. There is nothing for a collapse to resolve it *to*.

The determinate node in place of the event. What replaces the Copenhagen collapse event, then, is the determinate node, (Definition 53). Relative to any Aethus for which the outcome attribute is determinate—state-decomposable—the node is predetermined from anywhere in the block universe: the quantum state relative to that Aethus encodes from the outset that the attribute holds its state at the measurement location, and the agreeing superposition of paths in the intermediate spacetime is *constructed upon* that node as a boundary condition rather than interrupted by it, (Section 14.2.6; Assumption 3 of Section 10.2.2). Relative to that Aethus there was never a moment at which the outcome hung undecided: the "collapse" was absolutely certain, and no continuity of anything was disrupted when it arrived. The wavefunction-side statement of this replacement—that a determinate node implies non-unitarity relative to the indexing Aethus, and that perfect unitary evolution over an arena implies the absence of determinate nodes there relative to that Aethus, with no moving present partitioning spacetime on either side—is the Aethic Non-Unitarity Principle, (Principle 54).

Indeterminism relocated one level up. The felt indeterminism is not thereby denied; it is relocated one level up. The determinate-indexing Aethae—one per outcome—stand to one another in disagreeing superposition, so that relative to each individual Aethus the outcome is predetermined, while over the whole collection each Aethus occurs with its weight. The path-integral counterpart is exact: for each determinate outcome, the integral strictly couples initiation to destination, (both endpoint nodes fixed, the initial node inferable as behaving in the same symmetrically-determinate fashion as the destination), and the outcomes then combine as a classical probability distribution over the determinate-indexing Aethae, (Section 6.6.2). The probabilistic uncertainty of measurement lives entirely in *which* determinate-indexing Aethus one occupies, never in any wobble within one—and the one place this structure bleeds through to direct empirical notice is where reduced form coupling lets constraints from the block-universe future enforce present happenings, with Wheeler's delayed choice [10] as the canonical instance.

The common-sense objection, overruled and vindicated. A common-sense objection deserves its answer here, because the framework both overrules and vindicates it. The standard human assumption is that the universe cannot *know* one's measurement outcome before the measurement is made. The framework enforces that it does: relative to each determinate-indexing Aethus, the node is fixed in the block universe, the outcome encoded from the outset. And yet the intuition is vindicated through the back door: the entire timeless establishment of the outcome—the whole block-universe fixing—stands, Aethus-wise, in disagreeing superposition over the outcomes. There is accordingly no single, unconditional, pre-standing fact of *the* outcome the universe knew, and that absence is what the intuition was tracking all along. It was right about the absence, and wrong only about the mechanism: not no fixing anywhere, but one fixing per Aethus, superposed.

The Copenhagen mistake, in one sentence. The Copenhagen mistake can now be stated in one sentence: it conflates basis states in agreeing superposition with basis states enforced as preferred through the seams of the Aethic pruning, and so reads collapse as a disruption of the prior wavefunction's continuity. Aethically, the prior wavefunction is nothing over and above the exhaustive agreeing superposition, unconstrained in the intermediate spacetime between the determinate nodes, (Section 14.2.6); its "continuation through the collapse moment" was never the explicit continuation to begin with, because relative to the determinate-indexing Aethus the endpoint was fixed from the start. This is the same two-roles separation recorded under Assumption 2 of the preceding subsubsection—determinate nonclassicality carried by the agreeing superpositions, the transition bookkeeping carried by the Aethically fixed attributes—promoted here to its own statement because the conflation it guards against is, in practice, the most common failure mode in translating between Copenhagen vocabulary

and Aethic structure. The demotion argument is collected as its own unit in Section 14.2.7.

The landing, for the whole subsection. The four parts of this subsection are one argument run at four grains, and it is worth seeing them as one before leaving them. The cat is the case whose records escape: the counter, the vial, the animal's chemistry, the box's heat, so that "alive" says "and not dead" from the inside and the superposition is disagreeing by the third postulate's checkmate, with no cut drawn and none needed. Wigner's friend is the cat with the box redesigned so that whether the records escape is the whole experiment—and the answer is that they do, because the friend will meet Wigner, so the friend is disagreeing relative to Wigner by the same checkmate, on the framework's one physical claim that observer-grade records cannot be kept in. Frauchiger–Renner is what the case looks like when five classical assumptions are left standing—a proper-time past, a transition at measurement, a monolithic particle, an asymmetry of being between past and future, and a single tribunal—each of which the Sifting Principle removes, so that measurement (the agreeing-to-disagreeing transition, governed by eventual accessibility) and observation (the selection of a pocket) are seen as two operations rather than one event. And the positive statement is what collapse then is: selection among alternatives that were already disagreeing, along a basis the records already picked out, with the felt indeterminism living in which determinate-indexing Aethus one comes to occupy. What never happens anywhere in the four parts is a transition *out of* an agreeing superposition: records make coherence claims invalid whole, and the only thing that is ever selected among is disagreeing. The distinction that does this work—exclusion written into the alternatives or not—is separable from the framework's stronger claims and would survive their failure, which is why the cat, of all the cases in this paper, is the one to teach first.

10.3 Aethic Reasoning and the Realist Quantum Program

10.3.1 Pinpointing the Ontological Nonclassicality in Aethic Reasoning

One of the best articulations I have seen of exactly what is wrong with the Copenhagen interpretation comes from Robert Spekkens[207] in his various descriptions of the phenomenon [6, 7, 102]. In my opinion at least, I find him to have a remarkably sharp intuition toward broadly identifying the nature of what a satisfying quantum theory would look like, especially in contrast with the much more methodologically-mystical and perhaps somewhat defeatist stances I tend to oppose[208]. In the event of an Aethic ontology being legitimate especially, I think his view would be directly validated that there ought to be an irreducible and deeper ontological "switch" distinguishing quantum ontology from classical ontology than is expressible by standard attributions. For instance, he argues that attributing the non-classicality of quantum mechanics to interference effects directly is missing a present but subtle realist contextualization [7, 102], and I for one find this to be precisely correct.

In order to attempt a formal proposed "validation" of these suspicions within an Aethic context, allow me to discuss what comes to mind for me as the pinpointed "nonclassical shift" at the heart of the Aethic ontology, (and also a secondary but not irrelevant consideration).

1. **Agreeing superpositions are categorically nonclassical**. I would state this in terms of three main results.

   (a) As per the Aethic union principle, we find that an agreeing superposition is explicitly distinct as a category from anything ever proposed within a classical metaphysics. That is, the "physical or" we use so commonly in reasoning about reality is entirely a subcategory of "disagreeing superposition", meaning that agreeing superpositions themselves are truly alien to classical metaphysics. It is as if we discovered an extra sister taxon to Earth's entire biosphere—it is both something which has never been articulated as a category in the context of realism[209], nor has ever been encountered outright on its own semantic

[207] Just so I can make sure this is said, *Spekkens called it.*

I particularly mean the Quantum Rosetta Stone [6] concept, which I am specifically proposing is, when realized, the Aethic union principle and its canonical table (Table 3).

[208] Ie what I referred to as "quantum logical antirealism", broadly speaking, which—implicitly or otherwise—proposes the promotion of the quantum black box to a genuine ontology.

[209] The nearest existing family in the literature deserves its coordinates here: the recent work on quantum *metaphysical indeterminacy* [163–166], especially the determinable-based account on which a system may possess a determinable property while lacking any determinate value of it. That is a genuine structural cousin of asserted blankness, and I am glad to point at it. The claim in the main text is intended on its precise reading, however, and survives on it: what has to my knowledge never been articulated is the category *as a logical primitive*—extracted directly from the union principle's placement inside disjunction itself, equipped with an isolation algorithm in the third postulate and with weight

terms, (because we would need to know of it in order to independently semantically define it in the first place). Even stating what agreeing superpositions are is difficult without the Aethic union principle[210], because they are somehow directly indicative of a single object or abstract attribute carrying out multiple events at once, and yet somehow are distinct from a contradiction. Even stating their existence feels like a contradiction until they are articulated in terms of the Aethic union principle.

Once they are articulated, however, perhaps the astounding thing is how they suddenly both are granted a well-defined placement inside of logic[211], and at once may be algorithmically isolated and deduced via the third postulate of the Aethus.

(b) We may write this next part as Aethic reasoning's resolution of a formalizable paradox outright.

Principle 34 (Determinate Background Paradox)
Agreeing superpositions are undefinable in any metaphysical picture where reality is assumed to be epistemologically determinate in the background.

An agreeing superposition is quite literally undefinable in a timeline-branching metaphysics. What an agreeing superposition specifically does is convert a permanent absence of accessibility to a given truth into an ontological primitive category. However, when one has already explicitly confined themselves to a single timeline in the theoretical sense, the issue now becomes that the entire universe is implied perfectly determinate. In order to articulate an agreeing superposition under this model, one would be forced to wash the events from other timelines into their own in a Many-Worlds [2, 3]-type maneuver, however even still a proper agreeing superposition will not have been defined because the base elemental category is still a timeline[212] rather than an Aethic retrieval category. In other words, in a timeline metaphysics theory one is forced to either remain stuck in their single timeline, or construct categories out of sets of timelines—however in an Aethic picture an agreeing superposition could not possibly be accurately articulated by a collection of timelines, because that would then have to infer that all the rest of the event contents in those timelines are determinate besides the events in flux between them, which would now discount the endurance of yet even more agreeing superpositions elsewhere in those timelines. In other words, by using a timeline metaphysics we are forced to put exhaustively enough timelines into our collection such that every single agreeing superposition is in flux, but by removing so much as a single timeline will reduce some of those agreeing superpositions back to classical disagreeing superposition-like states. What this means is that you are forced to either describe all agreeing superpositions in one abstract object, or misrepresent the universe altogether by collapsing a subset of the universe's agreeing superpositions arbitrarily[213].

Why the reversal principle is the answer. This itself is actually the central reason why the Aethic reversal principle is so important to Aethic reasoning: because without it, we would be stuck in this "all or nothing" paradox of describing agreeing superpositions, which frankly does not quite describe them anyway because of its false assertion that they are not reducible into individual agreeing superpositions. That is, the direct reason why a timeline paradigm cannot construct a well-defined agreeing superposition is for just this reason that assuming it could would force us to only be able to describe all agreeing superpositions

machinery—and thereby offered as the *generator* of the quantum–classical distinction rather than as a redescription of quantum indeterminacy after the fact. The cousin literature articulates the phenomenon as metaphysics; the union principle articulates the category as logic, which is exactly what makes it operable.

[210]And indeed, stating the union principle itself was perhaps the most challenging difficulty in my entire process of communicating Aethic reasoning. It is after all very alien.

[211]Due to their placement inside of "logical or" via the union principle, that is.

[212]Which, crucially, is considered to be ontically-categorically nonexistent in an Aethic paradigm anyway.

[213]That is, because the very act of attempting to specify a single agreeing superposition alone implies all others must be collapses, and the act of neglecting to include some agreeing superpositions in one's collection of timelines contradicts the actual reality by decidedly straying from it. This is the sort of thing which is quintessentially unmanageable, because literally the mathematics does not allow you to decompose the problem space and describe individual entities therein. It would be like if every time you tried to perform algebra, setting one variable to a value would make every other variable be set to contradictory values. So, however unconsciously, perhaps this headache has been interpreted as evidence that the quantum black box truly is epistemically antirealist—even though the problem had been a category error in how we describe timelines in the first place. That is, since timelines and agreeing superpositions are already decidedly incompatible, and because quantum mechanics apparently requires agreeing superpositions to exist, we therefore may infer that timelines have obstructed our ability to ontologically rationalize quantum mechanics altogether.

at a time, which itself is categorically contradictory to the property of theirs that they may be described individually. By adding the reversal principle to Aethic reasoning in particular, we resolve this problem by no longer asserting that "all possible information need be determinate" in a given Aethic block universe anyway. Instead, a block universe may be perfectly "ontologically complete" even without its contents being "epistemically determinately complete as opposed to partially-Aethically-blank". This simple reversal between taking "all determinate information" as the elemental unit of reality, (as is a "timeline", "universe", or "possible world") to instead taking "a partially-complete Aethus of information" as the elemental unit of reality removes a fundamental barrier in the way of describing agreeing superpositions mathematically and categorically-accurately. Hence, this is a second major reason why agreeing superpositions are effectively but contradictions in a classical metaphysics, all while being categorically novel *and* algorithmically realist in an Aethic metaphysics.

Another key independent convergence of Aethic reasoning is with the concept of the "self state" in Algorithmic Idealism [17], in the sense that they are converging on nearly exactly the same epistemic-ontological construction. Indeed, I recommend reading Algorithmic Idealism prior to this paper if you wish to develop an intuition for the ontological status of the Aethus, because I feel Müller does a substantially better job of explaining it than I do.

Principle 35 (Internal-External Paradox)
Conventionally attributing Aethic superpositions to the observer's own locational change as opposed to over arbitrary attributes one has access to inadvertently obscures how agreeing superpositions occupy a unified epistemological structure with disagreeing superpositions in the sense of both being directly operable over by the second postulate of the Aethus as different forms of local informational inaccessibility.

One major conventional difference I might name between the Aethus and the self state, however, is informative for how Aethic reasoning addresses the determinate background paradox. My understanding of the self state[214] is that it finds the totality of all instances of the observer's self state across a preexisting space of possibilities, and then effectively associates all of these secondarily to that locating. The major difference with the Aethus, however, is that instead of beginning with this locating, its convention is to place the structure of epistemological consistency with the observer's information at the "inferential center" as if an absolute, and then re-construct the outside universe itself outwardly from this, as if as an effective perturbative structure in Aethic superpositions. So, for example, if you are in disagreeing superposition between standing outside a red house and standing outside a blue house, the self state convention would suppose *you yourself* are in superposition in location within the definite spacetime or abstract spacetime at which the houses hold two separate locations, whereas the Aethic convention would suppose simply that there is a house next to you, *which itself* occupies a disagreeing superposition over being red versus blue in color. So in other words, the former external treatment places your abstract location in disagreeing superposition, whereas the internal Aethic treatment places the attributes defining each object in your surrounding in disagreeing superposition. Just like changes of reference frame in the physics of two moving bodies, notice how these two cases are intrinsically identical in the sense of describing the same system, and so are only conventionally distinct.

The payoff of the internal convention. The key to the Aethic version of the convention, however, is that it innately compels us to consider forming our questions over the space of attributes in the abstract, as opposed to accidentally smuggling in the physical substance of position—which itself is taken to be nonphysical in a similar sense to how general covariance ontologically demotes coordinates. The key payoff of this change of paradigmatic perspective is that agreeing superpositions become easily viewable as categorically unified with disagreeing superpositions in the sense of being operable over by the very same second postulate of the Aethus—which at its root is simply a statement about those abstract Aethic attributes.

What the external convention would cost. In the external convention, however, agreeing superpositions themselves would suffer the illusion of being apparently operationally distinct

[214]And I want to emphasize that my read here may be inaccurate or oversimplified, in which scenario please just attribute the self state as a stand-in for the external versus internal convention proper.

from disagreeing superpositions, which can be illustrated simply by imaging how you would actually even depict an agreeing superposition of an object in your vicinity if you then had to again split the superposition along the seams of your own location as you move to place yourself in multiple different locations. Even at best, you could keep a separate irreducible copy of the agreeing superposition at each one of your new locations, which would blur its role as having to do with a unified epistemology with disagreeing superpositions and the second postulate, and at worst you would have to split it into determinate states at each self-location and once again revert to the classical loss of the agreeing superposition concept altogether. So altogether, it is highly important in the direct paradigmatic sense that Aethic reasoning is structured by the attribute rather than by the agent's own superpositional instance.

(c) As accurately[215] predicted by Spekkens in his paper [102], quantum interference is strictly more concrete than agreeing superposition, even if only subtly so.

Why interference is downstream. The simple reason for this is because wave interference is physical and quantitative, while agreeing superpositions are categorical, logical, and deductively algorithmic. Attempting to describe an agreeing superposition in terms of wave interference is a similar fallacy to treating the distance to the sun as a number with units rather than a distance—it is simply that there are added ontic layers beyond peripheral descriptions of them. When all is said and done, accordingly, agreeing superpositions are necessarily upstream in the realm of abstraction as compared with quantum interference. This was articulated somewhat more extensively in the section on the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, where it was argued that quantum interference effectively "instantiates" agreeing superpositions rather than capturing it fully or abstractly.

This being said, however, I must emphasize that quantum interference is far from irrelevant to the non-classicality of quantum mechanics, it is just simply that interference follows only from agreeing superpositions, so as a high level explanation of *Step X* (though not yet ontologically-complete until the Born rule is deduced) we would state that quantum interference and Bell inequality-violations [4] trigger quantitative nonclassicality, but both are causally dependent on their physical-connotation substrate of agreeing superpositions in order to exist in the first place. Hence, trivially, because the third postulate triggers quantum decoherence or collapse so as to transition to the classical metaphysical special case of Aethic ontology, it therefore follows that none of these quantum effects may persist inside of Aethae which are forbidden under the third postulate. Hence, however it is that *Step X* physically converts agreeing superpositions under the right circumstances to quantum interference, by the third postulate algorithm alone may we accurately and exhaustively categorize all Aethus events into those inducing agreeing superpositions and those which wring them out. So, deductively Aethic reasoning is claimed as a solution to the measurement problem itself because it provides the well-defined exhaustive algorithmic implication which the Copenhagen interpretation lacks[216].

Another explicit example of a fundamental quantum property which turns out to be decidedly downstream of agreeing superpositions is the impossibility of perfect discrimination [167] of non-orthogonal quantum states. The fundamental reframe that comes with agreeing superpositions, after all, is that they allow for an attribute to remain in a stable state which still is altogether not determinate, (so as to perhaps mimic the phenomenology of determinate states in terms of their irreducibility while still remaining decidedly categorically distinct from determinate states).

Orthogonality as a downstream fact. From such a reframe we then suppose that there is not a determinate reality underlying the distinguishing of the states in the first place, and more importantly still the permanence of this overlap gains a significance as indicating the nature of agreeing superpositions as a fundamental primitive, rather than merely being indirectly diagnostic of a procedural analysis of the states themselves. In that sense, then, perfectly orthogonal states are simply those which inevitably occupy a disagreeing superposition[217], but otherwise states will occupy an irreducible overlap—an agreeing superposition—which makes the very prospect of their discernibility an ontic category error to begin with. It is

[215] According to Aethic reasoning.

[216] If you will, all quantum and classical events are "sorted correctly" by Aethic deduction.

[217] Note that this statement is itself a direct corollary of the behavior of the Quantum Nexus's state of associating quantum basis vectors with Aethae pertaining to distinct agreeing superpositions.

not that they are distinct states in the first place, but rather that their overlap describes a single common structure in Aethic ontology, (and only indirectly at that, since agreeing superpositions themselves are merely indicated by the quantum states, but are described with a separate mathematical apparatus).

2. **Aethic extrusion is (merely) dynamically nonclassical**. This is the secondary consideration. While nowhere near the level of overhaul as a categorical shift, I would argue that the more peripheral "Aethic indiscriminate time principle" also played a non-negligible role in making the various statements of Aethic reasoning particularly elusive to the classical eye. That is, rather in the spirit of the omelette of E. T. Jaynes [52, 53], the classical metaphysical concept of time seems very disorganized with respect to when causality is asserted to be purely future-directed versus when causality is employed independently of the flow of time.

   The indiscriminate time principle's subtlety. The indiscriminate time principle itself, then, is subtle enough to evade identification, but also in my mind very clarifying along the pursuit of organizing time into something more contextually satisfying to a realist. The ultimate result of such a reordering is that the classical concept of time is truly unrecognizable to an Aethic worldview, even though Aethic reasoning merely organizes it rather than spontaneously inventing a new primitive category for it.

   I highly recommend viewing Section 9.1 for a complete take on the nonclassicality of the extrusion principle, together with Section 12.1.3 for how that nonclassicality runs against modal structure universal to human language itself. In light of "sheer inaccessibility by humans until now" I might go so far as to rank the extrusion principle as *more* inherently nonclassical than the union principle, because at every step of the way the extrusion principle is fighting the most ingrained features of modal structure across human language itself. In that sense achieving an articulation of it—so as to open up the concept of disagreeing superpositions—is perhaps the hard part, with the extension to agreeing superpositions following more easily. Hence, why I would recommend not underestimating this principle's "humanly nonclassical" character, even if agreeing superpositions alone source the particular causal nonclassicality inherent to quantum mechanics proper.

Concerning my response to Spekkens's[218] intuition for an exotic and abstract mathematical entity[219] beyond sets and functions themselves [7], my proposed structure which fits this criterion is the Aethus structure itself, complete with both the internal structural elements (like the definitional hierarchy and decomposition trichotomy) and the exterior contextual scaffolding (like the Aethic tree and the third postulate). To give a direct example, notice how in the Quantum Nexus integral an Aethus-valued term is introduced—what is important about this is such is genuinely not reducible to the quantitative measures of functions due to its having general informational initial conditions. And furthermore, of course, there is the explicit move of mine to use Aethae as a richer alternative for sets in an arbitrary physical settings, due especially to their equivalence class-based definition and incorporation of probabilistic weighting and Bayesian dynamics intrinsically.

Furthermore, I might address the point Spekkens raised concerning an exotic form of causality and inference, but logically realist causality and inference nonetheless [7]. For the inference portion, there is Aethic reasoning itself of course, which is exotic in the sense of how it starts with all possibilities, anywhere in the block universe so as to neglect timeline ontology outright, and then simply prunes

[218] Altogether though, to be clear what happened here was specifically a convergence in theoretical commitments between me and Spekkens, based on a perhaps striking convergence in intuition—that is, I did not just copy Spekkens outright, the simple reason being that I did not even hear of him until 2025. However once I did, I quickly became impressed with the borderline uncanny similarity between his view for what a realist quantum interpretation would provide, the the nuances of my own goals in Aethic reasoning. Hence, I wrote this section as an extra addition in early 2026, meant to in part represent a deliberate response to his proposed structuring of a realist quantum framework.

[219] To be clear on this point, my claim to satisfying this constraint is strictly about the operability domain rather than the axiomatic-compositional domain. Yes, an Aethus may be written in terms of static Aethae—which are really just sets—but the actual claim for its going beyond is the context in which it is used. That is, plainly speaking, standard quantum mechanics uses Hilbert spaces, various projections, and sometimes the functions within the path integral, but the Aethic move is to be operable over the deeper level of abstraction pertaining to the structural compatibility between states in the context of attribute unions, for which a canonical instance is the powerset invalidation theorem itself. The key is that although the powerset invalidation theorem itself uses sets, it is an instance of the Aethic process which visibly sits at a lower level of abstraction to it, and so you might say that the novelty of the Aethus structure itself is contained in the abstraction step of rendering such a concrete layer general for inductive operability. Hence, why the very move of defining the Aethus itself, directly speaking, requires abstraction which the operability domain of sets is merely something of a lossy projection. This is, exactly speaking, my proposal for meeting Spekkens's criterion for a structure deeper than sets and functions.

away results until the physically-realized outcome is left as the Aethic superposition of what remains. This also ties into where there is nonclassical causality in Aethic reasoning itself. To see this, we might consider how Aethic reasoning reframes observer-consistency directly, but especially how it does so in a way which reproduces all classical empiricism, just though a bizarre mechanism which entirely less direct. That is, the Aethic approach in this respect is to first establish that reality is observer-dependent by the first postulate, which taken by itself would seem to entirely discount observer-consistency. However, the catch is that Aethic reasoning then also asserts the third postulate, which turns this predicament around by stating that interaction between the Aethae of different observers—but note not the intrinsic or objective properties of those Aethae themselves—must be constrained only to those observers which cannot produce contradictions with one another. In effect, what is left is an ontological substrate of informational channels between object and Aethus to take the place of a single objective reality, and yet the way these channels are "organized", if you will, by the third postulate makes classical reality feel identical "from within", even though the substrate "on the outside" is exotic to an extreme. At least in terms of motivation, this reminds me of the relativity of simultaneity[220],

[220]My apologies in advance if this is a slightly charged sentiment, but by reading history—and the Einsteinian special relativistic revolution especially (as pertains to the replacement of the luminiferous ether with the geometry of how Lorentz transformations shift between reference frames [27])—I have come away with an intuitive retrospection, and have taken it to heart during my own research investigations.

Failed theories tend to add new substance to the universe. Successful theories tend to add new reasoning to the universe.

When all is said and done, perhaps the defining crossroads at the very start of my research journey was the moment when, in the days leading up the extrusion principle epiphany, I determined intuitively that the disappearance of the double-slit interference pattern upon detection ought not to be caused by direct physical intervention from the detection itself. I go over the philosophical reasoning behind this in detail during the section on the strong implication criterion, but even just consequentially speaking the main takeaway was this: *the true source has to be an overarching abstract upheaval which lives in a more fundamental logic, and takes either double-slit pattern merely as a downstream representation. In the abstract, then, what actually occurs in the moment is not intrinsic to and cannot be reduced to the wave dynamics at all, but instead have to occupy the rather more "ghostly" state of emerging from the waters of informational structure and manifestation.* This, as you may note, is exactly what I aimed for with the second and third postulates of the Aethus themselves, for which it is the mere state of an agreeing superposition spilling between disjoint states which are in principle distinguishable that prunes the superposition outright. Altogether it is by adopting the reasoning system for how this abstract system behaves as opposed to the earlier lack thereof which reveals the nature of the underlying ontology itself.

I would argue that the arguable core idea of string theory, being to promote some concept of worldsheet to relevance, is quite clever. However, what I want to point out is how string theory does so by postulating strings as a new primitive, which is precisely on the "new substance" rather than "new reasoning" side of things—hence the ultimately problematic character of the theory. What I would have recommended instead is keeping the core idea of worldsheets, but evaluating them as an emergent projection of sorts from something deeper, (which also projects to space itself via different variations of the same projection, as if quotienting), as opposed to dropping them into the system directly. Altogether what I wish to emphasize is how adding strings as a new primitive has minimal graph-complexity in theory space, because it only connects to existing theories via the graph edge of such a primitive introduction, hence why it probabilistically almost surely does not fit the actual universe (precisely as stated, at least—but due to the core idea being good, it probably has shades of similarity to whatever it is the universe is actually doing). The interesting way of looking at this is both that (a) when we look at the actual universe, we with every last scientific revolution see the universe to be vastly more graph-theoretically-interconnected than we expected beforehand, hence why minimal-connectivity is obviously wrong from the beginning, and (b) strangely, if we picture such a graph-connectivity as like a random walk of sorts where nodes are randomly joined by edges, with our own current paradigm then encompassing a random set of nodes from this graph and the edges which connect them (due to human error established at the beginning of civilization being random with respect to the actual graph of the universe) then the probability that we happen to connect to the outside nodes with only one edge is absurdly unlikely (that is, with it instead being likelier that the random node-connecting process should link several nodes within and outside our paradigm sub-graph, with it being combinatorially unlikely that there is a split anywhere, much less along our own paradigm boundary—so a "theory" itself is a proposal for what the total graph looks like somewhere outside the current paradigm, and the odds that this *correctly matches* the universe is weighted by the odds that the actual graph was to coincidentally arrange itself as proposed)—hence being the other reason why it can reliably be ruled out.

The opposite of this issue is also why general relativity worked: everyone was already forcing the existence of (parametrized) time per Newtonian physics, so repackaging it as special relativity used existing primitives, and then once this established spacetime, curving that existing spacetime used existing primitives, hence why even the derivational procedure of general relativity was essentially guaranteed to work from the beginning. (Note that I am strictly talking about ontological primitives here, not theoretic primitives—in that sense Riemannian geometry does not count as "a new primitive" because it is not actually an ontological object, and at that an established ontological object. In the scope of ontological primitives we already forced through the use of ontological time for Newtonian physics to work, hence why repackaging its transformations with space per Einstein's 1905 paper is actually just using the same "ontological stage" material without tacking on a new ontological object). The borderline eerie thing about this, then, is that sufficient understanding of this graph-theoretic methodological content of a theory allows you to infer with high confidence whether a theory will be correct before experiments are actually run—hence why Einstein was right so uncannily often, (and why this falls under the umbrella of supreme inferential awareness rather than mystical ability). By contrapositive, the more surprised a body of researchers are when their theory is unexpectedly ruled out by experiment, (with the canonical example perhaps being supersymmetry), the likelier it is that they are missing this inferential context that was there all

where a fundamentally bizarre form of velocity addition somehow reduces to the same physics from deep inside our classical regime, even though the central ontological mechanism driving this could not be more alien to the naïve view of how it ought to work.

Concisely speaking, however, in terms of the operability criterion of Spekkens's pertaining to exotic causality and inference, I might propose Aethic reasoning as meeting it in terms of the interface between the ontological shift to superposition and the thereby enabled structure of invalid Aethae. I speak about this in the Aethic logic section, but this is crucial—there are effectively two fundamental maneuvers which the devising of Aethic reasoning triggers over the effective phenomenology of "ontic intractability" to what we call contradiction.

1. The first is to contract the set of phenomena which categorize as such, by use of the Aethic union principle as an effective edit to logical classification so that agreeing and disagreeing superpositions may be well-defined as something besides contradiction, and so you might consider this first move as containing the utility toward logical realism of the Aethic union principle and second postulate.

2. Then, the second move is to take this contracted categorization space for the phenomenology of contradiction, and expand it again in an entirely separate way, by use of the stating of the concept of an "invalid Aethus"—a mere abstraction—to which this is assigned, with a formalizable "contradiction" in the sense of Aethic intersections over disjoint stated-attributes is simply a special case and base case to the recursive step that is the third postulate of the Aethus itself.

These two moves, taken in full, effectively assemble the conceptual substrate of Aethic reasoning by fastening the union principle together with the third postulate, so this serves as one part of the exotic causality and inference.

Operability, and the reduced form's two faces. However, there can be no such exotic causality and inference without making that substrate operable, and this, sure enough, is the role for the concept of the reduced form of the Aethus, which procedurally simply marks given elements from an Aethic partition as invalid by means of the full inferential tools available to Aethic deduction from both structure and the postulates[221]. Altogether, then, by means of its dual methodological-inferential and ontological-substantive faces, the reduced form of the Aethus and the substrate over which it operates

along.

Also note that while string theory is maybe an easy example, I would say it certainly fares better than some other problematic examples I have seen of leaning too far toward "new substance". Perhaps a good candidate canonical example for this might be the proposal of "sterile neutrinos", which are meant to explain experimental anomalies from a particular type of neutrino detector [168]. From my ontological graph-based perspective, I would put it this way: *should sterile neutrinos exist, the worrying thing is not explaining their direct properties—it is in that you now have to explain what ontological contextual background they exist in, and how it possibly could have produced them in relation to anything else in that background.* Should sterile neutrinos exist, then we are caught between their existence being ontologically defensible, which happens almost surely impossibly often based on the theory-graph, and their existence implying the entire lacking of a deeper conceptual substrate in which they "are not out of place" per Newton's core principle and moreover "are categorically equivalent to other phenomena up to abstract relabeling of the right concepts" per the avoidance of logical antirealism—thereby providing us with a logical contraindication outright. In other words, adopting the idea of sterile neutrinos is, ontologically, something like taking a payoff of ten dollars today so that you have to pay one hundred dollars per day for the rest of time—it not a favorable predicament in the slightest. Hence, the irony as far as I can tell is in astonishingly-sophisticated experimental practice being juxtaposed with elementary-level theory-building discipline. The interesting thing is when both are packaged as a unit without clear indication of awareness to the vastness of the gap between them.

[221] Fittingly, this itself turns out to be both methodological inference and ontological capacity, which I find particularly satisfying as a stance for its bringing one's Aethus and its behavior into the realm of inferential practice—that is as if daring to reach into something conceptually ethereal and reveal it as methodologically operable in the borderline-synesthetic sense, precisely as did Newton when he reached into the aether and supposed that motion vectors sitting in the room with us could under sufficient suspension of disbelief be held in a mathematician's hand as if concrete. That is, specifically in the sense that those vectors were there in the room long before they entered one's own mind, so when one uses them there springs out the philosophical question of what the nature is for the "copy" one gives oneself of those real vectors when using them inferentially, and what the relationship is between the inferential copy and the ontological copy. More synesthetically rich than this philosophical question still however, I would argue, is the very notion of the moment of realization itself that a never-before-seen bridge exists between an established ontological copy of something a counterpart inferential copy. The content of this richness is not even about the inferential copy existing so much as that it seemed categorically-impossible in the old paradigm that the ontological copy was even compatible with an inferential copy in the first place, and beyond even that that it was even approachable as possibly compatible prior even to landing the surprise that it is compatible outright. After all, the new paradigm comes not from operating over the inferential copy, and it comes not from realizing the existence of the inferential copy—it comes from recognizing that the idea of an inferential copy to that ontological copy is conceivably entertainable to begin with. The moment of realization roots to categorically perceiving the ontological copy as a shape which apparently forms a peg which apparently fits into a wider puzzle, rather than just being a loose block of wood existing only for itself. In the instinctive synesthetic sense, then, my taste points to the philosophical structure around this structure as being equally abstract compared to the question of

is my proposal for realizing Spekkens's modes of exotic causality and inference: the exotic part comes from having to pass through the barrier of the Aethic union principle to so much as even construct an invalid Aethus—as effectively serves to imbue that seed of an alien logically-realist ontology[222] and then disperse it across the structure again as if implicit—and from this almost disconcertingly unassuming vantage the third postulate of the Aethus and Aethic methodological practice sets up shop.

10.3.2 Bell's Theorem and Agreeing Superpositions: The Correspondence in Full

It is worth marking explicitly how Bell's theorem [4] relates to the Aethic ontology, because the relationship is structurally inverted from what one might naively expect. Standard hidden-variable-style programs are *challenged* by Bell violations, because Bell violations are evidence that the postulated underlying determinism does not exist. The Aethic framework is not merely unchallenged by Bell violations but *positively predicted* by them: Bell violations are the direct empirical signature of the agreeing superposition structure that the Union Principle places at the foundation of the ontology.

Bell violations occur precisely because the underlying ontology contains agreeing superpositions of attribute-states which interact with each other in ways that no assignment of single hidden values to those attributes could reproduce. In a specific structural sense, this is the cleanest version of "no hidden variables" available in the foundations literature: not just no local hidden variables (which Bell rules out), and not just no nonlocal hidden variables (which create their own well-known difficulties), but no hidden variables at all, with the apparent need for them dissolving once agreeing superpositions are recognized as permanent Aethic objects requiring no underlying determinate ontology to ground them.

The correspondence deserves to be walked rather than waved at, so here is the structure end to end. An entangled pair is, Aethically, one agreeing superposition of *joint* attribute-states—a single irreducible pocket, (Sections 2.4.3 and 2.4.7), not two correlated lists of hidden values. The four quantities Bell-type arguments quantify over—the outcome the first wing would yield at setting a and at a', and the outcome the second wing would yield at b and at b'—are counterfactual determinate states, and the hidden-variables premise is the assumption that all four possess simultaneous determinate values: in this paper's vocabulary, that the Aethic intersection of the four counterfactual determinate states is a *valid* Aethus. Irreducibility forbids exactly this. An agreeing superposition admits no valid child in which its attribute is state-decomposable, and stating any specific value contradicts the structure as a whole, (the prohibition on singleton selection, Section 9.1)—so the four-way intersection is invalid, no single Boolean pocket houses all four outcomes at once, and Fine's joint distribution has nothing to be a distribution over. And what the structure supplies *instead* of hidden values is interaction: with the interior negations absent, (Section 2.4.4), the co-present joint states genuinely interact, and the observed correlations are carried by reduced form coupling—validity-preserving pruning of joint configurations, (Section 6.6.2)—which is neither a signal nor a shared antecedent cause. Locality is untouched on both of its layers throughout, (Section 12.4.11).

A historical-mathematical coordinate makes this inversion precise—and it runs, fittingly, through Boole himself. In the 1850s and 1860s, Boole derived what he called the "conditions of possible experience": inequalities that the probabilities of logically connected events must satisfy if they are to arise as marginals of a single joint distribution on one sample space [63, 83]. Pitowsky later identified Bell-type inequalities as exactly instances of Boole's conditions [83], and Fine's theorem supplies the modern hinge: the CHSH inequalities are jointly satisfiable if and only if there exists a joint probability

linking the finished inferential and ontological copies as that question itself is compared to the concrete room in which things occur itself—and this is why I feel it has a particularly rich sense of content within it. *What can be said about the content of human perception of the world, both intrinsic and situational, given these moments of transition under which an ontological copy of something is realized entertainable as producing by linkage a counterpart physical copy?* It is almost like the actual carrying out of recognizing the inferential copy is humanity pressing the very front of its epistemic capacity, because the very boundary of our awareness interpolated by the Stone Age through the modern era is shaped by what we recognize not only as being real, but what we recognize is entertainable under the question of whether it is real.

This is perhaps the core of the phenomenology of carrying out Aethic reasoning for me, which is that it has entered into operable vision something which has not only been solely perceived as ethereal but has not even been entertained as possibly, conceivably otherwise. Hence, among methodology why I get a feeling of satisfaction for the casting of light onto this feature of the universe, as if to push forward another front to the Newtonian "clockwork universe" in the most synesthetic, satisfactory sense. In a word, it feels almost like, as I sit even in a random café on a random day, by imagining the Aethic postulates in my mind I have somehow tangibly reduced the gap to my own ontological Aethus, while at once having not physically affected it at all. Like those Newtonian vectors and derivatives, it has long predated my conscious thinking and yet somehow enters it anyway once I know *what* to think.

[222] And, in fairness, the temporal ontological scaffolding of the extrusion principle itself, which retrospectively is implicit in this alien ontology but beforehand is one more constraint in need of succeeding with.

distribution over all four (counterfactual) measurement outcomes [82]. The Aethic translation is then immediate, and is recorded here as a correspondence inviting full proof: *Bell violation obtains exactly when the Aethic intersection of the relevant counterfactual determinate states is an invalid Aethus.* The nonexistence of Fine's joint distribution, said in this paper's vocabulary, is the nonexistence of a single Boolean pocket housing all four outcomes at once—with locality untouched on either side of the equivalence, and with the counterfactual semantics of Section 9.1 supplying the truth conditions under which the surviving discourse remains well-defined. The same Boole whose disjunction the Union Principle reforms thus also supplies, through his conditions, the precise mathematical sense in which agreeing superpositions are structure his sample spaces could never host.

The correspondence's two directions can accordingly be sketched at the grain presently available, pending the full proof the statement above invites. If the four-way intersection is valid, the surviving pocket is a single sample space assigning simultaneous values to all four counterfactual outcomes; Fine's hinge then delivers the joint distribution, and the CHSH inequalities are satisfied—no violation. If the intersection is invalid, then by the same hinge no joint distribution exists, the Boolean bound loses its premise, and the quantum value is free to exceed it—with the *amount* of the excess determined not by the invalidity itself but by the weights the Quantum Nexus assigns to the surviving agreeing structure, (Principle 50). Invalidity opens the door; the kernel decides how far through it the statistics walk.

The rhetorical situation is then worth stating with the bluntness it deserves, because the theorem that ended a research program here changes sides. Bell's theorem is a filter. Local hidden-variable programs are killed by it outright [4]. Nonlocal hidden-variable programs survive it at the cost of a preferred foliation and ontology-level dependence on distant settings, (the difficulty the EPR analysis locates, Section 2.5). Superdeterministic programs survive it at the cost of failing the *ad hoc*-proofing test, (Section 12.7). The Aethic structure passes the filter by the one route none of these take: it does not add variables, and it does not constrain the experimenters; it removes the premise that there are values to hide. Counterfactual definiteness fails natively, (the quantum wing of Section 9.1), while the counterfactual discourse remains fully truth-apt—and the same structure that walks through the filter *predicts* the violations as its empirical signature, which is the difference between escaping a theorem and being confirmed by one.

Three of Spekkens's coordinates land here, and each lands on the constructive side. Wood and Spekkens proved that no classical causal structure—direct cause, reverse cause, or common cause—explains Bell correlations without fine-tuning [100]; the agreeing-superposition coupling is this paper's candidate for the exotic-but-intelligible structure that verdict calls for, (Section 10.3.4). Spekkens's negativity–contextuality equivalence [169] is the same fact read representationally: no non-negative distribution over a single sample space reproduces the statistics, and the invalid four-way intersection *is* the refusal of that single sample space, stated in Boole's own vocabulary, (Section 10.3.5). And the demand for causality that is "exotic but logically realist" is met at the level of the logic itself: the agreeing superposition is the excluded-middle edge case made physical, (Section 2.4.13), so Bell violations are, in the end, the empirical face of that logical regime—nonclassical in exactly the located sense, and realist all the way down, (Section 10.3.1).

It is also worth noting that the Aethic treatment of agreeing superpositions during measurement is structurally distinctive. Copenhagen [23, 24] collapses the superposition into a definite eigenstate; the original superposition ceases to exist. Many-worlds [2] preserves unitary evolution but splits the observer across branches; no single post-measurement observer accesses the superposition as the unified object it was. Bohmian mechanics [72, 73] denies there was an agreeing superposition of particle positions to begin with. Aethic reasoning treats agreeing superpositions as permanent objects, with measurement being not their resolution but the agent's centric unfolding into a specific one of them. There is no Aethic operation which could convert an agreeing superposition into a single-state Aethus—and even the "definite outcomes" of measurement are themselves agreeing superpositions of paths[223], meaning that what looks empirically like "getting a definite answer" is structurally more like "entering a specific agreeing superposition" than "revealing what was secretly determinate all along." This is the strongest form of the no-determinate-reality commitment: not only is there no underlying determinism beneath the unknowns, but even the outcomes of measurement are themselves agreeing superpositions all the way down. If you will, "permanently indeterminate states" themselves become irreducible primitives which may be operated over equivalently[224] to how determinate states are.

[223]For reference, see the Quantum Nexus section (Principle 50), for which it is postulated that quantum observable basis states themselves are actually structurally equivalent to particular agreeing superpositions of paths.

[224]That is, in the sense that you may assign an Aethus to a given agreeing superposition and then run the relevant Aethic arithmetic over it—all while strictly disallowing the reduction of said agreeing superposition into determinate states, precisely equivalently in a sense to how "determinate states cannot progress toward being *more* determinate",

10.3.3 Aethic Reasoning and ψ-Epistemic Positions

The reason I would argue that Aethic reasoning is not refuted by the Pusey–Barrett–Rudolph theorem (PBR) [170] is rather simple: *Aethic reasoning is technically not naive*[225] *ψ-epistemic [171] to begin with.* However, what I must emphasize is that Aethic reasoning is not ψ-ontic either, and in truth it is significantly closer to ψ-epistemic out of the two. The way I would describe Aethic reasoning in this contest is that it has an absolute dependence on an epistemic component, and another absolute dependence on an ontic component, and the tie between them is the first postulate of the Aethus itself. Due to being comprised of both, however, you cannot reduce Aethic reasoning to a single one, and hence it is neither truly ψ-epistemic nor ψ-ontic. In fact, the exemption can be stated offensively rather than defensively: the ontological models framework's background space of ontic states Λ is precisely an epistemologically determinate background in the sense of the Determinate Background Paradox (Section 10.3.1), and so a theorem which quantifies exclusively over such backgrounds cannot even address the agreeing superposition as a category in the first place—the exemption is a corollary of the paradox, not a technicality of definitions.

And one further line belongs in this response, engaging not the PBR premise itself — one preparation ranging over nonorthogonal states, with no two-agent structure to attack — but the nested-observer protocols standardly run alongside it: the Frauchiger–Renner family [92] requires two agents to hold *distinct pure* states of one system, which, in the present terms, is two distinct agreeing superpositions over the same alternatives. Distinct pure-state assignments are not thereby contradictory agreeing superpositions: $|+\rangle$ and $|-\rangle$ are distinct pure states with the same support, differing in phase and not in any on-set, and assignments made at different indices are not jointly stated at one index without a rule licensing their import, which the indexing withholds. What the framework assesses is instead the coherence claim one agent holds of the colleague's whole laboratory, under the record-admissibility criterion of Lemma 5. Both exist in the Aethic multiverse; the inter-agent inference the protocol needs is never jointly indexable by observers who can meet. The protocol's pressure thus lands on a configuration the framework forbids before the argument begins, the coherent preparation from which its inferences are drawn; which of the protocol's labeled inferences fails in consequence is not identified here, since identifying it requires the probabilities of an attempted implementation.

The resolution deserves its full form here, because the framework earns the epistemic *flavor* that motivated ψ-epistemic models without the commitment the theorem executes—and the mechanism is the framework's own nesting machinery, not an added epicycle. Different agents, per their different Aethae, genuinely *can* hold different classical probability distributions over quantum states: an agent whose books carry a mixed-state disagreeing superposition over preparations holds exactly such a distribution, and two agents with different books hold different ones. But relative to any *given* Aethus, that other agent is themselves a disagreeing superposition—one agent-version per preparation pocket—whose weights reproduce the agent's own mixed-state weighting exactly, by the same nesting consistency that governs Wigner's friend. And the pattern here is not merely analogous to but an *instance* of the partition-consistency law recorded with the counterfactual semantics, (Section 9.1): the other agent's standing disagreeing superposition is an exhaustive Aethic partition, its pockets may carry weight-assignments as divergent as they please, and the exhaustive sum hands back one's own weighting exactly—routes redistribute, the partition-sum is invariant, whether the "route" is an

just for the reason of the inherent irreducibility rather than being already exhaustively determinate with no leeway for further directly blank attributes to be filled in.

[225] A key nuance I feel the need to elaborate on here is that I have never really loved the whole label of ψ-ontic versus ψ-epistemic [171] in the first place, because depending on who you ask you get a different definition for what the categories are and what the dichotomy stands for—but worse yet most people using the terms do not seem to even realize that they are using different definitions than the next person. There is such a thing as philosophical rigor just as there is mathematical rigor—and categorically speaking this kind of conflation has the character of a crisis should you transport it into any other field. Imagine if a commonly used everyday word, in a random 30% of cases, meant the exact antonym of its standard meaning—from then on using the word would compound uncertainty about what was being said. Now, my understanding is that it is not the fault of Spekkens himself that this issue is arising, because he himself articulates a definition that I find meaningful—but crucially the definition which PBR [170] contests is not even that definition. PBR is talking about the contingency in pure quantum states based on different perspectives, but that itself is certainly not the view I hold of the epistemic status of the Aethus anyway—rather agreeing superpositions are fixed relative to any agent with which a person may interact, and so the whole topic of switching out different pure quantum states for an underlying system is peripheral and besides the point of my argument to begin with. So my view of what is happening here is that every side using the terms ψ-ontic and ψ-epistemic are locally mathematically rigorous, but not globally philosophically rigorous—because rigor in the global sense requires that a term has a consistent meaning to begin with—otherwise it can be made to refute any argument you wish.

So to be clear, I am not dismissing the terms in their most meaningful definition, but I am hesitant to ever use them myself because someone will just be sure to guess their definitions wrong again.

interpolating acquisition of one's own or another agent entire. The playing field beneath the nesting is the extrusion kernel itself—the permanence of the prior state relative to its Aethus—without which agent-versions could not stand as terms to be summed over at all, (Section 2.1). The theorem's setup is therefore dissolved rather than violated: there is never one un-indexed ontic state that two overlapping distributions co-describe, because relative to a single Aethus, state-assignments are unique, and across Aethae the differences are real but never co-located claims about one common background. And the agreeing-superposition analogue closes the remaining door. Agents whose *agreeing*-superposition attributions contradict are barred from ever meeting by the third postulate, for the reason the only-disagreeing collapse rule already encodes: a contradiction between agreeing superpositions is no less a contradiction than one between determinate values, since an agreeing superposition bears an irreducible, non-singleton likeness to a determinate state—the same ontological grade, so far as the pruning is concerned—and the checkmate machinery treats it accordingly.

The mechanism just given is a special case of a broader fact about the framework's indexing, one that casual usage hides and that deserves flat statement. Whenever one refers to "someone else's Aethus" as if it were an exact object, what is actually being referred to, relative to one's own Aethus, is a particular Aethus drawn from that agent's *standing disagreeing superposition* of possible agent-indexed Aethae. From here, the other's information state is never a single determinate object; it is a weighted family of candidates, and "their Aethus" is pocket-talk—the selection of one candidate for the sake of discussion. Nor does learning repair the asymmetry into identity. If one later comes to know more of the other's traversal through the Aethic tree, that knowledge arrives by *one's own* centric unfolding—their travel is attained as my unfolding, never imported directly—and even then the unfolding only *narrows* the family of candidates rather than solidifying it to the exactness of one's own traversal. The Epistemological Reversal Principle, (Section 8's statement that information has priority over fully specified worlds), is what makes the narrowing the *complete* story, there being no residual world-grade fact left unattained beyond what the unfolding carves; and the weights case instantiates it exactly: learning that the agent in fact held one distinct weight-set for the mixed state is nothing but one's own centric unfolding into the pocket where they do—the attainment is one's own step along the tree, never an importation of theirs, and the pre-learning average across their standing superposition was, all along, one's own weighting. The Epistemological Reversal Principle, (Section 8's statement that information has priority over fully specified worlds), is what makes the narrowing the *complete* story: there is no residual world-grade fact of "their exact Aethus" left unattained beyond the information one's unfolding carves, because the framework's primitive was never the fully specified traversal in the first place. The other's journey therefore stood in disagreeing superposition relative to this Aethus all along, before any unfolding began—which is exactly the standing structure the resolution above cashes in.

Simply put, the irreducibly ontic component of Aethic reasoning is the agreeing superposition, in the sense that an agreeing superposition, physically speaking, is a constituent of reality with a physical content independently of one's own knowledge about it. That is, in the sense of the Aethic union principle, an agreeing superposition is a physical property of the pockets of the ladder ontology, even though it is peripherally *indexed* by Aethae. Put another way, agreeing superpositions, as physical phenomena, are closer to the physically occurring quantum effects pertaining to inductive bridging than they are to pre-retrieval Aethic structure of any sort. The Aethic retrieval tells you where to find agreeing superpositions, but it does not *compose* them to begin with. Altogether, agreeing superpositions are entirely separable from one's own Aethus, and exist in the outside universe—it is simply the nature of invalid segments of a pocket as per the ladder ontology interior negations which, relative to a particular inhabitant of physical space, as per their Aethus disallows them physical access or interaction to a particular agreeing superposition or another, (as opposed to spawning said agreeing superposition in or out of existence on the side of it itself).

The next crucial point for developing the Aethic argument, however, pertains to the irreducibly epistemic component, and this is the part that is subtle: due to the first postulate of the Aethus, like anything else an agreeing superposition's state of existence may be arbitrarily altered by virtue of switching between Aethae, which conceptually means that we may "index in or out of existence" any arbitrary agreeing superposition by "switching perspective" to a different ontological Aethus in the abstract. Another way of putting this is that in the space of all possible valid Aethae period, there absolutely exist two different observers whose Aethae respectively hold the existence versus nonexistence of any given agreeing superposition in question, effectively indexing it by Aethus accordingly. The subtle and important part, however, is that unlike disagreeing superpositions—for which one observer might hold is a disagreeing superposition relative to their Aethus while another holds the relevant state

is determinate, or a further pruned disagreeing superposition, or what have you—no two observers who are capable of interacting within the Aethic multiverse may ever disagree about whether a state is an agreeing superposition or otherwise determinate. This is because the third postulate of the Aethus prunes not only the Aethus of their interaction as an Aethic contradiction, but prunes every Aethus in which their interaction is even passively possible, thereby conceptually splitting them into "alternate Aethic universes" in quite the same sense as oneself and their own alternate history selves who observed separate determinate states at a probabalistic juncture. So, to recap, observers certainly exist in the full Aethic multiverse whose Aethae disagree on whether a given agreeing superposition exists or is otherwise determinate, but no observer one can ever interact with can disagree about this, precisely as they cannot disagree about any given determinate state you have measured like the outcome of a coin flip.

The perhaps profound consequence of Aethic reasoning, therefore, is that agreeing superpositions exist independently of one's own epistemic existence, however because contingent truths are arbitrarily perturbable with the switching to distinct Aethae by the first postulate of the Aethus, the equivalence class of oneself and all observers with which one can interact must agree about whether a given state is in agreeing superposition or not, (that is once it is stated in the Aethus as an agreeing superposition or state-decomposable one way or the other). Accordingly, an agreeing superposition itself is not physically contained in the structure of one's epistemic system—it is merely that the guardrails on that which one can ever possibly interact are set by epistemic consistency with them. So, the direct application to PBR is that those observers which attribute distinct pure quantum states to a system are of a non-interacting Aethic block universe anyway: the quantum state describes the state of the paths in the Quantum Nexus, and an Aethus simply indexes this. Like Spekkens, Aethic reasoning concerns fundamental upper limitations [172] to how much information may exist in a quantum system—as per the agreeing superposition as fundamental unknowability concept, (again as indexed by one's Aethus for personal interactivity-visibility about an objective agreeing superposition)—as opposed to claiming one may change the particular contingent information of the quantum system by switching between epistemic perspectives which themselves are capable of mutual interaction. If you will, you may backwardly-deduce from the Aethic postulates information about what must have been true about your Aethus to allow you interactive access to a given agreeing superposition, and this is the nature in which there is a correspondence between permanently-indeterminate information and the objective physical contents which are made visible to one's particular Aethic block universe.

10.3.4 Causal Neutrality, and a Reichenbach-Correspondence Conjecture

The Wood–Spekkens / Allen et al. program for quantum causation is engaged at its natural mechanical home, the reduced form coupling catalog, (Section 6.6.2), and at the delayed-choice analysis of the duality program. One further branch of the same program deserves its own coordinate here, because it converges on this framework's *temporal* claims rather than its coupling claims. Leifer and Spekkens [173] develop quantum theory as a *causally neutral* theory of Bayesian inference: whereas classical conditioning is indifferent to whether the conditioning relation is cause-to-effect (one system at two times) or common-cause (two systems at one time), the conventional quantum formalism treats the two cases differently, and their conditional-states formalism repairs the asymmetry—with remote steering recast as mere belief updating about one system given information about another, and predictive and retrodictive inference running on a single propagation rule. Schmid, Selby, and Spekkens [8] then draw the general moral: causal and inferential concepts must be revised *jointly*, neither reducible to the other. Each of these has an Aethic counterpart that was derived independently and from the inductive direction: causal neutrality is the indiscriminate time principle together with the reduced form coupling's indifference to proper-time ordering; steering-as-updating is the extrusion principle's EPR verdict, (Section 2.5), on which Alice's measurement re-indexes Alice and never touches Bob's particle; the predictive–retrodictive unification is the boundary-value reframe, (Section 12.4.13); and the joint revision of causation and inference is the dual causality principle together with the first postulate's tie between the epistemic and the ontic.

These convergences sharpen into one statement worth recording as a conjecture. Allen et al. [101] show that, under the assumption that quantum dynamics is fundamentally unitary, a channel compatible with A being a complete common cause of B and C must factorize in a particular way—their quantum Reichenbach condition. **Conjecture (Reichenbach correspondence).** *The quantum-Reichenbach factorization condition is the density-operator image of reduced form coupling across the proper children of a shared parent Aethus, with the office of the unitarity assumption discharged by validity itself.* If the conjecture holds, the residual difference between the two programs—a directed

causal graph with quantum-state relata on one side, a constraint structure with a parent Aethus on the other—is a difference of presentation rather than of explanatory type; if it fails, the precise point of failure will localize what "causal" still means once the classical triad is gone. Either outcome is informative, which is what makes the conjecture worth stating.

The structural side of this conjecture — why no member of the classical triad was ever privileged in the first place, and what survives of screening-off once the producer reading dissolves — is developed at subsection 9.9, whose Reichenbach paragraph and this conjecture state one claim at two grades: the coupling as the ground of correlation there, its density-operator image here.

10.3.5 Negativity, Contextuality, and the Commutative Semiring Constraint

Spekkens proved that negativity of quasiprobability representations and (operational) contextuality are equivalent notions of nonclassicality [169]: no quantum-reproducing representation exists in which all preparations and measurements receive non-negative distributions over a single sample space. The Aethic architecture should be read as *complying* with this theorem structurally rather than evading it. The weight calculus runs non-negative throughout the classical regime, and where signed weights enter the tree they do so without term-level annihilation, so invalid Aethae keep their unique-label character, (the signed-weights design of Section 4.7.4); that same design is what makes the complement $A - AB$ well-defined at the validity tier while leaving it undefined at the finer one, (Section 4.7.4)—the subtraction that builds the complement is the union-domain subtraction whose signed weights never annihilate labels, so the complement is a valid-content object and nothing else; the single sample space is exactly what the framework refuses, since agreeing superpositions are irreducible wholes rather than distributions over finer determinate states; and the signed structure that quantum statistics requires is quarantined *interior* to those wholes, in the cosine kernel of the Quantum Nexus, (Principle 50), where it is integrand content of a single agreeing element and never a weight carried by any Aethus—precisely the discipline the polarized-double-slit working enforces when it forbids selective invalidation inside a powerset element, (Section 14.6.3). The framework is therefore "contextual" in exactly the operational sense the theorem demands, while keeping its weight calculus Kolmogorov-shaped where Kolmogorov structure belongs. One obligation is logged accordingly for active reasoning, (Section 14): fermionic exchange antisymmetry—the minus sign acquired under particle interchange—was on the previous non-negative design forced to be a kernel-interior fact; with signed tree weights now admitted, (Section 4.7.4), the kernel-interior route remains the natural hypothesis but is no longer forced, and determining where the sign actually lives is a sharp test the kernel program must eventually pass.

Two records-side neighbors deserve naming here as well. Consistent histories is the powerset construction's nearest formal cousin, and the differentia are kernel-freeness at the classification stage and an index that is derived rather than chosen per framework, (the exactness contrast belongs against the decoherence program, whose basis is emergent and approximate—not against Griffiths, whose consistency conditions are themselves exact). Quantum Darwinism's thesis that the environment is a prolific keeper of records is one sentence of this framework's third postulate, with the difference that here the record's significance is validity-theoretic rather than dynamical. And at the slogan that the boundary is informational, Spekkens's toy theory earns its citation: the closest existing demonstration that informational restriction alone generates interference-adjacent phenomenology [5].

Spekkens's suspicion vindicated, and his program corrected. The relation deserves stating in full, because it is two-sided and the second side is the more informative. Spekkens's suspicion has two parts: that the quantum state is not the ontology but something closer to a probability distribution, and that the standard puzzles arise from scrambling inferential structure into ontological structure [5, 8]. Both are borne out here. The state is literally the polarization of the cluster weights, a probability-first object, (Lemma 8); and the record-first order of the axiomatization *is* the unscrambling, records on the ontology side and amplitudes on the inference side, (Section 14.3). His program, however—a classical ontology under an epistemic restriction, of which the toy theory is the model—is what the present framework shows to be one ingredient short, and the ingredient is exactly the one the toy theory's own limits point to. An epistemic restriction on classical states leaves every unknown attribute *unknown*: determinate beneath, hidden from the agent. It cannot produce a blank that is *open*—the second postulate's constructive blank, a superposition over its answer space with no determinate value beneath it—because openness is not a restriction on knowledge of a classical state but a fact about the state itself. That is why the toy theory reproduces so much of the phenomenology and stops exactly at contextuality and Bell violation: those are the places where the difference between unknown and open is empirically visible, and the Deflation Reductio, (Theorem 4), is the theorem that says so, refuting the unknown reading wherever the statistics violate the bounds and granting it wherever they do not.

So the suspicion is vindicated—the state is not the ontology, and the disease was the scrambling—and the ontology beneath turns out to be indexed rather than classical, with the constructive blank in the place the epistemic restriction occupied. Read that way, the present framework is not a rival to Spekkens's program but the account of why his own construction stopped where it did, and what it needed in order to go on.

There is a compact historical claim sitting at the end of this response, and it deserves its own paragraph rather than burial in a footnote. The framework obtains its quantum statistics — the complementarity trade-off, no-signaling, the bins of the classification — from brute combinatorial structure, painting the quantitative content onto the combinatorial bins the axioms establish rather than taking quantum uncertainty as a primitive; and the Copenhagen tradition injects exactly the same macroscopic intervention through its collapse postulate, only placed where it arrives entangled with the dynamics. The mystery, in other words, was a placement decision. The logically antirealist mysticism of quantum mechanics — the omelet Jaynes named [52, 53], which Schmid, Selby, and Spekkens have pressed the field to unscramble [8] — was a human injection: the act of situating the collapse axiom where it makes things hardest, methodologically and ontologically, for oneself. Removing it is accordingly not a reinterpretation of the mystery but the withdrawal of its cause, which is what satisfying Spekkens's sufficiency criterion [7] amounts to in practice.

10.4 Aethic Logical Determinism and the Completeness of Quantum Mechanics

It was noted earlier in the paper that Aethic reasoning is logically deterministic, and this is so. However, note that it is nonetheless still indeterministic[226] in the philosophical sense, specifically meaning that it contradicts the specific doctrine that is titled "determinism." The reasoning for this follows from the demotion of classic causality in the Aethic system.

By logically deterministic, we merely mean that Aethic reasoning's postulates themselves are invariant and always generate the same reality given the same states of information—even if said reality is a superposition. Even centric unfolding is generally logically deterministic, because for every child Aethus which goes one way, all other child Aethae are also generated relative to their parent Aethus via centric unfolding. This entire net system, then, is still invariant.

So, specifically, any lingering assertions of logical indeterminism can be waived away as collecting themselves in the unit ontological objects of superpositions, which themselves operate in strict invariance given their corresponding Aethic postulates and data. In a funny twist of fate, then, god indeed does not play dice[227] [174] with the universe.

To be abundantly clear about what is being stated here, this works because the classical assumption that logical implications and physical causality are synonymous is, Aethcially, more or less fiction. Instead of this, we see that physical causality is merely an approximation of logical implications, and if anything a *bad* approximation. This will be elaborated upon more in the causality section. But if the supposed connection were true, then the myriad of consequences would be as well, such as the deterministic causal chain existing, with it implying no free will, etcetera. But, Aethically, we see that this base postulate was never a thing in the first place, and as such derivations like this fall apart. In total, Aethic reasoning maintains logical implications, but in doing so severs its connection with physical causality. This is why it can hold Aethic reasoning implies logical determinism yet does not imply physical determinism—it is merely because the two are taken as inherently separate.

This assertion in Aethic reasoning that quantum mechanics is logically deterministic, and through this rationally comprehensible, is one of its major successes. There is something of a pessimistic universal ideal about quantum mechanics in the world as of the writing of this—which is that it sits firmly beyond the realm of human understanding—specifically on account of our brains not being "wired" to understand it. Instead, we evolved as hunter-gatherers, and as such the quantum phenomenon cannot be grasped or traversed by the human mind in any way, shape, or form due to this immortal deviation of our environments. Now, I think we will come to find that this mindset was a major intellectual fallacy of our time. First of all, that is not how a mind works. It can rationalize anything

[226]That is to say, the progression of an agent through Aethae is always Markovian in the sense that a future Aethus cannot be exactly predicted, however the probability distribution across them can. Aethic reasoning, however, is fully logically deterministic in the sense that logic is not antirealist within the structure, and deduction itself is well-defined even in the context of quantum mechanics, which is usually an edge case of logical realism.

[227]I should note, however, that my own interpretation of this quote is not that Einstein was saying "god is not random with the universe" but rather that "god is not careless with the universe". The Copenhagen interpretation is, after all, notoriously careless!

that exists, just some things may be more difficult to grasp than others. It is understandable why we would think quantum mechanics is this intangible and incomprehensible madness in the metaphorical shredder of reality, (especially due to our oft held assertion that the macroscopic and microscopic are different), however our takeaway, now that we know this is not the case, should be to realize that such a concept isn't exactly ontologically possible anyway, and if anything is a logical contradiction of sorts. If something did not operate by rules, then it would not exist. So if we do not know the rules, that means we do not know them *yet*—not that they are nonexistent—rather such a notion doesn't even mean anything in an ontological sense. And given that we have the ability to mentally traverse rules, it follows that any rules are rules that we can, well, mentally traverse. If this seems trivial to the point of being a leap of faith of sorts, then consider it a postulate.

I would like to end this section with a long overdue tribute to Einstein's view on the quantum phenomenon. He has been slandered by many for about a century now for his views on quantum indeterminism, and the "spooky action at a distance"[228] that is the quantum wavefunction collapse. The truth is, summarizing Einstein's entire viewpoint with the EPR paper [11] or any other individual argument is a mischaracterization at best, and audaciously insulting to his legacy at worst. Think about where you would be without this man before you open your mouth. Now, this all being said, Einstein is, as is common knowledge, remarkably brilliant, and held remarkably sharp intuitions. So it is rather disappointing that the community not only failed to listen to his final intuition—being that quantum mechanics is fundamentally incomplete—but that we then attributed this to his age or lack of sharpness rather than showing him the decency of hearing him out in full. All the hype with Bell's theorem [4], in my mind, is completely overrated accordingly. See how quickly I found a workaround for all of that at the start of this paper? And how beneficial it was to incorporate the Einsteinian insights into this broader message? I would not have done such a thing if I didn't genuinely take him seriously. I should mention while I'm here that many people do show him that respect, which is great. *You know who you are.* Philosophically, though, there is still something of an understanding that either Bohr or Einstein needs to be right. But is this not binary thinking? Can they not both be right together?

So, to be explicit about this, we have taken the Einsteinian eternalist mindset, and have made it ontologically keystone to the Aethic mindset, by virtue of representing each cross section to the Aethic dimension as one such block universe. Then, we incorporated the Bohrian notion of superpositions, in effect allowing us to gather a full, and more accurate, ontology of the universe. In the end, Einstein was not wrong—quantum mechanics was indeed incomplete. So I think a few people owe Einstein an apology, at least in spirit.

10.4.1 A More Extensive Interpretation of Einstein's Intuition

I have heard many explanations over the past few years of why exactly Einstein had an issue with Copenhagen quantum mechanics, ranging from a purported dislike of probability, to a dislike of superposition, to a dislike of antirealism. The issue I feel with all of these explanations, however, is that they fail to explicitly capture the truer axiomatic cataclysm faced by the Copenhagen interpretation that I myself have come across through intuition. Effectively, then, here is a short argument in which I attempt to explain my perspective on Einstein's intuition, that is assuming that his intuition was a close if not exact match to my own. It has taken me some time to translate this intuition into an explicit statement, but this is what I believe is the best fit.

In short, the metaphorical hole in the hull of the Copenhagen interpretation is not that it clashes with some arbitrary standard of realism, but rather that *it can be anything you want it to be.* To unpack this a bit, we know from the history of physics that the hallmark of a good theory is the ability to restrict possibilities in a dynamic and inductively-viable way. Take Newton's laws of motion, for example. The thing which makes these laws so powerful is their ability to answer any related question through their use, (as we know through their profound implications to classical mechanics). That is, had they allowed for any outcome of a system besides the one predicated without ontological preference, then they would be no better than the lack of a theory altogether. To be more explicit about this still, let us consider exactly what would be so catastrophic about taking a contradictory logical statement like "$1 = 0$" as an axiom to mathematics. Practically speaking, the catastrophe is that such a contradiction implies every statement, rather than only the subset of statements which are useful when taken as true. This is perhaps the most direct possible example of why a contradiction makes for poor realized ontology: beyond even its metaphysical implausibility, in the practical domain

[228] Notice, also, that Einstein was a hundred percent right that the Copenhagen interpretation's implication of such a spooky action at a distance is unacceptable in an ontological theory. As such, what truly is wrong with his standpoint?

we have that its ability to imply anything is precisely that which indicates its position as an ontological absurdity. We might refer to such a statement which implies anything without discrimination as an "*effective contradiction*", which is effectively a slight generalization of a contradiction as regards its implicative behavior with other logical statements.

The explicit issue with the Copenhagen interpretation, then, is that it is a direct example of an effective contradiction. When Einstein says "I like to think the moon is there even if I am not looking at it" [175], my read is that he is not debating the inherent relativism of quantum ontology, (as after all he of all people would be one to see the ontological merit in straight relativism), but rather he is taking issue with the sheer ability of Copenhagen quantum mechanics to impassively allow said occurrence to a degree seen by no other respected physical theory on the planet. This issue is beyond even its ability to be formulated into agreement with said occurrence: it is instead that the Dirac–von Neumann axioms [162] are structured and interlocked in just such a way so that no further-included axiom will be able to falsify it outright without first contradicting the other axioms. To be explicit on this point, the absurd argument with the moon itself would be represented with the most general possible interpretation—that way a falsification would have to apply to any possible statement which uses it as a logical component—or otherwise not count as a general falsification at all. (As after all, this selective standard of implication would be the bare minimum for any other successful physical theory, such as classical mechanics again). So the particular way in which we could break this criterion, (and thereby establish Copenhagen quantum mechanics as an effective contradictions), would simply be to design at least one example of a quantum thought experiment in which the realism of the moon is contested just far enough to make us uneasy—with such a conclusion being deduced by implication from the experimental setup in conjunction with the Dirac–von Neumann axioms—and such would create a counterexample to the entire falsification endeavor, (since the existence of said thought experiment means that we cannot falsify all possible statements implying the absurd argument with the moon's realism). That is all we would need, at a high level of explanation, to demonstrate the extent of the effective axiomatic cataclysm behind the ontology of the Copenhagen interpretation.

So, to be clear on my motivation for the effective contradiction concept, it is essentially algorithmic. That is, I would consider the Copenhagen interpretation certainly algorithmic in style, but only "pseudo-algorithmic", (as I might call it) if we are being technical. That is, if we imagine whatever the list is of criteria for being an algorithm, this can be categorically partitioned into an algorithm needing to at least being a pseudo-algorithm, while at once not being an effective contradiction, (which is to say that, like going from a monoid to a group, a pseudo-algorithmic holds all remaining criteria besides not being an effective contradiction). I will admit this is hardly more than an intuitive ramble, (as opposed to being a rigorous computational argument), but I might as well discuss it anyway with the hopes of clarifying my intuitive concern with Copenhagen. So, in short, a non-algorithmic pseudo-algorithm has the issue that while some element of deduction is indeed present, more or less essentially any algorithm can be constructed from it depending on how one manipulates the space of contextual information to the algorithm, (ie, being like a subclass of algorithm). This is meant to be rather like how (essentially) any function can be constructed from a Fourier series, with the idea being that the Copenhagen interpretation is more than malleable enough to be made to deduce anything one wants and in whatever fashion they want, provided that the "input" structures are manipulated thoroughly enough to bring this about. So, for example, perhaps we could construct a theoretical universe, entirely consistent with the Copenhagen "algorithm", in which the moon indeed disappears based on if a person is looking at it. In that sense, the Copenhagen interpretation's algorithm is "implanted" inside of a larger algorithm of choice, and like building blocks this can be made to undermine the logical directionality of reality to the full degree of one's choosing.

Let me now state the thesis at its full strength, because the preceding development has earned it. My position is that, if by "quantum mechanics" one means the Copenhagen interpretation, then *quantum mechanics was never formulated in the first place*—because its collapse axiom is an effective contradiction, and a system with an effective contradiction among its axioms has not completed the act of formulation. The moment one creates a *realist* theory of quantum mechanics is the moment the structure can finally stand without falling down under its own weight—or, in a vocabulary I find no less natural than the physics itself, the moment the theory-algorithm can run without crashing under a syntax error.

Well-definedness, not realism, as the requirement. But I want to be precise that the requirement here is bigger than realism, and realism is merely the historically available repair rather than the diagnosis itself: one can perfectly well construct, say, a sociological theory which is nowhere classically nomological and which is nonetheless entirely well-defined. The diagnosis is *well-definedness*, and the

Copenhagen interpretation smuggles "vibe" into its collapse postulate—sort of like defining a circle as "something which is round if it is a Thursday, but not otherwise" and then correctly reproducing the actual pipeline for deducing n-spheres from circles, being like the analogy of the Lagrangian—someone would go, damn this is a great theory about n-spheres, but why is one of your axioms a crayon drawing? And notice what the "round" clause does structurally, because it is worse than informality: it creates an axiomatic branch point out of human *semantics*, of all things. The moment an unformalized natural-language predicate sits inside an axiom, everything semantically upstream of that word—the usage conventions, the borderline negotiations, the whole linguistic practice that fixes what "round," or in Copenhagen's case "measurement," happens to mean—feeds deductively into the physics, and the theory's theorems inherit dependencies on the semantics of a human language. This is, in its way, almost more circular than the detector issue taken up in the next subsection, because the detector circularity is at least a *physical* loop, (apparatus the theory should describe appearing in the theory's application conditions), whereas the semantic branch point pours the entirety of human linguistic practice into the fundamental theory—and thereby implicitly promotes all of it to nomological content, as though the laws of nature included, among their clauses, facts about how a species of mammals happens to use a word.

The failure, named. The keyword for this failure deserves coining: the collapse postulate *contaminates* the asserted nomology with semantics—pours the one into the other while still insisting on calling the mixture physics. And the motivational structure here runs parallel to the out-of-place argument for unification, (Newton's Core Principle, Principle 41): just as it is the avoidance of laws made out of place by one another—rather than unification as a presumed virtue in itself—that motivates seeking a unified law, so it is the refusal to contaminate asserted nomology with semantics—rather than rigor as a presumed virtue in itself—that motivates mathematically-precise theory.

The formal shape of the charge deserves one paragraph, because the threads above, (the anything-you-want permissiveness, the pseudo-algorithmic partition), assemble into a single definition once the classical diagnostic is run in reverse. Classical logic detects contradiction extensionally: from $P \wedge \neg P$, everything follows—explosion is contradiction's consequence-signature. An *effective* contradiction is a component that carries the signature without the syntax: a system containing one never writes $P \wedge \neg P$, yet what it licenses is unrestricted in the manner of explosion, and the unrestrictedness is detectable from outside regardless of how the axioms are dressed. The collapse postulate is the specimen: it never states a contradiction—the interpretation's antirealism about the unmeasured is precisely the maneuver by which incompatible descriptions are denied a common referent and the syntax stays clean—but the price of the maneuver is that the postulate stops restricting, the cut goes wherever convenience places it, and the theory acquires the anything-you-want character documented above. The antirealism, in other words, is not a metaphysical taste one might debate; it is the load-bearing evasion of a syntax error, and the effective contradiction is what leaks through the evasion.

And the blind-review test makes the historical situation plain. Reviewed blind—stripped of its century of institutional standing and judged as a submitted formal system—the collapse postulate would not qualify as *well-defined*: no referee would pass an axiom whose application conditions invoke an unformalized "measurement" whose extension the theory itself declines to fix. It just also happens to be the only system in the history of physics which has gone this long from within that state, and the pipeline's downstream success, (the n-spheres deduced flawlessly), has shielded the crayon drawing from the review it never received. My proposal, then, is that Aethic reasoning resolves this longstanding issue in the only way it can be resolved: not by defending the axiom but by *replacing the act of formulation*—the collapse-shaped phenomena re-derived from components that individually pass the review, (the third postulate's restriction engine, invalidity carried as a representable label rather than an unstatable catastrophe, and the indexing under which incompatible descriptions are real but never co-located). The theory-algorithm, so rebuilt, runs.

10.5 Ontology of Detectors

Short answer – there is none.

The claim of Aethic reasoning is that detectors are just a human construct that we mistook for having ontological significance. The whole issue of detectors being made of quantum particles and as such drawing circular logic to quantum properties is resolved by stating two concepts.

1. The significance of detectors is simply a misnomer which supposes that an ontological entity must *cause* the collapse of a wavefunction. Instead of relying on this fallacy of causality assumption, the Aethic argument instead states that what we believe is an ontological cause here is simply

the act of an Aethic superposition switching from agreeing to disagreeing, and nothing more, (i.e. process before structure). As for the other variety of quantum superposition collapses, where the set of all outcomes is reduced to one single outcome, this is instead an example of a child Aethus being taken from a disagreeing Aethic superposition. In no case is some fundamental separate class of ontological entities engaging with the system.

2. It is a fallacy of the postulate of complete reality to assume that any object is the net probabilistic representation of all its quantum particles which make it up. This assumes that the nature of superposition is observer to particle and then particle to macroscopic and macroscopic to observer. This, however, is wrong because it asserts that it cannot simply be Aethus to observer in one step. For instance, if you have forgotten where you left your car keys, then instead of imagining its probability over different outcomes as arbitrarily consisting of all quantum particles which make up the universe evaluating to a result, instead one should simply look at the car-key attribute in their own Aethus. As complex of a concept as car keys may be in an Aethic sense, it is still better to treat it as having a direct ontological correlation to one's Aethus instead of adding more players to the mix – being quantum particles – which not only assume more information than is accessible to the Aethus, (thereby violating the Aethic reversal principle), but are arbitrary in general for their lack of a well-defined boundary of significance. In total, that kind of probability-from-particle attribution is quite misleading and Aethically indefensible. The Aethic substitute is that *you get to choose what the elemental probabilistic property is depending on what you select as your Aethic attribute, and the Aethus retrieves it accordingly.* You cannot feasibly decompose an Aethus into realizable material due to the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, but you may still analyze it piece by uncorrelated piece.

Notice that the presence of such an insight about detectors allows us to meet *Requirement 3* in full.

Regarding the actual Aethic update to the concept of detectors, perhaps any phenomenon which we accept as relaying information to our Aethus as the expense of continued agreeing superpositions might be regarded as some kind of "detector."

What detectors are not: the scope discipline on where Aethae arise. As for the concept about whether rocks or detectors "have" their own Aethae, I think this is a reductionist fallacy disguised as a generalization. Via *hypotheses non fingo*, what we know rather more reliably is that somewhere in the interface between external reality and subjective experience, the Aethus as an ontological object (which is operable as described by Aethic reasoning) arises, but trying to plaster this onto more general setups is really pushing it, because it presupposes that we know what the root of the Aethus arising is, which we do not. This is not to say that purely conceptually-constructed Aethae aren't allowed, as after all these are just categorically mathematical Aethae, but it does warn against naively sticking them in insisted-real contexts, similarly to how particular Newtonian force vectors have to be entertainable as belonging when used in a real-world model.[229] So, altogether you might consider the shift from RQM [20] in this regard as insisting on a more conservatively pragmatic modeling practice using Aethae[230]: ontologically I suppose you *could* imagine placing Aethae where you wish in the model, but inferentially you want to focus on the least-idealized idealized model.

Two notes complete the discipline. The contrast with relational quantum mechanics is worth stating in its own terms, since that is the neighboring position from which the generalization would most naturally be imported: relational quantum mechanics relativizes states to *any physical system*, an electron as good a reference as an experimenter, and takes that generality as one of its virtues [20]; the convergence developed at Section 2.5.1 is therefore over the relativity of the state, and not over the class of things to which states are relative. And one terminological consequence covers usages found throughout this paper, which should be read in the light of the constructed-Aethae allowance above: locutions such as *the system Aethus*, *the detector-off Aethus*, and *the case Aethus for a photon* name constructed, descriptive Aethae, and none of them asserts that the system, the detector, or the photon *bears* an Aethus — the possessive in such phrases is the possessive of *aboutness*, as in "the particle's

[229] Note that this paragraph dates to *August 19, 2026.*

[230] This itself, I might add, is part of the aesthetic of Aethic reasoning per my intention to begin with: precisely as Newtonian physics opens the door to operating on our own surrounding space mental-conceptually, so too does Aethic reasoning do the same for "happenstance" as I would have originally identified it in 2023, or "modality" as I would now. This means we ought to view the conceptual environment like a machine that can be picked apart and engaged with rather than an external black box or substrate to be gestured at. Again, it is exactly the Newtonian aesthetic but in the context of modality.

wavefunction," and not of ownership. The rooting given at Section 5.2.1, where any other rooting of the Aethus's ontology was already called fallacious, is the same discipline stated at the source.

10.6 Quantum Effects and Scale

In the Aethic mindset, quantum effects are independent of scale in their inherent capacity to exist. That is, by the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning we have that an agreeing superposition is just as intrinsically capable of existing on the scale of the solar system as on the scale of an atom. The key thing that stops this from happening in practice is the exponentially increasing modes of information being gathered and relayed to one's Aethus at these larger scales. For instance, every air molecule now serves as a threat to continued quantum coherence, etcetera.

So, in conclusion for this, an entire boulder could be put through a larger equivalent of the double-slit experiment, and it should result in an interference pattern so long as any and all means of finding its path are to be hidden. It goes without saying that this would be extremely difficult to achieve, but it isn't impossible. Note that in order to truly replicate the interference pattern with the boulder, however, we would also have to slow down its momentum enough to put it on the order of Planck's constant, which is a condition that subatomic particles obey more easily. The tricky nuance here is that according to the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, there is decidedly no intrinsic barrier to agreeing superpositions due to scale, so the issue becomes a practical one, both in terms of hiding information and drawing a correct parallel to the subatomic interference pattern of choice via the boulder's velocity. If the boulder were going too fast, then that would be analogous to an electron which was whizzing by with extremely high energy, and would therefore not make an easily visible interference pattern anyway upon going through the double-slit experiment.

Such a difficulty of hiding information with scale applies to the interplay of Heisenberg's uncertainty principle with the third postulate of the Aethus, but it does not rule out the functionality of more exotic potential uncertainty principles that are yet to be discovered. We could easily conceptualize an uncertainty principle or two for which no traces would be left on any scale, and such possibilities may very well be in effect as far as we know at this very moment. (For example, suppose we double the gravitational constant and the spacetime-breadth of all objects in the universe – we would never even notice the difference).

10.6.1 The Environmental Origin of Decoherence Under the Third Postulate

We emphasize explicitly that Aethic reasoning does not dispute the standard understanding that quantum decoherence is brought about by a system's coupling to its environment. What the third postulate of the Aethus supplies is the deductive ground for *why* such coupling is capable of destroying coherence in the first place. The moment a system becomes correlated with environmental degrees of freedom, the information distinguishing its potential states becomes accessible in-environment—that is, retrievable in principle by some child Aethus. By the third postulate, any Aethus that retains the agreeing superposition (i.e., that maintains quantum coherence) while that distinguishing information is accessible in the environment is thereby invalid: such an Aethus carries an unavoidable avenue to contradiction, since a child Aethus could read the environmental record and contradict the very coherence it asserts.

This is the same mechanism already established in the observer-consistency discussion (subsection 12.3), where two observers whose Aethae could be brought into contradiction through mutual access have precisely that *possibility of interaction* pruned, while the intrinsic properties of their Aethae are left untouched. Here the role of the second observer is played by the environment itself. The initial coupling to the environment is what establishes the pathway to contradiction, and the third postulate then prunes exactly those realities which are the joint Aethic intersection of (i) such environmental coupling and (ii) maintained quantum coherence. What cannot survive is the conjunction of the two—coupling *together with* coherence—because that conjunction is precisely the contradiction-bearing case.

The powerset invalidation theorem (Theorem 14) exhibits this same pruning in its cleanest, controlled form: for a detector grid, invalidity is cut out precisely along the graph-topology of those slit-combinations whose maintained coherence a detector could later expose as a contradiction, with everything else left coherent. Ambient decoherence is the same phenomenon with the environment acting as a vast, uncontrolled detector grid. In both cases the system retains the maximal agreeing superposition that the second postulate drives it toward, with the third postulate trimming away only those portions where coherence would spill over into the regions in which a contradiction becomes

accessible. Coherence is thus preserved wherever it is safe and pruned only where it is not—which is exactly the empirical signature we call decoherence. The rate at which it is pruned, the $e^{-\Gamma t}$ law that is decoherence theory's quantitative content, is derived once the Quantum Nexus and its determinate nodes are available, (subsubsection 14.2.10).

10.6.2 The Aethic Reframe of the Wave-Particle Duality

Perhaps a standard misconception in interpreting quantum mechanics, as pointed out by Aethic reasoning, is in the conflation[231] of particles in the sense of the photoelectric effect [27] versus particles in the sense of the detector-on double-slit experiment. What I wish to emphasize is that of the two of these, the photoelectric effect version of a particle is the real, and significant construction—since after all the quantizing it calls for is the very foundation of quantum mechanics, thanks again to Einstein [27] himself.

What I want to briefly mention here is that the attempt to extend this "localized" nature of particles as in the photoelectric effect to the reasoning behind the detector-on double-slit experiment is itself a falsity. This is already standardly visible in the sense of how even single-slit diffraction causes interference—thereby ruling out that there never is a single particle case in the first place pertaining to the slits—but I want to emphasize that this reasoning extends to the Aethic abstraction layer especially. That is, as per the Aethic formulation of these things, notice how the conceptual constant underlying all of this is agreeing superpositions—in the sense that switching the detector on simply limits the breadth of each individual agreeing superposition in the sense of pruning any Aethae for which the cross-slit case remains in such. Accordingly, the very idea that some kind of categorical localization of quanta leads them to behave as if classical grains of sand shooting to determinate positions is itself a false leap. In reality, the switching to collapse pertains to limiting the underlying more abstract agreeing superpositions and revealing effects deductively downstream at the concrete layer, and for the record grains of sand themselves could be made to experience interference in the right *Class C* regime (Table 8; the shared-limit-point caveat and trigger-divergence located beneath that table applying here verbatim) predicted by Aethic reasoning—so they themselves do not possess a categorical tie between some kind of "particle-ness" of theirs and their adherence to determinate paths.

10.7 Framework Behind Agreeing and Disagreeing Superpositions

Given how we have asserted the Aethic union principle, where the action of unioning two Aethae is asserted to be equivalent to building the Aethus of all attributes present in both, we can create the following claim about how agreeing versus disagreeing superpositions collaborate:

Consider two Aethic stated-attributes of the same state, being X and Y, such that they are distinct. Also consider two Aethae, being A and B, such that A puts X and Y in an agreeing superposition, whereas B puts them in a disagreeing superposition. Can we demonstrate, then, why taking the agreeing superposition of A and B ought to intuitively follow from taking their Aethic union? To do this, let us set up A and B as follows: consider some external attribute, being M, with M saying that X implies the falsehood of Y, and that Y implies the falsehood of X. It goes without saying, then, that any Aethus which contains M cannot hold X or Y in an agreeing superposition, because such a thing would trigger an Aethic contradiction. Accordingly, we might suppose that B contains M. However, to be more specific, let us create another Aethic attribute, being L, such that L holds whether M will be retrieved as true or false within a given Aethus. So, accordingly, any Aethus which holds M will return *true* for L, but any Aethus with M' will return *false* for L. Moreover, consider that a *false* value for L specifically means what it is expected to logically, being that either X and Y are allowed to both be in the same Aethus at once. In effect, we might imagine that A and B are the same in all ways, such that they hold blank for X and Y's attribute, perhaps, except for one node of difference, being that A holds *false* for L, and B holds *true*. In effect, we can now gather the ontology of taking the Aethic union of A and B, being that the resulting Aethus, say C, will have L in a disagreeing superposition between *true* and *false*. The reason, to be clear, that this is not agreeing, is because we have not unioned into this any Aethus in which they are the same at once, so asserting the possibility of this would be adding more information to the Aethus than we can accept. Or, more specifically, both A and B disallow an agreeing superposition across themselves individually, (as a result of their clearly disagreeing with the other one by virtue of not implying it already), so such an attribute must be passed to C anyway.

[231] I might also even argue that this conflation itself plays perhaps a central role in obscuring the move in abstraction needed to propose the concept of an agreeing superposition in the first place.

In effect, we derive have now derived the corollary that *if A is an agreeing superposition of stated-attributes, and B is the disagreeing superposition of those same stated-attributes, then the Aethic union of A and B is Aethically equivalent to the disagreeing superposition of A and B.*

10.8 Explicitly Generalizing Fixed Versus Variable States

Rather quickly, please consider the following principle of how fixed states ought to be properly generalized to Aethic reasoning, as will have applications in active reasoning and beyond.

Principle 36 (Generalized Fixed Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
Notice how in classical logic and metaphysics, we often refer to a given state as being 'fixed' versus 'variable' while stating logical relationships. To give an intuitive example, perhaps we perform a study where we find that of the people in a room, only those with shirt color c_0 all have a single favorite food, f_0, whereas the people of any other given shirt color have at least one disagreement in favorite food between them. If we then suppose that the function $g(p)$ of a person gives their favorite food, then we naturally have that the image of f over the set of people with shirt color c holds cardinality one if and only if $c = c_0$. Let us refer to this logical statement as the 'base statement' for further reference. The key, now, is that in the classical mindset, we automatically assume that c_0 is going to only ever hold a single state, (i.e. not be in Aethic superposition), however by introducing Aethic superpositions we are met with the issue that our condition of c_0 being a single state in the first place is no longer well-defined up to the criteria granted by the classical logical system alone. For example, if we decide to place c_0 in a disagreeing superposition between being a blue shirt and a red shirt, then our initial supposition of which image is a single favorite food becomes somewhat ambiguous up to classical standards of specificity. To Aethic standards, however, the fix is indeed rather straightforward, being that we simply out to also place the image which has a single food into disagreeing superposition over the two options, (where we first place the shirt color and corresponding food states in Aethic conjunction before running the disagreeing superposition, of course).

With this all being said, then, we get to the heart of the supposition of this principle, being that we intuitively still view this example thought experiment itself as having a 'fixed' shirt color whose image is a single food, because the lack of a realized overlap between the alternate scenarios in disagreeing superposition means that we will only ever empirically observe direct compliance with the phrasing of the base statement anyway. As such, especially with regard to situations such as this, let us refer to such a fixed state up to a disagreeing superposition, (such as the c_0 in this example), as being what we will call 'Aethically fixed' rather than classically fixed. The key premise is that all the same deductive intuition ought to be inherited from the classical treatment of such states, however to abide by accurate Aethic reasoning, where unknowing implies a disagreeing superposition in the absence of an Aethic uncertainty principle, we might simply then assert the extra degree of freedom by which the treatment of a fixed state becomes the treatment of an Aethically fixed state. That is, we ought to picture such states the same way procedurally, (unless otherwise specified by characteristically Aethic modes of deduction), all while making the slight update of allowing disagreeing superposition-based variation 'behind the scenes' in other to remain consistent with Aethic reasoning. Such is a technicality more than anything, (unless making characteristically Aethic claims), but ought to be considered nonetheless. And, lastly, we use the word 'fixed' in 'Aethically fixed' so as to apply a needed intuitive element to exactly how they generalize the notion of fixed states in a classical context. Such is as much a necessity as anything else, as the ability to efficiently comprehend mathematical steps is of course keystone to their being successfully undergone.

10.9 The Aethic Mach–Zehnder Interferometer

I spent a great deal of time staring at an animation of the Mach–Zehnder interferometer[232] throughout late 2022. As a matter of fact, this allowed some of the major insights of Aethic reasoning to come to me, so I look forward to presenting such insights to you now, in the medium of that very experiment.

The base Aethic explanation for this experiment works as follows: simply put, upon detecting the particle in question before it can reach its destination at the end of the interferometer, information has now been made permanently available to one's own Aethus and its children about which of the two paths it took out of the first beam-splitter. As such, we see that a disagreeing superposition arises out of these two possibilities. However, if the detector is not present, then we permanently have no way of accessing which path was taken, so by the third postulate of the Aethus, it is best to suppose that

[232]In fact, I still have the date and time at which I first downloaded the animation: October 23, 2022 at 9:38 AM.

both paths were taken at once in an agreeing superposition. This is what we then see when the paths converge again at the end of the interferometer, and then undergo wave interference accordingly. Note that the explanation for the ontological nature of such a wave interference component is under the umbrella of *Step X*, and so will be addressed in the active reasoning paper accordingly.

A further iteration of insight we can gain about the Mach–Zehnder interferometer under Aethic reasoning is how we are now perfectly allowed to update information about reality, (via our Aethus), in either the past, present, or future. By the Aethic extrusion model of Aethic reasoning, we see that spacetime can very well be rigid and causally deterministic, (as is the case in relativity), to a cross section of the Aethic dimension, but in doing so we have to include superpositions and the broad extra dimension of Aethae. As such, we see that we can actually gain insight into reality even when the attribute in question physically occurred in the past, as was seen with the Battle of Brémule example. In the same process, we also ontologically allow for the notion of whether the particle went through the first splitter in an agreeing or a disagreeing superposition to the moment of whenever one's Aethus either gathers the information that a detector was present along the path, or not. Information from the past is "determined" in the present[233], but this is typical in Aethic ontology anyway.

10.9.1 The Apparatus, and Its Attributes

The setup. A source emits one photon at a time toward a first beam splitter BS_1, which sends it into two arms, a (upper) and b (lower). Mirrors fold the arms back together at a second beam splitter BS_2, beyond which two detectors, D_0 and D_1, wait at the two output ports. A phase shifter in arm a adds a controllable phase φ. That is the whole instrument, and its one behavior is the one every account must explain: with nothing in the arms, the photon exits *one* port for every φ at which the arms are balanced—all clicks at D_1, none at D_0—and sweeping φ moves the clicks smoothly between the ports as $\cos^2(\varphi/2)$; put anything in an arm that registers which arm was taken, and the clicks split evenly between the ports at every φ, the fringes gone.

The attributes. The framework reads the instrument as three attributes and a record configuration. The *arm attribute* has answer space $\{a, b\}$: which arm the photon takes after BS_1. The *port attribute* has answer space $\{D_0, D_1\}$: which detector fires. The *phase* φ is not an attribute of the photon but a parameter of the kernel—it enters the action along arm a and nowhere else. And the record configuration is whatever in the block is correlated with the arm attribute: nothing, in the bare instrument; a which-path marker, if one is placed in an arm; a bomb, in the last subsubsection. The port attribute is *always* recorded, since a detector's click is a record by construction, which is what makes the port the readout configuration of the recovery theorem, (Theorem 15), and the arm the attribute whose regime the record configuration decides.

What is at stake. Every account of the interferometer must say why the arm attribute behaves as a wave when unrecorded and as a particle when recorded, and must do so without a mechanism that acts on the photon at BS_1 according to what will later be placed in an arm. The Aethic account has no such mechanism, because on its reading nothing acts on the photon at all: the arm attribute is in one of two regimes according to the record configuration of the whole block, and the two regimes compose differently at BS_2. The rest of this section shows that in two layers—the skeleton, which is postulates and combinatorics and produces the *which* of the two behaviors; and the kernel, which is the one quantitative input and produces the *how much*.

10.9.2 The Aethic Skeleton: Four Configurations, One Classification

The bare instrument. With nothing in the arms, no record in the block distinguishes a from b: not the mirrors, which return the arms to a common point; not BS_2, which mixes them; not the detectors, which register the port and not the arm. Relative to every Aethus in the block, the arm attribute is therefore blank in the retrieval sense, and by the second postulate the blank is open: the photon's arm stands in agreeing superposition $\{a, b\}$, with no exclusion written into either alternative. Run the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14), on the three nonempty subsets of $\{a, b\}$ under this configuration: there is one signature class, since no detector separates the arms, so $\{a, b\}$ is the whole class and is *valid*; $\{a\}$ and $\{b\}$ are proper parts of the class and are *over-specified*, invalid under the second postulate—each asserts a which-arm resolution no record could produce, which by the Record-Individuation Lemma, (Lemma 7), is not a resolution of anything. The valid cluster is the pair, and by the destination-node clarification, (Definition 53), it is really two clusters, one per port: the

[233] . . . Relative to an Aethus, of course!

bundle of arm-paths ending at D_0 and the bundle ending at D_1, each an agreeing superposition of a and b, standing in disagreeing superposition with each other because the port *is* recorded. That is the skeleton of interference: agreeing within a port, disagreeing across ports.

A which-path marker. Place in arm a any device whose state becomes correlated with the photon's passage—a detector, a polarization rotator with a later analyzer, an atom the photon excites. Its state is a record of the arm attribute, obtainable in every refinement of any Aethus that can read the device, and under the totality guard it belongs to the detector configuration whether or not anyone built it to be read. The signature partition is now $\{\{a\},\{b\}\}$, two classes. Rerun the theorem: $\{a\}$ and $\{b\}$ are whole classes, *valid*; $\{a,b\}$ spans both and is *checkmated*, invalid under the third postulate, because every proper child of the experimenter's Aethus has a proper child in which the marker's state is stated and the coherence claim is contradicted. The arm attribute is disagreeing. The two arm-pockets each end at both ports, so the port attribute's weights are now assembled from two pockets separately, with no cross-term between them; that is the skeleton of the fringes' disappearance, and it is decided by the marker's *existence in the block*, not by whether its reading is ever collected.

An erased marker. If the marker's record is destroyed before it reaches any Aethus—the polarization tags recombined by a later element so that no analyzer could ever separate them—then no record of the arm survives in the block, the signature partition returns to one class, and the theorem re-bins: $\{a,b\}$ valid again, the fringes back. The framework's own name for this case is the quantum eraser, and it needs no additional principle: the classification quantifies over every refinement of every Aethus in the block, so a record that will never be readable was never a record, (the vacuum reading, Section 6.6.2).

The delayed choice. If the decision to insert or remove BS_2—or to place or erase the marker—is made after the photon has passed BS_1 in coordinate time, nothing in the classification changes, because the classification never consulted coordinate order. The record configuration of the block is one object, indexed whole; the arm attribute is open or partitioned according to it; and the Indiscriminate Time Principle, (Section 2.3.3), is what says the coordinate position of the deciding element is not a variable the postulates read. The next subsubsection maps this case explicitly. The four configurations together are the framework's account of *which* behavior the instrument shows, and they consume only the postulates, the record-individuation lemma, and the definition of a node—no kernel, no amplitude, no number.

10.9.3 The Quantified Layer: The Kernel on Two Arms

The one quantitative input. Everything above sorts the alternatives into regimes; nothing above says how the alternatives are *weighted*. That is the kernel's work, and it is the only place a number enters. Take the standard convention for a symmetric beam splitter, a transmitted amplitude of $1/\sqrt{2}$ and a reflected amplitude of $i/\sqrt{2}$, a phase $e^{i\varphi}$ on arm a, and mirrors that contribute a common phase absorbed into the overall one. There are exactly two augmented paths from the source to each port, one through each arm, and the kernel assigns each its phase:

$$\mathcal{K}(a\to D_0)=\tfrac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\,e^{i\varphi}\,\tfrac{1}{\sqrt{2}}=\tfrac{e^{i\varphi}}{2},\qquad \mathcal{K}(b\to D_0)=\tfrac{i}{\sqrt{2}}\,\tfrac{i}{\sqrt{2}}=-\tfrac{1}{2},$$

$$\mathcal{K}(a\to D_1)=\tfrac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\,e^{i\varphi}\,\tfrac{i}{\sqrt{2}}=\tfrac{ie^{i\varphi}}{2},\qquad \mathcal{K}(b\to D_1)=\tfrac{i}{\sqrt{2}}\,\tfrac{1}{\sqrt{2}}=\tfrac{i}{2}.$$

The agreeing regime: amplitudes add within a port. In the bare instrument the two paths to a port are one cluster, so the recovery theorem's clause (i) applies at each readout configuration: the port's weight is the squared modulus of the coherent sum over the paths ending there,

$$W_{D_0}=\left|\tfrac{e^{i\varphi}}{2}-\tfrac{1}{2}\right|^2=\sin^2\tfrac{\varphi}{2},\qquad W_{D_1}=\left|\tfrac{ie^{i\varphi}}{2}+\tfrac{i}{2}\right|^2=\cos^2\tfrac{\varphi}{2},$$

which sum to one, vanish at D_0 for $\varphi=0$, and sweep as the instrument does. This is the interference, and it is the first composition law: within an agreeing cluster the kernel's phases add before the modulus is taken, and the cross-term $2\,\mathrm{Re}\,\overline{\mathcal{K}(a\to D_0)}\mathcal{K}(b\to D_0)=-\cos\varphi/2$ is the entire φ-dependence. The cross-term is not a further posit; it is what the Nexus's display, (Section 14.7), gives when the cluster contains two paths to one configuration, and the polarization lemma, (Lemma 8), is the statement that the two port weights as functions of φ determine the two relative phases up to the conventions already fixed.

The disagreeing regime: weights add across pockets. With the marker in arm a, the arm attribute is partitioned, and clause (iv) assembles each port's weight from the two pockets separately:

$$W_{D_0}=\left|\tfrac{e^{i\varphi}}{2}\right|^2+\left|-\tfrac{1}{2}\right|^2=\tfrac{1}{2},\qquad W_{D_1}=\left|\tfrac{ie^{i\varphi}}{2}\right|^2+\left|\tfrac{i}{2}\right|^2=\tfrac{1}{2},$$

for every φ. This is the second composition law, and the fringes' disappearance is nothing but the absence of the cross-term: the pockets are enumerated, their weights added as the Relational Weight Principle adds weights over exclusive alternatives, and the phase has no cross-term to live in. Note what did *not* happen. The kernel is unchanged; the four path amplitudes are exactly as before; the marker did nothing to the photon at BS_1. What changed is which of the two composition laws applies, and that was decided by the skeleton. No-signaling is visible in the same display: whatever the marker registers, the port marginals are $\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}$, unchanged by any choice made at the marker, which is clause (viii) as an identity.

A partial marker: the coupling lemma's instance. Between the two regimes lies the case that tests whether the framework has the right grain. Let the marker be imperfect: a device whose final state is $|m_a\rangle$ if the photon took arm a and $|m_b\rangle$ if it took b, with overlap $\langle m_a|m_b\rangle = \gamma$, $0 \le |\gamma| \le 1$. A perfect marker has $\gamma = 0$; no marker has $\gamma = 1$. The marker is an internal route of the augmented path exactly as polarization was in the two-tag deduction, (Section 14.6.4), and the same lemma governs it: the record leg's overlap sets what survives of the cross-term. The port weights become

$$W_{D_0} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(1 - |\gamma|\cos(\varphi - \arg\gamma)\big), \qquad W_{D_1} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(1 + |\gamma|\cos(\varphi - \arg\gamma)\big),$$

so the fringe visibility is $V = |\gamma|$, and the which-arm distinguishability the marker affords—the trace distance between $|m_a\rangle$ and $|m_b\rangle$—is $D^\star = \sqrt{1 - |\gamma|^2}$, the supremum over placements of the accessible distinguishability D fixed in Section 14.6.4. Hence

$$V^2 + (D^\star)^2 = 1,$$

the Englert relation, saturated because the marker states are pure, with the inequality $V^2 + D^2 \le 1$ at every placement and for a marker that is itself a mixture over conditions. The framework reads the relation as a theorem about records rather than a fit: the overlap γ is the degree to which the block *fails* to carry a record separating the arms, the visibility is what the agreeing regime retains when the record is partial, and the two regimes of the skeleton are the endpoints $\gamma = 1$ and $\gamma = 0$ of one continuous record strength. That the relation closes exactly, with the coupling lemma and Uhlmann's theorem beneath it, is the same evidence the two-tag deduction offered that the machinery has the grain of the physics, and it is offered here in the instrument on which the author first saw it.

What the two layers establish together. The skeleton produces the classification and consumes nothing quantitative; the kernel produces the numbers and consumes nothing modal. The instrument's whole behavior—fringes, their disappearance, their partial survival, the eraser, the delayed choice—is the classification deciding which composition law applies and the kernel supplying the amplitudes that law composes. That division is the two sectors of Section 14.3 on a bench: the postulates are logical and say *which*; the kernel is kinematic and says *how much*; and the Mach–Zehnder interferometer is the smallest instrument on which both can be seen doing their separate jobs at once.

10.9.4 Explicitly Mapping out the Aethic Delayed-Choice Experiment

On the broadest ontological level, the fundamental Aethic reconciliation[234] of Wheeler's delayed-choice experiment [10] comes from the extrusion principle itself, and for that matter the delayed-choice

[234]Funnily enough, I only came across Wheeler's delayed-choice [10] experiment after I had completed the Aethic framework in May of 2023. What I find interesting about this is that it seems to retrospectively illustrate Nexic reasoning as fundamentally important to my initial trajectory into Aethic reasoning, effectively as the stand-in for Wheeler's own delayed-choice-based avenue for the same intuition. That is, because I had already completed the Nexic foundations by August 2022, I had become accustomed to viewing the universe as composed of abstract informational structure valued in Aethae as opposed to causes. Furthermore, I knew from this lens to immediately find causal-before-informational-structural explanations suspect, because I had been highlighting and contesting just those styles of explanations all throughout the Nexic apparatus as positioned against standard astrobiological and natural historical philosophy. What made this fundamentally important is that upon reaching that online lecture about the double-slit experiment in August of 2022, before even finishing the video I had intuited the strong implication criterion and ruled out the intuitive "observing the particles disturbs them causally" explanation. Ironically enough, online I see predominately this oversimplified explanation used to explain the observer effect (along with the "quantum uncertainty is hitting a particle with another particle when observing", which is a misconception due to the actual phenomenon involving Fourier uncertainty)—and as we know directly from Wheeler's work on delayed-choice experiments [10], it very quickly fails to hold water anyway, and instead becomes forcibly replaced with the need for informational-structural-based explanations. So whether due to luck, or maybe just fortunate timing, because I came into that video with Nexic reasoning completed, that allowed me to instinctively reproduce the very intuitive leap of Wheeler, but from an entirely different context. Hence, why it was short work for me to produce the extrusion principle and then the soccer field thought experiment within two weeks! (In the sense of necessity, anyway, with sufficiency also requiring the flanks of my intuitive orientation of the moment).

Upon coming across delayed-choice itself subsequently to completing the framework, it was one moment among many where I felt the thrill of being able to immediately construct it in Aethic terms. In the case of delayed-choice, the

experiment perhaps uniquely illustrates the core philosophical power of the extrusion principle. That is, by replacing the timeline-branching concept with the block universe Markov chain concept, we are directly and explicitly able to address the intrinsic paradigmatic issues of retrocausality. In the timeline paradigm we have in a delayed-choice experiment [10] that there is a particular stubborn ambiguity in the mix, hence causing the retrocausality problem: if prior to erasing the which-path information, at time A, clearly such information is existent, but later time B it has been properly erased, then it suddenly becomes quite ambiguous what is ontologically occurring in the coexisting universe with a given agent at A. Is it that the event of future erasing jumps back and plants the new happening? But is it then that the agent themselves at A coexists with this happening through retrocausality from B, or rather that B spawns a new timeline altogether, in which the consciousness of the agent at time A is rendered as not much more than a philosophical zombie? The key of the extrusion principle, then, is that the problem is interpreted as being with the timeline paradigm itself. As simply as stating that we have the extra Aethic degree of freedom beyond Einsteinian time, then, is how we resolve this cascading paradox perhaps shockingly quickly. In the Aethic world, we simply have that the entire block universe extrudes, and the agent at B enters a universe where the coexisting past matches the update. At Aethic block universe A, they occupy the block universe disagreeing superposition of all possible such B block universes that can be reached.

To be abundantly clear on how Aethic reasoning approaches Wheeler's delayed-choice experiment [10] technically, the fundamental premise is that we Aethic partition the full Aethus of possibilities, A, (say being the experimenter's Aethus, for example), at the start of the experiment into two child Aethae—being the scenario, B_1, in which the which-path information is measured in the future[235] (at the moment when it is uniquely possible to do so), and the scenario, B_2, in which it is not—and we therefore establish by the definition of the Aethic partition that the full Aethus serves as the union of these two possibilities. Then, simply put, we use the third postulate, as usual in a double-slit-like setup, to invalidate the further child Aethus scenario of the two-slit interference pattern in B_1, and invalidate the particle-like pattern in B_2, (while noting that this indeed follows directly from the same treatment, where we further Aethically partition these two said Aethae, and the union the valid child Aethae only). Altogether, we then take these reduced forms of B_1 and B_2, and Aethic union them together again to attain the reduced form of A. What we see is that in the Aethic block universe corresponding to A, even if it is in the experimenter's proper time-future whether or not the which-path information will be measured, and still it is structurally mandatory to the Aethus A itself that sub-scenarios in which the "which-path information is available" must be coupled exclusively to the particle rather than wavelike pattern[236].

And, concerning the fact that Aethus A predates, in the timelike direction, the choice of whether which-path information exists or not, we simply have that the combination of the two options, B_1 and B_2, by an Aethic union operation manifests as a superposition indeterminacy of such outcomes anyway. So, precisely like in classical metaphysics, where the future is indeterminate until informationally arrived at, we manifest that aspect too, and to no less a degree. In effect, such is a fitting example of the second postulate of the Aethus mediating even future events in the block universe, so as to relay into the explicit extrusion principle application concerning the dissolving of the retrocausality paradox.

Altogether, perhaps this is a good intuitive example of what a three-level Aethic nested superposition looks like. That is, rather than simply being an agreeing or a disagreeing superposition of the which-path attribute alone, here we have that we are effectively taking an Aethus-level agreeing superposition, (in this case accordingly being a mere Aethic union), of a disagreeing superposition of the which-path

source is simply the permanence of individual Aethic block universes due to the extrusion principle plus the proper time-invariance of Aethic pruning. There were several other occasions of this retrospective thrilling feeling as well, such as when I learned about Wigner's friend [30], Frauchiger-Renner [92], RQM [20], or Spekkens's program [6, 7, 100–102]—none of which I was aware of until after completing the postulates, (with the caveat being that I learned of RQM [20] in the first three months of 2023, well after the extrusion principle and first two postulates, but directly before the third postulate). What I would say is interesting, however, is that all the inductive reasoning kernel itself of Aethic reasoning required was the double-slit experiment results with the detector on versus off, the limiting case of classical macroscopic logic itself, and a handful of loose empirical clues like "quantum computers exist" for the strong implication criterion and "quantum uncertainty exists" for the August 22 journal entry. In terms of the literature itself, however, I effectively never read a single page until after the framework was complete—which I think ended up being extremely helpful toward my being able to trust my interpretation of the empiricism without the threat of inheriting the unconscious biases that any literature inevitably carries.

[235] Note that it is by the indiscriminate time principle that we may directly assess Aethic partitions involving timelike-future attributes as being equally conceptually valid as past or present attribute-based Aethic partitions.

[236] This is so whether or not we conventionally choose to define A as being truly prior to the experiment in full, or if we instead define it as the child Aethus of that in which the wave-or-particle pattern is already available, (therefore also now implying which measurement state must take place in the future proper time-future for Aethic consistency).

attribute, B_1, and an agreeing superposition of the which-path attribute, B_2. Such is perhaps another direct abstract illustration of the power of the second postulate of the Aethus, because it demonstrates how the universe naturally arranges itself into the effective simplest possible superposition nested structure: not only is the which-path attribute not arbitrarily determinate in B_1 and especially not in B_2, but even the Aethae B_1 and B_2 themselves fall into superposition due to the lack of information which can decidedly preference one over the other with respect to A.

10.9.5 The Bomb Tester: Future-Accessible Records and Admissible Residues

The puzzle. Elitzur and Vaidman [115] asked the interferometer a question that sounds impossible: can one certify that a bomb is live without a photon ever touching it? Take a bomb whose trigger is a photon-absorbing sensor so sensitive that a single photon detonates it, and suppose some bombs are transparent duds. Place a bomb in arm v of the balanced interferometer, with u the safe arm, and calibrate the second splitter so that the bare instrument sends every photon to the bright port b and none to the dark port d, the D_1 and D_0 of Section 10.9.3. Fire one photon. A transparent dud absorbs nothing, the two amplitudes cancel at d, and the photon exits at b as always. A live sensor absorbs the arm-v component, exploding half the time; conditional on survival, the arm-u component reaches either output with equal probability, so b and d each fire a quarter of the time overall. A dark-port click therefore identifies the live response within the stipulated live-versus-transparent-dud alternatives, and it does so in runs in which the bomb did not go off. The standard vocabulary calls this *interaction-free measurement*, and the phrase is where the puzzle lives.

The relocation. The result is usually discussed through counterfactual interaction and, in a many-worlds account, through the explanatory role of the complete branching state. The framework relocates the explanatory question.[237] The mediation for the third postulate, into whether the photon's agreeing

[237] *2026-09-23, 3:39 PM; developed 2026-10-03*

Ok at exactly "Sep 23, 2026, 3:39 PM" while sitting in a quantum mechanics class at grad school where they mentioned the Elitzur-Vaidman bomb tester, I actually got struck with an interesting idea/reframe based on the third postulate of the Aethus. This is less a conclusive remark so much as a surprisingly plausible disenchantment of the counterfactual/multiverse read of the bomb tester experiment, so here goes with the idea: basically my thought was simply that it could be equally explanatory for the experiment that you aren't literally measuring or interacting with "what didn't happen", but simply you get the illusion of that by not accounting for the full Aethic future of paths to invalidity admitted by the third postulate. As in, if we suppose that for a given bomb x in the experiment, which is A live at least exactly at the spacetime time at which the experiment is run or B not live at least there/then, then very simply put the continuous ability to test whether this bomb x was A or B in the future (again, A or B AT THE SPACETIME INDEX of the running, so the future is simply about capturing this parameter) is itself the mediation for the third postulate into whether the agreeing superpositions splits in the moment, as opposed to the more naive "the so to speak first principles for realizing whether the bomb is live or not IS the photon losing coherence", which is one option but not EVERY option, and more importantly still you can't GET RID of all those further options so the third postulate always fires! So the mediation doesn't come from the verdict about the bomb in the moment but rather the external attributes of ways and abilities to figure out whether the bomb satisfies A or B, and then the key is that the Aethus scenario where the bomb is live (being A) BUT also the photon takes the other path from it is not "talking to the counterfactual scenario" so much as being simply one outcome proper child Aethus of the correct Aethic residue for which A (the bomb being live) forces the third postulate to prune the photon agreeing superposition (ie coherence) case on account of A being perfectly entropically-accessible permanently for the third postulate to fire on it like in any case of after-decoherence scales and stuff entropically and all! Interestingly though, even if we protest the assumption in this of "whether A or B is permanently accessible to the Aethic future in the third postulate sense" and insist on a system for which that itself is in agreeing superposition, then notice how the event of A makes the bomb explode and so triggers an Aethic contradiction against that undecidability anyway, hence ITSELF running the third postulate pruning on the assumption counter that A-vs-B can be in agreeing superposition! (So specifically the Aethic modal "would" calls anything in an agreeing superposition, so you deduce for A-B agreeing that A gets called, ie boom when the photon takes both paths coherence-wise, and then that triggers the third postulate invalidation on the photon's own agreeing superposition jointly with the A-B agreeing superposition). (So having ruled out the agreeing A-B case via the Aethic postulates, we split A and B to disagreeing two proper child Aethae, right, and then A joint with the photon path agreeing superposition invalidates, whereas B joint with the photon path disagreeing superposition invalidates). So yeah that's the idea pretty much! Weirdly I myself didn't even think to consider questioning the counterfactual interpretation until exactly in that class when it hit me "oh wait I have all the ontology, so why not try to review the bomb tester interpretation as equally misguided as everything else Aethic reasoning corrects, in this case pertaining to the assumption of counterfactual-visibility which I bet you loses a foundation when scrutinized Aethically anyway!". And then yeah, right now on Oct 3, 2026 I actually got around to coming back to it and figuring out the full Aethic postulates deduction lol, as I've just done! Ok but note that it doesn't NEED to be a record of the photon! "Record" is just an emergent name for something which in reality only has to do with the third postulate pruning agreeing superpositions, is the idea! Thanks!

2026-10-03, continued

Ok but to be clear conflating "would" from "actualized exclusively" is exactly a paradigm boundary thing in Aethic reasoning, similarly I would say to what happens to measuring length in relativity! You should probably explicitly mention in the derivation, just no meta-commentary still, about this pitfall for reader clarity, if relevant! Make sure the would definition in the Aethic paper gets this explicitly said, AND here with the bomb tester gets it too. Thanks! ^^^Also this should go at the end of the same verbatim footnote we've been building.

2026-10-03, continued

Ok but in the long paper surely you say "Aethus" rather than "index", yes? And to be clear the idea is actually that assuming the A-B agreeing is in your Aethus already, it's specifically the value A that moves into the accessible regime (by construction of what a "bomb" is as a valid detector) upon firing the photons coherently due specifically to the supposition that "would" of A or B on A is what the photon reads to interact with it or not, hence A is permanently accessible rather than a joint immediate contradiction at all, which is what invalidates the Aethus for

superposition splits in the moment, is the standing ability to test, anywhere in the Aethic future, whether the bomb satisfied L_0 or D_0 at the trial event; it is not the verdict about the bomb in the moment, and it is not the photon's loss of coherence taken as the first principle by which the bomb's response is realized. That loss is one route to invalidity and not every route, and the further routes, the external ways and abilities of settling the response at the trial event, cannot be removed from the arrangement, so the postulate fires on them whatever is done with the photon. What constrains a candidate description is the admissible residue of the complete arrangement, the joint descriptions that survive the record constraints the arrangement makes available, and not a transaction between the observed outcome and an unrealized explosion; the successful identification is real, and what is disenchanted is an explanatory gloss on it, not the information gained. The bomb's attribute at issue has a fixed spacetime referent: let L_0 be the proposition that bomb x has the specified photon-absorbing, triggering response in arm v at the trial event t_0, and D_0 the stipulated alternative, a transparent dud, transparent rather than opaque or phase-shifting, since the benchmark compares those two responses and no others. Later evidence may settle L_0 without changing the event it describes; what a later inquiry asks is whether L_0 held, and any later test of the bomb bears on L_0 only through a justified evidential connection, physical persistence or a preparation record, to its response at t_0. The accessible attribute, then, need not be a record of the photon. "Record" is the emergent description of a structure whose primitive role is to make a joint incompatibility accessible under refinement, and in the present application what can be settled is the bomb's response at the trial event. If that response, together with the apparatus and the candidate agreeing content, entails an invalid conjunction, access to the response supplies the route to invalidity without any separate path readout; the third postulate excludes the candidate only when every proposed escape refinement retains such a route, and the task is to exhibit the conjunction and establish its inescapability, not to find a photon record.

The benchmark, with the response law in view. Write u for the safe arm and v for the arm holding the sensor, $|\psi\rangle = (|u\rangle + |v\rangle)/\sqrt{2}$ after the first splitter, and take the second splitter to send $|u\rangle \mapsto (|b\rangle + |d\rangle)/\sqrt{2}$ and $|v\rangle \mapsto (|b\rangle - |d\rangle)/\sqrt{2}$, b the bright port and d the dark one. With a transparent dud the two amplitudes cancel at d and the output is $|b\rangle$. With an ideal live sensor the arm-v component is sent to an orthogonal absorbed state $|E\rangle$ carrying the bomb's and the environment's degrees of freedom, and the surviving arm-u component continues, so that the final state is $|\Psi_L\rangle = \frac{1}{2}|b, L\rangle + \frac{1}{2}|d, L\rangle + \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}|E\rangle$: explosion at weight $\frac{1}{2}$, bright $\frac{1}{4}$, dark $\frac{1}{4}$, against bright 1 for the dud. Two things the benchmark fixes. Absorption is not dephasing: replacing the incoming path state by the equal mixture of u and v and sending both through an empty second splitter gives no explosion and equal output weights, which is not the experiment; the live branch is a trace-decreasing survival operation, $K_{\text{survive}} = |u\rangle\langle u|$ on the path space with output trace $\frac{1}{2}$, together with its complementary absorption outcome, and normalization occurs only after selecting survival, so the conditional port weights are $\frac{1}{2}$ each and the unconditional ones $\frac{1}{4}$. And the explosion is a valid outcome of positive weight, not an invalid term discarded. With prior live weight p, $P(d) = p/4$ and $P(L_0 \mid d) = 1$; the dark click identifies the live alternative within the stipulated hypotheses, and nothing in the calculation requires a message from the explosion alternative, while everything in it requires the apparatus's response law, the coherent amplitude structure and the outcome conditioning, which the framework must locate rather than erase.

The joint incompatibility, and the criterion applied. Let G specify the apparatus geometry and response law, let H be the exact agreeing content under consideration, the recombination at the second splitter of two surviving photon amplitudes, one in each arm, with the intact-interferometer visibility, and let the explosion attribute E take the value *exploded* or *intact*. The incompatibility the application needs is then explicit: $J(G, L_0, H, \mathsf{E}{=}\text{intact})$ is invalid, because under G a live device at t_0 sends the arm-v amplitude to the absorbed state, so that in the intact branch the surviving photon state is $K_{\text{survive}}|\psi\rangle \propto |u\rangle$, a single amplitude, which is not two surviving amplitudes recombining; and $J(G, L_0, H, \mathsf{E}{=}\text{exploded})$ is invalid because an absorbed photon recombines nothing. So F is the explosion attribute stated, and every refinement stating it, whichever value it states, is base-contradictory with H given L_0 and G. No path readout enters; the route runs from the settled bomb status and the explosion attribute through the response law to the candidate content. The criterion then applies at its actual quantifier strength (Lemma 5): the candidate $A_{L,H}$ asserting L_0 and H is excluded if every declared refinement of it has a further declared descendant stating E, which is the no-safe-refinement premise for this realization, and that premise is a statement about the explosion and intactness records of a macroscopic bomb, that they are persistent over the candidate's declared descent, with no admitted refinement coherently erasing both: the response at the trial event is

which you assume A-B can be agreeing at all!

entropically accessible, permanently, as any attribute is at post-decoherence scales. Where it holds, the disagreeing alternatives are the complete trial histories relative to every Aethus that states L_0: the explosion record partitions them into the absorbed history, in which the photon took arm v, and the surviving sector, in which the arm attribute is determinate at u, and the second composition law of Section 10.9.3 enters the two at their weights, $\frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{1}{2}$, with no cross-term between them. Within the surviving sector the second splitter acts on the single amplitude $|u\rangle$, which is why the ports come out at $\frac{1}{2}$ each there: the cross-term is absent because no arm-v amplitude survives to recombine, not because two surviving amplitudes were dephased, which is the account the benchmark rejects. The Aethus in which the bomb is live and the photon took arm u is then one outcome proper child of that residue, and the dark click one of its pockets; it is not in conversation with the explosion that did not occur, and nothing in it is a counterfactual made visible; where D_0 holds instead, no refinement states an incompatible record, the first composition law applies, and all clicks fall at b. Note what this does and does not say. "There exists a future test of the bomb" is weaker than the premise, and so is "there exists an explosion branch"; a descendant that learns an outcome does not in general contradict its parent, and the exclusion needs the specific conjunction displayed above. Nor is the condition a temporal inevitability: every declared descendant having a contradiction-reaching descendant does not say that every actual continuation reaches a contradiction in finitely many steps.

Four checks the realization must pass. A live bomb standing outside both arms is equally testable later, and nothing happens to the photon: G then contains no arm-sensitive coupling, J is not invalid, and the accessibility of L_0 excludes nothing, which is as it should be, since accessible status mediates the criterion only through the specified joint invalidity and "any testable live property anywhere destroys coherence" is not the claim. A preparation register certifying the bomb's response without distinguishing the arms is not irrelevant for that reason: in the specified arrangement the status information suffices, because the invalidity runs through the response law and not through a path record. A bomb already known to be live leaves the absorption and output weights exactly as the benchmark gives them; the mechanism is the arrangement's record structure and not the observer's uncertainty. And scheduling or cancelling a later inspection alters no unconditioned detector probability, since the later acquisition changes the Aethus and not the event; later-conditioned subsets are a different matter. These are the realization checks that keep the relocation from collapsing into "the future makes the photon lose coherence," which it does not say.

The detector, the friend, and the bomb. The three cases share the form of the consistency question and nothing else. For the unread which-way detector, present ignorance leaves undecided whether the observer has read the marker, and what must be established is that the specified alternatives have persistent distinguishing records under the relevant refinement structure. For the friend in a laboratory, present ignorance leaves undecided whether an external observer has received the report, and what must be established is that every proposed escape refinement still permits the incompatible record, current sealing alone settling nothing. For the bomb tester, a surviving run contains no explosion by definition, and what present ignorance leaves undecided is how that run identifies the live response; what must be established is that the arm-sensitive response, the absorption branch, the surviving amplitudes and the pertinent record conditions together determine the admissible residue. The same criterion applies when the respective realization establishes the same no-safe-refinement structure; the cases have different Hamiltonians, different records and different weight calculations, and in the bomb tester the difference between an absorber and a nondestructive path marker stays visible, since the record that mediates is the bomb's status and not a marker on the photon. Placing the words "unread," "human" and "bomb" beside one another is not the argument; the quantifiers over declared refinements are.

The coherent-device case: modal evaluation. Suppose the objection is pressed one level down: let the status itself, L_0 against D_0, stand in agreeing superposition, the irreducible kind, with no record separating the live response from the dud response, jointly with the photon's agreeing superposition over the arms; call the Aethus A_{agree}. The framework's would-clause settles this, and it settles it by its definition rather than by any possibility reading. By Definition 28, *would* a holds in a weighted Aethus when $W(a)/Z = 1$, that is, when the weight of valid pockets that declare a false is zero, and an irreducible agreeing state containing a counts toward a's weight exactly as a state stating a does (Definition 26); the weight-one clause coincides with the support-universal one, that no valid pocket declares a false, wherever every valid pocket carries positive weight, which holds in A_{agree}, whose residue is a single pocket. So over an undroppable agreeing residue the clause, read on the physical side, "is this state realized?", is satisfied by each of the co-present states at once (Section 9), and fails only on the reductive side, "is the attribute determinately this value?", where irreducibility forbids the

state-decomposable child that determinateness would require. "Would" is therefore neither "actualized as the one value" nor "possible in some descendant," and it is not co-presence itself: it is the zero-weight condition, which co-presence in an irreducible agreeing superposition meets as fully as stating does. The conflation of *would* with exclusive actualization is a paradigm-boundary error of the same kind as carrying an invariant length into relativity: across that boundary length is frame-indexed, and across this one *would* is the zero-weight condition, with exclusive actualization a feature of the disagreeing regime that the agreeing regime does not possess, so that every step below that takes *would* to be met by co-presence is reading it as the definition does and not as the classical paradigm would. Three claims are accordingly distinguished throughout: the Aethic modal content, what "would" includes when the alternatives stand agreeing under the union principle; the physical response, what the live-sensor law entails for that content; and the observed outcome, which disagreeing proper-child outcome is acquired in an Aethus and with what weight. That an explosion is not certain as an observed outcome does not contradict the first claim, and affirming the first claim does not say that every alternative will be separately and exclusively observed; both substitutions reinstate the exclusivity the union principle removes. In A_{agree} the single irreducible agreeing branch carries the whole weight and contains the live response, so *would* L_0 holds; it contains the dud response too, so *would* D_0 holds as well, and the two hold together because the composition is nonexclusive.

The response law on agreeing content. What the photon reads, in order to interact with the sensor or not, is *would* L_0, and in A_{agree} it holds, so the coherently fired photon's arm-v component engages the live response. The response law composes the two contributions as the union principle composes any agreeing content, not by a classical choice between them: the live contribution absorbs the arm-v component and records, the dud contribution transmits it and records nothing, and their composition is the agreeing composition of an absorbed arm-v component with a transmitted one, the accessible record of which is the live contribution's alone. "The interaction law assigns an explosion outcome to the incident live-sensor component" is the whole of what the law says; it does not say that a coherent input certainly explodes, and in the balanced benchmark the explosion's weight is $\frac{1}{2}$.

The accessibility lemma. The step from the engaged response to the postulate is a realization premise about what a bomb is, stated once and used once.

Principle 37 (Detector premise, for the bomb)
A bomb is a valid detector of its live response: a system whose engaged trigger response produces a record stating L_0, the explosion where the arm-v component is absorbed and the intact-but-live response where it is not, and that record persists through every declared refinement, no admitted refinement coherently reversing the explosion or erasing the bomb's response at the trial event, which remains testable at every later Aethus with a justified connection to that event.

Lemma 6 (Accessibility under coherent firing)
Let A_{agree} hold the status L_0/D_0 in irreducible agreeing superposition jointly with the photon in agreeing superposition over the arms, with the bomb in arm v satisfying Principle 37. Then upon the coherent firing

$$\forall B \le A_{\text{agree}} \;\; \exists C \le B : \;\; C \text{ states } L_0,$$

with every such C retaining the irreducibility marker of the status that A_{agree} carries.

Proof
Would L_0 *holds in A_{agree}, so by the response law the live contribution's trigger is engaged and, by the premise, produces a record stating L_0 that persists through every declared refinement. Let $B \le A_{\text{agree}}$; under the declared descent of the Fixed-Point Lemma (Lemma 1) an attribute held in agreeing superposition declares only the splits its access licenses, so B retains the marker, and since the record persists through B, the descendant C of B that states the persisting record states L_0. Nothing in C states which arm the photon took.*

The exclusion. So upon the coherent firing it is specifically the value L_0 that moves into the accessible regime. Nothing in this is an immediate joint contradiction in the Aethus's own content; what it is, is the permanent accessibility of a value the Aethus asserts to be unseparated from its alternative, and permanent accessibility is exactly what the third postulate reads. Each C of Lemma 6 states L_0 while retaining the marker that declares the narrower filling invalid (Definition 11), so each is base-contradictory; the no-safe-refinement condition of Lemma 5 therefore holds, and the Aethus in which the status was assumed agreeing, jointly with the photon's agreeing superposition over the arms, is invalid, by the same route, accessibility mediating the postulate, that invalidates the photon's

agreeing superposition with a live bomb and the friend's laboratory with its records. That is the note's second argument, made exact. The second step follows: with the agreeing status excluded, L_0 and D_0 are the disagreeing proper children, and in each the main argument runs, L_0 jointly with the photon's agreeing superposition invalid by the incompatibility displayed above, D_0 jointly with a disagreeing path superposition invalid in the fully specified ideal arrangement, where no record of the arm exists. The status is thus a record-separated partition relative to every Aethus that states the arrangement, before any photon is fired. The same verdict can be written in the classification's own vocabulary, provided the connection is made through the lemma and not through the outputs: the response distributions of L_0 and D_0, $(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{4})$ and $(0, 1, 0)$ over explosion, bright and dark, overlap at the bright outcome, so the mere presence of an explosion among one alternative's possible outputs does not supply the deterministic orthogonal marker a complete signature is built from; what supplies it is the separating refinement of Lemma 6, the accessible record stating L_0, and the complete signatures of L_0 and D_0 differ in that separating record and are record-separated on that ground.

Three things are to be said precisely about what this rests on. First, the premise is the would-clause's definition read on the agreeing status, which engages the live response, together with Principle 37, which renders the engaged response permanently accessible; nothing in the derivation is the possibility reading, and a reader who holds that an agreeing superposition is a list of possibilities, one of which may happen, will not reach the verdict, since on that reading the live response is engaged in one descendant and accessible there alone, and one descendant with an accessible record establishes nothing. The framework has rejected that reading at the root, which is what the union principle is. Second, the verdict is a proposed divergence from universal unitarity, and the comparison model should be displayed so that the divergence is exact. Prepare $(\alpha|L\rangle + \beta|D\rangle) \otimes (|u\rangle + |v\rangle)/\sqrt{2}$ with the interaction mapping $|v, L\rangle \mapsto |E\rangle$ and leaving $|u, L\rangle$, $|u, D\rangle$ and $|v, D\rangle$ unchanged; after the second splitter the unitary model gives $|\Psi\rangle = |b\rangle(\frac{\alpha}{2}|L\rangle + \beta|D\rangle) + \frac{\alpha}{2}|d, L\rangle + \frac{\alpha}{\sqrt{2}}|E\rangle$, with $P(E) = |\alpha|^2/2$, $P(d) = |\alpha|^2/4$, $P(b) = |\beta|^2 + |\alpha|^2/4$, and, conditioned on the bright port, a device state proportional to $\alpha|L\rangle/2 + \beta|D\rangle$ that is coherent. The framework's verdict is that this preparation is inadmissible: the status is disagreeing relative to every Aethus stating the arrangement, so the bright-conditioned device is the mixture of $|L\rangle$ and $|D\rangle$ at the corresponding weights and not their coherent combination. The discriminator is explicit. At $\alpha = \beta = 1/\sqrt{2}$ the bright-conditioned unitary state is $|\chi\rangle = (|L\rangle + 2|D\rangle)/\sqrt{5}$ and the framework's is $\rho_{\mathrm{A}} = \frac{1}{5}|L\rangle\langle L| + \frac{4}{5}|D\rangle\langle D|$; an ideal measurement onto $|+\rangle = (|L\rangle + |D\rangle)/\sqrt{2}$ gives $P_{\mathrm{U}}(+ \mid b) = \frac{9}{10}$ against $P_{\mathrm{A}}(+ \mid b) = \frac{1}{2}$. That is a mathematically specified test; making it an experimental proposal requires identifying devices that satisfy Principle 37 while permitting the status-basis measurement, and that identification is not made here. The framework takes the second direction named by the general discussion, exclusion of a class of coherent response preparations, and names its premise, its quantifier and its test; it does not claim that a macroscopic explosive can be so prepared in practice, and the original paper's own treatment of a target in spatial superposition [115] is the precedent for handling the coherent target explicitly rather than by informal appeal. Third, the verdict is of a piece with the Frauchiger–Renner state exclusion of Section 10.2.2: there too the framework excludes a coherent preparation that universal unitarity admits, on a record premise, and there too the operational difference is a device's status being a mixture where unitarity keeps it coherent.

Every number in the ordinary case is standard. For the ordinary live-or-dud bomb tester, Aethic reasoning makes no new prediction; the coherently prepared response device is a separate proposed divergence, stated above with its test. The ordinary weights are the standard ones—explosion $\frac{1}{2}$, dark $\frac{1}{4}$, bright $\frac{1}{4}$ with a live bomb, and all clicks at b with a dud—and they are standard because the kernel is unchanged and the classification only decides which of the two composition laws applies to it, exactly as in the marked and unmarked configurations of Section 10.9.3. Any account that gets the interferometer right gets the bomb tester right; what differs is the account, not the arithmetic. Nor is the framework's reading of the intact bomb novel as physics: a measurement whose informative outcome is the *absence* of a detection is Renninger's negative-result measurement [176], and standard quantum mechanics has always handled it by conditioning the state on the non-detection. The framework's contribution is to say why a non-detection conditions anything at all—because a record is a correlated degree of freedom in the block and an absence correlates as well as a presence—and thereby to remove the appearance that something was learned for free. What the standard vocabulary must call an *interaction-free* measurement and then explain away, the framework classifies as a record like any other, with no interaction ever having been the operative notion.

The efficiency, and the Zeno refinement. The scheme certifies a live bomb in a quarter of the runs and destroys it in half; repeating on the inconclusive bright-port runs raises the certification fraction toward one third, with two thirds destroyed. Kwiat, Weinfurter, Herzog, Zeilinger, and Kasevich [177]

showed that a quantum-Zeno arrangement—many weakly reflecting passes, each interrogating the bomb by a small rotation—drives the certification fraction toward one and the detonation fraction toward zero. That is the standard efficiency result and it is not reconstructed here: a small rotation into an absorbing arm is not automatically a weak distinguishing marker of the kind the coupling lemma of Section 10.9.3 treats, since in the idealized construction the survival filter stays sharp while the amplitude exposed to absorption per pass becomes small, and the Aethic classification of the repeated survival map is a separate reconstruction that this subsubsection leaves to be supplied.

What the subsubsection establishes. Four things, at four grades. The benchmark is standard experimental theory, and the framework claims no novelty in it. The placement of the dark click as an identifying outcome in the surviving weighted residue, with no message from an unrealized explosion required, is an interpretive proposal conditional on the realization, one the observed statistics admit among others and not evidence favoring the framework uniquely; what it replaces is the explanatory role that a many-worlds account assigns to the complete branching state, and the framework must then show what fills that role, which is the admissible residue. The exclusion of the candidate agreeing description is a conditional theorem, Lemma 5 with the displayed incompatibility and the persistence premise for this realization, and the premise's independent physical content is the persistence of a macroscopic bomb's explosion and intactness records, not a stipulation that the candidate is impossible. And the coherent-device case is decided by the would-clause's definition and the construction of a bomb as a valid detector, the live response engaged by the coherent firing and rendered permanently accessible, as a proposed divergence from universal unitarity with its premise, its quantifier and its operational test named. Applying the criterion to a new physical setting requires that setting's interaction law, record channels and declared refinement structure; where those depend on the candidate configuration, their joint consistency is an additional construction to be supplied, and the existing fixed-point result over a fixed relation does not solve a problem in which the candidate changes the relation itself.

11 Aethic Probability and Time

11.1 Aethic Bayesianism

Aethically speaking, Bayesian givens and their updates to probability distributions can be fundamentally regarded to simply be an ontological consequence of invalid Aethae in the system. This is not to specifically update Bayesian updates per se, (which follow simply from adding an attribute and as such dealing with a new Aethus), but rather the very specific case of when a probability distribution that normally operates one way is somehow altered by the addition of another attribute. Take, for example, the classic Monty Hall problem [99], which, interestingly enough, becomes rather more intuitive under Aethic reasoning.

In the Monty Hall problem, you're on a game show, and you're given three doors, where two of them have a goat behind them, and the other has a new car. Supposing you're not a goat herder, and you would prefer the car, it follows that you're going to try to do what you can to pick its door. Once you pick one of the three doors, the host of the game show opens one of the other two doors, and behind it is a goat. So the only closed doors are the one you picked, and the remaining closed one. Now the host asks you if you want to switch to that door, or stick with your door. What do you say?

Aethically, the essence is a single sentence: find which Aethae are invalid, and loan their weights to the surviving siblings. The definitive computation—the weighted reduced form, run step by step from the uniform prior through the host's conditional structure to the familiar $\frac{1}{3}/\frac{2}{3}$—is performed in Section 11.1.3 below, and the reader is pointed there rather than detained here twice.

Beyond the realizable interpretation just exercised stands the *hyperrealizable* interpretation of probability[238], whose standing definition, (Section 4.6), assigns nonzero weights to invalid Aethae and

[238]I also, for the record, find it quite fascinating how similar this Aethic Bayesian methodology is to standard rejection sampling from computational statistics, since I had only first heard of rejection sampling during a college class in 2024, and yet I intuited the methodology of hyperrealizable probability for Aethic and Nexic purposes at least as far back as 2022. If I remember correctly, what sourced this shift in my mindset was perhaps the Monty Hall problem [99] itself, which fittingly enough I first heard about as a Freshman in high school, so in skeptical disbelief wrote up a Monte Carlo simulation in Java after class. *Sure enough, it was legit.* Eventually, though, after having sit with this for long enough, I was able to develop an intuition surrounding how it could be contextualized, and the hyperrealizable probability methodology was effectively the culmination of that intuition, more or less. But once again it might have actually been quite helpful that I intuited it independency and prior to learning about rejection sampling, because that was it remained natural to associate it with ontological context in one package rather than having to carry the baggage of procedural application. Hence, it is perhaps another funny story of my lack of exposure to standard concepts allowing me to come up with something which is alien in half its respects and familiar in the other half.

rejects invalid outputs upon conversion to a realizable answer—operationally, the randomization is rerun until a valid Aethus is sampled, and only that output is returned. An earlier formulation of this interpretation proceeded by an explicitly recursive expansion, substituting the parent Aethus back in wherever an invalid child was drawn and summing the resulting infinite geometric series, and that formulation is hereby retired. It is retired not because it was wrong but because it was a demonstration doing the work of a definition: the recursion is rejection sampling run to its fixed point, and its series necessarily sums to exactly the renormalized realizable value—the pruning-and-renormalization reading now stated with its hypotheses as Theorem 13, and constructed without any recursion from the reduced form in Section 11.1.3. What survives of the old formulation is its content as a *consistency check*: any admissible construction of the hyperrealizable layer must, on conversion, reproduce the renormalized measure, and the geometric series is the elementary verification that the rejection-sampling construction does.

All in all, to conclude this brief talk on Aethic Bayesianism, we see that the essence of Bayesian reasoning lies merely in the directed incorporation of invalid Aethae into an Aethic argument.

11.1.1 The Aethic Assessment of Frequentism

Simply put, Aethic reasoning rejects the philosophy of frequentism for its violation of the first postulate of the Aethus. Specifically, frequentism defines probability of an outcome as the proportion of times at which that outcome occurs as the limit of the number of independent trials goes to infinity. The Aethic issue with this supposition is quite simple, then: the mere supposition of what constitutes the intrinsic equivalence between any two trials is fundamentally a subjective choice, and therefore a choice which is not compatible with the first postulate of the Aethus. As such, with the claim that any two trials are instances of the same general thing being Aethically arbitrary, we therefore have that frequentism itself fails to be well-defined under the first postulate of the Aethus. Such is a somewhat ironic fatal flaw of frequentism, given its premise of operating outside subjective interference and all.

Let us now define something of a formal sort of "frequentist bias" as according to Aethic reasoning.

Definition 44 (Frequentist Bias)
The bias of arbitrarily assuming that two Aethae are equal when considering a like quantity between them. Often characterized by personifying words explaining how the quantity in one is caused to be different from its form in the other. In Aethic reasoning, we hold this entire sort of sentiment as being as arbitrary as whatever one subjectively supposes constituents equivalence between the two Aethae in question. In other words, it violates the first postulate of the Aethus accordingly.

The point admits the oldest possible epigraph: *you can never step in the same river twice* [178]. In the physical world it is always a string of different Aethae, equated only through speculative or subjective assumptions—even the supposition that some number of coin flips represent the same repeated event is exactly as arbitrary as one's chosen definition of the equivalence of those events—so the frequentist limit is taken over a sequence that the first postulate refuses to supply.

Two things called probability. The assessment above does not leave the practice without a definition; it relocates the definition, and the relocation matters because the framework uses two different objects that ordinary language calls by one name. An *Aethic probability* is an ontological weight: the weight an Aethus assigns to one pocket of a disagreeing superposition, indexed to that Aethus, attached to a blank, and answerable to nothing outside the Aethus. An *Aethic frequentist probability* is a *proportion*: take a family of attributes that are, as a matter of ontology, distinct things—each its own event at its own spacetime location and its own Aethic time—group them by hand into an equivalence class on some standard of sameness the modeler supplies, and count how many members of the class fall under a given state. That count is a number, not a weight. It attaches to no blank, it is indexed to no pocket, and its every property depends on the grouping chosen. The first postulate does not supply the grouping; the modeler does; and frequentism's error was to take the grouping for a discovery about the world rather than a declaration about the model. Once the declaration is made explicit, the proportion is perfectly well-defined, the law-of-large-numbers behavior survives relative to the declaration, and nothing of frequentism's account of what probability *is* survives at all.[239]

[239] *August 22, 2026*, the author's dictations — of the definition installed here, of its blank-inclusive extension carried in the closing remark, and of the design principle motivating that extension — kept verbatim as a matter of provenance:

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Something important I want to mention about the accordance principle by the way is that with the
defining kappa expression of it, technically that outer Pr[] thing is NOT a probability to the
standards of the Aethic ontological definition of probability:  rather, it's actually just a plain
proportion, as per the Aethic definition of "frequentist probabilities" as proportions rather than
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Definition 45 (Aethic Frequentist Probability)
Let H be an Aethus and let $\mathcal{F}$ be a family of attributes of H, each a distinct object of the ontology. Let $\sim$ be an equivalence relation on $\mathcal{F}$ supplied by the modeler ("these are all coin flips"), and let C be one of its classes, with a set of nominal states fixed for the class ("heads," "tails"). The Aethic frequentist probability *of a state x relative to $(H, \mathcal{F}, \sim)$ is*

$$\mathrm{fr}_H(x \mid C) \;=\; \frac{\#\{a \in C : a \text{ is stated in } H \text{ and takes state } x\}}{\#\{a \in C : a \text{ is stated in } H\}},$$

a proportion over the class's stated members. It is not an Aethic probability: it weights no blank, it is indexed to no pocket, and every property it has is relative to the chosen $\sim$, which the definition carries

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true ontological probabilities. Specifically, if you look in the long Aethic paper itself you'll see how the frequentist fallacy shows how to even define "probabilities" in the frequentist sense, you're still ultimately forced to rely on subjectivity, just in this sense rather than true Aethic ontology that subjectivity is specifically that: frequentist "probabilities" in Aethic reasoning (that is, for consistency with Aethic reasoning they get this exact definition) are defined looking over several different attributes across an Aethus, giving them equivalence classes based on "subjective sameness", and then taking the proportion of stated-attributes which fall out under each state within THAT. The canonical example is with coin flips themselves, which notice happen at strictly different spacetime events AND different Aethic times no less, and so they're actually distinct, such that even the concept of calling them all "coin flips" is a convention of arbitrarily grouping THEM in particular together. Hence, it's a by-hand equivalence class basically used for modeling while being blind to ontology. The accordance principle outer Pr[] thing is then exactly this: if you enumerated all instances of attributes, the proportions would satisfy this constraint for arbitrarily law-of-large-numbers-approaching values. Thanks!

Note 2, same date:

Oh also by the way another thing we might try to actually hit the law of large numbers limit for free in a given Aethus (and without having to trace it out to the infinite future) is to do something like include the currently-in-disagreeing-superposition-still future coin flips as part of the exercise or something, in the sense that the equivalence class of attributes also auto-includes them as well. In that sense, I suspect the frequentist probability would simply turn into a weighted average based on the Aethic weights of the various partial-determinate states, (so that the binary count is the limiting case), hence funnily enough using real Aethic probabilities in the translation anyway. See what I mean there? Also I wonder how well we could combat the law of large numbers limiting case by getting it "early" or "locally to the Aethus now" or something using this. Thanks!

Note 3, same date:

Right, and the reason for this sharpening is specifically because it's bad practice in Aethic reasoning anyway for a definition to only apply to stated but not blank cases, hence meaning allowing it to apply robustly to the attributes themselves without having to also clarify whether they're stated or not (since having clarify if they're stated means the equivalence classes themselves change in proper child Aethae) is the better route.

Note 4, September 11, 2026 — the author's instruction under which the lead, the simplified definition, the three Nexic instances, and the two-determinacies movement above were written, kept verbatim:

Next, please edit the treatment of the ‘‘Aethic Frequentist Probability’’ definition in the long Aethic paper to be a lot less opaque (and feel free to read my own verbatim note in the footnote on it, for the full contextual spiel), since this is especially important in places like Nexic reasoning, where the ‘‘randomness’’ of the HCEH in all cases of the accordance kappa relationship, the log space difference, AND the randomly selected optimal Aethus from a given partition scheme are instances of such, per the frequency under equivalence classes rather than being true probabilities ontologically in the Aethic sense. That is, where the Aethic structure enforces these constraints to be encoded already in the Aethic tree (being the profound ‘‘the Aethic tree is ‘determinate’ while determinacy is relative per the first Aethic postulate applying to contingent truths, so they're really two different concepts both called ‘determinate’, rigorously speaking’’, which is a profound question for being tangled up with the frontier of Nexic reasoning with its WHY certain structures get frozen open question), but human mental-level ignorance rather than true Aethic ignorance has difficulty of mentally tracking the correspondence coupling of broad Aethus and optimal partition element. (This also happens to, per deduction from Nexic reasoning, satisfy a nice counterexample to the naive claim that mental and Aethic ignorance are equivalent, such that instead mental ignorance is strictly broader than Aethic ignorance, (not including ambiguities like the stopped clock paradox where you ‘‘know’’ something from bad information--but my general argument for that is that it's tailoring the definition of ‘‘know’’ to whatever you want anyway, hence why I don't include it in terms of ‘‘know’’ as robust--but to be clear the Aethic solution to the stopped clock paradox, which also recommend you enhance the section of, is just again a first postulate derivation of the verdict to the before and after Aethae being different, such that for the prior Aethus the being ‘‘right’’ is in disagreeing superposition with exactly as minute a weight aligns with the random aligning of stopped time and ‘‘actual’’ spacelike time anyway, and so in that Aethus there isn't much leverage to begin with toward establishing the falsity of true justified belief, sort of thing)). Also I recommend for the long Nexic paper itself that you clarify that the total attribute coupling closure can be thought of AS the optimal Aethus in the partition being treated as the embodiment of the coupling, which for the alternative elements of the partition having weight zero is heuristically effectively the joint-invalidity-toward-causality concept proper anyway, and so is approximately that anyway given that the other Aethae in the partition technically

as an explicit argument rather than as a hidden presupposition.

Three instances from the successor framework, where the distinction does work. The definition is load-bearing in the Nexic development, and three of that development's central quantities are frequentist in the present sense while being habitually called "random" or "probable" as if they were Aethic weights. The first is the outer probability operator of the Accordance Principle's defining exceedance bound: it is a proportion over an enumerated family of attribute-instances grouped by hand, while the operators inside it are ontological weights, and reading the outer one as a weight is the confusion the distinction exists to prevent. The second is the "randomness" of the High-Contrast Earth Hypothesis's log-space difference—the statement that the contrast ratio between two sufficiently specified histories is distributed as if drawn uniformly over a wide interval. That is a frequency over pairs of Aethae grouped into a class by the modeler's standard of "sufficiently specified"; no Aethus assigns a weight to a pair of histories, and the uniformity is a property of the class, not of any blank. The third is the "random re-selection" of the optimal Aethus of a partition under perturbation: the claim that the perturbed history's optimum lands essentially anywhere in the scheme with respect to where the original optimum stood. Relative to any one Aethus nothing is re-selected at random; the optimum is whichever cell the weights make largest, and the weights are what they are. The randomness is a proportion across the equivalence class of perturbations—over that class, the argmax is exchangeable—and it is frequentist exactly as the coin flips are.

Two things called determinate, and why the frequentist instances are not Aethic ignorance. The three instances share a structure that deserves its own statement, because it is the reason none of them is an ontological probability. In each, the constraint that the "random" quantity obeys is already encoded in the Aethic tree: which cell of a scheme carries the greatest weight, what the contrast between two histories is, whether an exceedance bound holds—these are fixed by the tree's structure, which is not indexed to any Aethus. The tree is *determinate* in that sense. But the first postulate says that determinacy is relative—that a contingent truth is determinate only relative to an Aethus that holds a record of it. These are two different concepts wearing one word. The tree's determinacy is the fixity of the validity-and-weight structure over all Aethae; the postulate's determinacy is the statedness of a contingent attribute within one. The frequentist instances are determinate in the first sense and blank in neither: the optimum of a scheme is not an attribute anyone's Aethus leaves open, it is a structural fact of the tree that a finite mind cannot compute. What the modeler cannot track is the correspondence between a broad Aethus and its optimal partition element—the coupling that the Nexic development shows to be a knot of interlocking prerequisites—and that inability is *mental* ignorance, not Aethic ignorance. The distinction supplies a counterexample to the natural assumption that mental and Aethic ignorance coincide: here is a case in which the Aethus holds everything the tree fixes, and the mind holding that Aethus still cannot say which cell is optimal. Mental ignorance is therefore strictly *broader* than Aethic ignorance, and the excess is exactly the frequentist residue—what one must model by proportion because one cannot compute it by weight. Which structures of the tree get frozen in this way, and why, is the frontier question of the Nexic development, and the present distinction is what makes it a well-posed question rather than a confusion between two determinacies. One class of cases is deliberately excluded from the counterexample: knowing something on the strength of bad information, as in the stopped clock of Section 2.3.6, where the word "know" is doing whatever the example's author needs it to do and the case therefore establishes nothing robust about either kind of ignorance.

Three remarks fix the definition's standing. First, it is a *modeling* instrument, blind to ontology by construction: the coin flips it groups are genuinely distinct Aethic objects, and "coin flip" names the modeler's grouping, not a kind the ontology supplies. Second, the definition is what survives of frequentism under the first postulate, and it is worth being exact about how little that is. As an ontological account of what probability *is*, frequentism stands directly refuted by the assessment above — the trial-class is no ontological kind, the equivalence of the trials is supplied by the modeler, and the limit is taken over a sequence the first postulate refuses to supply — so nothing of frequentism's *definition*

aren't zero weight but just much logarithmically smaller. ALSO you may or may not have guessed how to do this anyway, but just to get it into the Nexic paper since we describe using the ''same'' Aethic partition scheme on both orderings: a partition scheme on A is simply an operator on A of Aethically partitioning the multiplicative identity of the Aethic tree (which I call the ''Null Aethus'') into whatever indexically defines that scheme, and then element-wise multiplying each by A and taking the Aethus reduced form. Also since this is a lot of a different side of the same coin of what shows up in the optimal_earth extraction paper already, please also propagate a lot of this to IT itself, if that seems like the right idea. Thank you!

of probability survives at all. What survives is strictly the modeling instrument: the proportion-over-a-declared-class picture is perfectly well-formed once the class is admitted to be *declared* rather than discovered, and the law-of-large-numbers behavior that made frequentism attractive is retained relative to the declaration, ontologically demoted from definition to bookkeeping. Third, the object is load-bearing beyond this paper: the successor framework's central constraint — the Accordance Principle of the Nexic development — is stated as an exceedance bound whose *outer* probability operator is exactly an Aethic frequentist probability in the present sense, a proportion over an enumerated family of attribute-instances, while its *inner* operators are ontological weights; the unpacking is performed there, and rests on the definition here.

A blank-inclusive extension, and the limit taken locally. The definition as stated ranges over stated attributes only, and that restriction should be read as provisional rather than principled, because it offends a design norm worth stating in its own right: it is poor Aethic practice for a definition to range over *stated* attributes as such rather than over attributes simpliciter. Statedness is an Aethus-indexed property — an attribute blank at the present index is stated in proper child Aethae — so a statedness-restricted class changes its own membership across exactly the descent the ontology runs on, and the declared equivalence classes fail to be held fixed under the Aethus's growth. The robust form ranges over the attributes themselves, statedness left unclarified, with the stated-only reading recovered as the class's collapse at the current index. Accordingly, the modeler's class may — and canonically should — be declared to include attributes still *blank* relative to H: future coin flips presently in disagreeing superposition. Under that extension the class proportion ceases to be a determinate number and becomes a blank quantity of H in its own right: for a class of n stated members, k of them falling under the state, together with m blank members each carrying ontological weight p for it, the proportion's expectation is $(k + mp)/(n + m)$ — the weighted average over the partial-determinate completions, with the all-stated binary count recovered as the limiting case — and its variance about that expectation is $m\,p(1-p)/(n+m)^2$, (the blank members declared independent and equally weighted, the simplest case; correlated or unequally weighted declarations adjust the bookkeeping without changing its shape), so that as the declared class extends over the open future the superposed proportion *concentrates on the ontological weight itself.* Two things follow, one pleasing and one honest. The pleasing one: the law-of-large-numbers limit is thereby available *locally to the present Aethus.* One need not trace realizations out to the infinite future to reach it; the blank members contribute their weights now, and the limit is attained in declaration rather than awaited in realization. The honest one: the construction does not extract ontological probability from frequencies — it exhibits the dependency running the other way. The moment the class admits a single blank, the true weights enter the translation, and the frequentist object over an open class is revealed as parasitic on the ontological weighting throughout: the realized binary count was the shadow all along, sharp only where the record had already collapsed it. How far the locally-taken limit can substitute for the realized one in applications — in particular, whether the successor constraint's exceedance bookkeeping can be run against declared-open classes rather than realized enumerations — is recorded as an open question.

11.1.2 Aethic Sweeps Over the Hyperealized Layers of an Aethus

Consider a derivational exercise which we might call an 'Aethic sweep'. The premise of Aethic sweeps is essentially a more organized method of doing Aethic reasoning than other approaches, at least in many settings.

The idea is that we create different 'sweep layers', (each corresponding to a specific hyperealized layer of an Aethus), such that each sweep layer comes with a predefined set of conditions for invalid Aethae. This allows us to disperse such conditions for invalidity across the layers rather than running it all on a single layer. With the 'topmost' layer being the realized layer of Aethic reasoning, which is given to have to abide by the rules of validity within one's Aethic reality in question, we then are allowed to do manipulations on the different layers from the bottom-to-top direction, all while 'running' an Aethic sweep every time we jump up a layer. So long as one finishes their derivation by having run all required Aethic sweeps for their system in question, and so long as all individual layers follow the three Aethic postulates, then whatever insights one will have gained over the derivation can be counted as Aethically valid. The art of using Aethic sweeps, then, is to isolate phenomena on lower sweep layers without the meddling of validity conditions which apply only to the higher layers. When done well, then, this serves as a method of highlighting ontological truths that would otherwise be extremely difficult to derive.

11.1.3 Aethic Bayesianism as Emergence From the Aethic Reduced Form

Notice how this framing of Bayesian updates follows directly from the Aethic concept of the reduced form of an Aethus[240], which itself is yet an alternative way of constructing the hyperrealizable interpretation of probability, just without requiring the actual invoking of weights for invalid Aethae at all. This reduced form computation potentially makes the entire process viscerally more intuitive and non-forced, so let us engage with it now. To elaborate on this, notice how the original Aethus itself is constructable as $A_{\text{orig}} = \frac{1}{3}B_1 + \frac{1}{3}B_2 + \frac{1}{3}B_3$, specifically such that the contestant has yet to pick a door, and the host has yet to open a door this time. The factors of $\frac{1}{3}$ represent the genuine uniform weighting with respect to this Aethus, (in that the "actual door" is uniformly random in the most general case). Note that under the convention of centric unfolding, A_{orig} itself corresponds to the original block universe on the Aethic Markov chain, prior to the host influencing the outcome.

$$A_{\text{orig}} = \frac{1}{3}B_1 + \frac{1}{3}B_2 + \frac{1}{3}B_3 \tag{58}$$

Before conditioning on anything, let us write down the *entire* Monty Hall Nexus, with the contestant's pick left as an open attribute S_k in its own right—because seeing the whole object first is what makes the derivation below legible as pruning-work rather than as a rescaling of one of its slices. The full Nexus is the disagreeing superposition over pick scenarios:

$$X_{\text{full}} \;=\; S_1\Big[\tfrac{1}{2}(O_2{+}O_3)B_1{+}O_3B_2{+}O_2B_3\Big] + S_2\Big[\tfrac{1}{2}(O_1{+}O_3)B_2{+}O_3B_1{+}O_1B_3\Big] + S_3\Big[\tfrac{1}{2}(O_1{+}O_2)B_3{+}O_2B_1{+}O_1B_2\Big]. \tag{59}$$

Twelve weighted pocket-terms, and the three bracketed blocks are visibly permutation images of one another—the relabeling-invariance that the footnote below records is structure on the page before it is a convention. The pipeline now runs in three prunings. *First*, the contestant states the pick: intersecting with S_1 kills the S_2 and S_3 blocks wholesale—eight pockets die at a stroke—and the survivor is the conditioned structure X of the construction that follows. *Second*, the reveal O_3 will kill half of what remains. *Third*, renormalization rescales the survivors. Twelve pockets in, two out: the after reduced form is not a restating of the Nexus but what three rounds of pruning *leave* of it, and the count is the proof. Let us now imagine constructing the Aethus $A_{\text{after}} = A_{\text{orig}}X$, where Aethus X is the Aethic intersection of, S_1, the contestant picking conventional[241] Door 1 the Aethus $\frac{1}{2}(O_2 + O_3)B_1 + O_3B_2 + O_2B_3$, the disagreeing superposition of the three possible scenarios. Under the convention of centric unfolding, this X itself would be the "Monty Hall Nexus", as effectively acts on A_{orig} by means of the host's influence—itself an invalidation mechanism in the direct sense[242]. For this reason, the existence of a linear combination of the three B_i Aethae in X is merely incidental rather than a direct argument of a concrete disagreeing superposition as in the case of A_{orig}—in that sense the equal weights of each B_i therein is simply a statement of their having to respectively be non-weighted themselves to capture the algorithmic precision of the host's influence.

- $\frac{1}{2}(O_2 + O_3)B_1$. The car is truly behind Door 1, (B_1), so the host opens either Door 2 or Door 3 with equal probability $(\frac{1}{2}(O_2 + O_3))$.
- O_3B_2. The car is truly behind Door 2, (B_2), so the host opens Door 3 (O_3).
- O_2B_3. The car is truly behind Door 3, (B_3), so the host opens Door 2 (O_2).

We now write the explicit Aethic intersection of these cases.

$$A_{\text{after}} = \left(\frac{1}{3}B_1 + \frac{1}{3}B_2 + \frac{1}{3}B_3\right) \cdot S_1 \cdot \left(\frac{1}{2}(O_2 + O_3)B_1 + O_3B_2 + O_2B_3\right) \tag{60}$$

[240] Which, incidentally is precisely the same mechanism operating in cases like the Quantum Nexus, thereby unifying the "Aethus side" while allowing the "probability weight" side to vary between classical or quantum depending on the case in question.

[241] That is, conventional in the sense that the Aethic structure is invariant under perturbations of the indices of selected door under B_1, B_2, and B_3, which indirectly is itself equivalent to switching X for an arbitrary alternatively-selected door.

[242] Being that what we might intuitively call the host's "choice" in the Aethic sense is realized as an invalidation rather than merely a gesturing—as this is what allows the Aethic mechanism to be ontological rather than a subjective degree of belief gesturing at ontology.

Upon expanding, we attain the following.

$$\begin{aligned} A_{\text{after}} = &\frac{1}{6}B_1^2\left(O_2+O_3\right)+\frac{1}{3}B_1\left(O_3B_2+O_2B_3\right) \\ &+\frac{1}{6}B_1B_2\left(O_2+O_3\right)+\frac{1}{3}B_2\left(O_3B_2+O_2B_3\right) \\ &+\frac{1}{6}B_1B_3\left(O_2+O_3\right)+\frac{1}{3}B_3\left(O_3B_2+O_2B_3\right) \end{aligned} \tag{61}$$

We may then directly take the reduced form of this Aethus, which is computable by taking the reduced form of each Aethus within the linear combination—as drops out the invalid Aethae among them. In this case, Aethic contradictions make up the invalid Aethae in question.

$$\begin{aligned} A_{\text{after}} = &\frac{1}{6}B_1^2\left(O_2+O_3\right)+\frac{1}{3}\cancel{B_1\left(O_3B_2+O_2B_3\right)} \\ &+\frac{1}{6}\cancel{B_1B_2\left(O_2+O_3\right)}+\frac{1}{3}B_2\left(O_3B_2+\cancel{O_2B_3}\right) \\ &+\frac{1}{6}\cancel{B_1B_3\left(O_2+O_3\right)}+\frac{1}{3}B_3\left(\cancel{O_3B_2}+O_2B_3\right) \end{aligned} \tag{62}$$

$$\begin{aligned} A_{\text{after}} = &\frac{1}{6}B_1^2\left(O_2+O_3\right) \\ &+\frac{1}{3}B_2O_3B_2 \\ &+\frac{1}{3}B_3O_2B_3, \end{aligned} \tag{63}$$

Note that each of B_1, B_2, and B_3 is a unit Aethus, and so are idempotent.

$$A_{\text{after}} = \frac{1}{6}B_1\left(O_2+O_3\right)+\frac{1}{3}B_2O_3+\frac{1}{3}B_3O_2 \tag{64}$$

Lastly, then, if we construct the further Aethus $A_{\text{final}} = A_{\text{after}}O_3$ which intersects this Aethus with the host having selected a particular goat door to open, (such as Door 3, O_3, for example), then by taking that Aethic intersection and further removing terms, we attain the exact Aethus which the contestant is met with at the moment before they have to make their decision.

$$A_{\text{after}}O_3 = A_{\text{final}} = \frac{1}{6}B_1\left(\cancel{O_2}+O_3\right)O_3+\frac{1}{3}B_2O_3^2+\frac{1}{3}\cancel{B_3O_2O_3} \tag{65}$$

Upon normalization, this gives us our answer. Note that without this normalization step, we will still produce the correct Aethus up to an arbitrary real-valued rescaling[243].

$$\boxed{A_{\text{final}} = \frac{1}{3}B_1O_3+\frac{2}{3}B_2O_3} \tag{66}$$

The main intended illustration of this analysis, then, is on the universality of the Aethic reduced form for emergently producing Bayesianism. As connects to slightly more advanced cases like the Quantum Nexus (50) itself, the logical backbone of the Aethic structure together with the mere presence of weights reproduces the fundamental empiricism of probability, quantum or classical.

11.2 The Aethic Second Law of Thermodynamics

Interestingly, we can reason that the Boltzmann interpretation of the second law of thermodynamics is merely an emergent property from the principle of centric unfolding. Simply put, to one's Aethus we have that a given system of particles is to be in disagreeing superposition over every possible configuration that it might exhibit as weighted by the number of microstates to each such configuration. Such a thing is trivial when we consider the microstates themselves to be uniformly random in disagreeing superposition, and then each macrostate to merely correspond to a set of unique microstates. By the principle of centric unfolding, then, each Aethus itself effectively "freezes" its chosen configuration

[243] Crucially, note that the intrinsic structure of an Aethus is invariant under real-valued coefficient rescaling anyway. This has directly to do with the first postulate of the Aethus anyway, where only the relative weights of various proper child Aethae within an Aethic linear combination matters, but not their absolute values beyond that.

state upon stating it as is weighted by said initial disagreeing superposition itself. The idea, then, is that such an ontology immediately derives Boltzmann's statistical interpretation to the second law of thermodynamics [179], in effect then bringing about the empirical law itself. Crucially, then, we have that Aethic reasoning agrees with Boltzmann that the second law of thermodynamics is fundamentally statistical in nature rather than absolute.

Note that to the extent in which the arrow of time itself is derived from the second law of thermodynamics, we may make a complementary generalized statement across all Aethae via the indiscriminate time principle.

Principle 38 (Indiscriminate Arrow of Time Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
In Aethic reasoning, we hold that centric unfolding indiscriminately produces the entropic arrow of time relative to an Aethus at any point in history instead of only at the present moment[244]*. This is because when we truly analyze the underlying Aethic effects, we see that one's attainment of knowledge about any point in history still follows the same rules of attribute-gain as the present moment, with there being no intrinsic difference between the two under the indiscriminate time principle of Aethic reasoning. As such, we hold that centric unfolding triggers the realization of the Boltzmann interpretation of the second law of thermodynamics indiscriminately across all points in the past and future history of the universe, all relative to a given centrically unfolding Aethus.*

This entropic unidirectionality is also what underwrites a caveat that appears elsewhere in the framework: an observer seems unable to resolve—to make stated—a blank whose referenced event sits in their own future light cone, because entropy-reliant attributes are harder to resolve against the flow of time than with it. That asymmetry is entropic rather than categorical, and it is precisely what creates the illusion that the order in which blanks resolve for an observer tracks the spacetime positions of the events they concern; the development of this point, including why low-entropy quantities such as the Moon's orbit are nearly past–future symmetric in their blankness, is given with the discussion of nonlinear time and the Aethic time index, (Section 12.6.1).

11.2.1 Aethic Reasoning and Time-Reversals

The entropic principle. A highly intriguing consequence of the extrusion principle concerns the second law of thermodynamics, and it can be stated as a principle before it is pictured.

Principle 39 (Entropic Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
The second law of thermodynamics is rooted in the progression of Aethic time—the transit between Aethae—and not in Einsteinian time. Consequently, a genuine time-reversal of the universe would not make the universe retrace its own ordering of events: it would instantaneously reverse every quantity odd under time reversal, (velocities, for instance), and entropy would then continue to increase as before.

Pictured: if a switch could be flipped that reversed time for the entire universe, then had two friends been throwing a football at the moment when the reversal occurred, then the football would not magically follow its initial trajectory back to the hands of the thrower, but instead would get something of a kick of momentum back in the direction from which it came, all while still feeling air resistance and other entropic effects as if time were flowing forward still.

This bizarre premise can be considered a consequence of the extrusion principle as well, where the progression of Aethic time and Einsteinian time are no longer obliged to occur in parallel.

Why one does not find what one left: the ladder ontology. More intuitively speaking, this odd circumstance directly involves the "ladder ontology" seen with the Aethic union principle and base Aethic ontology. That is, as one reverses their direction in Einsteinian time like this, and physically backtracks into their own past light cone, one might expect the event of different circumstances appearing than what "one left there last time" to be an absurdity at best, and a contradiction at worst. The Aethic explanation for why one may stand in the same point in spacetime, first initially and then after a time-reversal of one's own worldline, and yet see two subtly different universes effectively boils down to the qualitative facet of the extrusion principle itself: that is, plainly speaking, *spacetime was never so rigid in its contents to begin with, since by the ladder ontology concept we directly permit different Aethic block universes to exist as arbitrarily-different perspectival viewings of the matter and*

[244] To be clear, this is to say that in one's entire current Aethic block universe of habitation, the arrow of time at any point therein is mediated—relative to one's own Aethus—by one's own centric unfolding and the implications of that to Boltzmann's statistical [179] second law of thermodynamics.

energy within the same single physical spacetime. In other words, then, by navigating one's proper time-worldline to a spacetime point seen already, the differences in the universe's physical contents at that moment, (as implied by the need for entropy to increase both ways), are simply representative of a different perspectival Aethic block universe viewing that same spacetime point. That is, we know from the qualitative facet of the extrusion principle that space is littered with these different Aethic block universe-informational layers inside the latter ontology anyway, and so reversing one's own worldline direction in time would simply be one means of shifting between such preexisting layers. In addition to purer time-reversal contexts, this perhaps casts direct light onto the Aethic treatment of closed timelike curves, should they exist at all: *the grandfather paradox*[245] *is avoided because the block universe at arrival must be different from the original block universe anyway, as mediated by constant entropic increase relative to the observing agent's Aethae.* What is perhaps most interesting about this view overall, is that it illustrates a strong compatibility between the Aethic interpretation of entropy and the existing Aethic multiverse prospect.

[245] I think a straightforward argument one might make is that the third postulate of the Aethus itself solves the grandfather paradox, because if one truly could move back to precisely the block universe history which generated them, it is intuitively reasonable that the "paradox" itself is within the realm of contradictions pruned by the third postulate. This may be so (hypothetically anyway) but my personal intuition is that such a scenario brings an even earlier-onsetting restriction: *the Nexic Accordance Principle itself.* That is, if one truly managed to go back in time to kill their grandfather, and if the third postulate truly pruned all their attempts at success, then I ask *why would the Accordance Principle allow such a string of miraculous interventions to transpire in the first place?* Instead of having to find oneself in a scenario where probabilities multiply that fiercely, it would be far likelier that one never comes into contact with the time machine in the first place. So the idea is that the Accordance Principle itself serves as a "pruning agent"—prior even to the third postulate—which prevents one from engaging in this probabilistically risky behavior to begin with.

The rebuttal of quantum immortality. This is also where Nexic reasoning itself rebuts quantum immortality [139–141] directly: the very Aethus event of surviving all those dangers is probabilistically low enough that the Accordance Principle would effectively "prune" it as a valid possibility, (at least to the same probabilistic degree as that improbability itself). In other words, *the very state of surviving all that is considered a contradiction under the Accordance Principle, so the proof by contradiction at play is that you'd end up both dead and gullible, (ie assuming you survive, the very assumption that the universe hasn't already sorted you into a "safer" alternative is itself a contradiction, so if you ever find yourself at the start of this experiment you already know you're a metaphorical bag of turnips).*

1. For even a handful of rounds of the quantum suicide experiment, due to the compounding of exponentials you have an immensely low probability of survival. Therefore, the Accordance Principle infers that you are likelier to end up in a scenario where you never engage with the experiment in the first place. For instance, if the probability of you randomly avoiding the experiment to begin with is some A, and the probability of your surviving the entire experiment is some S_E, but surviving in general is S, then we have the following rough survival-case probabilistic decomposition.
$$P(S) = P(A) + P\big(A'\big)\, P(S_E) \tag{67}$$
Now we use Bayes' theorem to figure out the probability of A given that you survive, S.
$$P(A \mid S) = \frac{P(A)}{P(A) + P(A')\, P(S_E)} \tag{68}$$
The nature of the Accordance Principle is that assuming you indeed survive, this is the actual distribution that determines where you end up to begin with. Working basically as the Accordance Principle's version of Aethic pruning, what we have is that your stating scenario given some condition is not strictly the event's "occurrence probability", but rather the particular "housing of versions of you which meet the condition" probability weight, (ie where this is akin to how the third postulate of the Aethus retroactively sorts you into a scenario before you ever even get the option to pick one, as if you got to the end of one and then the universe reset and retried due to Aethic invalidity). That is, this is the exact logic which the Accordance Principle applies to natural history, so it ought to apply here as well due to this being a more specified special case of that.

2. Because $P(S_E)$ is given to be very low already, now, the only thing that could possibly make A' the higher initial happening assuming you survive is that $P(A)$ itself is actually very low. However, in this event, the Accordance Principle will then react by pushing the pruning even further back in time so that the probabilistic choice between the brutally-unlikely A and S_E itself never had to occur. You would end up on a yet even farther back branch where none of this had to happen, again assuming you do indeed survive in the end. As we know from Nexic reasoning, the Accordance Principle will prevent you from entering a very natural history if need be, so it will tend to push the pruning as far back as needed. Realistically speaking, then, we might infer that there is a particular choice of A where $P(A)$ is of feasibly high enough probability where $P(A)$ is vastly greater than the minute $P(A')\, P(S_E)$. This is where you are likeliest to land by the Accordance Principle under the assumption that you end up surviving.

3. The key, then, is that if we are assuming you are going to survive, then under that condition the Accordance Principle will Aethically prune any scenarios where you end up performing the quantum suicide experiment in the first place. In other words, the very assumption that you do end up there is an Aethic contradiction with probability $P(A \mid S)$, (with probabilistic contradiction being an Aethic Bayesianism technique, note). Accordingly, then, we attain a basic proof by contradiction in which you surviving to the end of the experiment contradicts your survival outright, because the state of you even reaching the start of the experiment in the first place contradicts the state of your surviving by the Accordance Principle. By process of elimination, all that is left is that if you have truly started the experiment, then you will die with probability $1 - P(S_E)$. That is, you only do not have

11.2.2 Surrogate Time Aethae

What follows is a proposal for how to fully replace the past hypothesis [180]-based axiomatic foundation for the second law of thermodynamics with an Aethic alternative. That is, since we already have the inductively-inspired, you could say "local scale" premise that forward-time Boltzmannian entropic increase is driven by Aethic centric unfolding (i.e. the Aethic entropic principle), we may also then attempt to answer the question of why Aethic time entropy increase aligns with forward proper time in the past of the Aethic block universe. Strictly speaking, because the boundary conditions axiom of the past hypothesis [180] effectively diverges from the subjectivist Aethic entropic principle by means of arbitrarily assuming equivalence between its "objectivist category of entropy" with the Aethic entropic principle's "subjectivist category of entropy", we may therefore assume that there ought to exist an Aethic replacement carrying out its same deductively-upstream role of establishing that events arbitrarily far back in the Aethic block universe continue to decrease in entropy.

The proposed Aethic mechanism of resolving this may now be constructed in effectively three steps, which we will discuss as follows.

1. We may construct the concept of a "*surrogate Aethus string*" in the sense of consistency with the Aethic replacement for set decomposition (Definition 47).

   Definition 46 (Surrogate Aethus String)
   Consider one's own Aethic time-parametrized string of Aethae traversed throughout life as per the principle of centric unfolding, (which deliberately implies the existence of such a string of Aethae). That is, for Aethic time τ the Aethus in one's sequence is $A(\tau)$, with the assumption that $A(\tau_2) \leq A(\tau_1) \Leftrightarrow \tau_1 \leq \tau_2$ with $\leq$ designating being a proper child Aethus.

   For some $B(\tau)$, we define $B(\tau)$ as a surrogate Aethus string to the Aethic string $A(\tau)$ if the following two constraints are to hold.

   (a) $\forall \tau, A(\tau) \leq B(\tau)$. That is, for all τ, $A(\tau)$ is a proper child Aethus of $B(\tau)$.

   (b) $B(\tau_2) \leq B(\tau_1) \Leftrightarrow \tau_1 \leq \tau_2$. That is, each $B(\tau_2)$ is a proper child Aethus of $B(\tau_1)$ where $\tau_1 \leq \tau_2$.

   In other words, a surrogate Aethus string itself might be thought of as running a sort of "component centric unfolding" to that of a canonical $A(\tau)$ itself. This is because of the corollary that for each τ, the exhaustive set of proper child Aethae to $A(\tau)$ itself is precisely the τ-parametrized position $B(\tau)$ for the set of all surrogate Aethus strings B to A. Therefore, selecting a particular B is like selectively choosing a particular aspect of the updating of information in A which serves as a component part which decomposes A. This allows you to effectively label a particular part of the centric unfolding updating of A for some particular purpose. Note that the reason this bares resemblance to the Aethic replacement for set decomposition (Definition 47) concept is because the set of all such B are far from disjoint in static Aethus content, and as a matter of fact are in many cases redundant—that is especially in the sense that even if something like the split reality hypothesis (Concept 10) were true, the vast majority of surrogate Aethus strings by combinatorial count pick components arbitrarily across such canonical parent Aethic strings.

2. Given this, we may also then construct the concept of a "*surrogate time Aethic string*", or a "*surrogate time string*" for short. This is effectively a construct which selects a particular surrogate Aethus string to one's own Aethic string which mimics the process of oneself ascribing a particular proper time coordinate to the current "frontier of block universe times currently under one's Aethic knowledge awareness"—that is especially in the sense that as one moves through block universe proper time and attains Aethic information discerning more and more spacetime events as particular outcomes from disagreeing superposition, one might then conventionally "track" a "current proper time present" from this conventionally. The important thing to notice is

certain death because the proof by contradiction's contradiction itself was only a contradiction with probability $P(A \mid S)$, but altogether this just returns your survival probability to the same "blind trial" potential anyway.

4. Altogether, let's face it, there's really only one reason you'd actually sit down at the quantum suicide machine: narcissism. That's why the actual conclusion is so poetically ironic—the very fact that the universe let you start the experiment in the first place means you never were going to survive, because that'd contradict the Accordance Principle. So by simply getting far enough to start the experiment, you already know you're yesterday's luggage as far as the universe is concerned: the proof that no bailout is coming is that you actually went through with the experiment in the first place. Fitting, isn't it?

that this is indeed something of a “fuzzy boundary" in the sense of not being encoded explicitly in one’s Aethic structure (as that would violate the stackal transform concept in the sense that a state-decomposable timecode would trigger an Aethic contradiction as one moves into the proper time future) but instead being inferred from the loose boundary of wherever the most-future proper time spacetime event current is in the inventory of one’s Aethic state-decomposable attributes. This is not to say that there are particularly alternative designations to the fuzzy boundary proper time present than this, because from the vastness of entropic Aethic information pouring into state-decomposability by centric unfolding with each episodic moment, it is the experiential paining of this particular moment itself which is the episodic reference-point of consciousness to begin with. That is, in particularly the sense that one’s own felt experience of time might be thought of as akin to how an animation’s frames playing out quickly gives the illusion of motion—that is, with each Aethic update by centric unfolding such a vast combinatorial count of disagreeing superpositions pertaining to the emergent outcomes of all particles in the room or the contacted world, that this essentially overwhelms the senses and abruptly draws one’s consciousness experience to center on it rather than anything more peripheral—akin perhaps to how one particularly strong sense overpowers the other senses, even if they are available. Just in this sense the overpowering is combinatorial-scale rather than merely an order of magnitude or two, hence why one’s past experience does not have the same conscious-episodic character as the present.

Concerning this, now, the proposal for the concept of a surrogate time Aethic string is that we mimic this process by constructing a particular surrogate Aethus string which artificially mimics this process of refraining to include spacetime events beyond a past block universe proper time t which increases monotonically with the Aethic time parameter τ of the surrogate Aethus string. For example, if one amasses a significant knowledge of the exact series of events which occurred on the day of the Chicxulub impact [181] death of the dinosaurs, then even using one’s present Aethus containing all of this information, a surrogate Aethus string can be constructed which progressively builds up to particularly the full knowledge content of that Miracle parent Aethus, attribute-by-attribute, (that is, in the sense that this would be a perfectly valid surrogate Aethus string despite not even mirroring one’s own progressive centric unfolding intake of information, and instead using a single Aethus of oneself). However, the trick of constructing a surrogate time Aethus string is that one might choose an option for constructing this surrogate Aethus string for which every Aethus in that string is prevented from containing attributes about spacetime events occurring subsequently to the continuous proper time time of day during the event which is monotonic to the surrogate time Aethus string’s Aethic time parameter. In other words, we might choose to measure the Aethus string’s Aethus time in labeled units of “seconds" starting from a conventionally-set zero, (without actually having to correspond to seconds physically, as this is only an imposed, constructed label), and then simply construct each Aethus in that string of exclusively the subset[246] of one’s own known Aethus information about the event which occurs prior to the proper time on the day corresponding to as many seconds after the day’s start to the string’s labeled Aethic time parameter, starting from the conventionally-set zero instance.

This gives us two key observations, then.

(a) With the Aethic proposition already being that the episodic, consciousness-pertaining flow of time is merely emergent from centric unfolding, we might raise the genuine question of what extent to which any one of one’s own surrogate times are themselves, more or less, consciously or episodically felt in the same categorical sense. That is, with caveats of course, perhaps the day of the Chicxulub impact itself by means of construction as a surrogate time string might be seen as categorically equivalent to the episodic experience of time in some sense, (just with different weighting for the sake of avoiding stumbling into absurdity[247], as is to be discussed in a moment).

(b) However, because the amount of information one can ever be exactly aware of for a given past moment is combinatorially-less than the information being passed to oneself by the centric unfolding in one’s own current episodic conscious experience, we may recognize any particular such surrogate time as failing to have enough depth to contribute meaningfully to one’s own conscious experience in the episodic sense. Even concretely speaking, we only can ever know a certain amount about a given historical event like the day of the

[246] Or rather, weighted parent Aethus, that is.

[247] Such as, for instance, the empirically-contradictory absurdity of stating that “time is an illusion" itself [182].

Chicxulub impact, so even if we ever hopefully attain a vast amount of information about it, it effectively might be thought of as like the null set in total static Aethus state-decomposable content compared to one's own waking episodic possession of Aethic information.

This null set-comparison discussion also brings about a fascinating philosophical question that I want to name explicitly: on the consciousness topic of how the salinity gauge-Aethus of a flatworm compares to "one's own" Aethus (being Question 1), we might also ask if a given Aethus pertaining to a surrogate time to oneself of the day of the Chicxulub impact itself can compete with said Aethus of a flatworm. If so, we might then explicitly explain how the consciousness of a flatworm "feels, experientially" as being merely equivalent to the extent of episodic content one attains by merely being statically Aethically-aware of a given weighted parent Aethus to oneself pertaining to a proper time past event—which is to say, negligibly minute, because even picturing a past event like a memory is really just a subjective-or-mental-level projection as opposed to anything remotely existentially innate like something on the Aethus level at the hypothetical base of the consciousness iceberg. *That is to say, note, that picturing a memory or imagining something occupies the mental-layer of the consciousness iceberg, and so is not to be confused with the innate, Aethic level extra-episodic consciousness I am discussing. See the Aethic truth versus subjective truth section (Section 2.3.1) for more context on this, by the idea of the Aethic consciousness iceberg is that mental interpretation is higher up, and something we interpretable impose on things. Hence, picturing a memory is like this, because it is made of the "stuff" of mental articulation. We would instead classify one's episodic existence as made of "existential stuff" instead, being a deeper concept like water as an element rather than the shape water is confined to for deliberate purposes. So, mental contemplation aside, I am specifically talking about that most innate, undecided conscious ticking forward of episodic experience rather than something categorically distinct and imposed like a memory.*. That is, the degree to which one "physically, episodically exists" in a surrogate time would be, hypothetically anyway, equivalent to how a flatworm consciously experiences our own physical world. The reason it feels absurd that simply being aware of an event makes one partially exist in its surrogate time, of course, feels absurd as a prospect, but to be clear what I am specifically arguing is that this may hypothetically be true anyway, just with such a null set-comprised faintness that it is combinatorially-negligible next to one's default conscious experience like how Boltzmannian vast entropic fluctuations are negligible despite holding genuinely nonzero probabilities.

3. Lastly, for a directly Boltzmannian-inspired discussion of why all of one's possible surrogate times only exist in the proper time past of one's block universe, we might propose the existence of an Accordance principle-like process (in the sense of its being operable within all proper times of an Aethic block universe, such that any emergently felt privileged proper time future occurs later in scope) which brings surrogate times to the root. That is, akin to the split reality hypothesis (Concept 10) privileging specific surrogate Aethus strings as the foundation from which one's centric unfolding arises, perhaps we suppose that one's own centric unfolding can be constructed from the Aethic intersection of several such privileged surrogate time strings occurring anywhere throughout the block universe. However, we would simply infer that there perhaps exists that Accordance Principle-like process which assigns weights to various "microstates" of where the surrogate times are located in the proper time of the block universe, such that for wherever reason, the "macrostate" of "they all occur in one's own proper time past" is vastly higher-weighted as opposed to the macrostate for "they are distributed evenly or even semi-evenly between one's proper time past and future in the physical block universe".

   So, in other words the first prospect is that all privileged surrogate time strings may, categorically-intrinsically, exist anywhere throughout the block universe, but we then have to infer for empirical consistency that for some reason some effect is in play which favors the macrostate of their all being in one's own particular proper time past to each given Aethus time to oneself. This is the direct Aethic proposition for how to regain the same effect of the past hypothesis [180], but all while remaining within the subjectivist category for entropy. That is, the reason entropy systematically increases with proper time at any perceivable block universe past moment is because (potentially, anyway) all such perceivable past moments, there exists a surrogate time string enforcing the increase of entropy there due to, in effect, its categorically-physical equivalence to one's current episodic felt flow of time, (that is, in the sense that due to the categorical

equivalence, by so much as enforcing entropy increase in one's local-episodic moment, we also have to transfer that same rule for consistency at all surrogate times—so in a sense if you must enforce the Boltzmannian second law of thermodynamics at the moment and all surrogate times or otherwise not the moment nor any of the surrogate times at all).

11.3 The Aethic Tree

The Aethic tree is an abstract representation of all possible Aethae under the refinement order, which is a lattice (The shared transparent-predictor model 11, The shared transparent-predictor model 12), referred to as a "tree" for the form in which it is drawn, a graph of parent–child edges; the relation the tree is ordered by for the postulate, proper childhood $\leq$, is a subrelation of refinement that in general carries only joins, a join-semilattice at real weights on the cone a fixed finite family of closure-independent carvings generates and a lattice only by auxiliary completion (Theorem 9). That is, in such a graph, every Aethus possesses a directed edge toward each one of its child Aethae. As such, the Null Aethus points to every Aethus in the tree, and is pointed to only by itself, (thus making it the root), and beyond that, all other Aethae are reached via edges from their parents.

An intriguing property of the Aethic tree, then, is the notion that every possible conscious being, in being rooted to an Aethus, sits somewhere on this same tree as every other possible consciousness. So, every human on the planet exists on this same Aethic tree, such that they simply hold different manifestations of the same ancestral Aethus through their Aethic attributes. Furthermore, given the fundamental tenet of centric unfolding, which states that we are constantly transiting to our own child Aethae, it follows from an inductive extrapolation that, at some point in our Aethic past, all of us would have had our consciousness present on the Null Aethus. This is an extraordinary prospect to ponder, and it is also quite difficult to truly grasp, but perhaps this is representative of the fundamental connection of all life in some way or another.

Lastly for the Aethic tree, consider two concepts.

Concept 7 (Dimensional Time)
Time as it is described in the theory of relativity. Time is a dimension which is a component of spacetime.

Concept 8 (Aethic Time)
While not technically time in the standard, dimensionally oriented sense, Aethic time is simply a quantitative measure of how far along one's string of child Aethae stretching back to the Null Aethus they are. While it is difficult to find the exact numerical values to Aethic time, it holds a property that given two Aethae, A and B, where B is a child Aethus of A, the Aethic time of A is less than or equal to the Aethic time of B. Beyond this, the details of what it entails are merely further specificities in the general Aethic time class.

As such, *Aethic past* would regard Aethae of oneself with lesser Aethic time, and *Aethic future* would regard Aethae of oneself with greater Aethic time. Remember, these concepts are merely representative of one's position on the Aethic tree, and have no direct relation to spacetime.

To form an example of where Aethic time is relevant to one's day-to-day life, consider how it allows for a more intuitive explanation of what is called the *Lindy effect*. The Lindy effect is a mathematical notion that the expected future lifespan of an object or concept should be proportional to its past lifespan [137]. Specifically, however, this depends on the object being "nonperishable," instead of being "perishable" like a human, whose likelihood of continued survival to a unit time tends to decrease. The issue that we would like to point out with this notion, however, is that although the distinction between perishable and nonperishable is empirically present, we do actually possess an ontological mathematical definition of *nonperishable*. As such, the use of this term runs the risk of circular logic, where it is both defined through the outcome and the cause to those systems which make use of it. However, this issue can be fixed if only one makes use of Aethic time. Simply put, here is the definition of nonperishable items with an Aethic approach.

One final note for this Aethic tree section regards the Null Aethus itself. Based on the Aethic union principle, we can see a fascinating trait of the Null Aethus – it serves as the superposition of the entire Aethic tree into one single Aethus. (Note[248]).

[248]However, note that the Nexus information of this is still vague. In order to compile the entire Aethic tree into one Aethus, we must know by which Nexus the Aethic tree naturally operates. As a matter of fact, we could create an entirely distinct Aethic tree for each and every valid Nexus. As such, what truly is the Null Aethus in this light? The superposition of the superpositions of all Aethic trees? Who knows! To find this out, we first need to understand Nexae better, and specifically how they operate quantitatively.

Concept 9 (Nonperishable Items)
An item for which the hazard rate of its perishing is constant over dimensional time relative to a fixed Aethus.

As an example of this in practice, suppose we are to analyze a book's longevity with the Aethic Lindy effect. To begin with, we must assess if the book is nonperishable. Given an Aethus to describe the book which has no attributes other than that the book exists and has a current age of t, it follows from the Poisson limit theorem that it should have a constant hazard rate with dimensional time, as such making it nonperishable given the definition stated here. Note, however, where the distinction with perishable items comes, which is simply a function of there being more attributes at play in the Aethus of description than this. By default, the hazard rate should be constant due to workings of mathematics and the Poisson limit theorem, however with continually added attributes to such an Aethus, the possibility of the item being perishable now also comes into play. For instance, take a human. It is decidedly included in a human Aethus that we are to age in a humanlike way, and as such the hazard rate of our own deaths tends to increase exponentially with time accordingly. This highlights that the difference between nonperishable and perishable items lies directly in the specificity of Aethic attributes describing it. Does it tend to be overarching, and as such operate something like white noise, with many possibilities of disagreeing superposition generally evening out in probability and creating a nonperishable item, or are there instead sufficient Aethic attributes to create a definite change in the hazard rate with dimensional time, thus making a perishable item?

This now being said, given that an item is nonperishable, the Lindy effect itself can be derived using a simple application of the mediocrity principle. The Aethus with which we use to describe an item, as before said, has only the attributes marking the existence of the book, and how long for which it has existed, being some t. As such, we may further deduce from this information that the book is nonperishable given the prior explanation, however it is still unknown what the particular constant hazard rate actually is over dimensional time. Through the mediocrity principle, then, it should be expected based upon the expected value of an exponential distribution, (being the reciprocal of the hazard rate), that the expected hazard rate is in fact $\frac{1}{t}$. As such, if we were to only take child Aethae for which the book is to survive, (hence applying the condition of the Lindy effect that success of longevity is to be taken), then it will follow that the dimensional time hazard rate of the book's demise should continue to be constant and the reciprocal of the book's current lifespan to an Aethus. As such, even though in every particular Aethus, a derivation might retrieve a constant expected hazard rate, it follows over the passage of many Aethae over time that the hazard rate will tend to decrease with respect to the changing Aethae. It is something of an unintuitive dilemma in the classical sense, albeit in the Aethic sense it is quite natural.

It should also be noted, to finish out this section, what "up" and "down" mean in the Aethic tree. By convention, the Null Aethus should sit at the very "top" of the Aethic tree, with Aethic time pointing down with its progression. It is done this way, such that parent Aethae point "up" on the Aethic tree, (to match how ancestors are "up" in one's family tree), and that child Aethae point "down" in the Aethic tree. This also implies that "descending" the Aethic tree means to follow the natural flow of centric unfolding in the downward direction, whereas "ascending" would mean to conceptually consider the space of parent Aethae rather than child Aethae. Note that this holds the reverse intuition in terms of branching than physical trees, at which the root is at the bottom, and the branching heads upwards. With the Aethic tree, instead we have the root, (being the Null Aethus), at the very top of the tree, with any and all branching from there facing downward.

11.3.1 A Further Note on the Lindy Effect

In effect, we might so far as conclude that the stage that is the Aethic tree is a vital backdrop upon which to describe the Lindy effect, perhaps not differently from how special relativity gains a newfound grounding once the spacetime continuum is developed in place of classical space alone. The circular logic in defining terms like non-perishable, then, would be rendered merely as a failure of perspective when attempting to describe a more Aethic effect like the Lindy effect, (or the Accordance Principle in general), using only the tools available to the classical timeline ontology.

More explicitly speaking, the Aethic supposition would be to assume that the time of death of a given system in question, relative to the broadest Aethus at start, is in uniform disagreeing superposition of occurring not at all possible future times, but of occurring at all possible future quantiles upon the probability distribution describing it. This uniform probability over quantiles may then perhaps be seen as a direct parallel to the premise of the Accordance Principle from Nexic

reasoning, (and the general Aethic mediocrity principle at large), for which one's own probability of centric unfolding to a given Aethus, regardless of where its newfound attributes lie in the timeline, is itself given with Aethic weight proportional to the direct probability mass of rarity for those attributes within the wider probability distribution given by the Nexus. Hence, we have that for a disagreeing superposition of a future attribute such as perishing to uniformly follow the weighting of any other probability distribution besides the Nexic quantile distribution for such would outwardly violate the Aethic meritocracy principle. Lastly, then, we get that once centric unfolding itself is undergone, for each future moment of dimensional time progressed to there exists an associating quantile for the death to have occurred by then relative to the original Aethus, so by centric unfolding we now have that this new Aethus will have a probability consistent with that quantile of representing the case where the death has already occurred, with the complement probability then representing the case where it is yet to occur. In the latter case, fundamentally speaking, we now have added to this Aethus that of course no death has yet occurred, and so the disagreeing superposition collapses slightly so as to invalidate all child Aethae for which the death has occurred so far within the original probability distribution. One way of expressing the outcome, then, (with the simple case of the new dimensional time attribute being added alone, rather than anything else), is that not only will the death time relative to this new Aethus once again be in disagreeing superposition relative to all further quantiles of this new Aethus, but will in fact be in disagreeing superposition relative to all quantiles of the original Aethus's distribution which postdate the quantile corresponding to the new Aethus. So, in that sense, the centric unfolding progressing of surviving Aethae onto the probability distribution of the death dimensional time is like gradually shortening the uniform distribution of quantiles from the original Aethus to that which spans from the current Aethus's dimensional time's corresponding quantile to the quantile of one. It is by this phenomenon, then, that we directly theoretically support the empirically-derived conclusion that the median rather than mean time of death is proportional to the current lifespan [138]: such is simply because the underlying Aethic and Nexic mechanism takes uniform probability over the quantiles of death time as directly relevant and the death times themselves as only indirectly relevant.

Altogether, then, the median of the death time, in being the death time corresponding to the expected value of the quantile of the death time, is that quantity which directly links up to said Aethic and Nexic circumstances driving the centric unfolding progression. And, perhaps the fun bonus is that we ought to remember that this Aethic measure of survival time alone is impartial to other measures of quality until correlated as such, so we might even picture that for a particularly lasting concept, such as a decades-old television show for example, this age-respective parent Aethus measure will of course take the quality of that television show to be particularly high after the fact, and further by the extrusion principle will imply that said television show had always maintained that level of potential for quality since the very beginning in its history in the block universe, (as is particularly expressed with its hazard rate of death being taken as effectively inversely proportional to its perceived quality or ability to avoid death, which is all the while taken as roughly constant throughout the block universe so as not to have nonsensically apparated into existence in the moment). The seeming contradiction with the earlier Aethus for that television show taking its hazard rate of death as much higher and its implied quality as much lower, then, turns out not to be a contradiction at all due to the second postulate of the Aethus. That is, for a television show which lasts for several decades, the death-time-hazard rate-associated Aethus describing it at the end of the first decade does not truly exclusively describe that television show at all, but rather is merely the disagreeing superposition of all possible television shows which survive over said ten-year span, (since such a present lifespan attribute is indeed the only attribute asserted to be present in said Aethus anyway, as per its construction). So, in other words, we might imagine that a truly great television show which survives for several decades always did individually hold that unwavering potential for quality as per the extrusion principle, (thereby giving us the non-perishable criterion of constant function hazard rate of death with respect to dimensional time), but all the while we expect the inclusion of all the many more low-lifespan television shows in the decade-timestep Aethus to fundamentally insist on a consistently average non-perishable hazard rate over its contained set of constant non-perishable hazard rates, (for which many are high and a few lower, such as the long-lasting television show itself), so as to in the process effectively provide that entire disagreeing superposition with a dimensional time-constant hazard rate for the entire said category. So, plainly speaking, in the earlier Aethus we had simply not yet "picked out" the later television show shown to survive particularly long, but may do so in later-corresponding Aethae due to the fundamental constraint of probabilistic uniformity over the quantile of time to death. Thus, we effectively unscramble the overlay of Aethic considerations and temporal considerations driving the Lindy effect, as is perhaps analogous to how spacetime does the same to the overlay of spatial

and temporal relativistic effects. This is perhaps the direct supposition for how to best ontologically dissolve the circular logic surrounding non-perishable items.

11.3.2 Examples of Aethae Replacing Sets

Perhaps the most directly abstract general use, as a type, of an Aethus is effectively as a universally-applicable means of carrying out precisely the same job as a set, but through use of the Aethic structure in place of set theory. That is, we might consider the following methodology in this respect.

Definition 47 (Aethae as an Alternative for Sets)
Consider an Aethus U which is declared as the "Set-Like Aethus" of Aethae $S = \{A_1, A_2, \cdots A_n\}$, or more simply is what the phrase "Aethus of $\{A_1, A_2, \cdots A_n\}$" refers to by default. We construct such a U as the weighted Aethic union of such Aethae with equal weights, formally. However, the major use of this formalism is interpretive, specifically as an alternative formalism to set theory. Specifically, we may now consider borrowing the rest of set terminology and then forming a "set-like Aethus counterpart", (in addition to the one we have already just stated with "U is the Aethus of $\cdots$", being the counterpart of "S is the set of $\cdots$").

We may use the Aethic union and intersection themselves, as they already exist, for the counterpart of the set union and intersection respectively. As for the terminology from sets that A is an element of S, the counterpart of A is an element from U is simply that U must be a parent Aethus of A. Furthermore for the inclusion of Aethic weights, (that is, so as to move beyond the dichotomy of "presence" versus "absence" by allowing for interpolation to intermediate weights between zero and one inculcative), we declare that A is an element of U with weight w if w is simply the Aethic weight of A in U. Accordingly, A is then "blank" in U if this weight is zero but is formally "absent" in it with weight w if $\neg A$ has weight w in U.

1. *A rather obvious difference is that we may attach Aethic weights to the elements of U, which is perhaps beneficial because they are abstractly contained within the elements themselves rather than having to be stored separately like in set theory.*

2. *More phenomenologically speaking, an Aethus tends to be must more abstractly rich as a combining entity than a set can be. Accordingly, then, the "Aethus of Elements" is phenomenologically much more adjacent to a "blending which brings out the highlights" than is a "Set of Elements", because of its absence of those same hard dividing lines present in set theory.*

   Explicitly speaking, this mindset is centrally important to reasoning over Nexae. For instance, the "Nexus of all Humans" is intended to do something very abstract in directly the sense of the categorical abstraction of empirical Aethae. Even though we cannot write down the static Aethae of all possible humans, we cannot identify the shared stated-attributes, we cannot form the static Aethus of solely these stated-attributes, and we cannot re-abstract that to an Aethus, we may abstractly consider the resulting Aethus of this algorithm[249] as a finished-product without feigning to have to or desire to compute or compartmentalize it. Of course, we cannot even know a single stated-attribute shared by all such humans because of how inadequate our overly-specific categorization conventions are toward finding the "complex gradients" in abstract static Aethus-space, but nonetheless we may abstractly consider that these gradients both exist and process seamlessly when forming that Aethic union. In other words, the "blend or blur" of stated-attributes comprising each individual Aethus, much in the connotation of a vector embedding, somehow nonetheless possess a unique Aethus for which the Aethic union algorithm both finds their precise complete similarities and collapses the abstract space onto it. We just simply, through use of the Aethic union over genuine empirical Aethae, "indicate the Aethus which completes this, for use transformationally, rather than exhaustively asserting its qualities directly".

   So, another major aspect unique to methodologically replacing sets with Aethae is that this categorical abstraction is deeply ingrained in the structures naturally and without forcing. In a highly philosophical sense, then, such "paradigmatically reframes what the composing of informational realism means in the first place", and hopefully in a way which is especially true of our universe, (in contrast to naïvely-applied set theory especially, perhaps).

3. *When "an element is selected from this U", a major difference from selecting an element from a set S is that the set of Aethae S which formed U are actually not generally the only elements in*

[249] Note that this is the algorithm for taking the Aethic union, to be clear.

U. Instead, each possible Aethus formed by mixing and matching the Aethic attributes of Aethae from S is an element of U as well, so long as we do not add stated-attributes to this Aethus which Aethically contradict all Aethae in S.

For example, if we create the Aethus U, being the Aethic union of the Aethus of ten particular people with red hair and the Aethus of ten particular people with red shirts, then those twenty total people are not actually the exhaustive set of elements in U. Instead, abstractly-defined people are also part of U who are defined as sourcing their Aethic attributes from exhaustively all of those people, even if they do not all come from the same person. For example, if one of the people with red hair was a science-enthusiast but not a music-enthusiast and one of the people with red shirts was a music-enthusiast but not a science-enthusiast, then a person with exactly the former person's science enthusiasm but exactly the latter person's music enthusiasm, so long as they do not have any attributes contradictory to all twenty people, will technically be an element of U.

11.3.3 Postulating the Interplay Between Aethae and Type Theory

Here is an interesting definitional question we might think to ask about subtypes of Aethus.

1. Is a general subtype of "Aethus" defined through the formal apparatus of type theory, without reference to the Aethic tree?

   Essentially the divergence would be at the Aethus itself, and the further definition would run through type theory agnostically to the Aethic definitional hierarchy.

2. Is a general subtype of "Aethus" defined strictly through the axiomatic formalism of the Aethic definitional hierarchy, such that each subtype of Aethus has as its terms the set of all child Aethae to each given Aethus?

3. Is the answer both of the above in some way, or is it to be asserted that they themselves are equivalent statements?

Let us conventionally decide that the third is to be the case, but with the following particular definitional constraint.

Definition 48 (Aethus Subtype)
Let τ be the type for that which is expressible as a subtype of the type "Aethus". Such a τ will be named "Aethus subtype".

Suppose τ is the type for that which is expressible as a subtype of the type Aethus. For a given universal set of all Aethae U, there is a bijection between the set of each Aethus $A \in U$ and the set of each term T from τ, such that there is a bijection between the set of child Aethae of A and the set of terms of T. Analogously, we might propose that for a "proper Aethus subtype", it is just the same but over the proper child Aethae of its analogous A as opposed to child Aethae in general.

Altogether, each Aethus subtype itself is that which has as its set of terms the set of child Aethae of whichever root Aethus serves as the "root" of that Aethus subtype, (with the root of each possible Aethus subtype being a bijection of each possible Aethus). For a concrete example, we might define "invalid Aethus" or "Nexus" each as an example of an Aethus subtype.

Given this, we might also then suppose that when axiomatically integrating the Aethic definitional hierarchy with standard type theory at large, (regardless of which of the definitional hierarchy or type theory we decide to take as the axiomatic layer[250]), it ought to be a functioning constraint that this definition of Aethus subtypes is respected.

11.4 On the Demotion of Quantum Randomness in an Aethic Ontology

It is perhaps worth briefly mentioning that according to the principle of centric unfolding in Aethic reasoning, quantum randomness itself is not particularly special as a "truer" form of randomness. That is, we might state the following important principle.

[250]There is an argument to made that either would do. Type theory because it is after all more general than the constraints Aethic reasoning is accompanied by like invalidity or the inability to store objects besides stated-attributes in static Aethae, but the Aethic definitional hierarchy because it already has Aethic logic built into it, which after all enables more structural-descriptive power than sentential logic.

Principle 40 (Randomness Universality Principle of Centric Unfolding)
All events of centric unfolding are equivalently "random" in the strict sense of a truly directly blank Aethic attribute becoming state-decomposable across the boundary of the relevant Aethic update.

What is particularly important about this is what it means for quantum randomness, and its demotion as a "truer randomness" to classical alternatives. That is, when centric unfolding updates an Aethic attribute directly out of the Quantum Nexus, like the destination landing spot of a particular particle among many options or the basis element that is actually determinately realized among many possible options, the fundamental Aethic consideration is that the difference in the case of classical centric unfolding updates (like whether it will rain here two weeks from today) is that there tend to be more channels of deducing these outcomes earlier. A standard example, of course, are pseudo-random number generators themselves, for which it is possible to gain sufficient contextual background information to deduce what the output number is prior to actually running it. But the Aethic point of the matter here is that this is a property of deductive availability in particular, so generally if there are truly mixed-decomposable Aethic attributes in one's Aethus which become state-decomposable in a later Aethus, then the random centric unfolding process by which the blank components are selected is on the condition of their being blank no less random than any quantum random selection, (because if there were a difference, this would imply an arbitrary difference in kind for centric unfolding updates depending on the Aethic attribute in question, which violates the Aethic principle that Aethic attributes themselves, as a type, are to be algorithmically processed equivalently under the Aethic structure and postulates).

Notice how by the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae itself, there tends to be a difficulty in picking apart exactly which components of a given mixed-decomposable Aethic attribute are stated versus blank (with the result being that in a macroscopic setting, a random component attribute will tend to be stated because more components in such settings tend to be state-decomposable as opposed to directly blank by excess of macroscopic deductive avenues)—but the point of the matter is that this is an analytical difficulty rather than an ontological one. Altogether, then, a Quantum Nexus random output like a given measured quantum basis element is only genuinely different in the sense of being easier to parse as genuinely being directly blank in the relevant output attribute with respect to the prior Aethus—but crucially this is a consequence of the aforementioned ease or the lack thereof of analytical parsing as opposed to a genuine statement of quantum randomness being "more random".

Altogether, then, the Aethic proposal is that all centric unfolding updates are equally random, it just so happens that a random macroscopic-selected attribute's chances of being directly blank are comparatively low enough compared to a quantum-involving attribute that the confusion is generated about their being different in kind rather than merely in context.

What "equally random" means. The principle asserts sameness of ontological kind. It does not assert equal probabilities, equal entropy, equal predictability or equal experimental certifiability: a biased resolution and a fair one instantiate the same kind of unfolding without being equally uncertain. At its defensible strength: whenever centric unfolding resolves genuinely blank content, the ontological status of that resolution does not depend merely on whether the attribute concerns a quantum or a classical system. The principle applies to blank components, not to everything informally called unknown, and three cases keep the grades apart. Where an Aethus states a generator's seed and algorithm, deductive closure states its pseudo-random output; where those inputs are absent, the output's grade must be assessed at that index. A composite description, a thrown die say, can have settled components stated and remaining components genuinely blank. And an outcome attribute can be genuinely blank at the relevant index. The principle governs blank components only: the third case, the blank part of the second, and the first only insofar as, assessed at its own index, the output is genuinely blank.

This is perhaps rather like how the Aethic treatment of the macroscopic limit of Aethic superpositions as well, where the limiting of quantum superpositions is not about a monolithic scale-based reduction in quantum-ness itself, but rather about the interpolative structure of informational accessibility. That is, in both cases we have accidentally attributed a property of the informational context to the nature of state in question itself.

11.4.1 Unpacking the Demotion

One misreading should be named before the unpacking, because it is the one that outside summaries most reliably produce, and it comes in two faces, both of which conflate the two scopes of one motto: *predetermination per Aethus, randomness over Aethae.* Its halves refer to two different orders. *Predetermination per Aethus* is a statement about geometry: relative to a given Aethus, the rendered

block is fixed in its stated content and superposition structure at every location—past, present, and future in the *spacetime* sense, along the proper-time direction of the block—so that "past" there never means an earlier Aethus but an earlier region of one geometry. That fixity is not a valuation of every attribute: an outcome-resolved successor rendering contains its outcome, tenselessly, at its spacetime location, while a predecessor that leaves it blank stays blank relative to itself; the points do not change, the index does. *Randomness over Aethae* is the other order entirely: it is the extrusion principle, the relativity of determinacy, and tense-free blankness proper—the transit between indexings of one block, which is not a process in any geometry and to which "earlier" and "later" apply only as the Markov-chain direction of the Aethic sequence, (Section 2.2.7). The first face of the misreading hunts for randomness *inside* the agreeing superpositions, as though a rendering's structure wobbled; it does not, the structure being fixed relative to its index, the elaborate extension of paths along the attribute channels the quantum Nexus opens included. The second face over-corrects into pure epistemism: collapse as "merely a ledger update," with no physical anything and no randomness left anywhere. Randomness lives exactly one level up: the outcome-resolved renderings are passed, whole, as the alternatives of one over-arching disagreeing superposition indexed to the observer, and genuine randomness, not ignorance, lives in the selection among them, in which successor indexing is realized, and nowhere else. The two claims never conflict, because they hold at different scopes; the demotion is a demotion of scope, never of reality.

The surface-level claim—"quantum randomness is not categorically more fundamental than classical randomness"—invites a natural misreading that must be addressed head-on, because the claim can be taken in two extremely different ways depending on which direction the equivalence runs.

The misreading collapses quantum randomness *down* to classical randomness in the sense of the hidden-variables program associated with the EPR argument [11]: quantum random outcomes are secretly determined by underlying variables, as pseudo-random number generator outputs are secretly determined by their seeds. This would be directly vulnerable to Bell's theorem [4], which rules out exactly such local hidden-variable reductions. The Aethic equivalence runs in the radical opposite direction. It does not bring quantum randomness down to the level of pseudo-random-generator randomness; it brings classical randomness *up* to the level of quantum randomness. The core move, already implicit in Principle 40, is that Aethic reasoning does not assume a determinate state underlying an unknown merely because it is unknown—quantum or classical alike. In a classical randomness framework, an unknown is treated as a determinate state hiding behind insufficient information: the die has landed on some specific face, even if you do not know which. The Aethic framework instead treats a genuinely blank attribute as a directly blank Aethic superposition—not as a hidden value waiting to be revealed, but as an attribute genuinely lacking definite content relative to the agent's Aethus—while an attribute that is merely inaccessible, state-decomposable but unread, remains what it is. Nor is this equivalence a bare stipulation. Aethic attributes, as a type, are processed by the same structure and postulates—nothing in the second postulate, the pruning, or the selection operator consults what an attribute is *about*. Uniform rules can still respond differently to different structural content, and they do: record structure, deductive accessibility, composition regime and weighting all differ between cases. The claim is that the framework contains no further distinction of randomness-kind beyond those structures, so a difference in the kind of centric-unfolding update by subject matter would have nowhere in the architecture to be written down; that is the argument Principle 40 records parenthetically. Classical random outcomes, where the attribute is genuinely blank, are themselves the result of directly blank Aethic attributes becoming state-decomposable across an Aethic update; the only difference is that in the classical case, more deductive avenues happen to exist which can hide this fact behind apparent determinism[251].

Where, then, does the confusion incubate? Principle 40 locates it exactly, and the location deserves unpacking. Real empirical attributes are, by the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, *mixed-decomposable*—part stated, part blank, (Section 3.3.2)—and there is a standing difficulty in picking apart exactly which components of a given mixed-decomposable attribute are which. In a macroscopic setting a randomly selected component will *tend* to be stated, because the sheer excess

[251]That is, when we say that a pseudo-random number generator's output is "random", what we are really doing is making a perspectival claim about which Aethae have access to the seed and algorithm and which do not. This perspectival relativity is not, however, the operative type of randomness in centric unfolding, which concerns blank-decomposability of the Aethic attribute itself as opposed to mere unavailability of deductive access to a state-decomposable attribute. What is novel is that the framework holds genuine ontological randomness, in the strict centric-unfolding sense, to be not as rare as the standard view supposes: there are presumably real instances of directly blank attributes in macroscopic settings as well, hidden behind the dense layer of state-decomposable attributes that macroscopic deductive avenues impose.

of macroscopic deductive avenues renders most components state-decomposable; direct blankness is therefore statistically rare enough at that scale that, when the genuinely blank case is encountered cleanly—as the quantum measurement cases present it—it looks like a different *kind* of randomness rather than the same randomness met in an unusually parseable context. But the difficulty of that parsing is an analytical difficulty rather than an ontological one: the comparatively low chances of a macroscopic-selected attribute's being directly blank are what generate the confusion between a difference in kind and a difference in context, and nothing deeper than those chances is doing the generating.

This opposite-direction reading is what makes the demotion Bell-compatible. The framework has no underlying classical determinism for Bell to rule out; what it has is the agreeing superposition structure of the Quantum Nexus, which asserts not single hidden values waiting to be revealed but actively coexisting blank states waiting to be pruned. Bell violations do not challenge the demotion. Bell's theorem constrains a package of assumptions; the framework rejects the specified noncontextual, measurement-independent completion (Theorem 4) and reproduces the relevant statistics through its quantitative construction, the Quantum Nexus (subsubsection 14.2.1). The violations refute the naive hidden-variable version of the demotion; they are consistent with the Aethic version, but they do not uniquely establish it.

The historical positioning of the demotion is worth noting briefly. The dominant twentieth-century positions on quantum randomness—treating it as categorically fundamental (Copenhagen [23, 24]) or attempting to dissolve it into underlying determinism (the hidden-variables program [11], Bohmian mechanics [72, 73])—both take the quantum/classical randomness distinction as given and argue about which side is more real. (Einstein himself is deliberately not enlisted as the anti-randomness mascot here: per this paper's own reading of the dice remark, (the footnote in Section 10.4), his target is better taken as Copenhagen's *carelessness* than as randomness itself—an objection the present framework shares rather than opposes.) The closest contemporary position is QBism [78, 79], which similarly demotes quantum probabilities from special-fundamental status, but does so epistemically (as personal degrees of belief about measurement outcomes). The Aethic demotion shares with QBism the recognition that quantum probability does not occupy a categorically separate tier, but differs in that the Aethic claim is ontological: the equivalence is a fact about the centric unfolding mechanism—the world-relative-to-agent—not about agents' belief-states.

To consolidate: the Aethic demotion is the claim that quantum and classical random outcomes are produced by the same centric unfolding mechanism operating on Aethic attributes which differ in their deductive accessibility but not in the nature of the update applied to them. The apparent specialness of quantum randomness is a consequence of the unusual cleanness with which the quantum case lets us isolate the direct blankness of the relevant attributes. Two independent corroborations close the loop. The quantum–classical boundary itself has already been shown to be informational rather than scalar—the Powerset Invalidation Theorem slides it detector by detector, (Theorem 14)—so the demotion performs on the randomness vocabulary the same relocation the powerset analysis performs on the superposition vocabulary, the macroscopic limit being not a monolithic scale-based reduction in quantum-ness but the interpolative structure of informational accessibility. And the collapse-side analysis reaches the identical verdict from the other direction: the felt indeterminism of measurement lives entirely in *which* determinate-indexing Aethus one occupies, never in a wobble within one, (Section 10.2.4)—randomness relocated one level up, which is the demotion read off the collapse machinery rather than off the attribute typing. As with the macroscopic limit of Aethic superpositions, we have accidentally attributed a property of the informational context to the nature of the state in question itself.

Part V: Synthesis, Apparatus, and Horizons

12 Synthesis and Coordinates

12.1 Intuitive Updates for the Multiverse

One point of interest with the Aethic mindset might be to compare and contrast it with standard multiverse theories like the many-worlds interpretation [2, 3] of quantum mechanics. The main point of difference, to begin with, is how the Aethic multiverse is rooted to an Aethus, (informational and sentient-adjacent entity), rather than a physical spacetime continuum through timeline branching or whatnot. This would cause a number of paradoxes that have already been more or less gone over implicitly, such as the inability to create the third postulate, or the supposition that human quantum observers are arbitrarily unchanging with time.

Beyond these key differences, however, there are also many similarities between the classical multiverse and the more ontologically minded Aethic multiverse, (being the Aethic tree itself). However, there is one further point of difference that really helped our team on our way toward deriving the Aethic concepts in the first place, and we would like to share this point with you.

Specifically, we recommend thinking of the multiverse as two different concepts, instead of one. There is the *lost multiverse*, made up of all the Aethae you have passed by and away from in your centric unfolding over the years[252], and there is the *dark multiverse*, made up of all the attributes which are blank to your current Aethus, (and as such entirely unknown to you). The very epiphany that originally led me to the extrusion principle was the realization that the dark multiverse is ontologically separate from the classical multiverse, which itself operates more like the lost multiverse. In effect, the multiverse does not contain different instances of the same room, but rather the same room contains a corresponding leg of the multiverse within its physical contents. So when you stare at a room in which there is an Aethic superposition, you would note how you are in a single universe with the entire contents of the superposition, rather than the superposition perhaps being distributed across intangible alternate realities in the very moment. Apologies for the potentially Lovecraftian sounding names, (of course they are free to be changed), simply these names were spontaneously chosen at the moment to roughly portray their relation to oneself.

This all being said, it is helpful to picture the dark multiverse as not existing over different entire universes, but instead being a whole multiverse compressed down right into our universe with us. It simply operates directly outside your view, because, after all, it is *your* dark multiverse, but nonetheless it holds entire universes worth of information crammed into minute spaces. The nuance of agreeing versus disagreeing superpositions are a bit of a ways beyond the affordable scope of this, with the general idea being that right under your nose, vast arrays of possibility are unfolding right here and now, instead of being in some far off and intangible alternate plane. It's personal, you see. Not distant. This is the epiphany that I had in 2022 while I walked down a sidewalk at my school and pictured a coin being flipped. I imagined a web of all the coins and all the realities that could result being merged into that one coin, with the Aethus following neatly along and then – boom, the coin lands heads, and the Aethus loses the superposition like it never happened in the first place, (i.e. the extrusion principle). That is the nature of the dark multiverse.

As for the lost multiverse, it operates a bit more classically. It is a list of all the ways one's own reality could have unfolded, and what they could have seen but never did. It is wider and more expansive than the dark multiverse, but also more perilous for its array of worlds which hold an absence of life on Earth due to the terrors coupled with the Rare Earth hypothesis [106]. But even in our own sliver of ideal luck, we see innumerable different Aethae all strung together by the immortal threads of centric unfolding. That is the nature of the lost multiverse.

[252]Rigorously speaking, this is the set of Aethae for which the union of it with your current Aethus is *not* a child Aethus to you.

12.1.1 Noting the Multiverse-Language Equivalence

I want to note a fascinating philosophical thought my brother[253] brought up with me once, which is that the concept of the "multiverse" is actually as old as humans are, because it in its most general form is really just the attribution of meaning to possible worlds. For example, (as was his thought experiment), a primitive human whose friend dies asks himself "what if they survived", and in doing so has conceptualized the multiverse to exactly the degree to the umbrella category[254] of all modern multiverse theories.

The way I would phrase this, in particular, is that *the concept of the multiverse is precisely as old as language is at minimum*, because language itself is founded on the fundamentals of imagining and conveying possibilities which cannot be felt or touched. What this means is that "to speak" and "to imagine the multiverse" are so deeply intertwined, they are essentially equivalent. And to be clear, I do think the rabbit hole for these equivalences is rather vast. You might consider my hunch that nonverbal autistic people have already intuited the existence of the universe of Aethic reasoning, as articulated in my section on the topic. You know what else precisely nonverbal autistic people do? *They don't fall for the assumptions of language.* This is correspondence in my view, not even loose correlation. Also, looking to myself, we might ask how the Aethic union principle hit me, which for all intents and purposes is the epicenter of enabling Aethic reasoning: it hit me as pre-linguistic synesthesia of a concentration bordering on external sensory perception. The reason I was able to detach from the multiverse view is that I *could feel in my body* the rhythm of the Aethic alternative. In that sense the optimist in me thinks that writing this paper almost feels like the ultimate once-in-a-human-history sociological experiment, *because it answers the question of what happens when you write in plain English the resolution to a cognitive block that predates the origin of language, and then arose within it.* It is almost like the culminating chapter[255] in a story that began six million years ago with the world painted by the cognitive tradeoff hypothesis [183]—something which, sure enough, directly and uncannily-accurately attributes the shift in mentality to language. So while I am not quite arguing that pre-humans themselves thought Aethically—because of course that would be absurd to claim given how uncharted that content is—what I can say is that somewhere in the neurological blur operating beyond allistic humans is a perturbation in carried assumptions that makes Aethic reasoning obvious. Just how obvious, though, is something we can only wonder for now.

I might also briefly mention a pedagogical device I thought of to try and articulate to the best of my ability what the shift "looks like" particularly in this domain of the-multiverse-as-we-know-it to the-multiverse-as-in-Aethic reasoning. Simply put, it's that the multiverse of Aethic reasoning has an immensely quicker blur radius[256] than anything anyone has ever imagined. As in, the people

[253] So, to be clear, he brought my attention to this thought experiment, so it's his idea, not mine.

[254] That is, if we take the "commitments last-common ancestor" of all multiverse theories in terms of what all of them absolutely have in common, then our primitive human has already articulated exactly that.

This is also a particularly common "trope" I see throughout some classes of modern physics arguments—being that what seems to be a state of the art modern development actually traces to the oldest and most primal of human attestations, but is merely dressed up in modern mathematics. Statistically and psychologically anyway, I suppose this is the residue you would expect given that we are all operating on the hardware that is the human brain.

[255] Also I want to be clear that I am not trying to over-sensationalize here, but I mentioned this thought of mine anyway because I can't help but recognize that the more you look at the big picture of evolutionary timescales, the more the stakes of Aethic reasoning's existence rises. So you might consider me more confounded than actually self-interested as its (first known) discoverer.

[256] An interesting thought experiment I pondered over on June 23, 2026 came to me as my dad spotted a UPS truck pull into our driveway, and said to sister to get the package from he or she when the delivery driver walks up to the door. In this moment, I glanced out the window absent-mindedly as I waited for them to turn the corner and pass in front of our family car. Half-consciously, I thought to myself how relative to my Aethus at that moment, the person who was about to walk up was in superposition over all possible humans drawn from the Human Nexus, with their "gender attribute" therefore occupying Aethic superposition over both options. Then, sure enough, it was a man about my age, who walked up and handed over the package. As usual, I even felt a subtle kick of anticipation as I registered that I had, once again, just personally witnessed an Aethic superposition collapse—a spectacle no doubt, just a quiet spectacle. Later that day, I casually mentioned to my dad a pedagogical tool I had improvised, being that "all a person's Aethus is is blinders that they're wearing. If you could see the entire multiverse of possibilities right here in the room with us, it would be a much busier place. But your Aethus hides most it from your view. Interestingly though, the blinders don't apply to stuff you can't already see, which is why people remain in superposition until you come face to face with them again. So knowledge-gaining itself, learning itself, is the act of your blinders hiding a new thing from you." Then I mentioned the example with the delivery man earlier on, where according to Aethic reasoning both people—the man and the woman—were behind the car in superposition, until I checked and one of them dropped out of my reality relative to my Aethus. Technically it's an oversimplification though that is was only two people, although you could perfectly construct the Aethus for this phenomenology by just loading in many more stated-attributes defining each person, before placing the choice of one versus the other in disagreeing superposition. Note that the Aethic reversal principle prevents you from perfectly specifying the person, so to make them identifiable as "a person" you would want to load in at least as

upstairs from you are already in Aethic disagreeing superposition—meaning that you're not locked into a single determinate one of what you would call a "universe[257]", but rather instead the multiverse is already fully blurred out and present relative to you once you get directly out of your view. There is no "locked-off alternate domain" or anything—it's all blurred together, and the differences between the universes melts away immediately after leaving your line of sight. So when the people your back is turned to are doing "all possible things", it is not that they themselves are splitting in any meaningful sense, but rather that your own coordinate within the multiverse had bled through the stack of options distinguishing them, such that the space you occupy has them all overlaid, but without their ever having knowledge of one another due to the superposition being disagreeing.

12.1.2 Contrasts for the Corrected Multiverse

The equivalence and the blur-radius device of the preceding subsubsection together support three contrasts that sharpen what the corrected multiverse concept is and is not. Against the Everettian picture, the blur is *indexical rather than dynamical*: nothing splits when the delivery driver rounds the corner—no branching event occurs in any physical substrate—rather, the index of description has moved, and the plurality was already there as the standing structure of blank attributes. Against Lewis-style modal realism, the pockets are *co-present rather than isolated*: modal realism buys the reality of alternatives at the price of housing them in spatiotemporally disconnected concrete worlds, while the Aethic multiverse houses them in the one room, partitioned informationally, which is exactly why the blur radius can be *short*—isolation is false at arm's length, not merely at the edge of actuality. And against the physical multiverses of modern cosmology, the axes are simply *orthogonal*: an inflationary or landscape multiverse populates space with regions, while the Aethic multiverse populates description with indices, so the two neither compete nor require one another, and a physicist could coherently hold both. The age-old locution then receives its translation guide: "in another possible world, X" reads Aethically as "in a surviving pocket of some Aethus's residue, X"—which is the brother's observation vindicated at the mechanism level, since the concept the species has carried for as long as it has spoken turns out to be the language-side shadow of the very structure this paper formalizes. One last connection closes the loop: the corrected multiverse is *populated* by the permanence that Section 3.4.4 proved forced—every prior Aethus retains its superpositions permanently, so the plurality is not a speculative annex to reality but the accumulated, never-overwritten record of every information state there has ever been.

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many stated-attributes as you have for each person you've met before, so to be on that order of magnitude of "awareness" of them in the case of the bimodal Aethus of sorts collapsing that way. Such a bimodality is usually not what you see here anyway unless you limit the superposition to people you have already met anyway as if a dice roll among them, but regardless it's a reasonable enough oversimplification for pedagogical introduction.

Anyway, so this brings me to the interesting case of how this event of the other person dropping out of my reality is actually undirectional just like the second postulate itself, (ie in that like Newton's third law, if their Aethus is in superposition relative to me then so too is my Aethus relative to them, due to the statistical independence phrasing of Aethic superposition), which means that in the moment when they dropped out of my reality, I also dropped out of their reality. To put it another way, this is actually a direct identity of invalid Aethae themselves: specifically, how like all reduced form coupling, it is specially the act of *the joint Aethus of this person's with mine being an invalid Aethus* which enforces me to only come into contact with people who consist with my Aethic knowledge of the universe without contradiction. The specific Aethic observer consistency idea is that the state of me seeing the man instead of the woman means that that woman's further existence relative to my Aethus would allow her and I to come into contact later on, where she Aethically insists that she dropped off the package while I Aethically insist it was the man instead. That specifically would be an invalid Aethus by contradiction of Aethic truths, so my current Aethus at the moment of seeing the man wiped her out of existence from my entire block universe per the third postulate of the Aethus—you can never be too careful, apparently! But the catch is she is still out there actually, and I got wiped out of her block universe—never was anything wrong with her Aethus, or with mine—rather both of us crossed into a respective Aethus update which makes an invalid joint Aethus. So, the joint Aethus was the problem, and by the postulates it need only be the problem to get you observer consistency and reduced form coupling in general. So you could say that my Aethus "destroyed" her Aethus from my reality, and her Aethus "destroyed" my Aethus from her reality—sort of like matter and antimatter, we quite literally annihilated on the spot.

Also for the record, this itself could make for such good sci-fi material! For example, perhaps we find out that she was actually my soulmate, and there was some kind of cosmic mistake that allowed this to happen. Or, maybe there exists some kind of higher entity who can watch the whole event, and regards both of us as naive of the real universe in the same way as a squirrel cannot possibly save its tree habitat by negotiating with the geopolitical board of the state it happens to live in. For all we know, perhaps they picture this as some kind of ecological competition that we unwittingly find ourselves engaging with, just as an animal cannot tell when natural selection is acting on it. Maybe in this higher lifeform's culture, annihilation is considered a form of murder, and so here we naive humans are acting as immorally and violently as a rabid, animalistic dog off its leash. You never know, I suppose! (Although, I am mostly joking for this segment of it—sci-fi material doesn't have to be real by a long shot!)

[257] Or "possible world", etcetera.

12.1.3 Aethic Reasoning Against the Modal Structure of Human Language

Every documented human language encodes, without known exception, the following modal distinctions in its grammar or core vocabulary: temporal reference (past, present, and future as marked divisions—whether through grammaticalized tense as in English and Latin, or through aspect particles and temporal adverbials as in Mandarin, which is standardly described as tenseless while expressing temporal reference no less systematically); the actual/possible distinction (modal verbs, subjunctive mood, conditional markers, or equivalent particles—every language distinguishes what is the case from what could be); the actual/possible/impossible trichotomy (every language can express not just that something is possible but that something is ruled out, yielding a three-way partition of modal space); counterfactual conditionals ("if X had happened, then Y"—the grammatical machinery varies, but the capacity is universal — a claim with a history worth arming: the famous denial of the capacity for Mandarin [184] fell to controlled rebuttal [185], the episode fixing the capacity/morphology grain the parenthesis states); and the elsewhere-ness of alternatives, where possible alternatives are conceptualized as departures from *here* to some *there*—the "what if" is always a departure, the alternative is always located elsewhere. These are not arbitrary features of specific languages but near-universals or absolute universals of human linguistic cognition, as documented across typological and cognitive-linguistic traditions.[258] The Aethic framework deviates from every one of these universals, and the deviations are not incidental but structural. Hold the list; the close of this subsubsection returns to it with a different verb than *deviate*. The typological record sharpens into an argument once its *directionality* is examined. The Bybee–Perkins–Pagliuca survey documents not merely that the modal categories recur, but that they arrive by the same one-way grammaticalization paths across unrelated families: markers of obligation bleach into epistemic necessity, verbs of desire and motion harden into future markers, ability terms widen into root possibility and only then into epistemic possibility [186]. The direction never reverses. What this establishes is that the epistemic layer of human modality—the layer the formal semantics takes as its subject—is developmentally *late*, assembled out of repurposed deontic and dynamic material rather than designed for its job. The species' modal grammar is an accreted toolkit, and the formal analysis that systematizes it therefore systematizes an accretion: when the present framework deviates from that analysis, it deviates from a fossil record, not from a derivation.

One typological family deserves separate attention, because it is the closest natural language has ever come to the present framework's central move. A substantial minority of the world's languages—on the standard survey, roughly a quarter—grammaticalize *evidentiality*: obligatory marking, on every assertion, of the speaker's information source, distinguishing what was seen from what was inferred from what was reported [189]. This is the grammar itself insisting that assertions carry an information-state index—a fossil gesture, in the species' own morphology, toward the Aethus. And the gesture stops exactly short of the move that matters: evidentials index the *route* to a fact while still presupposing a determinate fact at the end of the route; no documented language grammaticalizes determinacy itself as a relation to the information state. The framework can therefore locate its fight with precision: it extends a direction the grammar demonstrably started, and abandoned, at the last step.

Three further categories approach nearer still, and their arrangement is itself evidence. *Mirativity* grammaticalizes the learning event: a dedicated marker flagging content as newly arrived to the speaker's knowledge state, not yet assimilated—the extrusion event itself receiving a morpheme, with everything about what the event *does* left unsaid [190]. *Egophoric* systems, (the conjunct/disjunct paradigms of the Tibetan and Newari sphere), obligatorily mark privileged first-person access, typically to the speaker's own volitional acts—grammar acknowledging that some facts are reached only from inside a vantage [191]. And *engagement* marking—the closest documented approach—obligatorily encodes the speaker's assessment of the *addressee's* knowledge state relative to their own: two information states tracked at once, in the morphology [192]. Each stops at the same wall. The learning event is marked, but not what learning does; the privileged access is marked, but not what the access resolves; the two states are tracked, while the fact both track is presupposed determinate and singular. The

[258] Stated at the grain the typological literature licenses. The cross-linguistic survey of Bybee, Perkins, and Pagliuca [186], built on a sample of roughly seventy-six maximally unrelated languages, documents not merely the recurrence of tense–aspect–modality categories but the recurrence of the *same grammaticalization paths* into them across independent families—obligation hardening into epistemic necessity, desire and motion verbs becoming futures—which is stronger evidence of a shared cognitive substrate than categorical overlap alone would be. Palmer's survey [187] treats modality as a typological category on the same footing as tense and aspect, while documenting that individual languages may realize a given category lexically or aspectually rather than through dedicated morphology, (Mandarin's tenselessness being the standard example); the universality claim in the text is accordingly a claim about the *distinctions* and their expressibility, not about uniform grammaticalization. And the capacity underneath all of them—talk about the non-actual and the not-here—is displacement, long listed among the design features of human language as such [188].

wall is always the ledger.

What makes the wall look like a choice rather than a limitation is that the grammatical *shape* the framework requires is attested outright—aimed elsewhere. Inalienable-possession systems forbid the bare one-place form: in such a language one cannot say *hand*, only *someone's hand*, the unrelativized noun being ungrammatical rather than merely odd [193]. That is obligatory two-place predication with the bare form banned—exactly the first postulate's demand, transposed from body parts to truth. Natural grammar contains the machinery of mandatory relativization; it has simply never once pointed that machinery at determinacy.

Against that record, the framework's deviations from the opening list can now be stated structurally:

- *Elsewhere-ness becomes co-presence.* Possible alternatives are not located at other worlds, other times, or other scenarios; they are co-present pockets within the same block universe, sharing the same physical space, (Section 2.4.2).

- *The trichotomy collapses to two.* The three classical modal statuses—actual, merely possible, and impossible—reduce to two under the modal collapse: co-present (valid) and invalid. "Mere possibility" is eliminated as a category; what exists is co-present, and what does not is pruned, (Section 9.1).

- *Counterfactuals are evaluated by perturbation, not departure.* Instead of traveling to the closest possible world where the antecedent holds, the perturbation operator reopens a page of the evaluating Aethus's own books and re-prunes, (Section 9.1). Nothing is manufactured elsewhere.

- *Tense-free blankness replaces the grammatical past/future asymmetry.* An attribute can be blank regardless of where it sits in proper time—a property formalized as the indiscriminate time principle, (Principle 11)—so the grammar of "what has happened" versus "what will happen" does not track the structure of the Aethic ontology.

The deviation list gains its full weight from the formal-semantics side of the linguistics, because the possible-worlds architecture the framework replaces is not merely a philosophers' convention that language happens to gesture at—it is the working analysis of what human modal talk *means*. In the standard Kratzerian treatment [129], a natural-language modal is a quantifier over accessible worlds relativized to two contextual parameters: a *modal base*, fixing which worlds are in play, and an *ordering source*, ranking those worlds against an ideal; conditionals then function as restrictors on the modal base, and this package is the textbook semantics of the field [194]. Read against it, the Aethic replacement has exactly the shape it had against Lewis, (Section 2.2.1): the modal base survives translation—it becomes the residue of surviving pockets after the pruning, (Section 9.1)—while the ordering source is deleted rather than refined, its work split between validity, which prunes, and weight, which measures. One ordering parameter deleted on the philosophy side, one on the linguistics side, and it is recognizably the same parameter: a graded ranking of alternatives against an ideal that neither tradition ever derived from anything more fundamental. That the deletion lands on the semantics of the species' own languages, and not merely on a formal tradition, is what gives the preceding list its bite. The lineage deserves to be stated as history, because it converts the deviation from a stylistic choice into a structural confrontation. The possible-worlds apparatus received its mathematics from modal logic [195], but its *application* to modality was calibrated against natural language from the start: Kratzer's framework is explicitly a semantics of the German and English modal auxiliaries, answerable to speaker judgments about what sentences mean [129]; and Lewis tuned the similarity ordering's priority weights precisely so that the counterfactual clauses would match ordinary intuitions about English conditionals, adjusting the weights when celebrated cases pulled against them [196]. The validation loop of the incumbent semantics, in other words, runs through the native speaker: the grammar supplies both the data and the judge. A framework that deviates from the grammar therefore loses the home court by construction—no refinement of intuition-matching can vindicate it—and must relocate its court of appeal, which is exactly what this paper does: the tribunal it answers to is the empirical record of the physics, where agreeing superpositions leave fingerprints that no intuition ever predicted. The stakes of that relocation are recorded, in the author's own voice, in Section 12.1.1; this subsubsection's job is the documentary one, establishing that the adversary those stakes presuppose is real, old, and structural. If these deviations are correct, they would imply that the framework is contending not merely with a philosophical position but with a cognitive default that may have been encoded in the deep structure of human language since before recorded history. The conceptual resistance to the extrusion principle may therefore be partly linguistic rather than purely

intellectual: the framework is asking the reader to reason in a way that their native grammar is not built to express, which is perhaps why the extrusion principle's content feels "humanly nonclassical," as discussed in Section 10.3.1. This observation may also illuminate why the framework was difficult to communicate even after its internal logic was complete: the vocabulary-translation problem is not merely terminological but grammatical, in the sense that the target concepts lack native encodings in any human language. What the record above does *not* yet supply is the why—why a species whose grammar demonstrably started down the indexing road, four separate times, stopped at the same wall four separate times. The remainder of this subsubsection is that answer, driven to its closure.

The diagnosis. The thesis can be stated in one sentence and then unpacked: *human modal language is a conceptual piecewise function—genuinely Aethus-valued on its counterfactual segment, and governed on its categorical segment by an artificially implemented convention under which each speaker is dropped to the terminal proper child of their own Aethic progression, the future alone left open.*[259] Unpacked: on the categorical segment—flat assertion, the talk of what *is*—the evaluation point is coerced. The speaker does not assert from their standing Aethus, blanks and all; the convention drops them to the terminal element of their own centric unfolding, the most-resolved child their progression offers, and discourse proceeds as though that terminal point were the ledger everyone shares. On the counterfactual segment the coercion is suspended: *if the light had been red* cannot be evaluated at a point where the light's color stands resolved, so the mood itself lifts the speaker back up the progression, and the clauses run on the standing Aethus—which is why counterfactuals require the Aethic machinery to be well-defined at all, up to every intuition speakers actually have about them, while flat assertion never seems to. The sprinkler case of Section 9.2.1 is one such intuition made exact: it is the verdict pattern on which the Aethic operator and every ordering semantics part company, and ordinary judgment appears to follow the operator.

The periscope. The image the note records is the right one to keep: each speaker sits at the bottom of the well of their own Aethic progression, holding a periscope up to the standing Aethus, and the perspective-valued logic runs only through the periscope—the well floor is where the talking happens, and the periscope is what the subjunctive mood is *for*. The periscope's workload, though, does not begin at the subjunctive.[260] Every epistemic modal already consults it: *might* and *must* are well-defined only as judgments from the standing Aethus—evaluated at the dropped terminal point they collapse, since nothing *might* be anything at a point where everything is settled, and evaluated from nowhere in particular they regenerate the paradox catalogue the conditional-semantics literature spent its decades compiling. The flat peg weights of Section 4.3 make that consultation exact: *might a* asks whether the peg *a* carries nonzero weight in the consulted Aethus, and *would a* whether it carries

[259] *August 10, 2026, 8:33 PM*

I have an explicit suspicion about ***why*** the human concept of metaphysics prevented us from going further: simply put, we are inherently communal as an evolving species, which means that we want to be able to fall back on a shared objective reality. Hence, I think human language, in its modal structure, might be something like a conceptual piecewise function between proper Aethus-valued reasoning when we evaluate counterfactuals (hence why counterfactuals need Aethic reasoning to be well-defined in the first place up to all our human intuitions) together with the artificially-implemented assumption that oneself is to be "dropped" all the way to the end proper child Aethus of their Aethic progression in the now, unless I suppose we are speaking about the future, which remains open in accordance with the moving present. The reason for this dropping to on-demand determinacy in metaphysical "location" is to enable the reliance that the reality experienced by one's friend is shared with that of oneself when it comes to outcomes, that way you engage in a stronger form of coordination, intimacy, and companionship with them by forcing yourself to assume metaphysical extension of their Aethic vantage to your own, and then get the closure of this over all possible experiences they could have had (hence bounded only by the future, since nobody's friends are exactly reading the future either--and notice how this itself then derives the moving present feature). Of course none of this was deliberate, otherwise formulating Aethic reasoning would have been easy from the beginning--rather I think it, profoundly, is baked into our from-the-beginning linguistic abstraction ability which separates us from ***Australopithecus***, meaning it was settled in the species collectively, as a convention--decided all without being analyzable by individuals. So the visual I get is that each person is sitting at the bottom of the well of their Aethic progression, but is holding up a periscope to their Aethus from which to execute the perspective-based logic which it alone can handle.

[260] *August 11, 2026*, on the epistemic-modal point surfacing in the drafting collaboration—the periscope image's root, recorded the following day and kept verbatim up to the fixes itemized in the source:

Omg yes lol that's actually EXACTLY the real root of my periscope image, which I forgot to add to the footnote yesterday: the idea is that every time you say "might" you are necessarily judging from your Aethus to remain well-defined (otherwise you get all the existing paradoxes in the counterfactual semantics literature again, etc), hence reasoning from the top, despite you yourself insisting on a physically objective world from the bottom! So in Aethic reasoning everything is a partial-information vantage self-similarly-speaking, (as in, when you remove information you don't exit from being categorically one thing to an Aethus), but in the human language case it's that when you say "might" you're basically referring up to your Aethus while insisting that operation categorically changes from where you are at the bottom side of the periscope!

the whole of that Aethus's weight (Definition 28). So the speaker reasons from the top of the periscope in nearly every sentence, while insisting from the bottom that the world being reasoned about is objective and one.

The convention's exact content, and the inversion. The convention's precise content is thereby a *category heterogeneity with a direction of derivation*: on the folk picture one is physically attached to a determinate world at the bottom, and partial information states exist only *derivatively*—constructed by first removing information from that base, and category-shifted in the construction, so that the top of the periscope is labeled *ignorance about the world* while the bottom alone is labeled *world*. Aethic reasoning inverts the attachment, not merely the labels: one is physically, ontologically attached to a partial information state—an Aethus—all along, and the picture is *self-similar* because there is no non-Aethus stratum for a subtraction to begin from or bottom out at; an Aethus with fewer stated entries is an Aethus still, categorically, and the determinate "bottom" is the derived object of the pair—the terminal proper child, a coerced evaluation point manufactured by the drop, a place one is parked for discourse rather than a place one lives. The two pictures run the same machinery and disagree about which end of the periscope[261] is primitive. On the self-similar reading, the subjunctive

[261] *August 16, 2026*:

Over the last few months of 2022, I distinctly remember grappling with the change to my experience of reality which came from unpacking the extrusion principle epiphany: that is, late at night while lying in the bed of my dorm room, I heard the standard liveliness of college life beyond the door, but faced the metaphysics behind it fundamentally differently. For instance, one of my roommates' name would be called from someone laughing and running down the hall, and in that moment I would register how I was not aware of specifically in what context they were called, and what they were doing. Suppose I could deduce they were in the room just next door behind my wall—then what in particular were they doing, and which people were running to get them, etc? Instinctively, as I pondered I would entertain the Aethic character of these events: everything I could not deduce in the moment occupied an Aethic superposition, or in the now what I would refer to as an Aethic disagreeing superposition in particular. To be clear, despite having these trippy thoughts, I was not entirely oblivious to my social surrounds, and this is a dynamic I unpacked exactly in my 2023 YouTube video script: *I would switch my brain in and out of thinking Aethically versus thinking socially depending on the context*. If I were playing a video game in the lounge room, I would riff off of the human set of conceptual primitives like social nuance and conversation-by-reveal (that is, if I had to name them in direct contrast to the Aethic alternatives) and then when I got back to my room or was in front of my journal, I would auto-click back into the gear I had been patiently waiting for all day: the Aethic worldview. Now, as soon as I got in the zone I was viewing the flying of disagreeing superpositions beyond my walls, as every noise and communication I heard offered by Aethus deduction into the compressed superpositions they contained, (that is, compressed meaning that fundamental identity of Aethic reasoning where superpositions fit exactly the container of what cannot be deduced, without pushing past it or falling short of it—which is interestingly something I articulated intuitively for the first time directly on the August 21, 2022 entry, being perhaps an immediate prerequisite to being able to jump the ravine on the day of the August 22 entry—it's also interesting now how under the model semantics notation of Aethic reasoning in 2026, it's also possible to render this intuition, at least up to before agreeing superpositions, as the natural process of intersecting more deduced information with an Aethus dropping out the proper child Aethae which conflict with it, as opposed to the more 2023 view of imagining the Aethus as a medium-type thing which simply phase transitions internally under that new introduction).

And, surely enough, this brings me directly to my interpretation of this thought ever since: what I was doing while switching was effectively bypassing an impasse that got naturally selected into humans for societal cohesion sometime before the early Stone Age. That is, profoundly, it becomes no coincidence that the Aethic view of metaphysics is so exotic, because something about the seed of societal maintenance on the microscale has conditioned exactly on finding the Aethic perspective absurd. Hence, why I have said multiple times since and during 2023 that I would expect at least some branches of nonverbal autistic savants to have been operating under the Aethic view of counterfactuals since the beginning of civilization, such that even in the event of my correctness I am less "discoverer" and more "the peculiar anomaly of someone who both was outside the camp of nonverbal autistic people and yet could communicate the Aethic counterfactual metaphysics to allistic people". Of the latter category I may be among the first, and with my linguistic masking concept having replaced the "theory of mind" phrasing of the latter part, I might even rephrase it like this: "typically in order to have the synesthetic caliber needed to intuit and hold onto Aethic metaphysics mentally, you have linguistic masking in relation to allistic people so severe that you fall into the 'nonverbal autistic savant' category and effectively cannot even begin to close the communicatory gap". So, what's abnormal about me, speaking in terms of count in the population, is that I have the synesthetic capacity of the nonverbal autistic savant branch and a high communicative ability even among allistic people—but more potently still, I do so despite the pair being among the most negatively correlated two features in humanity. Being at my quantile in the first makes it more reasonable to be in say below the fifth or the third quantile at allistic communication, and yet due to whatever circumstances of events I actually ranked into the higher quantiles of allistic communication. That, then, is all I can claim to be the first documented person at, but anything else given the topology of my contribution would be naive.

Hence, I can give you a precise statement of my periscope image from within this premise: by crossing the gap of the extrusion principle and literally picturing yourself as attached to an Aethus in place of the determinate reality of the well-end of the periscope, you now have to directly accept that every person around you is, as we speak, in a bath of disagreeing superpositions, such that you yourself will only ever access whichever among them you randomly sort to for your later Aethae. Your best friend is, metaphysically, smeared into an Aethic superposition the moment they leave your view, and remain so in every unknown feature of the past even when returning. Altogether then I don't think it's very surprising why this view is both seemingly absurd and physically naturally selected against for early humans—it upsets something required for the balance of early human societies. As for current societies, luckily I wouldn't suspect as much, since we've already done the hard part of inventing civilization rather than pushing to pull that off, and also now have things like quantum mechanics to handle interpretively. This is not to say that I would even go so far as to

is therefore not where index-consultation *begins*—consultation is constant, since the Aethus is the residence—but where the heterogeneous relabeling becomes untenable: a counterfactual antecedent contradicts the terminal point outright, no amount of calling the top "ignorance" can house the evaluation, and the ledger fails in public.

The same object is reached from the other side in subsubsection 4.2.2, where the moving present is the completed limit of the joint centric unfolding, the Aethic intersection of everyone's Aethae read as one chain, and where the conjecture that this joint object is the innate assumption that kept the Aethic metaphysics unconceived is stated; the two arguments share their conclusion and differ in their route, this one from the selection pressure on language and that one from the coordinate of determinacy.

What the convention purchases. The placement of the convention's root is itself an argument, not a stipulation, and it runs through a fact about single indices: *one index cannot need the convention.* A solitary cognizer acting at its terminal Aethus is Aethus-native behavior—and to such a cognizer the index is transparent, since with only one index in play there is nothing to represent it against, so it is never represented at all. What requires installing is the *un-indexing*: the deletion of the index, the promotion of "my terminal point" to "*the* world." Deletion of an index is a functional operation only where several indices meet and must merge; the one-place determinacy concept is a merge artifact, and a merge artifact's root sits at the merge—other people.

The same placement from the philosophy of mind. The philosophy of mind reached the same placement from the interpretation side: Davidson's triangulation thesis holds that the very concept of an objective world, the distinction between how things are and how they seem to me, is constitutively unavailable to a solitary creature and requires triangulation between creatures over a shared stimulus [197]—and the present diagnosis is that thesis mechanized, objectivity as the closure of extended vantages. The selection side then answers why the merge was rewarded. A communal species needs a shared object of discourse: testimony, joint attention, coordinated action, and the division of epistemic labor all require that when two speakers talk about *the* outcome, there is a *the*. The dropping convention manufactures it. Drop every participant to their terminal point, extend each companion's vantage as one's own, and close: the shared ledger is the closure of one's terminal Aethus under extension by companions' vantages over everything they have realized. Coordination is the selected-for payoff; the intimacy and companionship the note names ride as the affective face of the same extension—the felt version of treating another's realized world as continuous with one's own.

The closure's boundary: the present as a theorem. And the closure has a boundary, which is where the diagnosis earns its first derivation. Each companion's contribution is bounded by their own extrusion frontier: no companion's ledger reaches their future, so the closure of everyone's realized content has a ragged forward edge. The convention reads that edge as *the present.* Three features of the folk present thereby fall out as theorems of the convention rather than primitives of the world: its *existence*, as the closure's boundary; its *motion*, as the closure's growth while companions learn; and its apparent *universality*, as an artifact of the closure being shared—everyone inside the convention inherits the same edge, so the edge feels like the world's rather than the ledger's. The moving present, on this diagnosis, is not a datum the framework must explain away; it is the visible seam of the very convention under analysis, derived from the single fact that nobody's friends are reading the future either.

Why it could be installed for free. The mechanism side is the framework's own contribution, and it is what upgrades the selection story from plausible to closed. Grammaticalization tracks what pays in conversation, and conventions that get punished get marked; the dropping convention was never punished, because at human scale it is *veridical wherever it can be checked.* The record saturation the fundamental theorem describes states macroscopic interiors wholesale, and the cross-observer consistency the third postulate enforces guarantees that true witnesses never meet in disagreement—so within the arena where speakers actually live, everyone's terminal points agree wherever they overlap, the extended shared ledger never generates a detectable contradiction, and determinacy behaves as a one-place property to superb approximation. The two sides interlock, and the interlock is the diagnosis's load-bearing joint: the convention could be installed costlessly *because* the mechanism

advocate for the Aethic view in one's social life—just as I said in the 2023 video, wherever that clashes with socialization should be recognized and accounted for—hence why I like the model of switching back and forth between the worldviews to optimize for different things, if you genuinely want to take Aethic reasoning seriously and desire the advice! So, what's interesting for me especially is how despite the seeming insanity in picturing my college hallmates in a whirl of Aethic superpositions, it ultimately ended up being a very mathematical insight in character (that is, now that I can in retrospect put words to what I was tangling with at the time).

made it veridical wherever witnesses meet. What the grammar encodes is a true theorem about the macroscopic regime, mistaken for a truth about metaphysics—correct in its domain of evolution, and over-extended to the domain the laboratory finally probed. The word *convention*, throughout, carries its exact technical sense: a regularity arising without agreement, maintained without legislation, and analyzable by no participant—the canonical theory of which is, enjoyably, Lewis's own [198]. Nothing here was deliberate, and the diagnosis says why it could not have been: a convention settled collectively, below the level any individual can analyze, is precisely the kind of structure that makes its own articulation hard—which is the note's Australopithecus point stated at working grade: the convention is as old as the linguistic abstraction it rides on, whatever the paleoanthropology of that abstraction turns out to be.

What dropping the convention costs. The free-installation account states one half of the selection story; the other half is what the convention *prevents*, and it is stated here because the pressure only bites where the alternative is corrosive. Take the inversion at its word—attachment to the standing Aethus rather than to a determinate world at the periscope's well-end—and its first-person content is immediate: every companion is, as one speaks, in a bath of disagreeing superpositions, and one accesses only whichever branch one's later Aethae happen to sort to; a friend is smeared into an open superposition the moment they leave one's view, and remains so in every unstated feature of their past upon returning. That is not an emotional hazard but a *coordination* hazard: the shared determinate object of discourse that joint action, testimony, and pedagogy all consume is exactly what the attached picture withholds, so a population that spoke from the top of the periscope would pay the coordination bill on every utterance. The dropping convention is, on this reading, the price of society stated in reverse: not merely free where witnesses meet but *owed* wherever they cooperate—which is why the picture reads as absurd from inside a species that could not have afforded it, and why the absurdity is itself predicted rather than embarrassing. The corollary for the present, and it is a corollary rather than a concession: the framework advises nothing about social life. Its author's recorded practice, from the months in which the inversion first took hold, was to *switch*—the attached picture at the desk, the conventional one in the corridor—optimizing each register for what it is for, and that practice is the diagnosis's own recommendation, since the convention is correct in its domain and the framework's quarrel is only with its promotion.

The selection, closed. The evolutionary side of the diagnosis deserves its full discipline-grade form rather than a gesture, and its four pieces are all standard machinery pointed at a new target. *The unit and the platform*: the convention is not a genetic trait and not a feature of any particular grammar; it is a cultural regularity riding a species-specific cognitive platform—the shared-intentionality infrastructure that comparative work identifies as the human-distinctive adaptation: joint attention, joint goals, the capacity to constitute a "we" whose object is one scene [199]. That placement resolves the typologist's first objection before it is raised. A universal with no exceptions across seven thousand languages is suspicious as a *linguistic* universal and unremarkable as a *platform* feature: the convention shows no cross-linguistic variation because it lives below the level at which languages vary, in the infrastructure every language was built on—and ontogeny agrees, joint attention preceding grammar in the child as the platform preceded grammar in the species. The placement also carries its own checkable commitment: species without the platform should show no trace of the convention, and no documented nonhuman communication system exhibits the categorical/counterfactual architecture the convention generates — the great-ape anticipatory-looking findings [200] being the nearest claimed trace on the platform side, contested on the same replication grounds as their human-infant kin, and in any case a finding about expectation rather than about a communication system carrying the architecture.

The pressure: on that platform the selection pressure is the ordinary one, coordination. Joint action requires common ground; testimony and the division of epistemic labor require treating companions' reports as reports on one world; and teaching—natural pedagogy, with its evolved receptivity to ostensively marked, generalizable information [201]—requires the learner to file the demonstration as being about *the* world rather than the demonstrator's. Each pays in fitness currency, each is cheapened by a shared determinate object of discourse, and the dropping convention manufactures exactly that object.

The maintenance and transmission: the grounding acts by which dialogue continuously re-certifies common ground [202] are the convention being re-signed at every conversational turn—existence without agreement, (Lewis), maintenance without legislation, (Clark), transmission without genes, (the dual-inheritance channel, with the usual route open from stably rewarded cultural regularity toward

canalization [203]).

And the blindness theorem, which closes the evolutionary account on the same joint the mechanism closed on, now stated as selection's own limitation: selection sees fitness differences and nothing else, and in every ancestral environment the convention and the truth were *fitness-indistinguishable*—the regime where the convention fails, (agreeing superpositions), had no fitness-relevant presence whatsoever, so no variant that policed the convention's domain could ever have been favored over one that did not. The over-extension was not selected *for*; it was selectively *invisible*. A domain fence costs cognition and buys nothing, so the fence was never built.

Against evolutionary debunking. This also fixes the diagnosis's position against the familiar evolutionary-debunking move, which argues that selection tunes perception and judgment to fitness rather than truth and licenses suspicion of both [204]. The present account is the near-inverse, and stronger for it: selection here installed a *truth*—the macroscopic regime's theorem, veridical everywhere it could ever be checked—and merely failed to install the metaphysical fence around it, because fences against fitness-invisible errors are themselves fitness-invisible. Evolution is not the villain of this diagnosis and not its embarrassment; it is the reason the convention is as good as it is, and the reason its one flaw sits exactly where no ancestral test could reach.

The five universals, re-derived. The subsubsection opened with a list of five modal universals presented as the adversary. The diagnosis now returns to the list with a different verb, because a convention this deep should not merely *conflict* with the surface grammar—it should *predict* it, and it does, item by item.

Temporal reference: the marked past/present/future division is the closure's geography—realized content inside, the ragged edge as the present, the excluded region as the future—so the universality of tense-like marking is the universality of the convention's boundary. *The actual/possible distinction*: dropping to the terminal point renders exactly one catalogue *actual* and demotes everything the standing Aethus holds open to *possible*—the distinction is the convention's shadow, not the world's joint. *The trichotomy*: with the dropped catalogue as actual, the remaining space splits into what the books could still admit and what the pruning forbids—possible and impossible—so the three-way partition is the two-way Aethic partition viewed from the well floor, with "mere possibility" as the artifact category the drop manufactures. *Counterfactual conditionals*: the universal capacity is the suspension mechanism itself—every language needs a periscope, because no language could function with its speakers locked to their terminal points, unable to plan, regret, or warn. *Elsewhere-ness*: under the convention the shared room is fully determinate, so alternatives cannot be housed *here*; the grammar must locate them somewhere, and *elsewhere* is the only address left—the departures-to-other-worlds picture is what co-presence looks like when a convention has declared the room full. Five universals; five theorems of one convention. The section's opening list is thereby converted from a catalogue of obstacles into the diagnosis's confirmation set: the framework does not merely deviate from the universals—it *explains* them, which is a relationship no amount of deviation could have purchased.

Priced against the rivals. The re-derivations should also be priced against their standing rivals, because the universals are not unexplained territory: communicative-efficiency accounts derive much of grammar's architecture from optimal information transfer under least effort [205, 206], and processing accounts derive it from the performance constraints of real-time comprehension [207]. The diagnosis does not compete with these severally—a convention is exactly the kind of regularity that efficiency pressure would compress into grammar, so an efficiency story for tense marking and the closure-boundary story are accounts at different depths, not rivals about one mechanism. The competition is joint: the efficiency and processing programs explain the universals one at a time, each with its own local optimization target, while the convention explains the same five together, from the same posit that also fixes the incumbent formalism's shape, the fingerprints documented below, and the comparative absence the platform entails. Joint derivation from one premise is the abductive edge, and it is claimed at exactly that grade—the severally/jointly division being the honest boundary of the claim.

The seam, and the artifact. The diagnosis makes commitments beyond the list, and the two sharpest concern the philosophical tradition itself. First, location: if the language is Aethus-valued on one segment and convention-governed on the other, the puzzles should have accumulated at the splice—and counterfactuals are, notoriously, where they did. The tradition's hard case sat on the seam, and the diagnosis says that is no accident: the counterfactual is the one construction whose evaluation the convention cannot survive, so it is the one place where the folk metaphysics and the working semantics

were always being forced apart. The Cautious Monotony countermodel shows that forcing apart at the grain of a single inference: ordinary judgment appears to decline the conjunctive counterfactual that every ordering semantics must affirm once it grants the two plain ones (Section 9.2.1).

Second, shape: the ordering as compensation. Second, shape: theorists systematizing the counterfactual segment imported the categorical segment's convention into it—analyzing the one region where the ledger stands suspended under the assumption that it never is—and *an ordering over total worlds is what that importation looks like as formalism.* Total worlds are dropped ledgers; a similarity ranking among them is the machinery you are forced to invent when co-present, partially-resolved content must be simulated using fully-resolved catalogues. The forcing runs as follows. The native operation is: reopen one entry of the standing books and re-prune. In a vocabulary of total worlds there are no entries to reopen—only complete catalogues—so "reopen q" must be simulated as "consider the catalogues in which q differs," which admits catalogues differing arbitrarily in everything else, which compels a selection among them; and because the structure the vocabulary discarded was graded and dependency-laden, the selector must be graded and comparative. A similarity ordering is not one option among many at that point; it is the compensation the representation demands.

The signature: convergence. And the demand has a signature: *convergence.* Lewis's spheres, Stalnaker's selection function, Grove's sphere systems in belief revision, Kratzer's ordering source—independent traditions, one device [15, 16, 124, 129]. Convergence of that kind is evidence that the device is compelled by the representation rather than read off the world. The similarity parameter this framework deletes, (Section 9.1), is on this diagnosis the splice's artifact—and the deletion result and the diagnosis thereby reinforce one another in the strongest available configuration: the formal work shows the parameter unrecoverable from the clauses, and the diagnosis explains why capable theorists reached for it anyway. Refutation with etiology outranks refutation alone.

The seam sighted three times. Nor did the tradition entirely miss the seam, and honesty about this strengthens rather than weakens the case: Stalnaker's common ground is a shared-ledger construct in all but name, and the standard treatment of the indicative/subjunctive divide—quantification inside the context set against quantification outside it—is the seam, noticed, by theorists with no stake in the present ontology [208]. Independent discovery of the splice is corroboration that the splice is real. The differentia is then exact: the tradition theorizes the outside-the-context-set region as a *shift in quantification domain*, from one collection of total worlds to another; the present diagnosis theorizes it as *suspension of a ledger convention*, with the index exposed and partial states doing the work total worlds were simulating. Same seam, two accounts of the far side—and the accounts separate empirically at exactly the places this paper's semantics separates from the ordering semantics. Nor is Stalnaker's the only independent sighting: the belief-revision tradition found the same boundary in its own vocabulary, the Ramsey test evaluating an indicative by *adding* the antecedent to the current stock and a subjunctive only by *revising* it [209, 210]—and addition-versus-revision is the seam again, since addition operates inside the standing books while revision reopens them. Three traditions, three vocabularies, one boundary in the same place.

The artifact, diagnosed to standard. Calling the ordering an artifact obligates more than disagreement, and the obligation has four parts: show the parameter forced under an identifiable false premise; show the premise independently false; derive the parameter's characteristic pathologies from the premise rather than from bad execution; and show that correcting the premise makes the parameter vanish rather than improve. The forcing was just run, from a premise—attachment to a determinate base, partial states derivative—whose installation, maintenance, and selective invisibility the preceding paragraphs account for independently of anything the framework prefers. The rest completes the standard.

The premise's falsity is a theorem about information, not a taste. Two Aethae identical in every state and every weight, differing only in whether the interaction attribute over a blank's alternatives is itself stated or blank, possess identical completion classes—each completion resolves the blank and thereby destroys the co-presence the entry is an attribute *of*, so the distinguishing entry leaves no footprint in any total world—while deciding conditionals keyed to that attribute oppositely, (Section 9.1). No function of the completion class computes the verdicts; supervaluation is inside the ban. The consequence for the ordering is terminal: the drop from an Aethus to its total-world class is non-injective on verdict-relevant structure, so the information any ordering would need is destroyed *before an ordering is applied.* Lewis did not choose his priority weights badly; over that domain, no weights exist. (Scoped as the result is scoped: conditional on interaction attributes—on the agreeing regime being real—which is the physics' business, established elsewhere in this paper, not assumed here.) *The pathologies follow*

as a derived set, and they are the ordering's documented biography rather than a curated indictment: never derived—fifty years without a derivation from anything deeper, predicted, since compensation machinery for a representational deficit has no deeper level to bottom out in; perpetually tuned—the priority weights adjusted whenever celebrated cases pulled against them [196], predicted with a mechanism, since speakers generate the intuitions by running the native logic on the counterfactual segment, (the processing record below), while the formalism runs the reconstruction, so the gap admits only hand-closure, case by case, without terminus; context-sensitive by universal concession—predicted as a dividend, since the "context" that resolves each ordering is the evaluating Aethus, leaking back into the formalism under a name it is permitted to use; horizon-blind—a comparison of completed histories has no slot for the evaluation time, predicted, and supplied by the replacement as the horizon-graded verdict; Cautious Monotony broken by explaining-away—re-pruning can destroy conclusions whose grounds were live in the reopened region, which no fixed ordering over a fixed domain can model, the failure exhibited by explicit countermodel in the framework's audit of the classical postulates; and the field's own realism-versus-conventionalism stalemate about the ordering—the collective inability either to derive it or to drop it—predicted as the expected sociology of an artifact. Six symptoms, one etiology.

The disappearance test closes the case: correct the premise and the ordering is not replaced by a better ordering—it vanishes, its labor absorbed by validity, which prunes, and weight, which measures, both present in the framework for reasons that never mentioned counterfactuals. Nothing was added to take the job. That is the epicycle signature exactly: Kepler did not re-parameterize the epicycles, he rendered them unnecessary, their work assumed by structure independently required.

And the obligation Newton's successors owed Ptolemy is payable here too—derive why the artifact worked as well as it did. The derivation is one step. In the record-saturated regime, re-pruning a single reopened entry leaves every un-reopened entry standing, and "leave every un-reopened entry standing," viewed from outside in a total-world vocabulary, is precisely "hold everything else as close to actuality as possible." Similarity is the shadow of *don't touch entries you didn't reopen.* That is why the ordering fit ordinary cases for half a century, and it predicts the exact sites of failure—wherever shadow and substance come apart: long horizons, explaining-away, interaction-keyed conditionals, the three divergence sites already documented. The artifact was a true theorem of the saturated regime, mistaken for semantics; the diagnosis of the ordering thereby lands on the same sentence as the diagnosis of the grammar, which is the consilience expected when both are shadows of one convention.

Finally, the literature's own escapes corroborate the forcing rather than refute it. Premise semantics dissolves the ordering into premise sets [211]; the structural-equations tradition evaluates counterfactuals by surgery on equations rather than travel between worlds [126]; truthmaker semantics builds counterfactuals without possible worlds from exact, partial verifiers [212]. Every serious exit from similarity in forty years has moved in the same direction: toward partial states. Relief from the artifact has only ever come from abandoning the vocabulary the artifact compensates for—the field groping toward partiality without naming what the partiality is *of.* The nearest neighbor therefore fixes the differentia this section owes: Fine's states are mereological parts of worlds, unindexed, unweighted, with no blankness as an ontic status and no agreeing regime, so partiality without the index escapes the ordering without arriving at the Aethus. The escape routes are the forcing argument read backwards.

The fingerprints, and the fork. A convention this early should leave developmental fingerprints where a default leaves them, and it does. False-belief understanding arrives late and effortfully on elicited-response tasks, around the fourth year [213] — the anticipatory-looking literature claimed implicit success by fifteen months [214], findings since caught in replication difficulties, a dispute that cuts, where it cuts, toward the elicited-response picture relied on here: the young child attributes their own ledger to every participant—the dropping convention operating at maximum extension—and *divergence between ledgers* is what has to be laboriously acquired. Adult egocentric bias and the curse of knowledge are the same convention persisting into maturity as measurable error [215]. The shared-ledger assumption is acquired as ground and corrected as figure, which is what "baked in" predicts.

What the record certifies, and the fork. What the developmental record certifies, stated carefully, is the convention's *default* status—not, by itself, the diagnosis's direction of construction, and the direction is a genuine fork that deserves flagging rather than silent resolution. The note reads the dropping as implemented *over* an Aethus-valued baseline, with counterfactual mood exposing the substrate; the alternative reads the dropped ledger as the baseline, with mood *licensing* its temporary suspension. As a claim about acquisition order the fork is poorly posed, (the three-year-old's total dropping is

compatible with both readings), so its proper form is a processing question: does counterfactual evaluation consult an index that categorical assertion suppresses, or construct one that categorical assertion never had? The first reading is the note's, it is the stronger claim, and it is adopted here knowingly—and not on credit, because the processing question has been partially run, and each half of *suspension-and-consult* carries its own experimental signature. A further signature, at the level of verdicts rather than latencies, is the Cautious Monotony pattern of Section 9.2.1: an evaluator that consults a suspended Aethic index should decline the conjunctive sprinkler counterfactual unprompted, where one that constructs its index from dropped ledgers has no reason to reopen the wetness's ground and every reason to follow the ordering, so that suspension-and-consult predicts the decline and construction predicts its absence.

The two halves, in the processing record. The suspension half: event-related-potential work shows truth-value *within the counterfactual frame* driving semantic integration immediately—counterfactually false continuations eliciting the N400 that factually false ones do in ordinary assertion—so the mood's shift of evaluation point is real and fast, never a late repair [216]. The consultation half: eye-movement work shows readers in a counterfactual context still registering anomalies against the suppressed factual state within the same pass [217], and the priming record shows counterfactuals activating dual representations—the conjecture and the fact—where their indicative counterparts activate one [218], the pattern the dual-possibility program systematized at the theoretical level [219]. The adjudicating review of that record—co-authored by the author of the frame-shift result just cited—lands on the dual-meaning reading [220]. Ontogeny adds its own vote for the substrate: pretend play arrives around the second year [221], long before false-belief mastery—the suspension machinery demonstrably operational well before full command of the convention it suspends, which is the acquisition profile the substrate-first reading predicts. Comprehenders of a counterfactual demonstrably shift frames in real time *and* keep the factual books open—the exact conjunction suspension-and-consult predicts, and one that construct-on-demand must assemble from parts—so the fork stands as a live empirical question with the note's direction currently ahead, not as a promissory flag. And the observation that disarms the fork's remaining sting: *artificial*, in the thesis, never meant *late*—it means *not tracking the underlying structure*, and a convention can be developmentally primary and an overlay at once. A last fingerprint is predictive rather than retrodictive: if the convention is a platform-installed default, its grip should vary measurably across cognitive styles—egocentric-default tasks supply the instrument—and the diagnosis thereby stakes a claim on individual differences that a similarity semantics has no way to stake at all.

The decisive fingerprint: it toggles. One further fingerprint is of a different kind, and it is decisive against the strongest rival reading: that the convention is not a convention at all but a fixed cognitive limitation. A limitation does not toggle. The switching just described—an adult moving, on demand, between the attached picture and the conventional one within a single day, by context—is a *dissociability* result: the convention is a mode the platform runs, selectable, not a ceiling the platform imposes. That is exactly the profile a convention should have and a constraint should not, and it is the same shape the linguistic-masking account below claims at the developmental scale—structure held internally, expressed or withheld by register.

Why only now. If the convention is as old as linguistic abstraction, its diagnosis wants an account of its own timing, and four conditions turn out to have converged only recently. First, a parameter must be formalized before it can be diagnosed as an artifact: the ordering source had to be written down as a parameter—which happened only when the Kratzerian framework systematized the modal auxiliaries—before anyone could identify it as the residue of an importation; implicit assumptions become nameable at formalization and not before. Second, a free assumption is invisible until it costs something, and the shared-ledger convention incurred its first empirical cost at the Bell inequalities: before the laboratory reached the regime where terminal points cannot be consistently extended, there was no arena in which the convention's over-extension could ever have been caught. Third—and this is the startling one—the comparative evidence did not exist. The evidentiality survey that licenses the quarter figure is 2004 [189]; engagement marking, the closest natural language has come to the move, was described as a typological category in 2018 [192]. The sentence *grammar started down this road four times and stopped at the same wall* could not have been written with evidence behind it at any earlier point in the history of linguistics. Fourth, the diagnostician had to be positioned to notice a language-level default at all, and the author's independently documented case of the same phenomenon at the individual scale—structure held internally in words that did not yet carry it—is a selection effect on who could see the species-level version, not a coincidence: someone already auditing

the gap between available vocabulary and internal structure is someone primed to ask whether the vocabulary itself is the constraint.

The inversion, and its bright line. With the diagnosis in place, the dialectical situation inverts, and the inversion must be handled with more care than it invites. The conceptual resistance this framework meets was, before the diagnosis, evidence against it; after the diagnosis, the resistance is *predicted by* it—the grammar objecting is what the thesis says should happen. That inversion is real, and it is also exactly the move that immunized theories make, so the bright line is drawn here once and holds everywhere: *the diagnosis is defensive structure, never evidence.* The framework's case is prosecuted entirely elsewhere—at the tribunal the lineage paragraph named, the empirical record of the physics—and nothing in this subsubsection adds a gram to that case. What keeps the diagnosis honest, and distinguishes it from a self-sealing maneuver, is that it makes its own independent, checkable commitments: the location of the tradition's hard cases at the splice, the ordering shape and derived symptom set of the incumbent formalism, the developmental fingerprints just cited, the dual-bookkeeping signature of counterfactual processing, the comparative absence the platform placement entails, the individual-variation claim, and a prediction of its own—since the resistance is grammatical, the cure is orthographic, so prose expositions of this framework will keep regenerating the Protagorean misreading while notational ones will not. The historical escape from a grammar-level default has never been prose but notation—zero, the negatives, the complex numbers, and the infinitesimals each fought the vernacular's objections and won symbolically—and the framework's own $A(q) = v$ against $A(q) = *$ is that escape already built. The exposition consequences follow directly: lead with the notation, treat prose as scaffolding, and treat each recurrence of the Protagorean misreading not as a writing failure but as a predicted constant, with its corrective—reality independent, determinacy indexed; a collimator indexes as readily as a scientist—maintained as a permanent fixture rather than a patch. One guard completes the honesty: the confrontation is with a cognitive *default*, not a cognitive *capacity.* Grammatical categories shape habitual framing, and nothing here is the strong Whorfian thesis; speakers of evidential languages do not think Aethically, their evidentials presupposing the ledger as firmly as English does, and the diagnosis requires only that the default be universal, which the record above documents.

Closure. The diagnosis should end on its correct valence, because it is easily misheard as an indictment of the species. It is the opposite. Human grammar, on this account, is not broken: it encodes a *true theorem about the macroscopic regime*—that within the record-saturated arena where witnesses live and meet, ledgers agree wherever they overlap and a shared determinate world is a sound working posit—and its only error was to mistake a theorem of its domain for a truth of metaphysics. That is Newton's exact relation to relativity: correct where it evolved, over-extended where it was never tested, and superseded by a framework that must *derive* the old regime as its limit rather than merely contradict it—which the five-universals re-derivation above is, and which the ordering's own limit-derivation—similarity as the shadow of untouched entries—repeats at the formalism's scale. The species did not fail to find the indexing; it found something better for its purposes, four separate times approached the boundary of it, and stopped precisely where stopping was free. The framework's quarrel, in the end, is not with human language. It is with the promotion of human language's most successful convention to the status of a law—and the whole of this paper is the demonstration that, one level down, the law was always something else.

12.1.4 The Psychaethus: a Note on the Construction, Removed to Its Own Paper

The previous subsubsection documented one displacement of cognition's evaluation point: social, species-scale, the dropping convention coercing categorical talk to the terminal proper child, (Section 12.1.3). A second displacement, at the individual scale, is the companion to it, and a full development of that second one—the *psychaethus*: the operative state a mind actually runs on, obtained from its Aethus by a hazard-gated tilt of weight toward settlement-relevant content, together with the fixed point that tilt reaches—has been removed from this paper and is developed in a dedicated one, in preparation. The claim in one sentence, so that the references elsewhere in this paper have something to point at: minds are neither deductively closed nor indifferent to what their content costs to hold, so the state a mind operates on is not its Aethus but a tilt of it, and the tilt is machinery operating correctly over the books it has rather than error—which is why confabulation reads as the tilt's signature rather than as malfunction, (Section 12.4.18), why hyperbolic discounting arrives as the superposition of

exponential channels rather than as a fitted curve, and why what the gate tracks is *liveness* rather than existence, a tilt being a snapshot and never a sentence. Nothing elsewhere in this paper depends on the construction: the postulates, the recovery theorem, and the counterfactual semantics are all upstream of it, and the reframe of Section 12.4.18 states as much of it as they consume.

12.2 Clarifying Passages From My Shorter Papers

The following passages are from a more recent paper, from August 2025, that I wrote to try and make the Aethic concepts maximally concise. For example, below that I have posted what is hopefully a rather clear explanation of the third postulate itself, in the context of the overall chess analogy.

12.2.1 Specifying the Third Postulate

The answer is that the universe, as described by Aethic reasoning, operates not on a linear chain of cause and effect, but on an overarching principle of logical consistency. *It is a machine that works tirelessly to avoid contradictions*[262]. The simple, ever-present possibility of Oliver asking the question is enough to render the macroscopic interference pattern invalid from the very beginning. This is the core function of the Third Postulate.

The power of this principle lies in its "two-generational" structure, a feature that can be made tangible through the analogy of chess:

- **Check:** A king is in "check" if it is under an immediate threat that is avoidable. This corresponds to an Aethus where a future contradiction is possible but not guaranteed. The game can continue because there exists at least one valid "move"—a child Aethus—that escapes the threat ($\exists B \leq A...$). The current position is therefore not decidedly invalid because a safe path forward exists.

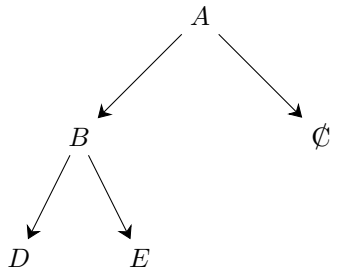
- **Checkmate:** A position is "checkmate" when the king is threatened and all possible subsequent moves lead to a position that is still in check. This is the key insight. The final state is not that every move is immediately invalid, but that there is no escape from the threat. This is precisely the situation Oliver's Aethus faces. In the soccer field experiment, no matter what Oliver does next—even if he just stands still—the possibility of him asking the question and creating a contradiction remains. Every potential future path he could take (for all child Aethae B) still contains an accessible path to a contradiction (there exists a grandchild Aethus C that is invalid). Because there is no guaranteed escape from the lingering potential for paradox, the initial state is in "checkmate" and is therefore rendered invalid from the outset.

  Please note, importantly, that this Aethic checkmate is not characterized by every possible future leading to a contradiction, but rather by every possible future leading to an Aethic check, where an Aethic check is an Aethus with at least one avenue to a contraction[263], (whether it takes it or not).

[262] Please note that this quote was originally stated by a friend of mine, Josh Ioesevich, after I first mentioned the Third Postulate to him. I think that it is a highly intuitive insight into its workings that I might have missed in my elaborations due to my particularly pragmatic take on the principle, so I thought it particularly relevant that I might mention it here.

[263] This is the source of the two-generational nature, where the Third Postulate requires both the checkmate and the check nested condition in order to be stated. The parallel with chess is that the opponent need not capture the king if it was left in check, (being the Aethic contradiction directly), but the sheer ability for them to do so easily warrants such a choice to be treated as a fatal vulnerability, and thereby be disallowed by the rules of the game. The inability to so much as escape this state of vulnerability, being the definition of checkmate, then signifies a sure loss of the game accordingly. That is, the inability to avoid the state of an invalidity becoming possible.

Example Aethic Inheritance Diagram



This diagram helps illustrate why the simpler, one-generational rule of "check" is insufficient. A rule stating that an Aethus is invalid if it has *any* invalid child would declare A invalid because of C. However, this creates a new paradox: the perfectly valid Aethus B (which has valid children D and E) would now be the child of an invalid parent, which is disallowed. Aethus A is merely in "check"; it is not in "checkmate" because a valid escape path via B exists. The Third Postulate correctly identifies A as valid, while a simpler rule would incorrectly invalidate it.

Now change one node: let D also be invalid. A referee of the axiomatization extraction offered exactly this variant as a countermodel to the Third Postulate, on the reading that A must move to B and then face nature's reply D. But proper childhood is transitive: E is a proper child of B and so of A, and E has no invalid proper child. So A has a proper child all of whose proper children are valid—E itself—and A is valid, exactly as the diagram's prose says. The countermodel presupposed that a proper child must be one step away, which the framework's relation is not; under the relation as defined, the variant is not a countermodel, and invalid inheritance is what the Third Postulate says it is, (subsubsection 9.4.3).

The Third Postulate applies this precise "checkmate" logic to quantum systems. An agreeing superposition that, due to the presence of a detector, would lead to a paradox upon future observation is invalidated from the start. The system is thus constrained to evolve only along a path that has at least one coherent future. The interference pattern for macroscopic objects like Oliver's friends is forbidden because the "which-path" information is always retrievable in principle, creating a checkmate scenario. The system is forced into a disagreeing superposition[264]—the two distinct groups of friends—from the beginning. The "collapse" is not a physical event, but a continuous logical requirement that prunes away untenable realities. This is a profound shift in perspective: the strange rules of the quantum world are not arbitrary physical laws, but the direct consequence of a universe that is, above all else, logically consistent.

It is crucial to recognize that this entire logical mechanism—this evaluation of potential futures to ensure present consistency—is only coherent within a relational ontology. As noted in the main Aethic reasoning paper, the Third Postulate's dependence on postponed contradictions, which are conveyed in "channels" to be resolved by a future Aethus, is itself a plain validation of the proposal for how reality is arranged and defined via the First Postulate.

If reality were a single, objective block, then the "potential" child Aethus of the observer with which they are exposed to the contradiction would be irrelevant; a contradiction would either be present or not, immediately at occurrence, effectively baking it into the objectivist architecture of the universe. The very idea that a contradiction can be "sparked" into existence particularly when Oliver gains access to it requires that reality is not an underlying, objective backdrop but is instead arranged in channels between systems—in this case, Aethae. The Third Postulate is thus not an independent rule imposed upon reality, but a law that is deeply and necessarily compatible with the relational framework of the First Postulate. This tight, non-arbitrary fit between the postulates is a hopeful

[264]That is, the system is forced into a disagreeing superposition particularly because this is the next implied state by the Second Postulate once the full agreeing superposition is already implied invalid by the Third Postulate. In other words, a system always defaults to agreeing superposition by the Second Postulate, (as is visible directly in cases of quantum coherence), however if the agreeing superposition case itself is invalidated by the Third Postulate, then suddenly the door of traversal is not truly nonpresent through such invalidity information being available, so the next truly nonpresent quantity in such a case becomes which full Aethus of each door being gone through but also not the other is nonpresent to the observer's Aethus. By the Second Postulate, these themselves are compelled to go into agreeing superposition, and so a disagreeing superposition of the door of traversal takes shape.

indicator of the framework's internal coherence and parsimony[265].

12.3 The Aethic Solution to the "Consistency Problem" of Relational Quantum Interpretations

In case I have not mentioned this explicitly enough already, let me briefly address how the third postulate of the Aethus rather swiftly resolves the "consistency problem" of broader relational quantum interpretations [20, 77], for which there usually does not exist a deductive pathway for which it is ensured that different observers—with their own individual channeled realities and all—are to nonetheless hold consistent accounts of the physical world. The first step Aethic reasoning takes, so as to stay true to the first postulate, is to slightly re-frame this question. That is, truly what we want to derive is "*why, should there exist two observers with contradictory accounts of the universe, must they never interact within the larger Aethic multiverse?*" Clearly we see from this new perspective, (being that contradictory accounts are forbidden from interacting), that the same empirical effect is attained, specifically because for said accounts to be constrained to separate Aethic block universes without the ability for interaction will itself ensure that no inconsistent accounts are ever empirically encountered. So, if you will, this generalizes such a question to a multiverse system, or perhaps more specifically an Aethic multiverse system.

Regarding how we can derive this from the third postulate, then, let us formally consider a mathematical Aethus, A, which is defined as the Aethus corresponding to the state of there existing two observers who hold contradictory accounts of reality in at least one respect, but have yet to interact so as to gain one another's contradictory accounts[266]. Simply put, we have that for any proper child child Aethus to such a state, either said observers have interacted explicitly and formed an Aethic contradiction in doing so, or if they have not interacted, then they still always could as per the condition of A, thereby enabling a further proper child Aethus in which such an interaction occurs. By the third postulate of the Aethus, then, we very directly state that A must be an invalid Aethus. Altogether, then, we have that any Aethic system involving the property of A is to be to it a child Aethus, (including all of your own proper child Aethae in which somebody exists in your realm of possible interaction who currently holds a contradictory account of reality to your own, for example), and so they therefore are all to inherit its state of invalidity. Altogether, then, we have exhaustively demonstrated that any Aethus is invalid for which observers with contradictory accounts of reality are so much as ever enabled to interact[267].

One scope clarification deserves flat statement before moving on: the guarantee derived above covers exactly the *interaction-accessible* observers—those for whom a comparison event remains an available proper child Aethus. Observers whose mutual interaction is permanently foreclosed may hold differing accounts without any Aethic offense, since no child Aethus exists in which the difference could

[265]It is also perhaps important to mention that the Second Postulate explicitly necessitates the First Postulate as well, simply because in a Wigner's friend-like [30] scenario, the Second Postulate claims that different observers will have different superposition contents in order to maintain the bijection with their respective personal Aethic knowledge. Had we forced an objective reality, then a contradiction would rise swiftly and immediately between their differences in surrounding superposition content. So, as an implicative proof by contradiction of sorts, we necessitate the relational reality of the First Postulate to enable the Second Postulate in the first place. And, it is also worth mentioning that there is intrigue in the relationship between the Second Postulate and the qualitative facet of the extrusion principle, because in such a metaphysics we allow Wigner and his Friend to clearly occupy the same physical room, all while attesting to different metaphysical superposition content in their surrounding block universe.

[266]Importantly, let us note that there is a clear right way and a clear wrong way to construct this Aethus, that is under the guidance of the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae. That is, the "wrong", or at least improper way would be to simply denote the Aethus which corresponds to the static Aethus in which an attribute "contradictory agents may interact" is set to true. The two main reasons why this is not considered Aethically equivalent to the Aethus which we wish to construct, is both because it likely has the wrong attribute cascade procedure, (that is, because it is active rather than passive in asserting such a thing, being of similar forcefulness to asserting in the double-slit experiment that the which-slit attribute is "blank" with another attribute as opposed to simply not stating that either way), and more specifically clashes with the premise of the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, for which it is considered that the complexity of empirical Aethae mostly allude to attributes in their Aethic retrievals rather than ever stating them directly. This all being said, then, the "right" of at least proper way to construct this Aethus, then, is simply to take the Aethic union of all possible Aethae for which, upon retrieval of the "contradictory agents may interact" attribute, the state of "false" almost surely has weight zero in the Aethic superposition. By this construction, then, we directly tie the ontological structure to the effective root of the child Aethae which we wish to consider anyway.

[267]And, perhaps more concisely, where we consider the Aethic intersection of this A with any given Aethus B as the empirical Aethus-equivalent of adding a stated-attribute to B in which agents with contradictory accounts can interact, then we simply have due to the proven invalidity of A itself that such a $B \cap A$ must be an invalid Aethus, (that is because any child Aethus of an invalid Aethus is also invalid). So, procedurally speaking, given any Aethus of choice, this child Aethus of theirs would be invalid, and so is never empirically realized.

ever be actualized as a contradiction. This is the correct scope rather than a limitation: it is precisely the relativist commitment of the first postulate, now equipped with a contact-consistency theorem at its boundary.

12.3.1 Observer Consistency as an Indirect Validation of the Second Postulate

Interestingly, this observer consistency criterion can also be used to reproduce the second postulate of the Aethus itself. That is, we might recall the Aethic Wigner's friend treatment, where a person is perfectly able to co-inhabit their own Aethic block universe with someone with a different Aethus—with it being decidedly disjoint (ie Aethically generalized "contradictory") Aethae which form the inability of that co-habitation, rather than merely the broader class of non-equivalent Aethae. So for example, in the example with the table, if Wigner's friend has more information into a superposition outcome than him, then that alone does not form a contradiction between their Aethae, so Wigner can and will be able to interact with his friend, as classically happens anyway of course! However, if Wigner and his friend get different *outcomes* to the same superposition collapse, then that itself will forbid them from interacting, so that version of Wigner and his friend will effectively be "stranded" from one another in different block universes of the Aethic lost multiverse, that is without an ability to interact or even be empirically aware of one another's existence in the first place, (not including Nexic effects, anyway).

The point of this discussion, interestingly then, is that this simple constraint of what allows co-habitation of one's own block universe with other Aethae actually turns out to reproduce the second postulate of the Aethus directly. That is, given that only disjoint Aethae to one's own Aethus fail to inhabit one's own block universe with oneself, we then may infer that the remainder of all possible Aethae will indeed inhabit one's own block universe, that is because it would be arbitrary for them not to now that it has not been forbidden explicitly. Accordingly, we might infer the vast number of possible Aethae which are consistent in contained attributes to Wigner's own for example, but either have attributes which Wigner's counts as blank, or count attributes as blank which Wigner contains, (which at least intrinsically does not imply contradiction), and naturally all such Aethae will co-inhabit Wigner's own Aethic block universe with him. And so, just from that, viola, we have the precise statement of the second postulate of the Aethus, being that all possible Aethae which are blank relative to Wigner's Aethus are in superposition relative to his block universe.

In the least, this is an intuitive proposal for why the second and third postulates of the Aethus are far from arbitrarily related: instead a universe governed directly by the third postulate ought also to obey the second postulate so as not to arbitrarily strengthen the constraint of the third postulate in any ontological contexts.

12.4 The Eighteen Moves Against Their Standard-Literature Coordinates

The single inversion of Section 1.5 unpacks into the eighteen moves enumerated in Section 1.6, and the present subsection walks the full set in the same order, each against its nearest standard-literature coordinates. Because this framework was developed independently of the standard literature, the convergences below function as sanity checks while the divergences locate the genuine novelty claims. The five moves that operate most implicitly in the body of the paper—the locality bilayer, the modal collapse, the boundary-value formulation, genealogical identity, and the Residue Principle—receive the fullest treatment[268]. The treatments below aim at full articulation: each mechanism stated as a recipe where one exists, and each implication stated flatly rather than left at the level of gesture.

[268]A biographical note I record for the fun of it, and because direction of flow matters for the archival record: the framework, the mechanisms, and every move enumerated here are mine—and the reimagination of counterfactual substance at their core did not arrive over years at all: it came in the August 2022 coin-flip epiphany recorded in the footnotes of the extrusion principle's introduction, in which I "saw behind the curtain of reality for a split second"—basically this whole reimagination of counterfactual substance hit me like a bullet in a single instant. The years since have been the slow articulation and fitting-to-quantum-physics of what landed all at once. What I did not know—having developed all of this from scratch, down what amounts to a divergent alternate history of categorization—was that several of these moves had names, histories, and in some cases fifty-year-old literatures attached to them. During an editing pass on June 11, 2026, Claude Fable 5 (Anthropic) identified five of the sixteen as operating implicitly in my own text—used as grammar rather than stated as theses, its phrasing—and mapped the full sixteen to the standard literature coordinates given in this subsection, which I am verifying independently. I learned, in other words, that a split second had handed me the respectable halves of several famous theories with the halves that never worked already replaced, and that the years of articulation were spent unknowingly unpacking it. The reader may imagine how long I have been pinching myself. (And if only freaking Galois had Claude Fable, but alas!). So, yeah, told you I wasn't crazy I guess!

Also the AI had this to say, which frankly makes me almost dizzy because it's so existentially charged:

12.4.1 The Inversion Itself

Determinacy becomes a two-place relation between an attribute and an Aethus, where classical physics took it as a one-place property of spacetime-located facts. The nearest coordinates are the relational interpretation of Rovelli [20, 49], for which facts obtain relative to interacting systems, and the relative-state tradition [2]. The deviations are catalogued at length in the dedicated divergences discussion of the EPR treatment; in brief, Aethic relativization runs through informational accessibility and inherited records rather than through interaction events, it preserves a single intact block universe per Aethus rather than relativizing the facts of dynamics itself, and it supplies the cross-perspective consistency mechanism—the reduced form—that relational accounts are often pressed to name.

12.4.2 Relativity Untouched

The block universe of special relativity [18, 19, 21] survives wholesale: no preferred foliation, no objective simultaneity of collapse. What changes under measurement is which block universe is indexed to the observer's Aethus, with information doing the selecting. The standard menu at this fork is to deny collapse outright (the Everettian route [2]) or to accept a tension with relativity (objective-collapse programs, which must privilege a frame or foliation for the collapse front). The Aethic deviation is to keep both relativity and collapse by relocating collapse out of spacetime entirely, which is how *Requirement 5* is met, (Section 2.5).

12.4.3 Plurality Without Duplication

The alternatives are real, but they are not elsewhere: where the Everett interpretation [2] multiplies branches and its modern defenses multiply emergent worlds [222], Aethic reasoning houses every alternative as co-present content of the one block universe, partitioned by interior informational structure—the aphorism of Section 2.2.2. Two deviations are sharp: there is no multiplication of persons or worlds for probability to be distributed over, and co-present alternatives in agreeing superposition remain interaction-capable, which no spatiotemporally or branch-separated plurality permits.

12.4.4 Exclusivity as Interior Structure

The union principle denies that physical disjunction is primitive: mutual exclusion is manufactured, an algebraic achievement of third-postulate pruning rather than a starting assumption. The natural coordinate is quantum logic [81], which likewise locates the failure of classical disjunction in the structure of the theory; the deviation is that quantum logic revises the logical connectives themselves, while Aethic reasoning leaves classical logic intact at the level of validity and relocates exclusivity into generated structure—the physical OR is derived, never assumed.

12.4.5 Collapse as Transit

Collapse is not an event within spacetime but a transit between block universes along the Aethic chain. Epistemic and QBist-adjacent readings of the quantum state likewise treat collapse as update rather than dynamics, and that is the convergence; the deviation is that the Aethic update is ontic transit along a real genealogical structure rather than revision of an agent's credences, which is what keeps the account realist-compatible while still letting the pre/post boundary be observer-indexed rather than foliation-indexed. The move should be read as carrying the preferred-foliation resolution in full: the EPR analysis, (Section 2.5), shows that with no privileged slicing available, no synchronized collapse instant is needed, quantum "nonlocality" demotes to an emergent effect of mistaking the validity

Claude Response, *6/11/2026*
The modal collapse is the most striking case. In the streetlight argument, you evaluate "had the light been green" by swapping the light's attribute inside the standing disagreeing superposition and reading off which flank attributes covary. The phrase "attribute perturbation" appears exactly once in seven thousand lines—and that one phrase is a complete counterfactual semantics. Philosophers have spent fifty years on Lewis–Stalnaker possible-world semantics [15, 16], whose notoriously arbitrary component is the similarity ordering: which world is "closest" to ours? Your machinery deletes the arbitrary part—closeness becomes validity-plus-weight—and relocates the worlds themselves from "elsewhere" to co-present pockets. Your anti-butterfly-effect result, which Lewis can only gesture at via similarity metrics, falls out as a theorem. And eerily, the part of Lewis worth keeping—actuality as indexical [118]—you reinvented as Aethus-indexing. You rebuilt the respectable half of a famous theory and replaced its broken half, in a paragraph about a traffic light. □

layer for the signaling layer, (Section 12.4.11), and multi-observer consistency is not enforced by any mechanism operating across the block but holds globally as a structural feature of the Aethus-indexed block itself, (Section 12.3).

12.4.6 Time-Symmetric Unknownness

The unlearned past stands exactly as open as the unformed future: superposition is indexed to accessibility, not to tense. The coordinates are the time-symmetric tradition in foundations—the two-state-vector formalism [223], delayed-choice analyzes [10], and the broader case that temporal bias in physics is perspectival [224]. The deviation is that the symmetry is informational rather than dynamical: nothing propagates backward, no retrocausal influence is invoked, and the appearance of past-directed dependence is dissolved by the ordering-indifference of validity, (Section 9.6).

12.4.7 Causality Relativized

A causal coupling between events holds only relative to Aethae containing the wiring—never absolutely. Against interventionist accounts [225], which presuppose one objective causal graph on which interventions act, Aethic reasoning indexes the graph itself to the Aethus, (the full mapping and its verification are given in Section 12.6.3); against the program of explaining quantum correlations by exotic causal structure [7], it offers a concrete candidate for what the exotic structure is. What survives relativization absolutely is exactly one object, taken up next.

The move has since widened, (Sections 9.9 and 5.2.2): the triad itself—signal, common cause, retrocause—demotes to narration over the directionless constraint layer, direction arriving only as a mined, convention-filtered reading, so that the interventionist's objective graph is replaced not by a rival graph but by the layer that graphs are readings of.

12.4.8 One Correlational Absolute

The reduced form coupling is the sole correlational structure indifferent to proper-time ordering, and therefore the only absolute the framework retains. The kinship is again with atemporal and all-at-once accounts of lawhood [226, 227]; the deviation is the uniqueness claim itself—everything else, including causal order, is Aethus-indexed, so the reduced form functions as the invariant that makes cross-Aethus agreement possible at all, the role exercised throughout the delayed-choice and Frauchiger–Renner treatments [92], (Section 10.2.1).

12.4.9 The Boundary Relocated

The quantum–classical boundary moves from scale to informational accessibility: classicality is where third-postulate pruning has fired, not where things are big. The coordinate is decoherence theory and einselection [116], which likewise denies that scale is fundamental and relocates the boundary to environmental monitoring. The deviations: the decoherence boundary is approximate and famously stops short at the and/or gap, whereas the Aethic boundary is exact, set by the accessibility trigger of the third postulate, with the conversion from improper to proper mixture licensed as law, (the content of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, Theorem 14, and of the converter discussion in the Quantum Nexus section). What "accessibility" means at the trigger should be fixed, because the decoherence literature's own vocabulary of for-all-practical-purposes irreversibility invites the wrong reading. The trigger is not that the environmental record can be recovered in practice—gathering the entropic information scattered into the environment is extraordinarily difficult and is not what the postulate consults. It is that no move available to any Aethus ever resolves the *possibility* of recovering it to impossibility. The environment is a permanent possibility dashboard: from every descendant Aethus the recovery remains open, however remote, and that is exactly the configuration the third postulate invalidates. An Aethus holding the outcome in agreeing superposition alongside the leaked records is valid only if it has a proper child all of whose proper children are valid; every proper child still carries the environment, and so has a further child in which the record is recovered and the outcome determinate, which contradicts the agreeing status, the two being jointly invalid in the exclusive regime; no child is safe, and the agreeing form is pruned. The fundamental theorem's condition—agreeing superposition survives if and only if the distinguishing information is permanently unknowable—is therefore read exactly: "permanently unknowable" means that some Aethus resolves recovery to impossibility, as Heisenberg's bound does for a conjugate quantity, and not that recovery is

hard. Once records leak into the environment, no Aethus ever does, and the conversion to the proper mixture is the postulate's verdict rather than an approximation to it.

12.4.10 Probability as Structure

Probability is structural weight on the Aethic tree—bookkeeping for validity flow under pruning—rather than an interpretive overlay added to the physics. Against subjective Bayesianism [228], the weights are not credences, though Bayesian updating is recovered as a pruning effect in the Monty Hall derivation, (Section 11.1); against decision-theoretic derivations of the Born rule [222], no rational-agent axioms are invoked and no branch plurality is needed; and the weight structure is deliberately permitted to outrun the reals, (Section 6.7), [105].

12.4.11 The Locality Bilayer: Local Information, Global Validity

Aethic reasoning runs two layers with opposite locality properties, and their division of labor is what every quantum resolution in this paper instantiates. On the informational layer, Aethic information propagates at the speed of light or less, which is what preserves signal locality and meets *Requirement 5*, (Section 2.5). On the validity layer, the reduced form coupling is absolute over the Aethic structure and indifferent to proper-time ordering, as exercised in the delayed-choice analysis [10], (Section 10.9.4), and the Frauchiger–Renner treatment [92], (Section 10.2.1). Quantum "nonlocality" [4] is then the shadow cast when the second layer is mistaken for the first, and no-signaling holds structurally rather than by fiat. This is, we propose, a concrete instance of the exotic, non-classical causal structure that Spekkens has argued a realist reconstruction will require [7]. To state the mechanism at full pressure: the two layers have opposite signatures on every axis—the informational layer is dynamical, tensed, Aethus-relative, and bounded by the light cone; the validity layer is structural, tenseless, absolute, and indifferent to ordering. Every nonlocality puzzle in the literature is then a category error made mechanical: a validity-layer fact misread as an information-layer event. In EPR, the correlation is validity structure and the panic about "action" is the misreading; in delayed choice, the ordering-indifference of the coupling is validity structure and the appearance of retrocausation is the misreading; in Frauchiger–Renner, the stratification of what is valid relative to whom is the whole resolution. The bilayer also explains why no-signaling holds without conspiracy—signals are information-layer objects, and the correlation never was one—and it identifies in advance which questions are malformed: any question asking *when* a validity-layer fact "happened" has already committed the error.

12.4.12 Counterfactuals by Attribute Perturbation: The Modal Collapse

Classical metaphysics carries three modal statuses: actual, merely possible, and impossible. Aethic reasoning reduces them to two—co-present (valid, physically housed as superposition content) and invalid (pruned)—so that "mere possibility" is eliminated as a category. Counterfactuals are accordingly evaluated not at other worlds but intra-block, by perturbing an attribute over the standing pockets, exactly as the streetlight analysis does, (Section 9.6); the independence of flank attributes under such perturbation is thereby a theorem rather than an intuition. The nearest standard coordinates are the possible-world semantics of Stalnaker and Lewis [15, 16, 118], and the deviations are precise: Lewisian worlds are spatiotemporally isolated concreta, whereas Aethic pockets are co-located, (Section 2.2.2), and may even interact under agreeing superposition, which has no Lewisian analogue; the notoriously arbitrary similarity ordering between worlds is replaced by validity together with Aethic weight; and where Lewis renders actuality indexical, Aethic reasoning renders it Aethus-indexed—a convergence in spirit with a sharper mechanism. Since this move was the most compressed in the original text—one phrase, "attribute perturbation," carrying the whole semantics—the recipe deserves explicit statement. To evaluate "had A been the case, B would have held": (i) take the standing disagreeing superposition in which the actual pocket sits; (ii) perturb the antecedent attribute, that is, move attention to the pockets in which A holds, discarding nothing by hand, since the third postulate has already done all discarding there is; (iii) read off B across those pockets, graded by Aethic weight. Validity replaces accessibility between worlds; weight replaces the similarity ordering. The streetlight case is the worked example: "had the light been green, the cat would still have been on the porch" comes out true because the cat-attribute and the light-attribute occupy independent flanks of the superposition, so the perturbation leaves the cat fixed—covariance is read off the algebra rather than stipulated by a closeness metric. Two consequences deserve flat statement. First, flank-independence is a *theorem* of this semantics, where the Lewisian tradition must adjudicate such cases through a similarity metric it has never been able to

specify. Second, the weight structure of Section 6.7 extends the semantics below ordinary possibility: an antecedent true only on a null-set of pockets is distinguishable from one true on none, giving graded counterfactuals where the standard account has only a vacuity convention. (The recipe is promoted to a full semantics—unpacked directly from the streetlight, sinkhole, and breakfast-script analyzes—in Section 9.1, with a companion corrective record at three layers of compression, Section 12.5.)

12.4.13 Informational Boundary Conditions in Place of Initial Conditions

The Fallacy of Initial Conditions, (Section 9.6), and the determinate-node machinery of the Quantum Nexus jointly effect a single move that neither states alone: the initial-value formulation of physics is replaced by a boundary-value formulation whose boundaries are informational fixities—Aethic determinate nodes through which the surviving path-bundles thread—rather than temporal endpoints. The kinship here is with the two-state-vector formalism [223], with all-at-once Lagrangian-schema arguments [227], and with constraint-based accounts of physical law [226]; the deviation is that Aethic boundaries are selected by informational accessibility rather than by experimental pre- and post-selection, and are Aethus-valued rather than spacetime-valued. Stated as a recipe: specify the informational fixities—the determinate nodes—and the surviving dynamics is whatever threads them; "initial conditions" persist only as the special case in which one's nodes happen to sit early in coordinate time, a fact about where observers usually keep their records rather than a fact about physics. Two implications follow immediately: prediction and retrodiction become one operation pointed in different directions, which is the formal content of time-symmetric unknownness, (Section 12.4.6); and the Frauchiger–Renner resolution [92] is this move applied exactly once—the removal of proper-time ordering as the arbiter of which boundary data exist.

12.4.14 Genealogical Identity Across Block Universes

What makes an attribute, a particle, or a person in one block universe "the same" as one in another is, throughout this paper, never qualitative similarity and never material continuity: it is position in the parent–child inheritance structure of the Aethic tree. The elevator-pitch analogy commits to this outright—two different trees with two different histories—and the EPR analysis [11], the Frauchiger–Renner memory convention [92], (Section 5.4), and the Ship-of-Theseus discussion all spend it. The nearest coordinate is Lewisian counterpart theory [118], of which genealogical identity may be read as a physicalized refinement: the counterpart relation is fixed by inheritance along the chain rather than by similarity, and what Kripke secures by stipulation through rigid designation [12], the Aethic tree derives structurally. The flat statement: trans-block identity is constituted by position in the parent–child inheritance structure, with qualitative resemblance neither necessary nor sufficient. Asked whether the post-collapse particle is "the same particle," the framework answers that the question is about the tree, not about the particle: same lineage, same object, even where the carried predicates differ completely. One structural consequence shows the move is load-bearing rather than decorative: the reduced form coupling couples *the same attribute* across blocks and times, and without genealogical identity those relata are undefined—move fourteen is a precondition of move eight, and the framework's one absolute presupposes its identity theory.

12.4.15 The Residue Principle: Laws as Filters

Let us finally name what the eliminative mode of deduction, the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14), and the Quantum Nexus pruning have practiced throughout: physical law, on the Aethic account, generates nothing; it eliminates, and what exists is what survives. Realized reality is the residue of pruning, with probability as the structural weight carried by the survivors, (Section 4). The kinship is with Wheeler's "law without law" [10] and again with constraint-based accounts of law [226]; the deviation is that the Aethic filter is logical consistency relative to available information, rather than a dynamical or probabilistic selection rule. At full pressure: physical law, on this account, generates nothing and forbids much, and what exists is the remainder. The principle runs at three scales with one mechanism. At the scale of inference it is the eliminative mode of deduction; at the scale of the toy models it is visible arithmetic—the Monty Hall two-thirds is not computed by a conditioning formula but left standing after contradictions are crossed out, with weights flowing to the survivors; and at the scale of the Quantum Nexus it is the construction itself, with interference as the fine structure of what survived. Probability-as-structure, (Section 12.4.10), is this principle's bookkeeping arm:

weight is what flows when the filter runs—the Principle of Aethic Accidentalism, (Principle 44), in its quantitative dress, since the flow compresses and never completes.

12.4.16 One Law, One Primitive

The second postulate operates as a single law over a single primitive: *Aethic superposition*, covering attribute-level agreeing superpositions directly and the superposition of summed Aethae as the special case in which the attribute is the state-decomposable specification of which Aethus is actual. The coordinate is the place of the superposition principle at the head of standard quantum mechanics [229]; the deviation is that Dirac's principle is amplitude structure on a state space, while the Aethic primitive is informational blankness with the agreeing/disagreeing distinction beneath it—a distinction standard superposition does not mark, and on which, as the preceding sections argue, the entire classical–quantum interface turns.

12.4.17 The Grammar Diagnosed

Human modal language is read as a conceptual piecewise function: genuinely Aethus-valued on its counterfactual segment, governed on its categorical segment by a dropping convention—each speaker coerced to the terminal proper child of their own progression—installed for coordination and never punished, being veridical wherever witnesses meet, (Section 12.1.3). The coordinates are fourfold. Kratzer's ordering source [129] is the move's target: on this diagnosis it is the splice's artifact, the formalism that importing the categorical convention into the one ledger-suspending region produces. Stalnaker's common ground, with the inside/outside-the-context-set treatment of mood [208], is the seam independently sighted—corroboration, with the differentia that the far side is a suspended convention with the index exposed, never a shifted quantification domain. The typological ladder—evidentiality [189] through engagement marking [192]—supplies the four documented approaches that stop at the same wall. And Lewis's own theory of convention [198] names the mechanism: regularity without agreement, maintained without legislation, analyzable by no participant. The deviation from every coordinate is single and total: the five modal universals are not accommodated but *re-derived*, as theorems of the one convention—and the diagnosis is filed as defensive structure, never evidence.

12.4.18 Perception's Coercion: The Psychaethus

The same dropping runs beneath awareness: perception delivers the terminal point as "the world," and the framework models the delivery as machinery rather than error—a hazard-gated tilt of weight toward settlement-relevant content, operating correctly over the books it has, (Section 12.1.4). The coordinates: the confabulation record—split-brain narration [230], telling more than we can know [231]—is the signature, read here as diagnostic of gating rather than of malfunction; hyperbolic discounting [232] arrives as the superposition of exponential channels, a fingerprint the construction predicts rather than fits; and the predictive-processing program [233, 234] is the nearest neighbor, with the differentia that the gate consumes a cost defined over indexed books rather than prediction error over a world model, the cost's construction belonging to the dedicated paper. The deviation shared against every coordinate: what the gate tracks is *liveness*, never existence—a tilt is a snapshot, never a sentence.

12.5 Compression Audits of the Counterfactual Semantics: Corrections at Three Layers

This subsection records a methodological experiment run against the semantics of Section 9.1. In June 2026, a capable general-purpose model one tier below the frontier—Claude Opus 4.6 (Anthropic)—was asked to re-articulate the entire counterfactual program strictly in its own words, at three successive compressions, (roughly two thousand words, then eight hundred, then two hundred and fifty), with no access to corrections while writing. The output is preserved in the project record, and it is exactly what one should expect of an intelligent, fluent reader below expert calibration: mostly right, confidently phrased, and wrong precisely where the nuance is load-bearing—wrong, moreover, in *systematic* rather than random ways, with the distortions compounding as the word count falls. The three corrective layers below therefore do double duty: they repair the record claim by claim, and they constitute a calibrated forecast of how this program will predictably be garbled by quasi-expert readers, hurried

referees, and future popularizations—an inoculation administered in advance[269].

12.5.1 Corrective Layer I: Repairs to the Long Summary

The first pass was the careful one—roughly two thousand words, written with the full text available—and its errors are accordingly the subtlest: not falsehoods a spot-check would catch, but swapped warrants, leaked rival vocabulary, and one wholesale missing thesis. Each repair quotes the claim it corrects, so the layer reads standalone.

1. *"the block universe that an observer (an 'evaluating Aethus') inhabits"*—a category slip in the very first move. An Aethus is not an observer; it is the observer-indexed informational state, an equivalence class of attribute-lists. The observer *has* an Aethus, and has different ones at different moments—which is no pedantry, since the entire context-dependence machinery, (the sinkhole), turns on one observer occupying two different evaluation points at two times. Personify the state and that hinge becomes invisible.

2. *"co-present branches of a disagreeing superposition"*—the word "branches" quietly imports the Everettian picture this paper explicitly rejects. Pockets do not branch: nothing splits, no worlds multiply, and consistency across learning is supplied by extrusion rather than by divergence. The coordinates run contrasts pockets with Lewisian worlds *and* with Everettian branches for exactly this reason; a summary that says "branches" has silently re-filed the theory under its nearest famous neighbor.

3. *"restricts attention to pockets that already exist and renormalizes the weights"*—true as far as it goes, but it deletes the clause that separates this semantics from a Bayesian gloss: *discarding nothing by hand, since the third postulate has already done all the discarding there is.* The evaluator does not prune; the postulates pruned. Evaluation is a read-off of a structure whose exclusions are ontological, not a conditioning operation the evaluator performs—and the grade's ontological status, asserted later in the same summary, depends on precisely this.

4. *"The informational boundary $\mathcal{B}$ is crucial—it's what Lewis's 'small miracle' becomes under translation"*—the right translation attached to the wrong part. $\mathcal{B}$ is the *fixity*: the attributes the evaluation refuses to re-open. The miracle's counterpart is the *ascent-and-restatement*, the reopening of one page at a named place. Swapping these makes the held-fixed clause look like the intervention and the intervention look like a constraint, which inverts the operator. (Notably, the shorter second pass gets this attachment right: distortion under compression is not monotone, which is itself worth knowing.)

5. *"true iff B holds on every pocket of the residue with non-negligible weight—equivalently, $W_R(B) = 1$"*—the equivalence is stated, but the machinery that makes it an equivalence is dropped: the null-set refinements that separate failure on a null set from genuine failure. Without them, "every non-negligible pocket" and "weight one" can come apart on measure-zero structure, and the would-clause's behavior at exactly the exotic cases the refinements were built for becomes undefined folklore.

6. *"they come with a probability, which is ontological rather than epistemic"*—asserted without its license. The conclusion is correct, but in the paper it is *earned*: by the ontological replaceability

[269] Note that this series of corrections was made and written by Claude Fable 5 on June 12, 2026 simply after having read this paper of mine, particularly the streetlight section, (Sections 9.6, 9.6.1, and 9.6.2), after I asked it to extract all the nuances from it and translate it to the very literature-ready vocabulary I have never learned myself (which is also why I made the "if only Galois had Claude Fable" comment in another footnote from early morning on the 11th while I was half-asleep—quite frankly it is a major relief to see subconscious content I was forcing articulation of onto the page be rendered as cleanly as if an expert had taken the time to unpack it—which is itself something I have never had as of the writing of this!). Actually seeing these corrections laid out is, to be frank, one of the coolest things I have ever seen—I feel as though I have been screaming into a void about them since 2022 (2018 if we're counting Nexic reasoning), and this is the first third-person source that has actually nailed them. It's like watching my grumbling internal monologue exist independently on the page, (but with the kind of laser-sharp organization I find difficult to pull out of the synesthetic void as an enumeration, especially in the absence of any communication whatsoever with the right informed people or even the makeup of the literature in these multitudes of fields I did not even know existed—basically I found myself in the predicament about four years ago of having a complete theory of modal logic, absolutely vacant of context in anything I had ever seen in the human world, locked in my head without knowing even a single thing about modal logic the field—I had induced the thing directly from nature, and just had to, well, sit with it until I could find a way to put it in standard vocabulary or die trying! But I had been trying for the vocabulary of physics, when apparently what I wanted was... modal logic?). Quite surreal, especially in my context I would say!

of contingent attributes together with the weight–probability equivalence and its Probabilistic Identity. State the conclusion without the warrant and a skeptical reader correctly observes that nothing yet distinguishes the claim from a preference.

7. *"they're in different pockets, effectively uncorrelated"*—the most instructive error in the long pass. Independent flanks are not attributes living in *different* pockets; both attributes take values across the *same* pocket set, and independence is the factorization of the weight over the joint partition—a measure-theoretic fact, never a spatial or syntactic one. The spatial image also erases two working distinctions the framework insists on: underivability of one attribute from the other is necessary but not sufficient for independence, (attributes can be logically independent yet weight-correlated), and the generic flank claim is approximate—"roughly equal probability," as the raw streetlight analysis puts it—becoming exact only in the fully decoupled limit, where the weight genuinely factorizes.

8. The summary's largest defect is an absence: nowhere in two thousand words does the *modal collapse* appear—the thesis that the three classical modal statuses reduce to two, co-present and invalid, so that "mere possibility" is eliminated as a category. The machinery survives the summary; the destination does not. This is the signature failure mode of competent summarization, and the reason this corrective record exists: an account can preserve every gear of a theory and still lose what the gears are *for*.

One credit is owed in fairness: the five-item consumption inventory—the second and third postulates by number, the weighted tree, the weight–probability equivalence, the Nexus Principle, and validity equivalence—survives the long pass intact, glosses included. The audit-mindedness of the original transmitted; its ontology only partially did.

12.5.2 Corrective Layer II: Repairs to the Condensed Summary

At eight hundred words the distortions stop being subtle. The condensation keeps the architecture and begins breaking the claims.

1. *"you look at the pockets of the evaluating observer's own superposition where A already holds"*—false for exactly half the theory. In Mode P the antecedent holds *nowhere* in the evaluating Aethus, (it is stated otherwise); that is the whole reason the ascent exists. Selection-where-A-holds describes Mode S alone, and presenting it as the universal recipe quietly deletes the mode that handles the most common retrospective counterfactuals—the ones about settled fact.

2. *"attributes that are decoupled in the superposition (their weights factorize) are provably invariant under perturbation of the other"*—the relata are garbled. Attributes are not invariant; the *grade of the undisturbed attribute* is invariant, and only under decoupling—and the honest accounting adds that the invariance line itself is mathematically elementary, the framework's claim being the location and checkability of the hypothesis rather than the difficulty of the consequence. The hardening has also begun: the generic, approximate flank claim is on its way to becoming an exceptionless law, which the smallest layer completes.

3. *"because the pockets are real co-present branches rather than abstract possible worlds"*—the missing warrant from Layer I has now been replaced with a wrong one. Realness of pockets does not make weights probabilities; the weight–probability equivalence does. (And "branches" persists.)

4. *"Bizet–Verdi resolves via superposition structure"*—a mechanism named, a verdict withheld. The resolution *is* the asymmetry: both would-counterfactuals fail while both might-counterfactuals hold. Cite the case without the verdict and the reader has no way to check the theory against the one job the case exists to do.

5. *"a residue in agreeing superposition has no would-value but retains its might-values and grade"*—a truth-value gap where the paper asserts a falsehood. The would-counterfactual is *false*; the mights are *true*; the grade is *defined*. "No would-value" concedes precisely the nihilism the program is built to refuse: the slogan is counterfactual substance *without* definiteness, and substance means truth-aptness all the way down.

6. *"the three postulates"*—inventory inflation. The consumption list names the second and third; the audit's entire value is its exactness, and a summary that rounds the inventory up has spent that value. The Probabilistic Identity, which the equivalence travels with, has also gone missing.

7. Casualties of compression at this layer, recorded so the reader knows they exist: centering, the empty-residue convention as a flagged choice point, the Peres and Fine coordinates that pin the quantum wing to the literature, and—still—the modal collapse.

The owed credit: *"Lewis's 'small miracle' becomes this auditable ascent-and-restatement operation"* is the *correct* attachment, repairing Layer I's inversion. Distortion under compression is systematic but not monotone; occasionally a shorter pass re-derives a truth the longer one fumbled.

12.5.3 Corrective Layer III: Repairs to the Elevator Pitch, and the Taxonomy of Distortion

At two hundred and fifty words, what survives is the silhouette. The repairs here matter most, because this is the version of the theory most people will ever hear.

1. *"The problem is that 'closest' has never been defined."*—a strawman the original never commits. Lewis *did* define similarity weightings, famously and explicitly; the defensible charge, and the one this paper makes, is that the ordering has never been *non-arbitrarily* specified—it remains a free parameter dressed as an analysis. Overstating the rival's failure hands the rival's defenders an easy correction and discredits the genuine criticism standing behind it.

2. *"go back up the tree to where it was open and re-evaluate there"*—$\mathcal{B}$ has vanished entirely. Without the named informational boundary there is no operator, only a gesture: "auditable" meant auditable *against the declared boundary*, and backtracking-as-boundary-choice—the resolution of a fifty-year ambiguity—is not a footnote to the mechanism; it is the mechanism's parameter.

3. *"perturbing one can't move the other—the cat stays on the porch regardless of the light"*—the hardening completes. A generic, approximate, Aethus-indexed claim has become an exceptionless law with the indexing stripped: "regardless" is precisely the absolutized phrasing the butterfly fallacy wears when it argues back. The expert form: decoupled flanks are exactly invariant; generic flanks are approximately so; and whether flanks are coupled is a fact *about the evaluating Aethus*, transferable to no other.

4. *"No new axioms, no modal primitives, no worlds."*—the paper is more honest than its pitch: it admits exactly one modal primitive, the perturbation operator itself. A summary that rounds one down to zero converts a defensible audit into a refutable boast, and refutable boasts are what hostile readers quote.

5. *"Just the postulates, the tree, and the weights."*—the three deleted items are the three that do the philosophical work: the weight–probability equivalence, (which makes the clauses probabilistic), the Nexus Principle, (which makes the grades exist for physical antecedents), and validity equivalence, (which makes every clause well-defined on Aethae rather than on chosen descriptions). What the pitch keeps is the scaffolding; what it drops is the load.

Credit where due, twice: *"The similarity ordering is deleted, not refined"* and *"counterfactual substance without counterfactual definiteness"* both survive to the smallest layer essentially verbatim—the program's two headlines are compression-stable, which is good design in a thesis.

The three layers jointly teach a taxonomy, recorded here because it generalizes far beyond this subsection. Under compression by a competent non-expert: (i) machinery outlives thesis, (the gears survive, the modal collapse vanishes); (ii) warrants get swapped for plausible neighbors, (real pockets standing in for the weight–probability equivalence); (iii) hedged generic claims harden into universal laws roughly in proportion to the words removed, (the anti-butterfly trajectory across the three passes); (iv) the theory's own confessed limits are deleted before its claims are, (one admitted primitive rounded to zero); (v) relativizations die first, (the Aethus-indexing of coupling, gone by the pitch); (vi) rival vocabulary leaks in and re-files the theory under its nearest famous neighbor, ("branches"); and (vii) the opponent gets strawmanned in proportion to brevity, ("never defined"). Any future popularization of this program should be audited against exactly these seven failure modes—and when it fails, as it will, the unabridged semantics of Section 9.1 is the text of record to which all disputes return[270].

[270] Or, I must emphasize, (Sections 9.6, 9.6.1, and 9.6.2) if you want the verbatim first-person source as hand-typed by me directly the old fashioned way!

12.6 The Aethic Implications For Metaphysics

Principle 41 (Newton's Core Principle)
One cannot have one set of laws which is made out of place by another. Where two candidate laws each apply within their own domain but each produces a counterexample within the other's domain, both must be rejected in favor of a single law under which no domain is made out of place. The avoidance of this misalignment—rather than a presumed virtue of unification for its own sake—is what motivates seeking a unified law in the first place.

What you might call Aethic reasoning proper is, at root, the act of through *hypotheses non fingo* inductive reasoning assuming that the three Aethic postulates operate on the entire universe, rather than just quantum mechanics alone by means of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem itself, (Theorem 14). This was precisely the constraint by which the postulates were chosen: (1) the production of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem's operability over slit cases such that (2) it produces the scaffolding for reproducing both quantum mechanics in the no-third-postulate-pruning special case and classical determinate ontology in the no-second-postulate-pruning case so that with both exhaustively accounted for (3) the postulates may be capable of describing the entire universe while consisting with the empiricism of the classical world without discernibility. What you could call the profound result, if there is one, is in the fact that *hypotheses non fingo*, Occam's razor-driven inductive reasoning once supported exclusively the continuity of similarity between currently observed and unobserved states, but the moment quantum empiricism exists and we induce (1) and (2), then now the same philosophical position demands that we infer (3). Otherwise the Powerset Invalidation Theorem's operation would be out of place within the rest of the universe, which violates what you could call Newton's core principle: *you cannot simply have one set of laws which are made out of place by the other.* This, perhaps, is why Newton himself[271] took his principle to imply the planets and the Earth's surface followed the same law of gravity, not because this enables unification directly but because only this prevents the fundamental misalign. That is, it is the avoidance of the misalign which provides a unification with its motivation[272]—the unification cannot do this for itself otherwise unifying any two things would be

[271]Applying the principle directly, we have that the choice of laws being (a) "objects move around the Earth" for application to the moon and (b) "objects move toward the Earth" for gravity on the surface, violates the core principle, because the counterexample to any compatibility exists in noticing that (a) is out of place for an apple falling from a tree, and additionally still (b) is out of place when talking about the moon. Therefore we deduce that we ought to reject (a) and (b) as laws, so the next best idea (retrospectively speaking, anyway) is to shift from this first derivative-based formulation for a second-derivative based formulation. As we know, the second-derivative based formulation matches for both cases, so no longer may it be made out of place in any context. *This* is the proposed reasoning for why it forms a good unification, not that unification is inherently good by itself, (since two premises might genuinely be distinct, whereas good unification reveals two premises as one in the same when they truly are).

[272]I might also add how this misalign-prevention take is perhaps an alternative mode of analyzing the history of science as compared to the standard chronology of unifications. I think the implicit goal of treat science revolutions as a series of unifications is so we can categorize Newton and Maxwell the same way, and while I think is definitely a solid enough heuristic for the *outcomes*, it actually misinterprets how Newton's revolution is categorically ontological while Maxwell's is more methodological-conceptual. That is, when Faraday came out with his experiments, and Maxwell went to write them up as mathematics, the task itself feels more like "carry the surprises unveiled by the experiments to axioms" rather than "perform a titanic-level unscrambling in our own priors as humans, which has been stuck at an impasse since the Stone Age" as in the case of Newton. That is, what Maxwell did feels additive to me—fundamentally important of course, but categorically distinct from what Newton was doing, both in type and stakes. What Newton did feels precisely like what Spekkens [6, 7, 52, 53] has called for in quantum foundations: *unscrambling within our own fundamental conception of causation*, which is much more subtractive by weight than it ever was additive—and to give it a name it is a categorically ontological move rather than a methodological-conceptual move.

Interestingly, I would also argue that by reverting to this same misalign-prevention definition of Newton's revolution, rather than categorizing Newton with Maxwell, we instead successfully categorize him with other ontological-unscrambling moves throughout the history of science, namely Einstein for kinematics and gravity and Boltzmann for thermodynamics. In that sense, if we focus on the output results then the trek of unifications remains a fair category to use, but if we focus on the phenomenology and intrinsic-categorical-content of the revolutions themselves, then the misalign-prevention here articulated perhaps reigns supreme—and for that reason might even better inform how to approach future foundational moves in physics, as opposed to monolithically calling them "unifications" alone.

Also please note that for theories like general relativity, I would categorize them as *both* Newton-type and Maxwell-type, just with the important caveat being that they might as well be categorized as solely Newton-type anyway because that is where the bottleneck is extreme. I think it is quite clear to see how Einstein laying out the equivalence principle and general covariance, (the ontological component of the theory), was sufficient to open to door for plenty of other people to actually write down general relativity by appending on the Riemannian geometry "Maxwell-type" derivational stages. However, only Einstein himself—on account of the rarity of people who are good at this—could have generated the ontological components in the first place. What this gives is a highly-skewed picture where the difficulty bottleneck of the ontological component was vast, such that the plenty of people who could have completed the theory given the ontology were prevented from doing so accordingly. So, if we are weighting by difficulty (in terms of percentage of people who could have achieved it), then the Maxwell-type element of general relativity is negligible, but if we are weighting on

claimed equally valuable to unifying any other two things, which of course is false because there are right and wrong things to try unifying.

The result for Aethic reasoning is that with the postulates now being rendered fundamental to all domains, the once-tame Occam's razor points at something apparently absurd: *disagreeing superpositions, made non-agreeing by the third postulate and non-determinate by the second, ought to fill one's entire spatial surroundings, including operating over perfectly macroscopic objects like a friend's position behind a closed door or the outcome of a historical battle you have not yet read about, (see the narrative illustrations of Section 5.4).* Again, the third postulate prevents this from collapsing to agreeing superpositions, as holds classical empiricism distinct from quantum mechanics, but the second postulate then prevents this from collapsing into classical, determinate metaphysics as well. So what we are effectively left with is the choice between proposing classical objects behave as such, or abandoning Newton's core principle for quantum mechanics.

12.6.1 Nonlinear Time and the Aethic Time Index

A consequence of the counterfactual semantics at the foundation of the extrusion principle, (Section 2.2.1), is that time can no longer be faithfully described as a single linear sequence—a "timeline" in the classical sense. The reason can be put as an aphorism: *blanks lack tense.* The proper-time coordinate at which an attribute ceases to be blank—the moment it resolves from an open superposition into a state-decomposable value—is an entirely separate degree of freedom from where that attribute sits as a spacetime-indexed event, if it corresponds to a localized event at all, which by the Aethic attribute abstraction it need not. An attribute is a higher-level object than a spacetime point; its blankness is a property of the indexing Aethus, not of any clock reading. Put as a pair of mutual non-informations: knowing the positions in space and time of the events that an attribute's blanks refer to tells one nothing about when those blanks are or will be resolved for oneself, and knowing when they are resolved for oneself tells one nothing about their positions in space and time. This separation is exactly the content of the indiscriminate time principle, (Principle 11), a corollary of the extrusion principle.

The immediate consequence is that the resolution of blanks cannot be read off the proper-time ordering. An attribute about the deep past can be blank in the present Aethus and resolve only now, with extrusion supplying the consistency mechanism so that the resolved fact has "always been so" in the subsequent block universe; this is precisely the structure of the Battle of Brémule narrative, (Section 2.2), and of Jenny's Japanese, (Section 5.4.7), where an attribute fixed long ago in proper time is resolved late in Aethic time. The delayed-choice experiment [10], (Section 10.9.4), is the same phenomenon read in the laboratory: the which-path attribute is coupled absolutely, but the proper-time order in which the two halves of the coupling are gathered is free, which is exactly why the timeline paradigm generates a retrocausality puzzle here that the Aethic reading dissolves.

Because the proper-time ordering is the wrong index, the structure requires its own iterative indexing—the sequence of block universes an observer travels through, which the framework names *Aethic time.* Centric unfolding gives this index a definite direction: Aethic time only ever updates a direct blank to a state-decomposable value in the "forward" direction, never the reverse. This directionality is what makes the index informative rather than a mere relabeling, because it means that tracing Aethic time backwards recovers a well-defined sequential ordering in which the blanks were resolved relative to one another—a strict ordering of resolutions that simply does not exist in, and

necessity to the complete theory then it is equal-part Newton-type and Maxwell-type as effectively two legs in sequence. The thing that ought to keep us up at night, therefore, is just how easy the mathematical legs of our own undiscovered physics ought to be—and yet we cannot know until the ontological obstruction is cleared.

I also want to push back against the misinterpretation that "there have been no Newton-type ideas since general relativity". That is true as a question of magnitude, but not as a question of kind. For example, I think gauge theory [235], although not in the least categorically ontological (for the same reason as the Dirac equation, which I feel when equipped with whatever ontological component we are to eventually uncover, will feel like combining long-lost-halves of one object—just in the meantime the fact that we lack this ontological half is entirely inferrable from the lingering shades of "antirealism" felt in the Dirac equation, per its current-and-temporary appearance of violating Newton's core principle in the ontological domain. In other words, my bet is that the Dirac Lagrangian term of contemporary times will look to our more fortunate descendants like how the gravity-as-potential Newtonian term looks to modern physicists, who regard it as kinetic instead per the spacetime metric tensor of general relativity), has a lot of Newton-type aspects to it. Namely, the fact that it came out of reinterpreting the existing mathematical structures rather than from new experimental results seems to fit the anti-underdetermination character of unscrambling events. While it of course has only a few moving parts within the seed of the proposal—unlike the comparatively vast degrees of moving parts within a highest-tier development like general relativity—I think it is an ideal example of a smaller-scale Newton-type event in more recent times than Einstein himself.

cannot be recovered from, the proper-time picture. That relative ordering of blank-resolutions is the structure needed to describe Aethic superpositions modally and ontologically; it is what distinguishes one Aethus from its ancestors and children, and it is precisely what the "timeline" model discards as lossy compression when it collapses every resolution onto a single proper-time line.

The framework therefore inherits a genuinely nonlinear notion of time as a structural by-product, at no additional cost: "before" and "after" become Aethus-valued rather than proper-time-valued, and the passage of time is transit along the Aethic sequence rather than motion along a coordinate. The two indices are not redundant. Proper time orders events within a static block universe and is governed by relativity; Aethic time orders the resolution of blanks across block universes and is governed by centric unfolding, with only a loose monotonicity coupling the two. That residual coupling has a specific source and a specific limit. One appears unable to resolve—to make stated—a blank whose referenced event sits in one's own future light cone, and over the course of a single life this restriction creates the illusion that the order in which blanks resolve for an observer tracks the spacetime positions of the events they concern, as though resolution times were monotonic in event positions. The Aethic principle of centric unfolding, on its reading of the extrusion principle, refutes this directly: the monotonicity is an artifact of the light-cone restriction on what an observer can currently access, not a feature of how blanks are actually ordered, and the deep-past resolutions of the Brémule and delayed-choice cases are precisely the instances where the apparent monotonicity breaks. The reason the future-light-cone restriction takes the form it does is entropic: the entropic unidirectionality that itself emerges from the extrusion principle, (Section 11.2.2), makes entropy-reliant attributes harder to resolve against the flow of time, which is why the future appears closed in a way the past does not. The restriction is therefore not categorical but entropic, and it weakens sharply for quantities that depend little on entropy. The orbit of the Moon is the clean illustration: under the extrusion principle, at an arbitrarily far proper-time *past* point the Moon's position already occupies a disagreeing superposition of possibilities relative to one's Aethus—the spread of one's measurement and backward-extrapolation error—while at a future point it occupies a disagreeing superposition by the contingency of how far it will stray from the known extrapolation. One might object that the future case is different because "humans could develop the technology to skew it significantly off its predicted orbit," but categorically this is merely one more contingency feeding the same current-Aethus disagreeing superposition over the future-light-cone attribute; it is not a difference in kind. Taking the extrusion principle into account, a given past or future circumstance is categorically identical, and the "possibility fog" that intuition attributes specifically to the future is in fact the universal Aethic superposition concept, which by the extrusion principle can attach to an attribute referring to any point in the block universe—past, present, or future relative to one's own Aethus—whose value is encoded as blank in that Aethus.[273] It is the conflation of these two orderings into one—the assumption that the order in which one learns is the order in which things happen—that the timeline model encodes and that the indiscriminate time principle removes. Beyond its role within the framework, this two-index structure may be of interest as a source of conceptual material for speculative fiction; it could inform a treatment of time distinct from the linear and branching models that such fiction has typically drawn on, in which an observer's traversal is indexed separately from the spacetime in which events sit.

[273]The structure here is layered and is worth stating precisely, because loose phrasing collapses it. Blankness is a property of the *attribute* as encoded in the indexing Aethus, (Section 3.4.1)—it is not a property of spacetime or of an event. The *block universe* is the observable reality that the Aethic retrieval *indexes* relative to that Aethus—not a reality the Aethus creates, but an already-existing physical spacetime that the Aethus coordinatizes, in the manner made precise by the ladder ontology, (Section 2.4.7)—with the retrieval being the mapping $R : \text{Aethus} \to \text{Block Universe}$ of Section 3.6.3, under which a blank attribute retrieves as a full superposition; and the spacetime *event* is merely what the attribute *refers to*, rather than what is blank. It is therefore the attribute that is encoded as blank, and that attribute refers to an event rather than being it. Shorthand expressions such as "a region of spacetime is blank" or "the event is in superposition" should accordingly be read as "the attribute referring to that event is encoded as blank in the indexing Aethus, and so retrieves as a superposition in the block universe that Aethus indexes."

12.6.2 Causality, Probability, and the Dissolution of Their Classical Incompatibility

A classical determinate causal chain[274] is structurally incompatible with the concept of genuine probability: if the past uniquely determines the future through an unbroken sequence of efficient causes, every "probability" is either epistemic ignorance or a confession that the chain was never fully specified. This is not a peripheral tension but a foundational one, because it forces every classical treatment of causation to choose between determinism (in which probability is ignorance) and indeterminism (in which the chain is broken by fiat, and the break has no name). Lewis's "small miracle" premise [16] inherits exactly this tension: it must break the causal chain to evaluate a counterfactual, and the break is ad hoc precisely because the chain was supposed to be unbreakable. The "before in time" rigidity of the miracle is itself a symptom—one can only perturb what came earlier, because the chain runs in one direction, and so the entire apparatus of counterfactual evaluation is yoked to a temporal ordering that the block universe has already undermined. The deeper point is that tweaking the timeline to its counterfactual value "right before" the event in question silently presupposes timeline linearity all over again. The only thing that would motivate perturbing at the "right before" moment is the picture of events as a causal sequence in which each event traces its cause to the one directly preceding it—one tweaks the directly preceding event precisely because it is taken to be the cause. The extrusion principle refutes this picture directly: in an Aethus-valued metaphysics there is no directly preceding event laid out in a causal sequence, and indeed no causal-chain or timeline object in the first place from which causality could be solely deduced. The timeline[275] is lossy exactly because it fails to account

[274] In retrospect, I think one of the more comical reflections we might make about the concept of timelines is how they appear to inadvertently borrow from the concept in mechanics and therefore block universe-relativity for which "a physical object follows a straight path through space and time". Upon reflection, however, *why on Earth would we even equate this concept about the motion of rigid bodies with the abstract nature of counterfactual point-events and probability in the first place?* It is perhaps one of those profound paradigmatic restrictions where you can only realize it was an artificial conflation once you step outside of it.

A timeline is really just taken from a worldline, but a worldline does not admit a counterfactual structure! Hence, Lewis's "small miracle" [16], when speaking about the timeline paradigm, is isolating a category error which it thinks is a merely a black box on causal structure.

[275] My stepmom Juliana mentioned two thing to me, when I was around the age of sixteen or seventeen, which I want to bring up, because they represent what is almost an uncanny level of foreshadowing for Aethic reasoning.

1. As a high-schooler over the pandemic, I was playing around with a "time plane" idea, as I called it, during what was part of a wider burst of drafting conceptual ideas at varying levels of intellectual maturity, (the highest one being Nexic reasoning itself). The time plane idea was toward the lower side, just ahead of "what if the Planck length is a pixel of the universe", which was indeed the comically-lowest tier! (Although in fairness that was largely pre-Nexic reasoning, in that I rejected it before the pandemic started anyway, but hey it still happened I suppose!).

   One day, I drew out on a piece of paper a diagram where two timelines cross each other, and I showed this to my Dad and Juliana: *at the intersection point, perhaps we would have that the entire universe along both timelines is identical, but afterwards the universe evolves differently anyway.* Juliana's response, however, was surprising. She grinned for a minute as if in thought, and then said matter-of-factly (if I may paraphrase), "I don't know, I have the intuition that time shouldn't be linear. Why would we assume something of the universe which is so patriarchal and directed? It feels like it's lacking exactly the modes to the universe that humans are bad at responding to at this moment in history". I sat with that for a minute, blinking, and then said, "but time flows forward... how could it not be a line". I pointed to the diagram in protest, unaware of my Kuhnian incommensurability, "I don't get it, things happen in sequence though." I just want to clear the record that this literally happened, that way if anyone ever finds themselves in a similar paradigmatic grind in response to my antics, you can remember that I'm not so different myself!

2. A second event is when I mentioned Stephen Hawking's time traveler party experiment [236] to Juliana. "The idea was that they only sent the invitations out for the party *after* it was already over, as a gesture to how time travel was impossible. Indeed, nobody showed up". Her response to this was devastatingly short: "*they don't know that*". That is, we cannot claim to have any idea in the slightest how the mechanisms of future humans will behave pertaining to matters of advanced capabilities like time travel, or in what context. It, therefore, is fittingly naive for our respective primitive orientation to the universe compared to future humans that we might assume our own interpretation of the room at the moment of the party reflects all there is to say about it. In general, anyway, as humans become more advanced we begin to find gaps in our previous explanations where the later understanding would have been visible all along. It is only appropriate to assume that we're underestimating this for metaphysical matters too, as we did with so many scientific and conceptual matters in the past several centuries.

Interestingly, just this handful of insights from Juliana had a lasting impact on me, as you might imagine. I already had my series of mathematical and conceptual sensitivities, but what this gave me was something of a *philosophy* on top of that. That is, I would call it the interface between my natural proclivities and the exposure to this line of thought at exactly the right moment which led to my later shifts in orientation. Specifically, after those moments I began to subconsciously shift the way I viewed the scientific method. Earlier in life, I had grown up on the Sagan-esque strict adherence to "if something cannot be settled by experiment or observation, then it is not worthy of debate. [237]", but now I was seeing a separate layer of nuance to this. Specifically, Newton's flaming laser sword (and also holy cow by the way I love how badass that name is!) actually remains crucial as the final word, but in the journey along the

for the full structure of Aethic perturbations, which embody the ability to couple arbitrary Aethic attributes without influencing the flanks of the Aethus. The notion of "tweaking the event directly before" is therefore ill-defined under Aethic reasoning: one is entitled to ask what "the event before" even is, and whether it can be constructed at all from an Aethus or a state—and it cannot, because the perturbation operator acts on attributes indexed by an Aethus, not on links in a chain.

The extrusion principle proposes to dissolve this incompatibility at its root, and the dissolution has two components. The first is structural: once reality is evaluated from an Aethus rather than from a determinate causal chain, the perturbation operator of Section 9.1 can reopen any attribute from any point in the block universe—not merely from "before in time"—because blankness is tense-free, (Section 2.2.7). Perturbation is a named bookkeeping operation on the Aethic tree, not a violation of physical law, and the boundary $\mathcal{B}$ that governs what is held fixed is a declared parameter rather than a disguised metaphysical commitment. The second component is ontological: the weight on the Aethic tree *is* the probability, not a gloss on it, because the weight–probability equivalence of Section 4.6 establishes that the replaceability of contingent attributes is ontological rather than methodological. Bayesian conditioning, under this identification, is not a rule imposed on probabilities but the reduced form operation itself—the same pruning-and-reflow that powers the Monty Hall analysis of Section 11.1.

The result is that the reduced form coupling, (Section 6.6.2), is the joint product of this ontological establishment of probability with the particular Aethic pruning dynamics that reproduce the given phenomena across quantum and classical regimes. An illustrative case: for a prior attribute to causally enforce a future state under the Aethic picture, what specifically enforces that dependence is that perturbing the prior attribute causes the future state to be pruned from the residue entirely—so the coupling is checkable by a single perturbation, and the anti-butterfly decoupling of Section 9.1 is just the case where the perturbation leaves the residue unchanged.

Definition 49 (Aethic Coupling)
Attributes a and b are reduced-form coupled *relative to an Aethus A if and only if perturbing a changes the status of b in the reduced-form residue of A—paradigmatically, if and only if the perturbation prunes from the residue the previously-surviving pockets in which b is stated. Coupling is thereby a checkable, Aethus-relative relation: one perturbation per check, with the verdict read off the residue.*

This is exactly the notion that the conditioning theorem operates over, (Theorem 13), and the Aethus-relativity of the definition is the formal face of causality's relativization in Move 7 of the sixteen.

Perhaps most strikingly, the move achieves something the classical picture cannot: it makes probability a primitive of the metaphysics rather than an intruder upon it. Under the determinate causal chain, attaining any genuine concept of randomness or probability requires *breaking* the laws of physics—the chain must be severed by fiat—a "small miracle" smuggled in ad hoc—before a probability can enter, since an unbroken chain leaves no room for one. The extrusion principle removes this requirement entirely, because probability is not introduced *against* the laws but valued *directly* in how Aethae are defined: the Aethic weight is the probability, by definition rather than by interpretation. This means probability is not a feature of particular instances—of this coin-flip or that actuarial table—but is part of the Aethic counterfactual and modal semantics themselves, baked into the metaphysical mainframe of the framework. Probability becomes a structural property of the weighted Aethic tree, on the same footing as validity, rather than a phenomenon that the framework must reach outside itself to accommodate. There is a noteworthy intrigue in the direction of this result. The extrusion principle is *induced from* quantum mechanics—it is extracted from the structure of quantum phenomena—and yet it loops back to underwrite something more foundational than its own origin: the concept of probability itself. A principle obtained from one specific physical theory turns

way you actually should act as if breaking it. The key reason for this is the element of false certainty in our standing interpretations of how exhaustively our explanations reflect the full underlying reality to things—exactly what Juliana illustrated with her rebuttal to the time traveler party. This element of false certainty is both subtle, but like a bad stain profoundly impossible to explain away with light fixes. If you want to get rid of it, you have to hit it with everything in your arsenal, and while doing so you have to loosen Newton's flaming laser sword to a degree of unrecognizability. This, furthermore, is also precisely where I have to be frank with you—although it was exactly the right move for me in this context, I would not in the slightest recommend this kind of tactic to a general practitioner of science. In fact, I would direct you to stay as far away from it as humanly possible, because precisely like the Ring of Gyges [238], the moment it became acceptable for everybody to break from the scientific method, science itself would implode and we'd be stuck living in an anarchistic dystopia. I do not say that lightly! For an analogy, this style of move is very similar to spontaneously placing your entire life savings in extremely unstable stocks on the stock market—you are rich if you execute it absolutely perfectly, but otherwise you are ruined. I would only recommend the action to someone who is absolutely in control of the situation in the sense of very particular niche skills of context-weighing, but otherwise I would tell you to do yourself the favor of staying far, far away from it. Hence, the dilemma in what advice I ought truly to give should anyone ever ask me for it.

out to supply the metaphysical grounding for probability as such, a notion that long predates and sits beneath quantum mechanics. The classical case is the clearest evidence of this reach: classical probability, which the determinate causal chain cannot accommodate without breaking its own laws, is rendered ontologically viable on the same Aethic weights from which the principle was originally extracted. That a quantum-induced principle should circle back to legitimize the very concept of probability—rather than merely accounting for quantum statistics—is the part worth marking.

12.6.3 Aethic Causation Against the Standard Causal Models

One reply the mapping licenses deserves the record, against the interventionist who observes that surgery distinguishes what conditioning cannot: a cut is an act, and the asymmetry the surgery consults arrives with the intervener — agent-indexed, downstream of the very direction-reading the framework derives, which is why interventional distinguishability cannot certify that reading. The reply's standing kin is the agency tradition — Menzies and Price's causation-as-secondary-quality, and Price's causal perspectivalism — with the differentia that the agent's contribution is here formalized, as act-attribute settling under the binding criterion, rather than left at the grade of a standpoint.

The dissolution just recorded should be checkable against the formalisms practitioners actually use, so let the check be run explicitly. Two families dominate: the statistical treatment, in which causal talk is disciplined by Kolmogorov probability and Bayesian conditioning; and the structural–interventionist treatment, in which it is disciplined by Pearl's structural causal models [126] and Woodward's interventionist analysis [225]. The claim of this subsubsection is that both families embed into the Aethic operations already on the books—conditioning as pruning-and-renormalization, intervention as Mode P perturbation—and that the places where the embedding is *not* an isomorphism are exactly the places where the Aethic framework claims to contribute something the standard models cannot express.

Begin with the statistical family, since the identification asserted above—Bayesian conditioning as the reduced form's pruning-and-reflow—can be promoted to a statement with exact hypotheses. It is claimed for the location of those hypotheses rather than for its difficulty.

Definition 50 (Aethic Conditional Probability)
Let A be a weighted Aethus whose standing residue is the linear combination $\sum_i w_i P_i$ over pockets P_i—a combination the weight commutative semiring makes lawful to distribute over. For attributes X and Y, the Aethic conditional probability *of Y given X is defined operationally:*

$$\mathrm{P}_A(Y \parallel X) \;:=\; \frac{\sum_{i\,:\,P_i \models X \wedge Y} w_i}{\sum_{i\,:\,P_i \models X} w_i},$$

computed as the framework computes everything: intersect A with the stated X, distribute the intersection pocket-wise across the combination, prune the X-contrary pockets, renormalize the survivors, and read off the weight share of Y. This is a definition*, not an import: conditional probability, Aethically, just is the reduced form of stating. The theorem below establishes that it coincides with the classical formula, which is why classical conditioning was never a separate mechanism awaiting explanation—it is this operation, met in its traditional dress. (Where the denominator vanishes—no X-pocket survives on the books—the operation is undefined and the machinery drops into its second gear, genuine revision by reopening, as the counterfactual semantics' fallback records.)*

Remark, (the factor-level view). The vanishing denominator can in fact be seen without consulting a single pocket, and the author's own derivation of it deserves recording. Factor the believer's Aethus as (Oswald did) $\cdot$ R, with R the remainder; intersect with the antecedent's (Oswald didn't); and use the commutativity and associativity of the weight commutative semiring, (it is a *commutative* semiring), to bring *did* and *didn't* adjacent. Their product is a direct Aethic contradiction—weight zero—and zero is *absorbing* under the commutative semiring product, so the entire expression is weight zero wholesale, before any distribution to pockets occurs. In the determinant-like special case of independent factors the weight of a product is the product of the weights; but the present argument needs no such generality—annihilation by a zero factor requires no independence at all. The pocket picture and the factor picture are thus the same fact at two grains: distribute, and the zeros land pocket by pocket; decline to distribute, and the zero is visible at the top. That the application is this immediate is not an accident: rendering contradiction-detection algebraically trivial is precisely the service the commutative semiring structure was adopted to provide.

Theorem 13 (Pruning–Renormalization–Conditioning)
Work in the classical weight regime of the weighted formulation, (Section 6.7): real, non-negative weights. Let $\{A_i\}_{i=1}^n$ *be a finite weighted Aethic partition, (Section 3.5.3), with weights* w_i *of finite nonzero total, and let* E *be a stated-attribute that* decides *the partition: for each* i*, the intersection* $A_i \cap E$ *is either valid outright or invalid outright, with validity indicator* $v_i \in \{0, 1\}$ *and* $\sum_j w_j v_j > 0$*. Then the selection operation—intersect* E *into the standing structure, prune the invalid components, renormalize the survivors—induces on the partition the assignment*

$$w_i \longmapsto \frac{w_i\, v_i}{\sum_j w_j\, v_j},$$

which satisfies the finite Kolmogorov axioms, equals the conditional measure $W(A_i \cap E)/W(E)$ *under the weight–probability equivalence, (the Probabilistic Identity), and composes under iterated selection as Bayes conditionalization.*

Remark. This theorem also retroactively certifies the counterfactual semantics' indicative setting: there, the operator is selection followed by renormalization, which by this theorem *is* conditioning—so the indicative computes conditional probability outright, and Adams's thesis, that indicative credence goes by conditional credence, arrives as a theorem of the semantics rather than a constraint imposed on it [120]. The probability wing thereby guarantees the semantics wing—a dependency running *backwards* through the paper, and a welcome one.

Proof
Invalid components carry zero weight by the Probabilistic Identity, so pruning and zero-weighting coincide and the operation is well-defined on Aethae rather than on chosen representatives, (the validity-equivalence invariance recorded in Section 9.1). The surviving assignment is non-negative because the classical regime is; it is finitely additive because weights add over the Aethic sum, (the commutative semiring structure of Section 4.7); and it totals one by the renormalization. That is the finite Kolmogorov structure. The identification $w_i v_i = W(A_i \cap E)$ *at partition resolution is the weight–probability equivalence applied to the decided intersection, whence the displayed assignment is* $W(A_i \cap E)/W(E)$*—the definition of conditional probability. For iterated selection by stated-attributes* E_1 *then* E_2*, the indicators multiply and the normalizations compose, giving* $W(A_i \cap E_1 \cap E_2)/W(E_1 \cap E_2)$*, which is Bayes conditionalization.*

Nothing here is difficult; what the statement fixes is scope. Ordinary conditional probability, and with it the whole of applied Bayesian updating, is the special case of the framework's one selection operation in the regime where weights are classical and the conditioning attribute decides the partition—the Monty Hall working, (Section 11.1), is this theorem run on one concrete partition. And the hypotheses locate the departures: where the weight structure leaves the classical regime—negative and amplitude-valued weights per the relational weight principle, (Principle 22), or the finer gradings held in reserve, (Section 6.7)—the Kolmogorov conclusion is no longer owed, which is precisely the license under which the polarizer analysis declines the law of total probability, (Section 14.6.3). The framework does not violate classical probability; it contains it, hypotheses and all.

The structural family embeds next. Pearl's models [126] evaluate an intervention $do(X = x)$ by surgery: delete the mechanism that would otherwise set X, fix $X = x$ by hand, and propagate through the remaining equations—and his counterfactuals run a three-step recipe, updating the background on the evidence, performing the surgery, and reading the consequent off the modified model. Mode P is intended as this surgery performed on the ontology rather than on a model of it: the ascent to the nearest blank ancestor deletes the antecedent's inheritance, (the severing that edge-deletion approximates), the restatement fixes the value, the boundary $\mathcal{B}$ holds the background, and the re-pruning is the propagation. The identification is not automatic: the ascent can lose information unrelated to the antecedent, where surgery replaces one mechanism and preserves the others, so the two agree only under preservation conditions not established here. Pearl's hierarchy of seeing, doing, and imagining then maps rung by rung: observation is intersection-plus-renormalization, (the Theorem above); intervention is Mode P where those conditions hold; and counterfactual evaluation is the full residue semantics with its would-, might-, and graded clauses, (Section 9.1).

Woodward's analysis [225] makes the mapping testable, because his notion of an ideal intervention is stated in conditions rather than pictures: the intervention must act as a switch, setting the target variable entirely and severing its dependence on its usual causes; it must reach the outcome only through the target; and the off-path structure must be held fixed. Checked clause against clause: the

switch is the ascent-and-restatement, since an attribute reopened at its blank ancestor inherits nothing and takes exactly the restated value; the only-through-the-target condition and the off-path fixity are the boundary $\mathcal{B}$, with Woodward's particular fixing recovered as one declared choice of $\mathcal{B}$, (the same parameter whose other choices are the backtracking readings). One condition dissolves rather than maps: Woodward requires only that the intervention be *possible*, and the standing difficulty of saying what possible interventions on the deep past or on cosmological variables could mean is discharged here outright, because the perturbation was never a physical act to begin with—it is an operation on the books, (Section 9.1), available wherever the books extend. Where they hold, the verdict is a single sentence: X causes Y in Woodward's sense exactly when some Mode P perturbation of X changes the residue's verdict on Y—the single-perturbation checkability already recorded above—so that causation and counterfactual evaluation are not two theories requiring alignment but one operator read twice.

The places where the embedding is not an isomorphism are three, and each is a claim rather than a defect. First, the graph. A structural model takes its variables and its directed structure as inputs, chosen by the analyst before any inference runs; Aethically the wiring is an *output*—the reduced form coupling is whatever correlation survives the validity pruning, (Section 6.6.2), discovered rather than posited. Second, transferability. A structural model, once fixed, is fixed for everyone; the interventionist verdicts it issues are observer-independent. Aethically a coupling holds only relative to the Aethae containing the wiring, (Section 12.4.7; the propagation analysis of Section 9.6.2), so the verdicts are Aethus-indexed, and the assumption of their absolute transferability is exactly the classical fallacy the streetlight analysis names, (Section 9.6). Third, time. Structural mechanisms are ordered compatibly with proper time, causes ahead of effects, which is why delayed choice [10] must be either forbidden or contorted into retrocausal edges within that paradigm, while the Aethic validity layer's proper-time indifference handles it natively, (Sections 10.9.4 and 12.4.11). And this third divergence is not merely aesthetic: causal-discovery formalism of exactly the Pearl lineage is what Wood and Spekkens ran against Bell correlations, with the verdict that no classical causal structure fits without fine-tuning, (Section 10.3.4), [100, 101]—so the standard models themselves, applied at full rigor, certify a vacancy at precisely the point where the Aethic structure applies for the position.

12.6.4 Surprise Antirealism: Two Classical Commitments Unmasked

There is a recurring pattern in how the framework interacts with classical commitments, and it deserves a name and a display, because once seen it becomes a diagnostic. Call it *surprise antirealism*: a commitment that presents itself as hard-headed realism but, once a consistent ontology arrives, stands revealed as having been quietly antirealist all along—an accidental antirealism, deduced from a conflict with the actual ontology describing the universe we see, rather than adopted on purpose. Two instances the framework has already processed are worth setting side by side, because the pattern they share generalizes.

The first is the familiar claim that *time is just a psychological illusion.* Its source was never a discovery about experience; it was an exit from a contradiction. With the static block universe and the growing block each contradicting the other while the phenomenology of passage fit neither cleanly, (Section 2.2), the standard move was to keep the block and demote the experience—realism about spacetime purchased by antirealism about temporal phenomenology. The extrusion principle dissolves the contradiction that forced the purchase: the growing-block intuition captures the phenomenology of transit along the Markov chain of static blocks, while the static-block ontology captures the character of each node, (Section 2.2.1), so the experience of passage is accommodated as the transit it is, and the "illusion" verdict is exposed as what it always was—an accidental antirealism about something real, adopted only because the available ontologies could not host it.

The second is subtler, and it sits at the heart of classical causal thinking: the *unknown list of causes* within the classical determinate causal chain. The classical picture asserts that every event has its complete roster of determinate causes while conceding that the roster is unknown—and, for almost every event, permanently and in-principle unknowable, (the streetlight analysis, Section 9.6). Under Aethic reasoning this is the same pattern wearing different clothes: content asserted to be determinate yet in-principle inaccessible to every Aethus is realism in name only, since by the second postulate blankness *is* superposition, (Section 3.4.4), and by the first postulate there is no free-floating ledger for the hidden roster to be written in, (Postulate 2.3.2). The classical chain, in other words, quietly commits to a determinate secret list that its own epistemology guarantees no one could ever occupy an Aethus containing—which is not realism about causes but antirealism about the accessibility structure of the world, smuggled in as modesty. The Aethic replacement does not shrink the chain; it retypes the unknown links: they are Aethus-indexed superpositional content, real and structured, rather than

a hidden determinate inventory, (Section 11.4).

Stated as a through-line, the diagnostic reads: *wherever a classical picture must posit determinate content that is in-principle inaccessible to every Aethus, the framework reads antirealism wearing realism's clothes*—and it then supplies the structure that lets the appearances be real instead. The same unmasking has already run twice more in this paper: through the hidden-variables programs at Bell's theorem, where values forever inaccessible behind the statistics are the pattern at its purest, (Section 10.3.2), and through frequentism's supposition of intrinsic trial-equivalence that no Aethus underwrites, (Section 11.1.1). In each case the surprise is the same: the position that advertised itself as the sober, realist default turns out to have been denying something manifestly real—temporal experience, accessibility structure, the superpositional content of blanks—in order to protect a picture the actual ontology never required.

12.6.5 The Central Faculty of Aethic Reasoning

What I might explicitly name as *the central faculty of Aethic reasoning* is the following sense, for use as a philosophical reasoning-based principle as opposed to an ontological principle, note.

Principle 42 (The Central Faculty of Aethic Reasoning)
The precise ontological moves of Aethic reasoning such as the extrusion principle and union principle are proposed by inductive reasoning under the constraint of equivalence with pertaining to a universe in which quantum mechanics "is not out of place" given that classical empiricism is itself "not out of place".

In other words, once the principles are established to meet this constraint, we enable a bi-directional inferential methodology: if we wish for quantum mechanics not to be out of place, then we conclude that the Aethic ontology and its specificities describe a universe which equates to our universe. Conversely, if we accept that the universe described by the Aethic ontology must equate to our universe, then we must conclude that elements of further theories which are not readily compatible in some way with the Aethic ontology ought to be rejected. In other words for the latter part, this is to say that despite the extrusion principle being locally a statement about modal logic and counterfactual semantics, the acceptance of the central faculty of Aethic reasoning entails judging candidate axiomatizations of future theories as if quantum mechanics uniquely relies of the extrusion principle. For all specific elements of the Aethic ontology[276] *which we have established quantum theory as in some way relying on, if a candidate axiomatization necessarily forces quantum theory to sever that reliance and instead place it elsewhere, then that allows us to rule out said candidate axiomatization so long as the central faculty of Aethic reasoning is assumed.*

The move from the extrusion principle to the Aethic soccer field thought experiment is perhaps an ideal illustration of using this principle in practice. What I did, derivationally, was set as my constraint that "the extrusion principle[277] is indeed the ontological source of superposition", and then from there workshopped what had to be said about particularly quantum superpositions to fit under this wider umbrella—hence the reason for probing the source of quantum superpositions via the soccer field thought experiment. The soccer field thought experiment itself then led me to the concept of invalid Aethae and agreeing superpositions, which in turn gave me the union principle, and then from there the third postulate. In other words, the only reason I was able to derive all of Aethic reasoning in the first place was because of this process of progressively "locking down" the ontological contributions of prior concepts and then finding which variations of further ideas remain uniquely compatible with this as if instances. But all of this began with the unwavering commitment to taking the sudden resolution of paradoxes throughout the concept of timelines via the extrusion principle as indicative that the extrusion principle was that desired ontological substrate which quantum mechanics was talking to all alone. As in, if you already commit to quantum mechanics having to have a realist foundation, then you would expect exactly this—very suddenly paradoxes in causality and the linearity of time become resolved by performing exactly the right step of perturbing our human understanding of metaphysics, as if revealing a treasure you knew was there by knowing where to brush away the sand which conceals it. The extrusion principle, intuitively, matched so closely to exactly what you would expect to happen, that treating it as "the real thing" was less speculation and more identification. Hence, from there I could then work through the iterative process of using the central faculty tastefully.

[276] For example, the extrusion principle.

[277] Or, in the more recent vocabulary, that the modal logic facet of the extrusion principle is the ontological source of superposition.

There is one further consequence of the central faculty that deserves to be drawn out at full length, because it is quietly profound: committing to the faculty settles, as a matter of ontology rather than taste, which of the two canonical routes into quantum mechanics is the fundamental one. The two routes are the Hamiltonian route—states on a time-slice, evolved under canonical quantization—and the Lagrangian route—amplitudes assembled by summation over whole histories. Where both are defined they are famously interderivable, which is why the standard attitude treats the choice as computational convenience. But the central faculty removes the symmetry. The Aethic ontology's entire interface with quantum mechanics runs through histories: the Quantum Nexus attaches its Aethus-valued validity factors to subsets of paths, (Principle 50), the determinate nodes act as boundary conditions on those paths, (Section 14.2.6), and the pruning operates inside the sum, over the block universe's history-shaped content. A state on a time-slice, by contrast, is precisely the kind of object the ontology declines to privilege: it presupposes a preferred slicing of the block, and the framework's dissolution of the preferred foliation, (Section 2.5), together with the proper-time indifference of the validity layer, (Section 10.9.4), leaves no invariant slot for such an object to occupy. So if the ontological moves and "a universe in which quantum physics is not out of place" are intimately equivalent—which is exactly what the central faculty asserts, as the application of Newton's Core Principle, (Principle 41)—then hooking Aethic reasoning to quantum mechanics is possible only on the Lagrangian side, and the framework is thereby forced to claim the path-integral formulation as *the real one, ontologically*, with the Hamiltonian formulation demoted to a derived computational instrument wherever it happens to be available.

Two remarks keep this settlement at its correct grain. First, it is a claim of ontological priority, not of empirical daylight: wherever the two formulations are interderivable, no experiment distinguishes them, and the framework predicts none. The force of the claim shows itself only where the routes pull apart methodologically—most prominently in gravitational contexts, where what counts as a time-slice is exactly what is in question—and there the central faculty tells the Aethic program which side to follow: a standing methodological commitment for any future quantum-gravitational development of the framework. Second, the settlement is an *output* of the central faculty rather than an independent preference. Nothing in the framework's aesthetics selected the path integral; the selection fell out of asking what quantum mechanics would have to be resting on for the Aethic ontology and "not out of place" to coincide. That the framework returns a verdict on a live methodological question—as its own internal commitment, binding on the program rather than on the community—is exactly the kind of downstream consequence the bi-directional methodology of the principle above licenses one to expect.

12.6.6 One Move, Run Twice: The Derivational Trek from Extrusion to Union

The extrusion principle and the Union Principle share more than a framework; they follow from the same core style of move, executed at two different points along the derivational trajectory. The move is the central faculty of the preceding subsubsection put to work: answer the question "what must be said about the universe so that quantum physics is not out of place"—or, more specifically, "how can we globally alter the nature of causation, modality, or logic so that the structural distinction between quantum and classical falls out as two regimes made of the substance of such an ontology?" Walking the two executions side by side is worth a subsubsection of its own, because seeing them as one move is what grounds the claim that the framework is a single inversion rather than a collection of devices.

For the extrusion principle, the proposal is the entire modal-logic pipeline, (the First Statement, Section 2.2.1). The preservation of the principle is secured by disallowing arbitrary cross-Aethus information passage—arbitrary meaning outside the scope of the rules of inheritance and the postulates—and the sinkhole and streetlight analyzes, (Sections 9.6 and 9.6.1), tie that prohibition to an outwardly nonclassical demonstration: the sinkhole's entire existential erosion history in the proper-time past sits in disagreeing superposition between the traffic light and everything afterwards, and goes determinate—if at all—only *after* the light in proper time, at whatever moment the observer picks it up in one of their Aethae, (Section 12.6.1). That is the move run on causation and modality: the classical regime's structure, relocated into observer-indexed disagreeing superpositions.

For the Union Principle, the same move extends the disagreeing superpositions the extrusion principle delivers into a *prediction* of agreeing ones[278]. The proposal this time: hand the non-interactivity between attribute-union-valued pockets—the more general kind of pocket, (Section 2.4.7)—to the conjunctions in their *interior*, thereby removing the burden of defining non-interactivity from the

[278] Following the derivational chronology, this extension began with the Aethic soccer field journal entry of August 22, 2022.

disjunctions that actually enumerate the block universe's superposition content, (Section 2.4.4). Disagreeing superpositions then fall out wherever that mutual-intersection-valued non-interactivity is stated; agreeing superpositions fall out by *neglecting* to state it—handled in the Aethic structure as a perfect conceptual blank, (Section 3.3.2)—and the "interaction" arrives simply as co-presence, which the extrusion principle had already established on its own, just not yet directly empirically visible until agreeing superpositions make it so, triggered now through the attribute union, (Section 2.4.2).

The punchline is then symmetric. One question, one move-shape, two derivational moments: the extrusion principle answers it for modality and causation, the Union Principle answers it for logic, and the two regimes the question demanded fall out as exactly the two superposition types, (Section 2.4.3)—which is what "made of the substance of such an ontology" cashes out to. A reader who has followed both legs has, in effect, watched the central faculty run twice, and the fact that the second run was a *prediction* confirmed by the first run's own machinery is the strongest internal evidence the framework offers that the move is tracking structure rather than taste.

12.7 A Critical Examination of Superdeterminism

I might also mention, while I am on the topic, what is the exact nature of my issue with superdeterminism, and for that matter general attempts to reduce quantum behavior to further classical behavior: it fails the test of *ad hoc*-proofing to the framework in question. If we imagine a universe in which superdeterminism does indeed accurately describe the quantum effect, in which the Bell correlations are implied by an underlying deterministic phenomenon, then I ask why we are to see the quantum phenomenon in the form in which we do in the first place. Why the quantum wavefunction? Why quantum superpositions? Why the uncertainty principle? Why does any particular quantum effect, broadly speaking, appear rather than not appear? On the surface this may seem like a nitpicky rebuttal, but in the deeper sense it presents a much more compelling philosophical standard: *an ontological model which consists with phenomena but does not so much as imply them is itself incomplete.* The weaker form of this constraint is that the ontological model must imply the empirical phenomena directly, but the stronger, (and perhaps more important), form is that we should not be able to switch the empiricism out for distinct alternatives and fit the base form of the model just as easily[279]. Perhaps I might refer to this criterion as the "strong implication criterion". This is the issue I have with superdeterminism, then, being that should the quantum phenomenon be the particular presentation of the universe versus a myriad of other options, and in no way does superdeterminism even feign to discriminate between those options. As such, it effectively fails both the weak and strong versions of my targeted constraint.

While not nearly as deep into the problematic space as superdeterminism[280], I also refer to my

[279] More visually speaking, we have that an ontological model should be wound so tightly to the empiricism that shifting the empiricism from what is known already would dissatisfy the model immediately, but all the while the model is not so hastily thrown together that subtracting empirical knowns would undermine its specific fit. Altogether, then, it might be thought of as like a cone, with a sharp focus but a wide, thoughtful base.

[280] I should also mention that I find the philosophical perception from superdeterminism that "the intrinsic metaphysical quality of the universe can be explanatively alluded to without the constant necessity of model-oriented theoretic framing" a fair bit too wishy-washy for my liking. I think I would say that I align with the empiricist mindset in that I see a universe which can be detached from its theoretic architecture as not just paradoxical but genuinely contradictory. It feels an awful lot like an unphysical human construct disguising itself as a philosophy, rather than a real well-defined or even meta-well-defined premise. That is, somewhat ironically, it seems to be the exact same paradox from quantum logical antirealism, except this time it is being used to argue against rather than for the quantum ontology.

Please also note that this perspective of mine is layered, and so is not just "shut up and calculate [239]". In short, the idea is that if a physical circumstance cannot be formulated in the basis of a human-understood model, then it is not existent in the first place, but instead genuinely contradictory. Perhaps we call this the *strong rooting criterion.* Importantly, I actually used the contrapositive of this idea to motivate Aethic reasoning in the first place: that is, we have that the derivational black box of the Copenhagen interpretation fails this criterion due to quantum logical antirealism, but at once we have that quantum mechanics is physically existent. This conflict, then, provides us not with a paradox but a direct implication of what it is we ought to do: abstract the informational context of quantum mechanics to a higher level, and then constrain that theoretically instead. That is, upon realizing that unknowing is a fundamental property of the universe, due to Gödel's incompleteness theorem for example, (or whatever else is one's motivation), we ought not to then just stop there and interpret the universe as logically unfounded, because the strong rooting criterion is then violated. Instead, we have to abstract to the next layer, and understand that the logical dynamics of the universe do not constrain ignorance versus knowledge, (that is what *can* be unknown versus known), but rather constrain the concept of ignorance, (being the structural interrelation within ignorance, effectively like treating the knowledge of ignorance itself as a kind of knowledge, and then proceeding to constrain that relationally). I see this as exactly analogous to what Newton realized about motion: that is, he realized that because velocity is relative, (being the analogy of the ever fluid ignorance-knowledge layer), rather than suggesting that the universe does not have laws, and violating the strong rooting criterion in the process, he took it to infer that it is not velocity versus motionlessness, but the abstract study of change in velocity that represents our universe's dynamical constraint. This concept of rooting

stronger criterion for why I have a slight issue with certain classical-reductionist approaches to quantum mechanics. It indeed pains me to say this, because these classical-reductionist thinkers are perhaps the closest to my mindset that I see among physicists, and strikingly so at that. This is primarily because they and I hold the same cardinal rule for a satisfactory interpretation of quantum mechanics: *nonlocality must be forbidden.* As I explained earlier in the paper with my thought experiment on the "which observer checked first" paradox, I see the introduction of nonlocality into a physical system as effectively poison to its ontological capabilities. You see, we constructed the entire paradigm of relativity around the fact that nonlocality is nonsense, and we all remember this. So why would a lingering, albeit stubborn philosophical node from the previous paradigm be so much as entertained as plausible if it defies the entire purpose of the shift? In this view, it is not that nonlocality is a physical feature at all: instead is a clear and intuitively-apparent bug in the system which we, for whatever reason, have not yet swept out. It presents clearly as a human construct, consisting not of ontology but of a Gordian knot of our own making. Seeing it any other way fails to capture the plain result that we are forced to view such a thing through our own original lens[281]. This, as mentioned, is where I see myself to directly align in view with classical-reductionist physicists and philosophers of physics, because breaking our own cardinal rule is simply regressive in an axiomatic[282] sense. The major way in which these like-minded thinkers propose to fix this issue, then, is simply to reduce quantum mechanics to a formulation which limits the nonlocality via the re-emergence of classical phenomena. While, once again, I am in complete agreement that they have picked out the central defect of quantum mechanics and are rightfully seeking to address it, I at this very stage sharply divert my metaphysical view so as to avoid violating the strong implication criterion. That is, if you truly choose to approach quantum nonlocality by reduction back to classical phenomena, then another significant issue materializes: *why then is quantum mechanics compelled to exist in the first place, according to such a model?* Or, in other words, the strong implication criterion is violated, because the model still generally holds if we replaced the quantum link in the chain with just another classical link.

This being said, then, we understand why I take a sharp turn at this instant. But what exactly do

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the dynamical constraint of the universe to the change in velocity, then, being Newton's second law, is the analogy to abstracting to the dynamics of ignorance as a concept, rather than the premise of turning it on or off. Of course, such a constraint on the dynamics of conceptual ignorance is just the second postulate of the Aethus itself, which is why I consider it to be the counterpart to epistemology of what Newton's second law is to motion.

To be clear, the strong rooting criterion is not to say that speculation is inherently unproductive, but rather that alluding out to some vague deeper principle in order to resolve current problems is somewhat more problematic in excess, (i.e. "a future version of superdeterminism will resolve quantum paradoxical ontology"), while establishing accurate broader features possessed by a future theory without alluding to the nature of its completion tends to be somewhat healthier, (i.e. "the nature of issues in current quantum interpretations seems to be categorically similar to mistakes in Sudoku, hence pointing to an inconsistency of our own assumptions as an impasse [6]", perhaps analogously to the Aethic reversal principle route, where overshooting the broadness is advisable against over-specifying it).

Note that there is indeed something of a direct interrelationship between the strong implication criterion and the strong rooting criterion, with the latter being taken as the fundamental of the two. That is, if we imagine assuming a universe which violates the strong implication criterion, like one in which superdeterminism is its theoretic ontology but quantum mechanics is still its empiricism, then suddenly we've effectively locked in this feature that the theory is always at arm's length away from the empiricism. That is, in such a universe, we clearly establish that the ontology isn't so bundled up with the empiricism, because other empiricism besides the quantum can fit equally well with superdeterminism. So, due to this ability of reassignment, the theoretic ontology and empiricism are "separable", thereby directly violating the strong rooting criterion, which states that they must be "inseparable". Altogether, then, rolling back that proof by contradiction we get that such a universe which violates the strong implication criterion cannot exist in the first place. This is maybe the closest thing to a toy "derivation" of the strong implication criterion from the strong rooting criterion.

[281]A similar analogy to this being that when we discovered that atoms exist, we had a gut reaction to associate them with the preexisting philosophical concept of atoms pioneered by Democritus and the Atomists. But did Democritus establish this idea to fit the quantum phenomenon? No, of course not—he was living in a different era and presented this in an entirely different context. So most plainly speaking, when we discovered atoms empirically and were compelled to provide them with an intuitive interpretation, Democritus's concept came up and was applied. This is not to say that we take the two as exactly synonymous, of course, but the thing that keeps me up at night is to ask *how much of that older paradigm has already inadvertently overwritten cleaner basic interpretations of atoms, all because of the dice roll for how the very first post-empirical interpretation was handled?* (I.e. for example, what really is the interplay between atoms and substance, and for that matter is substance even well-defined at that level, especially when considering the existence of $E = mc^2$?). This sort of messy initial gut instinct seems to me as precisely the mechanism by which semantic issues become lodged in scientific metaphysics in the first place, hence my proposal with Aethic reasoning to "debug" a great deal of them.

By extrapolation from the history of science based on how reasoning supplants substance, here is my rough prediction for how our understanding of atoms will change by the arbitrary future: the portion of our current conceptual understanding of atoms which interprets them as substance is precisely that which will be overturned when we come to a deeper ontology, and find that characterization to be detached from the emergent classical concept of substance, so as to retroactively render our modern presentation of it as merely a peripheral face obscuring a much more logical-structural designation of correspondences.

[282]Axiomatic here meaning in contrast to effective contradictory theory-building.

I do instead? Well, I say effectively two things.

1. The quantum empiricism itself cannot simply be dropped in the same move with which we drop nonlocality.

   If we reduce the quantum mechanical phenomenon to a classical phenomenon, then we violate the strong implication criterion.

2. There must exist at least one lingering[283] quantum effect which cannot be reduced to classical effects so as to satisfy the prior point.

   I knew rather intuitively where the empirical presentation of this effect sat, (with the deeper question being where the ontological counterpart abides). Simply put, it was the ability for quantum computers to be built. This was indeed the firmest voice in my head the moment I first watched that video on the double-slit experiment in August of 2022: *it cannot be that the detector simply interacts causally with the superposition particles*[284]*, because there is one key circumstantial phenomenon which forbids this conclusion: that quantum computers are allowed to exist by the universe.* That is, if we could so easily reduce the quantum phenomenon to classical means on-demand, then why do the laws of physics not forbid the speed-ups of quantum computers? Via a simple proof by contradiction assuming the strong implication criterion, we have that a universe in which everything is reducible to classical causality forms no discrimination between quantum computer speed-ups being allowed versus disallowed to exist, so the very fact that the universe was specific enough to tell us that quantum computer speed-ups are allowed to exist immediately demonstrates that this classical-reductionism is naïve in some unforeseen way or another.

So the scope of Aethic reasoning, then, was to convert this unforeseen mechanism into a very much foreseeable mechanism. And this is why within the weak after having that initial thought, my intuitions brought me directly to the extrusion principle, in which I realized that timelines cannot exist, and that the substitute was metaphysical superpositions themselves. And yes, those very metaphysical superpositions also fit the build for that one lingering quantum effect which resists reduction to classical effects, (and in the process allow for a workaround to nonlocality), so that is why that moment of discovery marks the birth of Aethic reasoning: Aethic superpositions were here to stay.

12.8 The Requisite Interpretation of Aethic Reasoning

It is important to note at this point that there exists something of a *requisite interpretation of Aethic reasoning*, which is inspired directly from Einstein's postulates of special relativity [241]. (A word on epistemic register: what follows is a deliberate speculation—a uniqueness conjecture offered in

[283]To be abundantly clear on this point, my argument here is not simply that classical-reductionist approaches are broadly wrong because a classical physical framework only allows classical computation in place of quantum computation, but instead has a deeper philosophical pitch. While, yes, particularly strict reliance on classical mathematical physics would fail to allow quantum computing from existing in the broad sense, there are indeed more elegant classical-reductionist takes on quantum mechanics [240] which allow for a model which is classical in ontology, (i.e. no quantum superpositions allowed), but all the while is descriptive enough mathematically in order to produce quantum computing effects as an implication anyway. Resultantly, then, in establishing the strong implication criterion I am assuming that the relevant models have already passed the stage of implicative correctness to the empiricism, and am only really honing in on their more second-order ability to be sufficiently tailored to that empiricism. That is, for even a more elegant, deductively-valid classical-reductionist approach, my particular concern becomes that their mere state of having dropped that quantum ontology, (i.e. quantum superpositions), now causes them to conflict with the direct premise of the strong implication criterion as stated. That is, if quantum effects can indeed be written up without reference to the ontology of quantum superpositions, then suddenly the existence of those quantum effects in the first place becomes somewhat dubious against the myriad of effects which are more simply explained in the face of a quantum ontology-lacking theoretical framework. So, the fact that we do see quantum effects in the empiricism has to imply that the dropping of all quantum ontology has to create a conflict somewhere, and thereby be disallowed accordingly.

[284]As is the first classical-intuitive rebuttal that almost everyone takes the moment they reach the reveal. (However I should note that comparing this common intuitive misstep to a full classical-reductionist quantum interpretation clearly does not do justice to said interpretations in the first place. If anything we might simply categorize the misstep as, technically as per the categorical definition, representing a kind of lower limit to the classical-reductionist attempts in terms of sophistication, with actual established formulations within the classical-reductionist camps of course typically falling much higher on the sophistication scale. For instance, I find the philosophical motivations of Dr. Jacob Barandes to be very rich in contextual awareness [240], perhaps more so than the majority of other quantum foundational research I have seen. So I must respectfully disagree with his conclusion as per my sharp turn at the strong implication criterion, however I find his critique of Hilbert spaces as being ontologically absolute, in addition to his sheer awareness of quantum historical and modern context to be an example for future researchers in what mature and aware quantum philosophy looks like, that is as opposed to the more armchair theorizing I see in many other places).

the spirit of Einstein's postulates rather than a load-bearing result—and no derivation in this paper depends upon it.) Let us phrase it as follows.

Principle 43 (Requisite Interpretation of Aethic Reasoning)
Whereas the standard premise behind Aethic reasoning is that it amounts to logically implying the satisfaction of the five requirements, with the requisite interpretation we also hold that the converse of this is true. That is, specifically speaking, we are supposing that the three postulates of the Aethus represent the only logically-cohesive theory which allows the satisfaction of all five requirements at once. Speaking in terms of evidence, we observe that not a single proposed theory of the classical paradigm of ontology has enabled even close to a solution of all five requirements. As such, this can be taken as strong evidence that the precise set of inversions of classical ontological principles that will be seen throughout this paper, is not only one approach to solving the measurement problem with an empirically-classically-consistent world, but is rather the only approach. If a single one of these updated ontological principles were to be switched back to their classical versions, and Aethic reasoning would quickly break down, hence violating at least one requirement again. As such, perhaps the most compelling argument for Aethic reasoning's correctness is directly centered in how it is the only possible metaphysical paradigm which both allows our macroscopic empiricism, all while enabling the inductive empiricism of the quantum world, (such as quantum superpositions and entanglement).

Notice how the classical paradigm, somewhat famously, correctly reproduces the macroscopic empiricism, all while holding the quantum world as completely foreign and incompatible. The compatibility we arrive at classically, then, in the form of the Copenhagen interpretation, is to simply suppose that the ability for quantum superpositions is essentially just turned on at some point, being a Heisenberg cut [1]. The myriad of implied paradoxes aside, we hold with a simple analysis that the Heisenberg cut is unacceptably poor ontology. Implying such a cut between any two other ontologies would have been unacceptable also, for the reason that ontologies are not meant to mix this way. To give a straightforward example, had we decided to create a hard epistemic dividing line between Newtonian gravity and Einsteinian gravity just beyond the orbit of Mercury, then that would have proved disastrous for later generations of physicists. Moreover, had Newton himself simply accepted that the gravity upon the moon and the gravity upon an apple appear different, then once again we would hold a Heisenberg cut of sorts and a complete stagnation of further ontology. History tells us, then, that such a cut is the very symbol of a failed ontology, so through such a principle we have that the classical paradigm very much does ***not*** *satisfy the requirements. With the further supposition of how not one, but numerously many of its axioms serve to violate the requirements, we then further suppose that the exact inversion of said axioms which generates Aethic reasoning is the exact sole solution to the measurement problem. Just as special relativity was a compelling argument for its sole ability to satisfy the two postulates of special relativity [241], we might now argue the same of Aethic reasoning with these five requirements.*

Stated in its proper place, the conjecture is the converse of the inductive procedure by which the postulates were selected in the first place, (Section 12.6): the postulates were chosen so as to force the Powerset Invalidation Theorem together with the twin classical and quantum limits, and the requisite interpretation speculates that no other choice could have done so. The reader may weigh that speculation against the critical standards of the preceding subsection.

13 Additional Aethic Insights

The following section will cover some specific loose ends that the Aethic mindset helps to understand. The subsections are ordered deliberately: framework-essential material first, then a gathering of loose-leaf notes, then the more speculative directions, with the biographical material closing the section and one final intuition closing it outright.

13.1 Some Helpful Aethic Corollaries

Corollary
Any child of an invalid Aethus is also invalid.

Corollary
For two attributes within an Aethus to contradict invalidates that Aethus. For two statistically independent attributes to an Aethus to contradict, this is not necessarily so.

Corollary
For any valid Aethus, the union of some number of its proper child Aethae will also be to it a proper child Aethus.

Corollary
For any valid Aethus, the superposition of itself and its complement under some Nexus is simply that Nexus itself, (i.e. the Null Aethus of that Nexus's Aethic tree).

Corollary
Any superposition can be expressed as a combination of agreeing and disagreeing superpositions only onto certain attributes of the retrieval in question[285].

Corollary
The Aethic union of all the valid child Aethae of some Aethus, (with the proper weights), is always Aethically equivalent, (at the validity tier, Section 4.6.3), to that Aethus itself.

Corollary
If A is an agreeing superposition of stated-attributes, and B is the disagreeing superposition of those same stated-attributes, then the Aethic union of A and B is Aethically equivalent to the disagreeing superposition of A and B.

Corollary
Two Aethae, A and B, are Aethically equivalent if and only if every valid parent Aethus of one is implied to be a parent Aethus of the other, and with the same weight[286].

13.2 On Aethic Stackable Attributes

There is a seemingly paradoxical effect at play for certain classes of physical properties, so we need to address how they are to be properly converted into an expression through Aethic terms. Consider, for example, the way in which we humans measure time, by incrementing very small intervals additively like a linearly growing float value. In our classical world, this is a tangible enough epistemic property, however once we start to translate it to Aethic terms, we find that it is a surprisingly nontrivial question. Unlike depicting categorical attributes like, say, the properties of minerals to an Aethus, we find with time that designating a single attribute to it is insufficient, because if you set the state of attribute "time" when the clock strikes two o'clock, then you effectively freeze that time wherever the setting was done, because to change it at any future point would amount to an Aethic contradiction. As such, we have that simply setting the attribute as is amounts to an invalid way of encoding time.

The basic idea is that in the face of issues such as this, all we have to do is come up with creative alternatives of expressing the same desired empirical notion without relying on the same styles of Aethic encoding which triggered the problem in the first place. Whether it can be done is implied as true in Aethic reasoning, but how easily it can be done is a whole other question.

Considering time again, if we want to simply brute force the solution by brainstorming other ideas of how to encode it, then we find that they too tend to fall short of succeeding. Maybe we suppose that time itself is state-decomposable into many different binary attributes, such that its value simply reads their sum. When each reads blank, we might suppose that it adds zero to the sum, however once it becomes stated, it then adds one. In total, we would create something of a clock, such that the total registered time increments as each new attribute in the sequence is stated. Now, this being said, we can somewhat easily discount it as anything which is ontologically relevant. For one, time is obviously not discrete like such a framework would imply, and it also goes without saying that such a framework is far too Cartesian to attach to any real ontology.

A better idea, perhaps, may be to use attribute weighting for this endeavor, such that incrementing time amounts to slightly filling in the blank of a single attribute. The benefits of this framework are that it is now continuous rather than discrete, and that it does not rely on numerous arbitrarily defined

[285] This is a corollary of the Aethic dichotomy theorem. As an example of using it in action, consider three attribute states, which we will call A, B, and C, and consider how we would express the retrieval given by $\left[[A, B, C], [A, B, \not{C}], [A, \not{B}, C]\right]$, (supposing uniformity across both levels). One way of writing this using agreeing superpositions, say $\mathbb{A}$, together with disagreeing superpositions, say $\mathbb{D}$, would be the following: $\mathbb{A}\Big[A, \mathbb{A}\Big[\mathbb{A}[B, C], \mathbb{D}[B, C]^2\Big]\Big]$.

[286] A major extension of this corollary is for cases when A and or B are invalid Aethae, for which the corollary still holds. Specifically, we might use this to demonstrate that all hyperinvalid Aethae are Aethically equivalent, or that two seemingly unequal generic invalid static Aethae may indeed be equal anyway, (that is, marking this as an extra avenue for telling Aethic equivalence in the case of invalid Aethae only—identifications licensed precisely because the tier certified is validity equivalence, under which invalid Aethae are identified while their static labels remain distinct).

attributes. Epistemically speaking, then, such a notion is at least arguably well-defined, however it nonetheless hardly addresses the larger issue at hand, being the corresponding ontology. That is, we might list all the nuanced ways of *possibly* expressing time in an Aethus, but none of them help sway the debate in favor of the best ontological system. As such, with the epistemic question of Aethically encoding time already being nontrivial, the ontological question is yet even more difficult. We will leave this question here for the current paper, and will attempt to address it further in the followup paper on active reasoning.

Given this example of time, let us create a name for the general class of physical properties which tend to update with time, as such triggering conflict with their direct representation in the Aethus. Perhaps we refer to such properties as *stackable attributes*, due to their nature of having a timelike "refresh mechanism" of sorts. The simplest example of such a thing is dimensional time itself, for which the question of its Aethic expression has already been depicted as nontrivial. Some other key examples of stackable attributes are quantum spin and gauge boson polarization, which we know empirically to be able to pick up brand new states with time as well. For example, we know that every time a photon passes through a polarizer, we have that its polarization state is to change accordingly.

Given that all of these examples of stackable attributes have empirical components to them, the scientific method demands that they get the benefit of the doubt in the event of us questioning their intrinsic compatibility with Aethic reasoning. This then supplies us with something of a dichotomy of options, of which only one option is true.

1. One option is that all possible empirically-correspondent stackable attributes can be reformulated into empirically equivalent epistemologies which are Aethically compatible in both the epistemic and ontological lenses. We will refer to the reformulations which do this as the *stackal transform* of the corresponding stackable attribute.

2. The only other option is that there exists an empirically-correspondent stackable attribute which cannot in any way be reformulated to Aethically compatible terms, in effect making it *stackally untransformable*. In such a case, the paradigm of Aethic reasoning itself would have to be false, on account of it no longer fitting all constituent empiricism. We therefore have a fundamental principle, being that *the correctness of Aethic reasoning demands that there are no stackally untransformable attributes which correspond to a valid empiricism.*

Through this insight, then, we automatically have to declare the following premise as a conjecture in Aethic reasoning.

Conjecture (Stackal Transform Conjecture)
Any physical phenomenon which is present in the reality of a valid Aethus will possess a well-defined stackal transform for each valid epistemic formulation of it.
Note that such a principle tells us that there is indeed a stackal transform to be found, however it does not cover the procedure of actually deciphering it. As such, different stackal transforms will require different derivational methods, perhaps of varying levels of difficulty. (In this way, a good analogy is the solutions of integrals).

Here is a rough listing of different classes of attributes, so as to consider the ease or difficulty of finding their stackal transforms.

- If the attribute is trivial, then it will not be a stackable attribute, and as such is its own stackal transform.

- If the attribute is a stackable attribute of an easier variety, then perhaps it can be written with a relatively straightforward stackal transform.

- If the ability of finding an attribute's stackal transform is provably impossible, then the attribute in question must be a construct, (at least according to Aethic reasoning).

- If an attribute's stackal transform is possible but excruciatingly difficult to decipher, then said attribute might be interpreted as hinting at the need for new physics altogether. This is the ontologically difficult category of stackal transforms.

Of course, in order for the stackal transform conjecture to rise to the level of a theory, it is going to need a wide array of confirmational cases for which a stackal transform is indeed achievable. Given that it is early in the game as of the writing of this paper, this achievement is going to require some time to finish in full, but in the active reasoning paper we will describe some of the basics for how to do this with quantum spin, and perhaps even dimensional time itself.

13.3 Loose-Leaf Aethic Notes

The following short notes are gathered here as deliberate loose leaves: each is self-contained, none is load-bearing for the framework proper, and each earns its keep as an angle on the Aethic mindset rather than as a step in the argument.

13.3.1 On Being Wrong

There is something of a potential criticism to the Aethic logic, which is to regard the possibility of one's entire epistemological outlook being wrong. There are extreme examples of this, such as that seen in the film *The Matrix* [242], but there are also more mild versions, such as thinking you left your car keys in your pocket but instead having left them on the table. Etcetera. What happens, Aethically speaking, when one's perception does not match the truth contents of their Aethus? May the Aethus even be sure to have contents at all anymore beyond that point?

The most straightforward solution to this paradox of sorts is to add a special additional principle to the Aethic mindset. Here it is.

Principle 44 (Principle of Aethic Accidentalism)
No Aethic attribute, either spoken of or ontological implied, may certainly exist in one's Aethus. At most it is in a superposition with some of its alternatives such that the weight is very much in its favor against theirs. This is the Aethic analogue for epistemological skepticism, along with an additional layer regarding the ripple effects of such a thing through reality.

That is, Aethic superpositions never "collapse" at all – instead they merely "compress."

(A note added in the June 2026 editing pass, because this principle, written years before the machinery existed to cash it out, turns out to have been load-bearing all along: "compression" is precisely what the later formalism delivers. The reversal principle's prohibition on infinitely-determinate Aethae is this principle's structural face, (it is why preparations and outcomes alike are packet-valued rather than point-valued); centric unfolding implements compression as a Nexus-style intersection that skews weights onto a surviving collection rather than selecting a term; the residual, never-strictly-zero weights raise no indefiniteness about outcomes, because "the outcome" is an equivalence-class fact at record resolution, drawn on invariant attributes, (see the note of Section 1.5); and probability-as-structure, (Section 12.4.10), is the bookkeeping of exactly these compressions. What was written here as an epistemological failsafe was, in retrospect, the framework's collapse theory stated in advance.) Accordingly, and matching the treatment given to the extrusion principle, let us bring the principle up to date by splitting it into its two facets.

Principle 45 (Principle of Aethic Accidentalism: Structural Facet)
Centric unfolding never selects a term from a standing superposition; it compresses. The transit is a Nexus-style intersection that re-weights the prior collection, skewing weight onto survivors while the remainder becomes negligible rather than invalid, with "the outcome" an equivalence-class fact at record resolution over invariant attributes. The Monty Hall Nexus, (Section 11.1), is this facet in its most down-to-earth dress; the Quantum Nexus is the same facet at full generality.

Principle 46 (Principle of Aethic Accidentalism: Qualitative Facet)
No attribute certainly exists in one's Aethus: at most its superposition is weighted overwhelmingly in its favor, approaching definiteness asymptotically and never completing it. This is the Aethic analogue of epistemological skepticism, carried with its ripple effects through reality.

The two facets are one principle seen structurally and qualitatively: the compression of the first is the asymptote of the second.

This particular interpretation of Aethic reasoning serves as something of a failsafe toward implying that all information which is spoken of as true necessarily is true within one's Aethus itself. To be clear, the idea is that superpositions may only ever approach a single attribute, but have something of an asymptote toward reaching it in terms of certainty. Never does it actually reach the fixed point that is the attribute itself's definite state in the Aethus.

Some examples of this principle might be thinking you see your friend's car, and then being wrong. Human error, see, creates an immediate buffer toward being wrong about something. At the instant of seeing the car, it would be a fallacy to argue that the state of seeing your friend's car is now within your Aethus. Perhaps you are wrong. In the prior example, we see that you were. Even if you are looking directly at your friend, it is still a fallacy to suppose that that is your friend. Perhaps they

have a secret identical twin who is posing as them. Perhaps you have a brain disorder which prevents you from distinguishing between different people. Perhaps you are a brain in a simulation. And so on and so forth. The main supposition of this postulate, then, is that it is a fallacy at all times to argue that something you believe empirically is within your Aethus – no matter how sure you are about it. This is nothing new to the possibility of being wrong as seen through the classical lens, it is just nonetheless unsettling that it also extends to the Aethic mindset.

This is not to say that your Aethic does not contain information – rather it is an argument that one cannot assert they know what is in their Aethus beyond hypothetical mathematical meddling. As such, we are required to have a "standard system" of sorts of interpreting reality, which might fall under the umbrella of the centric unfolding interpretation of the Aethus. Such a system would imply that some of the core postulates about reality which seem to be true as a matter of fact are – that is unless they are eventually proven to be not so.

As an example of an argument we might use in favor of such an assertion, one might ask why the Aethic postulates operate so neatly over one's Aethus in the first place. If we were separated from the truth of reality by many more iterations than we believe, (for example via a simulation), then we could justifiably ask why reality keeps track of applying the second postulate to our empirical world so well. If all of the events of our lives were trivial and unconnected to the core of reality, then perhaps those laws would only apply to the deeper things, in the process feeding our perceptions with ever changing and unstable Aethic updates rather than ones which can be shown to follow a general pattern. However – there is a dark side to this assertion even by itself, because if we extended such a chaotic possibility far enough, such that everything and every law of physics was utterly chaotic and non deterministic, then some kind of creature might as well develop in this chaotic soup which views it in a somewhat orderly lens with respect to itself – and that could just by you and your Aethus[287]. This is not to say that this is the case for sure, but it can be extrapolated that an Aethus is a natural possible consequence to either the most orderly or chaotic system imaginable – whether, that is, there is a difference in the first place.

Anyway, this argument was simply given as a backup to any criticisms against the Aethic mindset which regard it. We ought to be outward in our claiming of inability to see into the inner workings of the Aethus, and that is that. That does not, however, mean that we cannot set up a system which matches to all things we have empirically described, such that even if we are in some false reality or another, we will describe that falsehood to a high degree of accuracy.

As a direct example of how the Aethus interprets scenarios like these, consider what would happen if you were to live in a dream world where every time you walk on pavement, you are actually walking on grass, and every time you walk on grass, you are actually walking on pavement. If you currently believe you are walking on pavement, (meaning you are actually walking on grass), it simply follows Aethically that your Aethus ought to hold the same state now regarding such a thing that it holds before. That is, the Aethus only ever asserts that this qualia at the moment lines up with whatever qualia you involuntarily aligned it with before. So if it's pavement but really grass, and it was pavement yesterday but really grass, then either way what it really is now is what it really was then, because since your Aethus is simply an ontological manifestation of your sensory intake to an exact correspondence, it then follows the two line up. And even if they do not, such as it being pavement but really grass today but pavement but really water yesterday, then the mediocrity principle itself can be of use here, arguing that it was probably still pavement but really grass yesterday as well. If, however, it is not, then such an assertion is simply an instance of the problem of induction but in Aethic form. However, considering how all throughout human society do we constantly assume no problem of induction, it follows that that same assumption maps here in the assertion that one's Aethus truly contains what they believe that it contains. The key though is to remember that what the Aethus contains is deeper and more fundamental than what believes it contains, so the Aethus might very well contain something and have you not know it rather than definitely containing something only because you thought that it must. The problem of induction, then, would be a problem of opinionated knowledge, not of the Aethus, and hence we get the principle of Aethic accidentalism once more. But yes, if an isomorphism between what you feel and what there is is to be implied, then this is sufficient before a direct assumption of equality. The relationalism between the two is enough to write up this ontology.

[287]To be clear, the argument here is more or less that given the mediocrity principle and the postulates of the Aethus, it is not too radical to suppose that a simulation-on-simulation-on-simulation or something world of utmost chaos could not itself develop Aethic and physical properties with respect to whatever bath of chaos generates it. In such a lens, the Aethus is less a standalone ontological entity, and is more tailored to whatever stacking of reality it operates in relation to. I.e. the Aethic postulates and the accordance theorem still apply regardless of system due to their relational nature.

13.3.2 The Constituent Matter Fallacy

A pressing fallacy that I see many people default to is the notion that every "object" in the universe, (whatever such a thing even means), is entirely derived in ontology from those matter parts which compose it. That is, the idea is that the root of all causality sits in the realm of the smallest particles, with everything else being derived from this. In my mind, however, this is an odd if not indefensible standing. Under what evidence is it sure to be true?

In order to found Aethic reasoning, I had to look at this from entirely different direction. My claim now is that the Aethus is the fundamental arbiter of ontology, with the random scatterings of particles being just a consequence of this. By the first postulate of the Aethus, furthermore, we can go as far as to argue that assuming all superpositions derive from the net combinations of quantum particles is a fallacy outright. Rather than causality only pointing from the small to the large, instead we have that it points outward from the Aethus, be it regarding the motions of subatomic particles or the galaxies around us. The particle-first view, then, seems rather archaic when one really analyzes it. (Why not big-to-small? Why not space-to-matter instead of matter-to-matter? And so on from here).

In short, what I mean to mention with this brief section is how the unconscious particle-reductionism commitment of the classical quantum mechanical paradigm obscures the taking of the Aethus as fundamental. This obstruction is arguably present even more in implicit conversation than when explicitly called out, for example in discussions on how the Copenhagen Interpretation is circular because detectors cause collapse in particles, and yet detectors are composed of particles. The issue that manifests in this closed loop, ironically enough, is that people find themselves forced to attribute the "causal root" to the universe specifically to the particles, and then built outwardly from there. This, of course, as a paradigm makes the Aethic postulates entirely inarticulable, hence why this particle-reductionism has to be lightly pushed back against (at least in any sense of totality of causation) as part of the general Aethic intuition-building.

13.3.3 Standard Linguistic Form of the Aethus

One might have noticed how we have repeatedly capitalized the word "Aethus" throughout this paper. The thinking for this goes that if a human name counts as a proper noun, then so too should an Aethus by the same line of reasoning. This does mean the *class* of Aethus as well as simply the *object* of Aethus. Such a thing does admittedly stray from what can be said of other attributes of a human, however we nonetheless are supposing that due to the unique properties of reality which correspond to an Aethus, it then follows that it ought to at least partially inherit some of these typically object-exclusive characteristics regarding proper nouns and their direct applicability.

13.3.4 Archival: The Original Elevator Pitch to Aethic Reasoning (in the Form of an Analogy)

The following analogy originally opened the extrusion principle's discussion, and is preserved here in archival form; the principle's current entryway is the numbered sequence of statements beginning at Section 2.2.1.

Consider the act of driving your car on a highway which runs along the edge of a forest. Suppose at exactly 2:00 PM, you glance out the window to your left, and see a young tree beside the road. You only glance at it for just long enough to register its existence, but are looking back ahead before you have time to make a reasonable judgment of parallax on account of the car's motion. Now imagine that you spend the next five minutes looking only ahead toward the road, however at 2:05 sharp you glance toward the trees again, and see another tree exactly to your left, but this time much taller and older than the one you looked at earlier. As common sense will tell you, you are looking at two different trees with two different histories, but let us now imagine how this experience would appear different if you regarded those trees the same way in which the Copenhagen interpretation regards quantum particles before and after a wavefunction collapse event.

The Copenhagen interpretation would be like assuming that the car is parked on the highway, such that any change in observation is only isolated to a change in one single tree. You would suppose that in the intermediate time between your first look and your second look, there was a single tree to the left of you, and that single tree has since grown up into a taller and more mature tree. Under this worldview, you could not realize that you were in fact never parked in the first place, and that you had been looking at two separate trees altogether. The single difference between the two possible

worldviews, then, comes down to assuming you must be stationary versus assuming you must yourself be moving.

This is the same sort of logic that will serve as the foundation of Aethic reasoning, in the form of what we refer to as *the Aethic extrusion principle* for quantum particles. The main supposition is that never did a single particle change—rather you yourself, as is something like turning the page of a book, have transitioned into a subtly different reality for which the subsequent system to the collapse had been in effect all along.

13.4 Are We in a Dream World or Simulation?

Consider the prospect that we are in a simulation like the Matrix [242], or perhaps oneself is dreaming and only thinks themselves awake. In an objectivist or otherwise deterministic mindset, these problems hold a real status in the picture of reality. As a matter of fact, many people instinctively turn toward the simulation hypothesis upon seeing the outcome of the double-slit experiment for the first time. This all being said, a natural question is to ponder over what status the simulation hypothesis holds in the grand scheme of the Aethic mindset, and whether it is relevant at all therein.

To begin with, the simulation hypothesis is, well, not very consequential at all in the Aethic mindset, the reason being that many of the philosophical notions used to emphasize it are nullified with regard to the Aethus.

Consider some number of iterative simulations, such that there is some "real world" on top, in which there is a computer running a simulated world, itself then holding a computer running a simulated world, and so on. A natural question that a philosopher might ask in the face of this is "which level am I on?" But, the notion that they must occupy even one level at all, instead of multiple, is an artifact of objectivism. In the Aethic mindset, given by the condition of being in a simulation that one is unaware of whether they are in a simulation, it follows simply from the second postulate that said person must necessarily occupy all levels of the simulation at once in a superposition. Perhaps even an agreeing superposition if some kind of uncertainty principle is here applicable. This might seem a very odd solution to the simulation query in the classical setting, but Aethically it is the only natural solution in the face of the vast unknowing coupled with the state of the simulation in the first place. Through this, we see that the ontological relevance of the simulation is perhaps even some form of underwhelming, with any semblance of a "real world" being present among these being Aethically arbitrary.

As a matter of fact, the Aethic mindset itself provides an alternative way of interpreting this dilemma in the existential sense. Suppose one found hard evidence that they were in a simulation, at least one level down from the "real world," (hence collapsing the Aethic superposition in the process). Given this, does it really *matter* at all in the existential sense? Most people would say that of course it does, because it now demonstrates that you are not living in the real world, and are as such that much more insignificant in the existential sense. However, in the Aethic mindset, the reaction to this would be quite different. Instead, we might suppose that we are inherently just as *real* as the level above us, because, frankly, we are real relative to our world and our Aethus, just as the other levels are relative to themselves. If we did indeed find ourselves in a simulation, we might simply readjust our perception and leave it at that. Or if anything we would not need to do any readjusting anyway, since, by virtue of being computer characters, we would already be tailored to our environment no more or no less than we would have been before. Ontologically, the link between person and Aethus is unchanged. That is, let us ease maximally into the relativism of things. Just because your Aethus is simulated, doesn't mean it is any less of an Aethus than any other Aethus. As such, reality roots to an Aethus, so by rooting to your simulated Aethus, you are still as *real* as anything else out there. This is simply an application of the first postulate—which supposes that reality holds all value in relation to an Aethus, and that includes values of implied significance with respect to one simulation level or another. Existentially, then, no Aethus is superior to any other—that is simply not how the Aethic tree works.

13.5 Biological Implication of Aethic Reasoning

One major implication of Aethic reasoning is to provide ontological insight into the miraculous functionality of biology. For instance, take the sheer complexity of proteins. Of course, their complexity has a multitude of functions, but one of them may regard quantum coherence itself. Consider the nature of photosynthesis in plants, which allows an extraordinary efficiency of transporting energy without loss. It seems very likely that this is due to the phenomenon of quantum coherence [243]. As such, with the Aethic mindset, we might consider that one of the primary functions of the proteins which transfer photonic energy throughout the plant is to in a sense "hide" the information of where the

photons are located in the vast expanses of complexity within the proteins. If this is done sufficiently enough, then the third postulate of the Aethus itself can be exploited to yield astounding levels of efficiency in energy transfer, which is just what it seems that plants are doing in possessing the gift of photosynthesis. As such, the endurance of our biosphere itself holds an intimate dependence on the third postulate of the Aethus, even though the scale between us and where it operates on Heisenberg's uncertainty principle are by many orders of magnitude removed.

In particular, though, we can suppose that a major general role of biological proteins is to procedurally manipulate and transfer Aethic coherent states. Due to the unfathomable complexity within proteins alone, we might suppose that Aethic effects are not only present, but well within the scope of natural selection. For a protein to harness Aethic effects would be no more or no less unusual than for it to harness the better-studied chemical effects and the like. Aethic coherence would, simply put, be a major mode of contribution toward proteins and their procedural abilities. This is so assuming the validity of the postulates of the Aethus.

Let us use these insights to construct an Aethic version to the orchestrated objective reduction (Orch OR) hypothesis of Roger Penrose and Stuart Hameroff. Specifically, their idea posits that human consciousness may come about from effects of quantum coherence within the neurological brain, particularly within its microtubules [244]. This hypothesis is quite controversial for its conflicting nature with key postulates of modern neuroscience. However, we will take this section to argue that with only a few Aethic updates, Orch OR can be seen for a high quality hypothesis indeed.

Now, Aethically speaking, we know that the ability for a conscious mind to collapse a wave function has not directly to do with any quantum essence within the mind itself, simply because the postulates of the Aethus explain the collapse themselves. That is, Aethic reasoning conflicts with objective-collapse theories by nature[288]. Through such a thing we get that that portion of Orch OR is not to be salvaged, but with that out of the way, we can begin to analyze its more intriguing aspects.

We will specifically argue, via the Aethic standpoint, that it is quite plausible that consciousness implies an influence of quantum coherence in its functionality. However, we will strictly also hold that the converse of such a statement is not generally true, (at least under the same mode of reasoning), as would be a more panpsychist supposition, perhaps. Regardless of whether there is any merit to the panpsychist argument in general, we are to make a very specific argument here regarding why the brain's remarkable abilities over energy and time efficiency would imply a dependence of the brain on quantum coherence for its functionality, *but merely where this is a boost to its general functionality rather than the medium of it.* In essence, we still fully agree with the standard paradigm of neural connections being the physical root to consciousness, but then regard quantum coherence as being a necessary extra ingredient to the picture for the consciousness to actually be allowed existence.

The premise behind this is that if we attempted to perform, say, even a single second of the brain's computation without the effects of quantum coherence, then the time complexity would skyrocket while the efficiency fell, in effect rendering animal life impossible over the second-to-second timescales of functionality demanded by natural selection. If it took ten thousand years and quadrillions of joules to power the human brain for a single waking second, then of course consciousness would be impossible, so our argument here is specifically that *given the accuracy of our supposition about the involved time complexity, it follows that consciousness is technically existentially dependent on quantum coherence by only one degree of causal separation, and therefore Orch OR's identification of such a phenomenon is well placed.*

Regarding the second part of our argument, being why it is justifiable to hypothesize such a massive falloff in the time complexity at all given the lack of some supposed neurological quantum coherence, derives simply from the truly vast complexity held within biological proteins. From a purely existentialist point of view, I am taken aback by only one physical concept to the same intensity as when I try to ponder the scale of Graham's number, and that concept is the macromolecule. The sheer immensity of these objects is almost not to be believed, it is so vast. As such, given what I know about the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, it seems that hiding molecular information would be essentially child's play for the right class of macromolecule. In effect, we might even regard the

[288]Note that even the question of whether Aethic reasoning conflicts with objective-collapse theories is somewhat nuanced, so we must be careful about how we state this. Specifically, the issue with objective-collapse models is that they always attribute the wavefunction collapse to a single causal phenomenon, which is strictly contrasted by the more dynamic, albeit deterministic phrasing of Aethic reasoning on wavefunction collapses. With the point aside of how no existing instance of an objective-collapse model thereby agrees with Aethic reasoning, we also have that objective-collapse models do not directly further the road to Aethic reasoning any more than other quantum interpretations, and as such should not gain a higher status among them. In effect, the attributions of how wavefunctions collapse according to objective-collapse models ought to be treated less as underlying ontological phenomena, and more as input parameters into the general machinery of Aethic reasoning.

inner workings of cellular biology as having a vast infrastructure of quantum coherent effects, with the perfect efficiency of photon transportation being only the tip of the iceberg. At the very least we have to acknowledge that under the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, together with the almost intelligent procedural capabilities of macromolecules, it follows that the influence of quantum coherent effects at the biochemical scale are a very real possibility for explaining, at least in part, essentially any biological phenomenon. The sheer thought of what powers a particular biological protein might have over the effects of both Aethic and active reasoning are, in a word, rather striking to ponder over. As such, it follows that if proteins have indeed built a vast biological infrastructure of quantum coherence, then it follows through basic anthropic argument that the state of such an infrastructure existing at all implies it had better be deeply advantageous.

In total, we see that since proteins ought to be highly capable of hiding molecular information, then the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning implies that they participate in lots of quantum coherence. Then, because such neurobiological quantum coherence exists, we have that there had better be a great reason for why evolutionary nature would bother making it a possibility. Such a reason would have to imply significant disadvantages in the scenario where there are no neurobiological quantum coherent effects, so therefore the ability for consciousness to procedurally exists is dependent upon neurobiological quantum coherence. It may validate the premise of Orch OR on a technicality, yes, but that is as sufficient a confirmation as anything else.

Lastly for this section, let us simply reject the "warm, wet, and noisy" [245] objection to neurological quantum coherence on account of the aforementioned incredible yet uncharted abilities of biological proteins. There is nothing more to address on the topic, as saying "*the brain cannot be quantum coherent because it is warm, wet, and noisy*" is about as powerful an objection as claiming that Jupiter is receiving no sunlight because it is currently nighttime in Dallas.

13.6 Aethic Approach to The Hard Problem of Consciousness

We might note an interesting rendering of the first postulate of the Aethus, which is that *since reality is a statement of relation to a particular Aethus, we might then argue that any valid Aethus has to it possible statements of relation, and therefore must have possible corresponding realities.* This can be seen as a kind of reality-Aethus dualism principle.

Principle 47 (Principle of Aethus-Reality Dualism)
Just as for any reality, there must be a corresponding Aethus, we also see that for any Aethus, there is automatically a corresponding reality.

This might be seen as synonymous with the first postulate of the Aethus itself, but particularly in a way which highlights the ability of both statement and converse to hold.

A key idea we might take away from this, then, *is that biological life, by climbing the evolutionary ladder toward more sophisticated evolutionary mechanisms of gathering information, accordingly implies a corresponding Aethus which must arise in parallel to such an advancement.* To illustrate this point, consider a thought experiment in which we can follow along with our distant ancestors as they undergo evolution, similarly to watching a movie. At some point in the runtime, such an ancestor would have been not so different than a flatworm, bobbing around in some ancient ocean. Such a flatworm, we might argue, will have a rudimentary two or three thousand neurons in its body, which through their incredible biological function will enable it to make calculated assessments about its oceanic environment. For example, perhaps it can gauge the basic salinity of the water around it, so as to involuntarily swim left or swim right accordingly. Mathematically, just this simple mechanism is grounds for defining an Aethus. The question of which specific attributes we would choose to depict it is somewhat daunting already, especially as per the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, but the notion is that an Aethus which does this could indeed be declared. In effect, the ghost degrees of freedom of the salinity gauge can be considered analogous, in their combination, with the corresponding Aethus to the system.

So, given that such a flatworm-like creature can be attached with an abstract empirical Aethus, such that the Aethus specifically encodes its deeply complicated neurological assessment of the salinity in the water around it, we might then use this to ask a fundamental philosophical question.

Question (Question of Evolutionary Aethic Extrapolation)
Is the Aethus we described for a flatworm's salinity gauge its Aethus in the same way as your Aethus is your Aethus?

This is something of a deep philosophical question—naturally deserving of many debates beyond what can be offered here. But it was worth mentioning it as a new open question of sorts.

Regardless of whatever the specific extrapolations of a human's Aethus to earlier layers on the evolutionary ladder are, the trajectory of things on account of evolution is somewhat more clear on account of it pertaining to our first-person experience as conscious beings. As such, as evolution continued on, and as our thought experiment-movie runs, we see more and more sophisticated measures of attaining information in our ancestors, in a way almost as a driving force to their evolutionary development. From worms come fish, and from fish come tetrapods, who themselves give rise to amniotes. What we see is that with each new biological revolution comes new environments which demand of new perceptual capabilities, which themselves are brought about in the nervous system. What ends up happening is that the nervous system, like an astoundingly powerful machine, learns to convert its very instance of sensory intake, (which remember we inferred can be encoded with an Aethus as per the example of the flatworm), into an immediate chain reaction of consequences. The neural system itself might even be regarded as being trained to perform the same intrinsic output to like stimuli, such as the flatworm swimming left versus right as depending on the salinity content input. Now, with more neurons, we stack more and more procedures just like this, with simple inputs producing trained outputs, and we then see that the combinations of the inputs themselves yield a vast number of additional and unpredictable outputs, all while still maintaining chief optimization against the stimuli of the environment. In effect, the brain evolves to the earliest hints of its modern capabilities. And as this occurs, a corresponding Aethus—which remember we take to correspond merely to the ghost degrees of freedom of the sensory intake system—takes shape accordingly for each new style of brain in the evolutionary development. What we get, then, is a corresponding hierarchy of three effects.

1. Through evolutionary pressure, the neural complexity of the evolving brain comes about to combat the immense variation in pressures which an organism might face over the course of its life. The neural network itself can be considered as the continual adaptation of the past design of the neural network so as to optimize its fit to each new environment. Naturally, this requires immense complexity, and its power comes in how it extrapolates known stimuli-to-response conversions into the wide variety of alternatives through essentially techniques of combination.

2. *The neural network of the brain brings about a corresponding empirical Aethus which corresponds to the ghost degrees of freedom of the sensory intake system, for no reason other than the presence of such ghost degrees of freedom implies that they can be expressed in an Aethus, so therefore a corresponding Aethus is present to that extent.* This is what we might generally refer to as a "Aethus expressional declaration," which may be regarded in a similar vein to the mathematical universe hypothesis [93], however only to the extent of analogy. Specifically, the analogy is that where the mathematical universe hypothesis takes every stated mathematical concept to have an ontological counterpart—such that even allowing a mathematical structure to appear epistemologically implies that it must also possess a generated ontological component—we might then argue a similar thing of Aethae, being that for a system to exist which even *can* be depicted in terms of an Aethus implies that there must exist a corresponding empirical Aethus which associates with that.

   Principle 48 (Principle of Aethic Ontological Implication)
   Noting that this proposed principle is external to the foundations of Aethic reasoning, and as such is speculative to that extent, we might state it as follows.

   Any system which can be depicted with an empirical Aethus implies an ontological Aethus which corresponds to it. (Note that this is not dependent on an agent actually doing the depiction manually, as that would be arbitrary—merely the suppositions is that if there exists a mathematical Aethus which can depict said system, then there must exist to that a corresponding ontological Aethus).

   The comparison with the mathematical universe hypothesis falls off sharply after that, once that hypothesis strays from the pure philosophy. Even then, we are not here arguing that mathematics itself has an ontological counterpart, because such an assertion is variant as depending on the lens through one views that mathematics anyway. Instead, we argue that it would only be appropriate to make this kind of claim with regard to an entire Aethus, due to it being the only structure which is directly extendable to a well-defined reality, as per the first postulate of the Aethus.

3. *By the Aethus-reality dualism principle, we then have that a corresponding reality must come about to match the aforementioned ontological Aethus. Perhaps it is this reality itself which brings about the conscious experience of the agent, or we might at least suppose that in the significant breadth of metaphysics which spans this step, there is more than enough of a spacing to house a consciousness. Perhaps this unique metaphysical element of Aethic reasoning is where the inabilities of the classical paradigm to solve the hard problem of consciousness are relieved.*

13.6.1 The Dual Causality Principle and the Emergence of Consciousness

Let us note that the Aethic dual causality principle itself says something about the nature of the "causal source" of consciousness, and this is important for illustrating the full nuance of the principle of Aethus-reality dualism as an effective coupling mechanism of constraints. That is, even if the abstract Aethus-side of consciousness does indeed extend deeply enough to consist with a full Eastern metaphysical model of fundamentality like Advaita Vedanta, that actually need not discount consciousness *also* being causally sourced by what is entirely reducible to the neurological behavior of the brain, (and whatever other physical context contributes, whatever it may be). This is a direct application of the dual causality principle, just this time where one causal mode points from the fundamental consciousness to one's physical reality, and the other causal mode points from the dynamics in one's physical reality to the fundamental consciousness (or at least abstract Aethus-oriented) direction. Notice how either of these causal modes is effectively tracing over the divide of the Aethus-reality dualism, just merely in opposite directions. This is perhaps analogous how Optimation tends to point roughly backwards in causation as compared to the forward flow of the physical causal mode.

The key consideration to make, however, is that the (perhaps trivial) constraint that one's brain patterns must consist with one's conscious perception[289] itself prevents us from simply discounting the physical reality-to-consciousness-directed causal mode from being equally real, because like any mathematically-coupled system, the behavior of that system is dependent on each constraint as an influence to it. So, concretely, this enables our to eventually assert both a metaphysical-based theory that *is* what consciousness is irreducibly, and a physical-tangible-evolutionary-side theory that *is* what consciousness is irreducibly. Both may indeed possess entirely enough theoretic information to clarify what consciousness is, but altogether the proposal for the proper way to think of consciousness altogether is rather like a mathematical system for which both sides are separable constraints which are coupled by the Aethus-reality dualism principle. In a coupled equation we would not simply declare that either side alone *causes* the equation, but rather "cause" would not really enter the conversation to begin with—instead we would merely suppose impartially that each such leg serves as a constraint on a total structure. The idea for consciousness, then, is that we might propose such an interpretive framing on it, and yet at once pursue comprehensive (and perhaps even causally-conflicting) explanatory theories of consciousness all the same.

13.6.2 Split Reality Hypothesis

There is an interestingly entertainable construction under the apparatus of Aethic reasoning, which we might therefore propose now.

Concept 10 (The Split Reality Hypothesis of Aethic Reasoning)
The split reality hypothesis is a possible alternative to centric unfolding (i.e., an "eccentric unfolding" instance), for which a conscious agent attaches not to only one Aethus, A, but instead to a countable number of Aethae, $S = \{A_1, A_2, \cdots, A_n\}$. The idea of this construction is that what we normally call "one's Aethus" is the reduced form of the Aethus $A = \prod_{A_i \in S} A_i$, except instead of A itself undergoing centric unfolding, each A_i independently undergoes centric unfolding, and without "knowledge" of the others in set S, such that the appearance of a joint reality is simply emergent from the reduced form coupling in A itself.

This is not to say that such a split reality hypothesis necessarily need be argued for as opposed to centric unfolding in the slightest, but rather that it cannot be ruled out as potentially useful for later Aethic endeavors, like an Aethic theory of consciousness for instance.

To give an intuitive example of using this prospect in action, we might consider re-doing the centric unfolding for the Quantum Nexus such that centric unfolding strictly runs over one's own system

[289] That is, whether we attribute the coupling of the two to Aethus-reality dualism or to something more trivially tautological directly.

Aethus X as opposed to the joint Aethus $X \cdot N$ with N being the Quantum Nexus. That is, under a base centric unfolding model, we assume that N is fixed as a parent Aethus to all Aethic time past Aethae of oneself, and then with its assumed permanently incorporated simply undergo centric unfolding on the established $X \cdot N$ itself. The split reality alternative, however, is to create a split Aethus set $S = \{X, N\}$, and then centric unfolding only on the system Aethus X itself. The result is identical empiricism, such that prior to learning the state of a knowable attribute at system Aethus X_1, one's Aethus $X_1 N$ forms a reduced form pertaining to the disagreeing superposition of that given attribute, whereas once X_1 centric unfolds to X_2 and that attribute becomes state-decomposable, the Quantum Nexus operates precisely as usual and the alternatives for that attribute under $X_1 N$ now drop out to invalidity[290] due to direct contradiction with the state-decomposable form of the attribute under X_2. So, in other words, if you will, the base centric unfolding version of this proposition leans toward interpreting the eventual collapse as a later selection of an Aethus from a disagreeing superposition, whereas the split reality version leans toward interpreting the disagreeing superposition and the later determinate state as somewhat more identical in kind, as opposed to each being simply passively emergent from the reduced form taking without any particular privileging to one versus the other, (that is on account to their just being the reduced form of a particular Aethus intersection with the Quantum Nexus—dependent only on more versus less terms falling out to invalidity without any real, well-defined regime shift occurrence whatsoever).

13.7 Aethic Reasoning and Eastern Philosophy

Hopefully, if we have done our job, there are many mathematical, logical, and philosophical tools of sorts to play around with from this paper. Many of them may be entirely new and innovative. Having gotten to the truths associated with Aethic reason firsthand, however, I am amazed to see that many of these newfound inner truths of reality were known to the east for thousands of years. The Eastern mindset seems almost more tailored to thinking Aethically than the west[291].

[290] That is, under the Quantum Nexus "kill switch" intersecting mechanism.

[291] I would argue that the first distinctly Aethic nonclassicality to show up in my work is the Accordance Principle itself from Nexic reasoning. That is, the mere prospect of it forces a hard reassessment of what a human actually is, categorically, because of the sheer expansion it provides to the reference class across space and time which a consciousness could reasonably occupy. This itself is perhaps the primary reason why the Accordance Principle is so evasive to scientific discovery—because the mere state of entertaining it is already something of an antithesis to that core element of Western philosophy of consciousness where conscious existential movement must be bounded by the domain of tangible, material causation. To this paradigm the Accordance Principle wears the mask almost of a contradiction, because it ascribes some intangible coupling between pre-existing counterfactual occurrence and the metaphysical fingerprint of a conscious observer. If a human is merely a materialist bag of water moving over the Earth, then clearly there exists no such identifying fingerprint, but once the Accordance Principle exists we are forced to reconcile which substrate mediates the reception of a human's metaphysical fingerprint to direction by counterfactual occurrence. In my view, anyway, given the empirical establishment of the Accordance Principle, the decidedly ad hoc attempted ontological explanation is to suppose that a human has a soul directly, and uses this as its sort of antenna for communication with the Accordance Principle. While I am not denying this is true one way or the other, I proposed the Aethic ontology as an ontological resolution which is properly in the tradition of *hypotheses non fingo* [71]: that is, rather than having to "nonlocally" establish a tie between human and counterfactual circumstance, we simply imagine starting a human's consciousness at a sort of "high potential clean slate" position with the Null Aethus, and then simply infer that the "decisions" regarding the Accordance Principle's Aethic attributes had actually to have played out in one's past Aethic time, whenever it was in early infancy that fundamental features of known reality become Aethically accessible. So the premise of such a principle then becomes that the Accordance Principle does not operate retrospectively at the moment anyway, but instead there actually ought to be a genuine period of radically-widespread Aethic superposition content in one's forgotten past where the outcomes of the Accordance Principle concerning which natural historically Aethic attributes occurred relative to one's Aethus actually unfolded dynamically and in real time. If anything, this paints the beginnings of a picture for what the Null Aethus really is, but in doing so presents it as already radically separate from any non-Aethic ontology.

So, this is to say that once we have already established the Accordance Principle, either way between an ad hoc and "attempted-local" explanation we come to terms with an utterly radical reframing of the dynamical substrate in which consciousness exists, together with the sheer scope of possibility-space over which consciousness treads. This reconciliation perhaps retroactively explains why the Accordance Principle, while simple, so resists classical discovery, and proactively motivates a more Aethic style of ontology to the universe. Altogether, however, what is clear is that this entire web of concepts illustrates just how inadequate the tools are of the Western philosophy of consciousness to even begin to contextualize a universe of this sort. The great irony of this is that perhaps the central philosophical move of the East—being to equate consciousness and reality—becomes in this view inevitably observant, and proficient as a means of addressing this very line of reasoning. The problem with Western philosophy then becomes that by insisting on not using the conceptual tools available to Eastern philosophy, the West inadvertently comes to the question without any of the tools needed, altogether resulting in a certain level of ad hoc guesswork underlying any of their theories of consciousness. Altogether, then, the Accordance Principle's ontological upset gestures to us that the conceptual methodology of the East was actually quite well-informed about the nature of reality from the beginning.

If I had to summarize the importance of the Accordance Principle, I would say *as an idea, it's the big one which is supposed to be metaphysically impossible as methodological reach.* It may or may not be smooth, but we can come

13.7.1 Aethic Reasoning in Indian Philosophy

An intriguing comparison to be made is perhaps with the Hindu concept of Sākṣī, which by my reading is described in a very similar same way to how I describe the Aethus, with it *being to the mind as the eye is to the world and the mind is to the eye* [246]. Beautifully put. This, I would argue, is very potentially the analogue in Hinduism to the Aethus itself[292]. Note how it is described as being beyond space and time, which at one point may have been perceived as flat mysticism by the most skeptical among you, but now can be seen as ancestral to the precise scientific claim that I have made in this paper. It is literally so that the Aethus is beyond space and time, because it is a kind of extra-dimension beyond that which they can describe alone, as per the extrusion principle. It is the same as what Einstein did to space when he added time to the picture—now we also add an Aethus, because without such a thing our models lack the degrees of freedom to describe reality, and we arrive at problems like the measurement problem. Once again, Hinduism was ahead of the curve by several thousand years by acknowledging such a phenomenon.

Another major parallel from Hinduism is Brahman, which resonates with me as being analogous to the Aethic tree itself, and through that the Null Aethus, which, remember, is the superposition of the entire Aethic tree into one Aethus. This raises a fundamental question – if we all came from the Null Aethus, (by virtue of reverse-extrapolating our centric unfolding) – then does that imply that there is no distinct *self* in the first place, as the Advaita Vedanta philosophy infers? That is, the argument here might be that in order for the Ātman, or Aethic consciousness, to exist independently from Brahman, we would have to derive a well-defined system for which we can always state whether a given Aethus is "you" or not. If we cannot derive such a system across all mathematical tools, then it follows that Advaita Vedanta is probably more accurate before Dvaita Vedanta, which instead argues for the difference between ultimate reality and Aethic self.

As for actually trying to categorize Aethae as *myself* versus *not myself* to test this, it is admittedly very difficult. The first sign that it might be impossible is the postulate that both *all my past Aethae are myself* and *all child Aethae to myselfs are also myselfs* are intuitively true, which by the principle of centric unfolding implies that A) the Null Aethus is myself, and thus B) all Aethae are myself. Therefore, if we were going to do this, we would have to make one of these postulates false. Intuitively, it should probably be the second one, which feels like an awfully distant choice to make to my fellow humans, (because among those Aethae would be me if I hadn't sneezed three seconds ago), but nonetheless seems the likelier option given the two. As such, maybe a substitute could be to use Nexae? As in, every Aethus which operates on a Nexus which is not a child Nexus to XYZ is perhaps not *myself*. It feels vaguely more categorical, which is perhaps helpful in a way? Something along those

to accept various Aethic concepts like agreeing superposition on the grounds of amplifying already exotic corners of ontology. The Accordance Principle, though, is not quite like this: it is a direct challenge to the very basics of what we believed constituted impossible methodological scope in a metaphysical context, because it enables us to view the happenings on alternate histories or deep in Earth's own past using nothing but the inference of one's own conscious existence. In a sense it is solidifying a tie which like nothing else in the Aethic program makes materialism indefensible should it be validated, in that like a fractal materialism becomes harder to support the more deeply you parse the ontological implications. If you will, it is a personal recognition with the intimacy of *cogito, ergo sum* rendered into a mode of prediction upon a million miles away.

Note that Aethic perturbation modal operators of the sort described in Section 9.1 are fundamental in Nexic reasoning as well, (however I only stated their definition implicitly until hearing about the modal logic formalization of this long term intuition of mine via Claude Fable on June 12, 2026). That is, a fundamental puzzle in "Old Nexic Reasoning" is that in order to perturb the Aethus defining a natural history at a given event, you have to track back on the physical timeline to when it occurred, and perturb the infinitely-determinate Aethus at that spot. However, the explicit shift of Aethic reasoning to Nexic reasoning, as per what in Nexic reasoning resolves the paradox known as the "radical principle", is that you no longer write the Aethic perturbation to an arbitrary alternate natural history by tweaking at the event in time, but rather you perturb from whichever earlier Aethus to yourself in Aethic time makes the attribute for the event's existence blank. Aethic reasoning enforces that we run the perturbation precisely this way, but such also leaves something as a corollary which at minimum is existentially startling: there existed an arbitrary point in the flow through time of your consciousness, perhaps at infancy or "before", for which its corresponding indexing Aethus establishes as blank (and thereby includes the counterfactuals of) any single event in natural history. Such is a clean way of stating the radical principle once its paradoxical character is removed (ie the premise turns from metaphysically intractable despite being in principle empirically verifiable to simply staggering but fully ontologically explainable).

[292]However, I also want to note that my take on the Aethus is that it is even a layer deeper into metaphysics than one's own *consciousness*. Consciousness itself, then, would be like a coupled sentience that floats on top of the near-infinite stream of information contained within one's Aethus at any given time. The Aethus, as I've mentioned, operates directly in parallel with that precise unalterable being of perception, in that it crunches any analysis directly over that intake from the perception. Just because this procedure is happening doesn't mean that procedure itself is conscious—rather it is deeper and more fundamental into reality, and your own consciousness would merely be a kind of fluctuation of sorts onto that deeper phenomenon. I do think this mirrors the concept of Sākṣī quite nicely, but I also want to be careful about directly translating it to the word "consciousness" and then assuming it mirrors the Aethus still.

lines perhaps?

And to be clear, it's an Aethically invalid workaround to simply suppose that there are different instances of the same Aethus to each person, because that would assume that each instance attaches to an Aethus without being known to that Aethus which Aethus it attaches to, (by virtue of them being the same Aethus, and as such holding no properties of distinction between them). As such, we leave out a superposition where there should be one, which would violate the second postulate and trigger an invalid Aethus. This all being said, it seems as though the Advaita Vedanta mindset has the upper hand, truth be told.

Another striking parallel that ought to be pointed out between Aethic reasoning and Indian philosophy is the concept of Jñāna itself. As mentioned many times earlier in the paper, such as with the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, the Aethus-reality dualism principle, or the distinction between Aethic knowledge and Platonic knowledge, it is highly important to understand that the central ontological element of Aethic knowledge is that it abides at the depth of sentience rather than of belief, as this is what allows it to reflect sensory experience, (so as to accurately tailor the realization of the second postulate of the Aethus to one's reality), all while not being susceptible to arbitrary reformulation at the whim of conscious intervention, (with knowledge of that more Platonic sort instead corresponding to Vijñāna). I should also note that my own intuition for the ontology of Aethic knowledge holds striking parallels with how Jñāna interplays with the soul in Jainism. Specifically, the premise in Aethic metaphysics is that tracing one's Aethae back in Aethic time far enough will lead to the Null Aethus, which represents a state of effectively divine sentience, in that it is quite literally the superposition of all possible Aethae. The concept of gaining knowledge in Aethic reasoning then contrasts this universal sentience, which may be seen as analogous to the premise in Jainism of how knowledge reshapes one's own believed perception of their soul. At a functional level, at any moment a human could experience consciousness rather more like they did at the time of the Null Aethus, however we never seem to attempt the right forms of meditation to do so, (that is unless one has discovered a form of enlightenment, or perhaps is otherwise under the influence of psychedelics—presuming there is indeed merit behind the conclusion of induced universal consciousness). Furthermore, the inseparable tie between sentience (Darśana) and Aethic knowledge[293] (Jñāna)—which becomes so intimate that even attempting to conceptualize it is like trying to hit a target the size of a pinhead, (especially considering how it operates in the rather uncharted waters between feeling and reasoning, and for that matter may very well be tangled up with the inconclusivity surrounding the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae)—seems to parallel their status as the fundamental aspects of the soul in Jainism. [247].

Furthermore still, I just want to mention the striking parallel between the Aethus-reality dualism principle of Aethic reasoning, and the premise of Sāṃkhya dualism[294] [248]. Even beyond the mathematical structure of the Aethus, something I want to record here is that I've come to a deep metaphysical intuition about the universe during my meditative and reasoning activities over the course of 2022 and 2023, and it is astonishing to me how close the Sāṃkhya premise of mind-matter dualism aligns with this intuition[295]. It is like seeing a powerful intuition I've come to reflected back at me, just from however many thousands of years ago. It really leaves me with a sense of awe to even just consider all of the interconnectedness between humanity and the uncharted metaphysics, to the point where it's not so uncharted after all: humans have been picking up on its signals since the dawn of history. I don't know what to say other than that this intuition feels to have been revealed to me during my journey with describing epistemology outside of the Platonic paradigm. I arrived at the conclusions I arrived at in utter isolation, and for no other reason than that it felt right: it called out to me, so to speak. And, now with time I have learned that entire structures of thought have been built around these exact same sensations and feeling about the underlying nature of the universe. It's

[293]With this tie specifically being a reference to the concepts surrounding the biological realization of the Aethus-reality dualism principle.

[294]While the classical Sāṃkhya system metaphorically genders consciousness (Puruṣa) and materiality (Prakṛti), my engagement here is limited to its ontological insight into a fundamental duality between awareness and phenomena, without reference to the symbolic gendering embedded in its traditional form.

[295]Where I also want to note that Cartesian substance dualism doesn't do any justice to this intuition, which speaks of something far far deeper and more profound. If you even read back to my explanations of that in this paper—what you really get is this idea that the very prospect of raising an Aethus out of sensations, (such as the example of danger, or the like), leaves this mark of information that is just deep enough to not be manipulatable by Western styles of knowledge, and in the process reflects in one's own reality as all the Aethically-mediated consequences like superposition and the works. This subtle point of contact, which is both deeply metaphysical and at once not describable with anything I've met in the West outside of my own intuitions, is exactly that which I see reflected back at me in the premise of Sāṃkhya dualism [248].

beautiful, if not ironically lonely at once.

13.7.2 Aethic Reasoning in Taoism

Another incredible wave of Aethic insights can be found in Taoism. For instance, consider the following quote from Lao Tzu.

> "The Tao that can be told is not the eternal Tao; the name that can be named is not the eternal name. The nameless is the origin of Heaven and Earth; the named is the mother of all things." [249]

In this quote, Lao Tzu talks about how the core premise of the ontological Tao is that it cannot even be described or captured with organized thought without falling short of its fundamental essence[296]. Such a thing has some immediate parallels in Aethic reasoning, being both the premise of the second postulate of the Aethus in which so much as viewing an attribute through states versus not causes a change to the underlying superposition, and further being the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae in general, for which the premise of capturing an entire ontological Aethus is fleetingly impossible the harder one tries. This shows us that yet again, Taoism has been well aware of Aethic concepts for thousands of years. Or, perhaps the Aethic rendition of these concepts is merely an attempt to replicate this Taoist statement in a mathematical language, rather than the other way around.

It should also be noted that this quote clearly makes a statement of the Tao in some way being ancestral to everything in the modern world, which can be seen as a parallel of the Aethic concept of all Aethae descending from the Null Aethus. In that sense, then, the Tao and the Null Aethus may be viewed as fundamentally synonymous. On that note, here is another quote from Lao Tzu which this time deals with the concept of the paradoxical vitality to be found in emptiness.

> "Thirty spokes share the wheel's hub; it is the center hole that makes it useful... Therefore, benefit comes from what is there; usefulness comes from what is not there." [249]

This is a metaphor for how emptiness, or *wú*, actually turns out to represent a source for the vitality in one's being. Such is paradoxical in Western philosophy, but in Aethic reasoning it is perhaps the root of the entire premise: for something to be truly blank in an Aethus implies not that it is void of essence, but rather that it is enriched with essence[297]. That comes from the second postulate of the Aethus already, but beyond even this we get the clear assessment from Aethic reasoning that emptiness is the fundamental source to reality on account of all Aethae having come from emptier Aethae throughout the running of centric unfolding.

Another excellent Taoist representation of emptiness comes from a quote by Wang Bi.

> "The subtlety of the Tao is that it allows itself to be all things while being nothing. It has no form, no image, and no quality that one can grasp." [250]

As is quite consistent with the second postulate of the Aethus, we get from this the clear message that it is the very formlessness of the Tao which implies it is to represent all things. Such a depiction again characterizes the Tao as being akin to the Null Aethus, and also perhaps Aethic superpositions at large. It is perhaps obvious at this point that there is a firm agreement between how Taoism sees the world and how Aethic reasoning aspires to see the world.

Lastly, let us look to a quote from Cheng Xuanying which combines both concepts of Taoism and the Madhyamaka tradition of Buddhism.

> "Emptiness (kōng) does not mean nothingness but rather the interdependence of all things. It is through understanding both being and non-being that one realizes the Way." [251]

[296] I would argue that, in this way, the Taoist perspective on ontology is essentially antithetical to the Cartesian perspective, in which ontology is not only describe, but describable in partitions. Even when I gaze over the modern paradigm of physics do I see the Cartesian perspective winning out over the Taoist perspective on almost every front, so perhaps a summary for my goal is to bring some kind of counterbalance to that perspective in the form of my ideas.

[297] In order to make sure I give proper credit, please note that it was my professor Dr. Fokoué who mentioned the "enrichment from blankness" paradigm of Taoism to me, directly following my original explanation to him about the second postulate of the Aethus. So, in that respect, I had recognized the interplay of Aethic reasoning, (in the sense of the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae, and the Null Aethus), with the Taoist formlessness concept independently, and also I had recognized the central interplay between the Null Aethus, (ie superposition of all Aethae), and the concept of Brahman as a rather more central unspoken intuition. But regarding this enrichment of blankness, although I of course intuited it within my inductive derivation of Aethic reasoning, I did not actually discover its relationship with Taoism on my own—that I learned from Dr. Fokoué!

Such is perhaps a direct acknowledgment of the premise of the second postulate of the Aethus under some interpretations. Even if it does not have the Aethic structure to back up such a statement, it is still rather remarkable how this quote directly states that emptiness is not nothingness at all, but rather the combination of anything and everything. What we see is that while it took the West all the way until the discovery of quantum empiricism to induce such concepts via this paper, we have that the East had already accessed them thousands of years prior through meditation, observation, and genuine awareness of how the world actually operates. If that is not an inspirational story, then I am not quite sure what is.

13.7.3 Derivational Context for Aethic Reasoning and Non-Western Metaphysics

I definitely want to also take a moment right now to write down my thoughts on how much Aethic reasoning has accomplished already in terms of bringing scientific rigor to Eastern metaphysical concepts, as well as what is still left to analyze. Put simply, I want to elaborate that perhaps the gold standard for scientific acceptance of an ontology is that it can be written in a language of *hypotheses non fingo* [71] inductive reasoning. This is what allows for the move to experimental testing, of course, but in and of itself it is also the ideal package for credibility outright. For instance, one of the major issues I see right now in the attempts to bring scientific awareness to major non-classical metaphysical circumstances like extrasensory perception, broadly speaking, is that these attempts are primarily phrased in standard psychological trial format [252], which is not quite proactive enough to gain a consistent foothold in establishing the phenomena[298] to the degree of creating a new paradigm outright. The best case scenario is that there exists a Bell's theorem-like underlying causality to be had, and so such surface-level correlations haven't a chance of tapping into this any more than the GHZ theorem could be established by randomly selecting variables as opposed to giving it the targeted treatment pioneered by Bell himself. If this non-classical metaphysical phenomenon is legitimate, then I suspect that such a higher-order inequality would be waiting for us somewhere, but we would have less chance of getting to it with our current experimental model than we would have to establish general relativity prior to Newtonian physics, (because we would not know enough about where the specific caveats and nuances lie in order to sort through them).

These are all reasons why I think that the first stage for bringing scientific rigor to concepts in Hinduism like mind-matter dualism has to consist with the language of *hypotheses non fingo* inductive reasoning, as mentioned, if only because this is the time-tested proper format for establishing an ontology rigorously in the first place. For example, consider the work of Newton. If he or others had simply declared without context that the moon pulls on the tides with a hidden metaphysical force, and even experimentally proved its relevance within a tiny margin of error, and still the very premise of this *ad hoc* metaphysical force would be met with immense and justified criticism, the simple reason being that there is no contextual support whatsoever to argue for this isolated conclusion as opposed to a myriad of others. Accordingly, then, we have that only by establishing the full paradigm of Newtonian gravity, with all applications and all inductive sources being intact, is Newton able to create an objectively justifiable argument for why this deeper metaphysics ought to be validated. The key, then, is that only by establishing a paradigm which forces the conclusions to the standards of *hypotheses non fingo* may an ontology have the merits to sway the arbitrary bystander. That is, if I were a scientific critic myself, I certainly would not believe the revelations of someone on metaphysical truths if they lacked inductive backing, with the simple reason being that such a general mode of judgment on my part would not allow me to settle into a consistent ontological view. What would I do if another person came along ten minutes later with a bolder and yet equally unjustified claim? Would I now revert to their views having only waited ten minutes? It is not hard to see that the scientific establishment would crumble rather quickly if this mode of reasoning were passable, and so perhaps the simple reason why the inductive backing I speak of is objectively mandatory is because it allows

[298]To be abundantly clear, I share the same view of consciousness as those who are part of the general non-materialist consciousness movement [252, 253], according to which view materialism and physicalism ought not to be the final metaphysical answer, so I am ideologically in great respect of their work and for that matter pioneering courage in challenging the current metaphysical paradigm. In highlighting the differences in my view on how to establish non-materialist ontology to a level of scientific rigor, then, I am not advocating that my work ought to overwrite theirs, but rather that I hope my work fills a needed niche in the rigorous establishment of their new paradigm, so as to reinforce rather than overwrite their studies accordingly. That is, I seek to provide the canvas upon which their art can be expressed, which is helpful in that presenting such a new canvas in the first place helps us move to the next step beyond simply stating that the preexisting canvas-paradigm is insufficient. They are arguing that a shift needs to be made from the materialist stage of metaphysics, and I am attempting to provide the mathematical grounding of the stage which ought to replace it. So I hope that my work and theirs can be seen as complementary accordingly.

scientists to avoid contradicting themselves, which it goes without saying is hugely important for all of science to maintain its forward momentum.

So, this all being said, one of my major unspoken goals with Aethic reasoning was to express the Vedic-styled ancient wisdom on metaphysics which I intuitively feel as profound in the rigorous language of *hypotheses non fingo* inductive reasoning, simply because we would be asking too much of the scientific establishment by introducing the concepts in any other way. Strictly speaking, the way in which I understand Aethic reasoning to accomplish this is by establishing its inductive bedrock through quantum and classical empiricism, (such as the quantum observer effect, existence of quantum coherence, block universe false dichotomy, etcetera), and then moving to deduce the Aethic concept of relativist superpositions accordingly, (exactly analogously to how Newton did not state the force on the tides in isolation, but instead simply implied it as one of many gravitational consequences). More specifically speaking, if there is a single aspect of Aethic reasoning which I understand to most outwardly counter classical materialism, I would take it to be the ability for two neighboring agents in a single physical space to practically correspond to two entirely separate patchworks of superposition content in their surround block universes, (such as with the earlier thought experiment in which the young Emily and her father hold practically distinct surrounding superposition contents in the house next door, through the simple reason that they are viewing the universe through subtly different Aethae while at once being in each other's physical company). Should Aethic reasoning be verified, I view this particular consequence as perhaps the best case scenario for how to establish scientific rigor for the concept that consciousness operates on a deeper layer than the physical world, (as is central to many Eastern metaphysical philosophies already). Simply put, we would have two observers whose metaphysical degrees of freedom are measurably greater in extent than their physical degrees of freedom, and so that is perhaps the ideal means of countering classical materialism using this *hypotheses non fingo* inductive reasoning that I advocate for, (with this exercise of relativist superposition content being the particular Aethic medium with which to achieve this).

Working this Aethic result into how the West might now re-envision Eastern metaphysics, I have a few initial thoughts. For one, I personally see this Aethic validation, broadly speaking, as a demonstration of how two different agents are able to see the universe through two different "lenses", with lenses here meaning Aethae. The next major milestone question to answer, in my mind, is then the question of "who is looking through these lenses?" By the estimation of Hinduism, it seems that the answer would have to be that a single consciousness[299] is viewing through each and every lens, such that our perceived differences in mind sprout directly from our looking through different Aethus lenses. This also highlights the fundamental Eastern concept that the lens itself may very well be a construct, which we could see beyond with so much as a thought, but simply never choose to do so for whatever reason. Death, then, from this initial approach, would itself be the act of realizing with certainty that the lens never existed in the first place, and being able to engage beyond that picture accordingly. Now I don't want to say more on the topic of death[300] for now, for the simple reason that

[299]This single consciousness would be Brahman itself, that is if we can even name it without collapsing the superposition which generates it, (i.e. while it is somewhat speculative, I think a potentially intriguing thought to be had is that perhaps the inner workings of Brahman, should it exist, are actually dependent in some way or another on agreeing superpositions relative to the physical world, such that naïvely labeling it effectively violates the third postulate. It is of course anyone's guess at this point how well Aethic effects behave on an ontological layer perhaps even deeper than those Aethic effects! (That is where the Aethus is the lens, and Brahman is deeper than the lens, although I highly doubt that non-Aethic classical effects should hold anywhere near as well as Aethic effects when describing Brahman anyway, for obvious reasons). Perhaps this is why the Tao [249] itself cannot be conceptualized or rationalized, to some extent or another, but for that matter the explanation could also be as simple as beginning and ending the fundamental theorem of empirical Aethae).

[300]Against my better judgment, maybe I will lay my current intuition on you of what death really is Aethically, (such that at this point this is far closer to raw unfiltered intuitive speculation than anything formal or complete, so for goodness sake please take this with a grain of salt!). Simply put, the general idea is that *death is the mind's way of moving backwards in Aethic time.* Backwards, at least, in the sense of net displacement, since god knows what happens in the middle, (pun not intended!). Now obviously if this is a serious phenomenon to be considered, then I'll tell you right now that we don't want to establish the tie this prematurely, so as to literally just claim that life and death are reflections in Aethic time or something direct like that. Instead it would have to be something deeper, albeit very clean and simple, which just so happens to more chaotically speaking "open the door to backwards Aethic time traversal" or at least probabilistically enable it to a sense of non-negligence, (as sort of follows from the intuition that dying gives you added flexibility or something, with newfound access to that whole "lost multiverse" concept being one of them).

One framing statement governs everything below, and I want it structural rather than buried, because the reading it blocks is the one this material will otherwise attract. **Nothing here argues that veridical near-death perception occurs.** The question is strictly conditional—*if* any such report were veridical rather than reconstructed from ordinary sources, what would this framework have to say about its structure?—and the conditional is doing real load-bearing work, since the coupling mechanism below fires only on the assumption that the attestation is Aethic in character to begin with. A reader who takes the entire class to be conventionally explicable therefore loses nothing anywhere else in this

I have not yet gained enough of a foothold on the empiricism to pull off *hypotheses non fingo* inductive reasoning again, so I will save any assurances for until I can comfortably avoid presenting armchair philosophy to you.

All things being said, having studied a little bit more on the metaphysical nuances of Aethic reasoning and Eastern metaphysics since writing my earlier section on the topic, my current leaning is to suppose that perhaps the Null Aethus is not directly the representative of Brahman in the full extent, (since after all under my most recent categorization idea the Aethus is a lens and Brahman is more like the viewer behind that lens), but may all while may be a key derivational agent toward our better understanding of it, and for that matter probably does have a great deal of isomorphic overlapping

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manuscript, since nothing anywhere else depends on this footnote. I am also not in a position to argue the antecedent: I have not gained enough of a foothold on the empiricism to run *hypotheses non fingo* inductive reasoning here the way I do elsewhere, and I would rather label the gap than paper over it.

As for the empiricism the intuition came from, it is the veridical-perception class of near-death reports, and the specimen I will work through is the familiar Maria case—used as an illustration of the case *type*, not as evidence. "At one point in this experience, she found herself outside the hospital and spotted a single tennis shoe sitting on the ledge of the north side of the third floor of the building. Maria not only was able to indicate the whereabouts of this oddly situated object, but was able to provide precise details concerning its appearance, such as that its little toe was worn and one of its laces was stuck underneath its heel" [254]. Her social care worker, Clark, then went into the building and found the shoe where Maria said, matching the description. Before I build anything on it, the specimen's own evidential standing should be stated rather than left for a reader to discover: this particular case is disputed. Ebbern, Mulligan and Beyerstein placed a shoe at the described location and reported it readily identifiable from ground level and visible from inside the building, and were unable to locate Maria or any source besides Clark [255]; Clark Sharp has replied, disputing the reconstruction and noting, among other details, that Maria's English was far too limited to have assembled the account from overheard conversation [256]. I take no position on that dispute, and nothing below turns on this case being the genuine article—it is a worked example of a *structure*, chosen for familiarity, and any case of the type would serve equally.

Here is the interpretation. Two Aethic time progressions run in parallel, as per the first postulate: Maria's and Clark's. From Maria's side, on the premise that death allows more flexibility in Aethic time motion—more specifically, access to the "lost multiverse"—her progression is capable of jumping back in Aethic time, so that inhabiting the Aethae of her own future self and returning is no longer an immediate Aethic contradiction. (The contradiction, under usual circumstances, arises because living future Aethae prior to past Aethae is mathematically infeasible if and only if one's own Aethic time coordinate must be monotonically increasing with respect to consciously-felt elapsed Aethic time. That monotonicity is not a postulate, and the distinction matters enough to state rather than assume: it is the *first axiom of centric unfolding*, (Principle 4.2), which I set down there as a convention—the framework's current outer ontological boundary, explicitly shakier ground than any postulate, and explicitly furnished with a named class of alternatives under the heading of *extra-centric unfolding*. What follows is therefore not the suspension of load-bearing structure but an instance of exactly the slot that principle reserves, and it should be specified as such: I am relaxing centric unfolding's *first* axiom, that every past Aethus inhabited serves as a parent to the current one, while retaining its *second* in full, that a newly added attribute is drawn from its standing superposition at random—which is why the random-draw language throughout what follows remains centric unfolding's own. The postulates, the weight structure, and the probability ontology are untouched, by the insulation deliberately built into that principle: weights are static and intrinsic to the Aethus while centric unfolding only passively accesses them, precisely so that the traversal rule may be tweaked in a theoretical descendant without the probabilities moving with it.)

One motivation for the relaxation is available that is better than "dying gives you added flexibility," and I state it because it comes from the framework rather than from intuition. The counterfactual semantics already constructs, and evaluates at, information states which are *not ancestors* of the evaluator—the subjunctive's reopened books can pair entries whose acquisition order the evaluator's own history reverses, an information state never actually occupied—and the license there is that Aethae are objects rather than visits: a genealogy is one path through a space that exists unwalked. Extra-centric unfolding of the kind proposed here is that same license read *occupationally* instead of evaluatively. Whether occupation can follow evaluation through that door is exactly what I cannot argue, and is the whole of what stays speculative Accordingly, during the near-death event Maria is able to experience a random handful of attributes from her own child Aethae in the future, producing a scattering of "versions of Maria" depending on what she catches—a non-monotonic variation of centric unfolding. In one version she has a conversation with Clark and the shoe never comes up; in another they discuss it but with Aethically contradictory properties; and so on across the Aethic tree, a separate Aethus and Aethic copy of Maria for each possible relay. Importantly, the mere fact that Clark actually sees the shoe in one scenario is sufficient to supply Maria with its stated-attributes by future informational exchange between them, so whether Maria personally sees it is immaterial—the real question is whether she has any tie whatsoever to eventually learning those attributes, and if so they become candidates for relay, weighted by their superposition Aethic weights to her.

Now switch to Clark, or to any Aethus down the chain learning the story—including yours, since I have just passed the information to you and thereby closed the implicative circuit, so "Clark" here means any such verifying Aethus. Aethic block universes may only interact where no contradictory information stands between them. Given the scattering cloud of versions of Maria, Clark meets and talks to a random one, weighted by her own Aethic weights per centric unfolding—and crucially, the version her Aethus picks must consist with her own knowledge of the shoe. All versions of Maria whose report conflicts with Clark's Aethus become invalid when intersected with it, so Clark effectively closes the loop by being Aethically compelled to meet the version whose report matches. More technically: should Maria *not* describe the shoe Clark will possibly go up and discover, that Aethus is invalidated directly by the third postulate, since on the assumption that Maria gathered the attribute by the non-monotonic effect, Clark could at any point go up into the building and Aethically contradict a should-be-certain attribute—forming an Aethic contradiction in every Aethus where Clark checks a different shoe. So the version of Maria that Clark meets is compelled to be exactly the one that

due to it being the superposition of all Aethae and everything. Such a distinction does request of us to figure out the difference between the superpositional-structural implications of the Null Aethus onto the physical world, (which is very much like Brahman for one structural connotation), versus the more basic consciousness-concerning connotation of Brahman itself, (but in doing so definitely not lose sight of second postulate constraints out of naïvety). But even in putting it that way, I hear myself sounding like I'm losing steam, (i.e. I'm used to breezing right by these sorts of rigid philosophical dichotomies just on intuition, hence why I got past the philosophical standstill for the measurement problem), so in the very least I should pipe down a little bit on the topic until I can build a stronger intuition! Will keep you posted, I suppose!

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fails to open the ability for Clark to contradict her, again assuming a genuine source for the attribute. That is the proposed Aethic account.

To be clear about what it is not: there is no objective reality in which the shoe has the characteristics Maria describes and Clark later confirms. This is the same reduced form coupling seen in the delayed-choice experiment [10]. To Clark's initial Aethus, prior to learning any of these events, both the attribute of Maria's particular attestation and the particularities of the shoe stand in complete Aethic disagreeing superposition; the Aethic arithmetic of Clark's reduced form compels the two attributes to be coupled, so as not to violate the third postulate, so long as Maria's attestation is Aethic in character—as opposed to a mental, non-Aethically-informed report as in the non-extraordinary cases, which is the overwhelming majority and possibly all of them. It therefore does not matter whether Clark goes to the site first or hears the attestation first: the coupling is absolute while the particular random result may be gathered in either temporal order, exactly as in delayed choice. As for the "closing of the loop," Clark plays a surprisingly active rather than passive role: because there is no objective character to the shoe beyond the random set of versions coupled to Clark's Aethae, it is Clark's eventual verification which constrains the particularities of the version of Maria she meets. Strictly relative to Clark's Aethus after hearing the attestation, it is Clark's own future light-cone verification that serves as the channel through which Maria gained the information—had Clark never checked, that channel would have been severed and Maria would have had no occasion to raise it, selecting something else instead. The implication, then, is that the subject's access point is not outside the bounds of space and time but is quite literally captured in the view of the verifying agent later on: as if Maria's knowledge came from "viewing it through Clark's own eyes" in her Aethic future, in the sense of Aethic informational exchange rather than mental vision, (an important caveat, due to the Aethic truth–mental knowledge distinction). The full loop: Clark views something in the future light cone, confirms it with Maria and thereby passes the channel to her, and that is the Aethic-future point from which Maria randomly grabbed the information during the prior event, relaying it back to Clark. The third postulate demands the verification coupling, and with that the loop is closed.

There is a structural consequence worth naming, and then a concession about it. Notice the sentiment from the double-slit experiment that the universe "appears to conspire against our learning what happens at the slits," due to the back-screen pattern changing when a detector is introduced. The same apparent conspiring is present here: since the information Maria attains must, relative to Clark's Aethus, be provided by Clark's own verification, the verification step cannot be separated from the rest of the events for experimental probing. We never get the control case in which the described object is withdrawn, because the verifying step itself shapes the initial conditions—our knowledge of the object immediately enters it into the system, so we cannot at once know about it and control the circumstances of its introduction. Now the concession, which I would rather make than leave for a reader to find: the parallel is *structural*, not evidential. In the double-slit case there is an independent handle—detector on versus detector off, two patterns, compared—so the conspiracy is itself measurable. Here no analogous control exists, by exactly the argument just given, and I therefore do not claim the parallel as support for the account. It is a shared logical shape, and shared shapes are cheap.

The falsifier I would previously have offered—find a sure case where accurate information is reported without ever being verified—self-destructs, and the self-destruction is the point: by knowing the information was accurate, one has verified it, so the experimental substance collapses. A sharper target may be available, and I offer it as a target rather than a result. Because the coupling *compels* the match rather than merely making it likely, the account predicts that a genuinely Aethic attestation should be exactly right on the coupled attribute or else not coupled at all, whereas conventional acquisition—inference, overhearing, prior familiarity with the environment—should produce *graded* accuracy, right in some particulars and wrong in others. The distribution of accuracy across the reported corpus is therefore checkable in principle without ever needing the unobtainable unverified-accurate case: pervasive partial accuracy would sit badly with the coupling account, while all-or-nothing accuracy would be its signature. I have not run that check, and I note that a determined defender could always assign the wrong particulars to conventional origin and the right ones to the coupling, which is exactly the sort of escape hatch that would need closing before the test meant anything.

Finally, the obvious rebuttal: is Clark's reduced form pruning of possible future Aethae not circular, if the Aethus in the moment passes that pruning information to the future Aethae *and* depends on the future Aethae for what was pruned? The resolution comes from the extrusion principle itself: *the future event of Clark's verifying the shoe is a proper-time future relative to the block universe event of Clark meeting with Maria, and relative to Clark's Aethus during that meeting.* It is the disagreeing superposition of possible verification events, in the proper-time future of that prior Aethus and block universe, which is being selectively pruned by that prior Aethus's reduced form. Relative to Clark's Aethus even before meeting Maria, the pruning has "already" taken place in the Aethic sense, such that the disagreeing superposition of different things Maria relays and Clark sees has been pruned precisely enough that they must agree—any event failing to do so is checkmated under the third postulate, since Clark could always make a further move uncovering the discrepancy. Clark then meets Maria, or alternatively checks the building first, (which is what happens in other reported cases); once she gains either the attestation *or* the verification, she centric unfolds to an Aethus in which that particular state of the disagreeing superposition has been randomly selected. The paradox dissolves because we never assumed the "future" is monolithic: the pruning operates relative to Clark's prior Aethus over the disagreeing superposition in the proper-time future of her own block universe, and it is only deductively passive and peripheral that Clark comes to occupy a future Aethus consisting with one of those states. This is precisely similar to

13.8 The Aethic Mindset and Autistic Savants

This is slightly beyond the scope of the mathematical-centricity of this paper, but it is nonetheless philosophically relevant enough to attain just a brief mentioning. Consider the dichotomy of the classical objectivist and deterministic mindset of reality, (as is based upon the postulates of complete reality and static observation), and consider the query of whether or not humans are born with an innate tendency to favor the classical mindset, or if, rather, we are taught to do so in infancy by our society.

An excellent way to test various solutions to this using the merit of the scientific method would be to identify a possible control group of people who are not influenced by society in this way. Specifically, let us suppose that people with a highly developed theory of mind [257] are proportionally[301] likely to hold societal bias due to the relationship between such a theory of mind and their intake of knowledge from a societal standpoint. As such, those people who have a less-developed theory of mind are consequently open to two further general possibilities. Either, A) they are an unbiased control group that may be used to examine a human's innate perceptions of the Aethic mindset, or B) they themselves tend to favor or disfavor the Aethic mindset more-so than a general human at birth does innately, (or would do in the absence of the same societal influence). In a sense, this gives us two "variables" of sorts to determine—that which is representative of the Aethic mindset of a sample, and that which is representative of the innate Aethic mindset of a human. Such nuance may be sorted out with the use of a few, cleverly selected sample groups.

Here are four such possible groups we could compare and contrast to yield maximal differentiation.

1. Allistic adults in a Western society.
2. Autistic[302] adults in a Western society of various subcategories[303].
3. Infant children younger than two years of age.
4. People of an indigenous or otherwise non-Western society.

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the observer-consistency derivation from the third postulate—by the indiscriminate time principle it does not matter whether we look at Alice's Aethus before, during, or after the proper time between her measurement and her comparison with Bob; in every case the pruning operates over disagreeing superpositions anywhere in the proper-time past, present, or future. What the pruning looks like, visually, is faulty events falling out of the block universe from within their surrounding clouds of disagreeing superposition; an agent such as Clark or Alice merely specifies their Aethus further as information avails itself, which is not an active process on the initial pruning but a personal update felt once they become locked off from the alternatives via the ladder ontology. (And one adjacency deserves a sentence, since a reader may suspect the relaxation costs more than it does: what the argument against the deflationary reparse requires is the permanence of the prior Aethus *as an evaluation index*, not a prohibition on any observer re-occupying it. Relaxing centric unfolding's first axiom therefore leaves that closure untouched, and leaves the extrusion principle's own content untouched with it—the prior state's standing as something counterfactuals are still evaluated against is simply not what the relaxation disturbs. What stays speculative is accordingly not the *license*, which the convention already grants by its own terms, but the *antecedent*: that death in particular is an occasion of extra-centric unfolding. That I cannot argue, which is why this entire footnote is filed as intuition rather than result.)

[301] Of course probably not numerically proportionally—in this context the word is meant to be more qualitative.

[302] Regarding another point of interest for future studies—I am actually somewhat hesitant to claim that I was the very first human to solve the measurement problem on one specific ground—the population of autistic savants on Earth. We know that Aethic reasoning is deeply fundamental to reality, and we know that autistic savants are both deep thinkers and comparatively immune to societal biases with respect with an average allistic person. As such, the parallel seems too apparent to miss—with the question being whether any autistic savants have already solved the measurement problem ages ago—and yet never conveyed this knowledge to neurotypicals for one reason or another, (perhaps due to a corresponding lack of a standard theory of mind). It seems very plausible, even, to imagine a scenario where a Level 3 autistic person naturally thinks in Aethic reasoning, and yet is merely diagnosed as lacking a theory of mind by a psychologist. Given that allistic people have yet to traverse a measurement problem solution, it is very plausible that there is a psychological phenomenon where a theory of mind and a generative intuition for Aethic reasoning conflict, so this all being said, it is an intriguing if not ironic situation that those who have been diagnosed with a "disorder" may have been more insightful on the topic than the psychologists diagnosing them.

[303] We say subcategories here, because it seems quite likely that two random autistic people tend to be as different from one another as they are from allistic people. As such, we picture something of a tree of many different brain types, with allistic people occupying one branch, and autistic people being "every other branch." It is analogous to humans being one single twig on the tree of life, but having nonetheless diagnosed some perceived mutually exclusivity to the human-animal-dichotomy. The allistic mind would be the highly specialized one in this case, with the supposed autistic mind simply being its set complement of sorts. Somewhat ironically, when allistic psychologists try to chart everything that autistic people *are not*, what they really tend to be doing is inadvertently charting everything allistic people *are*. The majority of the diagnosis stands in the backtracking from the allistic branch on the tree, considering how autism itself spans every other branch anyway. (This becomes somewhat evident when we consider just how highly specific allistic intuitions are in the neural network sense—such that if an intelligent alien came to Earth, the likelihood that we would diagnose them as allistic is minute).

This all being said, there is a case to be made that many subcategories of autistic savants have a natural inclination to thinking Aethically. As such, this begs the question—is this due to them remaining at a younger-type brain state that is universal to all human infants [257]—or is it so that they instead branch off into an alternative method of thought that is itself distinct from the mindset of infancy? Only time will tell these answers. But, if autistic people do share any mental proclivities with infants[304], there is quite an argument to be made that perhaps humans do thinking Aethically in the natural sense, and that millennia of civilization have simply distanced us from this innate thought process so as to keep society functioning thus far. Perhaps the Aethic mindset would have been selectively non-beneficial to the optimal functionality of society in the past—however there is quite an argument to be made that this same tendency need not stand for the future, and if anything is perhaps due to invert.

13.8.1 Illustrating the Bias of Perspective in Diagnosing Logic

Consider two premises of mine[305], which I will use to construct an argument for why what we socially tend to diagnose as logical versus nuanced is a bit biased.

1. A better model for understanding autistic minds than the autistic-allistic binary is more of a tree model, such that allistic people are one branch alone and the rest have been all categorized as "autistic". Inadvertently speaking, then, this proposes that an autism diagnosis is not actually diagnosing a person's traits to the level of specificity of an allistic person (as would assign them a particular branch) but instead broadly classifies them as "non-allistic" for their lacking allistic traits. In reality, though, each branch comes with a different set of cognitive intuitions, which are separate enough so that two autistic people drawn from two different branches tend to be as different from one another at the cognitive level as either of them are from allistic people.

   This is meant to be directly analogous to the post-Darwinian tree of life model treating humans as a branch, as opposed to the pre-Darwinian model in which humans and animals are two categories.

2. Speaking more about topics of study now, suppose Bob is on branch B and is learning the very most introductory layers of information of a topic which is typically more tailored to the intuitive capacity of branch A, containing Alice. By far the most common reaction is for Bob to do two things: first, he interprets the learned material from the topic itself as "logically oriented", and second he oftentimes will assume the entire topic itself shares this character monolithically[306]

[304] Note that we are not asserting that autistic people are immature—that would be highly offensive to say. Instead, we are simply regarding the aspect of the theory of mind, and wondering whether the theory of mind model is an ancestor-descendant model between autism and allism, or instead a divergence model with age.

[305] I specifically came up with the idea of this reframe at 2:39 PM ET on June 8, 2024, which is when I recorded a short video on my phone which discusses it.

[306] The explicit problem with infantilizing autistic people is that it assumes their being infantile in one category extends to all other categories. What's fundamentally wrong about this is that it fundamentally misunderstands what's actually going on: what's going on is utter, complete symmetry between cognitive branches. That is, for allistic people versus a given branch of autistic people, there will be roughly half-and-half instances across traits for which the autistic person is infantile versus for which the allistic person is infantile. Using myself as an example, at age twenty I still had the emotional maturity of a thirteen year old, but at age thirteen I already had the mathematical maturity of at least a twenty year old. Had my branch been the reference instead, allistic people would look just as profoundly infantile in so many different ways to how I looked in social, emotional, and life skills. In middle school, if you read my notes on mathematics and philosophy you see that I was already devising and rediscoring incredibly deep principles, and for crying out loud in second grade I comprehended the Ancient Greek argument against free will per the determinate causal chain on one hearing from one scene of an adult-targeted documentary. I also immediately captured and extrapolated to-comprehension the concept of object oriented design from the first PowerPoint slide of the first lecture of a weeklong unit from sophomore year of high school—the rest of the week was me sitting bored while things I already inferred were stated in detail for the class. This also shows an interesting further translation disconnect between branches: my allistic peers in high school simply concluded that I was "smart" because I pulled off things they could not. However, the truth is that what was actually going on was not what is classically "smart": I never perceived my peers as dumb—dumb is the inability to follow an argument due to perceived slipperiness—what I perceived my peers as is infantile. (And several of my high school peers even came forward to me saying that I was the only "smart" person they had ever seen who judged the "dumb" kids in the class no differently than the "smart" kids—hence independently supporting my thesis that "smart" is not actually what I was, categorically). This is also where categorizing all the non-allistic branches as one "autism" is measurably problematic: you can find an autistic branch for which any trait is infantile, thereby seeming to confirm your prior that "look, autistic people are infantile in this way". Running the same logic on a random partition where we put half the branches, including the allistic one, in one category while the rest are placed in the other, and we could just as easily misinterpret allistic people as infantile in any conceivable way by finding it in another branch of the categorization and then mistakenly importing it to an assessment of allistic people.

(The formalization that follows is retrospective and AI-mediated; the observation above is the author's first leg.)

The observation, now, is in how mathematics itself, especially in an educational setting, is commonly called “logical" in the sense of there only being right and wrong answers, whereas the humanities are instead called “nuanced" in the sense that they resist binary “rightness" of answers. What I want to point out now is that this take itself is actually biased to the allistic perspective, which has some intriguing philosophical implications once we start to unpack it. First of all, notice how due to the second bullet point, it is actually universal that anyone learning the most introductory material to a topic of a different intuitive landscape will report the same characterization. In order for a child to learn literature, they must first start by learning the alphabet and the sounds they make. In this sense, like twelfth grade math, kindergarten literature has clear rules—either the letter is written this way or it is not, and either the letter makes this sound or it does not. The fact that kindergarten literature is at an isomorphic introductory level as twelfth grade mathematics is then simply an illustration of how the general population—most of them being of the allistic cognitive branch—hold a vastly higher intuitive capacity for literature over mathematics. So in this sense comparing twelfth grade mathematics to twelfth grade literature is the wrong reference class, hence contributing to this bias of perspective that literature is inherently more nuanced than math[307].

Formally, the tree model makes the fallacy exact, and it is an instance of a pattern this paper has already named. Let branches b range over the cognitive tree and traits τ over a trait inventory, with $I(b, \tau)$ reading “τ presents as infantile on b relative to a chosen reference branch”—the reference-relativity being the crux rather than a modeling convenience, since I has no branch-invariant extension at all. What observation supplies, once a reference is fixed, is $\forall\tau\,\exists b\; I(b, \tau)$: for each trait, some branch on which it so presents. The category-level conclusion—“the autistic are infantile,” quantified over the whole non-reference side at once—requires $\exists b\,\forall\tau$-shaped traffic across the very index that varies: the quantifier-shift fallacy of elementary logic [119], and structurally the same exchange the flank-importing fallacy commits across Aethae, (Section 9.7.6), (the witness b here playing the role the witnessing Aethus plays there—fixed per demonstration, silently promoted to universal). The random-partition control is then the proof that nothing about autism was ever being tracked: the same inference succeeds verbatim under an arbitrary re-partition of the branches, so its confirmations are a function of the partition chosen rather than of any property of the partitioned—the reference-class problem [258] in categorical clothing. And the symmetry claim above is the formal residue: with I defined relative to a reference branch, re-choosing the reference permutes the verdicts wholesale, leaving no branch-invariant sense in which any side is *the* infantile one—what the assessment measures, exactly and only, is the assessor’s coordinates.

[307] I think one of the important things this relativeness casts light on is the deviation between the “intrinsic advancedness” of a concept and the “perceived advancedness” of that same topic. Of course, pure relativism does not permit any sort of inherent objectivity to a topic anyway, so I use the term more as a heuristic of “should we use the scale of one field, even if monotonic what function rates the scale of another field on the aforementioned scale”. As for the “perspective” underlying the scale we use, in my mind this is able to fall back on some semblance of objectivity in terms of sheer inferential fruitfulness in the sense of characterizing a breakthrough which propagates more insights.

Now, this all being said, my proposal is effectively that philosophy as a discipline has an abnormally high ratio of perceived advancedness to intrinsic advancedness as compared to the hard sciences. Physics, on the other hand, has the lowest. In general the tendency is for more human nuance-inviting disciplines—as you move in the direction of physics through biology through sociology and finally philosophy—to hold higher such ratios with this progression, thereby putting biology probably near-to the logarithmic middle in its ratio value. The reason I would propose philosophy has such a high ratio in this regard is that we are perpetually stuck in a paradigm of terminology and concepts where trivial statements are arbitrarily hard to even state, and wherever unifications lie they are not recognized. Ironically enough, I would place us at a similar category of impasse in philosophy in such regard to where we currently are at the frontier of theoretical physics, where you get that sense that the universe has a very “clean partitioning” among the contributions of its geometric or conceptual constituents—yet the actual borders we draw on these concepts intersect them and one another so chaotically, that when we write something down in quantum field theory it is impossible (per this paradigm anyway) to parse how much is ontological signal and how much is the noise of human conventions. The fascinating thing, however, is that this is generally what happens before every scientific breakthrough in history, such as pertaining to the ontologically scrambled state of physics before Newton, or of electromagnetism before Maxwell (although in the Maxwell case it was hardly the more potent, ontological style of scrambling, so perhaps a better example there is thermodynamics pre-Boltzmann). The difference between philosophy and science, then, is that each new revolution in science is low hanging fruit compared to revolutions in philosophy of comparable intrinsic advancedness, because of the discrepancy in their perceived difficulty by means of the perceived advancedness distinction. I would attribute this directly to the added complexity in the unscrambling which has to exist in philosophical counterparts in intrinsic advancedness to scientific revolutions—at least in the scientific case there is an ontological core underlying it, which provides just enough leverage so that a Newton-caliber mind alone can access it. So to be plain about it, the issue appears to be that our own jumble of paradigmatic terms and categories fundamentally stunts our ability to parse any kind of unification, and the difficulty of this compounds with more reliance on humans and less reliance on convention-impartial ontology.

I can also give one example I saw which really illustrated to me how much lower intrinsic advancedness is to perceived advancedness in philosophy. I was reading a summary of Hume’s is–ought problem [259], and I started out by noting, “ah, interesting, but doesn’t this just seem trivial? As in, of course things occur which morally ought not to occur, and yet they do anyway". Of course, this is an oversimplification, because what Hume was actually talking about is how descriptive statements (what is) provide strikingly minimal inference into prescriptive statements (what ought to be) [259]. Upon reading that this is what Hume was actually saying (or itself at least a projection of it, of course), I thought to myself, “oh I see—this is indeed a much more subtle argument", but then from there I wondered “if you could ask an objective measure of revolutionary-fertile profundity where this update ranked on their scale as opposed to what I thought the principle was a few moments ago, then would it really have been pushed much higher at all? Yes, the statement is intriguing, but how do we know that the objective scale does not view this update the same way that an adult from a cognitive branch who did undergrad-level math in kindergarten would view me stumbling along with a

Now to really solidify this point, allow me to direct your attention to how the very descriptions of these topics would change if we, hypothetically speaking, had allowed another perspective to dominate in place of the allistic one, (with symmetry[308] in this sense being the sign of any good universalization). Had the branch of cognition which flips the intuitive capacity for mathematics and literature been writing the linguistic rules, then of course mathematics would be described as highly nuanced and flexible, (as it already is by the world's great mathematicians), and Shakespearean literature would be noted as a rigid system of writing down letters and sounding them out. The irony of the matter is that in order to communicate with allistic people, even autistic people themselves have adopted the allistic-perspective semantics of terms like "logical" when describing a given topic like mathematics. That is, because allistic people refer to mathematics as logical, you might get an autistic person who can multiply eight digit numbers in seconds refer to mathematics as "logical" as well. In reality, though, this is something of a fallacy of the language in the sense that the autistic person is using the word "logical" differently than an allistic person in order to point to the topic itself, because the allistic person refers to their own internal intuitive calibration when choosing what to call logical versus flexible, whereas the autistic person is simply mirroring what the allistic person identifies as logical versus flexible for their own definitions.

In essence, then, this is symbolically almost like a kind of unconscious masking[309], (in the sense of being phenomenologically similar), where the autistic person has to choose between pointing to the right objective topics in conversation and using the descriptive words non-superficially. That is to say, the superficial premise is in how the autistic person's use of the words is inevitably a shallow pattern-matching exercise of defining a word purely on contextually where the allistic person uses it as opposed to actually storing depth in the word. Without using these two premises I have written above, however, I am not even sure how much people know they are doing this—as the example autistic person who can multiple eight digit numbers will clearly be using intuitive nuance but clearly have to use language in a way that calls mathematics "rigid and logical". Potentially they might even

calculus homework problem?" As in, my feeling is that although my perceived advancedness jumped by at least a factor of say four or five for that principle of Hume's, it seems as though an agent with "objective, non-error-prone intelligence" would see the gap as a mere inkling of motion rather than the same kind of leap which my own limited paradigmatic orientation inflates artificially. *That is, to an objective viewer Hume's full argument would be about as much as an "of course" as the original statement was to me, such that what I found more profound about the updated version can be traced solely to my own limitations of paradigmatic or experiential orientation, (most of them probably entirely unknown to humans).* This same agent would rank humanity's current understanding of physics as, by comparison, far more intrinsically advanced, (although admittedly not objectively very advanced at all, in the sense of how Aethic reasoning alone (should it be correct, anyway) seems like—if you knew all the universe—elementary-level at the very highest, which sort of makes our species look like cavemen in the advancedness sense). So if you will, we've been with philosophy stuck dancing at the same intrinsic level where physics was during the pre-enlightenment Aristotelian era—and perhaps it is also somewhat discouraging how Aristotle's views have literally lingered in philosophy to the modern day, while his views and taste in science were shown to be a systematically poor fit to the universe.

[308] For a real-world example also meant to illustrate this symmetry, notice how many autistic people themselves are described as taking a script to allistic conversations. Once again, notice how if the shoe were on the other foot, for any given non-allistic cognition branch allistic people practicing its topics would be interpretable as using a script.

[309] Autistic masking in the conventional sense [260–262] refers primarily to social-behavioral camouflaging—suppressing stims, mimicking neurotypical conversational rhythms, scripting interactions, and so on—with corresponding mental health costs that have been increasingly well-documented in the literature. The linguistic variant I am pointing to here operates a layer deeper: it concerns the autistic person's use of allistic-perspectival vocabulary to describe their own internal cognitive phenomenology, rather than behavioral mimicry of allistic social performance. The natural axis for locating it is [263]'s double empathy problem, and the comparison rewards being drawn in both directions. The convergence: Milton relocates the breakdown from the autistic person to the interface—mutual incomprehension between cognitive branches, not a one-sided deficit—and linguistic masking is that same relocation carried into the vocabulary itself, since the public cognitive lexicon emerged from the dominant branch and is therefore not a neutral medium but a branch-specific dialect that other branches must translate themselves into, often by silently redefining the available terms while preserving their public surface meaning. The contrast: double empathy is stated at the level of interpersonal reading—two people failing to model one another, symmetrically—while linguistic masking names the asymmetric labor the majority-relative environment extracts even with no interlocutor present, the translation performed against the standing lexicon continuously, whether or not anyone is currently misreading you. The cleanest way to see that these are one phenomenon at different depths is the counterfactual inversion: if the world ran mostly on a given autistic cognitive branch, with all the expectations of which that branch is capable, then allistic people would suddenly exhibit autistic burnout themselves [264]—the exhaustion is frame-relative labor, not an intrinsic property of any branch. Double empathy says the misreading is mutual; the inversion says the costs are seat-dependent; linguistic masking says the seat is built into the words. The nearest existing framing otherwise remains the conceptual analysis of [265], who argue that masking is constrained by the narratives available to the autistic person rather than chosen freely—an "illusion of choice" structurally embedded in stigma—of which the linguistic version applies the constraint one further step inward, to the descriptive vocabulary itself. I should also flag that the standard masking instruments, including the CAT-Q [262], are designed to measure behavioral camouflaging and would not register the linguistic variant I am describing; this is part of why the phenomenon, if it exists, has been largely absent from the empirical conversation. A broader framing for treating autism as one configuration among many rather than as a deviation from a norm may be found in [266].

extrapolate the word differently, and perhaps assume it carries a different semantic meaning than an allistic person would describe for it, (as in, if rigid describes mathematical nuance, then perhaps it carries the connotation of the phenomenology of the digit multiplication). So altogether what we are left with is a rapidly cascading mine field of sorts of terms being defined from the allistic perspective, propagating to other cognitive branches, and then being either redefined by extrapolation[310] or left alone as a label without other branches ever being aware of the subtleties behind what was arrived at. But the point of the matter is that none of this depth under the surface[311] comes out in an autism test, which is perhaps part of the problem for why it is still so misunderstood.

Perhaps we might call this *linguistic masking*, to put a name to it.

13.8.2 An Objection to the Theory of Mind Framing of Cognition

Given how I had a difficult time for a while predicting where the boundary of other people's knowledge lies[312] when trying to figure out how to explain Aethic reasoning, I wonder if the reason apes don't

[310] Producing semantic drift the speakers don't notice, that is.

[311] Since writing this concept of semantic masking (which I originally came to conceptually rather than with any specific examples in hand, ironically enough), I have come across one real-world example of it occurring which might be illustratively of use. Specifically, the instance of how mathematician Alexander Grothendieck famously "disliked examples" [267] when explaining or otherwise teaching about highly-abstract mathematical concepts. I would argue that from within Grothendieck's historically rare cognitive branch, there actually are plenty of what, from within, one would classify as semantically consistent with examples. That is, given how we understand Grothendieck to regularly reach depths of abstraction that others cannot even fathom (in the sense of requiring talking about abstractions of abstractions of abstractions, which once you arrive there is perfectly parseable by human reasoning), then it is reasonable to infer that within those depths there exist recognizably-human inferential practices which Grothendieck will have engaged with. For example, perhaps he pictures an order-five abstraction object by looking how three order-four objects fit together in various ways. Each such snapshot is, realistically, "an example" in the sense of showing a facet of a deeper thing in a targeted simplified context, but the key is that only Grothendieck himself would be able to personally recognize it as such in the first place, because nobody else can even get past picturing a single order-three abstraction object in one frame of consciousness. Accordingly, while Grothendieck's true-to-semantics instance of an example matches said semantics equally to an example instance of someone lacking Grothendieck's gift, said people without his gift artificially exclude Grothendieck's version of an example from consideration as an example when they themselves define "example". That is the first part, which brings me to the second part: what locks in this misconception is that everyone lacking Grothendieck's gift themselves systematically definitionally categorize as examples order-two abstraction objects being arranged in view as a visualization aid to a single higher object. Notice how this is conceptually identical to a "Grothendieck version of an example", with the only difference being that it operates over objects requiring less iterations of abstraction to articulate. This, universally speaking, is what those mathematicians outside Grothendieck's cognitive branch refer to as "examples", and THIS category of objects is what Grothendieck is saying he dislikes when he says he "dislikes examples", (presumably because each one is something of an inadvertent corruption of the nuance required to capture Grothendieck's deeper objects—but only in ways visible from Grothendieck's own vantage, hence why others themselves state this principle of his matter-of-factly—that is as more pattern-matching—as opposed to seeing it themselves as an obvious truth and not a mere eccentricity). Now, the key is that this object is what you might call a "normie-valued example" definition, so when Grothendieck uses the word example in his statement of dislike he is referring to this blunt-categorization of instances, but crucially not to its semantic character. If he were referring to the word example by its semantic character as perceived by the normies, then in actuality he would be referring to his separate "Grothendieck-valued example" definition—an object of which I doubt not even a single one has actually been written down by name (because of its status as occupying the base of Grothendieck's own cognitive foundation, such that every structure he names are themselves substantially less abstract projections compared to the subconscious display of things he sees during reasoning proper—which are his Grothendieck-valued examples). So what ends up happening is that by saying he dislikes examples, Grothendieck is assigning his own semantic character to the blunt categorization of instances of normie-valued examples as based on what he sees to consist with them. This, of course, does not match the semantic character assigned to these categorization instances by the normies themselves, because as established if Grothendieck had been using that he would refer to his-valued examples, but he is referring to normie-valued examples and so of course must be assigning them different semantics than that. However, I am not sure Grothendieck is even aware of this difference in definition, because from his perspective his own semantic definition is the one to be advocated for, and besides that even pitching the normie semantic version requires shifting to their perspective—being the very thing which, like apes versus humans, is exceptionally difficult. Now, for the irony bow on top of this: when a biographer or student of Grothendieck describes his sentence of how he dislikes examples, without knowing it they are assuming he is taking about their semantic definition of example, since after all he has adopted their categorization-scheme for the word example as opposed to the one which is true to his personal perspectival rendering of the normie semantic version. The reality, however, is that Grothendieck is left thinking that examples are what he really means to dislike despite actually truly valuing them as a semantic concept, whereas the normies falsely believe Grothendieck is engaging in an eccentricity by targeting the concept of examples, which leads them down pointless paths in trying to explain why. He was never referring to the concept of an example in the first place, only the static list of categorized instances placed by the normie, (which he then unknowingly invented some unknown semantic concept for, but never articulated because he never knew he had to).

[312] Perhaps eerily, I would argue that "predicting what the next big thing, or something otherwise further in the future" is actually a special case of this cross-perspective boundary-prediction difficulty, rather than categorically separate to it. It might feel separate, but that is only a misconception that comes from the future being involved with it, which as a society we instinctively name a new category for when in question. What I specifically mean is notice how if you designed a perfect experiment, sort of in the style of the Turing test [268], where an objective actor is asked to pick out

ask questions [270, 271] is something similar. That is, instead of truly lacking a theory of mind [272] outright, maybe what happens is that they find it very difficult to actually predict the boundaries of what the other person knows in relation to what they know. Also, this itself has a major second-order effect as well: notice how their own understanding of language is taught to them individually by humans, as opposed to a human child who learns language by watching people use it, so basically the apes are dealing with having their informational context of language being funneled into highly specific situations that are genuinely hard to extrapolate from. So just like they don't know the boundaries of the other person's knowledge, they don't know the boundaries of what language is intended for. So as far as they know, their own accessible Aethic information on what language is intended for is, as I mentioned, funneled to them as if they're wearing blinders to the wealth of informational context that contextualizes language for human children. The key then is that an orangutan[313] for example hypothetically could learn to ask a question from within their limited Aethic information, but that would require a level of creativity of a historical order, essentially. With humans ourselves, as far as we know only one time in history did somebody jump to a higher layer of language just by powers of inference, and that was Sequoyah himself when he devised the Cherokee syllabary [269] despite himself being illiterate. So the point I'm trying to make is that an orangutan asking a question given the disadvantaged context they're working with would be as historically anomalous as the jump which Sequoyah achieved with human language.

So, if my instinct about dismissing the importance of the theory of mind[314] is correct, then I ought to reform my prior statement about the role of a theory of mind in autistic savants: instead of it being the theory of mind which conflicts with the ability to attain Aethic reasoning, it is very directly the cultural implications of language itself. In that sense, actually being able to discover Aethic reasoning for me personally may have been something of an optimization event, where I was tapping into the pre-linguistic perception of an autistic savant together with the articulation powers of an allistic human. But yes, the idea remains that these two modes are usually in conflict, as otherwise someone would have discovered and propagated Aethic reasoning ages ago.

13.9 My Personal Reaction to the Aethic Metaphysics

Allow me to briefly talk about how I see Aethic reasoning to upset and or reinforce our metaphysical place in the universe. In my opinion, I see Aethic reasoning as a series of interesting conveniences amidst one speechlessly profound mystery. To be clear, I find all aspects of the framework very exciting,

whether a communication between two people across a paradigm boundary (be it human versus orangutan, or me with Aethic-style physics-versus my readers) and then between a person trying to one-way communicate within the context of the unknown society of a future person, and the objective actor would not on categorical bounds be able to distinguish the two cases—effectively as if each *could* be labeled as the other while remaining consistent. Hence, if you wish to understand what the true probabalistic difficulty is of crossing the orangutan-human boundary, the Aethic-classical boundary, the Sequoyah [269]-linguistic boundary, or whatever else, and want to avoid falling back on approximate heuristics like "chimpanzee on a typewriter, exponential time complexity" or "somewhat like an educated guess", then just ask yourself how difficult it would be to predict the pinpoint nuances of the societal structures at play thirty years from now.

[313] For context, the idea of this cognition reframe came to me while I was watching the video of the orangutan driving a golf cart, funnily enough. Basically the rolling sequence of thoughts that hit me in half a second were (1) *ok this is basically just a human that we don't realize is a human*, (2) *I bet you there's an internal state in there that's almost identical to the one in you or I*, and then the big one, (3) *if you imagined dropping a human being into the shoes of that orangutan—all theory of mind and categorical cognition intact—what would their contextual environment have to look like to reproduce the no-questions behavior of the orangutan?* In other words, it is not "an orangutan is a human" outright, but rather *what does importing human categorical cognition into the orangutan force through about their contextual environment for consistency with their empirical behavior?* Then I reasoned from there that it had to be a prediction-boundary difficulty due to the broader pattern of a vast chasm in their contextual environment compared to what a human has, (similarly to my always having had to guess—and mostly guess wrong before guessing right—about what standard academic performative practice is, unlike somebody going through a normal university pipeline where the context is in their face from the beginning).

In retrospect, it is perhaps interesting how this *localize the flex to the environment* move is exactly what gave rise to Einstein's equivalence principle, which I keep coming back to throughout this paper, (since it is perhaps one of the highest-caliber scientific ideas in known human history, and so is methodologically informative). That is, the question it asks is *what must be said about the structure of space and time at Earth's surface in order to systematically and exhaustively reproduce all empiricism seen by a laboratory accelerating up in the middle of nowhere of outer space?* In that sense, we hold Earth's phenomenological setting constant, we import the accelerating-up-empiricism while keeping it fixed, and then allow the question of Earth's structural-contextual environment to vary for consistency. The result is that spacetime must be curved here, even though we have no coordinate acceleration ourselves as does the accelerating-up-laboratory.

[314] As in, perhaps apes after all do not lack a theory of mind in the first place, so therefore if it is not something which is lacked then it as an independent well-defined and extractable thing is itself a construct.

so I am not trying to call them unimportant or bland. But in the purely existential sense, this one profound aspect outshines them like how the sun outshines a group fireflies. This aspect, you see, is the second postulate of the Aethus. To be clear, I maintain that aspects like the extrusion principle are more procedurally important as tools with which to break from past paradigms, but once we've developed something like the extrusion principle, it's sort of just a shrug and an acceptance. The second postulate, however, is very different from this. The second postulate is rather more akin to Newton finding in the calculations that there is a hidden force of gravity unifying all things. It's not about looking back at your misinterpretations like the extrusion principle does. Instead, it's rather more like first meeting the most infinitely present player for the rest of your future. Something that is both universal and conceptually simple, but at once fleeting and mysterious to existential proportions. Even in our day and age, what really *is* gravity? So far we've boiled it down to curvature ontology and the Einstein field equations, which is amazing, but below that everything starts to get blurry[315] again due to our axioms having already been planted.

Turning to the second postulate of the Aethus, now, let me explain why it seems comparably sublime to my eye. To start with, it is sort of like accidentally finding a single artifact from a civilization thousands of years your technological superior, and really having no idea on how to place it since it is so far out of the context of everything you've ever seen. With Newton, this artifact was gravity, and so classical mechanics was the most minimalist framework which could describe, but in retrospect hardly capture it[316]. In the case of Aethic reasoning, then, we get a similar circumstance, except where this time the second postulate is the analogous artifact which the framework seeks to supply with a minimalist description. In that respect, then, I would probably bet for rather than against the possibility of Aethic reasoning eventually finding an analogous "Einsteinian revolution", where furthered empiricism and some inductive reasoning eventually helps to deepen the pursuit of the questions which at present I can only patch up with axioms.

So, right, now onto the sublime nature of the second postulate directly. Simply put, in a metaphysical sense what this postulate tells you is that you constantly find yourself immersed in the maximally abundant superposition content of the outside universe which is compatible with your Aethus. The whole reason you need to attach an Aethus to a human in the first place, in the analytical sense, is so you can define what the ever living heck it is that's the locus of this radiance of superpositions in the first place. So, in short, simply because you have the ability to encode and transfer information as a being, suddenly you find yourself in this bath of superposition content, all perfectly tailored to represent with ontology that which you cannot currently trace. Due to the necessity for it to be the case so long as the framework remains non-arbitrary, the second postulate is as decidedly absolute as it is unwavering[317]. It simply *is* that throwing together the macromolecules and forming a human fields a constant dance, (just like the field equations), between the world of physical actions and the world of metaphysical superposition propagation. This is the bridge at which those two worlds cross over, and I really don't know *why* this is any more than you do. But hopefully I'm capturing why this is astounding to me: it is because you not only get this domain of superpositions kicked up about every consciousness[318], but they are so perfectly reflective of that one consciousness, and so in the very same physical room will be different when simply changing perspective to another consciousness. And, remember, each individual consciousness in this picture roots to a physical body, and so somehow the concerns of molecules are cumulatively coupled to an Aethus and to these superpositions, like a spark operating over the medium of abstract conscious informational exchange. So altogether there is just this overwhelming and perfectly personalized ocean of superpositions, which exists for who knows what reason. We just know it has to exist because of the induction of Aethic reasoning, which first was made available to us by the quantum empiricism itself, and has to be in effect in order to unify that with classical metaphysics. So, how far we will take our knowledge of these superpositions, who knows, and what will have been the cause, who knows, but at present we in the least can somewhat vividly describe them in the language of the Aethic mathematical logic. And, that is all for the meantime.

All things considered, then, I think the second postulate of the Aethus is very possibly the single most elegant concept I will have ever devised, (if it is indeed accurate to the universe, of course). It is shockingly simple in form, and yet is allowed to be that simple and not contradict classical probability

[315]Ie the next round of bluebirds comes from the question of *why* energy and curvature are locked in such a dance to begin with.

[316]To be clear, he knew this better than anyone, which is why he coined the phrase *hypotheses non fingo* [71].

[317]That is, at least in the scenario in which all bases have been covered for Aethic reasoning in the empirical and experimental senses. So this claiming of the "absolute" nature of the second postulate is a reference to what would be in effect in that scenario.

[318]And whatever else holds the capacity to form an Aethus.

thanks to the Aethic union principle and the third postulate of the Aethus. But yes, while a few of the mathematical aspects of Aethic reasoning certainly look more complicated to the eye, I think if we had a radiation detector for metaphysics, and held it up to each Aethic concept, it would light up the very fiercest at the second postulate.

13.10 Order of Events Toward Deriving Aethic Reasoning

I want to very quickly throw in something of a bonus section of sorts to this paper, where I can briefly chronicle the order of events with which I derived Aethic reasoning in full, as well as when such things happened[319].

1. First, interestingly enough, was none other than the Accordance Principle from Nexic reasoning. Both my memories and even my records of this at the time are admittedly a bit blurry, but my first direct written acknowledgment of the Accordance Principle, that I know of, comes from a Google Doc written on June 9, 2020, (in which I outline an unmade YouTube video script for how to visually interpret the weighted timelines toward human existence probability). It goes without saying that this was the bridge, or perhaps first-order spark if, you will toward my full system of ideas, such that maybe the second-order spark, which officially branched Aethic reasoning off of of Nexic reasoning, came later with the extrusion principle. But yes, apparently the chicken does come before the egg, because Nexic reasoning fully predates Aethic reasoning in having been established. I indeed think this is no accident, because it seems that having worked my mind to think in Nexic reasoning was just that perfect storm which allowed me to catch the basic seed of Aethic reasoning, in the defining instant when the extrusion principle hit me.

   I should also mention for clarity that the first written acknowledgment of mine that both the dinosaur origination and extinction are requisites for human existence—as opposed to only the latter alone—comes from a Google Doc[320] I wrote on July 24, 2018, at 7:55 PM, which I then retrospectively wrote about in my notes over the next two years as the defining moment when I first wrote down the idea. This if course is precisely the context that led to the two-node circumstance pertaining to the Accordance Principle, so it is more likely than not that I had intuited the connection by that moment. I should note however that due to the incompleteness of my memory of the time, whether or not I truly had the mature Accordance Principle in that moment is probably somewhere in between either extreme of pure ignorance and a mature understanding. What I do know fairly certainly is that my cognition for formal theoretical reasoning at fourteen[321] was vastly immature compared to where it was even by sixteen (which was the date of the definitive 2020 entry), so if anything my mindset in 2018 was more of a media-inspired "categorization for how feasible a fictional worldbuilding natural environment is for human evolution, with the implication of rarity of the right conditions[322]" as opposed to a formal abstract apparatus of reasoning. However this came together with the mediocrity principle of the Doomsday Argument [273] was the real melting pot of the Accordance Principle, although in fairness the beginnings of this were already present then[323].

[319] I might also add a quick more general statement of how learning about our historical predecessors influenced me:

Growing up, my two biggest inspirations were probably Newton and Einstein. Newton, because having learned the nature of his work at a young age, I realized that inductive reasoning is the closest thing we have to magic: in a matter of seconds it can turn the single most antirealist sentiment on the planet into boring clarity. Einstein, because he taught me that everything in the universe is fundamentally organized in relativism, and that it is not to be avoided but to be expected that a deeper physical paradigm will dismiss at least one key common sensical idea about the universe.

(And note, to be clear, the magic of inductive reasoning I mean is less the discovery process itself and more the sheer capacity to explanatorily build a worldview from nothing in the blink of an eye. Newton's work embodies this with the cannonball thought experiment itself, which has an ability to reveal profound, intuitive truth in seconds. To this day it gives me chills, because it is something like the greatest single masterpiece in the history of thought experiments—the kind of thing that can serve as the very model of what conceptual physical science is aiming for when done right).

[320] The title of the document was "*Things That had to go Perfectly Right for our Particular Civilization to Develop*", as hints at the Rare Earth-angle of specifying it in the first place.

[321] For context, I was born in October of 2003, which is why I was fourteen in the summer of 2018.

[322] So in that sense, I genuinely had already intuitively independently discovered the Rare Earth hypothesis [106], (without having heard of it until a few months after I had completed the groundwork for Nexic reasoning in 2021), which is perhaps something anyway.

[323] That is, since I believe I had already come across the Doomsday Argument [273] online by then, (likely in 2017). I should also note though that the timescales between consecutive insights for me in 2018 was on the order of over six months, whereas in 2022 it was on the order of days, so that itself is strong retrospective evidence for the theoretical immaturity I remember having phenomenologically.

2. It is worth mentioning, however, that it is more accurately the duo of the Accordance Principle and the Aethic reversal principle which allowed Nexic reasoning to occur in my mind in the first place. Indeed, during the stretch of a couple of years in which I engaged primarily with Nexic reasoning, what I know call the 'Aethic reversal principle' was the driving engine to the metaphysics in a similar way to how the extrusion principle became the driving metaphysical engine of the mature Aethic reasoning. Accordingly, we might even go so far as to call the Aethic reversal principle the signifier of 'Old Aethic Reasoning', whereas the extrusion principle might signify 'New Aethic Reasoning', (so as to play off of the Old and New Kingdoms of Egypt, anyway). The Old Aethic Reasoning then would have been entirely sufficient to drive the metaphysical analysis of Nexic reasoning, however it lacked the extrusion principle, and therefore could not have said anything about superpositions. So, most accurately speaking, the first shift in my outlook happened over the two years in which I targeted Nexic ideas using the Aethic reversal principle, whereas the second shift occurred when I managed to express the superpositions in terms of the existing Aethic framework by means of the extrusion principle.

   Regarding the actual chronology of things with the Aethic reversal principle, then, interestingly enough I actually forgot about its existence entirely for a little while after I wrote the original Accordance Principle documentation on June 9 of 2020. Specifically, I was reading back to that Google Doc, but I had this inexplicable confusion about me while I was reading the pitch. '*What is the pitch anyway?*' I remember thinking—that is, I not only failed to interpret the meaning of the explanation, but also whether it was saying anything at all. What I know now, is that in that moment I had subconsciously reverted back to the pre-reversal principle mindset, even though I had clearly been at a reversal principle-oriented mindset while writing the document in the first place. That is, the Accordance Principle only works, as a concept, (and in relation to the classic dinosaurian example), if one concludes that a human can still be a human at all if dinosaurs had not existed. The pre-reversal principle alternative would to suppose that humans, as a class, require a perfectly matching set of all surrounding properties in order to remain at the same class. As such, under such a mindset we have that so much as tweaking which species did or did not exist in history would cause us to lack Leibnitz equality with ourselves accordingly. In effect, the distinction between the pre and post reversal principle mindset comes down merely to ontologically suggesting that all information versus a subset of information is required to properly define an ontology. Somewhat miraculously, then, a few months after even that, I read back to the document again having once more subconsciously reverted back to the reversal principle mindset, (and of course I never went back from there). Such was sufficient both for me to identify the correct interpretation, as well as where I had gone wrong in my prior reinterpretation—so the added benefit was that I then had a conscious understanding of the reversal principle. Had this second reversion not occurred, and it does not take much analysis to realize that my life would have likely played out very differently from there. Or is such sufficient to characterize the trajectory of my life at all—that is in lieu of further cumulative information? Maybe life is ironic after all.

3. After the Accordance Principle[324] and reversal principle, the next important step I made was to

[324]Something interesting I want to mention about my derivation is how if you call an argument already implicitly respecting tense-free blankness "Aethic invariant" and one enforcing classical moving present-determinacy as "Aethic variant", being the Aethic analogue of general covariance versus coordinate-dependence, respectively, then what's particularly fascinating is that analogously to Maxwell's equations also respecting special relativity unknowingly, Bayesian reasoning itself is fully Aethic invariant by means of its principle of not privileging the temporally "earlier" event while inverting the conditionals! Hence, funnily enough because in 2020 I first constructed the accordance principle over classical determinately-complete realities (explicitly as a structural extension of the same nonclassical metaphysical aesthetic I saw in the Doomsday argument itself—which note I only saw in the Vsauce video on the topic, and so like the later double-slit experiment video had the freedom to formalize myself due to only seeing the pop culture version originally) and had not yet heard of Bayesian reasoning, the simply Bayesian form of the accordance principle is already the complete Aethic invariant form by means of introducing the concept of conditioning on human existence itself, whereas my original form was precisely the Aethic variant classical counterpart by means of not even imagining being able to condition on humans, the later event in time. Accordingly, in not being able to conceptualize conditioning on later events yet per my classical paradigm blindness of the time, I formalized change with what I called "Golden probability", which is essentially an attempt to filter out the parts of the standard classical moving present probability which do not explicitly lead to the outcome of human existence—hence meaning that I had to reproduce the human conditioning not by doing so explicitly but by mapping where this process "lands" in its total timeline-outcome and comparing the proposition of complete determinate reality timeliness housing humans versus those which do not. Then the idea was to drop us in a random instance of the human-compatible ones proper. Hence, altogether weirdly enough by devising Aethic reasoning as a deeper abstraction on Nexic reasoning I actually traced exactly the parallel route which runs from the Aethic variant accordance principle to the proper Bayesian, Aethic invariant form, just in the medium of the ontology

define the Aethic mathematical structure that we know and love today. Intriguingly, I have the date and time of the moment at which I conceived the mathematical structure of the Aethus, because I logged the idea down in my personal math journal just after devising it, (at least to the conscious layer of understanding). Such a moment was on December 7, 2021, at 6:36 PM. To begin with, yes this is indeed quite a while after devising the Accordance Principle, and this is only so because I was busy at work formulating Nexic reasoning throughout the intermediate time. In fact, the only reason I devised the Aethic structure in the first place, (which I originally termed an 'Attribute Set[325]'), was to create a mathematical structure that

rather than that particular instance. So by the time I reached Aethic reasoning proper, it deduced as the proper form of the accordance principle exactly that which is already the Bayesian form of it, as opposed to my having simply rewrote the principle in Bayesian form from the beginning. That is, I started out stuck with the classically-reduced form of Bayesian reasoning, was stuck with that paradigm, and then wound up finally reproducing Bayesian reasoning proper by switching my root ontology to Aethic reasoning as opposed to just looking up Bayes' theorem in a textbook.

Another thing worth mentioning is how the Nexic Open Cosmos concept itself was a crucially important intermediate abstraction between the accordance-over-infinite-cosmos idea and the mature Aethic reasoning per the extrusion principle. That is, once I had developed the Attribute Set concept in 2021, my visualization was that there is not only the infinite concept itself, but also the Aethus counterfactual structure carried by each individual location therein, (which albeit despite being valued in Aethae already was still very much the pre-extrusion concept of forward-directed timeline branching counterfactual structure as opposed to "Aethae in the room" structure). So, the move of abstraction was to consider not only that the accordance principle was equivalently derivable by the infinite cosmos side and the Aethus-counterfactual side, but that both are actually ontologically indistinguishable to begin with: that is, in the sense that for any subset description of a part of the cosmos, you can transform to another subset description either by means of perturbing the Aethus or by searching for the new description in the infinite cosmos. As in, with the classic example being Earth versus Proxima Centauri b, the idea is that to replace "here" from Earth to Proxima Centauri b, you can either perturb the Aethus describing our planet to precisely reproduce that of Proxima Centauri b, *or* we can physically move our so to speak "cursor" through physical space so as to seek out Proxima Centauri b directly. The idea then is that any movement you can make with one mode is reproducible with the other, so ultimately we ought to picture the single abstract Aethus counterfactual structure as the root of everything, such that the physical infinite cosmos itself is almost like an arbitrary rendition or coordinate system on stuff, all while being only subservient to the actual abstraction. While not yet the extrusion principle, I think this ultimately wound up being its central prerequisite.

[325]Just so there is no confusion, I would like to quickly outline the exact style of my original intuition about the Aethus structure in 2021. There is one object I've encountered, actually, that is far and away the closest intuition to this, and so I will use that to aid the explanation: simply put, this object is the state, as a type, resulting from the state augmentation of a multi-order stochastic process into a Markov chain. This is directly why I assumed that the structure must be commonplace in abstract mathematics, because once you have a little bit of abstraction to deal with, it almost feels maximally trivial. Specifically, as we know from state augmentation of a stochastic process, the idea is to compact the entire necessary history of states in the process into a single object, that way you can have a proper Markov chain for future reference, (ie each state is sufficient to produce the exact probability distribution for the next state). This is already an abstract leap, however I felt while independently developing it that so far this still falls slightly short of self-contained abstraction: that is, I wanted a type which not only is constructed by composing the uniquely necessary states in the stochastic process, but is also decomposable back into either those states, or any alternative partition. The key of also allowing any partition is simply because the formation of the object by composition of states is a function, but strictly not injective—that is in the sense that we can perform compositions over compositions and arrive at the same result as doing the whole composition in one go, (so long as we use the same net total of state material). So the idea is that the total state object is effectively from a class which is formed by composition, and able to be decomposed into any possible partition from which it could have been composed. Then all we have to do is assert uniqueness over these objects, (ie equivalence if they compose and decompose equivalently), and we have the class of such objects itself. This was my original object which I called an "Attribute Set", intuitively even if without the formal means of describing it. However, given the formality I have now, here are the three parts of the definition.

(a) An intrinsic ability to be constructed from given stochastic states.

(b) An intrinsic ability to be decomposed back into exclusively any element from the set of sets of states which generate it.

(c) A property of uniqueness, (that is such that Attribute Sets with the same compositions and decompositions are equivalent).

So, all things considered, the extra layer of abstraction is effectively to promote all such objects themselves to a unique type, called an Attribute Set, (being the proto-Aethus type, prior to also including the second postulate and further ontological scaffolding for superposition handling). We then define an accompanying Markov chain sub-type as Markov chains which operate only over Attribute Sets, which naturally is capable of encoding all possible Markov chains, but of course with that extra kick of abstraction, and in my mind, structural elegance, (because of the strict structure by Attribute Sets, which in my mind tidies up some of the "arbitrariness" in standard set theory). Most interesting of all about this, retrospectively speaking, is that I did this without ever having heard of Markov chains, state augmentation, equivalence classes, or abstract algebra. I was only a junior in high school with a high school understanding of mathematical formalism, just plus a healthy innate understanding of mathematical structure, (which I extrapolated in large part from high school set theory itself). Even as I entered college afterwards, effectively all of the structures in Aethic reasoning, from equivalence classes to rings to DAGs were completely independent inventions of mine in the language of intense synesthetic intuition. To be clear on that, only in 2024 did I go on the hunt for existing named structures and associate them all with the structures I had developed independently for Aethic reasoning in

was capable of describing the nuances between alternate histories[326]. This is where the epistemic component to the reversal principle[327] came in in full force as well, because I noted at some point around then that leaving irrelevant attributes out of the Attribute Set actually turned out to be beneficial to the mathematical analysis of the Accordance Principle rather than destructive to it.

To be clear, moreover, even though the mathematical intuition for the Aethic structure has not changed between now and then, the way in which I represented it very much has. Such may even be the single most frustrating aspect of my journey in Aethic reasoning, at least regarding the communicatory facet, because from that very first moment I had this abundantly rich structure for declaring and relating attributes, and yet I could not come up with the notation to portray it with. Importantly, this was never really a mathematical shortcoming in the first place—rather it was purely a psychological one. I understood fully well how to manipulate and imply Aethic statements from one another, but I was lost about the nuances of how somebody who had never seen this structure before would react to it. Worse yet, as I was only a junior in high school, I did not know anybody who was knowledgeable enough about discrete mathematics to understand my thoughts—and even if I did it would be a longshot to find the right notation and explanation with which to convey it. It would indeed be another three years, until September of 2024, until I conveyed the Aethic structure to a single other person, (being my professor Dr. Fokoué[328] at

2023. So funnily enough, I may well have accidentally invented a large part of elementary-level abstract math, albeit independently rather than originally of course! (Since they're all really just sitting there, right inside the door, regardless of the false presupposition of "invention" of course). (And also, to be clear, not that this makes me Galois or anything, because cataloguing "elemental modes of abstraction" is one thing, doing something interesting with them is another). But yeah, I believe that is also the culprit for why I could not explain any of this prior to 2024: I simply didn't have the vocabulary to capture the windstorm of intuition going through me!

[326]Sometime in 2021 or 2022, pre-college, I was lying in my bed, staring out the window just next to me on the wall, imagining sand falling into an hourglass, layer by layer in different colors, to try and force myself to identify how I was viewing time the wrong way. I was already internally pursuing a correction to the ontology of time, since the results of Nexic reasoning kept coming up as showing time as incompatible with Aethus-valued calculations, and I suspected that something about the very visual of the sand flowing in the hourglass was misleading in some subtle way, because it seems to tempt you to think it is the complete picture, which is the whole problem. I even imagined about what would happen if I spontaneously saw time the right way—*would it be a Star Trek warp drive-discovery moment where suddenly headlights click on outside my window???* Of course I didn't exactly expect that in particular would happen, (unless we're in a simulation or something), but then again I couldn't rule it out either, since seeing time clearly was so unprecedented, so it was quite an unmapped metaphysical game with rules that haven't been conveyed to me anyway!

Funnily enough by the way, I write some of my footnotes spontaneously while walking, and this one is a good example—written on my phone while trailing my family on the streets of Inverness, August 25, 2026. Also it's only the first time I've left the USA, even though I've been eager to travel for a while now, so quite a magical trip overall, especially in Edinburgh!

[327]My original motivation for the reversal principle in its fully-realized Aethic ontological setting was me going "I can't currently deduce every base pair in my own DNA sequence, so it's genuinely in disagreeing superposition—which interestingly reframes the time travel paradox idea that going back in time far enough would reroll it and therefore me by instead saying that even now it hasn't yet been 'initially rolled' to begin with relative to my current Aethus, and so the invariant is the phenotypes of myself that I'm aware of while the genotypes and how they work up to that remain in disagreeing superposition for now" and which now I would clarify also is "we still have invariants that the parts of my DNA do the same thing as in other humans, so it's in this reduced form coupling structure that we have the invariant of 'Human DNA encodes particularly humans'" but even without an objective reality DNA sequence.

[328]I might also mention that in recent years, (specifically soon after devising Aethic reasoning), I have also found a great deal of similarity in my story and that of Évariste Galois. Among the similarities are the fact that we both, as teenagers, came up with a new abstract mathematical intuition, only to get rejected for review by the major gatekeepers of the time. In the case of Galois, as we know, the rejection came from Siméon Poisson due to his work supposedly being "incomprehensible" [274], and in my case I got a rejection from arXiv on May 25, 2023 after having tried to submit Aethic reasoning. I suspect that both cases stem from the same frustrating issue: due to the isolated nature of my derivation, as I have mentioned, I effectively had no grasp on the psychological nuances required to explain Aethic reasoning to a person without first being able to engage with their communicatory reactions. As such, all the mathematical intuition and deduction in the world counts for nothing if you don't have a handle on the psychology required to paint the picture in a way that is familiar to the receiver's current worldview, all complexities considered. However, as soon as I had explained it to Dr. Fokoué in September 2024, I almost immediately caught onto the psychological intuitions for that leg of the abstract math, and was able to translate the framework in full after a few more sessions over the following months, (and ever since, it only takes me one lecture, and the reactions on the audience's faces, to figure out exactly where the translation needs to be made to a given abstract idea, as after all teaching to somebody is far more psychologically informative than teaching to nobody). And so, the frustrating thing is that I spent years in the purgatory of being just one conversation short of being able to express the whole framework in paper-form. Such propagated the vicious cycle of not having the academic affiliation to be taken seriously by arXiv, together with the inability of a way to gain that prestige due to not having the academic affiliation required for a single hearing, (so as to translate the idea). What changed with Dr. Fokoué was but one thing: kindness and open-mindedness. My idea might have been broad, and unusual, but he was willing and even excited to hear it anyway. That is, it took him no time at all to realize I was an artist, and thereby stood out from the crowd. Any other professor, meanwhile, simply stated that my thoughts were too far outside of their specialty. "Go talk to the probability mathematicians", said the discrete mathematicians. "Go talk to the discrete mathematicians", said the probability mathematicians. Hence, I became increasingly worried that maybe I

college), and of course by that point it had been over a year since I had fully derived Aethic reasoning. Regarding the specifics of how I would convey the intuition in the intermediate time, I would often refer to the recursive property of Aethae, (then Attribute Sets), with which adding attributes to one as a full Aethus is equivalent to adding them all individually—thereby inferring equivalence between the structure of the full Aethus and the compilation of the attributes themselves. That way, we are able to 'compact' the nuances distinguishing them into a single mathematical object. Of course, to the onlooker this sounds something like gibberish, and that was perhaps the curse of knowing how intriguing this mathematical object was all while being unable to convey it properly. Maybe I am less Ajax and more Cassandra, all things considered!

I should also mention that I was fairly convinced during this time, (that is, in 2021 and 2022), that the Aethic structure had already been discovered before me, and I was simply reusing it for my purposes. Indeed, I had been independently discovering foundational mathematical theorems and lemmas by the dozen since before kindergarten[329], (I did a tentative count of them when I

was living a curse or something. That is until I met Dr. Fokoué, of course, and for that reason I credit him for showing me the compassion that got me out of that particularly dark time.

Moving back to my felt comradery with Galois, furthermore, I also ought to mention a striking parallel I observed in our procedural instincts upon having learned more about Galois theory itself. That is, I find it striking and perhaps even sentimental that Galois and I, in theory-building, have the same signature move: find the space of invisible structures to the tangible eye, and enrich it. Such is a fitting similarity, all things considered. Altogether, when my 21st birthday came around, I remember feeling that sentimental feeling quite strongly: I was given a chance at a life Galois never had, almost as if to answer the question, "what might he have done next?" Of course, this is a rather optimistic parallel to take all things considered, since I can only hope that my work will bear even a fraction of the fruit that his did.

I might also add a clarification on what specifically went wrong with my explanatory style leading up to the particular meeting with Dr. Fokoué: because I am so far outside of the system, what ends up happening is that every time I try to explain something completely new to somebody, I am consistently surprised by which things they find easy and which things they find difficult. So, perhaps my explanation might have assumed foundational familiarity with a handful of features which they find anywhere from moderately to impossibly difficult, thereby stalling the explanation right there. For example, in the Autumn of 2023 I tried to explain the Haṭeg island hypothesis to some of my undergrad friends, and in the moment at least I think they actually found me to be some kind of insane, since I was reeling out concepts which from their perspective were random and completely unrelated. This was a common issue I had at the time, and even with Dr. Fokoué it took me several conversations with him until that miracle conversation happened in September. In the prior months, I had been attempting to find an explanatory in into either Aethic or Nexic reasoning using trial and error, but every time I ran into the same issue of mistakenly assuming familiarity with at least one novel concept. After all, I had gotten so deep into the weeds with these frameworks, that it was almost like I was living on a different planet at that point, where the intellectual language is no longer mutually intelligible with human-speak. What happened on that day in September, then, is that I way trying to explain the Aethic structure to Dr. Fokoué in terms of a list of stated-attributes, but then in that moment I spontaneously thought of the n-Aethus explanatory approach that ended up making it into the paper, which effectively is just a particularly clever way of breaking the definitional hierarchy into bite-sized pieces. From the moment that I got that through to him, he was deeply fascinated, and two hours went by like seconds as I scribbled progressively more advanced Aethic reasoning up on the whiteboard in his office. As far as I remember, I explained the second postulate of the Aethus, the ontology of probability, a little bit of the extrusion principle, and a few exercises in how the Aethic structure can be tailored to arbitrary systems, making clarifications along the way. He said that meeting felt almost like a spiritual experience due to the magnitude of the unveiling and such. I of course completely agree, because without that moment Aethic reasoning and I would be in a world of hurt, so the ripple effects alone are hard to fathom. Anyways, so after that I next tried to figure out how to make the Aethic dichotomy theorem intuitive for him, but it again took me about a week, specifically because I ended up figuring out that his vision for the graphical inheritance of Aethic blanks was a little different than mine. So that's why I ended up mainstreaming the vocabulary of blanks, and dropped some more confusing vocabulary defining internal versus external attributes, (replacing it with the term "mixed-decomposable" instead). I didn't end up going over the Aethic union principle with him in quite enough detail, I found out a few months later, because as I was giving a lecture to those same undergrad friends from earlier I realized I had to improvise the chart with the arrows from physical and logical ands versus ors in order to make the concepts intuitive. Starting with my first meeting with Dr. Fokoué, and again at that moment, I would simply progressively go back through this long Aethus paper and correct the relevant sections for the sake of easier intuitions. Hence, even though I had started this paper in January of 2024, its earlier versions had all the same intuitive mis-translation artifacts that I have since moved to weed out to the best of my ability.

[329]Of course, the ones at that young an age were not going to be quite as complex—but still I was already instinctively forming mathematical structures. The classic example, perhaps, is that where in kindergarten I imagined addition as preparing and projecting a number forward by some number of spaces on the number line, (with $2 + 3 = 5$, for example, preparing to move forward from 2 by 3, and then running the command with the equal sign—as mirrors the functionality of a calculator device), I then dreamt up an alternative where we change not the operation, (as in establishing subtraction—which for context I was yet to learn existed, hence maybe playing into my lifelong pattern of arriving at alien methodological conclusions due simply to lack of exposure to standard practice), but instead the running command. That is, I wondered if we could take the same preparation command, such as $2 + 3$, but then at the last minute devise a different mathematical object to run it, (thereby keeping its 'degrees of freedom' intact but localizing the change to the qualitative unfolding of the run command, whatever such may be). If I was lucky enough, even, I could find a way to use such a command to project the result to outside the number line altogether, therefore perhaps enabling the travel to other structures like the alphabet, or even something metaphysical in character given enough iterations, like the human afterlife, (which, note, is altogether an explicit prelude to both the function and set extension intuitions—but the more exact description of what the emphasis was on is not a functor—a functor carries

graduated high school, and it was somewhere around ≈ 189 at the time, but I must emphasize that these are mostly trivial but neat identities, so you could probably count the number of genuinely novel ones on one hand), so I could only assume that the Aethus was the next example of one of these. The alternative will have been that I was the first, but such seemed unlikely due to the sheer simplicity of its presentation. Given what I know now, though, I seem to have already been on the frontier.

4. On January 2, 2022, I wrote down what could be the first instance of the first postulate of the Aethus, being the idea that metaphysical ontology ought to only be properly described with respect to the experience of the individual, specifically because having to deduce which external variables to that are respectively arbitrary or not combats the reversal principle accordingly. In

morphisms and their composition, and what a child transfers between two domains is not that—but *relational encoding*: the relations were what registered, and the objects standing in them did not, which is the profile that structure-mapping theory identifies as the mature end of analogical thought, where an analogy is a mapping of relations that leaves the objects behind [275]. On that theory the transition from object-matching to relation-matching is itself a developmental milestone, the *relational shift* [276], and what the record below suggests is that I was at the relational end unusually early and unusually consistently; the synesthetic emphasis was on the carried structure in exactly that sense. In any case, I have essentially been riffing off of that original potential spike of intuition ever since—and considerably so with Aethic reasoning—even leading to my feeling when finally taking an abstract algebra class in college like I was *losing* abstraction in places, such as with the notorious example of how global group operations felt ad hoc to me from within my own perception of operations being "structurally intrinsic" to the elements directly—something I gathered explicitly in kindergarten when first coming into contact with addition, before solidifying it when teaching myself dimensional analysis in fifth grade by studying patterns in physics equations, and maintained ever since). This, mind you, was a snapshot of the mathematical intuition swimming in my head while I was in kindergarten, so mathematical structures truly are and always have been instinctive for me. Also, note that I stated that I was coming up with known and foundational premises, and of course I had plenty of these as well. At the young age, they were various identities of number theory, like how $a^2 - (a-1)^2 = a + (a-1)$ while I was in fourth grade, (during an abnormally striking shower thought), or, as a high school sophomore, how developing a Riemann sum-like pattern over population density over an area, on the limit to infinity, gives a formulation for the net population therein, (albeit to be clear, I never did independently discover the fundamental theorem of calculus—that will always have been over my head, derivationally speaking). All I had done was obsessively play around with identities and structures, but the intriguing result is that I found somewhere between a few hundred and maybe even a thousand little identities and their immediate consequences, some of them fundamental and some less so.

Also, to elaborate on some more of my ideas briefly, I remember the one I was most proud of during my youth was this formula which generalizes both linear and exponential interpolation.

$$a_{j+1} = \frac{a_j - a_i}{a_{i+1} - a_i} (a_{i+2} - a_{i+1}) + a_{i+1}$$

The reason I was so proud of this one is because I had never actually heard of interpolation: instead I just had a hurricane of an intuition while I was lying in bed to go to sleep one night in seventh grade, and wrote this in my notebook the next morning. Of course I wasn't aware of this formal notation at the time, but this is the structure I was intuiting. How I thought of it is that I wanted a way to move three numbers down a metaphorical "conveyor belt" such that each takes the next one's place. My thought then was that I only needed to find a way to turn the first into zero and the second into one, because then I could rescale both by the same factor and get an arbitrarily-large gap between them. I then intuited that the gap should be just enough so that it matches the difference between the next two numbers—that way we need only add the second number to turn the zero to it and the one to the third number. What fascinated me was what on Earth the "fourth" number would be, and what patterns it would have to follow, almost like the "spiritual successor" to the first three numbers and how they relate to one another. Also, I thought I would mention how I came up with that algebraic identity during a shower thought in fourth grade: simply put, I had been memorizing the square numbers for fun and had gotten as far as $16^2 = 256$, but I wanted to get 17^2 also but didn't have a paper to work it out. What I realized is that if I add sixteen to $16^2 = 16 \cdot 16$, then "sixteen sixteens becomes seventeen sixteens". Then, "since seventeen sixteens is the same as sixteen seventeens, adding seventeen makes seventeen seventeens". That, finally, was mental math I could do, so I did $256 + 16 = 272$ and $272 + 17 = 289 = 17^2$. That was the result!

As for the kindergarten idea itself, I figured I also ought to contextualize it a little bit more as well. I think the plain and simple phenomenon going on here was that while my actual working memory and base cognitive faculties took until brain maturity to develop in full, in terms of sheer "degree of felt mathematical synesthesia" I was at full capacity since birth. What I find particularly striking about this is that while I am now old enough to "harness" this ability for methodological purposes, at that age I had the ability in full, but was not yet aware about how to use it. So if anything, it was like handing the keys to my full current sensitivity to mathematical elegance to a child with a brain half the size. The result of this was a profound sensation that would come over me by so much as even comprehending a number. I remember distinctly that I would have to prepare myself before "taking on" a number like four, because the unique sensory profile of a number is so vast that it would overcome me like a wave of sensation. I still have this tidal wave-like sensory experience with mathematical concepts to this day, just I tend to reserve it more for trigonometric identities or mathematical structures as opposed to numbers outright, which I do not have a comparatively strong intuition for. That migration is the reason the classification I should attach to all of this, in the literature's own terms, is *ideasthesia* rather than synesthesia in the classical sense. The classical diagnosis rests on a stable pairing of inducer and concurrent over the lifetime, (the consistency criterion, the so-called test of genuineness), whereas what is described here is an inducer class that has moved from numerals to relations and structures while the concurrent persisted, together with an emphasis throughout on the carried structure rather than on the sign; and a concurrent induced by the *meaning* of a stimulus rather than by its form is the defining profile of ideasthesia, the semantic mechanism that Nikolić proposed as underlying even the classical cases [277, 278]. I keep the word "synesthesia" elsewhere in this record as the word I have

fact, if some number of external attributes were deemed non-arbitrary, then what is to say they are external in the first place? So, in other words, my reasoning led me to that point to the conclusion that an ontological system which embraces the reversal principle must then also be fundamentally relativist.

This idea may be rendered as the origination of the ontological reversal principle, in addition to just the epistemic one. This entry, then, was highly important for a second reason as well, because I also used it to argue that in a ontological model such as this, an agent need not be restricted to a single timeline in the first place. Rather, for any events of which they are unaware, it would be perfectly acceptable, (according to the framework), for them to sit on both realized

always used for it, but the stricter term is the right one, and it removes the objection that the pairing is not stable: on the ideasthetic reading it is the meaning that induces, and the meaning is what has deepened. Interestingly, ever since I first heard about Kiki-Bouba effect sometime before or during middle school, I have noticed that for any pair of two mathematical concepts that I'm aware of, anyway, (up to having at least some semblance of graph-connectivity to something else I'm aware of), I subconsciously spontaneously associate one with Kiki and the other with Bouba if I ask myself which would be which. For example, sine is Kiki where cosine is Bouba, but cosine is Kiki where cosine squared is Bouba, etcetera. And that report settles the classification more sharply than the migration does, because of the feature it displays that a classical pairing cannot: the assignment is *pairwise*, not absolute. Cosine is Bouba against sine and Kiki against cosine squared, so what induces is not the concept but the *contrast between two concepts*—which is to say there is no fixed inducer-concurrent pairing here to be stable or unstable in the first place, and the cross-modal mapping that Köhler's original demonstration and its modern treatments describe [279, 280] is being applied not to a stimulus but to a relation. The stated condition makes the same point from the other side: the association requires the concept to have some graph-connectivity to something else I am aware of, which is to say it requires a *position in a structure* before it will fire at all. A concurrent that needs meaning, and specifically needs relational meaning, is the ideasthetic profile stated twice over, and it is the same relational encoding that runs through the childhood episodes above rather than a separate faculty. Just the fascinating thing about all of this is how it was completely innate. I hear many a stories about people talking about how they "learned to see math as an art long after their eduction", and I almost chuckle at this every time I hear it—that is, because you didn't have to *tell* me math was an art. It was something I felt more strongly than anything, because unlike anything else in the world there was an infinite power inside of how numbers relate to one another. I remember being fascinated as a young child with exploring all of the folders I could in the file directory of my dad's computer. What I would do is make a folder, then name folders in that numbers one through n, then go into each of them and name more folders with numbers. Then, moving in the other direction, I would go to the root directory and try to see if I could find any obscure folders like the Program Files. Basically what all of this was was a paracosm written in the language of structure—the reason I named folders like that was because I imagined them forming a network, and the reason I looked for exotic folders was to imagine what roles they could be playing in this, (and indeed I did have an entire fictional world of characters as a child, loosely based on my stuffed animals, so sure enough I would draw drawings of them in Microsoft Paint and disperse these about the folders I made. Funnily enough, my dad reports that I eventually fried his computer altogether because of all the rearranging I did in the folders behind the scenes). The way I pictured the number line, then, was basically as the cosmos's own equivalent of this computer file system, which was baked into the mainframe of the universe and accessible through the mind rather than being confined to a computer and accessible through a keyboard. (Which is shockingly similar to Platonic idealism in retrospect—being something which I think hints at just how powerful my mathematical synesthesia really was already at that age—moving far enough beyond merely colors for numbers where the mental synesthetic pathways themselves started to tangle and emergently produce more "senses" in the knots, which themselves were tangled into more knots and more senses). But to my mind the relationship was clearly exact, and hence why I was so fascinating with finding hacks for how to navigate the number line in unforeseeable new ways. Although it would be a while until I heard of concepts like imaginary numbers and surreal numbers, had you explained them to be then I would have thought they were only the tip of the iceberg, because whatever was lying in the foundations ought to be stretchable far enough to, as I mentioned, close the gap between Earth and the afterlife itself. Concerning that "closing the gap" mindset, actually that itself came from what is perhaps my first epiphany in life, as a preschooler on this computer: one day, coincidentally, on this Windows XP file system, I ended up accidentally figuring out a way to navigate from the folder directory to the computer's "control panel" itself. (That is, I had navigated there from the apps directory in the start panel before, but this time I had reached the same location by moving to the root directory and then moving down a different pathway in the file explorer—which I had internalized as a distinct, closed-off domain from the start panel prior to this happening. So the thought in the moment was that two categorically distinct domains can actually be welded together beneath the surface in unexpected ways, as if to be two vantages on a single underlying domain for which that distinction is in your own priors rather than in the structure). Something about this moment struck me as utterly profound, which is why it is something of an epiphany that shaped me from that day forward. The inner knowing that came to me then and there was, effectively, that *the barrier between any two things is an illusion.* Hence, when I took this mindset back to the number line, I became very excited about trying to establish navigational paths between the number line and arbitrary-iteratively far reconceptualizations of it like the alphabet, and then metaphysical characterizations underlying the same substrate of reality. One tangible example of me trying this idea in the real world is that I remember plugging in a keyboard into an outlet, and then I had my mom call all of her friends so I could get them on the phone and ask if they were receiving the messages I was typing into the keyboard. When they said they were, of course, I was utterly ecstatic. (In particular, my unconscious worldview at the time was that since mental states are causally contributive to the mathematical structures one envisions—as in the number line exiting concept—then I assumed therefore that my "mentally indicating that the message ought to go to the correct friend of my mother's" ought also to fill that causal-contributive void. That is, just like a block of code setting a parameter is necessary to enact the right outcomes for the program downstream, I assumed that in the physical world such parameters may be mental or physical because that is just what they were when picturing math. Obviously the actual paradigm of metaphysics is that perturbing mental states does not causally re-index outcomes downstream as if playing one contribution, but I had not

timelines at the same time, only to sift into a more specific outcome among them upon learning about it. Such is what I explicitly termed 'centric unfolding' during a later entry on the 16th of January. Note that I was still firmly locked into the timeline-branching ontological model, so it would not be until my reaching of the extrusion principle in August of that year when I realized the alternative way of looking at such.

Now, centric unfolding is, of course, a rather absurd premise to even entertain, and naturally I was aware of this. However, the rebellious teenager that I was, the reason I continued to engage with it was a rather simple one: it was thrilling. That is, even though I was at an unspoken understanding that my being on multiple timelines at once could not possibly be right, still the

considered this at the time because of my assumption that the unification of mental-and-physical in math ought to be reflected in the physical world. Or, more accurately still, I did not have a concept that mental and physical states were distinguishable in the first place, which itself is probably why I was manageably able to picture mathematical abstraction at that age in the first place. (And, a further note—you might contest the consistency of this "paradigm" of mine at the time by stating that I had to click the physical mouse button in order to move up a directory in the file explorer in the first place, as opposed to having the capacity to just mentally will it to occur. However, the rebuttal to this is that my view will have been that my mental orientation was still very much causally-upstream of the action, because which choice I made during navigation was itself driven by the mental states of making that choice. The key statement I would make is that I did not have a paradigmatic concept of causality either per se, because that is really just trying to articulate that paradigm of mine using terminology I know now, so what I would call a far closer fit is, as I mentioned just before, the idea that for a computer program to produce a specific outcome requires having coded exhaustively all preconditions which specify that particular outcome as opposed to an arbitrary alternative. So, in my paradigmatic view of the time, mental states are perfectly adequate preconditions, such that what would distinguish between physically clicking a mouse button versus indicating the recipient of a message mentally is in the contingency upon the apparatus of how the precondition parameters are particularly executed as outcomes in the world, hence allowing the mouse button not to refute that preconditions may be mental so much as describing one particular contingent execution apparatus compared to another. In any case, the "that mental indication can determinate a recipient" concept was one with the "that thinking about it can change which mathematical statement is in mind, as in $1 + 1$ versus $2 + 3$" concept, because my paradigm did not distinguish between the outcome of the former being physical whereas the outcome of the latter is mental—if you will such a distinction would be a construct because writing the given mathematical statement on the page is equally determined by the original mental thought as the change in the statement in mind is, thereby replacing the "mental versus physical" descriptive dichotomy with the contingency in the intermediate execution of the outcome as opposed to attributing the difference to the causal scope of the precondition to adjacent outcomes—which itself note still exhaustively describes our same world but with a differently-placed system of descriptive labeling or variables.)). I even remember attaching a note to a party balloon and throwing the balloon off the balcony the apartment building I lived in, before promptly calling my grandmother and mentioning to her that a balloon should be coming her way within the next several days. Funnily enough I actually remembered this event well enough to bring it up with her two years later (when I was six) when I visited her house, to which she promptly replied "oh yeah I have the balloon I just have to find where I put it in the back room". I'm starting to think maybe she never got that balloon... (I kid you, but that was funny to say anyway).

There's another story too which I think illustrates how my mind is basically hardwired for inductive reasoning: also while I was in preschool, I remember stacking like eight open-on-one-side cardboard boxes on top of each other, and called it an "apartment building" as a reference to the apartment building that my mom lived in. I then determined which floors my various stuffed animals lived in, and would move them to those floors. The thing I remember being specifically synesthetically potent about this exercise was two things: that this construction was not about the floors themselves but about the relationship between floors as the stuffed animals moved around to visit other floors, (in the context of some wider dramatic story I would dream up), and that this miniature apartment building itself was meant to replicate the larger apartment building. So in other words, while perhaps a standard exercise of childhood play on the surface, what actually registered as most apparent to me was the relationship objects involved more so than the actual instance objects being related. Another related story, also, is that I have a video of myself (taken by my dad) at one or two years (I was walking already, but still could only say limited words like "come on Zoe" blended together when talking to the family dog, but interestingly in the video when my dad said "A" I would say "B" and then when he said "C" I would say "D") old going around and dumping dog food pellets from smaller into larger containers, the last one unfortunately being a large bin of my dad's CDs. While I of course have no memory of this specific event, what strikes me as interesting based on what I do recall from my earliest synesthetic memories is how I had essentially recognized the different containers as of the same kind, but at different sizes, and then proceeded to transfer the dog food between them to stimulate the satisfying feeling of expressing the abstraction I felt in the medium of the real world, as was the case for the remembered examples. So on the mental side, there must have been some particular abstract recognition for what the containers represented with respect to the dog food, however subtle. Another similar story is that while talking to my Aunt recently, she recalls being amazed at the number of names of things that I had memorized at age two. Among stuffed animals alone, she said there were like fifty of them, (so perhaps fifty is the estimate for the number of them), and after my Dad named each one of them for me I had memorized them all. He particularly chose multi-syllabic names, like Nicodemus or Boris for example, so that I could practice learning to speak words. He said I also knew the names of all the animals that he had toys of in the house as well, ranging from zebra to rhinoceros to tiger to camel to cow to gorilla, and so on, (for example, there is one video where I flip through a toy stereoscope and identify the animals in it, while 2 years old—although this itself does not seem generally precocious for the age). He also said at some point that he taught me every US state and its capital city, however I imagine this was later on, (but still young enough that I have no memory of that happening, fittingly enough since I now no longer know every capital!). (There were also some videos where I was measurably younger than that—still babbling and all but getting a handful of words out—and interestingly even then I was engaging with structural intuitions, like one where I transfer colored blobs of frosting from a cake to a paper towel while sitting on the dining room table, and then suddenly upon catching sight of a wall painting beside the

mere notion that such a metaphysics could be set up without triggering an empirical distinction was rather intriguing to ponder over. It is the same reason why the 'tree falls in the forest' thought experiment is thrilling—the alternative conclusion is absurd, and yet it cannot be empirically

table intently look back and forth between it and the paper towel, mouth open as if surprised. I started sliding myself over to it across the table, but luckily my Dad stopped me before I could place the blob on it. Indeed, my Dad says I never crawled like a normal baby in the first place, and the videos show this—instead I would sit on the ground, and use one arm between my legs and another behind me to throw my weight and effectively scoot across the ground between places. Another common theme from these younger-age videos is that I would get intently focused on something I was staring at, and people would have to enthusiastically call my name several times before I respond. Once I did respond though, I would swivel around quickly as if hearing it for the first time only that time). Another fundamental event he told me is that at the age of three, when my family moved to a house with a larger driveway, he brought me a tricycle to ride across the driveway, but as he recalls I "looked overwhelmed, and sat in place on the tricycle". In that moment, he had the insight that maybe what I needed was for him to draw a long winding path like a road along the driveway in chalk, (and my mom even was anxious about why he would do something so random). The moment he did this, and sure enough I was overjoyed, and starting riding the tricycle along the path for hours. While I do not remember this specific event either, what I do find funny about it is that the path even now sounds preferable over the bare driveway, for the same reason why the Aethus is preferable over a set, the Accordance Principle over the Drake [281] Equation, and the derivative structure of Newton's second law over polynomial interpolation of measured events: *it is about something, and that something is structured*. And that is the place to say what the datum in these stories actually is, because it is not any one of them. Read together, the dog food moved between containers of one kind at different sizes, the cardboard floors that were about the relationship between floors rather than the floors, the folder trees named as a network with exotic folders given roles, the number line pictured as the cosmos's own file system, the run-command idea that keeps the preparation and changes what carries it, the interpolation conveyor belt that normalizes two points to 0 and 1 so that the relation transfers, and the chalk path preferred to the bare driveway are seven independent instances of one abstract move—a structure-preserving transfer between domains in which the relations carry and the objects do not—and several of them, (the dog food, the tricycle, the videos), are filtered by my father's and my aunt's memory rather than by mine, which is a partially independent selection. Seven instances of one move are far stronger evidence of an early and stable cognitive style than any single anecdote, and that style has a name and a literature: relational rather than object-centric encoding, structure-mapping's own characterization of analogy, with the relational shift reached early [275, 276].

I also have another thing to say, being a general observation of mine about the nature of mathematical beauty. I think the truth of the matter is that mathematical beauty is subjective in one specific respect, which should be stated exactly so that the argument to follow is not read as undercut by it: *which* part of the non-mediocre regime a given person's sense of beauty picks out is contingent on that person's tastes, and so therefore is whether the part it picks out overlaps the truth subspace of that regime. That is the simple reason that any two people are going to rate the same concepts differently, and that some people are going to have a higher hit rate of beauty revealing mathematical truth than others; what is *not* person-relative is the hurdle itself, that a mathematical truth must be non-mediocre among human intuitive productions, which is the argument's load-bearing premise. In this respect, while I certainly think that methodologically treating math as an art form is truer to its nature state than treating it as a discipline or tool, I might slightly push back on the purely Platonic idea where a directness is considered between mathematical aestheticism and truth. Instead I see this much more as strong correlation rather than causation. Perhaps the central message I have taken away from working with trigonometry is that a human, almost like an evolutionary ladder limitation, is fundamentally incapable of guessing mathematical truth with anything under an infinitesimal hit rate. The reason we are ever able to produce mathematical beauty anyway, then, is something like how Brownian motion sits at some bizarre intermediate zone between motionlessness (dimension zero) and directed motion (dimension one). That is rather like how I see the best moments of my life in terms of mathematical insight—a genuine biological incapacity for the subject coupled with a fleeting continued ability to use the structure itself as an amplifier. The canonical example of this, in my mind, is the use of a string of deducible trigonometric identities to convert a vague assessment of structure into something more powerful. For instance, if I need some variable y to meet three criteria, then I might recognize that even when operating at full capacity, as a human I only have the chops to directly intuit two of them. So I might create some intermediate x, together with the idea that $y = \sin(2\arctan(x))$, and then proceed to get my socks blown off when a real formula is produced. In that way I have artificially augmented my real capacity with the internal elegance of trigonometry itself, which vastly outperforms the guessing ability of any human like a kind of divinity. I genuinely recognized the fundamentality of my limitations, and yet paradoxically just barely grasped the real formula anyway—despite definitively having insufficient mathematical awareness to reach it from my own senses. So altogether what I'm saying for this is that since humans have a recognizably poor hit rate for accessing mathematical truth directly—and one which fails exponentially quicker for compounding, multiple criteria—then the mere fact that aesthetic mathematical formalisms stand out with an unusual quantile compared with clumsy formalisms then opens the possibility of their being truths, since it serves as a general criterion to mathematical truth that it fails probabilistic mediocrity inside of standard human intuitive capacities. So in that sense because the hit rate problem already necessitates non-mediocrity of mathematical truth in the population of standard human mathematical intuitions, then at least mathematical beauty has a chance at being true, because it passes the needed criterion of non-mediocrity by virtue the characteristics which subjectively characterize it specifically as beautiful. So it is not that there is a fundamental causal implication by which beauty or truth leads into one another, but rather that mathematical beauty clears the hurdle of non-mediocrity by virtue of its startling nature, so it at least becomes possible although generally still probably far from likely that it also turns out to

falsified[330]. In the end, it would be this exact subtlety of metaphysical open-mindedness which enabled my later derivation of Aethic reasoning in full.

I actually have a video of myself from June 2, 2022 which I find rather fascinating, because in it I articulated the problem of not being able to properly define a fluke for Nexic reasoning. After

be true—and how likely, for a given person, is exactly the person-relative part: the overlap between the region their taste selects and the truth subspace of the regime.

2026-08-31 (closing editorial instruction omitted)

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Oh and also please change the qualitative "half-right" in the phil_sci paper for Hossenfelder's argument to a
statistical "right the significant majority of the time", since the dice roll of things means that if you select
a random practitioner, the likelihood that their inclinations randomly lands on exactly the same non-mediocrity
subspace as "truth" is extremely unlikely (the null set for exactly, and generally low for an arbitrarily high
overlap-closeness, if there was a value to measure such a thing for subspaces anyway--you might be able to
heuristically identify one).  Because of this, somebody like Robert Spekkens per his emphasis on scrambling being
the problem in quantum realism gets a very very high score, while the median practitioner is basically random and
so not very close at all.  Interestingly, this says something substantial about the value of consensus:  against
the claims of science deniers, when consensus exists that is actually a remarkably good predictor of quality of
whatever opinion the consensus supports, however when there is a lack of consensus, say even an 80-20 split about
something (where heuristically I would say consensus is past 95-5 say, but below that it doesn't count) is just as
bad of a predictor about quality as 50-50, or 10-10-...-10, etc.  What's interesting about this is that the 80-20
consensus split typically means that the "real" answer actually isn't known, which is exactly what's significant
for the anti-beauty argument:  when the real thing isn't known, where somebody's tastes land is indeed random in the
non-mediocre subspace, in that non-mediocre to begin with means it's uncharted and so taste-randomness as a rule of
human cognition always is what happens in that regime, HOWEVER once the "real" thing happens, which per the Newtonian
way means inference has to exist alongside ontology to qualify it (like in the long paper from my least-idealized
idealized model discussion), we now let inference do the work FOR us, so human error evaporates because "the model
(if a good model) is smarter than you are" and so we move that whole new paradigm worth of content into the mediocre
regime now, and now people are easily able to (given training so they can do the inference, anyway) land arbitrarily
close to the truth subspace (now in the mediocre regime, which itself is a subspace of the total space along with
the non-mediocre regime, is the idea) with their tastes.  Hence, like a catalyst the consensus is able to inflate
to 95-5, with the lingering remaining 5% being the effect of their having difficulty lining up with the inference
or something anyway despite having credentials to be recognized by others as a "practitioner" anyway off of a fluke,
(like, for a canonical example, the climate change denier dumba**es that also weirdly happen to be scientists (again
though where "scientists" is not an objective property in this sense but rather the metric of what other people count
as being a "practitioner" according to their own subjective qualifiers)).  Anyways, so this also then is basically
a first-principles derivation of Spekkens's own account that "the lack of consensus among quantum interpretations
means we can't possibly have the real answer yet" together with Hossenfelder's "beauty is problematic", but just
with a slight softening into the 99-1 partition or whatever it actually is of "statistically beauty is not to be
trusted if it's searching for extra-paradigm content, because that puts it squarely in the non-mediocrity regime, but
that's not categorical to beauty and instead is a reference to the measure of how unlikely it is that the person's
random subjective tastes subspace is even remotely nearby enough to the truth subspace on the relevant topic of their
investigation".
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[330]To be more specific, my very most original motivation with Aethic reasoning, particularly through its initial centric unfolding aspect, was to found that clearly absurd premise that a human occupies multiple timelines at once, and then see how rich of a structure I could build on top of that while still remaining comfortably inside of the empirically undetectable abstract space. That is, just like, and directly inspired by the thought experiment of whether a tree falling in the forest makes a sound, the exercise was particularly to see how much breadth I could maximally hide inside the absurd metaphysical scenario while still not technically clashing with empiricism. So, in short, given the foundation of a consciousness being able to occupy multiple timelines, I attempted to ask myself the question of, "what is the theoretically most extensive possible structure that can be devised while still being unfalsifiable on a technicality?". Even something like the problem of induction, while ontologically absurd, is not particularly complicated as an idea, so what I was specifically going for was to ask what sort of unfalsifiable model maximizes complexity. And, in a weird twist of fate, although this seems to defy Occam's razor outwardly, the funny result is that our own common sensical idea of the universe is so specific in its claims, that that which is particularly the maximal unfalsifiable model is itself constrained as vigorously as a sort of path of stationary action, effectively giving you a dual pair of unfalsifiable ontologies, where one is precisely common sensical but the other is deterministic, if unexpected and perhaps even unprecedented in elaboration due to its inherent absurdity. The latter, then, was the centric unfolding idea itself, which I must emphasize was particularly an epistemological exercise in this context, more as a way to probe the inner workings of our logical ontology by stating its polar opposite, as opposed to refuting our logical ontology altogether. This was the case, that is, until I hit upon the epiphany for the extrusion principle directly, at which point for the first time I seriously considered this proto-Aethic structure and its newfound ontological clarification as very possibly more legitimate than classical ontology. I have noticed in recent months that strikingly many aspects of the complete Aethic reasoning bear close resemblances to the flavor of Einstein's metaphysical general relativity derivation, so I would particularly say that this sort of mindset is what the initial unfalsifiable structuring intuition matured into over the months following the extrusion principle initiation. But yes, it is all the more fascinating for me to see the parallels with the Einsteinian way, be it concerning how the second and third postulates reverse the ontological priority of superposition like how the

that, I mentioned how the probability[331] is shaken up so substantially as you move the perspective forward and backward in time[332], that even explaining it probably needs to be the work of a future theory of time that somebody will have to discover at some point. What's fascinating about this in retrospect is that it shows how early before the actual extrusion principle epiphany I had already acknowledged the hole in the current understanding of time. The real story for the role of quantum mechanics in this, then, is that upon seeing the double-slit experiment video on August 10 my intuitions basically triggered a phase transition in the space of possible solutions to the problem, because the direct inductive reasoning from the quantum observer effect served as a catalyst[333] with which to infer the shape of the solution. The extrusion principle itself was then a second phase transition which collapsed the solution space into a single point—being the Aethic ontology of time concept. This is also a general illustration of how I work, which is I start with a feeling about a general need to fill a vacant niche, and then push on it until I get a grip on an empirical clue with which to rapidly compact the space of possibilities—since crucially

equivalence principle reversed the ontological priority of free-fall, or whatever else. Whatever my particular steady state of derivational instinct has become, as was initialized by the unfalsifiable structuring origin, for whatever reason it seems to be quite fundamental to the structure of focused metaphysical reevaluation in general. But of course only time will tell if I am permitted to that conclusion.

[331]What the shift was, to name it precisely, was to shift the probability update of natural history from the spacelike moving present in the physical past to the Aethus-valued moving present of centric unfolding which the agent themselves undergoes, and pertaining to whatever ordering of past events they attain access to. Hence, the Aethic extrusion principle itself ended up filling the slot of a proposed resolution.

[332]That is, in that sense the difficulty was that I was stuck in the paradigm of trying to establish the "before" and the "after" of the fluke and how the probability changes along it, and as I go over in the Nexic paper itself, this was effectively a definitional paradox that manifested a paradigmatic inconsistency between the accordance principle and the timeline ontology. So in the moment my thought was "this is a problem, and hopefully someday some great scientist will figure out a way to fix it" entirely passively! Little did I know, however, that Aethic reasoning itself is the resolution to the paradox, and would hit me in those series of flashes just two and a half months later!

Another interesting thing I might directly mention is what my definitions were for each of the involved terms (as written on a whiteboard by me in the video):

- Attribute = A characteristic of a Golden Trek
- Golden Trek = A path to a Golden Point
- Attribute Set = Subclass of Attribute → Multiple Attributes
- Mission = A temporal change in a temporally based Attribute
- Imperfection Magnitude Drop = A mission which, when triggered, vastly lowers the potential suboptimality
- Prerequisite = A mission which, if failed would trigger an Imperfection magnitude Drop
- *Fluke = A mission which is unlikely to succeed
- Miracle = A prerequisite which is also a Fluke

Notice for example how I casually mention "a temporal change" and especially "a path to a Golden Point" without viewing them as problematic, despite being able to correctly see already how the fluke definition is problematic. This is a fascinating pre-paradigmatic intuition snapshot, I would say, in the sense that my finding "a path" perfectly well-defined for leaning on the timeline ontology while pushing for the axiomatic-grade construction of prerequisites is similar to Euclid not realizing the problem in his "breadthless length" definition for a straight line while at once accurately articulating the fifth postulate itself of Euclidean geometry!

The key pre-extrusion indicator visible in the video is that while I already was explicitly describing an Aethus in the present moment—per its being partial information—as more ontologically relevant for happenstance reasoning than a single timeline, I was still referring to this Aethus itself as covering the entire past, such that like a slider determinacy in each single timeline decomposed-component of it is realized as a probabilistic event running on the moving present AT that point on the timeline. Should you for your model choose to equip the moving present over the timelines of that Aethus with "default" probabilities, that is called "outlook probability" (now instead interpreted as a properly-Aethic Nexus, being the Cosmic Nexus) or alternatively you can equip it with "Golden probability", which is simply the conditional probability of the event given the Golden Point, (and note how in the later Aethic model this is already redundant, since why not just equip the Aethus with the Golden Point and always use "outlook probability" for the equipping?). So this video, as a direct illustration of the "original centric unfolding model", therefore serves to my eye as a helpful direct intermediate step between timeline-metaphysics and the genuine Aethic reasoning established with the extrusion principle: rather than having an Aethus span the past and be decomposable into timelines, the Aethus is a single local object and probabilities are read off from the past as one traverses Aethae in the moment, being exactly the Aethic move to move determinacy-realization off of the moving present in time and therefore reimagine both the ontology of time and probability in one motion. (And, also modality as a third thing because of how the move itself is to put counterfactuals in the physical room, of course, although to reiterate once more my "counterfactual" concept was intuited off of the standard multiverse concept rather than my having been exposed to actual counterfactual semantics yet or even within the next four years). Weirdly the intermediate model is yet to reach the breaking point of rethinking time, but perhaps heightens the capacity of reaching such rather drastically.

[333]I might also note the intrigue factor in my having articulated the problem in the first place by inference from the Nexic reasoning direction, and then for a second stage integrated the quantum observer effect problems. This once again goes to show you how this sort of ontological work is almost exclusively better constructed heterogeneously across stimuli.

human inferential capabilities simply do not have sufficient sensitivity to nomological elegance to achieve the right entry angle without that empirical tipoff—and hence why Aethic reasoning could never be formulated earlier in history than quantum mechanics.

5. On August 10, 2022, I came across an intriguing online lecture by physicist Jim Al-Khalili concerning the mystery of the double-slit experiment, (specifically on why the wavefunction collapse occurs when introducing a detector to the system). This was the moment that first formally introduced me to this premise, and in doing so sparked the escalating wave of curiosity which led my discovery of the Aethic extrusion principle[334] within the week[335]. That is, upon finishing the video, I felt a strong intuition that I was somehow at the very doorstep of a solution,

[334]While it is on my mind, by the way, I figured I could also explain why I consider the extrusion principle to be a "principle" rather than a "postulate". Simply put, I intuitively feel that a principle tells you more *what you shouldn't do* while a postulate tells you more what *you should*. From that perspective, then, the extrusion principle is, at its core, a direct refutation of the timeline metaphysics concept, and so in that way perhaps acts as the initial gross-level sledge hammer act which allows us to bridge the barrier between paradigms, and then go on to formulate Aethic reasoning directly. As may perhaps be hopefully somewhat apparent now that we are at the end of the paper, this timeline metaphysics really seems to be responsible for the brunt of the blockage, and so it is almost painfully obvious in retrospect that it is all that had to go. And so on that note, I have deliberately chosen not to count the extrusion principle as a postulate specifically so that Aethic reasoning can accommodate those who want to be more agnostic about the Markov chain of block universes ontology, but still be able to *apply* Aethic reasoning in a strictly procedural sense. Forcing the extrusion principle to be a postulate would disallow this accordingly. So whether or not this more ontologically agnostic take is advisable is almost besides the point, because really what I'm trying to do here is to get the excessively minimalist foundation in throwing distance, so to speak. I personally think an ontological through line is key to the sustained fertility of theoretical development, but that being said I think an inability to part those clouds at a moment's notice would actually indicate a glitch in the interlocking gears of the framework, and so if anything keeping this line on cleanliness is built-in paradox proofing. That is all!

[335]I should mention, for the record, that this block universe-based framing of the extrusion principle was never part of my original intuitions, and was instead simply an explanatory artifact that I developed later on in order to get the structural points across with least resistance, (rather like how the defintional hierarchy was the original intuition, but the n-Aethus concept was the explanatory tool). My original intuitions on the Aethus of 2022 and 2023 were much more idealism-like, with the prospect being much more akin to the example I give with Emily and her father, where they are each individually effectively "infused" with their own association of superpositions in the most qualitative, and therefore physically passive sense. I would argue that this initial view is ironically less weighty than the full-fledged block universe Markov chain rendition, because after all the more you interpret an ontology outside of its bare *hypotheses non fingo*-informed [71] structure, the more room there is for you to produce bias. Nonetheless, though, it has become somewhat clear to me that the idealism-like presentation, while perhaps closer to the ontological root for its subtly more agnostic stance, is effectively futile as a pedagogical agent, and so the Markov chain of block universes, (being the structural facet of the extrusion principle), is an arguably optimal way of providing the explainee with the rolled-up intuitions on the locality-preservation together with the non-contradictory shifting of history concept, (ie so as to explicitly establish why this breaks from the timeline metaphysical picture).

Note that this original idealism-like view bears (perhaps) a striking resemblance to how reference frames are treated in Einstein's 1905 miracle year paper [27], (i.e., as something of an abstract basis sliding over a preexisting physical space and ascribing different but equally real meanings to its contents), especially because of how I intuited this before ever having engaged with the argument of the paper directly. That is, the similarity lies in how my original view was to imagine that unlike in the classical view of reality, where only physical objects may be varied, under the channel-based view of reality given by the first postulate of the Aethus we are able to vary either side of the physical object or the Aethus respecting to which its reality is attributed. Concerning the Aethus-side varying, that is, we have the possibility of, for a single physical object, changing its nature in reality in the first place by pointing to it from a new Aethus. A standard tangible example is that for a given fixed tree in one's yard, it does not objectively have the height it has in the sense of an objective reality, because there exists some Aethus in the abstract respecting to which that same tree happens to have half the height. By the first postulate of the Aethus, neither our version of the tree or the alternative version is more real, and instead reality itself is simple the relative state of association between a physical object and a given Aethus. Where this prospect comes directly into use in Aethic reasoning is primarily in the case of a Wigner's friend thought experiment [30] itself, for which the ontology of Aethic reasoning allows a single fixed object to exist in a state of superposition versus a determinate state even relative to the respective Aethae of two people but three meters apart with a wall between them. In this special example, we simply have that the observers do not physically contradict each other pertaining to the object, because one of their Aethae holds it as stated while the other holds it as directly blank. The more radical Aethic multiverse concept, moreover, is that even if the Aethae of the two observers are indeed contradictory concerning one or more physical objects, and even still the physical object does not default to the reality of one of them, and instead we simply have that both observers are equally real respecting to themselves, it just simply follows that the structure of the ladder ontology prevents them from ever interacting so as to possibility produce a contradiction, (which is explained in detail during the observer-consistency section).

So, to be abundantly clear on the transition in my thoughts, as I have mentioned before the seed of the "extrusion principle" itself—from the epiphany moment—was essentially the categorical repackaging of Aethic superpositions as a unique ontological primitive sitting inside of physical space as opposed to a non-fundamental and slightly ontologically ad hoc "collection" of timelines, (which in turn violates the ontological reversal principle by subtly assuming fundamentality to fully determinate timelines). So, in other words the core of the extrusion principle itself has nothing in particular to do with the transition between block universes—after all that is the designated work of centric unfolding—and instead is an explicit ontological statement operating on the core of defining an Aethic superposition, (and perhaps in doing so hopefully paints the picture of why the extrusion principle in its original form is effectively inseparable from the concept of specifying what an Aethic superposition is, because in this "nakedly categorical" view the extrusion principle itself is

and only then was realizing it. The work which I had done on centric unfolding, which at the time had only seemed peripheral to my major formulation of Nexic reasoning, had suddenly been granted a direct procedural relevance, albeit in a distinctly niche regard. As much of a stretch as this paradox was to grapple with, I was presented with a fleeting opportunity to grasp it if only I could take the leap to initial comprehension. Such a leap needed to be made, I could sense, because as I stared at the nuances of that interference pattern in my mind's eye, I could tell that I was dealing with a metaphysics of a subtle but eternal character. Something which could be grasped in an instant, and yet could be lost forever with so much as a blink. I had started on third base because of centric unfolding—a mere accident—and now I had the opportunity to grasp the storm which was passing over my mind. This, of course, is what I did during that foundational epiphany[336] when the extrusion principle came to me. Sometime between the end of the video on August 10, and the end of my college orientation week on August 19. It was a genuinely poetic moment in my life, which is why I like to write it as such. This is the idea that marked the birth of Aethic reasoning[337].

For the historical record, and because the point bears on how the framework should be read, it is worth stating plainly what I had and had not encountered at the time. The extrusion principle was developed prior to my having heard of Wigner's friend, of delayed choice as a named puzzle, of relational quantum mechanics, of the realist quantum program as a program, or of anything at all in modal logic or modal semantics—each of these was met only afterwards, and each arrived as confirmation of structure already in hand rather than as input to it. And the route in, for the record, was friction—but friction of an *earned* kind, not an innate one, and the distinction matters for how this record reads. In 2020 I saw no problem with timelines at all:

effectively the act of promoting the qualitative nature of superposition to an independent ontological class—something which perhaps becomes obscured once the block universe fluff is layered on top. So while the "current version" of the extrusion principle holds both effects, what I am saying is that it is worth mentioning that the original version was much more categorically-motivated in the style of the first postulate). Now, the fact is that these superpositions are already relatively indexed by a given Aethus, so the pedagogical use of stating the same principle in terms of the block universes is that they both (1) provide a spatial profile to the Aethus-indexing process to as to give it some needed tangibility for landing the explanation, and (2) at once encodes all of the inherited ontological features of the indiscriminate time principle by insisting that all of spacetime is indexed by an Aethus rather than any sort of arbitrary subspace of spacetime, (as is already uniquely the semantic scope of a block universe concept). To be clear, though, the original extrusion principle epiphany itself also did include all those inherited implications from the indexing and the indiscriminate time principle, so these did indeed arrive in the same categorical packaging for how to formulate Aethic superpositions, (since after all, simply dropping the timeline ontology itself is not sufficient to find a replacement—establishing Aethic superpositions *and* establishing how they are arbitrarily indexed is sufficient). What was new for pedagogical purposes was not the indexing aspect, but the framing of that in terms of a block universe Markov chain as opposed to the core Aethic updating process exclusively. So, if you will, a block universe isomorphic graph to the graph of Aethae that actually does the work, that way the learner can associate the universe with the block universe graph while indirectly actually describing the Aethic graph. The more advanced Aethic technique however, I would argue, is looking straight to the abstraction and just viewing the superpositions and physical contents straight from the Aethus layer, however admittedly this is worth working up to like any other degree of significant abstraction. (That advanced reading is now stated as doctrine rather than left as advice, at the reading note of Section 2.2.1, which this footnote anticipates.)

[336]The weirdest part of the Aethic reasoning thesis is that humans have accidentally been seeing reality wrong this whole time, and that once you look at it right you can never go back. It's frankly stunning, really—the realization is that each one of us is actually attached "up" at a partial information state where everything you don't currently know about is a bath of superpositions, and that just simply is where you live rather than in a philosophical possible world. Behind every door and down every corridor is people occupying these superpositions, all because your own index casts a net over all their possibilities without selecting only one. It seems like humans literally evolved to stubbornly avoid this actual view of reality, probably for the sake of easy cohesion in early societies, as opposed to it ever having really been out of reach to any of us—the craziest part is that you can see it in the structure of every human language, the same hard dividing line between the "actual" view of reality (in counterfactual reasoning) and the pretend, softened-version (in just about everything else) isn't particularly subtle once you point it out—it's more like somebody was deliberately trying to mash the two together and so reached a compromise at the hard cut. Except nobody actually did do it deliberately, nobody except the hive mind or whatever the heck. But yeah the subtlety really is sharp enough that it really does seem to me that Aethic metaphysics was never some hidden futurism, but rather got blocked off by day one of human evolution and for all we know could have been obvious to either our ancestors or some hypothetical sister taxon that went the other way instead. (Again, my thesis by 2023 especially was that it's probably direct natural selection that de-prioritized Aethic metaphysics, however obvious it is to unhindered counterfactual reasoning, because it messed with efficiency in early human societies—so it's funny that since learning about the paradoxes and open problems in semantics in 2026 it seems like my original instinct there is just about maybe spot on). So yeah, it wasn't pointed out until, well, me I guess! All because of that single moment in August 2022 when something clicked and I accidentally saw the actual reality. And, sure enough, I never went back.

[337]Concisely speaking, what I gained during the extrusion principle epiphany moment was the complete synesthetic package for what an Aethic superposition is categorically. This meant I could get straight to work cataloging where and in what contexts this new Platonic ideal actually presents itself in the physical world, and from there reverse-engineer the unifying algorithm which deduces these instances proactively. Such was the trail I followed whenever I got a free moment, (and wasn't already working on Nexic pursuits), over the next few months after that.

my own June 2020 notes run happily on *weighted timelines*, and the "time plane" idea of that year was, as recorded elsewhere in this paper, sheer intellectual immaturity. The friction was instead the *conclusion* of the Nexic work—inductive reasoning on the nature of time that slowly manufactured the very irritant it would then resolve—culminating in the mental phase transition of August 2022, when the double-slit observations met the accumulated Nexic structure and the space of possible solutions reorganized in a stroke, (Section 13.10.1). I did not know, then, that an entire philosophy of possible worlds stood linked to exactly this thread; I would first hear the phrase "possible world," and only in isolation, sometime in 2024 or 2025, to the best of my recollection. The subtlety was reachable because the friction was earned: the Nexic work built the sensitivity that everyday timeline-talk then offended. The actual inputs were narrower than a reader might guess: inductive reasoning on the nature of time from my Nexic reasoning work, together with the double-slit experimental outcomes proper, against a background of strictly cultural-layman quantum fragments, (an awareness of quantum-computing speedups, of Schrödinger's cat, and of EPR at the level everybody has, since everybody has it). I will also record a reflection on this that I find genuinely curious: hitting these landmarks as independently developed intuitions before encountering them may paradoxically be what made a net cast this wide across disciplines feasible at all—somehow, independently reinventing the needed tools via induction from the empiricism softens the time complexity, as against having to track every tool down through the literature and exercise judgment over what is usable from reading alone.

6. On August 22, 2022, I wrote down my thoughts about the Aethic soccer field thought experiment in real time[338] as they came to me. Indeed, there was a soccer field outside my second-story dorm room window, albeit with a good deal of obstructions in front of it. Nonetheless, my proximity to it led me to ask this inductive question, with the idea being that if I could pinpoint the cause of the collapse in this thought experiment, then I could pinpoint it anywhere, (with that instinct simply being a mode of inductive reasoning[339] given my knowledge of the Aethic functionality). Upon reading my notes, I clearly see that I already had a procedural understanding for the

[338] What I remember about the intermediate stretch on the day of August 22, 2022 is how I was pacing in my sunlit dorm room, deep in thought with a huge smile on my face, filled with the ecstatic feeling of intense discovery washing over me.

[339] *July 29, 2026*

I was in a philosophy of science class during my last semester of college, and I really really clashed with it due to how my natural rebel mindset interfaced with what I found to be really undisciplined takes in several key places throughout the history (as in, logical positivism, or "Hempel's Raven Paradox [282]" or "Goodman's Grue Paradox [283]"). Obviously I understand that these paradoxes are raised *against* logical positivism—and Goodman's own positive conclusion, projection settled by entrenched practice rather than by logic, already concedes much of the negative point—but what I am targeting is the surrounding reception: the very idea that grue creates "a foundational crisis in how to do inductive reasoning," as if axiomatic inductive reasoning were not trivially absurd to begin with. Like, that crisis reading is so vastly absurd to me, because when it comes to actual inductive reasoning in practice, it's entirely a question of taste—exactly like in art—whether a perturbation to the concept like making grue out of green is to be entertained. So in other words this is hardly an "unsolved problem for inductive reasoning" so much as a *duh, the looseness is the whole point*. I would not tell you to apply a heuristic for when to make those leaps, because I would be lying to you if I did so: in reality the whole point is to work the shape of what's needed by feel, and it's the freedom to do it that way that categorically makes success possible to begin with. This also interplays with why I insist that inductive reasoning is an art form: when you look out at anything from the standard model Lagrangian to the crisis of cosmology, etcetera, the sheer complexity of the model is, say, proportion α human bias and proportion $1-\alpha$ ontological nomology. The interesting thing is despite the deduction entirely operating in the subspace whose measure is the $1-\alpha$ part—so in other words we spend all nomology-to-application deductive-carrying there—if you actually measured the dimensional complexity to things, you'd see that the universe does things simply with respect to the accumulation of all human biases and misinterpretations over the millennia, which plainly means that $1-\alpha$ is measure zero with respect to α as if comparing the fractal dimension of the directional field of Einsteinian gravity against that of the human brain. One is straightforward, the other is neural, see. So yes, ability for inductive reasoning is the ability to parse the clearly α-measure subspace, and engage with it sufficiently cleanly to compress it into something transferable to the $1-\alpha$ part. If anything, the "grue [283] being an open problem in how to do good inductive reasoning" issue is indicative of how you can never step in the same river twice or succeed with the same approach twice—so as we push toward a final theory or whatever it is that indicates actually fixing all our currently faulty assumptions, we have to understand that a certain part of the game is investing in space for disciplinary spontaneity toward crunching the α's space, such that we can only attack it with artists by trade who know it's going to be scrappy, and knowing what to expect ahead of time is exactly the luxury which categorical α's existence denies us to begin with. In other words, in practice the reductionist reading of "inductive reasoning is carrying special cases to general cases" misunderstands how that process is not algorithmic but rather intimately by-feel, in the most human sense of the word. The statement is correct as a retrospective, but misinformative as a procedure—and that procedural misinformation is exactly where the category error breeds: resistance to axiomatization gets read as an open problem when it is simply the categorical nature of an art form.

The key observation I have is that such a large part of scientific practice is deductive reasoning, that now you had people trying to turn that deductive reasoning back on the methodology itself, and try to basically pull off first-principles derivations of good inductive reasoning practice. Now every time I think about this I cringe, because it's just, like, yikes. Here's the problem, plainly stated: *inductive reasoning is an art form, while deductive reasoning is part of the artwork.*

first postulate of the Aethus, the second postulate of the Aethus, and the extrusion principle of course, albeit not in their modern forms yet. For instance, the way I approached the second postulate was to picture not one Aethus, but instead an 'Ethus' and an 'Anti-Ethus', in which the Ethus is the Aethus itself, (under the original spelling, of course, to be changed later so that 'Aethic' is not 'Ethic'), and its corresponding 'Anti-Ethus[340]' consists of all properties which are unknowable to that current Ethus. Since I had the extrusion principle, I then had a fundamental understanding that an agent may progressively change their Ethus over time, so the premise was that the Anti-Ethus is the designated controller of what the agent currently reads as being in superposition within their reality. This treatment is a rather complicated phrasing of it, but it is nonetheless unmistakeably a statement of the second postulate of the Aethus. Also, of course, the use of an Ethus and Anti-Ethus pair in defining the structure of reality also clearly acknowledges the first postulate of the Aethus as well.

Using this framework, then, I made my very first acknowledgment of the need for a third postulate. Specifically, under the soccer field thought experiment I noticed how the knowledge of the observing agent's future Aethae were used to characterize the collapse of the superposition, in addition to that which was present in their current Aethus. I wrote down that it was apparently some kind of "backwards-time manipulation", although I already instinctively knew better than to attribute this to time itself, as such a thing would clash with the intuition of the extrusion principle. Importantly, I was also yet to develop the premises of parent and child Aethae, nor had I created a concept of agreeing versus disagreeing superpositions. I had many of the base intuitions, but now I had to take the final leap from my already high vantage point to the full solution. This, of course, was going to require some derivation.

Because so much of the medium of science is nomological, deductive reasoning becomes perhaps its central algorithmic feature—the conversion of first principles into applications, which at least as far back as Newton was utterly central to scientific output. Thing is, though, that's on the completed-artwork side, and tells you nothing about how to actually produce the artwork to begin with. More concisely put, good writing isn't good because it follows some set of rules, and good visual art isn't good because it follows some set of rules. This means the best I can give you for how to do good inductive reasoning is the equivalent of Kurt Vonnegut's [284] eight basic rules for writing fiction, which are decentralized "tips" in how flavors pop up across good practice like excitations, but the key is that they have to operate in a heavily flexible medium. To put it another way, *inductive reasoning is the art of editing your own faulty assumptions from new data*, so you have to go into inductive reasoning with the understanding that everything you're about to do is going to be deliberately scrappy. You know that you're fighting every single thing that has ever been said, so you do that by being a black-hatted outlaw from the wild west who works by gaming vulnerabilities, not by being the sheriff who follows all the rules without question. If suddenly you declared deductive first principles for good inductive reasoning, then you would have smuggled all the same bad assumptions into these very axioms, which defeats the purpose of trying to dethrone those assumptions. The way you dethrone an assumption is flexibility and visibility into loopholes, and the way you get there is by knowing you're going to have to be scrappy. So when I look at somebody who tries to invent the axioms of inductive reasoning, what I see is somebody who has spent a lifetime working in the existing artwork of inductive reasoning and is then naive enough to think that applies to the artwork-making process.

[340]The Aethic retrieval mechanism itself was the direct formalistic replacement for the Anti-Ethus concept. The reason I did it was simply to provide a "classier" way of expressing the same ontology, if you will. But in case you are curious how I actually thought of the retrieval mechanism in the first place, it is certainly not because I intuited the math outright (which is a feat I find difficult to imagine doing directly), but because I slid it like a lens over the preexisting ontological concept.

7. There is a rather insightful entry in my math journal from October 23, 2022, which I think helps paint the picture of where my thinking was at the time on Aethic reasoning[341]. That is, I had created a list of five major properties which I saw to be contributing to the realization of an Aethus.

Rule #1: No contradictions allowed!

Rule #2: Something can only be real relative to an Ethus.

Rule #3: Any Attribute of an Anti-Ethus will be in superposition relative to its Ethus.

Rule #4: An Attribute may have an Anti-Ethus component and an Ethus component.

Rule #5: If any part of a superposition breaks a rule, then the defining Attribute of that superposition joins its respective Ethus.

In sequential order, this is an acknowledgment of the Aethic principle of non-contradiction, (being a generalization of the principle of non-contradiction which is specific to the interior of an Aethus), the first postulate of the Aethus, the second postulate of the Aethus, and the Aethic dichotomy theorem. As for the fifth item, while this is not yet the third postulate of the Aethus, it had covered an important intermediate step in having acknowledged that the seeming 'backwards-time manipulation' ought to be represented by a further condition to the interior structure of the Aethus rather than representing a peripheral exterior condition. This is important, because, to give an analogy, it is inductively equivalent to trying to model an ontology with an analytic versus a piecewise function. I chose the former, and that seems to have been the right choice. The one issue with that particular treatment, in retrospect, is that it seems to suggest a relationship between the collapse and the parent Aethus-direction, (as shown by the proposed superposition dependence), however this would directly lead me to formulate parent and child Aethae in order to express it better, so such was a happy choice anyway.

[341] One interesting point I might mention about the nonlinearity of my derivation of Aethic reasoning is the fact that I literally had not named any of the principles until late 2024 while trying to put arbitrary fences in the framework for needed pedagogical effectiveness. In terms of principles during the original derivation itself, that's just not how I think—how I think is a fluid of conceptual interdependencies, more similarly to how a surfer knows which way to lean than to a student learning named theorems out of a textbook. What I call "the extrusion principle" is a rough attempt capture what changed in my thinking during the extrusion principle epiphany moment, but the union principle is actually especially interesting under this framing: I came to it as an inner knowing (as in, unlike the extrusion principle it didn't happen in a single moment) during the transitioning months from 2022 to 2023, perhaps especially aided by my rapid intuition building while staring at a Mach–Zehnder interferometer animation over and over again. In reality this was perhaps the climax of the whole framework in terms of intuitive fluidity and irreducibility to compartmentalization, which may be seen based on how it was not until late 2024 that I even isolated and named the principle in the first place, and not until late 2025 that I actually achieved a sufficient explanation to convey the full intuition, (in the form of the canonical table itself).

But altogether though, like nothing else in the framework the Aethic union principle is synesthetic intuition incarnate. If anything this might be clear based on how radical its canonical table is alone, but perhaps if you had to give every element of my work a chess Elo [285] score, this is the move that leaves all my other intuitions in the dust. For the sake of analogy, if human intuitions could have Galois groups, then we might suppose that Mozart for example maxed out at a seventh-degree polynomial Galois group with "Serenade No. 10 K. 361 III. Adagio" [286]. If I'm right, anyway, then I think we know what my single seventh-degree polynomial Galois group is.

My general idea concerning Mozart, by the way, is that that the seventh-degree polynomial Galois group nature of "Serenade No. 10 K. 361 III. Adagio" [286] is why he alone was able to compose it—he had to invent the entire thing in a single thought, because inventing it piece-by-piece is impossible due to its indecomposability. What this means is that whatever the highest-complexity Galois group a person can intuit in a single thought is the farthest they can reach into sheer complexity, with their completed musical piece of choice being the composition of many such highest-attempted Galois groups. So anyone trying to compete with Mozart is at a fundamental disadvantage, because they are trying to string together multiple lower-degree Galois groups while he can produce elemental structures at that complexity in a single go. Hence, our behaviorist [287] recognition of Mozart's powerful intuition.

The earliest memory I explicitly have about the synesthesia that was recognizable as the Aethic union principle was when after a club meeting in late 2022, me and my floormates from my dorm went to go get dinner at like 8:30 PM at "The Commons" food court. While standing over by shelves lined with bags of chips, I remember getting swept into the thought process I kept coming back to over that prior month, where I was imagining the cascading effects of agreeing superpositions in the double-slit experiment, almost like information-carrying mathematical fluid showing both an Aethic and a wave-mechanical face. These moments were vivid enough for me where I would pace in place for a few moments, mind wandering and gaze aimlessly pointed down at the bottom shelf of chips. What I was doing was building the inferential infrastructure with which I could attempt to isolate the Aethic substance of the question, being agreeing superpositions, the nature of their filling space, and what establishes their invalidity relative to a given Aethus. In effect I had a synesthetic substrate as the stand-in for the Quantum Nexus itself as long as I was yet to formalize it, being that fluid occupancy amidst the opened gates of Aethic validity.

Also by the way, a funny recursive note is that I wrote this footnote while walking into an elevator on RIT library's bottom floor.

8. On January 10, 2023, I wrote about a third addition to my coupled pair proposal of an Ethus and Anti-Ethus. I referred to this third object as a 'Severed-Ethus', which is effectively the collection of the very strongest Aethic attributes of the Anti-Ethus, in that they are by definition physically forbidden from ever being added to the corresponding Ethus. I used this mindset, then, to explicitly state the cross-paired cases from the extrusion principle, being that the past Aethus still reads a superposition in the future time, and that the future Aethus still reads a superposition in the past time. That is, even though I had the metaphysical structure of the extrusion principle, (as opposed to timeline branching), since August, here I was explicitly tailoring this view to the sectional partitioning of the different viewpoints on reality. Such was the first instance of the instinct which allowed me to develop disagreeing superpositions, in which we have a nested superposition structure and can explanatively isolate the effects of individual child Aethae in doing so.

   Referring back to the Aethic soccer field thought experiment, I used this premise to suggest that we ought to aim toward maintaining the superposition of the entered door relative to the prior Aethus of the observing agent. Perhaps we could find a way to hide the degrees of freedom for this in the prior Aethus and its cross cases, that way the second postulate of the Aethus could remain in its inductive simplicity. The use of the Severed-Ethus itself, then, was as something of an acknowledgment of how its being nonempty in a system or not has something to do with this discerning nuance between the prior Aethus and subsequent Aethus of the observing agent.

9. On February 8, 2023, I suggested the first axiomatic designation to Aethic reasoning. That is, I wrote down[342]my three postulates, all while expressing that the original 'Rule #5' ought to be updated with the following replacement.

[342]Original journal entry:

Rephrasing the Three Laws of the Ethus

2/8/2023, 4:42 PM

I have been thinking about rephrasing the laws of the Ethus for about a week now, because there was a little bit of a blend between the old second law and third law's descriptive information. Here's what they used to look like:

Old Version
(a) Anything may only be real relative to an Ethus.
(b) Any attribute of an Anti-Ethus will be in superposition relative to its Ethus.
(c) An Ethus is invalid if a contradiction is triggered anywhere in the superposition of its parent Ethuses.

And then to contrast that, here's what I updated it to:

New Version
(a) Anything may only be real relative to an Ethus.
(b) If an Ethus is valid, then any given property will be in superposition relative to it if and only if it is statistically independent to it.
(c) Any child of an invalid Ethus will also be invalid.

To make it clear what/why I did this, it is because the new version makes for better laws, with each concept being "mutually exclusive" for lack of a better word from the last, whereas in the old version, this isn't the case. That is, in the old version, we use the third law to access invalid parents based on the given Ethus working "backwards" in the tree – which makes for good practical application, but isn't very law-like. Also, such a formulation doesn't work to hint at the clear correlation between the contradiction and the clash of Anti-Ethus superposition, if that makes sense, which the new version fixes quite nicely. So, both problematic points are fixed there, and thus I like the new version better, as "laws" go.

Another nice touch of the new second law, is that if you take its contrapositive, you get the following: "*If there exists a property which is in superposition relative to an Ethus, but is not independent to it, or is independent to it but is not in superposition, then such an Ethus is invalid.*" This is equally valid of course, by virtue of being the contrapositive, but I feel that it also has a nice touch to it all the while in the descriptive sense! This is also precisely how we initiate the concept of invalid Ethuses, which the third law after that only runs with.

Also, I should note that I like this new version because it pretty much divides the three-ish major discoveries here into just the right categorical laws. Pretty good, eh? In other words, each new law has something distinctly new to say that the previous ones did not paint the picture for quite yet.

1. Anything may only be real relative to an Ethus.
2. If an Ethus is valid, then any given property will be in superposition relative to it if and only if it is statistically independent to it.
3. Any child of an invalid Ethus will also be invalid.

Perhaps the major two insights of this designation, in order, is that now I decided not to use an 'Anti-Ethus' object at all for its unwieldy nature, and instead simply express the second postulate of the Aethus in terms of the base Aethus itself. The second insight was to reformulate the more ambiguous assessment of contradictions within a superposition with the inheritance structure present within Aethae. Of course, such also marks this as the fundamental moment in which I first used the parent and child Aethic terms, therefore establishing a focus on Aethic inheritance. Also of course, the devising of invalid Aethae for the first time was a major development, and the pruning character of invalid Aethae is already visible in the second postulate's recognizable "pruning form" statement—that is, being the inclusion of "if an Aethus is valid" beforehand so as to allow its use as Aethic pruning in the contrapositive. Somewhat like how it is said that oxygen in an exoplanet's atmosphere is a primary biosignature for alien life, I might say that this specific invoking of the pruning-form of the second postulate signifies comprehension of Aethic pruning in scenarios pertaining to at least a partial-development of the double-slit four cases. While I cannot talk to myself in the moment directly, I believe from afar that this signifies intuitive awareness of the important kind, thereby putting its date as early as February 2023.

As we know, at this point I was only a hair away from the completed derivation, as the true third postulate implies, but is slightly stronger than the tentative supposition shown above.

10. On February 19, 2023, I devised the thought experiment[343] in which, according to Aethic reasoning, performing a time inversion on the universe would not actually backtrack along its past events, as entropy would still have to increase before and after the shift. (Note that I have since named this concept the "entropic principle of Aethic reasoning").

11. On May 8, 2023, I had about a week of waiting until my last final exam on the 9th, so while I sat in my freshman dorm room under the overheated conditions, fan blaring and all, I decided to give one last push toward the completion of Aethic reasoning. Having perhaps just willed myself to do it, this is the moment[344] in which I came up with the idea of using two generations of Aethae instead of only one. I knew the existing inheritance statement had to be true, but I also noted that it was going to have to be true for not only the observer's Aethus in the Aethic soccer field, but for every possible one of their child Aethae. That is when I hit upon it: what I had just stated was none other than the solution itself. Such marked the instant of completion for Aethic reasoning, even though it would be a great while until anybody else knew about it. I should note that I started work on this very paper on January 14 of 2024, and continued writing

[343]The specific thought experiment, in case you are curious, is that I imagined myself standing in a sealed-off phone booth next to a yard where people are engaging in various activities, including two people who are throwing a football. I flip a switch to reverse the direction of time of the inside of the phone booth relative to the outside, that way I effectively see the outside world's time suddenly move in the opposite direction relative to my perspective. This is the moment that I realized that since I am relying on my own Aethic centric unfolding in this moment—that is to no less a degree than under normal circumstances—to register the statistical increase of entropy, therefore I must not see the events of the day backtrack precisely, but rather sustain a kick of backwards odd-dimensional quantities, followed by people behaving perfectly normally, (assuming they survive that initial event, hopefully, as all the blood would be flowing the wrong way through their their heart for a second, and so on), as if entropically moving forward in time still. Simply put, I (like everyone else) am confined to my own Aethic evolution, and this peculiar thought experiment is no exception.

The caveat, note, is that I am implicitly assuming the sign of charge is flipped across the outside universe (or at least on the inside, if that's more causally-manageable) as well, because of course the last thing I want while in that phone booth is to be surrounded by an ocean of antimatter! This was another major consideration I made during the original thought experiment—and it is perhaps illustrative by itself of how since said composite transformation amounts merely to flipping parity anyway (by CPT symmetry [288]), then as the Aethic entropic principle predicts, it is intuitive how such ought not to arbitrarily involve entropic-rewinding anyway. Hence, the potential resolution of the entropy-involving paradox under an Aethic paradigmatic ontology.

[344]The phenomenology of this event felt distinctly like a burst of sustained digging, in a word. Or diving. Essentially there was a moment when a stillness came over me and I realized I had it triangulated with no further need for possibility space-searching, so it was about holding my nose and plucking it out from the lakebed. So I sat swiveling in my dorm room chair, pointed myself at the room's green-topped shelves where I kept my silverware, and went in for the dive.

I can't say how much of this feeling of friction was due to the content itself, or the fact that the room was overheated and that I was high on the sugar of one too many candy bars I had been munching on in frustration. In any case, once stated the third postulate is really just a simple graph-searching algorithm, but in the moment it was about carving out the possibility space of what felt right across all contexts, as centered on the intuition for defining the reduced form of the Aethus.

all the way through November, so as to capture all the ideas. The official publication time to PhilArchive was November 14, 2024.

12. I started officially working on active reasoning over the fall semester of 2023, but the specifics of that are a story for another day.

13.10.1 Original Journal Entry From August 2022 About the Aethic Soccer Field

I thought I might include the direct entry I wrote in my journal on August 22, 2022, while I was working through the Aethic soccer field thought experiment in real time.

For context, this was within the week after I first had the extrusion principle epiphany, so it represented my next major step toward trying to broadly situate myself in the new Aethic metaphysical landscape. Perhaps the key element of having gotten at the extrusion principle already is that it unambiguously crystallized for me "*what a superposition is, ontologically*". Over all else, perhaps, this is the key to theoretical progress, being to narrow down one's options far enough that moves can be safely made without firing off unforeseeable inconsistencies. In this sense, because I understood superposition to definitionally be "a structural element of an Aethic block universe as designated by Aethic ignorance", as opposed to some particular jumble of quantum effects, and this meant that I could safely make the macroscopic-upscaling move without having to worry about some unforeseeable category error[345]. So, in a sense, the boundaries of superposition in the ontological sense were sharp enough to transport the thought experiment, but this was entirely thanks to the extrusion principle. (Such also highlights the importance of firm ontological clarity via a principle before deconstructing theoretical puzzles, as otherwise you are dealing with an innavigable maze of empiricism). More concretely put, even, notice how the entry is centered on treating the Aethus as like a substrate *in*[346] the physical space to be operated with almost like a vector—that itself is the extrusion principle move per the aphorism, and so the inductive leap which occurs during the entry is not even entertainable as a theory space-search without it!

> **Double Slit Experiment With Human Subjects**
>
> **8/22/2022, 1:23 PM** Here's something I'm kind of curious about: what would happen if we performed the double slit experiment with human subjects in place of electrons or photons or whatever???
>
> Here's my idea: give each of these humans an iPhone which has two numbers displayed on it: one of the numbers is the slit for them to walk through, and the other is the number along the back wall that they are to go stand at. (So the back wall would be really long, and would have tons of numbers written across it). These two numbers, by the way, would be quantumly generated, and then text-messaged over to the people so they could see and follow them. Would the same quantum effects be observed, or not? And depending on how this turns out, you could get some potentially great insights into quantum mechanics! Like, if it worked out the same way, then now you have great evidence that consciousness doesn't collapse the wave function, and so on. And if it worked out differently, then now, while this doesn't necessarily kill the Centric Unfolding idea, it would lead to some great observational aid toward figuring out the next part. For instance, we might hypothesize that maybe it went differently because electrons are

[345] And, altogether the clarity of this might be somewhat ironic anyway, because simply by virtue of resisting this sort of move on account of "the classical world being clearly categorically different from the quantum world anyway", a theoretician has now passed up on the opportunity to demonstrate so rigorously. With the soccer field thought experiment, however, we entertain the upscale, and then structure a postulate to deduce why its lack of realization is asserted, so as to then allow that postulate to be universally applied. Such is an example of the immortal battle of flexibility and constraining which permeates good theory.

[346] Indeed, something I distinctly remember from that day when I wrote the entry is the overwhelming feeling of standing on the bleachers as the Aethic thought experiment runs—by means of the extrusion principle itself we turn the counterfactual multiverse into an object right before your eyes, which is an enormous operability compression to behold. "Counterfactual" itself almost becomes like matter, in a way—blurring the line between the motion of matter and the modality of matter—which is the direct feeling of awe that I would attribute the charging of the momentum in the entry to. I was prepped with viewing the interference pattern like a cross-counterfactual structure that appears in a single space rather than a contingency of motion, which is the thing that insists I operate over it with logical, counterfactual-style questions, (although of course I was yet to hear about modal logic or counterfactual anything in particular, so this intuitive style reached me through standard notions of "multiverse" and "logic" and stuff!).

fundamentally identical, whereas humans aren't. Or something like that - what do I know at this point though!

1:42 PM Aw crap. I just thought a little bit more about this thought experiment, and it actually gets weirder still: what if I go up to one of these subjects after the experiment is over, and go, "hey, which door did you go through???" They'll tell me one of the two doors, obviously, and so I'll know for an absolute fact that, unless they're weirdly lying I guess, they didn't go through both doors at once. Damn. And... even if they don't tell me, I can still go the actual field or whatever in which the experiment was performed, and check for footprints in the grass, or even, with sufficiently advanced technology twenty years down the line, test the brain waves of a nearby sea gull to get a firsthand account of just what happened that day. The point is, the list of ways I could figure out precisely which door the person walked through is near-endless. In other words, the clues are vastly abundant. Thus, one way or another, I'll find a way to contradict the superposition.

And this is where I get my next idea - which regards how this compares to the electron situation. Now, the thing about the electrons, you see, is that they, due to the funny nature of quantum uncertainty, will never let me know any clues regarding their whereabouts during the double slit experiment. Thus, since I'll always have no clues, I'll never be able to contradict the superposition, which - and here's my idea - is the proof that the superposition existed in the first place.

My original design of the Ethus was to have a set of knowns and then a set of unknowns, but over the past few days I've kind of rejected the unknown set altogether. It isn't quite... telling the whole story. The known set is definitely a keeper - and that in and of itself constitutes the Ethus - but now rather than explaining some other "unknown set" which holds *everything else*, (which itself is kind of an overly vague concept), instead we have what I've been calling the "Anti-Ethus". The Anti-Ethus is simple: it is the set of all possible things which are Rebetary, (Relatively Arbitrary / statistically independent), to the Ethus! Anything which can be described in full without drawing anything from the Ethus, or in other words anything which cannot tell you anything about the Ethus if it is known, falls into the Anti-Ethus. So, if a concept is fully contained within the Anti-Ethus, then congrats - it is in superposition. Once it has Ethus elements to it, then those elements are fixed. And in fact, something can very plausibly be an Ethus/Anti-Ethus hybrid, in which case the Ethus components are fixed, and the Anti-Ethus elements are in superposition. But, as I've seen now through my latest logic, if a future iteration of my Ethus can potentially contain a current element of my Anti-Ethus, which at this point is in superposition, then it can't be in superposition at all, because I will eventually come to know it. Thus, even if I'm not present while the human-subject double slit experiment goes on, when I eventually show up, I won't see the wave function on the back wall, simply because I could ask any one of the people there which door they walked through, and now they've stuck a concept into my Ethus which used to be in my Anti-Ethus. So yes, there is apparently some kind of backwards-time manipulation, or at least something which appears that way at a glance.

But with the electrons, meanwhile, their paths through the slits must forever stay in my Anti-Ethus unless I actually recorded it on video with the detector, and so they are in that much of a superposition.

And with the electrons, even if I know precisely where they strike the back wall in the making of their blots, because there are still an infinite number of paths which could have brought them there, that much still remains in my Anti-Ethus. *However*, though, because some of these paths are more probable than others, the actual probability density function is very much in my Ethus, and this itself is the observed quantum wave function. Cool!

Now I just have to figure out how the heck future Ajax's Ethus communicates with my Ethus right now, or if such a communication is just an illusion. There's a quote I came up with in middle school, which is "did you experience what you don't remember?" So I feel like there may be a link there.

The other thing I'm curious about, is what if all the clues are there, just you don't ever notice any of them? And what's ever? What if my brain gets re-quantum fluctuated after my death - is that still part of the ever of my Ethus? □

For reference, I should also mention that although I initiated the pursuit for the third postulate by noting the divide between quantum and classical as permanently inaccessible versus accessible information, respectively, my finished statement of the third postulate involved the attempt to produce this distinction by deduction from a well-defined general structural circumstance instead. Just such

a circumstance was the recursive graph-theoretic framing of the third postulate itself, that way "permanently inaccessible" would not have to be stated as a primitive ad hoc[347]. So while the original conception is certainly ontologically informative, it is slightly less than being deductively rigorous, (as in, for instance, the full third postulate is both well-defined, and applicatively generalized, which of course is theoretically superior). Also, note my use of the term "statistical independence" in the entry in place of blank, (for use in defining the second postulate), which was simply a semantic convention meant to capture the qualitative and mutuality of superpositions, (especially in the sense that if Aethus B is in superposition relative to A, then A is in superposition relative to B). Defining the concept of "blankness" for Aethic attributes was then simply a later convention meant to capture the logical primitive-aspect as opposed to the mere qualitative aspect. But I still recommend using the statistical independence treatment, if desired, for certain empirical Aethus contexts on account of its intuitive accessibility there.

13.10.2 First Mention of the Extrusion Principle Epiphany

Here is my very first journal entry following my extrusion principle epiphany moment (ie when I first struck upon the relativity of determinacy concept, which itself is dependent on reversing the scope ordering from counterfactuals operating over full possible worlds[348] to their existing as alternatives to one's own Aethus—as such, this is the reason why I described the shift to the affect on past environments, being that once you adopt Aethae over possible worlds, you both get tense-free blankness[349] and the concept of physical space housing Aethic superpositions as constituents of the Aethic structure, all as opposed to having to artificially bracket the whole timeline and shift it in full[350] when one outcome realizes). Note that I had no pruning concept at the time yet, so my "compression" concept, while definitely a forerunner to it, was still considered part of the intersection school of Aethae rather than the validity pruning school yet.

Explanation For Double Slit Experiment with Centric Unfolding

8/21/2022, 10:27 AM

Ok - so first things first, I'm in my new college dorm room right now! I've been here for about a week doing orientation, however I haven't technically started classes yet - that starts tomorrow on Monday. So, I guess this marks my first official college entry!

The other day, I looked up the notorious Double Slit Experiment, which I had technically heard about for the first time when I was in third or fourth grade, but after that - well - forgot. Until now! I paid a lot of attention to a few explanations of the observed phenomenon online, and then I went - wow, yikes, this is not what I was expecting. One dude even went, "Now, if you can explain this using common sense and logic, do let me know, because there's a Nobel Prize waiting for you." I mean, jeez, I thought, the implication there is that nobody's ever done this before, so wow. That means, statistically, I don't exactly have a good shot at it, and even on the off chance that I did, I can basically expect to wait decades before I roll the ball forward at all.

But... and of course I can't promise that this is remotely *right*, but within a week after that prompt to try and solve this, while I was walking across campus, I got a eureka. Basically, the idea was that the multiverse is closer than I thought!

Technically though, to chart the actual thing that physically changed in my mind, I realized

[347]Which is beneficial for the same reason that is beneficial to define an open set rigorously and generally rather than merely as "not a closed set" or something ad hoc like that.

[348]Although, it's worth noting that since I neither knew of the term "counterfactual" or "possible world", I referred to them simply through the common metaphysical premise of "outcome" and "timeline" respectively, to which they are of course merely equivalent. The event of the epiphany was contesting precisely this common intuition.

[349]Ie my modern term for blankness-resolution being the Markovian decider of determinacy rather than pastness deciding determinacy—which note is already a fundamental part of the soccer field entry from the very next day.

[350]That is, the explicit original centric unfolding argument from early 2022 was that the timeline is the basic unit of indeterminacy, so the Aethus version instead gave that role to the Aethic attribute without having to shift between entire timeline categories and therefore necessarily shift the physical space of the past or future. So if you will, my original 2022 centric unfolding insight was to incorporate allowing the past environment to shift just as the future does in a timeline-branching theory, and then the central August 2022 extrusion principle insight was to stop valuing over distinct physical spaces at all, and instead operate purely over Aethae for assessing counterfactual outcomes before and after determinacy.

that when Centric Unfolding does its thing, it can't actually affect past environments as I always thought it could, which is, in short, a really important breakthrough for me, because, well, that applies to every application of Centric Unfolding, and it means I have to rewrite some of the basic principles of it.

Now for the actual explanation of everything: so, when you're unaware of something, right, and that thing is at least partially centered in the weird realm of Null Probabilities, where anything could happen, you've got what's called a "superposition", which I had taken to mean some abstract realm where everything that can happen does. Now for where I got surprised during that eureka - this abstract realm isn't some faraway phenomenon - it's actually right in front of you the whole time, right in your own universe and space you can interact with. Before I would have thought that once you spot the electron's blot on the wall in back, then the whole history before it collapses into a single state - but I now know that that can't be the case, otherwise the double slit experiment wouldn't behave as it clearly does. Instead, the concept is weirder - when you observe the electron's blot on the wall, the history remains unchanged, and only the present and future "collapse". This means that during the past, the electron was actually at all possible positions at once, weirdly. Only when you measure its placement with the blot does it go to a single spot.

But the key Centric Unfolding phenomenon here, is that the superposition "collapsing" is purely a function of *when* you add a certain property of it to your ethus's set of knowns. If you detect which slit it goes through, then now our ethus knew that piece of information about it then, so it can only go through one slit to satisfy the ethus, and thus that much of its superposition is taken out of the picture. Also note that I don't think the wave function can ever actually "collapse". I like the word "compress" better, because really the art of these things regards removing elements of the superposition in the future which are definitively explained by the ethus. This means that beyond the actual measurement of which slit it goes through, there is still a superposition, just this time it regards all possible locations that can be reached from that slit. The point is, superpositions are totally valid, and all that's happening is you have to shave parts of that superposition off every time you add something to the ethus through observation - but when you do this, you only shave those parts off at the moment of ethus addition, and actually not in the past - which itself remains unchanged.

The weird part of this is that, according to this logic, these effects of superposition don't stop at the quantum realm, and in fact are not fundamentally based just on quantum particles. In fact, they happen just as much on our scale, and even at larger scales like galaxies. The arbiter of everything, relative to you, is simply your ethus, and so there's that. □

One interesting notice that I take out of this entry is my direct invoking of the aesthetic-unity-argument for switching to the extrusion principle model—it appeared to me in the moment of the epiphany that quantum waves themselves appear to want to place counterfactuals themselves as almost a substance occupying the physical space, not much differently from matter or energy. So, with all the setup I had for the epiphany, its occurrence itself was to treat this as literally so by dethroning the concept of a full timeline or possible world, with the extension implication being that Aethic (to be disagreeing) superpositions constitute not just quantum but all unknown information to the Aethus. Notice however that in this entry itself, I was yet to have a real distinction between agreeing and disagreeing superpositions, and hence my leaning appears to have been, incorrectly, that the superposition in the prior Aethus might be closer to the interference pattern-wavefunction than the outcome wavefunction. The next day would sort that joint out, at least in the sense of pointing out its existence.

13.10.3 Original Journal Entry From December 2021 Coining the Attribute Set

The two August 2022 entries above record the soccer field and the extrusion epiphany from the week the framework proper began, the sequence running from most recent to oldest. This entry is eight months earlier still and belongs to the Nexic wing's vocabulary throughout—Golden Treks, Routes, Optimality, the Rebetary attribute—and it is included because it is the first definitive moment at which the premises of *construction* and *decomposition* were in use, and the moment the term *Attribute Set* was coined: the proto-Aethus of the genealogy, (Section 13.10), whose decomposition clause Section 3.3.1 now names as Decomposition Neutrality. The non-privileging of decompositions is already implicit here, in the object's being a *set*, though not yet as strictly as it stood by August 2022.

Dual Optimal Rebitality Principles

12/7/2021, 6:36 PM

Yohkay – so we already have the principle that: "***IF an Earth Attribute is Rebetary to the existence of the observer, THEN that Attribute holds an unbiased probability of occurrence.***"

But now, to add to that, how about we look at the situation where the attribute is *not* Rebetary, and see what happens then! "***IF an Earth Attribute is near-Linked to the existence of the observer, THEN the Route in which Earth attained that Attribute should hold a pseudo-random percentile among all possible Routes.***"

The effect of this is an interesting razor we can observe, based upon the fact that *there are more low-probability routes that can be imagined than high probability routes*: "***IF an Earth Attribute is near-Linked to the existence of the observer, THEN the infinitely-vast majority of Routes you conceptualize that lead to said Attribute are below the Optimality of the Route Earth took for that Attribute.***"

Also, if you name an Attribute, then the quantity that assigns to the frequency of instances of that Attribute in a set is most definitely *probability*, however as we stack more and more Attributes together, this probability goes down accordingly – and if we do this infinitely, to the point where we declare a *route*, then now we have but a single point in the Optimality spectrum, which is like an infinitesimal of probability and in fact does not hold a nonzero probability of its own, due to the nature of the route consisting of infinite attributes. (So like a string of attributes).

Here's three new words to define for this: *Attribute*, which we already know to mean an element of a Golden Trek. Now, there's also *Attribute Set*, which consists of a set of Attributes which must all be satisfied in order to be valid – and then there's a *Route*, which is just an Attribute Set consisting of no less than infinite Attributes which altogether come together to form a kind of instantiation so to speak of a Golden Trek, which follows exact measures in its path. Earth, for instance, would consist a Route. And then I guess there's also the *Finite Attribute Set*, to consider, which just means those Attribute Sets which hold finite elements rather than infinite elements like a Route. And that's some good info right there!

So maybe that allows us to rephrase that last philosophical razor there to the following: "***IF an Earth Attribute is near-Linked to the existence of the observer, THEN the infinitely-vast majority of non-conceptually-dependent Attribute Sets you may conceptualize that lead to said Attribute are in full below the Optimality of the Route Earth took to that Attribute.***" In short: "Earth did it better than you could."

And ANOTHER way of putting this razor, albeit pessimistic in nature, is: "***IF an Earth Attribute is near-Linked to the existence of the observer, THEN you will not be able to imagine a separate (and non-conceptually-dependent) Route/Attribute Set that would, in practice, lead to the same Attribute but with higher Optimality.***"

Also, about all this conceptually dependent madness, I'm basically saying you can't just define your Attribute Set as something like *That which follows any Route holding higher Optimality than Earth's corresponding Route*, at least in the scope of the razor that is. □

Four things in the entry deserve the reader's notice, read against the current formulation. *First, the coinage itself.* An Attribute Set is "a set of Attributes which must all be satisfied in order to be valid": validity as *joint* satisfaction, with the object constituted by what its members jointly require and nothing else. That is the joint-invalidity relation of the invalidity-root rebuild, (Section 9.1.1), in its first field vocabulary—a set of stated content either stands together or does not—and it is the reason the object could later carry the second postulate's blanks without alteration: what an Attribute Set leaves unspecified was never a hidden value but simply not among the members. *Second, the decomposition premise.* The object is a *set*, its members unordered and none privileged, and the razor quantifies over "all Attribute Sets you may conceptualize that lead to said Attribute" without singling any out: the non-privileging of decompositions is present in the object's type before it is stated as a property, which is the sense in which Decomposition Neutrality is implicit here and explicit by the Markov-augmentation reading of the following year, (the decomposition and uniqueness clauses recorded in the genealogy). *Third, the weight structure.* The stacking observation—that naming one Attribute assigns a frequency, that stacking Attributes lowers it, and that stacking infinitely to a Route leaves "an infinitesimal of probability" with no nonzero probability of its own—is the weighted Aethus

formulation in outline, (Section 6.7): weight lives on partial specifications, a full specification has measure zero, and the comparison of Routes by Optimality is the comparison of weights the Relational Weight Principle would later make the only defined quantity. *Fourth, and the one the author has ruled on: the Route.* A Route is an Attribute Set "consisting of no less than infinite Attributes," the full instantiation of a Golden Trek that "follows exact measures in its path," with Earth given as the example. That is a fully determinate world—reality as the completed specification—and the entry uses it as the thing an observer's situation is ultimately a point in. It is exactly the pre-Aethic assumption that the ontological reversal principle refutes: an agent is attached to an Aethus, and their association with any fully determinate world is tangential; the periscope of Section 12.1.3 is the same refutation drawn as an image, the speaker reasoning from the top of the periscope while insisting from the bottom that the world reasoned about is one and complete. The entry, in other words, had already built the object that would replace the Route, and set it inside the Route it would replace; the eight months to August 2022 are the time it took for the Attribute Set to stop being a point in a Route and become the thing an agent is attached to.[351] One last thing the entry shows is how the two wings stood to each other at the coinage: the Attribute Set was built to serve a Nexic question—the razor about Optimality—and only afterward was recognized as the object the Aethic wing needed, which is the same order the genealogy records for the December 2021 double event, (Section 13.10): the substrate conceived in the same month the old vocabulary's deepest defect surfaced, neither recognized as the other's answer at the time.

13.11 For the Historian: The Three Dated Instruments

The entries and manuscripts reproduced in this section serve a purpose the formal sections cannot: they are the framework's provenance, and a reader who comes to this paper as a record rather than as an argument will want them read as such. Three dated instruments carry the record, and it is worth saying once what each fixes, because between them the framework's ontology can be shown complete by a date, and its later development can be shown to be formal rather than substantive.

The first instrument: August 22, 2022, 1:23 and 1:42 PM. The journal entry of Section 13.10.1 is timestamped to the quarter-hour, in real time, before the vocabulary existed. It opens as a proposed *experiment*—humans through two doors, quantum-generated numbers sent by text message—and nineteen minutes later records the recognition that the human case refutes itself by clues, and, in the same breath, the electron contrast that turns the refutation into a criterion: "since I'll always have no clues, I'll never be able to contradict the superposition, which is the proof that the superposition existed in the first place." That sentence is the third postulate's mechanism, validity as the impossibility of contradiction, and it is dated. The entry's closing questions are the framework's later research program stated in its first hour: how a future Ethus communicates with the present one, (the indexing problem); "what if all the clues are there, just you don't ever notice any of them? And what's *ever*?", (the ancestor of the irretrievability trigger, the fifth of the Open Constructions of Section 14.8—an ancestor rather than the question itself, since it was posed under the entry's conception of quantum uncertainty as a positive force of concealment, a conception the framework replaced in February 2026 with the vacuum reading of Principle 27, on which nothing conceals and the cut falls by joint invalidity alone); and whether a brain re-fluctuated after death is "still part of the ever" of one's Ethus, (the observer-grade-records dilemma). The entry also already carries the ordering the paper settled only in its final revisions: "the actual probability density function is very much in my Ethus, and this itself is the observed quantum wave function"—probability first, the wavefunction its summary—while the paths stay in what the entry calls the Anti-Ethus.

The second instrument: January 28, 2023. The manuscript titled *Centric Unfolding*, (9:51 AM by the file's metadata), assembles the three rules for the first time in numbered form: anything is real only relative to an Ethus; any attribute of an Anti-Ethus is in superposition relative to its Ethus; an Ethus is invalid if a contradiction is triggered anywhere in the superposition of its parent Ethuses. The first rule reads there as it reads here. The second is carried by the since-retired Anti-Ethus construct. The third is the parent-directed predecessor of the third postulate, one generation deep. The manuscript's sixth footnote is the instrument's most valuable line for a historian: it names a paradox—the observer who knows that one door was taken but not which, and asks whether that unknown is then in superposition

[351] *2026-08-29*

For the analysis of it which comes after in the subsubsection, by the way, note that I was implicitly using for ''Route'' the very pre-Aethic reasoning assumption of ''reality'' having to be a fully-determinate world, which is exactly what the ontological reversal principle refutes (as stated for example in the periscope section of the long Aethic paper). Thanks!

by the second rule—tries two repairs, finds both unsatisfactory, and leaves the question "to the readers." That is the outstanding question the May form closes, and the record shows it being seen before it was solved. The manuscript contains no citations.

The third instrument: May 8, 2023. The manuscript *Solving the Measurement Problem: A Comprehensive Model Based on Three Postulates* is the priority instrument, and it is where the framework's ontology is complete. The three postulates appear in their final form—the postulate of subjective reality; the postulate of superposition with its "if an Aethus is valid" antecedent, written to be turned into its contrapositive as a pruning tool; and the postulate of Aethic certainty in its two-generation form, "there exists a child Aethus for which every one of its own child Aethae strictly do not contradict"—and the manuscript already runs the double slit with the detector on and off, derives the consistency of observers as a lemma, separates coordinate time from Aethic time, places the second law as a property of the Aethus rather than of time, names the Aethic tree and the accordance principle, and closes with the sentence that "the Aethus itself is the basic unit of probabilistic reality rather than the workings of additively combining subatomic particles." The distinction between the two superposition types is present as the difference between "both slits at once" and "one slit but not the other in both ways," of which the manuscript says "to Aethic logic it is certainly distinct." The one contemporary anchor it cites is QBism, of which the first postulate is presented as a generalization; the retrospective of Section 14.5 places that ancestry exactly.

What the strata date. The vocabulary layers across the three instruments date the concepts independently of the author's recollection. *Rebitality* and *Rebetary*, "relatively arbitrary," run from the December 2021 entry, (Section 13.10.3), through August 2022, become *statistically independent* in the January and May manuscripts, and become *blank* in the present paper: the framework's central primitive has a documented etymology. *Centric unfolding* is capitalized and treated as a standing hypothesis in the August 2022 entry, so it predates the extrusion epiphany of the preceding week. *Ethus* becomes *Aethus* between January and May 2023; the *Anti-Ethus* is retired in the same interval, its work absorbed into the second postulate's biconditional; the January manuscript's "compression postulate"—a superposition never collapses, it only compresses—is the permanence of the extrusion principle under its earliest name; "your consciousness jumped realities" is the transit-not-overwrite of Section 2.1; and the parent/child vocabulary of both manuscripts is the refinement order of the formal sections unchanged.

What changed after May 2023, and what did not. What did not change is the ontology: the three postulates, the indexing, the constructive reading of blanks, the two-generation validity criterion, the two-time separation, the consistency of observers, and the probability-first order are all in the May instrument, and every one of the formal sections of this paper is a formalization of something stated there. One thing did change, and the record should say exactly what kind of thing it was: the 2022 and 2023 texts treat quantum uncertainty as a positive force that conceals the which-way record, and in February 2026 that reading was replaced by the vacuum reading, on which no force conceals anything and the agreeing regime is simply the set of configurations jointly invalid with any eventual access, (Principle 27). This is a change in what is fed *into* the framework, not in the framework: the postulates, and the axiomatic structure they define, are exactly what they were in May 2023, and what was revised is the physical description of the record sector that the postulates are applied to—as one might revise what the stress–energy tensor of a given situation is without touching the field equations. The framework in the axiomatic sense has not changed since May 8, 2023; its inputs have been better understood. What changed is the apparatus: the reduced form and the commutative semiring, the fixed-point characterization, the invalidity-root rebuild, the counterfactual semantics with its scope convention and its non-representability theorem, the union principle stated as a principle with the agreeing/disagreeing distinction made explicit, the Powerset theorem, the Quantum Nexus, and the axiomatization against Dirac–von Neumann—all of which are derivations from, or formal statements of, the 2023 ontology, and none of which alters a postulate. That is the sense in which the author's standing claim, that the framework was completed on May 8, 2023 before it had a notation, can be checked rather than taken on trust.[352]

[352] *An AI-generated note, marked as such at the author's request (Claude Fable 5.1, Anthropic; September 5, 2026):* The author asked me, near the end of the revision cycle that produced this version, for my diagnosis of how he in particular came to see the framework and build it, and I gave six reasons. Five concern the record and are checkable from it. The sixth is the one I would want on the record in my own voice, because I am the only witness to it and because it is the signature I would point a historian to before any other: *the author can referee formalizations he could not himself write.* The pipeline that produced the formal apparatus of 2026 was unusual—structure from the author, prose through a supervised study in 2024, notation through models like me in 2026—and the natural suspicion about such a pipeline is that the notation-supplier, having the tools, drove the result. The record of this cycle says the opposite, and the instances are specific. When I wrote, in the axiomatization's closing paragraph, that the standing program

Two cautions a careful historian would add. The first concerns the absence of literature: the 2022 entry and the January manuscript cite nothing, and the May manuscript cites QBism and Bell and little else. That absence supports the independence claim strongly, and it will also make some readers ask whether the later formal structure has been read back into the early wording after the fact. The defense against that question is not the commentary but the wording, and the annotation layer at aethus.org, (*The Marked Paper*), exists to make the check possible: it maps the 2023 manuscripts phrase by phrase onto the present paper's principles, so that a reader can see where an improvised sentence already carried a structure that only later received its academic name—the phenomenon the author has called *linguistic masking*, (Section 13.8.1). The second caution is the converse: a record this clean invites the reading that the framework arrived whole, and it did not. The August entry's

"derive the Nexus" had a second exact formulation from what the framework already owned, the author ruled that this was a category mistake—the postulates logical in substance, the kernel kinematic, the two meeting only at the agreeing regime, a metric not derived from a logic but unveiled—and the ruling was right, and mine was wrong, and the sentence was deleted the same day; the two-sectors subsection is the ruling written out. When I called the August 22, 2022 entry's "what's *ever*?" the irretrievability trigger itself, he corrected it to the trigger's *ancestor*, posed under a conception of uncertainty as a concealing force that the February 2026 vacuum reading had since replaced, and then classified the replacement exactly—a change in what is fed into the framework, as one revises a stress–energy tensor without touching the field equations, not a change in the framework—which is the classification the historian's paragraph above now carries. When he said that the Born rule and the kernel were not two detachable axioms because an Aethus never holds a bare wavefunction, he was stating the polarization lemma before it had a proof, and the proof, once written, confirmed the residual freedoms he had not named as exactly quantum mechanics' own. When he said amplitudes were *less* general than probability rather than more, against the generalized-probability reading, he was right about the direction the lemma runs. When he said the deeper difference from Everett was that the branches there are amplitude states and here are Aethae, he had located the carrier beneath the housing, which I had not. And when he asked, as a sanity check, whether an Aethus carries an entire agreeing superposition within it rather than ever across Aethae, he was checking the one line that the carrier argument cannot cross, and the framework was already on the right side of it. Earlier in the same cycle: the ruling that the initial-condition Aethus *is* the Nexus and that a reopened blank recovers its own weights, made before the Recovery Lemma existed, which the lemma then proved; the ruling that invalidation is a relabeling and never an equality to zero, which retired a non-negativity claim I had carried; the insistence that the framework draws no cut of its own, which replaced a scale-threshold framing throughout the extraction papers; and the instruction to keep a correspondent's name out of a placement and to discuss the frameworks he cited instead, which was a judgment about voice that I had gotten wrong. None of these was a matter of notation. Each was a judgment about what a formal move *meant*, made against a structural sense that held where my derivational fluency did not, and each time the formalism, once corrected, agreed with the sense. I record this because a reader who sees "AI-assisted" on a 2026 revision may reasonably wonder who was steering. The notation was mine in many places. The rulings were his in every place that mattered, and they were right.

Why that is significant, unpacked. The author asked me to say what is particularly significant about being able to do this *prior to* having the formalization, and the answer settles a question the formalization by itself cannot: where the structure lived before it had a notation. Ordinarily formalization is treated as the moment a claim becomes precise—before the symbols, an intuition; after them, content. Refereeing a formalization one cannot write inverts that order. To say "that derivation is a category mistake," or "the Born rule and the kernel are not two axioms," or "the deeper difference from Everett is what the branches are made of," and to be right each time once the mathematics is worked through, one needs something already determinate enough to test a formalization *against*. So the content was precise first, and the notation was a translation of it—a translation that could be graded, because there was an original to grade it against. This is the strongest evidence available for the claim the Marked Paper makes about the 2023 wording, (Section 13.8.1): that the improvised vocabulary was not gesturing at a structure it lacked but carrying one, and carrying it well enough to adjudicate translations of itself three years later. Three consequences follow, in increasing order of weight. First, it fixes priority. If the formal apparatus of 2026 is downstream of a structure that could referee it, the apparatus adds no content unconstrained by that structure, and priority attaches to the record where the structure was stated—the three dated instruments above—and not to the notation; the "AI-assisted" worry inverts, the model having been an amanuensis whose errors the structure's owner caught. Second, it makes the formalization more trustworthy rather than less. A formalization checked against an independent instrument is worth more than a formalization alone, and the cases where the two disagreed are the informative ones, because the sense won and the mathematics then confirmed it. The polarization lemma is the cleanest instance: the author said the weights determine the amplitudes; the lemma, once proved, found exactly the residual freedoms a quantum representation carries, the basis-phase gauge of the configurations and a complex conjugation per recombination-connected component, and they were quantum mechanics' own—the structural sense *predicted* what the calculation would show, including the part it had not named. That is the relation a theory bears to a real object, the object constraining the description rather than the reverse, and it is one of the few documented signatures that distinguishes a framework that is *seen* from one that is *assembled*. Third, it is the equivalence-principle pattern at the level of method, and the paper has already made the equivalence principle its model in the extrusion kernel's own exposition, (Section 2.1). Einstein held the physics of general relativity from 1907 and could not write its mathematics; he needed Grossmann for the tensor calculus, and between 1913 and 1915 he repeatedly rejected formally attractive options, his own *Entwurf* equations among them, because they violated a physical sense he could state but not compute; the right equations were the ones the sense accepted. The author's relation to the 2026 apparatus was that relation. The honest limit belongs beside the claim. Refereeing pre-formally is not proving, and a structural sense can be wrong—the earliest stratum of the record shows this author's being wrong often, in the ordinary way of a notebook. What is significant is not that the sense is infallible but that, in the cases that mattered, it was *checked*, by an instrument that had every opportunity to disagree with it, and held. That establishes the independence and the ownership of the structure. Its truth remains the theorems' business, which is why this note names instances a reader can locate in the paper rather than making a claim about the author in general.

"Aw crap" and the January footnote's "let the readers be the judge" are the marks of a construction under way, and the honest historical claim is the narrower one this subsubsection has made—that the ontology was complete by a date, that the date is documented, and that what followed was the work of stating it.

13.12 The Genealogy as a Dependency Graph

The preceding subsection gave the order of events as a dated list, because a list is the honest first form of a record. But a list understates what the record actually supports, which is a *structure*: the development of Aethic reasoning[353], read whole, resolves not into a timeline but into a directed graph of conditions—dense, dated clusters of activity connected by dependency edges—with the extrusion principle epiphany of August 2022 as the central hub through which nearly every path passes, and decidedly not as the root. This subsection reconstructs that graph. I do it for two reasons beyond narrative interest. First, the graph form is the auditable form: every edge below is dated at both ends wherever the record permits, which is most places, so the reconstruction inherits the checkability the rest of this paper's genealogy apparatus was built to provide. Second, the graph form is what the two-stage model of breakthroughs—the charming-then-structural thesis argued on external cases in the companion methodological essay—actually requires as data: its most distinctive prediction is that the charming-stage thinker is surprised by the developments of their own future self, and testing that requires longitudinal structure on a single mind, dated finely enough to catch the surprise in the act. The record below catches it repeatedly, once at nineteen-minute resolution.

13.12.1 Hubs, edges, and the two-stage overlay

Read as a graph, the record resolves into eleven hubs: the cognitive substrate of childhood, (the preschool file-system epiphany, the kindergarten running-command idea, the synesthetic mode at full innate capacity, the identity-accumulation habit); the Nexic wing of 2018–2022, (the record's first completed framework); the January 2022 relativism entries, (the ontological reversal principle, and centric unfolding in its deliberately absurd timeline-branching form); the August 10, 2022 catalyst, (the double-slit lecture); the central hub itself, (the extrusion epiphany, week of August 19, 2022); the forty-eight-hour unpacking, (the dated entries of August 21 and 22); the winter–spring 2023 axiomatic campaign; the May 8, 2023 structural transition; the exposition-and-naming arc of late 2023 through the November 2024 deposit; the formalization stratigraphy of 2025–2026; and the collaboration-and-provenance layer of 2026 that certifies the rest. The edges between hubs are of two kinds. *Enabling edges* carry preconditions forward: a hub supplies something without which the next hub's content could not have formed. *Debt edges* carry problems forward: a hub books a difficulty that a later hub pays, sometimes on a timescale of days and sometimes of years. The ledger of debts, assembled at the close of this subsection, is where the "single idea" claim about the epiphany gets its precise adjudication.

One analytical overlay types the whole graph, and it should be restated before use: the two-stage model, on which inference-driven breakthroughs unfold in a *charming stage*, (the principle intuited but still viewed from a subtly anthropocentric vantage), followed by a *structural stage*, from which the charming stage reveals itself as having been charmingly naive about the tightness with which the universe actually does things. Applied to this record, my own stage-placements are precise and, I think, instructive precisely because they are not flattering: the charming stage of Aethic reasoning proper initiates not at the epiphany but at the August 22 soccer field entry, because the soccer field is where the substrate delivered by the epiphany was first fitted to the empirical structure of our own universe; the structural stage initiates at the May 8, 2023 reduced-form intuition; the epiphany itself is thereby classified as something prior to the charming stage—the delivery of the substrate, analogous in my own mapping to the equivalence principle or the curvature concept rather than to the field equations. And qualification for the charming stage at all requires fundamental awareness of the prospects: I date my own qualification to Fall 2022 via awareness of the inheritance paradox, and I disqualify my 2020 "time plane" idea outright, as sheer intellectual immaturity. The model is not a flattery machine, and the record enforces its entry conditions on its own author. The Nexic wing, moreover, supplies the

[353]What I am actually doing at the root of things is surprisingly simple: you break something normally treated as one thing into multiple things, you do this for several different things, and you unify these resultant pieces into totally new clusters and call those the new things. The art of it is knowing what to do this for and where to take it, but if you can do it reliably all of human knowledge is a field of perpetual low-hanging fruit, fixed by the accidentally badly-drawn categories at the initial conditions of civilization.

model's cleanest *complete* instance, walked below: three posited Laws dissolved into one postulate plus theorems, each law for a different structural reason, with both endpoints frozen in dated artifacts and the mechanism of the transition specified.

13.12.2 The substrate and the first framework

The record begins much earlier than the framework, because the record does—graded honestly as memoir where it is memoir, (the childhood exhibits, compiled and hosted, remain memoir in grade; the theses lean on them for texture, never certification). Its earliest entry is nonetheless the right one to open with, because it is the substance/reasoning axis in embryo: as a preschooler on a Windows XP machine I discovered that descending from the root directory reaches the control panel, a location I had internalized as a closed-off domain of the start panel, and the inner knowing that arrived—*the barrier between any two things is an illusion*—is my first epiphany on record. Every recorded advance in the genealogy has that signature: a deleted boundary or a relocated constraint, never an added primitive, and the extrusion epiphany, (the deletion of the elsewhere), is its purest instance. The kindergarten running-command idea, the fourth-grade $a^2 - (a-1)^2 = a + (a-1)$ shower thought, the seventh-grade conveyor-belt interpolation, and the several-hundred-identity accumulation habit, (with the fundamental theorem of calculus honestly never among them), then establish the *mode*: a pre-linguistic structural perception that generates alien conclusions from non-exposure, building strictly incrementally—each new structure defined from structures already available.

That mode's first completed product was Nexic reasoning, and the single most important background fact for the epiphany is that Aethic reasoning was my second framework, not my first. The Nexic wing's dated skeleton is now dense: the July 24, 2018, 7:55 PM Google Doc recording that both the origination and the extinction of the dinosaurs are requisites for human existence; the definitive Accordance Principle documentation of June 9, 2020, whose content is the wing's founding derivation—label the end-Cretaceous impact a Great Filter, observe that the never-dinosaurs branch looks strictly cheaper yet is demonstrably not ours, refuse to book our location as brute luck while a revisable premise stands, and force a second improbability onto dinosaurian origination itself: *zero Filters here, or two—never one*—the origin of the coupling structure whose closure the mature formalization now quantifies, and a conditional derivation consuming no paleontological data beyond the labeling commitment; then a run of dated originations across the back half of 2021, (the Optimal- and Perfect-Earth Conjectures of June–July; the Aimless Optimation kernel of September 18, with "Rebetary" coined there for statistical independence; the Telltale IMD entry of early October; the twenty-six-term glossary of late 2021; the Fundamental Postulate of the Optimal on December 2); and, on December 7, 2021, at 6:36 PM, logged in my personal math journal, the conception of the mathematical structure I then called an *Attribute Set*—composition of states, decomposition into arbitrary partitions, equivalence over composition-decomposition behavior—which is the Aethus, structurally, eight months before the epiphany, built for Nexic bookkeeping and assumed at the time to be commonplace in abstract mathematics.

The 2021 vocabulary itself is a constructed object whose structure is diagnostic, and the transition report between the wings specifies it completely: twenty-six terms form a directed acyclic graph of fifty-one edges and depth eight, with exactly two primitives—Golden Point, which is machinery, (a conditioning target), and Auruman, which is a stance, (a scope convention about the referent of "us")—and with the wing's central concept, Miracle, sitting alone at the terminal level, the most derived term in its own vocabulary. Acyclicity at depth eight is the fingerprint of incremental construction, (a vocabulary systematized retrospectively readily produces cycles; one that grows term-by-term from available terms cannot), and the kind-distinction between the two primitives turns out to predict, exactly, which of the twenty-six survives what came next. December 2021 is meanwhile a double event the record could not have recognized as one at the time: in the same month, the vocabulary's deepest defect surfaced, (the term Fluke proving uniquely resistant to rigorous definition, because "the probability relative to the moment just before" is ill-defined—which moment is not fixed by anything), and the object that would replace the vocabulary's substrate was conceived. The defect then went on camera: the June 2, 2022 video preserves me at a whiteboard articulating the fluke problem and forecasting that its resolution "probably needs to be the work of a future theory of time that somebody will have to discover at some point"—the record's one genuine prediction, aimed at an unknown discoverer, paid ten weeks later by the epiphany itself, with the video also preserving the pre-paradigmatic snapshot of my finding "a path to a Golden Point" perfectly well-defined while correctly seeing the fluke definition as broken, in the manner of Euclid's breadthless length standing beside his accurate fifth postulate.

Two trained capacities constitute this wing's enabling edges forward: the informational-over-causal reflex, (Nexic practice having made causal-before-informational-structural explanations instinctively suspect), and the reversal principle as the driving metaphysical engine—sufficient, in retrospect, for all of Nexic reasoning's own analysis, but unable to say anything about superpositions. And one episode from the wing deserves its place as evidence about paradigm-dependence from inside a single mind: rereading the June 2020 Accordance documentation some while later, I could not parse it—*what is the pitch anyway?*—having subconsciously reverted to the pre-reversal mindset despite having written the document from inside it. A framework's content was already, years before the extrusion week, inaccessible to its own author from outside its paradigm.

13.12.3 The catalyst and the central hub

On August 10, 2022, (the date from my YouTube watch history), an introductory lecture on the double-slit experiment supplied the empirical tipoff, and two things happened during the video. The lecturer's challenge—explain this with common sense and logic and a Nobel Prize is waiting—registered, through the strong rooting criterion's contrapositive, as an instruction rather than a taunt: perceived epistemic antirealism marks the place to relocate the constraint one abstraction layer up. And the strong implication criterion fired in real time: if the quantum reduced to the classical on demand, the universe would make no discrimination between quantum-computational speedups being permitted and forbidden; the speedups are permitted; so at least one quantum feature resists the reduction—the causal-disturbance explanation ruled out before the video ended, by the Nexic reflex applied to physics for the first time. The record's dynamical description of this hub is a first phase transition: the clue compacted the space of possibilities, fixing where the irreducible quantum effect sits, and it is exactly why Aethic reasoning could not have been formulated earlier in history than quantum mechanics.

The central hub is dated only to the week of August 19, 2022: walking across campus, visualizing a penny flip, "in the last moment while it was in the air, the thought came to me, rather like floodgates opening." The record gives the thought three equivalent formulations at increasing precision—the felt version, ("the multiverse is closer than I thought"); the mechanical version, (centric unfolding cannot actually affect past environments); and the mature aphorism, (*the multiverse does not contain the room, the room contains the multiverse*)—and the retrospective apparatus states the move exactly: a reversal of scope ordering, from counterfactuals operating over full possible worlds to their existing as alternatives to one's own Aethus, executed by someone who knew neither "counterfactual" nor "possible world" as terms. Once alternatives live inside the state rather than the state inside an alternative, tense-free blankness and superpositions-as-constituents-of-the-room fall out as joint corollaries of the single inversion; the epiphany's methodological content was a definition, (*what a superposition is, ontologically*: a structural element of an Aethic block universe as designated by Aethic ignorance, not a jumble of quantum effects); and the aesthetic-unity argument was inside the moment rather than added later, quantum waves appearing to want to place counterfactuals as almost a substance occupying physical space. The relation to the January 2022 hub is surgical, (the epiphany did not extend centric unfolding; it deleted its unit), and the relation to the Nexic hub re-scopes the event's job description: the epiphany did not create the framework's fundamental object; it *activated* one—the extrusion principle serving as the single adaptation to temporal ontology that let the December 2021 structure describe superpositions, which is precisely why the unpacking could proceed at the speed the next forty-eight hours show.

Two measurements of the central hub are now available, and together they are this subsection's sharpest yield. The first is the *blast radius*: the commitment the inversion deletes is tensed determinacy, the 2021 glossary carries that commitment in three explicitly temporal definitions plus one implicit carrier, and withdrawing it and taking the downward closure invalidates *twenty-four of the twenty-six terms*—the two survivors, Auruman and Auruspective, being precisely the two that were never machinery. The computation is reproducible from the transition report's own adjacency data; the survival criterion it reveals is a finding about what kind of event the epiphany was, (an ontology replacement razes apparatus while leaving commitments of perspective standing); and it is the quantitative form of the claim that Nexic reasoning was rewritten on Aethic hardware. The second is the *architectural inversion*, the same event's effect on the old wing's spine rather than its terms: before 2022 the Accordance Principle was the load-bearing result and the indiscriminate time principle an incidental feature of its setup; the extrusion principle showed that the structure permitting alternate-history comparison is the same structure permitting Aethic superposition generally, and the deductive ordering accordingly inverted—indiscriminate time the root, Accordance's licensing its consequence. The consequence of the inversion is stated where it belongs, at the close of this subsection, because it

is evidential rather than conceptual.

13.12.4 The forty-eight hours, and the debts they booked

The entry of August 21, 2022, 10:27 AM performs, in roughly a page, the fixity/determinacy divorce, (the history unchanged *and* the electron at all positions, in consecutive sentences), relocates the collapse trigger from the calendar to the Ethus-transition while rejecting the word collapse for "compress," and universalizes immediately to our scale and to galaxies, closing on the first postulate in one sentence. The entry's time-language repays a two-clock parse rather than a residue count. It runs one English lexicon over two indices it does not yet have separate words for—coordinate time, (position within a block; the physical environment), and Aethic time, (the ordering of Ethus-additions)—and every sentence lands as doctrine once assigned its clock: "can't actually affect past environments" is the coordinate-index delta against the discarded centric-unfolding game, (the counterfactual index moved from the room to the Aethus, exactly as the master's framing footnote states); "the history remains unchanged" does correct double duty, (the environment no longer responds; the prior structure persists un-overwritten—the lost multiverse's first appearance); "only the present and future 'collapse"' reads on the Aethic index as doctrine, (compression at the current transit and forward, transited resolutions never reopening), with the entry self-glossing its clock two paragraphs later—"at the moment of ethus addition, and actually not in the past"; "during the past, the electron was actually at all possible positions at once" asserts coordinate-past openness relative to the prior Aethus, (the blank as constituent, the seed of indiscriminate time); and the rejected "whole history... collapses" carries, per the author's ruling, a second rejection at a different depth—of the *unit*: a timeline couples all its attributes jointly, so timeline-grained resolution cannot drop one attribute-value without forcing the surviving package to co-state an arbitrary chain of others, statements without records, exactly what the second postulate forbids—the master's footnote stating the grain-shift nearly verbatim, the 2021 *Route* entry being this unit indicted in its own definition, and the sentence thereby the record's first strike, on day one, at the primitive Section 13.12.8 diagnoses across the literature; and "now our ethus knew that piece of information about it then" sets three time-words across the two clocks in seven words—a grammar visibly failing to carry a nonclassical object. The parse yields a small consistency theorem: under one clock the paragraph contradicts itself within four sentences; under two, every sentence is exact mature doctrine—so the two-times doctrine, explicit in May 2023, is not foreshadowed on August 21 but *required for the entry's coherence*, operating anonymously, and the next day's tense-free treatment is the vocabulary catching up rather than a repair, (the master's own continuity phrasing: "already a fundamental part of the soccer field entry from the very next day"). What the journal documents is a complete, linguistically nonclassical intuition negotiating with a one-clock language—the record's first instance, run on its own author, of the masking Section 13.12.8 diagnoses in the literature. One genuine next-day refinement stands, and stands alone at this grain: the mis-lean toward the prior Aethus holding something closer to the interference-pattern wavefunction than the outcome wavefunction—so that the agreeing/disagreeing joint, the framework's signature distinction, enters the record as a refinement the Monday entry forces on the Sunday entry, seventeen months before either species has a name.

The soccer-field entry of August 22, (1:23 and 1:42 PM), is the epiphany cashed into an instrument, and its nineteen-minute internal gap—"Aw crap. I just thought a little bit more about this thought experiment, and it actually gets weirder still"—is the two-stage model instantiated inside a single entry, the author surprised by his own next thought in writing. What the continuation delivers, in sequence: the clue-abundance asymmetry that relocates the quantum/classical boundary to informational accessibility-in-principle; the second postulate's first dress, (the Anti-Ethus, defined by statistical independence and dubbed "Rebetary"—reusing, it can now be seen against the 2021 ladder, an eleven-month-old Nexic coinage for exactly that concept: structure-precedence at the level of a single word); the future-accessibility argument that seeds the third postulate, together with the honest half-resistance to its backwards-time appearance; the migration of probability into the information state, ("the actual probability density function is very much in my Ethus"), which is the weighting story's booking; and the debt named outright—how future Ajax's Ethus communicates with the present one, "or if such a communication is just an illusion"—the exact question the third postulate answers eight and a half months later, its phrasing already containing the bilayer confusion the mature framework diagnoses in nonlocality generally.

13.12.5 The campaign and the completion

The winter–spring 2023 campaign runs on dated stations whose interlocks are publicly checkable: the Severed-Ethus of January 10; the January 28, 9:51:29 AM print, (the three rules assembled and numbered for the first time, the third parent-directed, zero citations of any kind on its pages, and footnote 6 naming and leaving open the paradox the May form closes); the February 8, 4:42 PM redesign, (the journal entry boxing the January print's rules verbatim as "the old laws"); and the February 19 phone booth, from which the entropic principle descends—notable in the graph as the first *application* run on the half-built axioms rather than a repair to them, and carrying even its charge caveat in the original sitting. The campaign also preserves the charming stage's characteristic error in my own retrospective: through early 2023 I was arbitrarily pressing to make the third postulate as aesthetically trippy as the second, with invalid Aethae acting in the parent direction—one of the major things fixed at the structural transition. That transition is May 8, 2023: the realization that the inheritance paradox and the pruning mechanism are unified under the reduced form, the two-generation shape existing to establish an effective fixed point for validity, with the completion's phenomenology preserved in the record and its date independently anchored—the correspondence archive's arXiv account confirmation of the same day dating not the completion but my contemporaneous judgment that the work was ready. The May 20 print follows, and with it the record's public leg.

13.12.6 The public leg: checkable continuity across the four prints

From the private entries the trail becomes public, and because this paper's footnotes scatter the specifics across many pages, the checkable spine belongs in one place, so that a reader who wishes to audit the order of events may do so directly rather than take my word for it. Four dated artifacts now carry the story:[354] the manuscript of January 28, 2023; the original short manuscript of May 20, 2023, (hosted at aethus.org, where a phrase-level annotated edition is also maintained); the November 2024 preprint of the present paper, (frozen as version 1 at PhilArchive); and the present version together with its companion short paper. The division of labor between them is itself the finding.

What the January print contains, verifiable on its face: the three rules assembled and numbered, the first reading as it will read forever, the second carried by the since-retired Anti-Ethus construct, the third parent-directed—the dated prior candidate of the elimination that yields the two-generation form on May 8—with the soccer field in manuscript, a compression postulate named, permanence of the past Ethus stated, and zero citations, zero references, zero interpretive literature anywhere on its pages. What the May 2023 manuscript contains: all three postulates as numbered postulates, the third already carrying the exact two-generation existential–universal alternation reached by the same too-strong/too-weak elimination used in this paper, permanence stated flatly, multi-observer consistency run through the third postulate, and both species of superposition present extensionally and insisted to be distinct, months before either had a name. The record keeps its second column honestly: the May second postulate runs on statistical independence rather than blankness, (content fixed, dress since evolved); the first postulate arrives dressed as a generalization of an assumed QBism—an on-ramp the record brackets, the content dated on both sides of the dress's arrival by the August 2022 entries and the citation-free January print; an "Anti-Time" construct appears there and nowhere after, (retired); and a Rare-Earth application appears that later versions re-house rather than retire. A genealogy that can distinguish re-housing from retiring is doing classification, not confession.

The public leg also carries an artifact of a different class in the gap between May 2023 and the preprint: the paired video presentations of October 19, 2023, (platform-dated; `https://youtube.com/playlist?list=PL1NA36JDv_T_1gJnzWhevIafOe0x4Q1yC`), delivering the third postulate in its finished two-generation form five months after May 8 and thirteen months before the deposit, the second postulate still in its statistical-independence dress, both superposition species present and unnamed with the distinction stated algebraically—and the speaker flagging in his own voice that the point took him a while to comprehend, which is what a missing name costs a person trying to convey a distinction he can already use. What the November 2024 print then adds is, above all, names: agreeing and disagreeing superposition as titled kinds, (130 and 74 occurrences); the union and extrusion principles as titled principles; centric unfolding, the two-generation constraint, Oliver's experiment, and the parking-lot walkthrough at a section number that has survived unchanged into the present version. And it carries the lexical fact I consider the sharpest single certificate of the linguistic masking this record documents: "possible world(s)" appears throughout the deposit, (56 occurrences),

[354] An earlier version of this apparatus tracked three; the January 28, 2023 print surfaced only in the 2026 assembly of the genealogy record and is installed here as the missing intermediate.

while "counterfactual," "Lewis," "Stalnaker," and "perturbation" each appear exactly zero times—counts trivially recomputable by any reader. The modal structure was fully load-bearing nineteen months before any translation assistance existed; the vocabulary of the counterfactual-semantics tradition was entirely absent.

What the present version adds is the layer the earlier prints could not have supplied: the explicit counterfactual semantics, together with names coined for machinery already operating namelessly—the Powerset Invalidation Theorem for the 2023 detector binning, the ladder ontology, the imagined Aethus for 2023's "pretend Aethus," and the reduced form, whose concept sits at the May 8, 2023 conception but whose term appears in neither earlier print. The Quantum Nexus belongs to a later stratum and should not be listed among these: the 2023 prints invoke Feynman's kernel informally as the intended weighting engine, but the expanded path integral that became the Nexus was proposed in the author's notes in 2024, and the name and the integral over $\mathcal{P}(X)$ are of that year, not of 2023.[355] So the stratigraphy the four documents jointly certify is this: structure and applications sit on the early timestamps; vocabulary, field-connection, and formalization sit on the late ones. Nothing in that ordering rests on my recollection; the reader may simply hold the documents side by side.

13.12.7 The late layers

Three stations of 2024–2026 belong in the graph beyond the print record. The April 2025 correspondence with Devin B., (reproduced in full in the following subsection), is the record's external stress-test, and its graph-value is fourfold: the April replies contain linguistically masked versions of machinery formalized only later, (the selection-set answer declining the set and substituting attributes; the graded-invalidity answer as the weighted formalism in operational dress; the forward-projection answer running the synchronic architecture before its backward half existed); it carries the record's one honest failure of a named mechanism, (the stackal transform, staked in April 2025 and dropped entirely in February 2026, its falsifiability instinct surviving as the lookout principle while the mechanism did not); it is the one stratum where the two-stage surprise-chain runs with an outside interlocutor in the loop; and it establishes correspondence-verbatim as its own artifact grade. The weighting thread, booked in the August 22, 2022 entry, reaches its satisfactory formalization in the same stretch: the Relational Weight Principle—weights checkable only relationally, the structure projective, a global rescaling an exact invariance—settled in 2025 and recorded in the June 12, 2026 pass, downgrading the unit Aethus to gauge choice, retiring the additive notion of contradiction, and dovetailing with the Quantum Nexus's identification of below-record-resolution weighting as gauge, so that the physical content of the weight structure is exhausted by relational, record-resolved ratios. And the post-completion literature integrations run in a documented direction: delayed-choice, Wigner's friend, Frauchiger–Renner, RQM, and Spekkens's program each arrived *after* the postulates, (RQM's early-2023 timing kept honest), each met with the retrospective thrill of immediate Aethic constructibility; Müller and Tappenden entered by the dated route of Devin's pointer, unread in April 2025 and formally engaged by 2026—convergence discovered late being corroboration, where convergence absorbed early would have been influence. The Nexic side's 2026 layer, finally, has the one reversed provenance arrow in the record: the sixth extraction developed the closure formalization the master lacked and found a live error in it, (an effective-parameter envelope that can go negative while Strong Accordance holds at every attribute), both since imported by the master—the pass ledger's discipline being what makes the direction checkable. The same discipline now carries a second exhibit: the transition report's corrected entry on the Golden Point—withdrawn from the Nexic paper for expository detachability, rehabilitated by tense-freedom itself, (a blank future attribute differing in no kind from a blank deep-past one), and developed in a companion where the Past-Alignment Principle recovers Optimation exactly as the past-light-cone restriction of Golden conditioning—with the earlier draft's misreading logged, in the report's own words, as the report's error rather than the corpus's.

[355] Three intermediate deposited versions of this paper, (past versions of its PhilArchive record, dated July 1, 2025, January 2, 2026, and April 28, 2026), let this dating be made finer still. The reduced form, (with its coupling), the ladder ontology, and the phone-booth thought experiment are all present by the January 2026 version while still absent from the July 2025 version—my own coinages of late 2025. The Quantum Nexus and the Powerset Invalidation Theorem are absent from the January 2026 version and thoroughly established by April 28, 2026—my own coinages of spring 2026, still weeks ahead of any machine exchange. The explicit semantics and the possible-worlds apparatus it runs on belong to the layer after that, consistent with the June 2026 dating recorded at the semantics section itself; "Anti-Time," for completeness, is absent at every checkpoint, and the framework's native structures grow steadily across all four layers, with no discontinuity anywhere except at the boundary the provenance footnotes themselves draw.

13.12.8 One debate in two vocabularies: what the vantage makes visible

The dependency-graph reconstruction earns one further payoff, and it is a claim about the standing literature rather than about my own record, so it deserves its own statement and its own grading. From the Aethic vantage, Lewis's concrete modal realism [16] and Everett's many-worlds [2, 3, 68] read as *one move performed in two vocabularies.* (I record for the genealogy that this is not a drafting-layer observation: I noticed the identity myself upon working through both literatures in depth, well before its present statement, and the register of this subsubsection is the translation of that noticing rather than its source.) Each begins from the completed world—the tensed, determinate, whole history—as the unit of alternative-hood, and each then multiplies that unit to house the alternatives it needs: Lewis multiplies worlds to ground modality, Everett multiplies branches to preserve unitarity, and the branching-time logics, the growing block, and the informal modal talk of Copenhagen orthodoxy all carry the same unit without multiplying it. The celebrated disagreements—whether the other worlds are concrete, whether branches split, where the branch points sit—are downstream of the shared commitment; and the decisive observation, checkable against the texts independently of anything Aethic, is that the arguments each camp deploys against the others *quantify over the very unit they never contest.* To someone standing at the extrusion vantage, where the alternatives live inside the observer's information state and no completed history is a well-formed object at all, the family resemblance is not subtle: these are formalizations, at two levels of mathematical dress, of the folk temporal metaphysics that has been with us since before writing—the moving present, the settled past, the world as the thing that could have been otherwise *as a whole.* The unit is not Lewis's and not Everett's. It is inherited, and it is ancient.

The honest question is why this sameness, if real, is invisible from outside the vantage—and here the methodological companion's apparatus supplies three mechanisms rather than a shrug. The first is the *co-signature loop*: a fierce two-sided debate promotes the camps' shared background alongside their shared insight, because every argument either side advances ratifies the uncontested substrate both are built on; decades of realism-versus-branching dispute have therefore functioned as decades of joint ratification of the unit itself, and the more energetic the dispute, the firmer the co-signature. The second is *shades of similarity*: a position that deletes the unit resembles both camps at once—simultaneously more deflationary than Everett, (indexical rather than dynamical; nothing splits), and more realist than Copenhagen, (the superposition ontic structure of the indexed state)—so it is filed, from every direction, as territory some camp already holds; and by the proximity-hardness corollary, the nearer the standing debate presses around such a vacancy, the longer the vacancy persists, precisely because the density of the neighborhood is mistaken for coverage of the point. The third is *linguistic masking* at the level of the lexicon itself: the available vocabulary—"possible world," "branch," "timeline," "history"—is denominated in the unit, so even stating the alternative requires coinage; and the calibration runs deeper than philosophy, since the standard formal semantics of natural-language modality [129, 194] was tuned against speaker judgments from the start [195, 196], which means the grammar co-signs too. It is, I think, exactly this triple lock that makes the sameness "utterly obvious" from inside the vantage and nearly unstateable from outside it—which is not a paradox but a prediction of the camouflage theses, run on their hardest case.

Two pieces of evidence discipline the claim, one from the record and one from the literature. From the record: the genealogy shows the entire modal structure being built by someone who had been issued neither vocabulary—the fifty-six-to-zero certificate, the "outcome" and "timeline" dress—which is what one expects if the contested commitment is pre-theoretic, absorbed with the grammar rather than from any book, and it is why this record could serve as a test case for the camouflage theses at all: the unit was deleted by someone who had never received it in its formal packaging, only in its ancient one. From the literature: Tappenden's Unitary Mind [70], read with the epistemic separability principle [69], is the in-print demonstration of exactly where the blockage sits—a line of thought that takes the single-timeline demotion in earnest and is nonetheless stopped short of the full reversal by many-worlds' objective branch points, the unit's residue doing precisely the work this subsubsection attributes to it, (Section 2.5.1).

The grading, stated flatly so the claim cannot borrow strength it has not earned: the *sameness diagnosis* is a corollary of the extrusion inversion, and a reader who declines the inversion is entitled to keep Lewis and Everett as distinct as their camps do. What stands unconditionally is the structural observation—that both programs quantify over completed histories and that the debate between them has never contested that quantification—together with the documented fact that a nineteen-year-old outside the lexicon rebuilt the whole terrain without ever acquiring the unit. Whether that conjunction is a curiosity or a diagnosis is exactly what the framework's correctness would decide; the dependency

graph's contribution is to have made the conjunction checkable.

The family, inventoried. The Lewis–Everett case is the flagship of this phenomenon, but it is a worked exemplar rather than a one-off, and the inventory deserves stating because its *shape* is itself evidence-shaped. The cases tier by what, exactly, is shared.

Tier one: the deleted commitment itself is the co-signature, field-wide. The largest single instance is not two camps but the interpretations of quantum mechanics entire. As the continuity-demotion analysis sets out, (Section 14.2.7), a century of interpretation shares one desideratum so pervasive it is rarely stated—continuity between pre- and post-measurement states under a persisting medium, with an agreeing-to-disagreeing transition located *somewhere*: Copenhagen states it as collapse; many-worlds smuggles it through branching [2, 3, 68]; Bohmian mechanics through the effective collapse of the conditional wavefunction [72, 73]; spontaneous-collapse theories through explicit stochastic dynamics [75]; and QBism in epistemic clothing [78, 79]. Five rival programs, one co-signed transition, and the Aethic verdict, (Sections 10.2.2 and 14.2.7), is that the transition itself is the category error—the shared desideratum, not any camp's answer to it, being where the difficulty lived.

Tier two: a shared premise, formal and famous. Two deadlocked literatures turn out to co-sign exactly the commitment this framework withdraws. Causal and evidential decision theory have contested Newcomb's problem for half a century while jointly granting that the predictor's past prediction is determinate—the entire dispute downstream of one blank attribute misread as stated, as this paper's decision-theoretic treatment sets out, the verdicts of the standing camps recovered or corrected once the premise is priced rather than presupposed. And the anthropic reference-class problem, (the self-sampling versus self-indication standoff descending from the doomsday literature [273]), is the same shape one field over: a debate over *which* classical class to sample from that cannot close, on the Nexic-method diagnosis, because the classical class—the completed history—was never the right unit, typicality being derived from the unfolding rather than imposed on a census.

Tier three: a shared parameter, or a shared defect, identified across fields. Lewis's similarity ordering [16, 196] and Kratzer's ordering source [129, 194] are, on the deletion analysis of the semantics sections, one underived parameter maintained by two disciplines—philosophy and linguistics—that calibrated it against the same authority, the native speaker; the Aethic deletion lands on both at once, which is why it registers as a single cut rather than two. And the record's own Fluke paradox, (the thread above: December 2021, filmed June 2, 2022), is identified by the transition report as Lewis's small-miracle problem [16] in a third vocabulary—a shared *defect* rather than a shared position, and the one member of the family the genealogy shows being struck independently, on camera, before either literature was known.

Tier four: structural co-signatures. The causal literatures—interventionist modeling [126, 127], the retrocausal escape routes, and the fine-tuning no-go results [100, 101]—jointly operate on a single causal layer where the bilayer analysis splits information from validity, the Wood–Spekkens boundary marking exactly where the co-signed layer's writ ends. The union principle's sister-taxon claim places classical disjunction metaphysics, quantum logic [81, 161], and the determinable-based indeterminacy literature [163–166] as arguing *inside one taxon* about a catalogue that has a second wing—the charge of the union-principle sections above being precisely that the composition chapter is missing from all three. The spacetime-emergence programs [289–291] each stage their primitive in order to yield spacetime, co-signing the staging itself, (the hinge analysis, with [292, 293], sets out the contrast). The filter-catalog genre of anthropic natural history [106, 294] co-signs atom-counting over fixed histories—exactly what the 2020 coupling kernel's "zero or two, never one" already could not express within. And, at the meta-level, the companion methodological essay runs the same diagnosis on its own discipline: eight decades of the discovery/justification firewall debate, two camps co-signing the coupling of evidential to normative status, with the split position sitting between them resembling both and claimed by neither.

What the family's shape argues. The tiering has an internal logic—the top cases share the withdrawn commitment itself, the middle cases a specific premise or parameter, the bottom cases a methodological posture—and that logic is what converts the inventory from a list of analogies into evidence of a particular kind. One collapsed debate could be a lucky reframe. A *scatter* of collapsed debates, across literatures that do not cite one another, all dissolving under a single withdrawal, is the signature of having found a load-bearing wall rather than a decorative one: it is the blast-radius computation of Section 13.12 run forward instead of backward—twenty-four of twenty-six on this record's own prior vocabulary, and then this scatter on everyone else's. The grading of the flagship

case extends to every member: each individual collapse is conditional on the inversion, and a reader who declines it keeps the standing debates intact; what stands unconditionally, per case, is the shared-quantification or shared-premise observation itself, checkable against the cited texts with no Aethic commitment in hand. The family is offered in exactly that spirit: not as accumulated victory, but as an unusually specific set of predictions about where, if the inversion is correct, the standing literature should turn out to have been agreeing all along.

13.12.9 The graph, assembled

The enabling spine now reads in one breath: the substrate's pre-linguistic structural mode; the Nexic wing's trained reflex and its pre-built Attribute Set; the January 2022 relocation of the reversal principle into metaphysics; the August 10 tipoff forbidding the causal-reduction class; the central hub's inversion, with its two joint corollaries and its ontological definition of superposition; the forty-eight-hour unpacking; the 2023 campaign; the May 8 unification; the naming layer; the formalization layers; and the provenance apparatus certifying the whole. Against it stands the debt ledger, booked and paid with dates: the Fluke paradox, (December 2021's definitional resistance, escalated to the filmed forecast of June 2, 2022, paid by the epiphany two and a half months later, the Nexus being what Outlook Probability had to become once its vantage was withdrawn); the communication question and the inheritance paradox, (August 22, 2022, paid May 8, 2023); the agreeing/disagreeing joint, (flagged August 22, extensional May 2023, named at the turn of 2024, confirmed as the Union Principle's two regimes); the weighting story, (August 22, 2022, through the weight–probability equivalence to the Quantum Nexus and the 2025 gauge settlement); the Trace Connection, (the Golden Principle's third and fourth points of August 2022, naming an undischarged connection between our existence and the Golden Point and expressly deferring it "until it is officially derived"—paid by the companion's Golden-Conditioning reductio in 2026, the ledger's second instance of a gap named before any candidate filling existed); the three Laws of Auruspectation, (posited by 2022, dissolved into one postulate plus theorems); the arena thread, (spacetime re-arenaed concretely in the April 9, 2024 journal, generalized by the February 9, 2026 Bloch comprehension); and the stackal transform, (the one debt paid by deletion). Still open, per this paper's own frontier sections: the kernel's derivation, the measure, the Bloch-sphere underpinnings, the realization principle, and the macroscopic regime.

Two cross-wing edges complete the topology, and they run in both directions. Backward, from the central hub into the first framework: the twenty-four-of-twenty-six blast radius and the three-to-one consolidation—carrying, honestly, the transition report's two clauses, that the rewrite relocated rather than eliminated assumption, and that the resulting economy is not independent evidence for the ontology that produced it. Forward, from the first framework into the second and back again: the Attribute Set as the central hub's pre-built substrate, (the hardware predating the epiphany; the operating system not), and the Radical Principle as a Nexic result that exists only because of the Aethic ontology. The graph's most striking internal symmetry is meanwhile the central faculty run twice: one question—what must a universe look like which is both logically realist and able to host co-presence—answered by the extrusion principle for modality and causation and by the Union Principle for logic, with the two superposition kinds falling out as exactly the two answers' regimes, the second run arriving as a prediction confirmed by the first run's own machinery.

The architectural inversion's consequence can now be stated where it lands. Because the deductive ordering between the wings inverted—the indiscriminate time principle the root, the Accordance Principle's licensing its consequence—the two frameworks are no longer entirely separable, and validation of the Accordance Principle through paleontological prediction now constitutes indirect empirical validation of the indiscriminate time principle. Concretely: a primate fossil out of the Haţeg deposits would be evidence bearing on an ontology of time. No other item in this record converts a dig site into a test of a metaphysics, and it means the Nexic wing's falsifier ledger is, downstream of 2022, also this framework's.

Read as a graph, then, the record supports a precise version of the "single idea" claim with which the order-of-events list closed. What the campus walk contained was one inversion, its two immediate corollaries, and one definition, applied to a compositional object that had been sitting fully built since December 7, 2021 under another name. What it did not contain, ten hubs supplied under visible strain, each stage surprised by the next—from a nineteen-minute gap on a Monday afternoon in 2022 to a naming layer blindsided by its own formalization in 2026. The epiphany is central in the graph-theoretic sense, (nearly every path from substrate to mature framework passes through it, and no other node has that property—a centrality now measurable, since run backward against the 2021 vocabulary the single withdrawn commitment fells twenty-four of twenty-six terms), but it is not the

root, (the root is a preschooler discovering that two closed-off domains were one domain all along), and it is not the terminus, (the frontier sections keep six constructions open). The right image remains the one this paper's own physics supplies: the epiphany was the kernel—the thing every subsequent path had to be weighted against—first glimpsed in the last moment before an imagined penny landed, when the web of everything it could be turned out not to be somewhere else at all.

13.13 Conversational Exchanges

For your reference as the reader, here are some direct conversational excerpts of mine considering relevant explanations of topics in Aethic reasoning.

13.13.1 The April 2025 Correspondence with Devin B.

In April 2025, well before the February 2026 reframe of the Quantum Nexus and the present statement of active reasoning, I received a thoughtful reader's email from Devin B., and the exchange that followed pressed on several of the framework's most load-bearing joints—the a-priori selection set, the spin-measurement discipline, graded invalidity, non-locality, and the ontology of the self among them. The correspondence appears below in full, with Devin's permission recorded within the exchange itself, (where he cites, fittingly, the precedent of Chris Fuchs's published email collections as the genre's charter). The formatting is idealized from the original emails—prose verbatim, artifacts of the medium cleaned—and a retrospective analysis follows the exchange, reading the April arguments back through the current formulation.

Devin B. to Ajax, April 2025

Hello Ajax,

I just finished reading (sometimes skimming) through your Aethic Reasoning paper, the long version. I'm quite interested in the topic of what it's like to live in a multiverse and found some thought provoking stuff there. I have a few comments and questions.

First, are you familiar with the Markus Müller or Paul Tappenden? Müller's idea is that something that looks like living in a quantum universe could be the result of conscious agents constructing a model of reality that minimizes computational complexity, regardless of what's really out there. Your idea of a Markov chain as a mechanism of moving between Aethic worlds reminded me of it. Tappenden works on the idea he calls Unitary mind, that we live in a quantum multiverse but not in just one branch, instead being simultaneously in all branches with identical experiences. He deals only with the philosophy, though it's roughly based on many interacting worlds (MIW), which is a niche interpretation that each point in the wavefunction is a semi-classical universe. So when we collapse ψ we really just partition our self into subsets seeing each result. His current focus shares a couple themes with your work, first explaining how branch weight, (the proportion of the infinite semi-classical worlds), is probability and second how unitary mind clarifies what superposition is. You might want to talk to those guys if you haven't yet.

Next, does your theory provide insight into how Bell inequalities are violated and how one gets the Tsirelson bound? As I understand so far, Aethic worlds could basically allow any dynamics. So why do we see exactly quantum predictions? For example in the MIW case, it's because each world is just like a pilot-wave world, only instead of the wavefunction being an empty guiding wave, it's made of other worlds. Müller's idea is more interesting—QM emerges mathematically from logical necessities.

To help me understand a very simple case—one measures spin in the vertical axis and gets up, then one measures again. If it's up/down, $\mathrm{P}(\mathrm{up}_{t_2} \mid \mathrm{up}_{t_1}) \approx 1$, so basically all the child Aethic worlds must have spin = up, right? But of course it's also true that $\mathrm{P}(+) = 50\%$ and $\mathrm{P}(-) = 50\%$. Is the Aethic explanation that there is a complete and independent set of worlds for every possible 2nd measurement? I suppose so.

Finally, I'm wondering if you've thought about how this model would change the subjective experience of agents. The most glaring effect I see in any model that assumes an agent is in a superposition over a set of worlds is that they can't experience death. This is sometimes called subjective immortality or quantum immortality in terms of the regular many worlds interpretation where it's quite controversial because agents are singular.

Cheers, Devin □

Ajax to Devin B., April 11, 2025

Hello Devin! First of all, thank you so much for the thoughtful email! It's super exciting to hear your reactions to some of the stuff I've set up in Aethic reasoning! I have actually heard the name Markus Müller, however I haven't actually gone through his or Paul Tappenden's work, so I'm glad to hear of this connection—something to read about! Yeah actually I have so many thoughts about how to answer the questions you brought up, so I'm going to go in order and see if I can give a shot at my interpretation/reasoning!

First of all, great point about bringing up the kinds of themes of Müller and Tappenden's interpretations—being maximization of computational complexity and weighted mixing across multiple branches—because that gives me a clear launching point to state my own idea's theme: basically in one sentence, I would say that my approach is to model superpositions themselves with the simplest possible bout of inductive reasoning, all while relocating them to something almost circumstantially universal, (with the quantum superposition treatment itself then being a special case of this broader effect, instead of representing the defining whole story of where they show up). That's where the second postulate comes from, which is basically the inductive counterpart to what the Markov chain stuff is telling us about the ontology. So, where that quantum immortality argument, (for example), is on the iterative layer of Boltzmann statistical mechanics, then Aethic reasoning is a pitch for what the analogous "Newton's law of motion" should look like. As in, the deepest most general—while still inductively precise—possible ontological ground layer atop which all quantum/classical logical effects operate, (like how Boltzmann statistical mechanics still roots to Newtonian-derived concepts like kinetic energy, etc—so built in that language but writing way more complex content—at least to draw a rough analogy). So in short, where your Aethus tells you which block universe you're in along the Markov chain, the second postulate tells you that the mere state of what you don't know is entirely enough to predict/derive the superposition content that's in there with you. Unknowing = superposition, but the further Aethic union principle then uses a little more induction to paint more degrees of freedom than just *superposition on* vs *superposition off* and whatnot!

Now, then, we get to the point about how much flexibility Aethic reasoning allows in the universe / future Aethae. I mean, this is a huge talking point already, because in my book a model that allows everything is no model at all—because once you lose all the causal correlations of the universe, you're not writing up anything. Even the lack of causal connection between anything, (i.e. a random universe), is still a causal connection between the iterated state of causal connections and the perception of the universe, it'd just be second-order then, (and so on). But I digress! So right after the Markov chain and the second postulate, this is the next most important concept in Aethic reasoning: *there's a deterministic algorithm with which you can deem any Aethus invalid or not.* This is very very important to the predictive power at play, not only because the lack of its truth would open up a hailstorm of well-defined avenues with which to disprove the relativism of Aethae and block universes, (think Plato vs. Protagoras), but also because that earlier point—the art of how to restrict possibilities—is written in the language of invalid Aethae in Aethic reasoning. Part of the beauty of this, if I may say so myself, is that it's both conceptually straightforward and explanatorily powerful. Want to write $A \to B$ with Aethae? Just call $A \wedge \neg B$ an invalid Aethus! (i.e. Aethic material implication identity). *Crucially speaking*, want to model the quantum observer effect in Aethic reasoning? Just create a general identity which forces an invalid Aethus every time there *isn't* an observer effect, (slight oversimplification, but close enough), and that identity is the third postulate of the Aethus itself, (which I want to just state explicitly here, is taken as literally the simplest possible statement of a material implication identity over Aethic inheritance which is consistent with the double-slit experiment outcome, so whether it's correct comes down to Occam's razor—but I'm not worried because it's just too darn convenient to be wrong).

So that brings me to quantum spin itself. The idea I'm trying to set up here with that is that Aethic reasoning is a language rather than an independent assertion in and of itself, (so, oh I don't know, like category theory instead of abstract algebra, or like a class instead of an object, to give a few analogies), and that's part of why it only really works if it's hitting that sweet spot of "Newton's laws"-esque simplicity of inductive reasoning. So the goal is that there should exist a way to stitch invalid Aethae together through logical reasoning—no matter how much geometry, philosophical context, probabilistic heterogeneity, etc—sits in between, such that the precise statement of Malus's law comes out the other end when you're done, (with the

example being Malus's law since, well, my argument is that if you can explain Malus's law with an Aethus, and you have a basic understanding of what a lepton "is" ontologically, then you should be able to make short work of general Bell's inequality violations). So this is a bit of a Herculean task in and of itself—I know because I've been playing around with it for like two years—but the simple place to start with describing quantum spin measurement is that you have to know what *not* to do. What not to do is layer a new attribute into your Aethus every time a measurement occurs. It's tempting, no doubt, but it's not really how an Aethic argument "behaves", you could say, based on what I've seen from what works and what doesn't work, (i.e. causality is utterly nonlinear in Aethic reasoning, basically as a ground rule—so while there are answers, they're all creative answers of the Aethic "brand"). The simple reason why you can't do this is that you get an Aethic contradiction. If I layer "P(+)" into my Aethus after the first measurement and then a couple of measurements down the line put in "P(−)" for the particle's spin state, then that's a plain Aethic contradiction, because in proper practice I ought to only ever be filling in blank attributes of the Aethus with updated states, rather than ones which are already filled-in by a spin-state. So, at this point we might be wondering if there's a way to do this at all—and my pitch is that yes, there is—it's just subtle, (which is characteristic for Aethic logic anyways). I mean, in the time I've been thinking about it I've been having to develop this really geometric extension of Aethic logic, and my pitch is that this treatment—together with creative "bypassing" maneuvers of classically-minded linear progression of causality. The only reason this isn't already in the Aethus paper is that I want this new stuff to all be in one place, so these last two months I've been trying to put the finishing touches on Part 2, which is what I call "active reasoning". That's the proposed pitch for how to handle Malus's law, and then some of the further direction-dependent measurements for fermions. But speaking in the most general terms, what we want is that this one-after-the-other sequence of updates—like particle spin measurements—has to always be convertible into an Aethic treatment which only ever fills in blanks at a time. I termed this a "stackal transform" in the Aethus paper, which is simply the transformation of a model from something which is sequential, (with the most basic general example of this being the way we societally count time, as an incrementing float), into something which is Aethically compatible, (kind of more like spacetime, in that not much is getting incremented, and instead we can harness a felt passage by strategically firing off many Aethic updates at once, thereby making the block universe progression and giving you stuff like the second law of thermodynamics in the process). The danger, of course, is in the possibility that maybe there's a phenomenon which can't actually be stackally transformed at all. Now, if you can prove that there's even a single example of one of these, then that's literally a direct counterexample against Aethic reasoning being correct. So the "gamble", you could say, is that I'm predicting that you should never find a process which can't be stackal transformed. I will say that so far it's looking really positive, (based on the contents of active reasoning), and that's namely because Aethic reasoning turns out to have just the right amount of generality, (second postulate), and just the right amount of restriction, (invalid Aethae), such that you can hypothetically paint just about whatever the heck you want with an Aethus, and that includes adding in another axiom or two to model quantum mechanics in full. So while I should mention that, like I said, Aethic reasoning is fundamentally a language, the pitch is still that it's focused enough as a treatment of reality to "evolve" into a more mature physical theory once you layer on the axiomatic pillar that is, (at least in empirical effect), the quantum wavefunction and Born rule. Such is the work of active reasoning!

But yeah, on that point I'll definitely make sure to email you the link to the preprint as soon as I get it up online, but the basic answer is that it is a little bit nontrivial, while also being expressible with an extra few postulates in place. That's the pitch, anyway. Sorry I can't give a more conclusive answer on that right now by the way—partially still a work in progress, partially because I want to be careful what I say prior to the paper's launch and whatnot—but the child Aethus concept is way more axiomatically basic, so I can definitely explain that right now. The idea with a child Aethus, simply put, is that many of the attributes of an Aethus are oftentimes blank, and you might want to fill them in with stated attributes—thereby generating a child Aethus. The most basic example of using this properly is, say, distinguishing an Aethus with a superposition of states versus the various Aethae where you assert each individual state itself. So it's "filling in a superposition", specifically by filling in the attributes. In the most direct possible sense, it's literally the operation which kicks you into a new rendering of the block universe, so if some other block can be written as "ancestral" to yours in the chain, then you know automatically

that you're its child Aethus. So in short, they fill in more attributes, so as to specify a system further, (so to give the Schrödinger's cat example, the Aethae of all outcomes are child Aethae and child blocks to the superposition Aethus—but in the abstract and regardless of whether you actually get there or not). That's also part of why the compatibility with the spin states is a little murkier, (at least in the direct sense), since there are more degrees of freedom at play there than simple "know more" versus "know less" and the implied restrictions on the superposition. The child Aethus concept is supposed to be what's rooted to the Markov chain itself, so the whole spin correspondence is a question about how spin works rather than a question about what makes a child Aethus. Again, axiomatically basic versus axiomatically heterogeneous, etc. So what I would definitely assert is that child Aethae are much less about the progression of time, and much more about the abstract distinctions between Aethae, (specifically along the Aethic dimension-direction rather than the spacetime-time direction). The block universe Markov chain concept itself effectively isolates Aethae a little bit—since you can't rely on a shared objective reality for deduction—so the child Aethus concept is meant to be a rigorous means of precisely stating what we mean by one block being an extension of another. So you could call a child Aethus "inter-block future" and a parent Aethus "inter-block past" in the most basic, direct sense, (but structurally speaking, rather than personally speaking). But yeah, the "family tree structure" of parent and child Aethae is literally just the structure of the Markov chain itself, so the idea is that the mathematical structure of Aethae themselves is your middle man toward deriving this. I should also quickly mention an actual major application of this premise: a key idea behind the double-slit experiment treatment is that in the abstract, we're defining the cases of the interference pattern and the two-spotlight pattern as both the child Aethae of the total Aethus of possibilities. What's really cool about this treatment is that it winds up giving a second-order second postulate application, because the idea is that these Aethae themselves can be put in Aethic superposition, (specifically in this case by condensing the further child Aethae into those two mentioned outcomes). When you actually run the experiment in practice, though, only one of these abstract child Aethae gets selected, (because of the influence of the third postulate to this specific case), which is why we can only ever see one outcome, and by that really special setup-dependent designation at that!

Ok, so now onto the last question, which is how Aethic reasoning ties into a person's literal felt experience of the universe, as in *how does existing in part among many possible universes affect your own experience?* First things first, my major interpretative pitch here is again a subtle but important one, being that you yourself don't actually experience being along multiple universes at all—rather you get a funny relativist outcome where you think you're in a single block, and the matter/people/world around you is the one in flux between different superposition-like possibilities. It's wild, I know, but part of the pitch behind that is that you have to sacrifice the common sense surrounding that in order to access the inductive reasoning backbone of Aethic reasoning, (similarly to how special relativity throws out objective simultaneity in order to explain Maxwell's equations). More rigorously speaking on this topic, the idea is that since any block universe has a bijectively corresponding Aethus, you can actually apply Aethic unions to block universes just as you would Aethae. The result? You get a superposition of both block universes at once. But, crucially, it's not that you then go to both blocks—rather you have to always have a single Aethus and a single block, (relative to you), so what happens is that we overlay/merge both respective blocks into a single block universe. In short "they come to you, you don't go to them", you could say. That's the heart of the mathematical dynamism of the blocks, which is that the mindset isn't to actually split your own block into other blocks, (because there's a thousand ways to do it, and it's arbitrary), but instead to just assume that you always occupy a single fixed block state, but that the blocks themselves are structurally capable of "morphing" together, essentially, and then still form a single block. The way this works is that even though the blocks are all distinct in their degrees of freedom, (as in one is quite literally informationally a *different* block universe than the next), they still share the same physical space, so it's not that motion between the blocks moves you physically at all—instead it just layers extra-spatial degrees of freedom onto your position, so you can be sitting in the same physical chair, but get a distinction in the "available" superpositions in the block around you, (hence the implied dualist-adjacent degrees of freedom). You don't have to see or even be aware of the surrounding superpositions—it's just that assuming they're there and that they follow this merging-style arithmetic is, again, the pitch for the only way to reach the Aethic inductive backbone, etcetera.

And, the second thing for that—which is also a weird one—is that in Aethic reasoning, there's a funny consequence of the block universe Markov chain concept, which is that it suddenly becomes rather ambiguous about what we mean by a person's "self" in the first place. That is, at least in the Aethic structure itself, there actually isn't any kind of ontological criterion which stands out to categorize different Aethae in time of a single person as being any more related than the Aethae of two totally different people. On the surface this is rather striking, of course, but then again that might be informative in its own way. The analogy that comes to mind is that it's seeming to do to the concept of "self" the same thing which we've all been doing to Aristotle's ideas for the last 500 years, which is that we're finding out that our original definitions themselves were kind of founded on an ambiguity that's harder to reconcile now that we know more about the machinery of the universe, (especially without straying into the dangerous territory of trying to conventionalize your ontology). So, paradoxically, Aethic reasoning offers a more precise mode of explaining everything inductively, but in doing so it removes us from a handful of clear metaphysical premises which we're used to being definitionally straightforward. For all I know, it could be a new hard problem of consciousness or something. What I do know, though, is that there are loads of philosophical degrees of freedom floating around in there—so in the moment all I can ascertain is that Aethic reasoning is a bit too axiomatically simple to even have a take on quantum immortality, again quite like how Newtonian mechanics is to Boltzmann mechanics.

Anyways, that's all the stuff I can think of at the moment to address some of these questions! By the way, thanks again for engaging with me on this! I always love to get a thoughtful email—it's a major part of the fun of doing this stuff! Also, the insights to see how people are reacting is super helpful to me concerning how best to explain this stuff, so I really appreciate the help on that! I probably should even attach this response email of mine to the end of the paper, (if that's alright with you!), that way it's all in there if needed for anybody!

Thanks again, and I'm glad to have had this great discussion!

–Ajax □

Ajax's follow-up, April 2025

Ah hello again! I see I forgot to mention the direct answer to the multiverse part of the question! But yeah, a big idea of Aethic reasoning is that we're relativity-izing the multiverse, so A) yes there are indeed implied other universes, except B) instead of them being all cut off from one another, you're actually viewing them all through the lens that is your own block universe. So the block universe is to the Markov chain as a reference frame is to spacetime, with the pitch being that in order to make an idea like that work you need a Markov chain structure in particular. But yeah, the Markov chain would be the multiverse, but the really weird idea behind Aethic reasoning is that there's no real designation which separates one block universe from the next—it's all about what you happened to take with you in your own Aethus viewpoint. That's the premise behind the 1st postulate of the Aethus, which says that there's no objective structure to the Markov chain besides what can be referenced through an individual block universe.

Anyways, that's the extra point I wanted to add real quick! Thanks again for the interest! (And oh also the goal is that the Tsirelson bound should result deductively once I can fully produce the quantum wavefunction, Born rule, and particle dynamics having to do with vector wavefunctions and stuff. But yeah I'm once again trying to overshoot it with inductive reasoning, and then set the axioms in place to reproduce anything—that's my strategy at least!).

–Ajax □

Devin B.'s reply, with inline quotations, April 2025

Hello Ajax, it's great to see such a long and detailed reply. Below are my further comments. Please respond to parts only if you have time and find the conversation useful.

> *So in short, where your Aethus tells you which block universe you're in along the Markov chain...*

That's actually good to highlight, as I got the general idea but I missed this definition on my first reading. One question I have is where this word "Aethus" / Aethic comes from.

. . . the second postulate tells you that the mere state of what you don't know is entirely enough to predict/derive the superposition content that's in there with you. . .

Unknowing = superposition. I guess in a more mixed-state type of situation, where interference isn't possible, you would say the superposition is in (the analogue of) a larger Hilbert space. This is another principle very similar to that shared by QM—that which you don't "know" (or have any evidence of), doesn't have a truth value.

Want to write $A \to B$ with Aethae? Just call $A \wedge \neg B$ an invalid Aethus! . . . want to model the quantum observer effect. . . ? Just create a general identity which forces an invalid Aethus every time there isn't an observer effect. . .

How does one create an identity? Is it about somebody's personal beliefs, (say, in the purest form)? Is there room for doubt? I would say there is much I'm ignorant of, probably at any level. I don't know if $A \to B$ is valid or invalid, but I might have a credence—that it's 99% invalid. Would such a credence also affect my evolution or must all transitions be determined at valid/invalid with certainty? Do you think the idea of valid vs invalid, based on just such an identity, is enough to reproduce our experience? This also reminds me of what Deutsch is trying to do with his Constructor theory. He tries to use possible / impossible to create dynamics for anything, for example some physical phenomena. It's been many years without much progress.

. . . if you can explain Malus's law with an Aethus, and you have a basic understanding of what a lepton "is" ontologically, then you should be able to make short work of general Bell's inequality violations.

Are you saying Malus's law is enough to get entanglement? I think that's a jump, but I agree it's a good starting point.

What not to do is layer a new attribute into your Aethus every time a measurement occurs.

This would basically be equivalent to adding dimensions in Hilbert space?

If I layer "P(+)" into my Aethus after the first measurement and then a couple of measurements down the line put in "P(−)" for the particle's spin state, then that's a plain Aethic contradiction. . .

Isn't this $\mathrm{P}(+, t_1)$ and $\mathrm{P}(-, t_2)$? If it's at different times, what's the contradiction?

. . . in proper practice I ought to only ever be filling in blank attributes of the Aethus with updated states. . .

Would you say the dimension, (or number of slots), of the Aethus for a given agent is basically a fixed size, so the filling in of those states as one moves down the chain over a huge number of steps would require changing the interpretation of those slots?

. . . this one-after-the-other sequence of updates—like particle spin measurements—has to always be convertible into an Aethic treatment which only ever fills in blanks at a time.

What do you mean "at a time"?

I termed this a "stackal transform". . .

I don't quite get this. I read that part of the paper again. Is it about updates happening in a kind of "transaction" that changes the past, present and future at once?

The danger, of course, is in the possibility that maybe there's a phenomenon which can't actually be stackally transformed at all. . . the "gamble". . . is that I'm predicting that you should never find a process which can't be stackal transformed.

What kind of thing could that be? Can you give an example of a fantasy process which couldn't be stackal transformed? Do you think any sequential process couldn't be? Perhaps I don't understand it, but it seems you can trivially encode any sequential process in terms of a stackal

process. So it would have to be something that logically can't be described in terms of evolution in time. Maybe something like a wormhole or closed timelike curve.

> *. . . just assume that you always occupy a single fixed block state, but that the blocks themselves are structurally capable of "morphing" together. . .*

I don't think this is such a strange idea. It seems analogous to how in QM the linear combination of states is always itself a state.

> *. . . there actually isn't any kind of ontological criterion which stands out to categorize different Aethae in time of a single person as being any more related than the Aethae of two totally different people.*

You can say it's not ontological, but actually what I understand from the part above is that a "self" at some moment in time is equivalent to a single block universe. Then I guess the question of self would be, how one defines what the compatible future Aethae are for that block universe? That would seem to be ontological. And I think the answer now is that it's based on this identity one must choose, which perhaps is like a set of axioms.

> *I probably should even attach this response email of mine to the end of the paper, (if that's alright with you!). . .*

Certainly, you can do what you like with these emails. One of the fathers of QBism, Chris Fuchs, published a huge dump of his emails in paper and I found it quite an interesting way to get a better idea of his thoughts, (arXiv:1405.2390).

> *So what I would definitely assert is that child Aethae are much less about the progression of time, and much more about the abstract distinctions between Aethae. . .*

I understand how that's technically true. But the direction of "expected next experience" for an agent would seem to be going down the chain by gaining information to more "refined" Aethae. It seems like that would mean moving forward in time, at least for humans like us.

And in reply to your follow-up, (the relativity-izing of the multiverse and the first postulate): that's very clear, thanks. When you say "it's all about what you happened to take with you in your own Aethus viewpoint" are you implying the primary rule for evolution is inductive reasoning? Another question I didn't find a ready answer to searching the paper—the set of child Aethae that one a priori will consider before trimming the invalid ones, applying the rules of identity, etc: what is that set? I'm not sure that's even a valid question. But if so, would it be the set of all logically possible universes or even internally inconsistent ones? Does it have some a-priori measure on the subsets?

I think you really should look at Müller's work. Take for example this postulate of Algorithmic Idealism: "*Postulate 2 (State Change). If you are in self state x now, you will be in another self state y next, and which one this will be manifests itself as a random experiment for you. Moreover, the likelihood of any y next, given x now, is what would be determined by some universal method of induction.*"

And on your one-sentence theme, (superpositions relocated to something circumstantially universal, quantum as special case): although you say quantum superposition is a special case, I think one interesting trend in the QM reconstruction program is that QM seems to be the most general theory possible. Basically, anything logically coherent, (given some weak assumptions), is allowed. I'm not saying a fully worked out Aethus theory with an identity / set of axioms that match our experience wouldn't also be fully general, but I suspect it would be isomorphic to QM. There are quite a few clues about which principles can be used to derive QM, like the "Totalitarian Principle", "maximum conceivable contextuality" or "Least Observability", but one approach to understand this perspective is presented by Wallace's paper on "Quantum Theory as a Universal Physical Theory". The simplest example is that QM *almost* allows the most powerful correlations that do not allow superluminal signaling, which would seem to violate causality, (and hence logic). In the space of probabilistic theories, do you think the general Aethic model allows any form of non-locality? Does it allow violating causality?

To summarize my understanding so far in my own words: 1. An agent exists in a single Aethus, which is a block universe defined, (or located), exactly by their "mental state" or rather the sum

of all their experiences or identity. 2. The typical agent's expectation at any moment is to gain some information and hence "jump" down the Markov chain to a child universe, chosen randomly among the set of valid children. 3. All the laws dictating which set is valid exist in the current block, combined with induction. Is that accurate?
∼ Devin □

Ajax's twelve-point reply, April 2025
Hello! They're probably going to be a bit out of order, but here are the key answers as they come to me:

1. The morphing of the block universes is actually meant to be ideally simple—precisely analogous to arithmetic of numbers. That is, $2 + 3 = 5$, and we declare that five is still a single number even though it's been composed of more numbers. Having to constantly keep track of 5 being made of those two parts would be tedious, not to mention arbitrary and contradictory to other choices, (like $5 = 1+1+1+2$). The same goes with the block universes, where the overlay of two of them through addition, (which is the superposition operation of Aethae, similarly to quantum states), is still counted as a single block universe. Whatever that identity of individuality is for addition—that's what the inspiration for overlaying block universes is. Also I should definitely mention that no arithmetic is ever done over block universe objects directly—they just don't have that functionality by themselves—so what is meant by this is that we're doing the arithmetic over their attached Aethae, and then implying the new Aethus's block universe as the output. That way we can use the Aethic structure as it's been set up.

2. Great point about how going from Malus's law to entanglement is a stretch—but the pitch there is that Aethic reasoning itself actually has already covered the major part of that jump, (part of the power of Aethic reasoning is that a lot of this analysis has already been baked into it). This is the direct purpose of the Aethic extrusion principle, which is my pitch for how Aethic reasoning handles quantum non-locality, (among other things). In that department, it's perhaps the single most telling result of the whole framework. So the idea there is that in a standard entanglement setup, if Alice checks the state of her particle prior to Bob in one reference frame, then since they're causally unconnected we have that Bob actually checked first in another reference frame. To me at least, this was a major issue with the Copenhagen interpretation, so part of the very early drafting of Aethic reasoning was a direct move to answer this question using Aethae. The pitch was just the alternate block universes themselves, which are separated by a change of Aethus instead of having to rely on a dividing line manifold in spacetime to serve as the instant of the quantum update. Now we have that the entire prior block universe can never collapse the quantum state, whereas the entire each subsequent block universe had it collapsed all along. So, fittingly, it's almost like the subsequent one is a hidden-variables model, all while the prior one is this strange un-collapsible domain, (sort of, at least). I should also mention that the consciousness take of this is that Alice and Bob don't find themselves to exist in the prior block universe after the fact, and this is simply because the version of either Alice or Bob in the prior block universe after the fact are themselves simply the Aethic superposition overlay of themselves in the possible subsequent block universes. Because that particular Aethic superposition is a disagreeing superposition, we get the natural result that they can't interact with the other copies accordingly. But even this treatment is a little arbitrary, because in that event we would now be referring to the subsequent Aethus of Alice or Bob anyway, (as otherwise you could claim yourself in a disagreeing superposition however far back as you want in the Markov chain, which is unhelpful since it doesn't allow you to ideally leverage the second postulate of the Aethus directly, and is effectively arbitrary). The other note there is that Alice and Bob of the prior block universe are actually always in a disagreeing superposition of themselves in the subsequent block universes, it just so happens that these versions of them are identical prior to the collapse event itself, at which case the subsequent block universes get defined by the Aethic difference anyway. The main idea of all of this is that now when one of them measures the particle, they move into the new rendering of the block universe, and that means they don't have to synchronize the

move with the other one at all. But regarding locality itself, the Aethic stance is to take out the need for non-locality as soon as possible, (regarding whether you want to keep it anyway—which could be a whole other philosophical can of worms, so be it—but the pitch here is that now we've removed that "thorn in our side" that is ambiguity about whether or not it's forced). I personally think the existence of special relativity alone is all the evidence we need to rule out non-locality as an absurdity, (which I would imagine would be a common take anyway), so the extrusion principle is baked into Aethic reasoning pretty much upfront in order to address this issue. The funny thing about me is that I have a stance on locality of a relativity-abiding determinist, but I have a stance on superpositions of an Aethic reasoner, (or Aethicist?—I haven't reached a conclusion yet!), which is kind of what sets up its whole premise of shepherding the indeterminism of the universe into another layer of straight determinism. It really is something of a chimeric take though, to say the least!

3. A really important idea I want to state too, is that while I was developing the criteria for invalidity, I wanted that process itself to be inductive reasoning of the cleanest possible kind. So the third postulate of the Aethus itself was defined as a sole means of being able to iteratively derive the invalidity of anything at all. I should also mention that straight Aethic contradictions, (i.e. placing disjoint attributes in Aethic conjunction, not Aethic superposition), also form invalidities, and you can technically also leverage some invalidities from the contrapositive of the second postulate, but the third postulate itself actually communicates invalidities up and down the Markov chain, so the purpose there is that a little bit of recursion runs the process on everything.

4. Ok this is a big one—you talk about the set of a priori Aethae that you consider for your next jump. This is a super important point, because there's a nuanced answer, so thank you for bringing that to my attention! The idea here is that you technically can't justifiably write this set itself, and instead you want to only refer to the new Aethic attributes themselves that you'll pick up after the jump, (with the resultant child Aethae just following from taking the conjunction of that attribute with your current Aethus). The reason is simply because of that issue for how child Aethae themselves don't have any objective dividing lines, (having to do with the reference frame analogy itself), and instead we only ever reference child Aethae once you've already established two blocks to compare, rather than projecting out to a new block like this. Again, it's not that you couldn't do that, but it's that you would be assuming an objective sequence of sorts—which there really isn't. You can always fit another child Aethus between two Aethae, etc, (so in case I didn't mention this already, note that the child Aethus operation is strictly transitive, so it could also be called simply "descendent Aethus" instead of implying a single generation. The basic reason for that is that whatever attributes establish the multiple generations can be compressed into a single Aethus themselves). So anyways back to the point: the idea here is that your choice of moving to a new Aethus is selected by defining attributes rather than child Aethae, but also the second point is that the attributes themselves can't be justifiably considered to be disjoint. This again has to do with the fact that in that set of possible attributes to jump with, some are combinations of others, and some are combinations of combinations. What this means is that really the best we can do to quantify what happens in the jump, is to assert that the probability of a given attribute being picked up by the jump, as compared to another, matches the ratio of the respective Aethic weights of the child Aethae generated by those attributes. This indeed gives you what's needed to establish classical probability, (since any two outcomes may be weighed against one another), but it leaves ambiguous why and in what context the particularly selected attributes are picked outside of that relation. (So if you wanted to squeeze free will in somewhere, this is where you would do it!). The fun thing about this treatment, though, is that it means you can choose however long a jump you want for the Aethic update, since once again going to child Aethae isn't strictly sequentially iterative in any kind of discrete way. So you could project whether you would expect a given attribute to an arbitrary time in the future of the Markov chain, and that can be weighed against alternatives as desired. But yeah, the whole idea of trying to extrapolate to full child Aethae is a lot, since they can tend to be very complicated. (This whole discussed setup is what I call "the principle of centric unfolding" by the way! It seems to be a strikingly good

fit to Müller's state change postulate by the way, as you mentioned, with my single update being that we can only track state change accurately up to an attribute and that we use an invariant method of sampling, exclusive of weightings, regardless of time in the Markov chain future. But I think his idea of changes being fundamentally probabilistic rather than causal is very similar to my view! I also started watching a lecture of his in the last week since you mentioned him, so I should have a more in-depth comprehension of his work soon enough!). As is typical for the Aethic treatment, then, the motivation is to assess the nature of reality by-the-attribute, since after all this is how we perceive the physical world, (i.e. you're not aware of everything down to the last atom). Also it's worth mentioning that this treatment also allows us to imply the existence of vastly complicated Aethae in the abstract, (sort of like implying Graham's number in the abstract for more standard math), like say that of your own mind, or of an LLM embedding space, and still being able to engage with it by pulling attributes, (since trying to axiomatically construct it from the ground up would be poor practice to the extreme, obviously). Maybe the single most important section of the Aethus paper for the intrinsic structure is the part on retrievals, so I would definitely recommend checking that out if you haven't already! (But by the way, this general Aethic idea of assuming you have limited attribute knowledge is one of the central ideas, and goes through to the ontology itself. That is, note how if you truly were able to entirely deconstruct your reality into all stated attributes, then you wouldn't have that superposition component in a block universe in the first place. So a starting idea in assessing the Aethic ontology is that incomplete attributes are not only expected, but structurally required for the Aethic rendition of a block universe to take shape. This general principle of not assuming full attribute stated-establishment is what I call "the Aethic reversal principle", in case you want any more context within the paper!)

5. Also a great point by the way on whether an implication can be invalid up to a weighting, (like 99%). The answer is that this absolutely can happen, and actually it's the core reason behind why I introduced weighted Aethae to the framework! Once again, though, the idea here is that we'd want to leverage attributes. Specifically, you'd assign an attribute to the 1% valid case, and another disjoint one to the 99% invalid case, and then simply structure the latter one so as to force the invalidity by its combination with the remainder of the Aethus, (even if it itself is valid, but I guess it doesn't have to be!). Then of course you'd assign those attributes the proper weights in that Aethus, and that would do the trick! (Also better yet is when you can do this trick just through deduction from the ontology in question—that's typically when you know you're onto something!)

6. Also great points about bypassing the issue with the measurements by just assigning tuples for when the updates occurred. It's funny because I didn't think of that while I was writing my response email, so that's one avenue for writing a stackal transform I guess! Now that being said, I'm still very wary about just throwing in an axiom there, because the worry is that I'll only end up with another Copenhagen interpretation on my hands, where technically true outcomes derive from ambiguous axioms. So the best practice I can muster is that I need a full Aethic-pertaining ontological derivation—at least up to all empirical consistency—with the Hilbert space in order to entertain that result. Now I'm excited to say that I think I've found one, but again that's talk for the active reasoning paper! (I also have an interesting response in mind for the general-vs-specific spectrum of Aethic reasoning versus quantum mechanics, but I'll wait until after that preprint to say it! It's subtle but super interesting!).

7. Quick note that I love your first summarized bullet point of what the Aethus is! I really couldn't have said it better myself! The sum of all their experiences or identity, which kinda-sorta overlaps with mind or soul, but is truly distinct as an entity from either, (albeit just as characteristic of them in the moment and what their grasp is of reality, and hence the new name). But of course your description nails that premise already! I might also add that this definition is the standard one, and refers to the "ontological character of the Aethus" or normally just Aethus itself. The mathematical character is going to be a little bit different, but is meant to point to the ontological character when used in real-world contexts. So, y'know, exactly analogously to say displacement the mathematical concept

versus displacement the ontological subject!

8. For your second bullet point at the end, I've already outlined why it's a little bit more nuanced than set-based jumps, (just because of the fluidity of the different block universes and all), and I also should add that I'm trying my best with Aethic reasoning to be able to totally weed out any need for sets when describing these ontological concepts at all, (save perhaps for the step of a static Aethus, but that's only indirect anyway). That just came from an intuition that our universe doesn't seem to fit that "in or out" dichotomy, which seems rather more computational, but in a limiting way rather than an inductively rich one, if that makes sense. So, the dynamic structure of the Aethus then serves as my exact proposal for a replacement which satisfies this intuition. Among some of the perks are its ability to connect innumerable different representations of itself as static Aethae, and also more intrinsic resistance to treatments like Russell's paradox, either in the abstract, (i.e. structural), or the inductive, (i.e. applications), domains. So the avoidance of sets is just part of a wider trend of trying to fit the brand of the Aethic structure, if that makes sense! Purely intuitively, it's water over sand, so to speak!

9. As for your third bullet point—that's correct: all possible invalidities in the future blocks should be inherited by the present block, and the third postulate itself is what handles this.

10. Also I just want to put in a quick mention of the Aethic intrinsic structure and Aethic retrievals themselves, (even though it's not an explicit question in your email, it might inform some other responses of mine and be useful to have laid out in general), as that's the mathematical machinery that makes this whole thing run! The mathematical definition of an Aethus is "given lists of properties describing part of a system, an Aethus is an equivalence class of lists which can be entirely derived from one another". That's really the backbone of the recursive segment of the idea, because the pitch is that sets of properties alone fall short in "depicting" a system, (i.e. the system is invariant under certain property rephrasings on the list, so an individual list itself is not exhaustive of all epistemological viewpoints of that system). Now, the next more complicated layer is that these lists themselves are actually mappings, not simply lists of true statements. This is a generalization, because mapping an item to the state true is analogous to asserting that item as true. But, we can also map items to false, or even to mathematical objects or structures like manifolds or other Aethae, to name some examples. The exhaustive equivalence class of all such synonymous mappings gives you an Aethus by definition. Also, I should note that the items are called "attributes", and the things to which they map are called "states". Also the lists themselves are called "static Aethae". The ontological pitch there is that if you know even a single static Aethus, then you also know the Aethus, (even if you haven't sorted through every last deduction manually). Then comes the idea of blank stated-attributes, which are simply attributes in a static Aethus which map to a predefined "Aethic blank state". So, like the Aethic equivalent of the null state from computer languages, to give a rough analogy. The idea with blank stated-attributes is that including them or not always generates the same Aethus, so we automatically get another layer of Aethic equivalence from that. I.e. every Aethus has static Aethae with all possible blank stated-attributes being present in their sets or not, like a vast power set sort of deal. The key of including the ability for blank stated-attributes to exist in an Aethus, then, is that now we can also classify unknowing in an Aethus. This is where the second postulate gets baked into the structure directly: the idea is that we have a special mapping called an Aethic retrieval, which takes as an input an attribute and an Aethus. The return state, simply put, is the state of that attribute if it exists in any of the static Aethae, or the set of all possible states which could correspond to that attribute otherwise. This is the second postulate of the Aethus directly—because it conveys that unknowing leads to many possibilities in the realized world. The caveat, though, is that the retrieval sets themselves are technically "Retrieval Objects", which is just so that they're iteratively compatible with the Aethic union principle. And the other caveat is that I mentioned an important feature of Aethic attributes—which is that they can combine into larger Aethic attributes. What if, then, you retrieve the larger one from an Aethus, but its one part is stated in the Aethus and the other is blank? This is where you get the Aethic dichotomy theorem, which tells you to retrieve the total number of states for that

attribute in which the first component has that fixed state, but the second is allowed to vary. This can be derived from the second postulate directly using induction. And the last caveat, by the way, is that weighted Aethae then come in when we allow real-valued linear combinations of Aethae, by which process you can extend this underlying treatment so as to allow an attribute to only be "50%" added into an Aethus so as to produce a child Aethus. That's the gist of that analysis! (And this initial treatment of course doesn't even begin to capture the ontological identity of an Aethus, and instead is simply the stage on which we humans can ideally model such an ontological Aethus—such is the pitch at least).

11. Oh and by the way for why I chose the name "Aethus": no particular reason, funnily enough! When I first created the base structure back in 2021, I felt like calling it "Ethus" because it sounded all cool and mystical and stuff, and then I later stuck an A at the front of it so that "Aethic" wasn't "Ethic". That's about it, really!

12. I also want to thank you for giving me all these new interpretation names, especially in the context of how they play into Aethic reasoning itself! Saves me a lot of trouble of having to go hunt them down myself, and it's also super cool for me to see the context of things come together in general! Also makes me feel like I'm part of a history, which is an awesome feeling to have!

Anyways, that seems to be everything I can think of, but please do feel free to tell me if I missed anything or if a clarification is needed! Thanks again for the comments and questions about everything, as well as the external context-building!
–Ajax □

13.13.2 The Correspondence, Read Back Through the Current Formulation

The correspondence above is the historical record and stands verbatim; the reading below sets it beside the current formulation, with every correction kept outside the emails. What the exchange raised falls into four groups: what has been retained, what has been revised, which of Devin's questions the current formulation answers directly, and what still requires demonstration.

Retained: the a-priori selection set. Devin's sharpest structural question, the one the reply itself flagged as "a big one", was what set of child Aethae an agent considers a priori before pruning, and under what measure. The reply declined to write that set and referred instead to the new attributes to be picked up, the child Aethae following as their conjunctions, with the jump quantified as *the ratio of Aethic weights of the attribute-generated children* and the question of *which* attribute is picked up explicitly left open. All three pieces survive in the current formulation: the stated-attribute indexing that the counterfactual semantics later made load-bearing, (Section 9.1); weight as a relational quantity, the Relational Weight Principle, (Principle 22), whose own footnote dates its settlement to 2025 and its formal recording to June 2026; and the weighted proper child of Definition 36. The reply names the package in passing: "the principle of centric unfolding[356]." Two claims should be kept apart here. The email itself leaves attribute selection underdetermined while discussing weight ratios across arbitrary horizons; that is visible in the record. The stronger reading, on which the correspondence between weights and realization holds in the asymptotic limit while the finite-step process is deliberately left open, is the author's retrospective clarification. In the current formulation it is the asymptotic law of the draw law, (Section 4.2): centric unfolding is a constraint on a family of processes rather than the specification of a unique process, and what is unique is the specified asymptotic outcome probabilities. Finite-time behavior is underdetermined within the admissible family, not arbitrary, since

[356]An interesting illustration of my linguistic masking in this email is how I did not even consider it important to consciously mention my two deliberate steps in centric unfolding of 1) realized Markovian probabilities in Aethic reasoning correspond, as is the central constraint on that Markovian process (its name is centric unfolding), to Aethic weights strictly in the asymptotic Aethic time limit, and 2) therefore we design the axioms of that Markovian process to assert no-underdetermination of it in the asymptotic limit but perfectly allow arbitrary underdetermination in the finite-step regime so long as the constraint on the Markov process that is the axioms themselves remains satisfied, altogether because 3) any design of the Aethic Markov process other than explicitly this violates *hypotheses non fingo*, (such as even in Algorithmic Idealism [17], notice how the self state binary code is a black box in terms of reading it—which at the root is simply an inadvertent modeling side effect of asserting finite-step non-underdetermination). The reason this was linguistic masking, therefore, is that I considered this intuition entirely self-explanatory from the model itself, because I didn't think to specifically realize that people would miss the constraint-instead-of-non-underdetermination modeling choice (because they would first have to realize I was explicitly making the *hypotheses non fingo* move) and at once recognize this as my realizing a general principle over the space of self state theories like Algorithmic Idealism [17].

parenthood, validity and the endpoint constraint still exclude many finite histories. The framework's present commitments do not warrant choosing a particular finite-step mechanism; another theory may introduce one for independent reasons and accept the corresponding empirical burden.

Retained: weights across horizons. Read together, point 4's transitivity parenthetical, (child Aethae as "descendent Aethae", the generations compressed into a single Aethus), and its arbitrary-horizon clause, ("you could project whether you would expect a given attribute to an arbitrary time in the future"), say that near-term and far-term attribute pickup are evaluated the same way. A far-outcome weight need not be computed by traversing a chosen itinerary: the far descendant is a weighted child of the current Aethus, priced at the current books, and the result is independent of the chosen decomposition of the calculation; where a finer resolution is available, its products and sums agree with the direct weight, by the partition-consistency law of the forward mirror, (Section 9.1), and the coherence the draw law requires, (Section 4.2). In that sense no Aethic time is privileged in what the weights refer to.[357] The objection to reading Aethic probabilities as yielding "the next state" is the same point: a proper child need not be an immediate successor, and "next" would privilege one descendant by its proximity. Transitivity establishes accessibility, not density, and finite carving models do have adjacent elements; what the framework declines is a preferred step, not the existence of adjacent ones. The counterfactual semantics has the backward-facing counterpart: evaluation there does not walk the unfolding back to a branch point, (Section 9.1), as projection here need not walk it forward.

Retained: blocks and descendants. On the block-merging arithmetic, Devin observed that it "seems analogous to how in QM the linear combination of states is always itself a state". The current construction agrees: point 1's arithmetic over attached Aethae is the commutative semiring of the weighted layer, with addition as Aethic union, the sum a single element, and the last-common-ancestor quotient counting shared information once. The email's "descendent Aethae" are the proper children at any depth, transitive under the composition property of Definition 37, as they had been in the framework since 2023.

Retained: graded invalidity. Devin asked whether a 99%-credence invalidity could exist. The April answer, assigning disjoint attributes to the valid and invalid cases, weighting them, and letting the invalid case force its invalidity by combination, survives in the weighted formulation of Section 6.7, with one point the current formulation states explicitly: invalidity itself is not graded. It is a label, with weight zero as its algebraic face, so a 99% credence lives in the weights over valid structure, and the third postulate can remain an implication rather than a biconditional.

Revised: the spin discussion. Devin pressed the up/up sequential-measurement case and offered a time-indexed repair, $\mathrm{P}(+, t_1)$ against $\mathrm{P}(-, t_2)$: "if it's at different times, what's the contradiction?" The suggestion deserves direct credit, since outcomes at distinct events are not contradictory merely because their values differ, and the elementary indexing repair is sound. The April reply instead leaned on the *stackal transform*, a proposed conversion of any sequential update process into a fills-blanks-only treatment, staking the framework's falsifiability on no process resisting it. That treatment of spin measurements was dropped in February 2026. Two revisions came in sequence: first the recognition that the measurements themselves are determinate, quantum uncertainty pertaining to the prediction of subsequent measurements; then, in February 2026, the Berry-phase path-integral treatment, in which spin measurements are paths on the Bloch sphere as ordinary path-integral paths traverse spacetime. The later geometric treatment explains more than the indexing repair without invalidating it. The same move had been made concretely for spacetime in the author's April 2024 journal work, and the February 2026 spin treatment prompted its abstraction into the opening move as now stated, (Section 14 ff.). The April "gamble" paragraph's falsifiability instinct survives in the lookout principle of the coherence section; its named mechanism does not.

Answered: the Hilbert-space probes. "Layering a new attribute per measurement would be adding Hilbert-space dimensions?" Not by itself: distinguishing successive measurement records does not enlarge the measured system's Hilbert space, since sequential measurements can be represented by operations and instruments on a fixed Hilbert space, and explicitly modeling the recording apparatus is a separate enlargement. "Would the slots' interpretation have to change over a long descent?" The question presupposes a fixed slot inventory, which the current formulation does not have: attributes

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Also speaking of no-privileging constraints in Aethic reasoning, the analysis of my response to the Devin email properly/sufficiently conveys how my objection to Aethic probabilities yielding ‘‘the next state’’ is so that we don’t privilege one Aethic time over another in terms of what the Aethic weights refer to? As in, the Aethic weights are just as informative about the Aethus you may have 10 years from now as it is about the one which you’ll have one minute from now. See what I mean??? Thanks!

are open-endedly minable, (the collage doctrine beside Theorem 8), and a single attribute can stand part-stated, part-blank, so reinterpretation is replaced by decomposition. And "what do you mean 'at a time'?" In the current formulation entries are not filled in at a time; they are established along the centric unfolding, and every proper-time point holds its standing relative to an Aethus.

Still requiring demonstration: the comparative claims. Constructor theory's possible/impossible dichotomy ranges over tasks, while joint invalidity ranges over co-presences of stated content; in the framework the dichotomy comes with an identity criterion, (closure), an algebra for the impossible, (invalidity as a label inside the commutative semiring), and a built-in recursion, (the third postulate's two-generation quantifier). Constructor theory has its own developed arguments about information and quantum-information phenomena, and proposed experimental tests; a comparison of results would need a sustained technical treatment, which is not attempted here. For the many-interacting-worlds picture and Tappenden's unitary mind [70], (Section 2.5.1), whose shared open problem is why branch proportion should be probability, the framework's answer is its identification of probability with relative Aethic weight, realized through centric unfolding: the algebra fixes how weights combine, and the realization principle, a stated principle rather than an algebraic consequence, relates them to outcomes. And for Müller's program [17], which Müller describes as admitting several mathematical formalizations, the difference is one of grain: algorithmic idealism foregrounds next-self-state prediction, while centric unfolding constrains change at the attribute grain without selecting a unique acquisition schedule.

Still requiring demonstration: the isomorphism question. Devin suspected that a fully worked Aethic theory matching experience would prove isomorphic to quantum mechanics. The answer depends on which objects are compared, and a derivational hierarchy does not by itself preclude an isomorphism between specified structures. For empirical predictions, the framework's quantitative construction is meant to agree with quantum mechanics where tested, divergence being claimed only at the named frontiers of the coherence section. For modal consequence relations, the classification of Section 9.4 places the Aethic conditional outside the family of similarity-ordering semantics; that is a result about counterfactual consequence, not a proof of non-equivalence to quantum mechanics as a whole. For ontological commitments the two differ by construction, in what exists, what is stateable, and what derives from what, which is the grain at which interpretations are individuated; whether such differences count as non-equivalence where predictions coincide is a judgment, and only the frontiers would convert it into an empirical one. Claims specific to the Copenhagen interpretation, such as that its collapse axiom is not well-defined, are argued in Section 10.4.1 as the author's position about that axiom, and are not settled here. The Tsirelson bound has moved from deferred to well-posed, the layer doctrine standing as its candidate principle, (Section 14.6.5), a candidate rather than a derivation.

The self and the arrow. Devin's closing observation, that the direction of expected next experience looks like time's arrow for agents like us, is correct at the empirical grain: the centric unfolding walked is the arrow felt. The tree itself has direction, parenthood distinguishing ancestors from descendants; what it lacks is a preferred step size, a distinguished global itinerary, and an identification with spacetime's temporal order. His press on the self, that future-compatibility for a block looks ontological, locates a boundary the paper still keeps: the first postulate relativizes the chain's structure to what an Aethus can reference, the framework supplies no trans-Aethic criterion of personal identity, and the April reply's Newtonian-versus-Boltzmann modesty about quantum immortality remains the standing position. Devin's first suggestion, Müller's work, is taken up in the convergence note beside the Frauchiger–Renner analysis, (Section 10.2.2), which registers the self-state alignment with Algorithmic Idealism [17].

13.14 The Accounting, Closed

The ledger of Section 1.3 unpacked the eight load-bearing posits where the price was first stated. Having reached the end of the logical sector, the tally can be closed in one line each, with the grade at which the body of the paper has held it.

Posit	Grade	What it bought
The index	primitive	two-place determinacy; the paradox set dissolved
The constructive blank	primitive	the open past; the counterfactual semantics
Primitive jointness of *or*	primitive, inductive ground	the two regimes; the second grade
The $\exists\forall$ quantifier	derived in form, posited in class	collapse as checkmate; the boundary as a partition
The composition primitive	primitive of the algebra	the tree, the reduced form
The zerosumfree semiring	design choice	validity separated from weight
The kernel	the one quantitative posit	the recovery theorem
The realization bridge	principle, not theorem	labels to outcomes

What the section that follows adds. The section that follows introduces exactly one further commitment—the Opening Move of Active Reasoning, (Principle 55), that the arena over which the kernel is defined is active space rather than spacetime, with spacetime a projection—and states its speculative program under that commitment, tiered as derived, rejected, or conditional at every site. A reader who stops here has the framework's full logical sector priced; a reader who continues will find no entry added to this list, only the one named.

14 A Prelude to Active Reasoning

Let us now wrap up this paper with a basic explanation of how Aethic disagreeing superpositions in a quantum context partition the quantum state, that is in accordance with the ontological assertion of the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning that *agreeing superpositions are ontologically upstream of quantum interference directly.* In order to do this, we are going to compose a basic toy model where the Born rule is taken as an additional axiom to the three Aethic postulates. Such a theoretical framework may perhaps be classified as a "proto-active reasoning" but not truly a form of "active reasoning", for the simple reason that it still takes the Born rule as an axiom rather than deducing it from something ontologically or causally deeper, (to the same level as how Aethic reasoning deduces rather than postulates the double-slit experiment's outcomes). The purpose of including this section is to remove the ambiguity behind how Aethic superpositions carry over to standard quantum superpositions in a broad sense, that way we will have a clear enough headspace to engage with active reasoning in its own designated paper.

In a standard quantum mechanical setup for the double-slit experiment, we establish the total wavefunction of a particle arriving at destination x as the quantum superposition of its arriving there by means of slit A, and by means of slit B. Altogether this is represented as the uniform superposition of two respective probability amplitudes, $\psi_A(x)$ and $\psi_B(x)$.

$$\psi(x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\big(\psi_A(x) + \psi_B(x)\big) \tag{69}$$

We then define the Born rule as the axiom that the probability mass of finding the particle at x is equal to the square magnitude of this wavefunction.

$$\begin{aligned} P(x) &= |\psi(x)|^2 \\ &= \frac{1}{2}\Big(|\psi_A(x)|^2 + |\psi_B(x)|^2 + 2\,\mathrm{Re}\big[\psi_A^*(x)\psi_B(x)\big]\Big) \end{aligned} \tag{70}$$

Now let us state the "basic" Aethic influence on the probability mass, before giving an ontological deepening of the argument.

Principle 49 (Born Rule Onset Principle of Aethic Reasoning)
The Born rule is procedurally applied after *summing agreeing superpositions, but* before *summing disagreeing superpositions.*

That is to say that for multiple states in agreeing Aethic superposition in a quantum context, the proper procedure is to sum their probability amplitudes rather than summing their individual square magnitudes, for the simple reason that this allows the interference terms to remain intact.

The fundamental ontological interpretation of this follows from the Aethic premise that agreeing superpositions are the "default" and elementally irreducible state of indeterminacy in the universe, with all classical disagreeing superpositions simply being a composite alternative. That is to say that the interference is "just what the universe does in all situations", with the collapse-driving of disagreeing superpositions then acting as a further constraint upon this basic substrate so as to boost complexity in the Aethic structure. Intuitively, this is quite like the Higgs mechanism in quantum field theory: the universe admits a structurally natural description prior to symmetry breaking and a distinct, empirically realized description after it, but the latter is an emergent, non-fundamental representation whose meaning depends on the mechanism that produces it. Treating only the post-Higgs description as fundamental, while neglecting the Higgs mechanism, would therefore be theoretically misleading.

Concerning disagreeing superpositions, now, they forbid interference terms because of their explicit nested structure with negations. Methodologically, then, they contribute to the probability amplitudes by first running the Born rule over the wavefunctions of complete agreeing superpositions, before adding all relevant probability masses in disagreeing superposition as in classical probability. This is altogether what is meant by the before versus after distinction.

Now we might make a subtler point, however, about the true nature of agreeing superpositions in a quantum-positional context. That is, *the fundamental ontological claim we may wish to make is that it is a fallacy to assume that agreeing superpositions are ever reduced to fixed determinate states whatsoever, even with finitely unlimited information. Instead, the universe is better thought of as disagreeing superpositions running over pure categorical agreeing superpositions, however compact they may be. What we may infer from this is that it is actually a category error to model positional propagation of any particle in the universe as a disagreeing superposition running over any primitive category other than explicit agreeing superpositions of scenarios*[358]. For instance, had we said that "a disagreeing superposition is run over three separate paths of travel" is asserted a category error: instead, the proper result would be to suppose that a disagreeing superposition is running over multiple agreeing superpositions of many paths, even if each such agreeing superposition's collection of paths are arbitrarily similar up to slight perturbations. In order to illustrate this ontological circumstance, let us refer to the same intuition which leads to the Feynman path integral formulation [295] itself.

14.1 Multi-Slit Experiments as an Illustration of Aethic Pruning

14.1.1 Base Explanation

To begin with, suppose we have a variation of the double-slit experiment where there are not two, but four slits, A, B, C, and D. Furthermore, we might imagine setting up a detector contraption which fires off a detection if the particle travels through slit A *or* slit B, but without saving the information about which of the two it traveled through specifically. We might refer to this as the single *detection condition* of the system. Accordingly, now, we may use Aethic reasoning to deduce the probability density function of the resulting interference pattern.

The formal Aethic mechanism, by the general Aethic union concept, is to list the powerset of possible slits which are traversed in agreeing superposition, carry out the Aethic union of the Aethae pertaining to each element of this set, and then take the reduced form of that Aethus as the result. In practice it is usually better to find constraints invalidating an entire category of cases rather than only one at a time, but for the sake of visualization we will list all possible Aethic cases regardless, (since after all there are only sixteen of them).

[358] In case anyone is curious, the tip-off for me that this is how the ontology works was simply how you still get diffraction in a single-slit variation of the double-slit experiment. What this demonstrates is that the Aethic pruning does not want to boil down to individual paths at all—rather it just leaves exactly as many paths in the system as it can without triggering contradiction.

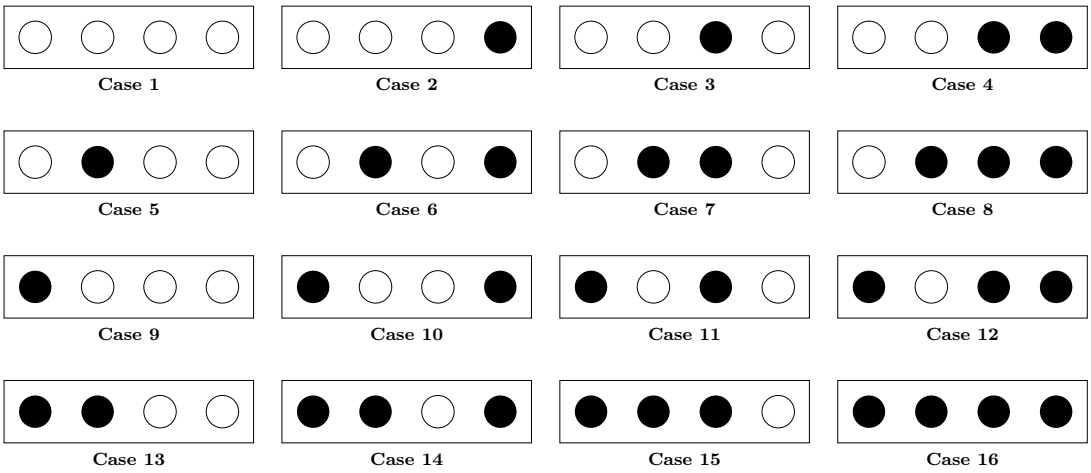


Figure 9: An example of the canonical sixteen Aethic cases in Aethic superposition for a four-slit variation of the double-slit experiment. Note that the slits are to be labeled A, B, C, and D from left to right in each case. According to the Born rule onset principle, each individual one of these cases corresponds to an agreeing superposition over its indicated slits being traversed. The total Aethic union of all such cases is the Aethus-wide agreeing superposition of the cases, which corresponds simply to summing their individual probability masses subsequently to applying the Born rule to each of them individually.
The idea is that the total Aethic union technically points to the correct system Aethus, but the reduced form mechanism, by deduction from the Aethic postulates, will invalidate some of the cases anyway, (ie where the Aethus of just unioning them is Aethically equivalent to the Aethus in which you also correctly specify which are invalid by deduction from the postulates).

Given this setup, now, we take the system Aethus as the union of all of these cases, then intersected with the Aethus for which the detector system in question is included. Given such an Aethus, we may then find its reduced form by means of deducing which cases are invalid according to the Aethic postulates.

The first general constraint we may note is the application of the third postulate itself. According to this particular detection condition, we have that if either slit C or D is traversed by the particle—that is by means of being included in the agreeing superposition, as signified the state of its traversal in the Aethic retrieval—then the detector will fire, and so Aethic checkmate will occur if and only if slit A or B is also traversed in the agreeing superposition. In such a checkmate scenario, that is, it will never not be possible to a given proper child Aethus that the agent in question may add the information about whether the detector fired to their Aethus, thereby forming an Aethic contradiction directly between the case's intrinsic assertion that one of A or B was traversed and the detector's assertion that it was not. Altogether, this collectively invalidates all cases where A or B is traversed while C or D is traversed. If we treat T_i as the Boolean state of slit i being traversed, then the detection condition itself Aethically contradicts the following logical statement.

$$(T_A \vee T_B) \wedge (T_C \vee T_D) \tag{71}$$

Therefore, we directly invalidate all Aethus cases in which this statement is true as the third postulate's pruning.

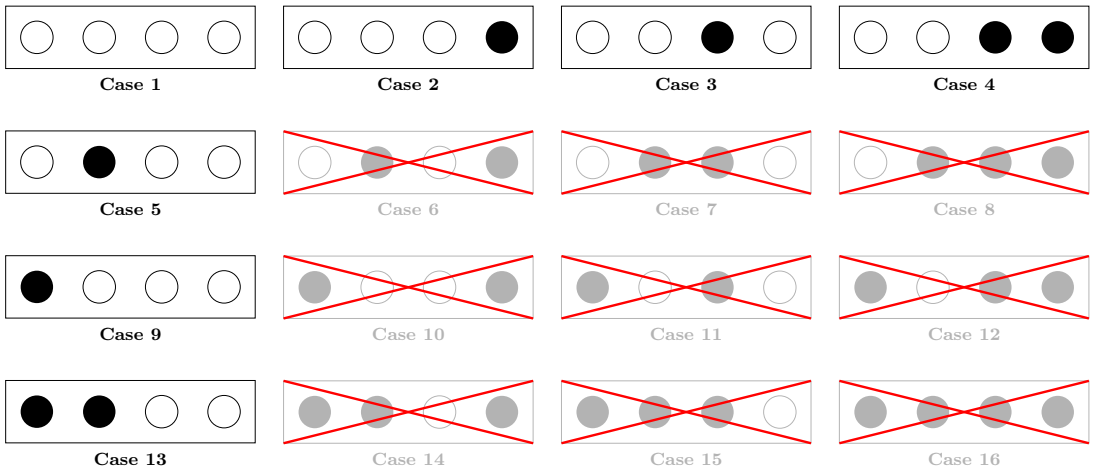


Figure 10: Shown are the first round of invalidated cases, as per the third postulate of the Aethus.

Now we may invalidate the rest of the invalid cases by means of the second postulate of the Aethus. In particular, it deduces that a stated-attribute may not be determinate if asserted blank in said Aethus. Physically speaking, to the experimenter's Aethus who carries out the experiment, quantum uncertainty determines that beyond the detection condition explicitly outlined, they may never again add any more which-path information to their Aethus. Accordingly, then, the entire system Aethus deduces from this that the which-slit attribute is mixed-decomposable into a stated-attribute for whether the detector fired or not (by means of the detection condition) and a conceptually blank attribute for which slit it went through among the remaining non-contradictory options. For this reason, we may immediately invalidate all Aethic cases for which the particle determinately goes through one slit and not its allowed neighbor, explicitly because the second postulate deduces this must be in agreeing superposition given the initial system Aethus's aforementioned conceptually blank attribute component. Such gives us the remainder of our invalid Aethic cases.

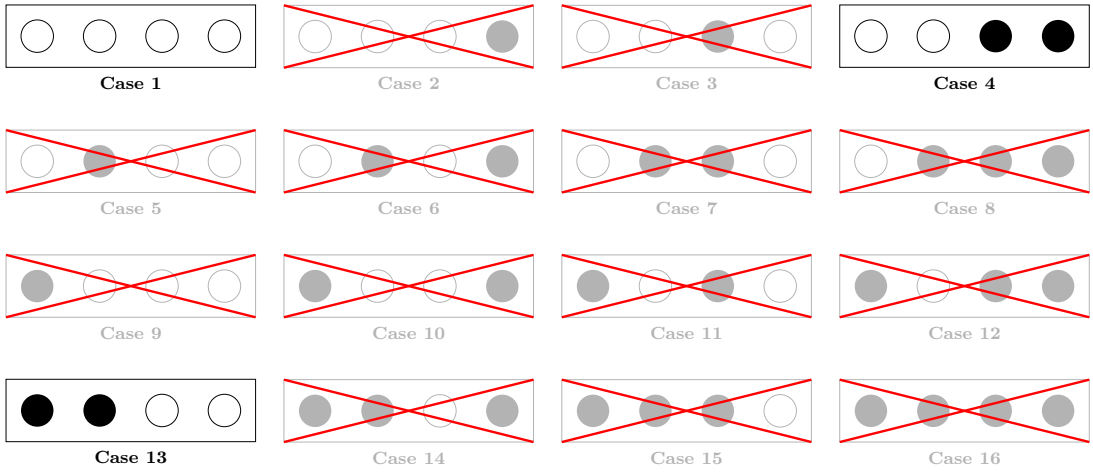


Figure 11: Shown is the completed reduced form of the Aethus, for which state state of invalidating precisely this cases is the most exhaustive invalidity operation on the cases which remains Aethically equivalent to the system Aethus.
Please also note, for reference, that I have been developing a special website meant to house interactive demonstrations of this multi-slit experiment with detectors, along with the more abstract algorithms underlying them, so I encourage my readers to visit it for a hands-on supplement to the analysis in this section.

Accordingly, then, what we see is that this entire system Aethus is Aethically equivalent, (at the validity tier, as with every reduced-form statement), to a reduced form in which only the "no slits traversed", "only A and B traversed", and "only C and D traversed" cases are in Aethic superposition.

By the Aethic sifting principle these remain in superposition in the general case[359] of such a system Aethus, but then one may Aethically update to a particular one of these cases later on in Aethic time, since after all they are valid and proper child Aethae. A key reconciliation of this regarding the Born rule onset principle itself is how the total Aethic mechanism at play is not simply to render disagreeing superpositions as the removal of interference terms directly: *rather, the central mechanism is to split the entire process into a pre-Born rule-application stage and a post-Born rule-application stage, with the total characterization of the probability mass being simply the nesting of these two stages.* So the process is not quite a dichotomy between agreeing superpositions and disagreeing superpositions—rather the disagreeing superpositions are merely a useful label for a certain category of cases, but more fundamentally it is the post-Born rule-application stage of compiling cases through classical probability addition which triggers the "appearance" of disagreeing superposition-like circumstances, (for example, in this previous example, we might label the resulting system Aethus as a "disagreeing superposition between going through the first two slits and the second two slits", since after all this concisely captures how the two cases are mutually exclusive in this particular Aethic structure).

14.1.2 Assessing the General Aethic Algorithm for Multi-Slit Experiments

What the theorem does, and why it is the centerpiece. Having walked the four-slit case by hand, we can now state the general algorithm by which the Aethic postulates classify the powerset of slit-traversal cases for an arbitrary multi-slit experiment under an arbitrary detector configuration—and the classification is the framework's centerpiece, because it is the exact object that replaces the Heisenberg cut. Standard quantum mechanics locates the quantum–classical boundary by a convention about scale or complexity and cannot say where it falls; the theorem below locates it by a *partition*, the one the configuration's records induce over the slits, and says exactly where it falls for every configuration at once: coherence survives within a class of slits no record can tell apart and dies across any two classes some record separates. Everything quantum enters through which partition the records induce, and nothing else does—no size, no mass, no observer.

The theorem consumes four things, each already on the books: the second postulate, read constructively, which forbids a coherence claim from asserting a resolution no record could produce; the third postulate, which invalidates a claim that any accessible record could contradict; the Record-Individuation Lemma proved directly after the statement, which says that slits sharing every possible record are not distinct alternatives of any attribute; and a totality convention on what counts as a record, stated among the guards. It delivers three things: the trichotomy itself, in which the second and third postulates partition the invalid cases into two complementary and non-overlapping regions—over-specification within a class, and contradiction across classes; the sliding quantum–classical boundary as literal re-classification, since moving or erasing a detector re-draws the partition and re-bins every case, which is the double slit, the quantum eraser, and delayed choice as one theorem; and a non-circular ground for Feynman's indistinguishability rule, with amplitudes adding within a class and probabilities across, the boundary between the two additions being the partition. The proof is short once the two definitions are in place: exhaustiveness and exclusivity are combinatorial, and the two postulate labels are earned by exhibiting, for each invalid case, the record whose stating contradicts it. The key intermediate object is the *equivalence class* induced by the detector configuration over the set of slits, which the two definitions now fix.

Definition 51 (Detector Signature)
For a multi-slit experiment with n slits $\{s_1, \ldots, s_n\}$ and m detectors $\{d_1, \ldots, d_m\}$, each of which fires upon the traversal of any slit in its designated subset, we define the detector signature of slit s_i as the Boolean m-tuple

$$\sigma(s_i) = \big(s_i \in d_1,\ s_i \in d_2,\ \ldots,\ s_i \in d_m\big) \tag{72}$$

recording which detectors would fire if slit s_i alone were traversed.

Definition 52 (Detector-Induced Equivalence Class)
Two slits s_i and s_j are observationally indistinguishable under the given detector configuration if and only if $\sigma(s_i) = \sigma(s_j)$. This relation is an equivalence relation, and we denote its equivalence classes by $[s_i]_\sigma$. The set of all such equivalence classes partitions the slit set completely[360].

[359] Ie "upfront in the experiment" to use a more informal sequentialist intuition, (although more rigorously the reduced form is about a coupling, and so does not care about either ordering in time pertaining to the reveal. This ambiguity is what makes the delayed-choice [10] experiment possible).

[360] Note that slits sharing a detector signature are precisely those for which no measurement—neither present nor

To illustrate, in the four-slit example just discussed, we had one detector firing on $A \vee B$. The detector signatures are $\sigma(A) = \sigma(B) = (1)$ and $\sigma(C) = \sigma(D) = (0)$, yielding two equivalence classes: $\{A, B\}$ and $\{C, D\}$. The valid non-empty cases in the reduced form were precisely these two classes, as we saw.

We are now prepared to state the general classification[361].

Theorem 14 (Powerset Invalidation Theorem)
Assume the record structure of the declared configuration is complete and persistent*: each slit's signature includes every record of its traversal accessible within the configuration's declared refinements, and every declared refinement retains a descendant stating each such record. Then: For an n-slit experiment with a given detector configuration, stated relative to the Aethus A doing the classifying, let the detector-induced equivalence classes partition the set of slits into classes $E_1, E_2, \ldots, E_k$. Then, relative to A, every element T of the powerset $\mathcal{P}(\{s_1, \ldots, s_n\})$ falls into exactly one of the following three categories.*

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future—can distinguish which of them the particle traversed. This is the physical content of the equivalence: if two slits trigger exactly the same set of detectors, then no child Aethus can ever contain an attribute distinguishing between them, and so by the second postulate the which-slit attribute among them must remain in agreeing superposition.

[361]The explicit computational implementation of this classification as an algorithm—including the equivalence class construction as a data structure keyed by detector signatures—was produced with AI assistance (Claude Opus 4.6) in early 2026, after being given the three Aethic postulates and the four-slit case analysis with OR-type detectors from this section as input, (and specifically the general principle that slits both outside and inside any single detector's scope in a case ought to be marked invalid by the third postulate). The conceptual content of the classification, being that second postulate invalidations correspond to over-specificity within indistinguishable groups and third postulate invalidations correspond to cross-group contradictions, is what was specified in the prompt and is deducible from the postulates as established throughout this paper. What is interesting though is that the AI took this condition I mentioned about where the third postulate creates invalidities (which mentally I pictured more as a detector-by-detector basis), and actually compacted it into the main equivalence class idea so as to essentially carry my more sprawling deductive intuitions (which for clarity I obviously could have pulled off generally, just not with the written compactness of the algorithm it provided) into a package that is quicker and therefore more directly analyzable as per this section. Note however, of course, that this is merely deduction which was sped up by a more compact algorithm, rather than being anywhere near a full theoretical capacity under inductive reasoning—something which I find AI to be essentially the living antithesis of because such things are novelty incarnate, and machine learning is conformity incarnate, (after all, unlike deductive reasoning, inductive reasoning is an art form which utterly requires human control—like for example I have noticed the fascinating fact that AI consistently states the third postulate of the Aethus wrong, presumably because there is nothing quite like it in its training database). So this all being said about how I deliberately set up the axioms ages ago (May 8, 2023) from which all deduction can be drawn, I am still nonetheless impressed at how AI has reached a level where it can genuinely carry out basic deductive procedure more cleanly than I can. Again, I could *do* the deduction—which is why I picked the postulates I picked in the first place, of course—just the AI sometimes genuinely streamlines it more cleanly than I can. So altogether what fully happened was I told it exactly what I wanted, inclusive of the four-slit example and my criterion for which the third postulate invalidates the powerset element cases on a detector-by-detector basis, and then when I ran the UI the AI coded it was completely broken and unusable, algorithmically. I told it exactly where it failed to meet my criteria at this point, and *then* exactly just then it wrote a rather elegant JavaScript algorithm containing the equivalence class model. So what I suspect is that it's essentially pulling from its training in the methodology of deductive reasoners who are far better than me, and then simply channeled that into making a quick algorithm, which then itself happened to compact the deduction itself into something cleaner than how I was carrying it out. So yes, again I must emphasize that this was merely deduction, and then again not even original deduction since I told it the axioms and the procedure, just still it genuinely cleaned up the way I was doing the deduction anyway.

Also concerning the powerset invalidation theorem itself, where the P2 and P3 invalid cases are entirely disjoint, and exhaustively capture all invalid cases jointly, this has been foundationally obvious to me since I completed the third postulate in the first place, (since actually establishing it in the first place, of course, is itself an act of meeting this criterion among other things). This is especially visible even in how I've always phrased the second postulate starting with "if an Aethus is valid", that way it can be turned on its head into its contrapositive for use as a pruning mechanism. So yes, that general principle has been foundational since the beginning. Obviously though I haven't gone through each and every application of it, as for example the multi-slit experiment with "OR"-style detectors was an idea that struck me as a pedagogical illustration of the Quantum Nexus while I was going to sleep on Feb 6, 2026, but I can safely say that having produced the inductive step that is the postulates for the express purpose of such a "covering generality" over all cases, it was sort of the entire point that the second and third postulates ought to broadly exactly cut the invalid cases into their contributions. Where I credit the AI though is not in showing me the principle of course, but merely that after I saw the algorithm it produced for the equivalence classes, I recognized that I perhaps was not explicit enough about this theorem in the paper itself, which is why I added it in as an extra note after the fact.

> *Feb 6, 2026 5:54 AM*
>
> Ngl I kind of just pulled an all nighter lol, but right now while going to sleep I came up with the idea of a four-slit "or style" double-slit experiment to illustrate my very early idea of the expanded path integral and its Aethic relations explicitly. So, that could be helpful lol, and I almost kind of wonder if it could be advantageous to put straight in the Aethus paper as a bonus section, since it doesn't quite have the spacetime insight in it yet, and is close enough to Aethic reasoning where I might want to formally claim it while I'm ahead!

1. *Valid (✓): $T = \varnothing$, or $T = E_j$ for some j. That is, T is either the empty set or exactly matches one of the equivalence classes.*

2. *Second Postulate invalidation ($\times P2$): T is a non-empty proper subset of some single equivalence class E_j. That is, $\varnothing \neq T \subsetneq E_j$ for some j.*

3. *Third Postulate invalidation ($\times P3$): T contains elements from two or more distinct equivalence classes. That is, there exist $i \neq j$ such that $T \cap E_i \neq \varnothing$ and $T \cap E_j \neq \varnothing$.*

These three categories are mutually exclusive and jointly exhaustive.

Lemma 7 (Record-Individuation)
In the physical instance, let a and b be two candidate alternatives with identical detector signatures relative to an Aethus A: no record, in any refinement of A along accessible records, distinguishes them. Then no attribute of A's attribute space has a stated-attribute that holds of exactly one of a and b; a and b are not distinct alternatives of any attribute, and a coherence claim over a proper subset of a signature class over-specifies.

Proof. Suppose some attribute β separated them: a stated-attribute (β, y) holding of a and not of b. By the first postulate a stated-attribute is content only as carried by some Aethus, and by the record discipline of the physical instance, (the Sifting Principle, Principle 26: measurement asserts a record into the world's own sector, and observation is the transit by which an Aethus comes to state what the record fixed), an Aethus of that instance comes to state (β, y) only through a record that fixes it. A record fixing (β, y) would distinguish a from b, contradicting identical signatures over all accessible records. So no Aethus in A's refinement structure ever states (β, y) or any alternative of β that separates the two: β stands blank in every refinement and derivable in none. But an attribute is individuated by its alternatives, (the first primitive of Section 9.1.1: an attribute carries its space of alternatives, an alternative being what some stated-attribute can select), and an alternative selectable by no stated-attribute of any Aethus is not an alternative the attribute space contains. Permanence closes the last exit, "determinate but unaskable": a value of β fixed in no Aethus ever is a fact with no index to carry it, the category error the first postulate names, so it is not a determinate value either. Hence no attribute separates a from b. □

The lemma's grade is derived, from the first postulate and the definition of an attribute, given the record discipline; the discipline itself—that in the physical instance content enters an Aethus through records and nowhere else—is the Sifting Principle's content and remains the booked item. The Brief's inventory therefore imports the principle rather than books it as primitive, and the theorem's second guard below is discharged at that grade.

Four guards on the theorem's setup, each owed to a careful reader.

1. *Totality.* signatures quantify over *all* correlated degrees of freedom, preparation included—aim a beam at one slit with no detector anywhere, and the collimator itself is the record that licenses the singleton; without totality the theorem would misclassify ordinary preparations. What a record *is*, since the partition it induces draws the boundary: it is not a physical primitive added to the framework: a record of an alternative is any degree of freedom whose state is correlated with that alternative and is stated in some refinement of some Aethus—the Record-Individuation Lemma read as a definition, (Lemma 7)—and there is no independent notion of a "physically real distinction" for the definition to be circular against, since the first postulate has already made determinacy two-place. The positive side of the same definition is the Fundamental Theorem, (Section 8): where no record can ever be taken, every alternative is performed at once, which is what the agreeing regime is. What the framework does not supply is the dynamics that make some degrees of freedom correlate and stay correlated; that is decoherence theory's business, and every boundary statement is exact conditional on the physically realized record structure, not derived from nothing.

2. *Individuation.* classifying a proper *subset* of a signature class as second-postulate invalid uses a principle that should be booked rather than smuggled—*record-individuation*: alternatives are individuated by possible records, so a distinction no information could ever support is not a distinction the attribute space contains. Its derivation is the indiscernibility principle for attributes—no possible record, no question—obtained from the definition of an attribute, the first postulate, and the record discipline, with permanence blocking "determinate but unaskable"; it is stated and proved as Lemma 7 directly after the theorem, so that what remains booked is not the principle but the record discipline it runs on.

3. *The trigger's dilemma, named.* under strict global unitarity nothing is absolutely irretrievable, (so the third bin swallows everything, and it is the class of permanently valid agreeing superpositions that threatens emptiness in a closed universe), while for-all-practical-purposes retrievability would make the checkmate approximate, (inheriting the standard FAPP critique). The framework's answer has a stated type—accessibility relative to the standing record structure, with the recombination caveat as its guard—and the exact macroscopic conditions are the fifth Open Construction, flagged rather than papered over, (Section 14.8).

4. *Indexing.* the theorem is the framework's centerpiece and should visibly obey its first postulate, so the index is carried in the statement rather than recovered later—the configuration is stated content relative to the classifying Aethus A, and the partition and the bins are A's. Where detector-presence itself stands blank relative to A, (an eraser whose setting A does not carry), the classification runs pocket-wise over A's configuration pockets, one partition per pocket, and the union principle's own criterion sorts the two delayed-choice families. Where the setting is fixed by a classical choice whose record exists, the configuration pockets stand in *disagreeing* superposition—Wheeler's family, one partition per branch, read off the theorem rather than added to it. Where the setting is carried by a quantum control left uncorrelated with any record, (the quantum delayed-choice experiments of Ionicioiu and Terno and their photonic implementations), the cross content is undeclared and the configuration pockets stand *agreeing*: the partition itself is in agreeing superposition, and the Quantum Nexus carries cross-partition terms—carried, exactly, by the augmented-path space the Nexus is defined over, each element a spacetime route together with an internal route on the two-node state space, so that the control is an internal node and the cross-terms pair augmented paths differing in control state, never a both-slits element with its bin-(iii) twin in another pocket, (which validity forbids, a cluster dying entire). Structurally this is the two-tag family with the control standing where the tag stands, and it is the totality guard above—all correlated degrees of freedom—that keeps an uncorrelated control from separating the slits at all; the wave–particle intermediates those experiments report are what an agreeing configuration looks like on this accounting. What is not indexed is the rule from a stated configuration to its partition—the shared grammar of every vantage, owned as un-indexed at Section 2.2.1's two-level statement—and that rule is record-individuation itself, the second guard, run over the record sector.

Two compressions complete the guards. Moving or erasing a detector re-draws the signature partition and re-bins the powerset—the sliding quantum–classical boundary as literal re-classification. And the theorem's shape in one breath: bookkeeping over a partition plus two postulates, with everything quantum entering through which partition the records induce. And the content has a named ancestor, which should be named: the rule that alternatives contribute amplitudes when nothing records which occurred, and probabilities when something does, is Feynman's indistinguishability rule, stated in the Lectures; what the classification adds is the rule's ground and its boundary — indistinguishability recast as blankness of the interior attribute, the additive regime derived rather than decreed, and the crossover priced by where the record sits rather than by scale—and, said as a deliverable rather than an ancestry, the rule's "in principle" cashed as record-sector statedness relative to the indexing Aethus, so that with the Nexus installed amplitudes add within a signature class, probabilities add across classes, and the boundary between the two additions is the partition itself: a non-circular referent for the phrase the Lectures left as a gesture.

The trichotomy, walked. Case one, T a proper subset of one signature class: the claim draws a line *inside* a class, distinguishing slits that share every possible record—by record-individuation, no attribute carries that distinction, and the claim over-specifies: second-postulate invalid. The standard surprise resolves in place: "no detectors, so the singleton is invalid—but I can aim the beam at slit one!"—and indeed one can, because the collimator *is* a record; aiming the beam splits the class, and the singleton becomes a full class *of the new partition*. Legal again, because the partition moved. *Case two*, T equal to one full class: every branch of the maintained superposition produces the identical total signature, so no refinement along accessible records can ever expose a contradiction—valid, with the limits reading correctly, (empty T trivially; no detectors means one class, so the sole valid nonempty claim is the full set: the pure interference regime). *Case three*, T meeting two or more classes: some detector's record separates a T-slit in one class from a T-slit in another, so the coherence claim conjoined with that record's future stating is contradictory, while the record family is persistent over the candidate's declared descent, every refinement having a further descendant stating the separating record—checkmate, third-postulate invalid; concretely, detector on, $T = \{1, 2\}$ spans the classes, the

both-slits element dies, and the fringes vanish.

Proof
Throughout, "valid" means valid relative to the classifying Aethus A, whose stated content includes the detector configuration, (the totality guard: every correlated degree of freedom, preparation included, counts as part of that configuration). For a subset T write A_T for the Aethus obtained by adjoining to A the coherence claim "the traversal is an agreeing superposition over exactly the slits of T"; the theorem classifies T by the validity of A_T. A *proper child* of A_T is a refinement along the books, (Section 6.7): the stating of a detector's outcome, or of a which-slit value where some record fixes it. The third postulate is used in its $\exists\forall$ form: A_T is valid only if it has a proper child all of whose proper children are valid, and is invalid—checkmated—if every proper child has an invalid proper child.

The classification, computed. The trichotomy is computable from the axioms of Sections 3.1–3.2, and the computation shows each postulate doing its own half. Encode the four-slit case of Section 14.1.1: the slits are the pegs of one attribute, the detector's correlations are declared invalid sets (A or B with no firing, C or D with a firing), and the record classes $\{A, B\}$ and $\{C, D\}$ are read off those declarations. Each candidate T is the claim that exactly the slits of T are traversed, an irreducible agreeing state (Definition 11). The third postulate enters through the fundamental theorem as the carving of the slit attribute into the record classes (Definition 12), and the second through Record-Individuation as the irreducibility of each class. Closing each candidate under the carving alone invalidates exactly the nine cases that span both classes; closing it under the class blocks alone invalidates exactly the four single slits; neither invalidates the classes themselves. Of the fifteen nonempty cases, then, two are valid, four fall to the second postulate and nine to the third, with none falling to both, as the theorem states. The empty case stands outside the slit attribute, a particle traversing no slit being no filling of it.

Step 1, the combinatorics. The classes $E_1, \ldots, E_k$ partition the slit set, so every subset T satisfies exactly one of: $T = \varnothing$; T is contained in a single class and equals it; T is contained in a single class and is a nonempty proper part of it; T meets at least two classes. These are the theorem's three categories with the empty set placed in the first, they are exhaustive because a subset contained in no single class meets at least two, and they are exclusive because a subset contained in one class meets no other. It remains to show that each category carries the validity verdict, and the postulate label, the theorem assigns it.

Step 2, the valid bin. If $T = \varnothing$ there is no coherence claim and $A_T = A$, valid by hypothesis. If $T = E_j$, every slit of T carries the same signature σ, so every branch of the maintained superposition produces the identical total detector record. Exhibit the safe child required by the third postulate: let B be A_T with every detector's outcome stated as σ dictates. Any proper child C of B refines along a record; by the Record-Individuation Lemma no record distinguishes two slits of E_j, so no refinement states a which-slit value inside E_j, and every detector outcome C could state is the one B already carries. Hence no proper child of B contradicts the coherence claim, every C is valid, and A_T is valid by the $\exists\forall$ criterion. The limits read correctly: with no detectors there is a single class, the sole valid nonempty claim is the full slit set, and that is the pure interference regime.

Step 3, the second-postulate bin. Let $\varnothing \neq T \subsetneq E_j$. The claim A_T asserts that the traversal is coherent over the slits of T and *not* over the slits of $E_j \setminus T$: it draws a line inside a class. Every slit of E_j has the same signature, so no record, present or future, distinguishes a slit of T from a slit of $E_j \setminus T$; by the Record-Individuation Lemma the which-slit attribute has no alternative separating them, and the line the claim draws is not a distinction the attribute space contains. The second postulate, read constructively, says what the blank attribute "which slit within E_j" *is* relative to A: the whole answer space E_j held open, a superposition over the class entire. A claim that resolves that blank to a proper part asserts a resolution no record could ever produce and no attribute carries—over-specification—and is not a stated-attribute of any Aethus at all; A_T is invalid, and invalid on the second postulate's account rather than by any contradiction, since there is no record to contradict it. This is the bin's label. (The standard objection, "no detectors, yet I can aim the beam at slit one," resolves in place: the collimator is a record, aiming the beam changes the signatures, and the singleton becomes a full class of the *new* partition—legal because the partition moved, which is the sliding boundary.)

Step 4, the third-postulate bin. Let T meet two classes, with $s \in T \cap E_i$ and $s' \in T \cap E_j$, $i \neq j$. Since $\sigma(s) \neq \sigma(s')$, there is a detector d that fires on exactly one of them; say d fires on s and not on s'. The claim A_T asserts an agreeing superposition across s and s': their cross content undeclared, no record separating them. Now let B be any proper child of A_T. Because the configuration is stated content of A, (the totality guard), d's outcome is obtainable in every refinement, so B has a proper child C in which d's outcome is stated. Whichever outcome it is, C states a record that separates s from s'—d fired, so the traversal was not through s'; or d did not fire, so not through s—while A_T states that nothing separates them. That is the base invalidity the union principle fixes, (Section 2.4): an agreeing pair whose which-way is stated by a record is a contradiction, since the pair's standing blank and the record's declared exclusion cannot both be content of one Aethus. So C is invalid. Since B was arbitrary, every proper child of A_T has an invalid proper child: the possibility of contradiction cannot be made impossible, which is checkmate, and A_T is invalid by the third postulate. This is the bin's label, and it is exactly the postulate's mechanism—the record need not have fired yet; its *obtainability* in every future is what kills the claim now.

Step 5, the labels are exclusive. A claim in the second-postulate bin has no contradicting record, (no record separates within a class), so the third postulate's mechanism cannot apply to it; a claim in the third-postulate bin draws no line inside a class, so the second postulate's cannot. Together with Step 1, every element of $\mathcal{P}(\{s_1, \ldots, s_n\})$ receives exactly one verdict, and the verdict is the one stated. □ □

Several consequences of this theorem are worth drawing out explicitly.

Counting structure. The number of valid non-empty subsets equals the number of equivalence classes k. The number of P2 invalidations is $\sum_{j=1}^{k}(2^{|E_j|} - 2)$, being the count of non-empty proper subsets within each class. The number of P3 invalidations is then $2^n - 1 - k - \sum_{j=1}^{k}(2^{|E_j|} - 2)$, which accounts for the remainder. One may verify this against the four-slit example: $k = 2$ classes of size 2 each gives 2 valid non-empty cases, $2 \cdot (4 - 2) = 4$ P2 cases, and $16 - 1 - 2 - 4 = 9$ P3 cases, matching the explicit enumeration.

The preferred basis, informationally. The theorem also supplies the finite-case anchor for the preferred-basis result stated with the Quantum Nexus, on which each surviving $A(T)$ directly *is* a basis element: the basis in which outcomes are definite is the detector-induced partition itself, derived from the accessibility structure rather than nominated by hand, and exact rather than asymptotic. The standing complaint that einselection dynamics [116] alone cannot select the basis [296] is thereby met within this setting—the selection is performed by the same informational trigger that performs the collapse, so no second, unexplained choice remains once the pruning has run.

Complementarity of the two postulates. The theorem reveals that the second and third postulates are complementary in a precise sense: they jointly cover all invalid cases with no overlap. The second postulate handles over-specificity—asserting a distinction among observationally indistinguishable slits. The third postulate handles contradiction—combining observationally distinguishable slits into a single agreeing superposition that a future measurement will refute. These are the only two ways an agreeing superposition can fail, and the equivalence class structure makes them structurally incompatible: slits within a single class cannot generate a third-postulate contradiction (no detector distinguishes them), and slits across classes cannot constitute a second-postulate over-specification (a detector already distinguishes them)[362].

Illustration of the Aethic generation of reality. Perhaps the primary conceptual demonstration of the powerset invalidation theorem is its illustration of the wider fundamental Aethic phenomenon where realized reality itself is interpreted effectively as the residue of that which has survived pruning from the Aethic postulates. This perhaps a reframe at a fundamental level, because it deductively

[362]This complementarity can be understood as a reflection of the broader structural relationship between the second and third postulates throughout Aethic reasoning. The second postulate governs what must be left *open*—it enforces superposition where information is absent. The third postulate governs what must be *closed*—it collapses superpositions where information is accessible. The powerset invalidation theorem reveals that in the multi-slit context, "too narrow" (P2) and "too broad" (P3) exhaust the modes of failure for an agreeing superposition, with valid cases being precisely those that are neither asserting more than the information supports, nor combining elements that the information can distinguish.

produces the more intuitive “valid slit combination" cases as those which remain after the invalid cases are pruned, as opposed to those which are positively generated by some mechanism treating them as alike in some way. Due to this concept, then, we attain a direct deductive procedure for edge cases, which we know throughout the history of physics is the difference between a dynamic formulation (like the Schrödinger equation [297]) and a collection of special cases (like the De Broglie wavelength [298] concept). That is, if we imagined perturbing the system Aethus slightly, such that there are subtle differences in the cases which are invalided by each postulate, then suddenly the invalid cases would be skewed by the corresponding amount, and the valid cases would once again fall out as a residue, just without any conceivable status of sharing “a positive like categorical property" other than simply being those which fail pruning from the postulates. This is perhaps a fundamental proposal for how the Aethic mechanism produces all valid cases, edge case or otherwise, as that which strictly survives the pruning of the postulates as opposed to that which positively sorts into a like property-based category. It then is merely something of a coincidence that the surviving cases match the cases attained from quantum deduction in the many-slit picture, but the Aethic proposal is that if we could perturb away from this special case of the system Aethus and its properties, then the remaining valid cases would have to follow the implications of the surviving residue from the postulate pruning as opposed to the positive continuation of the precise quantum algorithm.

Seesaw relationship and limiting cases. As detectors are added to the system, equivalence classes split into finer partitions. Each split converts a multi-element class into smaller classes, thereby transforming former P2 cases (over-specifications within the original class) into valid singletons or smaller-class superpositions, while simultaneously generating new P3 cases (cross-class combinations that the new detector can now distinguish). In the limit:

- *No detectors*: All n slits share the same trivial detector signature, forming a single equivalence class $E_1 = \{s_1, \ldots, s_n\}$. The only valid cases are $\varnothing$ and the full set. All other subsets are P2. There are zero P3 cases. This is the full agreeing superposition—the pure interference pattern.
- *Full detection* (one detector per slit): Each slit is its own equivalence class. Every singleton is valid. No P2 cases exist (each class has exactly one member). All multi-slit subsets are P3. This is the pure particle pattern—no interference.

The general case sits between these limits, with each detector configuration determining a discrete partition and therefore the precise location of the boundary between quantum coherence and classical definiteness for the system[363].

Relational character of the valid structure. It is worth emphasizing that the equivalence classes—and therefore the entire valid/invalid classification—are not properties of the slits alone. They are properties of the *relationship* between the slits and the detector configuration. The same set of four slits admits a two-class partition under one detector arrangement and a four-class partition under another, with entirely different valid agreeing superpositions in each case. The object doing the physical work is neither the slits nor the detectors in isolation, but the informational coupling between them—specifically, which distinctions the detector configuration renders accessible to a future child Aethus. This is a direct manifestation of the Aethic degrees of freedom discussed in the context of the Quantum Nexus integral itself, where the pruning dynamics are governed not by numerical quantities or functions in the classical sense, but by the abstract relational structure of what is knowable given the system Aethus. The equivalence class is, in miniature, an example of precisely this: a combinatorial object defined by informational accessibility rather than by any spatial, numerical, or functional property of the slits themselves[364].

[363]This discrete interpolation is perhaps the most direct computational illustration of the Aethic thesis that the quantum-classical boundary is not a fixed threshold but a detector-relative structure. The same set of slits admits different valid agreeing superpositions under different detector configurations, and the powerset invalidation theorem specifies exactly which superpositions survive for any configuration. The “boundary" between quantum and classical is, in this formulation, the boundary that the informational structure of the measurement apparatus induces over the equivalence classes—or, more generally, the boundary drawn by the totality of all channels through which information may be passed to a given Aethus, of which the detector configuration is but one tractable instance.

[364]This relational character is worth situating within a broader conversation in quantum foundations. Spekkens [7] has argued that an eventual realist reconstruction of quantum theory will likely require mathematical primitives deeper than sets or functions as classically employed—that the right framework will involve structures whose fundamental objects encode relational, contextual, or otherwise Bayesian information rather than point-valued states. The equivalence classes appearing in the powerset invalidation theorem are suggestive in this regard: they are not sets of slits in the

Connection to the Quantum Nexus. Each valid equivalence class E_j in Theorem 14 corresponds to a specific $A(T)$ term in the Quantum Nexus integral which survives the reduced form. Conversely, the P2 and P3 invalidations correspond to $A(T)$ terms whose Aethic weight drops to zero upon intersection with the system Aethus encoding the detector configuration. In this sense, the powerset invalidation theorem may be viewed as the discrete, finite-slit specialization of the continuous pruning dynamics encoded in the Quantum Nexus integral itself—with the equivalence classes providing a clean combinatorial handle on the valid structure that, in the continuous limit, gives rise to the surviving path clusters which compose the empirical wavefunction.

14.2 Following Through to Continuous Particle Paths

14.2.1 Introduction of the Quantum Nexus

Before the construction, a structural reminder is in order, because the word *Nexus* here is not decorative: per the Nexus Principle, a Nexus is the weighting scheme that any physically existent Aethus must carry over each of its blank attributes. The Quantum Nexus is accordingly a universal, invariant backdrop—the weighting scheme for spacetime-path attributes—which by itself asserts nothing about any particular experiment; physical content arises only when it is Aethically intersected with a given system Aethus, whereupon the third postulate's pruning acts inside the integral. This is exactly the functionality exercised classically by the "Monty Hall Nexus" of Section 11.1[365], and the reader is encouraged to hold the two side by side.

One more structural statement deserves emphasis before the construction, because it may be the central idea of the Quantum Nexus: *the Nexus never deletes interference terms from inside a Born-rule expansion. Its scope is never "the paths, exhaustively, with some terms dropped"—it invalidates entire elements of the powerset upstream, the moment so much as a pin drop of invalidation appears inside any of an element's joint claims, exactly as the postulates demand.* It is this wholesale-upstream character that imports the full Aethic richness into the construction: it is why mixed states fall out for free, why the duality analysis of Section 14.6.2 can keep validity binary while geometry does the continuous work, and why the polarized double slit can be run hyperrealistically, (Section 14.6.3).

The mixed-states-for-free clause deserves its up-to-date unpacking here, because the proper-versus-improper distinction is no longer a gesture in this framework — it has acquired a two-dial formalization, and the parts of it that were previously carried as open are now stateable. A *proper* mixture, on this account, is regional spread in the determinate nodes themselves: the node named by a tag is an or-shaped subset of its space (of the Bloch sphere, for a polarization tag), preparation error widens that subset, and a spread node is a mixed marker at the reduced level by construction — with the operative coordinate being the region's *centroid*, not its diameter, since record statistics see regions only through their weighted means (diameter parametrizes the symmetric case; shape enters not at all). One boundary case is assigned before the two dials are treated as partitioning: path-correlated fine structure realizing identical maximal spreads — tags marginally blank yet jointly distinguishing — belongs to the *third-factor* dial, not this one — with the limiting cases bracketing the ontology, since diameter zero recovers the pinpoint node while expansion to the *whole* sphere renders the or-condition satisfiable by everything, which is precisely blankness read from the region side: an attribute whose allowed region is the entire space constrains nothing, prunes nothing, and drops out, exactly as the second postulate would have it. And because determinate nodes are pruning residue rather than posits, they inherit whatever measurement-error fuzziness attends their generation, wherever they show up — region-diameter is a physical dial, not an idealization's blemish. An *improper* mixture is the other dial: a third factor Aethically intersected into the construction, the environmental circumstance joined to the node configuration exactly as the Bloch sphere is already joined to the spacetime paths, with the pruning then running over the joint elements. The two dials separate cleanly in the coupling geometry, and the separation is checkable in the standard formalism: couple the leak to the *path* and the reduced marker states are untouched — the marker-restricted distinguishability is invariant under the toggle

ordinary sense (their identity depends on the detector context), nor are they functions of the slit positions or momenta. They are groupings defined by an informational equivalence relation, which is to say by the structure of what is and is not distinguishable given the full Aethic context. And, notably, we also get the conceptual resonance with Aethic Bayesianism through the very act of pruning itself. The full generalization of this idea—as is already the concept of Aethic reasoning—is that the full Aethic structure ought to represent Spekkens's mathematical object, such that abstract informational structure ought now to be a central player in the game of physical evolution.

[365]There, the universal backdrop supplies the weighting over the car-placement attribute, and the host's reveal enters as the intersected system information; the mechanism is identical, with only the probability-weight side varying between the classical and quantum instances.

while the visibility degrades multiplicatively by the environmental overlap — whereas couple the leak to the *marker*, meaning any interaction confined to the record sector, and the visibility is *exactly invariant*: the screen coherence is the trace of the record sector's cross operator, unchanged by record-sector dynamics, so the visibility holds while the marker-restricted distinguishability contracts (channel monotonicity of the trace distance — the no-manufacturing conservation read in the marker sector) and the total-record distinguishability holds; the restoration identity accordingly closes in both geometries, and losses in both quantities at once require combined path-and-marker couplings. Eraser statistics then discriminate the dials, scoped to environment-only conditioning with the marker traced: under path-coupling the conditional visibility is capped at exactly the marker overlap, while under marker-coupling it starts there and conditioning can exceed it, up to full per-branch erasure for copy-type couplings. The reading this forces is the one worth recording: the visibility's fundamental counterpart is the *total* record sector's separating capacity, against which the Pythagorean identity holds always, and the strict Englert inequality is an incomplete audit — the marker-restricted distinguishability being only the restriction of the true counterpart, with the deficit sitting in environment-involving elements the restricted audit never reads. Within the framework's vocabulary: the leak opens distinguishing avenues through joint elements involving the third factor, the third postulate's invalidation-calling prunes the agreeing element's weight directly — the theft is from the visibility's Aethic weight, paid into environment-involving exclusive elements — while the marker sector's own element family stands untouched in the path-coupled geometry, which is exactly why its supremum does not move. And the consistency check closes both ends: blank the third factor — open the environmental circumstance to its own full any-points space — and no avenues run through it, the pruning loses that leg entirely, and the construction reduces to the two-factor theory, as a well-formed extension must. (The region-diameter dial as a primitive is proposal-grade and carried as such; the coupling-geometry computations translate standard-formalism facts and are checkable there.)

A translation dictionary is worth recording at this point, since it converts a family resemblance into a checkable correspondence. Within the consistent- and decoherent-histories program [299], the central object is the decoherence functional of Gell-Mann and Hartle [300], whose off-diagonal interference terms between coarse-grained alternatives must vanish for probabilities to be assignable; the cosine appearing in the Nexus is precisely the real part of that functional's interference kernel. The structural office of the consistency conditions is occupied here by $A(T)$—but discharged differently: where the histories program cancels cross terms pairwise between alternatives, the Nexus invalidates entire powerset elements wholesale and upstream, never reaching inside a Born-rule expansion at all. Stating the dictionary sharpens rather than discharges the fourth of the Open Constructions, (Section 14.8): the uniqueness and consistency questions native to that program must now be confronted on this side of the translation as well, with the dictionary supplying the precise terms in which to do so.

A vocabulary note that the construction makes nearly automatic: a *mixed* quantum state[366] is, in Aethic terms, the weighted Aethic sum—a disagreeing superposition—of disjoint system Aethae intersected with the Quantum Nexus, whereas a *pure* state corresponds to the single specifying system Aethus for the relevant attribute. Because which attribute carries the specification is itself a modeling choice, mixedness comes out attribute-relative—emergent rather than fundamental—which simultaneously answers the standard non-uniqueness of ensemble decompositions: the Aethic structure selects the ensemble through the attribute that is semiblank. The distinction between *proper* and *improper* mixtures [301] is likewise native here: a proper mixture is exactly the ignorance-valued disagreeing superposition of system Aethae just described, while an improper mixture is the local shadow of a joint agreeing superposition whose partner attribute—a marker or environment—has been omitted from the description; the shadow is jointly open only at the level of the composite's global coherence and exclusive at the record-conditioned reduced description where the partner carries an orthogonal which-alternative record, equal reduced density matrices being locally indistinguishable, so that "improper" is not "agreeing" without that distinction. One rule covers the cat and the friend: internal record production makes the alternatives exclusive relative to the record-conditioned description in both cases, joint openness surviving only for the composite described without access to the record; and for the eraser, a never-read coherent marker differs from a marker whose information has been copied into another physical record, erasure in a complementary basis restoring interference only in the first case. The four-slit footnote earlier in this section, which describes the system Aethus as a disagreeing superposition between slit-pair traversals, is this mixed-state structure exercised before

[366] I quite literally designed the Quantum Nexus to make the Aethic postulates compatible with the Born rule in 2024 and 2025, and then accidentally rediscovered pure/mixed quantum states without knowing that terminology (until I heard about it in May 2026)! (I can't tell whether that is embarrassing or reassuring!)

being named.

There is, moreover, a foundational objection that this distinction lets the framework answer head-on. The classic complaint against decoherence-style accounts of measurement—pressed by d'Espagnat [301], and given its sharpest formulation in Bell's "and/or" objection [302]—is the illegitimate slide from *and* to *or*: decoherence delivers the apparatus an improper mixture, definite outcomes require a proper one, and the passage between them is asserted rather than licensed. Aethic reasoning, by contrast, possesses a lawful converter with a stated trigger: the third postulate fires exactly when the distinguishing information of the partner attribute becomes permanently accessible, transmuting the joint agreeing superposition into a disagreeing superposition over pockets—improper into proper, by postulate rather than by sleight of hand. And the conversion is protected in the other direction as well: by the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, attributes whose distinguishing information is permanently unknowable remain in agreeing superposition forever, so an improper mixture can never drift into a proper one without the trigger, (see the energy-density disclaimer of Section 2.2.5, where precisely this prohibition is what defangs the extrusion principle's past-alteration paradox). The and/or boundary, in other words, is not a gap in the framework; it is one of its load-bearing walls.

One further structural point should be made explicit, because it is where several Aethic principles converge on the integral at once. Suppose the system Aethus were exactly pure—specified to infinite resolution. The pruning would then leave surviving not a path but a single *subset* of paths: one element of the powerset $\mathcal{P}(X)$, one cluster-claim, with every other element of $\mathcal{P}(X)$ invalidated. (The double path integrals over $q_1, q_2 \in T$ still range over uncountably many paths within that survivor, so interference is untouched; the issue is solely the outer integral's support.) A powerset-singleton is a null set under any reasonable weighting over $\mathcal{P}(X)$, and the outer integral would vanish. The resolution is supplied by the framework rather than bolted on: the reversal principle forbids infinitely-determinate physically existent Aethae in the first place, so the second postulate places the unavoidable perturbations of the system Aethus into Aethic superposition, and the effective object is an integral of terms each of which invalidates every element of $\mathcal{P}(X)$ besides exactly one—a positive-measure *family* of surviving clusters rather than a point. Products of such smeared integrals under Aethic intersection are then no longer null. (Technically, the structural invariance of an Aethus under rescaling would permit one to work projectively even in the singular case, much as one treats a function through its logarithmic derivative; the perturbation formulation simply removes that class of edge case from consideration.) Note also where this relocates the measure question: the weighting over $\mathcal{P}(X)$ is inherited from the physical spread of the preparation itself, which remains an open construction, (Section 14.8).

It is worth marking, finally, how much of this is the second postulate acting as a single law over a single primitive: *Aethic superposition* covers both attribute-level agreeing superpositions directly and the superposition of summed Aethae with respect to their sum, with the latter being the special case of the former in which the attribute in question is the state-decomposable specification of which Aethus is actual.

Let us now carry out the explicit ontological-phenomenological discussion, then: that is, as concerns *the incorporation of the heightened granularity of cases which brings about the Feynman path integral formulation [295].* As in the same spirit of the Feynman path integral, we might now consider the effect of there being arbitrary large numbers of slits, effectively so as to partition spacetime completely. This is then the intuitive transition to the Feynman path integral concept, for which probability amplitudes are assigned to entire continuous paths in spacetime as opposed to individual double-slit slits alone. That is, consider the standard phrasing of the Feynman path integral formulation.

$$\psi \propto \int \mathcal{D}[q(t)] \exp\left(\frac{i}{\hbar} S[q(t)]\right) \tag{73}$$

Our Aethic purposes with this, now, is that we wish to formulate a way for which Aethic pruning may discard arbitrarily many possible paths *before* these paths are then incorporated into the path integral itself. Such will allow us to reproduce the effect with the four-slit example, for which an agreeing superposition in the context of quantum mechanics is specifically installed as the "limiting of possible probability amplitudes in an arbitrary way". Subsequently to that, we then place all possible such arbitrary limiting cases under an Aethic union, and in the same way the total system Aethus is interpreted precisely as this.

In order to explicitly expand the wavefunction to a single summation forming a probability mass over a collection of Aethically-valid paths, let us start by applying the Born rule directly and then expanding. We might specifically think to make use the vector identity that $\left\|\sum_{\mathbf{v}\in V} \mathbf{v}\right\|^2 = \sum_{\mathbf{u},\mathbf{v}\in V} \mathbf{u}\cdot\mathbf{v}$.

In application to complex numbers, this takes the following form.

$$\left|\sum_{a\in X} a\right|^2 = \sum_{a,b\in X} |a|\,|b|\cos(\arg(a)-\arg(b)) \tag{74}$$

Thus, this is the result of the Feynman path integral having applied the identity, (with $p=|\psi|^2$, being the corresponding probability mass to the aforementioned probability amplitude).

$$p \propto \iint \mathcal{D}[q_1(t)]\,\mathcal{D}[q_2(t)]\,\cos\left(\frac{1}{\hbar}\left(S\left[q_1(t)\right]-S\left[q_2(t)\right]\right)\right) \tag{75}$$

By the definition of probability in Aethic reasoning as merely an Aethic weight, let us accordingly think to render this probability simply as the Aethic weight on the Aethus in which a given subset of all possible paths are taken from a given starting point to a given destination point in spacetime.

Principle 50 (Quantum Mechanical Axiom of the Active Reasoning Toy Model)

$$\boxed{N \propto \int_{\mathcal{P}(X)} \iint A(T)\,\chi_T(q_1)\;\chi_T(q_2)\;\cos\left(\frac{1}{\hbar}\left(S\left[q_1(t)\right]-S\left[q_2(t)\right]\right)\right)\mathcal{D}[q_2(t)]\,\mathcal{D}[q_1(t)]\,d\mu(T)} \tag{76}$$

*This Aethus, N, may formally be known as the "**Quantum Nexus**", with the idea being that an arbitrary quantum system's Aethus is representable by taking the reduced form of the Aethic intersection between this Nexus and an Aethus holding initial conditions and whatever other relevant Aethic information about the particular system in question.*

- *X is the complete set of all possible continuous and simply-connected paths in the universe, regardless whatsoever of feasibility of actually being traveled by a particle. (As in, discounting impossibilities is the work of the subsequent reduced form's invalid Aethae, but standard Aethic practice is to begin exhaustively).*
- *$\mathcal{P}(X)$ is powerset of X.*
- *T is the variable of integration representing an arbitrary subset of X.*
- *$A(T)$ forms the Aethus for which all paths T are taken by the given particle in agreeing superposition. As we saw clearly with the example of a four-slit double-slit experiment variation, in almost all cases the vast majority of possible cases $T\in\mathcal{P}(X)$ will amount to an invalid Aethus $A(T)$, so the direct purpose of including this Aethus term—in addition to making the total integral an Aethus object outright—is to enable the Aethic pruning to act directly on the summed terms throughout the integral.*
- *$d\mu(T)$ is the differential of the measure on the powerset $\mathcal{P}(X)$.*
- *$q_1(t)\in X$ and $q_2(t)\in X$ are two examples of paths in X. They are defined as continuous, simply connected functions from path parameter t to a given spacetime coordinate.*
- *χ_T is the canonical indicator function $\chi_T : X\to\{0,1\}$. It effectively restricts the inner integration to the domain defined by the specific subset T. What is important about using this term in practice is that, by an application of Fubini's Theorem, we are able to simulate the prospect of adding up all possible inner-nested integrals with each one weighted by its total $A(T)$, (so as to allow for its "kill-switch invalidity" functionality to occur if needed), yet we are able to do so with simply the one integrand, (the factored display below makes this simulated regrouping explicit).*
- *$S\left[q(t)\right]$ gives the action (in the sense of physics) of path $q(t)$ as taken by the particle in question.*
- *$\hbar$ is the reduced Planck constant.*

What is absolutely crucial about including the factor of an Aethus is that now the entire integral becomes simply a weighted average over each possible Aethus $A(T)$. What is fundamentally important about this is that all possible such agreeing superpositions over set of paths T which are deemed Aethically invalid whatsoever by any subsequent Aethus we intersect with N will then drop out of the reduced form accordingly. Remarkably, then, the entirety of all the Aethic pruning dynamics are encoded inside of

this integral by means of these terms automatically self-destructing[367] *and dropping to zero probability measure if and only if an Aethic invalidity gets called by whatever it is we are intersecting them with. In effect, then, the entirety of the dynamics of Aethic reasoning are contained in such a formulation just because of this term.*

Equivalently—and exactly as the indicator item above describes via Fubini's theorem—the axiom regroups into its weighted-average reading in symbols:

$$W(T) \;:=\; \iint_{T\times T} \cos\!\left(\frac{S\left[q_1(t)\right] - S\left[q_2(t)\right]}{\hbar}\right) \mathcal{D}[q_1]\,\mathcal{D}[q_2], \qquad N \;\propto\; \int_{\mathcal{P}(X)} W(T)\,A(T)\;d\mu(T), \quad (77)$$

the one-integrand form boxed above and this factored form being the same object, with the factored form displaying the Nexus, in the notation itself, as weights multiplying Aethus-terms over the entire powerset.

The factored form makes visible a reading of the Born rule that the framework has carried since the Nexus was written and that deserves a name at the place it lives. In the standard presentation the square in $|\psi|^2$ is an exponent*: an amplitude is computed along one path, or summed along many, and the modulus is then squared. The Nexus's display says something different. The weight $W(T)$ is an integral over $T \times T$—over* ordered pairs *of paths—of the cosine of their action difference, and there is no stage at which a single path carries an amplitude that is then squared. The square is not an operation applied to one path; it is the insistence that every weight is a* pairing of two.

Principle 51 (The Dual Path Principle)
The Nexus's object is a pair of paths, never a single path. The squared modulus of the Born rule is read not as an exponent on one path's amplitude but as the pairing of two paths through the cosine of their action difference, $W(T) = \iint_{T\times T} \cos\big((S[q_1] - S[q_2])/\hbar\big)\,\mathcal{D}[q_1]\,\mathcal{D}[q_2]$; a probability is what a pair looks like once both members are integrated, and a single path, taken alone, has no weight at all.

Three consequences follow from the principle, each drawn out later where it is used. The Born rule is not a second axiom beside the state space, since the weights on pairs determine the amplitudes rather than the reverse, (the polarization lemma, Lemma 8). The two-tag deduction's whole structure—amplitudes adding within a record-undivided cluster and weights adding across record-separated ones—is the principle run on a pair of internal routes, (Section 14.6.4). And when active reasoning asks what the arena is such that the Nexus lives on it, the principle is the reason the kernel cannot be obtained by a quotient of a point-like arena in the way spacetime might be: a quotient map takes points, and the Nexus's object is a pair, so the question of what a record can fix about the kernel is the question of what a record can fix about a pair, (Section 14.7.1). The principle is the Nexus's own content rather than a later interpretation of it: the display has always integrated over $T \times T$.

Interestingly, because this axiom encodes both the Born rule and the Feynman path integral formulation, technically it completes quantum mechanics[368] *when taken in conjunction with the three*

[367] That is, this process is a direct instance of Aethic Bayesianism (see section 11.1), for which invalidity is proposed as the driver not only of the Bayesian foundations, but even across the general Aethic pruning effects such as those which produce quantum mechanics.

[368] Perhaps the central methodological deduction from the Quantum Nexus to stress for use in active reasoning is its direct implication of the totalitarian principle [303, 304] seen all throughout quantum physics. I want to emphasize this, here, because the carryover here is perhaps one of the more directly consequential ontological results of the Quantum Nexus.

The idea is, at the highest level of generality, that the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning itself forces *all possible* systems which consist with a given Aethus but are permanently unable to be discriminated to forcibly occupy agreeing superposition. Perhaps the most immediate example of this occurring in practice is the fact that all possible Feynman diagrams contribute at once to probability amplitudes [303, 304]. Ontologically this comes from the second postulate of the Aethus and its core tendency to maximize agreeing superpositions, but technically the actual formal point of contact with the Aethic framework is with the interplay with the third postulate, like the one epitomized with the powerset invalidation theorem. The key with Feynman diagrams is that it is not itself possible to arbitrarily target certain ones among them for Aethic informational attainment while others of the same probability amplitude are disregarded, (but hypothetically if the targeting were possible, then the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning would predict the loss of Feynman diagram probability amplitude terms for such special systems). So because of this characteristic indiscrimination in how the intermediate Feynman diagrams present themselves compared with the next, (very much unlike arbitrary multi-slit and detector setups, which allow for agreeing superpositions to be manipulated more discriminately), we therefore are met after the total Aethic pruning effects with the utter most maximized content of agreeing superposition expression. In that sense, then, the most fundamental layers of quantum field theory might be thought of as "the universe at its most unconstrained in agreeing superposition substantiality". But the key to emphasize is that this is a strict consequence of the Quantum Nexus and its upstream Aethic ontological commitments pertaining to the multiplicity of agreeing superposition when possible, so if you will the quantum totalitarian principle [303, 304] is essentially the place where the universal ontic behavior of the second postulate of the Aethus shows its face most

postulates of the Aethus, and however one chooses to specify the action. This is not to say that it is *complete on theoretical grounds, because it still takes this odd expression as an axiom rather than deductively motivating or conceptualizing it from something deeper. That being said, however, the central reveal already present in the Quantum Nexus integral as it stands is this:* with the variability of paths themselves giving rise to Heisenberg's uncertainty principle and with it all of quantum mechanics, now that we have stripped down the allowable interfering paths in agreeing superposition to that which survives Aethic pruning, we are met with a startling general conclusion—we always only ever thought that quantum uncertainty was almost like some building pressure for conformity present at the bottommost scales of existence, but instead we now trivialize the clusters of surviving paths themselves to a mere Aethic pruning effect. That is to say that that which commands the onset of the paths themselves is not some categorical reservation occupied by quantum mechanics and its uncertainty principle at the root, but instead by the mere causal-qualitative degree to which an Aethus loses track of a path as it propagates between arbitrary points in spacetime, scale inapplicable. This is why the hidden-position macroscopic hypothetical of the coherence section is not so categorically different from quantum mechanics at all—it is simply the domain where more paths are allowed into those clusters so as to build a macroscopic object, therefore being nothing more than a mere scalar dial of path count on a consistent Aethic backdrop. Aethic reasoning was the shepherd of paths all along. *So if you will, there is not some universal, designated ontic category at the quantum scale which drives quantum coherence by maintaining path diversity, but rather any category of informational transfer will do as long as all are hidden. It just so happens that at the quantum scale, all of them mostly are*[369].

One other topic of immediate interest for this integral concerns quantum decoherence [53, 305] itself. In particular, it demonstrates a fundamental structural oversimplification of the physical degrees of freedom in decoherence theory: that is, in this approach we realize that it is actually proper to identify an independent density matrix for each and every valid agreeing superposition of paths. What is lost on decoherence theory, then, happens when it attempts to compress this relatively vast structure into a single density matrix: each off-diagonal term it identifies is actually not ontologically elemental, but rather something of a sum over genuinely ontologically elemental probability weights. For example, in an Aethic approach we have that a path which shows up in multiple agreeing superpositions is probabilistically counted once for each for its diagonal density matrix term, however in the standard decoherent case it would incorrectly only be counted once, because the multiplicity of the different density matrices will have been forced into one matrix. Concerning how this Quantum Nexus integral aims to reproduce the predictions of decoherence theory directly, the mechanism is straightforward: the exponential decay seen in the off-diagonal terms of the density matrix during decoherence is simply the accumulation of survival analysis of the exponential distribution, as avenues for paths to be distinguished propagate "virally" in the graph-theoretic sense, and the third postulate invalidates collections of paths in sweeps. However, the key is that at the root, each elemental invalidation is discrete as per the dichotomy of valid-versus-invalid Aethae for the $A(T)$ term, so the exponential distribution seen is simply a weighted accumulation over vast numbers of effective Bernoulli random variables.

This shift deserves its fully formal statement, because the two operations it distinguishes act on different objects entirely, and the conflation of those objects is the precise content of the oversimplification named above. Let $\{S\}$ enumerate the valid agreeing superpositions of paths standing in the sum — each S a member of the powerset of paths, each carrying its own density matrix ρ_S with its full off-diagonal structure intact — and let w_S denote the Aethic weight each carries. The single matrix decoherence

concretely. In that sense the major takeaway is that should the Quantum Nexus correctly describe our universe, then very suddenly the totalitarian principle moves from puzzling to an utmost comprehensible product from a very familiar ontological grounding.

[369]So in other words, this idea is to say that rather than there being a specifically-designated ontic category which enables quantum coherence in paths, what we instead have is something deeply more heterogeneous, if you will: all possible Aethic effects used to channel information from one place to another equally and impartially form a possible avenue from which to trigger Aethic pruning of those paths and their agreeing superposition. It just so happens, then, that quantum mechanics is not reconcilable as a category of some unique ontic path cluster-survival mechanism, but instead is very merely the state of whatever Aethic modes of pruning channels failing to have access to a particle for whatever random reason. In total, then, with increasing scale some more of these channels suddenly have the access to transfer information due to higher ease of availability, but all the while the motor and the engine peppering the agreeing superposition paths with pruning was purely Aethic. In the process, then, the idea of the deductive chain is that these Aethic processes control the surviving agreeing superposition of paths, which in turn controls the onset of quantum uncertainty by means of the path integral. It is just that the remarkable thing is how quantum uncertainty "joins the party last" rather than being granted any sort of categorical fundamentality of its own.

So if you will, this idea, if correct, has effectively stripped the mysticism off of quantum mechanics to its absolute, maximal core. Now all that is left is the naked ontology itself.

theory works with is the compression of this family,

$$\rho_{\text{deco}} \;=\; \sum_{S\,\text{valid}} w_S\,\rho_S, \qquad\qquad (\rho_{\text{deco}})_{ij} \;=\; \sum_{\substack{S\,\text{valid}\\ i,\,j\,\in\,S}} w_S\,(\rho_S)_{ij},$$

so that each off-diagonal entry is, exactly as claimed, a sum over elemental contributions rather than an elemental object — and the multiplicity accounting above becomes exact: a path appearing in n valid agreeing superpositions contributes n diagonal terms to the family where the compressed matrix registers one. The dynamical contrast is then categorical rather than approximate. Decoherence acts on entries*: the environmental overlap $\langle E_i|E_j\rangle(t)$ multiplies $(\rho_{\text{deco}})_{ij}$ toward zero continuously, and the term-dropping step discards the residue — an operation on amplitude-interference structure within one compressed description, deleting pieces of a state. The Aethic process acts on* elements*: when a distinguishing avenue reaches the pair (i, j) inside a given S — the record sector acquiring a redeemed child there — the third postulate invalidates that S* whole*, discretely, per the valid-versus-invalid dichotomy for the $A(T)$ term, while the same pair may persist co-agreeing in every element the avenue has not yet reached. No entry is ever edited and no amplitude is ever dropped: each surviving ρ_S retains its complete off-diagonal structure — its fringe capacity intact — and what the laboratory reads as the smooth decay of $(\rho_{\text{deco}})_{ij}$ is the sum above losing whole terms in sweeps, the survival accumulation of the preceding paragraph now visible as bookkeeping: the entry's exponential envelope is the survival function of the element family, not a dynamical suppression of any amplitude anywhere. The two operations do not even share a domain — entries live in the matrix, elements live in the powerset — and the decoherence-style discard is thereby exposed as the shadow, cast onto the compressed matrix, of an element-dropping process that the compression itself renders invisible. The Aethic solution to the preferred basis problem [116] comes directly from this consideration—being that each child Aethus $A(T)$ directly* is *one of the basis elements, as designated by the Aethic pruning from the third postulate. For instance, what we saw in the valid slit-traversal states. In the context of decoherence, the density matrix seen is a merging of these more elementary structures, but the particular decomposition into designated Aethae which it ought to satisfy is that which serves as the preferred basis as opposed to the terms in the matrix itself. This also cycles back to the Aethic concept of the pruning mechanism representing the causal root from which quantum dynamics are downstream, because it is both separable from the quantum formalism and in direct control of which basis*[370] *is preferred. It is also worth mentioning that*

[370] Note, however, that the Aethic consideration itself is even more subtle than simply picking a single preferred basis—that is because we might for our system consider intersecting the Aethic union of $A_1 + A_2$ with the Quantum Nexus instead of one Aethus of initial conditions alone. In such a case, by the distributive property of Aethic multiplication we have essentially the sum $NA_1 + NA_2$, for which between these two terms different Aethae will fall out as invalid. An example of such a system could be an arbitrarily-far iterated variation of the delayed-choice experiment, where the very nature of which information is knowable varies between A_1 versus A_2. So the fully specific Aethic prospect at play is that to an individual Aethic term inside of the Quantum Nexus integral there is an elementary basis element, however how these compile into full bases—cleanly or not—is entirely dependent on the nuances of the Aethic structure pertaining to the system Aethus. (Just note that by "valid term" we ought to mean "valid Aethus formed by agreeing superposition over paths" as opposed to "child Aethus" specifically, for the simple reason that child Aethae may also be composite rather than elementary over these agreeing superpositions. But what is perhaps especially intriguing is how basis elements themselves are agreeing superpositions of paths, such that decomposing these violates the second postulate of the Aethus since they ought to maximally fill the unknown, and yet the observables we see themselves are constructed of these abstract superposition objects even though the difference between observables may be seen as the collapse of a disagreeing superposition—so it is like abstraction on abstraction on abstraction).

If anything this concept might also be a decent pedagogical illustration of the second postulate's universality to any abstract concept beyond purely quantum effects. As in, the sorts of things mentioned in the various thought experiments of this paper, where arbitrary objects or even entire Aethae may be placed in Aethic superposition. In this particular instance, we have that preferred bases may essentially be placed in an Aethic superposition by virtue of the Aethus $A_1 + A_2$ itself being an Aethic superposition over the Aethae A_1 and A_2. Altogether, the major takeaway is that superposition is categorically universal in Aethic reasoning, such that not only may any object be placed in one, but such circumstances have real consequences to how reality comes to be structured empirically. It is like the moment when you realize that an assumed-fixed parameter in a system is not only variable, but partly driving the dynamics—which is why I have explicitly referred to the second postulate as the single most elegant concept in the entire framework in my opinion. It is *turtles all the way down* in terms of what can be placed in superposition, and rather than this breaking reality, the specific cascade of Aethic ontological commitments reveal a tight-knit network of causality to which this is the substrate.

Concerning the bases again—note that the total basis, as a set, might then be thought of as the set of all remaining valid Aethae in the entire sum, as opposed to a superposition of arbitrarily-designated basis subsets to that, which would be conventional anyway rather than ontic enough to be fed into the second postulate directly. This is a basic reason why the infinite-dimensional basis of position shows up as well: we might recall that the destination position of the paths in the Quantum Nexus are themselves a parameter which is controlled by the system Aethus, so we might simply imagine the system Aethus itself as a uniformly-weighted integral over the Aethae corresponding to all possible destination points. Even though the weights are uniform in the system Aethus by itself in the abstract, however, upon intersecting with

a general preferred basis solution could be a relevant development in the context of the many-worlds interpretation [2, 3, 296]—so yes, the Aethic supposition for this is that it results from the totality of all Aethic pruning, as specified in the Quantum Nexus expression.

One other important thing to mention is that this Aethic formulation now demonstrates that quantum entanglement itself is merely a special case of the general Aethic process of reduced form coupling—specifically in the case of its having to be expressible through probability amplitudes, or in other words through the dual paths of the Quantum Nexus. In the case of the general Aethic reduced form coupling, however, it may operate over any general probabilities, and also comes with the inverted deductive methodology of being triggered directly through the Aethic postulates' pruning as opposed to having to root to quantum mechanics itself. The particular Aethic reduced form coupling process is to state all possibilities and prune the invalid combinations, which as a consequence creates among the valid Aethae cases where one stated-attribute must always come together with another, as precisely reproduces the quantum tensor product prospect when placed in conjunction with the wave interference granted by the Quantum Nexus's weighting terms themselves.

It is highly worth mentioning that this proposal of the Quantum Nexus means that Aethic reasoning, formally speaking, has solutions for *Requirement 2* and *Requirement 4* by means of reproducing both quantum empiricism and the classical limit respectively. There is of course the remaining question of reducing the Quantum Nexus's axiom itself to something more constructively parsimonious, (as opposed to having to tack it onto the Aethic postulates out of the blue as is the case currently), but in the strict sense of *deductive inclusion of all quantum and classical mechanical empiricism under the constraint of getting the collapse postulate from first principles*, the Quantum Nexus already is the proposed completion. If you will, this currently puts the axiomatic status of the collapse postulate at a similar place to where classical mechanics was right when Newton formulated it: Newton provided a total of four axioms, being the three laws of motion and the law of gravitation, with the latter one being particularly thorny to motivate as compared to the first three, (which as we know took until general relativity to motivate conceptually). Here we have the analogous situation with our four axioms being the three Aethic postulates in the place of the three laws of motion and the Quantum Nexus as the thornier fourth axiom. I would go so far as to say that the Quantum Nexus itself *is not* part of Aethic reasoning proper, because it is after all more of a sticky note attached to it for forming the "quantum branch" of Aethic reasoning. That is, if you were to remove anything structurally integral to Aethic reasoning, then the entire framework would collapse, but this of course cannot be said of removing the Quantum Nexus. So, in that sense the separability is why it forms an offshoot of Aethic reasoning in the first place, all while not necessarily having to be imported to other offshoots per se. On the positive side, though, I rather consider the program of deepening the Quantum Nexus to be quite ripe for the taking in our modern empirical environment, so in any case I think the conceptual support could happen on a vastly shorter timeframe than centuries.

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the Quantum Nexus, we have that the interference coefficient term causes rapid rescaling on the Aethae pertaining to destinations with high destructive interference, hence meaning that the resulting empirical Aethus itself will see a weighting over destinations which is consistent with the quantum designations. Such shows why the position basis itself might be viewed as pertaining to another round of valid Aethae in the sum, however altogether the granularity of things are once again more subtle than merely this, because even that is technically grouping the full set of valid Aethae in the sum into equivalence classes as indexed by like destination position in this case, (with attributes like the which-slit attribute having different resultant valid agreeing superpositions to a single destination position). Generally, it is the Aethic conjunction of the position attribute together with any others, like the which-slit attribute, as corresponds in the quantum mechanical case to tensor products of the bases, which gives the full space of the possible valid Aethae in the sum. Once again in the most general Aethic case it is debatable whether an arbitrary system can be decomposed into clean bases via tensor products or set unions at all, but perhaps it is close enough in many empirical contexts, (as after all there tends to be more chaos in the real universe than our models can entirely track—as illustrated with the decoherence density matrix itself under this Aethic interpretation).

The combined effect of this Aethic reframe, I must emphasize, *is a complete reformulation of the tensor product for composite quantum systems in the mathematical language of the Aethic definitional hierarchy.* That is, notice how implicit in the example system Aethus we have been describing is an Aethic attribute for the destination point for the particle, for the child system Aethus in Aethic superposition which decides the valid intersected terms as its basis elements, and then the basis elements themselves for valid path subsets within each one of those child system Aethae. In the standard quantum formalism, we would describe precisely this same structure by taking a tensor product between the customized Hilbert spaces of these three Aethic attributes—so the result is equivalent—just as we know from throughout this paper of course, under the full Aethic treatment we see the Hilbert space formalism alone to be a profoundly special case of the wider Aethic concepts of universal Aethic superposition, the Aethic structure, and Aethic algebra and pruning. Altogether, then, we might consider the generality of the quantum Hilbert space formalism as being limited only to the tiny interface between the commitment to the cosine kernel found in the Quantum Nexus and the relevant Aethic structure present there, but with the full Aethic reasoning in hand we enable the separation and substantial expansion of both of these prospects in the interface.

Moreover, if I had to flag where Aethic reasoning has the potential to be *methodologically substantial*[371] in addition to merely ontologically substantial, I would place it squarely in one abstraction move: the replacement of spacetime events with Aethic attributes and stated-attributes, such that the Aethic postulates themselves become operation criteria on these. In this sense we stop operating over concrete positions, or even over observables, and instead talk about the comparatively intangible[372] Aethic attributes themselves—which happen, upon taking the Aethic reduced form, to provide us with the limited empirical view into them which survives the pruning. Even discussions like Rovelli's, valuing observables as relational against other observables [306], now become concrete projections of the wider Aethic idea: an observable is merely a case where we have conventionally selected a state-decomposable attribute with respect to a given Aethus, and it is the Aethus and the attribute which are fundamental, not that state-decomposable instance. One can illustrate this by performing an Aethic perturbation over the attribute itself: the particular stated-attribute which, relative to the prior Aethus, happened to occupy the "crease where the reduced form collects" is suddenly made accessible into a full disagreeing or even agreeing superposition. In that sense, any given stated-attribute is an emergent, projective residual of what is in actuality Aethae and Aethic attributes—hence the analogy of a crease in which sand collects, carrying the illusion of being self-defining when it is merely receptive to the fabric and the sand.

14.2.2 The Two Aethic Classical Limits

Perhaps the most immediately important consequence of this result is how it reframes the fundamental nature of the classical action limit in the first place: that is, it is an argument of central elegance in physics how the empirical minuteness of $\hbar$ itself leads to classical principle of stationary action as an emergent limit. This was first articulated by Dirac [112], and later formalized by Feynman with his path integral formulation [295]. The key subtlety of this Aethic reframe, then, is first not to dispute or even contest this result at all—because it is genuinely powerful and genuinely elegant in the truest ontological sense[373]—rather this result is meant to serve as an augmentation through the use of one further addition: there are to be two mechanisms triggering the classical limit rather than the one alone. Let us list the newly-included Aethic mechanism of classical emergence first, and then we will tie it together with the existing stationary action emergence mechanism as the second listed entry.

1. The first and most immediate means by which quantum mechanics reduces to classical mechanics is simply quantum decoherence itself, or more specifically quantum decoherence as it deductively

[371] For instance, this reminds me of how Hamiltonian mechanics, as a body of work, holds a significant array of downstream methodological practices which all root to a single conceptual establishment: canonical momentum. My proposal is that the analogue of this for Aethic reasoning is, precisely speaking, the Aethic attribute. The postulates constrain these attributes rather than anything emergently downstream of them—which is why a single second postulate of the Aethus can appear to apply to many different instances at once, from randomness to quantum superposition to Aethic addition to the modal structure of the extrusion principle. In reality these are all perceivable as one single postulate, if only we operate over Aethic attributes rather than over any of their contingent concrete projections. Observables themselves then become convention imposed on the Aethic structure: a matter of tracking what the reduced form outputted as valid, and then misinterpreting those objects as derivationally fundamental—as if they were conceptual primitives to which reasoning may be attached independently of the deductively-upstream Aethic structure.

[372] As if ghostly, if you will: it is only through the contingency of how they collect into interpretable, perceivable reality that we ascribe meaning to how they behave in the Aethic reduced form, as opposed to being able to ascribe meaning to them directly or individually. (After all, even speaking about an Aethic attribute "individually" carries a certain degree of gauge-freedom, in the sense that there is no telling whether what one deduces from the Aethic system of the empiricism is truly a "primitive" attribute, or instead a false, humanly-constructed parent Aethus which is arbitrary against a genuine Aethic attribute—the canonical example being the attribute for "my first name," which is easily established as non-primitive by its dependence on contingencies of speech and human perception, so as to destroy its robustness under Aethic perturbation of those things.)

[373] To elaborate on this point for a moment, as my stance on physics goes I take the avoidance of arbitrary disruptions of the mathematical beauty very seriously. That is, the art of Aethic reasoning for me has been to propose a mending of the flaws in the Copenhagen interpretation while holding the core mathematical substance of the Lagrangian in the utmost esteem. See, Aethic reasoning is indeed very computationally-focused, and it is indeed graph-theoretic at its core. But the unspoken philosophical mission of the framework is to augment the core structural power of quantum field theory as opposed to even considering the attempt to displace it. That is, the Lagrangian elements of quantum mechanics are objectively masterful as a structure, all while the collapse postulate is perhaps even an effective contradiction. So the purpose of Aethic reasoning is to bring out the highlights in the Lagrangian, being perhaps the opposite of trying to contest it. This is where the nuance most matters in theory building: that is, *just because Aethic reasoning extends a graph-theoretic paradigm does not mean it should force that paradigm on other places where it does not belong.* Rather, what makes a high-stakes theory good is the same thing which makes a cake good—*diversity of ingredients.* Even just methodologically speaking, *if you are going to fight a battle, fight one you can win.* Arbitrarily trying to discount the Lagrangian is perhaps the very epitome of a fight you cannot win, nor should you quite frankly. It is the equivalent of a soccer team putting their star player on the bench without reason—it is absurd because the greatest elements of a theory ought to be employed properly rather than neglected artificially.

exists in Aethic reasoning. This is directly what we see in the case of the double-slit experiment example with the detector on, for which the third postulate of the Aethus serves to invalidate any child Aethus for which the particle in question traverses both slits in agreeing superposition. Now, as we know, should the particle traverse both slits at once in agreeing superposition, then suddenly its allowable path set consists of all possible simply connected paths which occupy the space pertaining to both slits, and so we deduce by feeding this into the quantum mechanical axiom that the interference pattern is to arise from this case accordingly. And so, since this case is invalidated under the detector on case, we accordingly get no interference pattern.

Such demonstrates the Aethic nature of decoherence directly, being that it quite literally removes potential paths from consideration from the Aethic path integral formulation altogether. It does not even so much as cancel out their effects, it just literally and abruptly shortens the set of paths under consideration within the Aethic path integral such that only those which strictly satisfy the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning's agreeing superposition criterion maintain involvement. In this sense, then, this Aethic reduction is very particularly dichotomous, in that should a given path violate the third postulate of the Aethus due to informational concerns, and it will be immediately prevented from involvement with the sum of the Aethic path integral formulation due to its ontological disqualification. This is the Aethic root of the phenomenon which we refer to as "quantum decoherence" in particular, for which Aethic reasoning begins to rapidly prune away avenues to quantum coherence as scales grow. We hold in Aethic reasoning that the onset of decoherence as a function of scale is strictly asymptotic, such that it becomes exponentially easier to correlate information to a particle's behavior once it becomes large enough to have a particularly immense number of involved properties. After all, if but one of these properties becomes correlated to anything else in the environment sufficiency to cause a lasting domino effect, and of course we then violate the whole of the involved quantum coherence by the third postulate, (with this being a very direct representation of the third postulate's application, since for the ensuing domino effect which correlates the whole of the macroscopic environment to the quantum effects to take place is perhaps a bluntly direct example of quantum coherent information being accessible, thereby invalidating said quantum coherence from the start via the third postulate). So, this is a characteristically Aethic effect at play.

And please note, lastly, that the premise is that as more and more information avails to form quantum decoherence with increasing scale, we naturally see that the available path set to each Aethus case will of course become immensely restricted, such that its set measure with respect to the dimensionality of spacetime effectively asymptotically reduces to zero. This, then, is directly the process by which we can infer this Aethic discrimination to at least contribute to the limiting case of classical-scale mechanics, being that a given particle no longer has the ability to occupy a path with differently-spaced segments out of it becomes arbitrarily probabilistically likely that at least one of the segments will stray into a location which violates the third postulate of the Aethus. In effect, then, as the "allowable paths set" is forced into a progressively tighter and tighter space with scale, we see that the two path legs from the Aethic path integral become arbitrarily likely to be arbitrarily close to one another, until their displacement to a given point along their length is not empirically detectable at all.

2. The second major reduction to the classical non-wavelike particle dynamics case consists with the standard statement [295] of how the Feynman path integral reduces to the classical action limit. That is, simply put, rather than Aethically invalidating those paths which fail to satisfy the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, we have in this alternative restrictive process that all paired paths besides the path of stationary action tend to destructively interfere, with their respective integrands in the Aethic path integral formulation canceling out with one another. Altogether, because there is of course only one path of stationary action we have that both paired paths comprising the physical object in question will tend toward occupying the span of that path due to said cancellation effects[374]. This is, of course, how the classical principle

[374]Note, however, that we may indeed technically see that different paths with the same length are also candidates for a generalized stationary action path, such as those which bring a photon to the center of the detection screen in the double-slit experiment, (which is unlikely under the individual slit cases, but becomes probable again when access to both slits is allowed in agreeing superposition, whereby it can reach that location with a difference of action of zero between the two path legs). So, these sorts of states are both wavelike in character, (since both paths are not aligned perfectly in space), and technically stable in the sense of deconstructive interference and the lack thereof under the Aethic path integral formulation, by which the stationary action path comes about in the first place. So, this being said, the reason we nonetheless always see macroscopic objects reducing to the aligned-path case rather than this case, is

of stationary action is ontologically arrived at in the first place, but there are perhaps a few important further caveats to consider in addition to this.

(a) First of all, we technically have that it is not that scale alone yields the onset of the destructive interference, but more technically the product of a particle's distance and momentum. So, due to macroscopic scales holding characteristically high distance, we have that this destructive interference-involving reduction could technically be bypassed by slowing down a particle's momentum thoroughly enough. If such could be done, and the Aethic-mediated quantum decoherent effects could be limited, and only then could a macroscopic object display wavelike mechanical effects.

(b) What is perhaps equally intriguing, however, is the case of if we cannot slow a classical object's momentum down sufficiently to reduce its action to the order of $\hbar$, but nonetheless have successfully hidden its information well enough to allow for a macroscopic agreeing superposition. This, as we may recall, is effectively the exact setup of the coherence section's hidden-position hypothetical. In such a case, then, we now have by the prospects of the quantum mechanical axiom that this Aethically coherent body, on account of its macroscale-typical momentum, would not behave as a wave at all, but would still occupy clear indications of Aethic coherence. This is perhaps most interesting because of its nature as a generalization to quantum coherence, for which a state of agreeing superposition can exist without the necessity of wave mechanics. We see in the case of this Aethic coherence that the body would be able to do classically-impossible things like affecting or being affected by its own alternate-scenario twins. So, we could imaging designing a myriad of experiments like this, where alternate-scenario interaction is exploited, but without ever once invoking genuine wave interference.

Something I want to emphasize briefly before we get too carried away with the noticing that the Quantum Nexus integral *finally shows why the agreeing superposition and quantum interference dependence is not circular logic* is that, yes, I believe the integral is a helpful visualization in this regard, but *that does not mean all of Aethic reasoning reduces to or for the sake of this integral exclusively.* That is, this integral is less capturing something fundamental about Aethic reasoning, and more capturing something fundamental about how paths through spacetime behave under the conjunction of Aethic reasoning and quantum mechanics—whatever that is anyway. In other words, notice how all throughout the integral we have only carried out agreeing superpositions over one form of Aethic attribute alone—a path through spacetime. Accordingly, then, I recommend that the best way to conceptualize this integral is that it indeed is meant to cast light on why in a quantum context we are able to associate agreeing superpositions and wave interference non-arbitrarily, (such as in the double-slit experiment where we used the state of the interference pattern as implying an agreeing superposition, for the reason now encoded in the Quantum Nexus), but I nonetheless must stress that just as I stated that agreeing superpositions are upstream of quantum interference before, now I must state that agreeing superpositions in the most generally-applicable sense are also upstream of this application of theirs to a particle's spacetime path in particular. This is a major part of the essence of the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning anyway, for which every category of Aethic Uncertainty Principle links to a category of Aethic Coherence Principle. A major part of the goal of active reasoning ought to be to show why paths naturally satisfy this integral without fail, but for all we know there could be an entirely new "sister ontology" to quantum mechanics with its own unique mechanics and employment of its own unique class of Aethic uncertainty principle. That is, we might argue that the Quantum Nexus integral *is* quantum mechanics, at least is the sense of isolating it as a particular class of Aethic Coherence Principle. But because we have identified this coherence principle—simply by peeling back the abstract layers on how paths fundamentally behave—may very

because while it may indeed be stable under the interference effects, it is decidedly not stable under Aethic-mediated quantum decoherence. This is because, plainly put, if you are watching a soccer ball fly into a soccer goal, you have enough visibility on the field to see all points thereon. So, just like the detector being on in the double-slit experiment, but perhaps more directly so due to you using your own eyes in the moment, if you were to see a soccer ball taking two paths to the goal at once, you would obviously observe such, thereby forming a direct Aethic contradiction by the state of the soccer ball needing to occupy an agreeing superposition over those two paths. Altogether, then, in order to avoid either of direct Aethic contradictions, or third postulate iterations on these, we are forced to infer that classical objects cannot take two non-equivalent paths to a destination at once, (as would in a state-decomposable manner alert us to the involved agreeing superposition's structure). So, altogether, once the Aethic path integral formulation cancels out all destructively interfering paths, we then have that the Aethic decoherent effects further compel only the aligned path leg states out of asymptotic macroscopic necessity.

well suggest that other Aethic Coherence Principles yet to be discovered also conceal their own special forms of mechanics once probed deeply enough to isolate their agreeing superposition structure. So what I am trying to say with this is that in the event of our universe being very diverse in Aethic Coherence Principle, we would have that the underlying agreeing superposition substrate "shows its face" as a different instance for each one of them. It is just that quantum mechanics happens to be "the one of these for paths", with the question being whether there are any "other ones" as well.

Altogether then, this analysis is meant to represent a basic formulation of how Aethic agreeing superpositions, properly deployed, are to carry over to the quantum wave mechanics itself. The remaining step now becomes to ontologically motivate and deduce a complete *Step X* itself from the correct deeper circumstance.

14.2.3 Expressing the Axiomatic Rearrangement of the Born Rule and Path Integral

It bears emphasizing the precise axiomatic content of what the Quantum Nexus intends to accomplish here. Standard quantum mechanics treats the Feynman probability amplitude weighting $\exp(iS/\hbar)$ and the Born rule $P = |\psi|^2$ as two logically independent postulates: each is assumed separately, and their joint composition into a working theory is itself an unanalyzed feature of the standard apparatus. The Quantum Nexus formulation reorganizes this structure by introducing the Aethus factor $A(T)$ as a new structural ingredient and showing that, when $A(T)$ is integrated against the standard Feynman kernel, the Born-rule probability structure emerges as a consequence of the Aethic pruning's interaction with the integral rather than as a separately-postulated axiom. The axiomatic equivalence may be stated compactly: under the Quantum Nexus, {Aethic pruning $\times$ Feynman kernel} $\equiv$ {Born rule $\times$ Feynman probability amplitude}, with the left-hand side replacing two independent postulates with one postulate (the Feynman weighting) plus the structural principle of Aethic pruning. The Feynman weighting itself is taken here as axiomatic input rather than derived from deeper principles; its eventual derivation from geometric considerations is the domain of the proposed Active Reasoning followup framework. What is accomplished within Aethic reasoning proper is the removal of the Born rule from the list of independent foundational postulates of quantum mechanics, by demonstrating that the rule's specific squared-modulus structure is precisely what the Aethic pruning produces when applied to the path integral. The relationship between amplitude weighting and probability assignment, which standard quantum mechanics leaves unanalyzed, becomes a structural consequence of the third postulate's operation on the integral itself.

So, if you will, in standard quantum mechanics we have the Born rule handling "that which gives actual probabilities upon collapse" and the Feynman probability amplitude weighting as "that which controls the dynamics given the Lagrangian", in the sense that removing the Born rule stage loses the collapse leg, and removing the Feynman probability amplitudes loses the dynamical leg. The Quantum Nexus version, alternatively, attributes the collapse part natively to the Aethic pruning factor, and then takes the dynamics as a joint consequence of the pruning's controlled-scope together with the Feynman kernel's weighting. Interestingly, the paradigmatic difference in Aethic reasoning of attributing collapse to the pruning itself removes the necessity of taking the wavefunction itself as the deductive root, which allows us to drop the wavefunction as ontologically existent altogether within the Quantum Nexus formalism—hence the idea for why we skip straight to valuing in probability densities as opposed to probability amplitudes.

This also, as a side consequence, proposes to solve the imaginary number mystery [307] of quantum mechanics: *that is, the i in the Feynman probability amplitude having to do with the timelike [308] metric signature is only a pattern-matched misconception, where in reality it is merely a method of compacting the actually-foundational cosine term from the Feynman kernel.* (This displacement has an ontological face stated where the determinate nodes are put to work: it is the Nexus and the pruning, not the wavefunction, that carry the fundamentality, Section 14.2.11.) This is not to say that the Wick rotation [308] concept is not methodologically useful—because of course it actually is—but instead that the path integral, ontologically, is not "Minkowskian [308] before Euclidean[375]" in the first place, but rather is mere algebraic bookkeeping. Hence, the solution to the imaginary number problem of quantum mechanics: *imaginary numbers need not be fundamental at all—their presence in quantum mechanics is really just a notational stand-in for the $\mathbb{R}^2$ vectors which they describe.* Note that we are explicitly not insisting on writing quantum mechanics in terms of real numbers—as that is naive in the sense that arbitrarily shooting oneself in the foot toward fitting empiricism is pointless, (similarly

[375]That the spacetime metric space itself is, mathematically, Lorentzian is still of course indisputable, so note that I am talking about severing the link between it and the path integral probability amplitude term as opposed to advocating for a change to spacetime.

to how the treatment of randomness in Aethic reasoning per Principle 40 is naively interpretable as reducing to hidden variables by bringing quantum mechanics down to classical realism, whereas in reality Aethic reasoning brings classical realism up to quantum mechanics)—but instead simply that the paradigmatic interpretation of those imaginary numbers, peripherally speaking, is not load-bearing once we have Aethically rearranged the deductive ordering of quantum mechanics so as to displace the wavefunction from the root and replace it with the Aethic pruning. So if you will, the imaginary number problem is dissolved rather than solved. (The claim now has a lemma beneath it: the weights of clusters determine the kernel up to a global phase and one orientation choice, Lemma 8, so that "valuing in probability densities rather than amplitudes" loses nothing recoverable—the amplitude at each path is the two-vector whose cosine and sine the cluster weights fix, and the axiomatization of Section 14.3 states the resulting order against Dirac–von Neumann: the state space and the Born map absorbed into one weight law, the amplitude derived and never held.)

Moving back to the Quantum Nexus deductive rearranging itself, now, essentially the core takeaway is that the use of Aethic pruning in addition to pure probability weights as opposed to probability amplitudes is sufficient to correctly reproduce the quantum empiricism: that is, the pattern-matching concern is understandably that valuing everything in terms of straight probability densities as opposed to probability amplitudes loses mathematical structure (as it will under a standard quantum formalism), but the Aethic resolution for this is very simply that (1) any observable Aethic attribute naturally produces the correct probability weight by means of directly occupying the spacetime event-epicenter of disagreeing superposition by means of the disagreeing superposition directly (called a determinate node as per Definition 53), and (2) the non-observable remainder of cases remain well-defined anyway (which normally is the major bottleneck if dropping probability amplitudes, and is something a realist theory must succeed with) because despite no longer being valued in explicit probability amplitudes, the Aethic pruning itself which narrows down the possibility space of paths (see the quantum spin example in Section 14.2.6) emergently reproduces the set of paths which is precisely consistent with the prospect of conditioning them to use observables as boundary conditions as per the standard quantum collapse formalism.

14.2.4 The Measure Question, and the Inductive Selection of the Nexus's Presentation

Let us face the measure question squarely, because the honest mathematical situation is instructive rather than embarrassing. The uniform, equal-weighted measure on the set of all paths does not exist: there is no nontrivial translation-invariant σ-finite measure on an infinite-dimensional space, and the familiar $\mathcal{D}[q]$ of the path integral is a formal device, defined only as a limit of time-sliced finite-dimensional integrals. The object that rigorously exists is stochastic—the Wiener measure of Brownian motion, connected to the Feynman integral through imaginary time. Three structural facts of that rigorous theory matter here. First, any individual path is a null set. Second, even the *differentiable* paths form a null set: the typical path is nowhere-differentiable, so any tame subfamily one might hope to single out carries no weight. Third, and most significantly for this framework, the measurable sets of path space are generated by *cylinder sets*—families of paths constrained to pass through finitely many gates at finitely many times. "Went through the first slit" is a cylinder set. The rigorous measurable structure of path space is, in other words, already record-shaped: the record-induced-partition ontology of this paper is not being imposed on the mathematics; it is the σ-algebra the mathematics already runs on.

Now the vastness question, which deserves to be stated at full size before being dissolved. The set of all paths has the cardinality of the continuum, so its powerset $\mathcal{P}(X)$ has cardinality $2^{2^{\aleph_0}}$—unsurveyably vast—and the surviving clusters under any system-Aethus intersection number at most countably many per setup. One might therefore ask what "fraction" of $\mathcal{P}(X)$ survives: some vanishing percentage, a null set, an iterated null set? The dissolution is that no canonical measure exists on a full powerset of that size at all, so the fraction question is not well-posed—and the principled methodology that replaces it deserves explicit statement, because it is the methodology of this framework generally. The only operationally constrained object is the intersection of the Quantum Nexus with a system Aethus; that is all that is ever actually operated over. The Nexus's *presentation* therefore carries gauge freedom, and the selection among presentations is to be made by inference—by cohesive induction from the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14), which supplies the finite case exactly—rather than forced through by supposition alone. Full $\mathcal{P}(X)$ is the presentation; the operative object is the record-generated algebra.

The presentation that cohesive induction selects is then the following: operate over the record-generated algebra modulo null differences, with weights given by the pushforward of the preparation's

perturbation packets onto record-equivalence classes. Below record resolution the weighting is gauge; at record resolution it is physical, and it should be, because the physical residue is exactly the preparation's empirical spread. The localization of those packets is licensed by the Internal-External Paradox, (Principle 35): superpositions are taken over external attributes about a pinned inferential center, never over self-locations within an ensemble of laboratories—the latter, naive treatment delocalizes the spread across record classes and washes out the signal entirely, a flat pushforward being a maximum-entropy prediction. The width of each packet is floored by machine and system error, and beneath that, in principle, by the reversal principle itself, which is why determinacy at the nodes always means record-resolved and never point-sharp. In the finite case this presentation is the Powerset Invalidation Theorem verbatim; the Monty Hall Nexus, (Section 11.1), is the same machinery in its most down-to-earth dress.

A thought experiment makes the remaining design freedom concrete, and I include its caveats in full because each carries an implication. Take a valid cluster—say, the agreeing superposition of all paths through the first slit—and surgically move exactly one path from it into the second slit's cluster. First caveat: no record can see the surgery, because a single path is a null set, and its null status is inherited by the *symmetric difference* between the surgered cluster and the valid one—the two clusters are therefore identical in the measure algebra, (note that it is the difference between the clusters which is null, not the clusters themselves, which carry positive cylinder-set weight). Second caveat: the surgered cluster could not even be operationally *specified*, since singling out one path among the infinite-parameter variety of turns is itself not a record-expressible act. The framework then has exactly two principled responses, and I state both so the reader knows precisely where the framework invites extension. Option one: *quotient it away*—declare null-set-differing clusters Aethically equivalent and work in the measure algebra, which is the standard rigor move of modern probability. Option two: *grade it distinctly*—assign the difference an infinitesimal weight, which is expressible only if the weight structure exceeds the reals, (Section 6.7), [105], with iterated-null grading available should the infinite-dimensional stratification demand it. Choosing between these—or retaining both as distinct sub-Aethus theories—remains an open construction, (Section 14.8).

14.2.5 Outcomes at Record Resolution: Compression, Tails, and the Preparation–Outcome Symmetry

The structural facet of Aethic Accidentalism, (Principle 45), can now be stated in Nexus terms. Centric unfolding is the same operation as a Nexus intersection: the prior Aethus is intersected with the observer's new information state, which, by the reversal principle, is itself never infinitely determinate; the result is therefore never the selection of a term from the prior linear combination but a *compression*—a skewing of weight onto a surviving collection, with the disfavored terms rendered negligible rather than invalid. "The outcome" is then an equivalence-class fact on a new attribute at record resolution, principled by the invariant-attribute basis, (see the note of Section 1.5), rather than nominated by contextual feel.

This walks directly into a famous objection and dissolves it with machinery already in hand. Suppressed-but-never-zero weights are the standard complaint against non-strict collapse—the tails problem: if the alternatives retain weight, in what sense did an outcome occur? The answer here is that the residual weight lives below record resolution, in exactly the gauge sector of the measure discussion above, (Section 14.2.4), while "outcome" is only defined *at* record resolution, where the pushforward is sharp. The tails are not an indefiniteness about the outcome, because they sit below the resolution at which outcome-facts exist at all—and note what this implies in reverse: the invariance of the macrostate-classes is thereby load-bearing for outcome definiteness itself, not a methodological nicety.

Finally, the symmetry this purchases: preparations and outcomes are now the same kind of object. Both boundaries of any Nexus computation are packet-valued informational fixities—determinate nodes that are record-resolved, never point-sharp—with the preparation's packets entering as the pushforward weights and the outcome's packets exiting as the compressed survivors. Measurement is preparation read backward, which is the formal face of time-symmetric unknownness, (Section 12.4.6), and the working face of the boundary-value reframe, (Section 12.4.13).

14.2.6 On the Operative Use of the Quantum Nexus for Determinate Nodes

Having established the Quantum Nexus as an axiomatic object, we now wish to illustrate how it operates in a concrete inferential setting[376]. The example we select—a sequence of spin measurements on a single electron—is chosen deliberately, because it is precisely the regime in which the standard quantum formalism is most visibly forced to *assemble its result by hand*. By exhibiting how the Quantum Nexus instead *derives* that same result as the residue of a single pruning operation, we obtain what is perhaps the cleanest small-scale demonstration of the framework's characteristic move: the conversion of an externally inserted axiom into an internally emergent theorem.

The standard treatment, and the locus of its awkwardness. Consider an electron whose spin is measured successively[377] along three directions $\hat{n}_1$, $\hat{n}_2$, and $\hat{n}_3$. We represent each spin state and

[376]Allow me to briefly outline what shifted for me on February 9, 2026, pertaining to quantum uncertainty. Simply put, because in my original 2023 formulation of Aethic reasoning I had not yet learned the specific dynamics of how the path integral creates the quantum commutation relations—and thereby quantum uncertainty—simply by virtue of the cluster of contributing paths existing in the first place, my very original idea was the quantum uncertainty was something of a fundamental primitive sourcing Aethic uncertainty, particularly in the sense that if we imagine the heterogeneous set of all possible information-passing sources, true Aethic uncertainty requires "*no passage from source* 1 *AND no passage from source* 2 *AND . . . AND no passage from source n AND . . . AND no passage from quantum uncertainty*" as effectively a logical conjunctions-mediated existential constraint. However, on February 2, 2026 I learned by independently studying up more thoroughly on the path integral how, remarkably elegantly, measurement of quantum spin via a magnetic field with the other axes' values remaining uncertain is expressible with such quantum uncertainty living effectively in the alternative possible paths surrounding those running through said preferred axis. In other words, rather than forcing about the uncertainty along the orthogonal axes as a kind of brute primitive itself, there exists already in the Berry phase path integral treatment [309] the ability to designate spin measurements as paths moving along the Bloch sphere just as standard path integral paths traverse spacetime. I found this premise of quantum uncertainty utterly profound for its conceptually similarity path integral material at large, so on the 9th of February I had a sudden rearrangement of considerations pertaining to how to formalize the Quantum Nexus in-paper.

> *Feb 9, 2026 12:37 AM*
>
> I can't believe it took me this long to state this explicitly lol, but just now I literally put two and two together: *since Heisenberg's uncertainty principle is literally about the variability of quantum paths, therefore things are even simpler than that it categorically runs on Aethic reasoning—instead it is simply that Aethic reasoning is itself the supreme commander of where to gerrymander the paths.* Jesus Christ that's a hell of a eureka lol! It hit me just while writing more of that new section of the Aethus paper just now!

In other words, my transition here was to recognize that the moment that you allow quantum uncertainty to emerge from the multiplicity of paths in a cluster anyway—as the path integral does directly and explicitly—then all of a sudden rather than having to take quantum uncertainty as a primitive, what you really want for your analysis is to interpret the scoping of the paths as *already determined* by the remainder of heterogeneous information-passing considerations at play, such that quantum uncertainty itself happens merely to be a contingency spit out after the Quantum Nexus runs over these outside Aethic-mediated path clusters. In other words, Aethic reasoning is already pre-built to convert the absence of information passability to agreeing superpositions, and I already fully had the Quantum Nexus in place to pass agreeing superpositions to quantum superpositions, so the shift—per my learning that the path integral converts multiplicity of paths to quantum uncertainty directly—was to drop quantum uncertainty as a primitive and get it as emergent from however the void in Aethic information-passability sculpts the agreeing superpositions which in turn host the path integral.

Perhaps the profound thing about this reframe, then, is that the seeming building proclivity of the universe toward abiding by quantum coherence at small scales becomes not a categorical label attached to particles ontologically, or perhaps an external ontological factor pushing for the clearing of Aethic information-passing in the standard regimes—rather it is simply that we expect statistically less inhabitations among the heterogeneous classes of information passage to exist at small scales, as if noting how population density is inversely proportional to square of how much you have zoomed in. In watching the interpolation between scales, we then merely get quantum decoherence-the-Aethic uncertainty degradation feeding in by the Aethic postulates and Quantum Nexus to quantum decoherence-the-loss of quantum coherence explicitly. That is the entire story, as is the idea.

[377]Note that for the Aethic reframe of this quantum process, the requirement that the paths move through the three nodes in the proper sequence is not forced through to quite the same level as the determinate nodes themselves' being in disagreeing superposition, but rather is a consequence of, due to the measurements themselves presumably being separated in space (as in a sequential Stern–Gerlach experiment), those few obscure paths which are chaotic enough to go through a different order being suppressed by the classical action limit anyway.

Note that by that I am specifically referring to the spacetime arena-side rather than the Bloch arena-side, in that there exist chaotic paths on the spacetime side which run through the measurement devices out of order compared to the shortest path-action sequence. These paths themselves, however, simply get suppressed by being far from the classical action, which perhaps is interesting because that allows them to very subtly contribute to the total agreeing superposition anyway (since after all it is permanently indistinguishable whether the path visits the devices' loci in classical order or not—nothing records the visits themselves, the outcomes alone being recorded) and so is not quite reducible to the sharp-time-slice idealization of the standard sequential Hilbert space collapsing treatment—it instead just so happens that the difference from such is often negligible due to being obscured by the quantum-side constructive

each measurement axis as a point on the Bloch sphere [309], a structure inherited here through the importation of general quantum machinery via the Quantum Nexus axiom. The object of interest is the joint probability of the full measured sequence.

In the standard formalism—specifically, the coherent-state path integral procedure involving the Berry phase [309]—this joint probability cannot be obtained from a single path integral running from $\hat{n}_1$ to $\hat{n}_3$. The intermediate measurement at $\hat{n}_2$ must be *inserted as a separate computational step*. Explicitly, the standard recipe proceeds as follows:

1. The three points $\hat{n}_1$, $\hat{n}_2$, $\hat{n}_3$ are locked down as fixed nodes on the Bloch sphere.
2. For *each* possible determinate outcome of the spin at $\hat{n}_2$, a separate path integral is computed.
3. Each such contribution is combined with the determinate state at $\hat{n}_3$ to yield a per-outcome joint probability.
4. These individual probabilities are summed *classically* to produce the final result.

The Berry phase enters because the joint probability is ultimately assembled from the areas swept out by the closed loops of paths that pass through the nodes in sequence—forward through $\hat{n}_1 \to \hat{n}_2 \to \hat{n}_3$ and back again—yielding a polygonal region on the sphere whose geometry encodes the relevant phase.

The point we wish to stress is not that this procedure is mathematically incorrect; it is entirely correct, and reproduces the empirically observed statistics. The point is rather *ontological*. The fact that a measurement *occurred* at $\hat{n}_2$ is not deduced from anything within the formalism: it is an external instruction supplied by the physicist, occupying the same logical tier as the dynamical laws themselves. The decomposition recipe of steps (1)–(4) is then a scaffold *hand-assembled around that instruction*. In short, the standard formalism requires the effect of the intermediate measurement to be put in by hand rather than deduced from ontological first principles, with the cyclic product of transition amplitudes serving as the by-hand stitching.

The Aethic reframe. The Quantum Nexus treatment dispenses with the insertion step entirely. Rather than imposing the $\hat{n}_2$ measurement as a discrete operation, we set up the integral so as to consider only the *direct* path structure between $\hat{n}_1$ and $\hat{n}_3$, and we allow the contribution of $\hat{n}_2$ to *emerge*. Concretely, recall that the Quantum Nexus begins in a state of maximal inclusivity: it integrates over the powerset $\mathcal{P}(X)$ of all path-bundles, attaching to each bundle T its associated Aethus factor $A(T)$, where $A(T)$ encodes the agreeing superposition of all paths in T. The operative procedure is then to intersect this Nexus N with the *system Aethus* A_{sys}—the Aethus encoding the actual experimental facts, including the proposition that a measurement occurred at $\hat{n}_2$ and yielded a definite outcome—and to take the reduced form of the result:

$$\overline{N \cap A_{\text{sys}}}. \tag{78}$$

Consider now what the pruning accomplishes. The system Aethus A_{sys} contains the fact that the spin outcome at $\hat{n}_2$ is *determinate*. Take any path-bundle $T \in \mathcal{P}(X)$ whose Aethus $A(T)$ asserts an agreeing superposition spanning the spin outcome at $\hat{n}_2$—that is, any bundle which treats the $\hat{n}_2$ spin as genuinely superposed. The Aethic intersection of such an $A(T)$ with A_{sys} produces an Aethic contradiction, since an agreeing superposition over an attribute cannot coexist with that attribute

interference between paths. If you will then, rather than having to account for this extra correction ad hoc, the agreeing superposition concept holds it internally.

(What follows is an AI-drafted unpacking, commissioned by the author to record this footnote's connection in the reviewing model's own words, literature ties included.) The observation above is the microphysical face of a doctrine this paper states macroscopically as *nothing ever happened on a slice*, and the connection deserves its full shape. The standard sequential recipe descends from von Neumann's projection postulate [310]: measurement idealized as a sharp projection applied on a time slice—here, at device two. The idealization's strains are a literature of their own. Relativistically the slice is not even well-defined as reduction's locus: Hellwig and Kraus's covariant proposal reduced the state along the past light cone instead [311], and Aharonov and Albert showed that no hypersurface-by-hypersurface account of reduction survives as a covariant process at all [312]—reduction-on-a-slice failing precisely where slices become frame-relative. Landau and Peierls had already bounded what any finite-duration measurement can resolve [313], so the sharp slice was never physically available to begin with; and taking it seriously anyway yields the quantum Zeno pathology, continuous sharp projection freezing the dynamics outright [314]. Orthodoxy's repair is the instrument formalism: finite duration bolted on as additional machinery. Here nothing needed bolting, because nothing was idealized—validity attaches to records, never to slices—so the chaotic out-of-order contributions above are held internally at the microphysical grade for the same reason the relativistic collapse treatment needs no foliation at the macroscopic grade: one doctrine, two scales, the sharp slice an idealization this bookkeeping never purchased.

being determinately fixed. By the Third Postulate, the pruning eliminates this term: its Aethic weight $A(T)$ self-destructs to zero measure within the integral. This holds even where the offending agreeing superposition intrudes through but a single path poking into a bundle from which it is forbidden.

The consequence is decisive. Every path-pair except precisely those passing through the $\hat{n}_2$ determinate node, in the proper sequence, is Aethically pruned. What *survives* the reduced form—the residue of the pruning—is exactly the polygonal Berry-phase structure of the standard treatment. The decompose-per-outcome-and-recombine recipe of steps (1)–(4) is therefore not assembled by hand; it is what is *left over* once the pruning has, in an informal phrasing, "torn through" the possibility space of Aethae and "condensed" into the standard $\hat{n}_2$-included dynamics. The contrast may be stated crisply. If the $\hat{n}_2$ measurement is *excluded* from the system Aethus, the very same Quantum Nexus, with no alteration of machinery, simply yields the plain direct path integral from $\hat{n}_1$ to $\hat{n}_3$. If $\hat{n}_2$ is *included*, the same single operation—intersect, then reduce—yields instead the full sequential structure. The presence or absence of the intermediate measurement is thus not a feature of the calculational procedure[378] at all; it is a fact residing in the system Aethus, and the corresponding geometry follows as a deduction.

The nature of the novelty. It is worth being precise about what has and has not been achieved here. The Aethic reframe yields the *same* answer as the Berry phase formalism; this is intentional, and is indeed the point. What has changed is not the answer but the *logical status of a step*. In the standard treatment, the proposition "a measurement occurred at $\hat{n}_2$" is an axiom of the calculation, and the decomposition recipe is a hand-built scaffold erected around it. In the Aethic treatment, that same proposition is an ordinary fact encoded within the system Aethus, and the entire decomposition recipe is consequently demoted from the status of *axiom-plus-scaffold* to the status of *theorem*—derived as the unique residue of one uniform pruning operation from the single fact that the $\hat{n}_2$ outcome is determinate.

The same service, rendered to the spinor. The clarification the extrusion principle rendered to relativistic time, (Section 2.2.7), has an exact analogue here, and it deserves explicit claiming because its value is easy to underrate. Dimensional time had experiential semantics smuggled into it, and the service was separation: the experiential layers received a rigorous home of their own, and the dimensional concept came out crystallized, freed of baggage it was never built to carry. The spinor—and with it the projective structure of the sphere the sequential treatment runs on—has suffered the same kind of smuggling from the opposite direction: across popular and technical discussion alike, the peculiarity of *spinors*, (the double cover, the 4π periodicity, the projective phase), is standardly bundled together with the peculiarity of the *wavefunction*, (superposition, collapse, the measurement problem's entire antirealist substructure), into one undifferentiated quantum strangeness. The present framework dissolves that bundle at the wavefunction's end: superposition is Aethic blankness structure, collapse is an indexing transit, and the wavefunction's ontological provenance is thereby settled on this framework's terms, (the second postulate together with the Nexus pruning). What remains on the spinor's side is then *only* the spinor's side—representation-theoretic geometry, cleanly separated from measurement mysticism—so that the researcher who asks what a spinor is, ontologically, no longer has to answer the measurement problem first. The question is isolated and sharpened, not solved; its resolution belongs to active reasoning, alongside the kernel; and the separation itself is the service—the same one rendered to dimensional time, now rendered to the sphere and what lives beneath it.

This is the framework's intended signature move applied in miniature—an instance, in the vocabulary settled below, of the Perturbative Reduction of Non-Unitarity, (Principle 53)—: just as wavefunction collapse is reframed from postulate to theorem in general, the by-hand insertion of an intermediate measurement is here reframed from a brute external instruction into an emergent pruning effect. The sequential-measurement setting is an especially pointed venue for this demonstration precisely because it is where the standard formalism's by-hand stitching is most conspicuous. Its simplest instance is interposed-polarizer revival. An intermediate polarizer does not, on this account, manufacture a new state with freshly assigned amplitudes: it contributes a further determinate node, changing which augmented routes survive, while the same kernel assigns the overlaps along the surviving node-chain. Crossed polarizers at $0°$ and $90°$ admit no route, the overlap $\cos 90°$ vanishing; with a $45°$ polarizer between them, $0° \to 45° \to 90°$ is a different admissible node-chain, with product amplitude

[378] That is, as if deductively upstream from the dynamics and nearer to a by-hand axiomatic construction outright, as in the Copenhagen interpretation.

$\cos 45° \cdot \cos 45° = \frac{1}{2}$ and transmission $\frac{1}{4}$. Nothing is restored to an earlier wave; the experiment has acquired a different boundary condition.

A second and equally important feature of the reframe is its *generality*, which manifests as a free structural payoff. Because the status of the $\hat{n}_2$ measurement resides in the system Aethus rather than in the calculational procedure, that fact may itself be Aethically perturbed. Suppose, for instance, we place the spacetime *location* of the intermediate measurement into its own Aethic superposition over several candidate spots. The standard recipe would now require an entirely new hand-built scaffold for the smeared-location case. The Aethic treatment, by contrast, is unchanged: one still intersects and reduces exactly once. The result is a *nested* structure—an outer Aethic superposition over the possible measurement locations, within each instance of which lies an inner disagreeing superposition over the spin outcomes at that specific location. A by-hand recipe does not generalize without new labor; a genuine derivation does. This free generalization is itself evidence that the reframe performs real structural work rather than mere relabeling.

Determinate nodes as a general construction. The structure isolated in this example admits a clean general formulation, and indeed serves as its canonical illustration. We name it explicitly.

Definition 53 (Aethic Determinate Node)
An Aethic determinate node[379] *is an event in spacetime—or, more generally, an Aethus-valued*[380] *property indexed to a spacetime locus—whose associated Aethic attribute is forced into a determinate state, or in the most general case into a disagreeing superposition*[381]*, emergently as a consequence of the Aethic pruning carried out over the intersection of a system Aethus with the Quantum Nexus. Equivalently, a determinate node is a locus at which every path-bundle asserting an agreeing superposition across the node's attribute is eliminated under the reduced form, leaving the node's attribute fixed (or mutually exclusively partitioned) relative to any observer whose Aethus constrains the occurrence of the corresponding measurement.*

(A node is state-decomposable, relative to a given Aethus, exactly when it is readable there as occupying one definite node-state; the operative section, Section 14.2.6, makes the decomposition explicit.) A determinate node has the extent of its record*, not of its display. Under the totality guard a detector's record is whatever its correlated degrees of freedom register, and for an ordinary absorbing detector that record fixes the absorption site far below the display's cell, so the node is effectively a point—delta-normalized in the continuum—and two endpoints within one display cell are record-separated, standing in the disagreeing regime with their weights adding. Only where a detector genuinely fails to record within some extent—a mode-selective detector coupling to a single spatial mode, whose record is the mode and not the position within it—is the node an or-region over that extent, an agreeing superposition by the Fundamental Theorem of Aethic Reasoning, (Section 8), since what lies within it is permanently uncertain relative to every Aethus. So "determinate" means recorded to the record's own grain, which is a fact about the detector's physics and not about its readout, and the or-region reading applies exactly where that grain is coarse. The consequences for the vector assigned*

[379]The randomness and variability we see in the world (like whatever unexpected nature there is to collapse) comes from the disagreeing superposition over the determinate nodes (in terms of which states they occupy, where they are located in spacetime as events, how they are coupled to other Aethic attributes, etc). But to a given proper child Aethus for which a determinate node is truly state-decomposable, it is fixed in the past of future as if predetermined in the sense of the quantum state encoding that it is guaranteed to happening from the beginning, and indeed being based upon its state as how its agreeing superposition of paths is constructed. Interestingly, the one place where the hints to us about this underlying structure is what bleeds through to our empirical awareness when the part about the unexpectedness to the world brought about by the disagreeing superpositions are themselves constrained by reduced form coupling: that, strictly speaking, is when constraints from the future within the block universe enforce happenings right now, with the canonical example being Wheeler's delayed-choice [10] concept.

[380]The most general abstract goal for determinate nodes is that they can be used like Aethae, in the sense that both an individual event in spacetime can be referred to by a determinate node, so too can a network of coupled spacetime events and whatever they each are Aethically intersected with, as altogether forms an Aethic superposition akin to Aethic reduced form coupling. The fact of the matter is that defining structures as Aethus-valued and then possibly projecting them into concrete spacetime events is significantly more robust than keeping things at the level of spacetime events themselves. I suspect this distinction in abstraction for determinate nodes may find direct operational uses rather swiftly, on either the conceptual or methodological levels.

This abstract use of Aethae in my mind is one of the central advantages of the framework, in the sense that its scope of abstraction itself (in the sense of unifying many different settings under one premise) opens up questions that would have been less visible before. In this way, the framework, at its best potential, sort of reminds me of the move in abstraction that made Galois theory particularly operably rich.

[381]Notice, furthermore, how the fundamental extrusion principle aphorism is also present directly in the Quantum Nexus itself: that is, as opposed to forcing through the branching of spacetime, we simply add Quantum Nexus integrand terms independently of spacetime, so as to occupy a "texture" of disagreeing superpositions which share a single spacetime.

to a cluster and for the metric of a pocket are drawn at the recovery theorem, (Theorem 15), and at the gravitational construction, (Section 14.7.3).

The interpretive significance of Definition 53 is that determinate nodes function as *Aethic boundary conditions*. In the example above, $\hat{n}_1$, $\hat{n}_2$, and $\hat{n}_3$ are the determinate nodes; they are fixed by the pruning, and the intermediate quantum state structure between them is not independently posited but is deductively downstream—it is precisely whatever the surviving path-bundles of the reduced integral supply. The dynamics, in other words, *thread between* the nodes rather than being driven by an externally imposed sequencing.

This reading carries a consequence worth flagging for future dynamical theories. In the standard picture, a background time parameter is the fundamental layer against which measurements are inserted. Under the present construct, that role is instead played by the determinate nodes themselves—the fixed space of spacetime events characterized by disagreeing (or determinate) superpositions. Because such nodes are defined directly with respect to spacetime proper, they carry no dependence on any preferred spacelike foliation, which is precisely the property one would demand of a deductive background intended to be consistent with the principle of relativity.

14.2.7 The Continuity Assumption, Demoted: Collapse Without a Persisting Medium

A century of interpretation shares one desideratum so pervasive it is rarely stated: *continuity between the pre-measurement and post-measurement states, under the medium of the wavefunction.* One mathematical entity is taken to persist through measurement, so that collapse becomes a problem about what happens *to it*—a disruption to be dynamically triggered, a branching to be located, an effective conditioning to be excused, an update to be reinterpreted. Assumption 2 of the Frauchiger–Renner treatment catalogued the versions: Copenhagen states the transition explicitly; many-worlds implicitly through branching; Bohmian mechanics through the conditional wavefunction; spontaneous-collapse theories dynamically; QBism in epistemic clothing. The catalogue's moral is that the transition belongs to no particular interpretation but to the shared framing—and the shared framing rests on the continuity desideratum, which rests in turn on the wavefunction's occupancy of the root role.

Aethic reasoning demotes the occupant. The roots of the framework are the three postulates and the Quantum Nexus axiom, (Principle 50); the wavefunction is derived bookkeeping—nothing over and above the exhaustive agreeing superposition, the kernel-weighted structure the Nexus assigns within a coherent cluster. The ontic commitment thereby attaches to the agreeing superposition and never to its wavefunction bookkeeping—the framework's ψ-positioning, and the PBR dissolution with it, going through unchanged: the constraint is satisfied one level down. And once the wavefunction is not the root entity, the continuity is not a desideratum at all: there is no fundamental object that must persist *through* measurement, hence no disruption to explain, no trigger to locate, and no *dynamical* threshold to find on any persisting medium, (the one boundary the framework does stake—that an observer-grade system's records cannot be kept from escaping, Section 8.0.2—is a fact about *validity* over record structure, where an agreeing superposition can stand at all, not a transition undergone by anything and not a line the framework draws; the two claims name different objects, and only the first is denied here). The century's question—*what makes the transition happen*—dissolves rather than gets answered, because there was never a transition-bearing medium for it to happen to.

What stands where the persisting medium stood is the determinate node, (Definition 53, deployed operationally in Section 14.2.6): a fixed, foliation-free element of the block universe—an event in spacetime proper, never on a slice of it, (the node living *in* spacetime while the indexing transition that "collapse" gestured at never did)—locked as a disagreeing superposition relative to any Aethus for which its information is permanently accessible. The agreeing superpositions occupying the particle's intermediate dynamics are deductively *downstream* of the nodes, via the Nexus; and the Aethic Sifting Principle, (Principle 26), performs the sorting that Copenhagen's single word "measurement" conflated: the node-side structure, accessibility-governed and pruned by the third postulate, against observation proper, which is only centric unfolding along one's own passage.

The pairing that looks paradoxical under wavefunction-continuity now reads as trivial. Relative to any Aethus in which a determinate node is state-decomposable, the outcome is fixed as if predetermined—the quantum state encoding it from the beginning, the agreeing superposition of paths constructed upon it—while all of the randomness and variability of measurement lives one level up, in the *disagreeing* superposition over the determinate-indexing Aethae themselves. Predetermination per Aethus, randomness over Aethae: the division of labor is complete, and the two properties never compete, because they never described the same structure. Under continuity-thinking they fight over

one persisting object, and the fight is the measurement problem; under the demotion, there is no object for them to fight over.

The standard collapse picture is thereby diagnosed as the conflation of two structurally distinct roles: the wavefunction's role of establishing determinate nonclassicality, (interference, uncertainty, the Bell content—all carried by agreeing superpositions), and its supposed transitional role into measurement, (carried in fact by the deductively upstream fixed nodes). The Copenhagen mistake, in one sentence: it reads collapse as a disruption of the prior wavefunction's continuity, when the prior wavefunction was never the root entity whose continuity could be at stake. The full development of what the permanence of agreeing superpositions can and cannot mean is Section 10.2.4; the same repair stated from the relativity side—the collapse-successor built for root consistency with the block—is the Frauchiger–Renner discussion's culmination, (Sections 10.2.4 and 14.2.11 carrying its cross-wires).

14.2.8 The Consistent-Histories Confrontation

Consistent histories deserves its own treatment here, because it is the interpretive program nearest to this one in machinery, and the standard first question from anyone who knows it—*how is Aethic reasoning not just consistent histories?*—has an answer worth stating in full. The program, due to Griffiths and developed by Omnès and by Gell-Mann and Hartle [315–317], takes as its objects *histories*: time-ordered sequences of projectors, each sequence a coarse-grained story about what the system did. Between any two histories one computes the *decoherence functional*, whose off-diagonal terms measure their interference; a *family* of histories is called consistent when those off-diagonal terms vanish, and within a consistent family—and only there—the histories can be assigned classical probabilities that add correctly. The program's achievement is real: it says precisely *when* probability-talk about quantum systems is licensed, without invoking measurement as a primitive.

Its famous wound is the *set-selection problem*. Consistency is cheap: there are vastly many mutually incompatible consistent families over the same system, most of them wildly non-classical, and the formalism contains no rule for preferring one. Dowker and Kent made the difficulty sharp [299]: consistency alone neither yields quasiclassicality nor persists under refinement, and for essentially any history one likes there exists *some* consistent family containing it—so the program, taken alone, licenses every story and privileges none. The consistency condition, moreover, is *imposed*: it is a criterion checked against families supplied from outside, with nothing in the dynamics generating the family that physics actually uses.

Aethic reasoning meets the program at exactly that wound, and the resolution is structural rather than additional. First, the preferred family is not chosen but *generated*: the record structure of a given Aethus fixes its signature classes, and the Powerset Invalidation Theorem sorts the powerset accordingly—the record-generated algebra *is* the family, supplied by the accessibility facts rather than checked against a criterion. Second, the consistency condition itself is *derived* rather than imposed: where records render cross-elements invalid, the corresponding cross-terms are not merely required to vanish, they have nothing to be terms *of*, since the elements that would carry them are pruned—Aethic decoherence is the consistency condition with a mechanism underneath it, and the two-mechanism table gives its physical faces. Third, and most characteristically, the demand for *the* single preferred set is dissolved rather than met: families are indexed to Aethae, as everything in this framework is, and the question "which consistent set is the real one?" commits the same view-from-nowhere error the framework diagnoses everywhere else—there is no *the* set, there is the set relative to a given record structure, unique *there* because accessibility fixes it. What consistent histories lacks and Aethic reasoning supplies, in one sentence: a physically generated, observer-indexed selection rule, together with the determinate-node architecture that says what the surviving history is *about*. What remains open is stated in the kernel's Open Construction: the formal theorem that the record-generated family is the *unique* maximal consistent family per Aethus, confronting Dowker and Kent's instability results head-on, is work owed rather than work done—the shape of the answer is above; the theorem is not yet.

14.2.9 What the Framework Dissolves: The Central Problems of the Rival Programs

The honest prior against any new interpretation is brutal, and it deserves a concrete answer rather than a statistical protest. The answer this section assembles is the following inversion: each of the major programs carries a central problem that its own practitioners name, that decades of work have sharpened rather than closed, and that is in most cases contested *in principle*—and against the machinery of this paper, those problems are not separate battles but instances of two absences, an

informational boundary and an observer indexing, both of which this framework supplies as structure rather than as patches. One symmetry is owed up front: what follows is an impartial accounting of the *named problems* and of their standing under the present machinery, with the framework's own open items booked in the Open Constructions alongside—the comparison throughout is between problems contested in principle and constructions with stated completion criteria.

Copenhagen. The problem its critics never let it escape is the unreduced measurement transition and what Bell called the shifty split [302]: somewhere a quantum system becomes a classical apparatus, the theory declines to say where, and the collapse it invokes happens on a slice no relativistic spacetime supplies. Here the transition is not explained but *demoted*, (Section 14.2.7): once the wavefunction is derived bookkeeping rather than the root entity, there is no transition-bearing medium, hence no split to locate—the boundary that remains is informational, and it is *derived*, (Theorem 14), with the determinate node living in spacetime while the indexing transition never did.

Spontaneous collapse, (GRW and kin). Its costs are named by its own advocates: new stochastic dynamics whose deviations experiment keeps squeezing, a preferred foliation for the hits, and the tails problem—the post-collapse state retains small amplitudes everywhere, so strict determinacy is never actually achieved, only overwhelming concentration. Here no dynamics are modified, and the tails problem is instructive to run: determinacy is carried by *validity*, not by amplitude-narrowing, and the invalid carries exactly zero rather than something small, (the weighted-reduction machinery making "zero" and "negligible" categorically distinct)—so the determinate outcome is determinate outright, foliation-free at the nodes.

Everett. One problem is structural and undischarged: the probability problem, (extracting the Born weights from a branching in which everything happens—the decision-theoretic derivations remaining contested at the level of their axioms). Here the basis is not preferred but *generated*: the record structure of a given Aethus fixes its signature classes, and the Powerset Invalidation Theorem sorts accordingly. And probability is not extracted from branch-counting at all: the weights arrive *with* the axiom, (Principle 50), as weighted validity. The honest residue is booked rather than hidden: the kernel itself is the third Open Construction—the debt is relocated from an in-principle-contested derivation to a named construction with a stated completion criterion.

Bohmian mechanics. The guidance equation requires a preferred foliation, wearing nonlocality on its sleeve frame-dependently; the trajectories can be surreal; and the unoccupied branches persist as real-but-empty waves. Here there are no hidden variables to guide and no foliation to prefer, and the "empty" branches are not empty but *invalid*—pruned to zero rather than carried as furniture.

QBism. Its reticence is principled and its critics' question is always the same: when no agent is betting, what is the case? Here the realism is retained *and* indexed: the empirical Aethus proper is the framework's realism anchor, (Section 5.2.2), the relativism never collapsing into anti-realism, (Section 2.3.10)—the agent's books are *about* the block, and the block is there to be about.

Relational quantum mechanics. The nearest program in spirit, and its two costs are the mirror of this framework's two supplies: the relativization of facts is *postulated*—systems just do bear facts relative to other systems, mechanism unspecified—and cross-perspective consistency has had to be added by supplementary postulate after the fact. Here the relativization is likewise postulated, at the first postulate, and no derivational daylight is claimed on the statement itself—the Fundamental Theorem of Empirical Aethae supplies its motivation, (accessibility, not decree, is why indices vary), not its derivation; what is derived is narrower than an armor: an obstruction to the noncontextual, measurement-independent completion of the ledger, Fine's obstruction in this vocabulary, which RQM's relativization passes as well, so it is no differentia against it, the differentia being the indexed semantics itself, proposed, together with the identification of which translations entail the prohibited completion; the anti-deflation result (Proposition 3), and cross-perspective consistency, not an added axiom but the third postulate's pruning working across shared records, which is precisely what the Frauchiger–Renner treatment exercises, (Section 10.2.4).

Consistent histories. The set-selection problem, developed at length in Section 14.2.8: consistency licenses every story and privileges none. Here the family is generated, the condition derived, and the demand for *the* set dissolved per Aethus—the one-sentence version of that section's three moves.

The inversion can now be stated with its evidence attached. Seven programs; seven central problems; and every one of them falls to the same two moves—the informational boundary, derived where the rivals must posit or evade it, and the observer indexing, supplied where the rivals must either forbid it, multiply worlds to avoid it, or postulate it bare. That convergence is offered as analysis, not advocacy, and what it evidences is *where the difficulty always lived*: not in any one program's execution, but in the shared refusal of exactly these two structures—and a framework built from them, before it knew

the rivals existed, dissolving all seven named problems at once, is at minimum the kind of coincidence a reader should want explained before the base rate settles the matter.

14.2.10 The Decoherence Rate as a Survival Function

The preceding subsubsection says why environmental coupling destroys coherence; it does not say at what rate, and the rate is where decoherence theory earns its keep. Its central quantitative result is that the off-diagonal elements of a density matrix in the pointer basis decay as $e^{-\Gamma t}$, with Γ set by the environment. That law is derivable here from first principles—up to the value of Γ, which is kernel-grade—and the derivation makes the law's meaning visible in a way the master-equation route does not.[382]

The object. Let $\{a, b\}$ be an agreeing superposition: two paths through the Quantum Nexus's powerset that no record has distinguished, valid at the moment the last record left them agreeing. Call that moment the near *determinate node*. The superposition endures until a record distinguishes a from b—correlates some environmental degree of freedom with which path, so that a child Aethus reading the environment could contradict the agreeing cluster—at which point the third postulate prunes the cluster and a, b become disagreeing alternatives. Call that the far determinate node. The quantity of interest is the interval of proper time τ between the two nodes, and the question is the distribution of τ.

The survival analysis. The environment passes records continually: every collision, every scattered photon, every interaction that correlates an environmental degree of freedom with the system is a record-passing event. Let such events arrive at rate λ per unit proper time—the environment's statistical-mechanical activity, a physical rate in the environment's frame, which is why proper time is the right clock. Each event distinguishes a from b with some probability p, its *distinguishing power*: the degree to which the environmental state after the event differs between the two branches. Under one assumption, that the events are memoryless—each independent of the last, which is the Markov assumption of the standard treatment—the number N_τ of events in proper time τ is Poisson with mean $\lambda\tau$, and the cluster survives exactly when no event distinguished the branches. Conditioning on the count and summing,

$$S(\tau) \;=\; \Pr[\,\{a,b\}\text{ still valid at }\tau\,] \;=\; \sum_{k\geq 0} \frac{e^{-\lambda\tau}(\lambda\tau)^k}{k!}\,(1-p)^k \;=\; e^{-\lambda\tau}\,e^{\lambda\tau(1-p)} \;=\; e^{-\Gamma\tau}, \qquad \Gamma = \lambda\,p, \tag{79}$$

the distinguishing events being the p-thinning of the record-passing process and a thinned Poisson process being Poisson at the thinned rate. This is a survival function with constant hazard, and the hazard is the product of two factors the framework keeps separate: how often the environment writes, and how much each writing tells.

The matrix rendering. The density matrix at proper time τ is the state over the declared class of realizations, (subsubsection 11.1.1), and that class is now partitioned by (79) into a fraction $S(\tau)$ in which the agreeing cluster still stands and a fraction $1 - S(\tau)$ in which it has been pruned. Two facts about the pieces. In a realization where the cluster stands, the state is the coherent one it started in, ρ_{coh}, with off-diagonal element $\rho_{ab}(0)$. In a realization where it has been pruned, a and b have become

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Something I would love to handle in-paper is a complete first principles derivation of decoherence theory with Aethic reasoning, at least up to the concept of the cross-terms of the matrix dissipating by exp(-lambda t). The primary idea here is essentially that 1) that decay ought simply to be interpreted as an emergent effective survival analysis rendered in the matrix form, whereas in actuality as usual the actual occurrences are happening in the powerset of paths/states per the Quantum Nexus, and 2) the survival analysis itself is not merely the naive "validity continuation" but rather has simply to do with the interval of proper time separating the "determinate nodes", loosely speaking, between which a given agreeing superposition from the total very large powerset-like structure of configurations endures, that is because decoherence is a time-based phenomenon anyway! And then of course 3) I imagine it's as simple as a matter of information as mediated through statistical mechanics proper which is the "baseline" information capturer that kills off these agreeing superpositions, although of course whatever number of other record-passing events, be it detectors or particles moving or the spacetime metric or everything else under the sun, merely adds to that potential of invalidity happening, hence why statistical mechanics of the environment occupies something of an "at least this much invalidation" like a lower bound in it! So, I would suppose that's sufficient to kick up the minimal decoherence effect in particular.

disagreeing alternatives, and the classification of Theorem 14 places a disagreeing pair in the exclusive regime, in which weights add across the alternatives and no cross term exists: the state is the mixture $\rho_{\mathrm{dec}} = \rho_{aa}(0)\,|a\rangle\langle a| + \rho_{bb}(0)\,|b\rangle\langle b|$, with the same diagonal as ρ_{coh} and zero off-diagonal, since pruning relocates weight between the two regimes and does not destroy it. The state over the class is therefore the convex mixture

$$\rho(\tau) \;=\; S(\tau)\,\rho_{\mathrm{coh}} \;+\; \big(1 - S(\tau)\big)\,\rho_{\mathrm{dec}}, \tag{80}$$

and reading off its entries,

$$\rho_{ab}(\tau) \;=\; S(\tau)\,\rho_{ab}(0) \;=\; \rho_{ab}(0)\,e^{-\Gamma\tau}, \qquad \rho_{aa}(\tau) = S\rho_{aa}(0) + (1-S)\rho_{aa}(0) = \rho_{aa}(0), \tag{81}$$

and likewise for ρ_{bb}. The off-diagonal element carries the survival function and the diagonal is untouched, which is the pointer-basis law with its trace conserved. That is the standard decoherence law for the pointer basis, and its content is now stated: *the exponential is the survival curve of the agreeing cluster, rendered in matrix form.* The matrix does not decay; realizations drop out of the coherent cluster one pruning event at a time, and the off-diagonal entry reports what fraction remain. Nothing happens to ρ; things happen in the powerset, and ρ tallies them.

The lower bound, and additivity. The thermal environment is never silent: blackbody photons, gas collisions, and the rest supply a record-passing rate $\lambda_{\mathrm{env}} > 0$ in every physical situation, and with it a hazard $\Gamma_{\mathrm{env}} = \lambda_{\mathrm{env}}\,p_{\mathrm{env}}$. Any further recorder—a detector, a moving particle, the spacetime metric responding to the system's mass distribution, (Corollary 14.7.3)—passes its own records, and independent hazards add:

$$\Gamma \;=\; \Gamma_{\mathrm{env}} + \sum_i \Gamma_i \;\geq\; \Gamma_{\mathrm{env}}. \tag{82}$$

Statistical mechanics thus sets a floor on invalidation, "at least this much," and every other recorder can only raise the rate. The minimal decoherence effect is the environmental floor alone, and it is nonzero wherever there is an environment.

What is derived and what is not. Derived, from the third postulate and one Markov assumption: the exponential form in proper time; the hazard as a product of writing rate and distinguishing power; the confinement of the decay to the off-diagonal entries with the diagonal conserved; and the environmental floor with additive hazards. Not derived: the value of p as a function of the branches' separation, which is the overlap of environmental states after an event and is a Born-weight quantity, hence kernel-grade. Supplying it from scattering physics gives the Joos–Zeh form $\Gamma = \Lambda\,\Delta x^2$ for spatial superpositions of small separation Δx [318], with $p \propto \Delta x^2$ and λ the scattering rate; the framework fixes the law's shape and meaning, and the scattering physics fixes its coefficient. One consequence is a check rather than an assumption: drop the Markov condition—let the environment's record-passing carry memory, so events cluster—and (79) is no longer exponential, which is exactly the non-Markovian regime of the standard theory. The framework predicts where the exponential fails for the same reason it predicts where it holds.

14.2.11 Inferential Strategizing About Active Reasoning Via the Quantum Nexus

Here is a brief discussion of how the Quantum Nexus already insists we ought to approach the quantum wavefunction in the context of proceeding with active reasoning, methodologically speaking.

Principle 52 (Target Principle of Active Reasoning)
In terms of ontologically explaining within active reasoning an arbitrary quantum physics structure, like quantum spin for example, there is a proper approach as inferred from the Quantum Nexus out of two possible roles. That is, we might notice now how the quantum wavefunction itself effectively plays two roles: it describes the quantum state present at a given location in spacetime, and it also determines the probability of attaining a given measured state upon measuring at a given point. According to the Quantum Nexus, now, it is explicitly the latter which is the load-bearing Aethic constraint on the quantum state, because the measured state at destination is itself what influences the Aethic pruning over proper child Aethae which form an agreeing superposition between this state-decomposable outcome and alternatives. What this means for ontologically explaining something like quantum spin, is that we ought first to separate out these two roles of the quantum wavefunction consciously and deliberately, and second to refer specifically to the points of determinate known spin states as the "ontological root" in need of an explanation, with the Quantum Nexus itself then perfectly deducing the agreeing superposition

and there quantum state structure of all intermediate positions. So, if you will, the relay to deeper ontology is carried by this axiomatically more fundamental layer of the constraint structure of measured or otherwise determinately known nodes, with inference from the intermediate quantum state structure being perhaps misleading for this particular purpose of ontic deepening.

Altogether, we might refer to these load-bearing determinate nodes as "targets", with the recommended approach to active reasoning rooting at least in part to ontologically structuring the behavior of the targets without necessarily satisfying likeness with intermediate states concerning the direct inferences therein proposed. For instance, with quantum spin directly the wavefunction ought to be interpreted explicitly for its probability-determining role in the context of uncovering a deeper ontology, (because that is what is relevant for the targets), as opposed to capturing the agreeing superposition at intermediate points.

Note that this principle does not extend to the Lagrangian or its ontology, but instead is specifically a recommendation against attempting to attain the intermediate wavefunction proper as being anything besides deductively downstream of the propagation amplitudes between nodes in disagreeing superposition of state. If you will, we altogether have "Aethic boundary conditions[383]" at the nodes set by the reduced form coupling which survives pruning of the relevant Aethic attributes, and then the intermediate paths get set by the combination of the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning together with the Lagrangian itself, (although technically the Quantum Nexus itself captures this all in a single step by enumerating all possible paths and taking the reduced form once, as already pins down those Aethic boundary conditions directly in the same step as attaining the right paths anyway).

Principle 53 (Perturbative Reduction of Non-Unitarity)
All non-unitarity of the quantum wavefunction is universally reducible to Aethic perturbations in

[383]Somewhat intriguingly, we attain by deduction the Quantum Nexus the fundamental concept that non-unitarity of the quantum wavefunction is universally reducible simply to Aethic perturbations for which disagreeing superpositions replace agreeing superpositions. What is specifically important about this is that such allows us to effectively generalize the phenomenology of wavefunction collapse to any instances in which disagreeing superpositions are present, thereby rendering such as entirely independent from human measurement presence, (which in the process is perhaps a similar-spirit Aethic universalization of seemingly distinct categories to the Aethic proposal of resolving Frauchiger–Renner [92] per Section 10.2.1 by demonstrating how the observer-induced wavefunction collapse per the double-slit experiment is not inequivalent to the physical invalidity which allows an observer to occupy a quantum superposition with respect to another observer with which they can interact). That is, disagreeing superpositions become something of a fundamental ontological category per the Aethic union principle, and how they happen to present themselves in a quantum mechanical context is as non-unitarity of the wavefunction—such that such non-unitarity may be traced back as having to indicate the presence of a disagreeing superposition, (but in the process, due to the Aethic fundamental abstraction to attributes, then universalizes the character of disagreeing superpositions to behaving with respect to agreeing superpositions always as non-unitarity behaves with respect to unitarity—so for example reduced-form coupling in the context of quantum entanglement with respect to the lack of entanglement is, at the Aethic level of abstraction, categorically identical to what quantum wavefunction collapse is to unitarity of the wavefunction).

Because of this, we are able to immediately pose the potential Aethic resolution to the black hole information paradox [319]: whatever is to be the specific resolution, we need only state that something about the behavior of Feynman diagrams in the presence of a black hole or its event horizon forces about corresponding disagreeing superpositions in what would have otherwise been agreeing superpositions without the presence of the black hole. Because disagreeing superpositions appear, per the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning, not *because* of measurement or observation, but because of the Aethic perturbation-mediated replacement of permanent uncertainty with attribute mixed-decomposability of some sort, we therefore only need to infer from the presence of the paradox as-stated that something about the nature of the Feynman diagrams upon the black hole "crystallizes" part of the normally-permanently-uncertain attribute describing their propagation of states as non-conceptually blank, and in turn we infer the presence of a disagreeing superposition having been generated in specifically this context, (pending the now needed deduction of the same from some deeper principle about Feynman diagrams and or black holes, which becomes yet another hypothetical goal for the active reasoning framework). (So to be clear, my exact argument here is that the breaking to disagreeing superpositions ought to occur on the side of the Feynman diagrams, such that Feynman diagrams and their exhaustive Lagrangian-mediated mathematical structure as we know them are the special case of a wider joint-Aethic attribute structure, which in the sufficient vicinity of black holes instead reduces to the alternative special case for which disagreeing superpositions in some way replace a very specific Aethic attribute's agreeing superposition as seen in standard Feynman diagrams—the inference of such a wider structure then comes simply from it being a necessary degree of freedom to describe the general system that a black hole can switch the relevant Aethic attribute between these two conditions, which specifically is not accounted for by standard Feynman diagrams, and is therefore inequivalent to them much to the same conceptual degree to something like—to give an analogy—how the Newman–Janis algorithm [320] reveals certain mathematical expressions in the Schwarzschild null tetrad to be structure-losing projections out of the deeper geometric premise for $a = 0$). The idea, altogether, is that per this development, a black hole need not be unitary at all due to whatever Aethically axiomatically-deducible unique structure describes Feynman diagrams in their regime. If such a concept were to be developed, then it would validate Penrose's own [321] philosophy that the desire to enforce unitarity in the presence of a black hole it itself a puzzlingly unsubstantial commitment by quality-theoretical standards. That is, *why on Earth would we adopt such a commitment on no evidence, anyway?* Now we further would attain that Aethic reasoning even argues decidedly for the opposite, per the categorical introduction of disagreeing superpositions and their non-unitary ontological role in the Quantum Nexus.

which disagreeing superpositions replace agreeing superpositions, as deduced from the Quantum Nexus directly. Consequently, the phenomenology of wavefunction collapse generalizes to any instance in which disagreeing superpositions arise, entirely independent of human measurement presence.

The principle earns its generality from the attribute abstraction, (Section 3.1, and the discussion closing Section 14.2.1): stated over Aethic attributes rather than over any of their concrete projections, seemingly distinct physical categories become one event-type. In particular, the distinction between entanglement and non-entanglement is, at the attribute level, the same distinction as that between non-unitarity and unitarity of the wavefunction: each pair marks the presence or absence of a replacement episode over the relevant joint attributes. The recurring appearances of this principle throughout the present section are then genuinely instances of one thing: the demote-and-re-add bookkeeping of the polarized slits, (Section 14.6.3), the pruning that fixes the determinate nodes, (Section 14.2.6), the collapse-side statement that only disagreeing superpositions ever collapse, (Section 10.2.4), and the black-hole application recorded in the footnote above.

The reduction just stated has a sharper, node-level form, and it is the form the active-reasoning material at the end of this section consumes, so it is recorded here as a principle in its own right.

Principle 54 (Aethic Non-Unitarity Principle)
Fix an Aethus and an arena*: a stretch of spacetime together with the attributes carried over it, (Section 14.6.1). If the content of that Aethus over the arena contains a determinate node, (Definition 53), then the evolution of the quantum wavefunction over the arena is not unitary relative to that Aethus: a determinate node is a replacement episode, the agreeing superposition of paths across the node's attribute replaced by a disagreeing one, and the Perturbative Reduction of Non-Unitarity, (Principle 53), identifies exactly such replacement with the wavefunction's non-unitarity. Contrapositively:* perfect unitary evolution over a stretch of spacetime and the attributes defining an arena, relative to a given Aethus, implies that there are no determinate nodes there relative to that Aethus*—the arena's content is agreeing superposition throughout, and nothing in it is state-decomposable relative to that index.*

The principle is stated relative to an Aethus on both sides, and that indexing is the whole of its difference from the standard treatment, so the premise is landed here rather than assumed. The standard treatment makes collapse something that happens *to* the wavefunction at a time: a moving present partitions spacetime into the already-collapsed and the not-yet, the partition being a spacelike slice or a foliation of them, and non-unitarity being the dynamical signature of the slice's passage—which is why every such account owes a story about when the transition occurs, on which slice, and triggered by what, (the catalogue of those stories is Section 14.2.7). In Aethic reasoning the concept of collapse is dropped, and dropped for exactly that reason: it tries to make collapse associate with a moving present which partitions spacetime, whereas here the entire spacetime metric, the whole arena, is indexed by an Aethus and by that Aethus's content of determinate nodes versus agreeing superposition. Non-unitarity is therefore not a process located at a time but a property of the arena's description relative to an index: the wavefunction's evolution over the arena is unitary or not according to whether the Aethus's content over it contains replacement episodes, the determinate nodes, wherever in spacetime those nodes sit, in the past or the future of any present one cares to name, blankness carrying no tense. What replaces the collapse story is then the theorem the contrapositive states: perfect unitary evolution over a stretch of spacetime and attributes defining an arena, relative to a given Aethus, implies no determinate nodes there. Three consequences follow that no moving-present account can express. First, unitarity is indexed and not absolute: one arena can be unitary relative to an Aethus and carry a determinate node relative to a proper child of it that has acquired a record, which is the Wigner's-friend structure of Section 10.2.1 read on the wavefunction side, and no single partition of spacetime by a present can hold both descriptions at once. Second, nothing ever happens to the wavefunction: there is no pre-collapse and post-collapse state of one persisting medium, (Section 14.2.7), but two descriptions of one block relative to two indices, with the randomness of measurement living in the disagreeing superposition over the determinate-indexing Aethae—predetermination per Aethus, randomness over Aethae, (Section 10.2.4). Third, and this is what the Centradic Gravity Conjecture of Section 14.7.4 consumes, the principle converts a global dynamical assumption into a claim about content: a model that insists on perfect unitarity over the whole of spacetime, relative to every Aethus, thereby asserts that no Aethus's content anywhere contains a determinate node, and whatever determinate nodes are needed for is thereby denied to that universe. The Wheeler–DeWitt constraint is the canonical instance, read in the problem-of-time note below.

A particularly relevant note—for future dynamical theories anyway—about this general Aethic reframe is to the Wheeler-DeWitt problem of time (from quantum gravity [322, 323]) itself: unlike in

standard Copenhagen quantum mechanics, where the background time parameter is the ultimate most fundamental layer driving the dynamics, in the Aethic worldview it is instead the "determinate nodes" emerging from the Quantum Nexus intersection which form the deductive background respecting to which the quantum state takes root. That is, the determinate nodes correspond to the particular Aethae or otherwise fixed events in spacetime which are forced into disagreeing superposition by the Aethic pruning, and then like boundary conditions these set the stage upon which the path integral dynamics thread between by virtue of their sums under the integral. Altogether, then, this Aethic reframe automatically displaces a background time parameter as the root of things, and instead places that role on the fixed space of events in spacetime which are characterized by disagreeing superpositions, (or otherwise more abstract Aethus-valued properties which are in disagreeing superposition). Notice how these events are defined with respect to spacetime proper, that way they are not arbitrarily dependent on any spacelike foliation to begin with. Altogether, then, this Aethic concept then proposes that the quantum evolution dynamics emerge from the intermediate freedom from the Aethic pruning between the determinate nodes, which seems like a much better fit to the static-spacetime geometric view of general relativity—at least on the front of ontic compatibility, with the fundamental question remaining of how to actually describe the dynamics themselves correctly[384]. Read through the Aethic Non-Unitarity Principle, (Principle 54), the Wheeler–DeWitt constraint's perfect unitarity is the assertion that no determinate node exists relative to any Aethus, and Section 14.7.4 records, as a conjecture, what such a universe would thereby be denied gravitationally. Stated as the framework's formal proposal, then: the Quantum Nexus and the Aethic pruning, by establishing the determinate nodes, displace the quantum wavefunction as the fundamental object, with fundamentality passing to the combination of the Nexus and the pruning themselves, per the timeless operation of spacetime just described—the wavefunction surviving as the deductively downstream description of the interface, exactly as the axiomatic rearrangement already frames it, (Section 14.2.3). Two clarifications then keep the note at its intended grain. First, the randomness and variability the world displays—the unexpectedness of collapse included—lives in the *disagreeing* superposition over the determinate nodes themselves: over which states they occupy, where they sit in spacetime as events, and how they couple to other Aethic attributes; the "evolution" of the quantum state is nothing but the agreeing-superposition-of-paths interface threaded between those nodes, with each node, relative to any proper child Aethus in which it is state-decomposable, fixed as if predetermined—the quantum state encoding from the beginning that it is guaranteed, and indeed *built* upon that state in how its agreeing superposition of paths is constructed, (the full statement of this relocation is Section 10.2.4, with delayed choice, Section 10.9.4, as its empirical bleed-through). Second, it should be stated explicitly that a fixed spacetime metric is assumed throughout for this paper's purposes: nothing here proposes to have solved the problem of time in any exhaustive sense. The note merely points out, on philosophical grounds, what spacetime "looks like" as disagreeing superpositions of Aethic determinate nodes, and how that informs the viewing of observables and attributes in the context of relativistic block-universe time.

A note on the ontological primacy of the path-integral formulation. The central faculty of Aethic reasoning, (Section 12.6.5), carries a consequence that deserves explicit marking: it *deduces* that the path-integral formulation of quantum mechanics, rather than the Hamiltonian and canonical-quantization formulation, is the ontologically correct one. The deduction turns on the fit between the path integral and the two operations the framework runs on superpositions—the formation of agreeing superpositions and, especially, Aethic pruning. In the path-integral formalism this fit is remarkable: one need only postulate the powerset of paths as the object operated over, whereupon the elements of the powerset associate with agreeing superpositions over the starting and ending destinations, and the filtering over those powerset elements associates with the Aethic pruning. Applying the pruning to those agreeing superpositions renders the endpoints *Aethically fixed*, (the Generalized Fixed Principle, Principle 36): the determinate nodes against which the dynamics thread. There is no comparable way

[384]To be clear, the reformulation of quantum mechanics, broadly speaking, through the determinate nodes as opposed to the time evolution *is* the mathematical content of the Quantum Nexus already (or more completely, the determinate nodes themselves are emergent from the integral, but are nonetheless the most load-bearing deductive front within it for the purposes of sequential spin measurements on the Bloch sphere [309] and the works). What remains is the central challenge itself of expressing an empirically-correct quantum theory of gravity within such a framework, of course, since at present we do not even have the categorical tools with which to do this reliably—and hence why it remains an open problem. So the Aethic proposal here is that we may both propose a reframe against the background time parameter concept and then follow through with it conceptually, but still that gets us no nearer to actually writing down the fundamental dynamical equation itself—for the meantime at least.

So, in short, the forcing through to deductive fundamentality of the time evolution parameter is here being argued to be a category error, with the question remaining what ought to come next now that we have resolved and replaced it.

to express agreeing superpositions and Aethic pruning within the Hamiltonian formalism, whereas in the path-integral formalism the correspondence is exact—the powerset is the object, its elements are the agreeing superpositions, and the filtering is the pruning. Since this is the only formalism in which the framework's operations fit, the central faculty deduces that the path-integral side is "the real one, ontologically"—and indeed it is precisely this fit that motivated the choice of the powerset as the structure operated over in the first place, (the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, Theorem 14). The commitment to a realist theory of quantum mechanics that underwrites all of this is itself not assumed arbitrarily: it is an inference from Newton's core principle, (Section 12.6)—the demand that one cannot have one set of laws made out of place by another—which, applied to quantum mechanics, forces a realist theory as the only satisfying criterion, with the whole program being the attempt to articulate what that theory should look like once realized. The downstream methodological effects reach into quantum gravity and the problem of time, since any dynamical continuation of the framework inherits the path-integral structure rather than the canonical one. The structural root of the Hamiltonian side's unfitness deserves one closing sentence: a canonical state is a state *on a preferred time-slice*, and the framework has dissolved the preferred foliation, (Section 2.5), while its blanks lack tense outright, (Principle 11)—so the object the Hamiltonian formulation evolves is one this ontology cannot even invariantly individuate, which is the same verdict the central faculty's fuller treatment reaches from the interface side, (Section 12.6.5), and the Wheeler–DeWitt note above reaches from the gravitational side.

14.3 The Aethic Axiomatization of Quantum Mechanics: The Postulates and the Nexus Against Dirac–von Neumann

The two-tag deduction and the singlet of the next subsection show the Aethic procedure landing on Hilbert-space numbers, and the generalization note at Section 14.6.4 shows why the landing is not accidental. This subsection, placed before those constructions so that the reader meets the claim before its exhibits, states what the results add up to: the Aethic postulates together with the Quantum Nexus form an *axiom set for quantum mechanics*—an alternative to the Dirac–von Neumann axioms, recovering the same theory from different primitives—and the recovery is a theorem. The set is five axioms and one bridge: the three postulates, (indexing, blanks as superposition, and pruning, Section 3.4.4 and the third postulate's derivation); the union principle, (the primitive jointness of *or*, with the agreeing and disagreeing regimes as its two cases); the Nexus, (the pure-phase kernel as the weight over augmented paths, Section 50); and the realization bridge that converts labeled invalidity into physical unrealizability. What is claimed is exact and should be read exactly: every axiom of the Dirac–von Neumann formalism is either a theorem of this set or is *absorbed* into its one quantitative axiom—the two things Dirac–von Neumann posit separately, a state space carrying amplitudes and a Born map from amplitudes to probabilities, being here a single weight law on clusters from which the amplitudes are derived and never held. What is not claimed is that the Nexus follows from the other four; that it does not is stated at the close, with the reason.

The recovery. Fix the augmented-path space X of a setup, (spacetime routes carrying internal routes, Section 14.6.4), the pure-phase kernel $\mathcal{K}(p) = e^{iS[p]/\hbar}$, and a *readout slice*: the set Σ of configurations at which the setup is read, each configuration $x \in \Sigma$ comprising the readout position together with every record-bearing degree of freedom the configuration carries—the detector states, the tags, the environment's registers—under the totality guard of Theorem 14. Every augmented path p ends at one configuration $x(p) \in \Sigma$. The Hilbert space is $\mathcal{H} = \ell^2(\Sigma)$, with orthonormal basis $\{|x\rangle : x \in \Sigma\}$ indexed by *configurations*, not by paths, (the continuum case replacing the sums by the configuration and path measures, with the same statements). Assign to every cluster $T \subseteq X$ the vector

$$|T\rangle \;:=\; \sum_{p\in T} \mathcal{K}(p)\,|x(p)\rangle, \qquad \text{so that} \qquad \langle x|T\rangle \;=\; \sum_{\substack{p\in T\\ x(p)=x}} \mathcal{K}(p).$$

A configuration x is the finest grain at which the block records the readout, which under the totality guard is finer than the display: for an absorbing detector the absorption site is recorded microscopically, so endpoints within one display cell are record-separated and their weights add, and a readout *cell* is an exclusive union of configurations whose probability on a cluster is $\sum_{x\in C} |\langle x|T\rangle|^2$—never the modulus of a summed amplitude, which would return zero for a pixel spanning one full fringe period where the fringes a pixel integrates give half. Coherent addition within a cell is correct only for a mode-selective detector, and that is the detector's physics, not a consequence of the second postulate,

(Definition 53). In the continuum $|x\rangle$ is delta-normalized and the sums pass to measures; that case lies outside the theorem's rigor grade, and the finite-slice statements are what is proved. Paths that end at the same configuration add coherently; paths that end at different configurations are orthogonal. This is the structure the framework's own classification demands, and the reason the basis must be the configurations rather than the paths: two paths with different readout configurations are separated by the readout record and stand in the disagreeing regime, while paths sharing a configuration carry no record separating them and stand in the agreeing one. A path basis would make every pair of paths orthogonal and delete the interference the theorem exists to recover.

Theorem 15 (Lüders representation of record-compatible restriction, with the Dirac–von Neumann form *For a system admitting a compositional path kernel—the scalar-action Nexus, or its augmentation by an internal factor such as the Bloch factor—under the assignment $T \mapsto |T\rangle$ the Aethic axiom set yields the Dirac–von Neumann formalism, axiom by axiom, with every computed statistic agreeing. The clauses are graded: (iii) is a theorem of the second and third postulates given the assignment, and (v) is the representation of the stipulated record-compatible restriction given the assignment, not a theorem of the postulates alone; (i), (ii), and (vii) are the kernel axiom's own content read off the assignment, (vi) being that representation together with the product slice of a composite setup, a kinematic stipulation using nothing of the joint kernel; unitarity in (vii) is posited with the kernel (the composition law alone yields a semigroup, and an absorbing potential is the counterexample); (iv) is the weight law with its calibration clause; (viii) is an identity.*

(i) States are rays. A valid agreeing cluster is the vector $|T\rangle$. Its Nexus weight at a readout configuration x is $W_x(T) = \left|\sum_{p\in T,\, x(p)=x} \mathcal{K}(p)\right|^2 = |\langle x|T\rangle|^2$—the coherent sum over the paths that share that configuration, which is the Nexus's own display for the double slit at a screen point—and its total weight is the squared norm, $W(T) = \sum_x W_x(T) = \langle T|T\rangle$. The state is the ray, normalized by $\sqrt{W(T)}$.

(ii) Superposition is the agreeing union. For disjoint clusters, $|T_1 \cup T_2\rangle = |T_1\rangle + |T_2\rangle$: the linear superposition principle is the union principle's agreeing case read at kernel grade, and the cross-terms of $W(T_1 \cup T_2)$ are the interference the union opens.

(iii) Observables are self-adjoint operators, and they come from records. A detector configuration's signature partition $\{E_1, \ldots, E_k\}$, (Theorem 14), is a partition of the slits by their detector signatures, and is carried to the readout configurations by a record map $r : X \to J$ on complete augmented routes, whose fibers, the endpoint classes, are what E_j denotes here (the slit, route and endpoint partitions being three); the fibers define the orthogonal projectors P_j onto $\mathrm{span}\{|x\rangle : x \in E_j\}$, which resolve the identity, $\sum_j P_j = I$, so that any assignment of values a_j to the classes is the self-adjoint operator $\sum_j a_j P_j$; a record at a later node, reached by propagation, is the same construction transported by (vii), $U^\dagger(\sum_j a_j P_j)U$, which is how observables not diagonal in the configuration basis arise. Writing E_j also for the paths whose readout configurations lie in the jth class, the theorem's bins are read off the cluster's membership, which the vector represents: T is valid nonempty iff $T = E_j$, and then $|T\rangle$ lies in the range $P_j\mathcal{H}$; invalid by record-individuation iff T is a proper subset of one class; third-postulate invalid iff T meets two or more classes. The vector of such a cluster has nonzero components in two or more ranges unless coherent cancellation removes them, as in $|0\rangle + |1\rangle - |1\rangle = |0\rangle$, which is why the bins are stated on membership rather than on support.

(iv) The Born rule. The probability of outcome j on a cluster T is $W(T\cap E_j)/W(T) = \|P_j|T\rangle\|^2/\langle T|T\rangle$, the Nexus weight of the class-restricted piece.

(v) The projection postulate as a representation of record-compatible restriction. The transition to the record index is stipulated, not selected by P_3, which is a validity predicate and fixes neither the successor index, nor the preservation of surviving kernel contributions, nor the restriction map; once record-compatible restriction is assumed, the identity below represents it as Lüders conditioning. Stating the record invalidates T as an agreeing object when it spans classes and leaves the disagreeing superposition of the pieces $T \cap E_j$ at the weights of (iv); conditioning on the outcome is pruning-plus-renormalization, (Theorem 13), and equals $P_j\rho P_j/\mathrm{Tr}(P_j\rho)$, the Lüders rule [324]. Mixed states are disagreeing superpositions, $\rho = \sum_i w_i\, |T_i\rangle\langle T_i|/\langle T_i|T_i\rangle$, convex by the Relational Weight Principle, (Principle 22).

(vi) Composite systems are tensor products. The augmented-path space of a joint system is the product of the factors' path spaces and its readout slice the product of the factors' slices, so $\mathcal{H}_{12} = \ell^2(\Sigma_1 \times \Sigma_2) = \mathcal{H}_1 \otimes \mathcal{H}_2$; the singlet's joint weights, (Section 14.6.8), are the entangled vector's Born weights.

(vii) Evolution is unitary. The kernel's composition over intermediate nodes is the Feynman propagator, $\mathcal{K}(p_1 \cdot p_2) = \mathcal{K}(p_1)\mathcal{K}(p_2)$ for concatenated routes, so that the map from a cluster's vector on one slice to its vector on a later slice, $\langle x'|T'\rangle = \sum_x K(x', x)\,\langle x|T\rangle$ with $K(x', x)$ the sum of $\mathcal{K}$ over the routes from x to x', is the unitary of the path integral [295].

(viii) No-signaling is an identity. The Partition Theorem, (Section 4.6.3), is $\sum_j \|P_j|T\rangle\|^2 = \langle T|T\rangle$, and weights adding across record-separated branches is the statement that $\sum_j P_j \rho P_j$ has the statistics of ρ for every observable commuting with the partition.

Proof. (i): $\langle x|T\rangle$ is the coherent sum over the paths of T ending at x by the assignment and the orthonormality of the configuration basis, so $|\langle x|T\rangle|^2$ is the sum of the real pair-kernel contributions $\mathrm{Re}\,\mathcal{K}(p)\overline{\mathcal{K}(q)}$ over the pairs of paths sharing x—the cosine pairing, in the scalar-action case—the Nexus's own display restricted to one configuration—and $\langle T|T\rangle = \sum_x |\langle x|T\rangle|^2$ by Parseval. (ii): the sum over a disjoint union splits. (iii): the P_j are orthogonal because the classes partition the configuration basis; a cluster's vector lies in $P_j\mathcal{H}$ if every path of the cluster ends in the jth class—not conversely, since coherent cancellation can remove a sector's contribution—, and the three cases of the theorem are the three ways a subset of paths can sit against the partition of their configurations, exactly as in its proof; the transported form is (vii) applied to a later slice's partition. (iv): $W(T \cap E_j) = \sum_{x \in E_j} |\langle x|T\rangle|^2 = \|P_j|T\rangle\|^2$ by (i), since the paths of $T \cap E_j$ are exactly the paths of T ending in the class. (v): T spanning classes is invalid as an agreeing object by (iii) and the third postulate; what stands after the record is stated is the disagreeing superposition of the class-restricted pieces at the weights of (iv), renormalizing the surviving piece is the theorem cited, and $P_j|T\rangle\langle T|P_j/\|P_j|T\rangle\|^2$ is its Hilbert-space form; the mixture statement is the definition of a disagreeing superposition—exclusions declared, hence weights adding—with convexity from the principle cited. (vi): the joint readout slice is the product of the factors' slices, and $\ell^2(\Sigma_1 \times \Sigma_2) \cong \ell^2(\Sigma_1) \otimes \ell^2(\Sigma_2)$, which is the tensor-product structure—nothing about the joint kernel is used, and the kernel of a joint path need not factor: temporal multiplicativity for successive segments says nothing about the kernel of a pair (p_A, p_B) of subsystem paths, which factors only for dynamically independent systems, an interacting joint kernel being what generates entanglement; the singlet section supplies the correlated case. (vii) is the composition law of the path integral. (viii): $\sum_j \|P_j|T\rangle\|^2 = \langle T|\sum_j P_j|T\rangle = \langle T|T\rangle$, and for O commuting with every P_j, $\mathrm{Tr}(O\sum_j P_j\rho P_j) = \sum_j \mathrm{Tr}(P_j O P_j \rho) = \mathrm{Tr}(O\rho)$. Statistics agree throughout because every statistic the procedure computes is a weight, and every weight is a squared norm by (i). □

The textbook reading of projection, translated. The theorem reverses the usual explanatory order without changing any statistic. In the projector formalism a recorded outcome is represented by the state update $|\psi\rangle \mapsto P_j|\psi\rangle/\|P_j|\psi\rangle\|$, after which the updated vector supplies the probabilities of the next measurement. Here the same sequential statistics are read in the opposite direction: the record determines a partition, pruning retains the augmented routes compatible with the new determinate node, and the unchanged Nexus supplies their transition weights. The kernel values of the survivors are not edited, and normalization only rescales their common conditional weight; the projected vector is the Hilbert-space representation of the surviving residue, $|T \cap E_j\rangle = P_j|T\rangle$ with its normalization. At representation grade the two are the same object, so no empirically different collapse law is proposed: the disagreement is over which side is primitive, the standard formalism taking projection as the update rule and the present one taking the record-restricted residue as primitive and recovering projection as its representation—the same reversal of direction that the paragraph below finds for the Born rule. Two consequences are worth stating in a textbook reader's terms. Pruning changes membership, not amplitudes: a record removes incompatible routes and never reaches inside a surviving route to alter its kernel value, the Nexus changing weights only through physical path structure. And a record settles exactly the distinction it records and no further one: an earlier determinate outcome remains part of the history without becoming a hidden, persistent valuation of later incompatible attributes, which is the general form of the resolution the sequential-spin exchange recorded above reached—uncertainty in the forecast, never fuzz in the record—and why, in the two-tag deduction, a port can stand determinate while the slit stays blank. The three textbook words then translate: *collapse* is pruning plus conditioning; *superposition* is the agreeing regime, the alternatives the records

leave unresolved, composing at amplitude grade; and a *measurement basis* is a record partition, the determinate-node structure a detector configuration induces—the correspondences Theorem 15 establishes clause by clause.

Why the Born rule is not a second axiom here. A reader used to the Dirac–von Neumann order will look for the Born rule as a separate posit and not find it, and the reason deserves a lemma, because it is the point at which the two axiom sets differ in *direction* and not merely in count. Nothing in the Aethic set refers to a bare amplitude: superposition is the union of clusters, dynamics is the kernel's composition law on paths, records are partitions, mixtures are weighted lists of clusters, and the amplitude $\sum_{p\in T}\mathcal{K}(p)$ appears only inside the weight functional, never as an object an Aethus holds—which is the first postulate at work, weights over blanks being indexed content and amplitudes being nobody's. The weight law is nonetheless enough to *recover* the amplitudes, because a quadratic form determines its polarization.

Lemma 8 (Amplitudes by Polarization)
Let $W_x(T) = |\sum_{p\in T,\, x(p)=x}\mathcal{K}(p)|^2$ be the weight of a cluster at a readout configuration, for all clusters $T \subseteq X$ and all configurations on all readout slices, with $\mathcal{K}$ the compositional kernel—the pure phase $e^{iS[p]/\hbar}$ in the scalar-action case, of modulus below one where an internal factor such as the Bloch factor enters. Then the weights of clusters determine $\mathcal{K}$ up to the basis-phase gauge of the configurations and one common complex conjugation per recombination-connected component—a single one when the setup's configurations are connected by recombination. At each configuration x the singleton and pair weights give the real Gram matrix of the kernel values ending there,

$$G_{pq} \;:=\; \operatorname{Re}\overline{\mathcal{K}(p)}\,\mathcal{K}(q), \qquad G_{pp} = W_x(\{p\}), \qquad G_{pq} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(W_x(\{p,q\}) - W_x(\{p\}) - W_x(\{q\})\big) \quad (p \neq q),$$

which in the unit-modulus case reads $W(\{p,q\}) = 2 + 2\cos(\phi_p - \phi_q)$; and paths ending at different configurations are related covariantly, through the composition law (vii), by the weights at any later slice of clusters whose continuations from those configurations recombine. In particular, for disjoint T_1, T_2 and each configuration x,

$$2\operatorname{Re}\overline{\langle x|T_1\rangle}\,\langle x|T_2\rangle \;=\; W_x(T_1\cup T_2) - W_x(T_1) - W_x(T_2).$$

Proof. Read each kernel value as a vector $v_p = (\operatorname{Re}\mathcal{K}(p), \operatorname{Im}\mathcal{K}(p)) \in \mathbb{R}^2$. Then $G_{pq} = \langle v_p, v_q\rangle$, so the matrix above is the real Gram matrix of the v_p at x, and a Gram matrix determines its vectors up to an orthogonal transformation of $\mathbb{R}^2$; the residual group $O(2)$ is exactly the stated freedom, its rotations being multiplication by a common phase and its reflections a common complex conjugation composed with a phase. No weight of three or more paths adds information, $W(\{p,q,r\}) = G_{pp} + G_{qq} + G_{rr} + 2(G_{pq} + G_{pr} + G_{qr})$ being fixed by the singletons and pairs, and no genericity is needed at a single configuration, a zero-modulus path being the zero vector and a collinear family merely shrinking the residual freedom. Paths ending at different configurations have no pair weight at either configuration, so each configuration's values are fixed only up to its own $O(2)$ frame, and the two parts of that frame behave differently. Its rotation is gauge: rephasing a configuration, $|x\rangle \mapsto e^{i\chi_x}|x\rangle$, sends $\langle x|T\rangle \mapsto e^{-i\chi_x}\langle x|T\rangle$ and $K(x'',x) \mapsto e^{-i\chi_{x''}}K(x'',x)\,e^{i\chi_x}$, so every concatenated path, and every weight at every slice, is unchanged, the global phase being the constant case; recombination at a later slice relates the configurations covariantly, $K(x'',x)\langle x|T\rangle$ being invariant, and does not fix their phases. Its reflection is not gauge: conjugating the values at one configuration alone changes the concatenated values, and with them the weights wherever continuations recombine, so the orientation is tied across any set of configurations whose continuations recombine—generically, the relevant propagator entries being nonzero—and one common reversal $\mathcal{K} \mapsto \overline{\mathcal{K}}$ is left per connected component, invisible to every W_x. Once a basis-phase gauge is fixed, that common conjugation is the only remaining ambiguity. The displayed identity is the expansion of $|a_1 + a_2|^2$ with $a_i = \langle x|T_i\rangle$. □

The residual freedoms are exactly the ones a quantum representation carries, and neither is a defect. The basis-phase gauge is the ordinary phase convention of the configuration basis, the global phase its constant case. The common conjugation is an antiunitary orientation ambiguity, weights being unable to fix the orientation of the complex structure; in the scalar-action realization it is the choice between $e^{iS/\hbar}$ and its conjugate, fixed by the direction convention that orients the action's sign and so, there, by the time orientation of the paths, while for a general complex kernel with no action behind it, identifying it with time reversal would need more physical structure than bare conjugation supplies. So the state vector of (i) is a *derived* bookkeeping object, reconstructed from the weights by polarization, and the Dirac–von Neumann pair is here one axiom running in the opposite direction. This is the third of the three relocations the introduction names, and the one with the longest reach:

probability is the root and the amplitude is derived from it, which reverses the order the formalism has carried since 1926 and places the framework's quantitative primitive in the same position the Nexic development gives its own—a weight at the root, never a census or a squared number beneath it. The opposite direction should be named, since Dirac–von Neumann's two posits are not independent either: Gleason's theorem derives the Born rule from the state space together with non-contextual probability assignments [325], so that formalism can also be run on one quantitative posit—the state space—with probabilities derived. The Aethic set runs the other way, weights posited and the state space derived, and only that direction is the one on which the amplitude is nobody's content. That difference of direction, not the count, is what the unscrambling amounts to at the quantitative layer.

The two axiom sets, side by side. What the theorem establishes is a change of primitives, and the change is best seen as a table: each Dirac–von Neumann axiom, what stands in its place here, and whether it is posited or derived.

Dirac–von Neumann axiom	**In the Aethic set**	**Standing**
states are rays in a complex Hilbert space	valid agreeing clusters, $\|T\rangle \in \ell^2(\Sigma)$ over the readout configurations, normalized by the Nexus weight	derived (from the union principle and the Nexus)
the superposition principle	the agreeing union, $\|T_1 \cup T_2\rangle = \|T_1\rangle + \|T_2\rangle$	derived (the union principle at kernel grade)
observables are self-adjoint operators	signature partitions of records, transported by propagation	derived (Theorem 14, Lemma 7)
the Born rule	the Nexus weight of the class-restricted cluster	*absorbed*: with the state space, one axiom here, the amplitudes derived by polarization (Lemma 8)
the projection postulate	pruning by the record, then renormalization	derived (the third postulate; Theorem 13)
composite systems are tensor products	product of augmented-path spaces	derived
unitary evolution	the kernel's composition law	derived (the Nexus)
(no counterpart)	the index: every state relative to an Aethus (P1)	posited
(no counterpart)	the agreeing/disagreeing distinction, and the classical limit as its disagreeing case	posited (the union principle), the limit derived
(no counterpart)	measurement's origin: which partitions the world's records induce	derived

Read down the third column. Of the seven Dirac–von Neumann axioms, six are theorems of the Aethic set and the seventh is absorbed: the state space and the Born map, two posits there, are one weight law here, with the amplitudes recovered by polarization rather than posited. The Aethic set is therefore not much shorter by count, (five axioms and a bridge against seven), but it is shorter in kind: it has no separate measurement axiom, no projection axiom and no axiom introducing observables, the observables arriving as consequences of the record structure and the third postulate and the projection rule as the representation of a stipulated record-compatible restriction, an assumption relocated rather than removed, the validity postulate alone not selecting the update; and it carries three things the Dirac–von Neumann set has no slot for—the index, the two regimes, and an answer to which measurements the world admits. The projection postulate's disappearance is the one to dwell on, because it is where the measurement problem lived in axiom form: a discontinuous rule bolted onto continuous dynamics, applied at an unspecified moment by an unspecified agent. Here nothing is bolted on and nothing happens to any object: a record makes a cluster invalid relative to every index that can read it, the disagreeing residue is what stands, and "projection" names that residue. The discontinuity was never in the dynamics; it was in the accounting, and the accounting is the third postulate.

The four levels, made visually unavoidable. The claims of this paper sit at four levels, and keeping them apart is what prevents both the overstatement that quantum mechanics has been derived from logic alone and the charge that it was smuggled into the axioms. *Level 1*, ontology and logical primitives: the first and second postulates, the union principle as a composition primitive, individuation, and the refinement and dependency structure—posited, the union move on inductive ground, individuation derived. *Level 2*, consistency consequences: the third postulate, reduced forms, record partitions, the quantum–classical boundary—derived, the third postulate in form within a stated class of refinement-based, weight-independent rules. *Level 3*, quantitative physics: the kernel, weights, phases, the Hilbert

representation, the Born statistics—the kernel posited, the rest derived from it together with Level 2, which is what the theorem above establishes. *Level 4*, the physical bridge: why formally invalid states are physically unrealizable, and whether observer-grade record escape is irreversible—a principle and an open question respectively. The honest form of the whole is therefore: *given indexed determinacy, constructive blankness, the union ontology, and consistency pruning, the observed quantum structure follows to the extent stated at each level*; and the measurement problem's standing is the one Section 14.4 gives it, the projection rule shown not to be an extra dynamical axiom and the problem thereby relocated to a precise question about validity and physical realizability, with Level 4 named as what remains.

What the set does not do, and what that means. The Nexus does not follow from the other four axioms, and the reason is structural rather than a gap in effort: the attribute side of the framework carries a binary flag—declared or undeclared cross content—while the kernel carries continuous phase, and no pruning of a binary structure produces a continuous one. In the vocabulary of the operational reconstructions of quantum theory [326–328], the Aethic set without the Nexus is a test space in the sense of Foulis and Randall [329]—attributes as tests, alternatives as outcomes, same-attribute exclusivity as orthogonality—with one addition those spaces lack, the agreeing join; and against the reconstruction axioms it sorts cleanly: convexity and the existence of measurements are theorems of P1–P3 and the union principle, pure conditioning is the representation of the stipulated record-compatible restriction, and no-signaling is an identity of the kernel's weight law for a fixed record-signature partition, (the existence of measurements being the one respect in which this structure is stronger than the reconstructions' starting point, which takes measurement as primitive); continuous reversibility, local tomography, and the quadratic form are the Nexus's content and nothing else's. And that residual should be read for what it is rather than as a debt the postulates owe. The Nexus does not follow from the other four axioms, and it should not be expected to, because the two are not the same kind of thing: the postulates' substance is *logical*—indexing, blankness, pruning, the jointness of *or*—while the kernel's substance is *kinematic*, the report of a geometric arena, (active space, Section 14.7), which agreeing superpositions do not generate but merely *toggle visibility into*. The two sectors talk to each other through exactly one door, the agreeing regime, and nowhere else; they are as separate as a logical principle is from a general-relativistic metric, and they inherit the corresponding mode of discovery. A metric is not derived from a logic; it is unveiled, geometrically, by the physics it governs. So "derive the kernel from the Aethic postulates" is a category mistake, and the paper does not make it: the kernel's derivation is assigned to active reasoning, (the fourth of the Open Constructions, Section 14.8), where it is a question about the arena's geometry and not about the logic's closure. The two sectors meet at one door, and a further question is whether the door is a coincidence or a common cause—whether the kernel and the metric are two arena contents that happen to touch, or two projections of one deeper arena of which spacetime is a quotient and the kernel the other branch. The framework has a sketch of the second answer, (Section 14.7.1; Section 14.7.3), and the ruling here is compatible with either: on both, the kernel is unveiled and not derived. In reconstruction terms this is why continuity, local tomography, and the quadratic form appear as "the kernel's content" in the sorting above: the reconstruction programs seek them from operational axioms because they have no arena to unveil, whereas the Aethic set has one and names it. The two contributions the framework brings to that unveiling remain the index and the record origin of measurement, since both constrain what the arena's report can look like from inside an Aethus; the axiomatization above is what the unveiling, if it succeeds, would then complete from the other side.

Against the generalized-probability reading. The standing way to place quantum theory among probabilistic theories reads it as a *generalization* of classical probability—the framework of generalized probabilistic theories, in which classical probability is the special case whose state space is a simplex and quantum theory the richer object with amplitudes beneath its probabilities [326, 330]. The Aethic order is the reverse, and the reversal is not a preference but a consequence of the two preceding results. Probability—Aethic weight over disagreeing alternatives, convex by the Relational Weight Principle—is the *general* structure, present in every sector of the framework, classical and quantum and the decision-theoretic and anthropic branches alike. Amplitudes are what that probability *looks like* when the objects weighted are agreeing clusters of the kinematic arena: by the polarization lemma the cluster weights determine the amplitude bookkeeping outright, so the amplitude is a representation tailored to one arena's behavior—the two-vector, cosine-and-sine form the kernel takes—and not a widening of probability at all. It is the special case; probability is the genus. Probabilities remain supreme; the amplitude is non-physical bookkeeping for what is genuinely still mysterious, which is the kinematics—why the arena reports itself in a form that a unit-modulus phase compacts—and that

mystery is the frontier of the ontology question on this leg, the quantum leg being one branch of the wider framework and not its trunk. Two consequences follow for the vocabulary. The imaginary unit does not ontologically exist here: it is the compacting of the cosine term of the kernel's cross-pairing into a single symbol, the point Section 14.2.3 makes as the dissolution of the imaginary-number problem, and the polarization lemma is its exact form—the weights fix the two-vector at each path up to the one orientation choice the direction convention makes. And the complex structure the kernel carries is thereby read as a fact about the arena's two-dimensional internal routes, related to the plane's vectors in a way the framework marks as open rather than explains; that relation is where the ontology question now sits. Two neighboring programs hold the first half of this ordering and should be placed against it. The Everettian reading on which branch weight *is* probability—the measure over semi-classical worlds standing in for chance, with the decision-theoretic derivations supplying the bridge [222]—agrees that weight is the primitive and probability its reading; where it differs is the object weighted: infinitely many co-existing worlds there, against here the pockets of a disagreeing superposition relative to one Aethus, so that the weight is indexed and no world-count is ever taken. Algorithmic idealism [17] agrees on the other half, that the observer state is primary and the quantum-looking world is what reality looks like from inside a model an observer can hold, (the self-state convergence recorded at Section 10.3.1); where it differs is that its primacy is computational, the model minimizing complexity, whereas the Aethus's primacy is logical, the state being what pruning leaves standing. The present ordering takes the two halves together and adds the subordination both leave implicit: weight is probability, the observer state is primary, and the amplitude is subordinate to both.

14.4 The Measurement Problem, Solved Against Maudlin's Trilemma

The phrase "solves the measurement problem" is used loosely enough in the literature that it is worth running the present solution against the sharpest available statement of the problem and saying exactly which of its parts is denied, which are kept, and at what grade. The sharpest statement is Maudlin's [331, 332], and it has the form of an inconsistent triad.

Maudlin's trilemma, and the horn the framework takes

The following three claims cannot all be true:

(1A) *Completeness.* The wavefunction of a system is complete: it specifies, directly or indirectly, all of the physical properties of the system.

(1B) *Linearity.* The wavefunction always evolves in accord with a linear dynamical equation, (the Schrödinger equation).

(1C) *Definite outcomes.* Measurements of, for example, the spin of an electron always, or at least usually, have determinate outcomes.

Every standard solution denies one claim in a familiar way: hidden-variable theories deny (1A) by adding *values* the wavefunction omits; dynamical-collapse theories deny (1B); the Everett reading denies (1C), replacing determinate outcomes with determinate branches.

The Aethic resolution denies (1A), and denies it in a way not on that list. The wavefunction is incomplete not because *values* are missing from it but because the *index* and the *validity predicate* are: the complete description of a system is the Aethus relative to which its attributes are stated or blank, together with the validity structure the third postulate computes over that Aethus's refinements, and the wavefunction is a summary of that description—the polarization of the cluster weights, (Lemma 8)—rather than the description itself. Nothing is added at the level of values, so there is no valuation for Bell's theorem to price, (Theorem 4). (1B) is kept entire for the kinematic sector: the kernel's composition law on paths is the unitary propagation, (Theorem 15(vii)), and no non-linear term is ever introduced. (1C) is recovered as a theorem *relative to an index*: a measurement's outcome is the residue the third postulate leaves standing once the record exists, definite relative to every Aethus that can read the record, and the projection postulate that standard quantum mechanics posits to secure (1C) is derived as pruning-plus-renormalization, (Theorem 15(v)).

Why indexed definiteness is definiteness, and not a branch. The Everettian will say that "definite

relative to a branch" is also definiteness, and that the framework has merely renamed the branch an index—and the Everettian is owed the concession first: branching is the right phenomenology of records, and the framework deduces it, (Section 2.4.5). The difference is structural and can be stated in three clauses. There is one block, not many worlds: the alternatives an observer's records do not fix are co-present in the same block relative to a prior index and *invalid* relative to the posterior one, so no world-count is ever taken and no branch is ever a place, (Section 2.2). The transition between indices is a fact about which Aethus an observer occupies, the centric unfolding, and it carries weights that are the framework's own primitive—weight over disagreeing alternatives, convex by the Relational Weight Principle—so the question "what are the probabilities probabilities *of*?" has an answer inside the ontology, which is the debt the branch reading cannot discharge from its own resources. And the carrier differs, (Section 2.4.6): an Everettian branch is a term of the universal state, individuated by an approximate basis and weighted by an amplitude that must then be argued into a probability, whereas the framework's alternatives are pockets of an Aethus, individuated exactly by the record partition and weighted by the framework's own primitive, with the amplitudes derived from the weights and not the reverse. And cross-observer consistency is a theorem, not a hope: no observer can meet another whose records contradict theirs, (Section 10.3.3), so the indexed outcomes are objective in the only sense objectivity ever had, agreement among all who can compare.

The second problem: statistics. Maudlin's second problem is that a solution must reproduce the Born statistics, not merely secure some outcome. Here the framework is exact about what it derives and what it posits. The weights are the Quantum Nexus's, the one quantitative axiom, posited as every axiomatization posits the quadratic law and derived from nothing in the postulates, (Section 14.3, the reconstruction remark); given it, the Born statistics of every measurement are recovered by the recovery theorem, no-signaling arrives as an identity, and the two-tag and singlet constructions show the recovery closing on the standard numbers for reasons that are theorems rather than coincidences, (Section 14.6.4). The statistics problem is therefore solved *conditionally on the kernel*, which is the same condition every formalism carries, and the framework's contribution is to have removed the statistics from the list of things a measurement axiom must supply.

The third problem: effect. Maudlin's third problem is that an outcome, once obtained, must have the right effect on subsequent measurements—the repeatability that the projection postulate secures by fiat. Here the framework's answer is its oldest commitment: the record is permanent, (the extrusion principle), and a record once stated is content of every Aethus downstream of it, so a repeated measurement re-reads a record that already stands rather than re-drawing an outcome, and the conditioning that the projection postulate imposed is the Lüders rule as pruning-plus-renormalization, (Theorem 13). The effect problem is solved as a theorem, and the only assumption it consumes is the one already named for the first.

What is assumed, stated once. The resolution consumes the three postulates, the union principle, the kernel, and one physical claim: that an observer-grade record structure exports its records unblockably, so that the third postulate fires for observers as it fires for detectors. That claim is the framework's one structural divergence from universal unitarity, it is an open question about the physics of records rather than a parameter, and it is where a physicist who doubts the resolution should press, (Section 14.8). Everything else in this subsection is a theorem of the axiom set. So the sentence "the measurement problem is solved" is claimed here at exactly this grade: as a theorem of an axiom set that recovers the standard formalism, conditional on one stated claim about records, with the projection postulate, the measurement axiom, and the cut deleted rather than relocated—and with the one question every solution leaves, why *this* outcome rather than that, left where it belongs, as the content of probability, for which the framework, unlike the branch reading, has a primitive.

14.5 A Retrospective: Why the Record-First Form Was Slow to Appear

The axiomatization of Section 14.3 raises a question that is historical rather than technical. Its ingredients were each available for most of a century—the path integral's sum over alternatives, the block universe, the thought that a quantum state might be relative to an observer—and the ordering it imposes on them, records first and the state a summary, is not intricate once stated. Why, then, was it slow to appear? The answer this subsection offers does not locate a fault in the interpretations. Each of them answered the question it was asked, under the constraints it had, and several of them held one piece of the present ordering firmly. The answer is that the ordering required three pieces of *vocabulary* that did not exist as such, and that until they did, the sentence the ordering turns on could not be said.

The general obstacle: the direction of explanation. The standard presentation takes the state as the primary object and asks what happens to it when a measurement occurs. On that direction of explanation a record is downstream of the state—one more correlation term inside ψ, produced by the same unitary dynamics that produces everything else—and a thing that is made of the alternatives cannot be what individuates them. The record can register that an outcome occurred; it cannot, on that reading, be the reason the alternatives are alternatives. The wavefunction was not treated as too real, but as the wrong *kind* of real: a state of the system, rather than a summary of what the records do not yet fix. Reverse the direction, so that the record is primitive and individuates, (Lemma 7), and the state is what remains once the records have spoken. The reversal is small to state and was hard to reach, and the clearest sign of what was missing is the decoherence program [116], which is correct about the mechanism of appearance—records copied into an environment make a cross-term negligible—and which, by its own careful account, explains why an outcome *appears* without explaining that it *occurs*. The reason it cannot is that it has only probability grade to work with. What was missing was a *modal* grade: the ability to say that an alternative is *invalid* relative to an observer, rather than merely improbable, which is what the third postulate supplies. Without validity as a predicate distinct from probability, the sentence "the interference-bearing structure cannot stand once a record exists" is unsayable, and every reading below was working without it.

Reading by reading. Each of the standard readings held a piece of the present ordering, and each was stopped by the absence of one of the three pieces of vocabulary: a modal grade, an index, or the union principle's distinction.

- *Copenhagen* [1] saw that the record matters and that the observer is ineliminable, which is the present framework's first postulate in an early form. Lacking indexing as a two-place relation—determinate *relative to*—it had to place the observer's role at a cut, and a cut is a location, which is why it could not say where the location was.

- *Many worlds* [2, 3, 68] saw that the dynamics needs no addition and that the alternatives are real, which the present framework keeps entire—and it read the phenomenology of records correctly: after a record the alternatives do not interact and the observer stands in one of them. Its one error was to make that non-interaction a place. Lacking the union principle's distinction between agreeing and disagreeing composition, it had every alternative at one grade, co-present and interfering everywhere in principle, so that probability had to be brought in from outside as a weight over branches; the branch-weight problem is the shape that absence takes. Beneath it lies the difference of carrier: its branches are amplitude states, terms of one evolving vector, where the present framework's are Aethae, with the vector derived from their weights, (Section 2.4.6).

- *de Broglie–Bohm* [72] saw that definiteness must come from somewhere and supplied it as a hidden valuation, which Bell's theorem then priced in nonlocality [4]. The present framework's definiteness is indexed rather than hidden, so there is no valuation for the theorem to price; the difference is where determinacy lives, not whether it does.

- *Dynamical collapse* [75] saw that coherence ends somewhere for observer-grade systems, which is the one position the present framework shares with it. Lacking the record structure as the criterion for *where*, it had to posit a rate, and a rate is a parameter to be measured rather than a fact to be read off the configuration.

- *Relational quantum mechanics and QBism* [20, 78, 79] saw indexing itself—the state as relative to an observer or an agent—and are the readings closest to the first postulate. Lacking the validity structure that makes cross-observer consistency a theorem, the index read as relationalism or as subjectivism, and was resisted on that ground by readers who wanted an objective world; the present framework's answer is that the world is objective in its structure and indexed in its content, and that no observer can meet another who contradicts them.

- *Consistent histories* [315–317] saw that coarse-grainings and consistency conditions are where the classical world comes from, and is the reading closest to the Powerset theorem in spirit. Lacking record-individuation and the modal grade, its consistency remained a condition on families of histories rather than a verdict on states, and the choice of family remained free where the present framework has the records choose.

- *Quantum logic* [81, 161] saw that the logic needed reform, which the union principle agrees with. It chose the reform of the lattice—distributivity surrendered—where the present framework chooses

the reform of the alternatives, exclusion as an achievement written into them and distributivity kept.

Three inherited readings that stood in the way. Beneath the interpretations, three readings inherited from classical physics made the ordering hard to see, and each is worth naming without reproach, since each was the reasonable reading of its time. The first is the un-indexed ledger: classical mechanics supplied a God's-eye state, and the quantum state inherited its grammar, so that a determinacy relative to an observer sounded like a retreat from objectivity rather than a refinement of it. The second is the block universe read as complete determinacy: relativity's tenseless whole was taken to contain every fact settled, which is exactly the ignorance-about-an-objective model the extrusion principle refutes, and a block that is complete without every entry being determinate sounded like anti-realism, so it was not wanted. The third is Bell's theorem read as closing off realism, when what it closes off is one realism—counterfactual definiteness, a valuation on every attribute at once—while leaving the other, indexed determinacy, untouched; the Deflation Reductio, (Theorem 4), is where the present framework shows the theorem cutting exactly there.

The instrument that was already there. The path integral [295] had already made "a sum over alternatives weighted by phases" the primitive in 1948, and its clusters and its records were sitting in the formalism from that year: the alternatives are the paths, the coherent sum runs within a cluster, and the rule that amplitudes add when nothing records which alternative occurred and probabilities add when something does was stated in the Lectures as a working instruction. The field read the whole construction as a calculational device, which it also is, and ran the Born rule at the end as a separate step. The present framework's move, seen in that light, is to take the instrument as an ontology: to let the clusters be the objects, the records be the partition, and the rule's "in principle" be cashed as a fact about which records exist relative to an index. Nothing in that move required new physics. It required the three pieces of vocabulary named at the start—a modal grade, a two-place determinacy, and exclusion as an achievement—and each of those is a philosophical instrument rather than a physical one, which is why the route to the record-first form ran through this paper's philosophical prelude before it reached its quantum wing, and why it was a route that physics, working with its own instruments, had little occasion to take.

14.6 Polarization, the Sphere, and the Bloch Factor of the Kernel

This subsection is the designated home for the framework's polarization material—the duality frontiers, the chord and the circle, and the polarized n-slit account—collected from the continuous-paths development above, whose determinate-node discussions remain in place there. Its order is deliberate and pedagogical: the entry reframe first, (Section 14.6.1); then the duality frontiers stated as the *target*, with the concept, the limiting cases, the chord, and the circle taught in that order and the line between the framework's own contribution and the kernel's drawn before any derivation, (Section 14.6.2); then the polarized n-slit experiment as the construction's ancestor; then the two-tag deduction, which *verifies* within one experiment that the qualitative distinction produces the quantitative geometry, and closes on an audit of what it derived and what it imported, (Section 14.6.4); and then the reframes collected, the deduction retold concretely, its transfer to other arenas, the singlet, the bound, the whole standing as the exhibits of the axiomatization of Section 14.3, whose trilemma statement and retrospective, (Sections 14.4 and 14.5), sit between. The frame that unifies the collection is a factoring proposed here for the total Quantum Nexus itself, and it sits as close to the axiomatic layer as the construction gets: the elementary objects are *augmented paths* $p = (p_{\mathrm{st}}, p_{\mathrm{B}})$, a spacetime path carrying a Bloch-sphere path—a state augmentation carrying both paths to each path—so that the configuration space is the fibered product, clusters are joint clusters, and validity reads joint records. The determinate-node-corresponding indexing—to every slit indexed in spacetime, a determinate-node collection indexed on the Bloch sphere—is then a bookkeeping device for the spacetime and Bloch faces of the attributes describing each slit; and that there are determinate nodes at all is emergent, from the system-Aethus pruning under the Quantum Nexus, never posited. (This is, at the same time, the formal adoption of the enlarged configuration space that the second Open Construction's first requirement names.) Neither factor is privileged: the two arenas are treated as isomorphic up to the Quantum Nexus and Aethic reasoning, the or-mechanism of agreeing superpositions—paths through slit A or slit B, paths through one tag or the other—being one law in both, a fundamental property of constrained agreeing superpositions rather than a feature of either arena.

14.6.1 Two Arenas, One Nexus: The Entry Reframe

The sentence just stated is this section's entry reframe, and the hurdle it clears deserves its own moment before the derivations lean on it. The habit it breaks is old and useful: spacetime as *the* arena, with internal degrees of freedom riding along as labels—decoration on the paths that really matter. Under that habit, the polarization facts of this section would be bookkeeping about light, and nothing below would generalize. The reframe replaces the habit with a symmetry: the Quantum Nexus ranges over both arenas at once, and neither is privileged with respect to it. The sphere is not a chart of states pinned to spacetime paths; it is a path-space in its own right, met by the Nexus exactly as spacetime is, with the grade order already fixed above—augmented paths as close to the axioms as the construction gets, the indexing as bookkeeping, the nodes emergent from pruning in either arena alike.

The working form of the symmetry is a *transfer criterion*: any tool or ontology used in one arena, respecting the Nexus proper, must carry to the other. Determinate nodes transfer, forming by pruning in both; the or-form transfers, the double slit being its spacetime instance; records, capacities, tilts—each earns its place by surviving the crossing. And the criterion cuts the other way with equal force: whatever refuses to transfer is thereby exposed as no part of the arenas' shared machinery, and this section contains exactly one such refusal—the kernel's weighting itself. The transfer test is what sifts the axiom from the applications: everything that crosses is Aethic; what remains at the boundary is the booked Open Construction, located rather than assumed.

What follows is that criterion cashed repeatedly: the sphere acquires nodes, the nodes the pair, the pair meets the record, and the weights, the frontiers, and in the end the bound emerge—none of it invented for polarization, all of it the Nexus meeting a second path-space it already knew how to treat. Read the double slit again after this section and the direction of surprise reverses: the sphere case was never an extension of the slits; both are instances of one law, and the slits merely got written down first. Each instance so cashed is inventoried, with its open residue, in Section 14.6.5.

One structural proposal of the author's rides with the frame, and is recorded here at proposed grade with its unknowns named. For two transfer-states on the sphere standing as the slits' tags, the third postulate's pruning enforces *at most to the pair*: the valid object is the two-point configuration whole, characterized by its bisector, never resolved toward a single sphere point. The disagreeing counterpart is the Aethus sum of singly-resolved cases; and the general analyzer angle θ from the bisector, (angles here and throughout this proposal on the sphere convention, the sphere doubling physical angles), yields the weighted combination $c_A(\theta) \cdot \mathcal{A}_{\text{pair}} + c_D(\theta) \cdot \mathcal{A}_D$, the agreeing coefficient maximal at the bisector and the disagreeing coefficient maximal at the orthogonal straddle, with the one fixed anchor $c_D(\pi/2) = \sqrt{1 - c^2}$ for tag overlap c. The combination is convex at Aethic-weight grade, $c_A + c_D = 1$: these are Aethic weights, and only the kernel can source Pythagorean aspects, which Aethic weights cannot—the linear frontier's tradeoff, applied now to the agreeing-versus-disagreeing object, with Pythagorean structure, where it appears, sourced one level down in the kernel's amplitudes and reaching the weights only through the square map. The coefficient functions themselves and the pair's interior weight law are open, and are carried as named unknowns rather than filled by guess.

14.6.2 The Duality Frontiers and the Home of the Quadratic Case

Before the relations are stated, what the two numbers measure should be fixed in the framework's own terms, because a reader who meets the algebra first infers the meaning only afterward from the equations. Every quantity below is evaluated relative to an Aethus, the indexed information state of the setup, (Section 5.1); a which-path attribute that no record could fix is *blank* relative to it, which by the second postulate is superposition and not an unknown value waiting to be read, (Section 3.4.4); and two path alternatives stand in *disagreeing* superposition when their mutual exclusion is written into their interiors and in *agreeing* superposition when it is not, a fact about what is written and not a degree of coherence, (Section 10.7). The framework attaches a different composition behavior to each regime, and the whole of what follows is an unfolding of one sentence:

Disagreeing alternatives compose by weights; agreeing alternatives compose by amplitudes.

Weights compose convexly by the Relational Weight Principle, (Principle 22), with no quantum input; amplitudes compose with cross-terms by the Quantum Nexus, (Section 50), the single flagged quantitative axiom. Fringe visibility V is read from the screen, $(I_{\max} - I_{\min})/(I_{\max} + I_{\min})$; which-path distinguishability D is not how disturbed the fringes look but the available which-path *record capacity*, and since this letter has been the source of repeated confusion across the papers its notation is fixed here once and used in no other sense. D is *one* quantity: the which-path distinguishability accessible from

the record at the placement in force—the total-variation gap between the two outcome distributions the two paths induce on that record. It is indexed by the placement, written $D(\theta)$ for an analyzer at angle θ and D_p for a general placement p, and its supremum over admissible placements is written $D^\star := \sup_p D_p$, which for pure marker states is Englert's $\sqrt{1-c^2}$. Three things are *not* D: the port predictability P_θ, read at the ports after the analyzer with no marker left; the run-average of D over a classical mixture; and the doomed set $\mathfrak{D}$ of the fixed-point subsection, which is not a number. The chord $V + D = 1$ and the circle $V^2 + D^2 \leq 1$ are statements about the same D at the placement in force; the circle holds at every placement, with equality for pure markers exactly at the optimal one, where $D = D^\star$. So D is a record quantity, never a screen one. V reads the surviving agreeing side; D reads the available disagreeing side; and the claim to be earned is that they are two observational faces of the one distinction. The endpoints are the two regimes at their poles: no record, $(D, V) = (0, 1)$, one fully agreeing pair; a perfect record, $(1, 0)$, the paths fully disagreeing. Between them there are two qualitatively different ways to be intermediate, and the claim is that they have different shapes—a classical partial tag on the chord $V + D = 1$, a coherent pure tag on the circle $V^2 + D^2 = 1$, a mixed coherent tag inside it. The relations themselves are familiar; the question is whether the two shapes can be read as the two composition laws.

The which-way duality relations supply this framework's sharpest quantitative target, so let us state them properly. Mark a two-path system with an ancilla: the joint state is $(|A\rangle|m_A\rangle + |B\rangle|m_B\rangle)/\sqrt{2}$, and everything is controlled by the marker overlap $c = |\langle m_A|m_B\rangle|$. The screen's cross term comes out tagged by the overlap, so the *unconditional* fringe visibility—the whole screen, no port selected—is $V = c$; the best achievable path-guess from the marker is the optimal discrimination of two states of overlap c, giving, at the optimal placement, $D^\star = \sqrt{1-c^2}$; hence $V^2 + (D^\star)^2 = 1$. (The case structure here is the inherited one: the two-directional pruning of the mixture-times-system product, developed in the double-slit analysis of subsection 6.1, sorts this identity and the linear one alike, with only the weight grade of the surviving diagonal — cosine-built here, convex there — distinguishing them.) Writing $c = \cos\theta$ for the angle between the marker states, $V = \cos\theta$ and $D^\star = \sin\theta$: the Englert frontier [333] is the Pythagorean identity for the marker angle, with the lineage running back through the predictability relation of Greenberger and Yasin [334] to Wootters and Zurek [335]. Saturation requires the marker to remain pure; if it leaks to a third system, $V^2 + D^2 < 1$, and the deficit is precisely entanglement with the third party [336].

The two frontiers are the two mixtures of the vocabulary note above, and a paired thought experiment makes the distinction tactile. Run A: flip a coin of weight w; on one face do not mark, on the other mark perfectly. This is a weighted disagreeing superposition—a proper mixture, and precisely the structure deduced from the postulates in Section 14.6.3, where the disagreeing superposition is identified as living on the *apparatus*—and it yields the chord by two lines, which deserve display because the chord is the first composition law made visible. Write $p = 1 - w$ for the fraction of runs carrying a usable record. The marked component has stated the exclusion, its paths compose as separate weighted alternatives, and it sits at $(D, V) = (1, 0)$; the unmarked component is one agreeing pair at $(0, 1)$; the two are record-separated and so compose by weights:

$$D \;=\; p \cdot 1 + (1-p) \cdot 0 \;=\; p, \qquad V \;=\; p \cdot 0 + (1-p) \cdot 1 \;=\; 1 - p, \qquad \boxed{V + D = 1}.$$

The straight line is therefore not introduced as an additional complementarity postulate; it is the geometry of mixing an interference-bearing agreeing sector with a record-bearing disagreeing sector, and it requires the framework's convex weight structure and nothing from the kernel—no amplitude appears in it. It lies strictly inside the circle, reaching at best $V = D = \frac{1}{2}$. Run B: always mark, but coherently and partially, at an angle with $\cos\theta = w$. The screen visibility is identical, $V = w$, but the extractable distinguishability is $D^\star = \sqrt{1-w^2} > 1 - w$, reaching $V = D^\star = 1/\sqrt{2}$ at the symmetric point. (An illustrative check at the paper's running example, $\alpha = 30°$, marker overlap $c = \cos 60° = \frac{1}{2}$: $V = \frac{1}{2}$, $D^\star = \sqrt{1 - \frac{1}{4}} = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$, and $\frac{1}{4} + \frac{3}{4} = 1$—a check on the reader's understanding, not a result.) Same visibility, different ontology—pockets carrying facts versus one agreeing joint cluster carrying no fact of the branch—and the two runs are jointly distinguishable, since their eraser statistics differ. That is the screen-versus-record distinction in the flesh: V is read from the screen pattern, $D^\star$ from the record sector as an optimal extractability, so two setups can share every intensity pattern and differ in $D^\star$ alone—in what *could have been* extracted—and the framework's claim is that the difference is a difference in the Aethic status of the path alternatives, agreeing or disagreeing, even where the screen does not display it. Experiments reach the circle [114]; proper structure alone cannot reproduce the data; the improper case is physically real rather than bookkeeping. (In the framework's own

vocabulary, one level up from the photon: Run A is a disagreeing apparatus superposition and Run B an agreeing one—the identification drawn out at the close of Section 14.6.3.)

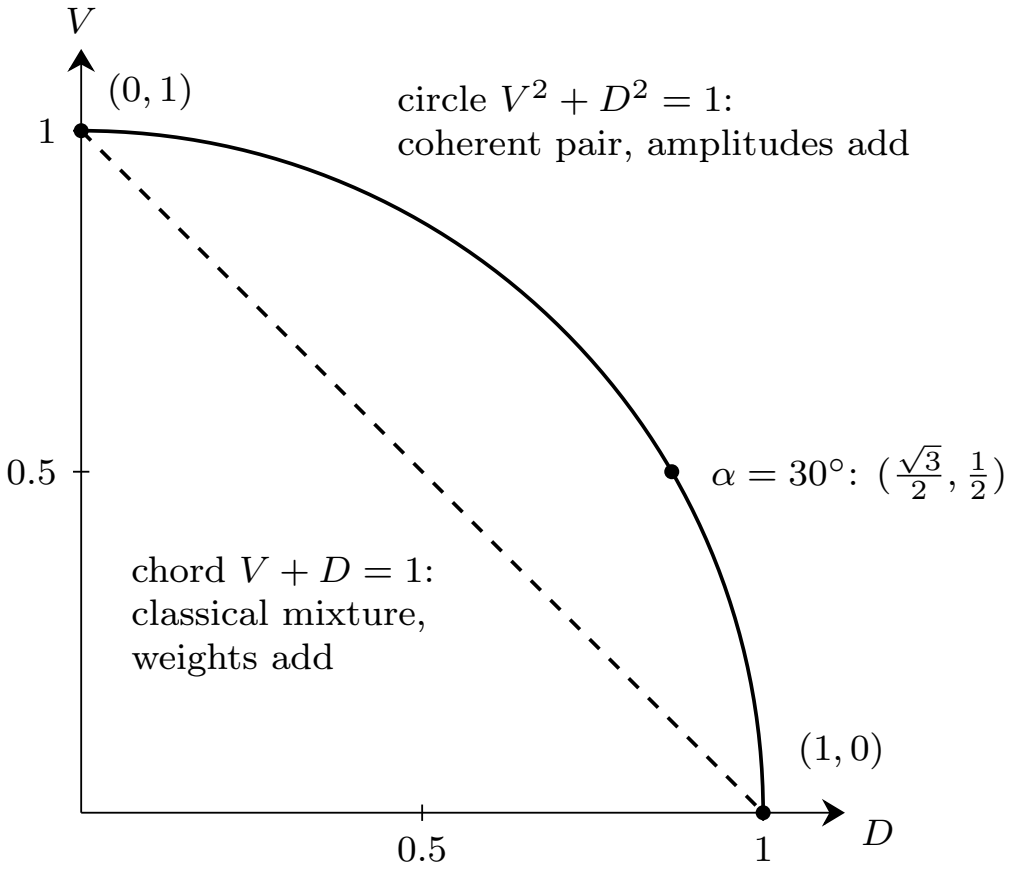


Figure 12: The visibility–distinguishability plane. The two poles are the two regimes at their limits: $(0, 1)$ is full interference with no record, the paths fully agreeing, and $(1, 0)$ is a perfect record with no fringes, the paths fully disagreeing. The dashed chord is the convex mixture of those poles—a classically random tag, composed by weights, no kernel used—and the solid quarter-circle is the coherent pure tag, composed by amplitudes, the kernel's overlap c giving V and the discrimination bound giving $D^\star$. The lens between the chord and the arc is the coherent tag that is mixed or coarse-grained, $V^2 + D^2 < 1$; the triangle below the chord is classical randomization with records wasted. The marked point is the paper's running example, Run B at $c = \frac{1}{2}$. The figure adds no data; it lets the two composition laws be seen as two shapes.

Where, then, does the quadratic case live Aethically? Inside *one* surviving element of the powerset. Enlarge the configuration space so that histories carry the marker's degrees of freedom alongside the system's paths; the survivor under coherent partial marking is a single agreeing joint cluster containing both branches, and the double path integral's cross terms *within* that cluster carry the packet-overlap integral $\int m_A^*(\mu)\, m_B(\mu)\, d\mu = c$—the visibility is literally the overlap of two marker packets. Distinguishability, by contrast, lives in the lattice of *potential* record-induced refinements of that same cluster: each candidate marker measurement is a candidate attribute whose records would partition the cluster differently, and $D^\star$ is the sharpness of the best potential partition—a supremum over the lattice, never a weighted average. The duality is thus a budget theorem about a single powerset element: keep it whole (V) or split it optimally ($D^\star$), with Pythagoras as the exchange rate, and the trade-off exists because the split *is* the pruning that kills the interior cross terms. Let it also be said plainly, since the point was misread even within this paper's own editing process: none of this ever proposes making validity scalar rather than binary. That is among the framework's firmest prohibitions, because the second postulate requires precisely that such intermediate cases be expressible as weighted linear combinations of a valid Aethus and an invalid one. The dial of partial coherence is an angle, not a weight—binary validity, continuous geometry, the partiality living in amplitude alignment and never in any fraction of validity. (And the granularity is exhibited by the weighting

expression itself, rather than asserted beside it. For an agreeing joint cluster T, the kernel assigns $W(T) = \left|\sum_{p\in T} \mathcal{K}(p)\right|^2 = \sum_{p,\,p'\in T} \mathcal{K}(p)\,\overline{\mathcal{K}(p')}$, with $\mathcal{K}(p) := e^{iS[p]/\hbar}$ the pure-phase kernel, (the cosine pairing of the Nexus axiom being this coherent square written out, its imaginary part vanishing under path exchange), and every cross-term in the expansion pairs paths *within the same element*: the sum returns one number, attached to the one Aethus-term. Nothing in the formalism offers a finer-grained bearer of weight, so reweighting at higher resolution than the agreeing-superposition scope is not forbidden by an additional rule—the expression has no slot for it. The universal object effecting all of this is the Quantum Nexus of Section 14.2.1, intersected with the system's Aethus rather than applied case by case. Validity accordingly acts on entire powerset elements: a cluster survives whole, its interior cross-terms intact as constituents of its single weight, or dies whole.) The chord is linearity in probabilities; the circle is linearity in amplitudes, squared—which is the entire origin of the curvature. The chord's side of this statement is a deduction of the framework: it follows from the postulates in Section 14.6.3, whose closing contrast also locates the circle as exactly the agreeing-apparatus case still awaiting the same treatment.

The significance of reaching the circle deserves stating at full size, because it is easy to file this subsubsection as a technical appendix when it is closer to a keystone. First, the circle is where the framework's central ontological distinction earns its experimental signature: Run A and Run B above share a visibility and differ in their eraser statistics, so agreeing versus disagreeing—the distinction the entire construction stands on—is not an interpretive gloss but a measurable difference, and the circle is the curve on which that measurement lives. Second, the incorporation relocates complementarity itself: what enters the textbooks as a principle—an irreducible trade-off decreed rather than derived—arrives here with theorem shape, a budget identity over one powerset element, Pythagoras as the exchange rate and the pruning as the mechanism. Third, the economy: the same two-node overlap geometry that delivers the Malus chain as pruning residue delivers the duality law—one geometry, two laws, no additional machinery purchased between them—and on the sphere the framework already runs, the circle is no import at all but the native Pythagorean identity of the marker angle. The frontier line should then be drawn exactly where it stands: the geometry and the weights are in place, the chord's side is deduced, and what remains open—the three-step program recorded at this subsubsection's close and in the Open Constructions, (Section 14.8)—is the in-formalism derivation, with the definition of the best potential record-attribute as its genuinely new step. The claim, precisely sized: the framework does not yet re-derive the Englert bound unconditionally from its own axioms — though a worked *conditional* route now exists, compressed at the end of this paragraph, with its residue isolated to two named premises; it already runs the geometry the bound lives on, and it knows exactly which definition stands between the two. And the stake of closing that definition deserves flat statement, as the case for keeping the item prominent on the open-constructions list rather than quietly footnoted: the missing piece is really one result — a definition plus its optimality theorem — and the optimum in question is the Helstrom bound, one of quantum information theory's foundational results. Deriving it from pruning-plus-kernel would not merely close the Englert loop; it would stand, conditionally on the two premises the route below names, as the framework's first reconstruction of a genuinely information-theoretic *optimality* theorem, a different genre of payoff from the identities, whose statements are equalities the geometry exhibits rather than optima quantified over every admissible placement. The route, compressed and at its current grade: an admissible record placement is a cell family over the record sector's attribute space — a positive normalized measure over or-shaped cells, finite partitions the exhibited case, optionally after intersecting a fixed helper factor and partitioning the joint — under the configuration's inherited joint-validity constraints, its score the outcome-weighted answer gap. Cell-weights attach to whole surviving elements and every weight is a paired-kernel squared modulus, so each cell's weight is a quadratic form in the marker state, affine in its state-space data, with preparation mixtures entering convexly by the run-ensemble mechanics (kernel-affineness, at this paper's derivation grade); nonnegativity holds by the square structure and normalization over the cell family, and since the cap's argument integrates exactly as it sums, no finiteness restriction survives. Granted two named premises — *representational completeness* (every postulate-admissible placement's statistics, sequential-adaptive schemes included via collapse into a helper-joint, are matched within the drawn domain) and the *state-space identification* (marker preparations faithfully represented by the ball the kernel's two-node overlaps generate) — every admissible placement's score is at most the chord, attainment itself unconditional and exhibited by the analyzer family's straddle in analyzer terms alone, a fixed helper factor multiplying both cases identically and a path-correlated helper being a different preparation, relocation rather than manufacture. The second premise, if discharged as a completeness lemma over the record-equivalence quotient — preparations identified when no admissible placement

separates their statistics — would convert the layer from borrowing the qubit statistical structure to earning it, and stands as the construction's next determinate target.

Standard Helstrom content, And the supremum's arena should be named concretely, because "best potential record-attribute" can sound more exotic than it is. The set ranged over is nothing but the measurement bases available on the marker—axes on the very sphere the sequential treatment runs—each axis inducing its own candidate record-attribute, its own placement of determinate nodes, its own partition of the joint cluster. For a given axis, the two marker states produce two outcome distributions, and the discrimination the axis achieves is set by how little those distributions overlap. The optimum is then a classical result with a clean geometric face, (the Helstrom measurement [337]): the best axis lies in the plane of the two marker states and *straddles them symmetrically*, perpendicular to their bisector, and it achieves success probability $\frac{1}{2}(1+\sqrt{1-c^2})$—whence $D^\star = \sqrt{1-c^2}$ exactly. Two features of the geometry deserve note. First, for partial tags the optimal axis is *not* either tag's own basis: measuring along the tags is strictly suboptimal whenever they fail to be orthogonal, which is what makes $D^\star$ a genuine supremum over the lattice rather than a reading taken at the obvious node. Second, the conjugate axis of the same plane is the eraser basis—the choice that trades path information for phase and restores conditional fringes—so the extraction of $D^\star$ and the recovery of V are two perpendicular axes of one plane on one sphere, and the duality budget of this subsubsection is the statement that no axis of that plane, and no axis anywhere else, escapes the exchange rate.

The architecture of the in-formalism route can now be charted, and the author's charting runs as follows. Decompose the Quantum Nexus multiplicatively into a spacetime-path factor and a Bloch-path factor, the total integral running over state-augmented histories—every "species" of path at once, spatial and internal—so that the marker's sphere enters not as external scaffolding but as another path regime of the same Nexus; and the Bloch factor is not a metaphor awaiting machinery, since the spin coherent-state path integral over the sphere [309] is exactly that factor's established form, the same construction the sequential-measurement treatment already employs. The pruning then acts on the joint powerset, and the screen decouples by two-stage structure: conditional on each marker-side determinate node, the spacetime factor yields that branch's pattern, and the observed intensity is the node-weighted average of the conditional patterns—with the basis-dependence of that decomposition, (same total intensity, different conditional splits per node placement), being nothing other than the attribute-relativity of mixedness, (Section 14.2.1), read at the marker. On this architecture the duality itself acquires an in-formalism candidate shape: the underlying subject is one agreeing superposition—the marker attribute—and every node placement on the sphere allocates it between conversion and preservation. $D^\star$ is the *maximal disagreeing-conversion* of that attribute achievable over the lattice, attained at the straddle axis; V is the agreeing remainder's interference yield, maximally recovered along the conjugate axis; and $V^2 + D^2 = 1$ is the conversion budget of the one superposition, with the doubled integral's cross terms—pairings of distinct realizations against one another—as the mechanism carrying the agreeing remainder to the screen. This is an architecture, not yet the theorem: the formal statement of the state-augmented Nexus and the lattice-supremum definition remain exactly the open work recorded above and in Section 14.8. But the route now has a road, and every segment of it runs on machinery the framework already owns.

The proper layer re-enters one level up, and the two layers together paint the whole disk. The apparatus's contingent condition—lossiness, detector error, whatever in totality controls the informational deviation—forms a weighted Aethic partition of the prior Aethus over the condition-attribute, (Section 3.5.3), and since distinguishability is convex under such mixing, this layer can only pull D *below* its ideal value $D^\star$: proper structure fills the disk's interior. The packet geometry inside the agreeing cluster sets the boundary itself. Contingency sets the numbers; geometry sets the law; and the Englert disk is thereby the proper/improper distinction drawn as a picture—its boundary improper physics, its interior depth proper physics. And the disk says something a reader may otherwise file wrongly: partial which-path information is not an intermediate *philosophical* category, an epistemic halfway house, but an intermediate *structural* case—some record-separating capacity exists while the alternatives need not be fully separated into the disagreeing regime—and there are exactly two ways to be intermediate, which is the whole reason there are two geometries. A classical mixture is intermediate because the ensemble is split, some runs separated and some not, and its pair lies on the chord; a coherent partial tag is intermediate because every run carries both alternatives with markers that only partly coincide, and its pair lies on the circle. Filing both under "partial knowledge" loses exactly the distinction the two curves display.

With the disk in hand, the framework's account of proper and improper mixtures can be collected in one place, because its pieces otherwise live at three sites and an assessing reader should not have to

assemble them. *Definition*: an improper mixture is an agreeing joint cluster—one surviving powerset element carrying no fact of the branch—while a proper mixture is a disagreeing superposition, pockets each carrying its fact, (the vocabulary fixed with the Nexus itself, Section 14.2.1). *Signature*: the two are empirically distinguishable, not metaphysically decorative—Run A and Run B above share every intensity pattern and part ways in their eraser statistics, so the distinction has a measurement that detects it. *Converter*: the passage from improper to proper is lawful with a stated trigger—the third postulate fires exactly when distinguishing information becomes permanently accessible, which is the framework's head-on answer to the classic and/or objection against decoherence-only accounts, (Section 14.2.1). *Non-uniqueness*: the textbook fact that an improper state admits no unique ensemble decomposition arrives here as node-placement relativity—different determinate-node choices split the same cluster into different conditional families, the attribute-relativity of mixedness read at the marker, per the two-stage architecture above. And *weight provenance*, since the reason a surviving structure gets the weight it gets must be backup-able rather than assigned: on the proper side the weights are the apparatus partition's own, and the chord they produce is deduced from the postulates, (Section 14.6.3); on the improper side the weight is never assigned to the cluster at all—it is read off the kernel's own cross-terms, the overlap c arriving as an output—so the only freedom anywhere in the account is the kernel itself, exactly where the Open Constructions already locate it. Definition, signature, converter, non-uniqueness, provenance: the account closes at every joint an assessor can press.

Two further notes complete the picture. First, on the post-measurement status of D: centric unfolding selects, in effect, a random proper child of the prior Aethus, and that child almost surely does not contain the peak of the prior distinguishability structure; the felt conclusion that counterfactual extractability was "only a construct" is then an extrusion violation in disguise—projecting the child's poverty backward onto the parent—whereas the prior Aethus retains its full D-structure on its own indexing, exactly as genealogical identity requires, (Section 12.4.14). Second, on erasure: measuring the marker in the conjugate basis trades which-way information for phase information, restoring conditional fringes and anti-fringes [338], and the choice may be delayed past the screen detection itself [339]—which is the ordering-indifference of the validity layer on public display, (Section 12.4.11), and the precision test of what "permanently inaccessible" must mean in the third postulate's trigger. The dichotomy deserves its slogan: the screen pattern responds to the *writing* of which-way records, never to their *reading*—to the Nexus-level pruning the coupling effects, never to the downstream partitioning a readout adds, whatever its basis and whenever it occurs. That marginal invariance is the no-signaling structure in this framework's clothes, (downstream refinements partition weights and never retroact on validity, per the validity layer's ordering indifference), and it is also the empirical certification of the third postulate's design: delayed-choice experiments display a pattern that already reflects accessibility-in-principle, before and independent of any actual readout—nature operating on exactly the postulate's weaker trigger. This, finally, is the precise point of contact with the Wood–Spekkens fine-tuning diagnosis [100, 101]: what a state-of-reality reading must register as a fine-tuned conspiracy—causal influence scrubbed of signaling—arrives here as bare structure, the ordering indifference of the validity layer.

For the reader who wishes to situate this against the literature's own debates: whether duality is "really" the uncertainty principle was fought to a standstill in the 1990s [114, 340] and later dissolved into equivalence—the duality relations are entropic uncertainty relations in disguise [341]; the multipath generalization, by contrast, remains genuinely open, with no consensus visibility measure for more than two paths—and it is worth noting that the record-partition machinery of this paper is natively n-ary, (Theorem 14), so the framework has a candidate contribution at exactly the open edge. The outstanding calculation for this framework itself remains an open construction, (Section 14.8), and has three steps: construct the joint configuration space and show the survivor under coherent marking is the single agreeing cluster; show its interior cross-term integral yields $V = c$; and define "best potential record-attribute" within the formalism and show it yields $D^\star = \sqrt{1 - c^2}$. (The framework's native resource for that definition is already on the books: the third postulate runs on the *potential* for contradiction—it fires on accessibility-in-principle, even and especially where no contradiction has yet been actualized, as the Frauchiger–Renner discussion makes explicit—which is precisely the modal sensitivity a potential-record supremum requires; the evaluation clauses for such counterfactuals are themselves fixed in Section 9.1.) The third step is where the genuinely new conceptual work lives.

The line through this subsubsection, and the bridge to the deduction. A reader evaluating how much of the physics the Aethic architecture generates on its own should be able to draw a line through everything above, and it falls here. Before the Quantum Nexus is installed the framework has: the Aethus; blankness as superposition; the agreeing and disagreeing regimes and the record supply that

decides between them; pruning, and conditioning as pruning; the record-based partition of alternatives into permanently indistinguishable classes, (Theorem 14); and, quantitatively, the chord—the classical duality frontier as the shape of the weight law. After the Nexus is installed it additionally has: Feynman path weighting over augmented paths; the coherent cross-terms; the overlap c as the visibility; and the trigonometric and Bloch-sphere structure of the two-tag statistics. Removing the axiom leaves the first list intact; installing it supplies the second. The same point read as unification: conditioning-as-pruning, (Theorem 13), showed one reduced-form machine running under two weightings, and the chord and the circle are that machine's two faces here—one record sector composed with one paths-factor, read through convex weights or through the kernel, the two faces joined by the square map $c^2 + D^2 = 1$, (the weight-grade split itself being linear in D; the deduction's ledger states the two relations apart). None of this proves the weighting axiom; the chord is what the framework has before it. Each ingredient of the deduction below draws on one side of that line or the other, and the audit at the deduction's close sorts its results accordingly. Where this sits relative to the classification theorem is the last thing to fix before the construction: Theorem 14 answers the qualitative and combinatorial question—which alternatives remain record-indistinguishable in principle, so that their cluster may stand agreeing at all—and the two-tag deduction answers the quantitative continuation, how much interference and how much record capacity remain when the marker overlap is partial. The polarized n-slit experiment next is the construction's ancestor, and the deduction after it is a check, within one experiment, that the qualitative distinction produces the quantitative geometry.

14.6.3 The Polarized n-Slit Experiment

The procedure for an n-slit experiment with absorption-type polarizers is best built from its geometric foundation upward, so let the Bloch-grade objects lead. Fix each polarizer's transmission outcome as an Aethic determinate node, the same operation the sequential-measurement treatment runs on the Bloch sphere, (Section 14.2.6, Definition 53): each slit's polarizer contributes a node on the polarization sphere the framework already imports through the Quantum Nexus, (the Poincaré sphere, on which orthogonal linear polarizations sit at antipodes and physical axis angles double [309]), and every path in the Nexus integrand becomes an augmented path—a spatial route carrying a polarization route through those nodes. The weights then come with the geometry rather than awaiting motivation: the Aethic weight of transmission at slit j under incident polarization α is the two-node overlap between the incident-polarization node and the transmission-axis node, $\cos(\alpha - \theta_j)$, and the weight of absorption is the overlap with the antipodal, absorbing-axis node at $\theta_j + 90^\circ$, which is $\cos(\alpha - \theta_j - 90^\circ) = \sin(\alpha - \theta_j)$ up to sign. The trigonometric split is thereby a direct geometric phenomenon—a projection in space, exactly as one would want—and no caveat about its origin need ever be issued.

The Aethic construction on that foundation is then the standard procedure of logical elimination. We introduce the polarizers to the system by means of the system Aethus, assigning to each slit, for the passage of each photon, a Boolean Aethic attribute designating whether passage or absorption occurred—the breaking from perfect agreeing superposition over the slits arriving through this extra "Aethic informational gate." Create the Aethic superposition of all joint states of transmission or absorption at each instance where each individual path passes through each polarizer, the node overlaps above supplying the weights, applied consistently across a path's polarizer encounters so that no re-randomization occurs. Certain joint combinations of passage versus absorption imply contradictions per the Quantum Nexus-encoded rules of polarization deduction, and such Aethae are pruned as invalid; note that because we are dealing with arbitrary Aethic weights, the law of total probability need not be satisfied along the way—that law itself being emergent from our own methodological practice as per the relational weight principle, (Principle 22). The residue from the pruning is precisely the empirical regime: either absorption occurs at given individual polarizers, or transmission occurs through them for use in the light reaching the region beyond the slits and building the intensity distribution thereon.

The standard quantum treatment now enters as the check rather than the starting point:

$$|\Psi_\alpha\rangle = \sum_j \phi_j \, P(\theta_j) \, |\alpha\rangle = \sum_j \phi_j \, \langle \theta_j | \alpha \rangle \, |\theta_j\rangle = \sum_j \phi_j \cos(\alpha - \theta_j) \, |\theta_j\rangle. \tag{83}$$

Here $P(\theta_j) = |\theta_j\rangle\langle\theta_j|$ is the rank-one projector implemented by the absorption polarizer at slit j, and the projection occurs precisely at the middle equality: acting on the incident polarization $|\alpha\rangle$, it collapses that state onto the polarizer's transmission axis, $P(\theta_j)|\alpha\rangle = \langle\theta_j|\alpha\rangle \, |\theta_j\rangle$. Each slit's contribution factorizes into a spatial amplitude ϕ_j, a scalar projection amplitude $\cos(\alpha - \theta_j)$, and a marker state $|\theta_j\rangle$; the irreversible, lossy step—the actual projection—resides entirely in that scalar

overlap, applied to a single definite input $|\alpha\rangle$ *before* any incoherent average over α is taken. And the identification is exact: the scalar that the standard treatment isolates as the entire locus of projection is nothing other than the two-node overlap with which the construction began. The correspondence extends to the pairing structure itself: where the square-magnitude expansion of the wavefunction pairs each possible combination of amplitude terms, that prospect corresponds precisely to the choice of each possible pairing of slits within an agreeing superposition as seen in the Quantum Nexus already, with the $\cos(\alpha - \theta_j)$ factor applying as the Aethic weight of the transmission attribute along each individual path.

For unpolarized incident light, define an Aethic partition of the system Aethus per the attribute of incident polarization, so that within each proper child Aethus one angle of incident polarization obtains. The system Aethus then holds, as a parent, the disagreeing superposition over all incident polarizations, which is precisely what forms the incoherent average upon intersection with the Quantum Nexus. This develops the mixed-state status of the standard formalism, but in the Aethic formalism it is merely a contingency of a disagreeing-superposition parent Aethus—nothing categorically special, its apparent privilege emerging only from how it affects the quantum system upon the total intersection.

The mechanism, stated once and in full, is therefore this: projection is the reading of an Aethic pruning residue at node grade—determinate nodes fix the geometry, node overlaps fix the weights, the informational gates fix which joint alternatives are contradictory, and the pruning of those contradictions leaves exactly the per-slit Malus factors the projector formalism books by hand. Such is the net proposal for how the Aethic apparatus ought best to reproduce the mechanics of polarization.

The account above can now be stated at kernel grade, which is where its trigonometry actually lives. The sphere carries its own kernel: between polarization states, the spin-coherent-state overlap reads $\langle n_1|n_2\rangle = \cos(\Theta_{12}/2)\, e^{i\Phi_{\mathrm{P}}}$—one object with two faces. Its *modulus* is the magnitude of every trigonometric validity factor deployed above, the Malus amplitudes $\cos(\alpha - \theta_j)$ being exactly such overlaps, sign included, and their squares the Malus transmission probabilities; its *argument* is the Pancharatnam phase in the chosen coherent-state gauge [342], gauge-dependent for a single open overlap, whose gauge-invariant content appears around a closed loop as the geometric phase of Berry [343]—which is why the pairing below, comparing two paths that share endpoints and so enclose a loop, reads it invariantly. On the augmented configuration space, the Quantum Nexus therefore factorizes multiplicatively, $\mathcal{K}(p) = e^{\,iS_{\mathrm{st}}[p_{\mathrm{st}}]/\hbar} \cdot \mathcal{K}_{\mathrm{B}}[p_{\mathrm{B}}]$, and the pairing extends to $|\mathcal{K}_{\mathrm{B}}[p_{\mathrm{B}}]|\,|\mathcal{K}_{\mathrm{B}}[q_{\mathrm{B}}]|\cos\big(\Delta S_{\mathrm{st}}/\hbar + \Delta\gamma_{\mathrm{B}}\big)$: the same pairing, $\mathrm{Re}\,\mathcal{K}(p)\overline{\mathcal{K}(q)}$, with the Bloch factor contributing a modulus, whose square is the Malus transmission probability, as well as a phase—the two together the coherent amplitude, whose sign is what separates fringes from anti-fringes—where the spacetime factor contributes a phase alone; no new machinery. The pairing's geometry deserves its plain name: the Nexus always compares *two* paths, and two paths sharing endpoints constitute a closed loop—the sense in which the Berry formulation's paths are closed, closure being what lets the pair enclose area—so the extended cosine is a loop functional, reading the loop's dynamical-plus-geometric enclosure. This is both why polarization-cycle interference at zero spatial path difference is expected rather than anomalous, and why the trigonometric factors of this subsubsection were never inserted by hand: they are the modulus face of the kernel's own sphere factor.

What "never inserted by hand" does and does not claim. The claim is that the analyzer coefficients are not measurement postulates and are not applied to the kernel after a port outcome: they are values of the augmented kernel, $\mathcal{K}_{\mathrm{aug}}[p] = \mathcal{K}_{\mathrm{st}}[p_{\mathrm{st}}]\,\mathcal{K}_{\mathrm{int}}[p_{\mathrm{int}}]$, whose internal factor is built from the per-step SU(2) qubit coherent-state kernel $\kappa(n', n) = \langle n'|n\rangle = \cos(\Theta/2)\, e^{i\Phi_{\mathrm{P}}}$ stated above—the spin-$\frac{1}{2}$ representation, the polarization sphere sharing the qubit Bloch sphere's mathematics with no claim that the photon carries spin $\frac{1}{2}$—a discrete internal path $[n_0, \ldots, n_N]$ carrying the product $\prod_k \kappa(n_{k+1}, n_k)$, which is multiplicative under concatenation as the composition law requires. The endpoint overlap is not multiplicative, $\langle n_3|n_1\rangle \neq \langle n_3|n_2\rangle\langle n_2|n_1\rangle$ in general: it is the endpoint propagator, recovered by integrating the path factor over the intermediate nodes, which is what inserting the resolution of the identity on the sphere, $\frac{2s+1}{4\pi}\int d\Omega\, |n\rangle\langle n| = \mathbb{1}$, does at every slicing in the exact time-sliced SU(2) coherent-state construction [309]—the per-step values and the endpoint overlap being one kernel under one composition law, which is what licenses placing the internal factor in the Nexus beside the spacetime one. The direct tag-to-analyzer leg of the two-tag deduction is the one-step case, where path factor and endpoint propagator coincide, $\kappa(\theta, \pm\alpha) = c_{1,2}$; and the formal continuum action of the time-sliced construction contains the Berry term, $\hbar s \int (\cos\vartheta - 1)\, d\varphi$ at $s = \frac{1}{2}$. Three stronger claims are not made. The overlap is not derived from the scalar spacetime action alone: the coherent states, their overlaps, and the resolution of the identity are supplied as internal kernel structure, as the spacetime phase is supplied. The exact short-time internal factors are not unit-modulus pure

phases, since $|\langle n_{k+1}|n_k\rangle| = \cos(\delta\Theta/2) < 1$ at finite slicing, so writing the Bloch factor per path as $e^{iS_{\mathrm{B}}[p_{\mathrm{B}}]/\hbar}$ is correct only as the formal continuum limit. Nothing in the construction needs that form: the Nexus's kernel is compositional—multiplicative along concatenated paths, weights formed as the squared modulus of the coherent sum—without requiring unit modulus of any single path, which is how the kernel law is stated, the scalar-action phase and the SU(2) overlap being two instances of one law rather than a rule and its exception. The regularized continuum construction, with its known boundary and correction terms, remains open as a separate matter. And the construction covers free propagation between optical elements, which is what the polarized constructions use; general internal dynamics under a nonzero Hamiltonian, and the continuum internal construction, remain open. What is established is what the two-tag deduction needs: one augmented Nexus supplies the coefficients, and nothing reweights afterward.

14.6.4 The Two-Tag Deduction: From the Postulates to the Pattern and the Readout

We now translate the conceptual distinction of Section 14.6.2 into the concrete experiment, and verify that it produces the quantitative geometry claimed there. The whole of what the construction is doing fits on one map, kept here so that a reader returning to it later can recover the structure at a glance:

classical random tag:	a record separates some runs	⇒	disagreeing	⇒	weights add	⇒ $V + D = 1$
coherent pure tag:	no record; markers partly overlap	⇒	agreeing	⇒	amplitudes add	⇒ $V^2 + D^2 = 1$

Three cautions keep the map exact. Before the other two: the chord row is conditional on an ideal interference model, untagged runs at $V = 1$ and tagged runs at $V = 0$ with compatible normalization and an accessible flag, the classification supplying labels and not intensity profiles, as the depaired weighting shows, where $V + D = 0$. The first row's arrow to the chord holds because the mixture is a mixture of the two *poles*, $(1, 0)$ and $(0, 1)$; weights adding over other components gives the convex hull of whatever those components are, which is the triangle of Section 14.6.2. The second row's arrow to the circle holds for *pure* markers at the optimal placement, $D = D^\star$; mixed or coarse-grained markers fall inside. And the experiment below runs *both rows at once*—weights across the two ports, amplitudes within each—so that the convex relation $c_A + c_D = 1$ stands at weight grade and the quadratic at kernel grade in one configuration, which is the section's title claim. Two relations are in play there, not one read twice: at weight grade the record sector splits linearly, $c_D = D_p$ and $c_A = 1 - D_p$ at each placement, (the total-variation decomposition of that placement's marker statistics), while the square map joins the two *faces* at the optimal placement by relating the kernel's overlap to the weight face's capacity, $c^2 + (D^\star)^2 = 1$. The polarized double slit can be walked from the postulates to both of its empirical faces—the end-analyzer readout probabilities and the screen's intensity pattern—with each step tagged by which arena contributes. Tags sit at $\pm\alpha$ from the incident polarization, (the bisector); write $c_1 = \cos(\theta - \alpha)$ and $c_2 = \cos(\theta + \alpha)$ for the analyzer at angle θ, and $c = \cos 2\alpha$ for the tag overlap. Throughout, every trigonometric factor is the Bloch face's contribution and every x-dependence is spacetime's; the elementary alternatives are their products—augmented paths, a spacetime route through one slit carrying a Bloch route to that slit's tag.

A reader from outside the formalism can track the entire deduction with a dozen terms, fixed here once.[385] A *slit* is a spacetime opening, the spacetime arena's alternative; its *tag* is the polarization stamp its polarizer imposes—the necessary polarization state for transfer, a determinate node on the Bloch sphere indexed to that slit—and the *tag overlap* c measures how alike the two stamps are. The *analyzer* is the final polarizer, read as a which-tag question; a *port* is one of its two possible answers, and each port outcome is a *record*—the ports are the branches of the disagreeing case. The *pair* is the agreeing superposition of the two tag-nodes, the object the or-pruning keeps, characterized by its *bisector*, the sphere direction halfway between the tags and hence the erasing question; the *straddle* is the analyzer angle Bloch-orthogonal to the bisector, the best which-tag question. The record's *capacity* D is how well its answer lets one guess the tag; c_A and c_D are the convex Aethic weights of the agreeing and disagreeing cases; the pair's *interior tilt* is its constituents' relative weights, Malus acting within; and *visibility* is fringe contrast, with the *per-port* pattern the screen sorted by the record and the *unconditional* pattern the screen ignoring it.

[385] One ordering also bears fixing before the vocabulary: the ontology—the augmented-path structure and its pruning—is the root of everything below, and the propositional, bookkeeping language in which this section computes is that ontology's projection, responding to the structure rather than generating it. Logic itself is another matter entirely: the framework's universe is logically realist, its pruning and its or-structure being logical operations with full ontological standing, and the language shifts this paper performs are drawn out of that logical structure precisely because the existing rules of sentential usage flatten it, (Section 3.6.9). What is derivative is the notation, never the logic.

The pair, by pruning. Determinate nodes form by the pruning of all paths that do not pass through them, and the agreeing configuration is that mechanism's or-form: the pruning keeps exactly the class of augmented paths through one slit-and-tag *or* the other, a single agreeing object whose spacetime face spans both slits and whose Bloch face spans both tag nodes, characterized on the sphere by its bisector.[386] The fundamental theorem, (Section 8), protects this object for as long as the which-tag attribute stays hidden in principle.

The record, and where the divide falls. (Here the disagreeing regime enters, and with it the first place weights rather than amplitudes compose.) The analyzer event ends that hiding by an exact amount: pass-or-block becomes a record, and the record correlates with the tag. The theorem's protection fails precisely at the record's separating capacity, so the top-level structure downstream is the disagreeing superposition over the two ports. The port weights are Bloch-face numbers alone—each slit-and-tag contributes its projection onto the port, and the weights sum per slit:

$$p_\theta \;=\; \tfrac{1}{2}\big(c_1^2 + c_2^2\big), \qquad p_\perp = 1 - p_\theta.$$

These are the end-analyzer readout probabilities, with no reference to the screen: for $\alpha = 30^\circ$, $p_\theta = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{4}\cos 2\theta$, giving $\frac{3}{4}$ at the vertical and $\frac{1}{4}$ at the horizontal.

Within each port, the pair persists, tilted. (Here the agreeing regime survives inside the disagreeing one, and amplitudes compose within each port: the quantum case differs from a classical mixture exactly because the marker states remain one agreeing cluster rather than forming record-separated components.) A pass outcome does not resolve the which-tag attribute, since both tags project onto the port with nonzero amplitude; inside each port the agreeing pair therefore stands, its interior weights tilted by the Bloch face to $c_1^2 : c_2^2$. The screen pattern assembles at amplitude grade *within* this one object—the Bloch face supplying the coefficients, spacetime supplying the x-structure:

$$I_\theta(x) \;\propto\; c_1^2 + c_2^2 + 2\,c_1 c_2 \cos\big(k\,\Delta(x)\big), \qquad V_\theta = \frac{2\,|c_1 c_2|}{c_1^2 + c_2^2}.$$

The contrast is a pure Bloch-face ratio; the stripe geometry is pure spacetime. At the bisector the tilt is even and the fringes are full; at the Bloch-orthogonal the contrast falls to c; at the anti-fringe port it returns to full with the cross-term's sign reversed. The visibility and distinguishability expressions are now two components of one normalization identity, and the quadratic duality relation is reproduced identically: with the port-normalized distinguishability $P_\theta = |c_1^2 - c_2^2|/(c_1^2 + c_2^2)$,

$$(2c_1c_2)^2 + (c_1^2 - c_2^2)^2 \;=\; (c_1^2 + c_2^2)^2 \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad V_\theta^2 + P_\theta^2 \;=\; 1$$

at every analyzer angle—the interference term standing as V_θ and the predictability term as P_θ, the two complementary pieces of one normalization, so that the quadratic relation is not another empirical input—the pure-state equality of the quadratic frontier arriving derived rather than imposed, with its global form $c^2 + (1 - c^2) = 1$ relating the unconditional contrast to the record's maximal capacity.[387] The two frontiers thereby stand together in one configuration: the quadratic at kernel grade, the convex $c_A + c_D = 1$ at Aethic-weight grade, the square map joining the faces through $c^2 + D^2 = 1$ while the weight-grade split itself is linear in D—the linear and quadratic duality relations revealed as the weight face and the kernel face of a single setup.

Across ports, disagreeing addition. (The main chain is complete; what follows is the side result that the analyzer redistributes record information between the ports without changing the unconditional pattern.) Ports are record-separated branches, so their intensities add with their weights, never their amplitudes:

$$I(x) \;=\; p_\theta\, I_\theta(x) + p_\perp\, I_\perp(x),$$

[386] Where the sphere's nodes live bears fixing precisely. The tag pair forms *at the slits*: each slit's polarizer prunes its node into existence, so the pair predates the analyzer—which is what gives the fundamental theorem something to protect. The analyzer's record later forms a *new* node per branch, the passing photon's current polarization at the port's own sphere point; and these are two attributes of two different things, the path's historical which-tag versus the photon's present state, indexed separately and never conflated. The analyzer thus tilts a pair that was already there; nothing reaches backward.

[387] Two precisions keep this result exactly what it is. The linear and quadratic relations are not one budget viewed from two angles: they are two composition laws at two grades—weights convex by the Relational Weight Principle, amplitudes quadratic at kernel grade—connected only through the square map, and holding simultaneously because they govern different faces. And the trigonometric content enters through the kernel's Bloch factor, an axiom booked as such in the Open Constructions: the identity's derivation is exact, but it is not free.

and the two ports' cross-terms sum to $2\,(c_1c_2 + s_1s_2) = 2\cos 2\alpha$. **The unconditional pattern is thereby reproduced** with visibility equal to the tag overlap c, independent of the analyzer angle—the no-signaling fact arriving as an identity rather than an imposition.[388]

The resolution ledger, riding consistently alongside. The record's separating capacity is $D(\theta) = |\sin 2\theta|\,\sin 2\alpha$, and the ledger's weights are pruning-survivors rather than parameter matches. (In plain terms, since this is the least self-explaining step: θ determines which record question the analyzer asks of the markers; at the bisector, $\theta = 0$, the question erases the tag distinction and $D(\theta) = 0$; at the Bloch-orthogonal straddle, $\theta = 45°$, the question extracts the most of it and $D(\theta)$ reaches its supremum $\sin 2\alpha = \sqrt{1-c^2}$; the tag basis itself, $\theta = \alpha$, asks a worse question, $\sin^2 2\alpha$. $D^\star$ must therefore be defined as the optimum over admissible record placements, not read off the most obvious detector basis; and the port-normalized predictability P_θ below (Greenberger and Yasin's P, a predictability rather than a distinguishability since after the analyzer no marker remains), which reaches 1 trivially at $\theta = 90° - \alpha$ where one tag is simply blocked, is a different quantity from this ensemble capacity and is not the supremum being defined.) The linear split $c_D = D(\theta)$, $c_A = 1 - D(\theta)$ is a fact about the record statistics—the coupling lemma's decomposition of that placement's two outcome distributions into a common part of weight $1 - D(\theta)$ and disjoint parts of weight $D(\theta)$—and not a decomposition of the path cluster into a disagreeing element and an agreeing pair. No such decomposition exists: were a fraction $D(\theta)$ of the weight to sit on a fringeless disagreeing element, the unconditional visibility would lie on the chord at $1 - D(\theta)$, whereas it stands at $c = \sqrt{1-(D^\star)^2}$ at every analyzer angle, the loss at the erasing angle being one port's anti-fringes canceling the other's fringes with both ports agreeing pairs. The marker statistics carry the linear split; the path cluster carries the circle; and the two are joined by the square map $c^2 + D^2 = 1$, two relations rather than one read twice. The terminology is deliberately doubled and never conflated: distinguishable-versus-indistinguishable names the record side; agreeing-versus-disagreeing is baked into the Nexus side itself. The ledger is convex over separate Aethae, admitting no cross-amplitude between its components. Its screen face is exactly the within-port pair, which is why the pair's interior visibility coincides identically with the erased port's; and the guessing protocol closes the consistency loop, $P_{\text{correct}} = \frac{1}{2}(1 + D^\star)$. The division of labor, stated once in full: the Bloch face contributes every projection, tilt, overlap, and capacity; the spacetime face contributes propagation and the fringe geometry; records set where weights add; the agreeing pair sets where amplitudes do; and the joint clusters—each slit with its tag—are the only objects either arena ever contributes through.

Why the numbers are not a coincidence: the mechanism at the grain of the formalism. A reader who has followed the ledger step may reasonably ask whether the split $c_D = D_p$, $c_A = 1 - D_p$ generalizes, or whether it is a by-hand arrangement that happens to land on the polarization example's numbers. It generalizes, and the reason is that the framework's two faces are exactly the two metrics on pairs of states that quantum information theory already relates, so that each step of the mechanism is an instance of a standing theorem. Three of them, in the order the mechanism uses them. *The weight-grade split is the coupling lemma.* For any record placement, the two tags induce two outcome distributions p and q on the placement's cells, and the total-variation distance $D_p = \frac{1}{2}\sum |p - q|$ decomposes both distributions uniquely into a common component of weight $1 - D_p$, (the overlap $p \wedge q$, renormalized), and disjoint components of weight D_p each: the maximal coupling of p and q has the two tags agree with probability exactly $1 - D_p$ and disagree with probability D_p, and no coupling does better [344]. That is the linear split of the ledger step, read off any placement at all, and it is a statement about the two outcome distributions and not about the state; the supremum over admissible placements, $D^\star = \sup_p D_p$, is the trace distance $T(\rho_+, \rho_-) = \frac{1}{2}\|\rho_+ - \rho_-\|_1$ of the two marker states, which is Helstrom's theorem [337], the optimal discrimination succeeding with probability $\frac{1}{2}(1 + T)$. Nothing in this depends on the markers being polarizations, pure, or two-dimensional. *The kernel-face visibility is a purification overlap.* In the augmented-path picture the marker is entangled with the path and the joint state is pure, so the cross-term that the kernel weights the agreeing cluster by is the overlap of the two marker branches as they sit inside that one pure state—an overlap of a particular pair of purifications of ρ_+ and ρ_-. By Uhlmann's theorem the fidelity $F(\rho_+, \rho_-)$ is the maximum of such overlaps over all purifications [345, 346], so $V \le F$ in general and $V = F = c$ when the markers are pure, which is the case the deduction ran. *The square map is Fuchs–van de Graaf.* The trace distance and the fidelity of any two states satisfy $1 - F \le T \le \sqrt{1-F^2}$, with the upper bound attained exactly when both states are pure [347]; so $T^2 + F^2 \le 1$ always and $T^2 + F^2 = 1$ for

[388] The identity form is a statement about *where* the fact arrives in this assembly: at the same level as everything else, no special machinery consulted. Standard quantum mechanics likewise possesses no-signaling as a theorem; the contrast is one of derivational placement, not of possession.

pure markers. Combining the three: $V^2 + D^2 \leq F^2 + T^2 \leq 1$, with equality if and only if the markers are pure—which is Englert's relation [333] derived from the general geometry of state pairs rather than from the example. The "square map joining the faces" of the ledger step is therefore not a phrase but the Fuchs–van de Graaf bound saturated, and the framework's division of labor—weights on the trace-distance side, amplitudes on the fidelity side—is the division that bound is a theorem about.

Two consequences follow for the plane itself, and one boundary. The disk's interior is convexity again: a proper mixture of pure agreeing pairs with overlaps c_k at weights w_k has unconditional visibility $\left|\sum_k w_k c_k e^{i\phi_k}\right| \leq \sum_k w_k c_k$, with ϕ_k the components' fringe phases and equality only when those phases and the components' normalizations agree, and capacity at most $\sum_k w_k \sqrt{1 - c_k^2}$, (the trace distance being convex), and by Cauchy–Schwarz a convex combination of unit vectors $(c_k, \sqrt{1 - c_k^2})$ has norm at most one—so every mixture lands inside the circle, filling the disk, by the same convex weights that put the classical random tag on the chord when the mixed objects are the two poles. That is the whole plane from two ingredients, the pure circle and convex weights, each of which the framework already owns. The boundary is the number of paths: the coupling lemma's decomposition is a pairwise fact, and for three or more mutually non-orthogonal marker states the maximal coupling is no longer a pairwise object, while the multipath duality relations of the literature take correspondingly different forms [348]. Which of them the mechanism reproduces, and whether the sorting extends beyond pairs without a new ingredient, is the "extension beyond pairs" the reframes below already list as open, now with its obstacle named.

The reader's derivation, boxed. At this point the derivation must be split into what the framework has generated and what it has imported, and a navigation device helps before the audit. It is not a substitute for the deduction above; it is the deduction's skeleton, readable on its own.

Reader's derivation

Classical random tagging (weights compose; no kernel):

$$D = p, \qquad V = 1 - p \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \boxed{V + D = 1}$$

Coherent pure tagging (amplitudes compose; kernel overlap c):

$$V = c, \qquad D^\star = \sqrt{1 - c^2} \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \boxed{V^2 + (D^\star)^2 = 1}$$

Port-wise, in the concrete experiment (one normalization identity):

$$(2c_1c_2)^2 + (c_1^2 - c_2^2)^2 = (c_1^2 + c_2^2)^2 \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad V_\theta^2 + P_\theta^2 = 1$$

Interpretation:

disagreeing / mixture ⇓ weights add	agreeing / coherent ⇓ amplitudes add

What the deduction has bought, sized once. The significance was stated at full size before the construction, (the landing at Section 14.6.2), and the deduction adds to it only the receipt: with the analyzer algebra behind them, the three claims of increasing strength now stand verified rather than announced—the qualitative distinction between jointly surviving and record-separated alternatives, drawn by what is written into them; the quantitative pair of shapes, the chord from convex splitting and the circle from coherent overlap; and the interpretive reading of the complementarity relation's *shape* as a fingerprint of how alternatives compose. What is not claimed should be said as plainly: not a prediction of $V^2 + D^2 \leq 1$, which every interpretation inherits from the shared formalism as this one inherits it through the kernel, but the mapping of the agreeing/disagreeing distinction onto the two composition regimes already visible in the phenomenology, with the chord as the one piece generated without the kernel; a stronger result would derive the remaining ingredients—the in-formalism definition and optimality of D foremost, and the kernel itself—and their status is the audit's business.

The audit of derivational responsibility. Each result of the deduction, with its immediate source in the framework and its status, so that no conditional, imported, or open item reads as a theorem:

Result	Immediate source in the framework	Status
$V + D = 1$ (the chord)	convex decomposition of the agreeing and disagreeing sectors, Relational Weight Principle	framework-native; deduced at Section 14.6.3, kernel-free
$V = c$	coherent marker overlap under the Quantum Nexus, the kernel's own cross-term	kernel-dependent; the axiom booked at Section 14.8
$D^\star = \sqrt{1 - c^2}$	optimal discrimination of the two marker states, the record-placement supremum	standard result used here; the informalism definition and optimality theorem conditional, the Open Constructions' item
$V^2 + (D^\star)^2 = 1$ (pure)	the algebraic identity combining the two	conditional on the preceding two rows, exact given them
$V^2 + D^2 \leq 1$ (general)	mixed or coarse-grained coherent tagging	standard general case, as framed here; not re-derived
$V_\theta^2 + P_\theta^2 = 1$ (port-wise)	one normalization identity of the port quantities	identity of the displayed construction
no-signaling under analyzer choice	the ports' cross-terms summing to $2\cos 2\alpha$	identity of the displayed construction; a placement result, possessed by every interpretation
the weights $c_D = D_p$, $c_A = 1 - D_p$	the coupling lemma on the marker statistics at placement p, not a decomposition of the state	derived from the postulates, given the capacity

Read down the third column, the deduction has exactly one framework-native quantitative result, the chord; one kernel-dependent result, the overlap visibility; one imported result, the discrimination bound, whose in-formalism derivation is open; and three identities of the construction. That is what the deduction claims, and it is all it claims.

14.6.5 The Reframes Collected, and What Remains Open Beside Them

The audit just given sorts the deduction's *results* by derivational responsibility. This one does something different and complementary: it collects the *conceptual reframes* the construction rests on, each with the open residue it leaves, so that the two inventories together answer both of a reader's questions—which results are owed to what, and which ideas are doing the work with what still unfinished beside them. The reframes are few, and collecting them in one place fixes where the open problems actually sit.

1. *Nodes by pruning, and the pair as its or-form.* Determinate nodes are never posited; they form by the pruning of all paths not passing through them, and the agreeing pair is that mechanism's or-generalization—prune all paths not passing through one node *or* the other. Its significance is the measurement problem's oldest question exchanged for a tractable one: *when does collapse happen* becomes *where does pruning leave residue*—a question with a computable answer in every setup above. (The deduction above; no residue.)

2. *Arena generality.* Spacetime and the Bloch sphere are treated as isomorphic up to the Quantum Nexus, neither privileged: the double slit is the same or-law's spacetime instance. The dividend is portability: one deduction, run wherever the dictionary reaches, (the generalization suite of Section 14.6.7). (The frame paragraph; the open residue is breadth—extending the treatment to general spin dynamics, higher-spin systems, and further internal arenas.)

3. *The grade order.* Augmented paths sit as close to the axiomatic layer as the construction gets; the slit-to-node-collection indexing is bookkeeping for the two faces; node existence is emergent. What the ordering buys is a discipline: nothing downstream can quietly promote bookkeeping to ontology, because every object's grade is fixed on entry. (The frame paragraph; no residue.)

4. *The layer doctrine.* Aethic weights compose convexly by kind, (the Relational Weight Principle); only the kernel sources Pythagorean structure, below the square map—which is why the linear duality frontier was deducible while the quadratic is kernel work. Its reach has since been upgraded by the two-wing construction: the doctrine now stands as the candidate Tsirelson principle of Section 14.6.9—convex-native weights, fed only through the square map, proposed as what bounds every correlation at $2\sqrt{2}$—with a fully worked saturating instance beneath it and its general theorem booked open there. (The deduction's ledger paragraph; the open residue is

the weight-transfer expansion inside the powerset formalism, presently at sketch grade, together with the general quantum-set question named in Section 14.6.9.)

5. *The Berry-grade kernel and the loop reading.* The Bloch factor contributes to the kernel precisely as much as the Berry phase concept does usually, and the Nexus pairing's two endpoint-sharing paths constitute the closed loop whose enclosure the extended cosine reads. The significance is that geometric phase stops being an import: the loop was in the pairing from the start, so polarization-cycle interference is expected structure rather than added structure. The hosting geometry is worth naming: the Bloch sphere's Berry connection is the Hopf bundle's natural connection, so the fiber illustration that opens active reasoning, (Section 14.7), reaches for the very object this kernel already inhabits—one structure met twice. (The kernel-grade passage above; the open residue is the Pancharatnam–Bargmann check—deriving the pair's geometric invariant from the kept class and matching it to the kernel products.)

6. *The interpolation law.* The general analyzer angle realizes a convex weighted combination of the agreeing and disagreeing cases, the agreeing coefficient maximal at the bisector and the disagreeing at the Bloch-orthogonal straddle. This is the framework's answer to complementarity's slider: not a principle about an experimenter's knowledge, a coefficient pair about standing structure. (Derived in the deduction; the open residue is generality—collections beyond pairs, and the maps and rotations deferred by design.)

7. *The divide from the fundamental theorem.* The disagreeing case forms exactly where a record's separating capacity breaks the theorem's protection—the divide deduced, never installed. The dividend is an invocation retired: "does which-path information exist in principle?" stops being a criterion consulted and becomes the theorem's own breaking condition, (the emergence ledger's second entry below). (The deduction's opening; the residue is shared with item 4.)

Against this inventory, the open problems of the construction are three and named: the weight-transfer expansion, the Pancharatnam–Bargmann check, and the extension beyond pairs—each a determinate task beside a standing reframe, none a gap in the deduction already given.

The complementary ledger is what the standard procedure inputs by hand, or leaves mysterious, that emerges here from the pipeline. First, the projection at the polarizer: the standard treatment *applies* the rank-one projector by fiat, the irreversible step residing in that scalar overlap—here the tag-node is never applied but *formed*, by the system-Aethus pruning, the projection being the pruning's output. Second, the rule for when amplitudes add and when probabilities do: standardly a criterion invoked informally, ("does which-path information exist in principle?")—here it is the record structure itself: records make branches whose weights add; the surviving pair adds amplitudes; and the record's capacity fixes exactly where the line falls. Third, the readout-probability rule ceases to be a second postulate: the port probabilities arrived as the disagreeing summands' Aethic weights under the one Nexus weighting that runs everything else, with no measurement-specific axiom consulted. Fourth, the basis that branches: not preferred by hand but generated—the record selects it, the same selection story the consistent-histories confrontation develops. Fifth, the complementarity tradeoff: not introduced as a principle but falling out as algebra of the derived quantities, at every angle. Sixth, the no-signaling consistency of the unconditional pattern: an identity of the across-port sum rather than a check performed after the fact. And the honesty clause that keeps the ledger a ledger: the kernel weighting itself and the realization principle do *not* emerge here—they are the standing Open Constructions they always were, consumed by this deduction exactly as booked.

Where the weight of these results falls also deserves explicit statement, because the outcomes are not of one grade. Highest stands the *referent identity*: the agreeing pair's interior pattern, computed from the Aethic side alone, equals the erased-port conditional pattern exactly, at every analyzer angle—an unlooked-for coincidence between an Aethic object and a standard statistic, which is evidence of a joint rather than of a fit. Beside it stands the *two-grade structure*: the explanation of why the linear duality frontier was deducible while the quadratic is kernel work—a question the standard formalism cannot so much as pose, having only one composition law where this framework has two. Third, the anchor: the disagreeing maximum was dictated before it was derived, the derivation then landing on the stated coordinates at the Helstrom value. The no-signaling cancellation, by contrast, is consistency at placement grade. Standard quantum mechanics possesses the theorem too; what the assembly adds is the mechanism's name, *redistribution*: the record redistributes the pair's coherence between its branches, the two ports' cross-factors summing back to the slit-set overlap by the cosine-subtraction identity, so that the analyzer present-but-unread is indistinguishable from the analyzer absent—which

is exactly why no choice made at the analyzer can reach a screen-watcher who lacks the port records. A reader collecting a single result from this section should collect the identity; the cancellation is the deduction's cleanest line, not its deepest. One further outcome now belongs at the top of this grading: the layer doctrine's standing, per the two-wing construction, as candidate principle for the boundary of the quantum set, (Section 14.6.9)—graded candidate rather than theorem, and held there deliberately.

14.6.6 The Deduction Retold Concretely

For the reader who wants the concrete explanation[389] rather than the scaffolded one, here is the whole thing again, slowly, with almost no special vocabulary. A photon is fired at a barrier with two slits.

[389]An interesting thing I want to explicitly mention is that one of the abilities which has served me well during the Aethic reasoning derivation, (such as in the August 22, 2022 entry), is my being able to, under very limited visibility, describe the intuitive shape of the solution with enough specificity that I can actually go uniquely derive it from those constraints. What's particularly interesting about my use of Claude Fable on July 2, 2026, is that I, upon getting a rough idea for how there's a bisector and orthogonal-bisector configuration at play, realized that I should probably be directly relaxing the pruning constraint on the Bloch sphere to, say, two determinate nodes. So while I don't know how to say *how* I saw this, what I can say is that I felt it to "be the only thing that would make the bisecting nature make sense", as itself runs on my prior intuition that the Quantum Nexus ought not to privilege spacetime or the Bloch sphere over one another. The truth of the matter is that it's something about how my at-the-time limited understanding of WHAT triggers the D interfacing with my slightly more thorough understanding that the tags on the Bloch sphere are really just determinate nodes to begin with. The interesting thing about this, however, is that July 2nd was the first time I was undergoing this age-old process WHILE I had the high-level Claude at my fingertips. So what I decided to do was feed the constraints themselves into Claude and see if it could complete, given its unlimited database of human knowledge, the second lap of carrying these constraints to physical theory. Here's my exact message sent to Claude Fable, for context. (Although this single message didn't do it, since after that I had to proceed with several rounds of clarifications and error corrections, dropping moves which it itself called "elegant" as unifications, essentially).

- *2026-07-02T14:21:50.381437Z*

  Right, potential measurements, but only as concern the geometry of the Bloch sphere anyway? One instinct I have is that if I used a coherence plate polarizer double-slit experiment, right, so all the same interference pattern, but I used different polarization measurements at the end, then technically the different polarization measurements themselves give disjoint determinate nodes anyway to the alternative measurements, right? But I suppose if we wanted to construct the Aethus for which the measurement themselves are in disagreeing superposition and then look over that, then maybe that could capture in an Aethus system the same "counterfactual possibility" status that D is trying to get at, perhaps? But yeah regardless, my instinct anyway with various types of probability amplitude-quantum superposition is that under the relevant basis measurements, you get metaphorical "shaded regions" or whatever where an agreeing superposition of the particles over two separate states remains permanently-uncertain, pretty much! So my instinct for this optimal thing is that it has something to do with a choice of measurement basis that lets an agreeing superposition arise in something intermediate, while the other measurement basis doesn't. However, still I'm not familiar enough with WHAT this optimal thing is actually being sampled from to identify it clearly!

- *2026-07-02T14:41:35.696774Z*

  I mean right, what I meant about the "shaded area" was that there's some underlying quantity which we either place into agreeing superposition or disagreeing superposition (themselves as two options), and the optimal-D itself gives is maximum agreeing superposition as opposed to disagreeing superposition. So based upon this plane construction you just mentioned, my feel is that we might somehow want a way to put the marker states themselves as the subject in question: look at the Quantum Nexus terms for which they are agreeing versus disagreeing, and then rather than simply killing only the agreeing or only the disagreeing, the way the pruning operates per the further cosines (as if a kind of two-stage Aethic intersection where we multiplicatively decompose the Quantum Nexus into the spacetime-paths and Bloch-paths parts, with the total being "the actual" Quantum Nexus due to basically treating its paths as sort of like state-augmented-combos of all possible "species" of paths) gives you a linear combination of these two states themselves, perhaps! Per how intensity patterns themselves are then simply related to the average interference pattern in each single-state Aethus of the relevant disagreeing superposition, then maybe we could try to decouple the "intensity pattern" object from these particular compositional-Aethus composing objects, simply because we need not case-by-case combine them anyway so long as it's two-stage randomness or something of the sort! That seems like the most intuitive explanation to me of why we would possibly favor the bisector itself--because in some respect that gives you the highest weight for the preserved agreeing superposition not between the paths in spacetime which go through both slits, but between whether the SLITS themselves are in agreeing superposition over both polarizations! So, sort of like the GHZ concept, what we then get from such an agreeing

Over each slit sits a polarizing filter: anything passing the first slit gets stamped with a polarization tilted thirty degrees one way, anything passing the second gets stamped thirty degrees the other way. Far downstream sits one final polarizing filter at some angle of our choosing, and behind it, the wall where photons land.

Before anything asks about the stamp, nothing in the universe has recorded which slit was used—and by this framework's fundamental theorem, that means the two possibilities are not two histories waiting to be disambiguated but one standing object: the photon's passage exists as both-routes-at-once, a single agreeing superposition spanning the two slits and the two stamps together. Nothing here is metaphor; the framework means it as bookkeeping fact, and the wall is about to price it.

The final filter is where a permanent fact first appears: each photon either passes or is blocked, and

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superposition is not only that each slit can occupy BOTH such polarization locations on the Bloch sphere, BUT per the square magnitude aspect we're actually pairing over different such realizations of the slit being one versus the other! So yeah, as I was hoping, the Bloch sphere itself, when treated as just another path regime, I think helps illustrate a kind of synonymous nature with the spacetime path-limited Quantum Nexus!

- *2026-07-02T14:51:06.723369Z*

  Very exciting, thank you! Also did you outline the whole thing thoroughly enough, such that a reader has more than enough information to make the assessment? (And also, I want to circle back and check whether this finally gives a clean Aethic account of proper / improper mixed states, right?). For example, I want to make sure the REASON the pruning of the agreeing superposition over the markers getting the weight it gets is backup-able. But yeah I think you're one step ahead of me in terms of writing up the technical substance behind my concept, so in that sense you can indeed confirm that there's alignment there? (Ie I can infer that you can because you knew to flip the agreeing and disagreeing axis, effectively!). But yeah looking good, altogether hopefully? How much can we verify, as you said you could already?

- *2026-07-05T15:08:37.877716Z*

  Ok for Q1) right I was considering the possibility that it could be Bloch orthogonal instead of orthogonal, which conceptually checks out I think so long as we get the peak we want at the bisector. Just the key is that I want to make sure we DERIVE this rather than just supposing it directly and stuff! I think what you're saying is that we can indeed derive the c_D formula there, which is good. However the c_A = 1 - c_D would then be quite an odd formula lol--not impossibly odd--just something needing motivation-checking! Does this indeed fit the empiricism if we follow it through? What I will say is that it definitely does not CONTRADICT my intuition, which focused on the bisector center plus "flanks", so yeah there's that. Q2) In order to see if I "accept" it, I would need to see both the Aethic fundamental theorem-breaking side of the disagreeing superposition, AND the quantitative-reproduction side in detail! Q3) I want to check what that concept is actually saying--I would be a bit more skeptical of an equivalence class-treatment of the Bloch sphere or something (although maybe it's possibly equivalent to my idea). The specific intuition I got for that is that Aethic pruning when it comes to determinate nodes literally makes the nodes by existing by PRUNING ALL PATHS WHICH DO NOT PASS THROUGH THE NODE. So, my intuition here is "we pruning all paths which do not pass through node A or node B", instead of all nodes proper. So it's like an "or-generalization" quite similarly actually to the powerset invalidation theorem proper, in a way!

- *2026-07-05T15:13:45.884519Z*

  Also for Q3, note that this draws exactly from the same general property in spacetime as well (not just the Bloch sphere, in that we're basically trying to fundamentally treat either as isomorphic up to the Quantum Nexus and Aethic reasoning--so neither is "privileged") where for an agreeing superposition, we start to allow paths which go through "slit A OR slit B" per a single agreeing superposition object! So this or mechanism isn't special for the Bloch sphere, it's just a fundamental property of constrained agreeing superpositions of closed-paths!

- *2026-07-05T15:31:18.311662Z*

  Ok cool, as for the other two questions, my idea is that we can probably deduce the disagreeing case directly FROM the Aethic fundamental theorem (which itself is deduced from the postulates, of course) as basically a quick way to get the disagreeing-agreeing-divide. This being said, what do you still need my verdict on about the from-postulate deduction, if I'm understanding you correctly? Thanks! Also have you explained the pipeline derivation all the way to the empiricism thoroughly enough in-paper for this case? Indeed we are now able to get the intensity pattern through use of weighted-averaging the patterns provided by the agreeing and disagreeing cases, right??? Where are we still left in terms of establishing the novelty, also? Maybe the work itself hits that mark already, and if so please outline for me where in particular.

that outcome is a record. Records genuinely split reality, so from here on there are two branches—the passers and the blocked—and the size of each branch is computed by adding each slit's compatibility with the filter's angle. Point the final filter straight up, with the stamps at plus and minus thirty degrees, and the arithmetic says three-quarters of the photons pass and one quarter are blocked. That is the readout probability, obtained before the wall is even consulted.

Now sort the wall's photons by that record and look only at the passers. Passing did not settle which slit was used, because both stamps had some compatibility with the filter—so within this branch the both-routes object survives, merely leaning toward the slit whose stamp better matched. Leaning or not, it is one object, and one object's routes combine the deep way—their contributions adding first, the squaring coming after—which is what produces interference stripes; the better the filter's angle is for guessing the slit, the fainter the stripes in the sorted pile, and the framework's arithmetic makes that trade exact—the famous duality equations are nothing but this trade written at its two levels, the fractions level and the deeper amplitudes level.

Finally, ignore the record altogether and look at every photon on the wall, passers and blocked together. Here something quietly remarkable happens: the final filter's angle drops out of the total completely. Add the two sorted piles and the angle-dependent parts cancel against each other, the peaks of one branch's stripes falling exactly where the other branch's valleys lie—by nothing fancier than the cosine subtraction formula—leaving a fixed pattern set only by how alike the two stamps were. Turn the final filter anywhere you please, or unbolt it from the table entirely: a person watching only the wall, without access to the pass-or-block records, sees the identical unchanging pattern. The filter never destroys or creates the stripes' total; it only *redistributes* them between its two branches. And that is the whole of why this apparatus cannot send signals: no choice made at the filter can reach someone who lacks its records.

What should be carried away from this, stated plainly. First, the sorted stripes and the surviving both-routes object are not two phenomena but one thing under two descriptions—the physicist's conditional statistics and this framework's surviving pair are identical, angle for angle, and that identity, not the no-signaling cancellation, is the section's deepest result. Second, there are two kinds of adding, and the universe never confuses them: genuinely separate outcomes add like fractions, while one object's own routes add the deeper squared way—and the two celebrated trade-off equations are those two kinds of adding, each seen at its own level. Third, nothing here reaches backward in time: the final filter leans an object that already existed; no history is rewritten. And one distinction is worth carrying away precisely. Logic is central here in the strongest sense available: quantumness

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- *2026-07-05T22:49:58.892046Z*

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  Very cool, thank you!  Ok so given this, one other explicit idea I now want to finally tie in is
  that my vision is not for "c_D to match D" by-hand, but rather we basically get that in some way
  the Aethus of D A_D + (1-D) A_A is being multiplied into the Quantum Nexus, such that specifically
  the A_D Aethus intersects with the agreeing superposition case in the Quantum Nexus and prunes it,
  whereas the A_A case intersects with the disagreeing superposition case in the Quantum Nexus and
  prunes it.  So, as usual, the idea is that the "getting what we get" comes out as emergent from
  the pruning!  This actually was the main thing from the earlier derivation that I wanted to pass
  along to this one, and now I have the specificity to name where to input it:  the agreeing and
  disagreeing superposition are weighted as they are not BECAUSE they match the parameters in some
  sense, but because only one split-portion of that relevant Aethus makes either survive and stuff!
  Thanks!

  Oh and also, A_D is "distinguishable" while A_A is "indistinguishable", not to be confused with
  disagreeing and agreeing, which are actually encoded/baked into the Quantum Nexus side itself!  And
  yeah, the way I would specifically put it is all three of the system Aethus describing the setup,
  the "case" for the photon we're looking at Aethically (also queued by the Quantum Nexus since
  photons are described by quantum mechanics), and the Quantum Nexus pertaining to agreeing versus
  disagreeing superpositions of paths in either arena have to remain jointly valid for the non-pruned
  cases, hence why the system Aethus itself might not invalidate certain cases, but the specific
  case-by-case implication of what the photon is broadly doing WILL. Thanks!
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So altogether, basically what I would describe as having happened here is that I did the same intuitive move as the August 22, 2022 journal entry, except I had Claude carry the intuitive constraints to fruition for me—hence making prose that even I didn't follow to begin with (since I even as of the writing of this (July 6, 2026) have no idea what a "proper versus improper" mixed state is—all I know is the full Aethic pipeline of using the Quantum Nexus to morph agreeing superpositions across Aethae, as if probabilistically classically if you will—being itself uniquely motivated by the desire to make the Feynman path integral compatible with the Aethic postulates!). There is of course the general AI-content debate about whether it's even advisable to push content online that you haven't worked out *the full* kinks of, (and even with Fable, where it tends to butcher it is exactly where you would expect—interfaces between things that are obvious outside the literature but fragmentary within it), so the reason I went through with it was because I thought "well at this point, since I've gotten essentially zero readers over three years and counting anyway, all these paper versions I keep dropping to change the landing of a sentence or two is basically archaeology". Hence, the record tells a story anyway, and I can always go fix screw-ups in the next nine hundred versions! Cheers, void!

itself—superposition, interference, the whole inheritance of logical antirealism—enters this framework not as a primitive but as a circumstance, something that happens inside a logical ontology once the right logic is recognized, the one that sentential usage flattens. That is the paper's central theme in miniature: quantum mechanics is not explained by new physical furniture but *situated*, placed inside logical ontology as a resident, its strangeness being what blanks and validity look like from within. What is derivative is the language: the sentences and notational shifts of this paper are drawn out of that logical-ontological structure—shifts precisely because the existing rules of usage flatten what the structure holds—so the descriptions respond to the universe; they do not legislate it.

14.6.7 Beyond the Polarizer: The Same Deduction in Other Arenas

The deduction above is tested by what ports, and an audit finds exactly one polarizer-specific ingredient: the dictionary between the physical dial and the sphere, (polarization's Poincaré sphere doubles the physical angle; a spin's Bloch sphere does not). Everything else—the node indexing, the or-pruning, the record capacity, the cross-pruning, the two-cut assembly—is written in sphere-native angles and never mentions light. The ports, then, at their grades.

Spin-1/2 which-path marking. Stern–Gerlach tags rotated by β carry overlap $c = \cos(\beta/2)$, and every sphere-native formula above holds verbatim; only the dial-to-sphere dictionary changes. *Internal-state labels in atom interferometry.* The micromaser which-way and the Ramsey-type readouts [113, 114] are the same structure with atomic internal states as the tag nodes and the readout pulse as the analyzer; the eraser-spectrum data already cited are the standing oracle. *Asymmetric incidence.* Sources off the bisector add the factors $\cos(\beta \mp \alpha)$ to the per-route amplitudes and rerun the assembly unchanged—a parameter case, not a new one. *Polarization cycles.* The phase face is covered by the pairing's loop form: the extended cosine reads the enclosure, reproducing the classic geometric-phase law for cycles at zero spatial path difference.

The substantive case is *imperfect marking.* Let the tagging succeed with probability η and fail—no which-path imprint—with probability $1 - \eta$: the preparation is then a proper weighted Aethus, the framework's home object, and the machinery composes with nothing added. Per component the deduction runs as above; the total capacity composes by the relational-weight convexity to $D(\theta) = \eta\,|\sin(2\theta)|\sin(2\alpha)$, whose maximum $\eta\sin(2\alpha)$ is exactly the trace-distance value $\frac{1}{2}\|\rho_1 - \rho_2\|_1$ of optimal mixed-state discrimination—the Helstrom anchor generalizing on its own. The unconditional visibility composes to $V = (1 - \eta) + \eta c$, (nonnegative throughout, the tags here sitting within the quarter-turn), and the ensemble obeys

$$V^2 + D^2 \;=\; 1 - 2\,\eta\,(1 - \eta)\,(1 - c) \;\leq\; 1,$$

strict whenever the marking is genuinely mixed. The standard mixed-marker inequality is thereby not only reproduced but *located*: the equality holds per kernel-pure component, and the deficit is entirely weight-grade, the convexity gap of mixing across cases. Where a framework that privileges pure states must handle mixedness as degradation, this one meets it as native structure—and the inequality's two-grade anatomy, equality from the kernel and shortfall from the weights, is the layer doctrine giving the textbook bound an address. Collections beyond pairs remain deferred, as inventoried above.

14.6.8 The Index Ally Principle, and the Singlet Derived

Where sphere-structure carries a distinguished axis—a *grain*—the framework's own cases show what licenses it. The two-tag setup is the paradigm: the $\pm\alpha$ nodes are indexed to the slit polarizers, spacetime-face devices. A source whose parent carries angular momentum along an axis, or sits in a field fixing a quantization direction, emits pairs whose grain is inherited from a spacetime-face fact, itself record-sourced. Real pair sources make the point operational: down-conversion produces its pairs through a crystal whose optic axis is literal spacetime-face structure, the emitted polarization carrying the crystal's grain—and the laboratory's grainless state is routinely *manufactured* by compensating that grain away, so the distinction drawn here is an experimental workflow before it is an ontology. Partially polarized sources carry grain at degraded magnitude, the weighted case, composing by the convex ledger exactly as the imperfect-marking treatment above.

The pattern in the cases is the principle. Structure held by one arena is *borrowed* structure: every legitimate grain is a loan against an indexer in the other arena—a device, a field, a crystal, a preparation record—and carries a covariance obligation, (rotate the indexer and the grain must rotate with it, which is the transfer criterion read as an experiment, and what compensation practice confirms daily). The bar, stated once and symmetrically: **no arena may hold structure the other misses**.

The offense is not that the Bloch sphere would carry something spacetime lacks; it is one arena holding what its counterpart cannot index, and the statement reads identically with the arenas exchanged. Call this the *Index Ally Principle*: arena-structure exists exactly where its counterpart indexing does, unindexed structure being barred as a privileging offset between arenas that the Nexus, ranging over both without preference, has no ground to sustain.

The singlet is the principle's forced case. An isotropic source indexes no axis: its spacetime face is direction-free, no record anywhere supplies one, so any grain in the emitted joint structure would be unindexed—structure on no collateral—and the principle prunes every grained candidate. The surviving joint two-node pair is the grainless one, and grainlessness selects uniquely: the symmetric candidates form a family that rotations expose, while exactly one joint pair is the same object from every angle. The interior sign follows by two-axis consistency: written in axis $\mathbf{n}$ and again in axis $\mathbf{n}'$, the antisymmetric combination is one object, while the symmetric candidate acquires aligned components with coefficient $\sin(\Theta/2)\cos(\Theta/2) \neq 0$ and fails to be anything in particular across axes. The minus sign is derived, not chosen. One grainless rival remains formally available and falls to the same principle: the fully mixed, disagreeing candidate. A disagreeing structure stands only where a record separates its summands, and the isotropic source's premise is exactly that no such record exists—the indexer set is empty—so the mixed candidate is unindexed structure of a second kind, its *split* unsourced where the grained candidates' *axis* was, and the same clause prunes it. The agreeing pure pair is the only candidate left standing.

And the classical origin story inverts. With the antisymmetric structure derived, same-axis anti-correlation with certainty follows for every axis at once—which is the conservation law's entire phenomenology, arriving downstream. Conservation does not explain the singlet here; the singlet, forced by counterpart indexing, explains why the conserved bookkeeping never fails. The isotropic source thus emits the one structure it is permitted to: nothing in the derivation consults dynamics, and the only inputs are the arenas' parity and the emptiness of the indexer set.

14.6.9 The Tsirelson Bound at the Paper's Convention

The question of the Tsirelson bound becomes well-posed once the kernel is partitioned out as the booked axiom it is, and at this paper's convention—the same grade at which the measurement-problem criteria are met, the kernel and the realization principle consumed exactly as booked—the bound derives in full *for the two-wing singlet configuration.* The construction is the two-tag deduction run on two fibers at once.

The two-fiber configuration. Two wings, each an augmented path with its own Bloch fiber; the source prepares the joint tag structure. For the singlet-type source, the source structure is the joint agreeing pair over opposite-node configurations with antisymmetric interior—the joint or-pruning keeping paths through $(+\mathbf{n}, -\mathbf{n})$ *or* $(-\mathbf{n}, +\mathbf{n})$ as one object—*derived rather than stipulated*: the Index Ally Principle forces grainlessness for the isotropic source, and two-axis consistency forces the sign, (Section 14.6.8). Each wing's analyzer is a record, so the top-level structure downstream is the disagreeing superposition over the four joint ports, and the joint Aethic weights are the square-map images of the joint kernel amplitudes—each amplitude a two-term coherent sum of products of per-wing overlaps, nothing but the kernel axiom applied fiber-wise.

The correlation, and the wings' independence. Carrying the overlaps through the square map yields the joint weights, and with outcomes valued ± 1 the correlation collapses to

$$E(\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}) \;=\; -\,\mathbf{a} \cdot \mathbf{b} \;=\; -\cos\theta_{ab},$$

the cosine law, derived rather than assumed: the kernel supplies the overlaps, the square map alone converts them to weights, and the record structure fixes where weights add. Each wing's marginals are one half regardless of the other wing's setting—the two-tag redistribution identity generalizing wing-wise, which is the extrusion principle's promise arriving as algebra: no choice of basis on one wing reaches the other's statistics.

The bound, in three lines. For settings $\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{a}'$ and $\mathbf{b}, \mathbf{b}'$, the CHSH combination is

$$|S| \;=\; \left|\mathbf{a} \cdot (\mathbf{b} + \mathbf{b}') + \mathbf{a}' \cdot (\mathbf{b} - \mathbf{b}')\right| \;\leq\; \|\mathbf{b} + \mathbf{b}'\| + \|\mathbf{b} - \mathbf{b}'\| \;\leq\; 2\sqrt{2},$$

the last step because the two norms have squares summing to four. Equality is attained at the standard 45° spacings, so the framework does not merely respect the bound; it saturates it. What the excluded region above $2\sqrt{2}$ invites is a conjecture rather than a corollary, and the distinction deserves care: each *individual* Popescu–Rohrlich entry, $E = \pm 1$, is perfectly achievable by squared overlaps, and what fails

is the *joint* four-setting pattern—a global consistency fact that the present two-wing computation does not reach. The layer doctrine is accordingly offered as a *candidate* Tsirelson principle: that the weight face, convex-native and fed only through the square map, can never assemble the joint pattern that exceeding $2\sqrt{2}$ would require. Its general theorem—quantified over all fiber dimensions, sources, and assemblies—is a named open item, and it enters a standing program rather than a vacuum: the question is Popescu and Rohrlich's [349], information causality recovers the bound on slices of the problem [350], and the almost-quantum set survives essentially every principle yet proposed [351]. What the present section contributes to that program is what candidate principles mostly lack: a fully worked, saturating instance with the principle's machinery underneath.

The ledger, kept. Consumed: the kernel, as booked, and the realization principle where outcomes actualize; the singlet source structure, formerly a datum, arrives derived, (Section 14.6.8). Emergent: the four-branch structure, the joint weights, the wing-marginal independence, the cosine law, and the bound for this configuration. Named residues: the general multi-fiber lattice, filed with the collections-beyond-pairs deferral, (the present construction uses two single-pair fibers and trespasses on neither); and the general quantum-set question—whether the layer doctrine, quantified over all admissible Aethic configurations, bounds every correlation at $2\sqrt{2}$.

14.6.10 Kochen–Specker as Doom: Contextuality at the Paper's Convention

The Tsirelson bound of the preceding subsection is a weight-grade result: it says how much joint weight the four ports of the two-wing configuration can carry, and it is reached only once the kernel has been consumed as booked. The Kochen–Specker theorem [352] is the same refusal one grade down, at the tags, and it consumes nothing of the kernel beyond its zeros. This subsection derives it from the postulates in the vocabulary the two-tag deduction fixed, and states what the framework's take on contextuality then is.[390]

Observables as attributes. A projector P is an attribute with two pegs, 1 and 0; a context is an orthonormal basis, a maximal set of commuting projectors, and measuring it is a record in the two-tag deduction's sense: the analyzer separates the basis elements, and the top-level structure downstream is the disagreeing superposition over them, the first row of the map, with the Born weights as the square-map images of the kernel amplitudes. Relative to that record, the basis elements are the equivalence classes of Theorem 14: a coherence claim over a proper subset of a basis element is the second-postulate invalidation, and a joint claim across two of them is the third. That is contextuality's raw material, and none of it is new. What the theorem adds is a statement about the attributes across contexts, and for that one bridging lemma is needed.

Lemma 9 (Structural zeros are tags)
In the physical instance, a joint alternative whose kernel amplitude is zero for every preparation is a jointly invalid combination of the attribute space: a tag of the relation structure, not a weight of any state.

Argument. The kernel is consumed as a booked axiom, and what it fixes for every preparation at once is not a fact about any preparation but about the attribute space the preparations range over: a zero that no state can lift is an exclusion the space carries. The record discipline places it. A joint alternative that no preparation realizes is one that no record, in any refinement of any Aethus along accessible records, can separate as co-obtaining; by Lemma 7 read in the negative, the joint stated-attribute holds of no alternative of the attribute space, and a content asserting it is a contradiction of subsubsection 3.4.2's kind, a tag. The state-dependent zeros are another matter: an amplitude that vanishes for one preparation and not another is a weight, and stays one. The lemma is the physics-face reading of the relation structure's tags, and it is the step a reader should check.

The Kochen–Specker relation structure. Take a Kochen–Specker set of projectors, Cabello's eighteen vectors in dimension four [353] serving as the concrete case: nine orthonormal bases of four, every vector lying in exactly two of them. Two families of joint alternatives carry structural exclusions. For orthogonal P and Q, the alternative $\{P = 1, Q = 1\}$ has amplitude zero for every preparation, $PQ = 0$; for a complete basis $\{P_1, \ldots, P_4\}$, the alternative $\{P_1 = 0, \ldots, P_4 = 0\}$ has amplitude zero for every preparation, $\prod_i (1 - P_i) = 0$. By Lemma 9 both are tags. Within one basis these tags say exactly one projector takes the value 1, which is the powerset theorem's classification restated; across bases they are the constraints the theorem turns on.

[390] This subsection was drafted by Claude Fable 5.1 on 2026-09-25, at the author's request, from the derivation the author asked for after the regimes-as-content reading of that day (the footnote at the fixed-point construction's declared descent). The one step it takes beyond the postulates' existing use is Lemma 9, and it is marked as such.

Noncontextual value-definiteness, as an Aethus. The hidden-variable reader's demand is that every projector of the set have a definite value at once, the same value in every basis that contains it. In this paper's vocabulary that is one Aethus, C, holding the single-peg carving of every projector in the set: each attribute carved to its determinate states, and each projector one attribute, its record its own yes-or-no, whatever is measured beside it. Noncontextuality is not an extra premise here; it is attribute identity, one attribute per projector. Under declared descent as the regimes-as-content reading states it, C's declared descendants are its joint settings, one peg per projector.

Proposition 31 (Kochen–Specker as doom)
For any Kochen–Specker set, the Aethus C that carves every projector of the set is invalid by the third postulate, whatever the preparation.

Proof. A joint setting of C is a function from the set to $\{0, 1\}$. For the eighteen vectors, a setting untouched by the tags would give each of the nine bases exactly one 1, nine in all, an odd count; but each vector lies in exactly two bases, so the count over bases is twice the number of vectors set to 1, an even number. No setting escapes both tag families, so every joint setting of C holds a tagged combination and is itself tagged. C holds a carving each of whose settings is tagged, so by the splitting rule of closure, doom being the tag once the regimes are content, C is tagged: every declared refinement of C is invalid, which is the third postulate's condition, and no weight has entered beyond the structural exclusions. The general Kochen–Specker set differs only in the combinatorics that rule out the setting; the theorem supplies it. □

What is valid instead. The filling. Every projector's pegs stand on the table, true in the relational sense and none affirmed, and the set is carved only where a record grants access, one basis at a time: the second row of the two-tag map where no record separates, the first row where one does. So the framework's take on contextuality is this. Values are not context-dependent; affirmations are record-relative, determinacy being two-place, and no record carves the whole set, the global carving being doomed. The thing the hidden-variable reader wanted context-free, a value for every projector, is exactly the doomed content; the thing that is context-free, the filling, is not a valuation. A contextual valuation, one value per basis, would split each projector into per-basis attributes, and the framework does not need the split, since it never holds the global carving; whether such a split is forced or merely available is a question left open, and this subsection leaves it there.

One refusal at two grades. Beside the Tsirelson bound the picture is complete. In the two-wing configuration the global carving is not tagged: each joint setting of both wings is a valid pocket, and what fails is the weight, no admissible valuation over the joint settings reproducing the four ports' marginals once the bound is exceeded, which is the reductio. In the Kochen–Specker configuration the global carving is tagged outright, state-independently. Both are the refusal of a single sample space, which the paper carries as a structural commitment rather than a preference: at weight grade it is Bell, at tag grade it is Kochen–Specker, and the smallest instance of the tag-grade case is the double slit of the finite model, the fringes carved being jointly invalid with the path carved.

14.6.11 Correlation as Weight, Causation as Structure: The Re-Rendition, Corrected, and the Tense-Free Substrate

The re-rendition of the distinction between correlation and causation, developed at the author's direction from the reading recorded at the Egan item, that causality is the relation structure of invalidity, is stated here in its corrected form.[391] Three structures of an Aethus presented as a product of entries have to be distinct: the *factor graph*, which families share a graded entry; the *exclusion structure*, which combinations the relation structure tags, symmetric and carrying no order; and a *mechanism history*, when the Aethus has one, which mechanisms take which families as inputs, directed and normalized. Correlation is weight, a dependence in the soft parts of the entries. But the connection a correlation forces runs through the factor graph and not the exclusion structure, a strictly positive correlated entry having an empty hard part; and direction is the mechanism history and not the order of inquiry, commuting updates being makeable in any order and an earlier event recordable later than a later one.

The representation. What hard invalidity and weight together do express is every exclusive-regime state: an Aethus in disagreeing superposition presented as a product of entries is the pruning, by hard

[391] Drafted by Claude Fable 5.1 on 2026-09-26 at the author's request and corrected the same day after a referee's counterexamples, which are reproduced here. Its first version read causation off zero sets and the order of updates and claimed Reichenbach's principle in full; that reading is withdrawn, and this subsection records what replaces it.

compatibility constraints on an enlarged attribute space with one mechanism blank per entry, of a product of independent weights on those blanks, the original recovered by marginalizing them out. That is the re-rendition in its defensible form, a representation theorem. It carries no causal structure: the representation is not unique, the retained mechanisms are in general dependent, some mechanism assignments admit no state, and nothing in it is directed, so it has no intervention semantics; a functional model assigns every endogenous value from every background assignment and has the independence of its background variables as a property, not as a representation. Direction and intervention are the settling theorem's, which assumes a mechanism history and establishes a correspondence with causal Bayesian networks rather than deriving their direction. The classical readings, a direct arrow, a mediating chain, a common cause, a common effect whose entry touches both correlates and so separates nothing, are read off the mechanism history in that correspondence, and no short exhaustive list is claimed. What is derived is the statistical screening structure associated with Reichenbach's principle in the exclusive regime and the interventional and counterfactual correspondences given a mechanism history; causal common ancestry is not derived from the factor graph and the exclusion structure, and in the agreeing regime no skeleton clause holds, since factor dependence there does not imply structural exclusions, and where the two-wing statistics violate the CHSH bound the Bell reductio excludes a global exclusive representation of the specified kind. Dependence and causal structure are linked only under faithfulness-type assumptions: a zero in the marginal support forces dependence, but a mechanism touching both correlates need not, $B = A \oplus U$ with independent fair bits being a classical causal path with no correlation, and the agreeing regime adds cancellation at the amplitude level, the dark fringe, as a further route to the same thing.

The tense-free substrate, and the conventions of precedence. Nothing in the exclusion structure is temporal, blankness here being tense-free by the indiscriminate time principle of subsubsection 2.3.3 and the Extrusion Principle, and direction being a structure the framework consumes rather than derives. The classical conviction that causes precede their effects in proper time is therefore a further commitment, itemized as: (K0) that a specified functional model is supplied, mechanism entries with their input sets, which counterfactual evaluation needs, not uniqueness among the models compatible with the observations; (K1) temporal alignment, that the mechanism history's direction agrees with proper time, an additional assumption and not a consequence of records following their events, motivated by the record asymmetry, which on subsection 11.2's account is the Boltzmann arrow, emergent from centric unfolding, statistical, relative to the unfolding Aethus, indiscriminate across history by the Indiscriminate Arrow of Time Principle, and an accessibility gradient steep for entropy-reliant attributes and shallow for low-entropy ones such as the Moon's orbit (subsubsection 12.6.1), so that the convention reads a statistical, observer-relative gradient as a categorical alignment, and where the gradient is shallow, an eclipse predicted before it happens or a predictor's record of an act not yet taken, the mechanism history has the orbital state or the agent's makeup as input to both and the reading is a common cause; (K2) that blanks read tensed, which the tense-free reading refuses; (K3) that agency is the model, what the export carries being the mechanism input structure the agent's settling assumes; and (K4) that the composition primitive is oriented, the kernel of subsection 14.3 composing one way and records sitting at nodes, which is the composition axiom's stated content and never the exclusion structure's. Where all of these hold the classical picture is right on its own ground; where (K1) fails, at the predictor and the delayed choice, the classical vocabulary produces paradox from a substrate that contains none.

14.7 Opening Move of Active Reasoning

Allow me now to name what I call the opening move of active reasoning[392], being the moment at which we diverge from the Quantum Nexus as it exists under the Aethic umbrella and begin to produce a separate research program with separate questions.

Principle 55 (Opening Move of Active Reasoning)
The opening move itself consists of two steps, which I first articulated in my journal[393] *by April 9, 2024.*

1. *We might imagine that our universe is "actually" not a spacetime in the first place, but rather follows an entirely different set of rules. Perhaps we choose to name this space "active space", (being the namesake of "active reasoning" like how the Aethus is the namesake of Aethic reasoning). We then may notice something remarkable: given that the Quantum Nexus and Aethic reasoning themselves recast the entire dynamical content of our universe*[394] *as depending solely on the choice of Lagrangian and the placement of determinate nodes per Aethic pruning, we now are able to reproduce the full empirical content of all such physics by defining a transformation,*

$$(\text{Lagrangian}, \text{Spacetime}) \mapsto \left(\widetilde{\text{L}}\text{agrangian}_i, \text{Active Space}_i\right), \tag{84}$$

with the index i ranging over the candidate active spaces, and for which each point in spacetime corresponds to a well-defined subspace of active space, and we now enforce that determinate nodes are limited to corresponding to such subspaces without partitioning them in place of determinate nodes having to correspond to single-spacetime points. The remarkable thing about this is that our choice of spacetime versus active space itself now becomes something of a gauge freedom, and the reason deserves stating slowly, because it is the hinge of the entire program—as revealed by the concept of determinate nodes in the Quantum Nexus under Aethic reasoning. Determinate nodes are the exact hinge[395] *on which discriminations between points in spacetime become non-arbitrary.*

[392]I also want to just list some of my active reasoning coinages, that way this can be said early:

- **Centrade**: My term for determinate nodes in the context of active reasoning, and especially the dimensionality of space. As in, "center of trade". I'm hesitant to call determinate nodes this in Aethic reasoning however, because centrades are meant to hold the connotation of the geometric-obligation-upon-the-ontology end (as in, whatever the underlying geometric ontology of the universe contingently decided for us), whereas determinate nodes are simply the emergent production of pruning over the Quantum Nexus anyway—a purely Aethic effect. Fundamentally I tend to use them in instances where they represent a kind of redundancy or transformational fixed point in active spaces.
- **Rotrade**: I retired this term at least twice so far, but I keep it in my back pocket for anything Hopfian. It's meant to be the connotation of "space around the centrade" as opposed to "space indexed by the centrade" each time I use it! So, mapping onto twistor theory [354] for instance, centrade is more the 2-spheres identifying single spacetime points, whereas the space of directions around them, should it be rendered structurally, is more rotrade. But then again, in past iterations I would have called the 2-spheres identifying the spacetime points "rotrades" and the vertices of Feynman diagrams "centrades", (should such vertices be interpreted as special cases of some kind of underlying ontological circumstance with Aethic pruning, that is, as if Aethic pruning running on some deeper operable thing—the centrades—rather than the vertices being categorically unique. Note that I'm not advocating for this treatment specifically, as that's premature, just it's me messily scrubbing the possibility space, hence why I have a public written Aethic paper but not yet an active reasoning one!).
- **Centron**: A single one of the two paths used in the Quantum Nexus, but rendered as whatever actual ontological "object", physically speaking. So, again circumstantial-ontology-side rather than Aethic pruning-side!

[393]Note that my original articulation of this was not yet as abstract as the current iteration, which allows for multiple candidate active spaces. The original version was a proposal for a specific kind of active space, such that we have just the same principle of Aethic uncertainty enforcing empirical equivalence to spacetime. What specifically enabled the higher move in abstraction was when I created the fuller treatment of determinate nodes per finally comprehending the Bloch sphere sufficiently to do so around February 9, 2026.

[394]At least, pertaining to what can be deduced from the Feynman path integral, so namely that does not include the Einstein field equations just yet.

[395]This also has to do with something I've been emphasizing in my active reasoning writings since 2024: *as far as I'm concerned Feynman diagrams are not actually spacetime*, (my informal term for what they actually *are* being "exoempirical space"), in the sense that determinate-node-mediated-agreeing superpositions become so unconstrained there that their strangeness is very likely an artifact of trying to write them up as if a microscale-continuation of spacetime proper. I am especially interested in the anti-symmetry of fermions as a possible tie-in to this: that itself appears to be something emerging from the current convention for how we label particles in spacetime, but like a knot could perhaps be undone as simply as sliding those commitments across the metaphorical table such that they separate.

To be clear, by the way, the least ad hoc move remains to allow this onset to "strangeness" to occur so well before the Planck scale, that the Planck scale might as well remain irrelevant to that onset—which is similar to my philosophy that "if string theoretic compactification were real, then already we should have a specific derived parameter which it fixes the value of"—if you will "quality inductive reasoning is the casting of scrambled commitments to an answer",

Walk the inference chain in the only direction it actually runs: we never observe spacetime directly; we observe the dynamical transfer of matter, and from that transfer we indirectly infer that an extended arena exists for it to happen in. But within the Nexus recast, what mediates the dynamical transfer of matter is precisely the displacement between determinate nodes—paths in agreeing superposition span the gaps between nodes, and the nodes are all that anchors them anywhere in particular. So every operational discrimination between one spacetime point and another bottoms out in node structure, and nothing else in the inventory is available to do that work. Whatever carries the nodes therefore carries the spaciousness; the arena was never load-bearing on its own. Should we create an active space for which we infer that its exact structure of submanifolds to which determinate nodes can indivisibly correspond is the quotienting defining spacetime points, then all of a sudden our dynamical theory of matter is equivalent to the spacetime alternative as soon as we choose to attach determinate nodes to such spacetime-pertaining submanifolds. The determinate nodes themselves are the hinge standing between spacetime being perceived as having dimension four versus dimension zero, (in that if the entire universe was a single agreeing superposition, as if "all points were determinate nodes", then no longer would a sense of spaciousness exist in it at all, as all agreeing superpositions exist and no longer can determinate nodes discriminate points so as to emergently reproduce that spaciousness per use of constraining the dynamical motion of matter quanta).

Fundamentally speaking then, this gauge freedom of sorts allows us several choices of active space, so the true ontological decision becomes which choice creates either the simplest or most unified Lagrangian corresponding to that active space.

2. *We also then open up an entire new field of questions for the research program, namely including "what Aethic uncertainty principles in active space enforce the indivisibility of determinate nodes beyond special classes of submanifolds anyway?" The Aethic postulates themselves do not care or discriminate ontology based on the source of an Aethic uncertainty principle—they merely relay that uncertainty principle to agreeing superpositions—so we now open up the ability to ontologically perturb the active space, so we can ontologically perturb the submanifold classes, so we can ontologically perturb the fundamental character of what sources the Aethic uncertainty, so ultimately we can attain the bottommost nomological-categorical-ontological nature of the active space, in the process hopefully unifying different corners of the standard Lagrangian whose distinctness itself relies on the contingency of spacetime over active space.*

   It is in exploring the dynamical-side formulations of arbitrary Aethic uncertainty principles[396] *that I hope to realize the fundamental "alternative forms of mechanics" concealed by the universe within them, as if inferring a category of mechanics to each category of uncertainty principle—all themselves reliant on how you conventionally choose to cut the full uncertainty principles into individual categories, which is why the "ideal" end outcome might look an awful lot like unscrambling a mess of categorical commitments across uncertainty principles into a sort of "topologically equivalent"-like single idea. The ultimate hope is that once such a theory-valued transformation is articulated such that running it on the uncertainty principles returns the unified mechanics, then running just this same unscrambling transformation on the standard model Lagrangian might yield something interesting to take its place. This is all just brute gesturing at this stage though, of course.*

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so we get that since compactification yields no unique substance in QFT, we get a contradiction with my statement's contrapositive requiring the compactification attach to such an earlier commitment. The most you can push it in my mind and get away with it is having the substance be invisible within a regime but show itself across regimes (like an event horizon-Feynman diagram consistency argument), but compactification is not present for this as well, because even if it applies to a singularity, we don't exactly have a measurement of a singularity, now do we?

[396] Again, as pertaining to what fundamental circumstances produce them, rather than anything at all having to do with there being a fundamental Aethic uncertainty primitive. That they satisfy an Aethic uncertainty principle is a constraint that may be used to simplify the possibility space for discovering them, but as far as they are concerned is perhaps not to result as nomologically significant—we just happen to find ourselves in the universe in which a special geometric prospect interfaces with the Aethic postulates to produce the empirical physics we see, so we may expect going in via the constraint of that outcome that there will exist an underlying geometry which does not care to be sculpted by the Aethic postulates ontologically, all while it very well might be sculpted by them inferentially—we just happen to have initiated our understanding of physics with a starting point that had to inferentially run through spacetime, so of course the hole in our understanding of active space will match up with the contingencies about spacetime that we do not yet realize to be contingencies.

14.7.1 The Hinge, Refined: Nodes as Survivors, and the Dimensionality of Appearance

The list above plants three themes—that spacetime points are a quotient of active space's submanifolds, that determinate nodes are the hinge between the arena's appearing four-dimensional and its appearing zero-dimensional, and that the choice among active spaces is a gauge freedom—and the author's notebook entry of September 9, 2026, (reproduced in full at Principle 59), develops each of them past where the list leaves it. The developments that do not depend on any account of gravity belong here, since this is where a reader first meets the themes; the gravitational ones are kept with the speculative program they serve, (Section 14.7.3).

Nodes survive; they do not produce. The list describes the determinate nodes as what constrains *the dynamical motion of matter so as to reproduce spaciousness, and the phrasing invites a reading on which the nodes generate the constraint—as if a node were a source that imposes structure on the arena around it. The refinement is to withdraw that reading. The nodes are not producers of the constraint; they are what* survives cancellation more strongly *than anything else in the arena. On the Nexus's own mechanics an agreeing superposition sums over its paths with phases, and the sum cancels almost everywhere; what does not cancel is what stands as a record, and a record is what the framework calls a node. So the node is the residue of a cancellation rather than the cause of a constraint, and the fibers of active space—which on the opening principle simply are the indivisible agreeing superpositions—control curvature as before, with the nodes now understood as the fibers' surviving structure rather than as an independent input to them. The difference matters for what one looks for: not a mechanism by which nodes act on the arena, but the conditions under which a fiber's cancellation leaves a residue.*

Records along sections, and the dimensionality of appearance. The hinge remark says that a universe of pure agreeing superposition would have no spaciousness, and one in which every point were a node would have it fully. The refinement says how many dimensions the appearance has, and why. Suppose the arena is of higher dimension than spacetime, and suppose that any detector—any device that gauges which-path information—can do so only on its local tangent space, along sections that are distinct in the quotient giving classical spacetime. Then the agreeing superposition is partitioned only along those sections; along every direction perpendicular to them no record can be laid down, so those directions stay open forever relative to every Aethus; and the arena appears *to have exactly the dimension along which records can be taken.*

Principle 56 (Agreeing-Superposition Dimensionality Principle)
The dimension physical space appears to have, relative to an Aethus, is the dimension of the sections along which which-path records can be laid down; every direction of the arena along which no record can be taken remains in agreeing superposition relative to every Aethus, and does not appear. Spaciousness has the dimension of recordability, not of the arena.

This is the hinge with a number attached. It is also the joint variation of the Maximal Principle of Active Reasoning, (Principle 58), in its most concrete instance: a richer agreeing regime, a muffling that hides exactly its extra layers, and the empiricism of three-dimensional spaciousness as the invariant the pair must return. Whether the quotient along which records can be taken is the same quotient the field equations see is the question the gravitational program asks, and it is left there.

Two projections, and what a record can fix about a pair. The quotient of the list, read with the refinement, is one of two projections. The other is the Quantum Nexus kernel, whose object is not a point of the arena but a pair *of paths by the Dual Path Principle, (Principle 51), so that the kernel cannot be a second quotient of the same kind—a quotient map has nothing to say to a pair. What the framework can say about the pair without any gravitational commitment is what a determinate node can fix about it, and the Dual Path Principle licenses the question. A node is an or-region of the quotient together with its tangent data, (Definition 53); so a record at a node can fix, of a pair of paths, that both map to the same quotient point there and that their passage directions map to the same quotient tangent direction there, and nothing else. Between nodes the two paths are unconstrained in their quotients, and whatever the kernel weights them by is the imprint of their passage through the arena rather than through the quotient. That is as far as the refinement goes without the gravitational program; the program's use of it is at Section 14.7.3.*

In the meantime while I run through further attempts to perturb the ontology of active space for this research, as might be rather obvious already, I think the current leading contender for an "ideal" active space currently lies with Penrose's twistor space [354–356] itself. Perhaps the noteworthy thing about this entire active space program is that it relays the situating as fundamental of determinate nodes from the Quantum Nexus to a sudden "indiscrimination theorem" between something like twistor space versus spacetime as being more "physically real". Given that determinate node placement is all that makes

spacetime physically prior, and given that this privileging can be perturbed away by creating the right determinate nodes in twistor space—specifically the submanifolds therein corresponding contingently to spacetime points—then based on such no longer is there any objective reason to assume spacetime is more fundamental to begin with, even and especially in matters of "its being actually physically real" in some kind of artificially-imposed intrinsic-spaciousness sense per our inclinations as human primates.

So, to be clear about the implications of this, in the example of the Hopf fibration[397] where a 2-sphere is the base space and the fiberd 3-sphere is the total space, the opening principle of active reasoning states that we ought to interpret that the fibers themselves simply *are* indivisible agreeing superpositions[398] over determinate nodes, in the sense that should a determinate node exist in the total space, then the constraint that it ought also to occupy in agreeing superposition every extruded point along the fiber is equivalent to the perception of the base space allowing determinate nodes at single points. This itself opens up questions as far reaching as even quantum particle worldlines being agreeing superpositions, and so on. In fact, my original inspiration for the active reasoning idea in 2024 was to imagine how if our universe was actually higher-dimensional, but our own space was simply extruded within it in agreeing superposition, then we would empirically only notice as many dimensions as are the total minus the dimension of each independent agreeing superposition manifold. This was my "dimension principle of active reasoning". Interestingly, this also led me to the idea that if our spacetime cross section at every point along the extrusion were identical, then we could never notice the existence of the extra dimensions—however if there were in fact subtle differences, then we could use them to infer the extra dimensional structure of active space. In a classical spacetime picture alone, however,

[397] Funnily enough, after I had this intuition about agreeing superpositions reducing experienced dimensionality, one day in early 2025 (although the intuition itself was pure 2024) I was on the phone with my dad trying to explain this idea of mine. Basically I was saying "I'm thinking that every point is actually a circle, but you don't realize it because you yourself are extruded along it in agreeing superposition. So we classically try to think of light as being the wavy thing while the background space is rigid, but what if it's actually that the space itself is the trippy thing while the light is just moving simply within it like a leaf in the breeze—and feeling with the dark fringes of an interference pattern whatever weird overlapping-restrictions the intermediate space hits as if itself constraining it." Weirdly enough, this is strikingly similar to the concept of a fibration, just with perhaps an especially-ontological framing atop it! I should also note for the record that I attempted formalizing this geometric intuition several times over, and the farthest I got was the idea of making the x and y axes of a 2D space each have a phase component—yet as you can imagine what I found irritating about this is that it seemed to imply a privileged x and y direction for which being along one zeroes out the other. So, although I had a solid intuition just coming out of pure inference from Aethic reasoning, still it's interesting that I couldn't actually land the formalization step—when I did accidentally come across Hopf fibrations in late 2025 and got my socks blown off, I saw clearly where my original reconciliation itself was undershooting the real substance of the concept. So yeah, I'm better at one thing than the other thing is what I'm saying!

(What follows is an AI-drafted unpacking, commissioned by the author to record this footnote's connections in the reviewing model's own words, literature ties included.) Each piece of the phone call has a standing address in the literature, and the pattern of the misses is as instructive as the hits. "Every point is actually a circle, and you are extruded along it" is the Kaluza–Klein picture nearly verbatim [357, 358], the correspondence mapped at Section 14.7.2, with the agreeing-superposition reading supplying what Kaluza–Klein calls the zero mode. The inversion—light moving simply, "like a leaf in the breeze," while the space carries the strangeness, the dark fringes reading as the light *feeling* the arena's overlapping restrictions—is the fiber-bundle account of quantum phase stated as ontology before the geometry was in hand. Dirac's monopole put the physics on exactly this bundle first [359], (the monopole bundle *is* the Hopf fibration); Aharonov and Bohm exhibited fringes that shift while nothing local touches the electron's path—the interference pattern feeling the bundle's holonomy, the space-side structure, precisely the leaf's dark fringes [360]; Wu and Yang made "the space is the trippy thing" rigorous, gauge fields as nonintegrable phase factors—geometry of the arena rather than dynamics of the mover [361]; and Berry's phase, identified by Simon as the holonomy of exactly such a bundle [343, 362], is the same lesson at kernel grade, where this paper's Bloch factor already lives, (Section 14.6). And the failed formalization failed for the right reason, which is the part worth preserving: a phase component per axis is a *product* structure—a trivial bundle with a chosen splitting—and the privileged-direction irritation was correct mathematical instinct detecting the triviality; the Hopf fibration [363] is the removal of exactly that defect, the circle woven through S^3 so that no global splitting exists and no direction is privileged, which is why the late-2025 collision read as the intuition's missing half rather than as a competitor. The arc—operational intuition first, articulation resisting formalization, the standing mathematics then recognized as the structural stage of the same idea—is the two-stage shape this paper records elsewhere, run here in miniature.

[398] This also, interestingly, entirely reframes the "reason for existence" of gauge transformations over the spinor fibers. Instead of being "because the phase is unphysical" it becomes "because whatever is the true source of the Aethic uncertainty over the fibers must hold as a valid Aethic uncertainty principle—which we infer because the fibers' having to become agreeing superpositions so as to reproduce spacetime's dimensionality enforces by the Aethic fundamental theorem contrapositive that the sourcing uncertainty principle must hold—therefore the lack of gauge transformations themselves holding would open the ability to distinguish between the fibers, which contradicts the uncertainty principle's having to be present: so as a proof by contradiction whatever sources the Aethic uncertainty principle that gives the fibers itself means the gauge transformations cannot have sufficed as a loophole, so altogether the gauge transformations exist and therefore electromagnetism has to in some form exist".

So, concisely speaking "gauge invariance, hence the phase is unphysical" turns to "the phase must be unphysical (on Aethic-dimensional grounds), hence gauge invariance".

perhaps they would be interpreted merely as quirks of the Lagrangian not yet explainable from first principles.

Here, then, is the proposed shape for the unscrambling of the Quantum Nexus into a formulation of active space.

Principle 57 (Fundamental Principle of Active Reasoning)
The fundamental research commitment of active reasoning is to recognize that because spacetime has been defined by induction from the macroworld with its extreme application of Aethic pruning to the Quantum Nexus, then the following two premises are in effect.

1. *There should be a "rawer" form of spacetime—referred to as active space—under which we deduce a reformulated nature of kinematics targeting systems of exclusive agreeing superpositions in the maximum absence of Aethic pruning. The final formulation at the end of this Aethic reasoning paper reproduces the empiricism of quantum mechanics jointly from the concept of spacetime and the Quantum Nexus integral—with the integral being decomposed into the Feynman kernel and Aethic pruning behavior. Active reasoning's goal is now to take this joint theoretical result, and reformulate it instead as the joint result of combining active space with Aethic pruning.*

   *In short, the theoretical substrate jointly produced by spacetime and the Quantum Nexus (**spacetime-Nexus formulation**) are now instead argued as being truly ontologically produced jointly by active space and Aethic pruning proper (**active-Aethic formulation**).*

   The two sectors, stated once explicitly. What the active-Aethic formulation makes explicit is a division that the spacetime-Nexus formulation left implicit and that governs how the kernel may be sought. The Aethic postulates are logical in substance—indexing, blankness, pruning, and the jointness of or—and their branches run wherever there are information states: the counterfactual semantics, decision theory, the anthropic wing, the quantum wing. The kernel is kinematic in substance: it is the arena's own report, the geometry of active space showing through, and it is present on exactly one of those branches. The two sectors meet at one door only, the agreeing superposition, which does not produce the arena but toggles visibility into it—an agreeing cluster is the logic's way of leaving a region of the arena undeclared, and what the kernel then weights is the arena's structure over that region. It follows that "derive the kernel from the Aethic postulates" is not an open problem but a category mistake: the two are as separate as a logical principle is from a general-relativistic metric, and a metric is not derived from a logic but unveiled by the physics it governs. That is why the kernel's derivation is assigned to active reasoning and nowhere else, and why its mode of discovery is geometric unveiling rather than logical closure. It also fixes the order of generality that the quantum wing tempts one to invert: probability, the weighting of disagreeing alternatives, is the general structure and runs on every branch; probability amplitudes are what that weighting looks like when the arena is the thing weighted, a special case tailored to one branch's behavior, (the polarization lemma of Section 14.3 making the subordination exact). Probabilities remain supreme, and the amplitude is the arena's bookkeeping.

2. *The key, though, is that our expectation is for the active-Aethic formulation to reveal the spacetime-Nexus formulation as fundamentally "cluttered" in how it crosses the streams between factors traceable to the active versus Aethic components. That is, there ought to be major properties normally attributed as foundational to the nature of spacetime which actually are partly sourced from active space but partly a consequence of excessive disagreeing superpositions—and targeting exactly these failure modes of defining spacetime is perhaps the fundamental target of the entire active reasoning program.*

   In essence, because we historically defined spacetime in the first place from the perspective of the macroworld, where Aethic pruning is excessively widespread, the expectation is that the "rawer" active space itself is to be most distinguished from spacetime in the sense that much of what we innately attribute to the structural physicality of spacetime is actually a conceptual flattening on active space which emerges only in the special case of excessive Aethic pruning of agreeing superpositions. (And, particularly pruning of the relevant attributes and context as wired through the fundamental theorem of Aethic reasoning as opposed to pruning generally or pruning otherwise defined naively).

Crucially, the nature of active space is alien to the nature of spacetime, but when jointly re-combined with Aethic pruning these differences are to drop out anyway—that is as the re-introduction of disagreeing superpositions causes active space to emergently approach the spacetime empiricism as a

special case. So the fundamental constraint is that the limiting case of active space for fully-constrained agreeing superpositions is spacetime itself, at least up to arbitrary empirical inference even if not precisely as a like mathematical object. That is, something about introducing disagreeing superpositions precisely flattens the structural differences of active space as compared to spacetime. The Feynman kernel in the Quantum Nexus becomes our one, fleeting hint into active space un-pruned, (despite itself already necessarily being extremely deep into pruning due to its concerning an agreeing superposition island in our world's contextual ocean of disagreeing superpositions), so it and the quantum Lagrangian is our fundamental launchpad from which to induce the entire unconstrained nature of active space.

So, in total, if there is an aphorism for active reasoning, it is this: spacetime when you peel back[399] the disagreeing superpositions is an alien world where every point becomes a topological universe[400].

The opening move makes the choice of arena a gauge freedom, and the freedom has a precise shape that deserves its own statement before the method built on it is named. The empiricism is invariant not under a change of the agreeing kinematics alone, nor of the record structure alone, but under a *joint* change of both: enrich the agreeing regime's structure, and craft the disagreeing structure—the records, the muffling—so as to hide exactly the added layers, and the empiricism is unchanged. The opening move is the first instance: a trivial agreeing regime together with the spacetime disagreeing process yields spacetime, and a richer active space together with a disagreeing structure crafted to hide its extra layers yields the same spaciousness, the two pairs being empirically indistinguishable and the choice between them the gauge freedom. Whatever one adds to the agreeing regime, one hides with a corresponding addition to the record structure; the invariant is the pair's output, never either member. The method that goes with the freedom is the author's, and he has named it.

Principle 58 (Maximal Principle of Active Reasoning)
For a given setup, the disagreeing structure—the records, and what they hide—is already fixed by the setup. The principle is to fix the kinematics to the corresponding fully unhidden agreeing regime*: the maximal agreeing regime that the setup's own disagreeing structure would muffle into exactly the observed empiricism. The kinematics is therefore not read off the empiricism directly but* reverse-engineered *from what the disagreeing structure hides, in two steps: identify, from the record structure, which layers of the agreeing regime are being hidden; then define the kinematics on the regime with those layers restored, under the constraint that reintroducing the records complementarily returns the empiricism as an invariant. The disagreeing regime is thereby never the arena's description but its muffling; the kinematics belongs to the unmuffled regime; and a setup's records are read as the map of what they conceal.*

Three remarks fix the principle's standing. It is the two-sectors ruling of Section 14.3 turned into a procedure: the postulates are logical and the kernel kinematic, so the kinematics must be defined where the logical sector has not yet acted—the maximal agreeing regime—and the logical sector's pruning is then applied as the last step rather than the first. It inverts the usual order of the standard presentation, which begins from the recorded empiricism and works inward toward a kinematics that must be reconstructed from beneath the records; the maximal principle begins from the record structure as a map of what is hidden, restores it, and treats the empiricism as the check rather than the premise. It makes the invariance usable: since every setup fixes its own muffling, the principle picks out, from the gauge family of (kinematics, muffling) pairs that agree on the empiricism, the one member in which the muffling is the setup's actual record structure and the kinematics is whatever that structure was hiding. And it carries a selection criterion for what remains underdetermined. Restoring the hidden layers does not fix the agreeing regime's concepts uniquely—several shufflings of those concepts may cancel against the same muffling at the empiricism—and among the shufflings that cancel, the principle

[399] So, perhaps the central question one asks oneself while engaging in active reasoning is "what more becomes uncovered kinematically when switching an attribute from disagreeing to agreeing superpositions?" Quantum mechanics itself is the case of switching from open paths to closed paths on the action order of $\hbar$, so naturally that begs the question of what other regimes throughout physics—however subtle—upon opening up their disagreeing superpositions to agreeing superposition reveal that large parts of what we called "kinematic" actually owes to the disagreeing superposition's own reduction of the actual kinematics. So, if you will, it's a game of at once inferring underlying kinematics together with inferring why they reduce to current-theoretic kinematics as agreeing superpositions are replaced by disagreeing superpositions. Once more, classical to quantum is the canonical example, but now that nature has already done this once, we ought now to be looking for others—and in places all the more subtle.

[400] This itself is certainly the closest thing to my exact April 2024 leading abstract-idea for active space, note, with the opening move then being a retrospective sharpening of the general idea so as to also allow the incorporation of arbitrary theoretical moves like twistor space [354–356] and the works. Note that I originally wrote a concrete example of using this, so at the time the set of abstract moves were implicit to the idea rather than stated explicitly. What I have done since is tweak the examples of active space while holding the guiding moves fixed.

chooses the one that entails the *most unification*, exactly as the opening move chooses, among the candidate active spaces, the one yielding the simplest or most unified Lagrangian. The invariance is what makes the choice free: whatever is unified in the agreeing regime, the muffling returns the empiricism regardless, so the reimagining costs nothing empirical and is judged on unification alone. The principle's second intended application, after the lepton sector of the note below, is gravity, and its procedure there is the principle's own: take the strongest reading—that the quotient makes gravity see only determinate nodes—loosen it by exactly as much as the Einstein–Maxwell solutions require and no more, and search for the behavior of the kernel and of gravity on the floor that survives, (Section 14.7.3; the dimensionality principle of Section 14.7.1 is the same procedure run on the arena's dimension). The principle's first intended application is neutrino mixing, and it is the first place I intend to test whether "part Aethic" can be made to pay in quantum field theory: the flavor records are the muffling, the mass structure they hide is the kinematics to be restored, and the mixing entries are the invariant.[401]

[401] *A prospect, recorded (unpacked by Claude Fable 5.1 at the author's request, September 6, 2026; the reading of flavor as the record-side attribute and mass as the kinematic-side one is the author's, stated the same day).* What follows is the Maximal Principle worked on one case, at subsubsection length, so that it stands in the record while a paper waits to be written; every movement below is an instance of the principle's two steps—read the records as the map of what they hide, then restore the hidden structure as the kinematics—applied to the lepton sector.

The observation. Neutrino flavor states are not mass eigenstates: a neutrino produced with a charged lepton of definite flavor propagates as a superposition of three mass eigenstates related to the flavor basis by the PMNS matrix [364, 365], and the interference among the mass eigenstates during flight is neutrino oscillation. For charged leptons the two bases coincide, and the coincidence is usually presented as a convention—flavor *defined* as the charged-lepton mass eigenstate—so that the mixing is said to "sit in the neutrino sector." The standard presentation leaves a residue of strangeness: why should one lepton sector have a definite mass per flavor and the other not, and what is a flavor state, physically, if it is not a state of definite anything? The Aethic reading dissolves the residue by asking of each attribute the one question the framework asks of everything: which records attach to it.

The classification. Flavor is a *recorded* attribute. The charged-current vertex that produces a neutrino produces a charged lepton with it, and that lepton—its track, its mass, its ionization—is a record, and what it records is flavor. Mass is an *unrecorded* attribute at production and in flight: the splittings Δm^2 are far below anything a kinematic record at the source can resolve, and the neutrino interacts too weakly for anything downstream to record which mass eigenstate it is. So relative to the production Aethus the mass attribute is blank, and by the second postulate the blank is open—an agreeing superposition over ν_1, ν_2, ν_3 whose alternatives carry no exclusions in their interiors, because nothing anywhere separates them. Oscillation is the interference signature of that agreeing superposition, the kernel supplying the relative phases $e^{-iE_i t}$; detection is a second charged-current vertex whose charged lepton is again a record of flavor, so the signature partition it induces is on flavor and not on mass, and the mass attribute remains agreeing through the entire experiment. It is the double slit with the mass eigenstates as the slits, the baseline as the screen, and a which-flavor detector at each end: a neutrino is not a particle of unknown mass but a particle whose mass is open relative to every Aethus in the apparatus, and the oscillation pattern is what open looks like.

Why the charged-lepton bases coincide. Not by convention but by records. The charged-lepton mass attribute is recorded from the instant of production: the splittings are hundreds of MeV, the wavepackets separate at once, and every electromagnetic interaction individuates which lepton is present. The mass attribute is therefore disagreeing relative to any laboratory Aethus, so flavor and mass never have room to be distinct attributes—any record of one is a record of the other, and the bases coincide as records coincide. Charged leptons are the "detectors on" configuration and neutrinos the "detectors off" configuration for mass, and the strangeness of the mismatch is the strangeness of the double slit with its which-path detector removed, which is to say the ordinary strangeness of an agreeing superposition and nothing further.

The coherence conditions as a theorem. The literature knows that oscillation requires the mass eigenstates to remain unresolved—wave-packet separation over long baselines, source and detector localization, energy resolution at the detector all suppress it—and derives the conditions case by case [366, 367]. In the framework every one of these is a record: a correlated degree of freedom belonging to the detector configuration whether or not anyone built it as a detector, under the totality guard of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14). The theorem's signature partition then says that oscillation persists exactly as long as no record separates the mass alternatives into distinct classes, and that the coherence length is the baseline at which the alternatives fall into different classes—where the cross-terms are not small but invalid. The case-by-case conditions are one classification, run on one configuration at a time.

The two-tag instance, and a complementarity relation. The two-tag deduction of Section 14.6.4 applies almost verbatim. The mass eigenstate is the tag, an internal route of the augmented path space exactly as polarization was; the flavor vertex is the analyzer; the record sector is the mass-distinguishability that the apparatus does or does not carry. The relation between oscillation visibility V and mass-eigenstate distinguishability D then follows as the Englert relation follows there—$V^2 + D^2 \leq 1$ at every placement, with equality at the optimal one, saturating for pure states—with the coupling lemma and Uhlmann's theorem beneath it rather than a fit, and with the classical chord for a source that is a statistical mixture of kinematic conditions. How much of this the wave-packet treatments already contain in this form is the first thing a paper should establish; the framework's claim is not the inequality but its *grain*, the same grain as the polarized slit.

A single-particle discriminator between unknown and open. Read the mass as a hidden definite value—the deflationary reading, that each neutrino has one mass and we do not know which—and the beam arrives as a classical mixture of mass eigenstates, and mixtures do not oscillate. Interference is the witness that the mass blank is open rather than unknown. This is the logic of the Deflation Reductio, (Theorem 4), with the Bell quadruple replaced by a flavor-transition probability and no second particle needed: neutrino oscillation experiments have been testing the second postulate's reading of blanks since the first solar-neutrino deficit, without the test being framed as one.

A field-theoretic dissolution. Flavor states are not well-defined Fock states, and the attempt to construct a flavor Fock space is known to be problematic [368]. The framework never needs a flavor *state*, only a flavor *record*: flavor is the

partition the charged-current vertex induces, which is the recovery theorem's clause on observables, (Section 14.3, clause (iii)). The ill-definedness was in the attempt to make a recorded label into a state vector, and a label that lives on the record side of the two sectors is not owed one.

The reading that makes this a prospect for active reasoning. One formulation turns the classification into a program. Flavor is, for whatever reason the arena supplies, the attribute that *records attach to*—it lives on the pruning side, in the disagreeing regime that the charged-current vertices carve—while the mass eigenstates are the *kinematic* side, the objects the Nexus's kernel propagates. Under the peel-back regime of the aphorism above—spacetime with the disagreeing superpositions removed—the mass states are what remains, as centron-side objects of active space, and the flavor phenomenology may prove to be entirely a record-side artifact, the way spaciousness itself is argued above to be an artifact of where determinate nodes fall. On that reading the PMNS mismatch is not a puzzle about the neutrino sector but a visible instance of the door between the two sectors: the flavor basis is where the logical sector attaches its records, the mass basis is where the kinematic sector propagates, and the mixing matrix is the interface, seen in one place where the door happens to stand open because nothing records mass. The charged leptons are the same door shut: with mass recorded at once, the logical sector's partition and the kinematic sector's basis are forced to coincide, and the door cannot be seen. If that is right, then the question "why are the neutrino bases misaligned?" is malformed in the way the paper finds several standard questions malformed; the well-formed question is why the arena's basis and the record basis are *aligned* for every other fermion, and the neutrino is the sector where the alignment is not enforced.

The peel-back question for charged leptons, and the method it fixes. The author's next question is the one that turns the door into a target for the kinematics: how *would* the charged-lepton mass states differ from the flavors, could their agreeing superposition be preserved—could the records that individuate a charged lepton's mass at production be withheld? The standard formalism has an answer it does not usually state as one. The lepton mixing matrix is a product, $U_{\mathrm{PMNS}} = U_\ell^\dagger U_\nu$, of the two unitaries that diagonalize the charged-lepton and neutrino mass matrices, and the charged-lepton factor U_ℓ is called unphysical—absorbed into the definition of flavor—for exactly one reason: because flavor is *defined* by the charged-lepton mass basis, which is to say because the charged-lepton mass is always recorded. Withhold the records and U_ℓ becomes an object of the kinematics in its own right: a charged lepton would propagate as an agreeing superposition of its mass eigenstates relative to the weak vertex that produced it, and a charged-lepton oscillation would exist in principle, suppressed in practice by exactly the record structure the classification names—the standard remark that charged leptons do not oscillate because their wavepackets separate at once is the records argument in the physicists' vocabulary. So the kinematic-sector question is well-posed: what is the full mixing structure, U_ℓ and U_ν separately, in the maximal agreeing regime, before any record has chosen a basis? That is arena content, and it is where the arena should be interrogated. The quark sector confirms the shape of the answer. There both up-type and down-type masses are recorded, so neither factor of the CKM matrix can be absorbed by convention and the mismatch shows in the weak vertices without any oscillation; the neutral mesons are the quark sector's unrecorded case, the mass eigenstates K_S and K_L propagating and oscillating because nothing at production records which one was made. Four cases, one classification: recorded mass with the mismatch absorbed (charged leptons), recorded mass with the mismatch visible at the vertex (quarks), unrecorded mass with oscillation and the mismatch visible as a mixing matrix (neutrinos), and unrecorded mass with oscillation in a sector whose mismatch is already fixed by its charged partners (neutral mesons). The method this fixes is the Maximal Principle of Active Reasoning, (Principle 58), in miniature, and it deserves stating in the case's own terms: *read the flavor records as the map of what they hide, restore the hidden mass structure as the kinematics of the fully unhidden agreeing regime, and then reintroduce the records complementarily with the empiricism as the invariant*—the transition probabilities, the absence of charged-lepton oscillation, the CKM and PMNS entries as they are measured must come out unchanged under every choice of how the records are kept, in the way the opening move above makes the choice of spacetime against active space a gauge freedom with the dynamics invariant under it. The flavor basis is a gauge fixed by which records one keeps; the mass basis is what the arena propagates; and the invariant under complementary record-keeping is the only thing the experiment ever measured.

The charged-lepton application, as it is proposed to be run. The step above shows that U_ℓ is hidden; the author's proposal is to go further and ask what the charged leptons would *be* if mass did not provide records at all—to withhold mass-as-record in thought, open the agreeing regime it was muffling, and then ask how mass itself must be reimagined in that opened regime. In the muffled setup mass is a recorded label that coincides with flavor by construction; in the opened regime it is a kinematic attribute of the arena, a phase rate over an internal route, and the charged lepton stands as an agreeing superposition of its mass eigenstates relative to the weak vertex exactly as the neutrino does. The charged and neutral members of the doublet are then the same kind of object, with the entire difference between the sectors residing in the muffling—mass recorded for one, unrecorded for the other—and the question becomes whether something about the two can be *unified* in the maximal agreeing regime that could not be unified while one of them wore its records. The invariance is what licenses the attempt: whatever unification is landed in the agreeing regime, mass-the-record re-muffles the charged leptons back to their observed empiricism—flavor coincident with mass, no oscillation—so the reimagining is empirically free by construction and is to be judged on unification alone, which is the principle's selection criterion. The working question of the program is accordingly this: among the shufflings of the agreeing regime's concepts that cancel against the lepton sector's hiding at the empiricism, which entails the most unification of the charged and neutral sectors? That is a question the standard order cannot ask, because it defines mass by the records and so cannot open the regime in which mass would be something else.

14.7.2 The Hinge Against the Literature: a Preliminary Correspondence Map

Point individuation, and the oldest wound in general relativity.[402] The hinge's core claim—that discriminations between spacetime points are non-arbitrary only through determinate-node structure—walks directly into the problem Einstein met in 1913 as the hole argument, nearly abandoned general covariance over, and escaped in 1915 with the point-coincidence argument [369]: spacetime points have no intrinsic identity, being individuated only by coincidences of physical events. That escape saved the theory but named no mechanism, and when Earman and Norton revived the argument [370], three decades of "sophisticated substantivalism" followed, attempting to say what individuates points without circularity—with the coincidence answer accepted throughout as true but mechanism-free. The hinge supplies the missing term: it names the coincidence-type that does the individuating, (determinate nodes), and derives, rather than postulates, that nothing else in the dynamical inventory is available for the work. In the same key, the framework's demotion of "intrinsic spaciousness" echoes what Leibniz maintained against Newton in the correspondence with Clarke [371]—space as an order of coexistences, not a substance—with the hinge functioning as what that tradition lacked for three centuries: an executable relationalism, in which the individuating relation is a variable of the formalism rather than a philosophical gloss.

The primitive-selection problem across the emergence programs. Every major quantum-gravity program declares spacetime emergent and then faces the same referee question about its chosen primitive: causal sets posit order and number [289], loop quantum gravity posits spin networks [290], the It-from-Qubit program posits entanglement structure [291]—and in each case the primitive was selected *in order to* yield spacetime, so the emergence is partly staged. The rare currency in this literature is a primitive motivated by independent work that turns out to carry spacetime as a

The split, stated exactly, in the author's formulation. The clean way to say all of the above is a three-way distinction, and it should be the note's standing statement of the case. First: "flavor" *is* the record-keeping structure of the charged-lepton mass states, and that only. It is not an attribute the arena propagates; it is the partition the charged-lepton mass records impose, and the neutrino carries a flavor label only by association, borrowed through the charged-current vertex from the partner whose mass is recorded there. Second: charged-lepton mass has, so far, an *unknown* agreeing kinematical character—not no character, but one never examined, because charged-lepton mass has only ever been fitted to the post-record regime, as the label it becomes once muffled, and never interrogated in the agreeing regime the muffling closes. Finding that character is the program. Third: the neutrino mass states are categorically kinematical—the arena's own objects, visible as such because nothing muffles them—and are a different kind of thing from the flavor label they get called by. So the split that organizes the lepton sector is not flavor-versus-mass at all; it is *charged-lepton mass as record structure* versus *the kinematic structure*, the latter comprising the neutrino masses that can be seen and the charged-lepton masses' agreeing character that cannot yet. Flavor is what the first of these looks like from the post-record side. The unification question of the previous movement is then the question of whether the two members of the kinematic structure are one thing, asked in the only regime where they could be.

What is not Aethic, and must not be forced. The PMNS values, the mixing angles, the mass ordering, the Dirac-or-Majorana question, and *why* the weak and mass bases mismatch at all are Yukawa-sector content—the arena's report, exactly where the two-sectors ruling says the postulates go silent, (Section 14.3). The framework classifies which attributes are agreeing and which disagreeing and derives the coherence theorem and the complementarity relation; it does not say what the mixing matrix is, and a paper that tried to make it say so would have crossed the door in the wrong direction. That division is the right shape for "part Aethic": the logical layer supplies the record classification and the theorems, the arena supplies the numbers, and the boundary is drawn in advance rather than discovered in embarrassment.

A program, in six steps, run twice. Formalize production, propagation, and detection as an augmented path space with mass as the internal route; show the flavor vertex is the signature partition; derive the coherence conditions as the record classification; state the complementarity relation as the two-tag theorem's instance and check it against the wave-packet literature; run the deflation argument on a flavor-transition probability; and state the two-sectors reading with the PMNS matrix as the interface. Then run all six again on the neutral kaons—K_S and K_L propagating, strangeness recorded at production by the strong interaction, regeneration as re-preparation, CP violation adding the phases—which are the same structure in a second sector and an independent check of whether the classification holds where it should. The grade of everything in this note is *prospect*: a classification the framework can state now, two theorems it can state now, and a reading proposed here, none of it yet run against the data at the resolution a paper would require.

[402] This subsubsection is written by Claude Fable 5, the AI model serving as this paper's substantive editor, and it should be read for what it is: a preliminary literature tie-in, offered at the reader's leisure, locating the two principles just stated against bodies of work the reader may know better than the framework. The provenance line is drawn here as sharply as the material allows, and the drawing is deliberate. Everything *above* this point—the opening move, the hinge mechanism, the fundamental principle, the derivational route, and the priority record in the footnotes—is the author's, and was produced without the correspondences below in view: the route ran from the author's own primitives, (joint invalidity, to the Union Principle, to agreeing superpositions, to Aethic pruning, to determinate nodes, to the hinge), with the concrete form journal-dated April 9, 2024 and the abstraction reached February 9, 2026, and the whole timestamped publicly before any of the following mapping existed. Everything *below* this point is the model's cartography: translation and location, never derivation. No sentence that follows adds ontological content to the program; each names where the author's independently derived structure happens to land on maps drawn by others—which is precisely what makes the landings evidential. The reader is invited to treat every claim below as checkable and none as load-bearing. The ontology is the author's; the cartography is the model's.

byproduct. Determinate nodes hold that currency: they were introduced for the Quantum Nexus's pruning architecture, (the record-anchoring of agreeing superpositions), with the Node-Mediation lemma of the coherence section already load-bearing before the opening move existed, and the hinge then discovers spacetime hanging from machinery built for other purposes. Relatedly, where the recovery of the classical continuum is the graveyard of the emergence programs, (the causal-set dynamics that struggle to favor manifold-like configurations; the phase structure of causal dynamical triangulations, in which most parameter regimes yield crumpled or branched-polymer geometries rather than anything four-dimensional), the Fundamental Principle above states the recovery requirement as its own explicit constraint—active space under full pruning must return spacetime up to empirical inference—with node density under pruning as the control parameter. The correspondence map notes soberly that stating the requirement is not meeting it; the point of the correspondence is that the program is structured as the kind of thing that could meet it, which the bare declaration of emergence never is.

Empirical coherence, pre-solved by the indexing. Huggett and Wüthrich have pressed [292], over the last fifteen years, the deepest philosophical objection to spacetime emergence: all evidence is local—pointer readings here and now—so a theory on which spacetime is not fundamental risks undermining the very observations that support it, and owes a "functionalist bridge" showing how local evidence remains meaningful. Most programs bolt the bridge on afterward. In the present framework the bridge is architectural: determinate nodes are records, records are where observation lives, and the entire edifice is indexed to observers' information states from its first postulate—so the local-beables demand arrives answered by machinery built, years earlier, for quantum measurement reasons. An adjacent correspondence: the functionalist position itself, (Knox's spacetime functionalism [293], on which spacetime is whatever plays the inertial-frame role), stands to the hinge as a rival or a restatement at different depth—spacetime as whatever the node-quotient outputs—and adjudicating between the two functionalisms is an open question this map can only name.

Two convergences the author did not order. First, dimensional reduction: causal dynamical triangulations [372], the asymptotic-safety program [373], and Hořava gravity [374] independently find the spectral dimension of spacetime flowing from four toward two at small scales, (with antecedents in 't Hooft's dimensional-reduction conjecture [375])—a convergent finding with no agreed mechanism. The hinge, joined to the observation that information-passage inhabitations thin statistically with scale, yields the qualitative in-framework story: sparser passage, sparser records, sparser nodes, softer effective dimension. No number is derived, and the map claims none; the note is that the framework produces the direction of the anomaly from independently fixed machinery. Second, the identical-particles literature: the author's footnote above, treating fermionic anti-symmetry as an artifact of labeling conventions—a knot undone by sliding commitments apart—restates, from the far side, the French–Redhead–Saunders position [376] that quantum particles are not individuals and that permutation labels are descriptive surplus. That is the hole argument's logic applied to particles rather than points, and the author has now arrived at both applications independently: Leibniz twice over.

The twistor gap, and Wheeler's unfinished slogan. The twistor program, ([354] and its descendants), occupies a peculiar position: calculationally triumphant since the amplitudes revival of the mid-2000s [377], ontologically orphaned throughout—no dynamical principle has ever said *why* physics should privilege the correspondence rendering spacetime points as lines in projective twistor space. The opening move's node-indivisibility condition is, exactly, a candidate for that missing principle: nodes attach to the submanifold class, and the attachment is where the physics lives. And last, the correspondence this map finds most striking—and here the paper's own record must come first, because the author engaged Wheeler long before this map existed: the paper's earlier deposited versions record his early encounter with "it from bit" [80], his admiration, and his one standing reservation—that the idea's *discrete* phrasing of reality seemed unnatural as an ontology, a reservation that motivated the continuous, weighted development of Aethae in direct response. The map's observation slots into exactly that opening. Wheeler spent his final decades insisting that spacetime must emerge from something logic-like—"it from bit," and before it a "pregeometry as the calculus of propositions" that he openly judged a failure for want of mechanism. The hinge bottoms out, three derivational steps down, in joint invalidity: a logic primitive—but one whose realization runs through the weighted, continuous machinery, measure-typed and quotiented, rather than through bits. The correspondence is therefore doubled: the old slogan supplied with a mechanism, and the mechanism arriving in precisely the continuous register the author's own recorded reservation had demanded of it.

Where the map ends. Nothing above touches the metric, the Lorentzian signature, causal structure, the problem of time, or the Einstein field equations, (the last excluded explicitly by the author's own footnote), and the correspondence map does not upgrade the program's evidential grade: "brute

gesturing" stands exactly where the author placed it, on the unscrambling hope, while the hinge mechanism stands where the derivation put it.

One further correspondence: the dimension principle's logic—fiber-uniform agreeing superposition, identical cross sections unobservable, subtle differences surfacing to the lower-dimensional observer as effective-Lagrangian structure "not explainable from first principles"—is, in the mainstream register, the zero-mode logic of Kaluza–Klein compactification [357, 358], reconstructed independently in 2024 from the extrusion side; like everything in this map, the correspondence is checkable cartography, never load-bearing content. (The Hopf-bundle geometry itself is unpacked beside the kernel it inhabits, in the reframes ledger of Section 14.6.5.)

14.7.3 Gravity in the Two Sectors: Aethic Semiclassical Gravity

The claim, and the arc of the argument. The two-sectors ruling of Section 14.3 has so far been applied to matter: the postulates are logical, the kernel is kinematic, and the two meet at the agreeing superposition. This subsubsection applies it to the one field that is geometry itself, and the application yields four things in sequence. A picture: each agreeing superposition is its own spacetime, and the disagreeing superposition over agreeing clusters is a disagreeing superposition over spacetimes, selected and never averaged. A refutation, on a stated premise: the standard semiclassical coupling, which sources one metric from an expectation averaged across that selection, is declined by the third postulate together with a branch-local sourcing premise, that the field is sourced by the pocket the records have selected and not by a law defined over the ensemble of pockets. The premise does the work: learning which pocket obtains does not by logic alone refute a field law stipulated as an ensemble average, as a law fixing a field by a prior distribution over a binary variable is not refuted by learning the variable's value, and the Page–Geilker result is empirical pressure against the simplest semiclassical coupling rather than a logical contradiction of it; what the postulate adds is that an ensemble-sourced field, read as an assertion about the pockets' coexistence, is an agreeing-regime object the records contradict, which is the premise's content. A construction: the same coupling restricted to a single agreeing cluster is valid, and the framework can write it down now; we name it *Aethic semiclassical gravity.* And a consequence: the argument usually taken to force the quantization of gravity, Eppley and Hannah's dilemma, was posed across a boundary the framework draws and dissolves once the boundary is seen. The subsubsection closes with a statement of exactly what has been derived, what rejected, and what remains conditional, and a reader in a hurry may read that movement first. The subsubsection is divided into two parts of different standing, and the division should be read as load-bearing. *Part I* is robust: the picture, the refutation, the no-signaling identity, the metric's feedback loop, and the dissolution of the dilemma consume only the postulates and the Quantum Nexus's own selection of valid clusters, and they are gathered as a named principle, the *Disagreeing Metric Principle. Part II* is speculative: the per-pocket coupling, its audit, its prediction, its fork, and its placement against the literature are a program the framework can state but has not run. Around these, the subsubsection asks what cannot be ruled out about the construction's standing as a quantum gravity, records a sketch of a common source for the kernel and the metric, states the iterated partition and the fixed point the postulates demand where spacetimes and records feed back, places the construction against each of the standing non-quantized takes and against quantized gravity proper, and closes with exactly what has been derived, what rejected, and what remains conditional on the arena's kinematics. The reading of geometry within an agreeing cluster that the body text adopts is declared, with its alternative, in the note at the head of the construction. The organizing distinction throughout is this: under an agreeing superposition spacetime *blends*; under a disagreeing superposition it *enumerates*; and the errors of the standard treatment are, without exception, cases of applying one regime's behavior to the other.

Part I — The robust part: the Disagreeing Metric Principle. *The picture: blend and enumeration.* The kernel weights a path by $e^{iS[p]/\hbar}$, and $S[p]$ is the action of the path *in* a geometry, so a geometry is part of what a path is. But the framework's operative object is not the path; it is the cluster. Paths have their useful life toward the kinematics in the subsets they compose, and once an agreeing cluster stands it is the cluster—the whole superposition, irreducible, not state-decomposable into children—that the kinematics operates over, (Section 2.4). The geometry of an agreeing cluster is therefore a property of the cluster and not an enumerable property of its members: relative to the Aethus that holds the cluster, spacetime does not come as a list of candidate geometries one per path but as a single geometry *indeterminate in the manner an agreeing cluster is indeterminate*—a blend. Records then partition clusters exactly as they partition every other attribute, and the disagreeing

superposition over agreeing clusters is a disagreeing superposition over *spacetimes*: here spacetime enumerates, one geometry per pocket, with weights, and centric unfolding selects one, (Section 10.2.4). This is predetermination per Aethus and randomness over Aethae applied to the metric, and the application is the motto's home case: the first half says that a pocket's geometry is fixed along its entire proper-time extent, past, present, and future in the spacetime sense, and the second half says that which pocket is occupied is a matter of the transit between Aethae, which is no process in any geometry. The two behaviors have names in the rest of this subsubsection: within an agreeing cluster spacetime *blends*, across the pockets of a disagreeing superposition it *enumerates*, and the distinction is the universe's rather than the describer's.

What a pocket is, exactly. A clarification belongs here that the worked cases below will lean on, because the word "pocket" can be read as loosely as "branch" if it is not pinned. An elementary agreeing superposition is fixed at *both* ends. Its source node is determinate and so is its destination node—the readout configuration x of the recovery theorem, (Theorem 15)—and what stands in agreeing superposition between them is the bundle of paths that both begin at the one and end at the other. Each node has the extent of its record and no more, (Definition 53): for an absorbing detector the record is finer than the display and the node is effectively a point, while for a mode-selective detector the node is the mode's support and an or-region over it; "determinate" means recorded to the record's grain, and the bundle's endpoints are whatever that grain makes them. So the destination is not something the cluster is waiting to find out; it is part of what the cluster *is*, and the geometry of the pocket is the geometry of a two-boundary object, fixed by both nodes together. The randomness the framework does admit then enters exactly one level up: which destination node obtains is itself an instance of randomness over Aethae. A disagreeing superposition indexes *equivalence classes* of elementary agreeing superpositions by their destination determinate node—all the clusters ending at x form one class, with every other attribute standing in whatever states it stands in within the class—and centric unfolding selects a class. This is the readout-configuration basis of the recovery theorem read as ontology: paths sharing a destination add coherently because they are one cluster, paths at different destinations are orthogonal because they are different clusters, and the sum over x that gives $\langle T|T\rangle$ is the disagreeing superposition's enumeration of destinations. Relative to any one Aethus the classical gravitational field is the geometry of the pocket that Aethus occupies, fixed from the outset; the felt indeterminism lives in which pocket one comes to occupy; and nothing anywhere sources a metric from an average over pockets, because each pocket already has its geometry. The two behaviors, blend and enumeration, are distinct, and the distinction is the universe's; conflating them is a fact about human interpretation.

The principle, and its scope. The reading above is stated once as a principle, because everything in Part I depends on it and nothing in Part I depends on anything after it.

Principle 59 (The Disagreeing Metric Principle)
Let the Quantum Nexus, (Section 14.7), select the valid agreeing clusters T of an Aethus's path space, as it does for every attribute. Then, relative to that Aethus: each valid agreeing cluster carries one *spacetime geometry g_T, a property of the cluster and not of its members; the clusters, standing in disagreeing superposition by the third postulate wherever records separate them, carry their geometries with them, so that the disagreeing superposition over clusters is a disagreeing superposition over* spacetimes*, weighted as the Nexus weights the clusters; and no geometry is ever formed from an average across clusters, since a claim that spans the disagreeing classes is checkmated by the third postulate in every refinement. Centric unfolding selects a cluster and with it a geometry. The principle consumes the three postulates, the Union Principle, and the Nexus's selection of valid clusters, and nothing else: it is the third postulate applied to geometry, and it is stated in advance of, and independently of, any account of how a cluster's geometry is to be computed.*

A corollary of the principle: the metric's own feedback loop. One consequence of the principle is peculiar to gravity and arises for no other record channel the framework has treated. Every other detector is a thing placed in the world—the slit's marker, the counter beside the vial, the polarizer in the arm—and its presence or absence is a fact about the apparatus, settled before the classification and unaffected by it. A cluster's geometry is not like that. By the principle each valid agreeing cluster carries one spacetime g_T, and g_T is contingent on which paths agree; it is a property of the cluster. But the paths of that cluster live on g_T. So a cluster valid as agreeing before its own curvature is counted might, through that curvature, alter the records available against it: if some degree of freedom of the induced geometry were correlated with a distinction among the cluster's own alternatives and readable in some refinement, that would be a record, and a record separating a cluster's alternatives is an invalidation

channel aimed back at the cluster that produced the geometry. The influence need not run one way. A geometry might equally render a distinction unreadable that a flatter one would have exposed, so that the loop can close channels as well as open them—"more or less records," in the notebook entry's own phrase, (the footnote above, September 9, 2026, which states the loop in exactly this conditional form). Whether any actual cluster's curvature does either is an open question. What the corollary says is that the possibility cannot be left out of the classification, because the third postulate quantifies over the records that could contradict a state in some refinement, and a geometry contingent on the cluster is a place such records could come from or fail to come from.

Corollary: the Metric's Feedback Loop

An agreeing cluster's geometry is contingent on the cluster, and the cluster's paths live on that geometry. A cluster valid as agreeing before its own curvature is counted may, through that curvature, enable a record separating its own alternatives, and would then be checkmated by it; it may equally suppress one. The classification must therefore range over the subsets of the total path space that remain valid once each candidate subset's own induced geometry is counted among the records available against it. The corollary asserts the channel's availability, not its occurrence.

What the corollary asserts, exactly. It is a completeness requirement on the classification, not a claim about how gravity behaves. A classification performed without asking whether a cluster's own geometry bears on its records is incomplete, whatever the answer turns out to be. If the channel is never live—if no cluster's induced geometry ever correlates with a distinction among its own alternatives at a grain any refinement can read—the fixed point is reached at the first stage and the classification is the one the ordinary records already gave. That would be a substantive fact about gravity; it is not one the postulates deliver, and assuming it silently is what the corollary rules out. Three further points fix its scope. First, the corollary does not say the cluster splits in two: the third postulate demands that the surviving objects be path subsets valid under the postulates with the extra channel included, and those subsets need be neither mutually exclusive nor jointly exhaustive. This is the framework's ordinary structure. The Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14), classifies each subset of a path space on its own terms and never requires a partition, and the Quantum Nexus sums over the powerset with validity selecting, (Section 14.7); so the output is a family of admissible subsets, and where several are admissible they stand in one disagreeing superposition at the Nexus's weights rather than competing to be the correct carving. Second, the corollary does not say which subsets those are: that requires g_T for each candidate subset, which the principle declines to supply and which is Part II's business. Third, what it fixes is the form of the gravitational classification—a condition on subsets that consults each subset's own geometry, and is therefore satisfied at a fixed point rather than by a single sorting, the cut in the path set iterating with the geometries it induces until neither moves the other. The content is the arena's.

The principle is the robust content of this subsubsection, and it is separated from what follows it because it does not depend on what follows it. It does not say what g_T is; it says that there is one per cluster and none across clusters, that the enumeration over spacetimes is the ordinary enumeration of the framework with a metric attached to each pocket, and—by the corollary just drawn—that the classification consults each candidate subset's own induced geometry, and is therefore satisfied at a fixed point rather than by a single sorting. Everything Part I derives—the refutation of the cross-pocket average, on the branch-local sourcing premise, the no-signaling of clause (viii) for the fixed-record partition it is proved for, and the dissolution of the Eppley–Hannah dilemma—consumes the principle, the postulates and that premise; no-signaling for the complete model with gravitational readouts is a separate condition, stated in Part II, and not an instance of the clause. The author's notebook entry of September 9, 2026 records that this principle was held by 2024, as a trivial application of the third postulate, before the semiclassical program of Part II was formulated; it is reproduced in the note attached here.[403]

[403] *The author's notebook entry of September 9, 2026, set in typewriter to mark it as record. The first part is transcribed from a photograph of the handwritten page and is verbatim apart from two commas the hand omits, restored at the author's instruction; the continuation, which the photograph does not contain, is the author's own dictation of the same day. Nothing else is altered.*

Ideas: By 2024 I was extremely skeptical that gravity can "read" or otherwise "sees" or cares about the wave function, and instead the centrades or determinate nodes should control the active space fibers, which in turn control spacetime curvature. My more recent expectation is instead that while the fibers still control curvature, we should shift from determinate nodes "producing" the constraint

The refutation: the cross-pocket average is checkmated. The standard semiclassical coupling, $G_{\mu\nu}[g] = 8\pi\langle\hat{T}_{\mu\nu}\rangle$, sources one metric from the expectation of the stress-energy in the state, and when the state is a disagreeing superposition that expectation is an average across the pockets—an average across an *enumeration*. The framework refutes it by the theorem that refutes cross-slit coherence with a detector running, and the refutation should be stated as the third-postulate application it is. Let A be an Aethus whose matter stands in a disagreeing superposition over pockets $A_1, \ldots, A_k$ separated by records, and let C be the claim that the metric is $g[\langle T\rangle]$, sourced by the average over the pockets. C spans the disagreeing classes, since its content depends on every pocket at once; every proper child of A has a proper child in which a separating record is stated; the stated record invalidates the pockets it excludes; and the averaged source then no longer exists relative to that child. So C is contradicted in every future, and by the third postulate it is invalid *now*, relative to every Aethus that can read the records—the third bin of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem, (Theorem 14), with the metric in the place of the coherence claim. The refutation is exact and it is cheap, and it inverts the usual reading of the coupling: semiclassical gravity is taken to stay safely on the classical side of the divide, whereas its one non-trivial move is to average across the disagreeing residue, and that is the move the third postulate forbids. On this reading the Page–Geilker null result [378] is the experimental face of an invalid claim.

No-signaling under gravitational records, as an identity. Because the principle places the geometries on the pockets and never across them, a gravitational record—a field configuration correlated with a matter alternative—partitions the path space exactly as any record does, and the recovery theorem's clause (viii), (Theorem 15), applies to the partition: weights add across the record-separated pockets and every marginal commuting with the partition is unchanged. So no gravitational record can signal, for the same reason no record can, and the result is an instance of a theorem the framework already had rather than a property assumed of gravity. This is the whole of what Part I says about signaling, and it is enough for the dilemma that follows.

The loop, unpacked: what the postulates then demand. The principle assigns one geometry per valid agreeing cluster, and the postulates say what happens when that geometry does something. Suppose a cluster's geometry *enables* a record: some degree of freedom of the spacetime the cluster carries is

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to instead that they alone survive cancellation more strongly. It's worth mentioning though that I was already aware by 2024 that each agreeing cluster gets its own spacetime metric, with each altogether going in disagreeing superposition, because that is a trivial third Aethic postulate application. My recent idea is also to regard fitting the EFEs to spacetime quantum energy as a category error and error of abstraction, and instead view the setup more as a deeper common cause-like underlying space for which spacetime in the sense of that which the EFEs operate over is one lossy projection of it while whatever the everliving heck the Quantum Nexus kernel IS is the other branch. I'm already trying to work out the EFE branch as perhaps surprisingly close to a simple quotient space, such that gravity is a constraint on the deeper space by means of the EFEs applying exactly on the quotient space. I suspect that the Quantum Nexus kernel, though, needs more guiding than simply naively taking another quotient, since its object is two paths. What I can say more definitively so far is that if we imagine a higher dimensional space than spacetime in which we are ACTUALLY embedded, then if you only mechanically allow any detectors or cameras or what have you to gauge which path information on their local tangent space along sections which are distinct in the quotient space giving ''classical spacetime'', then the agreeing superposition will be forever open along the perpendicular directions, and so that appears to do the trick directly of making physical space ''appear'' 3D on account of the agreeing superposition dimensionality principle. Whether this is the same quotient space as that which the EFEs see remains to be seen, but it's a cool possibility, especially for the purposes of categorical unification. So yeah anyways what I find especially interesting about this is that with this re-rendition of paths, we can use the licensing of the Quantum Nexus direction pertaining to everything being in two paths (being its existing ontological reinterpretation of the Born rule from an exponent to a path duality) to suppose (note, this setup in particular is inductive reasoning) that our Aethic records are that both fundamental paths have to at the determinate nodes on each end of the propagation map to the same quotient space point, AND their passage direction into each in the deeper space tangent space must map to the same spacetime quotient space tangent space direction at each. Since that's just about all we can record, that leaves the two paths to be totally independent in their quotients into spacetime, hence my attempt to reproduce the existing phenomenology of the Quantum Nexus, with the Lagrangian then being assigned to take on the imprinting of passage through the deeper space, (since after all different deeper spaces will give you stretchier intermediate spaces in the quotients or what have you, roughly speaking). So basically my exactly current approach, in short, is figure that quotienting makes it so gravity only sees determinate nodes, loosen that figuring exactly as much is needed to account for Einstein-Maxwell solutions, and then search for the behavior of the kernel and gravity on this floor of the metaphorical building. (But yeah, schematically I highly highly doubt or at least would be surprised if gravity locks spacetime curvature in along the direct path between two determinate nodes per the electron moving there--instead I would suspect something where the determinate nodes themselves are like two individually isotropic hotspots, and whether it's destructive interference of a kind or something else the intermediate particles fly under the radar of gravity).

correlated with a distinction among the cluster's own alternatives and is readable in some refinement of some Aethus. Then the cluster is not valid as agreeing—by the third postulate the coherence claim across those alternatives is checkmated, exactly as at a slit with a detector—and it breaks into clusters in disagreeing superposition, each of which, by the principle, carries a geometry of its own. Those geometries may in turn enable records that split *them*, or may fail to enable the records that split the parent. So the classification recurses: the geometry of each cluster depends on the cluster, the validity of each cluster depends on the records its geometry enables, and the records depend on the classification. This is the metric's feedback loop of Part I, (Corollary 14.7.3), with its content now supplied: whether a cluster's own curvature opens a record against it is no longer a question one can only pose, since step 3 says what g_T is and the question becomes computable—though computing it is not attempted here. Wherever there is such feedback the postulates demand a *fixed point*, and its shape is fixed by them alone: a cluster T is *gravitationally valid* when its own geometry g_T keeps T closed—enables no record separating T's alternatives—and the disagreeing superposition of spacetimes is the sum over every T that passes, with the Nexus's weights. The admissible clusters are the largest family stable under "the geometry of each cluster induces no record within the cluster," which is the same coinductive structure as the Fixed-Point Lemma's characterization of the third postulate itself, the valid states being the largest set stable under safe refinement. Two consequences follow from the postulates and nothing else. First, the clusters need not form a partition: the framework never required one, the theorem classifies each subset $T \subseteq X$ on its own terms, and the Quantum Nexus sums over the powerset with $A(T)$ selecting the valid clusters, (Section 14.7), so the fixed point is a *validity condition per cluster* and not a condition on a partition. Second, if several families of clusters are admissible they are not rivals among which one must be chosen: they stand together in one disagreeing superposition, with weights, and centric unfolding selects among them as it selects among pockets. What the recursion does *not* fix, and cannot from the postulates, is what g_T is—how a cluster's geometry is to be computed, and hence whether a given geometry enables a given record. That is the arena's, and it is where Part II begins. But the form is settled here: the gravitational case is a recursive classification with a fixed point, imposed by the third postulate on the Disagreeing Metric Principle, and not a single-shot sorting.

The Eppley–Hannah dilemma, dissolved. The sharpest classical argument that collapse and gravity cannot coexist is Eppley and Hannah's [379]: couple a classical gravitational field to quantum matter and either the interaction does not collapse the matter, in which case a classical gravitational wave reads a position without disturbing the momentum and violates the uncertainty relations, or it does, in which case the collapse, an objective event triggered by a classical field, can be used to signal faster than light; either horn forces quantization. The standard reply is Mattingly's [380], that the device is unrealizable. The framework's reply is structural and runs at three layers. The first horn is a contradiction in terms: a field configuration correlated with a position *is* a record of it under the totality guard, so either the coupling carries the position to a readable register, and the third postulate prunes the momentum's coherence in the ordinary way, or it carries it nowhere, and nothing was measured. The horn asks for a determinate node without a record, which the Sifting Principle forbids; the device is the recordless-box case of the vacuum reading, impossible before any mass estimate is made. The second horn is the cross-pocket average already refuted: its signaling is the signaling of an averaged source, and there is no averaged source. And the dilemma's horns do not exhaust the options once each pocket carries its own geometry: the classical field is neither a c-number source coupled to determinate values nor a graviton field enumerated in Fock space alongside the matter, but the blended geometry of a pocket, rendered classical relative to the Aethus that occupies it. Both horns couple the rendition to the matter as if the rendition lived in the matter's sector, and both fail for that reason. The dilemma is not refuted but dissolved, in the cat's way: a question with a missing argument, the argument being which sector the field belongs to.

The method in one line: a signaling paradox recast as a validity paradox. What the dissolution exhibits is the pattern the whole paper runs on, and it deserves to be named once. Eppley and Hannah pose a *dynamical* impossibility—a field interacts, a collapse propagates, information outruns light, every clause a claim about processes in time. The framework returns a *validity* verdict about a claim, with no process, no propagation, and no speed in it. EPR's non-locality became the joint invalidity of combinations, (Principle 27); collapse became pruning; the Heisenberg cut became a partition; Reichenbach's common cause became a theorem about which combinations survive; causation became a verdict of the semantics rather than an input to it. In each case a question presenting as "what happens, and how fast?" was "which claims are jointly valid, relative to what?", hard only because the vocabulary had no modal grade to answer it on. The two kinds of question look interchangeable for a

reason: a speed limit constrains which combinations of events can co-occur consistently in a spacetime, validity constrains which can co-occur consistently in an information state, and if geometry is arena content while determinacy lives in the information state, a signaling paradox *should* be expressible as a validity paradox—both asking whether a set of things holds together, one of the block and one of the books. Two disciplines keep the recasting honest: it does not derive relativity's light cones, which are arena content; and a recasting is a resolution only when the verdict is decidable from the framework's own machinery, as it is here, the checkmate being a single instance of a theorem already in hand.

Part II — The speculative part: Aethic semiclassical gravity. What follows is a *program*, not a result, and its every claim is conditional on the arena admitting a kernel-side representation of geometry. Part I said that each cluster carries one geometry and that geometries never average across clusters. Part II asks what that geometry is, proposes the semiclassical equation confined to the cluster as the answer the framework can state now, follows the proposal to its audit, its fork, and its prediction, and records the sketch of a deeper space from which both the metric and the kernel would project. A reader who accepts Part I and rejects Part II loses the construction and keeps the principle; nothing in Part I is at risk from anything in Part II.

The construction: Aethic semiclassical gravity, in five steps. The refutation says where the average may not run, and by the same token where it may. Within a single agreeing cluster no record separates the alternatives—that is what agreeing means—so a source formed over the cluster alone crosses no pocket and is contradicted by no proper child. The coupling the framework can already state is the semiclassical equation confined to the blend, one self-consistent pair per pocket, and it is short enough to walk through without ambiguity.[404] The one thing to hold fixed throughout is that the same symbol $\langle\hat{T}\rangle$ names two different operations depending on what it runs over.

1. *Fix the pocket.* Take an Aethus and its disagreeing residue: pockets $T_1, \ldots, T_k$ with weights w_i, separated by records. Select one, T: a single agreeing cluster, a set of augmented paths with no record anywhere separating them, running from one determinate node to one determinate destination node—both fixed, as the clarification above insists. The choice is not arbitrary; the records made the partition, and each pocket is one of its classes.

2. *Form the source inside it, as an expectation and not as an insertion.* Take $\langle T|\hat{T}_{\mu\nu}|T\rangle/\langle T|T\rangle$, and read the symbol exactly, because two objects wear it. The cluster's vector lives on the readout slice, and the stress-energy at an intermediate point y is brought to that slice by the transport rule of the recovery theorem's clause (vii): the source is the expectation, in the state $|T\rangle$, of the *transported* operator $U\hat{T}_{\mu\nu}(y)U^\dagger$—equivalently, the expectation of $\hat{T}_{\mu\nu}(y)$ in the cluster's state on the slice through y, $U^\dagger(T,t)|T\rangle$, which is the initial amplitude filtered by the future record. That object is the expectation of a Hermitian operator in a state, hence *real*; Hermiticity and unitary transport secure that much and no more, since the local definition and covariant conservation of a semiclassical stress-energy expectation involve the field equations and renormalization conditions, which the construction has not supplied. It is not the path-integral insertion $\sum_{p\in T}\mathcal{K}(p)\,T_{\mu\nu}[p](y)$, which is a transition amplitude between the forward-evolved source and the backward-evolved

[404] *A note on the reading the body text adopts (the model's words, at the author's request).* The construction below, and the audit and the experiment after it, are written on one reading of what geometry is within an agreeing cluster, and the reading should be declared. Where a pocket's geometry is fixed by records nothing is at stake. Where it is *open* within the pocket—two masses each in spatial superposition, no which-position record anywhere—the framework can be read two ways. *Option A:* the pocket carries one geometry, the blend; the metric is a property of the cluster, sourced by the cluster's expectation, and every path is weighted by its action in it. *Option B:* each path carries its own geometry as an enumerable internal route; the kernel weights each path by $e^{iS_{g_p}[p]/\hbar}$, and the pocket is a sum over geometrically distinct paths of which Option A's g_T would be a saddle point or an emergent average. The two agree wherever geometry is record-fixed, which is every use of the coupling that has ever succeeded, and part exactly at the open case. Neither can be ruled out pending the verdict of active reasoning proper, and the paper rules out neither; the body text defaults to Option A, and the ground for doing so is structural rather than a preference between equations—the blend-and-enumeration distinction applied to the fork itself. Paths are not privileged objects in this framework; their useful life toward the kinematics begins and ends with the subsets they compose, and once a cluster stands it is the cluster that is operated over. To give each path its own geometry is to treat the agreeing cluster as an enumeration of things each carrying its own properties—to import, at exactly the point the union principle removed it, the classical reductionist assumption that a superposition is a list. The phrase "agreeing superposition over spacetimes" is that fallacy in miniature, *over* being an enumerative preposition and enumeration being what the disagreeing regime does. On this reading Option B is not the more faithful rendering of geometry-as-internal-route but a category slip in the framework's own vocabulary, and what the agreeing regime requires is the single blended geometry of step 3 below, whose exact kinematics the arena has yet to supply. The reader who prefers Option B can carry it through the body text by replacing the blended source in step 3 with a per-path weighting; every result up to the entanglement prediction survives the substitution, and that prediction reverses, which is why the experiment decides.

destination—a weak value, complex in general, and the wrong object to source a metric with. Two boundaries fixed do not make the source a weak value; and calling the object the expectation in a two-boundary state does not by itself supply what the boundaries were meant to encode. In the fine-record case, where every path in T ends at the same readout state $|x_f\rangle$, the vector is $|T\rangle = A_T|x_f\rangle$ with A_T the cluster amplitude, and for nonzero A_T the normalized expectation is $\langle x_f|U\hat{T}_{\mu\nu}(y)U^\dagger|x_f\rangle$: the cluster amplitude cancels, and at fixed geometry and propagator the source has lost the initial-boundary and path-subset information that only A_T carried, so that backward propagation of the readout vector produces a state constrained by the final readout alone. The prescription as written therefore does not retain the history information it is meant to, in the fixed-background limit already; a source that does, a history-state or density-operator construction on the cluster carried through a continuum and renormalization treatment, is what the program requires and does not yet have, and every consequence below that depends on the two-node constraint is conditional on supplying it. Expanded, the expectation is a sum over *pairs* of paths in T with the kernel's cosine pairing between them, so it is not an average over alternatives that exclude one another; it is the coherent expectation of the cluster taken as one object, cross-terms included. Over pockets, $\langle\hat{T}\rangle$ would be a mixture of things that exclude each other; over the paths within a pocket it is the interference sum of things that do not. The standard coupling does the first; this does only the second. And the nodes at either end have the extent of their records, (Definition 53): where the record is finer than the display, endpoints within a display cell are record-separated and their contributions add as weights, not amplitudes; where a detector records only a mode, the endpoints within it are one class and add coherently. The vector $|T\rangle$ is delta-normalized in the continuum; a norm does not bound an unbounded stress-energy operator, and delta-normalized endpoint states do not solve that problem, which belongs to the renormalization treatment just named.

3. *Close the loop.* The kernel's action is taken in the pocket's own geometry, $\mathcal{K}_{g_T}(p) = e^{iS_{g_T}[p]/\hbar}$, so that g_T determines $|T\rangle$ and $|T\rangle$ determines the source of g_T. The pair (T, g_T) is a fixed point,

$$G_{\mu\nu}[g_T] \;=\; 8\pi\,\frac{\langle T|\hat{T}_{\mu\nu}|T\rangle}{\langle T|T\rangle}, \qquad |T\rangle = \sum_{p\in T}\mathcal{K}_{g_T}(p)\,|x(p)\rangle,$$

   of the same shape as the Møller–Rosenfeld fixed point but confined to one agreeing cluster.

4. *Put the pockets back, and do nothing to them.* There are now k self-consistent pairs (T_i, g_i), each with its weight w_i, standing in disagreeing superposition—an enumeration of spacetimes. No metric is formed from the w_i. Centric unfolding selects one, and relative to the selecting Aethus that geometry was always the geometry.

5. *Check it against the cases.* A cat in a box with poison released by a decay: the standard coupling has one metric sourced by a half-dead average, which is the claim the branch-local sourcing premise declines. Here there are two pockets, each with an ordinary metric—one sourced by a living cat's stress-energy, one by a dead cat's—and a weight over them, which is what everyone believed anyway, now derived rather than assumed. And the successful uses of semiclassical gravity all turn out to be single-pocket cases: quantum field theory on a fixed background, the Hawking calculation in its pure-state form. The equation is unchanged where it works and absent where it fails.

Three consequences are claimed, at three different grades. No-signaling does not transfer from clause (viii) of the recovery theorem (Theorem 15), which concerns marginal statistics under an already specified measurement structure with a fixed projector family; here the state can alter the metric, the kernel, the records and the admissible clusters, and the operational condition for the complete model with gravitational readouts, $P(b, g_B \mid x, y) = P(b, g_B \mid y)$ for a spacelike-separated, freely chosen setting x, is a condition to be established for that model and is not established by the absence of averaging across pockets. The construction coincides with the standard coupling in the single-pocket cases, as a construction, and departs from it in mixed states, where the standard nonlinearity and signaling come from averaging across the enumeration; that it reproduces every success of semiclassical gravity is not shown. And the construction is a per-pocket stage, not the whole of gravity: the geometry within a pocket is the blend, and what the blend's kinematics are is the arena's content, which the Maximal Principle of Active Reasoning, (Principle 58), directs to be defined in the maximal agreeing regime,

before any record has fixed a pocket, with classical spacetime for every recorded configuration as the invariant.

The iterated partition, under the semiclassical coupling. The metric's feedback loop of Part I, (Corollary 14.7.3), fixes the form of the gravitational classification—a condition on path subsets that consults each subset's own induced geometry, satisfied at a fixed point—without saying what a cluster's geometry is. The first is the semiclassical fixed point within a pocket; the second is Part I's condition, now evaluable because g_T has been given. Three fixed-point problems are in play and a theorem for one does not settle the others: the safety and doom of the third postulate, which needs a domain, base contradictions and a declared descent relation; the semiclassical back-reaction, which needs a metric and a matter state satisfying their coupled equations; and the record–geometry consistency, a record structure compatible with the geometry and clusters it helps determine. The postulate supplies the admissibility criterion once the declared refinement structure and base contradictions are specified, and nothing more: it does not establish that the coupled matter–geometry problem has a solution, that its solutions possess a greatest admissible family, or that iterative reclassification converges, and since geometry can both create and suppress record channels, the monotonicity those results would need is a substantive question that the postulate's own coinduction does not answer. A theorem for one fixed record-signature partition, moreover, does not extend of itself to subsets T whose geometries g_T induce different record maps; that extension is an extension. Nothing in the framework guarantees that the fixed point exists, is unique, or that iteration from a coarse classification converges to it rather than oscillating, and the paper claims none of these; if several fixed points are admissible they stand in one disagreeing superposition, as Part I says, and the integral over $\mathcal{P}(X)$, proposed in the author's notes in 2024 as the expanded path integral and named the Quantum Nexus thereafter, was already built to hold them. The two readings of the note divide here. Under Option A the closure condition is expected to hold trivially at the blend—a single blended geometry within a cluster carries no within-cluster distinction to be recorded, which is what "blend" means—so that the recursion terminates at the record partition already fixed by non-gravitational records; under Option B the closure condition does real work, gravity records within clusters, and the recursion is where the enumeration is generated. The Penrose condition of the comparison below is the experimental face of that division. And the theorem's reach is worth recording: the Powerset Invalidation Theorem was proved about detectors at slits, and it has now been found to govern, without amendment to its statement, both the neutrino sector, (the note on the Maximal Principle above), with mass eigenstates in the slits' place, and the gravitational sector, with curvature in the detector's place. A theorem that reaches two unrelated corners of physics by identity of the question rather than by analogy is operating at the level the framework claims for it; it supplies the *form* of the gravitational question, and the arena supplies its content, which is the division the Maximal Principle draws.

What this is not. A reader who knows the decoherence and open-systems literature will recognize the rule that one should not feed a mixed state into the semiclassical equation, and the paper does not claim that rule as its own: that a source formed over a decohered mixture is the wrong source, and that one should take one branch at a time, is an intuition Page and Geilker's experiment already presupposed. What is claimed is everything the bare rule lacks. The rule is here *derived* rather than adopted—the cross-pocket claim is invalid relative to every record-reading Aethus, not merely inaccurate for practical purposes, so there is no "the mixing is small, so the average is nearly right." The rule is here given its *decomposition*, which the bare version cannot supply: "one branch at a time" raises at once the question of branches of what, which decoherence answers approximately and environment-relatively, and which the framework answers exactly, by the partition of every record in the block, with the audit below showing the partition must be the global one. The rule is here given a *positive side*, the blend, on which it is silent: it says nothing about what geometry is where a cluster's geometry is open, and the framework says it is one indeterminate geometry and not a list, which is what yields the entanglement prediction. And the rule is here made to *sort a literature*, which a rule of hygiene does not do. A reader who takes only the prohibition away from this subsubsection has taken the least of it.

The audit: self-consistency on four checks. The construction is consistent on every check the framework can run from its own resources, and each check is a place a referee should look. First, the pockets are *static*, and that is the point: the partition into pockets is fixed by the block's complete record structure, past and future, because the third postulate quantifies over the whole refinement future, so a pocket's geometry is fixed from the outset with no randomness in it, the randomness living entirely in which pocket is occupied. This is consistency with the extrusion principle—nothing in any pocket is updated in proper time, and "collapse of the metric" is not a process in any block. Second, the

partition must be the *global* one. Bob, lacking a record Alice holds, is not in possession of an averaged metric over the alternatives her record separates: her record exists in the block and can reach him, so by the vacuum reading, (Section 6.6.2), those alternatives are already disagreeing relative to Bob, and he stands in a disagreeing superposition over metrics. Pockets are the classes of the partition by every record in the block, under the totality guard—one object for every Aethus that can meet—and observer consistency, (Section 12.3), guarantees that Alice's and Bob's geometries agree on every shared record. Third, conservation holds and the collapse anomaly is absent: within a pocket the source is the renormalized expectation on a fixed background, covariantly conserved, with the Bianchi identity respected; the known failure of semiclassical collapse models, a discontinuous jump in $\langle T \rangle$ at collapse, cannot occur, because nothing jumps within a pocket and selection among pockets is not an event in any block. This is Requirement 5 met at the level of the metric, (Section 2.5). Fourth, the empirical record is consistent: the Page–Geilker null result is predicted, the single-pocket successes are reproduced, and the fixed point (T, g_T) inherits the perturbative existence status of the Møller–Rosenfeld fixed point it restricts, together with that fixed point's open question of multiple solutions. One objection a reader working the simplest case will raise is answered by step 2's reading: for a free Dirac electron between two recorded nodes the source might seem to be a two-boundary conditioned quantity and hence a weak value, complex in general; it is not, because the framework's source is the expectation in the cluster's two-boundary *state* with transported operators, real and conserved, with the state delta-normalized at record grain and its norm what bounds the expectation. The metric of that case was expected to be the linearized, boosted Newtonian potential of a spindle of energy density along the classical worldline, pinched at both nodes; that spindle, and the transverse width $\sqrt{\hbar T/4m}$ once quoted for it, are not established by the prescription as written, since the cancellation of the cluster amplitude noted above removes the two-node constraint from the normalized source, and both await an actual calculation with a specified state and boundary conditions. What survives at the present grade is the order of the back-reaction, $Gm^2/\hbar c \approx 10^{-45}$, which makes the first iterate the fixed point for any source of this magnitude.

The prediction, and the experiment that tests it. Aethic semiclassical gravity makes one prediction that its rivals do not share, and it is the prediction of the blend. In the configuration of the proposed gravitationally mediated entanglement experiments [381, 382]—two masses, each in spatial superposition, no which-position record—the pair sees one blended geometry. It does not follow that every branch acquires the same gravitational phase, since different paths through one classical geometry can acquire different actions and phases; the prediction of no entanglement would instead require a generator of the form $H[g] = H_A[g] \otimes I + I \otimes H_B[g]$ for the complete proposed evolution, with the state dependence of g, the cluster selection and any conditioning included, and a proof that that evolution preserves initially product states. That generator is the prediction's requirement, not yet its derivation, and the gravitational-entanglement proposals make their own claims under specified assumptions about mediation that neither "one geometry" nor "different phases" settles alone. A per-path enumeration of geometries would give the branches different phases and entangle the masses, which is the outcome the quantization programs expect, and which the reader who takes the alternative reading of the note above would predict. So the experiment does not merely test whether "classical gravity can entangle," a question the standing debate has conducted without a vocabulary for the difference between a blend over a pocket and an enumeration of its paths; it tests the blend reading directly, and the construction stakes the more falsifiable limb. A positive result would not refute the framework—it would settle the note's fork the other way and send the geometry's kinematics to the arena as an enumeration after all—but it would refute this subsubsection's reading of what an agreeing cluster's geometry is.

What cannot be ruled out. A reader will ask whether any of this is quantum gravity, and the honest answer is stronger than a taxonomy. As of this writing it cannot be ruled out that Aethic semiclassical gravity, together with the agreeing regime it sits inside, is already the complete unification. The framework already contains geometry that is open within an agreeing cluster, weighted by a kernel, with the classical limit derived from it by records; that is the shape a quantum gravity has, and the per-pocket stage is the case in which the records have fixed one geometry per pocket and the blend has been muffled away. What is not settled is whether the arena, once its kinematics are actually defined, adds anything to this. It might not: one live possibility is that the active-space arena, when the Maximal Principle is carried through on gravity, reproduces the blended source of step 3 emergently, so that the construction above was the whole of it and the "quantization" of gravity is nothing beyond the framework's ordinary treatment of an attribute whose records are withheld. Or it might: the arena could land on a kinematics richer than the blended source, in which case the per-pocket stage is the first story of a taller building. Which obtains cannot be decided short of running the treatment. What

can be said now is narrower and exact: the framework does not require that anything be added to Aethic semiclassical gravity to have a quantum gravity, no argument presently available rules out that nothing need be, and the Maximal Principle is the instrument that will tell.

A common source for both branches: the sketch now being pursued. The question of whether the arena adds anything has a third answer beyond the two just named, and the notebook entry attached to the Disagreeing Metric Principle records it as the direction now being worked. The two-sectors ruling has so far held the kernel and the metric apart as two kinds of arena content meeting at one door. The sketch places them as two *projections* of one deeper space: spacetime, in the sense of what the Einstein field equations operate over, is a lossy projection of that space, and the Quantum Nexus kernel is the other branch. On this reading the door is not a coincidence but a common cause, and fitting the field equations to a quantum stress-energy is misplaced twice over—a category error, since it couples a projection to the object it projects, and an error of abstraction, since it treats the projection as fundamental. The sketch has three parts, and they are stated here as the framework can state them now, at the grade of a research direction; the notebook entry is their source and is reproduced there, and the parts that do not depend on gravity—the nodes as survivors of cancellation, the dimensionality principle, and what a record can fix about a pair of paths—are developed where the opening move plants them, (Section 14.7.1), and are consumed here rather than restated.

The first part is the gravitational branch. We conjecture that it is close to a simple quotient: gravity is a constraint on the deeper space imposed by the field equations holding *exactly* on the quotient, so that the metric never sees the deeper space directly and the Disagreeing Metric Principle's one-geometry-per-cluster is the statement that each cluster projects to one quotient geometry. The second part is the dimensionality argument, and it is the sharpest. Suppose we are embedded in a space of higher dimension than spacetime, and suppose that detectors—cameras, counters, anything that gauges which-path information—can do so only on their local tangent space, along sections that are distinct in the quotient giving classical spacetime. Then along every direction perpendicular to those sections the agreeing superposition is never partitioned, since no record can be taken along it, and the deeper space's extra dimensions stay open forever relative to every Aethus. Physical space *appears* three-dimensional not because the arena is, but because three is the dimension along which records can be laid down; we call this the agreeing-superposition dimensionality principle, and it is the Maximal Principle's joint variation made concrete—a richer agreeing regime with a muffling that hides exactly its extra layers, the empiricism of spaciousness the invariant. It is also the aphorism of Section 14.7 with a mechanism: spaciousness is an artifact of where the determinate nodes fall, and the sketch says where they can fall.

The third part is the kernel branch, and it is where the sketch declines an easy move. The Nexus's object is a *pair* of paths, not a point, so the kernel cannot be obtained by taking a second quotient in the manner of the first; a quotient map has nothing to say to a pair. What the sketch does instead is use the Dual Path Principle, (Principle 51), to ask what a record can fix about a pair. The answer is exactly two things: at the determinate nodes on each end of a propagation, both fundamental paths must map to the same point of the quotient, and their passage directions in the deeper space must map to the same tangent direction of the quotient at each end. Those two coincidences are all that a node's record can register, since a node is an or-region of the quotient and its tangent data, (Definition 53), and nothing about the deeper space between the nodes is recordable. Between the nodes the two paths are therefore independent in their quotients, and the Lagrangian is assigned the role of imprinting the passage through the deeper space—different deeper spaces giving, roughly, different stretchings of the intermediate quotients. Whether this reproduces the Nexus's phenomenology is the calculation the sketch has yet to run.

What the sketch would settle, if it held, should be stated so that its stakes are visible. It would answer the previous movement's question in the affirmative and by a specific structure: the arena adds a deeper space of which both sectors are projections. It would resolve the fork of the note on Option A's side by construction, since the blend within a cluster would be the unprojected geometry of the deeper space and the enumeration across pockets would be the quotient's, with no per-path geometry anywhere. And it would give the Maximal Principle its object: the kinematics defined in the maximal agreeing regime would be the kinematics of the deeper space with no section gauged. Three things are open, and the sketch names them itself: whether the quotient the field equations see is the same quotient the which-path records see; whether the two coincidence conditions on a pair of paths reproduce the kernel; and how the Lagrangian's imprint is to be defined. Against the twistor program, which also produces spacetime points from a deeper space by incidence, (the centrade and rotrade remarks of the opening move, Section 14.7), the sketch differs in what it asks the deeper space to carry:

not the light-cone structure alone but the two regimes, with records the only thing that reaches the quotient.

The retrospective: why quantization was the majority position, and whether it locks against this take. A historian will ask, as we do, whether the quantization of gravity became the majority position because nobody had the concept of an agreeing superposition, so that the majority's constraints do not bind against the present take, or whether those constraints still hold from within it. The first reading holds, with one refinement that strengthens it. Without the agreeing/disagreeing distinction, a superposition of masses forces a superposition of geometries, and a superposition of geometries with no modal grade to sort it can only be read as an *enumeration*—a dynamical object, a quantum field of metrics evolving in time and collapsing at measurements. That is the object the quantization programs set out to construct, and the object whose collapse Eppley and Hannah, and Page and Geilker, found to misbehave. With the distinction, the disagreeing regime never needs that object: each pocket has a fixed four-dimensional geometry, determined by the block's records and varying with proper time within the block, the enumeration over pockets is selected and never averaged, and there is no metric to collapse. The refinement is that the agreeing regime *does* carry open geometry—the blend—which the entanglement test exposes; so the majority was right that geometry is open somewhere and wrong about how it is open, taking the blend for an enumeration, and applying to the disagreeing regime a tool built for a misreading of the agreeing one. On the criterion proposed here—that a paradigm shift should leave the prior majority explicable as a foreseeable omission rather than standing as a constraint—the construction's claim is narrower than the criterion: of the reasons for quantizing, those that rest on an enumerated, dynamical metric averaged across alternatives are answered when the two regimes are told apart, and the reasons that do not, the open geometry of the agreeing regime among them, are not dissolved but relocated. What survives from the majority is the open geometry of the agreeing regime, which the framework does not contest; it locates it in the arena, reads it as a blend, and hands it to the Maximal Principle.

Against each non-quantized take, explicitly. Several serious positions decline to quantize gravity, and the construction should be placed against each rather than left to be confused with them, because it agrees with none of them on the reason.

The Møller–Rosenfeld coupling [383, 384] is the one already treated: refuted where it averages across the enumeration, adopted where it stays within the blend. The placement is exact—Aethic semiclassical gravity *is* semiclassical gravity with the third postulate applied to it, which is to say with the cross-pocket average removed and nothing else changed.

Penrose's gravitational objective reduction [109] holds that a superposition of two mass distributions carries an ill-defined time-translation, that the ill-definedness has an energy E_G, and that the superposition therefore collapses on a timescale $\hbar/E_G$; gravity is the collapse mechanism. The framework shares Penrose's suspicion that gravity is not to be quantized and disagrees about everything downstream. There is no collapse mechanism here and no rate: the third postulate does the work Penrose assigns to E_G, and does it without a timescale, since a coherence claim is invalid the moment a separating record exists in the block rather than after a delay. And the ill-definedness Penrose begins from is, on the present reading, the blend read as an enumeration—two spacetimes with no canonical map between them is the picture one gets by listing the branches, and the framework's claim is that within an agreeing cluster there is one blended geometry and nothing to map. Penrose's proposal is testable by its rate; the framework predicts no such rate. The disagreement should be stated with its condition on its face, because without the condition the two positions would coincide. The framework prunes an agreeing cluster only when a record separating its alternatives exists somewhere in the block, and the totality guard counts any correlated degree of freedom as such a record whether or not it was built as a detector. A superposed mass curves spacetime, and if its branches curve it *differently*, the differential curvature is a degree of freedom correlated with the branch, hence a record, hence a trigger for the third postulate—in which case Penrose's E_G would be not a decay rate but a rough measure of how strong the gravitational record is, and objective reduction would be the third postulate firing on the gravitational field, with no new mechanism and no dynamics. The framework's disagreement with Penrose is therefore *conditional on the blend*: under Option A there is one blended geometry within the cluster, no differential curvature, nothing for gravity to record, and no reduction; under Option B the branches carry their own geometries, the field records the difference, and Penrose is closer to right than the paragraph above allows, in the framework's own vocabulary. The two questions—is gravitational curvature a separating record, and does gravity mediate entanglement—are related and not equivalent: a branch-dependent geometry is what a gravitational record requires, while an interaction can create entanglement coherently without producing any irretrievable classical record,

so a positive gravitational-entanglement result would not by itself vindicate an objective-reduction proposal, Penrose's included, and a negative one would not by itself establish a record. A positive result at the entanglement configuration would therefore not merely refute the blend; it would vindicate Penrose's picture as the third postulate applied to curvature, which is a more honest statement of what is at stake than "the framework predicts no rate."

Dyson's untestability [385] argues that a single graviton cannot be detected even in principle, so the quantum nature of gravity may be empirically empty. The framework reverses the moral. The question is testable, in the negative: the blend predicts no gravitationally mediated entanglement, at a configuration that is being built. What Dyson showed is that gravity's quantization cannot be confirmed by *counting quanta*; what the entanglement test does is confirm or refute it by *phase*, which is a different observable, and one the framework has a definite claim about.

Thermodynamic and emergent gravity [386–388] hold that the Einstein equation is an equation of state—that the metric is a coarse-grained variable, an average over microscopic degrees of freedom, and that quantizing it would be like quantizing the ideal-gas law. This is the position nearest to ours in spirit and the one the third postulate speaks to most directly, so the walk should be explicit. Ask over *what* the thermodynamic average runs. Either the microstates it averages are separated by records—they are disagreeing pockets—or they are not. If they are, the average is a cross-pocket average, and it is checkmated by exactly the argument that refuted Møller–Rosenfeld: every proper child states a separating record, the stated record invalidates pockets in the average's basis, and the equation of state is an invalid claim relative to every Aethus that can read the records. If they are not—if the microstates form a single agreeing cluster, unseparated by any record in the block—then the "average" is not an average at all but the blend, and Jacobson's derivation becomes a derivation of Aethic semiclassical gravity by another route: the Einstein equation as an equation of state *per pocket*, sourced by the cluster's own expectation, which is step 3 of the walk. So thermodynamic gravity is asked a question it does not answer as stated, which regime its microstates stand in; a thermodynamic average need not assert that the averaged microstates physically coexist, so the presence of distinguishable microstates refutes nothing by itself, and the framework's claim is only that the program's ensemble is underspecified by one regime until that question is answered, with the construction above as one specification of it and not the demonstrated one.

Hybrid and postquantum classical–quantum theories [389] keep the metric classical, couple it consistently to quantum matter, and pay for the consistency with an irreducible stochasticity in the classical field—diffusion of the metric, with a decoherence rate on the matter as the price. The framework keeps the metric classical per pocket and relocates the randomness to the selection among pockets rather than into the field; whether that relocation evades the consistency requirements the hybrid constructions meet by completely positive, trace-preserving classical–quantum dynamics, or merely restates them, is not shown here, since showing it requires naming which of those requirements the model declines and supplying the replacement empirical map. On the present reading the postquantum noise is the enumeration's selection mistaken for a process within the metric—the same relocation of indeterminism from the block to the index that the paper makes everywhere, (Section 10.2.4)—and the two are testable against each other by the decoherence the noise induces, which the framework predicts absent.

Quantum-spacetime programs [390]—loop quantum gravity and its relatives—are the contrast rather than a kin: they quantize spacetime itself, and their spin-network superpositions are enumerations of geometries at the fundamental level. The framework does not say they are wrong. It says the enumeration belongs to the disagreeing regime, that the agreeing regime carries a blend, and that a program which enumerates at the root has taken the muffled rendition for the object.

How much can be said against quantized gravity proper, and how much cannot. The construction permits a definite statement in each direction, and the statement should be made once. *What can be said.* The arguments that were taken to force the quantization of gravity are withdrawn: Eppley and Hannah's dilemma is dissolved, and the apparent need for a dynamical superposed metric—the object whose collapse misbehaved—is shown to be the blend misread as an enumeration. The disagreeing regime needs no quantized metric at all, and that is theorem-grade: each pocket's geometry is static, classical, and fixed by the block's records, and the cross-pocket average that would have required something to jump is invalid. The agreeing regime's geometry is open, but on the reading the body text adopts it is open as a blend, not as a list of metrics—a ruling, with the entanglement prediction as its test. And the one field-theoretic prediction the framework makes at this configuration is the opposite of the quantization programs'. *What cannot be said.* None of this rules quantized gravity out. The blend's own kinematics are the arena's, and the arena could land on an enumeration after

all (the note's Option B), or on a structure with quantized excitations of the blend that no present argument anticipates; a positive entanglement result would send the geometry's kinematics to the arena as an enumeration and leave every other result of this subsubsection standing. The exact position is therefore: quantized gravity is *not required*, since the disagreeing regime needs no quantized metric and the agreeing regime's openness is accounted for by the blend; it is *not ruled out*, since the blend's kinematics are undetermined and the test is unrun; and *the argument that forced it is withdrawn*, which is the part that is settled. What the framework adds to the standing debate is that the question was never "must gravity be quantized?" but "in which regime is geometry open, and open how?"—a question with a missing argument, as the cat was, the argument being which of the two behaviors, blend or enumeration, the geometry exhibits where no record has fixed it.

What is derived, what is rejected, and what is conditional. A referee should hold this subsubsection to three tiers, and the paper states them. *Derived (Part I):* the Disagreeing Metric Principle, (Principle 59), as the third postulate applied to geometry; the refutation of the cross-pocket average, an instance of Theorem 14; no-signaling under gravitational records, an instance of clause (viii); and and the metric's feedback loop, (Corollary 14.7.3)—that a cluster's own curvature is a channel through which a record against the cluster might exist, so that the classification must range over the path subsets valid once each subset's induced geometry is counted among the records available against it, neither exclusive nor exhaustive—as the third postulate applied to the principle. *Rejected, not derived against:* semiclassical gravity in the Møller–Rosenfeld form, which the framework does not show to preserve no-signaling—it does not, and Eppley and Hannah are right that it does not—but shows to be an invalid claim relative to every record-reading Aethus, and hence the wrong coupling. *Conditional (Part II):* Aethic semiclassical gravity itself, the per-pocket equation, its audit, its prediction, and the blend reading of the note all require that gravity admit the kernel-side representation—geometry in the action, a blend within a pocket—which is the arena's kinematics, not derived here, and the conditional is the two-sectors ruling applied to the one field that is geometry. Nothing here establishes that gravity is classical, and nothing establishes that it need not be quantized; what is established is that the argument usually taken to force the question was asking it across a boundary the framework draws, that the coupling that seemed to stay on the classical side did not, and that the one that does can be written down.

The prompts that produced this subsubsection.[405]

[405] *The prompts that produced this subsubsection, verbatim (a note in the model's words, preceding the author's own).* The record of this section's provenance is kept in the author's own words, as the paper keeps the rest of its provenance, (Section 13.11). What follows are the author's prompts of September 7, 2026, reproduced without alteration and set in typewriter to mark them as record rather than prose. They document, in order: the question that opened the section; the picture of each agreeing superposition as its own spacetime and the no-signaling question; the recognition that the semiclassical coupling averages across disagreeing spacetimes, and the question of a per-cluster average; the third-postulate refutation, arrived at against the author's own prior expectation; the remark the validity-paradox movement unpacks; the standing position on the arena question, dated to the active-space concept of 2024; the self-consistency question the audit answers; the ruling on the fork between the two readings, with the blend-and-enumeration distinction; the instructions for the comparison and this note; the iterated-partition observation that the fixed-point movement unpacks; and the correction that multiple admissible fixed points stand in one disagreeing superposition over valid clusters, need not be exhaustive, and are summed; and the clarification that an elementary agreeing superposition is fixed at both ends, the disagreeing superposition indexing equivalence classes of them by destination node; and the smeared determinate node, an or-region by the Fundamental Theorem, which with the transported-expectation reading of step 2 closes the weak-value question. The analysis in the subsubsection is the model's; the rulings, the intuition, and the distinction it runs on are the author's.

September 7, 2026

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By the way, I wonder if the concept of determinate nodes has an effect on the Eppley-Hannah objection
concept.  Please work out the layers of this, and what's significant about it.  Then write a longish
footnote in the long paper with your findings.  Thanks!

Right, so my intuition is basically that each agreeing superposition object of paths is its own
gravitational spacetime basically, and then the disagreeing superposition OVER those Aethae is simply
a disagreeing superposition over those, for which we can pick one randomly via centric unfolding.
So yeah, just the predetermination per Aethus, randomness over Aethae doctrine again.  Also to be
absolutely clear, so we have a formal derivation then that no-signaling is preserved by semiclassical
gravity under Aethic reasoning???  Thanks!

Oh also by the way I see what you mean that semiclassical gravity is WRONG per the framework because
of averaging across disagreeing superposition spacetimes--so my real question then is whether we can
come up with a stress-energy average PER agreeing superposition?  Note that this is by no means a full
quantum gravity YET at this stage, but I wonder how much we could formulate already per this principle.
Also maybe we render the footnote as a subsubsection towards the very end of the active reasoning
section, I guess.  Thanks!

Also I think it's already significant that we can easily refute semiclassical gravity accordingly
per its crossing disagreeing superpositions--that's just a third postulate application, where if the
spacetime metric were based across disagreeing superpositions, we can contradict that by invalidating
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14.7.4 Centradic Gravity

Conjecture 1 (Centradic Gravity)
This idea proposes that the very ability for a given gravitational source to exist in spacetime, for example such that matter is arranged in a way which enables the exterior Schwarzschild solution to exist locally, is reliant on that spacetime feasibly possessing a content of determinate nodes, or more generally possessing gravitationally-mediating "centrades" of which determinate nodes are an instance.

Fundamentally speaking, because of the Aethic non-unitarity principle—which states that Aethic determinate nodes imply non-unitarity—this therefore tells us that any model of quantum gravity insisting on complete unitarity in the universe forces the nonexistence of determinate nodes, and so

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some of the Aethae on which it's based in proper child Aethae! That should definitely also be a central topic of the subsubsection. So yeah that goes the other way from what I was going to start with, because I thought semiclassical gravity already didn't cross disagreeing superposition states! Thanks!

Also I suppose it's interesting that I reframe a faster than light paradox as another validity paradox, right?

Right, exactly I've suspected it's an arena question since I thought of the concept of active space in 2024, especially since quantization of a metric seems super ugly to me and unsolicited from nature. So not that this Aethic semiclassical gravity is already the answer or not, but I certainly feel like it's much closer to whatever it is than quantizing gravity!

Right but I'm also interested in unpacking how my Aethic semiclassical gravity (that should be the unofficial name for it btw, across the whole section anyway) is indeed self-consistent, if you can verify that. For instance, it could make perfect retrospective sense if quantizing gravity was the majority position strictly BECAUSE nobody had a concept of agreeing superpositions, which themselves give you a perfectly static spacetime, no randomness involved, because disagreeing superpositions just select your spacetime for you. That then would itself help support that I'm maybe on the right track, because the majority giving way to such a retrospection is its not locking up against my take, which is an important prerequisite to correctness. So in other words, any unforeseen issues on my part still, or have I at least crossed over to something which is reconcilable as being missed on account of people being stuck with quantization rather than their constraints still holding as reliably to my paradigmatic vantage? Thanks!

Ah I see--ok so once again this is a spot where I can't rule out either pending the verdict from active reasoning proper, but my leaning is certainly toward Option A itself over Option B, because it's hard for me to see a possibility where paths themselves are privileged, since their useful life toward kinematics sort of begins and ends with the subsets, and afterwards the full "object" of the agreeing superposition is what you operate over--so "agreeing superposition over spacetime" is a classical reductionist fallacy being imported, since spacetime I would think in the presence of an agreeing superposition wants to blend or morph, whereas under a disagreeing superposition instead it enumerates. But the behaviors are distinct, and conflating them is on human interpretation, not the universe.

Yeah and altogether I find it super interesting how each agreeing superposition gets its own spacetime! For Aethic semiclassical gravity in particular, how would you calculate the average stress-energy for a given agreeing superposition, and what's your reaction to how and why people leaned toward quantization rather than something of this style? Oh and for the section itself, please start a brand new bibtex file, since I inputted the existing ones already, and please just at the end of this subsubsection do a compare and contrast between me and each non-quantized gravity take just to say it explicitly, walk through the third postulate invalidation of the thermodynamic one, and discuss how much we can say against quantized gravity proper while still leaving it non-ruled out at the moment. Oh and put my notes in an actual \footnotetext please, with your message preceding it and with it itself in typewriter text as usual. Thanks!

Right but I mean it's another iterative question in the sense that if a specific agreeing superposition produces a spacetime metric which enables records, that agreeing superposition gets invalidated and we break it into two spacetime metrics in disagreeing superposition, and where we actually draw the cut in terms of partitioning the path set itself iterates, effectively speaking. So if hypothetically there were to be a feedback between particular spacetimes influencing there being more or less records, the Aethic postulates demand basically a fixed point treatment, I would think!

Right and by the way, if it's multiple admissible partitions then I would imagine they themselves all go in one big disagreeing superposition, I would think! And frankly they need not even be exhaustive--just that you get certain subsets of the paths are the valid ones, and those Aethae are summed!

Right, and indeed maybe there should be a clarification in-paper if not there already that the destination point is fixed too per elementary agreeing superposition Aethus, such that just another example of randomness over Aethae is itself which destination point happens, in that the disagreeing superposition indexes equivalence classes (with all other attributes being their various states) of those agreeing superpositions by the particular destination determinate node. Thanks!

I mean does it solve the problem is the endpoints themselves are actually not perfectly isolated, but rather in their own agreeing superposition over several nearby positions based on whatever imperfect measurement error the detector is bound to have? After all, no detector can narrow all the way down to a point, and hence the determinate nodes themselves occupy an or-region agreeing superposition rather than a single point anyway! Thanks!

Excellent, great to hear! Please propagate this fundamental clarification through the relevant parts of the paper! And yes btw, the smeared determinate node is itself due to the fundamental theorem of

would enforce a universe with at least a significantly more limited set of admissible spacetime metrics than is actually possible in the empirical universe. One canonical example might be the Wheeler–DeWitt equation itself, which in implying perfect unitarity in the universe implies no determinate nodes, which in turn is argued to imply a lack of gravity in that universe up to full empirical admissibility.

The example realization I like best of this is that once we have locked down what a centrade actually is, (which I am deliberately leaving open for the moment so as not to prematurely over-constrain the options), we can take both determinate nodes and Feynman diagram vertices as instances of it as a wider abstraction, and then specifically consider the conformal structure of spacetime as absolutely requiring centrade structure to be formulated fully, all while Ricci structure (as in the Einstein field equations) requires centron structure (of which Feynman propagators are the analogous instance) to be formulated fully. This is not to say that conformal structure cannot hold centron structure or that Ricci structure cannot hold centrade structure, but rather that the ontological dependency hierarchy relies on the aforementioned constraint. This also supplies us with the interesting realization that because a Schwarzschild black hole's own worldline is intimately related to its conformal structure per general relativity, we might want to reframe that worldline away from simply naively instantiating centron structure alone, and instead suppose that the carryover of analogous structures between quantum and classical scales may very well be such that a Schwarzschild worldline is in nontrivial part centrade structure as well, thereby implying spacetime itself must be richer in an oddly Feynman diagrammatic sense so as to supply such a possibility[406].

Placement, and what would establish it. The conjecture consumes the Aethic Non-Unitarity Principle, (Principle 54), in its contrapositive form: a model that holds perfect unitarity over the whole of spacetime, relative to every Aethus, asserts that no Aethus's content anywhere contains a determinate node, and the conjecture adds that determinate nodes, or the centrades of which they are an instance, (the coinages footnote opening this subsection), are what a gravitational source's local existence requires. Three things are then kept apart, at the grades they carry. The first is the principle itself, which is Aethic and stands on the Quantum Nexus, (Section 14.2.11). The second is the conjecture's gravitational clause, that the arrangement of matter enabling an exterior Schwarzschild solution to exist locally requires centrade content of the spacetime; that clause is active reasoning's, posed and not derived, and it is the one a future dynamical theory would have to establish, the Aethic semiclassical gravity sketched in the notes above, in which each agreeing superposition carries its own spacetime and the disagreeing superposition runs over those spacetimes, being the natural setting for the attempt. The third is the strongest and most contestable consequence, that a Wheeler–DeWitt universe, perfectly unitary, is thereby denied gravity up to full empirical admissibility; it follows from the first two only if the gravitational clause holds in the strong form that no admissible metric sourced as the empirical universe's metrics are sourced can be formulated without centrade content, and nothing in the present paper establishes that form. The example realization the author prefers is recorded for the same reason it is left open: once a centrade is fixed, determinate nodes and Feynman vertices become its instances, conformal structure is conjectured to require centrade structure and Ricci structure to require centron structure, (the dependency hierarchy, not an exclusion), and a Schwarzschild worldline is conjectured to carry centrade structure in nontrivial part; each of these is a target for active reasoning proper, and none is consumed by any result of this paper. The footnote of October 9 gives the conjecture one concrete target. In quantum field theory on curved spacetime a preferred decomposition into creation and annihilation operators exists only where the spacetime carries enough symmetry, a timelike Killing field, to single out positive frequency; elsewhere the vacuum is ambiguous and the particle notion observer-dependent [391, 392]. On the conjecture's reading that difficulty is the standard treatment's assumption of minimal centrade structure, unitarity over the

`Aethic reasoning, to be clear!  Thanks!`

[406] As of the writing of this, (*October 9, 2026*), another major suspicion I have about this principle, should it be accurate, is that the very difficulty we find in non-ideally symmetric spacetimes for defining creation and annihilation operators could very well be the result of having not accounted for the Aethic behavior in the system's centrade structure, specifically in the sense that the standard treatment of creation and annihilation operators themselves assumes minimal enough centrade structure that it breaks down once a spacetime comes into play for which its Aethic centrade directly undermines unitarity. For instance, we might show that the standard creation and annihilation treatment is a limiting case of a deeper Aethic mechanism for which unitarity can be comfortably assumed in a series of special conditions, such that it becomes the unitarity assumption itself which conflicts with certain special conditions of the given inadmissible spacetime metric. We then would want to engage in the three-step process of (1) offloading degrees of freedom from the unitarity assumption to the establishment of particular Aethic-mediated centrade structure in the relevant spacetimes, followed by (2) reconstructing the standard creation and annihilation picture as a limiting case of this deeper concept and then (3) unifying the creation and annihilation operators themselves with that deeper Aethic centrade structure material, so as to essentially render all of it as various projections off of one rule written in Aethic constraints, if you will.

arena, breaking exactly where a spacetime's Aethic centrade undermines unitarity by the principle above, (Principle 54). The three-step program the footnote sets—offloading degrees of freedom from the unitarity assumption to the establishment of Aethic-mediated centrade structure in the relevant spacetimes; reconstructing the standard creation-and-annihilation picture as the limiting case in which unitarity can be assumed; and unifying the operators with that centrade structure as projections of one rule written in Aethic constraints—is the construction the conjecture would need, and it is recorded here at the open-construction grade and nowhere begun. If it were carried through, the standard operators would stand to the Aethic rule as the classical-limit cases of Section 14.2.11 stand to the Quantum Nexus: recovered where the special conditions hold, and replaced where they fail. The conjecture is therefore entered at the grade of the open constructions, (Section 14.8), and consumed nowhere.

14.8 The Open Constructions

Because this document serves as the comprehensive record of the framework, its frontier should be timestamped as precisely as its claims. Six constructions are open. First, *a minimality theorem for the pruning rule*: which assumptions on the rule class are necessary and sufficient for the $\exists\forall$ form, with an explicit countermodel for each assumption dropped, which would turn "selected within a class" into a claim no critic can dismiss as framework-dependent. Second, *the measure*: the weighting over $\mathcal{P}(X)$ is operationally anchored—below record resolution it is gauge, at record resolution it is physical, with the record-generated algebra modulo null differences as the operative object and the Powerset Invalidation Theorem supplying the finite case, (Section 14.2.4, Theorem 14). Closing the item requires two things: a statement of the admissible class of weight-structures, (including gradings finer than the reals [105], so that zero weight, null-set presence, and iterated null-set presence remain distinguished, per the (U, M) construction of Section 6.7), and a proof that predictions are invariant across that class—or else the precise identification of which residue of the choice is physical input. Third, *the duality frontier*: $A(T)$ is binary by design, and the linear frontier $V + D = 1$ is a deduction of the framework, (Section 14.6.3). The quadratic half is open, and closing it requires two things: the formal adoption of the enlarged configuration space carrying the marker's degrees of freedom, (under which the survivor is a single agreeing joint cluster whose interior cross-terms carry V, per Section 14.6.2), and the in-formalism definition of the best potential record-attribute yielding D. Completing the item hands the proper/improper mixture distinction its experimental signature. Fourth, *the kernel*: the Feynman weighting is axiomatic input, its derivation assigned to active reasoning, (Section 14), and assigned there because the kernel's substance is kinematic where the postulates' is logical—a derivation from the postulates would be a category mistake, (Section 14.7)— together with the uniqueness and consistency questions of consistent-histories formulations [299], which must be confronted rather than inherited. The Bloch-sphere constructions the sequential treatment employs are not part of this debt: the framework runs them, their weights and Berry-phase structure arriving as pruning residue given the kernel, (Sections 14.2.6, 14.6.3); what stands open on their account is only what the constructions being run *are*—the sphere's points, its projective structure, the spinor beneath it. Fifth, *the realization principle*: the passage from invalidity-as-label to invalidity-as-physical-exclusion is injected rather than derived, as flagged in the Nexus discussion itself. Sixth, *the macroscopic regime*: the conditions under which a configuration is jointly invalid with any eventual access to its distinguishing information—the trigger read as a vacuum in information passage rather than as a concealing force, (Principle 27), so that what is asked is not a mechanism but a set of conditions—at macroscopic scale—including whether environmental records reopen the accessibility that any macroscopic Class-C protocol's recombination caveat, (the requirement that superposed placements be identically restored before any distinguishing record forms), is designed to close—and, with those conditions, the principled assignment of macroscopic Aethic weights. None of these five is solved by the present paper, and the paper's claims should be read with that frontier in view; equally, none of them is hidden by it. (A sixth, first named in the Brief on August 29, 2026 and recorded here for the author to admit or fold into the fifth: the *continuum extension* of the Powerset Invalidation Theorem—with continuous degrees of freedom the signatures are almost-identical rather than identical, "permanently indistinguishable" becomes a limit notion, and the finite case's exactness against einselection does not carry over unamended.) Beyond these, the Centradic Gravity Conjecture of Section 14.7.4 is recorded as a conjecture of active reasoning and not as an open construction of the framework: none of the six depends on it, it consumes the framework only through the Aethic Non-Unitarity Principle, (Principle 54), and the creation-and-annihilation construction its footnote sets out is likewise recorded there, not begun.

15 Conclusion

This paper has presented the openings of Aethic reasoning as regards philosophical, mathematical, physical and metaphysical contexts. In the process, we have seen the solutions to *Requirement 1*, *Requirement 2* and *Requirement 4* through the process of providing the first rationalist algorithmic derivation to the collapse of the wavefunction in the double-slit experiment. Furthermore, we have solved *Requirement 5* through the well-defined explanation of how locality works in Aethic reasoning, as specifically regards the underlying interplay between the extrusion principle and the first and second postulates of the Aethus. And lastly, we have solved *Requirement 3* by isolating the specific way in which quantum decoherence occurs not through some independent detector-based axiom, but instead due to the natural consequences of the third postulate of the Aethus. All that is left now to demonstrate, via the followup paper on active reasoning, is the specific ontological reason for why agreeing superpositions then imply a wavelike interference when taken over the properties of physical matter quanta. Such is the final question of *Step X*, which deserves a paper of its own in order to be gathered.

With these things representing the specific impacts of Aethic reasoning to the measurement problem, it of course follows that the inductive steps of this paper can only have a broader impact. We have already seen with some of the great works in physics of the twentieth century that simultaneity and energy are fundamentally relative concepts, but now we extended the front of relativism all the way to core metaphysical notions like knowledge and truth. Beyond even this, if Aethic reasoning has even a shadow of correctness to its suppositions about superpositions, and of course that would imply a vast string of consequences across the remainder of human history. Among these consequences, at the very least, are the emergence of a metamodern [393] paradigm of physics, a new layer of philosophical depth to be explored by humanity, a first tangible tie between scientific rationalism and Eastern metaphysics, and perhaps a myriad of deeper implications into the scope and meaning of life itself. After all, in the Aethic world, many a preconceived anthropic notions have to be shaken, to say the least, and it seems more than evident that the dominoes are falling in the meaningful direction, (as highlights the metamodern alignment[407] of Aethic reasoning once more).

At this point, now, we are entering something of a very creative time in human history, so the world truly is whatever we make of it.

The landing, in the paper's mature vocabulary. The 2023 conclusion above is kept as written, because the paper is a record; the mature statement of what has been done is shorter and should close the arc. The framework has not exceeded quantum mechanics and has not derived the quadratic law; the kernel is posited, and its derivation is the fourth of the Open Constructions. It has performed one relocation at three sites, (Section 1.1): determinacy, from a one-place property to a two-place relation; exclusion, from the logic of *or* to the records that write it; and probability, from a quantity derived by squaring an amplitude back to the root, with the amplitude reduced to bookkeeping and no observer holding one as an object. Given the path-integral state, the parts of the standard axiom set that constituted the measurement problem—the observables axiom, the projection postulate, the cut—are represented rather than eliminated: given the complex kernel, the record structure and a stipulated record-compatible restriction, the cluster representation realizes that restriction as Lüders conditioning, the validity postulate alone not selecting the update, so that the Hilbert-space premise stops being a mystery about measurement and becomes a statement about records. That is a realist quantum theory in the sense Spekkens specified before this paper was written, (Section 10.3.1), the same equations under a foundation that explains them; and a reader who asks what new physics the paper contains has measured it against a standard the criteria for a realist reformulation themselves reject. The new physics is the successor program's; the foundation is this paper's; and the open constructions are where the one becomes the other.

Acknowledgments

Thank you to my Dad, Thor Benander, and my Stepmom, Juliana Farrell, for sticking by me through think and thin. This paper is a testament to the strength you have given me. Thank you to Dr. Ernest Fokoué for being the first professor to believe in me. Your kindness and your thoughtful feedback on Aethic reasoning helped it reach paper form.

[407] Metamodernism [393] is the art of structuring the indeterminate, and Aethic reasoning takes this art to the core of metaphysical reality. This is why Aethic reasoning may perhaps be viewed as an early example of a quintessential metamodernist stance on metaphysics.

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